Something Wicked This Way Comes

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Rating:	Mature
Archive Warnings:	Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Graphic Depictions Of Violence
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	僕のヒーローアカデミア | Boku no Hero Academia | My Hero Academia
Relationships:	Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku, Minor or Background Relationship(s), Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead/Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead & Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic, Midoriya Izuku & Shinsou Hitoshi, Akaguro Chizome | Stain & Midoriya Izuku, Izuku Midoriya/Pain and Suffering, Class 1-A & Midoriya Izuku
Characters:	Bakugou Katsuki, Bakugou Mitsuki, Bakugou Masaru, Midoriya Inko, Midoriya Hisashi, Midoriya Izuku, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead, Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic, Yagi Toshinori | All Might, Nedzu (My Hero Academia), Class 1-A (My Hero Academia), Shigaraki Tomura | Shimura Tenko, Kurogiri (My Hero Academia), Akaguro Chizome | Stain, Sensei | All For One
Additional Tags:	BAMF Midoriya Izuku, Cute Midoriya Izuku, Scary Midoriya Izuku, Midoriya Izuku Has a Quirk, Midoriya Izuku Does Not Have One for All Quirk, Everyones a dad, except Hisashi, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead Adopts Midoriya Izuku, Abusive Midoriya Inko, Abusive Midoriya Hisashi, Midoriya Hisashi's Bad Parenting, Midoriya Hisashi Has A Different Quirk, Protective Bakugou Katsuki, Bakugou Katsuki is Bad at Feelings, Midoriya Izuku & Shinsou Hitoshi Friendship, Shinsou Hitoshi Replaces Mineta Minoru, Self-Harm, Additional Warnings In Author's Note, Triggers, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Past Abuse, Emotional/Psychological Abuse, Physical Abuse, Overpowered Midoriya Izuku, Sensei | All For One is Not Midoriya Hisashi, Parental Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead, Minor Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead/Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic, Parental Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic, Yamada Hizashi | Present Mic Adopts Midoriya Izuku, Midoriya Izuku is a Ray of Sunshine, Midoriya Izuku Needs A Hug, Mentor Akaguro Chizome | Stain, Abused Midoriya Izuku, Reluctant villain deku, Parental Akaguro Chizome | Stain, Mute Midoriya Izuku, dark themes, authority figures being fantastically incompetent, Dadzawa - An Aizawa Shota Zine, almost platonic bkdk, Villain Midoriya Hisashi, Villain Midoriya Inko, Izuku's too OP, Pining Bakugou Katsuki, apparently this fic is "angst porn" according to one of my comments, apparently people didn't realize the slowburn wasn't applying to just bkdk lol, Heroes Murdering Villains, Kurogiri is Not Shirakumo Oboro, Suicidal Thoughts, Suicide Attempt
Language:	English
Collections:	

Dad Vibes, BNHA BEST CHAPTER FICS TO EVER GRACE THE INTERNET, Katya’s Korner Fic Recs, Crow's collection of shinys, Storycatchers' pile of heroic hero stuff, Creative Chaos Discord Recs, its-yaboijojo Read Later/Favorites, If I ever had a will to write it would be because of these fics, BNHA Fics, DerangedDeceiver's Favorite Fics, Bnha Bookclub Discord Recs, I suffer from this condition called having good taste, long bnha fics i'll always come back to, Amaris' Favorite Ever BNHA Fictions That She Has Read More Than You Can Count, Unpleasant's MHA Recommendations, The best of mha on ao3, Extraordinary My Hero Academia FanFics 💯, nonsense station's discord recs!, Elite 50k+ My Hero AUs, 📚 Fanfic Forum Discord Recs, Se eu perde-las, I’ve given my heart and soul for this fic, FreakingAmazingFics, ✨🦉 Wan Shi Tong's Library 🦉✨, Road to Nowhere Discord Recs, Faves and must-reads, bakudeku love :) <3, bnha faves that keep me going, In-Progress I Want To Read, Yubi Heroic Bookshelf, the holy grail of fanfiction, .⋆°.•*.↩My Bebu multiverse♡♡↬.*•.°⋆., BNHA, The Goodest Shit™, My Favorite: Incomplete Edition, Worth It BNHA Fanfics Reading List - Ongoing, MHA_fanfics_because_idk, Elite_Izuku_Centric_Fic_Recs, The Good Stuff n All That Jazz, Everything so far, Seul’s Favorite BNHA Fics, Eatbook's Cherished and wanting more All Fandoms, .🌌 Thoth's Luxury Library🌌., 🌌 The Witch's Library, BestofBNHA_rereadMONTHLY, Our Hero Academia!, Da leggere all'occorrenza, quetegustandebnh, The worms in my brain, Testing The Limits of my Emotions, ❀리아❀'s library, bkdk books id reread over and over again and never get tired of rereading, To_read_main_rom, Rebel Devil To Read, Subscribed books I've finished, Best of the Best, My hero academia, DWL kindle, Tia's Eclectic Collection of BNHA Fics Worth Reading Again, Gryffs fics II, ✨ My Lengthy Lovelies ✨, Bnha fanfics I recommend {They are amazing (ᵔ◡ᵔ)♡}

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Something Wicked This Way Comes

by Eternal_writes

Summary

Izuku Midoriya's Quirk was...dangerous. Since the age of four he knew what true nightmares were made of. Demons were the soldiers of hell, and they made it their mission to terrify him for fun. Peeling skin, black sillouhettes, and grating screams that froze him in place where only a part of it. Their words and dark hymns followed him, crushing his body and soul.

But not as much as his mother did. Inko was prone to using her fists and venomous words to beat him down, and she was worse than the demons who followed him day and night.

"God does not shine upon you,"

The demons repeated it like a mantra, and they were all right. God hated them all, the fallen wingless angels who he damned for eternity. He loathed Izuku too, the boy who could see them. Izuku was cursed with an uncontrollable Quirk, but he tamed those demons. They were his, and his alone.

God sneered at him, and he smiled devilishly back. God had given the demons exactly what they needed...

Izuku Midoriya. A King.

This fic now has a russian translation!

Act One: Fallen Angel

Chapter Notes

First off, I'd like to thank you for taking the time out of your day to click on my fanfiction! I'm very grateful. ヽ(>∀<☆)ノ **Unfortunately, due to the number (I think it's like five or more?) of comments that I've gotten about me not tagging, or giving proper warning, I must issue a warning before you begin. This is probably the only warning that'll be in the notes in all honesty...**

I'd like to start off with this: In no way, shape, or form am I experienced in actual trauma, PTSD, abuse, or the aftermath of abuse. I just did my best to do my research, and sometimes I'm probably wrong. (very, very wrong. I've only ever been gaslighted, even though I never realized it until very recently, lol). Nor am I a therapist, or a professional writer by any means. (Aspiring writers and actual writers are completely different things… lol) I'd also like to apologize for any inconvenience this fan fiction may cause(d) you, due to the lack of personal experience that I have. Some things may be inaccurate, flat out wrong, or illogical. Somethings may not make sense.

For this, I am very sorry, and I hope you can forgive me in the future if any of the events in this fanfiction triggers you.

HOWEVER, I would like to point out that I am NOT asking for any criticism unless it's to give me pointers on my actual writing. I am well aware that I don't put warnings in my chapter notes, and I'm sorry. (I work a 40-hour workweek, and I don't have set days off. Somedays I'm updating after work which is 8 pm. I don't have time to add warnings seeing as I get up at 11 am, and I am NOT an early riser). I'm not going to update my tags, either. Everything I've tagged is everything I'm willing to tag. Anything more, and I might spoil the fanfiction, which is something I'd rather not do.

Here are the most concerning tags I have at the moment (if any of this triggers you, please don't read this fanfiction. Please don't comment about it.): **[triggers, self-harm, implied/referenced child abuse, past abuse, emotional/psychological abuse, physical abuse, trigger warning, dark, dark themes, bad parent Inko Midoriya, abusive Inko Midoriya, Abusive Hisashi Midoriya, Bad Parent Hisashi Midoriya]**

This fanfiction features descriptive child abuse, self-harm, depression, and other darker themes. For more on this topic, please read my tags.

If you read this entire thing, thank you! You've been properly warned (￣▽￣)

[edited: 5/22/20]

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mommy had rules, very simple easy-to-follow rules. There were only three of them so far, and Izuku was happy to comply if that meant mommy wouldn't hit him anymore. It was a fool's dream, but Izuku put hope into it anyway. Follow the rules, and you might survive.

Don't speak, mumble, cry, or whine. Ever. Do everything mommy tells you. Make sure the house is clean, and make her breakfast.

Izuku, four years old knew that these were the rules. He had them memorized and stored away, mommy liked it when he followed these rules. Izuku didn't mind that mommy made him follow these rules. He didn't mind when she hit him, either.

He wasn't allowed to mind. He could only accept it and move on, like when daddy left them. That day, mommy had been very mad and she'd slapped him across the face. It was the first time she struck him, and it never stopped after that day.

"How'd he get that nasty bruise, Inko?" Mitsuki asked as the young boy played with Kacchan. Inko gave her a confused look before going over to her son. Izuku perked up, hoping mommy would be nice.

"Hm," She mumbled softly, taking a hold of his face. "I'm not sure, I'll have to keep an eye on him!" Izuku beamed at her, hoping his mommy was better now. He was wrong. He was so, so wrong.

Kacchan handed Izuku an All Might figurine and they played together, Kacchan wielding an Endeavor action figure. Izuku liked Kacchan because Kacchan was nice to him, unlike other kids in preschool. He was three at the time, and it was the day that he realized mommy would pretend to be a nice mommy, and then hit him whenever the company left. Kacchan and Izuku played for a while longer before mommy stood up.

"Sorry Mitsuki, but I have to clean the house today, it's too bad we couldn't stay longer."

"Oh! It's fine Inko! Same time next week? Katsuki really loves Izuku," Mitsuki nearly begged the woman, and Inko smiled a smile made of sunshine and razors. Not that Mitsuki

noticed the last part.

“Sure, that shouldn’t be a problem,” Inko told her, gesturing for Izuku to get up and leave. Izuku pouted and handed Kacchan the All Might figure, and Kacchan pushed it back into his hand. Izuku arched an eyebrow in confusion.

“Bring it next time we play, Deku!” He yelled gruffly. “You better not be late, either!”

Izuku giggled at the blond, and his mommy grabbed his hand and guided him out of the room. He was buzzing with excitement, nearly jumping out his skin as he gripped that All Might action figure in his small pudgy hand. His mommy walked him all the way to the nearby neighborhood where they lived. She trudged up the stairs and shot a glare at him as she yanked her keys out of her pockets.

"You don't ever tell Mitsuki about me hitting you," Izuku nodded profusely, gripping the All Might figure just a little tighter. She opened the door to their home silently and opened the basement door. Izuku fought the bile in his throat and the tears threatening to fall. Mommy just gave him that angry look, and he reluctantly made his way down the stairs. It was dark and cold in the basement. It had no lights. He was afraid of the dark.

As soon as he reached the end of the stairs, he rushed to his bed desperate to find his tablet. He turned it on and sighed in relief when his face and his surroundings were engulfed in light. This tablet was something he found soon after daddy left them, and he hid it in his dark room.

Sitting in the basement on his bed, Izuku kicked his feet and smiled to himself as he scrolled through the news. It was his birthday tomorrow! That meant mommy wouldn't hit him, but he wouldn't get cake.

She wouldn't congratulate him either, but he could spend the whole day watching an old clip of All Might! It was his birthday present to himself, every year he'd watch the same video over and over. It was comforting and he absolutely adored All Might.

He silently hoped that he'd get a Quirk tomorrow, and he hoped it was cool. Nothing could be worse than being Quirkless, so he begged any deity or god up in the sky that he got one, no matter how useless it was.

How ironic, considering he'd do anything to be Quirkless merely days from now.

Would mommy love him if he became a hero and got a cool Quirk? Maybe! He grinned at the implications, he could sleep in an actual room! Mommy would kiss him goodnight, and make him cake on his birthday. Mommy wouldn't have to hurt him anymore, hopefully. Mommy would act like a mommy from those movies she always watched when she sent Izuku to bed.

Izuku grinned, still holding the tablet. He crawled under his covers hastily and tried to turn off his brain. He was almost too excited to sleep, but after watching a newer video of All Might giving a speech about Quirks, he finally went to bed.

The next morning he opened his eye with a small well-rested sigh. He blinked the drowsiness out of his eyes and yawned. He rubbed at his eyes and did a double-take. What he saw made his limbs lock, and his lips tremble. The monster looming over him had teeth sharper than a sword, and they were longer than his forearm. They dripped with red saliva. it made Izuku sick to his stomach.

The black limbs attached to the dark man were too long, and they gripped the ceiling, his bed. The floor. A human spider. Blacker than black. It was nose to nose with him. Terror bubbled up his throat, and he wanted nothing more than to run.

But, four-year-old Izuku was frozen to his spot. His throat ached, as he fought for air. No matter how much he begged to scream, his mouth didn’t move. His throat refused to open. He couldn’t even breathe. Everything had come to an abrupt stop.

He hated his Quirk, he quickly decided.

Then the thing began to scream. So loud, that Izuku was finally spurred into action. He tried to push the monster away, but his hand went straight through the demon. He stopped short, letting out a relieved sigh as the monster's hand went through him too.

It couldn't hurt him. It was just merely there. Upon realizing that it couldn't hurt him, the spider-like man sprung from Izuku's bed, making the four-year-old squeak in surprise. Izuku watched as the monster tilted its head, it's white eyes glaring into his own.

He relaxed finally, letting out a breath he didn't realize he'd been holding this entire time. The spider-like monster continued to stare at him before Izuku shooed him away. It hissed at him and glared. It stayed put but didn't bother to meet his eyes again.

Izuku was just fine with that, as he scrambled in the darkness to change his clothes. The dark was more ominous now, as he grabbed his tablet and it glowed through the darkness. Izuku bit his lip and jumped back with the smallest of yelps. His heart jumped into his throat, as he ran back to his bed, his breathing labored. They were everywhere.

Demons surrounded him on all sides, and he choked back a sob. A garbled growl echoed through his room, and Izuku gripped his blanket and tablet tightly. No one had told him that Quirks could be scary. He wanted them to go away! Izuku bit back a whine, he didn't want this Quirk. Who in their right mind would want something like this?!

Definitely not Izuku. The door to the basement opened, Izuku could see the light leaking down the stairs. “Izuku,” A stern voice snapped. His mother. “Get up here,”

Izuku didn’t want to move. He couldn’t even open his mouth to breathe, but he got up anyway. He didn’t want to make mommy mad, and it was a rule. Do what mommy says. So he did.

He ran up the stairs at lightning speed and pressed his lips together. His throat bobbed slightly, and he could feel his hands beginning to shake. His mother's face was one of anger and red-hot viciousness. “Do you know what today is?” She asked. Well, she didn’t ask. She already knew, and she knew he wouldn’t answer her.

She crossed her arms, her lips curling into a scowl. “It’s your birthday,”

Izuku nodded, wringing his hands together. “Did you get a Quirk?”

Should he tell her? It wasn’t cool, or heroic in the least. She would hate it.

She’d be angry if he lied though. So he nodded, and she raised an eyebrow.

Lips trembling he said only three worlds. “I see monsters,”

Her hand came down faster than little Izuku could comprehend. “DID I SAY YOU COULD SPEAK TO ME?!” Her voice was shrill and made him shrink back.

He shook his head vigorously and backed up into the nearby wall.

“Exactly,” she mumbled calmly, her hand coming to touch his face. Izuku jumped. “You don’t have a Quirk,” she told him sternly.

He furrowed his brow, confused. He definitely had one, even if he didn’t want it. “You don’t have a Quirk,” She repeated.

He nodded if only to appease her. She smiled at him, her hand going to his wrist. “Good. Make mommy some breakfast ok?”

Izuku chewed on the inside of his cheek and grabbed a bowl. He could only make cereal at his age, and mommy didn’t care. He filled her bowl with the cereal and then retrieved the milk from the fridge. He poured a respectable amount in the small bowl.

He handed his mommy the bowl and she didn’t spare him a single look. “You can go back in your room now,” She grumbled. “Or do whatever, just stay away from me,”

Izuku didn’t have to be told twice. He went into his room, momentarily forgetting about his scary Quirk. He retrieved Kacchan’s All Might figure and sat down in the spare bedroom and played by himself. He smiled gleefully as he swung the toy around back and forth. But it wasn’t as fun as playing with Kacchan, who could talk enough for the both of them.

The young boy puts down his action figure and pouts. He doesn't like it when mommy makes him be alone. He wants to play with Kacchan and eat dinner with Auntie Mitsuki! He was truly just a child craving human interaction at this point. He loved his mommy, but she wasn't nice.

With a defeated sigh, he takes a hold of his All Might figure again and ventures out of the room. The TV is on, but it's faint, and he can hear his mommy talking on the phone. "Oh, I'm not feeling too well today Mitsuki. I know...I know it's his birthday but I literally can't even make it out of bed right now."

She goes quiet for a moment, and Izuku dares to venture closer. She barely spares him a glance, her voice high-pitched and cheery as she asks him a question. "Do you wanna hang out with Kacchan today Izuku?"

He nods vigorously and mommy continues on with her conversation. "You can come on over and pick him up, thanks for this Mitsuki!"

Ten minutes later, Kacchan is holding an Endeavor action figure with a smile. Mitsuki talked to Inko, her eyes glimmering with pity. Izuku and Kacchan are playing right away, and Mitsuki takes them out for ice-cream. The small shop is bright and colorful, and inside parents were everywhere. Children trail their parents like little ducklings, and Mitsuki asks both him and Kacchan what kind of ice-cream they want.

Obviously Kacchan chooses chocolate, and Izuku picks vanilla. It's a simple and sugary flavor and Izuku enjoys it every time they go out for ice-cream. The three of them take a seat at a table with plush chairs.

"So, Izuku," Mitsuki begins, looking uncomfortable. "Is your mommy nice to you?"

Izuku takes a lick of his ice-cream and ponders the question. He nods feverishly, and Mitsuki lets out a relieved sigh.

"That's good!" She exclaims, ruffling his curly hair. Izuku gives her a beautiful smile, only for it to falter just slightly. Another demon is hanging around, there are a few more outside. He can see them through the shop's window, and they stop to stare at him but quickly move on.

He sighs in relief silently, and Mitsuki gives him a side-long glance. Her expression is soft, and she wraps him in a half-hug that he burrows himself into with vigor. They move on to another place, the park this time. He and Kacchan play tag, and Kacchan has tiny explosions coming from his palms.

"Your Quirk is so cool Kacchan!" Izuku exclaims, and Kacchan blushes. It makes Izuku grin even wider, and Kacchan tackles him yelling about Izuku being a dumb ass. Not that he minds in the slightest.

Some other kids are playing, some in the sandbox to their right, and some playing on the plastic fort with slides. Kacchan and Izuku are fine the way they are, playing tag and fighting with their action figures. The two of them are so engrossed in their playing that they don't notice the man wearing a mask. Mitsuki does though, and she positions herself in front of the two children. Everyone is screaming, and she can hear sirens in the distance.

Her lips are curled into a frown, and she crosses her arms. The man in the mask has a gun, and Izuku glances up as the man raises the gun in his hands. "Mama!" Kacchan starts but never finishes.

A shot rings out, but Mitsuki never falls. "You know, Mic, if you would stop yelling in my ear for one god damn second-"

"I'M SORRY SHOUTA!" Present Mic practically screeches, as he watches the single bullet from the gun drop harmlessly onto the ground. Thank god Eraserhead had the sense to wear a bulletproof vest today.

"Present Mic," The criminal grumbles, with the slightest of nods. "Eraserhead,"

"Yep!" Present Mic yells, "That's us! The wonder duo!"

"Don't ever call us that again. The only reason I'm even awake right now is because you bribed me with coffee."

"Awww, but Shouta!"

"It's Eraserhead!" The man with black hair snaps, wrapping the criminal in his white scarf. Izuku's eyes go wide in amazement. Mitsuki lets out a shaky breath of air. The park is empty save for them, and Kacchan is tugging on his mother's sleeve.

"Who're they, mama?" He asks, and Present Mic whips around excitedly, nearly brimming with energy.

"Why hello there dear listener!" The man exclaims. Kacchan looks confused for only a second before Izuku walks over and gawks. Kacchan practically matches his expression as Eraserhead and Present Mic enter into another bickering match.

Mitsuki grabs both boys by the hand and thanked the heroes profusely. Present Mic waves his hands desperately, while Eraserhead yawns.

"It's fine really!" Present Mic tells her, "We lost sight of him, it's our fault he even got that close!"

"It is your fault. If you would've let me wrap him in my capture weapon we wouldn't even be here," Eraserhead pointed out.

Mitsuki grins, "You two bicker almost as much as those two," She jerks her thumb to the two boys crowding her legs.

"We should really get going, and get this villain detained before he can escape," Eraserhead mumbled, then he pointed at Present Mic. "Sorry about him,"

"Hey!" Present Mic whined, "You're mean!"

"Tell me something I don't know,"

This might just be the best birthday he's ever had. Especially so when Auntie Mitsuki manages to haggle autographs out of both of them. She tucks the autographs away in her car after the two pro-heroes leave, and they drive home. She doesn't take Izuku to his house yet, she tells him it's because she bought him a cake and she bought him a few gifts he needs to open first.

He opens them with unbridled excitement that makes Mitsuki and Masaru coo at the sight. He gets an All Might onesie, and an All Might poster. After eating some dinner, and munching on some of the cake, Masaru, Mitsuki and Kacchan pile in the car to take him home at long last.

Mitsuki and Kacchan walk him to his house, and Mitsuki knocks on the door. Kacchan turns to Izuku who is smiling. "Happy Birthday," He mutters, gripping an All Might figure. "You can keep this 'cause it's your birthday,"

He hands Izuku the action figure for good, and Izuku tackles him in a hug. Kacchan sputters, finally breaking away when mommy opens the door, looking tired. "Oh Mitsuki," She mumbles, "Thanks for bringing him home,"

Mitsuki nods, but Izuku misses the air of suspicion weighing the blonde woman down. Izuku waves goodbye to Kacchan and Auntie Mitsuki as the door closes behind him. The house is dark, and the grey colors of the walls only make it seem darker. The floor is cleaner than usual, to the point he can actually see the wood flooring, which means mommy cleaned! He throws off his shoes at the entrance, slipping on his house slippers.

Mommy says nothing. This was a good day for her, she didn't even hit him! Maybe his mommy was really ok! She takes to staring at him as he takes his presents and head for his room.

He went downstairs, passing a black figure on the way. His hand barely brushed the demon's, but the gasp of shock elicited from his mommy is enough to startle him. Izuku peers up at her through his eyelashes, and she's shaking. "What is that?"

Izuku bites his lip and shuffles his feet. Did she want him to tell her? Or was she just shocked? Her face is deathly pale, and she backs away into the kitchen. Her hand shoots out as if on instinct, and all Izuku can think is: oh no.

A knife flies into her hand almost immediately, it glowing a faint green that makes him nauseous beyond belief. "G-get that thing out of here," She snapped. "Take it downstairs with you, and don't bother coming out tomorrow,"

Izuku's bottom lip quivers, but he yanks on the demon's hand, and it seems to comply to an extent. It gives him a Cheshire grin that makes his blood go cold, but it goes nonetheless. He grips his poster, action figure and onesie tighter. "Go," Mommy growls, knife still in hand, her hair falling in messy clumps. Her green eyes pierce his, and he scrambles into the petrifying darkness.

His mother was scarier than any Quirk, and any darkness. He threw his birthday presents onto the concrete floor unceremoniously, only holding the onesie as he grabbed his little tablet.

Izuku plays that video for himself, that one where All Might is saving people all the while he has blood dripping down his face. It offers Izuku comfort, as he changes quickly and adorns his new onesie. It's soft and warm. He ignores the white eyes in the darkness, the way their garbling voices itch at him. He ignores their long claws that yank at his blanket.

He ignores how ugly they are. Izuku shoves the image of the stumps they all had on their backs where wings were supposed to be out of his mind. Despite himself, he wonders what they'd done to have their wings ripped off.

Something horrible. Something bad. Something taboo and dark.

Chapter End Notes

the discord invite!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

[the discord invite!]

Izuku is ten-years-old when he realizes that his mother hates him more than anything else in the world. It's a sobering realization, but a realization he needed to come to nonetheless. It could be because of his Quirk. Or his father leaving her. Who knew.

All he knew was that his mother hated him, and told him he was Quirkless repeatedly even though they both knew he wasn't. It was strange, but Izuku figured out it was safer to agree than to refuse it. She'd kicked him in the stomach more times than he could count when he talked about his Quirk. So he did the only thing he could think of, and he learned to ignore his Quirk entirely and to fear it at the same time.

It didn't make much sense, to be afraid of something he pretended didn't exist at all. But he'd do anything his mother asked of him, including lying to the world about his Quirk. Midoriya Izuku, a boy with a Quirk? No, no. Midoriya was undoubtedly and unequivocally Quirkless. His birth certificate said it. His ID said it. Even he said it, albeit only when she *made* him.

No one had any reason to doubt him, and he was grateful for that. The only people who were anywhere near suspicious of him and his mother were the Bakugou's. Only because Auntie Mitsuki found it odd that Izuku never ever said a word. Not to his teachers, not to Kacchan — though the boy always knew what he was thinking — not to his own mother. Over the years Mitsuki constantly asked him why he never spoke, and Izuku just shrugged. It wasn't like he couldn't read or write. He just...

He just didn't like talking. It set him on edge, and it made him mother mad. He didn't like it when his mom was angry. She'd go quiet and cold, and her nails would dig into his scalp as she dragged him into the hallway where she'd beat him. It was like his voice was a trigger, and he'd much rather avoid talking altogether.

Today though, he'd followed all the rules and she still ended up backhanding him across the face. His cheek throbbed and ached, and he could feel hot tears begin to sting at the back of his eyes. "I told you to clean the kitchen!" She screams shrilly, and he finds himself wishing he could go back in the basement even though the thought sent goosebumps down his arms and legs.

He definitely didn't remember her telling him to clean the kitchen, but her anger was beginning to bubble over. It would only be a matter of time before she hit him again and handed him a bucket full of harsh chemicals to scrub the floor with.

But today he ducked past her and grabbed it himself, his tiny hands shaking as he got to work and she left him, an ugly frown marring her otherwise beautiful face. The sponge in his hand was dipped into the bucket of bleach, and he didn't even bother to put safety gloves on as he bent down to scrub the perfectly clean floor. The kitchen floor was made of white tiles, and in all honesty, they could go without an in-depth clean with bleach.

The sharp smell of bleach assaulted his nose and he resisted the strong urge to rub at his eyes. The smell of the bleach always had a dizzying effect on him, but he pushed through it.

His mother was scarier than passing out from the bleach, so he made quick work of cleaning the kitchen and the kitchen counters. He stored the bucket of bleach under the sink and closed the wooden cabinet before moving on to sweeping the floor.

Throwing the crumbs of food and chunks of food into the trash he grabbed a rag and scrubbed at the counters. Some of the food was stuck on the counters pretty good, and his arm burned with all the energy he was using to scrub all of the gunk away. His mother got up from the couch around an hour later, once he was sure the entire kitchen was spotless and clean. She studied the white plain counters and gave the floor a pretty critical look before glaring at him. Izuku swallowed his inevitable yelp, and she moved before he could react.

Her hand wrapped around his wrist, squeezing with way more force than necessary. Her eyes flashed with malice and resentment, emotions he was used to by now. Her frown morphed into her signature scowl, and he cowered. He tucked his chin into his chest and avoided her eyes. Her fist cracked against his face, his eyes were squeezed shut and white light sparked behind his eyelids. Izuku clenched his jaw as another blow was aimed for his temple.

Pain sliced through him, leaving him swaying on his feet and clutching his head with a slight hiss. He opened his eyes just slightly, becoming nauseous almost as soon as his eyes were open. His vision was blurry, and the ground seemed like it was moving closer and closer.

His mother spat something, but he couldn't quite hear it. All he knew was that she left him after that.

It was then that he decided to take his leave, and head for the Bakugou's home. He promised to go over some homework with him earlier this week, and it would be suspicious if he didn't show up. He went down into his darkened room and navigated it with practiced ease even though he could barely see anything. He grabbed an All Might hoodie from the pile of clothes on the floor, sniffing it to make sure it didn't smell like it hadn't been washed. And it hadn't been, not for a while. He hoped they didn't notice.

He bit the inside of his cheek as he changed into sweat pants his vision swimming, and his chest tightening. He always felt the tears before they came, and every once in a while he couldn't keep them at bay. Today was not that day, as he swallowed them back, taking deep breathes to clear his vision. A ghost of a hand rested on his back, and he shrugged it off. A garble of dark curses soon followed, and Izuku glared over his shoulder.

The rough mumbling stopped, but those white eyes stared at him. The hairs on the back of his neck rose, and he could feel himself breaking out into a cold sweat. He needed to leave before the darkness got to him. He could only handle so much before breaking down completely. The demon sighed through its nose, the noise loud and clicking in his ears.

He ignored it and trudged back up the stairs quickly. His mother was nowhere in sight, and Izuku silently thanked his lucky stars as he left the house in a hurry. He shoved his hands in his pockets and took the memorized path to the Bakugou's home. The walk was relaxing and entirely a welcome distraction. The sky was open and nearly cloudless. It too warm for his hoodie, but he didn't mind. He liked being warm over being too cold.

He walked down the pretty deserted sidewalk, only coming into contact with a minor hero who asked him if saw a cat named Salem. "Hey there! Have you seen this cat?"

The small-time hero held out a little flyer with the picture of the cat and gestured toward it. He shook his head silently, and the hero looked dejected and upset. "Oh, sorry for bothering

you,"

He really wished he could help, but he wasn't really good at finding cats. They avoided him at all costs, and when they got to close to him they lashed out. He still had a few healing scratches from a week ago where a cat attacked him out of nowhere while he was walking to school. It was probably because of his stalkers who followed him day and night.

The demons who screamed at him, and ripped off their skin to scare him as a kid. They still scared him, but they couldn't touch him so they were relatively harmless. Most of them yelled unintelligible things at him and gave him obscene gestures. Sometimes, though rarely they repeated one phrase. "God does not shine upon you,"

He could attest to that, honestly. Izuku saw out of the corner of his eye a particularly large demon, but he shoved away all traitorous thoughts about his Quirk. He was Quirkless. He was Quirkless. Mother was always right. Everything she says goes, so if she says he's Quirkless, then he's fucking Quirkless.

He didn't even spare those dark figures a single glance as he crossed the street. One of them brushed against his shoulder, but he pretended not to notice. It was easier to stare at the cracks in the pavement and ignore them than to acknowledge them. It would make his mother angry, and it egged them on. Even just a drop of blood would send them into a frenzy. He didn't want to fuel the already out of control fire.

No thanks.

He walked down the street for a little while longer before coming upon the small house. It was bigger than what they needed, but Izuku was over there a lot so it made sense as to why they'd save the extra room for him. He rang the doorbell and shuffled his feet eagerly. He loved hanging out with Kacchan and Auntie Mitsuki. She always fed him a lot of food and gave him random presents. Sometimes he caught her staring at him with worried eyes.

She was wary for him, and rightfully so. Izuku waited patiently for Kacchan to open the door and startled slightly when he immediately screeched when the door swung open. "You're late Deku!" He growled angrily, even though it didn't match his relaxed stance and soft eyes.

He smiled thinly, and Kacchan stepped aside to let him inside. Izuku instantly feels welcome as soon as he takes in the carpeted floor that's a dull beige color. The walls are a soft grey that compliments the carpet pretty well. "Deku's here hag! You got him some snacks right?!"

He didn't deserve these people he quickly decided, as Kacchan went into the kitchen and handed him a nutrition bar. "You look skinny as fuck, stupid Deku," The boy spat, "You gotta eat more,"

Izuku nodded. "And you gotta start talkin' more too! How are ya gonna be a hero if you can't talk to people!?"

Kacchan's voice was rough and rude, but his words were always gentle beneath all of that. It was almost like he had a soft spot for Izuku, and it made the shorter boy grin. "What you grinnin' bout damn nerd?!"

Izuku shrugged, and downed the nutrition bar in record time, dragging Kacchan into his room.

"Fuckin' fine! Let's fuckin' study damn why are so impatient!?" Kacchan growled, closing the door behind them. Izuku makes a beeline for Kacchan's backpack and grabs the many textbooks resting inside. He drops them loudly on his desk, Kacchan curses, and Izuku flashes his winning smile. He has a pad of sticky notes at the ready, and he motions to the open textbook and the worksheet that accompanies it.

Kacchan rolls his eyes. "I hate that you're so smart,"

They settle into a simple routine. He watches Kacchan work through the packet, slapping a sticky note down when he gets it wrong. The stick note is filled with a long-winded explanation of the question and exactly where he went wrong.

"Sometimes I think you have a fucking analysis Quirk," Kacchan says with a deep sigh when Izuku slams another sticky note onto the packet. Izuku gives him a smile that looks like the cat got the canary.

"You smug little bastard!" He exclaims, launching himself from his chair, and Izuku lets out a yelp as the taller boy crashes into him. Kacchan is on top of him, and Izuku pouts silently when Kacchan snickers at him. "No ones better at combat than me," Kacchan's expression is self-assured, and it makes Izuku roll his eyes.

Combat genius. He wrote quickly.

He smacks the sticky note on his head, and Kacchan snatches it off, rolling away so Izuku can sit up. He lets out a snort and helps the green-haired boy up. This is always when his mother bursts in, yelling about watching a movie or a TV show together. Right on time, Auntie Mitsuki kicks the door open — she's dramatic — and smiles at Izuku warmly.

"Do you wanna watch a Marvel movie with me?" She asks as Kacchan puts his now-finished homework away. "Katsuki, go make your mom so fuckin' popcorn. How 'bout it Izuku?"

He nods eagerly, and his eyes must be shining his excitement and contentment for once because Mitsuki looks really, really happy. "Alright, y'all let's go!"

They all move from Kacchan's room into the living room where Masaru is setting up the surround sound. He sticks the disc into the DVD player, and Kacchan is in the kitchen making popcorn. Izuku goes to help him, grabbing a big plastic bowl with an All Might decal on it. Three minutes later the popcorn is ready, and Kacchan pours it into the bowl mumbling about how he could've used his explosions to make the popcorn faster.

That boy is ridiculous sometimes.

Izuku darts out of the kitchen popcorn in hand and Kacchan growls when he ducks away from him. "Sit down problem children," Mitsuki mumbles as Masaru presses play.

The two of them take up one side of the couch, and Mitsuki and Masaru are on the other side. The movie starts pretty quickly and Izuku deduces that it's a Thor movie as soon as Loki walks into the screen. Thor and Loki are some of his favorite Marvel characters, and Auntie

Mitsuki knows that. She's honestly like an angel, an angel who keeps him from starving and becoming socially inept.

Honestly, he'd be dead without her. He hopes he never loses her, as Kacchan grumbles about Loki being an absolute ass. It reminds Izuku of a certain blond. "I am not like Loki, you shitty nerd,"

"Sometimes I wonder how you can read his mind like that," Masaru says as the movie continues on. "Soulmates I wonder?"

Kacchan sputters, a mad blush creeping onto his cheeks. Izuku elbows him, glaring but blushing too. Masaru and Mitsuki bark out bouts of laughter at the look on their faces and Kacchan loses his mind.

"Shut the fuck up ya old hags!" He yells, grabbing a hold of the popcorn and monopolizing it. Izuku can see Mitsuki holding back a laugh, and his shoulders begin to shake. He holds his hand over his mouth, fighting the laugh bubbling up in his chest.

Kacchan gapes, but Izuku lets out a breathy wheeze, and Mitsuki is on the floor cackling. "Even fuckin' Izuku is laughing!"

After the endless laughter subsides and Izuku can catch his breath, they all direct their attention back to the TV. The movie ends too soon for Izuku personally, but Mitsuki lets him stay for dinner.

Masaru fills his plate full of vegetables and rice, accompanied by some chicken. "Eat up, kid,"

He doesn't need to be told twice, as he picks up his chopsticks and downs the whole plate in less than a minute. Mitsuki gives him a fond look, and then her eyes widen just slightly. "Oh, I have something for you,"

Izuku arches up an eyebrow, and she goes into her office. She quickly emerges with an older phone model, and suddenly she shoves it into his hands. It older, but not by much, it's her old phone. He turns to her and Masaru, giving them a confused glance.

"It's for emergencies. It already has our numbers in it, including Katsuki's, you don't have to pay for it either I'll take care of it."

He started to shake his head incredulously. "No, it's okay honey! You need a phone in this day and age, and I don't mind paying for it as long as you use it."

Izuku knows his eyes a glistening with tears, and he tries to push them back. Mitsuki engulfs him in a hug, handing him a charger for the new phone. "Call me if you need me, yeah?"

He nods mutely into her collarbone and she releases him. "Now, why don't I send you home, before it gets too dark? Katsuki and I could walk you,"

Izuku shakes his head, pointing to his phone with a smirk. He'll be fine, and there are always plenty of heroes patrolling in the afternoon along the populated streets. Besides, what was the worst that could happen? He runs into a pro-hero and gets their autograph? Wow, how scary.

Mitsuki ruffles his hair with a grin. "Alright, get going before it gets too dark. Send me a text when you get home, I don't want to be worrying about you all night young man,"

Izuku gives her a curt nod and leaves. The sky is turning orange and red, and Izuku can't help but be a little distracted. It's warm, the sky is beautiful, and he's calm. No one is actively trying to kick his ass, and he doesn't have to clean anything or even go home yet.

He's so distracted that he walks right into a stranger, their shoulders knock together. Suddenly he's in a chokehold, his world whirling as he got his feet under him. Izuku's breath is already ragged, and the arm around his throat tightens.

"Be very quiet, boy," A tall burly man says, holding out a knife for him to see. It glints gold thanks to the sunset. Izuku nods quickly, air puffing out of him in short panicked breathes. "Good."

Izuku grips the man's arm, clawing for air. His throat aches, and it spreads to the rest of him. He's pulled into the nearest alleyway, and his vision blurs drastically as if he's underwater. He lets out a choking noise and digs his nails into the man's muscular arm. It's a futile fight, but he notices a dark figure watching with white eyes. The demon locks eyes with him, and he gasps slightly.

The demon does nothing but place a hand over Izuku's and the boy watches that hand, pleading silently. His assailant jerks his arm away from him, hissing. Izuku whips around, only taking two seconds to see what happened. There was a burn in the shape of Izuku's hand, and he was cradling his arm with a murderous glare. He failed to notice the vigilante waiting to swoop in an decapitate his attacker the vigilante was wearing a red scarf and held a Katana in one hand. Izuku is running before he notices the world whipping past him.

He doesn't dare look behind him or stop running until he's retrieving a key from his pocket. He jams it into the lock and unlocks the door, letting it click softly behind him. His throat throbs, and he lets himself gather his thoughts and catch his breath.

That demon helped him, and Izuku had no idea why. The house is dark, and that sudden thought hits him like a train. It's dark. He can see, because of the light filtering through the windows, but it's still dark.

Dark enough to set him on edge and make his skin prickle. It's not like the kind of terror he feels when he's locked in his room, but it's very similar. It's almost enough for him to turn on the living room light, but he couldn't. It might wake up his mother.

And a forcefully awoken Inko is an Inko he'd rather stay far, far away from. Reluctantly he goes down into the pitch-black darkness that is his room and, he can already feel the fear building up in his chest. It constricts him, and he feels his eyes burn. The only thing he can hear is his own labored breathing.

As soon as he leaves the stairs he turns on the All Might themed nightlight near his bed frantically. He has another one on the other side of his bed, and he turns that one on too.

The room is very dimly lit now, but it helps him immensely nonetheless.

He sits on his bed, tucked in the corner, watching the whole room from his angle. He grips his single pillow tightly, and his eyes never leave the dark staircase. White eyes stare back at him.

He squeezes his eyes shut, shuddering and hyperventilating. He hates the dark. He hates it, he hates it, he hates it. The night lights make it bearable, but he'd rather be in a room filled with light. He grabs his tablet and turns it on. His shoulders slumped as soon as he upped the brightness. He didn't mind that his eyes stung. It was so much better than the darkness.

He'd rather die than be trapped somewhere in the dark. It was such a silly but debilitating fear.

Izuku held his pillow tighter in his arms, before remembering that he promised to text Auntie Mitsuki once he was home. He got his phone out of pocket and turned it on. He manages to find Auntie Mitsuki's number pretty quickly.

Izuku: I forgot to message you when I got home. I'm still alive.

Auntie: Good kid! I was starting to get a little worried!

Izuku: Sorry Auntie.

Auntie: Oh it's okay kiddo, just don't forget next time. Katsuki wanted me to ask you if you know what his English essay was about. He put it off until the last second, typical.

Izuku: I think it was an essay about Quirk theory. He's supposed to choose a topic. Tell him to pick how Quirks can affect personalities. The essay is argumentative and honestly he argues about it with me too much. Might as well write an essay on it.

Auntie: Aw thanks honey! I'll be sure to show him your text.

Izuku: Make sure he puts his name on it too, he always forgets.

Izuku waited for her reply, and after a while, he realized he probably wouldn't get one for an hour or two while she helped Kacchan with his essay. Talking to Auntie Mitsuki always had a calming effect on him, but the second he looked up from his phone that semblance of calm was shattered.

A demon with long, long claws stood nose to nose with him. He yelped and scrambled backward, bumping into the headboard at the back of his bed. The demon tilted it's head to the side, but didn't make any moves towards him.

Heart hammering in his chest, Izuku didn't sleep for a long time that night. He almost never slept in that dungeon of a room. He hates this room almost as much as he hates the dark, hates his Quirk, and hates his mother. And that's saying something.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Hey! If anyone is interested in roleplaying mha, please click this link below. It'll take you to my advanced scribes profile (im really desparate for a roleplay partner.)
>
> click here

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's one thing to learn that mothers aren't supposed to hit you, but it's another to learn that your mother has let a strange man stay with them. It's a shock, Izuku being the tender age of twelve and mute nearly his entire life when a man named Hisashi comes home with his mother.

He doesn't question it of course, as he continues to get ready for the school day. He's gotten used to wearing a middle school uniform, and he's used to his mother's cursing and swift deliverance of pain. He doesn't feel so hopeless as he should, not yet. Izuku still has Auntie Mitsuki to lean on and Kacchan always keeps the bullies at bay.

He buttons up his uniform and winces when his fingers brush against his bruised collar bone. The blotch of bruising is a deep purple that has yet to begin healing. He hisses between his teeth before trudging up the stairs with his bright yellow backpack.

That's when he comes face to face with Hisashi, and the man looks gentle. So different from Izuku's mother, who didn't bother to hide her malice toward him. Hisashi's hair is basically a copycat of Izuku's hair, but black. His eyes are a deep brown that almost looks black. He gives Izuku a slight smile. Izuku doesn't return it, not with his mother standing a little way off.

It almost feels like a bucket of ice has been poured down his shirt. He can feel it in his bones. This man is weird, and this man is Hisashi Midoriya. His smile is off-kilter and his eyes are devoid of anything, and Izuku doesn't trust it.

He shoulders his way past the man, and Hisashi watches him leave the house with sharp eyes. He can still feel them as soon as the door shuts behind him, and he tries to shake it off. It doesn't work as well as he'd hoped, but his thoughts melted away as soon as he left his dilapidated house and stepped onto the cracked concrete sidewalk. There, adorning his own uniform was Kacchan.

A black figure was wrapped around Kacchan. It's long arms wrapped around Kacchan's throat, holding itself up. The demon's legs were hooked around the blond boy's middle. Kacchan was possessed since they were eleven. At first, he was worried sick about the boy, but the only effect the demon seemed to have on him was making him more irritable.

Maybe Kacchan was resistant. He was meaner than he used to be, and he was way more cocky that he'd been originally when they were younger. Sometimes the demon bared it's fangs at Izuku and Kacchan snapped at him, but it was a rare occurrence.

Instantaneously, Kacchan was talking, waving his hands around. "Yo Deku, you know how we were talking about going to Yuuei together?"

Izuku nods, feeling a bit apprehensive. Kacchan tried to give him a reassuring smile, but it ended up being a smirk. "So, I was thinking that I should apply for the Heroics Department, and you could for General Ed. You could be the smart one, and I could be the one that puts those crazy plans of yours into action, how does that sound?"

He nodded ecstatically, his smile going wide. He barely noticed the dusting of pink on Kacchan's cheeks. "You like that idea? Good, we can be a wonder duo!"

Now that was something Izuku could get behind. Kacchan went on a whole tangent about it too, as they walked to school. The cherry blossoms were in full swing at this point. They caught in Kacchan's hair and Izuku stared at the petals absently as Kacchan talked and talked. "We should probably have hero names too. What about...Deku and Kacchan?"

Izuku shot him a thumbs-up, and Kacchan smiled at him that soft smile that made Izuku's insides go tingly and warm. Before Kacchan can notice the blush on Izuku's cheeks, they arrive at the shitty school they call Aldera Junior High.

Not only is the school shoddy and run down, it's also filled to the brim with shitty teachers and even shittier students who didn't know when to keep their mouths shut. In the end, Kacchan always got them to stop talking, either through threats or a beat down they weren't going to forget for a while. It was comforting to know that Kacchan would be there with him all day.

It was a relief to have a legitimate excuse to stay away from his mom, too. Kacchan goes near-silent as they enter the building. The two of them shoulder their way through the crowds of bodies that clog up the hallways. Izuku was never a fan of people he didn't know touching him, and this whole situation made it worse. Luckily before he could panic, he and Kacchan managed to make it through.

Taking a deep breath, Izuku followed Kacchan down the next hallway, dodging bodies and dodging teachers who happened to be in the way. It was almost a dance of sorts, he and Kacchan darting out of the way, sometimes Kacchan would yank him one way or another to avoid someone or a wall in some cases. Sometimes it was Izuku pulling him out of the way with an annoyed sigh.

"Damn this school's fucking packed," Kacchan grumbled, "It shouldn't take this long to get to fucking class,"

Izuku nodded in agreement, gripping the strap of his backpack tightly. They take their seats all the way in the back, and Kacchan sends him a text. Izuku's phone buzzes in his pocket, and he shoots Kacchan an exasperated look. They were literally sitting next to each other!

Kacchan: So how are you?

Deku: You're literally sitting next to me why are we texting.

Kacchan: Because someone decided to be difficult and never talk.

Deku: Okay, ouch. Asshole.

Kacchan: Seriously though, are you okay? There's a bruise on your eyebrow.

Deku: It's fine, I just hit my head.

Kacchan: Oh. Ok.

Deku: What?

Kacchan: Nothing. Did you eat anything before school?

Deku: I can barely wake up this early, and you have the gall to ask me if I ate? The answer is obvious.

Kacchan: You're a dumb ass.

Deku: Tell me something I don't know.

Kacchan clicks his tongue loudly and Izuku looks up from his phone. The blond boy is holding out a few pieces of wedged apple for him, and he takes it with a smile. Their class begins as he takes his apple wedges and eats as quietly as he can manage. If he's chewing loudly and being annoying no one voices it. No one even spares him a single look.

Maybe it's because Kacchan is emitting a no-nonsense aura, but Izuku isn't paying enough attention to his friend to notice. He's diligently taking notes for the both of them, and watching a demon out of the corner of his eye. He tries his best to ignore his Quirk all together, and sometimes he manages to. Other times they captivate him, just like now.

The dark figure is thin and taller than what should've been humanly possible. It was a bit of a mess, trying to watch the teacher while that thing placed its hands on the chalkboard.

Izuku felt his muscles tense and resisted the strong urge to cover his ears immediately. The claws whispered against the board at first, but suddenly they were raked across the board. His ears stung, and he vaguely felt his teeth dig into his tongue as the screeching reached it's lethally annoying crescendo. He could feel himself beginning to grind his teeth together, but he pushed past the annoyance and sudden anger.

He quickly caught up on his notes and snuck a glare at the demon who decided to torment him today. The demons white eyes narrowed, and he swore that the monster pouted at him. His eyes had gone wide for only a second, as the demon left the room without so much as a word.

Izuku stared at the door awestruck for a few seconds before trying to focus once again. It was kind of difficult, considering a demon pouted at him. Usually, they flipped him off or cussed him out. They hung around him and chanted dark things as they walked with him. Never have they ever pouted at him, or helped him.

Besides that one time, he almost got killed by a criminal in an alleyway. That had been something to behold as well. It was kind of scary to see them listening to him too. That was new.

His Quirk was getting stronger, and he had no idea why or how. He wanted nothing more than to stop it or make it disappear altogether. Honestly making it go away forever sounded pretty appealing. He had no idea how to go about it, but he'd figure it out eventually.

Izuku had heard some wild rumors about villains selling Quirk Suppressors for a hefty price. Maybe he could save some money and get one? Who fucking knew, but having something rather than nothing was preferable.

He was pulled out of his thoughts when someone kicked his desk. He startled, nearly letting out a yelp when he made eye contact with Kacchan. "C'mon nerd, class is over let's go to lunch,"

Did three hours pass by so fast? He must've been so engrossed in his own thoughts and taking notes that he didn't pay attention to the time. He scrambled up from his desk, hurry to catch up to the blond who went on ahead.

The lunchroom was large, and so was the fucking line. Kacchan went to secure a table for just the two of them, his mother's homemade bento in hand. Izuku checked his phone for any recent hero activity. Despite his circumstances with his mother, he hadn't forgotten all of his hobbies.

Especially analyzing heroes and picking them apart by just knowing their Quirks. He was still fascinated by them, and he still adored them. Even if they failed to notice a suffering teenager right before their very eyes.

Well, Izuku didn't make it very obvious though, did he?

Finally, the lunch line went forward a bit, and Izuku stared at the rapidly filling round white tables seemingly placed at random. He wasn't hungry, and he really didn't need food right now, but Kacchan would kick his ass if he came to their usual table without any food on his plate.

Soon enough, Izuku was filling his plate with food and leaving the line to sit down. He let out a tiny sigh, eyes scanning every table before he spotted the spiky-haired blond. Thank god Kacchan was hard to miss because he didn't want to spend all day looking for him. It would be embarrassing and annoying.

He sat down quickly, with a stifled yawn. "Did you even sleep last night Deku?"

He gave Kacchan a shrug and pulled his wooden chopsticks apart to begin eating. Kacchan merely opened his lunch from his mother and slid his phone over for Izuku to look at, it was a newly published article in new and upcoming heroes.

Kacchan really knew how to get Izuku’s attention, huh?

“I’m betting Kamui Woods is gonna be big,” he grumbled through his food as Izuku scanned the article like a rabid animal. Izuku shrugged. “What you think Mt. Lady will beat him?”

He gave a slight shake of his head, before grabbing his phone. They both knew that if Izuku wanted, he and Kacchan could study JSL and communicate that way. Honestly, he didn’t want to make Kacchan learn it, so he just never bothered with it.

Maybe he should’ve. That would’ve been wise, but Kacchan always spoke enough for him, and could practically read Izuku’s mind. It was kind of unnerving almost, how easily Kacchan could read him like an open book. He didn’t need JSL to communicate if he had Kacchan.

But he wasn’t that naive, he knew if he wanted to become something he’d have to speak. He just wasn’t sure how, or if he could. Or maybe he could get off his ass and bother with some JSL. Auntie Mitsuki would probably be very interested in helping him learn it, and she’d even offered to help him learn a few times. So maybe he could try that out. Anyway, he shakes his head at Kacchan. He slowly types out his response in his phone as he eats, and Kacchan’s eyes widen slightly. *I give it a month before they're dating.*

“You think they’ll get together?!” He exclaims incredulously, giving Izuku a shocked look. Izuku nods vigorously, and Kacchan leans back in his seat with a smirk. “How could you possibly know that?”

He shrugs and Kacchan shakes his head. They continue in companionable silence as they eat, with Kacchan sliding his phone over for Izuku to look at. Most of them are about All Might's good deeds today, like how the man stopped a hostage situation before it could escalate. All Might was truly a good hero, through and through. And the world's number one hero didn't have time for small cases of child abuse.

That was fine for Izuku. It could be worse, he guessed. He could be homeless or dead.

Or maybe...maybe that was preferable.

Kacchan had to serve detention for his "harsh" behavior towards other students during school. He'd been standing up for Izuku, so he felt bad and wanted to stay with him, but Kacchan told him to go home. So he did, by himself for the first time in a long time. His friend always wanted to make sure he got home safely because he was mute, and people would take advantage of that. Or so Kacchan said.

Izuku had yet to meet someone who even looked in his direction. He was ordinary and plain looking. No one even bothered to spare him a glance unless Kacchan was slinging an arm around his shoulders. It was a blessing honestly because he hated talking to people. He walked through an underpass, phone in hand as he texted Kacchan. He wanted to come over to his house tonight to hang out, and Izuku needed to figure out a way to deter him. Izuku was coming up with an excuse. Something along the lines of needing to finish an art project.

It was a valid excuse because when he wasn’t analyzing heroes and avoiding his mother, he was drawing. That was when he heard it. A wet sound, coming from behind him.

Izuku stopped in his tracks, turning slowly. The underpass is dark, and the slime figure looks disgusting in the dim lighting. And might he say, terrifying?

A cocky grin, all teeth is displayed on the villain's face. Izuku grimaced, taking a retreating step back. "Don't run away, kiddo," It's like there's gravel in his throat, the way his voice sounds.

Goosebumps blossom along his arms and legs, like ice. He isn't stupid, and he doesn't waste time hesitating. Izuku has to move if he wants to live. He hears his shoes slamming against the pavement before he registers that he's running. Izuku passes a few dark figures who watch him with fascination, but he ignores them.

It's sad really, how close he was to the street where tons of people walked. How close he was to escaping before he was grabbed, and slime entered every airway. His vision blurred almost instantly with tears. It was a strange sensation to suddenly stop breathing because slime was pushing its way into his lungs and stomach. Down his throat and nose, burning and making him gag.

He couldn’t even close his mouth, and his jaw began to ache and add to the overall pain of everything. Every moment of pain in his entire life couldn’t hold a candle to the pain he was experiencing right now. And the despair that coiled in his gut, and the sudden rush of thoughts that screamed at him.

Louder than the alarmed screams from his demonic entourage. This was the first time he’d ever had a thought such as this one. One so desperate and simple. Primal and uncontrollable.

A single thought.

I don’t want to die here.

But Izuku Midoriya was cursed. His hands twitched, and his entire chest and face positively ached and screamed at him for air. Even just a second of it. Anything. Anything.

I don't want to die here.

Izuku didn't beg to be rescued. He knew what he was, and what he deserved even if his thoughts betrayed that. Angels didn't save Demons, they ripped them apart starting with their halos and wings. Until they burned.

Until nothing but stumps and blood remained, their tortured screams only heard by a single boy. Izuku, who was no better than them. He was tainted and dark. He didn't deserve the gentle words and touches that heroes handed out like free candy. He wasn't a potential hero worthy of praise. Izuku was an abomination, yet he wanted to live.

He was so engrossed with his thoughts and struggling that he didn't see the flash of red. He didn't see the blond hair of a hero he used to admire with almost a religious adoration. But suddenly he was falling and there was air in his lungs.

The second his hands skid on the pavement he vomited. Sludge fell in disgusting heaps out of his throat, and Izuku scrunched up his nose. He looked over the two heroes who saved him. All Might and Eraserhead stood a little way off. He gaped at them, his breath coming in short breathes.

A man where the sludge villain used to stand stood in its place. Looking terrified. "A-ah, All Might! Eraserhead-"

The voices sounded muffled to Izuku, and he noticed how Eraserhead left quickly as soon as he made eye contact with All Might. He knew that the number one hero could take care of it. Izuku took one look at the distracted number one hero, and the retreating underground hero. And then he left, scrambling to grab his bag. They hadn't noticed him.

He blended into the crowd nearby and dusted off his school uniform. Dark green smears were all over it, but that was fine. He had all weekend to clean it. He could sneak in some laundry

at some point if he was lucky. Then he remembered something very important. Hisashi was home. He gripped the strap of his backpack tighter at the sudden reminder.

Izuku stopped before the door to his mother's small house. The paint was faded and cracked in some places. The house key sat heavily in his pocket, and for a moment he debated actually going inside. It was silent inside as far as he could tell, and it made him grind his teeth together. Izuku reached into his pocket and quickly throws caution out the window. His mother would be furious if he didn't come home. There was no getting around it.

He opened the door with a creak, and all of the lights were on. Strange. He took a cautious step forward. The floor squeaked under his weight, and he jumped nearly a foot in the air. Izuku made a beeline for the basement door, steps hurried and his lips pressed into a thin line.

Anxiety bubbled in his chest, similar to the sensation of being strangled like earlier when the Sludge villain assaulted him. Someone cleared their throat behind him. It was obviously not his mother because it was deep, too deep and masculine. His hand froze around the doorknob. Izuku didn't move. Not even when footsteps sounded behind him, heavy yet quiet thanks to the carpeted floor. "My boy, I was wondering when you'd get home,"

Izuku chewed on his lip and glanced over his shoulder. "Turn around Izuku,"

It was like someone poured a bucket of cold water down his shirt. His mother had never called him that. No one called him that except for Auntie Mitsuki. And this man's tone was cold and devoid of emotion. Izuku carefully detached his hand from the doorknob and turned to face the man who he'd inherited his curly hair from. His freckles. It was like looking in a mirror. A scary, distorted one.

He gulped, ducking his head. He could barely see the man through his bangs and eyelashes. But he could never miss that smile that pulled at his lips. His hands started shaking immediately, malice radiated off of that man, his teeth gleaming like fangs. Everything about Hisashi made Izuku want to stay far away from him.

Preferably light-years away, please and thank you. But no, he only had a wooden door with the lock on the *outside*. Suddenly he had a gut feeling that his room wasn't safe. Well, scratch that. His room was a prison cell, but now he knew it was a cell that Hisashi planned on invading. It was bad enough that it was shrouded in perpetual darkness, but now Hisashi...

Hisashi prowled.

Chapter End Notes

it's kinda getting dark there at the end, but I promise you Izuku's suffering does end! Please once again scroll alllll the way up and click on my profile link if you're interested in roleplaying with me on advanced scribes.

Also! Here's the discord invite!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> JUST TO WARN YALL. Lowkey this is a slow burn and he doesn't even have the entrance exam until chapter 15
>
> Want to yell at me about that? Feel free :D
>
> the discord invite!

A cold, sick feeling coiled in his gut. It hit him like a punch to the stomach, fast, sharp, and unexpected. Hisashi was strange, he had that air about him. The stray demon who managed to follow him cowered in the corner next to him. It's back was to them, its form a solid black. Where wings should be, rested stumps and scars that were a slightly lighter color of black.

Izuku's gaze didn't linger, he was too focused on the man in front of him. Asking him a question he'd never answer. Only because he couldn't. He would never be able to.

"What were you doing? School let out a little while ago," Hisashi grumbled, his arms crossed. "Aren't you going to answer your father?"

The silence that follows is deafening, and Hisashi takes a step towards him, and of course, Izuku takes a cautious step backward in response. His fingertips brush against the wood of the basement door. It sends cold chills through him at the thought of that dark room.

His muscles lock in place as Hisashi places one hand on his shoulder. The wave of pain hits him like a freight train, and Izuku is frozen in place. He's on fire, he's burning. This is *hell*, pain bubbling and overflowing beneath his skin. His teeth snap together, and he doesn't cry out. He can't.

His skin screams at him, and his bones jostle just under his skin and muscle. His vision explodes, and everything goes white-hot for a single moment, in that single second everything distorts. Everything is too sharp, everything is too clear. He can see those god-forsaken wings fanned out behind Hisashi. He saw the cowering demon flicker and disappear. He's hallucinating from the pain. That's the only explanation.

The basement door he's leaning against shakes, and Izuku let's out a growl of pain. His hands shake, and his knees keeping knocking together as Hisashi's grip only tightens. A deep scratchy voice whispers faintly. A single word that has Izuku reeling.

"...God?"

The pain escalates, and Izuku is barely aware of falling to the floor in a big heap. Barely aware of the words Hisashi is spouting. "That's my Quirk,"

His Quirk. All of this was his Quirk? Izuku carefully lifts his head only slightly. The world tilts, and Izuku groans. "One side can cause pain, and the other can cause panic. You should be a very careful boy, Izuku."

Izuku finally manages to get his feet under him, the hand finally pulled away from him. Relief rushed to him in euphoric waves. He uses the basement door as support, watching Hisashi carefully. "Break any of your mother's rules, and I'll make sure you pay the price, got it?"

Izuku blinks the vague pain away and nods eagerly. Hisashi grins. "I think I like you, my boy. I like my victims better if they're quiet and complacent, like you."

Hisashi's calloused hands grab a handful of his hair, his picky lifted up and away from him. Izuku flinches back, his breath labored with terror. Izuku grinds his teeth together and ducks his head. Hisashi bares his teeth at him, his next words whispered into his ear. "Go in your room and don't come out,"

Izuku's hand is already around that cold doorknob, and by the time Hisashi walks away he's already opening the door. The darkness swallows him too easily. Izuku squeaks in surprise

when the door slams closed on its own. All light is extinguished, and Izuku can feel that rising panic and worry.

He hurried down the rickety set of wooden stairs that were never carpeted. Once down into his room the quiet settles like a thick blanket. He chews on his lip, listening for anything.

The floor is cold beneath his feet, and his eyes dart around the empty black. A pair of white eyes blink before him. Heavy footsteps make their way closer to him. He can't see anything but he sure as hell can *feel* it. The ice encircles his wrist, so cold it burns against his skin. A hand wraps around his wrist, and the creature rambles loudly incoherently. Izuku tears his arm away and scrambles backward until his shins slam into his bed. The footsteps begin anew.

Izuku shoves his hand through the demon before him and usually where his hand would faze through, it felt like he plunged his hand in ice and fire. He yanked his hand back with a gasp of shock and pain. The demons advance halted and it grumbled again. *"...Poison."*

Izuku scrambles beneath his bed covers and hides. The rambles continue loudly, and he can feel the demon's claws scratching gently at the blanket. Izuku curls into a ball, ignoring how that *thing's* voice sets him on edge. *He's Quirkless. He's Quirkless.* That *isn't* a demon trying to talk to him. *"...Poison."*

In his pocket, his phone vibrates, and he extracts his hands from his face to take it out. It's a text from Auntie Mitsuki, and Izuku answers her quickly.

Auntie Mitsuki: Katsuki wants to hang out with you tomorrow, are you free?

Izuku: Yeah, but why wouldn't he text me himself?

Auntie Mitsuki: I grounded him, he refused to eat dinner until I nearly shoved it down his damn throat.

Izuku: He's so dramatic.

Auntie Mitsuki: Yeah. He said he was worried about something, and then wouldn't shut up about wanting to hang out with you tomorrow.

Izuku: Tell him I'll meet him at the park. I'll text him when.

Auntie Mitsuki: Okay! Have a good night sweetie!

His room was silent now, not even an inkling that there was something else in here with him. He lets out a sigh of relief and uncovers himself from the blanket. His room is dark as usual, but there's an aching difference, there aren't any white eyes staring at him from the corners. There are no gleaming teeth or gritty grumbling.

It's strange, but he takes in stride, emitting relief and minor anxiety. Izuku clutches his blanket, the darkness burning at his eyes. Even with the absence of those things, this room was still...a cell.

He could definitely leave at any given moment, but the thought of the repercussions that would follow kept him in his bed. His mother and father would lock him down here forever.

And he couldn't let that happen under any circumstances. So he sat in this endless inky dark and stayed put. He reached for his water bottle on the floor next to his bed and drank a few gulps. He always got dehydrated after painful experiences like the one he just had with Hisashi. There were sure to be more, so he should probably think about keeping a few bottles down here at a time. Just in case they decided he wasn't worth the effort anymore, or if Hisashi beat him again.

Izuku closed his eyes but didn't sleep for a long time.

Even the silence was loud and unbearable in this room.

It was when he turned 14 that he realized just how trapped he *really* was in this house and in this life. Izuku finally came to the realization that things were worse now that Hisashi had been here for two years. He rummaged around his room, looking for his phone. That was the first sign that something was off. His phone was gone, and he scrambled back over to his bed. Somewhere on the floor underneath was the tablet he only used for emergencies now.

It was gone. Both of his only light sources were *gone*.

Panic grips him with an icy firm hold, and Izuku sprints up the stairs. Ignoring how loud he's being, and ignoring the dozens of white eyes blinking at him. His hand is around that cold doorknob before he can even realize he's made it to the door. He twists the knob this way and that. And it doesn't open. It's locked from the outside, and a wave of terror crashes into him.

He drowns in it, shaking and hyperventilating as soon as he realizes he is truly and unequivocally imprisoned in his own room. The darkness whispers to him softly, and he can't hear anything over his own fear and hysteria.

His shaking hands come up to cover his face, his nails digging into his cheeks. He can think of a million things to scream, but his mouth has never been in his control. His vocal cords could never produce a sound. His face stings and his eyes burn with tears. Izuku can hear heavy footsteps venture closer to his bedroom door. Izuku freezes completely, taking a few steps down on the staircase backward.

Hisashi's voice is easy to recognize. The alarms go off in his head, and he listens carefully at the words his father says. "Your Quirk is ugly, you're an abomination to society. So you're going to stay locked down there all day, do you understand me?"

Izuku finally steps off the last step and slides down into a sitting position, his nails dragging down his cheeks and chin. His teeth clang together in his mouth, and his jaw aches from clenching it too much. Even his teeth ache. His fingers dig into his neck, stinging and burning with the force of his endless scratching. The panic is rising, and he can feel his heartbeat a million miles a second in his chest.

There's a lump in his throat, and a scream begging just to be let out. The skin under his hands is warm and sticky. He can taste iron and fear coating his mouth. His fingertips are warm with his blood, but he didn't care.

Those white eyes kept watching him. They kept whispering, but it might as well be roaring. *"Purgatory..."*

It was a chorus of voices and guttural whines. Almost like a mob of monsters growling at him. He couldn't see their bodies in this deep darkness, but he could see their eyes, and that was enough for him. His shirt clung to him, and suddenly he was coated in sweat and prickly skin. Fear wrapped around him like a blanket, and it just wouldn't go away. He didn't want to be locked in here anymore.

He wanted out.

That's when he heard it, his possible escape. The sound of the only human being who he cared for more than he cared for Auntie Mitsuki. Kacchan. "Hey Auntie Inko, have you seen Deku around anywhere? He hasn't been answering my texts."

But Izuku is frozen in place, his fingers digging into his delicate skin still. The darkness swirls and distorts before him as his mother's voice gently reaches his ears. The glow from under the basement door is the only meek source of light, and he can see the telltale sign of someone standing right in front of that door. Two spots under the door are dark, and as he quietly walks up, he catches a glimpse of shoes.

He stands a step below the door and listens. "He isn't here right now," Inko merely says, her voice light and airy. Izuku can practically see her blank face and tired eyes. Her empty words mean nothing when paired with her face. It’s painfully obvious to Izuku that his mother is a blank shell.

But maybe it’s a good enough act for Kacchan because Izuku can hear his familiar footfalls begin to retreat. Closer and closer to the door. Swift and confident but heavy due to his stormy sea of anger.

Izuku listens silently, not daring to move even an inch, but the white eyes hiding in the walls around him have other ideas. The demons converge, refusing to be locked up in here, and for a second he believes it’s for his behalf but that can’t be right. Demons hate and want to torture everything. They hate him, and they want to make him suffer, so they’re next move

made sense only after he realized the full scope of it all. They merged together, a wet gurgling sound shook the rickety wood stairs, and Izuku blanched as the door shook and the hinges screamed. Kacchan stopped in his tracks, and Izuku launched himself forward into the icy depths of the unnatural black.

It was jumping in an icy cold lake in the peak of winter, it was so cold that his very bones seemed to freeze and burn. His face was numb nearly instantly, as he pulled the black mass of demons toward him and away from the door. Izuku's fingers sunk in deeper to the monstrosity slamming itself into the door and pulled physically and spiritually. The feeling in his fingers dissolved quickly, as the silence beyond the door ripped at him. He messed up. This was a mistake, he was damned and cursed. This would *not* end well for him in the slightest.

The icy feeling spread through him as if it had entered his bloodstream and began to infest him. His heart sunk in his chest as the demon mass lashed out. It's outraged scream shook the walls and the door. Izuku bared his teeth and yanked even harder, and the demons fused together faltered. Almost immdieately he remembered that he was standing on the weak wooden stairs. His hair tussled in the rush of air that accompanied his quick, painful descent.

His stomach plummeted to his feet, and he only had a few seconds to feel nausea before his knees and ankles ached. He tumbled down the set of stairs, rather loudly he might add. The conversation beyond that door didn't resume, and that demon mass seemed to have exploded apart. Many pairs of white eyes stared at him, grumbling and rattling wordless rasps at him. His head throbbed, and everything seemed to hurt as he stumbled to his feet. The darkness whispered against his skin, and he managed to shove the intrusive thoughts of fear so he could listen to the conversation upstairs.

"What was that, Auntie Inko?" Kacchan asked, sounding confused and concerned. "Are you sure you haven't seen Deku?"

"Oh I'm sure, it's just our cat. He likes to scratch strangers so we keep him downstairs when guests are here. He has a habit of making a lot of noise too," His mother explained smoothly. It was alarming.

And then, just as quickly as Kacchan got there, he was gone. His escape and hope were gone. All that was left was this invading darkness and those white eyes that made him want to

gouge his own out.

And the impending doom of his punishment. If used correctly his mother's Quirk was quite terrifying, but he was more concerned about his father if he was being honest. The duality of his quirk was concerning, and the ease of which it could be used for villainy was also a cause for fear and horror. He waited with bated breath, chewing at his lip and pinching the skin off in his mouth. It didn't really hurt, it was more of a nervous tick than anything.

Like how people bit the skin off their bottom lip. He did that too and chewed his fingernails. He watched that door with sickening anticipation because he knew what was coming, he just didn't know who would dish it out.

For a few long minutes, it was nearly silent. Eerily so, as the floor creaked just above him. The door up those narrow stairs jingled loudly before something heavy thumped onto the floor. A few seconds later that door creaked open and a little light shone through. It brought him no comfort as his mother's honey-like voice reached him. "Izuku dear, get up here,"

It was too cheerful, and too much like how a real mother would speak to him. So much like a demon imitating a demon like in movies, it's effect was exactly the opposite of what his mother probably wanted. She probably wanted to lull in into a false sense of security, but Izuku wasn't stupid. It made that same icy feeling from grabbing those demons slam into him again. This time it felt even worse. Izuku despite knowing that he had no choice but to go, stood still as a statue.

It was strange and he didn't want to do it. No. He didn't want to see what awaited him. *He really didn't.*

"My boy, if you don't get up here right now I swear to god-"

And Izuku rocketed himself up the stairs, knowing full well that his father wasn't afraid to go down into his room. He'd drag him by the ankles up those stairs if he had to. Izuku was engulfed in the light as soon as he left his room, his eyes burning as they adjusted. Inko stood well enough away, looking absolutely pissed. Hisashi had his arms crossed, looking like a real angry father for only a second. The malice coming off him in waves was overwhelming, and Izuku had to duck his head away with urgency.

He waited, staring directly at his feet. His fists were clenched at his sides and he practically jumped five feet in the air when Inko was the first to speak. "Drink this," She merely said, holding a glass of water. She must've snuck off silently while he stared at the ground in horror. Izuku grabbed it quickly and downed it faster than he thought he could. Izuku didn't care if it contained a lethal poison or sedative drug. He just did what his mother told him to do.

If it meant he had to drink this he was fine with it. If this was his punishment, it was a mercy. Izuku handed the glass back, and Inko disappeared for a few seconds into the kitchen and Hisashi took the spotlight. “Your mother is truly a brilliant woman, I wouldn’t have thought of that in a million years,” Hisashi told him.

Izuku blinked slowly, in fact, everything was slower. His chest ached, and nausea wracked him in waves. He couldn’t breathe, and suddenly he had a face full of floor. It was like an elephant was sitting on his back, and whatever was in that drink wasn’t good he quickly decided. Was it really poison? Was this what the demon had been warning him about?

His gut told him that either way, something was gone. Something was repressed and stripped away from him. It hurt, it hurt. He covered his mouth with his hand, as he nearly dry heaved. His stomach was doing backflips, and his heart was twisting and beating erratically in his chest. There wasn’t enough air. He blinked through the blurry haze as Hisashi crouched to his level. Izuku raised his head — wait, no. Hisashi grabbed a handful of his green curly hair and jerked his head up. That was more accurate.

His words were unintelligible, and Izuku completely blanked. He seemed pretty heated.

“You...deserve...fault...stupid Quirk. Cursed boy...hated...” Everything was muted.

Izuku couldn’t understand a single thing happening. Those words were lost on him for now. “Suppressants...”

Okay, he was wrong. He understood that in perfect clarity. That water was filled with Quirk Suppressants, and that’s why he felt so weird and sick. He felt like he was high and drunk at the same time and it was strange. It was a great escape once the pain and nausea subsided.

It was like he wasn't attached to his body anymore. Hisashi helped him to his feet and practically threw him back into his room. Izuku couldn't see those white eyes for the first time. He couldn't hear the screaming. He couldn't feel that fear. This drug numbed everything, even his Quirk. Izuku was in love with it, until he woke up the next morning.

The crash was a bitch, his lungs and chest screaming and aching like he just ran a marathon. He couldn't even move, every muscle burned and stung in agony. Every shift or twitch made him bite back a roar of pain. He was wrong. He was wrong, so so wrong.

That drug was torture. And they gave it to him again. Hisashi has snuck into his room and forced him to drink it again, and that same euphoric feeling calmed him for only an hour before he crashed again, only this time it was worse.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> the discord invite!
>
> - my random discord server coz I'm bored and want people to fight me about how I treat Izuku in this fic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

His weekend was a haze of highs and lows, literally. Either he was high off his ass thanks to this drug, or he was bedridden, on the verge of ending it all so he didn't have to feel anything anymore. His fingers itched for anything sharp while he came down off the high. Maybe cutting his own head off would be better than suffering through another dose of this shit. All weekend he was tense, waiting to hear his fathers footsteps. Waiting for that beautiful wave of euphoria but dreading that all too consuming wave of agony. He was eager to go back to school and avoid home as much as possible.

He was eager to see Kacchan again and forget about all of this as soon as he could. All he knew was that he didn't see those all-seeing white eyes anymore and he didn't hear that endless hair raising screaming. The fear of the dark was always there though, even if he didn't want it to be. No amount of drugs could put a stop to that. No matter how much he prayed for it and hoped.

Izuku woke up on Monday morning with sore muscles and a throbbing head. He managed against all odds to get up from his bed and grab his school uniform and put it on. His steps were near silent on the wooden stairs, as he made his quick ascent up them. The door opened easily and Izuku let out the tiniest of relieved sighs before making like a bat out of hell outta that house. Once the front door closed softly behind him he took a chance to breathe at ease for once.

The sky outside was still dark and gloomy, but he could see Kacchan waiting for him a little ways away. "Deku! Where the fuck were you all weekend?" Kacchan asked immediately. Izuku offered him a vague shrug in response. Did Kacchan really think he'd respond with words?

Izuku stared at Kacchan as he watched his expression change to one of annoyance. Izuku gave him a weak smile, and he must look like shit because Kacchan sighs softly and drops it for now. Their walk to school is unusual and quiet for once, and Kacchan let's Izuku lean against him when they finally get to class. Izuku doesn't remember much of class, or anything if he was being honest. He must've fallen asleep a couple of times, or maybe he zoned out completely. He vaguely remembered Kacchan dragging him to lunch and making him eat something, but he wasn't too sure.

He was concerned about it and how it must look to Kacchan, but he couldn't control any of this. He was lucky that Kacchan even cared, and had the compassion to help him out while he was out of commission like this. He didn't even remember that Kacchan was taking him to his house tonight until Auntie Mitsuki greeted him with a bright smile.

Things got less hazy from there, and the Bakugou's looked relieved. They asked him what he did over the weekend and he responded with finishing his art project, and that he completely forgot that Kacchan wanted to hang out.

"That's understandable," Auntie Mitsuki replied, "What did you make?"

Izuku quickly reached into his back pack and grabbed his sketchbook. Which drawing could he show them? A lot of them were drawn in charcoal, some of them were hastily drawn and smeared. Most of them weren't drawings of people either, they were of those creatures with the white eyes.

They were drawn horribly, and they carried a certain amount of terror with each drawing. The eyes were large, colorless holes, and their hands were long and needle like. Some had white smiles and some where ripping their skin off. There was the rare picture of Kacchan leaning against a wall, or an even rarer one where he was grinning.

When he wasn't drawing scary demons, he nearly drew Kacchan exclusively. As a kid, as an adult, as a teen, as a pro-hero. He stopped at one with the hero design he created not too long

ago. Kacchan was sporting a feral-like smile, his grenade shaped gauntlets weighing down his wrists and forearms. He stood with one arm up wiping the sweat off his brow, and the other swinging lazily in the wind. Behind him was a massive mess of concrete debris and the road was littered with explosion-like craters.

Izuku quickly displayed with detailed drawing to the family before him, and Mitsuki snatched it as soon as she saw it. Izuku's heart clenched in his chest, worried she'd flip through the pages and see the other drawings that weren't as perfect and unconcerning. Luckily she didn't, and she passed it to her husband who studied it in awe, who passed it to Kacchan. He looked like a tomato, embarrassed but also impressed at the same time, which made Izuku fuzzy and warm.

"Is this a new costume design for me?" Kacchan asked, "I think it's the best you've come up with so far,"

Izuku nodded enthusiastically. Kacchan grinned slightly at him and handed him the notebook back. "You're crazy good at drawing,"

Now it was Izuku's turn for his face to heat up. Kacchan smirked at him and they went into his room where one or two All Might posters adorned his walls. There was one poster of Eraserhead and Present Mic. The pair of them sat down on the bed and Kacchan gave him the set of notes his missed all day. Izuku was quick to copy them down and silently thank Kacchan profusely in his head. "Are you sick?"

Izuku looked away from Kacchan but he knew Kacchan would get it out of him eventually so he nodded curtly without looking in his direction. He laid down on the massive bed and angled his body away from the other boy. "If you were sick why did you come to school?"

Izuku shrugged, groaning lightly when Kacchan draped himself over Izuku's stomach. Kacchan was half on the bed, and half hanging off it trying to reach something. Izuku glared at him, confused yet slightly amused. Kacchan pushes himself back onto the bed once he got whatever he was trying to reach. A blank notebook and pen was thrown in his direction and Izuku sighed shortly through his nose to voice his annoyance.

Kacchan sat up completely, crossing his ankles over each other and stared at Izuku expectantly. Izuku cocker up an eyebrow. "I'm gonna ask you a question, Kay Shitnerd?"

Izuku flipped him off with a smile and nodded. “Answer honestly,”

He nodded, but had no intention of being honest depending on the question.
“It’s...well...um...”

Izuku gave him a concerned look as Kacchan attempted to form his sentence. “Do you have a Quirk?”

Izuku nearly laughed, Kacchan had been his friend his entire life, and he was asking Quirkless Izuku Midoriya if he had a Quirk. The answer was an easy lie. *No. Come on Kacchan you already knew that.*

Kacchan grinned slightly, “I know I know.”

Izuku crumpled up the paper and waited for the *real* question. It came quickly after Kacchan’s response to his sass. “Is...is Auntie Inko treating you good?”

What kind of question is that Kacchan??

“A valid question. What I guess I mean is, is she hurting you?” Kacchan asked warily, wringing his fingers together. Izuku tore at his lower lip with his teeth, his skin becoming slick with sweat.

Of course not. I’m going home that was rude.

Izuku stood quickly, leaving the notebook and pen behind. He swung open Kacchan’s bedroom door and was halfway to the front door when he heard Kacchan’s heavy footsteps. He hesitated for not a second but it was enough for Kacchan to catch him.

“Deku wait!” Kacchan pleaded. “I-I don’t think she’s actually — god I’m just worried — you look like shit, like you got hit by a train or something. You couldn’t even stay awake in class and you didn’t respond to any of my questions all day! You’ve got bruises everywhere and your hands are all fucked up and ripped open. There are scratches on your throat, how is that not concerning? How is that not a red flag, Izuku?”

Kacchan’s hand wrapped around Izuku's wrist and tugged. Izuku didn't turn to face him, wrenching his arm away from the blond's grip. He heard the other boy growl and glanced back. Kacchan's hands were carding through his unmanageable hair, and he looked like he just ate something sour, or something absolutely disgusting. His face was pale, but Izuku didn't stop. He tore at the inner lining of his mouth, feeling out the irregularites with his tongue as he made a quick departure.

"Izuku!" His heart ached for Kacchan, but he couldn't risk that secret becoming a known fact in the Bakugou houseold. Who knew what would happen if Inko and Hisashi found out? How long would it remain abuse, and not the newest homoicide in Musutafu, Japan? "Is it him?"

He made no indication that he heard Kacchan's outburst and took the quickest route home. He didn't hear any tell-tale signs of Kacchan following him, which was a major relief. He cut through unsavory alleyways to save time and to avoid Kacchan if he was trying to find him. This particular alleyway was littered with foul smelling trash and only one sleeping homeless person. The alleyway was dark due to the setting sun that set the sky on fire. The orange and red rays made everything seem a little more sinister, not that Izuku minded in the least.

Izuku's life was cut from the same cloth as horror movies were. His life was a living breathing nightmare with sharp claws and entrancing eyes. It seemed innocent on the surface, but if anyone managed to delve deep and break the surface apart they would see nothing but darkness. Darkness and *hell*.

He clenched his fists as he walked. How would he fix this new array of problems with Kacchan? How could he get him off his trail? He was so engrossed in that train of thought, and the thousands of answers that came with it when something dropped from the sky. Oh wait. It wasn't some*thing*, or some*one*. It was the Sludge Villain, it's dark green slime familiar and sickening as he was harshly reminded of the strangulation he suffered at the hands of this villain. "It took me long enough to find you again Izuku Midoriya, nice to see you. Maybe this time I'll kill you,"

Izuku backed away, heart slamming in his ribcage with vigor. His hands were slack at his sides, but his eyes were wild and reckless with anxiousness. He made the mistake of glancing behind him in search of escape. It was futile, and in that milisecond the villain lunged. Izuku didn't dodge in time, but somehow he was out of the way in an instant. Ice encased his wrist, and he hissed through his teeth. He glared at the black figure yanking him away, and ripped himself free. He was mildly grateful, but he didn't like the demons. Izuku was determined to keep them at a distance and pretend they didn't exist.

"Don't struggle, it makes everthing worse."

The Sludge Villain screamed, and Izuku attacked this time, his eyes scanning and scanning the liquid body before him. Where there any obvious weaknesses? His eyes locked onto that villains eyes and it clicked almost audibly in his mind. Of course the only solid part of him would be a weakness. That same feeling of ice crept over his skin again and Izuku begrudgingly did the only natural thing that he could think of. That demons hand caressed his own, and he gripped that hand tightly and pushed everything he had into it. His entire arm tensed and went ramrod straight.

Fire burst from his skin, it was sizzling and burning like a piece of meat. Or maybe he wasn't on fire, maybe his arm was being ripped off. That would make more sense, as he watched the demon distort, enlarge and then turn back to its original size. The Demon looked more defined than usual, and more human-like. Black flames glimmered in each of it's hands, and it grinned at him gleefully. Without being told, it launched itself at the Sludge Villain. The slime stood no chance as the otherworldly fire came into contact with it. It melted away and wisps of evaporated liquid wafted into the air. It smelled awful, even worse than this alleyway.

Some of the slime fell off like wet slabs of meat coming off a melting corpse. A morbid analogy, but true nonetheless as Izuku watched the Sludge Villain fall. While that Demon had the villain distracted, Izuku rummaged through his bag in search of something sharp. He was hoping to find a pencil or a pen, but he truly struck gold when he found a pair of very, very sharp scissors.

He grinned to himself, and that Demon giggled. "WHAT THE HELL IS THIS THING!?"

Izuku raised an eyebrow, before the Demon answered. Sounding concerningly more human than before. "...Demon...can...you see?"

He gaped at the Sludge Villain as he nodded frantically. "Greetings..." Came a guttural response that shook the very ground they stood on. Izuku felt every hair on his body rise in horror and astonishment. The Sludge Villain could see that monster? Maybe he'd been wrong. Maybe his Quirk was pratical in combat. It was a horrible but thrilling idea. So was it the energy he pushed into it that made it stronger?

No. No. No. This was very bad. This was a mistake, he needed to end this now before the sun set for the night. He needed to pretend this never happened. No one could know about his Quirk. His mother and father would be absolutely furious if they found out his Quirk had *uses*. He gripped the scissors tightly in his hands, his grip so tight that the scissors creaked and shook in his hand.

The lunge towards the Sludge Villains eyes was painfully easily. The scissors were sharp enough to cut through both eyes like water, but that might be because of the villains body being made of mainly sludge and slime. Deep green liquids sprayed everywhere, and it was safe to assume that it was blood. The sharp tang of iron hung in the air, and the Sludge Villain screamed and thrashed like a fatally injured deer.

Izuku grimaced as he stared at the dark green stained scissors. The Demon who assisted him was long gone, after Izuku had a quick survey of the surroundings. He'd dwell on that later, but now he needed to get away. Right now he needed to not be *here* when authorites arrived. He shouldered his backpack back on and hid the bloody scissors as he left the alleyway and entered another.

His blood was pounding in his ears, and his fingers were cold and shaking. He'd hurt someone for the first time, and he felt sick with fear and regret. Even though he was a villain, The Sludge Villain was still in fact, a person. A person Izuku hurt to defend and protect himself.

The alleyways got concerningly darker, but Izuku was getting closer and closer to home trying to discard any lingering thoughts of the villain. Izuku stopped at the front door and listened. The house was dark and it was silent. It was getting rapidly darker by the second outside, and Izuku licked his lips anxiously. His breath hitched slightly when a black cat swaggered by, and he could see a black figure approaching him. He couldn't tell if it was a demon or a person, and he wasn't going to stick around to find out.

He opened the door silently and locked it behind him. The carpeted floor silenced his footsteps, and he avoided a figure who was trying to reach out to him from the kitchen. It's arms were so long that went through him anyway when he tried to avoid it. His chest froze where the demon touched him, but he ignored it in favor of going into the bathroom.

His parents were nowhere to be seen and as alarming as that was, he took this moment to completely relax for the first time in a while. He tip toed into the bathroom, closing the door before he turned on the light just in case.

Izuku put his elbows on the sink and put his head in his hands. He took much needed deep breathes and forced his muscles to relax. Occassions where he could do this was so rare that he immersed himself in it. He rolled the dice and took a quick shower as fast as he could possibly manage. He got out feeling refreshed and put on the same clothes he'd been previously wearing. He'd change out of them soon enough.

He dressed himself and stared at the mirror once he was fully clothed. He studied the bruises on his skin, and the scratches he'd given himself during his mental breakdown. Kacchan was right, he did look like shit.

He was busy staring at his bruises, but he didn't fail to notice that the mirror shifted and moved. Behind him a black figure rose to it's full height, too tall to be anywhere near human. Izuku stared at it, as his hands in the mirror moved by themselves. He was ripping at his own skin, red beads of blood dripped into the sink and Izuku stared in horror as he realized that it wasn't blood. It was black. His skin fell into the sink with a wet slap, and half of his face was that of a demon with gleaming teeth.

Izuku choked back the urge to vomit right there, right this second. "*Ha ha...one of us...*"

"One of us..."

"...Demon"

The demonic half of his face was speaking, forming each word with some level of difficulty. Izuku backed away, tripping when he stumbled slightly. He touched his own skin frantically,

relieved that his skin was smooth and dry. The mirror was empty now, nothing stood in it or stared at Izuku. He stood with a shaking hands and wobbly legs. He swung open the door and turned the light off before he practically launched himself into the basement where more white eyes waited. What he wouldn't give for a dose of that insane drug Hisashi gave him the other day.

Izuku stumbled down the stairs, his breathing heavy and labored with adrenaline and horror. He changed out of his school uniform quickly and wore his hoodie and sweatpants and crawled into his bed. Out of habit he ran his hands over the covers and searched for his phone. Of course it wasn't there, he thought to himself, as he brushed against the cold screen.

He latched onto it immediately, and powered it up. The light was blinding, but a comfort he'd missed for too long. That hallucination still stood in the back of his mind, itching at him and terrifying him. He should be used to it now, the crazy visions the demons gave him when he was alone and vulnerable. Izuku crept out of bed, his light source clutched defiantly in one hand as he searched through his small dark room. He found his discarded backpack easier than he expected and ripped it open. His hands begged to do something, wether it was draw or analyze his own Quirk he couldn’t decide.

So he grabbed his ratty notebooks, one gray and one black. Written in shaky Japanese was his Quirk Analysis book, no not the one he used on a regular basis for his peers Quirks but the one specifically for his own. The gray notebook was his sketch journal that was nearly full cover to cover with gory, dark drawings that could put him in a mental institution if they knew he saw these things on a regular basis.

Figures with white eyes, and no pupils were his specialty of sorts. Almost every single page was a different unique looking monster. Some had long claws that dragged across the page, too long to draw. He flipped through loads of drawings, some drawn in perfect detail but unfinished. Some half drawn, shakily and hastily. Some were drawings from his memories, like the first night he had his Quirk and stayed in that dark basement. A long demon hovered over his bed, nearly nose to nose with him looking like a massive spider.

Another page was completely black. In fact, sometimes that’s all he could draw for days, and it showed. He flipped through more pages that were just black. Sometimes when he went through his sketchbook he noticed a few drawings he couldn’t remember drawing. This was one of these times, as he came across a series of drawings that acted as a flip book. At first it was all black, but as he flipped through faster and faster a black figure grew bigger and bigger in the darkness only discernible by a thin white outline detailing the claws, torso, and head. White eyes stared at him, and as he continued to leaf through this mini flip book it drew

closer and closer. Until it stopped, and there was where words written in white. Words he'd heard so many times and just learned to accept. God doesn't shine upon you.

Izuku stares at it for a while, trying to recall a time when he'd drawn something like this and couldn't pin point a time. Izuku just turned to a fresh page and began to draw anything that came to mind. He sat on the cool ground and propped his phone up as it projected light from its flashlight setting and watched as his hands almost moved on their own and drew. It started as a black dot, chalky residue rubbing off onto his hands. The piece of charcoal in his hand wasn't thin like a pencil, and it worked wonders for the kinds of things he drew. He left white slits for eyes and his hand began to move faster and faster. The body came into being, and the mouth was wide open, gleaming white and too big to be natural. It's claws were at its head, clawing away at its skin, not that anyone who didn't have his Quirk would be able to tell if he showed them.

He took a long look at it, hating the drawing almost immediately. Izuku hated all of his drawings except the ones he drew of Kacchan. Izuku slammed his book shut and glanced over at his other notebook. He opened it and stared at the first page.

Quirk Analysis: Izuku Midoriya

Age: ~~6 7 9 10 12~~ 14

Gender: Male

Parents: Inko Midoriya and Hisashi Midoriya.

Inko: Attraction Quirk, small objects. Toys, salt and pepper shakers, chess pieces, pencils, and knives.

Hisashi: ~~Gone.~~

Izuku scratched out Hisashi's status and added his Quirk.

Hisashi: ~~Gone.~~ Five finger contact activation. Half pain and half panic. His left hand activates pain, and the right activated panic. Used as a means of torture. Plausible villain. Why did he come back?

Izuku: Developed Quirk at four, can see ~~monsters.~~ Demons. The monsters can interact with the real word on a small scale. Scratching chalkboards. ~~(No one can hear it but me).~~ They can open doors, close doors, turn on lights. They can scream loudly. If I put my energy into them other people can see them, and they can attack. Avoid doing that. Quirk Suppressors can help get rid of them. Demons can make vivid hallucinations. Quirk has no applicable uses in hero or rescue work. ~~Villains Quirk~~. Better to use Quirk Suppressants and get rid of it all together. ~~Quirkless. Quirkless. Quirkless.~~

Relation to Parents Quirks: None. No similarities like most people. Not a combination. Completely new and different from Inko and Hisashi's Quirk. Mutation.

Izuku looked over the notes and raised his eyebrows. He really didn't know much about his Quirk, huh? Something told him it was probably better that way.

Chapter End Notes

Join my discord to yell at me :D

the discord invite!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Here take these, they'll make you feel better." He didn't believe Hisashi's words, but he downed the pills anyway that afternoon after having a hell of a time getting Kacchan to leave him alone. For once his father let him leave the house for the night, but not without a slur being thrown his way. The door clicked softly behind him as he headed straight for the nearest store. Yesterday he'd finally used up the last few pages of his sketchbook, and he couldn't go without a new one if he wanted to remain sane.

Izuku knew the way to the store by heart because he used to pick up things for his mother as a kid. The path there was desolate of people, and Izuku preferred it that way until he spotted something *not* human. He felt a flicker of fear at first, but it quickly became overshadowed by annoyance because he just wanted to be left alone. They were always lurking and jeering, and Izuku detested it.

He picked up his pace, turning the corner to the small convenience store just on the next corner. But it turned out that power walking was too much for him at the moment, or maybe the meds were finally kicking in. That dark figure flickered in and out of existence before becoming just a grey screen of smoke. Izuku's world tilted on its axis, but he fought down the onslaught of nausea. He really needed a new sketchbook.

Izuku couldn't live without it, it was like every time he thought about not having one he felt like he was dunked in a bucket of ice. He'd fight the sickness in his stomach and head to a nearby park as soon as possible once he bought his new notebook.

He entered the small store and was quick to retrieve what he needed. The cashier was a nice old lady who never stopped droning on and on about her son who was a friendly neighborhood hero. Izuku indulged her by nodding at the right spots in the conversation and smiling when she bid him a good day.

Izuku was leaving the store when a man with black hair pulled into bun walked in. His hair was frizzy and looked pretty unmanageable, but Izuku wasn't one to judge. He was wearing a scarf and tracksuit, looking extremely at ease and relaxed. Izuku envied him as the man whistled as he walked, a paw sticking out of his scarf. Izuku raised an eyebrow before

something soft was launched at him. He was lucky his reaction time was sharper than a blade, as he caught this random-ass cat mid-flight. It was all black and had a smushed face.

At first, his mind went blank, panicking for a few seconds before the cat meowed at him. His shoulders relaxed, and the man who supposedly had a cat in his scarf glared at the black mass in Izuku's hands. "Get down dumbass, you're being rude."

Izuku smiled weakly, expecting the cat to jump off of him but that didn't happen. It burrowed itself into Izuku's chest and purred. "Alright ignore me then,"

The man disappeared deeper into the store, and Izuku looked at the cat, confused. The cat just rested in his hands and purred even more, and it was relaxing. Izuku smiled slightly and barely took notice of the blurry vision that was creeping in on him. It stayed in the edges of his vision, so he didn't worry about it too much.

Izuku just really hoped that the black-haired man would come back for his cat eventually. His arms were beginning to tire, and that's when he reappeared carrying a single bag with what looked like instant coffee. "Quit bothering the kid, Eclipse. It's time to go home."

The cat meowed at Izuku before hopping out of his arms and onto the floor easily. "Sorry about that, you're not allergic to cats, are you?"

Izuku shook his head vehemently. "That's good. Sorry again, he kinda does what he wants. See ya around I guess," And he took his leave.

He was left staring after him, clutching his own bag with his notebook in it. Then he left too, heading in the opposite direction of that man, craving that warmth that the cat provided. Izuku had always wanted a pet, but for obvious reasons never brought it up to Inko. He cut through the street, approaching the park across the street so he could sit for a while and draw.

The sun was more than halfway through the sky, casting warm light across the park where kids screamed and played. He took a seat on a vacant bench and brought out his new sketchbook. He'd bought a few pens and pencils but he had a feeling he wouldn't be using

them. He had snuck a few pieces of charcoal into his pockets and drew them out of his pockets, his hands already itching to draw and create.

For a long time, the only sound was the scratching of the charcoal against his sketchbook as his thoughts ran wild. Kacchan had been very apologetic today, but he also seemed pretty distracted.

Yuuei's entrance exam would happen as soon as summer vacation began, and summer was coming quicker than either of them had thought. Izuku hated summer in all honesty because he spent much of it locked down in his room and wishing he was somewhere, anywhere else. It was spent cold with fear and horror.

He was secretly hoping summer would end as soon as possible, and it hasn't even begun. Then again, he was chomping at the bit for the Yuuei entrance exam as well because he wanted to go with Kacchan. It didn't matter if he was in General Studies as long as they were together.

On top of being with Kacchan, Yuuei also offered all year-round dorms for everyone attending the school. That was definitely a selling point for him. He'd sell an arm and a leg to get out of that house for more than a few hours a day. He took his time drawing anything that came to mind, for a while it was a half-finished drawing of the other night in the bathroom. Half of his face was full black save for the white eyes and white teeth. He left it unfinished so he could start drawing a patch of flowers sitting in front of him. Luckily flowers still satisfied his need to draw, as he meticulously sketched out each petal and stem. It was kind of relaxing to draw something tangible and alive that wasn't Kacchan.

It was nearly therapeutic, the motion of blowing away excess charcoal and creating curling lines. The picture came together pretty well, and Izuku was happy about it. Maybe he should pick up painting because he felt like that would be pretty fun and different from his usual stuff.

For a while he debated it, basking in the sunlight that he rarely had time to appreciate. Most of his time was spent in darkness in terror. Maybe he should give himself a splash of color and excitement, but he didn't have money, nor the balls to ask for some from his mother or father. Izuku closed his sketchbook quietly and closed his eyes.

He couldn’t ask for anything from his parents. It was hard enough to ask to go outside. His life was so controlled and contained.

The sudden realization of his dire situation was like being hit by a train. Normal kids could ask for nearly anything without feeling icy fear in the pit of their stomachs. They could live their daily lives feeling a sense of safety, but Izuku didn’t know what that really felt like. In the absence of love and safety only fear and hopelessness were allowed to fester. Izuku wasn’t stupid, he knew what was happening and he knew on a subconscious level that it was wrong. But he accepted it as his way of life and that was the damning fact that kept him in this situation. He was too accustomed to this environment to want a change and to realize that he needed a different space and different people.

He was too scared to hope for it. Too scared and unsure to work for it. Izuku licked at his lips, and let out a voiceless sigh. “Sleeping are we?”

Izuku’s eyes were opened immediately, scanning his surroundings. His eyes locked with a pair of blue ones the bore into his very soul. Izuku stares with his mouth slightly parted, and a skeleton of a man gave him a gentle smile. He tilted his head to the side, waiting for the man to continue. “Did I frighten you? I’m sorry about that my boy,”

Izuku shook his head quickly and the man seemed to relax slightly. “So do you like drawing? There are smudges all over your hands.”

He pretended to ponder his answer for a moment, only so he could study this strange man more. He was concerningly thin and gaunt. Maybe he was anorexic?

Izuku shoved the thought away almost instantly. That was rude, and even if the man was he shouldn’t think it, so he answered the man's question by nodding with a grin. His fingers sat in his lap and he wrung them anxiously at the same time. The man seemed to stare at his hands a lot, and it was making Izuku increasingly nervous. The man seemed to realize he was staring at Izuku intently and began to apologize feverishly.

“I’m making you nervous, aren’t I? I shouldn’t have disturbed you young man, but it is weird to see a teenager out on this side of town alone and casually napping nonetheless.”

Izuku shrugged, always at a loss for words. Out of the corner of his eye, he spotted a demon skipping through the park like a little girl. He ignored it even as it stopped to stare at him. So the medicine had already gone through his system? Maybe he should take more. He was so focused on how long he'd been out today that he didn't hear anything this man had been saying. "-Toshinori. What's your name?"

Izuku grimaced and stood abruptly. He was so awkward and socially incapable of regular conversation. With his face turning rapidly redder by the second, Izuku gathered his things with a small bow in the strangers way. "A-are you ok?"

He nodded again and again, embarrassment flooding through him. If this guy asked him another question he couldn't answer he was going to die. "I really am sorry for bothering you,"

Izuku waves his hands placatingly as if to say it wasn't his fault and retreated with his art supplies. The man — Izuku is going to take an educated guess and say his name is Toshinori — chuckles awkwardly. "Have a good night kiddo,"

Izuku was gone quickly and silently. Toshinori watched him go, and he pondered where he should go. He should really head to the house — not his home. It wasn't home to him and it was becoming increasingly clear as Hisashi pumped him full of drugs and hate.

He hated being there. Every step forward into that house was mudslide backward in any progress toward a normal life. There had been many times where he rejected Auntie Mitsuki's offers to help him learn sign because of anxiety and worry that came with that house and the people in it. Some days he almost said yes, and instantly shoved it away.

He should learn. He *needs* to learn if he wants to interact easier with other people. But would he need to? In all honesty, he'd been waiting his whole life for it to end. Whether it be silently, the way he came into the world, or loud, angry, violent and hurting. More recently he'd been thinking it would probably be the violent way.

The world was never fair, and he should stop hoping for it. His feet carried him halfway home and he stopped very suddenly and stared at Dagobah beach, the only beach of Mufatsu. It was littered with trash and rarely frequented by any locals or tourists at all. A man weaved

through the trash with practiced ease, and Izuku found himself wondering why anyone would be doing that. Unless they were homeless and searching for salvageable furniture and stuff.

That man didn't seem to be homeless though, and it became pretty clear pretty quickly as the man approached him. He felt his heart clench in his chest like someone was twisting it in his chest. He glared menacingly at the man, who didn't seem to care that he was getting stared down by a teenager. As he got closer Izuku noticed his strange attire. He connected the dots surprisingly fast, and he frowned at the villain standing before him.

There was a white bandana with holes for his eyes covering the top half of his face. A long red scarf darker than blood adorned his neck, draping down to his ankles stopping just before the strands touched the ground. Izuku wasn't worried about that. That wasn't the part that scared him. It was the countless weapons visible around his torso and strapped to his back. Most noticeable were the three katana's visible just over his shoulder.

They were stained a rusty red color that didn't bode well with Izuku at all. This man was a villain, and Izuku couldn't even manage to breathe. He was frozen in fear, and as this man walked toward him he didn't even back away like a normal human being would've. "You're Izuku Midoriya correct?"

Izuku nodded shortly and stared at him. "You don't look scared, and I can't decide if you're an inspiration or a fool," Izuku furrowed his brow. "Are you mute?"

He nodded again and crossed his arms. "I thought so. My name is Chizome, but I'm known better as Stain the Hero Killer,"

Stain leaned down slightly to look at Izuku in the eyes before he began to speak again. Izuku was confused as hell, wondering why he hadn't been chopped to pieces yet. Stain wasn't well known yet, but Izuku was obsessive about the Pro-Hero world. He knew who Stain was, and what he'd been doing. He found himself in a staring match with a Hero Killer.

"You have a very *dangerous* Quirk, don't you?" Stain grins. "One your mother refuses to acknowledge, and one that can make you the most powerful villain in the world if you let it. You think it's horrible, and you want to suppress it, but you are wrong. Pretending it doesn't exist makes it harder to control and causes more problems than solutions. Your mother and

father will abuse you no matter what you do. I saw you attack that Sludge Villain when you were twelve. I've been watching you ever since, and I've decided that you're worthy."

"Why am I approaching you now, after all this time? The Yuuei entrance exam is soon. Your Quirk could easily make you the perfect villain, but it could also make you a hero. Your Quirk isn't what makes you a hero or a villain, it's what *you* do with it that separates one from the other."

"I want to help you become a hero if that's what you want. You remind me a lot of myself in my younger years, but no one approached me to offer me salvation when I fell into the darkness of the villain leagues and vigilantism. I'm offering you a raft in the ocean that will surely drown you Midoriya, if you don't get on. I know how this road ends. It's a dark lonely road, boy and I can help you avoid that at all costs. What do you say?"

"Will you become my apprentice and survive, or will you suffer long enough that you see yourself become a villain?" Stains words struck him deep somewhere. He didn't even realize that the wetness on his cheeks was his own tears until Stain pressed something into his palm and turned to leave. He took a shuddering breath as Stain veered into the nearest alleyway and vanished like smoke.

Izuku was left on that abandoned road next to a shit ton of trash crying his eyes out. He unfolded the piece of paper Stain handed him and smiled slightly at the words written on it in hasty handwriting, his chest heavy. *Dagobah Beach tomorrow afternoon.*

He tucked away the note into his pocket, sniffling and wiping away the wetness off his cheeks. No one had ever said something quiet like that to him in his lifetime. It was constantly being beaten down and emotionally destroyed by both of his parents. The only praise he got was from Kacchan and Auntie Mitsuki whenever he managed to hang out with them.

It was a foreign experience and he didn't really know how to feel about it. As he finally began to walk again he couldn't stop thinking about how much Stain knew about him already. How did he find out about his mother and father's less than kind treatment of him? Stain had been watching him since he was twelve, so maybe he'd gotten the hint over the years? Or maybe he snuck into the house?

An even more terrifying thought struck him. Did Stain have solid evidence to support it? Would he show it to the authorities if he refused to be his apprentice and get him put in foster care? That would be the worst possible outcome he quickly concluded, trying to stop his shaking hands. Izuku no longer had a choice, he had to go and he had to make sure Stain didn't have any ulterior motives.

It was more difficult than Izuku thought it would be to get Kacchan to go home and leave him alone for the day. The school year was coming to a close quickly, and the high school entrance exams would take place before then.

He had three months to train with Stain before the entrance exam *if* he took the man up on his crazed offer. It was a long shot, and Izuku was almost certain he was going to refuse. The sun was blossoming in beautiful oranges and reds, casting the world in a golden glow. The walk was quick, but the demons seemed to be more curious today. Practically a mob of them walked with him, craning their necks to spot the villain named Stain.

He reached Dagobah beach without incident and scanned the piles of trash to find him. At first, he felt extremely stupid as he searched, feeling like Stain had done this all as a prank to make him feel like shit. Then he saw it. A tall, terrifying figure crouching on the tallest pile of trash. The sun cast a golden glow around Stain as he stood to his full height looking like a stone gargoyle coming to life on a castle roof.

"You're here earlier than I thought you would be, did you come here straight away?"

Izuku nodded with wide eyes as Stain leaned over the pile of trash and stared down at him. Izuku strained his neck trying to look at his face, and Stain grinned at him slightly. A lot of his weapons were gone today, he noticed. He almost yelped when Stain landed near-silently next to him and asked. "Well? Have you made a decision?"

Had he? Could he trust a criminal to train him? No, he wasn't a criminal, he was a *serial killer*. Those two words sent ice skittering down his spine and caused goosebumps to blossom on his arms and neck. Stain seemed to be genuinely curious to hear his answer, and he wasn't reaching for the only katana he'd brought today.

"You can tell me no if you want, I won't kill you," Stain told him, with a quick glance around the beach. "What'll it be Midoriya?"

Strangely enough, Izuku didn't feel as threatened as he thought he would. Yes, he was absolutely shaking and terrified, but he wasn't hyperventilating and running like he though he would.

Stain held out a single hand, covered in nasty scars. Izuku's mind was hopping back and forth between answers, weighing the pros and cons.

He could list many, many cons. One, Stain could easily kill him at any point. Two, he could prove to be useless and weak, and Stain would give up. Three, this was all a ploy to get a chance to kill him. Four, he'd be forced to be a villain. Five, he'd get hurt.

The number of pros was scarce. He could become strong and eventually become a hero. He could learn to defend himself even if Stain deemed him unworthy at the end of the line. That was probably the end of the pros and yet, he felt the pros no matter how few there were outweighed the cons. His hand was shaking Stain's hand before he even realized it.

"Good, we start now,"

And that's how Izuku landed on his back in less than two seconds, being thrown like a ragdoll over Stain's shoulder in a judo flip. All the air seemed to leave his lungs, and he wheezed, trying to remember how to breathe. "First lesson, always be ready for battle, no matter what."

Izuku took a deep breath before scrambling on the sand to stand. "Right now you lack muscles to do any real damage, but I have a plan for you. Do you see this beach all around us? Do you see all this trash thrown here by landfills and locals? You'll spend your time here every day clearing away trash until there's not even a spec of trash left. Don't worry about your parents being a problem."

He watched him as he explained, Stain started toward the ocean with a sinister smile. "Your father is a busy man, but he's been on vacation for too long. His employer will be happy to

put him *and* your mother to work."

The way he said it was ominous and had an undercurrent of fear. Izuku licked at his lips nervously. Who did his father work for exactly? From the way Stain said employer made it seem like the man wasn't a good person. Not in the slightest.

Izuku had enough sense to avoid that topic, as Stain went on to explain how his entire schedule would change now that he was going to be training him. "—Of course you'll be going to middle school until the summer begins, so that really only gives us the afternoon. That works just fine as long as we make the most of it, you'll be pushing you limits physically as well as mentally Midoriya. Are you sure you want to do this? You could just inject yourself with Quirk Suppressors all of your life and live as a Quirkless teen if you wanted—"

Izuku shook his head vigorously. "No? I knew I liked you for a reason, Midoriya. You're going to be a true hero worthy of the title, with that drive and determination of yours. I'm going to enjoy training you. Let's start,"

Chapter End Notes

[the discord invite!]

- my random discord server coz I’m bored and want people to fight me about how I treat Izuku in this fic.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

the discord invite!

Join my discord server!!!!

Katsuki was downright suspicious. Worried, anxious and suspicious. Deku — no Izuku — was avoiding him ever since he mentioned something about the bruises and suspected abuse. Izuku had gotten quieter, and he didn't mean that literally. Usually, Katsuki could read him like an open book so he would always know what Izuku was saying. Now it was like he was in a dark room with no light. Everything was blank and empty. Every smile was dark, cracking and hurt. Izuku never needed words to communicate with Katsuki, but now it was like Katsuki was learning a different language and he had no idea how to decipher any of it into a meaning he understood.

It was like getting sucker-punched in the gut when Izuku jumped when Kacchan grabbed his shoulder. Izuku never used to do that, but now it was a constant. Like he was preparing to get jumped at any point or something. It left Katsuki simmering with rage, and it made Izuku act even more anxious. But the rage wasn't toward him, not in the least. It was all directed towards his shitty ass parents who thought it was funny to abuse a Quirkless teen who was smarter than Katsuki could ever hope to be. He was an angel who didn't deserve to be hurt the way Auntie Inko and Hisashi were hurting him.

Katsuki had come to firmly believe that Auntie Inko and Hisashi were hurting him. He'd even gone to school high off his ass — at least he hoped Izuku was high. He couldn't exactly be sure, but Izuku was passed out the majority of that day. His pupils were massive and he walked like he was drunk. Katsuki knew it was some kind of coping mechanism he'd come up with for all the shit going down at home.

Deku was constantly covered in bruises like violets blossoming on his pale skin, and his eyes always looked haunted and wild. Katsuki wanted to help him. He wanted to save him, and make him so much happier than he was now. Katsuki wouldn't admit it, but he wanted to be Izuku's knight in shining armor. Even angels needed saving, and god willing Katsuki would do exactly that. Deku used to be so bright and happy, but he was dulling. He was deteriorating right before Katsuki's eyes.

Katsuki was staring blankly at the clock, kicking at his desk waiting for their lunch break. Izuku had only spared him a couple of glances as their classes wore on, and Katsuki was itching to have a chance to talk to him one on one when they went to lunch. He had another ten minutes of listening to their stupid homeroom teacher talk about potential high schools they could be attending.

Then there was a whole tiny speech their teacher did too. "—What am I saying? All of you want to go into the hero courses!"

The class erupted in screaming cheers, and Katsuki snorted. "Yeah like any hero school's gonna want all of you assholes. I'm going to Yuuei."

A boy grinned playfully at him, "Your so full of yourself Bakugou,"

"Midoriya didn't you want to go to Yuuei too?" Their teacher asked, getting sniggers and laughs in response. Their teacher pretended not to notice the discriminating behavior of their classmates but Katsuki didn't let it slide.

"Hah! Midoriya? Isn't he like Quirkless or something?"

Katsuki saw Deku scribbling away on his sketchbook. He glanced up momentarily, and it sent rage down Katsuki's spine. Deku was just minding his business, and he was going to *ignore* all the hateful comments spewed his way.

"Yeah! I don't know why Bakugou is friends with him, honestly,"

Katsuki wasn’t afraid to be Deku’s voice.

“He doesn’t even talk, he's kind of creepy,”

“IT AIN’T NONE OF YOUR BUSINESS IF HE GOES TO YUUEI OR IF HE’S QUIRKLESS! HE’LL FUCKIN MAKE IT IN UNLIKE YOU EXTRAS!”

Katsuki scowled and crossed his arms defiantly as the classroom went dead silent. “Any of you make another fucking comment about him, and I’ll—“

But he was practically yanked off his feet by the person he was defending. Deku gave him a blinding smile just as the release bell for lunch rang. Everyone around them practically ran out the classroom door murmuring it up to each other.

Katsuki huffed out of his nose, still steaming. Deku dragged him to the lunchroom, grinning the whole way. Katsuki and Deku got in line together, Katsuki filling the silence by exchanging phones with Deku. They both found different articles on heroes and they switched off.

Deku seemed extra lively today, but Katsuki was sure it was just to cheer him up after he had to yell at their classmates. It was definitely working, he realized as he found himself smiling right back at him. Katsuki grabbed both of them some food as Deku let him look at some of his more recent drawings. They were always quickly drawn and somewhat shaky — they were still fucking amazing — but this one was all calm lines and meticulously drawn. A simple patch of flowers and another one was a black cat, sitting delicately with one paw swatting at a cat toy that dangled above it.

He showed his final drawing as they sat down, of a beach with a sunset. Katsuki loved all of Deku’s art and sketches. “You should try painting too,” Katsuki told him, “Or maybe digital art,”

Deku nodded eagerly like he’d been thinking about trying it out for a while. Katsuki was sure he’d be fucking amazing at it, no matter what he decided to do. He’d even make an extraordinary hero, even without a Quirk.

Katsuki secretly hoped that Deku got a Quirk, but knew about the percentage of that happening. It was a fool's hope, but his hope nonetheless.

He wanted Deku to become a hero with him. They'd be a dynamic duo, and duos always received a good fan base. They were rare, and they scarcely stayed a duo for long. But Katsuki was determined to stay with Deku no matter what. Deku was Katsuki's only friend and his best friend. They'd been friends since they were kids, and Katsuki didn't stop being his friend just because he stopped talking and never developed his Quirk. He really hoped Deku managed to get into Yuuei with him.

Deku was amazingly bright and intelligent, and if either of them got in it would probably be Deku. He could even get in by submitting a portfolio to Yuuei before they took the entrance exam together. He could easily attract a good amount of attention from a lot of teachers like that, and if he got a good score on the exam his acceptance would be guaranteed.

He decided to tell Deku this, and Deku looked at him like it was the best idea he'd ever had in his life. "You could submit some of your art to Yuuei before the exam. They'd give you a scholarship,"

Deku's chopsticks hung loosely and lazily from his fingers, and after staring straight at Katsuki he got out his sketchbook. Katsuki could practically see the gears turning in the other boy's head, and decided it'd be better if he left him alone for a while.

He ate in comfortable silence with Deku, and the only sounds were their classmates screaming at each other from across the room. He finished his food quickly, and quietly asked Deku if he was done too, and grabbed his plate from him.

A little while later the bell rang to send them to their next class, which was History of Quirks. It was the most boring, and long-winded class in Katsuki's opinion. Of course, knowing Deku, the other boy loved it. Katsuki sat down at one of the rickety desks in front of Deku, and stared at the clock, already begging for this class to be over before it began.

They were reviewing everything right now because they only had a few months before they took entrance exams for high school. The teacher who taught this class was older than dirt,

with white wispy hair. "Alright everyone, as all of you know the year is drawing to an end. Seeing as all of you are moving on to high school it is my duty to ensure that you pass your final. As a result, we'll start reviewing right away." The old man looked at all of them with a wrinkling smile.

"All of you should be familiar with the dawn of the Quirk Age, but we're reviewing it anyway."

Katsuki heard a few groans, and he was positive he heard Deku scribbling away on his sketchbook. "Quirks officially came into the spotlight and began to sprout up during 2050. Contrary to your history textbooks, new information on the beginning of Quirks has surfaced. They are thought to have begun in medieval times a little after 476 AD. During this time, Kings, Queens and the like were very prominent in Europe, but stories and mythical creatures were also. Witches, wizards, werewolves, vampires and abominable monsters are all thought to be Quirks before they were Quirks. This time is the true beginning of Quirks, but they weren't called as such. Quirks came back into the spotlight during 2050,"

"At this time, two strong figures rose to power. Their Quirks are still very unknown, and anything about these two individuals was erased or forgotten. What we never forgot was that they existed, and they started the boom of Quirks. These two were enemies and the first documentation of a hero vs. villain situation in our era. The two fought a lot, and during a particularly nasty fight was when the world turned against the idea of Quirks. The casualties were at an all record high thanks to the devastating destruction caused by this fight. Quirk protests sparked all around Japan during this time, but the world was changing and people soon began to realize that. Boycotts began everywhere in Japan, and segregation was becoming a very real problem,"

"After many rally's and court cases to allow people with Quirks the same rights as everyone else, peace was achieved between the two different peoples. Skip toward a few years, and Quirkless people were becoming outnumbered, and led to our time now, where Quirkless people are a very rare occurrence." Katsuki saw how the teacher stopped to glance in Izuku's direction, and he felt himself begin to heat up. That *bastard*.

He was about to stand up and rock this old guy's shit when he felt something tug at his shirt. He glanced behind him to find Deku scowling at the teacher and holding onto Katsuki's shirt to keep him from doing something stupid.

Katsuki sighed loudly. "And now it seems as if the tables have turned against the Quirkless, and they are the ones being discriminated against. Anyone unlucky enough to be diagnosed Quirkless — which is determined by your number of toe joints one has — has been bullied relentlessly in recent history. Contrary to public opinion, I believe that Quirkless people shouldn't be bullied or discriminated against. That makes us no better than our ancestors, and Quirkless people are just a lot more vulnerable than people with Quirks. We should be protecting them, not hurting them or bullying them for no reason. If I catch any of you doing that, you *will* be sent to the principles office, am I clear?"

Okay, Katsuki liked this teacher. He glanced behind him and saw Deku gaping at their history teacher.

Chizome watched his new pupil constantly. He followed him to school and waited for him to get out of school and then continued to follow him. It wasn't because he'd taken a liking to him, no it was because his villain alias Stain had a lot of nasty enemies. He didn't want his student out of commission before he even had a chance to see what he was made of.

He was pretty — no one hundred percent — sure that Midoriya was made of some tough shit. He saw it in those dark eyes, dark, wild and strong. Saw it in the way he worked when they trained, he didn't slack or stop when he was exhausted. He saw that fire igniting in that boy's heart after it had been stomped out so long ago, merely a wisp of smoke when Chizome approached him. It was only a flicker right now, but Chizome knew that fire would set everything alight.

Right now Midoriya was dark and depressing, but Chizome would kindle that flame and make him a hero. Midoriya would be that ray of sunshine he used to be when he was eleven, Chizome would make sure of that.

Chizome pulled a cigarette from his pocket and lit it with his All Might themed lighter, waiting by Midoriya's house for him to get here. It wouldn't take long, he got here around the same time every day, after trying to get his friend to leave him alone. He could see him right now, in fact. He could never miss that green hair. Midoriya hurried over to him, looking tired and freshly bruised. Chizome nearly scowled, his parents were supposed to be working and leaving him *alone*.

Guess it had the opposite effect. "C'mon Midoriya, we've got work to do,"

He turned without waiting to see if his apprentice was following and headed straight for Dagobah beach. Once there Midoriya would spend an hour or two just hauling trash, and then Stain would train him how to fight and wield a weapon. As they reached the beach Midoriya spotted Stain's truck already there. Stain quickly scaled a tall pile of trash and perched over it. He watched as the boy got to work, hauling a TV bigger than him to his truck. After they finished training today he'd drop off all the trash to a trash depot.

He spent the next hour rummaging through Midoriya's bag, bored. He came across the sketchbook and flipped through the pages. This particular one was completely full and he spent a whole twenty minutes admiring all the demonic drawings and rare drawings of his friend and random scenery. After he satisfied himself by snooping through his art, Stain came across the Quirk Analysis book. He read it cover to cover, amazed by how detailed and accurate the journal seemed to be about all the Quirks listed.

Stain watched as Midoriya cleared away more and more piles of trash. He was making quite the dent in all this trash, and maybe it was possible to get all of it cleared away before the entrance exam. It'd been a month since he started training him, and he could already see a difference in the boy's muscle mass.

He watched for another hour or so before he jumped off the pile he'd been sitting on. Midoriya stopped immediately and watched blankly as Stain approached. Stain drew a katana from its sheath and turned the blade towards himself, the handle pointed in Midoriya's direction. Midoriya took the blade easily and shifted into a fighting stance that Stain ingrained in his head during the first week.

Stain was an impatient person and struck first fast and strong. The sound of metal scraping against metal rang in his ears as Midoriya parried easily. Quickly the fight commenced, faster than Stains eyes could follow. He let instinct take the wheel as sparks flew between the two swords that kept meeting. Each blow was met with a counterattack, and Stain was proud to say that Midoriya had been doing well in his training.

He had started out with close-combat training, drilling offensive moves and defensive moves into Midoriya for the entire first month. He was building muscle and becoming stronger now, so they'd moved onto training with weapons. He was *really* good with a sword, and Stain could see Midoriya surpassing him soon enough.

Between blows, when Stain and Midoriya jumped apart he decided to ask his apprentice something. "Why do you want to be a hero?" He knew if he wanted an answer he'd have to give Midoriya a minute to grab a pen and paper. He lowered his weapon and allowed his pupil to grab both and jot down an answer.

So I can have meaning.

Honestly, it was a depressing answer that hit Stain right in the heart. He knew how it felt to have no meaning in life, he'd once been in the same situation as Midoriya found himself in. Except Stain never found a mentor to help him and point him in the right direction. As a result, he came to hate heroes and even ended up killing them and making a name for himself as the Hero Killer.

Midoriya was lucky Stain took an interest in him and decided to teach him how to save himself. Stain was lucky too. He was doing something good by helping someone as lost and as hurt as Midoriya.

Their swords clashed together, and Stain's pocket buzzed. He ignored it for now but knew he should probably answer it. Midoriya gave him a raised eyebrow and a slight grin. "It's just a message. Keep going,"

The scream of the weapons scraping against each other nearly drowned out his ringtone. His phone buzzed loudly, and he sighed in annoyance. "Hold on, go practice your form really fast." he grabbed his phone out of his pocket and answered it.

"What do you want, I'm in the middle of something,"

"Oh, nothing in particular," A deep grainy voice answered. "I just have a job I need someone to get done for me tonight. Everyone I've assigned this task to is...reluctant,"

"What did you have in mind?" Stain asked, watching Midoriya as he went through different kinds of forms with the sword like he was a samurai or something. "You should be holding

the sword with one hand, not two,"

Midoriya glared at him, and Stain nearly snorted. "Who're you talking to Stain? Do you have an apprentice now?"

"No, I don't," Stain snapped quickly, "What's the job you have for me?"

"I need someone to transport weapons to the League of Villains,"

"Your little project with that crazy kid with a bunch of hands on his face? No wonder no one wanted to do it." Stain picked at his gnarly nails.

"Yes...I'm well aware of how immature Shigaraki can be, but I do need someone to transport these weapons for me. Seeing as my headquarters of operation is far from the League. You could even take that apprentice you *don't have* with you. I have a new sword that might fit him well if you introduce me to him."

"I don't think he'd like that—"

"Bring him, Stain. You know our deal if you don't do what I say then—"

"Fine...but you can't keep him,"

"I wouldn't dream of taking him from you," The man rasped, "The last one was sufficient enough even though he didn't last too long,"

Stain sighed, as the call ended.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

IN SPIRIT OF HALLOWEEN HERE YALL GO

Izuku was having a rough week. He had a little less than two months to get strong enough to make it in to Yuuei's hero course, and Stain was training him harder than Izuku thought was possible. He could see himself gaining more muscles and his fast reflexes saved him from more than a few nicks from Stains crazy intense sword training.

His classes were easy enough but it was his parents and his training that made his week difficult. Hisashi and Inko seemed to be more angry than usual, and they never got home until really late at night. Hisashi would always wake him up, drunk and stupid with anger. Then Hisashi would tell at him all night and beat the shit out of him before heading to bed. And by then, Izuku would be wide awake and in pain until he had to go to school.

It was a never-ending cycle of being absolutely bone tired and done with everything. He'd rather sleep in his room all day than go to school or do anything.

The clock on his phone read 3a.m., and he could hear his mother and father yelling at each other, before a door slammed. "Stupid psycho bitch!" Hisashi shouted, probably strolling into the kitchen for a beer.

A few seconds later Izuku heard the door to his own bedroom open slowly. Anxiety clung to him like a thick blanket as Hisashi stumbled down the rickety wooden stairs. This was quickly becoming a nightly affair with his father. Come home from work, yell at your wife, grab a drink and get drunk, beat up your son for no god damn reason, and then give him Quirk Suppressants.

Izuku clutched his sheets tightly between his fingers, and those familiar white eyes winked out of existence. The demons were afraid of Hisashi, for a good reason. With that kind of Quirk, interrogating would be the best kind of job for him. Or maybe he should become a professional at torturing people.

He was beginning to realize he should be very afraid every time Hisashi came into his dark room. His father reached the end of the stairs, cursing loudly to himself. “Fucking dark as hell in here...”

Izuku held his breath, refusing to make any noise whatsoever as Hisashi tripped over his own feet trying to find Izuku, who was sitting up in his bed, knuckles white from gripping his bed sheets too tightly.

His breath came in shallow and hurried, he knew exactly how this would go. It was never quick, or at least it never felt that way. When in pain, seconds can become hours in ones mind. He was positive that Hisashi could hear his heart pounding in his chest from all the way across the room. It was like being thrown into snow without clothes. Ice pumped through his veins burning and freezing at the same time as Hisashi took a seat on the edge of Izuku’s bed.

The bed creaked with the added weight, and Izuku pulled his knees to his chest, wrapping his arms around himself. The two were silent for a while as Hisashi took long swigs from his beer, he slurred his words together mostly complaining about work and his mother. Izuku ignored him for the most part, as most of his words became unintelligible. Just then Hisashi’s hand came up to cup his cheek, and Izuku jumped back as white-hot pain exploded in his jaw.

“...I really...hate you,” Hisashi declared, “You’re useless, you know that right?”

Izuku wasn’t listening, as he watched Hisashi’s hands whip around as he spoke. The inevitable pain and panic would come, and it was always terrifying. The yelling that followed was crushing and depressing too.

Hisashi placed his hand on the back of Izuku’s neck and they were nearly nose to nose. Suddenly Izuku wished he couldn't see anything, it was better than seeing Hisashi up this close. “You’re the worst thing that’s ever been born. I don’t know why I deal with you, and that Quirk of yours,”

Izuku's world was nothing but searing hot pain and cold fear and panic. Every cell in his body was screaming in pain, and he could feel himself tensing up against his will as his mind developed tunnel vision, registering over and over the freezing cold on his neck where Hisashi touched him.

His teeth snapped together in his mouth loudly, and sharp pain skittered down his spine. His nails dug themselves into the soft skin on his neck, until warm sticky blood dripped from the crescent moon shaped cuts. Hisashi made no sign of moving, and Izuku tore at his lips with his teeth in his frenzy of pain. His breath is loud and labored now, bad Hisashi laughs lowly at him.

"I'm thinking..." Hisashi whispers his hand petting Izuku's neck. His smile was dark and sinister. Crashing waves of agony seized him over and over. "Maybe my boss could help with that,"

Izuku's hands wring together, tangling with his blanket. "Would you like that?"

Izuku nodded his head slightly, shaking. Hisashi stood quickly and scowled at him from what he could see in this pitch black darkness. He almost gasped in relief as the pain dulled. "Good," he snapped, grabbing his beer on the way out of his room. "Don't forget to take the pills,"

Izuku slumped in his bed, tears already obscuring his view as those white eyes reappeared around him. He covered himself head to toe in his bedsheets and squeezed his eyes shut, trying to breathe normally again. His heart was beating so loudly in his chest he thought it might explode. His body trembled and he couldn't get it to stop. His body throbbed in time with his heart, burning and cold at the same time from the after-effect of his father's nasty Quirk.

His Quirk always left bruises where he touched him, a light blue and purple like a galaxy against his skin. It was easily dismissed as him being accident prone, and clumsy. His teachers never questioned it, but Kacchan was harder to fool.

Izuku rubbed his hands up and down his arms, trying to dispel the goosebumps that ended up appearing. He was almost glad that Chizome-san didn't end up training him today, informing him by a simple text to head straight home after school. His body was finally catching up to

his mind, exhausted and burnt-out. Chizome could probably tell, and maybe that's why they didn't train today.

He was wrong, and he realized that as soon as he tried to head to school the next day.

Hisashi was always at work around this time, but today he was sitting at the dining room table that Izuku never had the luxury to sit at. Izuku glanced at him uneasily. "Izuku," Hisashi grumbled very quietly, "You're not going to school today, put your bag away. We're going somewhere,"

Izuku's anxiety spiked immediately, and he opened his bedroom door slightly and chucked his bag into the darkness. It landed with a quiet thump, and he closed the door again. "Your mother's almost ready, let's go."

He didn't like this at all. This wasn't something that Hisashi has ever done before, and he didn't have a good feeling about it. Hisashi looked all too happy as his mother, Inko finally emerged from the bathroom. Her hair was up in a sophisticated bun, and she gave Izuku an icy glare as she applied the last of her mascara. Izuku shrunk back, wanting nothing more than to go back to being completely ignored.

He'd even be okay with a few dirty words slung at him as he headed to school. He didn't want to go where ever they wanted him to go the demons that usually followed him weren't grinning at him like they usually did. They were mumbling warnings.

"No..."

"...Evil.."

"Run."

Izuku felt sick to his stomach as Hisashi stood up and handed him a small pill. "Take this, and then we'll go."

He knew what it was, and swallowed it swiftly. The demons before him turned into smoke clouds, still visible but hard to catch if he wasn't paying attention. It seemed as if the Quirk suppressants Hisashi was giving him were already too weak. He'd already built up a tolerance. He hated it, and he wanted his Quirk completely gone. Maybe that's where they were going?

A sudden flicker of hope came to life in his chest. Maybe he could finally become Quirkless! The three of them left the house quickly, and Izuku felt a faint buzz of hope go down his spine. It was warm and fuzzy, unlike the world outside. It was strange. It was supposed to be a really hot day today, but it was almost cold and the sky was grey and cloudy.

Izuku nearly yelped when he spotted Chizome-san, who glanced at him in shock. "Why Stain, nice to see you here!" Inko said in mock cheer. "I didn't know you were meeting the boss today too!"

Chizome-san didn't take his eyes off of Izuku, and Izuku pretended to ignore him. "This your kid?" He asked lowly.

"Oh, don't mind him. He's pretty useless, I'm taking him to meet *him*. Hopefully he can fix Izuku,"

Chizome's eyes flashed with alarm and concern as they began to walk. Izuku's phone buzzed in his pocket and he ignored it. Inko gave him a sharp, burning glare that made him hold his breath. They walked in the opposite direction of his school and he was relieved that Kacchan wasn't at the house already waiting for him. It would be difficult to explain exactly what was happening. Truthfully he didn't even understand anything going on right now. All he knew was that this felt wrong.

Every fiber of his being was screaming at him to leave. Against his better judgement he ignored his instincts and followed his mother, father and mentor as they veered into an alleyway that Izuku had never ventured into before.

It was littered with trash, and covered in bright eye-catching graffiti. There were a few concerning-looking puddles, it could be piss or just water. But from the acrid smell he had to

assume it was piss, he stepped over it carefully. A little ways away, at the dead end of the alley, was something that looked like a portal. Chizome-san strode into it with his shoulders tense. Izuku was shocked. Teleportation Quirks were extremely rare and limited.

Where ever they were going, it had to be nearby. That was the one rule about Quirks like this one, they had to know the exact coordinates and they needed to be somewhat close. Anyway, he watched as Hisashi and Inko went into the portal. He hesitated, and glanced behind him. He could use this moment to run, but then his parents would just try it again. So he ducked his head slightly and entered the portal. The world darkened and it felt like he was on a rollercoaster, dropping at a million miles an hour before the world materialized again. There were no demons where ever he was. It was dark in this room, and the only light was from tubes in the walls and floor. They were interconnected and almost looked like a blue glow-in-the-dark maze. Whatever substance was in those tubes also fed into large cylinder tanks.

Floating inside those lightly glowing tanks were bird-like monster, and they all seemed to be sleeping at the moment, and Izuku hoped they'd stay that way. He was nearly entranced by the monsters resting inside those tubes until one of them opened their eyes to stare at him. They were wild and terrified like a caged animal. They were so pained and human that Izuku felt like throwing up. Those weren't monsters. Those were *people*.

They were practically screaming at him to rescue them. His heart ached for them, but he knew he couldn't do anything. His eyes traveled around the dark room, catching Chizome-san's eye and the killer took a few steps closer to whisper in his ear while Hisashi and Inko walked forward.

It was then that he noticed the huge chair farthest from him. "Don't piss him off. Be careful,"

Izuku nodded slightly and Chizome-san left him to stride forward toward that chair. Izuku followed reluctantly, feeling dread drown him in a crashing wave. Whoever was in that chair was not someone he wanted to mess with. He startled when a deep voice sounded. "Ah, is this your son Hisashi? Inko?"

Izuku froze to his spot, fear seized every muscle in his body. This was true terror, making him break out in a sweat almost immediately as the man in the chair shifted. He noticed how that man wore a suit, and had an air about him that made Izuku feel as if he was facing a tyrannical King of the villains. A king who had no problem executing Izuku on the spot with his bare hands.

“Come closer, my boy.” The boy said gruffly, and Izuku spotted his huge scarred hand. He gulped thickly and took a shaky step forward, weak at the knees with anxiety. He stopped a good ways away from that chair, and he waited his breathing heavy and loud in the silence that followed. The strange man let out an annoyed sigh and Izuku grimaced. The man stood, and Izuku’s breath hitched.

The mans face was half melted, skin stretched over where his eyes should’ve been. Tubes protruded from his face, and his smile was sinister and horrifying. He ducked away, eyes averted as the man walked the rest of the way to him. “Izuku Midoriya. Stain’s protégé, and son to my second in command, Hisashi. Your father has told me you want your Quirk removed?”

Izuku was too frozen to move. He held out a hand and Izuku didn’t move to shake it. The stranger smiled gently at him, but in the darkness it didn’t look convincing at all. “Shall we begin with introductions then? I already know so you are, and it’s only right you know who I am. I am the first man in history to get a Quirk. I’ve been alive for a very, very long time...I am known only by a few, namely All Might. You could say I’m the super villain who almost tore All Might in *half*...”

Izuku was going to throw up everywhere. For someone to almost kill All Might...he could feel his heartbeat thunder in his chest. His body was frozen, and his breath was hurried and frantic with horror.

”I am All For One,”

“WAIT DON’T!” Stain shouted, but All For One just grinned like a maniac.

Before Izuku could blink, All For One grabbed both of his hands and something in him tore itself to shreds. It was like everything was getting sucked out of him, and something vital was trying o escape. His vision flashed a blinding white, but as suddenly as it began it stopped, and Izuku fell to his knees and threw up everywhere. Every muscle screamed in agony, and reflex tears sprung to his eyes as he emptied his stomach again. All For One grabbed him by a handful of his hair and shook him, scowling. “Why?” There was a tiny hint of fear in his voice. “Why can’t I take it from you?”

Izuku shook his head in confusion. He didn't know. He didn't know. How was he supposed to know. "Stand up, Izuku," All For One snaps, but he didn't wait for him to stand, he dragged him to his feet, hissing obscenities.

"Why...?" All For One mumbled again, moving Izuku's head this way and that, glowering. "What exactly is your Quirk?"

Izuku looked at him hopelessly, but something strange happened. Where All For One's eyes were supposed to be was a flashing golden glow, and his eyes widened in realization. "I see...what a beautifully intriguing Quirk you have Izuku Midoriya. I think I like you, would you mind if I do an experiment? Of course you don't mind, my boy."

Stain stiffened, and watched warily. All For One took a hold of his hands again, and Izuku fought the urge to pull away and almost didn't stifle the reflexive hiss when they're hands intertwined. He didn't like the way All For One's grip tightened and how he smiled at him darkly. "All For One...please," Stain muttered weakly.

"Shut up, damn it." Hisashi glared at Stain and crossed his arms, sick satisfaction obvious in his expression. Izuku turned his wide eyes to All For One, and that's when it happened. He heard the cracking and smelled the iron smell of blood before the pain hit him. It was like getting hit by a freight train again and again. His breath was caught in his throat as he stared at his bloodied and crushed hands. The bone peeked through the gashes. He realized the screaming he heard was his own, as blood squirted out of his completely destroyed hands. Large deep cuts littered his arms, but he didn't care about that. His hands on their hand were unrecognizable and mutilated.

Izuku didn't register anything happening around him. *"His hands..."*

"His...hands..."

"I smell blood..."

Warm blood covered everything. It was everywhere and his vision was red with it. Pain pulsed worse and worse with each passing second as All For One laughed, the cracking noise

getting louder and more sickeningly wet. “Stop,” Stain snapped, over Izuku’s own excruciating screams as every bone in his hand broke *again*.“Please stop.”

“Alright, I guess I’ll leave him in decent condition for now,” All For One relented. For a long time it was silent, and Izuku clutched his mutilated hands to his chest. “Be grateful, Izuku Midoriya.

Stain may be able to train you in different types of combat, but *I* can teach you to use your Quirk.”

Izuku didn’t fucking care about that. He wasn’t registering anything All For One was even saying. He was too busy riding through the pain of having his hands *destroyed*, thanks. He whined weakly, as someone grabbed him by the shoulders and brought him to his feet. “Let’s go get you fixed up,”

That’s all he heard before the world went dark, and he was conscious no more.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

https://discord.gg/BdGsq8Z

Join my discord server!!!!

ALSO VERY IMPORTANT:

im doing a Q&A on my discord, and i decided to include everyone on Ao3! Give me questions and I'll answer them on Nov. 12th!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was bright when he woke up. It smelled strongly of rubbing alcohol and Izuku let out a groan of confusion. He opened his eyes and squeezed them shut almost as soon as he opened them. It was too bright.

Then last night's events hit him like a bus. His eyes snapped on and he sat up instantly, breathing heavy and sweating in terror.

“Woah, take it slow, idiot,” Chizome-san grumbled, sounding alarmed and worried. No one except Kacchan and Auntie Mitsuki ever seemed too worried for him. “You shouldn’t be moving—“

Chizome stopped, and glanced guiltily, as he spotted Izuku's tears dripping down his cheeks. Izuku was laying down on a couch and Stain joined him, perched on the edge with his back hunched. "H-hey, it's okay you're okay — shit I don't know how to comfort kids — Jesus,"

Izuku looked at his heavily bandaged hands and arms. The bandages stopped right at his elbows. The occasional gauze pad was taped to his shoulder and some were on his back, pulling at his skin slightly. Stain looked away, his eyes swimming with regret and sadness. "I'm sorry. I — I didn't think he'd do *that* to you. I fixed you up as good as I could, but your hands...the bones are very delicate and I'm no doctor. Y-you probably have nerve damage, and they'll look deformed. I'm sorry. I'm sorry,"

Izuku pursed his lips together. "He wants you back next week after school too," Stain admitted, looking livid. "I tried to convince him otherwise, but he was too interested in your Quirk. I'll be there the entire time, and I won't let him do that to you again. I swear to god I'll kill him,"

Izuku smiled weakly, and his lips trembled. Stain left without a word, only to return with a drink of water with a straw in it and two small pills. Stain didn't hand them to him, and he was grateful but he eyed the pills in suspicion. "Just pain killers you paranoid ass," Stain told him.

Izuku smiled at him weakly, and Stain set the drink and pills down for a moment. "Do your arms hurt?"

He nodded mutely. The pain wasn't overwhelming, he hadn't tried to use his hands yet so he was fine for now. Stain went back into his kitchen, remerging with two ice-packs. He placed each one in Izuku's hands, but the added weight ignited the sleeping pain within his skin. But at the same time, he relished in the soothing cold that the ice-packs provided.

"You really look like shit," Stain sighed to himself. "It *pisses* me off that I couldn't do anything against him while he hurt you like that. You're my apprentice, you're supposed to depend on me to protect you from people like him. Damn, I can't even help you get out of that fucking house where they lock you in pitch black a basement every day,"

Izuku shrugged trying to convey silently that it was fine, and he wasn't *dead* so that was always a plus. Chizome seemed to get it, but he still seemed immensely guilty. Izuku felt

really bad, but it really wasn't Chizome-san's fault. Izuku wouldn't stand up to someone like *that* either. All For One was absolutely terrifying, and his parents were too.

Stain let out a heavy sigh and grabbed the pills and drink from the table he set them on. Even though Izuku hated the idea of it, he let Stain pop the pills in his mouth and give him a drink. Yeah, his arms may be broken beyond repair, but fuck he didn't want to be treated like glass that's already shattered into a million pieces. "Don't give me that look," Stain groaned, "Your fucking arms are broken, you can't do shit. Maybe I could call in a favor to speed it up,"

Izuku tilted his head to the side, confused. Stain elaborated quickly. "I know someone at Yuuei who could heal your hands a little bit. She's a stickler though, about using her Quirk. Hopefully, she can heal it almost completely, but if she can't you probably won't pass the entrance exam. I don't even think I'd let you take it, with what condition your hands are in right now,"

Chizome licked at his lips absently, looking sadder by the second. "You'll have to deal with it for a while though, considering her Quirk uses your stamina to work. Right now you must be exhausted..."

Izuku glared down at his hands, self-loathing already springing to life in his heart. "You have two months to allow yourself to heal before the entrance exam, hopefully, my friend can help you heal enough to do well. Honestly, injuries as serious as this should've put you in the hospital with all the best healing-quirk heroes for a month, but we both know what would happen if we went to the hospital,"

The thought of pissing off All For One made him feel seriously sick. Stain pursed his lips together, "I'll give my friend a call and see if she can do anything,"

Izuku leaned back into the couch and stared at the wooden flooring, feeling down he watched as he watched Chizome leave the room to make a call. His heart ached dully in his chest, and he didn't notice the small animal dash in from where Chizome went and fly onto the couch. He only noticed because something plopped down right on his chest and barked loudly at him.

Izuku stared blankly at the tiny pug wagging its curly tail at him a million miles a second. He barked at him again, and army crawled up Izuku’s chest and nudged at his face. He laughed

softly, coughing at the itch in his throat. “Edgar! — Don’t fuck with him!”

The dog stood up on all fours and turned toward where Izuku heard Stain yell. The pug howled, before turning back to Izuku and plopping right back down. Edgar nudged at Izuku’s injured hands, and he shifted one of his hands up from under the ice pack and brought it up to pet Edgar. He smiled softly as that curly tail whipped around eagerly. Moving his hand around like this hurt like a motherfucker, but he’d never had the chance to pet a dog before.

Edgar closed his eyes and within seconds the pug was snoring against his chest. The dog was warm, almost like a living heating pad. Izuku could feel himself drifting off and didn’t mind. He wasn’t that close with Stain yet, but if this man had a dog like Edgar, how bad could he really be?

It was strange, finally feeling comfortable enough to sleep in a house that wasn’t Kacchan’s. He was out like a light before he even realized it.

Recovery Girl has been friends with Chizome, a Yuuei Dropout for a very long time. The man was always sporting a hoodie and baggy jeans and had a thuggish look to him. Chiyo was old enough to know that Chizome was a kind-hearted civilian with a heart for heroism.

That's why when he called her about an injured boy, she wasn’t surprised. She was alarmed, yes but she was used to calls like this from almost everyone she knew. So she made her way to his apartment in the ghetto part of town and knocked on the door at the dead of night. She’d had a long day at work today and only managed to get enough free time to help Chizome out.

Chizome opened the door, eyes red and droopy with exhaustion. Chiyo smiles at him, “Where’s the boy?”

“Right in here, and he’s sleeping right now. He’s a pretty jumpy kid so try not to wake him up,” Chizome grumbled, looking more agitated than he usually was. Chiyo gave him a soft pat on the shoulder.

“He’ll be fine, I can heal almost anything!”

“I’m not so sure you can this time Chiyo, but I decided I could try contacting you first,” Chizome led her to a couch where a small kid — who didn’t look a little over thirteen she observes — was sleeping. Edgar, Chizome’s dog has apparently taken a liking to the boy and is sleeping right on his chest.

Chizome shooed the small pug away and nudged the small boy on the couch awake. Chiyo watched as the boy opened his eyes instantly, and locked eyes with her. She could see the primal fear in those green eyes, she could practically feel the pain and panic that radiated off of him. It made her heart ache, but the way he cradled his hands to his chest and flinched when she took a step forward was a cause for concern.

She tried to placate him immediately. “I’m here to see if I can heal your hands, is that okay?”

The boy bit at his lips, and Chiyo waited for him to speak, or nod. She got neither as the boy just ducked his head away and held out two shaking hands. Chiyo took one hand and unraveled the abundant amount of pink stained bandages. At first, she wasn’t too worried until Chizome turned on a light, and she twisted his hand slightly.

The bruises and swelling were more obvious with the more lighting, and she flinched when the boy snatched his hand away, gasping in agony. “It’s his hands,” Chizome told her. “Every bone is completely shattered, can you do anything?”

“I would need to do some x-rays,” Chiyo told him, “He needs plenty of rest but I can reduce his swelling and bruising. You should keep him out of school for a while,”

“I agree,” Chizome grumbled. “I’ve already called his school and everything to let them know he’ll be gone for a while. When can we get those x-rays done?”

Chiyo brought up a hand so she could stroke her chin in thought. She could easily manage to do it really early in the morning.

She would have to take this boy to the Yuuei infirmary really early in the morning, but she could squeeze him in, in the end. That's all that mattered. "Tomorrow morning, if you can get up early enough for it," She replied.

Chizome nodded mutely. "As soon as possible would be best, we'll make it. Thank you Chiyo-san,"

"Don't thank me, it's my job to help people," Chiyo told him, patting the boy timid teen on the hand before releasing him.

She turned to the small teenager before her. "Who are you?"

The boy didn't say anything at all, as Chiyo stared at him. He did shuffle slightly and look at everything but her. The silence became concerning very quickly. "He's mute," Chizome told her reassuringly. "He won't answer you, and he doesn't know sign language."

"Why would he not know sign language if he was mute?"

"That isn't our business, now is it?" Chizome mumbled solemnly. "How early do you want us there tomorrow?"

Chiyo shrugged, "Five a.m. should suffice. I don't think anyone at Yuuei will need the nurse that early in the morning. We'll do some x-ray's and I'll see if I can't heal him a bit more."

She leaned forward into the small boy's space and kissed his forehead. A look of confusion passed across the teenager's face before it was effectively masked and empty. Chiyo smiled gently at him, and let Chizome lead her out the door.

The two of them stood in the doorway, and Chiyo glared at him. "Well?"

Chizome grimaced. “His name is Izuku Midoriya, there’s not much else I know about him,”

“From what I saw, his injuries are quite severe. How did he manage to get hurt that badly? I’ve never seen wounds like that.”

“We’ll talk about that tomorrow,”

“You really need to stop dodging my questions Chizome, I always figure it out eventually,” Chiyo told him rather firmly. She looked in those hurricane-like eyes, and too many emotions were swirling in Chizome’s eyes. Only one overpowered the others, and it was unease.

She knew Chizome was involved in something, but what it was still seemed to evade her no matter how much she looked into it. She was a hero, and Chiyo should be able to tell what was happening to Chizome and Midoriya. It was something dangerous, that much she knew.

Chiyo wasn’t going to let Chizome fall into the darkest depths without trying to save him. What kind of hero would she be if she allowed something like that?

“We’ll see you tomorrow,”

“And you’ll be answering some of my questions,”

She didn’t get a response, so she turned to leave. She’d be lying if she said she didn’t glance behind her ever so often, feeling as if someone was watching her. She definitely didn’t miss the civilians glaring at her from the corner of her eyes. Whoever Chizome was involved with, the man had a very long, long reach.

Shouta Aizawa was effectively getting a headache from this staff meeting, and Present Mic. He was married to this man, but it didn’t help to quell his annoyance whenever he got too

loud.

Hizashi was smiling big and talking adamantly with Principal Nedzu about the new art program they'd just put funding into. Now it was no longer a course at Yuuei just for show. Now Present Mic would get a chance to teach his favorite subject besides Heroics.

"I think it's a perfect addition to Yuuei!" Nedzu told them all. "Hero, support and general courses do ask a lot of our students! Art could prove to be a relaxing class for every student, but it could also be a whole course on its own aside from our other studies. We could be the first hero academy with a successful Art studies program, could you imagine?!"

"HELL YEAH!" Present Mic screeched loudly, puffing out his chest. "I JUST LOVE ART!"

"Truly a beautiful and masterful addition to our school indeed. Now, while we're on the topic I would like to add that Yuuei will be putting more consideration into our art scholarships. In the past art scholarships were essentially useless, but they did look good on resumes for general education students looking for jobs after graduation." Nedzu spread his arms wide.

"Now only one art scholarship will be given out a year, and we will pay their tuition in full for their entire high school career! Art has never had much appreciation in our world, and art-related quirks are far and in between these days! I think it's important for the world to stop and enjoy a masterpiece every once in a while,"

"I TOTALLY AGREEEE!"

Shouta rolled his eyes, his agitation growing with his pounding head. He was glad Present Mic's dream of an art course was finally being implemented, but he really needed some painkillers right now. He wanted this meeting to end, and he desperately needed a nap and maybe a quick talk with Nedzu about the entrance exam.

He put his head against the table and tried his damndest to ignore Nedzu's long-winded speech about a new school year. Was he practicing his speech for the entrance ceremony or something? "—Of course this year we will be having a new teacher joining us as all of you are sure to be aware. He'll be taking over Present Mic's job as the Heroics teacher because our

Art Program now requires a full-time teacher to be successful. This new teacher is none other than the number one hero, All Might!"

Shouta yawned, watching Yagi Toshinori out of the corner of his eye. No one in the world was aware of Toshinori's weakened state except for maybe Recovery Girl, but as of this year, all Yuuei teachers had become notified of it. Aizawa was surprised of course, but it explained a lot about All Might's recent change in his hero schedule.

Nedzu was *still* talking now, as soon as Yagi took a seat. "Let's have a great school year everyone! Go ahead and continue preparations for the upcoming entrance exam!"

Shouta almost cried when he finally got to leave and head to Recovery Girl's office. It was *barely five in the fucking morning,* and he still had a whole day to go through. He definitely needed Recovery Girl's magic touch for the shitty day he was about to have. He weaved his way through the vacant Yuuei hallways. Everyone else was headed to the support department, helping out with the robots so Shouta was blissfully alone for now. As Recovery Girl's office came into view he heard voices. Two to be exact, and one was Recovery Girl.

He wasn't one to eavesdrop, but what they were saying was pretty interesting. "—injuries like that since All Might..."

Shouta stopped, and leaned against the wall near her door, but far away enough to escape. "How did his hands get hurt this bad, Chizome? The type of nerve damage...and the joints in his hands are completely destroyed beyond repair. His bones will heal in a few months, with careful care. The nerve damage, unfortunately, can never be repaired either. His hands might shake a lot, but that's to be expected with this kind of injury. It's almost as if a bomb went off on his hands..."

Okay, maybe Shouta shouldn't be listening to this. It wasn't his business, but he was fucking curious damn it. That's why he didn't move. He knew himself well, and if he left now without the whole story he'd wonder about it all day. "I-I really can't tell you Chiyo-san,"

"At least tell me why his hands are cut up in the shape of a summoning circle? What happened to him? Where have you been for the past month and a half?" Recovery Girl sounded pained and worried. It was just like her, to worry too much about her patients. "I

can't heal him, and I can't prevent any scarring. I can't do anything for him Chizome, not if you don't tell me what the *fuck* you've got yourself into,"

"Stop worrying too much, old lady," Chizome grumbled roughly, but endearingly.

"I want to help you."

"If you can't heal him you can't help," Chizome told her, "But that's okay we can go to someone else,"

"Everyone else will say the same thing," Recovery Girl replied, and Shouta took his chance. He wanted to see who these two were talking about. And he wanted painkillers, or a kiss from Recovery Girl to make his migraine disappear in an instant. Plus, it sounded like this conversation was getting too emotional for Recovery Girl to handle. He made his steps audible and rounded the corner and into her office in a split second.

Recovery Girl glared at him, and this Chizome guy who looked like a thug. Shouta waved half-heartedly and ventured deeper into her room. "I need painkillers for a headache, sorry,"

He wasn't sorry. He just wanted a glimpse of the boy they were talking about. He rummaged through her medicine cabinet and grabbed the correct bottle labeled painkillers and took an experimental glance toward the back of the room.

His eyes went to his shaking hands. Bruised purple and blue, and a hue of alarming black. His palms were carved and slightly scabbed over, and Shouta blanked completely. The boy's fingers were slightly twisted and pointing in all the wrong directions. Aizawa's eyes couldn't help but stray to his carved up arms, but then he made the massive mistake of locking eyes with dark emerald ones.

The boy squeaked loudly and curled his hands into fists. Shouta winced with sympathy. It must be painful to move his hands at all. Chizome seemed to think so too. "C'mon Midoriya, and stop fucking moving your hands. You'll hurt yourself,"

The boy — Midoriya? — stood quickly and Chizome took a bunch of bandages and quickly wrapped his hands. "See you around Recovery Girl,"

Then they left, and Shouta glanced at Recovery Girl in confusion. "Who are they?"

"Eraserhead, you know all of my patient's identities are confidential..."

"I just — I feel like I've seen him somewhere before,"

"The man?"

"No. Midoriya,"

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

Alright, guys, first off I'm very sorry for not updating on time...I had things going on. BUT I FINISHED MY Q&A! It'll be at the end notes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chizome didn't want to do this. He didn't want to grovel for help and make Izuku owe them. He never thought his apprentice would already be dragged into this shit so soon. He'd thought he'd had time to warn him, or at least get him in Yuuei and leave him to become a hero on his own.

He never wanted Izuku involved with All For One, and he didn't want Izuku to *owe* this man something. Sadly they had no choice. Izuku still had his heart set on becoming a hero, and Chizome was determined to help him no matter what. Even if that meant he sent Izuku to get his hands healed by a crazy doctor by the name of Tsubasa.

"Alright Midoriya, I know for a fact you never want to go back to All For One, but we don't really have a choice here. To be able to compete in the entrance exam you need your hands mostly healed so we can resume our training. Understand?"

He got the smallest of nods from his teenage apprentice, and they stepped into the nearest alleyway. The warp was already waiting, inky black and bubbling. Chizome stepped inside first, and he heard his apprentice sigh shortly in distress. He didn't blame him, as the two of them ended up in the familiar dark room lit only by the tubes with a blue substance in it. Each tube connected to a single Nomu tank, and standing right in front of one was Doctor Tsubasa, looking eerily excited to lay eyes on Izuku as soon as they entered the room.

The chair on the other side of the room was mercifully empty for now, and Doctor Tsubasa seemed to be the only one in the room. Izuku visibly shrunk as soon as the Doctor strode toward him. "Ah, you must be Midoriya, am I right?"

He didn't wait for a response, before turning on his heel and motioning for Izuku to follow. He glanced at Chizome and smiled slightly. "He'll be out for you in a moment, Stain,"

Chizome glared at Tsubasa furiously. What did All For One want, and why wasn't he allowed to be with his apprentice while his hands were healed? It put him on edge as he stood, waiting. He must've waited a solid ten minutes before *anyone* showed up. It turned out to be just Hisashi, and Stain glared at him, sporting a rather vicious scowl. "All For One's a little busy right now, but he did want me to remind you of the job he gave you,"

"Delivering some weapons right? Is that all?" Stain asked, crossing his arms.

"Yes, but he does want to speak to your apprentice afterward. He wants you to bring him on the job with you, too."

"Show me where the weapons are and I'll get them delivered right away," Stain told him, and Hisashi turned and went in the same direction his apprentice just disappeared through. Stain followed, always cautious in the presence of Hisashi, Inko or All For One. He passed by Dr. Tsubasa's room and caught only a glimpse of his apprentice, but he heard no screaming so he should be fine for now.

Hisashi turned the corner and opened the door to a well-lit room. It was a garage filled with unsuspecting vehicles, but only one of them was loaded with something as far as he could tell. It was a pickup truck with logs in the bed of it, and Hisashi directed him to it and handed him a pair of keys.

"Under all of this are the weapons we need delivered to a villain named Bullseye. He requested these weapons specifically a few weeks ago, and we had them custom made for him. There's a phone in there already prepared with GPS directions, and he should be there by the time you get there. He already knows your the one dropping off the goods. After you finish with Bulleye's delivery, the rest of the goods will go to the League. Both locations are on the GPS. After both deliveries are completed All For One would like to speak to you and your kid,"

"My kid?" Stain snapped, annoyed. He was pissed off that Hisashi kept ignoring the fact that Midoriya was biologically his son. What an asshole. "He's actually your kid, and you're allowing this to happen to him? You're allowing Inko to treat him the way she is?"

"I'm not *allowing* anything. I've been the one telling her to do that, and now that I live there I get to do it myself,"

"Abuse your son? What the hell is *wrong* with you?"

"Nothing's wrong with me," Hisashi told him, "The boy's birth was a mistake, Inko's pregnancy was a mistake. He wasn't supposed to be born, and he needs to know that,"

"Ahem," Came a raspy voice, and Stain jumped. Dr. Tsubasa was standing nearby, and Midoriya was standing next to him, face carefully blank and emotionless. "His hands are functional now, but I couldn't heal the cuts and nerve-damage. The cuts should scab over and heal but it'll scar pretty badly. His hands will shake uncontrollably, but it could probably be helped with therapy not that he'll get it. He owes us, Stain, don't forget." Dr. Tsubasa left immediately.

"In the car, my boy," Hisashi mumbled, and Midoriya didn't hesitate, but he didn't spare his father a glance. Stain opened the driver's side door and jammed the key into the ignition and the car roared to life. On the other side of the room was a massive dark tunnel that would take them up into the city. He directed the car toward it and glanced worryingly at his small apprentice.

"Are you okay?" Stain asked as they entered the dark tunnel. He flipped on the headlights and glanced every so often at Midoriya, who nodded. "Hands are good?"

Another nod. The rest of the ride was composed of silence and the GPS shouting orders at them as they drove. Stain would like to say that Midoriya was being quieter than usual, but that would be a lie. The boy was mute after all and was always quiet. Today was no different, but he seemed even more depressed than usual probably because of what his father said about him.

It struck Stain somewhere deep, to see Midoriya go through the same treatment Stain went through as a kid. He was determined to be that light in the darkness for this boy though, even if he couldn't save him like he originally planned.

The weaved through traffic, getting stopped at almost *every* stoplight in existence, and he could tell it was annoying Midoriya. At one of these stoplights they ended up stuck at, Stain decided to speak. "All For One wants to speak with you when we get back, but I'll be there the entire time, I promise. Last time he said he was interested in training you, and that's probably why he wants to talk, nothing more,"

Midoriya didn't acknowledge that he heard anything, but Stain knew he was listening. "I'll try my best to keep you alive while he trains you, I promise."

The light turned green, and Midoriya looked out the window. They were headed to the more suburban part of town and soon ended up at a small trailer where a rather buff man waited with his arms crossed and his expression fierce. Stain noticed the small garden of vegetables and fruits next to his small home.

Stain got out of the car and so did his painfully small apprentice. Stain went to the back of the truck and managed to uncover the weapons and bring them out. Midoriya was busying himself by staring at the man before him. "Hello, small boy,"

Midoriya waved, his face blank and bored.

Bullseye smiled at him before turning to Stain, "Do you have them?"

"Why the hell would I be here if I didn't have them?" Stain snapped, getting annoyed.

Bullseye walked over and took each weapon from his hands, taking a second or two to analyze them. "They look good, thanks,"

"Whatever, I have places to be. See ya,"

"Yeah, go running back like a good dog to your master," Bullseye grinned at him, and Stain flipped him off. Midoriya rolled his eyes and headed back to the truck, and leaned against it to watch Stain and Bullseye spit back and forth.

"You're an asshole,"

"Says the boy who can't even protect their own apprentice from the big bad mastermind, that's just cruel,"

"Don't get all mad that I switched organizations," Stain grumbled.

"You're the one that got fucked over, not me. I mean look at your apprentice, his hands are destroyed,"

"He's fine,"

"Oh really? You call that fine?" He strode toward Midoriya, and the boy flinched when Bullseye lunged for his hand. With Midoriya's hand in his grasp, he dragged him toward Stain and unraveled the bandages around one of his hands. Hid eyes widened just a fraction, and he glared at Stain. Stain winced, as Midoriya hissed through his teeth when Bullseye twisted his hand just slightly.

"His hands are fucking mutilated. What kind of teacher are you if you can't protect your students? I understand that your life before meeting me was a rough twenty years, but that's no excuse to let that happen to him,"

He jerked a finger toward Midoriya, and Stain felt his get heavy with sorrow and guilt. Bullseye was right, and Midoriya was suffering because Stain wasn't strong enough. "You don't understand—"

"Yes, I do. You've got yourself into a shitty situation and you're too deep to escape now. That boy isn't. Don't let him repeat your mistakes, Chizome,"

Stain looked away, feeling like a failure. Midoriya snatched his hand away and flipped Bullseye off. He could see Midoriya's tense shoulders, and he could almost smell the fear rolling off him in waves, but he still flipped Stain's *former mentor* off. Stain was proud, he threw an arm around Midoriya's shoulders and guided him back to the truck. "Leave us alone, and ask for someone else to deliver your damn weapons,"

"Fine," Bullseye grumbled, as Stain slammed the car door shut. As soon as his apprentice put his seatbelt on, he pulled out of the driveway and headed to the next location marked on the GPS. He already knew the location of the League, and after a few seconds of listening to an automated voice yell out directions he turned it off. Stain didn't try to fill the silence this time, he was boiling with rage, self-loathing and guilt. It *was* his fault. All of this was.

This time though, he would make sure All For One didn't hurt him. Stain accelerated the car. He didn't want to take up too much time doing this job and make All For One mad. He'd much rather deal with an annoyed super villain than an angry one. Fifteen minutes later they stopped the truck at an abandoned building, but it wasn't *really* empty.

It was an underground bar, only known by local villains. Inside this bar, was the League of Villains. He parked the truck on the side of the road a little down the street from the bar, as to not draw attention to himself or his companion. The two of them left the truck and Stain walked around to the back of the truck where the rest of the weapons laid in duffel bags with a big L on the each.

He handed one to Izuku and then shouldered the other two onto his back. "This way," He mumbled, and Midoriya didn't hesitate to follow him as they walked toward the League of Villains. As they neared, someone opened the door and grinned at the two of them.

"Earlier than I expected," Giran grumbled, his arms crossed. "Can I have a look at them?"

"No, but you can ask Shigaraki later," Stain told him, shoving past Giran and into the building.

He doesn't like it here. It's dark and cold much like All For One's lair is. The bar they walk into is poorly lit and smells strongly of smoke to the point he feels like coughing up a lung.

Izuku stays as close as he dares to Chizome-san the entire time as the two of them wait for this man named Shigaraki to arrive. It's pathetic, how much anxiety is thrumming through his veins as he watches the entire room carefully. There's no one in here except for Chizome and him, but he still feels like he's being *watched* somehow. In fact, he's felt like this all day but even more so right now.

He takes a second to try to calm himself by taking everything in. The bar itself is well stocked with all types of drinks, and the barstools look ripped up but otherwise still in good condition. Izuku's eyes keep locking onto the door that the man who was at the entrance went through. Before he'd left, he explained to Chizome-san that he would get Shigaraki and that made Izuku practically vibrate with unease.

If Shigaraki is anything like All For One he want's absolutely nothing to do with him. Izuku swallows the lump in his throat as the door in front of them swings open to reveal a bizarre-looking man with hands all over his face. His pale blue hair is shocking, to say the least, and Izuku tries his hardest to pretend to be invisible as Shigaraki steps into the room.

A whole crowd of demons trickle in after him, going straight for him and Izuku has to resist the urge to run. They're tall, and not at all the friendliest looking beasts he's ever laid eyes on. The temperature drops drastically in the room, but only Izuku seems to notice. The demons crowd around him, and he glares fiercely at them to move, Luckily they don't try to touch him or distract him, and they move away quickly once they meet his eye. Shigaraki takes the bags out of Stain's arms and then turns to Izuku.

Izuku freezes up instantly at the glare he receives and holds out the bag heavy with guns and other weapons he kind of doesn't want to think about. Shigaraki takes it, clearly holding up a pinky. Izuku immediately recognizes the action and knows for a fact that his Quirk is probably five-finger contact-oriented. It's highly probable that his Quirk is also destructive to considering he was a villain.

He *really* doesn't want Shigaraki to touch him. "Well?" Shigaraki growls, "What are you still doing here!? You finished the damn job, now get out!"

With panic laying heavily in his gut, Izuku moves even before Chizome can. He's halfway to the truck when Chizome-san catches up, looking annoyed. For a moment worry seizes Izuku, did he do something wrong? Is Chizome-san mad at him? The non-stop shaking in his hands increases ten-fold, as Chizome's cold eyes go to him straight away. His mentor says nothing as he gets in the truck and it roars to life.

In tense silence — or at least tense to Izuku — they drive back to that warehouse where All For One waited. He couldn't help but feel a wave of panic creep up on him as they enter the same dark tunnel they left from.

He tries to push it down as they get out of the car and enter the same room he first met All For One in. It's still dark and cold and crowded. All For One's face points in his direction promptly, and ignites a fire in his blood. Before he realizes it All For One is across the room, holding him by his shoulders. A cruel smile pulls at this man's lips, and Izuku is already trembling and breathing heavily.

"You made it back quicker than I thought, did Shigaraki not give you any trouble?"

It took a moment for Izuku to realize All For One wasn't talking to Chizome, but *him*. He opened his mouth slightly, but nothing came out. Panicking he shook his head, and All For One grinned happily. "Good, I told him not to. You guys will have a formal introduction soon enough, now on to more important business!"

"The other day I told you about how I can train you to use your Quirk,"

Izuku doesn't like where this is going and can feel himself slipping on the edge of a panic attack the longer those scarred hands rest on his shoulders. "I've taken quite the interest in you, young Midoriya. As a result, I want you here every Sunday all day long to train. Of course, you and Stain are welcome to continue your regular training every day except for Sundays if you wish. Though I will warn you that I do *not* recommend it. You'll be lucky if you can make it to school the next day,"

Izuku's heart nearly stops at that, and he finds himself trying to pull away as All For One's grip tightens. "I'll go easy on you for now, but my analysis Quirk tells me you'll be very formidable if trained correctly. This Quirk hasn't failed me yet, and I'm excited to see what you'll do under pressure,"

The nausea that hits him is enough to weaken him at the knees. The way his mouth twists into a smile made of knives and sick excitement only makes Izuku feel ten times worse than he did before.

Izuku isn't stupid, and he can feel himself sweating and hyperventilating. That kind of training would leave him unable to make it to school? What the fuck had he gotten himself into?

"Now, my dear boy I think you've already missed too much school," All For One brought a hand up to caress Izuku's cheek, and he's never felt so disgusted and terrified at the same time.

"A *hero*—" All For One grabbed him by the jaw and tightened his grip until it was painful. His voice was sharp with venom and resentment. Izuku's muscles seized up, and his breathing stopped short. "—should always prioritize education, don't you *think*?"

Izuku managed a short nod, and All For One released him. Izuku let out a relieved breath of air, only to be shoved by Hisashi — who he didn't even realize was there — into a black bubbling portal waiting for him. "It's time for you to go back home to your parents," All for One said.

He's never been so petrified in his life, as the world disappears and he knows exactly where he's headed. These last three days aside from All For One have honestly been more relaxing than anything he's ever known. Chizome-san was *nice* to him. He helped him and got him healed even though it would hurt both of them in the long run when he didn't have to.

So when he's thrust down into that basement, he cried. His fear of the dark hits him like a tidal wave. It's colder and more unforgiving than he remembered, and it's so, so dark. He — he doesn't remember it being this dark. He doesn't remember it being this scary. He doesn't remember the fear of being home being so drowning and debilitating.

Izuku grabs his bottle of Quirk Suppressant pills and swallows one. He tells himself it's because he has to, not because he likes the way they make him feel.

Chapter End Notes

Here's the link to my Q&A document!

my something wicked q&a document

also the discord server link, as per usual.

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Trigger warning: self harm and dark thoughts

Chapter Notes

https://discord.gg/BdGsq8Z

-my discord c:

Katsuki was relieved to see Deku after three days of him not showing up to school or giving him a text. He almost crushed the missing boy in a bear hug but restrained himself. Yes, he was worried sick and yes he wanted nothing more than to shake the answers out of Deku but it had to wait. Almost as soon as he laid eyes on him, Deku flinched and Katsuki noticed his shaking hands.

He slowed his pace and came to Deku's side without a word. He could see his friend glancing at him anxiously every once in a while as Katsuki began to walk. He hurried to keep pace with him, and Katsuki watched him carefully as they got closer and closer to school. Deku hadn't been sick, no that much was obvious. Something else was at work, and Katsuki couldn't take his eyes off of Deku's bandaged hands that never seemed to stop trembling. Someone hurt him, and that made Katsuki boil with rage and guilt.

He should be able to protect Deku no matter what, but he was failing. He was a worthless excuse for a childhood friend, and Deku probably thought the same. "Where've you been?" Katsuki asked quietly.

He saw Deku shrug out of the corner of his eye and he frowned. "Not gonna tell me?"

Deku shook his head furiously and picked up his pace. "Aye Deku! Wait for me, it's too early to be runnin' god damn!"

The nerd didn't listen to him, but Katsuki did manage to catch up to him. "Fine, asshole. I won't ask any damn questions as long as you *stop* running,"

Deku stopped abruptly and grinned triumphantly at him. Katsuki bared his teeth, pissed off that he fell for such an obvious trap. Deku was always really conservative about everything in his life. Katsuki had never in his entire *life* spent the night at Deku's while Deku constantly decided it was his job to sleep on Katsuki's floor. He didn't even know his father was back until he went to his house a couple of weeks ago to hunt Deku down. At the time he'd pretended that he wasn't surprised, but damn he'd never been so shocked in his fucking life.

Even his mother didn't know Hisashi was back until Katsuki brought it up later that night at dinner. She'd called Inko after that, shocked and happy for her. Katsuki felt differently about that, more concerned than excited. Hisashi didn't look like father material to him, and with his rising suspicion that Deku was being abused only added to his worry for his childhood friend.

And now that Deku had reappeared after three days of being M.I.A. like it was nothing made Katsuki way too overprotective. The two of them entered their classroom together and Katsuki launched himself into a new topic. "Are you excited about the entrance exams?"

An eager nod, with a smile that didn't reach emerald eyes. It ripped at Katsuki's heart and made him feel like shit. Yeah, he seemed to be the only one who noticed his three-day absence, but he still didn't *do* anything. "Good, have you been training for it?"

At this, Deku shrunk in his seat and averted his darkening eyes. A short nod and a shaky breath through pale lips. "Do you want to train together? We could go on runs and stuff,"

Usually, he could tell what Deku was thinking, or what he was trying to say. Today though, and like many days before it was becoming increasingly more difficult to read him. Katsuki could feel his eyes beginning to sting as he reluctantly took his seat after he got no response. He wanted to *help*. He wanted to know what was *wrong*. Was that too much to ask?

There was obviously something wrong, and someone was *hurting* him! Someone was hurting him and Katsuki was doing literally nothing. He wanted to be someone Izuku could run to

when life got too hard, and not helping him right now when he needed it most made Katsuki *livid*.

He sat through his classes, practically on fire with anger. He was an aspiring hero, and one day he would be saving a lot of people but the only person he truly wanted to save was Deku.

He was the only person who truly, desperately, needed his help as soon as possible. Deku needed a hero but refused to voice his situation. That's how Katsuki came to his sudden idea and a new course of action. He would figure it out himself, and get to the bottom of this all on his own. Even if Deku refused to tell him what the hell was going on. Even if Deku hated him in the long run, Katsuki would do anything to save him from whatever was happening.

Lunch was a haze of wordless looks and food that neither Katsuki or Deku bothered to touch. Katsuki was busy thinking about ways to help his best friend, and Deku didn't bother him. He could just call in an anonymous tip to child services, but he doubted they'd find anything or even *do* anything. Maybe he could try confronting Deku head-on? No. That definitely would drive him away more than anything, so that was out.

He could try to warn a teacher about it, but all the teachers here were shitty and didn't give a fuck about them. They wouldn't help him. He needed to get into Yuuei and tell a teacher, who was a *hero*. They would definitely do something about it and investigate it thoroughly. They would save him when no one else could because that's their *job*.

Katsuki would make sure of that.

Izuku ended up staying the night at Kacchan's somehow, thanks to Auntie Mitsuki. Apparently she had called his mother earlier before school let out and talked her into letting him stay the night and Izuku was surprised. How she managed to do that was a mystery even to Kacchan.

Anyway, that's how Izuku ended up on Kacchan's bed playing video games with him all night until he couldn't keep his eyes open. Well, Kacchan was playing games, and Izuku was watching silently until Kacchan thrust a controller into his hands. He gave the blond a

confused look, and Kacchan started up another match. The game was based on the concept of all-out warfare.

Izuku quickly realized Kacchan was truly a master of combat. The boy was quick and deadly in all his attacks, completely relentless and confident with each move. Izuku let the instinctual side of him take control and analyze Kacchan's mannerisms. He soon deduced that he should definitely keep his distance if he wanted to survive more than sixty seconds each round.

For his next load-out, he chose a sniper rifle. He led his character to a place on higher ground and waited for Kacchan to come to him. If he knew Kacchan half as well as he thought he did, Kacchan would shoot first and ask questions later. Izuku was counting on it, as he weaved his way through destroyed cars and thin pathways. The world around him was ravaged by war and destruction.

Cracks lined the concrete and buildings like a gigantic spiderweb. Izuku was happy to take the role of the spider, waiting patiently for Kacchan to walk aimlessly into his web and get devoured.

Okay, maybe Izuku was taking this *too* seriously. Kacchan shot him a glance, his red eyes dancing with challenge and excitement. One that Izuku would gladly accept, and he thought maybe Kacchan was the one who was taking this game all too seriously. Those eyes flashed at him, as Kacchan made his way over to where Izuku was on the map.

Izuku led his own character up a set of half-broken downstairs with graffiti drawn on the landing. Going up another set of beaten upstairs he passed by a massive hole in the wall most likely a result of an explosion. He didn't go through the hole that led to a dark hallway, but he went up the rest of the steps. The stairs led him to a small room that looked like a tornado came through it. Everything was overturned and thrown on the ground in a haphazard mess.

Paper littered the floor in messy scraps, and the small bed was upside down. Izuku made his way over to the window that was still intact and crouched down. Izuku aimed his gun at the broken street below. He would be lying if he said he wasn't spying on Kacchan's screen to see his location. Kacchan would have to walk down this exact street to reach him.

He would be here at any second, and Izuku would rock his fucking shit. Maybe Kacchan thought he'd win because Izuku had never played this game before. Kacchan was looking pretty smug as he marched down the road. He had no clue that Izuku knew *exactly* how to aim and shoot. He would make sure he took Kacchan down, as the boy came into view.

He adjusted his aim quickly, and it seemed as if time slowed down as he pulled the trigger.

There was a second of silence, as Kacchan's character fell to the ground in a heap and re-spawned a second later. "Fuck, Deku, that's some crazy skills!"

Izuku shot him a smile. "Let's go again," The blonde boy told him with a grin.

For the next hour, it was a game of cat and mouse between them, sometimes it was Kacchan who dominated. Other times it was Izuku, who completely decimated him.

In the end, Kacchan agreed that it was a draw and that they should bug Auntie Mitsuki for some food.

Izuku was particularly wary about this. He never asked for much and felt bad doing so — even if it was Kacchan who did all the talking. He dragged Izuku to the living room where Auntie sat on her computer. She was most likely working, and that made Izuku even more reluctant to bother her. It soon became apparent that it didn't matter because Kacchan shouted as soon as they got in hearing range. "AYE HAG WE'RE HUNGRY!"

Mitsuki doesn't miss a beat, glaring up at him from her computer screen. Her eyes a fiery and sharp. He could feel her mood shift like a breeze in the wind. Her eyes glitter with an undercurrent of annoyance and it makes Izuku want to shrink away. "YOU CAN GET YOUR OWN FOOD — but I can make Izuku some food. What do you want honey? Instant Ramen?"

Izuku gives her a wavering smile and nods, and Kacchan gives his mother the most scandalized look he can muster. "That's not fair," he growls.

“Life isn’t fair, and Izuku is a guest here so he shouldn’t have to make his own food,”

“That doesn’t count he practically lives here,” Kacchan tells her, as he grabs some dinner leftovers. He sets them on a plate and warms them in a microwave.

“Be that as it may I’m still going to make his food,” Mitsuki tells him as she puts a pot on the stove and turns the stove on. Kacchan takes his food out of the microwave and grabs a pair of chopsticks from a kitchen drawer. Izuku takes to watching the pot as Auntie Mitsuki goes back to working for now. Slowly but surely the pot heats up and small bubbles form on the bottom of the pot. In a few minutes, the pot would be boiling and then Izuku could finally eat his instant ramen after it cooked and go to bed. He didn’t care if Kacchan was gonna stay up all night because Izuku was determined to pass the fuck out as soon as he got a pillow and a blanket.

Kacchan took a seat at the dining table and silently began to eat. After a minute or two of watching the slightly boiling pot grow into a fully boiling pot, Izuku saw Auntie Mitsuki get back up from the couch and come back into the kitchen.

She merely gave the pot a glance as she passed by before opening the package of instant noodles. She took out the small seasoning packet and dropped the noodles carefully into the boiling water.

She glanced at Izuku with soft eyes, and Izuku could feel Kacchan’s eyes burning at the back of his head. Kacchan was always jealous that his mom seemed to baby Izuku more. It was true that Auntie Mitsuki seemed to, but Izuku knew it was for a reason. She wanted to make him comfortable, and the only way Auntie Mitsuki could do that was by acting that way.

He didn’t mind, but Kacchan certainly did. After pure silence for a couple of minutes — something that was completely out of the ordinary for the Bakugou household — Auntie Mitsuki deposits the cooked noodles into a bowl.

As soon as the bowl of ramen was placed in front of him, he dug in. Auntie Mitsuki takes back her seat on the couch, but not before patting Kacchan on the head with a smirk. Kacchan huffed sat next to him, doing his best not to look ticked off for no reason. In all honesty, it was a poor attempt and Izuku couldn’t help but grin at Kacchan’s expense.

Kacchan sighs heavily, his chopsticks picking around his food absently as he stews on his mild anger. Izuku doesn't bother him as he finishes his food and places the empty bowl in the sink. He goes back to the table and Kacchan stands abruptly.

His chair screeches loudly as he does so, and he turns to glare at Izuku. Izuku frowns slightly and Kacchan waltz over and grabs him by the wrist and drags him back into the room. "My mom is so annoying," he grumbles as he sits down and presses resume on the game.

"This is the last round, whoever loses is a villain,"

Needless to say, less than ten minutes later, at 11:00 p.m. the winner was decided.

In the end, it was Kacchan who killed Izuku with a well-placed bomb.

The next afternoon after school was completely different from the day before. Yesterday it was relaxing and fun, but today Izuku dreaded the end of the day bell.

Alas, it rang despite his wishes and he had to head home. Was it really a home to him though? The answer was a definitive no, as his hand hesitated around the doorknob.

Before he could do anything though, the door was swung open and he was met with a scowling Inko Midoriya. His throat closed in on itself right away, as she dragged him inside. Her nails were digging into his wrist, and Izuku's bit at the inside of his mouth, tearing at the skin. His heart drummed erratically in his chest, twisting in panic.

Inko threw him into the kitchen and scowled at him. Izuku stood as still as he possibly could. "WHERE WERE YOU LAST NIGHT?!"

Izuku flinched back into the kitchen counter and Inko advanced. “DID I TELL YOU THAT YOU COULD LEAVE THE HOUSE FOR SCHOOL?! WHO DO YOU THINK YOU ARE, HUH?”

Izuku’s hands gripped the counter tightly as Inko’s screaming reached its peak, and spit landed on his cheek. “I DON’T KNOW WHY I NEVER GOT RID OF YOU, YOU'RE USELESS, YOUR QUIRK IS AN INSULT TO THIS FAMILY! YOU SHOULD NEVER HAVE BEEN *BORN*!”

Inko’s fist slammed into his cheek, and Izuku didn’t hesitate to drop to the floor. “I HATE YOU!”

He covered his head with his arms as Inko slammed the heel of her foot into his back. His forehead was pressed into the cold tile, and his spine and ribs screamed at him with each brutal kick. His elbows and knees dug into the floor, but he ignored the pain. He ignored the silent tears and his heaving chest. He couldn’t ignore the stinging words and screeched insults. “HOPEFULLY ALL FOR ONE KILLS YOU!”

With a heavy breath, Inko retreats. Izuku doesn’t move for a long time after she walks into her bedroom and slams the door shut. *Hopefully All For One kills you*. Izuku stood, his heart screaming in terror still and his eyes dry. His throat burned, and the strong taste of iron assaulted his tongue as he licked his lip. Numbly he stared at the crowd of demons with their vague outlines, who arrived due to the scent of his blood.

He walked right through them, and into the closest bathroom. He didn’t want to force himself to sleep in his room as he turned on the bathroom light. He just wanted to sleep on the bathroom floor, feeling nothing but everything at the same time.

His hands shook even more than usual as he locked the door, and slid down the door. He hugged his knees to his chest and fought the wave of tears that threatened to overwhelm him. He chewed on his lips and touched his quickly bruising cheek. He took a second to stare at his hand, the scars that marred his right hand were the same on his left.

His cuts were still red and pink, healing slowly under the bandages, and he stared at his shaky hands. He took off the bandages and stared at his palm, a circle was carved there, and inside the circle was a pentagram with small symbols inside. His instincts told him that what was

carved on his hands, and it wasn't anything close to holy. They were summoning circles for demons, and why All For One would carve that into his skin was lost on him.

Izuku wrapped up his hand again and wrapped his arms around his shins and rested his head on his knees. His heart rested heavily in his chest, as he finally let it all out. Tears flooded down his cheeks, and his shoulders shook with the effort of trying to keep them from overwhelming him.

Right now, Izuku was finally at his limit. His heart was too weak to handle any more of this. He was out of things to give, and things to give up. Izuku didn't have much fight in him to begin with, but he'd finally run dry. No, he wasn't out of tears or sorrow. He lacked the energy to go on, and with each passing moment, a darker option seemed to become more and more appealing. His mother had razors under the sink, and he itched for them.

It could all be over in a few seconds if he had the balls for it. He found himself getting to his knees and crawling over to where the razors rested harmlessly in their box. In his hands, they would be the death of him. He grabbed one and positioned it vertically on his forearm. A clean swipe on both arms would end it pretty quickly, and he could finally be at peace as soon as he was dead.

But the blade rested coldly and shakily on the soft skin of his forearm, waiting to be dangerous and deadly. His constant shaking hands didn't help with his decisions as the blade pricked at his delicate skin. He hiccupped and few stray tears sliding down his pale cheeks. He closed his eyes and took a deep, shaking breath as the blade cut into his skin, and his arm stung. He tightened his grip on the blade, he'd made his decision.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

> GUYS ITS THE FIRST CHAPTER WITH INKO'S PERSPECTIVE :OOOO (its two seconds)
>
> I just added it so everyone could get an insight in all of her thoughts and "reasonings" behind everything she does. It also should clear somethings up as well.

Izuku woke up the same way he'd been waking up all week. To yelling and cursing. His was drenched in his own sweat, and his heart was already pounding loudly in his chest. Fear gripped him because tomorrow would be Sunday, and that would be his first training session with All For One. Underneath that drowning fear was relief that he didn't do anything stupid two nights ago when he wielded that razor like a sword. That night he'd thrown away the razor and taken his pills instead.

He checked his text messages as soon as he sat up. He'd gotten a text from Chizome late Friday night after he got a new slew of bruises, and he double checked the rendezvous point. Chizome-san has something for him apparently, and he needed to meet him as soon as he could manage to get out of the house.

Izuku finally found his window of escape almost as soon as he got dressed. Inko and Hisashi were still yelling at each other, and he could easily escape if he was quick enough about it. They would be too distracted with their petty fight to notice his silent escape. At least he hoped so, as he wrung his perpetually shaking hands together. He crept up the stairs, hardly sparing the dark figure in his room a single glance.

The rickety wooden boards creaked under his weight, and he froze for a second to listen. His parents continued to scream at each other as if nothing happened, so he kept going. As he reached the top stair, he paused. He took a deep breath and cracked open the door just a smidgen. The screaming continued.

"I don't understand why he wants *us* to deal with him!" Inko screeches from their bedroom across the house, and Izuku stops to listen in.

"We'll do whatever he needs us to do Inko! He's taken an interest in that — *thing*, and we need to make sure he doesn't try to run away! Or worse, actually go to Yuuei!"

Oh. Izuku moved quickly in hopes of not having to listen to this shit any longer. He silently tip toed his way out of the house, his raging hot anger making him grind his teeth together until it hurt. "He shouldn't be our responsibility Hisashi! If All For One wants to use him, he should just take him away! It's not like anyone would notice!"

He heard Hisashi sigh heavily, and he took a hold of the doorknob and waited for him to speak before he opened it. "You and I both know the Bakugou's would notice right away. And the school would contact us as well, there's no way people wouldn't start asking us questions..."

He opened the door, and stepped through. The streets were quiet and calm compared to the dark and heavy house that he resided in. He took a moment to relax before steeling himself.

"*I don't care!* We could hold a fake funeral for him or something! Please Hisashi! I can't have him near me anymore, he drives me insane. H-he's a monster..."

He shut the door behind him, and headed for Dagobah Beach with a heavy heart. His eyes remained cold even as the sun shone down on him, and warmed his body. Strangely enough he couldn't feel it as he picked up the pace. The walk wasn't as scenic as one would think, there weren't any tourists heading to the beach because the beach was relatively still covered in trash.

There were no store-fronts near the beach either, most people avoided it. It was probably because it smelled like shit, which was predictable since there was trash *everywhere*. Izuku was supposed to clean this beach up before he met All For One.

Now it didn't seem like he'd have the energy for that, according to All For One himself. He dreaded what All For One had planned for him, as the beach came into view.

Chizome-san was waiting for him as he got there, with a worn out sword in his hands. Izuku's curiosity was peaked as he neared, almost slipping on the sand on his way to his mentor. He felt incredibly drawn to the Katana in Chizome's hands. Chizome gave him a half-hearted smirk, and Izuku stood before him. He tilted his head to side, and glanced down at the sword.

"A-ah, this..." Chizome began. "This is a sword. Specifically it's a cursed Katana that's identical to my swords in every way — well mine aren't cursed like this one. I got it from a friend of mine, and they said it has a demon trapped inside,"

Izuku nodded slightly. He could feel the dark energy pulsing intoxicatingly, pulling him in and begging for him to touch it. Chizome gently placed the weapon in Izuku's already open hands. The weapon was freezing to the touch, but other than that nothing happened. Izuku frowned, feeling a little dissapointed as he gripped the hilt and lowered it down to his side.

Chizome looked disappointed too. "Maybe it's broken...?"

Izuku shrugged, but nevertheless he was estatic to get his first gift from his mentor. It may have been broken, but he didn't mind in the slightest as he held it in his hand. It was the perfect length, and weight for him. It was his, through and thrrough.

"Oh well, let's test the thing out anyway," Chizome-san said when Izuku smiled.

In one smooth move, Chizome freed his sword from it's sheath and lunged for him. Izuku side stepped, and brought his own sword down. In the blink of an eye, Chizome met him sword for sword, and the sound of them colliding rung loudly in his ears. As soon as Izuku jumped back, Chizome rushed to join him, and their swords slammed together in a shower of sparks.

Their swords danced together in a waltz of battle, turning and turning and meeting. The only sound was Izuku's heavy breathing and the scream of swords meeting each other in over and over in a flurry of blows and bright sparks. Chizome was fast, *very* fast. Izuku found himself dodging, and parrying more than he thought he would. He should've known, seeing as Chizome was basically an assassin — a murder — in his own right. The man was well-versed in every weapon in the book, most-likely.

Plus, this man had years of experience on Izuku, who could barely muster up a month or two of basic training. But hey, Izuku had proper form and he knew how to hit — and *hard* — with or without a sword in hand thanks to his teacher.

Izuku took a cautionary step backwards as Chizome thrusted his sword forward into Izuku's guard. In one smooth arch, Chizome's sword closed the distance between them, and Izuku's sword was faithful and he stood his ground. Their blades met again, in a new flurry of sharp blows. Meeting again and again in a song of clashing blades, Chizome and Izuku danced.

Panting with the effort of keeping up with Chizome-san, Izuku weakly parried a particularly quick blow, and his worn out sword went soaring through the air, landing delicately into the hot sand. Chizome pauses for a second, either waiting for Izuku to pick up his weapon or call it off, but Izuku didn't do either.

Izuku left the worn out sword in the sand, and got in close to Chizome. Shocked, Chizome swings his sword. Izuku lunged in, and the sword swung right behind him. They were standing nearly chest to chest now, and Izuku grabs his mentor by the wrist and flips him over his shoulder, surprising both himself and Chizome-san.

His mentor lands roughly on his back, his weapon falling out of his grip. He stared at Izuku for moment in awe and Izuku's heart does what it's always does. It over analyzes the situation, and jumps in his throat with fear and anxiety.

The fear cradles him in a freezing embrace as he lets out a shaky breath. The word sorry itches desperately at his lips, but like always no sound seems to come out. Chizome-san sits up and brushes the sand off of himself, and Izuku is frozen to his spot. His hands seem to shake more than usual and his teeth chew at the skin of his bottom lip. His shaky hands are clammy, and burning.

His eyes are hot with his irrational fear as Chizome raises a single hand. Chizome gives him a soft pat on the head, and every overthinking cell in his body fades away, as Chizome smiles at him. "Good job, kiddo,"

His fear and anxiety wash away almost instantly at the praise. It was almost like Chizome-san knew exactly what he needed to hear, and could see the rising terror in Izuku's dark eyes.

“I’m sorry the sword didn’t end up working, but it seems to do the trick for now,” Chizome said, gesturing to the work out sword still resting in the sand. He walks over to it, and goes to his duffel bag he left laying in the sand nearby. Chizome sets the sword back down, as he rummages through the contents of his bag. After a few seconds of looking, his mentor pulls out a sheath, and puts Izuku’s sword in it. Izuku's heart returns to itself rightful place in his chest, and the cold heat of fear recedes as Chizome reveals the rest of Izuku's unexpected gift.

The sheath itself is red like most of Chizome’s sheaths, but down scabbard is Izuku’s name in splatter-like black strokes like ink. With the sheath is a belt with a loop for his katana, and Chizome turns to him. “This is everything, kid," And suddenly Chizome moves on, "Let’s freshen up on your hand to hand combat, that’s what All For One will focus on first,” he pauses, and gives Izuku a grave look. “He always likes to make sure whoever he trains knows how to fight without their Quirk, and then once he’s satisfied he’ll move onto your Quirk and start the *real* training,”

Izuku gives him a weak nod, Chizome-san’s implications running through his mind. His hands were frozen stiff with anxiety, and his heart felt crushed with fear, twisting and aching. Chizome made it out to be exactly what Izuku thought. This wasn’t training Izuku would be going trough, he could tell. Chizome looked paler than usual, and he looked racked with guilt.

Tomorrow Izuku would know what hell really was. He would know that happiness would be a long forgotten emotion. Izuku would learn that demons weren't the ones to fear because All For One was no demon of *any* kind. For that man was an angel, of the purest kind. And it was his god-given mission to torture the King of demons.

Chizome-san was his saving grace, willing to prepare him as much as possible for what was to come. So Izuku shifted into a defensive stance, and watched his mentor very closely. Chizome puts all of his weapons away in their respective sheaths, and then their gritty battle of fists begins.

Izuku is the first one to move. Their fight is fast-paced, and nerve-wracking as Izuku throws a swift punch, aiming for Chizome's jaw. Chizome dodges faster than Izuku can follow, and begins with a swinging kick for Izuku's legs. He jumps back, out of the way, and throws a kick of his own. It's a high kick almost coming to Chizome's chest, but Chizome swipes it

away with ease and retaliates. In seconds his palm-strike is coming right at Izuku, and he manages to sloppily grab Chizome's wrist, and throw a punch that almost misses entirely.

Luckily it lands lazily and roughly, and Chizome's head whips to the side. His mentor comes back fiercer than before, headbutting Izuku with such force that Izuku staggers back. Chizome takes that window of opportunity and delivers a kick to Izuku's unguarded abdomen. Izuku loses his balance on the sand, and the world spins as he lands. Despite the dizziness that assaults him from all sides, Izuku stands and the fight continues.

Izuku gets a good hit in, a swift kick to Chizome's knee. Chizome grunts, air in his lungs hissing between his teeth but he doesn't fall or cry out. His mentor ends the fight quickly by tackling Izuku into the sand. The warm sand covers him as they land in a heavy heap. He can instantly feel sand sneak its way into his shoes, and all he can see is the bright blue sky above him.

Chizome gets up after a few seconds of silence, and brushes off the sand coating him. He helps Izuku to his feet with a slight smirk, and Izuku busies himself with brushing away the stubborn sand that seems to have attached itself to his clothes. "That was better than usual," Chizome told him, "You could actually win a fight with how much you've improved, and your hands dont hinder your sword skills either like I thought they would. That's good news,"

Izuku grinned weakly, and Chizome ruffled the sand out of his curly green hair. "You're getting really good kid. You'll be a hero in no time at the rate you're going,"

Now his smile widened, and his face became bright with excitement. Oh, how quickly it could be destroyed, this happiness.

In her mind, muddled with fog and disdain Inko had no son. For fifteen — was it fourteen? — years she neglected to acknowledge the *thing* that prowled in that accursed basement. She derived pleasure from beating it and screaming at it sure, but she never acknowledged it.

Did that monster have a name? For a moment she didn't know, and she didn't want to know but her mind supplied the answer for her. Izuku Midoriya. She hated him, hated him, hated him, hated him. From the moment that thing of a boy rested in her arms after she gave birth to him, to right this second she hated him more than she hated anything. Maybe it was because of the hair, or the eyes. Maybe it was Izuku's siren-like cries that almost made Inko cover her ears and let the child fall to the floor right after his birth.

Some days the answer was more clearer than others, but she knew it had something to do with his ugly quirk that didn't belong. It wasn't Hisashi's, or Inko's. It was something else entirely, something dark and foreign. Something that invaded her home and made it's ugly nest there like a member of the family. Those monsters were attracted to Izuku ever since the tender age of four, and she hated it. She hated it so much that she poured all of this information into the ear of her boss, who took an instant liking to that quirk.

The man sent one of his own, her husband, to watch Izuku. Inko didn't care, and she had missed Hisahi's company. You see, Hisashi was usually on long-term missions from All For One that kept him away from home for long, long periods of time. So Inko was grateful for an excuse to get her husband a sort of break.

Hisashi watched that *thing*, and reported back to All For One annually, and Inko hoped they'd be getting rid of him. Take his disgusting quirk, and hopefully All For One would do away with him forever. Maybe he'd make a Nomu out of him, something useful. She didn't care because that *thing* wasn't her son. It grew inside her for nine months, but by no means was it hers. It may have her DNA, but it wasn't hers.

Inko hated Izuku as much as someone can hate something. What she created hadn't been human from the start, and never would be. He had a human shell, a human heart, but in her eyes he had no right to be called human.

That's why she beat him, and screamed at him at every chance she got. That's why All For One took such a great interest in that thing. That's why all of this was beginning, All For One had told her earlier today. He wanted to experiment, and see how much the boy could take. All For One was looking to get an informant inside the impenetrable walls of Yuuei, and if trained he said Izuku would be that spy.

With that, it would be wrong for Inko to be angry. That thing would probably get caught, and after that *it* wouldn't be her problem anymore. She was glad he called her, and she could still

recall exactly what he told her.

"He'll be our in, Inko. We can finally achieve our long awaited dream,"

"We don't need a spy,"

"My dear Inko. You don't see how beneficial this would be for us. With the information he could provide we would have a great advantage,"

"I know but—"

"We need *this, Inko. For our plan to succeed we need him. We need every possible bit of information he finds, he could give us a list of every student attending Yuuei! Every teacher! He could be the difference between the world staying the same, and a world where villains rule. A lawless world, where I would rise in the chaos and take action! That's what we want, isn't it Inko?"*

"Yeah,"

"Then we need him,"

"Don't humanize it,"

"He's human Inko, don't be like that,"

"Not in my eyes,"

"If our dreams come to fruition, then I'll rid this world of him for you. After we take control of Japan,"

"Alright..."

All For One's plan was a glamorous one. Kill All Might and change the world from it's foundation. Destroy this world of peace, and build a new one birthed from chaos. He would be the Symbol of War. The pillar that holds this new world up, and the mastermind behind it all. The age of heroes was over, All For One always said. Inko naturally agreed, and if Izuku was the key to that...

Then maybe she could endure his existence a little longer to reach her dream. She leaned against her bedroom door, and sighed. Hisashi smiled gently at her. The plan would be moving along smoothly as soon as today was over, and Sunday dawned. That was when it would truly begin. The end of an era was upon them all, even if the Heroes didn't know it.

The age for Heroes was over, and it was finally time to make room for the of Villains.

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

please enjoy c':

Izuku wanted to throw up. One moment he was just barely waking up from a fitful sleep, and then in the blink of an eye he was on the ground retching in All For One’s cold basement. The world swam and spun around him, and nausea hit him like a wave. The room was dimly lit with that blue fluorescent tubes that housed those monstrous Nomu's, and they were blurry and distorted for a moment.

Bending over again he nearly vomited, but nothing came up. He hadn't eaten since the day before yesterday, and he was grateful he wasn't spewing vomit all over the floor before his training even began. Izuku swallowed back his nausea and stood. The ground was steady beneath his feet this time, and he blinked away the blur in his eyes as he scanned the room for All For One.

At first, he sees no one. The room is dark, and the shadows are still as statues made of ivory. Then as he's glancing around — not pausing to spare a glance at the Nomu's floating in tubes — a door on the right side of the room opens, and light streams in. Dr. Tsubasa walks into the room, stroking his mustache with a sinister smile. "Ah, dear boy you're right on time,"

Izuku hates the way his voice sounds, like ice cracking beneath someone's feet. It's sharp and alarming, and it sounds similar to the voices of his demons that follow him everywhere. Except here. They never tred here, and never will. Dr. Tsubasa strides across the room and grabs each of Izuku's hands. His touch is even colder than his voice, and Izuku fights the urge to yank away his broken hands.

"Your hand seems to be functional, that's good. Come, boy. He is waiting for you, and you'll soon know that his patience is thin at best. We should go right away before he comes looking for you himself," Dr. Tsubasa lets go of one of Izuku's hands and keeps his grip tight on the other.

He practically drags Izuku across the room, and into the dark hallway to the left. Izuku follows him down the hallway shrouded in darkness, and Dr. Tsubasa flicks on the lights as he goes. Blessed light fills the hallway, and the throne seated in that room with the Nomu's in the tubes. "He likes to intimidate people by keeping the lights off, but I can't see a damn thing," Dr. Tsubasa grumbles, but Izuku can see that sadistic gleam in his eyes that tells Izuku Dr. Tsubasa came up with the idea.

Or maybe they know all of his weaknesses already, and this is a warning in disguise. *We know you. We know what makes you tick, and we know exactly how to rip you apart at the seams*.

Dr. Tsubasa draws a silver key from his pocket and jams the small key into the keyhole, and unlocks the door. Beyond is a brightly lit room, with concrete walls and floors. Each wall is lined with weapons of every kind. Swords, katanas, bow and arrows, guns, warhammers, and daggers with curved blades that were polished until they shone. In the middle of the room was All For One, tossing a sword longer than Izuku's entire arm in the air.

The door creaks on its hinges and All For One turns towards him and ice crackles in Izuku's veins, freezing him to his spot in the doorway. Familiar panic rushed forward from the darkest parts of his mind, rearing its ugly head like a monster in the dark. Its sharp claws have ahold of his mind, and he struggled to breathe or move. Dr. Tsubasa didn't seem to care in the least, as he shoved Izuku through the door.

"Thank you, doctor," All For One says, dipping his head slightly. Dr. Tsubasa nods and leaves without so much as a glance back. Izuku tries to suffocate his fear, he tries to bury it deep in his chest until it's nothing more than a slight ache in the back of his mind. He fear remains, so demanding of all of his senses that he can't possibly think—

"Young Midoriya, shall we begin?" All For One suggests, putting away the sword. All For One presses something on a remote-looking device, and the walls lined with weapons begin to turn inward until they lock in place again and there are no weapons on these walls. All For One shrugs off his suit jacket and rolls up the sleeves to his dress shirt.

Izuku shifts into a defensive stance and his hands curl into fists. All For One's soft smile is all he sees before something cracks against his jaw. Pain explodes in his mouth and face. The taste of iron rushes to his tongue hot and thick. Blood. Izuku peels open his eyes again —

when did he close them? — and All For One is circling him like a hawk circles a dead corpse as it picks the corpse apart until nothing but bone is left.

"Did Stain not teach you how to block attacks?" All For One asked an eyebrow raised, "Did he even teach you how to attack your opponent?"

He ignores All For One and watches his movements closely this time. The fear is at the forefront of his mind, but he bears it. His vision of the world is obscured by it, but he forces himself to watch All For One closely.

“You’re afraid,” All For One stated.

Izuku stared at him with wide eyes.

“Fear is a demon of its own, my boy. Don’t let it control you and debilitate you. You’re the consort of demons. They will bend to your will. You aren’t chained down by fear, young Midoriya,” All For One told him, but then he laughed. “Is that what you want me to say? God, I sound like All Might preaching like that. I don’t care if you’re afraid, and I don’t care how many beatings you take before you start *moving*,”

Izuku sees it in perfect clarity this time, as All For One comes for him, his fists at the ready. Izuku managed to block that meaty fist with his arm, but it was sloppy and he still ended up getting hit pretty hard. Pain throbbed up his arm, down to his elbow.

He sucked in air between his clenched teeth and shifted backward with the force of the next blow. All For One was relentless, delivering punch after punch until Izuku lost his balance and fell. Izuku tried to scramble to his feet, but All For One was much, much quicker than Izuku could ever hope to be.

He was kicked across the room, and he slammed back first into the wall behind him.

All the air in his lungs left in a blink of an eye and left him gasping silently for air that refused to enter his lungs. Pain rocketed up his spine, stabbing and sharp. He rolled into his stomach and drew in gulps of air. His chest loosened, and he started to stand. All For One has been watching, and he slammed his foot onto Izuku's back. His chin cracked against the concrete beneath him, and his face burned with pain.

He didn't cry out, he never did. Not as All For One's kicks sent him flying like a rag doll. His muscles burned, and the newly forming bruises ached with dull pain as All For One kept him down. Each attempt to stand was stomped out, literally. More than once blood dropped between his lips, and streamed down his face and stained the floor red. His only defense was to curl in one himself and wait out the storm as he did with his mother.

He couldn't tell if it was All For One beating him in a concrete room, or his mother — screaming and cursing at him — in the kitchen.

It wasn't any different from the times before, but it lasted so much *longer*.

He could barely feel each blow. He wasn't here anymore. He was in his mother's basement. He was in the kitchen getting another beating for a meaningless reason. He was hiding in the bathroom, so he wouldn't have to be in the dark. He was anywhere but here. He wasn't here. He wasn't here. This pain wasn't his. He wasn't All For One's next investment. This life wasn't his. This was all just a bad dream.

At least that's what he told himself as he squeezed his eyes shut and shut out the pain of each kick. His fingers gripped his wild green hair, shaking and his knees were tucked under him. Everything throbbed and screamed at him, but Izuku couldn't bare the thought of moving even an inch. He couldn't—

"My boy," The voice was soft. "You can stand now,"

Izuku didn't move, the pain was like a snake. It cooled around all of him and squeezed. It squeezed and brought agony with each tightening coil. He could taste the hot iron coating his mouth, and the pain throbbing every single fiber of him. He didn't want to move and make it worse.

Izuku definitely didn’t want to fall for some sick trick and start the cycle all over again. All For One spoke again, slightly annoyed. “Get *up*,”

Izuku ignored those words. Soon enough All For One lifted him into the air like he weighed nothing and set him down on his feet. Shaking and bloody, Izuku stared at All For One.

“Again, until you can block me properly,”

Dread laid heavy in his stomach, and he once again assumed his defensive stance. “See this right here is why you keep falling on your ass,” All For One told him, walking over to him.

He easily corrected his stance and nodded to himself. “That’s much better, now see if you can block me successfully this time,”

Swallowing the bile in his throat, Izuku nodded ever so slightly. All For One launched himself at him with a fist raised and Izuku managed a clean block.

All For One came for him again, and Izuku wasn't swallowing back fear this time. He was swallowing back his hesitance to fight someone with *this* much power. It intimidated him, but he didn't want to get the shit beat out of him again. With aching muscles, he tried his best to block every attack that came his way. When blocking one of All For One's crazy strong punches — how was he this strong? — he slipped. Every aching joint was on fire as he fell, and All For One growled at him. As soon as he fell, All For One kicked him across the room.

"Again,"

Another slip up.

"Again,"

A punch that broke his nose, and sent blood streaming down his face.

"Again,"

A simple sweep of his leg sent Izuku falling again, and he crawled to his feet again with shaking legs. All For One waited with his arms crossed, anger rolling off him in waves.

"Again,"

"Again,"

"Again,"

"Again,"

Again. Again. Again. Each time he crawled to his feet it got harder and harder. Dried blood had crusted on his face, and now his knuckles were coated in it from wiping it off his face. He knew his knees *had* to be split open. His jeans kept sticking to his knees, and the stung each time he fell. *Again.* His body began to resist him, and more than once All For One had to be the one who dragged him back to his feet.

He couldn't even bring himself to lift up his arms in defense for the next attack but he was so *tired*. He couldn't do it anymore, he just wanted to *hide*. He didn't want to be here anymore.

Izuku wanted to wake up from this nightmare in Kacchan's room, where Kacchan would tell him to quit being a baby and play his console with him. Too bad this wasn't a dream. He let out a shaky sigh as he brought himself to his knees again, spitting up blood. This floor was littered with his own blood, Izuku observed.

All For One tapped his foot, not looking disheveled in the least. Izuku lifted himself up again, his knees almost buckling beneath him. "That was good, next week we'll work on your

offensive skills,"

And once more the world around him swirled and changed.

Shouta had been following this boy around for a while. His name was Izuku Midoriya — yes he'll admit he was snooping around the kid's school to find out — and he was mute. Apparently he was Quirkless and only had one friend. Bakugou Katsuki.

Whenever Midoriya didn't leave his house for days — every Sunday, — Shouta took to watching Bakugou. His day would always start out with knocking Midoriya's door and walking to school with the kid. Why was Shouta bothering with a kid like Midoriya Izuku? Well, it was simple.

He was interested ever since he saw him in Recovery Girl's office. He was curious about the wounds on his hands and how he got them. Shouta had seen this boy before, and he determined to confront the boy. Was he being abused? Was it the thuggish guy by the name of Chizome?

It was just the hero in him trying to help the boy with broken hands. No one could blame him, as he watched Midoriya leave his house with Bakugou. His hands were bandaged completely, and he wore a hoodie even though it had to be at least ninety degrees outside.

Nasty bruises marred his face in a collage of black, purple and blue. He watched them from his spot on the roof, playing it off like a pro hero going on patrol. Shouta followed the duo all the way to their middle school and watched as they disappeared within its walls.

Shouta sighed. He gained no new information by following Midoriya during the week, and he always seemed to miss him on Saturdays. Just as he was about to turn around, and head to Yuuei he was stopped by an arm.

He whipped his head around and glared at the man, and was surprised to see that it was Chizome. "Eraserhead," He said gruffly. "What're you doing here?"

Shouta shrugged, "What do you think? I'm doing a damn patrol,"

"Don't play dumb with me. You were watching him," Chizome mumbled.

"What if I was? What's it to you?"

"Don't stop. Whatever you do, never keep your eyes off of him. Do your fucking job, and save him because I *can't*,"

Shouta could only gape for a moment, as Chizome went on. "You're a pro hero that teaches at Yuuei right? Make sure he makes it into Yuuei, and *save* him,"

His phone buzzed in his back pocket and he glanced down and reached for it. When he looked up, Chizome was gone. "Ah, shit—" With a heavy sigh he answered his phone, his voice monotone and bored.

"What do you want Present Mic?"

"Aw don't be like that Shouta!" Present Mic whined on the other line. "I just called to make sure you were okay!"

"What does Nedzu want this time?"

"O-oh he needs you to review our entrance exam preparations with him. He says — and I quote — 'Aizawa-sensei is the only one who understands anything I say'"

Shouta glared at the sky, cursing everyone in Yuuei and the principal as well. "Fine, I'm on my way,"

"See you then Shouta!"

"It's *Eraserhead*,"

He hung up the call and started off toward Yuuei, hating every step. Nedzu was the most intellectual person — or was he an animal? — at Yuuei. Yet, that rat still insisted on performing exams that favored more flashy and physical Quirks.

Shouta was of course against it every year, and Nedzu liked to argue with him about it. That's why Nedzu wanted to review all the preparations with him. Not because Aizawa was smart and fun to talk to, but because it was entertaining to argue with him. Soon enough he found himself at Yuuei's entrance and groaned as he walked into the halls.

The place was swarming with teachers and heroes who were enlisted to help with entrance exam preparations. Shouta made his way down the hallways toward Nedzu’s office. He made it there uninterrupted, which he considered a blessing. But his blessings ended there. Nezdu sat in his chart sipping away at his coffee with a smirk. “Aizawa-sensei! Glad to see that you actually showed up,”

"Of course I did, why wouldn't I?"

"Maybe because you're too busy patrolling the streets of Musutafu day and night. Why is that?"

"I'm concerned is all," Shouta told him cooly, taking a seat in the chair in front of Nedzu's desk.

The principle clasped his hands together, and all the screens in the room turned on. Each screen played a different section of the practical exam, zone A, zone B and zone C. The

robots were currently being calibrated and tested thoroughly before they were put in their final positions. The entrance exam was almost upon them. Shouta would most likely see that boy again, and Midoriya was destined to fail. His hands would still be too ravaged to help him in any way. He was sure of it.

That's part of the reason he wanted to speak to Nedzu. "Well," Nedzu began, "Unlike last year, I won't be dragging out an argument like I usually do. I'd like to go over a few things that are going to be different this year. First and foremost Yuuei will have dorms this year—"

"Why are you only telling me this and not the other teachers,"

Nedzu grinned slightly. "You weren't listening to me at the staff meeting last week,"

Shouta grunted and motioned for Nedzu to go on. "As you already know, we have an art scholarship up for grabs, and many people have already presented their pieces. We're under the process of narrowing down our current applicants with the help of Present Mic but that's not something I need to discuss with you. I want to offer you a room at Yuuei for this year, as the teacher in charge of managing the dorms,"

Shouta's response was curt and sharp. *"No way,"*

Nedzu frowned, "You're the only teacher I can count on to expel your entire class! You'll be the only one with free time!"

"Yeah, and? I spend my free time doing things I like, not looking after bratty children,"

"Do me this one favor, Aizawa. Plus, you'll probably get to expel a few of them," Nedzu pleaded.

"I need a raise,"

"Done," Nedzu exclaimed, "I'm so glad you decided to say yes!"

"Fuck,"

Chapter 14

The world was black, and swimming. This world wasn't the *real* world, it was the world within his mind. For the past few weeks, his Sundays were filled with training, and fighting. Apparently he had graduated from hand-to-hand combat, and even sped past weaponry training. All For One had been impressed with him, and apparently decided to divulge a little information. When he started attending Yuuei, he'd have to spy on the staff and students. Even if he didn't want to.

That's when his spy training began, and it started with learning how to keep his mouth shut, no matter what.

"Yuuei won't hesitate to torture you for answers if you're revealed as a spy,"

That's what All For One had told him two weeks ago after their training session as he explained Izuku's purpose at Yuuei. The hilt of Izuku's sword had been slipping from his grasp, sweat coated his hands and his body. He couldn't tell this man no. In this world there were no choices, only commands. That next week week he had been introduced to Mysterio. She had straight black hair, cut just below her chin. She had instructed him to sit down in a chair. The room was brightly lit like a patient's room at the hospital, but this wasn't a hospital. This was hell, and he realized that the second she put her hands over his eyes.

They called this girls Quirk Nightmare. He had no clue how long he'd been in her thrall, running in terror, and crying within his own mind. And today he sat in the same chair, in the same room, with the same girl.

The world had melted away to pure black. The fear had seized him almost immediately, but just before he could even think about panicking the world came to be. The walls were the first to materialize, grey and dingy. The floors were the same, and this room was only lit by lightbulb hanging limply on a string.

Izuku was strapped to a chair, and his body was already ripped apart with cuts and bruises. His head throbbed, and he was missing a few fingers. A tray full of surgical instruments rested nearby, along with his detached fingers. Every instrument was already stained with his blood.

He’d had this same Nightmare last week, but he’d only got this far before it ended. Now he was picking up where he left off, he realized. And it didn’t look too good for him.

“You have thirty seconds to answer my questions, young Midoriya. Who is your master? Why were you spying on Yuuei?”

Izuku, disheveled and in agony didn’t respond. It was like his mouth was sewn shut, and no words would form, no matter how much he wanted the pain to end.

All Might was holding his other hand in his tight grip, wielding a plier in the other hand.

“Come on! Answer me!” But he couldn’t. He *couldn’t*.

Izuku watched with wide terrified eyes, as that plier clamped around his pointer finger. All Might waited for a breath and squeezed, and pain exploded in the joints of his finger. Izuku bent over in agony, clenching his jaw so hard his teeth and jaw ached. "Surely you value your fingers, young Midoriya? Why don't you answer a few questions of me?"

Sucking in a trembling breath, Izuku tried to. He tried, and tried. It was like something was jammed down his throat and he couldn't say anything. No matter how much his body and mind screamed at him to just spill *everything* just so the pain could end quickly. There was a sickening ripping and popping sound, and Izuku didn't dare to look as the pain struck him like lightning.

He screamed. It was a high, shrill noise, and it made All Might frown. "You've got seven fingers left Midoriya, and if you don't answer we'll move on to your toes,"

"Who is your boss?"

After a long silence only filled by Izuku's labored breathing, All Might tore off another finger. Izuku's excruciating screams echoed through the small room, and All Might grabbed a handful of his curly green hair and yanked. Izuku's vision was blurry, but he could see All Might glaring at him. "Is it All For One? Tell me,"

Izuku tried to nod, but he soon came to the conclusion that the illusion wouldn't allow it. All Might pulled out a pistol and rested it against Izuku's forehead.

"I'll ask this one more time. Do you work for All For One?"

Izuku could only squeeze his eyes shut as the shot rang out and blared in his ears. He braced himself for the pain, but it never came. For a moment he was confused, but then he realized what had happened. A different Nightmare began. More horrifying than the last.

It was dark. That's what he noticed first and foremost. He couldn't see anything, but he could smell the forest around him. He could smell the unearthed soil, the wet leaves and the faint scent of rain. Slowly his eyes adjusted to the darkness and he could see the trees around him.

The forest was alive around him, the leaves of the trees swaying in the breeze, but his body tensed even though the forest should've calmed him. Izuku let out a trembling breath, waiting for the Nightmare to start. He heard something snap. A twig, his mind supplied. The hairs on the back of his neck rose, and and fear latched onto him, primal, instinctual fear.

That's when he heard it. The *thing*, the *monster* of this Nightmare.

It's wail of destruction made the ground shudder. The scream was deep, and booming. The trees creaked and swayed, almost bowing. Izuku was surprised the trees didn't snap themselves in half.

Izuku didn't hesitate to run. He launched himself through the trees, his breathing quiet and quick compared to the low, long growl of the monster chasing after him. The trees behind him snapped as the creature pursued him. He was already sweating, and his breathing was labored.

He didn’t dare look behind him to catch a glimpse of the horrendous monster. Branches whipped across his cheeks but he hardly noticed the sting. Izuku’s knees protested every movement, but he forced himself to go faster.

He could feel its breath on his heels. Rotting and dangerously hungry for its next meal. If he didn’t pick up his pace he’d surely end up in the stomach of that thing.

“There’s no where for you to run,” A low growl. *“No one will save you, King of Demons,”*

Its voice was like metal scraping on metal. A choir of screaming demons. A chill skittered down Izuku's spine like a spider.

Izuku didn’t listen to it's words. He could almost see the end of the forest. He was so close to the sunlight, to freedom. He could feel it in his soul. His body screamed at him to stop running, but fear kept him going. It muddled everything, his sense of direction, his logic. Everything. His fear distorted everything.

So he didn’t notice the trap. He didn’t notice that this entire forest was a trap, and that the monster chasing him was one too. Izuku was running into the heart of the forest, where the monster waited, it’s huge jaws waiting for him.

In Izuku’s eyes he was running toward safety, where help waited. Once he reached out for the light and touched it, the world lost its glamour. He was standing right in front of a hunchbacked monster, this whole time he’d been running toward what he thought he was running from.

It’s skin was hanging off it’s arms in heavy wrinkles. The monster was covered up by a shredded blanket that covered its entire body. Only it’s arms and feet were visible.

Its skin was dark, black even. It reached out to him with its thin arms, and Izuku kept walking toward it no matter how hard he tried not to. He wasn’t in control anymore.

Its hand beckoned him closer, and his legs moved faster. Toward that monster.

A whimper escaped his lips, as he drew ever closer. He only stopped when he was close enough for the monster to touch.

It reached up a hand to touch his face, and Izuku felt hot tears streak down his cheeks.

The smell of rot and death was stronger than ever, and it only made everything worse. It's sharp claws dug into his cheek, and the creature finally pulled back it's hood.

Izuku's heart plummeted in his chest, his eyes flashing with terror. Rows and rows of yellowing teeth greeted him, and the monster spoke.

"I am god."

And you deserve to die, it seemed to add without speaking before it tackled him, and a gut wrenching scream filled the forest. His own scream, low and painful. God didn't wait to start eating him alive.

Those jaws chomped down on his arm first, tearing his muscles and crushing his bones. Izuku kicked at him, his screams piercing his own ears as he fought to free himself. His arm was in agony. Blood squirted as God finally ripped his arm from his shoulder. It pooled around him quickly, sticky and warm.

Slowly the pain began to dull, until he couldn't feel anything at all.

The world changed, but a Nightmare didn't begin. He was back in that chair, with that woman. But they weren't alone. All For One stood close by, the Chizome-san next to him. "Care for a little Quirk training?" He asked.

But to Izuku it wasn't a question, it was a demand, and Izuku was happy to oblige. All For One turned away, and Izuku got up on shaking legs and followed. Chizome said nothing as thet went down an unfamiliar hallway. It was brightly lit, just like the rest of the place, but he could smell the mold and musty smell of water. This hallway led to a single door, and All For One entered.

Izuku hesitated, but he had no choice. The room was huge, and dimly lit. The walls and floors were made of cracked concrete, and on the opposite wall of the door, a single chair sat. On the walls next to the chair were two garage doors. One on each wall. All For One took a seat in that chair, and crossed one leg over his knee. Izuku looked around, confused for a moment.

Chizome didn't move from his spot, and All For One began to explain. "Do you remember the scars I gave you on your hands?"

How could he forget? His hands had been *destroyed*. He unwrapped the bandages around his hands, struggling as he began to shake even more. "Those are pentagrams on your hands, and do you know what *you* can do with those, my boy?"

Izuku didn't like where this was going. Not one bit. He rubbed at the back of his neck, nodding slightly. "Good, then do it,"

He froze. He could feel a cold sweat coming on, and he sucked in a sharp, short breath. The walls seemed to close in on him, and he didn't realize he'd started to hyperventilate. Izuku covered his face with his shaking hands and shook his head. *No. No way, he couldn't do it. There was no* fucking *way he'd do that.*

Cold hands cupped the sides of his face, and for a fleeting moment he thought it was Chizome. But then he felt the fire, the pain, and he felt like he was exploding. *"Forceful Quirk Activation,"*

It was like every pore in his body was being forced open, and all of his energy was being sucked out. Izuku's hands felt heavy and hot. His eyes flew open, and he *screamed*. Black fire danced in his hands, and from that black fire, demons emerged. The air was filled with their piercing screams, and wails of agony. Izuku's hands flew to his ears, and the fire stopped completely as All For One pulled away.

"Nothing happened, why is he screaming?" Chizome whispered softly, as if he couldn't see all of the demons crammed into the room. Some had horns sharper than anything Izuku had ever seen. Others had red, dripping eyes.

Could it be that Izuku was the only one who could see them? "No it worked," All For One mumbled, "Izuku, control them. I know you can,"

Izuku glared up at him, pressing his hands against his ears in an attempt to block out all the screaming.

"Use your thoughts, and they'll follow your command. They're your demons Izuku, don't be afraid of them,"

But he *was*. There was no way he could just stop this fear in it's tracks.

"Command them Izuku, quit wasting time," All For One snapped, with a low growl. "This fear of yours is a sign of weakness. Destroy it before I destroy *you*,"

"What are you thinking?!" Chizome shouted, and Izuku shrunk back, battling to push his fear away. "You can't just—"

"I'll kill you where you stand, Stain. This isn't your business,"

"He's my apprentice!"

He's my *experiment!*" All For One shouted, "And if I'm going to allow him to attend Yuuei and spy on them, then he needs to meet my standards,"

Izuku blocked out everything, all the wailing, and the arguing. All that was left was silence, and his heavy breathing. He wanted them to go away. He wanted all of the wailing demons to dissappear into thin air.

He took a deep breath, and calmed his panicking heart. He let his hands drop, and cup together. At first nothing seemed to happen as he slowly blinked, keeping his breathing as steady as possible. Then it started slowly. The figures walked closer as if they were being pulled.

One by one each monster got sucked into Izuku's hands. The joints in his hands stung and burned. The energy from the demons he absorbed seemed to vibrate and throb, and All For One stopped mid-sentence to grin. It was a terrifying sight. "Finally," He breathed.

It'd been a few days since Midoriya began his training, and Chizome was determined to save him. He *himself* couldn't do it, but he had followers. He had his Roses, as he liked to call them. They accepted his philosiphy as gospel almost, and often joined him back when he spent most of his time killing corrupted heroes. In case anything should happen to him, he needed them to do his work for him.

Chizome needed to save Midoriya no matter what. So when he entered the abandoned warehouse where his Roses hung out, he held hope in his heart. As soon as the door closed behind him, teenagers and former Pro Heroes stepped into the light. They greeted him with excited grins, and shouts. Chizome waited for them to go silent before he spoke.

"I have a mission for all of you," He said plainly, and his followers smiled slightly. "A dangerous mission," He added.

"Just tell us already!" A girl with blonde hair squealed. Her hair was twisted into twin buns, and the older man next to her with purple tendrils of purple fog jabbed her in the ribs.

"Be quiet now, Himiko"

"Aw you're so mean Kurogiri-chaaan!"

Chizome silenced them with a stare, and continued. "A few months ago I accepted an apprentice. He's not a vigilante, he wants to be a hero. Due to my error, All For One — a villain — has taken an interest in him. As a result he's being forced to spy on Yuuei and develop a Quirk he hates. This is your mission: Should the villains ever use his information he gathers to attack his school and hurt him, go there and protect him, take him away if you have to,"

At first they'd all looked confused but as they listened they seemed to understand. His roses nodded, slowly but surely. "Gladly, Stain," Kurogiri told him, "We'll do as you ask,"

He hoped it'd never come to that. He stayed for awhile, just to indulge his followers and get to know his new members. Most of them were pretty young, almost as young as his apprentice.

Chizome made sure to caution them against doing anything crazy just because he did crazy things. He didn't want to hear about children dying because they'd been imitating him.

He left later at night, and decided to go hunting. Hunting for targets always calmed him, and god only knew how much he deserved a chance to relax right now. He stalked the deserted alleyways and rooftops, looking for a hero to slaughter. It didn't take long for him to find one.

Igenium, speed hero. He wasn't particularly corrupted by any means, but Chizome was itching to get a chance to spill Hero blood. They'd failed him a long, long time ago, and he was still hellbent on revenge no matter what. It didn't matter how many Heroes his sword struck down, he craved more and more. He loved the taste of blood on his tongue, metallic and hot.

Igenium was fast, but Chizome doubted he'd be too hard to kill. He'd killed speed types before, and they'd begged for mercy just like all the rest.

Chizome spent his night stalking his prey, until dawn kissed the sky and the world lit up around him. He retired to his apartment and spent the morning studying Ingenium through video footage shared on the internet. He leaned back in his swivel chair, shoveling chips into his mouth. He shoved all his worries about Midoriya to the back of his mind. He'd figure something out eventually.

For now he needed to focus on something soothing and routine. Everything was stressing him out, and he never made good decisions when he was stressed. He clicked on another video of Ingenium saving a woman from an oncoming car. He got out his knives and started to sharpen them.

Soon they'd be stained with the blood of that hero, and the world would remember to fear the Hero Killer. Soon, a well-known and loved hero would be getting buried deep in the ground, to be forgotten as years went by. It was a shame.

He almost felt bad for Ingenium. Almost.

Act Two: Ain’t No Rest for the Wicked

Chapter Notes

In honor of all holidays, if you celebrate any, I’m posting two chapters!!!!

A month of Quirk training and "Spy training" went by. Izuku was given a break a week or two before the Yuuei's Entrance Exam from All For One's brutal training. School had been let out for a week already. He was drained, and he avoided Kacchan at all costs the entire break. He spent most of it outside too, drawing and trying to calm his nerves.

It never worked, of course. He was frustrated that he hands shook too much, and his artistry suffered for it. His lines were shaky and awkward. It pissed him off, and he found himself tearing page after page out of his notebook. Maybe painting would yield better results?

He knew Yuuei was getting a revamped art program, and maybe he could take part in that. Izuku sighed quietly, and pursed his lips together. In a few hours he’d have to head off to Yuuei, and he wasn’t mentally prepared for the rush of anxiety he would undoubtedly get when faced with huge crowds of people.

“Sleeping in parks again, young man?”

Izuku jumped, and his sketchbook fell into the grass. He recognized that voice. He looked to with right and gave Toshinori a strained grin. “Can I see what you’re drawing?”

Izuku practically lunged for the sketchbook, and Toshinori laughed slightly.

He opened it to a random page. It was messy and dark, with two hands visible, reaching out. Hisashi’s hands, to be precise. They could be All For One's too because they were strong large hands, seeking to crush and destroy. He held it out for Toshinori, hoping he wouldn’t flip too far into the book and see his other, darker drawings. Toshinori took it, and his brows furrowed slightly, before he flipped through eagerly. Izuku glanced away, embarrassed.

Toshinori didn't say anything for awhile. "Yuuei would accept you into it's new art program in a heartbeat if you submitted stuff like this."

Izuku gave him a silent shrug as Toshinori handed him the sketchbook back. "I really mean it. I'll start working there soon, and I could bring some of them for Present Mic to look over, if you want,"

If Izuku could've spoke, he would've jumped up, and said "Could you really!?"

But he couldn't speak, or wouldn't. Either way he gaped at Toshinori, and Toshinori began to smile. "Here, tear off a few pages for me, and I'll deliver them before the entrance exam,"

Izuku didn't need to be told twice. He tore off the page of a simple landscape of flowing grass, and another of that guy's cat named Eclipse. He even tore off a drawing of Kacchan, glaring at him from the corner of his eye. He looked all brooding and angry in that drawing, propping his head up on his hand.

"Theses should be enough to catch Present Mic's attention. Can I have your name— oh wait it's on the edge of this paper! Midoriya Izuku, right?"

Izuku nodded, and Toshinori went off, not wasting a moment. "Good luck on your entrance exam!"

If Izuku had the words, he would've thanked him. But for now he had to meet up with Kacchan, who had been blowing up his phone all break. Izuku finally caved and decided to go with him to the exam, but Kacchan had made him promise they'd hang out beforehand.

He had to stop by Chizome's apartment to grab his sword first. He'd already sent in a support gear application, All For One and Chizome-san helped him with it. Anyway, he made his way into the apartment, pulling out the key from the chain around his wrist. He took it off and opened the door. Chizome was waiting for him, looking a little more relaxed than usual.

"Today's the day, huh?" He mumbled, as he reached for the sword propped up next to him. "You'll definitely pass, Izuku. Don't doubt yourself, you know how to use your Quirk now, and that suppressor around your neck should help you keep from over exerting yourself. I don't care what All For One ordered you to do during this test, but don't go overboard,"

Izuku grinned and nodded. "And do *not* stab anyone with this, you hear me young man?" He rolled his eyes and nodded. Chizome handed over Izuku's katana and Izuku strapped it around his waist.

Chizome stood and hugged him fiercely, like a father would his son. "Do what you have to do, and don't get yourself killed. I'll kill you all over again if you do,"

Izuku nodded, and he gave Edgar the pug a few belly rubs before leaving with his sword at his hip. The sky was clear and bright today, and it was already getting pretty hot despite the early hour.

He weaved his way through the streets, barely seeing the demons that lurked behind and smiled at him with too wide teeth and too white smiles. The Quirk Suppressant cross — for irony — was given to him as a gift from All For One. It would help him control his Quirk enough so he wouldn't hurt someone or himself on accident.

But he'd be taking it off, and he dreaded it. In the month that he'd had it he'd became attached to it. It was his defense against the demons raging, waiting for a command and a chance to deal some damage. It was his only comfort, his semblance of control. Without it he'd over use his Quirk and then— He stopped that thought. He couldn't let himself ponder over it and scare himself all over again.

Izuku would take off his suppressant and he would keep calm and control it. He would only be taking it off for a few minutes. Or seconds. It really depended on his willingness to use his full potential.

He was going to pass, and he would pass in first place. Just like All For One instructed. *"Keep yourself in the spotlight, so they don't see your darkness,"*

Or so he said. Izuku thought it would be better to hide in the shadows he'd ran from all his life. But All For One's word was law, and he would follow it.

Izuku came upon Kacchan's house, and raised his hand to knock when the door flew open. "Izuku!" Auntie Mitsuki shouted. "You're finally here! I have your snacks packed, and no matter what your guys' results are I'm gonna be proud!"

Izuku was crushed in a massive bear hug that only Auntie Mitsuki could deliver with such ferocity. He let himself melt into it, before she let go and thrust a backpack in his hands. "Here are your snacks, and Katsuki's — shove them down his fucking throat if he refuses to eat them — and good luck! Now go, both of you — KATSUKI BAKUGOU GET YOUR FUCKING ASS DOWN HERE THIS INSTANT OR—"

"IM FUCKING COMING GOD FUCKING DAMN YOU OLD HAG—"

"Call me an old hag again, Katsuki. Try me,"

Izuku's eyes went wide, and he grabbed Kacchan by the arm and dragged him away with a wave. Mitsuki smiled a him, and waved back.

Kacchan glared at her the entire time until they turned the corner. Izuku gave him a concerned glance. "She's all worried about both of us. She wants both of us to pass, but she thinks we won'r pass. What she doesn't know is that we can do it,"

Izuku nodded, excited.

"We'll fucking show her,"

Kacchan then launched into a long winded tangent about what the entrance exam could hold for them. He discussed the hero exam for the longest time before switching to the support

entrance exam.

Little did Kacchan know, Izuku planned on taking the hero course entrance exam, and he planned to blow away his competition just like All For One instructed. All he needed to do was take off the suppressant for a few seconds. Nothing more. Then he'd secure his spot at the top of his class.

The two of them walked down the sidewalk toward Yuuei, and Kacchan thankfully filled the silence with words of encouragement. Too quickly they came upon the front gates, where teenagers swarmed. Izuku slammed down on his anxiety, refusing to let it control him. He stuck close to Kacchan, but even then people seemed to overlook him. A guy with crazy purple hair slammed into him, and gave him a fleeting apology that was mostly a mumble.

Kacchan glared at him. "What an ass,"

Izuku jabbed him in the side with his elbow. "Ow! What the hell? You know I'm right!" Kacchan rolled his eyes. "Fine, he's *not* an ass,"

He gave Kacchan a rare smile, and they entered the building together. Izuku pulled out his phone and typed a small message out, preparing for Kacchan's confusion when he didn't leave his side.

Izuku could easily spot the sign that directed him to the support course exam, and even Kacchan pointed it out to him but he shook his head. For a moment Kacchan looked confused, until Izuku handed him his phone.

I lied to you.

"Lied to me about what?"

I never planned on joining the support course.

Kacchan raised an eyebrow, and Izuku quickly typed out an explanation. *I want to be a hero.*

"Then let's go," Kacchan replied, but his eyes promised that he'd be asking a *lot* of questions after this. They entered the massive auditorium and it was already dark and full of people. In spite of that, they still managed to sit together. Present Mic explained the entrance exam quickly. He was loud, but clear and understandable. When he was done, the images of each robot they'd face still projecting against the wall, he spoke.

"Can I get a PLUS ULTRA!?"

The room filled with stiff, awkward silence. "Tough crowd," Present Mic muttered softly, "All of you are to head to your respective zones,"

As it turned out, him and Kacchan ended up in different zones. Izuku was almost relieved, as he stuffed his bandaged hands into the pockets of his hoodie and waited for the exam along with his the other teenagers around him. Most of them where laughing to each other about him being easy to beat. He wrapped his hand around the cross on his neck and rubbed it thoughtfully.

I'll put it right back on. He told himself, as Present Mic gave them a quick review of the rules.

"KILL AS MANY ROBOTS AS HUMANLY POSSIBLE EVERYONE!" He yelled, standing on the massive wall around the fake city where they'd be taking their test. The metal gate sunk into the ground slowly, until there was an opening for everyone to run inside. Everyone waited for a bated breath for instructions.

"Well!? YOUR EXAM BEGINS NOW!"

Izuku was the first to move, already scaling a building with difficulty. He wasn't the best at climbing. Izuku was a powerhouse, not a cat who jumped rooftops for fun. Everyone else rushed by him, and Izuku ignored them all as they cut their way through all the robots. All of

them were in competition for first place, and if Izuku knew what was good for him, he'd be *running* to finish his first mission. He waited because he was curious about everyone's Quirks. Because he wanted everyone to get a chance to pass.

Because he needed to calm himself before jumping off the edge again so soon. Izuku sat down on a rooftop in the middle of the zone, watching with roving eyes and curious glances. His hands shook in his pockets, but when did they not?

He watched as a girl with an anti-gravity Quirk lifted robots into the air and deactivated her Quirk to make them smash into pieces on the ground. He watched as a boy with engine-like leg shot across the streets, taking down robot after robot without breaking so much as a sweat in the process. It was fascinating to watch as robot after robot fell to the hands of teenagers, and reappear just as quickly.

A boy with purple hair caught his attention instantly, using only a crowbar to destroy robots. He wondered vaguely what his Quirk was.

I hope he passes. I mean, he' not even using a Quirk and he's destroying robot after robot.

Izuku tore his eyes away from the kid only because he was painfully aware that he had no points whatsoever, and that someone or something was watching him. A little drone hovered by him, and he gave it a meek wave. He figured it was the way teachers watched the entrance exam as it progressed. Maybe they were curious about him.

It flew away, and Izuku went back to watching everyone destroy more and more robots. He'd do it soon. He just needed to gather the courage.

It'll just be a minute.

He rubbed at his cross again, and listened as Present Mic called for them to hurry up. One minute was left. The drone flew by again, and stayed fixated on him. He stared at it, and stood.

One hand rested on his weapon, and the other gripped his cross in a death grip. The drone seemed to follow him as he peered over the edge of the building, and the ground began to tremble and shake.

Izuku raised an eyebrow as a zero pointer emerged, destroying sky-scrapers in the process. People scrambled to run away, but Izuku didn't join them. There were still hundreds of robots to destroy still, and the girl with the anti-gravity Quirk seemed to be trapped. His heart squeezed in his chest, and he ripped off his cross. Izuku unsheathed his sword, and the world shuddered in response.

His power tasted like iron in the air, like blood.

He jumped to the next roof, past the girl with the anti-gravity quirk, and stood face-to-face with the zero pointer. It raised it's big metal arm, ready to destroy him, but Izuku merely stared at it, eyes blank and his mouth a thin line.

Dabi materialized from his sword and bowed to him, all dark scars and blue fire. "Your orders?" Dabi asked, with a devilish smile.

Izuku matched his grin, and gave him one single command, and all the robots in the zone fell. One by one, until the zero pointer itself was the last one standing.

He pointed his sword toward it, the very end of the blade coming up to touch the cool metal. The robot flew backwards like it had been hit, it's massive body slamming into every possible building as it finally crashed to the ground. *Destroy.*

And Dabi had done exactly that, without moving a muscle. Izuku carefully put his cross back on and sheathed his sword. Dabi vanished, and Izuku clambered down the building he'd been standing on. The girl he saved hugged him immediately, gushing her thanks and gratitude.

"Thank you so much! You didn't have to do that!"

Izuku awkwardly smiled and scooted away. A blush rose to his cheeks, and shoulders. Suddenly his hoodie was too hot as he panicked.

He couldn't exactly tell her not to worry about it, and she looked at him with her brows furrowed. Izuku felt bad, and embarrassed as she let the subject drop. It was a small blessing, as they left the entrance exam zones and headed back for the school where all their things were.

He was half way through gathering his stuff and eating a sandwich when he found Kacchan and offered him a bag of chips. Kacchan walked him home, and they stood at Dagobah beach which was still full of trash.

"Explain," He grumbled, his anger hitting Izuku like a tidal wave. Izuku took a cautious step back, and glanced around. Anywhere but at those burning angry eyes that reminded him too much of his fathers. Fear reared it's head in his mind, like an unwelcome guest. He sucked on his lower lip, trying to get rid of the anxiety tightening in his chest.

A number of demons stood around, grinning at him from the shadows. He grabbed the nearest one and pushed his energy into it, and Izuku took another step back. He knew from the terrified look on Kacchan's face that it worked and Kacchan could see it too.

"Hello...." The demon croaked with a toothy smile, and Kacchan paled, and still said nothing.

Izuku let his hands fall to his sides and he *pulled*. He felt a slight tug in his chest before the demon vanished, it's power brimming just under Izuku's skin. "What...?"

He waited silently for the inevitable rejection and disgust. He waited for Kacchan to hate him, and yell at him. He waited, but none of that happened. "This is your Quirk? Why would you keep a secret for so long?"

Izuku shrugged, and Kacchan roared with laughter. "With a fucking Quirk like that you'll have all the stupid ass villains running for their lives!"

He couldn't help but smile. After Kacchan collected himself, he walked all the way home with Izuku until they were at the front door of his house. "Text me when you get your acceptance letter, damn nerd,"

Izuku nodded, and swung open the door to deliver the news to Hisashi. Kacchan seemed reluctant to leave, but he shut the door on him nonetheless. Hisashi was waiting for him in the kitchen, and Izuku stopped a good ways away. "Well?" Hisashi snapped, "Did you do well?"

He nodded slightly, and Hisashi frowned. He stood from his chair, and circled around Izuku. Like a lion with a gazelle. Izuku watched with sharp eyes, too frozen to move. "You can't mess this up for us," Hisashi whispered as he rested his hand on the back of Izuku's neck, the hand that brought unending pain. "You understand that, don't you?"

Izuku's mouth went dry, as pain assaulted him from every inch of his body. He tensed up, almost like he was about to start seizing up. *"Do you understand?!"*

He fought the urge to scream and cry. He ignored the memories itching at the darkest part of his mind, and managed a nod. His vision seemed to blur as Hisashi's grip tightened and stayed firm.

"That's good," Hisashi mumbled, with a soft smile. Izuku sucked in a shallow breath, before wheezing right back out. His entire body was crying out for the pain to end, but Hisashi didn't look inclined to do so.

"Oh, am I hurting you?" He mumbled harshly, his breath hot on Izuku's ear. "I'm sorry. I didn't realize,"

Then, as quickly as the pain came, it was gone. Izuku dropped to the floor, gasping and retching. Hisashi gave a disgusted sigh, and took a seat at the kitchen chair again. "Go see that crazy ass mentor of yours and spread the news,"

Izuku was only too happy to comply, scrambling for the door.

Chizome had been waiting all day for this. Tensei Iida was walking home after a patrol, and his younger brother decided to meet with him. It wasn't ideal, but Chizome could roll with it. It didn't bother him in the least.

He wouldn't kill the kid. He'd paralyze him and knock him out, and then kill his brother. The streets would be stained with the blood of Ingenium before the night was over. Chizome was itching for his desire to come to fruition, as he stalked Tensei. The Speed Hero and his younger brother entered an alleyway, talking away, nonplussed by the darkness descending upon them as the sun began to set.

Now would be the ideal time to strike, if ever. Tensei's guard was down, and Chizome had leverage over him. Tensei had to protect his brother, and that would lead to his downfall.

Chizome slowly climbed down the wall of a tall building and landed lightly on his feet. The alley was dark, and dingy. He could barely see, but he got his knives and swords ready. He strode forward, his grin full of malice and hatred. "Ingenium," he grumbled, "A pleasure to see you,"

Tensei whipped around, his eyes wide and alarmed. They didn't call him the Speed Hero for nothing. "The Hero Killer, Stain," He breathed, before he shifted into a defensive stance.

Chizome's sword screeched as he pulled it out of it's sheath, and he grinned at the two brothers. One of whom would be dying tonight, if he had anything to do about it. Tensei glared at him, but Stain could smell the fear coming off him in waves.

"Why are you doing this?" Tensei asked.

"Because the world of Heroes is corrupt, why else?" Stain snapped, "It's a blight upon us all, and only true heroes — like All Might — deserve the title of Pro Hero!"

"Tenya," Tensei said stiffly, "Run for help,"

"No! I'm not running while you face this — this villain!"

Stain nearly rolled his eyes in exasperation. "Good because I don't plan on either of you leaving alive,"

A lie, of course but they didn't know that. Stain wasn't into killing kids.

Tensei ran for him, and Stain grinned. His moves were too predictable as as sent a flurry of kicks Stain's way. Stain dodged them easily, managing to land a single cut. That's all he needed.

A single drop, to paralyze him long enough to deliver the killing blow. Tensei dropped as soon as Stain's tongue flicked along the blade of his knife, the taste of iron lingering on his tongue.

This would end almost too quickly, as Stain walked over to where Tensei laid, his eyes wide and terrified. His katana was already out and he raised it, but never got the chance to deliver the last blow. That pain in the ass brother of Tensei's had tackled him. Stain growled, and threw his sword away in favor for his knife. "Tenya no!" Tensei screamed. It was an ugly, sob filled scream.

A scream that made Stain grin, as he wrapped his fist around Tenya's neck and slammed him into the pavement. His knife glinted in the moonlight, as he plunged it into Tenya's arm. The boy screamed, and Stain retracted the knife and licked it clean.

Now both of the Iida brothers laid paralyzed on the pavement, and Stain had his chance.

He decided he wanted to have fun, as he drew another knife from it's sheath. He wasn't thinking about what his apprentice would think of him as he stabbed Tensei in the stomach. He wasn't thinking about how his apprentice would feel as he sliced Tensei open elbow to forearm. He wasn't thinking about how this would affect his apprentice if word ever got out that he trained Izuku as he stabbed Tensei again.

He wasn't thinking of anything but blood.

After all, he was truly a murderer at heart, no matter how much he wanted to protect Izuku from harm.

He still loved to kill. But he never thought that one day, he might be the one getting killed. It all happened so quickly, that Stain had no time to react as one of his own knives went flying for him.

It hit him in the shoulder, and another one found it's way into his stomach. He stumbled, and glared at the stranger standing in the alleyway, only it wasn't a stranger at all.

It was Izuku.

Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

2 chapters today!!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku had been looking through Chizome's apartment for him all night. He wasn't concerned at first, and he'd spent a good ten minutes playing with Edgar. But then, out of nowhere he had the urge to look for him, as it got later and later. He called him first but got no answer. Izuku looked through the apartment again, just to be sure.

Then he looked through Chizome-san's computer history, as the thing was still running. What he found made his blood run cold. Not for his mentor, but for who his mentor was surely out killing right this second.

Youtube Video: Ingenium saves a girl from an oncoming train.

Ingenium saves a dog.

Ingenium rises in the ranks of the Hero Industry!

Ingenium's Quirk Explained.

10 reasons Ingenium is the best hero ever (A Quirk Analysis!)

On the desk, he saw Chizome's in-depth analysis of his own, accompanied by notes of where Ingenium would be. Where he patrolled. Where he lived. His real name. His family. How to

kill him. Izuku clenched his jaw and grabbed his sword, almost running. He slammed the door behind him, his sword in hand as he took the apartment stairs two at a time.

He needed to get there and convince Chizome to stop before he did anything stupid. He picked up his pace as the clock on his phone reached midnight. Now he was sprinting, shoving people out of his way without so much as a word.

He even came across that man he'd seen at the convenience store — the one with the cat who had also been at Recovery Girl's nurse's office. Izuku ran past, and the man shouted after him, "Is there something wrong?!"

Izuku prayed that the man wouldn't follow him. He didn't have time to explain, nor could he if that man saw him trying to placate a murderer. Izuku cursed himself. For as much as he loved and respected Chizome-san, he should've known that he'd keep going after Heroes. Why did he even think that for one second Chizome would stop killing?

What was *wrong* with him?!

He should've been keeping an eye on his mentor. Who else has he killed during their time together? Who else could've been saved if Izuku had stopped Chizome-san?

He pushed those thoughts away, but the anger and horror still stung deep as he weaved through dark alleyways. He should be getting there soon. He could still save Tensei and save Chizome-san too.

His hands went to his knives, hidden in his hoodie as he heard the sound of knives singing in the darkness. His power rumbled inside, and he let it loose. He ran even faster, with the dark energy running through his veins.

Izuku skidded to a stop at the bloodshed. His eyes widened, and he fought the urge to be sick. Chizome-san was standing over Tensei, the Speed Hero, sword positioned to strike him dead once and for all.

He didn't have time to convince Chizome. He didn't even have time to think as his knives went flying. One in the shoulder, and one in the stomach.

Tensei was limp and still, blood oozing from every cut and stab wound. Izuku had to look away to keep himself from throwing up. He drew his sword in one fluid motion. The alleyway was silent as Chizome spat blood and smiled sadly at him.

It all happened so fast. Izuku's sword screeched as it was released from its scabbard, and Chizome yanked out the knives protruding from his body. They ran for each other, Chizome wild and ravenous for blood, Izuku fast and brutal with his sword clashing against Chizome's. They collided, they're swords squealing loudly in the dead silence. Chizome was so *fast*, as he sent a flurry of strikes Izuku's way. Izuku matched him blow for blow in a deadly waltz.

Izuku didn't even notice Tenya gaping at him silently from his heap on the ground. "My own apprentice, trying to kill me," Chizome said, looking sad and proud.

He kept his mouth in a thin, determined line. Black ink-like tendrils of dark energy danced around them. Demons summoned themselves, jeering and watching from every corner. Izuku kept his eyes on his mentor, as Chizome swung wildly like he was drunk, his eyes wide and excited. He kept looking around him as if he could see the demons screaming. Maybe he could.

Izuku grit his teeth, and the demons howled as he dodged and kicked Chizome's sword right out of his hands.

The sword clattered to the ground loudly, and Chizome drew his knives. He jumped back and darted around, using the walls to propel himself. Izuku gripped his sword tighter. Chizome came from the left, and Izuku turned away, his sword slapping the knife away. "He sure taught you how to fight better than I did, huh?"

Izuku shook his head. "No, you're right. Not even All For One can make fighting look like a dance like you can. You'll truly make a great hero,"

Chizome-san from the right this time, and Izuku was prepared to meet him knife for blade again, but Chizome left himself open instead. Izuku was too quick, and his blade went straight through Chizome-san's chest.

The world seemed to freeze. Izuku let go of his blade, watching Chizome fall. Izuku went to his knees, his face frozen in shock. He'd just killed someone. He'd just killed the Hero Killer.

He'd just killed his only *father* figure. Chizome reached up a hand, to touch his cheek, as blood poured from his lips. Izuku's eyes were wide, and he could feel every cell in his body freezing in shock. He found feel tears pricking at the edges of his eyes. He could feel horror and self-loathing crash into him in waves.

Izuku hovered over him, shaking and barely breathing. "You know," He began, before spitting up blood. There was so much blood. *He'd killed him.* "I always knew you'd be the one to kill me,"

Izuku blinked past his tears and sorrow and shook his head. No. This couldn't be happening. Why was he talking like this? Izuku could still call 9-1-1, he could save him. he could— "I could only teach you so much. I couldn't protect you from *him*. You have such a big heart for a boy who's been through what you've been through. Become a hero, and *stain the roses red with his blood."*

Chizome guided Izuku's hand to his blade that protruded from his chest. The blade had returned to its true form, broken and bent. As his fingers wrapped around it, the blade became pristine and brand-new. "Kill me, and then you find a way to save yourself."

Izuku shook his head again, his tears coming in waves. "It's okay," Chizome whispered, his hand on his face still warm despite all the blood he was loosing. "It's okay. Be a hero, son. Become the next symbol of peace, and show the world what you're made of. It's okay,"

He gasped as Chizome wrapped his own bloody hand around Izuku's and lifted the blade from his chest. "You're my *hero*, Izuku Midoriya,"

And then he plunged the sword back down, and his eyes lost all their light.

If you asked him a few hours later, what he did after killing Stain he'd tell you he was in shock. He took his blade out and wiped at his tears again and again. He grabbed his phone and dialed 9-1-1, and summoned Dabi and made him speak into it for him.

He took a moment to grieve for Stain, and then he took Stain's knives and katana. He took his red scarf, and held it in his hands for a moment. He looked over Ingenium, glad to only find his unconscious with a few cuts and bruises. But as he inspected him more closely he realize Stain must've gotten him pretty good. Blood was pouring from the wound in his stomach. With trembling hands he ripped apart Ingenium's bloody shirt. He ripped the cloth into thin strips and wrapped it around his abdomen, staunching the flow of blood.

As soon as he was sure that Tensei wouldn't bleed out, he looked around. His eyes went to Iida, and he headed over to make sure he was fine. The boy's eyes were closed, and he didn't look like he was hurt. He turned back to Chizome's body.

"You saved both of them, Izuku," Dabi said gently. "It's not your fault Chizome tried to kill Ingenium,"

Then Izuku heard the sirens, and he sent one last look toward Chizome-san's body. He was reluctant to leave it as it was. He wanted to be there when police found it, and found his victims. He wanted to be near Chizome as he was finally taken away. With guilt heavy in his heart, he left the scene, feeling nothing but agony and horror. He went to Chizome's apartment and locked the door behind him.

Izuku let himself slide down the door, and sit there with his knees hugged to his chest. He sat in complete silence for the longest time, even as Edgar came to beg for pets and cuddles. His body was wracked with hiccupping cries and sobs that ripped his throat apart. He sat for a long while, wiping his tears and trembling. He'd killed Chizome-san. He was in his *apartment*, covered in his *blood*.

He was covered in Chizome's blood.

He made no move to change or clean himself. For a while, he just sat there his eyes roving around the pictures of Chizome smiling with Edgar. He found a picture of himself and

Chizome too, nearby to where he sat. He didn't make any moves to grab it. He just sat there silently, crying his heart out until Edgar started to lick his bloody hands with a snort. Then he had to change and clean himself up. He let Edgar follow him as he grabbed some extra clothes of his that Chizome took upon himself to steal from Izuku's room. He took a shower, scrubbing himself raw until he emerged.

Izuku wasn't even thinking about how fucking livid his parents were going to be when they found out. He didn't even want to think about what All For One would do. He just wrapped his arms around himself and turned on the TV to check the news. He would go home once he was sure he hadn't killed his mentor for no reason. He was almost relieved at what he heard.

"Just last night the Hero Killer Stain had attacked and critically injured the Pro Hero Ingenium and stabbed his younger brother. Luckily someone — neither of them know exactly who it was, or if they were even a fellow Hero — but this man killed Stain and saved the lives of both the Pro Hero and his brother. We give our thanks to this mysterious Hero, and we're all praying for Ingenium's speedy recovery. According to doctors, Ingenium was in critical condition but seems to be stable. His brother is to be released from the hospital in a few hours. Whoever that Hero was who put a stop to the terror of Stain, we are lucky to have him,"

Izuku went through everything in Chizome's apartment, taking everything incriminating just in case the police investigated the place. He even took Edgar and his bloody clothes. He stuffed the picture of Chizome and him in a bag along with his other stuff. He took a picture of Chizome with Edgar. He stayed in the center of the apartment, soaking it all in for a moment.

This was the last time he'd see this place. This was the last time. He wiped away the tears that threatened to consume him again.

His sword was still covered in blood, but he put it away in its sheath before he headed out and he went to Kacchan's.

He was quick about it, knowing his parents would already be suspecting something of him if he didn't return soon. He knocked on Kacchan's door, holding the dog in his arms. Kacchan raised an eyebrow, looking tired and exhausted. "'Zuku, why do you have a dog,"

Izuku gave him a flat smile. Kacchan sighed. "Are you serious right now?"

He nodded. "And you want me to keep the dog?"

He nodded again.

Kacchan glared at him but took the dog anyway. "Fine, I'll try to convince my mom to keep it,"

Izuku hugged him, and Kacchan blushed slightly and grumbled, "Alright, alright you're welcome. Don't come to me with any more animals you got that? Just this once."

He smiled at him, and Kacchan rolled his eyes. "Do you... wanna come in? I'm gonna go back to bed if you wanna crash here all day,"

Izuku's smile faltered, and he shook his head. He'd just *killed* someone. He didn't think he'd ever be able to act normal around Kacchan now that he had blood on his hands. He was no better than Stain, after what he did.

"Damn it alright, don't forget to text me an explanation about this damn dog,"

Then Izuku went home. The walk there was too short, and he found himself wanting to run away. But he didn't. He couldn't. They would find him. He opened the door, and Inko was already standing there, with her arms crossed.

"Did you hear about Stain?" Inko asked snappily. Izuku froze him fear, before nodding. "And where were you last night?"

Izuku shrugged, ducking his head. His sword gently floated out of its sheath due to Inko's Quirk, and Inko glared at him. Izuku kept his eyes on the bloody sword. "You killed Stain!" She shouted. "You killed him!?"

Izuku's lips began to tremble and his vision darkened at the corners. "HISASHI!" She howled, gripping the sword tightly. Izuku couldn't stop his shaking as Hisashi ran into the room, looking disheveled.

"What is it Inko—" Then his eyes landed on Izuku's sword. "You...*you* did this!"

The anger and sorrow was like a death sentence in itself. "We...we..." Inko began, her voice trembling.

"We have to call All For One," Hisashi said flatly. "He'll decide what to do to him,"

"Right...right..." Inko muttered, "He'll know what to do,"

Izuku didn't move, as Ink grabbed her phone and Hisashi glared at him, his glare like icy daggers in his heart. He felt so, so guilty, he hated himself and most of all he hated his power.

Even with the suppressant, it was too much.

It was all his fault. He killed Stain. He got this Quirk. He was born. It was his fault. He shouldn't have been born. Now he was going to suffer a fate worse than death. He let himself get shoved into the purple inky portal that appeared. He let himself be dragged in front of All For One, restrained by his own mother and father.

"You two say he killed Stain," All For One began, as he leaned down to face Izuku. He grabbed him by the chin and stared right into his eyes like he could already tell the answer. "Did you?"

There was no point in lying. So he nodded, and All For One spat on his face. "What the hell where you thinking, my boy?" He asked calmly, but Izuku could see the stormy sea of anger swirling in his eyes.

"Did you think you were saving them? You weren't. You aren't a hero, you aren't *anything*. You're *my* spy, Izuku. You can't be running around possibly blowing your cover before the school year even begins. Do you realize how reckless you are!?"

Izuku clenched his jaw and gave him a terrified nod. "You don't ever do anything without my permission! Do you understand me!? I'll have you killed where you stand!"

"Sir," Hisashi began, after a beat of silence. "Shouldn't he be punished? He killed *Stain!"*

All For One looked at Izuku, and then to his father. "Yes, of course. Do what you will, Hisashi, Inko. He's your son, therefore you get the pleasure of teaching him a lesson, *again.* Make sure you don't kill him,"

Shouta was concerned and confused. The results of the entrance exam were instantaneous. The part that took the longest was compiling the students who got in and the ones who didn't.

Then they had to record every single video for the ones who got in, and an apology letter for the ones who didn't. Shouta had finished all of the ones for his class, and now he and Hizashi were sitting outside enjoying their break.

"Shouta," Hizashi mumbled, "You've been out of it for a few days, is something wrong?"

Yes, there was. He'd seen Izuku Midoriya again, and he'd blown away the teachers within a matter of a few seconds. He could still remember the footage their drone caught. He could still remember how Nedzu had been intrigued.

"Ah, Ectoplasm could you direct the drone over to the student who still hasn't gotten a single point yet? The Quirkless one, Midoriya Izuku. I'm interested to see what he'll do,"

As instructed Ectoplasm moved the drone to follow Midoriya. They all watched as Midoriya sat on the edge of a rooftop, watching the other students. The boy waved meekly at the drone. "What is he doing?" All Might asked.

"I'm not sure," Nedzu replied, "Send in the Zero Pointer,"

From the drone, they could see the ground shake, and the boy raised an eyebrow. The huge robot emerged, knocking over buildings in its wake. "Surely he'll do something now," Ectoplasm mumbled.

He was right.

With thirty seconds to spare, Midoriya stood, and Nedzu leaned forward in his chair. "What'll he do?" He asked to no one in particular. "Will he try to destroy it with just that sword?"

"That boy won't do anything," Recovery Girl snapped, "A friend of mine came to me begging me to heal that boy. His hands are completely destroyed. He shouldn't even be able to lift a sword, nor destroy that robot,"

Recovery Girl was right about his hands. They were heavily bandaged, but he didn't do nothing as everyone thought he would. He ripped off his cross, and the footage from the drone blacked out for a second.

He drew his sword, fluid and quick. He jumped off the rooftop onto the next. And something materialized beside him, but the camera footage turned blurry. "Your orders...?" The voice croaked.

Midoriya said nothing, but that seemed to be enough for that person. Blue flame danced in his hands, and without even moving the robots fell, one by one. They only robot left standing was the Zero Pointer. Nedzu clapped, with a wide smile. "I have no idea what just happened, but what an interesting Quirk! Such power, to take down all of the robots in one move—!"

But Nedzu stopped mid-sentence as Izuku swung his sword toward the massive robot as it raised an enormous hand to destroy him. The end of his blade touched the metal, and Shouta watched with wide eyes as the robot flew back, before falling a long ways away, leaving a ravine where it had once been.

"Oh my god," Midnight gasped, "What was *that?"*

"He didn't even move!" Hizashi yelled, his eyes wide with shock.

"What a powerful Quirk!" All Might added as everyone watched Midoriya put away his sword.

All Shouta could think while Midoriya put on his cross again was, why? Why would his ID say he was Quirkless?

"That— That should be impossible! His hands were absolutely crushed just a few weeks ago!" Recovery Girl told them all. "He had months of recovery before he could even hold anything!"

Nedzu ignored her. "How did Midoriya Izuku place?"

Instantly, the video footage changed and it displayed the top ten students. Izuku was tied for first place with Bakugou Katsuki. "Oh this is interesting," Nedzu told them, "Not only is this the first tie since All Might attended Yuuei, but they know each other. Childhood friends actually. Could we go to Bakugou's footage?"

Shouta was suspicious. "I feel like I've met Midoriya somewhere before, a long time ago."

Hizashi thought for a moment, before jumping up from his seat. "Oh! I know! Remember when we were younger and we were chasing this shooter? Do you remember how we lost

him, but then found him in a park?"

Shouta sighed. "What does this have to do with—"

"The shooter almost shot Midoriya and Bakugou!" Hizashi reminded him, "Do you remember that?"

For a few seconds, he thought his husband was going crazy, but then he suddenly remembered. "Yeah...yeah, I do,"

"Is that's what's bothering you?"

"Well, I'm worried about him,"

"Oh. My. God. Aizawa Shouta is worrying about a student?" His husband exclaimed dramatically. "Am I dreaming?!"

"Shut *up*," Shouta snapped. "I really am worried. Something's off about him,"

"What do you mean? Do you think he's crazy or something?"

"He's mute, and he doesn't know how to sign. Sometimes he'll not come out of his house for days," Shouta confessed, "I've been watching him after I ran into him at a convenience store. Something's very wrong about him,"

"Oh come on Shouta, you don't know that,"

"Yes, I do."

"Just wait until you start teaching him, maybe you're wrong,"

Shouta had a feeling Hizashi was the one that was wrong.

Chapter End Notes

I’m sorry T^T here's the discord invite!

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

they can say, they can say I'm crazy -- these plot points make so sense. lmao

https://discord.gg/BdGsq8Z

-my discord server c:

All Might — Yagi Toshinori — had been helping Shouta, Hizashi, and Nedzu go through the many many applications for the art scholarship. Shouta had been going through them all week, and he was glad that All Might was here with his enhanced speed. They flew through most of them pretty quickly, quickly enough that they could take breaks in between each one.

The office was pretty quiet as they sipped their coffee, and Hizashi gushed about the sheer talent of every applicant. "I mean come on! Look at that shading! Absolutely impeccable, and did you see the way that kid used make-up products instead of paint or other mediums?"

Shouta nodded indulgently. He always loved to listen to Hizashi ramble on and on about art, and this was the only time Hizashi could really do so. "I agree! We're going to have an interesting elective art class this year!"

"I sure hope so!" Hizashi shouted, jumping up from his chair. "Let's look through all of them already! I'm too excited!"

Hizashi snatched up the papers out of All Might's hands, and his face quickly became pale. "What is it, Present Mic?" Nedzu asked, concerned.

Shouta leaned closer and looked over Hizashi's shoulder, curious. What he saw made him almost jump. It was so detailed and dark. It was a couple of papers, all of them filled with

these kinds of drawings, and on the corner of each of them was a scrawled name in small messy print.

A name Shouta recognized.

Izuku Midoriya.

One after another, they flipped through the papers. All Might awkwardly cleared his throat, but Shouta spoke first. "I know who drew these," He told them all. "Midoriya Izuku, the kid who destroyed the zero pointer without even touching it,"

"I-I know him too, but he knows me as Yagi," All Might said, "I submitted these for him,"

"And it seems someone else had the same idea," Nedzu told them. "I had the boy he tied with for first place come to me after the exam and hand me *this*,"

He put a notebook on the table. "He said Midoriya was amazing at art, even if his style is dark and morbid. He begged me to accept him, telling me he *needed* to be accepted, Bakugou doesn't even know what's in it,"

"So he didn't submit the art himself? Other people did it for him? Does he even know?" Shouta asked.

"Well, he knew I'd submit these for him," All Might gesture to the loose papers on the table.

They all looked at the drawings and then moved onto the notebook. If the drawings he gave to All Might were bad, then the ones in his notebook were worse. They all crowded around Hizashi as they flipped through it.

They saw demons. Saw Bakugou, with a smile, a scowl, a grimace, a glare, a frown. "That kid looks like trouble," All Might muttered, as they continued on.

"I don't think so," Shouta commented. Each drawing was darker than the last. Creeper, and sadder.

They saw utter darkness. They saw Izuku on his bed, with his knees drawn to his chest, a demon looming over him as he cried. "These are really good," Hizashi said quietly. "Scary and sad, but good,"

They saw demons screaming, and tearing off their darkened skin. They saw strong hands reaching out from the darkness. One drawing wasn't a drawing at all. It was words. *I WANT TO HELP YOU BECOME A HERO.*

"Maybe he has a mentor?" Hizashi theorized as they kept going.

Then they saw a drawing that made them go quiet. It made Shouta choke on his words and ignited anger in his chest, as he stared at it. Hizashi paused for a moment, his eyes boring into the image.

Izuku was in the center of the drawing, tied to a chair, with a band of cloth around his mouth to keep him from speaking. The entire drawing was covered in black charcoal, except for the rough words written over and over in the image.

Written across the cloth tied over his mouth, was the word SPEECHLESS. Rough, and angry.

Around him, some of them overlapping, and some unintelligible were words. QUIRKLESS, QUIRKLESS, QUIRKLESS, SHUT UP. STOP TALKING. SHUT UP. SHUT UP. KEEP QUIET. QUIRKLESS. USELESS. NOTHING. SHUT UP, SHUT UP, SHUT UP, YOU'RE QUIRKLESS.

Shouta stared at the drawing for a long time. He noticed how calm Izuku seemed in the image as if these were his own thoughts. After a long awkward silence, Hizashi continued through the notebook, they came across the man named Chizome. Shouta recognized him instantly.

They even saw a picture of Eclipse, and Shouta grinned.

Then that grin dropped away. They went to one of the last drawings.

It was Bakugou, glaring at Izuku something fierce. In the drawing, he was yelling at Izuku. “Take a swan dive off the roof. I hate you,”

Shouta frowned. “Maybe he’s afraid his friend secretly hates him?” Present Mic muttered.

”Or maybe not. He has a history of occasion violence,” Nedzu told them.

“He was defending him,” Shouta assured them. "They're childhood friends. He'd only ever fought other kids on Midoriya's behalf,"

At last, they reached the last drawing. One that made Shouta completely blank. All Might had gone pale, and his hero form deflated upon seeing the drawing.

It was a beautifully gruesome drawing. As if Midoriya had poured his soul into it.

It was All Might in his hero form, holding a limp, bloody figure by the neck. Angel wings protruded from his back, and Shouta moved onto the figure getting choked in the picture.

It took him a moment to realize who it was.

It was Izuku, with bat wings dragging limply on the ground. Demon wings. Around All Might and Izuku was an absolutely destroyed terrain.

Blood dribbled down All Might's chin. He wasn't smiling.

Five words were written across the page.

YOU'LL NEVER BE A HERO.

Shouta shut the book. "I think we all know who we're giving the scholarship to?"

"Izuku Midoriya, by a landslide," Nedzu mumbled.

"Agreed,"

"We'll send his acceptance letter with his scholarship acceptance," Nedzu told them. "We should keep a good eye on this boy,"

He couldn't breathe. He could feel hands holding his head down in the freezing water, his mother's hands.

They were in a dark, dark room with a single tub in the middle. His hands had been bound, like his ankles.

Then she pushed his head into the icy depths, cruel and grinning as he twisted and flailed.

His terror flared, as all the air in his lungs slowly left. His mother's cruel hands held him down as air bubbles surfaced, and he fought for air. Even just a second.

His face went numb after just a few seconds. Then she yanked on his hair, and sweet sweet oxygen filled his lungs.

Then his head was thrust underwater again. An eternity seemed to go by as his body *screamed*.

His heart pulled in his chest, and his lungs spasmed in an attempt to find air. He swallowed a mouthful of the freezing water, and tears filled his eyes as all his oxygen escaped him.

His body seized and fought. *I need air. I need air. I can't breathe.*

Make it stop. Kill me. Just kill me.

Izuku's mind screamed, fought and begged for it to end.

He couldn't take much more, and just as he thought his body was about to give in, Inko pulled him out.

Tears flooded down his face, and water splattered to the floor from his mouth. He sucked in a deep wet breath, and he was put under again. He could only take so much before all the fight let him.

That's what they wanted. What they craved.

...And it was beautifully tempting to do so.

He craved it almost as much as they did. But a voice nagged at him. From a video, he'd seen as a kid, from the small tablet of his.

When you think you can't go on anymore look inside. Remember why it is you clench your fist. Your past, remember where you came from. Keeping your origin in mind will help push you past your limit.

Izuku only recalled those words right at this moment. When he needed them most. When he was walking the dark road once more, surrounded on all sides. While walking the tightrope of good and evil. Of giving in or fighting.

"I want to help you become a hero,"

That was his beginning. That was his origin. His lungs went numb, as the freezing water went still around him. His arms and shoulders went limp and put all his energy into pushing his head up. She would tire eventually.

Her hands gripped his curly hair tightly, but he lifted his head out of the water slowly and gasped gratefully as air filled his lungs.

Another pair of hands pushed him back down. Izuku couldn't feel the pain this time, as he felt the rope around his hands loosen. His deception had worked. They'd been too worried about him breathing to notice he was freeing himself.

With his hands free, his Quirk would save him. The building pressure in his chest wouldn't last much longer, he promised himself.

He quickly placed his hands on the tub, and let his power explode outward in a blast of inky black power. The tub exploded, and Izuku fell forward with his parents collapsing nearby.

He gasped down air and went to untie his feet. With trembling fingers, he loosened his ankles and got to his feet.

He whirled on his parents, his trembling hands ready to release a wave of power. He walked around them as they crawled to their feet. He went straight to the door, but two cold strong hands wrapped around the side of his head. They burned against his cold skin, and pain shattered him. Panic broke him, both mingling and stripping him bare of all thought and function.

So much pain, and terror.

Tears welled up in his eyes, as his knees gave out. He realized that ear-piercing noise was his own screaming. His own agony and fear, colliding in one primal noise that filled the silence.

Coherent thought was impossible. Moving was not even an option. He could do nothing but scream, low and tortured, as those hands held him firmly.

Izuku didn't even remember vomiting onto the floor and all over his clothes. He didn't remember getting carted off to a different room, strapped to a bed. He didn't remember Hisashi even letting go after All For One told him Izuku could rest until he lessons began anew the next morning.

He only knew pain and fear. He woke up the next day, head pounding, and strapped to a chair. Izuku was delirious for a moment before he stared wide-eyed at Inko holding a pair of scissors.

He tried to move, but his restraints were iron clamps, stained a brownish color that reminded him of blood.

On the wall next to her were weapons, and Izuku whimpered quietly. She ripped open his shirt and set the scissors down. Izuku's labored and terrified breathing filled the air as the lights flickered. Inko looked unperturbed by it, and Izuku could suppress the terror that flickered through him as the world went dark for less than a second.

Her hand wrapped around a dagger, and she admired it for a second. “Blindfold him and cover his mouth,” Inko demanded.

From behind someone gagged him and wrapped a blindfold over his eyes.

Then he felt the cold metal against his stomach. Fear drowned him, and Inko pressed the tip of the blade into his muscled skin.

He has originally thought she was going to stab him, but then she began to carve him like a piece of meat. His skin burned, sharp and excruciating. The pain settled in his core, tearing at him and ripping him apart. He had no way of knowing what she was carving into his skin, but he screamed. It was muffled by the gag, but it burned his throat, the sound rough and loud.

Hot blood poured into his lap, and he didn’t stop thrashing and howling in pain.

For a moment the knife slid away, before plunging itself back into his flesh.

Again and again. A scream followed by a scream, letter after letter.

Blood and pain.

After what felt like hours, Inko set the knife down with a clatter. Izuku’s stomach exploded with agony with each breath. He didn’t dare breathe too deeply, as he tried to catch his breath in the midst of the pain.

For a moment, Inko seemed to just revel in his pain. Then, quick and sharp pain radiated from his hand. Horrible pain, as his hands seemed to remember every second of pain he’d ever had.

His hand jerked but stayed put, as Inko ripped off the next nail. Izuku bit down on his scream, as his fingers throbbed. Sweat dripped down his forehead, and he felt dizzy. "My turn, Inko,"

Izuku recognized Hisashi's rough voice and balled up fists, as he tried to ignore his mounting pain. Hisashi took Inko's place, and the door shut behind her with a soft click. Overwhelming panic crashed into him, as Hisashi touched his face. "What should I do with you today?" He asked himself.

He thrashed, trying to escape. "Stop," Hisashi snapped, *"Stop!"*

Izuku refused, as he slammed his wrists against the iron restraints. They were freezing, but Izuku didn't care. He just needed to leave, and never come back. *He wanted out. He wanted out!*

Panicking, he thrashed again. He didn't care about being a spy. He didn't care about Yuuei. He just needed to get out. At this rate, he was okay with sawing himself apart to escape.

He couldn't do this anymore. An ugly sob escaped through his gag, and Hisashi's hand retracted. Another voice joined them. "I think that's *enough*, Hisashi. He needs stitches, and he's losing a lot of blood. I told you to keep him alive,"

"R-right, sorry sir," Hisashi mumbled, "I'll get him fixed up, I promise,"

"See that you will," All For One growled, "His acceptance letter just came in, along with his art scholarship,"

"So all we have to do is send in our designs for his hero outfit. When does he start?"

"Next week," All For One replied, and Izuku heard his footsteps coming closer. Then his hands undid his restraints, gag, and blindfold. Izuku fought to keep himself sitting upright, gasping in pain as his stomach thrummed with pain.

All For One clicked his tongue and pulled Izuku to his feet. He nearly fell over, but All For One rolled his eyes and picked him up. Izuku tried to blink past his exhaustion, as All For One set him down on his bed. Not the bed in his mother's house, but the room he'd been in last night. He was restrained by handcuffs on each wrist.

In the corner of his room was his sword, he realized, as All For One slammed the door behind him when he left.

He couldn't hope to reach it, though. God knew he tried, as he nearly broke his wrist. Izuku tried and tried, until after a while someone walked in. Izuku froze. "You have to be very quiet," The person said. Izuku watched as they walked to his bed, frozen with fear.

The person turned on the light, and Izuku relaxed. Whoever this person was didn't matter to him, as he stared at the needle and surgical thread. "I'll be as quick as possible,"

Then he walked to the side of the bed and set down his tools. He glanced nervously at Izuku but then got to work. Izuku couldn't watch. Not as this stranger began the painstakingly long task of stitching him up with unpracticed hands.

His wound stung, but the man was true to his word. It was painful, but it was quicker than he expected it to be. Izuku took a moment to stare at the stranger with the purple swirling smoke. It engulfed his entire body, but the man spoke even though Izuku couldn't see a mouth.

"My name is Kurogiri, hopefully, we don't meet like this again Midoriya,"

Then he was gone, and Izuku's exhaustion hit him in a tidal wave. He didn't even remember going to sleep, and he certainly didn't remember going back to his mother's house. Despite that, that's where he woke up the next morning.

The room was dark and cold as usual, but he wasn't freezing like he usually was. On his nightstand were his bottle of pills and his sword. He swallowed a couple of his pills instantly. His body begged for it. He'd been without them for so *long*, and he beginning to feel attached to them.

He felt himself relax, but his relaxation didn't last long. His phone buzzed loudly and almost made him jump out of his bed in terror. He grabbed it, and looked at the notification.

Kacchan: Hey.

Kacchan: You there?

Kacchan: Seriously Deku, answer me.

Kacchan: Are you okay?

Kacchan: Did your mom take your phone?

Kacchan: It's been two days, and I still have no idea why you left this dog with me.

Kacchan: Hey.

Kacchan: Hey.

Kacchan: Hey.

Deku: hi

Kacchan: And where the fuck have you been?

Deku: Ahh. Kinda got grounded.

Kacchan: Your mom doesn't even pay for that phone. She shouldn't take it.

Deku: I'll have you tell that to her face.

Kacchan: Alright. Explain Edgar. My mom is officially in love with him, and he drools on my pillows.

Deku: He was abandoned, and I knew I couldn't keep him so I gave him to you.

Kacchan: Okay, that makes since as to why the number on his collar doesn't work.

Deku: Yeah.

Kacchan: I saw our scores.

Deku: Yeah?

Kacchan: We tied for first.

Deku: WHat?

Kacchan: Why didn't you tell me you had a Quirk earlier? Was it because of your mom?

Deku: You know my mother. She'd have a heart attack if she found out.

The lie came easily to him.

Kacchan: I guess...but why wouldn't you tell me?

Deku: I mean...

Kacchan: It doesn't scare me.

Deku: Well then you're the only one.

Kacchan: It's cool.

Deku: Seeing demons and hearing them scream all night long isn't cool.

Kacchan: I think it is.

Deku: Good for you, Kacchan.

Izuku heard his bedroom door swing open, and he typed out a quick text.

Deku: Sorry gotta go. I'll see you at Yuuei.

Izuku heard his mother call for him, and he trudged up the stairs, clutching his burning stomach. Fear clutched him, but he tried to push it away. He couldn't let his fear control him, not when he was supposed to be spying on Yuuei soon.

Not when his end was coming near, his discovery as a spy inevitable.

Chapter 18

Izuku had thought he was a pretty panicky person, but he was wrong. He was worse than he thought, as he met up with Kacchan as they walked to school in their Yuuei uniforms. He was worried. Very worried. He wasn't used to being a spy, but All For One had assured him that he would be very good at it. Anxiety was coiling in his gut tighter and tighter, like a snake wrapping itself around its prey.

For once, Izuku hoped All For One was right, as they neared the school building. All the students heading for Yuuei looked pretty pale and worried themselves, probably still trying to convince themselves that they made it. They looked exhausted.

He was trying to convince himself that his death would be quick if he was discovered as a spy. That thought kept him from loosing himself completely in his own anxiety. It would be quick. I wouldn't hurt. He squeezed his eyes closed for a moment and took a small breath. Izuku couldn't be thinking like that this soon into the school year. He'd be fine, he just needed to distract himself.

That distraction wasn't hard to find. Izuku could see the finishing touches being made on their new dorms, as Kacchan spoke. They'd start living there next week. Izuku put his hand on the hilt of his sword to comfort himself. "Oh, there's that crazy shark looking dude from my entrance exam," Kacchan mumbled into Izuku's ear. "He's got a skin hardening Quirk,"

He mentally filed away that information as they walked into the building. It was huge, and bustling with teachers and students alike. Izuku's heart shot to his throat as he spotted All Might almost instantly. He felt sick, as All Might's blue eyes locked with his own. He could feel his jaw clench, and sweat slick his hands.

He looked away before All Might could think of trying to introduce himself. He was terrified the man could smell his deceit if he got close enough. "Holy *shit*, All Might just totally looked at you, ya damn nerd!"

Izuku felt a hot blush climb up his cheeks, as Kacchan slung an around his shoulders. He shook his head vehemently. "He totally did," Kacchan told him again. It made chills run down his spine. "Now where the hell is our class?"

That was a good question.

Kacchan glanced down at his acceptance letter that listed their classroom, and they spent a few minutes tracking it down. The first thing Izuku could think of when they saw the door to his classroom was that this school *must* be made for giants. The door was huge, but Kacchan strolled forward like he didn't even notice. Izuku followed a little way off, admiring the whole place.

He couldn't believe he was here. He couldn't believe he had to spy on all of them. He didn't want to do it, but he'd never had control over his life. Not once. He should've been resigned to this fate, as he opened the door.

Class 1-A was loud. Everyone was getting to know everyone, and Izuku stood in the doorway with an expression of worry etched all over his face. He forgot that people would expect him to speak. Expect him to make conversation.

Worry settled heavily in his stomach, as Izuku took a seat next to Kacchan. Kacchan was scrolling through his phone but did take a second to glance at him. His lip quirked up in a smirk, and Izuku propped his head up with his hand.

For a blissful moment, he thought everyone would ignore him. Then the girl with the anti-gravity Quirk spotted him and rushed over with a loud squeal. "*Oh my god!* Oh my god! You're the guy from the entrance exam who saved me! My name is Uraraka nice to meet you!" She exclaimed, "Your Quirk is really strong!"

Izuku stared at her in silence, as another voice piped up. "I saw that too! He truly figured the entrance exam out! He knew it wasn't just about destroying robots. The thought never even crossed my mind! My name is Iida—"

"I have a video of it," A monotone, tired voice added. "Y'all wanna see it?"

Kacchan grunted, looking pretty annoyed, as Uraraka, Iida and a boy with purple hair came to crowd him. A few other classmates came to look, as the boy played the video. Some gasped, and others looked pretty impressed.

"Let me see that damn video," Kacchan grumbled. The purple boy complied, but not without a glare.

"Isn't it cool!?" Uraraka asked, grabbing Kacchan by the shoulders.

"Don't touch me, round face," Kacchan snapped.

"What's your name?" Iida asked as Uraraka pouted.

Izuku glanced around, panicked. He opened his mouth slightly, and then shut up. He glanced helplessly at Kacchan as they all went quiet. Anticipating and answer.

"Leave him alone," He growled, catching Izuku's stare.

"You can't tell me what to do!" Uraraka told him, "C'mon! Tell me your name—"

"If any of you aren't in your seats your expelled," Aizawa snapped, sitting up in his sleeping bag. He rubbed the sleep from his eyes and waited for all of his students to sit down. A demon stood in the corner of the room, staring at Aizawa. Izuku ignored it, focusing on Aizawa as he spoke.

"—We won't be going to the school assembly, thank god," Aizawa began. "But before that, I'd like to make a little announcement and take attendance,"

He began his announcement by pointing at Izuku. "One of your classmates is mute. His name is Midoriya Izuku. Don't expect him to talk to you, and if I see any of you making fun of him you'll be expelled. Speaking of expelled, I can expel you for any reason. If you aren't quiet by

the time this class begins, you're expelled. If you wake me up, you're expelled. If you bring food to school, and I see it, you're expelled. If you have your phone out, you're expelled. If you piss me off, you're expelled,"

"Now let's move on,"

Then he went through the attendance, calling everyone's name. Izuku was quick to connect names to faces as everyone said an assortment of things. I'm here. Here. Present. What up teach?

He hoped he had time to jot everyone's names down.

"Iida Tenya,"

Iida was one of Stain's last targets. He saved him. Izuku ducked his head at the memories that flashed in his head. Repeating over and over. *"It's okay, it's okay—"*

"Here,"

"Shouto Todoroki,"

"Present,"

"Katsuki Bakugou,"

"Here,"

"Izuku Midoriya,"

"He's here," Kacchan replied, and they continued down the list. Once they were done, Aizawa made them change and go outside. He changed in a bathroom stall, still covered in bruises and healing wounds. It would be absurdly suspicious if anyone saw them.

Izuku brought his sword, just in case as they left the building. Izuku admired the clear blue sky and reveled in the warmth of the sun. It wasn't often that Izuku had a chance to see the open sky and appreciate the worlds beauty.

"Instead of going to the assembly today, I'm going to test your potential. The student to come in last place will be expelled,"

Izuku swallowed the lump in his throat. He clenched his fists, and he rubbed his thumb over the bandages wrapped around his hands. Aizawa glanced at him, and then at his hands. He crossed his arms, glancing away from his teacher. They began with sprints.

Iida came in first place. Not a surprise, considering he was Tensei's brother.

Izuku wrapped his hand around his cross, as they moved onto a small obstacle course. Izuku breezed through it without even using his Quirk, and Kacchan beat him. They went into the gym for a while to do weight exercises to see who could do the most reps. Shoji beat everyone at that, with his multi-arm quirk.

They went through many physically demanding trials, before going back to where the Quirk Apprehension test first began. Izuku didn't excel at many of them, but he wasn't the worst at it either. He didn't really want attention, but All For One's request rang in his ears.

Outshine them all.

He didn't want to. He wanted to lurk in the shadows and watch from a distance. He didn't want the spotlight. But the walls had eyes, and Izuku wasn't about to get caught disobeying orders.

That's when Aizawa told them to do their last trail, and Izuku saw his chance. "Throw this baseball as hard as you can," Aizawa told them, handing it to Kacchan first.

Kacchan smirked, drawing back his hand and then throwing it as hard as he could. An explosion sounded, and the ball went flying in a ball of fire. Everyone quickly created a line, and Izuku positioned himself as last.

Izuku watched as everyone tried their hardest to beat Kacchan, and Uraraka beat *everyone* with her anti-gravity. Aizawa quickly acknowledged that Uraraka was the winner of this round, but everyone had to go either way. Finally, it was his turn, and everyone watched. He was the only one who hadn't used his Quirk yet. Some people still had no idea what his Quirk was, and he was disappointed that he couldn't keep it a secret.

He held the ball in his hand for a moment, but just as he was about to get ready to throw it his fingers cramped. His grip was still pretty weak, and his hands were sensitive after having his nails ripped off. He placed a hand on his sword and Dabi materialized.

Judging by the gasps and raised eyebrows, everyone could see him. "What the hell?" Shinsou sputtered.

Dabi took the ball from Izuku's trembling hand, taking a moment to stare intently at Izuku's hands even though bandages covered everything. Aizawa held up his hand. "Who is that?" Aizawa asked.

"Oh me?" Dabi asked, pointing at himself, as he slung his arm around Izuku's shoulders. Izuku let out an annoyed sigh, as Dabi smiled. "I'm a result of his Quirk. Kind of like Tokoyami's Dark Shadow, but he can summon me through the sword,"

"So he has a summoning Quirk?" Ashido asked.

"No, he doesn't," Kacchan snapped.

"Alright, go ahead then," Aizawa relented. Dabi grinned and threw it. The sky seemed to be ripped apart as bright blue fire erupted around him and Dabi. It was hot, but it didn't burn him.

As the dust settled, and Aizawa read his score out loud. Izuku placed his hand on his sword again, and Dabi disappeared. "You broke my scale.“

Izuku pressed his lips together carefully, and Aizawa sighed heavily and then acted as if nothing happened continued to speak. "You and Uraraka officially excelled at this exercise," The ball was long gone.

Then Aizawa went through everyone's scores, and Izuku placed pretty well. He thanked his lucky stars that he had Dabi to help him. He certainly wasn’t first by a no means, but he wasn’t last. That’s what mattered to him the most.

Shinsou ended up getting the short end of the stick, but Aizawa said nothing for a minute. After letting Shinsou nearly have a heart attack, he finally spoke. “I’m not expelling anyone,”

“HUH?!” Uraraka exclaimed, sounding relieved.

“It was a logical ruse!” Aizawa exclaimed with a rare smile.

Shinsou looked about ready to throw up. Izuku didn’t blame him, as they headed back to their classroom. He didn’t catch Aizawa’s eyes boring into his head. He was too distracted by Kacchan, who threw an arm around his shoulders.

“I knew it was a lie,” he told him, “The glasses guy mumbled that in the very beginning of the test,”

Izuku shook his head.

“I should’ve told you,” Kacchan said, as they took their seats. Izuku shrugged, a soft smile on his lips. He was glad it was a ruse. He didn’t think he could handle getting expelled on the first day. God only knew what All For One would do to him. He shuddered at the thought.

As they all settled down, Aizawa launched himself into a long-winded explanation of what he expected of them. Izuku was half-listening as he placed his notebook on his thighs.

His small scrawl filled every page with names, and Quirks attached to them. “—And I expect you to *pay attention*,”

Izuku glanced up and found Aizawa glaring at him. He shut his notebook and locked eyes with him. Aizawa moved on, explaining the situation with their dorms. “Everyone should be able to move in, in a few days,”

Kacchan seemed to paying way more attention to Aizawa then Izuku had time for. He returned to his notebook of rough notes. All For One was impatient and undoubtedly expected information even on the first day of school.

Izuku jotted down almost everything as the bell rang. He would ask Kacchan about everything Aizawa-sensei had been saying later. For now, he was determined to get all of this information to All For One, despite how much he didn’t want to.

Kacchan waited for him in the doorway, and Izuku joined him. They were just about to leave for the day when Aizawa-sensei spoke.

“I want you here twenty minutes early tomorrow,” Aizawa-sensei demanded, looking pointedly at Izuku.

He gulped, clutching his notebook to his chest. He nodded curtly, hoping he didn’t already blow his cover. “I’m coming too,” Kacchan told him.

“Fine by me,” Aizawa-sensei grumbled.

Then they left. As they were getting closer to Kacchan’s house, Kacchan offered him a place to crash. “If—if you want a night away from your parents you’re welcome to climb through my window, again,”

Izuku nodded and they parted ways. His shoulders slumped forward, and he scratched at his lower lip. His notebook felt like a ticking time bomb in his hands. Full of incriminating information that could get his whole class killed if in the wrong hands. And it was about to be, as he neared his home.

He paused right at the door, knowing he hand no choice. His life wasn’t his own. He knew that. But he still didn’t want to do this to innocent people, undeserving of the carnage that was sure to ensue once All For One got his hands on this information.

He opened the door slowly, swallowing the lump of guilt in his throat. Inko stood in the kitchen, and Hisashi sat on the couch. All For One sat down next to Hisashi, his back ramrod straight. His head whipped over to Izuku, and he closed the distance in two strides. Izuku took a cautious step back, holding out his notes.

All For One grabbed them and read them even though he didn’t have any eyes. “This is a good start, my boy,”

Izuku shuffled past him, but All For One grabbed him by the wrist. The man nearly yanked him off his feet. Izuku felt tears prick at the edges of his eyes. He kept his eyes trained on the floor beneath him as All For One’s words brushed his ear. “If you become compromised, I won’t hesitate to kill you myself. It won’t be pretty, nor will it be quick for you,”

Izuku nodded hastily, tears sliding down his cheeks cold and heavy. “I’m glad we understand each other, my boy,”

He let go of Izuku’s wrist, and he rushed for the basement and terrifying dark of his room. Any fear was better than the terror All For One ensued. He slammed the door behind him and hid away. He wrapped his comforter around himself and curled in on himself.

He was nothing but a spy. He didn't deserve to be in Yuuei when so many other kids — who would actually become heroes — could've been accepted in his stead. He stifled his sobs and guilt.

Izuku slept fitfully that night. Dreaming of demons tearing him apart, limb by limb. He dreamed of Kacchan leaving him forever.

He dreamed of bloody bodies and disembodied screams for mercy. Their blood was on his hands.

He woke up an hour earlier than usual. His head throbbed with phantom pains, but he managed to get to his feet and dressed. He even had the gall to throw a hoodie over his dress shirt instead of his blazer. He took the grey blazer along with him because he had a feeling Aizawa would probably tell him to change before class.

Izuku trudged up the stairs, his shoulders heavy with stress already. Quickly he double-checked that his sword was strapped to his hip. He quietly crept through the living room, almost to the door when his mother snapped at him. "Where are you going?"

Izuku paled as he turned around. His mother's cold voice but through his hoodie like he wasn't even wearing it. His hands trembled, more than usual. He wrung them together and pointed to his blazer. Inko rolled her eyes at him. "Come here," she snapped.

He was quick to comply. Pain laced through his jaw and cheekbone. He recoiled as her hand struck him again, and again. He held his hands up in front of his face to block her blows, but she didn't seem to care. She slammed her clenched fists into his arms, and his wrists throbbed with pain. She would no doubt leave purple bruises along his arms, and on his face.

How could he explain something like that away? He fell? His mom had an episode of lunacy and hit the shit out of him? — Oh, wait. That was the truth.

He was pretty sure he didn't have the intelligence to outwit Aizawa-sensei. Nor the balls, if he was being honest. She grabbed him by his hoodie and shook him.

"Don't give me that shitty excuse. You're running off to betray all of us, and tell the teachers at Yuuei that you're a spy, aren't you?!"

Izuku shook his head rapidly. No. He wasn't stupid. If he was going to do that he'd need a plan. He'd need an army behind him.

Betraying them was impossible, and not on his list of top priorities. He just needed to keep Kacchan safe.

He didn't have time to think for himself. "Don't lie to me!" She screamed shrilly.

Izuku hissed through his teeth as his mother grabbed a fistful of his green hair. "I knew I should've killed you the second you were born,"

He nodded slightly, ignoring the flare of sadness ripping at him. She let go of him, but not before cracking her fist across his cheek again. His mouth stung as he accidentally bit his tongue.

She turned away from him, muttering nonsense and gibberish. He didn't stay to decipher her words. He had to leave if he wanted to be there twenty minutes early. His face throbbed as he left his house. His phone buzzed in his pocket, and he glanced at the time. He was late for class. On the second day.

And he had completely bailed on going to school twenty minutes early. Now he looked suspicious.

As he practically ran to school he cursed his mother and her moments of complete insanity. Anxiety pooled in his stomach as he raced down the sidewalks, and ran nearly the whole way there. He didn't stop until he was at the door of his classroom, silently catching his breath. He pushed his anxiety away as he pulled open the door.

Aizawa merely gave him a glance as he walked in, muttering. “It’s only the second day of school and you’re already late?”

Izuku didn’t want to be a smart ass, but he couldn’t resist. He gave Aizawa-sensei a nod.

“Be late to my class again and you’ll be expelled,” Aizawa told him, "And didn't I go over the dress code yesterday? No hoodies or hats. This is your only warning, don't do it next time."

Izuku nodded again, hands shaking as he took his seat. Kacchan gave him a worried glance as Aizawa started up class again.

“Are you okay?” Kacchan whispered. Izuku gave him a vague nod as he jotted down the notes.

“No talking,” Aizawa sighed in annoyance.

Kacchan gave him another concerned glance, and then returned to his own notes on the lecture.

The entire first period of today was spent learning Quirk theory from their homeroom teacher. When the bell rang, Aizawa stopped his lecture and instructed them to go change into their P.E. uniforms and head outside. Izuku managed to change without aggravating his healing wound, which he still hadn't looked at. He'd wrapped it in bandages he had Dabi steal from Recovery Girl's office the other day.

He changed in the bathroom stall again and blissfully avoided changing in front of his classmates. They went outside to a nearby field, and Aizawa waited for everyone to get settled down before he started speaking. "Alright, we'll be playing tag today," Aizawa said in his usual bored and tired tone.

"We're playing *tag?"* Denki asked in disbelief, raising an eyebrow.

"Yes, that's what I just said,"

"I think this is gonna be unfair!" Kirishima pointed out, glancing at Iida. "He's got *engines* in his calves!"

"Then learn how to beat him with your Quirk," Aizawa replied. "As a pro, you'll be exposed to a lot of Quirks that oppose yours, and you'll need to learn how to overcome that. This is a perfect example of that,"

"I'm glad you aren't playing with us," Ashido commented with a slight sigh. Aizawa crossed his arms, and Izuku watched him intently, dully noting that the sky had turned a gloomy grey. Izuku ignored the pit of anxiety growing in his stomach, as he looked at Aizawa-sensei. He still didn't know who Aizawa was. Well, he knew his name, but he'd didn't know his *Hero name.*

That's what he really needed to know. "Oh, I am," Aizawa-sensei told them, with a wicked smirk. "All of you have a mission. To take out me, *and* Iida before school is over,"

Izuku rolled his shoulders, as Aizawa's scarf lifted in the air and seemed to defy gravity. Aizawa lunged for Iida, and everyone jumped out the way. He rested his hand on the hilt of his sword and calmed down as he watched chaos erupt around him. Kirishima was gunning for Denki, and Tokoyami was standing nearby Izuku. He looked less than inclined to participate, and Izuku thought he would help him out.

As long as no one seemed to think of tagging him yet, he made his way over to Tokoyami and lightly touched him on the shoulder. "Tokoyami is out," Aizawa told them, as his scarf whipped around, trying to catch Iida in its thrall.

"Thank you, fellow child, of darkness," Tokoyami said a bit dramatically as he sat down in the grass. "Shall I keep your sword company?"

Izuku thought on it for a moment before shaking his head. Tokoyami nodded slightly. Izuku entered the fray.

"Denki is out,"

Todoroki lunged for Izuku, but Izuku was fast. He twisted out of the way and dodged another hand coming for him. Ice exploded from the ground, surrounding Izuku. His sword came out in one fluid motion, and Dabi exploded with hot searing flames. Todoroki gasped but didn't relent in the slightest as his ice melted almost instantly. Red fire collided with blue, and Izuku darted out of the fray. For a few precious seconds Dabi kept Todoroki distracted.

Then Dabi disappeared and Todoroki found a different target.

"Ashido is out. Jirou and Kirishima are out,"

It seemed as if everyone was gunning for each other, and not giving Aizawa or Iida a second thought as the two danced around each other. Dabi materialized with a mischievous smirk playing on his lips. "Midoriya thinks everyone should be going for Aizawa-sensei or Iida if we plan to get this wrapped up before schools over! C'mon, guys, I have a date with a pretty fire-demon at four! I don't wanna be late!"

It was like everyone had opened their eyes, and Izuku heard Aizawa curse. It was like watching moths fly into a light, the way everyone converged on Aizawa as one. In all the chaos Dabi had snuck behind Iida and tagged him. Izuku stood a little way away, shocked at how stupidly they went about trying to tag Aizawa and get him out of the game.

"Iida's out!" Ashido called, as Aizawa dodged and tagged anyone who got to close to him. His eyes flashed red as Kacchan tried to explode him, and Izuku was hit with a wave of recognition.

This entire time, his homeroom teacher had been *Eraserhead*.

Kacchan jumped back away from Aizawa's outstretched hand and shoved Aoyama.

"Aoyama is out!"

"Hagakure is out!"

"Shinsou is out!"

Aizawa tagged them all quickly, as soon enough, it was just Uraraka, Todoroki, Aizawa, Kacchan and him. Kacchan glanced at him, as he dodged tag after tag. Todoroki lunged for Izuku again, and Dabi appeared, grabbing his hand. "Hey, that's not fair!" Denki pointed out.

For a split second, Aizawa glanced at Izuku and Dabi. "I'll allow it. Todoroki is out,"

Kacchan then tagged Uraraka.

"Uraraka is out,"

Circle Aizawa-sensei. Izuku told Dabi silently. Kacchan glanced at him with a playful smirk — or his angry-looking version of a smirk. "Oh, shit Midoriya's about to be out!"

"Language Kirishima," Aizawa snapped.

Kacchan rolled his shoulders. "You got a plan in that nerd-brain of yours?"

"'Course he does," Dabi smiled, glancing at Izuku hurriedly. "You do, don't you?"

Izuku shrugged. "Well damn, that's a fucking first," Dabi grumbled. "Let's just wing it,"

"Alright, scarface,"

"First of all, rude," Dabi told him, lunging toward Aizawa. His scarf hit Dabi's hand away, and Dabi glared at his teacher.

Izuku really had no idea how to go about it, but he wasn't here to learn. He was here to spy, whether or not he wanted to. He needed some information on Aizawa's Quirk to give to All For One.

He hated himself. He felt horrible for doing this, but he needed to follow All For One's orders. So he followed Kacchan's idea as he launched himself at Aizawa, palms exploding.

Izuku watched as Aizawa's hair lifted up, and his eyes flashed red. "Bakugou is out!"

Not even a second later, Aizawa tagged Izuku.

"Damn we didn't win," Uraraka whined.

"Well, we all tried our best, which is what matters!" Iida replied.

Then, like the crack of a whip, thunder rolled. Lightning flashed in the sky, and Izuku ignored the fear rising in his throat. "You did really good Midoriya," Denki commented as they all headed inside to change. Izuku sheathed his sword and smiled. Dabi disappeared.

"Yeah, you really were!" Sero added with a nod, "I didn't even get to tag anyone!"

Izuku fought the wave of guilt that assaulted him. He was spying on these people. And maybe one day his classmates would die because of him.

Chapter 19

All For One drilled him relentlessly. He'd woken Izuku up around four in the morning and spent the entire time sparring with him. Being drowsy with sleep, Izuku was slower than usual. His sword strokes and parries were weaker, and his stomach throbbed with every movement.

All for One wasn't happy about his less than motivated attitude today. He ruthlessly slammed the hilt of his sword into Izuku's stomach, and Izuku stumbled back as pain exploded in his abdomen.

His vision burst with blinding white, and he sucked in a shallow breath as the world tilted and whirled. His head cracked against the freezing concrete as he landed. Izuku ignored the throbbing dull pain in his head and clutched his burning stomach.

"Get up," All For One growled. "Did I tell you your training is over?"

Izuku pushed down the urge to vomit, as he stood on shaking legs. He tightened his grip on his katana and struck. His lunge was quick and precise, and his attack landed.

But it didn't matter. All For One was inconceivably fast. He slapped the sword as if it was nothing but a stick.

Luckily Izuku kept a hold of his weapon and tried to strike again. His teeth snapped together as the sword met nothing but a concrete wall. He whipped around, and just barely dropped himself to the floor in time to avoid the rocks that were launched toward him.

"Use your Quirk Izuku,"

His sword clattered to the ground without a single thought. The power greeted him easily, and every time he summoned it, doing so got easier and easier. The hellfire danced and writhed

around him, and he embraced the frozen infernal flames. His power. His birthright. His flames, black like ink, but colder than any ice.

Izuku didn't worry about losing control this time. "You're getting stronger," All For One rasped, with a huge smile that pulled back his molted skin. "Good,"

White puffs of air accompanied each word. Izuku knew All For One couldn't see his flames — no one could see them unless he took his Suppressant off.

His movements were quick, lethal, and accurate. He swung his hand in a wide arch — like Shigaraki had done so many painful times — in an attempt to land a hit. He wasn't surprised or disappointed when All For One shifted his stance and Izuku missed him by mere inches. His black fire followed his movement and slammed into All For One despite him missing.

A small victorious smile quirked Izuku's lips up in the corners. The fire dissolved as All For One stumbled back. His hellfire was no fire at all. It acted like wind, sharp, strong and deadly. Able to cut flesh and bones like it was nothing but paper. Except all it did to All For One was make him stumble.

The said man grunted, once again gaining back his balance. Izuku shifted into a defensive stance, his knees bent and his hands close in. He watched him wearily for his next move.

It was too fast for him to follow, and without warning, Izuku was sprawled out on the floor with his feet swept from under him. Momentarily forgetting how to breathe, Izuku gaped. It took a few seconds for his lungs to kick back in gear, and he gasped sharply. Then the pain erupted, as All For One kicked him where he was weakest, in his stomach. Where his wound still tried to heal.

White-hot pain made it hard to breathe, much less stand. He remained on the ground as All For One gave him a disgusted look. He didn't move to help him, and Izuku didn't expect it anyway. He was All For One's toy. A plaything that All For One took an interest in. He was *nothing*.

Izuku pressed a hand to his stomach, wincing as his hand came away red and warm with his blood. The watch around All For One's wrist blared shrilly, and All For One threw him his Yuuei uniform. "You're late for school. Get changed and I'll have Kurogiri teleport you,"

He was quick to pull off his black hoodie and glance down at his bloodied bandages. He'd steal some from Recovery Girl and rewrap them if he had the chance, or maybe he could have Dabi do it while he was at lunch. He grabbed his katana.

He put on his dress shirt and did his tie quickly. His shaking hands made it hard. He threw his blazer, pants, and shoes on hastily. Kurogiri entered the room just as All For One made his leave, and set up a portal.

Izuku stepped through it without a word. He pushed away the feeling of nausea he always got when stepping through one of Kurogiri's portals. He ended up in an alley not too far from Yuuei, and he was there pretty soon. The halls of Yuuei were deserted and quiet. He put a reassuring hand on his sword as he opened the door to his classroom. Aizawa-sensei didn't even look from his chalkboard when he spoke.

"Wait outside Midoriya,"

Of course. He let out an aggravated sigh and rolled his eyes as he turned to walk right out again. Kacchan caught his eye and there was the mirth in those red eyes. Then an underlying spark of concern, but Izuku whirled around and stood by the door before anything could become of it. He didn't have a chance to cover up the bruise from his mother, and he knew it must look pretty bad.

His classroom filled with not so subtle whispers of concern. The door closed softly, and Izuku got his phone out. Chizome-san's death was still making headlines, and he shut off his phone guiltily.

Aizawa came out a few minutes later. He looked tired, but that wasn't an uncommon occurrence. He played with the bandages around his hands, looking at anything but the teacher before him. Aizawa sighed tiredly. "Midoriya, you're late again,"

Izuku crossed his arms if only to hide his hands. He didn't want Aizawa to see his chronic shaking and assume he was scared. While it wouldn't be a wrong assumption, he didn't want his teacher thinking he was weak already.

"Why are you late again? Did you miss your alarm? Do you need me to buy a clock for you?"

He shook his head vehemently. "Are you just trying to avoid early lessons with me?"

He shook his head again. "Then why are you late again?" Aizawa asked as if he could speak. "You can only be late so many times before I have to expel you."

Izuku pressed his lips together, head low with his fists clenched. It wasn't *his* fault. He didn't get a choice.

"This is your last chance," Aizawa told him softly. "Usually I would expel you after the second time. Consider yourself lucky,"

Aizawa turned around and headed for the classroom, and Izuku went to follow. Just before they went inside, Aizawa gave him a glance out of the corner of his eye. "I better see you tomorrow, twenty minutes early,"

Izuku nodded.

He was quick to catch up on his notes and found time to compile some of his own on his classmates. He tucked that journal away and didn't bring it back out.

After lunch, they headed back to class, and all the desks had been pushed back to the walls. Standing at the front of the classroom was Present Mic out of his hero costume and in a hoodie. He wore sunglasses, and his hair was pulled into a tight bun. Blank canvas' sat all around the room, with two stools at each one.

"Come in, listeners! We'll be doing a very relaxing activity today!" Present Mic began as everyone filed in. "We'll be painting today and half of you will be painting while the other half will be the subjects of your painting!"

Everyone sat down apprehensively. Except for Izuku who grabbed Kacchan instantly and sat him down on a stool. Kacchan huffed in annoyance, but it didn't match his eyes that danced with admiration. "There aren't any rules, except that all paintings be appropriate for school!"

Izuku started with black paint. He grabbed the biggest brush available and slathered it over the entire canvas, and lightened up the right side of it with dull greys and silvers. Standing in the lighter spot in the painting was Kacchan, only recognizable by his spiky blonde hair. His eyes were covered by his hair, and his mouth was pulled down in a frown. A single thin demon stood nearby with a hand tight on Kacchan's shoulder.

Kacchan was reaching into the darkness with one hand, beckoning something.

That something was Izuku, who stood on the left side of the painting. He was brandishing his katana. He was the source of the darkness throughout the painting. Fitting he supposed.

He was a monster either way. He added a few touches, not even paying attention to anything around him. He didn't even look at Kacchan as he finished up, adding a few touches of light to create the ground beneath them. Then he added the chasm between them and stood back to examine it.

"Whoa, I didn't know you were good at art," Denki remarked. "Damn,"

"Well done little listener!" Present Mic exclaimed, putting a hand on his shoulder. Izuku flinched, but not too noticeable as his classmates came over. Present Mic seemed to notice it though and withdrew his hand immediately. Izuku tried to push away the image of All For One putting his hands on his shoulders.

"It's really black," Todoroki mumbled dully, with a slight shrug.

"Yeah like my soul," Shinsou grinned as he spoke.

"I like it," Tokoyami affirmed. "A true work of art,"

"The nerd's been good at art his whole life. You're fuckin' right it's a fucking *masterpiece*," Kacchan said with a smirk. Izuku shook his head. "Don't fucking tell me no, damn it. It *is*."

Izuku shoved him. Shinsou snickered.

"He was the one to get the art scholarship, right?" Momo asked, and Izuku nodded.

"Speaking of!" Present Mic exclaimed excitedly. "Could I see the rest of your art sometime?"

Izuku shrugged, not willing to tell the man no outright. He never planned on bringing any of his sketchbooks to school. None of his old ones, anyway. They had a lot of drawings of Chizome, and All For One in them.

He didn't want to blow his cover already. As everyone took turns looking over his art, the bell rang. He nearly jumped out of his skin in terror, before he put a hand to his chest to calm himself.

Izuku wasn't expecting to see All Might so early into the school year. He found himself getting his journal out again, even though he'd thought he wouldn't have to for the rest of the day.

“I’m coming through the door like a normal person!”

He'll admit, he blushed in excitement but he also felt dread pool in his stomach, as the man entered their classroom. He was the strongest hero alive, and also the most likely to kill him on the spot if he found out Izuku was a spy. He couldn't help but clench his hands under his desk in apprehension as his blue eyes met Izuku's.

The man could probably smell lies from miles away, and Izuku was a bundle of them. He launched into his instructions quickly, eager to get class up and going.

"Today everyone will be learning basic self-defense and hand to hand combat! Your homeroom teacher and I will be helping you today! Everyone, please get dressed in your gym uniforms, and head for the gym!"

Izuku wasn't as enthusiastic about getting taught by All Might as the rest of his classmates were. He went and changed quickly, hiding away in the locking room stall again as he checked on his wound. It was healing and no longer bleeding. He let out a soft sigh of relief as he got dressed.

He and his classmates all gathered in the gym with All Might and Aizawa waiting for them. "Alright everyone, pair up,"

Izuku found himself paired with Tokoyami, and he wasn't sad about it.

"All of you will spar with your partner until this hour is up. Either I or Aizawa-sensei will come to give you pointers and instructions!"

Tokoyami bowed to him, and Izuku suppressed a smile. "Let the best of us win,"

Izuku nodded. Sounds of people slamming into cushioned mats echoed through the room instantly. Tokoyami was quick and fast, but so was Izuku. They danced around each other, and Izuku was the first one to land a hit. It was a simple roundhouse kick, not too rough. He was too afraid of becoming like his parents, so he was really, *really* careful.

Tokoyami retaliated by throwing a punch that slammed right into Izuku's fresh bruise. He winced, and Tokoyami's eyes flashed with concern before they resumed. Izuku ignored the flare of pain in his stomach as Tokoyami kicked him, and threw the avian man over his shoulder. Tokoyami landed on his back and gasped for air.

Izuku hovered over him apologetically as Tokoyami got up again. "I'm okay. I'm just shocked— are you *bleeding*?"

Izuku looked down, anxiety twisting around his heart. Blood has begun to deep through his shirt, and he grit his teeth angrily. His stitches had been aggravated again. During *class*. He put a hand to his abdomen and could feel his shoulders begin to shake.

Out of nowhere, Dabi took it upon himself to appear. "Aizawa-sensei! Midoriya-kun is bleeding!" Tokoyami exclaimed calmly.

Izuku wasn't calm. His breath shuddered in his chest, and he felt fear rising in his throat. "Shit, shit you are," Dabi muttered softly, his hands waving around him anxiously. "I don't know how to deal with bleeding humans. What do I do?"

Izuku felt himself paling as he ignored Dabi's whispers of concern and confusion. Izuku was looking at the demons crawling closer, through walls, through the door, from the ground. He could see demons already coming from all sides, begging for a taste of his blood.

"Get out of my way All Might," He heard Aizawa snap, from across the room. "He's my kid I'll handle it,"

Izuku didn't want anyone to handle it. This would raise questions. This would make him suspicious. This would be the end, and he couldn't let anyone see what had been carved into his skin. By his own mother, who held no love for him.

"What's going on?" Aizawa asked as he came up, "Where are you bleeding?"

“His stomach, sir,” Dabi answered. Izuku shot him a look of betrayal, before looking at Aizawa-sensei. “What?! He asked!”

“I’ll take you to Recovery Girl, let’s go,” His tired eyes were alive with concern and apprehension.

He didn’t want to, but he knew it would be suspicious if he refused. All the while, as they walked sharp pains stabbed at his stomach. He was dizzy and tired when they finally reached her office. She was busy patching up a kid with a bloody nose as they walked in.

She kissed the boy on the forehead and sent him on his way. Aizawa cleared his throat, and Recovery Girl locked eyes with him, before looking at Izuku and Dabi.

“Come on in, what seems to be the matter?”

“My students were practicing hand-to-hand combat, and he got hurt,”

“Can I see?”

Izuku shook his head despairingly. He didn’t want anyone to touch him. “Midoriya—“

Aizawa reached out to touch him, but Dabi slapped his hand away. “I wouldn’t recommend that,” He growled. “I’ll kill you,”

Izuku willed Dabi away with a single thought, and he disappeared. He shook his head again, wincing.

“Midoriya-kun I need to heal you,” Recovery Girl told him softly. “It won’t hurt, I promise,”

He wanted to run. He wanted nothing more than to disappear. But he moved toward the bed on the other side of the room and sat down. “Alright, sonny, let me see your injury,”

More like mutilation.

Izuku glanced at the Recovery Girl, and then at Aizawa. The worry must’ve been reflecting on his eyes as Recovery Girl spoke again. “Nobody but me and Aizawa-sensei will see this, I promise,”

That didn’t make him feel any better, as he lifted up his shirt. Recovery Girl undid his hasty job of bandaging his wound. The small horrified gasp that left her lips was hard to miss.

Aizawa’s eyes widened with sympathy and concern. “Who did that to you?”

Izuku shook his head. “He’s too exhausted for me to heal, Aizawa. You need to stop pushing your class so hard,”

He could see the suspicion in Aizawa’s eyes. Cold, and sharp. Nothing like those soft parental eyes that flashed when Tokoyami said he was bleeding.

“I’m sorry,” Aizawa replied.

“Midoriya, I need to redo your stitches okay?“

That wasn’t okay. He didn’t want that woman anywhere near him with a needle. He shook his head. The last time someone “healed” him, it was absolute agony. He ignored the image of Dr. Tsubasa holding his broken hands in his. He ignored the fear.

He had no idea how this woman’s Quirk worked. He didn’t want her anywhere near him. She reached for him, and Izuku slapped her hand away. He didn’t — he couldn’t—

In his panic he thrashed. He didn’t want to be touched. *Stay away, stay away!*

Aizawa grabbed him by the shoulders. He forced to lay down.

”Sweetheart, if you don’t start cooperating I’m going to have to sedate you,”

Izuku wanted to kick her in the face or yell at her. This *shouldn’t* even be happening! But he was being suspicious. He forced himself to relax and to calm his breathing.

“Okay, that’s better,” Recovery Girl told him softly. She grabbed a pair of scissors and ripped open his shirt and examined his stitches. For a moment it was silent. "Whoever did this wasn't a professional in any capacity. Next time you need stitches, come straight to me,"

Izuku frowned. He wouldn't come to her if his life depended on it. He was sure of that, as she began to redo his stitches. Izuku didn't flinch, but he did wince when she got her needle ready.

He didn't want her to touch him he hated how her fingers were cold against his skin. They were too much like his mother, and he didn't think he could handle it. It was like getting carved open all over again. With one word getting etched into the skin of his stomach.

VILLAIN.

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

> the discord invite!
>
> Join my discord server!!!!
>
> Happy Valentines Day <33
>
> --
>
> December 13 edit: me remembering that I changed his hero costume later on in the fic lmao

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shouta sat in bed that night worrying about Midoriya, and he woke up worrying about it. The bruises on his face, on his chest, and shoulders. He had a sick feeling of dread in his stomach ever since he saw the kid with his shirt off.

He must’ve looked terrible as he got out of bed.

Hizashi even commented about it in their small empty apartment as they made their morning coffee.

"Hey, Shouta..." Hizashi began, "Are you okay?"

Shouta shook his head, with a heavy sigh. "No. I'm not,"

"Are you worried about something?"

He nodded and downed the whole cup of coffee in one go. Hizashi gave him a wary glance and tentatively sipped his. His husband waited silently, knowing full well that if Shouta had something important on his mind he would tell him eventually.

He shook his head and ran a hand through his messy hair. "You had a class with Midoriya yesterday. Did he look like he was...I dunno, in pain?"

"No, but he did have a huge bruise on his face if that's what you mean,"

Shout shrugged. "We were doing basic combat training, and he was doing really well. That was until one of my other students kicked him in the stomach, and ripped open his stitches I didn't even know he had,"

"Why did he have stitches? Did you take him to Recovery Girl?"

"I did, and he didn't take it well at all," Shouta began, "He didn't want anyone to touch him, and I had to hold him down at one point. Then Recovery Girl told me he was too exhausted to get healed. We took a look at his wound and do you know what it was?"

Hizashi raised an eyebrow, looking rightfully concerned.

Shouta avoided making eye contact with his husband as he spoke, looking right at the clock on the wall. "Someone had carved the word villain into his stomach. All Recovery Girl could do was redo his stitches. They looked like he did them himself. He refused to tell us who did that to him, and I can't stop thinking about it,"

Hizashi looked really pale, and he almost felt bad about telling him. Then Hizashi pressed his lips into a thin line. "Did you give him medicine? Have you contacted his mother? Is he okay?"

"I'm not sure, but I did try reaching his mother. It went straight to voice-mail, and so did his father's number," Shouta told him. "I did ask him to come in early to class, so I could—"

"I want to be there, hurry up Shouta! Let's go! I need to see if he's okay!"

Shouta grinned slightly and he got dressed quickly. They both seemed a little too eager to check on Midoriya as they piled into his car and peeled out of his driveway, headed for Yuuei.

The halls were quiet but busy with teachers getting ready for the school day to begin. Some students hung around, trying to finish up last-minute assignments. Hizashi followed him to his classroom, and as they got to the door they realized they'd been beaten.

Midoriya stood there, with an out of breath-looking Bakugou. "Damn bastard— Opened my door for one fuckin' second— he was gone—"

Bakugou wasn't even in his uniform, and Shouta raised an eyebrow. A dog jumped around Midoriya excitedly, a pug. "What's going on?"

"What a cute dog!" Hizashi cooed, and Midoriya smiled.

"This motherfucker got out while I was going outside. I ran after him, all the way here! Dumb dog!" Bakugou snapped, with a growl.

Midoriya didn't seem to be listening at all as he leaned down to hold the dog. The dog howled excitedly and licked at Midoriya's bruised cheek. Shouta could already see a new bruise on his collarbone right where Midoriya's dress shirt began.

He glanced at Hizashi and from the look in his eyes, he saw it too. The pug in his arms leaned dangerously to try to lick Hizashi, poking out its pink tongue. Hizashi reached for the dog and melted as Midoriya handed the dog over. "Can I take him to my office until school's out?" Hizashi asked, with pleading eyes.

Midoriya nodded with a grin.

"Are you ready?" Shouta asked Midoriya as Hizashi cradled the pug in his arms, "Bakugou you can go with Present Mic to get a new uniform,"

The boy nodded again, and they went inside as Bakugou left. Midoriya looked anxious as he stood in the classroom alone with Shouta. He decided to begin immediately. "You don't know how to sign, do you?"

Midoriya shook his head, wringing his hands together. "Did your school not offer to teach you?" Shouta asked softly, with his arms crossed.

Another shake of the head. He thought as much. He wanted to ask why his mother didn't bother to teach him, but he resisted the urge. He wanted to get straight to the point, but learning that his middle school refused to help him pissed him off. "Do you want to learn?"

Midoriya seemed to pause before he picked at his nails. Shouta saw the smallest of nods, as Midoriya avoided looking at him. Shouta's heart hurt for this problem child. "I can teach you if that's okay,"

He nodded more visibly this time, and he got a chance to see those eyes. Usually, they reflected nothing, but right now they shone with determination and excitement. Whoever thought that this child was a waste of time to teach sign language was an asshole. Who could look at that kid and say that he didn't deserve a chance to communicate?

Shouta shoved down the anger that exploded from him. He would talk to Nedzu about it later, as he began his lesson. Midoriya was confused almost the entire time as Shouta carefully taught the boy the alphabet.

He was determined for Midoriya to be able to finger-spell by the end of this week. Slowly but surely the halls began to fill with noise and laughter so Shouta cut his lesson short.

Midoriya drifted to his seat silently, and Bakugou burst through the door and took his seat. “I swear to god if that dog gets out again I will throw him out in the street Deku!”

Midoriya glared at Bakugou. “Don’t test me, I will,”

Shouta sighed through his nose. He could tell today was going to be a very long day.

His class with All Might was more than exciting. The number one hero all deemed them all ready to move on from basic combat training. Today they’d be using their Quirks to take down some extra robots from the entrance exam. From there they’d all be scored on how many robots they managed to take down.

Izuku was dreading seeing everyone’s Quirks in action. He would have to document everyone, and he didn’t want to. He didn’t want to be the reason everyone died, if the villains ever thought to attack. It made him feel sick, as he got dressed in his hero costume for the first time.

All For One had designed it for him and he felt obligated to hate it, but as he put it on he found himself liking it. It was a simple black t-shirt with the words Not Today Satan printed on it. Ripped black jeans, combat boots with pentacles on them. A cloak with blue fire on the bottom half of it — Dabi's fire — and on the back was an upside down cross. Lastly he adorned his headband with his horns on it.

He slipped on his gloves, and stepped out of his stall distracting himself with his phone. His eyes lingered on the tabloid articles on Stain, and he clicked on one.

Stain's Body Lost!

Earlier today, officials were preparing to perform an autopsy on Stain's body to shed some light on his recent death. His autopsy was scheduled to begin tomorrow morning, but as they were checking on the body they discovered that Stain's body was gone. All of his belongings from the police station nearby were also gone.

The robber left no traces or evidence of even being there. As of now, the police are tackling the issue and reassure us that Stain wasn't involved with a group of villains like we all fear.

At the moment no other information is available, and we will work diligently to report any new findings on this strange theft.

Izuku had a feeling he knew exactly who stole Chizome-san's body and all his belongings. "Holy shit, Bakugou your costume is so manly!" Kirishima exclaimed. He saw Kacchan glare at Kirishima, and he couldn't help but smile slightly.

"Fuck off shitty hair! Let's go Deku!" Kacchan yelled, stomping over angrily to drag Izuku out of the locker room. Once they were outside, Kacchan gave him a quick once over, with a smirk. Izuku raised an eyebrow at him. "With that kind of costume, you'll scare off villains for sure," He told him as they waited for everyone to catch up.

It was kind of awkward standing the gym alone with All Might. For him at least. Kacchan looked ready to explode some robots, and All Might looked a little too eager to teach this class. Izuku was determined to ignore the number one hero.

Soon enough the rest of their class arrived, and they all complimented each other on their outfits. Izuku liked Kacchan's, Tokoyami's and Shinsou's the most. You could say he was pretty biased with Kacchan's seeing as he designed it himself. But with Tokoyami's he just liked how the avian went for a dark theme much like he did.

And Shinsou. He looked like Aizawa-sensei, a *lot* like Aizawa. "Whoa Bakugou, who designed your costume!?" Ashido asked excitedly, and Izuku flushed.

Kacchan shrugged. "Deku did,"

And just like that, all eyes were on him and he blushed. "You did!? Did you design yours too? It's so cool!" Ashido exclaimed, taking a hold of his cloak and feeling the fabric. Izuku nodded slightly, even if it was a lie. All For One's smile flashed before him, and he ignored it.

"Damn I wish you would've designed mine!" Sero whined.

"Your costume looks hot on you, shut up," Denki replied.

"Thanks babe,"

"You're all gross!' Kacchan blurted. Everyone busted out laughing, and Izuku rolled his eyes at Kacchan.

All Might cleared his throat to get their attention and everyone finally calmed down. The fake city gleamed in the sunlight as All Might spoke, explaining their exercise. "Alright everyone! Listen up, all of you will be defeating robots today. Bakugou, Midoriya please stand by me to demonstrate what I mean,"

As he spoke, robots from their entrance exam came from underground on a moving platform. The robot activated instantly, and Izuku watched it warily. "Midoriya, please destroy the first one,"

He gave All Might a slight nod before unsheathing his katana at his hip. He didn't summon Dabi this time, as he rushed forward. His blade cut through the metal like butter. Sparks ignited as the robot flopped down, cut in half with one sword stroke.

"Good job my boy—"

But Izuku wasn't listening. His body froze up, and he sucked in a silent breath. *My boy.*

Fear curled up in his gut, but an explosion brought him out of his stupor. Kacchan's. He let out a breath, once again listening in on All Might's instructions. "Your goal today is to kill as many robots as possible until the hour is up! The student with the most points will win a prize!"

And then, as soon as All Might finished explaining, their exercise began.

It was like the entrance exam all over again, as everyone scrambled to win. "This isn't fair!" Iida told All Might, as everyone else ran. "Last time we were fighting robots Midoriya-kun destroyed *all* of them!"

Izuku ran off, with a wince. He had forgotten his stunt at the entrance exam. Now he kind of felt bad for everyone who had been unlucky enough to be in the same one as him. He came face to face with a robot and summoned his cold fire. It curled around him, embracing him in the icy cold. Izuku gave the robot one kick, before the robot fell in a metal heap.

With another he held out his hand and shot out a stream of fire, and it rocketed toward it. The robot landed a few yards away, sparking. He didn't even touch his sword the entire time as he darted between his classmates. His fire burned through every single robot he encountered. At one point he even yanked Shinsou off his feet as a robot nearly fell on him.

He darted into an alley way, listening for the sound of Kacchan's explosions. The ground beneath him rumbled, and he knew he was nearby. He walked out into the street and dispatched another robot. At the intersection was a mob of robots, and right in the thick of it was Kacchan popping off explosion after explosion.

Izuku grinned devilishly, and took out his sword. He ran forward, and Dabi materialized. Blue fire incinerated all of the robots around Kacchan, and Kacchan glared at Izuku. The creeping cold of his hellfire made Izuku's hands go numb, but he still managed to flip him off.

“Do that again, and see what happens!” He exclaimed. Izuku put his sword away, and Dabi disappeared.

Kacchan grinned as Izuku gestured at himself, as if to say *come at me.*

Kacchan snickered, as All Might announced over an intercom that the exercise was over. “Alright everyone! Time is up! Please return to the entrance and I’ll go over the results!”

Izuku followed Kacchan back to the entrance and his friend filled the silence. “How many do you think you took down?” He asked.

Izuku shrugged, he hadn’t thought of keeping track at all. Guess they would find out when they joined the rest of the class.

They reached the rest of the class pretty quickly, and once everyone returned All Might told them who won. “With sixty confirmed kills, young Midoriya, you won!”

Sixty? Had he really taken down that many robots?

Izuku stood in the observation room in shock, staring at All Might in awe. Had he really destroyed that many in that short of a time? All Might congratulated him. "And now for your prize!" The man exclaimed joyously, pulling out an All Might pen from one of his pockets. A *limited edition* All Might pen. It reminded Izuku of Stain's limited edition All Might lighter he carried around. Or *used* to.

He accepted it gratefully, ignoring how his eyes stung with unshed tears.

After classes were over, Izuku hurried down the hall to the nearest exit. He was eager to leave, but not too eager on going home. He knew All For One would be waiting for him.

As he was leaving the building he slammed into Shinsou, and he winced as Shinsou raised an eyebrow at him. "You good Midoriya?"

Izuku smiled, and nodded. "I didn't mean to run into you, I'm sorry,"

He shook his head, and held up one finger. *One second.*

Shinsou waited, looking a little anxious. Izuku fished out a notebook from his backpack and turned to an empty page. *It's okay. I wasn't paying attention.*

"I guess we're both pretty clumsy, huh?"

He nodded in response. *I forgot to tell you that I saw you during the entrance exam! You didn't even use a Quirk at all! Do you have a Quirk? It's cool if you don't...*

"Oh, um..." Shinsou began stiffly. "My Quirk is brainwashing..."

REALLY!? That's so cool! How does it work? Can you show me some time? So cool.

"Y-you think it's cool?" Shinsou asked incredulously. Izuku nodded. "Thank you Midoriya, it means a lot,"

And for some reason Shinsou left with a word. Izuku stood there for a moment, confused. Then he shrugged it off and finally went home without Kacchan. He was getting Edgar back from Present Mic.

As soon as he opened the door to his mother’s house he suddenly began to wish he was with Aizawa-sensei or any pro hero.

There were villains sitting on the couch. They were in his kitchen, sitting on the floor, leaning against walls. In the center of it all was All For One. Dread filled all of him as he spotted his parents in the throng, talking animatedly with another villain.

He had a bad feeling about this. All For One smiled widely as Izuku entered, “Finally! Now we can start planning!”

Izuku stopped himself from wondering exactly what he had just got himself dragged into. This was the dark and dangerous road Chizome-san had unwittingly led him down.

And he was trapped, with villains creeping in on all sides. No chance of escape. But maybe he could dig himself out, with the information he was being given. This was his one way ticket to salvation. He hoped.

All For One stood, and took Izuku by the shoulders. "My boy, you're in charge of taking notes. Get your journal, and when this meeting is over with, get me a full report on everything. Who should be positioned where, which student's Quirks to avoid entirely, and which students are easier targets. This plan cannot fail. I expect at least five pages from you,"

Izuku nodded. He could tell by the way All For One was looking at him that this was a test. The man wanted to know if Izuku would run to the police with this information. This was risky, but he was willing to take this risk for his freedom. He sat himself down on the floor in the corner and wrote down everything. He committed everyone's faces to memory, half-listening to All For One and Shigaraki plan.

There would be a Nomu, the brainless monstrosities that All For One tortured Izuku with. They would split up the class, putting them where their Quirks worked the worst. They'd place the villains where their Quirks would shine.

Izuku quickly deduced that a lot of these villains were weak and easily taken down. He shifted his focus to the most dangerous of the bunch. He had a lot of people come up to him and tell him their Quirk.

Pretty soon he had a long list of names and Quirks to match them. A list he would somehow get to a teacher.

"The Nomu will kill All Might. That's our goal with our attack on the U.S.J.," All For One told everyone. "It's also to retrieve our spy, Midoriya Izuku. He's gathered plenty of information and his skills are needed elsewhere. Kidnapping a Yuuei student would destroy Yuuei's reputation forever, especially if they can't retrieve their lost student,"

"Then society will lose faith in their so-called heroes!" Shigaraki laughed, scratching at his neck.

He frowned, as he finished up his notes and began compiling a report. Who should he give this information to? Who would believe him? How could he avoid being thrown in jail?

His mind kept going back to a man with messy black hair and tired eyes. He could hide notes for Aizawa-sensei to find. Then at least his teacher would know and do something about it. Hopefully.

But Izuku knew how reliable heroes could be, and he knew how they acted. With his luck, Aizawa-sensei wouldn't understand in time, or he would think it was a joke. No matter what he had to try, and rely on a hero he barely knew.

He swallowed his anxiety and silently continued his report, placing Shigaraki with the Nomu in the center of the attack, and a few villains with water Quirks in the water zone. He also kept another page of notes, detailing the plan. He would keep this for himself, to make sure he could stop the attack before it escalated. Shigaraki, the Nomu, and Kurogiri would be the first to leave the portal.

Izuku would have to work quickly to stop this plan in its tracks. He would have to get rid of Kurogiri and kill the Nomu with Dabi's fire. Then Shigaraki would be the only dangerous villain left.

They would be safe, and hopefully, Izuku would be able to save himself.

Somehow he doubted it. Somehow he had a gut feeling that this plan of his would crumble. With a sense of impending doom, he knew deep, *deep* down that he would die for his recklessness. And he was okay with it if his classmates survived.

Nobody saved *fallen angels*.

Nobody saved *villains*.

Nobody would save *him*. He had to do it himself or die trying.

"It's okay. Be a hero, son. Become the next symbol of peace, and show the world what you're made of. It's okay,"

Find a way to save yourself.

And he'd found it.

Chapter End Notes

also a note: i'm a wiccan and i'm fully aware of the true meaning behind the pentagram! For this fic though, im using it as demon summoning circles!

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

[the discord invite!]

Izuku made copies of his notes, and ripped them from his journal. Over the course of a few days he placed them around the school. The first one was in Aizawa-sensei's desk. Another was in the bathroom. Another was in the staff room.

He placed his information anywhere he could, leaving clues everywhere for Aizawa-sensei to find. He hoped he found them in time. He was stuffing a few new pages of information in his backpack when the door to his bedroom opened. The hinges creaked loudly in the silence. His hands trembled as he zipped up his bag and shot to his feet. The wooden stairs creaked with Hisashi's weight as he walked down. "...Izuku?" He sing-songed quietly.

He stood frozen for a moment, trying to make out Hisashi's figure out on the stairs. He scrambled for his bed, where a knife waited, positioned under his bed so he could reach it easily without needing any light. Goosebumps blossomed along his skin, as Hisashi's steps stopped.

"You've been a good boy, today," Hisashi whispered into the darkness as he entered the room and left the stairs behind. He could barely make him out in the complete darkness of his room.

His heart hammered in his chest as he heard Hisashi's foot falls end at his bed. He gripped the knife tightly in one hand, ready to use it if Hisashi tried anything. In the silence all he could hear was his own shaky breathing.

Fear gripped him tightly, and the knife shook in his hands. Panic exploded in his heart, as Hisashi ruffled his hair. "Keep being a good boy, and don't tell your stupid hero friends about all of our plans okay?"

He stopped breathing. It was like his brain hit pause, and his entire body was still with fear and panic. Hisashi didn't move his hand, and Izuku's grip on the knife slowly loosened until it clattered to the floor.

A scream ripped from him as Hisashi grabbed Izuku's face with his other hand, cupping his chin. "I'll kill you," Hisashi growled. "And I'll make it slow. Do you *understand* me, boy?"

Izuku's jaw ached, as Hisashi dug his nails into his cheekbones. Pain exploded in his face, blinding hot. He couldn't even breathe, as Hisashi grinned. "Good, now go upstairs your mother wants a word with you,"

He gasped in relief as Hisashi pulled his hand away. The pain left him, but the panic remained. It was a constant. His body shuddered and ached as he grabbed his bag and went up the stairs. His eyes burned as he swung the door to the basement open and went into the living room where his mother waited.

He set his bag down and watched her with terrified eyes. Hands shaking, he watched as she stood and glared at him. She didn't say anything, and Izuku never expected her to. Her fist smashed into his face, and he felt his nose crack. Warm sticky blood dropped from his nose like a waterfall. Izuku didn't know what he'd done, but he'd somehow managed to make his mother mad.

Again.

His eyes watered, and his face throbbed with sharp pain. Before he could even think of raising his arms to protect himself, she grabbed a handful of his hair and screamed at him.

"I don't understand why he had to choose you of all people! What makes you so important?! Why has he taken such an interest in you? You're nothing!"

Izuku let it happen. He listened to every word she said, and took it to heart. He felt tears prick at the corner of his eyes. It wasn't like he had been given a choice in the matter! All For One had taken it upon himself to make Izuku a spy.

His mother didn't see it like that. She shoved him with almost super human strength and Izuku fell. His chin knocked into the floor, and he winced. That was definitely going to bruise. He curled in on himself and waited. Her foot slammed into his side, and his back.

Pain ached throughout his body as she kicked him relentlessly until she was out of breath. With one last kick to his head, Inko turned and left. Still spouting angrily about All for One had chosen the wrong person for the job.

Izuku's head slammed into the floor, and he groaned as the door to his mother's room closed. He sat up slowly, covering his nose with one hand to stop the flowing blood. With the other hand he grabbed his bag and stood.

He left quickly before his mother could come back for round two. He could feel a bruise forming on his chin and forehead. It was still a little dark as he began his walk — a run? What could he say, he was going late for Aizawa-sensei's early lessons otherwise — to Yuuei.

As he entered the building he looked down at himself. His uniform was all wrinkled. There was blood on it too, from his broken nose. Anxiety ripped at him, squeezing in his chest as he made his way to Aizawa's classroom. He needed to tell him he was going to Recovery Girl's office first.

"Midoriya," A gruff, exhausted voice sounded from behind him. Izuku jumped, and turned around.

Aizawa-sensei looked exhausted as usual. As soon as Aizawa looked at Izuku however, his expression changed into worry. "A-are you okay?"

Izuku nodded.

"Who did that to you?" Aizawa asked, but Izuku just shrugged. "Move your hand let me see it,"

Izuku complied, wiping the blood on the back of his hand. Aizawa sighed heavily and dragged him to Recovery Girl's office without a word.

Recovery Girl looked up from her work and gave Izuku a pitying look. "What happened dear? Did you pick a fight with someone?"

"He won't tell me," Aizawa replied, and Izuku pursed his lips together to emphasize the point.

"Well get over here and I can fix you up! I'd like to take a look at your stomach as well. Aizawa would to you mind locking the door behind you?"

Izuku came over cautiously, and Recovery Girl gave him a peck on the forehead. The throbbing pain in his face vanished, and she smiled at him. "Good as new!" She went over to her desk and pulled out a wet wipe seemingly out of nowhere. She handed over the wipe, and Izuku scrubbed the blood off his face neck. "Now if you wouldn't mind taking off your shirt?"

Izuku did so apprehensively. He felt exposed. Izuku didn't entirely trust Recovery Girl yet, and she seemed to notice. Recovery Girl didn't waste time and prolong his suffering. "Ah, I can take out your stitches now. It shouldn't hurt a bit,"

She grabbed the tiniest pair of scissors he ever saw, and cut the thread on each letter carved into his skin. She then carefully yanked the thread out until there were no stitches left. "I'll ask one more time, and you can write it out for me. Who did that?"

She gestured to the word carved on his stomach. He looked away from her. He could feel Aizawa staring at him. When he didn't answer, Recovery Girl spoke again. "Who broke your hands like that? Who broke your nose? Who's hurting you? If you don't answer me, then I'm going to come to my own conclusions,"

Izuku covered his face with his hands. He didn't know how to approach this. He thought the only thing he had to worry about was the U.S.J. attack, but now this was falling into his lap. And he had no instructions. Panic consumed him, eating away at him.

"Midoriya-kun," Recovery Girl began softly, pulling his hands away from his face. He didn't realize he'd been hyperventilating and crying. "You can tell us,"

"We're heroes. It's our job to help you," Aizawa told him, and Izuku glanced at him. He looked drained, as he leaned against the door.

For one dangerous moment Izuku was about to tell them. And then an alarm blared to life, screeching shrilly through the air. Aizawa-sensei and Recovery Girl moved for the door. "Stay here!" Aizawa told him.

Aizawa was gone before Izuku could do anything, and he was grateful for that alarm. He had time to figure out his answer whenever they decided to question him again. Recovery Girl followed Aizawa, and Izuku found himself curious.

He put his shirt back on and ventured outside the nurses office. As soon as he looked out into the hallway he knew it wasn't villains or anything because All Might was sipping on a glass of water. He joined his teacher, and All Might gave him a glance. "Young Midoriya!" He exclaimed. "What're you doing here so early?"

Izuku got out a piece of paper and wrote a simple message. [I was supposed to learn sign language with Aizawa-sensei.]

"Ah I see, how is it going?"

Izuku groaned. All Might smiled slightly. "At least you're here, trying to learn it! Give yourself that!"

Izuku smiled, and pointed to the teachers rushing past. At one point he even spotted Nedzu. “Oh, there’s a fire in the dorms. It’s already being taken care of and I was told to stay far away because my Quirk would probably cause more damage. They’ll have to start completely over on the dorm buildings now,”

Izuku frowned. “Never fear, Young Midoriya! The dorms will be completely safe when they’re finally completed!”

He probably wouldn’t be there for that. His hands curled into fists, and he went back into the nurses office to grab his bag.

All Might didn't say anything as Izuku left him in the hallway. He still had some notes to scatter, and this fire was the perfect cover up. He put a hand to his katana as he walked, and summoned Dabi.

He knew that the camera’s wouldn’t pick up Dabi’s form well. These camera’s weren’t as good as the ones from the entrance exam. And he was in the camera’s blind spot anyway, so it didn’t matter if the camera picked Dabi up just a bit.

They wouldn’t know it was Dabi until the attack was already over. Dabi silently grabbed the ripped pages from Izuku and went into Nedzu’s office. He came back outside without them.

Now all Izuku could do was wait for Nedzu to find them. Hopefully he put all the pieces together before the attack. Hopefully he made extra teachers go with them.

Hopefully no one died.

Izuku took the last of the pages to All Might’s desk in the staff room. Right now no one was inside, and he slipped the papers in his desk.

One paper in particular was the most important.

He lives.

That's all the last page said, and hopefully All Might understood.

By the time he was finished, all the teachers slowly came back from the fire. The fire *he* started, using Dabi's flames as a distraction. School should be starting any minute, but as Izuku went back into the nurses office to grab his blazer Recovery Girl stopped him. “School is out today thanks to that fire. I’ve called everyone’s parents to let them know, but I haven’t called yours. You’re welcome to stay,”

Izuku paused for a moment. Slowly he set his bag down. “Alright I’ll contract them to tell them you’re doing some extra studying,”

He nodded slightly, and the door to her office opened. Aizawa’s eyes scanned the room and landed on him. “If you’re staying we can go into my classroom and we can continue the lesson,”

Izuku nodded and Recovery Girl shooed him off. “When you come back tomorrow I expect you to be able to sign to me,”

Then the two of them left and went into Aizawa’s classroom.

It was quiet for a long time as Izuku reviewed the alphabet over and over again. Once Aizawa was satisfied he spoke. “What’s your Quirk?”

Izuku was astonished that his hands didn’t shake all that much as he signed to him.

[I can see, and control demons.]

“I see. Do you summon them too?”

[Yes, with my hands.]

“Can I look at your hands?”

[Do I have a choice?]

“Yes,”

[Then no.]

“Why not?”

[Because.]

”I won’t judge you,”

[I don’t care.]

“I’ve already seen them, remember? What does it matter if I look at them again?”

[Ok fine.]

Izuku held out his hands, with his palms facing up. After a moment of hesitation Aizawa took held his hands and studied the scars. A summoning circle carved into each palm. His fingers were slightly crooked and lined with scars. All the way up to his elbows long lacerations littered his arm.

“Did you do that to yourself?”

Izuku yanked his hands away in disgust. He gave Aizawa-sensei a glare.

“Then who did? You can tell me,”

Izuku shook his head. [No I can’t.]

“Why not?”

[I just can’t.]

“We’re done for the day—“ Aizawa told him, almost angrily.

“SHOUTAAA IS THE KID STILL—“

Izuku jumped, and Aizawa groaned. “Yes he is, what’s going on?”

“O-oh! I just wanted to see if he wanted to paint?”

He nodded eagerly. Present Mic grinned widely. “OOH YEAH! LET’S GO! LET’S GO! NO ONE HERE APPRECIATES ART AS MUCH AS ME AND YOU MIDORIYA!”

Izuku stood with a shaky smile, and grabbed his bag. Present Mic led him to an empty art classroom and Present Mic sighed softly.

“Do you want to draw? Do you want to paint?”

Izuku pointed at the paintbrushes, and Present Mic set him up with an empty canvas and paints. Present Mic himself pulled his long blonde hair back into a messy bun. In his hands was a sketchbook, and Present Mic started to draw. Izuku started to paint. He didn't know what he was painting, and after a while. He left the brushes behind and used his hands.

His mind zeroed in on the empty canvas before him, and he poured his fear into it. He poured his sorrow, and his pain into the painting. He still had no idea what was going to become of this painting. It was black. It was dark. It was evil, and sad and painful.

He took a step back, what felt like hours later — and maybe it was — and saw what he had created. All For One's face leered at him from the painting, with a smile stretching the shiny scarred skin on his face.

All For One.

His pain, his sorrow, his fear. He blinked away the tears in his eyes, and bumped into Present Mic who had been watching him.

"Hey are you okay—?" And then those bright expressive eyes found Izuku's painting. And they darkened. "—How did you—? Do you know him? Do you know who you just painted?"

Izuku nodded fearfully. [Burn it. Take it away from me.]

"Midoriya—"

Izuku turned around, paint drying on his hands. "Midoriya don't run—!"

And then he ran. And he didn't stop until his feet ached and he was far, far away from Yuuei.

The look in Present Mic's eyes made fear curl up in his gut and fester. He didn't hesitate as he swung the door to his house open. He deserved the inevitable screams and curses. He deserved any blows that came his away and broke him.

He was stupid. He was *so* stupid, drawing All For One in front of someone. A pro hero no less.

He was going to be killed. Present Mic, or All For One himself would see to that.

The next day he was worried, and his back ached with new bruises and cuts. The entire walk to school with Kacchan was lively. He kept yelling about how it was stupid that school had been canceled.

"How's your lessons with Aizawa goin'?" He said suddenly, after he finished his rant.

Izuku shrugged. "Say something in sign,"

[I only know the alphabet Kacchan.]

"That's good enough for me,"

[You know sign?]

"I learned a while ago, that whole month where you avoided me. I only wanted to come with you to Aizawa's lessons to help you,"

[Oh.]

“Yeah. Don’t ever avoid me again you little shit,”

[I won’t.]

”You better not,”

Izuku smiled, and Kacchan took a hold of his hand with his own. Izuku completely blanked, a blush covering his cheeks.

Kacchan was holding his hand. *The Kacchan*. His best friend. A shiver ran up his spine as Kacchan’s thumb rubbed his hand.

He wasn’t used to this but he liked it.

They walked all the way to school like that. Hand in hand.

He was calm and content until he remembered what was supposed to happen today. Everything was supposed to come crashing down. And him with it.

His hand went cold in Kacchan’s grip, and Izuku began to hope that Aizawa had found a lot of his notes. Maybe even Nedzu found his, and hopefully All Might had a brain and noticed his.

Thankfully their walk was short, and they arrived at the school early for Aizawa’s lessons. He could see if he had found anything before school started.

Kacchan’s hand squeezed his own, and he glanced at his best friend. “Are you okay?”

He nodded.

“You look really worried about something,”

Izuku shook his head and threaded his fingers with Kacchan’s. “Alright, don’t tell me then,”

“Don’t tell you what?” Aizawa asked, rubbing at his eyes as he walked to his classroom with Present Mic in tow.

“Nothing,” Kacchan grumbled angrily.

“Are you ready for more practice, Midoriya?” Aizawa asked as he opened the door. Izuku nodded and Kacchan followed them inside.

All four of them pushed together two desks and pulled up a chair. The lesson began and twenty minutes passed easily. As Present Mic left the classroom he pulled Izuku outside with him for a moment. “Midoriya, about yesterday...”

[I can explain—]

“It’s okay,” Present Mic told him. “I just want to know how you’re associated with him,”

[I can’t.]

“It’s safe for you here, Midoriya,”

[It’s not.]

“If he’s forcing you into this, then all you have to do is nod,”

Maybe it was the fear in his eyes. Or maybe it was because he really did nod, but Present Mic gave him a pat on the head and whispered as he walked away, “I’ll save you, kiddo,”

He stood there shocked for a while, and only snapped out of it when Shinsou bumped into him sleepily. Instead of an apology, he simply patted Izuku’s shoulder and muttered under his breath.

“I’m so tired...it’s so early,”

Izuku nodded in agreement, and went back inside. He sat down at his desk and put his head down. He agreed with Shinsou one hundred percent. His body begged for a nap. He didn’t intend to actually fall asleep, as he closed his eyes. He didn’t think Aizawa would let him, but maybe an hour later he woke up with a start and almost fell out of his seat.

“Oh good, you’re finally awake I see,” Aizawa said. Izuku blinked blearily and stood. “Hurry up and get dressed in your hero costume, we’re headed somewhere for the rest of the day,”

The U.S.J. he already knew. Anxiety made his hands shake even more, as he got up and headed to the locker room where the rest of his class was.

He got dressed quickly, and before he could worry too much, they were on the bus headed for the Unforeseen Simulation Joint.

And for a moment it was like the calm before the storm. Soon the air that was filled with laughter would be filled with screams of terror.

Act Three: The Good, the Bad, and the Evil

Chapter Notes

I just got so excited I decided to upload early lol

Guys I really can't believe how many ppl enjoy my fic, so thank you. please join my discord for update alerts, and plenty of spicy spoilers ;)

the discord invite!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He was ready to puke as soon as they entered the building. He spotted Thirteen a little ways away in the building. They greeted the class as Izuku and his classmates walked inside. “Hello everyone!” They said excitedly.

If only Thirteen knew what was about to happen. If only they knew the danger they were in.

Aizawa-sensei joined Thirteen and they began to explain what he and the rest of his class would be doing today. “The building everyone is now standing in is called the Unforeseen Simulation Joint, otherwise known as the U.S.J! Today all of you will be practicing your rescuing skills! Even if your Quirk isn’t suited for rescue work it’s still useful to know exactly how! For example, at first I didn’t think my Quirk would be useful for rescue. It’s called Black Hole, and my Quirk could easily be used to kill as it is to rescue. Always keep that in mind when you ultimately decide which path of heroism you’ll follow!” They told them, with their arms wide. Too eager, too kind. Too ignorant.

Izuku was too busy glancing around worriedly to listen. The sun was high in the sky, and through the opaque glass ceiling he could feel the warmth of the sun in the sky. But terror made the blood in his veins freeze. He could already feel sweat beading on his forehead, and his heart skip a beat in his chest. Any second now, it would begin.

That's why he wasn't surprised to see a purple warp appear down by the fountain. He wasn't surprised when the lights in the building flickered for only a second. He was surprised,

however, at how quickly the assault began. They'd barely been in the building for more than a minute or two.

It was long enough for his classmates to notice, and look at the swirling purple of the portal. "What's that?" Iida asked, pointing with a raised eyebrow. Izuku could hear the tremor in his voice. The worry, and unease that seemed to wash over his classmates, as soon as Iida had spoken.

He could see the fear in those eyes, and he felt a pang of guilt. They'd gotten information on all of his classmates directly from him. If anyone got hurt or worse, *killed* it would be his fault. Aizawa-sensei turned around. Izuku could see from where he was standing that Aizawa looked just as worried as Iida, and Izuku felt his hand go for his sword.

End it here. Right now.

Aizawa glanced at him, and shook his head slightly at him. "Is the exercise already happening?" Sero asked, a bit dumbly.

Shigaraki poked his head out of the portal and waltzed into the U.S.J like he owned the place. His smile was crooked, wicked, and sharp. His arms were spread wide, as if he was about to embrace someone. Following him was Kurogiri and the Nomu. Villains streamed out behind them, and Izuku watched with wide eyes as Shigaraki scratched at the dry skin of his neck. He grating laugh danced in the air.

"No. Those are real villains, Thirteen! Protect the students, keep them back!" Aizawa yelled, his goggles coming down to cover his eyes as they flashed red, his Quirk at the ready. Izuku's grip on his sword was tight. His knuckles turned white as all the blood left his fingers. Aizawa-sensei leaped down to the fountain where the villains waited. Izuku stopped himself from jumping down there with his teacher, and instead his unsheathed his katana.

As Aizawa landed and used his scarf to knock out villains, Izuku took his sword and summoned Dabi. The flames erupted instantly, filling the air with the smell of smoke, as Dabi flew forward without an order. He could probably smell Izuku's fear. He could probably read the need to protect, written all over his face.

"Aizawa!" Dabi yelled as he landed beside him, "I'm here to provide assistance with taking out the trash!"

Izuku glared at his teacher as Aizawa looked up to glare at him. He wouldn't let Aizawa refuse all forms of help. After a second, Aizawa turned around to stomp a villain into the dirt. That's when Kurogiri took his queue and teleported himself up to where Izuku and his classmates stood, shielded by Thirteen. Kurogiri's form expanded until they couldn't even see Dabi and Aizawa fighting. A wall of purple smoke circled around them, and they were trapped on all sides exactly according to plan.

Except Izuku knew how to stop this plan in it's tracks. If he was quick enough. If he was strong enough.

Izuku tightened his grip on the hilt of his sword. He took a deep breath, but just as he was about to fight Kurogiri Thirteen held out a hand to stop him. "I'll take care of him," They growled. "I can't allow you to get in harm's way,"

Thirteen positioned themselves in front of Izuku, facing Kurogiri head-on, with nothing but their Black Hole Quirk. They *had* to know it was a horrible match up. They had to know Kurogiri wasn't just chosen for this mission because of his Teleportation Quirk. He was the perfect counter for Thirteen, but despite that fact, they still put themselves in front of Izuku.

Izuku watched in horror as Thirteen activated their Quirk and attempted to suck Kurogiri into their black hole. But Kurogiri was smarter than that. He wouldn't allow himself to get caught up in that, and Izuku already knew his plan. He could practically see it in slow-motion. Kurogiri opened a purple portal. He could already see it. Thirteen's death. He needed to *move.* He needed to get them out of the way.

Izuku rushed forward, fear fueling him. He slammed Thirteen to the ground with all of his strength, but he was still too late. Kurogiri had successfully turned the tables in an instant. He'd still managed to reverse Thirteen's Quirk right back onto them.

Kurogiri had used the first portal he summoned to protect himself from the attack, but he'd used the second one to turn it back on Thirteen. Izuku had barely made it in time, even if he wasn't entirely successful. Thirteen's suit, which held their body together, had been ripped open. Izuku looked over them, his eyes skimming over the suit. He couldn't breathe. He'd

done this. He'd caused this. All of this was his fault. Blood pooled from Thirteen's suit. His hands were covered in it, as he tried to staunch the bleeding.

"Thirteen are you okay?!" Uraraka asked worriedly, coming to their aid immediately.

Thirteen nodded, but didn't move. They were loosing a lot of blood, and yet... Thirteen reassured Uraraka. But Uraraka didn't buy it. She had already taken off her track jacket, and ripped it apart to use as bandages.

"It's unwise to take your eyes off your enemy, Midoriya-kun," Kurogiri grumbled, adjusting his sleeves.

Izuku glared at Kurogiri, and stood. He was so *angry*. His hands were shaking, but it didn't stop him from clenching his fists. His nails cut into his palms, but he didn't care. He went for his sword again. Before he could move though, Kacchan and Kirishima launched themselves at Kurogiri's form. Explosions pulsed through the air, and Kirishima followed him with his hardened skin. For a moment, everything was still. Then a purple portal sucked up both of them, and more appeared to scatter the class.

Half on the class was instantly thrown about the U.S.J. where villains were waiting. All except Uraraka, Ashido, Iida, Denki, and Thirteen. Izuku stood frozen for a moment, before remembering exactly where all of his classmates had been placed. He could rescue them, if he took down Kurogiri. Those dark eyes found Izuku's and Izuku had the nerve to grin manically.

He sliced his own hand open on his katana, and he could see the demons summon themselves. Drawn by the sweet, sweet scent of their king's blood, and Izuku used it to his advantage. They screamed loudly at him, and for a minute he couldn't hear anything except their hollers. The angry wails of the damned.

Izuku knelt down, and pressed his palms to the earth. He pushed his power through the circles in his palms, and all the demons around him became corporeal. His black hellfire arched in and out of the earth, and touched each of them. Kurogiri seemed to falter, and Izuku ran forward. The demons grinned wickedly at him, and joined him.

He swung his sword, only missing Kurogiri by a few inches as the purple smoke condensed back into him, and his suit was once again visible. Kurogiri took a few steps back, and threw up a portal as a shield. Izuku darted around it, and grabbed Kurogiri by his metal brace.

Izuku's sword was positioned to slice the metal in half. His deep voice met Izuku's ears, and he hesitated. "Stain the roses red, Izuku. Remember those who helped you,"

Damn. He was right.

His hand loosened just enough on the metal brace that Kurogiri slipped out, and Izuku let himself fall forward. He owed Kurogiri that much. He glared at Kurogiri and scrambled to his feet, and then he heard Shigaraki laugh manically. "Nomu, attack the stupid teacher! Break his face!"

Izuku's eyes widened in horror for a moment, and that's when Kurogiri disappeared and reappeared at Shigaraki's side. Wrapped in Kurogiri's fist was Iida, choking. They whispered together, and Shigaraki glanced up at him. The demons leered in response, as the Nomu followed Shigaraki's orders. Izuku took the stairs two at a time as soon as he glanced behind him. Everyone was still tending to Thirteen, or crying.

They were safe for now. He needed to save Iida. He needed to save Aizawa. He needed to save *everyone*.

His fire danced to greet him, icy cold yet hot at the same time. Shigaraki watched him with eager eyes, as he grabbed Iida from Kurogiri. He kept one finger up, and his eyes sparkled with a challenge, and exhilaration. "Kurogiri, get the Experiment: Prototype-Nomu,"

Izuku furrowed his eyebrows in confusion but rushed forward anyway as Kurogiri warped away. "Tenya Iida," He said, as the Nomu and Aizawa fought in the background. Izuku couldn't bring himself to look at his teacher. No. He had to have faith in Eraserhead, and Iida needed him.

"Brother to Tensei Iida, both of whom have speed Quirks, isn't that right, Midoriya?" Izuku fought the urge to freeze as Shigaraki spoke. He needed to keep Shigaraki distracted enough

to save Iida. As long as his classmates were safe nothing mattered. He didn't *matter*.

"Todoroki Shouto, Half Cold Half Hot. Bakugou Katsuki, Explosion Quirk. Uraraka Ochako, Anti-Gravity. Denki Kaminari, Electricity Quirk," Shigaraki smiled wickedly, and Izuku had to focus to keep himself from glancing at the demon that had been inching it's way behind Shigaraki.

It doesn't matter. It doesn't matter if he tells everyone I'm a spy. I just need to save Iida.

"Midoriya Izuku, spy for the League of Villains! Did you hear that Eraserhead!? He's our spy!" Izuku felt the tears drip down his cheeks, but his demon was finally in range. "He's been spying on Yuuei this entire time!"

With otherworldly strength, the demon grabbed a hold of Iida, and yanked him out of Shigaraki's grasp. Those crazed eyes went wide, and he yelled and pointed at Izuku. "You *fucking traitor!"*

Izuku flipped him off, as the demon dragged Iida over to where the rest of his classmates were. Iida looked so relieved and exhausted already. "Iida find your other classmates and make sure they're safe!" Aizawa yelled, and Midoriya looked over to his teacher. He saw anger reflected in those eyes, but also fear. The Nomu launched itself back at Dabi and Aizawa.

Izuku needed to get rid of Shigaraki and save Aizawa—

A loud roar that made the ground shudder and him halt in his steps. He fought for balance as he saw Dabi's flames sear the Nomu. Next to Shigaraki was a portal and sticking half in and half out of it was something Izuku had never seen before.

"Prototype-Nomu, it's time to play," Shigaraki said with an excited huff. There was a glint of satisfaction in his tone. "Inko, Hisashi, make sure your son doesn't escape it,"

His breathing quickened when he locked eyes with his mother and father. Neither of them were masked whatsoever. He felt himself begin to shake as they walked side by side with that *monster*.

And Izuku felt himself fly off his feet. Felt the Prototype-Nomu's claws rip him open as they took him.

Katsuki was taken away by a stupid fucking portal, and he was stuck with fucking Shitty Hair to top it all off. They were in rocky, snowy terrain and he knew that these villains had to have a spy on the inside. They had to know their Quirks.

Only a spy would know that Katsuki's Quirk relied on sweat, and cold was the worst area for him to be in. He was at a huge disadvantage here, but luckily he had Shitty Hair by his side. A shit ton of thuggish villains appeared as soon as they got teleported here. "Shit!"

Ice exploded from one of the villains, and Kirishima shoved Katsuki out of the way, hardening his skin against the ice. Kirishima slammed his fists into the ice, and it cracked. Katsuki let out a sigh of relief as Kirishima plowed through the low-level thugs.

"Hey Bakugou, isn't like, snow bad for your Quirk? Let's get outta here!" Kirishima exclaimed.

"Yeah shit for brains. Hurry the fuck up,"

"Gotta get back to Midoriya as soon as possible, huh?" Kirishima commented, "You seem to like him a lot,"

"Fucking shut up! He's just my childhood friend and I have to protect him! That's it," Katsuki explained with a scowl. Shitty Hair sure was fucking dumber than he thought.

"Aw I think that's cute!" Kirishima told him, "I wish I had a boyfriend like you! Midoriya's really lucky,"

"We aren't *fucking* dating you fucker!" Katsuki yelled with a blush as they walked out of the snow zone. Now they were entering the fire zone, and he could feel himself to begin to sweat. They quieted down as they glanced around anxiously. There were probably a hell of a lot of villains crawling through the U.S.J. that they had yet to take down.

As they were rounding a corner they found Tokoyami, the Bird Boy fighting off a few villains. Bakugou used his explosions to propel himself forward. He let off an explosion in a villain's face, and used another to change his trajectory mid-air. Dark Shadow took down a villain with a weak punch. Katsuki was surprised.

Kirishima was panting by the time he reached them. The villains laid in heaps on the ground, and Shoji came to join them. One of his multi hands were missing, but Katsuki could see it was already growing back. "The villains don't seem to be very dangerous," Tokoyami commented.

"Yeah, they're pretty weak," Shoji replied, "Have you guys seen anybody else recently? Do you think we should find everyone and go back to Aizawa?"

"Duh, now let's get a fucking move on you extra's!" Katsuki shouted, and they moved on to the next zone. With their strength in numbers, Kirishima talked animatedly with Tokoyami and Shoji. Along the way, Katsuki and Bird Brain took down a villain or two.

"So is Dark Shadow like...it's own entity?" Kirishima asked.

"Yeah, pretty much. He follows my orders well enough in daylight, but when it gets darker he's harder to control,"

"So light is your weakness?"

"A necessary weakness to keep everyone safe, yes," Tokoyami muttered ominously.

"Damn," Kirishima commented. "That's so manly!"

"I agree," Shoji said quietly. "I like Dark Shadow, he's like a pet,"

"Dark Shadow is *not* my pet,"

"Fucking okay, we get it Bird Brain," Katsuki snapped, with his arms crossed.

"What about you Shoji, do you know how your arms grow back?" Kirishima asked.

"Would you all shut the *fuck* up?!" Katsuki yelled, "We're getting attacked by villains, and this is the shit y'all talk about?!"

"Yes, yes it is," Kirishima said with a nod. "Anyone see anybody else yet?"

They kept going as no one answered Kirishima, and they got to the water zone with the shipwreck. They were nearing where Aizawa-sensei should be. That's when a huge group came from the city zone. Shinsou was leading them, and it consisted of almost the entirety of the rest of the class. But a lot of their classmates were bleeding and wounded.

The only one's missing were Todoroki, Uraraka, Ashido, Denki, Iida and Deku. Katsuki frowned. "Anyone fuckin' seen Deku?"

There was no response, as the two groups came together as one. For the moment they were safe, and the wounded sat themselves down — Jirou, Tsuyu, Kouda, Ojiro, Shoji, Aoyama — but no one was severely injured.

Katsuki was grateful for at least that. As everyone began to treat their own wounds Katsuki remained diligent and kept a lookout for any villains. They had enough uninjured people that they could protect themselves from any weak villain. Todoroki came after a little while, and Katsuki glared at him, just because he really, really didn't like that Half and Half bastard.

That's when they heard the roar, and felt the ground shake. That's when they *saw* it.

A monster, tall and lean. Black fur covered it head to toe, and it's skull was visible. White horns protruded from the skull, and glowing eyes met Katsuki's. It stopped for only a moment before running past them. Katsuki felt sick, when he saw that the thing had *Deku* in it's hand. Then he lost his voice entirely when he saw Inko and Hisashi.

Cold, fierce fear hit him like a wave. *Deku.*

He turned to follow it, but Kirishima put a hand on his shoulder to stop him. "W-was that thing taking Midoriya away?"

Shouta watched in horror as Kurogiri trapped his students while he was fighting villains. They dropped like flies as he and Dabi fought them off, but they kept coming, wave after wave.

Soon they'd be too exhausted to go on, and they'd be killed. Then his students would be thrown to the wolves, but he wasn't going to let that happen. He needed to protect them at all costs, not matter the cost. Dabi's blue flames incinerated a villain with a water Quirk in an instant. Aizawa wrapped his capture weapon around a villain, and gave him a swift kick to the head to knock him out.

He had to focus on taking out all of these villains, and then he could make sure his class was safe. He slammed his fist into the face of another villain, disabling their Quirk with his Erasure. He and Dabi made a pretty good team, he was willing to admit as they fought together.

"Hey, duck teach!"

Shouta didn't hesitate, and Dabi shot out a stream of beautiful blue fire right into a villain who had just been about to knock Shouta unconscious. "Thanks," Shouta muttered, taking a deep breath.

"No problem," Dabi shrugged. Shouta wrapped up a villain in his scarf, and slammed him into another villain. The two went down in a heap. Shouta's eyes were beginning to sting with the overuse of his Quirk. He could tell by Dabi's tense shoulders, and excessive sweating that his Quirk was exhausting him as well.

Then out of the corner of his eye he saw Kurogiri and Midoriya fighting as the purple smoke wall dissipated. Kurogiri said something to him, and Midoriya faltered before getting ready to fight again.

Then Shigaraki started to laugh, and Shouta felt goosebumps blossom along his arms. "Nomu, attack the stupid teacher! Break his face!"

The big monster that had been standing next to Shigaraki — Shouta knew him from the secret notes he found around the school — moved. It launched itself at Shouta, and he hand to dodge to avoid it's enormous hands.

And as Shouta and Dabi fought the Nomu, Kurogiri disappeared and reappeared with Iida in his grip. It's all Shouta could look at or concentrate on. Iida was in the arms of the *villains*. He was a *hostage.*

His fear seemed to increase tenfold when Midoriya jumped down to save Iida, demons trailing him with sinister, dark smiles. The demons looked as scary as Midoriya's drawings depicted them to be. He felt sick to his stomach, as he looked at them. Dabi kept the Nomu at bay with his flames, and Shouta was forced to help by trying to restrain the beast with his scarf.

It didn't work, and Shouta got yanked off his feet. The Nomu pounced and Shouta just managed to roll out of the way. The Nomu stopped for a moment as Shigaraki began to

speak. He said something to Kurogiri, and Iida got handed to him as the portal guy left for a moment.

"Tenya Iida, brother to Tensei Iida, both of whom have speed Quirks, isn't that right, Midoriya?" Shigaraki said, and Shouta felt his eyes go wide. "Todoroki Shouto, Half Cold Half Hot. Bakugou Katsuki, Explosion Quirk. Uraraka Ochako, Anti-Gravity. Denki Kaminari, Electricity Quirk,"

No. This couldn't be right.

"Midoriya Izuku, spy for the League of Villains! Did you hear that Eraserhead!? He's our spy!" Shouta gawked at Midoriya, feeling rage, betrayal, and sadness, but most of all confusion. He had many suspicions about Midoriya, but he didn't think of *that*.

That kid was probably abused and traumatized, but he never thought—

It never crossed his mind—

"He's been spying on Yuuei this entire time!"

He saw the tears running down Midoriya's face, and he knew it had to be true. His heart squeezed in his chest, as the realization hit him. Midoriya had helped *plan* all of this. Rage coiled in his chest, as he glared at Midoriya. He let his classmates get assaulted by *villains*. He was the *reason* that this was happening. Dabi covered his face with one hand, and looked hopelessly at Midoriya.

"It wasn't his choice." Dabi whispered softly enough only for Shouta to hear. "Don't make it sound like he did it willingly, you fucking bastard,"

Shouta pressed his lips together angrily, as he watched Shigaraki. Then he saw it. The thing that cut through the haze of anger, a demon. One that had been inching toward Iida the entire

time. He watched in relief as Iida got ripped from Shigaraki's grasp. Instantly Shigaraki was screaming at Midoriya, and it clicked for Shouta.

Midoriya had been the one leaving notes. He was trying to tell him without *telling* him. He locked eyes with Midoriya for a moment, finding terror and guilt in those dark green eyes that always seemed to be filled with pain.

"Iida find your other classmates and make sure they're safe!" He shouted, and a few seconds later he saw his student go off running.

The ground trembled beneath them. A roar cut through the air, and Shouta whipped his head to the source of the noise. Every hair on his body raised, and he looked at the monster in horror.

"Prototype-Nomu, it's time to play," Shigaraki said with an excited huff. "Inko, Hisashi, make sure your son doesn't escape it,"

Shouta felt frozen as Midoriya's parents emerged with the monster, the Prototype-Nomu. Midoriya looked the same way, but he seemed to look even more terrified than Shouta. He dropped his sword entirely, and his eyes had gone impossibly wide. His breath shuddered in his chest, and he could see Midoriya shaking.

And in a blink of an eye blood splattered everywhere, and a scream shattered through the air — terrified and shrill. Midoriya's blood.

Midoriya's *scream*.

Chapter End Notes

Also, I updated the Q&A doc!

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1-QTshERTbYsEltXewTymv0HOoWGadBW0tNl3AuzhstQ/edit?usp=sharing

Chapter 23

Chapter Notes

WARNING: CHILD DEATH. GRAPHIC DESCRIPTIONS OF INJURIES.

EDIT FEB 26 2021 2:34 AM:

Changed Wendigo to Prototype-Nomu to fit canon of MHA. :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

All he could see was the blood. Covering the walls, the floor, his hands*. It wasn't his blood, but the blood of the innocent children that died because of him. All because he couldn't speak. All because All For One was angry with him, and wanted Izuku to suffer.*

He could still the gunshots ringing in his ears as he desperately tried to wipe the blood off. Every time his hands came back more bloody than before, and the screams of terror pierced his ears.

"Save me, save me!"

"Please mister! Just say something!"

But all of this was a joke for everyone except Izuku and these children. His mother and father held him down, on his knees. They all knew he couldn't speak — not because he was mute — but because they gagged him and bound his hands together. He couldn't even scream. He couldn't move. "Please,"

'Please. Please. Save me. Save me.' Izuku thrashed in his parents' grip, but they held tight. The Quirk suppressors around his ankles made it impossible to use his Quirk to save the children. He was useless.

Tears pricked at the edges of his eyes, and he flinched as the first child fell in time with the first shot.

The small girl next to the dead corpse of a boy vomited. Blood splattered onto Izuku's face, and he stood frozen to the spot, his eyes burning into the dead corpse before him. His fault. His fault. All of this was his fault, and none of this would've happened if he just died—

The girl was next, and more blood covered him. He felt himself go limp, as All For One reloaded his gun, and pointed it at the last child. There was screaming, and begging. There were tears and blood.

Three corpses of children. "You see Izuku?" All For One whispered, his shoes getting stained red with the blood of children. "You couldn't save those children. Their deaths are on your hands. What kind of hero are you, my boy?"

All For One waited for a response that would never come. Izuku stared blankly at the three small bodies in the room and he couldn't register anything. There was so much blood. And it was his fault. All For One grabbed Izuku's face and pulled him close enough that Izuku could feel his breath on his cheek.

"Exactly. You'll never be a hero. You are a murderer. You are a spy. You're a villain,"

His eyes snapped open, and he got to his feet instantly.

Where was he? What was going on?

It took a moment for his brain to catch up and remember what was happening. The U.S.J. attack. Right. His side ached, but it didn't matter as he locked eyes with his mother. And then his father.

And the Prototype-Nomu. The monster that hadn't been apart of the plan. He reached for his sword, only to find it gone. His eyes widened and looked around wildly for it. Izuku felt his heart jump into his throat, as he realized he must've dropped it.

"Prototype-Nomu you can play with your new toy now," Hisashi said, "A game of cat and mouse,"

Izuku summoned his flames and waited for abated breath. The monster rushed forward through the broken city zone. The ground trembled with each step, and it's long claws swiped for him. He darted out of the way, sweat already making his hands slick. He could feel himself beginning to panic.

"You better start running!" Inko shouted from her spot on a rooftop. Izuku's eyes flickered to his parents for only a second. Hisashi wrapped an arm around her waist and grinned down at him.

He dodged those deadly talons again, but they still grazed him. Pain hit him sharply and throbbing. Blood seeped through the gash of his shirt, but shock started to set in and he couldn't feel it.

His feet skid against the asphalt as he scrambled back to his feet. Where the hell would he run?! He couldn't bring this thing back to Aizawa-sensei, or risk running into his classmates. The Prototype-Nomu screamed as Izuku threw caution to the wind and ran toward a zone where he knew none of his classmates had been placed.

The ground quaked, and he covered his ears. The glass ceiling of the U.S.J. seemed to crack a little. He willed his feet to go faster as the Prototype-Nomu plowed through buildings like it was nothing. It was playing with him.

This monster could've outrun him and killed him already. Izuku ran into a small alleyway and briefly saw his mother and father follow him by jumping rooftops. His fire swirled around him, and he blasted away a wall of debris in his path. The world around him caught fire, as he threw a ball of fire at the Prototype-Nomu without glancing back.

The Prototype-Nomu growled, and he felt the reverberations in his chest. Then the worst happened, as they came to a destroyed intersection. He tripped over uneven ground, and the Nomu *pounced*. He felt something in his arm snap.

It's large claws dug into his shoulders and ripped at his skin. He found it difficult to breathe, as the Nomu's hands pinned him to the ground. "Keep playing with your food, Nomu," Inko mumbled, and the Prototype-Nomu complied easily.

Izuku was thrown like a rag-doll into a building. His ankle and arm throbbed as he slammed into a concrete wall. For a moment everything went black before he blinked blearily. The Nomu ran to meet him as Izuku struggled to gain his footing. The world seemed to keep tilting and swirling.

He could feel blood trickle down his face as he took a breath. He summoned his fire again and sent a wave of it toward the Nomu but it did nothing. He spat out a mouthful of blood and reached for the cross around his neck.

To survive he'd need all of his power. *Every last drop.*

The Prototype-Nomu grabbed him by the ankle and dragged him. Those huge claws cut through his skin like butter. Izuku blasted hellfire right in the thing's back, as he ripped off his Suppressant.

The buildings shook. The ground groaned. The Prototype-Nomu roared in excitement, and let go of Izuku for only a moment. That single moment was all he needed as the full power of his Quirk greeted him. Demons rose from the ground, and without a thought, he absorbed them completely.

More and more of them ran to his aid as he sent a shock-wave of his demon-fueled hellfire. With their energy in his body, he was stronger. The Nomu stumbled, and the buildings around them tilted uneasily.

"Nomu, time to show him your Quirk!"

Izuku got to his feet, absorbing the demons that reached him. The power was hot in his veins as he glared at the monster, but the Nomu stood still. He waited anxiously, and then the Nomu opened it's massive mouth and screamed again louder than ever.

The U.S.J. building itself began to tremble and quake and a stream of white light exploded from the Nomu's mouth.

Izuku thanked his lucky stars that he managed to dodge it entirely. Everything that had been in the path of that beam had been completely *vaporized*. Half of the City zone, in *one* breath.

His body started to shake, and Izuku gaped in horror. He felt his knees go weak, and his heart began to explode in his chest with each beat. A Quirk like that— That monster had such a dangerous Quirk.

Izuku couldn't beat that.

It screamed again, and Izuku rolled out of the way as another beam shot out. He scrambled to his feet and ran as he realized that the Nomu's Quirk was still activated, and following him. Trying to vaporize him into oblivion.

He couldn't hear anything past the utter destruction that things Quirk was causing. He wasn't going to be fast enough. He could feel the heat of the beam on his heels. He could feel it burning his cloak completely. He kept running, faster and faster, undoing the clasp to cloak as he went.

Desperate, he shot fire at the Prototype-Nomu as he ran in a circle around it. His body ached and burned. He couldn't keep this up for long.

The city around him was completely vaporized. Scratch that, almost half of the U.S.J. was vaporized. In frustration, the Prototype-Nomu stopped his Quirk to scream and tear at its face. Izuku fell to his knees and gasped in lung fulls of air. "Nomu, kill him," Hisashi breathed, from his spot in front of the Prototype-Nomu.

With his Quirk all but forgotten, the Prototype-Nomu charged at him. This time, Izuku didn't have the strength to dodge. His body and soul were tired. Even if he wanted to, he couldn't move. All the pain and exhaustion seemed to be catching up with him.

The Prototype-Nomu tore him apart, and Izuku almost didn't care.

He could feel his ankle shatter, as the Nomu grabbed him and slammed him back into the ground. Again and again. His face burned against the asphalt, and the Prototype-Nomu ripped at his arm.

He heard himself scream. Low, guttural and tortured as his arm twisted. It was still playing with him, making his death slow and horrible.

Its claws ripped at his back, and suddenly it had its huge paw around Izuku's neck. His legs kicked uselessly as he was raised into the air. His lungs squeezed harshly in his chest as the air was cut off. It's grip tightened around Izuku's throat, and he was surprised his neck didn't just snap.

His vision darkened, and he ripped uselessly at the claws around his throat. He choked uselessly and barely heard the sound of Shigaraki shouting orders. "Take him! Sensei wants him back alive, that's our only objective since All Might refused to show up! He has to pay for his treason,"

No. He didn't want to go back.

"Those stupid Roses ruined the whole operation! Let's go before the fucking heroes arrive!"

The Roses? What the fuck was going on?

The Prototype-Nomu lessened its harsh grip, and Izuku sucked in a breath of much-needed air. He glanced down at Shigaraki to see that his hand was bleeding. Kurogiri put up a portal. They weren't paying too much attention to Izuku. He absorbed the demons that rushed for him. The power made his body shudder. So much power. Enough to kill that *thing*. He spotted a particularly large one, the size of a building. That demon smiled at him and reached out.

"...I save...you..?"

Izuku nodded and absorbed that one too, and he felt sick. It was too much for him to handle. His body nearly seized up completely.

No one was watching as his fire greeted him again.

But the Prototype-Nomu was. It happened fast. One second he was in the air, and the next there was a talon in protruding from his face and he was on the ground. His scream cut through the air, and Shigaraki whipped around to look at him. Izuku pulled out the claw — it wasn't in too deep, but it grazed his eye — and screamed again.

He clutched his face and got up on his shaking feet. Blood squirted from his face in between his fingers as he covered his eye. The special Nomu came for him, but Izuku condensed all of his stored up energy and poured it into one attack.

He could see Shigaraki running for him. But he'd be too late.

His fire swirled and began to freeze even more than usual. It writhed with the power, and Izuku shot it out in an explosion. His hellfire ripped through the Prototype-Nomu. Bone crunched and broke.

WHOOMP.

There was silence as the Prototype-Nomu tilted, and fell. The ground shuddered, and Izuku vomited.

Shigaraki stomped over, seething. He grabbed a handful of Izuku's hair and dragged his over to the purple portal. Villains poured into the portal, and Izuku thrashed, digging his nails into Shigaraki's bleeding hand.

"Inko fucking help me with this brat!" Shigaraki snapped, and Izuku groaned as Inko delivered a quick kick to his abdomen. Shigaraki then grabbed his broken arm and twisted it behind his back.

Pain, agony, horror, terror. It hit him like a tidal wave, and he threw his head back and felt the satisfying crack of Shigaraki's nose. Shigaraki let go of him and spit out a string of curses. Izuku collapsed, and Inko lunged for him.

He blasted his hellfire in her face. It was weak, but it still sent her falling on her ass nonetheless. He almost laughed.

A pair of villains converged on him and pulled him to his feet. One of them moved to put a hand over his mouth, and he took his chance as they dragged him closer and closer to the portal. Most of the villains had already entered. All that was left were Kurogiri, Shigaraki, Inko and the two villains dragging him.

He bit the hand coming to cover his mouth. He tasted the metallic iron of blood. The villain cursed and dropped him. Izuku shot a stream of fire at the other one, blinking back the urge to pass out. His back throbbed. Blood still poured from his eye, and he could barely see.

His arm was a broken mess, twisted and bleeding. Every inch of his exploded in agony with each movement but he *had to keep fighting.* But he was so tired.

Shigaraki reached for his face, with all five fingers. Izuku tried to move, he really did. His ankle throbbed with pain, and he ended up staying put. Then the shots rang out. Blood splattered on Izuku's face. With wide eyes, Izuku stared at the bullet wound in Shigaraki's

hand. Another round of shots rang in his ears, and he saw his mother go down. He saw Kurogiri grab Shigaraki and escape.

He tensed as the pro-heroes approached the scene. All Might was there, not smiling in the slightest. Izuku vomited again, still clutching at his eye. Aizawa, bloody and tired but otherwise okay, rushed over. He locked eyes with Dabi and whimpered.

Dabi got him first, his blue fire flaring angrily as he positioned himself in front of him. Izuku felt a pang of gratitude. "Leave him alone, you assholes!" He shouted. With that shout, some demons crawled out of the ground. Izuku heard a gasp.

One of them with a smile waved at All Might. Another wandered over to grab Izuku's Quirk suppressor, and Izuku sighed in immense relief as it took the liberty of putting it back on for him. The demons vanished from the Pro heroes' view. There was another round of surprised gasps, and no one came near him.

Aizawa glared at Dabi. "He needs medical attention, *now,*" He told Dabi, "I don't think you understand,"

Izuku blinked back the fog in his mind as Dabi stepped aside with a terrified look. He was so tired. He didn't even remember passing out.

He woke up screaming. It was too bright in the room where ever he was. His eyes burned, and his body ached dully. What hit him the most was the wave of terror that crashed into him. In his mind, he was still getting ripped apart by the Prototype-Nomu. His bones were cracking. His skin was being torn.

So he screamed.

He thrashed, and his heart monitor screeched along with him. He covered his face with shaking hands and *screamed*. His body shuddered, and voices reached his ears, concerned

and frantic.

"Midoriya—"

My boy.

"Young Midoriya—"

Kill him. Kill him— you're a villain.

You're no hero.

"I need you to calm down, okay Midoriya?"

Someone pulled his hands away from his face. He thrashed and fought. He was confused, he didn't know what was happening. Someone else grabbed him and held him down, and he kicked wildly.

He opened his eyes and thrashed, but he couldn't move. "Stop moving,"

Izuku glanced around, but he didn't register anything. *He was in danger.* That's all his body could process. That's all he wanted to process.

And suddenly his eyes met Dabi's, and he felt himself relax. "That's it..." He said softly. "You're fine. You're at Yuuei, and you're not getting chased by the Prototype-Nomu,"

Oh, that's right. Yuuei. The U.S.J. attack.

It was all coming back to him, slowly but surely. He'd killed the strange Nomu and passed out after the pros saved him. His heart calmed down, beating slower now in time with the heart monitor, and he looked around again. This time people were in the room. All Might, Aizawa, Recovery Girl, Dabi, and Nedzu.

They knew. They knew he was a *spy*. His heart monitor picked up speed again, and he stared at everyone with wide eyes. What would happen to him now?

After a moment of silence between everyone in the room, Dabi disappeared and Nedzu spoke. "I'm glad to see that you're awake, Midoriya-kun!"

"Nedzu shouldn't we let him rest first?" Aizawa grumbled, "It's not like he can run away with his leg broken,"

His leg was broken?

"I agree," Recovery Girl commented, "Look at the boy, he can't even stand. I healed as much as I could, but his arm's in a cast. His eye is going to heal, but it'll take a while. He has to heal naturally, and he needs *rest*,"

"Ah, yes! I agree, but there are some very important questions I want to ask him first," Nedzu told them all. "Aizawa-sensei, you taught him sign language yes?"

Aizawa nodded, but he didn't seem happy about it. "Wonderful! Please translate everything he says for me,"

Izuku waited. Aizawa-sensei didn't look too happy about helping Nedzu question him.

"First question, are you a spy?"

[Yes.]

"He says he is," Aizawa said with a dark look.

"Are you a *willing* spy?"

[No.]

Aizawa translated softly for him, and Nedzu continued. "In what way were you unwilling? How did you become involved with the League of Villains?"

[My parents and my mentor.]

"Inko and Hisashi? Am I correct?" Izuku nodded. Nedzu stroked his chin. "Who was your mentor?"

[Stain the Hero Killer.]

"So he trained you to kill heroes?" Nedzu hypothesized, putting a paw up to his face to stroke his chin. "He was a part of the League before his death?"

[He wanted me to become a hero, but he never planned on introducing me to the League.]

"But both him and your parents dragged you into it?"

[My parents forced me into it. Stain was forced to bring me along.]

"Why would they want you to join the League?”

[To spy.]

“Spy on who? What was your goal?”

[No.]

“What do you mean no?”

[No more questions.]

“The questions will stop when I’m satisfied Midoriya-kun,” Nedzu told him his gaze sharpening. “Who is your master?”

"Nedzu stop." Aizawa growled. "He just woke up,"

"I don't care. Who is your master?"

[No answer.] His breath hitched.

“Please Midoriya,” Nedzu pleaded, but there was no desperation in his eyes. Only the want to know the answer. No fear, no worry for his staff and students. "We need to know."

[No answer.] Izuku’s hands shook.

“He’s not going to answer us anymore. He’s given us everything he can give,” Aizawa said, his hand coming to rest on Izuku's shoulder comfortingly.

Izuku nodded, hands trembling. The door to Recovery Girls office flew open. "MIDOOOORIYA!" Present Mic screamed, "I'M SO GLAD YOU'RE ALRIGHT— What's going on?"

"I'm asking him a few questions," Nedzu explained. "He's a spy, did you not know?"

"Let's remember he was *forced."* Aizawa stopped Nedzu instantly, holding up his hand. "He left notes around the school. And in *your* office, if I remember correctly. He was playing both sides,"

"I'm aware of that," Nedzu said offhandedly. "I'm trying to figure out if he's a threat. I need him to answer my question,"

"What's the question?" Present Mic asked.

"Let's try again Midoriya. I'm against using force to get answers. Especially if they're children, and I don't want to have to,"

[Go ahead and use force. You'll get no answers. Any torture you could come up with would pale in comparison to what I've already been through.]

"What if I tortured your mother, would you answer then?"

"Principal Nedzu!" Recovery Girl shouted. Her face had gone a sickening shade of green. "We're heroes!"

[You wouldn't get answers. Not from her. Not from me.]

"I figured. I just wanted to see what you would say,"

“What did you ask him?” Present Mic asked again.

“I wanted to know who his master was,” Nedzu explained.

“I think I know,” Present Mic told them quietly. Izuku’s heart monitor screeched loudly as his heart began to pound even faster. His hands felt clammy, and he felt sick. Present Mic had that painting.

“I’ll be right back!”

Izuku turned away from his teachers and looked down at himself. His arm wasn’t twisted anymore, but it was in a sling. His leg was also in a cast, and the rest of him was wrapped in bandages.

“You were severely injured,” Recovery Girl told him, after she noticed him looking at his wounds. “That monster sure did a number on you. I’m surprised you didn’t pass out as soon as he twisted your arm. It broke your leg and nearly ripped open your stomach,”

“I’m surprised he killed it,” Aizawa commented.

“It vaporized half of the U.S.J., that’s how we found you,” All Might said, "How did you manage to survive and kill it?"

[I took off my Quirk Suppressor and nearly died even though I was at full power.]

"Quirk Suppressor?" All Might echoed in confusion.

[My Quirk is too dangerous without one. I need it to help me control my Quirk.]

"So you're never at one hundred percent unless you take it off?" Nedzu asked, suddenly intrigued.

[It's too dangerous.]

"Is your Suppressor the cross around your neck?" Aizawa asked. Izuku nodded and wrapped his hand around it cautiously. Just then, Present Mic entered the room again. Carrying in his hands was Izuku's painting.

The oh so incriminating painting, his portrait of All For One. He stared at it from across the room, and All For One smiled at him creepily. It looked so real.

"Ah, Present Mic! What does a painting have—"

But Nedzu went quiet. They all looked at the painting in mounting horror.

"He painted this the other day," Present Mic explained, "All For One,"

It was like he was thrown back in time. He could see himself screaming, he could see his hands getting crushed again and again.

He could *feel* it. He covered his face with his hand, trying to block out the whispers caressing his ears. It was like he was standing in the room with him, crushing his hands. Izuku whined.

"You could say I'm the supervillain who almost tore All Might in half..."

The heart monitor beeped loudly. He ignored it. "So you know All For One?" Nedzu asked.

"I am All For One,"

It was silent in the room, but Izuku kept hearing All For One whisper in his ear. Aizawa came over and placed a hand on his shoulder, and Izuku slapped it away. He couldn't breathe. *His hands, his hands, his hands!*

" Why can't I take your Quirk?"

"Midoriya are you okay?" Aizawa asked, his voice thin with worry. "Get that painting out of here!"

Izuku could feel himself panicking.

“Why can’t I take it from you?”

“I see...what a beautifully intriguing Quirk you have Izuku Midoriya. I think I like you, would you mind if I do an experiment? Of course, you don’t mind, my boy.”

He could hear his bones crunching and cracking. His breath shuddered in his chest, and his nails dug into his face. *Crack.*

“His hands...”

“His...hands...”

”I smell blood...”

They broke again, and Izuku jumped. He needed his mind to shut *off*. "Midoriya," Aizawa said softly, "Take deep breathes,"

He tried, but he could still hear his own screaming. "Present Mic took the painting away, you're okay now," He shook his head. Aizawa pulled Izuku's hand away from his face. "Stop hurting yourself,"

His face stung, and he realized he must've ripped open his skin. He gripped Aizawa's shirt as he tried to stand. *No. Don't leave.*

Reluctantly Aizawa leaned down again, and the whispers in his mind seemed to go quiet.

"I guess we'll go for now," Nedzu said quietly, "Aizawa we'll discuss his situation at a later date when he's healthier,"

Aizawa nodded, and suddenly the two of them were gone. Even Recovery Girl left them for the time being. Izuku took a deep, sobering breath and let himself relax. The voices didn't come up again and he sighed in relief.

"We're trying our hardest," Aizawa mumbled, "We all want to save you, I promise. So please cooperate with anything Nedzu wants you to do,"

He pulled back, and Izuku gaped at him. He didn't even know he was crying until Aizawa wrapped his arms around his shoulders. He never thought he would ever get to hear those words. Not with the things he did, and the things that had been done to him. He sobbed into Aizawa-sensei's shoulder, and for the first time, hope sparked in his heart.

We all want to save you.

Chapter End Notes

Guys I really can't believe how many ppl enjoy my fic, so thank you. please join my discord for update alerts, and plenty of spicy spoilers ;)

the discord invite!

Chapter 24

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku didn't sleep very well, and he kept jumping every time a demon wandered in his room. Fear of what was to become of him after the whole U.S.J. situation ate at him until he couldn't even fathom trying to get some rest.

He was almost about to have a breakdown when the sun finally kissed the sky with light. He watched from his bed, as the sky filled with many different shades of crimson and orange. The same sky every single day without fail, no matter what happened. The world could crumble in one day, but the sun would always rise. Celestial bodies cared not for the humans on Earth.

He vaguely wondered how many more sunrises he had left to see. Probably not many, and he found himself not too worried about it. He had long since accepted that his life would burn fiercely and horribly, only to die out quicker than he could imagine. He'd accepted it when his Quirk manifested, and his mother stopped loving him entirely. Yet, the fear still remained, ever-present and debilitating.

Against his better judgment, he hoped it would all be okay, even when his brain told him it couldn't possibly be okay. It would never be okay, what he did. He was a spy, and that wasn't even the worst of it. He had watched children die. He'd let them die, all because he was too weak. His hand curled into a fist and squeezed until his knuckles popped. Izuku was a horrible person.

He didn't deserve to be saved, even if Aizawa-sensei promised that they all wanted to. Anxiety rolled in his gut, and he did the only that relaxed him when he was worried. He grabbed his phone and texted Kacchan.

Deku: hey.

Kacchan: Hi.

Deku: No one told me what happened to you at the U.S.J., was everyone okay?

Kacchan: Who fucking cares about them? You should be more worried about yourself. You looked half dead.

Deku: I was fine.

Kacchan: They brought you out on a stretcher, and you were unconscious.

Deku: Okay, so maybe I wasn't exactly fine.

Kacchan: You fuckin' think? You're lucky I didn't wake your ass up and kick your ass all over again.

Deku: It's the only sleep I've gotten in a long time. Thanks.

Kacchan: Are you serious.

Deku: Deadly.

Kacchan: Why the fuck are you awake right now? Go to bed you crazy ass.

Deku: I can't.

Kacchan: And why can't you?

Deku: Because I'm too worried.

Kacchan: About all that shit that happened at the U.S.J...?

Deku: Yeah.

Kacchan: They can't seriously be thinking of pressing charges.

Deku: Dude I have no clue.

Deku: With my luck I'll be in jail as soon as I'm healed.

Kacchan: That's bullshit.

Deku: Not really, I did actually spy on everyone.

Kacchan: Did you have a choice?

Deku: Not really, to be honest.

Kacchan: Yeah, then that's utter bullshit.

Kacchan: I'm on my fucking way.

Deku: Kacchan no!

Kacchan: Kacchan yes .

Deku: I'll literally have a heart attack please no.

Kacchan: You don't control me Deku! I'm already halfway there anyway.

Deku: Dear god they might as well arrest us both .

Izuku shut off his phone and groaned soundlessly. Now he was kind of hoping they'd put him in jail just to avoid getting embarrassed by Kacchan. It was too early for this, and he hadn't got any sleep. With his good arm, he covered his face. Now he was restless and worried.

Just as he started to debate whether or not to text Kacchan again the door to the nurse's office opened. He tensed, worried for only a second until Recovery Girl came into the room. Not for the first time, Izuku wondered why he wasn't in a hospital. He had been wounded and needed medical attention, but they never took him to a hospital. He knew for a fact that Recovery Girl's Quirk was a wonder and a blessing, but she couldn't have possibly forgone taking him to a hospital.

He hadn't had time to worry about it yesterday, but now he was curious. "Good morning Midoriya-kun!" Recovery Girl exclaimed cheerfully, "I should be able to heal most of your wounds right now if you're okay with it,"

He nodded slightly, feeling a rush of excitement buzz through him. He didn't want to be stuck on this bed anymore. Recovery Girl smiled at him and walked over to his bed. She started with yanking out his IV, pressing a cotton ball to the tin pin-prick in his hand. She placed a band-aid there, and kissed him on the forehead. Her Quirk activated nearly instantly, and he could feel his wounds close at an accelerated rate.

It felt as if he'd been zapped of all his energy, as soon as the rather extensive damage done to him was fixed. He felt a soft click as his foot shifted back into place just slightly. "You should be all better now, except for your arm and eye," Recovery Girl told him, "I don't want to wear you out, and sometimes accelerating the healing process isn't a wise choice. Your eye is a prime example,"

He shrugged slightly, finger-spelling with one hand. [That's okay. Why didn't I get taken to a hospital? Why am I at Yuuei?]

"Ah. That's because Yuuei is the safest place for you to be at while you heal. That and we wanted to keep a close eye on you until we figured out what do to,"

[So what're you going to do?]

"I don't think I should be the one telling you," Recovery mumbled, "But you're not going to jail if that's what you're worried about."

He'll admit, hearing those words was reassuring. He let out a sigh of relief, as Recovery Girl set a bundle of clothes in front of him. "Get changed and then Aizawa and Nedzu should be getting here to talk to you about some things,"

Okay, nevermind. He was concerned, and he didn't want to *talk* about things. He wanted to put this all behind him and ignore it entirely. Izuku wanted to pretend he hadn't spied on the most prestigious school in the country, and he wanted to pretend everything was okay. But he knew the world didn't work like that and never would. He had to face Nedzu and Aizawa, and accept whatever fate they saw fit to give him.

Fate was never kind to the king of devils and fiends.

And he wouldn't be surprised if they wanted to throw him to the wolves. Yuuei had a perfect reputation, and Izuku could only think of one way they kept it so spotless. Maybe they'd just kill him. Maybe they'd erase his memories with a Quirk, or maybe—

No. He needed to keep himself calm. All he had to do was get dressed, and he couldn't let himself ponder the worst possible outcomes of every single situation he was thrown into. For once, he needed to be positive. At least he wasn't facing All For One again. Nothing could be worse than that, he told himself. Nothing could be worse than that basement he'd been forced to live in most of his life.

Nothing was worse than Hisashi and Inko Midoriya. Absolutely nothing. He was strong enough to face this. He pulled off his hospital gown and pulled his injured arm out of the sling. He felt instantly comforted by the hoodie that Recovery Girl was kind enough to procure for him out of the blue as he pulled it on. With minimal aching, he put his arm back

in the sling. The hardest part was actually pulling on the sweatpants and shoes with one hand.

What a day to be Izuku Midoriya, still sore and tired from the U.S.J. attack. Once he'd painstakingly got dressed — Recovery Girl being an angel and turning her back to him the entire time — he finally got out of bed. She turned back to him and gave him a soft smile. "Alright I'll go get them for you, please don't go anywhere,"

He'll admit that it was a tempting idea. Just to run, and never look back. But he knew that wasn't a good idea. All For One had influence everywhere, there was nowhere he could go that he could escape him fully. Not unless he stayed with the heroes.

He finally texted Kacchan again.

Deku: I'm serious, don't come.

Kacchan: Why not?

Deku: Because if any of us gets to become a hero it should be you. Don't get yourself tangled up with me. And Recovery Girl said I wasn't going to jail.

Kacchan: Okay, first off I'm already in all of this shit. And you're definitely becoming a hero, no matter what. If your sure you aren't going to jail I won't come. But I swear to god you're not the bad guy.

Deku: Thanks Kacchan.

He breathed a sigh of relief. He had been so engrossed with his conversation to the point he didn't realize that Nedzu and Aizawa were already in the room until he heard Aizawa-sensei clear his throat.

Izuku looked at him apprehensively. "Well young Midoriya," Nedzu began, "After a long debate we've decided exactly how we're going to deal with your situation. We've decided that you'll stay at Yuuei, on two conditions. You must agree to be monitored by a Pro hero, Aizawa will be that hero, and you must agree to get a psychological evaluation with the rest of your class,"

Izuku must've looked a little too confused because Aizawa jumped in to explain more thoroughly. "You'll be living with me and Present Mic, and when the dorms are finished you won't be moving into them. All of your classmates are required to have an evaluation with a psychologist, and I think it's a good idea to get you evaluated too,"

[Oh. Okay.]

"I'm surprised! You're taking all of this in stride, I didn't expect you to agree!" Nedzu commented.

[Can't be any worse than what I've already been through.]

This was a fucking blessing if Izuku ever saw one. He wasn't going to jail. He wasn't going to die. He just had to agree to be monitored and evaluated. Easy enough, or he thought until Aizawa decided to ruin it.

"You'll have to come with me and All Might to get your things from your house. Your father has been missing since the U.S.J. attack and we're pretty sure he won't be going back anytime soon. Still, you'll be with me and the number one hero, so if he does decide to show his face you'll be protected,"

That wasn't the problem. The problem was, he didn't want anyone to see how he'd been living. He was ashamed of himself that he wasn't good enough for his parents to love him. He didn't want Aizawa or All Might to see that blatant neglect of which they treated Izuku. Izuku didn't even have that many clothes to take with him. He also didn't want to go into the basement where it was dark. And lonely. But reluctantly he nodded.

[Okay, when?]

"Now, if you're feeling up to it," Aizawa replied.

He wasn't, but he nodded again anyway. Right then, All Might decided to make an appearance. He gave Izuku a huge, happy smile. "I'm glad to see you're doing well, Young

Midoriya! Are you ready to stop by your house?"

[That place isn't my home.]

"Then where was your home?" All Might asked, almost dumbly. Izuku found himself thinking that the number one hero was kind of dim, but he didn't mind all that much.

[I don't have one.]

Aizawa was quick to translate, looking sad and exhausted. Just as Izuku was about to leave, Recovery Girl stopped them. "Hold on, Midoriya. I just got the results from your blood test,"

He raised an eyebrow at her. "There's an unprecedented amount of Quirk Suppressant medicine in your system, care to explain? Usually, you need to get these prescribed, who did you get access to some?"

He paused. Hisashi and Inko had forced him to take them, and then he'd nearly gotten addicted to them until All For One gave him a Quirk Suppressant necklace. For a moment he considered lying, but he knew it'd probably bite him in the ass later.

[They made me take them.]

"You realize that these can be lethal if you take them too often? With how much is clogging your systems, you shouldn't be *alive* right now. How did you even fight that Nomu and survive?" Recovery Girl seethed, concern sparking in her eyes.

[I don't know.]

"Well, there's not much I can do to fix it right now," Recovery Girl muttered, "It'll make it's way out of your system in a few days, but I don't want to see you taking any more of them,"

Izuku nodded with a slight smile.

[Okay.]

"Alright, go all of you. I have work to do," Recovery Girl told them, waving her hands toward the door. Izuku grabbed his sword from his bed and didn't wait for All Might and Aizawa-sensei to follow him. He walked down the hall, his hand resting comfortingly on the hilt. He heard All Might's heavy footsteps and knew they had finally caught up to him.

The sky was clear when they finally left the campus. Izuku felt tense and worried. He half expected All For One himself to appear and attack him in broad daylight, but in the back of his mind, he knew All For One wouldn't do so without a foolproof plan. He forced himself to remain calm, and lead All Might and Aizawa to his house. They were silent the entire time, and Izuku found himself hesitating.

His mother's home was easy to spot, and it was second nature to him to seek it out and glare at it with all his might. He could already feel the telltale signs of fear prickling at the edge of his mind. Tugging him forward in its alluring haunting embrace, achingly familiar and colder than his own hellflame. It was like the sky suddenly darkened as he climbed the stairs up to the front door, and the air grew cold.

His vision darkened at the edges as he beheld his mother's home — not his, never his, this personal hell of his would never be a home to him. Not ever. He paused as he stood at the doorway. He'd grasped the doorknob, but it was like merely touching it had sent him back in time by only a few days.

Avoidance sparked in his gut, sharp and powerful. He didn't want to go home to Inko or Hisashi again. He didn't want to hide in his room away from the warmth that sunlight provided and open air. Away from the world, in the darkness which he so despised and feared beyond all rationality. His fist tightened around the doorknob, and he squeezed his eyes shut.

I don't want to be stuck here. I don't want to go inside. I hate the dark. I hate the dark—

All Might cleared his throat, and it was like the illusion shattered into a million pieces — the fear remained, heavier than bricks in his stomach — and he blinked. All Might's words have always been soothing to him. Even when he lost his love for the hero, and chose Eraserhead. Now it was warm like a mother's embrace. "Young Midoriya, would you like us to wait outside while you gather your things?"

He didn't turn to them as he gave a small nod. His hand was still glued to the doorknob, and he didn't see himself moving to open the door anytime soon. But he knew he had to get this over with as soon as possible.

"Give me your sword before you go inside," Aizawa mumbled, and Izuku turned to face him. He was holding out his hand, face a hard mask. "I don't want you running off while our backs are turned,"

As much as Izuku loathed the idea of giving his sword up, for the time being, he understood where Aizawa was coming from. He knew he couldn't convince Aizawa that he wasn't going anywhere without having to give it up. The missing weight from his weapon was distracting, as he finally turned back to the door and threw it open.

He was grateful All Might and Aizawa let him go in alone, as the door closed behind him.

The house was dark and deathly quiet. It was like he was coming home like any other day. He felt like his mother would jump from behind any wall, screaming obscenities and insults that struck harder than any punch. It made his hands shake. It made his lungs shudder and struggle for air.

Fear trickled like sweat down his spine, and for a painful moment, she was actually there, screaming, cursing, and insulting him with every possible swear word she could think of.

"You're an abomination!"

"You're nothing but a monster."

"You shouldn't have been born."

You're Quirkless. You're Quirkless. You're Quirkless.

I'm Quirkless. I'm Quirkless. I'm Quirkless. I'm Quirkless—

He took a deep breath and covered his eyes with a hand. The world was swirling. His shoulders rose and fell with each breath, and he forced himself to relax. The world stilled for now. His mother was in police custody. He was fine. No one was here. He was alone. Everything was fine.

He needed to remember that, as his breathing finally slowed, and his fear wasn't at the forefront of his mind. It was still lurking, dark and familiar, but he couldn't let it control him just yet. Maybe in Yuuei's bathroom an hour from now, where he could be alone, but not here. Not anymore.

His shoes were silent against the carpet as he ventured from the living room to his own. If you could even call it that.

The fear reared its ugly head again, and Izuku swallowed thickly. He stared blankly at the door before him and didn't move. This door was different than any other in the house, and Izuku wrapped a hand around the doorknob.

Five locks. One with a chain, and a regular lock on the doorknob itself. A sliding lock. A deadbolt, and another sliding lock. All of them were to keep him locked *inside*. Izuku's breathing quickened until he was suddenly hyperventilating into the silence. He didn't want to go down there again. He didn't.

But he needed to.

Slowly he undid the first lock and clenched his fists. He *had* to do this. The second lock and the third were easy to undo. He was hesitant to undo the fourth, and when he finally reached

the last lock he felt tears at the edges of his eyes.

"Go down there, and don't come back up,"

"Bad boys go down to their rooms. Do you want to go to your room?"

No, no he didn't. He'd be a good boy. He would tell Kacchan he was Quirkless when it was so obvious that he wasn't. He would be good. He didn't want to go down into the basement again and again— No, no, no, no!

His heart was in his throat, and his hands struggled to undo the last lock. Sweat dripped down his temple, and he brushed it away with shaking hands. Fear gripped him again, stronger than last time.

He pulled the door open slowly, and a low creak issued from the rusty hinges. His eyes found the darkness, so terrifying and dangerous. His fear froze him to the spot, but he forced himself to move. He'd been taking too long, and he was afraid that Aizawa would come inside. He didn't want the man in his mother's home. He didn't want him to see exactly how his parents treated him.

No matter how much he deserved it.

Effectively ignoring the cold claws of fear that raked his body, he walked down the stairs. The wooden steps screeched as he took them two at a time, barreling into his dark room.

He turned the flashlight of his phone on and looked around. That's when he heard it. The door slam, jarring and loud in the silence. That's when he heard the familiar sing-song voice.

"Izuku..."

Chapter End Notes

Guys I really can't believe how many ppl enjoy my fic, so thank you. please join my discord for update alerts, and plenty of spicy spoilers ;)

https://discord.gg/BdGsq8Z

Chapter 25

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shouta hated having one on one meetings with Nedzu. And they seemed to be having more and more of them as time went on. It was torture listening to Nedzu done on and on uselessly until he circled back around to the topic at hand. But still, after his conversation with Midoriya that left the boy in tears, he headed for Nedzu's office.

The principal's office was impeccably designed, with live feeds of all the camera's in Yuuei. White carpet ran along the floors, and there were two white couches on either side of a black sleek looking coffee table.

Nedzu sat at his desk, and Shouta watched wearily as those beady eyes scanned the papers on his desk, and then popped up to the live feed TVs with camera footage. Shouta glanced at some of the tv's and that's when he realized that the camera feeds weren't live. They were old feeds. Specifically, feeds on repeat of Midoriya sneaking around Yuuei.

"Ah! Aizawa, you're here!" Nedzu exclaimed. "And I see you've already realized that I'm going through all of the feeds with Midoriya in them. I'm trying to find any traces of him placing his notes around Yuuei, and I've found a few. Would you like to see?"

Shouta sighed and took a seat in front of Nedzu's massive desk, and scanned the tv screens. "Why not?"

"One moment," Nedzu mumbled, his paws clicking on the keyboard of his computer. It was annoying to listen to in the awkward silence that ensued as soon as Nedzu stopped speaking. After a moment, all the tv screens went black, and only one remained on. A video played on it, a video of Midoriya snooping through the staff room — well he wasn't snooping, he was placing notes of information.

"This particular one I wasn't aware that All Might received. Until now, I thought we were the only ones who knew about these notes," Nedzu continued. "I've asked him to meet us, and he should be here soon. I'd like to go over the rest of the notes we found, really quickly,"

Shouta nodded, and Nedzu procured every single note sent their way by Midoriya. The pile of ripped papers seemed small, but it was just enough. It saved Shouta during the final moments of the U.S.J. incident. He and Nedzu went through each paper.

The first was Shigaraki's file and all known information from Midoriya.

Tomura Shigaraki

Real Name: Unknown.

Age: Unknown. Possibly 18? 20?

Gender: Male.

Affiliation: League of Villains, leader.

Personality: A very childish man (teenager??). Unstable mental state, very unpredictable and dangerous. He thinks life is a game and sees All Might as an endgame boss. His goal is to test his luck with All Might, all the while trying to get me back and reassign me to another job within the league.

Quirk: Five finger contact disintegration. Speed varies with the time within contact of an object. The longer he is touching something, the faster the object disintegrates. Dangerous individual, avoid all possible physical contact with him.

Fighting Style: Fast, wild and unpredictable. Hands are his selling point. He will rush at you with his hands outstretched, and he's not afraid to play dirty.

Notes: Not afraid to kill. Keep that in mind. He doesn't play fair. To defeat him, cut off a finger or break his hands.

"All this information seems to be as accurate. You dealt with Shigaraki head-on, did this information help whatsoever?" Nedzu asked.

Shouta breathed a sigh through his nose. "Of course it did, especially the Quirk analysis Midoriya added in,"

"Let us continue on before All Might arrives. Kurogiri,"

Kurogiri

Real Name: Unknown.

Age: Unknown.

Gender: Male.

Affiliation: League of Villains.

Personality: Not as villainous as his mist-like Quirk makes him out to be. Has a goal, (goal is unknown) and is using the League to attain it. He is very close to Shigaraki, and they seem to get along for the most part. Luckily he keeps Shigaraki in line especially when Shigaraki is losing his shit. He's against killing children? Stain ideology? Very level-headed and logical. Polite. Has a sinister side.

Quirk: A mist teleportation Quirk. He must have the exact coordinates in order to use his teleportation skills. His weakness is the metal brace around his neck. If engaged with him, aim for that. He can summon portals on floors, walls, and in mid-air. Quirk is very versatile. He's mostly the transportation for the League.

Fighting Style: Reliant on hiding his real body through using his fog-like mist to cover it up. Very defensive of his metal brace. Will teleport body parts off.

Notes: Vital asset to the League. Although, his loyalty is questionable. He's helped me before. He stitched my wound for me, even though he didn't have to. Most likely a follower of Stain. "Stain the roses red," His only main weakness is that a part of his real body must be present at all times, allowing the opportunity to attack that body part. The brace is that body part. Aim for that. Aizawa-sensei or Tokoyami would be a good match.

Nomu

Real Name: Nomu #1256

Age: A few weeks old.

Gender: Neither.

Affiliation: League of Villains.

Personality: None. Follows orders from Shigaraki only.

Quirk(s): Regeneration. Absorption. Speed. Can regenerate limbs, and punch super fast. Faster than Ingenium. Beware. Built to withstand even All Might's punches at one hundred percent. Built to destroy All Might. DO NOT ENGAGE.

Fighting Style: Very reliant on orders. Their fighting style is unknown/uncertain.

Notes: Do not engage. If there is no choice, Dabi will interfere. I will kill it myself. Other options include Aizawa-sensei or Todoroki. The best tactic is to burn the entire body, so it can't regenerate.

Nedzu went through every single note, and once they finally finished he began to speak. "I've begun to wonder why exactly Midoriya saw fit to give us these notes and reveal this information,"

"Maybe because he was forced into this kind of life, and saw this as an opportunity? It could be possible," Shouta replied, "It was risky as hell, but he was willing to stick his neck out to help us in his own way,"

"I agree with you Aizawa! He's very intuitive and sharp. His notes on all of these villains are thorough and accurate as you tell me," Nedzu told him, "I can see why he was recruited by the League to spy on us, his Quirk is quite powerful, and his almost obsessive note-taking is an asset. As it was confirmed a few moments ago, he was connected to All for One, as well. I have a theory,"

Shouta crossed his arms, fighting the urge to lean forward and shake it out of him. What was this smart rat thinking? What had he hypothesized in a few short minutes?

"We all know why he was initially recruited, which was because his parents were villains. Why would they make him a spy? Well, I think it's because he owed them. You and Recovery Girl both said during the entrance exam that he shouldn't have been able to use his hands, based on the injuries he sustained a while back. I believe Midoriya had them healed by one of the villains, and he owed All for One. The man saw his potential as a spy, and he knew that Midoriya owed him. That would explain why he'd been made a spy, but it doesn't clear up why he decided to betray them,"

Shouta paused for a moment, mentally. *Why* would he betray them? It seemed painfully obvious.

"I have a theory of my own," He began. "I believe that Midoriya was being abused by his parents because of his Quirk, and he couldn't handle it anymore. It's as simple as that,"

"We don't have solid evidence for that, but I considered it. I want all the facts before I jump to conclusions as much as I believe that theory— Ah All Might! Thank you for joining us! Please take a seat!"

"You wanted to see me Nedzu?" All Might asked as he took a seat next to Shouta.

"Yes! We were just discussing Midoriya and the role he played with the League of Villains,"

"I see...where do I come in?"

It was quick to catch him up and tell him about the notes. They went over them again, and All Might shifted uncomfortably. "You received notes as well?"

"What did young Midoriya give you?" Nedzu asked hungrily. "What do yours say?"

Shouta watched with bated breath as All Might got out pieces of torn papers. "Mostly minor villains, not too dangerous. I did get one disturbing note though,"

"What was it?" And it was like Nedzu was drooling almost in anticipation. Shouta couldn't blame him.

"'He lives,'" All Might relayed softly, "And I knew instantly who he was talking about,"

"This just proves that Midoriya really knew All for One, thank you All Might," Nedzu replied, "Now that we've all convened, let's move onto what we should do with Midoriya-kun,"

Now, this is what Shouta had been worried about. This is what he'd been so anxious about. "Before I make my decision, I would like to hear what you two think about his character,"

All Might spoke first. "I think he's a great kid. I met him before he got into Yuuei, and it was obvious that there was something going on with him. For a time I didn't know he was mute, but that changes nothing. I found him napping in parks a lot of the time, and we discussed his art. He has the passion of a true hero just like any other kid at Yuuei. He never seemed sinister in the slightest,"

Nedzu nodded with a slight smile and then turned to Shouta. He sat for a moment on his feelings toward his student. Suddenly it all started with spill out. "I admittedly followed him for a time. Just observing him because I was curious after I saw him in Recovery Girl's office. He'd be absent to school for days, and on the weekends he'd never leave his house, but now I know it's because they have Kurogiri, a villain with a warp Quirk. It's painfully obvious that he was being abused, or even being trained without care for his health. He'd go to school looking like he just came out of a boxing ring, and he unequivocally lost. I think he shouldn't be punished for his actions but merely monitored for the time being. If he shows signs of having sinister intent, then I think he should be dealt with. We should definitely have Detective Tsukauchi question him and his mother,"

"Then you'll have no objections to the idea I'm going to propose," Nedzu mumbled, putting both of his paws on his desk. "I was thinking of allowing him to learn at Yuuei as long as he agreed to be monitored. Of course, he'd need to be evaluated by a professional to make sure he's mentally stable. All of 1-A needs to be, and I was thinking of hiring a therapist for your class. This evaluation will make it easier to see who really needs one, and who doesn't,"

Shouta nodded. Relief flooded him. "Who should monitor him?"

"Why not you?" Nedzu replied, "You can erase his Quirk, and you seem to have a pretty good connection with him already,"

Me?

"Me?" Shouta mumbled, confused. "Are you sure?"

"I'm always sure! I wouldn't trust anyone else with his safety and health. He may have been a spy, but I see the makings of a hero in him,"

Shouta didn't try to hide his smile. "I'm sure Present Mic will be excited to hear the news and as much as I'd like to let you tell him right this second, we have another matter to discuss,"

"What's that?" All Might asked.

"Can Detective Tsukauchi's Quirk work on people using sign language?" Nedzu asked instead.

"Yes, it's a form of response," All Might told him. "Why?"

"Because I'd like to have him questioned along with his mother as soon as possible," Nedzu told him. "I'm most excited to learn exactly how Inko Midoriya treated her son. A verbal confession is practically a jail sentence waiting to happen,"

Izuku cursed himself for allowing Aizawa-sensei to take his sword. The stairs creaked with the weight of Hisashi, and Izuku frantically turned off his flashlight despite the fear that drowned him. The darkness swallowed him, but he pushed away the terror that threatened to doom him. Again the soft, sing-song voice reached his ears.

"Izuku..."

It was louder this time, and Izuku was quick to turn and go for the knife under his bed. He would use it if he had to, but then as an afterthought, he grabbed the handgun hidden in his dresser of clothes and put down the knife. He hadn't bought this gun for this purpose, but today he wouldn't be afraid to point it at someone else rather than himself. As long as that person he was pointing it at was Hisashi.

Still, his hand shook, and sweat slicked his palm and his grip wasn't the best. He blamed it on the fear. He blamed it on All For One for breaking his fucking hands. He blamed it on the fucking Prototype-Nomu that broke his arm and made him useless. Those familiar white eyes found his in the darkness, and Izuku looked away.

His hellfire was eager to meet him, but he didn't trust himself when Hisashi was involved. Too many times did he freeze and completely forgo using his Quirk. The stairs creaked heavily again, and he could hear Hisashi laughing. It was chilling in the darkness, and Izuku felt the hairs on his neck rise as he readjusted his grip on the gun. Then he heard Hisashi's feet shuffle on the floor, and Izuku held his breath.

"Where are you, Izuku?" Hisashi asked, and Izuku tried his damndest to move silently. "You can't run from me, or All For One. I don't know what went through your head when you decided you'd betray us. We treated you really well, and this is how you *repay* us?"

He could hear Hisashi taking his sweet time finding him as if this was all a game, and he'd win in the end no matter what. Like it didn't matter if he had some fun before dragging Izuku right back into the arms of All For One. His eyes had adjusted to the dark, and he still couldn't see Hisashi.

That was fine because he could tell where he was. Hisashi never stopped talking and Izuku was frantic. Should he use the gun in his hand, or put it in his pocket and throw the knife? For what felt like an hour, he weighed his options. Without a second thought he put the gun in his back pocket and wrapped his fingers around the knife. After a second he let it fly. "All For One wants you—“

And then the darkness was full of Hisashi's screeching. Izuku had aimed for his general direction, and apparently his knife struck true as he'd planned. That's when Izuku pounced.

It must've been his pounding terror, and his body pumping adrenaline that helped him because he didn't hesitate. He scrambled to move, to tackle and take Hisashi down before the man had any time to remove the knife from where ever it struck, and retaliate. His broken arm exploded in pain, but he pushed through it.

On instinct just like Stain taught him, he slammed himself into the larger man. They went tumbling, and Izuku pulled back his hand to punch him in the jaw. That's where his luck completely fizzled out. Hisashi's hand wrapped around Izuku's wrist and the other grabbed a fistful of his hoodie.

There was a moment of agonizing pain, but then he was thrown across the room. He collided with his dresser, and he could hear Hisashi getting up and running for him. Izuku fought through the sharp pain zipping down his back and got to his feet. He crouched low to the floor, and when Hisashi's hands reached for him blindly in the darkness, he darted out of range.

Hisashi followed the sound of his scrambling feet, and Izuku's ragged, terrified breathing. He needed to end this quickly. Izuku grabbed the gun tightly in one hand and stood to his full height. He wouldn't use the gun just yet. He slapped Hisashi's wrist away with the barrel of the gun when he reached for Izuku. Hisashi pulled his hand away, and Izuku went for the stairs. He needed to *leave*.

Izuku could practically smell the taste of freedom as his feet carried him to the stairs. Then suddenly he was on his back, with Hisashi on top of him. "You're not leaving," He snapped. "All For One has plans for you! He wants to make you his heir, and you don't have a choice in the matter! You will do exactly as he says, and I'll do anything to bring you back to him,"

Izuku froze. *His heir?* What did that even mean?! That's when Hisashi wrapped one of his hands around Izuku's wrist, and the other one grabbed and twisted his broken arm. The world stopped. Completely stopped, silent and utterly dark.

He felt nothing, but everything at the same time. *All* of his fear. *All* of his pain. Over and over. Hisashi’s Quirk burned him alive with pain.

Every part of him was in agony, and his brain couldn't function with all the fear rolling off of him in waves. He could feel himself begin to seize up, just like the last time this happened.

All For One himself had to stop Hisashi, but no help was to be found this time.

So everything *shattered*, silently and brutally. The worst pain was the silent type. The type that made it impossible to scream, or fight back. Hisashi's kind of pain. His body burned, and he felt as if he was being ripped apart. It was an explosion after explosion of pain. Even though the haze of pain made it impossible to move, Izuku's fingers wrapped around the gun in his hand. He didn't need to shoot Hisashi. He needed to make a noise. He needed Aizawa. He needed All Might.

He needed a *hero*.

Most importantly, he didn't want to go back to All For One. The sound of the gunshot startled Hisashi, but the pain didn't stop. His jaw exploded in pain, but it still wasn't as severe as Hisashi's Quirk. The man still had his hand wrapped around Izuku's wrist, keeping the gun pointed away from him as he tried to tear it out of Izuku's hand. He had finally released Izuku’s broken arm in favor for the gun.

Izuku's grip was iron tight, and he struggled to keep it in his grasp. Hisashi's hands ripped at him, and he got ahold of the weapon. He turned it on Izuku and pointed it at him. "Get up, and go into the portal,"

They were both still for a moment, and then Hisashi slowly climbed off of him. Izuku's whole body screamed at him in pain. His jaw ached, and so did his stomach. He struggled to stand with one hand, falling a few times before he finally got a sure footing. The pain and panic receded as he finally stood. Only to be replaced with his bone-crushing fear, as Kurogiri's purple warp appeared.

"Go!" Hisashi yelled loudly. "Fucking hurry it up!"

Something tugged harshly in his chest. He didn't want to go. He wanted to be a hero, just like Chizome-san said he could be. He wanted to honor Chizome-san by saving himself and becoming exactly what he was meant to be.

He barely flinched when Hisashi shouted angrily, and Izuku felt the cool metal of the gun pressed up to his forehead. "Go in the fucking portal, damn it!"

When Izuku didn't move, Hisashi grabbed him and started to drag him. The pain burned him as Hisashi's hand came in contact with him, and he pulled him closer and closer to the portal. Izuku pulled against him, and Hisashi cursed.

No. He wouldn't go. Not when he was so close to freedom that he could feel it in his soul. No fucking way. He was too close to let Hisashi drag him back.

He'd much sooner die than become a villain. He pulled against Hisashi with each step. Finally fed up, Hisashi threw him to the ground, Izuku sucked a pained gasp between his clenched jaw as his back and arm screamed in pain. Hisashi didn't even use his Quirk. He slammed his foot into Izuku's abdomen. His head cracked against the floor as Hisashi delivered a blow to his temple. Stars danced in his vision, even in the darkness.

Fear drowned him, and he scrambled to fight back. Hisashi didn't even give him the chance. As soon as Izuku showed the signs of getting ready to fight back, Hisashi pounced. His nails dug into his neck as his hands wrapped around it. With oxygen suddenly cut off from him, Izuku kicked uselessly and choked. Pain burned through him like he was paper. His vision began to get even darker at the edges, and slowly his arms and legs went limp. He was losing this fight.

And that's when the door blew open. Blue fire erupted, and Izuku had never been happier to see those flames in his life. Hisashi didn't miss a beat. He pulled Izuku to a sitting position and put Izuku's knife to his throat. Izuku froze, eyes wide. The gun had been completely forgotten.

Hisashi's other hand rested tightly on Izuku's shoulder. Pain throbbed in time with his heartbeat as Dabi, Aizawa and All Might ran down the stairs, only to stop. All Might didn't swoop in with his usual spiel, and he looked *livid*.

Dabi looked absolutely pissed, and Aizawa looked even angrier than the both of them. "None of you move," Hisashi spat, and Izuku felt the warm trickle of blood dripping down his neck. "Or he dies,"

Izuku's ragged breathing was loud in the silence. He was being overwhelmed. Pain throbbed sharply throughout his entire body. Fear embraced him, and wouldn't let go. All Might was their best bet.

The man could move must faster than what should be humanly possible, but he wasn't moving. He opened his mouth to speak. "Now, don't do anything rash..." He began, his eyes meeting Izuku's wide terrified ones. "He's just a boy—"

"Shut the fuck up! *Just a boy* my ass!" Hisashi shouted, and Izuku's breath caught in his throat when Hisashi yanked his head back and sliced his face just below his eye. Pain exploded from where Hisashi's hand touched his forehead. "Stop talking,"

Blood dripped down Izuku's face, as Hisashi placed that knife at his neck again, pressing ever so slightly. His hands twitched at his sides, and he watched as All Might clenched his jaw.

Hisashi was distracted. All Might was the only foe to him, so maybe he wouldn't be expecting Izuku to strike. His hand was free. Hisashi didn't expect Izuku to summon his hellflame.

Izuku forced himself to be as slow and unassuming as possible as he positioned his hands. The flames licked his hands, and he waited. "He's coming back with me. He has plans for him,"

Fear made his breathing ragged. He could do this. He could do this. He closed his eyes for a moment. "Who is he?" All Might asked.

"Don't you already know, All Might?" Hisashi said. Izuku could hear the smile in his voice. "He's your enemy. He's a mastermind, you know his name,"

All Might was silent. Aizawa took a quick step forward, his scarf coming to life. Hisashi hissed at him.

"Don't *fucking* move!" Hisashi shouted. "I won't hesitate to kill him!"

"If you need him, why would you kill him?" Dabi asked, his flames dancing the dark.

"No one ever truly dies. Not when you know All For One," Hisashi smiled. "He has a reanimation Quirk. We could turn Izuku into a Nomu, and he could be an immensely useful tool with that Quirk,"

Dabi scowled, and Hisashi tightened his grip on the knife. His other hand went back to his shoulder, and the pain was renewed, stronger than ever. His body throbbed, and Izuku felt himself stiffen. He'd fought Hisashi, and he was fatigued. He was too tired and terrified to fight. Fear flashed in Dabi's eyes, and Izuku could see him shaking. "Erase his Quirk, Eraserhead,"

Aizawa was quick to comply, and red flashed as Aizawa's hair rose. The pain stopped, and Izuku felt himself relax just slightly. "I've always hated that fucking demon of yours, Izuku," His words were hissed angrily. "I hate your Quirk, and Stain was stupid to think you could *ever* be a hero. Such a stupid dream to have. You should've become a villain just like I told you. These heroes don't want to *help* you. They don't like you. You're nothing but a villain in their eyes, why not prove them right?"

Izuku fought the urge to agree. After all, he'd been thinking the same things in the back of his mind. What if all of this was a lie? What if they didn't care at all? What if this was all a game to them, and he didn't belong anywhere?

"Don't listen to him," Aizawa replied, his eyes hard as stone and angry.

"Come with me, Izuku," Hisashi insisted.

Become a hero.

Stain was stupid to think you could ever be a hero.

It all happened so fast. One second Hisashi was distracted by trying to get Izuku to go back, and then in the next, he was sprawled out on the floor. All Might was there in an instant, and the knife was gone.

He grabbed Izuku by the shoulders, and locked eyes with him. "Are you okay?" He asked gently, his eyes soft.

Izuku didn't have the heart to tell him that he, in fact, wasn't anywhere near okay. His cheek was bloody. His throat as a mess of small cuts and his entire body ached. Even his soul was aching and tired. So he nodded, and All Might flashed his signature smile at him.

All Might turned around to deal with Hisashi, but the man was already gone. Aizawa was too occupied with coming over to Izuku to check his injuries. "I knew I shouldn't have let you go on your own. I'm sorry,"

Izuku shook his head violently.

[No it's not your fault.]

It was probably hard for him to see Izuku's signs in the dim lighting. It was better than no light at all. "It was my fault. I'm an adult, and I let this happen to you,"

[It's okay. I'm used to it.]

"We're going to talk about that mindset later, Midoriya," Aizawa said sternly. "For now I'm going to have Dabi get your things, and we're going to my house,"

Izuku glanced at Dabi, who had already begun that task as soon as Aizawa crouched down beside Izuku. He had a blue ball of flame floating in the air to light up the room. Usually,

Dabi was very protective and brotherly, but he knew Aizawa would take care of him, apparently. The level of trust Dabi had with Aizawa was astonishing.

All Might studied the whole room, with a flashlight. Izuku watched him wearily as he inspected everything. Aizawa stayed at Izuku's side but watched All Might too. "Ah, Young Midoriya you have a poster of me, and one of Eraserhead!"

Izuku smiled slightly, his cheeks warming. "Of course he does," Dabi said, deadpan, "He's a massive hero nerd,"

"Not surprising," Aizawa commented. "Are we almost ready to go?"

"Yeah, yeah, hold on," Dabi mumbled, rummaging frantically through all of the drawers in Izuku's dresser. "Your room is a mess,"

[Blame Hisashi.]

"I always am," Dabi said, without looking at him. "Alright let's blow this popsicle stand y'all,"

Aizawa nodded and stood. All Might turned back toward the bedroom door, and Dabi shouldered on Izuku's backpack. Izuku got to his feet, and the world tilted dangerously. The ground swam up to meet him, and without warning, he was out cold.

Chapter End Notes

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https://discord.gg/BdGsq8Z my discord server <33

Chapter 26

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shouta was worried, but when was he not? Izuku Midoriya was a problem child, and he honestly shouldn't expect any less than this from him. Passing out after a traumatic experience? Shouta should've seen that coming. It was quite a shock to see him fall nearly face-first onto the floor, and the only reason he didn't was because Dabi caught him. He vanished into thin air soon after Izuku passed out, but it was plenty of time for Shouta to grab Midoriya and carry him.

"H-he disappeared!" All Might exclaimed, shocked. His blue eyes were wide with it, but there was a flicker of worry in those eyes. He was worried about Midoriya too.

"Yeah. His Quirk deactivated as soon as he passed out," Shouta explained, trying to keep his worry from making his voice break. It'd been too much to watch Midoriya get held at knifepoint by his own father. It pissed him off that he'd been too terrified to move — he was afraid if he did, Hisashi wouldn't think twice before slitting Midoriya's throat ear to ear.

It pissed him off that All Might took that long to get his head out of his ass and save them. He was the only one of all four of them that could move faster than humanly possible. Yet, for a long time, he'd just stood there. Shouta didn't blame him because he'd been the same way. Too frozen with fear and worry.

Too horrified by the way Midoriya looked terrified but resigned to it all. Like he expected it and deserved it. Like all the things Hisashi spouted had been true. It had been horrible to hear and watch. It was heartbreaking. What was even more heartbreaking was how light Midoriya was in his arms. The boy seemed to weigh almost nothing as Shouta cradled him in his arms. He took one last look at the room around him. Blood was splattered everywhere — Midoriya and Hisashi's blood. All Might's phone flashlight was the only source of light in this room. It was strange. Dabi didn't bother to explain anything when he led them into the dark basement that was apparently Midoriya's room.

It was odd. All of this. He and All Might had been standing outside of the Midoriya home, and Shouta was studying the katana Midoriya had given him. The two of them had been

pretty quiet the entire time with All Might scrolling through something on his phone. For all the hype about the number one hero, he was pretty awkward and quiet around Shouta.

Anyway, Shouta had been studying that katana, admiring the craftsmanship of the weapon. Its sheath was sleek, not scratched in the slightest with Midoriya's name on it with red splatter-like letters. He released the blade from the sheath and furrowed his brow. The blade itself was worn down, and nothing special at all. It was chipped in places and scratched beyond belief. He wouldn't doubt it if this sword was a thousand years old.

It was strange because whenever Midoriya used the sword, it looked like it was in perfect condition. Maybe it was part of his Quirk? Shouta didn't know, but he'd ask later. It all happened when he glanced into the dark, quiet house.

First, Dabi suddenly materialized out of nowhere. "Something's wrong,"

Shouta whipped his head back over to the sword in his hands and gaped as he laid eyes on Dabi standing a little ways away. His face was dark, his eyes sparkling with worry and fear. Then Shouta heard the gunshot. Then as a group, they rushed inside—

"That was..." All Might began, ripping Shouta out of his thoughts. "Terrifying,"

Shouta was quick to agree to that, with a silent nod. He watched as All Might picked up Midoriya's backpack that had been all but forgotten on the floor. "Yeah, it was," Shouta said softly, as they headed up the stairs.

He didn't miss the deep gauges in the wooden stairs, or the one or two concerning red stains. Blood. Claw marks. He didn't have a clue what kind of past Midoriya had endured here, but he knew it couldn't have been good.

There were even claw marks in the walls, and on the door as they passed it. Like he'd tried his damndest to escape that room at one point and time. Once they were upstairs Shouta took a moment to look around the house. Just being inside the house gave him chills for no conceivable reason. It all looked like a normal house. Yet, Shouta knew that was impossible. This was the house of villains, with a boy trapped inside.

His eyes narrowed as they locked onto the many locks on Midoriya's bedroom door. He didn't have to guess as to what they were used for, not after his confrontation with Hisashi Midoriya. Overall, as he and All Might headed for Shouta's home where Hizashi waited, he found himself heavy with sadness. And guilt, a lot of guilt.

He could've saved Midoriya long before this moment. He'd been following him for a while, before the entrance exam and he could've done it then. He could've just talked to Midoriya and offered a helping hand, but he did nothing but watch. Just like everyone else. He was no better than anyone else, and Midoriya probably knew that.

He couldn't imagine being Midoriya for as long as this child has been alive. He just couldn't. His dreams wouldn't have survived for as long as Midoriya's have, and they would've been crushed long ago. Midoriya was made of something strong and resilient. He was truly something to behold, but Shouta was upset with himself that he didn't save him sooner.

Shouta gave the boy in his arms a quick look. He looked utterly exhausted and drained. It just solidified his guilt. "I was thinking of making him my successor," All Might states simply, as they walk.

He glanced at All Might in awe. "Y-you mean—?"

"Yes," All Might affirmed. "But that might be too much strain on him, now that I think about it..."

"I'm not going to agree with you, but I'm also not going to tell you what to do. If you think it's too much strain then go ahead and look elsewhere." Shouta mumbled. "There are plenty of kids who would accept your Quirk All Might,"

"Ah, I suppose you're right," All Might replied awkwardly. "The Sports Festival would be a good time to scope out possible candidates. Do any of your students stand out to you as a possible successor?"

"Kirishima, I suppose." Shouta told him. After that there was a lull in the conversation. "Do you think that Midoriya could really be a villain?"

"There's always the off-chance that he could be one," All Might mumbled, "But he's too kind to be a villain, and he's got the eyes of a hero,"

"The eyes of a hero?" Shouta echoed, confused as he stared at the gloomy grey clouds swirling in the sky. It was going to rain, but luckily Midoriya's home wasn't too far from Shouta's. Why they had decided to walk was a mystery to him. They could've used a car, but it didn't matter now. They were almost home.

"Everyone says that a person's eyes are a gateway into the soul. That's the case for Young Midoriya," All Might began. "When I first met him, I asked him if he wanted to be a hero. You should've seen the way his eyes came to life. As if I gave him the one thing he'd always wanted. He wants nothing more than to save people and be someone's hero. I can tell that he doesn't care about being first, or being the best. He just wants to *save*. That is the true meaning of having the eyes of a *hero*."

"Oh, I see," Shouta replied, a soft smile playing on his face. A rare sight. "He really is like that. A hero to the point it's almost dangerous,"

All Might chuckled as they finally reached the front door to Shouta's home. All Might had barely reached for the doorknob when the door swung open quite dramatically to reveal Hizashi. Shouta tried his best to smile, but then he remembered that Midoriya was unconscious in his arms, with cuts all over his face. Nothing was too serious, but Shouta was determined to bandage him up as soon as they got inside.

Hizashi paled as soon as he laid eyes on Midoriya, and he said nothing as he grabbed Midoriya from Shouta's arms. Shouta blinked, once, twice. Hizashi glared at both of them in a tense moment of silence. He glanced between All Might and Shouta before speaking.

"What happened?!" He exclaimed, holding Midoriya tightly like the boy would disappear if he didn't. "He's bleeding! Why is he passed out!? Weren't you just going to his house!?"

"Listen," Shouta began calmly, even though the whole ordeal hadn't left him calm in the slightest. If he was being honest, he was still reliving the moment where Hisashi almost slit Midoriya's throat. "We went to his house to get his things, and he went in alone—"

"And why did you let him go *alone*?!" Hizashi exclaimed hysterically. "He's a child, and there are *villains* searching for him! He's a former spy, and you let him go in alone?!"

"Well—"

"Save your excuses for later Shouta! Tell me the rest," Hizashi pouted angrily, and Shouta could only think that he'd never seen Hizashi this mad in a long, *long* time.

"He got attacked by Hisashi," Shouta told him, "But All Might saved him,"

Hizashi sighed softly and readjusted Midoriya in his arms. "I can't believe either of you," He mumbled, "Thank you for saving him All Might, would you like to come inside?"

"Oh no," He told both of them, "I should really get going, Nedzu will want to hear about what happened,"

"I understand," Shouta said, as All Might handed him Midoriya's backpack. "Goodnight All Might,"

"Goodnight to you both!" All Might said with a wave, before jumping into the sky. He was gone in an instant, and Shouta turned back to Hizashi. His husband glared at him, and Shouta sighed.

"I'm sorry,"

"He's fine, and that's all that matters," Hizashi told him, "But I don't forgive you just yet,"

Shouta wearily stepped inside, and Hizashi set Midoriya on their couch. "Now I want the entire story. Don't leave anything out, Shouta,"

He took a seat at the table, setting Midoriya's bag down as he did so. He took a deep breath, trying to find a good point to begin. "Well, we got to his house and he didn't seem to want us to go inside. I swear he stood there for a full minute before All Might asked him if he wanted us to stand outside. Obviously he nodded, so I asked him for his sword. I was afraid he'd run as soon as he got the chance, but I knew he wouldn't run without his sword. He gave it to me, surprisingly, and went inside. I didn't even know anything was wrong until Dabi summoned himself and told me that there was something wrong. Then I heard a gunshot. So I went inside with All Might and we went into the basement to see what was wrong,"

"That's when we found Hisashi holding Midoriya at knifepoint. It was the most terrifying thing I've ever seen. It was like I was frozen, and I couldn't do anything except watch. He held Midoriya hostage and told us not to move, and All Might must've been scared too because even he didn't move. He's literally the strongest, fastest human alive and he didn't *move*. Hisashi tried to convince Midoriya to come back to the villains, by telling him he could never be a hero, and Hizashi, that boy *believed* that he could never be a hero. For a single moment, he believed the lies that were coming out of that man's mouth,"

Hizashi, who had been maintaining eye contact with Shouta the entire time, looked toward Midoriya. His eyes were dark with emotions that Shouta couldn't place. Not quite anger, but not sadness either. It was guilt.

"Luckily All Might snapped out of it and saved him. And then Midoriya passed out, not that I blame him. It was probably tough to see his father again and fight him," Shouta said softly.

Hizashi stared quietly at the boy unconscious on their couch. He was quiet for a while, and then suddenly he stood. "I'm glad both of you are alright, but I'm going to patch him up really fast before he wakes up," Hizashi turned to Shouta. "Why don't you start dinner? Maybe food will wake him up,"

"What do you want to eat?" Shouta asked as he watched Hizashi disappear into the bathroom to grab the first aid kit. He heard Hizashi rummage around for a few seconds before emerging from the bathroom.

"Anything is good for me," Hizashi replied vaguely. "Make whatever you want,"

Hizashi wasn't any help.

Izuku was calmer than he'd ever been in his life when he finally woke up. Honestly, he didn't remember ever falling asleep, but it was fine. He felt well-rested for once, which was a shocker all on its own. He debated going back to sleep but ultimately knew his body was too accustomed to waking up and not going to sleep until he couldn't move anymore.

He was too awake. Begrudgingly he opened his eyes and was disoriented for a few seconds. He had no clue where he was so he sat straight up, his heart rate skyrocketing. His eyes glanced at everything, missing nothing as he scanned his surroundings. He was in a living room, but not his mother's. Instead of carpet, the entire room and probably the entire house had wood flooring.

There were traditional Japanese paintings lining the dull grey walls tastefully. A huge flat screen television sat on a table opposite of the couch, and the news was playing muted with subtitles. Apparently there had been a robbery, but All Might had defused the situation before anyone could be taken hostage. Now reports were wondering if All Might had an account set up with the bank.

Izuku doubted it, and he moved on. That's when he turned and yelped. A cat was walking along the back of the couch, and Izuku came face to face with it. If he remembered correctly, this cat's name was Eclipse.

She hopped down from the back of the couch, landing gracefully in Izuku's lap. Her tail flicked around as she nudged her head against his hands. Izuku smiled, and pet her. Seeming satisfied, she laid in his lap. That's when he noticed the blanket that had been thrown over him.

"You're awake,"

Izuku jumped, but Eclipse didn't move whatsoever. He whipped his head around to where the voice had come from, and he realized it was from Aizawa. He was in the kitchen with his dark hair pulled into a bun, and he was cooking something. Izuku couldn't really see it that well. Izuku stared wide-eyed at Aizawa for a moment, before remembering everything that had transpired at his mother's house.

His hand went to his neck and his face. Both had been patched up. He nodded slowly at Aizawa, feeling his shoulders tense. "Are you feeling okay?"

Izuku nodded again. Worry furrowed his brow. What if Aizawa was mad at him for passing out? Was All Might? Was he in trouble? Aizawa didn't *look* mad, but Izuku felt like he was. He swallowed thickly, his tongue feeling like cotton in his mouth. His shaking hand — they never stopped — gripped the blanket that had pooled around his hips. Eclipse hadn't moved at all, sleeping peacefully. His other arm had a fresh change of bandages and was placed in his sling.

Izuku clenched his jaw, and Aizawa turned back to the food he was making. The fear heating his face, and freezing his heart was extinguished only slightly. Aizawa had to be mad, but he didn't *say* anything. That was the most nerve-wracking thing about all of this. He could be mad about anything. Hisashi and Inko were always angry for no conceivable reason, so why would it be any different for Aizawa?

Izuku watched as Aizawa went around the kitchen in a sort of dance that he'd never be able to replicate. Not for the first time, Izuku wondered exactly where he was, but he had a few ideas. This was probably Aizawa's house that he owned with Hizashi — aka Present fucking Mic! — and Hizashi had probably agreed to watch Izuku alongside Aizawa. It made sense. He looked around the room, in search of Hizashi, but he didn't find him right away.

He emerged from another room, out of his hero costume. He was wearing an exclusive, ultra-rare Eraserhead themed hoodie. Izuku had never seen one quite like it. He was also sporting sweat pants, and his hair was braided. It was a good look for him.

Hizashi spotted Izuku instantly. A huge smile tugged at his lips, and Izuku felt the urge to match his smile. But he didn't, he wasn't comfortable enough for that. "Midoriya! You're finally awake! Are you feeling okay? Do want another blanket? Want some water? Are your injuries hurting you at all? Did Hisashi hurt to your arm?"

[I’m okay. And I don’t need anything, I’m not in pain.]

”That’s good! Bakugou’s mother called to check up on you, and I told them you were doing okay. I just wanted to be sure,” Hizashi made his way over to the couch, and sat down next to Izuku who quickly made room for the man. Hizashi didn’t hesitate to get up in Izuku’s space. His heart rate spiked as soon as Hizashi leaned in. He was afraid that Hizashi was going to hit him, so he flinched when Hizashi threw his arms around him in a warm hug. For a second his eyes were wide with anxiety and confusion. Then he hugged Hizashi back after a bit of hesitation.

“I’m *really* glad you’re okay,”

Izuku didn’t know if that was true. He wanted it to be. He hoped it was. With his luck, it wasn’t. Finally, Hizashi let him go, and Aizawa seemed to have finished their dinner. He pushed away the stray thoughts that asked him if they’d made some for him. He could clearly see three plates, and why wouldn’t they? They were heroes, not villains. They’d feed him. Hopefully.

”Dinners done?” Hizashi asked excitedly.

Aizawa nodded, as he placed all three plates on the table. “Come eat Midoriya, before the cat decides she’s hungry,”

Izuku hesitantly followed Hizashi to the table, and then his stomach growled softly. All his hesitation was quickly replaced with slight desperation. He was practically starving as he took his seat at the table. He didn't even care to register what he was even eating. All he knew was that he hadn't eaten in what felt like forever. The second he grabbed the chopsticks, half of his meal was already gone. He inhaled it like air, and he only looked up from his food when Hizashi chuckled.

"Were you hungry?" He asked, his smile soft.

Izuku gave him a slight nod.

"Do you want more?" Aizawa asked, but Izuku shook his head. He really didn't want to be bothersome, especially since he was supposed to be living with them now. He didn't want to test their patience.

Aizawa gave him a concerned glance, and Izuku looked down at his empty plate. Then Aizawa cleared his throat. "Um, I've been meaning to tell you something, Midoriya,"

He looked at Aizawa, momentarily concerned. Quickly his concern turned to horror with Aizawa's next words. "We're going to question your mother, Inko tomorrow, and you're required to come and get questioned as well,"

And with that, Izuku was no longer hungry. His lingering hunger was replaced with fear. Fear of the questions his mother would answer, and how exactly she'd answer them. Fear of what Izuku himself would divulge now that he was safe.

Most of all, he was scared that they'd hear everything they needed to hear and decide they didn't want Izuku anymore. Of course, he knew that he'd agreed to this so he could still attend Yuuei, but he hadn't expected to be questioned with his mother. He was under the impression that it would be a private affair, with Nedzu, and a couple of others present.

But no. He was going to be in the same room with a monster of a mother.

Chapter End Notes

https://discord.gg/BdGsq8Z my discord server <33

Chapter 27

Chapter Summary

Inko's questioning begins! >:U

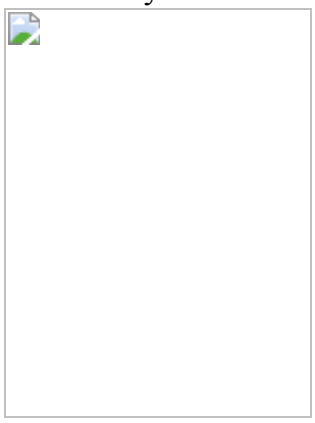
Chapter Notes

SOME AMAZING PPL IN MY DISCORD DREW US SOME FANART <33

izuku: by baby maker in my discord <3



demons: by Kacchan V. Deku's Female Dog <3



See the end of the chapter for more notes

“He ate like he hasn’t eaten in days, Shouta!”

Okay, to be fair, Izuku couldn’t possibly sleep. Not in that room that they gave him. It was dark, dark, dark. So he somehow ended up eavesdropping on Aizawa and Hizashi. He wanted to know what they were thinking about him, and they talked pretty loud so it wasn’t like he

planned on doing this. He'd been on his way to the bathroom — he swore to himself he was going just to go to the bathroom, but honestly, he couldn't keep himself calm anymore. In the last week, he'd been through a lot, and he needed a second to himself. To shatter the pieces and then pick himself haphazardly up and hope for the best.

Yet, on his way, he heard them talking, so here he was. "I know, and he looks like he hasn't slept either,"

Izuku frowned. When *had* he slept last? When *was* the last time he had a full meal?

"I'll go check on him before bed," Hizashi told Aizawa.

The floor creaked as either Aizawa or Hizashi got up. Izuku didn't waste any time. The conversation seemed to have ended, and he didn't want to get caught listening in. He turned around and headed down the hall with near-silent footsteps. The darkness the engulfed the house was unsettling as darkness always was for him. He picked up his pace, fighting the urge to run.

"Shouta, do you want any coffee? I'm going to get a drink before I finished up the last of my work today,"

"No, I'm fine but thanks," He replied softly, as Izuku closed the door to the bathroom most of the way, only leaving a sliver which he could peek through. He clicked on the light, just as Hizashi was walking out of the room. Staring at himself in the mirror, he listened as Hizashi walked about the kitchen. His own eyes stared blankly at him, exhausted yet restless with worry as Hizashi made himself, and probably Aizawa some coffee. He could smell it from here, the bitterness. Did Aizawa like his coffee black?

Izuku tore his eyes away from his face, he couldn't look at himself in the mirror any longer. He couldn't look at his bandaged eye, and the cut from Hisashi. He couldn't look at his destroyed arm. He just *couldn't*.

He peeked through the crack in the door, watching as Hizashi carried two mugs of warm coffee into the room. For a moment their bedroom door was wide open, and Izuku could see

Aizawa hunched over a computer, and footage was playing on it. Then Hizashi closed it halfway. Izuku turned off the bathroom light, swallowing back his fear as he waited a few seconds. He wanted Hizashi to think he'd gone back into his room.

After a few seconds, it was Aizawa who picked up the conversation again. Izuku crept out of the bathroom silently. He positioned himself near enough so he could hear their conversation, but far away enough that he could run into his room if they decided to check on him. He listened intently.

"He didn't seem too happy when I told him he had to speak to his mother," Aizawa began softly.

"Well, technically they're both getting questioned," Hizashi mumbled. "I don't see why he has to get questioned,"

"As much as I'd rather he stay here and recover, we need to question him before we can safely say it's okay for him to rejoin his class. Besides, I'm sure detective Tsukauchi will stop the interrogation immediately if it becomes too much for him,"

"You're right," Hizashi replied, "And I am really curious as to what Inko will have to say to our questions,"

"So am I, but I'm even more curious about Midoriya. It's safe to say he'll probably lie at first," Aizawa said, and Izuku smiled slightly. He was right about one thing. Izuku would lie his ass off if he could help it, and no one could make him tell the truth.

"Haha! Probably! I'd be really surprised if he didn't. What kind of questions is Tsukauchi thinking about asking?"

"Mainly he's going to focus on Inko and Izuku's involvement with the League. We need as much information as we can gather about these people before they try to attack again. We're thinking about doing separate questionings for *certain* questions,"

"I think that's for the best,"

"I think so too,"

Izuku pursed his lips together. "And we'll also be doing that class exercise with that therapist tomorrow right?"

"Yeah, Nedzu thought it would be best that we addressed what happened at the U.S.J. as a class as soon as school resumed," Aizawa mumbled. Izuku turned and finally went into his room. He'd heard enough, and he'd try to sleep. His room was dark but considerably warmer than his room back home. But it was the same. Still dark. Still filled with roaming demons.

Still scary.

He curled his hands into fists as he entered, his eyes skittering away fearfully as his eyes made contact with a demon. Sweat trickled down his forehead, and he tried to swallow the familiar fear that drowned him every time he went into his room. His shaking hands found his bed. Bigger than the one in his mother's home. Trying to ignore the eyes that followed him everywhere as he sat down with his back to the bed board. He ripped the blanket off of the bed and covered himself with it. The only part of him that wasn't covered was his face, but he put his forehead to his knees. He tried to make the fear that gripped him disappear. He tried to push it deep down. He tried to ignore his labored breathing and shallow gasps that were too loud in the quiet.

He couldn't stop the image of Hisashi from popping up in his head. He couldn't stop the explosion of phantom pain that throbbed, his body remembering how it felt to be a victim of Hisashi's Quirk. Everything seemed to be hitting him all at once.

In his room, he could finally break down and properly process everything that had happened. Then he could shove himself back together and move on like he always did. He pressed his cool hands against his face. He took a deep breath. And then, he finally fell apart.

Hot tears trailed down his cheeks, and his shaking hand went to cover his mouth and stop the sobs that would no doubt begin. His throat tightened, and his vision blurred.

You're Quirkless.

He sucked in the first hiccup, trying to as quiet as possible.

You can never be a hero.

His lower lip trembled, and he didn't hear his bedroom door open.

Stain was stupid to think you'd ever amount to anything. You should just become a villain. These heroes don't care about you.

You have to train much harder, my boy, if you hope to please me.

Spy on Yuuei.

His shoulders shook, and the tears didn't relent. They didn’t stop, and he didn’t want them to. He clenched his jaw to keep his sobs as silent as possible. His throat ached with the effort of keeping them at bay.

He choked on his fear. Drowned in it. Got consumed by it. His heart pounded in his chest, he could hear it. His hands throbbed in time with his heart, and he gripped the comforter around him. It was difficult to breathe past the sobs.

Then like the flip of a switch, his sobs stopped. He froze. The door was open, and a hand was reaching for him. *When did Hisashi get down here? He would’ve heard his footsteps*. In a moment of desperation, he grabbed the reaching wrist and twisted it.

Stay away from me! His mind screamed, as he flinched back. His back slammed against the backboard of his bed. Then it all clicked. He blinked, and suddenly he was somewhere else

entirely. And it wasn't Hisashi's wrist he was twisting.

It was Hizashi's, and the man was staring at him with wide eyes. Izuku released him instantly, his fear exploding in his chest with renewed vigor. He froze up completely, utterly horrified.

He'd just hurt Hizashi. *He just hurt Hizashi.*

"I told you to leave," Dabi snapped, and Izuku wasn't breathing at all. He was so dead. He was going to die. They were going to kill him. "Leave, get out,"

Hizashi opened his mouth to say something, but Dabi growled. "Get the *hell* out!"

After a moment of hesitation, Hizashi turned around and walked out, sparing Izuku a glance that Izuku ignored entirely.

What the hell? Why wasn't Hizashi yelling at him? Or threatening him? He didn't understand.

It scared him more than it comforted him. Dabi turned to him, his eyes softer than usual. "Are you okay?"

He shook his head, covering his face. He wouldn't sleep tonight. Not after that.

Shouta wasn't too surprised when Hizashi came in last night to tell him that Midoriya had twisted his arm.

He especially wasn't surprised when he learned that Midoriya had been having a panic attack beforehand. It was understandable that he'd react to someone trying to touch him. But he worried about the kid. He wanted to go in his room and tell him that everything was okay and he'd be fine, but Hizashi advised against it.

"Dabi will rip your head off of you try that right now," Hizashi explained. So Shouta waited until extremely late to check on him. He'd finally finished all his work, and he doubted that Midoriya could stay up this late. So he opened the door to his bedroom slowly and peeled inside. Shouta almost froze, as he saw Midoriya sitting up in his bed until he realized he was sleeping sitting up.

He would've moved him into a more comfortable position, but he was too afraid that it'd wake him up. So he closed the door quietly and went to bed.

He woke up early the next morning for coffee and to train before he had to get Midoriya and Hizashi up. He went into the kitchen and made himself a quick cup of coffee. His house was silent and dark as he scrolled through his phone. Then he heard the cabinet where he'd got his mug slam close. He jumped and whipped his head over to look around the kitchen. No one else was here with him, but as he glanced around he saw Midoriya shuffle into the kitchen looking scared, but mostly annoyed.

[Don't do that.]

Shouta raised an eyebrow. Izuku wasn't signing to him, and he wasn't looking at Shouta at all. He must be talking to a demon. "A demon did that?"

Midoriya glanced at him, eyes wide in the darkness and a little paranoid. His reply was fast.

[I'm sorry.]

"It's okay," Shouta told him with a shrug. "Are you having trouble sleeping?"

Midoriya stared at him for a moment before nodding. “Do you want to spar with me then?”

There it was. A spark of excitement glinting in those eyes. Shouta gave him a small smile, and he took a quick sip of his coffee before nodding. “Alright, follow me, I have a training room,”

He turned around and glanced behind him only once to make sure Midoriya was following him. He swung open the door and turned the light on with a soft click. He was honestly surprised Midoriya was up so early. He downed the rest of his coffee quickly and set it down in the corner on the floor. He had been planning on doing simple exercises, but now that Midoriya was here he could actually spar. He turned to face Midoriya, who looked a little more rested than he had the other day.

Midoriya set his sword down on the ground out of his reach. "We can spar with or without your Quirk if you want,"

[I can fight Quirkless.]

Shouta smiled. He liked this kid a lot because he didn't back down from a challenge even when he was injured and only able to use one arm. Shouta didn't waste a single moment as he rushed him. Midoriya didn't shy away, not like he usually would. He stood his ground, watching Shouta as he closed the distance between them. His eyes narrowed and sharpened in focus.

"If I tag you, the match is over. Let's see how long you can last, Midoriya," He explained, and Midoriya gave him a smile. It was almost unnerving, as Midoriya jumped away at the last second. He landed gracefully on the ground on the other side of the room. Avoidance was something Midoriya had mastered, apparently.

Midoriya watched him as Shouta ran for him again. This time, Shouta tried to sweep his feet out from under him, but it didn't work. Midoriya danced out of the way again, determined to stay far, far away from Shouta.

He was much faster and much better than he'd been at class when they'd played tag. Shouta was taken aback when Midoriya came for him, his feet nearly silent against the wooden floor. He face was set in determination and Shouta felt it was only natural to do the same. He seemed extremely serious about this entire match.

The kick was too fast for Shouta to dodge, but he managed to block it just in time. His arm ached with the force of the attack, and his entire perspective of this kid changed. This was a trained soldier, who was supposed to sell out Yuuei.

Shouta dodged the next attack, a sloppy punch. He retaliated with a sweep of his leg, and Midoriya went tumbling this time. But that didn't stop him at all, he got to his feet faster than Shouta thought possible, and tackled Shouta.

The world tilted and swirled, and suddenly they were both on the ground. Shouta didn't mind, because his hand wrapped around Midoriya's wrist. "You lost," He said simply, and Midoriya blinked. Once. Twice.

And then he frowned.

[Again? I should've lasted longer.]

"Sure, and you can use your Quirk if you want. You can try to tag me instead," And then he added, "Be careful of your injuries though, kid,"

Midoriya nodded slightly, but never went for his sword, nor did he summon any demon that he could see. Shouta waited for him to move and after a tense moment of nothing, he closed the distance in a split second. Once again, Shouta was surprised. He didn't seem scared to touch or hurt Shouta as he'd been with Hizashi. Shouta grabbed the hand that reached for his shoulder, but that didn't stop him.

He swept his feet under Shouta's, but Shouta had been prepared. He released Midoriya and jumped back. Midoriya didn't give him time to breathe, rushing for him again and again as Midoriya tried to tag him.

Shouta watched with a smirk, as Midoriya came at him again with simple one-note attacks. He was slowly realizing Midoriya had a pattern. He would kick, and then he would try to go in for the kill. He wanted to throw Shouta off balance.

Then, like the flip of a switch, Midoriya's entire demeanor changed. His frown turned into a scowl. His eyes flashed with anger and frustration, and Shouta hesitated. Then Midoriya put a hand to his head and blinked rapidly, and his malice disappeared. Shouta felt his shoulders relax, as Midoriya calmed himself down and came for him again. They traded blows, with Shouta slapping Midoriya's hand away, and Midoriya kicking him in the stomach.

They continued like that for a while, until Shouta tripped, and Midoriya finally tagged him. Shouta's eyes went wide when Midoriya's hand tapped his shoulder as he went down. Midoriya looked just as shocked.

"Good job, kid," Shouta told him as he got to his feet.

"That...was intense," Hizashi said tiredly from the doorway, and Midoriya jumped practically a foot in the air. He was back to being himself, but it was kind of painful to watch him retreat into himself like he was afraid *Hizashi* would hurt him. It was heartbreaking.

Shouta watched as Hizashi pretended not to look hurt about it. He watched as Midoriya looked anywhere but at him, and he frowned. Shouta himself couldn't really do anything about Midoriya at the moment. It wasn't his place. It was Hizashi's because he'd been the one to go into Midoriya's room and get his arm twisted. He needed to be the one to explain that it was fine.

He caught Hizashi's eye, and glanced back at Midoriya. At first, Hizashi looked extremely confused before his eyes widened and he smiled slightly. He looked a little anxious to approach Midoriya, but eventually, he did. Midoriya glanced at him worriedly, and then at Shouta as if he would yield any answers.

"Midoriya," Hizashi began, coming to stand in front of Midoriya, and Shouta watched both of them, holding his breath. "About last night..."

He could see Midoriya take a cautious step back. His heart broke for him. "I just want you to know that you didn't do anything wrong, kiddo," Midoriya looked at him fully at that, his eyes wide. "I should've expected that I would scare you, considering everything that you went through yesterday. I'm not going to yell at you, and you're not in trouble,"

[You're not lying, are you?]

There was an expression of pure disbelief on Hizashi's face, like he never expected Midoriya to ask him that. He stared at Midoriya for a moment, trying to figure out if he was being serious. Shouta has a feeling that he was.

“I’d never lie to you,”

[That’s what they always say.]

“You can trust me, Midoriya,” Hizashi replied. “I told you I would save you, right? And did I lie about that?”

Midoriya slowly shook his head. “Exactly!” Hizashi gave him a wide smile. “You can trust me, and Shouta!”

Midoriya still seemed skeptical. He furrowed his brows in thought and didn’t reply for a second.

[Okay.]

”So are both of you going to get ready for school, or are you going to skip another day?” Hizashi asked after a moment.

Shouta glared at Hizashi, but grabbed his coffee mug and headed back into the kitchen to put the dish away. “Fine, I’ll get dressed then,”

They left ten minutes later, after Midoriya came out of his room with Dabi in tow, who was talking about everything and nothing at the same time.

Shouta wasn’t paying much attention to Dabi. He was watching Midoriya too closely. It was strange to see him in his Yuuei uniform.

Then they headed to Yuuei, and the ride was silent. Midoriya was texting someone the entire time, and Hizashi was too busy driving to really make conversation and Shouts was immensely grateful for the radio. He spent almost the entire ride flipping through radio stations until he finally settled on a police station frequency.

“Aw, come on Shouta, we’re teaching! Not fighting crime!” Hizashi whined, and Shouta glared at his husband.

“But I’m bored!”

“I’m sure nothing is happening—“

Shouta shrugged, and Hizashi sighed softly. “Too late,”

“Ugh...fine,” Hizashi mumbled.

The police radio was silent for a while, with the occasional order thrown in. They needed someone to investigate a noise disturbance reported by residents. An elderly woman fell in her house and needed medical attention. Things like that. Shouta felt himself relax.

There was no huge villain attack going on. He could rest easy now.

Then they finally pulled into a parking spot, and headed into the Yuuei building. Midoriya stuck close by them, and Shouta gave him a smile. “Let’s have Recovery Girl check up on you before we go see your mother,”

Midoriya nodded, a happy smile on his face at the mention of Recovery Girl. The halls were empty as they walked. They went to her office first, and she looked surprised to see them.

“How are you feeling Midoriya?” She said instantly.

[I’m okay.]

”That’s good,” she replied, “Let me look at your arm and eye,”

Midoriya went over to her, and she went for his eye first, and a pleased look over took her. “Your eye seems to be almost healed.”

Then she took his arm out of the sling, and undid the bandages. Shouta paled when he saw the messy scar that encircled his entire arm, starting at his wrist, and stopping at his elbow. “Ah! That’s really good! You’re arm will be sore for a while, and I don’t recommend that you don’t do any really intensive activities. You can take the sling off. I’ll give you a brace. You’ll be able to participate in class, but I don’t want you pushing yourself,”

Midoriya’s excited smile was enough to make Shouta melt. She helped him get the brace on his arm and tightened it around his arm. “You’re all set, honey!”

She ruffled his wild green hair and turned back to her work. The three of them left her office soon after and headed for Nedzu’s office. That’s where they had decided to do the questioning. Ectoplasm stood outside the door, and Midoryia watched him in awe as Shouta stopped to talk to him. “Is everyone else already inside?”

“Yes, we were waiting on you,” Ectoplasm replied, “I’m glad to see all of you are doing well, after the U.S.J.”

Shouta went inside without another word. Of course, he was fine. Midoriya had taken the brunt of it all. He positioned himself behind Midoriya, as the door opened. He had a feeling Midoriya might try to leave, and as much as he didn’t want to force the kid to do this, he’d have to stop him if he tried to escape.

Izuku was shaking and trying not to lose his composure. It was like he was willingly walking the gallows. He wasn’t ready to face his mother, and his eyes avoided her figure at all costs. He caught the eye of Nedzu, and All Might. They sat on the couch facing the table that had been placed in the middle of the room. Sitting at that table was a detective. Detective Tsukauchi he assumed.

Izuku didn’t look at his mother. He couldn’t bring himself to. “Oh Midoriya-kun, you’re here!” Nedzu exclaimed, getting to his feet in an instant. “You look nearly healed! That’s a relief!”

Izuku smiled warily, and Nedzu sipped his tea before he spoke again. “Please! Take a seat next to Mrs. Midoriya and we shall begin the questioning immediately, thank you for going along with all my demands Midoriya-kun,”

Izuku cast a glance at his mother and was startled to see her looking at him. He was hesitant to sit next to his mother, but he walked over and did so without a complaint.

“Just for the report,” Detective Tsukauchi began, “You’re both aware that this entire process will be overseen by All Might, Principal Nedzu, Eraserhead and Present Mic?”

Midoriya nodded and kept his eyes from straying anywhere where he could see his mother. “Alright, let us begin. Inko Midoriya, I’ll start with you—“

“You’ll get no answers from me,” She spat.

Detective Tsukauchi cleared his throat and looked to Izuku. “Okay, then Izuku Midoriya, would you be willing?”

As much as he didn’t want to, he nodded.

“Thank you. When did you receive your Quirk? There’s a paper there to write your responses, I have a lie detection Quirk, so please refrain from trying to trick me,”

Izuku wrote his answer, and handed it over to him. His mother shifted in her seat, and Izuku pressed his lips together into a thin line.

I got my Quirk at four years old.

“True,” Tsukauchi gave him a soft smile. “Next question—“

“He’s Quirkless,” Inko spat.

“I assure you that you’re son has a Quirk. Now, where was I? Oh. When did you meet Stain?”

Before the end of middle school.

“True. Why did he offer to train you?”

Stain wanted to make me a hero, and save me.

“Stain is an idiot. He was a villain, and he could never make you a *hero*,”

”Mrs. Midoriya I’m going to have to ask you to not interrupt,” Detective Tsukauchi looked angry, and a little offended by that remark. Izuku found his eyes trailing away from both of them. “Why did you join the League of Villains?”

A man was interested in me, and my parents forced me to go. I didn’t have a choice.

“So you didn’t want to be a villain?”

No, I didn’t.

“True. Is that why you betrayed the League and planted the information on the members around the school?”

Yes. It was my chance to save myself.

“True. Do you want to be a hero?”

Yes.

“True. Do you think you can succeed?”

No.

“True. Why don’t you think you’ll succeed?”

“Because he’s going to die,” Inko shrugged. “Now every villain in Japan wants his head,”

“Mrs. Midoriya—“

“He knows it!” Inko slammed her fist into the table, and Izuku jumped in his seat. He felt his shoulders begin to shake. “You’ll die for what you’ve done!”

She was right. She was always right.

“*Mrs. Midoriya!* Would you like so answer some questions considering you keep interrupting?”

She was silent.

“First question, did you ever physically hurt your son?”

“No, I didn’t. I would never hurt my child,”

Izuku bit his lip. It would come back false. Her face was pulled into an angry scowl. For a moment there was tense silence as everyone waited for Tsukauchi’s confirmation on whether or not it was a lie. Izuku felt himself start to shake.

“T-true,”

Izuku froze in his seat, confused. Shocked and confused. That was a lie. She was *lying*. Unless...she didn’t consider him as her son...

Detective Tsukauchi seemed to have thought the same thing. “Do you consider Izuku Midoriya to be your son?”

“He’s never been a son to me,”

Izuku clenched his hands in his lap. He fought the tears and sorrow that threatened to swallow him entirely. He told himself that he knew this all along. He told himself that he should’ve known. He told himself that it didn’t hurt and sting as much as it really did. This was fine. Everything was perfectly fine. It didn’t bother him.

“True. Did you ever raise a hand to Izuku Midoriya?”

“Yes,”

Chapter End Notes

join my discord server if yall want!~ its full of crackheads

ALSO WE JUST REACHED 40,023 HITS AND IM GONNA DIE?!?!?!!? I love all of you so much ;-;

Chapter 28

Chapter Notes

> First off I’m sorry this is late!~ (this was supposed to come out yesterday, not at 3am... so I’m probably gonna edit it after I go to bed. Feel free to tell me any typos!!!)
>
> join my discord server if yall want!~ its full of crackheads

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He was shaking. He was so angry. She didn't even consider Midoriya to be her *son?* If this was how Inko thought of her child, then how did Hisashi view him? How did Midoriya view himself? No wonder he was convinced he probably wouldn't live long enough to become a hero. His parents probably ingrained it into his mind that rebellion only had one outcome.

Certain death.

Shouta could see it in his eyes, the distant resigned look. Like he was finally hearing what he'd always thought was the truth, and it stung, but he should've expected it. Those were not the eyes of a hero. They were the eyes of a broken child, who was only just now realizing that he never could've become a hero. He only had two bitter paths laid out for him. Villainy, or death. Shouta wanted to end it all here, to shake him out of it. He wanted to tell him and tell the world that he, no matter his upbringing, could become a hero too.

But no matter how much he wanted to end all of this right now, he couldn't. They needed to answer all of the questions they had before they could safely return Midoriya to class. They needed to be sure that Midoriya wouldn't turn his back on them. But they also needed to interrogate Inko.

"True," Detective Tsukauchi looked pale and angry. "Can you tell me why?"

"He's a monster. His Quirk is a freak of nature, and I should've killed him as soon as he was born,"

It was a punch in the gut to hear those words come out of her mouth. Disgust colored Detective Tsukauchi's face. He looked about ready to throw adoption papers on the table between them, and demand that Inko gave him custody rights. "True."

"Why did you force Midoriya to join the League of Villains?"

"He was interested in him and asked me to bring him." Inko spat, losing herself in her anger. She was saying too much, and Shouta could see the sweat beading on Midoriya's forehead. He was chewing his lip and looking at his mother with wide eyes. "He decided Stain was a mediocre mentor and took him under his wing despite my best wishes. It was a waste of time to train *that.* He insisted and spent months and months training him in time for the entrance exam. I was honestly surprised that he survived half of the training he was given,"

Detective Tsukauchi was writing all of this frantically down, despite the fact that he was currently recording everything. "Can you tell me the name of this man? What kind of training did Midoriya receive?"

Shouta shifted in his seat leaning forward in anticipation. This is the confirmation they so desperately needed. If they knew All For One was involved with the League of Villains, then they could get more hero support to track them down and destroy them before they became more powerful. And it helped him learn exactly what Midoriya was up against. All For One was a terrifying enemy, and if they were up against him then they needed all the time that they could spare to prepare. If they were going to bring the villains down to their knees they needed to know who was in charge.

Shouta could see everyone else in the room sharpen their focus to Inko, who opened her mouth to speak. Even Midoriya seemed to be watching her closely, on the edge of his seat. Inko glanced at Midoriya, a smug look overcoming her features. Shouta furrowed her brow. But they never heard what she got to say. "His name is—"

Midoriya launched himself out of his seat in one fluid motion, slapping his hand over her mouth. His eyes were blown wide, and wet with tears he wouldn't shed. His shoulders were

shaking, and his legs looked about ready to give out. The only thing Shouta could think, as everyone froze in shock, was why?

They couldn't know. His mother fucking *knew* that, and here she was about to tell everyone in this room about All For One. She did it because she knew exactly what All For One would do to him, and everything he held dear.

"His name is—"

His body moved before his mind could even think of doing so. It was quick how it all happened. His hand was over her mouth in an instant, and everyone was looking at him in shock. This was dangerous, so utterly dangerous. How easy it was for his mother to push his entire life to the edge, and risk nothing in return. All For One could hear them, he didn't doubt it one bit.

That man had his eyes and ears everywhere. Not even Yuuei had good enough security to keep his spies out when he needed them. He himself was a prime example of that. His mother knew too, and she was trying to kill him. Trying to destroy everything with three simple words. She fought him, her nails slicing his hands. His sword was at his hip, and his hand clasped the hilt as Aizawa and All Might stood.

"Young Midoriya, why are you stopping her? We need to know his name," All Might asked, and Izuku just stared at him. His mother growled, trying to pull his hand away, but failing.

"Why are you protecting her?" Aizawa asked, his eyes soft. Izuku had to look away. The pressure weighed heavily on his shoulders. He desperately wanted everyone to know who she was talking about, but he couldn't risk endangering the lives of his loved ones. He knew how it must look like. He was protecting his mother, a villain. What if they decided he wasn't worth the effort?

What if they forced his hand away, and she told them anyway, even after he tried so hard? What if she told them while he was gone? He didn't even think about summoning Dabi, but he was there in an instant. He looked between him and the teachers confused. And Izuku

realized that it didn't even *matter*. All For One would try to kill him and everything he'd worked towards no matter what.

"What the hell's going on?" Dabi asked no one in particular.

"Let me take a guess," Nedzu began, and Dabi raised an eyebrow. "I've been going through the possible reasons as to why you don't want us to know, would you like to hear them, young Midoriya?"

Izuku gave a slight nod, and Nedzu gave him a reassuring smile. "The first possibility is that even though your mother was cruel to you, you still love her,"

He shook his head with a frown. Detective Tsukauchi mumbled softly into the silence. "True,"

"Another is that by saying his name, she is putting everyone you love in danger. Is that true?"

Izuku gave a reluctant nod.

"True." Detective Tsukauchi replied.

But it didn't matter. He was being hunted, and no one seemed to understand that *at all*. And with a predator like All For One chasing him, there was nowhere to hide. His mother reminded him of that. So he dropped his hand and stepped away. He couldn't save any of them. Not really.

He was useless. He was nowhere near strong enough to think that he stood a chance.

Save yourself.

What a load of shit that was.

Inko cleared her throat and licked her lips. She was excited to see how they would react. “He’s been alive this whole time, biding his time until the moment was right. He created the League of Villains while he waited. Now he’s ready to come back into the spotlight, and All For One is on the hunt,”

Izuku fought the wave of despair that threatened to drown him. He could tell all of his teachers were trying the same.

"You've finally seemed to realize what you're up against, haven't you?" Inko asked. *Even All Might didn't stand a chance, how could I? If All Might couldn't save him, then no one could.*

Izuku didn't even look at her. "Get her out of here," Nedzu said simply, and the door opened instantly. Ectoplasm entered the room and walked over to where his mother sat. She gave them all soft smiles as she was dragged out. "And make sure to gag her too, Ectoplasm,"

After she was gone there was a tense moment of silence. He touched the hilt of his sword, and Dabi vanished. His mind kept running in circles, panicked and disoriented.

I'm no match for All For One. What's the point? Why even bother?

He could end all of his suffering right now and go peacefully. He had a chance to control exactly how he died. It was so tempting to stab himself right now, while he had the chance. He stood in the center of the room, and couldn't bring himself to look his teachers in the eyes. The temperature seemed to plummet as the sudden confirmation given by Inko began to sink in. The most dangerous villain in history was no longer dead and gone to them. He was alive and breathing fear down their necks.

The only person he could stomach looking at was All Might of all people. He was the only one who could truly scope how utterly doomed they were. He was the only one who knew that this was a losing battle. When he found All Might's electric blue eyes he noticed that

those eyes were watching him. All Might's face was flushed of color, paperwhite. He looked like a ghost almost, and his face was grim, with his lips pulled into a frown. His eyes were dark with an emotion Izuku was painfully familiar with. Fear. Fear that Izuku was losing himself to.

All Might was just as afraid as Izuku was, and he found himself drawn to it. He couldn't bear to see All Might in all of his glory, looking gaunt and ghostly with horror. He hesitated slightly, debating if he should even bother. It was futile for them to try and defeat a man like *that*. It was *impossible*. Inconceivable. It was impossible. They would all die—

"Fear is a demon of its own, my boy. Don't let it control you and debilitate you. You're the consort of demons. They will bend to your will. You aren't chained down by fear, young Midoriya,"

Izuku faltered, confused as to why he would ever even think of remembering something All For One told him at a time like this. But All For One was right. Fear was Izuku's constant companion, and he didn't want All Might to let it be his.

The only problem was that he didn't know how to comfort the man. He was so out of his orbit, All Might was still like a legend in his mind. Someone he never hoped to actually meet, and never expected to interact with. He was untouchable, but seeing him look like this broke his already fragile heart. All Might held his head in his hands, finally breaking eye contact with him.

Detective Tsukauchi looked lost, as he looked towards All Might. Izuku felt that. The urge to leave him be was strong, but his heart twisted in his chest. He wanted to tell All Might that it would be okay and that he was the strongest hero in history. He wanted to lie and tell him everything he needed to hear. But he wasn't good at lying when he knew the truth. And he couldn't even hold a conversation with anyone, even if he wanted to.

But he'd seen mothers comforting children before, even if it was rarely. Maybe a simple gesture of affection would help him? He didn't know, but he made his way over to All Might nonetheless. The room was thick with tension, but Izuku ignored it entirely. He was scared and considering the coward's way out of things, but he didn't want All Might to be consumed like he was.

He wanted to give him the reassurance he so desperately needed. All Might didn't move or acknowledge his presence whatsoever as he stopped in front of him. He was drowning in fear. Izuku could see it in his shaking shoulders and bowed head. A position he often found himself whenever he thought of All For One. He ruffled All Might's hair without warning.

He pulled his hand away and smiled softly at the hero he had idolized almost the entirety of his life when All Might finally looked up.

[Fear is a demon of its own. You aren't chained down by fear All Might, no matter how much you think you are. There's still hope.]

All Might stared at him. It was deathly quiet, as everyone stared at him in awe or disbelief — he couldn't tell which. For a moment Izuku thought he did something wrong, and Aizawa wouldn't translate for him. But then he saw All Might's face break out into a huge smile. Izuku didn't get any warning as he was suddenly swept off his feet and crushed into a tight hug. All of the tension was sucked out of the room, and he was immensely grateful.

"You're very right, Young Midoriya!" All Might exclaimed. "He hasn't made a move yet, so we've still got time to prepare! There's still hope!"

The world tilted again as All Might set him down. "Thank you," He said with a relieved sigh, "I needed that,"

All he was thinking about was that All Might seemed to understand him. Had he been practicing just for Izuku's sake? It filled him with warmth at the thought.

"You're right," Nedzu mumbled, suddenly animated once again. "We can think more about our plan of action as soon as Midoriya-kun heads to class. Thank you so much for your cooperation. Aizawa you're welcome to accompany him and prepare for your class today. School is about to start,"

Izuku could take a hint, even if it wasn't a subtle one. They wanted to discuss everything in private, and Izuku was happy to comply. He could leave this to the pros for once and try to keep from losing his mind at the thought of All For One killing him at any given moment. He

followed Aizawa as he walked across toward the door, and as soon as the door closed behind both of them Aizawa spoke up.

He didn't break his stride in the direction of his classroom, but he did glance at Izuku as they walked. "You don't have to pretend in front of me, Midoriya,"

Izuku froze, staring at his teacher as his heart twisted in his chest. Was he angry? Aizawa glanced at him again, and he stopped abruptly. Izuku skidded to a halt, glancing nervously again. Had he done something wrong?

And just like that, his mind twisted everything out of focus. Had he said something wrong? Had he revealed too much? Was this all a trick to get him to tell them everything he knew?

"It's okay to be scared Midoriya," Aizawa told him, "I'd be shocked if you weren't,"

And that's when it finally clicked. Aizawa was probably waiting on him to break down, but that wasn't going to happen. Not in front of anyone, and definitely not in front of him.

[I'm fine.]

Aizawa deflated, looking tired and defeated. "Fine. Say what you want Midoriya. If you're fine, then you're fine. I'm only trying to help,"

Izuku felt a tinge of guilt. He could tell that Aizawa was being sincere, but he just wasn't comfortable doing that right here, right now where anyone could see him. He would feel too exposed doing that. He just couldn't bring himself to be able to do that right now after everything. He still had to go through a day of school and talk to a therapist or something along those lines.

Without another word or glance, Aizawa started walking again and Izuku followed him just a few steps behind. It wasn’t too long until they were standing in front of his classroom door, with thirty minutes before class to spare. Izuku didn’t hesitate to go inside and take his seat

instantly. He could feel Aizawa's eyes on him and he ignored it, blocking out any opportunity to talk by laying his head on his desk, with his arms blocking his view of his teacher. Aizawa watched him for a moment, and he could tell because he could still feel the prickly feeling of being watched. Then his teacher left the room momentarily. For a second he wondered why he left, but then he realized he must be getting the therapist. Izuku let himself doze off for a while.

Izuku woke up to the shrill sound of the bell ringing. He lifted his head, glancing around to see that his classmates were all sitting around or standing, talking loudly and animatedly. Aizawa was nowhere to be seen. He rubbed at his eyes and found himself looking for familiar blond hair. It was easy to find those red eyes that were already watching him carefully. Kacchan was up in an instant and he made his way over to his desk.

"Deku," His voice was a deep growl, his anger obvious in his voice and on his face. And then unexpectedly his face softened. "Are you okay?"

Izuku gave him a nod and a reassuring grin. Kacchan's shoulders relaxed, and Izuku hadn't even noticed that he was tense.

[Are you okay?]

"Yeah, I wasn't really in the action,"

[That's good. How is Auntie? Did I worry her?]

"Did you worry her? You're like her fucking kid! She lost her shit when she heard what happened!" Kacchan exclaimed. "She almost came to the school herself to get you, and she hasn't slept since the attack,"

Izuku felt a twinge of guilt as he glanced away from Kacchan. [Sorry.]

"Don't be. She'll be fine as soon as she hears that you're fine," Kacchan told him, with a rare smile. That's when Aizawa-sensei finally returned with a woman trailing behind him. Kacchan stopped any words that had been about to come out of his mouth and found his seat instantly. Izuku almost smirked. Aizawa sure did know how to deal with a room full of rowdy teenagers.

But then his slight smirk disappeared instantly as Aizawa spoke. "Midoriya has something to explain to the entire class,"

He fought the urge to groan and refuse. But he stood even though he didn't want to. He figured his classmates should know who they were dealing with. They deserved the truth. He was the reason they all got attacked. So he made his way to the front of the class, willing his shaking hands to still as much as possible. His classmates had gone silent. He knew Kacchan would probably stay by his side after all of this, but he was skeptical about his other classmates.

He had no idea how they'd react to the news. He wouldn't be surprised if they all hated him. Aizawa was the one to speak for him, and he was grateful. He could've had Aizawa translate for him, but Izuku wasn't sure how to exactly phrase all of this. "Midoriya is the reason the U.S.J. attack occurred," Aizawa began in the silence. Izuku kept his eyes trained on the floor in front of him.

His classmates whispered instantly, already trying to come up with a reason that didn't involve him being a villain in any shape or form. He almost pitied them. He was almost grateful. "What I mean by that..." Aizawa struggled. Was he trying to come up with a way to tell them that didn't make Izuku look bad? Or was he angry about it? "He spied on Yuuei. He was spying for the League of Villains,"

Then the class exploded with exclamations of surprise and betrayal. "He spied on us...?"

"That's how they knew to attack us at the U.S.J.!" Sero exclaimed.

"Then why the hell is he even here? That means he's a villain right?" Shinsou snapped, his anger obvious. "Why isn't he in jail somewhere getting interrogated?"

"I think we should let Aizawa-sensei finish!" Uraraka told them, "Maybe there's a reason he isn't locked up!"

"I agree with you! We don't know Midoriya-kun's situation! It would be unwise to jump to conclusions without hearing the entire story!"

Izuku wrung his hands together wearily, and Aizawa began his explanation. "Even so, Midoriya was playing both sides. Despite his mission to gather information on his class and All Might, he decided to betray them. He planted information on all of the villains involved in the attack. He was lucky that I found them in time, but that's not excusable. The attack still happened, and some of you even got injured,"

Izuku fought the frown that edged its way over his features. Aizawa was right. He was the reason that everyone got hurt, and it definitely could've been so, so much worse. In a way, this was the best possible outcome he could've hoped for. "But you have him to thank for saving all of you,"

All whispers stopped, and Izuku's classmates looked at him, almost astonished by Aizawa-sensei's words. He knew what they all must be thinking. He *saved* them? A villain? A spy?

"What do you mean, Aizawa-sensei?" Ashido asked, her soft pink face contorted into one of confusion. Izuku didn't blame her for being confused at all. He was even more confused than half the class. He hadn't saved *anyone*.

"He fought Kurogiri after Thirteen fell. He saved Iida, didn't he?" Aizawa snapped, with his arms crossed. "He fed us information behind their backs and risked it all,"

"I don't get it. Why would he do that? Couldn't it all be for show?" Todoroki asked, with face grim.

"Do you think getting taken out of the U.S.J. in a stretcher when no one else was, was an act?" Kacchan snapped. "Did you see that state he was in?"

"I have to agree with Bakugou on that!" Iida exclaimed, and Izuku looked up, catching his eye. Something sparked there, a soft kindness that Izuku had never seen from the boy. "He saved me when he could've let me die! He's a hero to me,"

Izuku felt himself get choked up at that. "We've already decided that he'll stay as a Yuuei heroics student. He's already agreed to every demand we've asked of him. He's currently under the careful watch of myself and Present Mic for the time being. He's already agreed to an interrogation which he went through this morning. He's already proven himself to not be a threat, but we had one more demand from him. Just as all of you have to go through a talk with a therapist as a class, he does too. On that note, that's what we'll be doing today,"

Izuku took that as his queue to sit down, and that's when the woman beside Aizawa decided to speak. Her voice was calming and warm as she looked at all of them. "Hello," She found Izuku's eyes, and Izuku felt the tenseness in his muscles disappear. "My names is Yuki Hirai and I'm a therapist who specializes in heroes. I'm who they call when a hero is traumatized from a difficult mission. I'm here to help you relive your memories of the U.S.J., and work through the trauma. At Aizawa-sensei's request we'll be simultaneously doing that as well as seeing your worst fear. We'll work through everyone's trauma's and as a result make you a more well-rounded hero,"

"We'll be going to the gym to do all of this, so please follow me," Aizawa continued when Yuki stopped talking.

Izuku seemed to be the only one who seemed worried whatsoever. How would they go about all of this? Was it her Quirk? Could she see into someone's past or were they just going to go talk through all of it? That's what kept him on edge as his classmates stood up around him and headed for the door, following Aizawa and Yuki's lead. He stood as Kacchan came over to his desk and gave him a reassuring smile. "C'mon you nerd,"

He was reluctant, but he followed his class to the gym. His classmates talked cheerfully together, as if they hadn't been told Izuku was a spy. But then again, he didn't fail to notice how no one bothered to make conversation with him. Not that he'd ever left himself open to conversation in the first place, but he noticed it all the same.

"Dude, did you see that video of All Might stopping a train earlier?" It was Sero, speaking to Denki.

“I did, that was so cool! I’ve never seen anything like it!” Denki exclaimed. “The train was going so fast too! And All Might just— bam! Stopped dead!”

“That’s what I’m saying! He’s crazy strong,”

“Oh I saw it too!” Uraraka replied. This incident must’ve taken place really really early in the morning. He itches to join in on the conversation, but for obvious reasons he couldn’t. One, he didn’t want to join in uninvited, and two, he couldn’t even talk.

He didn’t see Kacchan catch him staring longingly. All he felt was his phone vibrating in his pocket.

Kacchan: And what does the nerd think of All Might stopping a train?

Deku: How the FUCK did he not break his arms??

Kacchan: That’s what I was thinking.

Deku: Maybe his Quirk is actually strength, like everyone says.

Kacchan: You didn’t think it was?

Deku: It’s possible that it is, but I personally don’t think so. It could be an agility Quirk. It could be strength. It could be anything, so I don’t want to stick to just one. I kind of wanna ask him...

Kacchan: All valid points.

Deku: Thanks...

And then they finally arrived at the gym. Everyone filed into the gym as a group, and Izuku stopped momentarily. In the center of the gym were chairs. Just enough for his classmates, Aizawa, and Yuki.

Everyone seemed to take all of this in stride and they took a seat on the chairs, excitement obvious on their faces. Aizawa lagged behind and Izuku glanced at him. He turned the lights off, but the gym was too dark to see. This entire situation threw him off. Something wasn't right.

He didn't like this.

Chapter End Notes

THE NEXT CHAPTER. OMFG. THIS IS THE ARC THAT INSPIRED THIS ENTIRE FIC. IT'S TEN CHAPTERS LONG.

Also here's more fanart from my friends in the discord! (by furby master)



Act Four: The Fallen Son

Chapter Notes

Unfortunately, due to the number of comments that I've gotten about me not tagging, or giving proper warning, I must issue a warning before you begin this chapter.

THIS ARC FEATURES VERY DARK THEMES, INCLUDING — BUT NOT LIMITED TO — CHILD ABUSE. SELF-HARM. FORCED THERAPY AND RELIVING PAST TRAUMA. DESCRIPTIVE THOUGHTS AND SUICIDE ATTEMPTS. TORTURE. THIS IS ONE OF THE ONLY WARNINGS I WILL ISSUE. PLEASE GO TO CHAPTER ONE OF SOMETHING WICKED TO SEE THE FULL WARNING.

Also I would like to remind everyone as this arc in my fic begins.

There's a whole month-ish gap in my fic. During that time he was doing training (refer to like... chapter 15?) before he takes the entrance exam. A LOT of his memories will take place during that month (a little more than a month, but lets just say a month.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku reluctantly took a seat next to Kacchan. Sitting on the other side of him was Uraraka, who shot him a warm, beautiful smile. He smiled right back, and a blush crept up her cheeks. It wasn't subtle in the slightest, but Izuku pretended not to see it. He turned his attention to Kacchan for a moment, who scowled at her for some odd reason. He saw a glint of jealousy in his red eyes but brushed it off. Kacchan wouldn't be jealous of Uraraka. There was *no* way.

But...it was kind of cute. Kacchan glared at Uraraka, and she glared right back, full of uncharacteristic ferocity. It was kind of funny to watch, as Kacchan looked taken aback by her glare. He turned away, and Izuku grinned at Uraraka, who smirked right back. Like they were sharing a secret. "He's a handful, isn't he?"

Izuku shook his head, and Kacchan growled at her, shocking everyone in the gym as he shouted. Izuku could honestly *see* a vein pulsing on his forehead. "SHUT UP ROUND FACE! I'M NOT A HANDFUL!"

Uraraka spat out a laugh, doubling over in her seat as she clutched her stomach. Denki turned around in his seat to grin at Kacchan, as did Sero. "Are you being bullied Bakugou?" Then he burst out laughing as Kacchan bristled. Izukuu fought the grin that tugged at his lips.

"Don't be mad Bakugou! Even Midoriya thinks this is funny!" Kirishima told him, "Look he's smiling!"

"I'm not bullying him!" Uraraka giggled, "Just teasing I swear,"

"Fuck off, all of you,"

"You know you love us, Bakugou." Sero cooed, with the biggest grin on his face, and Izuku felt a twinge of envy creep its way into his heart. He wished he had the guts to speak, just like everyone else so he could really be a part of this moment. Like, really, truly be a part of it in every sense of the word. He knew that he could never truly be a part of anything going on without having to speak. One day, Kacchan would realize he'd be better off without Izuku, all because Izuku could never really make conversation.

It hurt to think about, so for now, he pushed his melancholy thoughts away as Aizawa made his way over to Yuki. She settled herself on a chair in the very front. "Everyone listen up! We're about to show you how this is going to work,"

Any lingering conversation was snuffed out by Aizawa's announcement. Everyone who had been teasing Kacchan turned back around to watch the demonstration. "Every single one of you will come up and sit beside Ms. Hirai to view and relive your most terrifying memories.

Afterward, we'll discuss, and Ms. Hirai will give you an idea on how to cope with everything that happened during the U.S.J., and how to overcome any crippling fears that could cause you trouble down the line of your hero career,"

"And afterward if you feel like you need another session with her, then contact me or Recovery Girl," Aizawa told them all before he sat down on the chair positioned next to Yuki, and Izuku struggled to see what exactly what was going on. Yuki grabbed Aizawa's hand, and it suddenly made sense as to why Aizawa turned off the lights.

It was like a movie was being displayed on the wall, and Izuku could see the whole thing perfectly without having to stand. Footage played on the wall, and it was a video of Aizawa almost falling down the stairs as a kid. The footage — memory? — flickered and changed. It was Aizawa again, chasing down a cat in heavy traffic. He heard some of his classmates gasp in surprise, but Aizawa was a teenager in a Yuuei uniform this time. Older.

He swiped up the cat and carefully found himself on the other side of the road with a cat in hand, huffing with adrenaline and exertion. The moon was bright, making the night almost seem like day as Aizawa frowned. "You're such a dumb cat! You could've been killed!"

What a cute cat...

Izuku was shocked that they could hear Aizawa's thoughts. It was kind of awkward. "What a mood," Shinsou mumbled in the silence, and Izuku grinned slightly. Izuku went back to Aizawa's memory.

A few cars zoomed by. The cat purred in Aizawa's grip, and Izuku was struck with a sudden realization. That was Eclipse!

Once again the memory switched, and it was him almost falling down another set of stairs. *God damn it.*

It changed once more to an all too familiar scene. It was Aizawa and Present Mic chasing down a masked criminal. The day was early in this memory, and they could hear Aizawa thinking one word over and over.

Shit. Shit. I knew I should've drunk more coffee this morning.

Denki snorted at that. Aizawa kept running, turning into a park quickly and looks shocked. The criminal is pointing a gun at Auntie Mitsuki and he hears Kacchan grumble incoherently. Positioned behind Mitsuki is Izuku himself as a child, happy and bouncy, and Kacchan.

Shit, there are kids here!

A shot rings through the air, and Izuku hears his classmates gasp, and he watches Uraraka cover her eyes. But the situation is easily de-escalated. Aizawa jumps in the path of the bullet and starts bickering with Present Mic.

"Hold on guys. Is that Midoriya and Bakugou as *children?!"* Uraraka yelled, and Izuku kept his eyes trained on the video as almost everyone gasped in agreement.

The memory ends, and another begins. Present Mic and Aizawa fighting a villain. Then it changes to Aizawa running alongside All Might. "You lost what!?" He exclaimed.

"I—I lost a villain!"

"Are you serious!?" Aizawa yelled, angrily. "You can't be *serious*!"

All Might stopped for a moment, and Aizawa did too, frowning like an angry parent. "I'm sorry Eraserhead, but he just slipped out of my grasp!"

"You're the number one hero, and you fucking *lost* a villain?"

"I thought we established that..." All Might said weakly.

"What was his Quirk?" Aizawa asked, shifting his weight to his other leg. *This is the world's number one hero? Jeez. This man can't even catch a villain...*

"I'm not too sure, but he looked green and slimy," All Might grumbled, "He went this way, we should go,"

And with that, Aizawa watches as All Might picks up speed and runs, and he has no choice but to follow. Izuku could tell by the annoyed look on his face that he didn't want to be involved in this at all. Maybe he didn't want the press that was sure to find them. Izuku knew for a fact that he was not a fan of the press whatsoever. They ran for a while before All Might turned into an underpass.

Izuku felt the tension begin to build in his shoulders, and he almost fell out of his chair when Kacchan elbowed his hard in the side. The scene before Aizawa and All Might was a very familiar one.

It was himself getting killed by the sludge villain. *Erase his Quirk.*

"Wait! Is that Midoriya!?" Ashido exclaimed, sounding way too excited.

With a flash of red that's exactly what Aizawa did. The sludge was gone instantly and Izuku fell, coughing up green sludge. The villain looked at Aizawa and then to All Might with a terrified expression. “A-ah, All Might! Eraserhead—"

Aizawa found All Might's eyes, and Aizawa turned to leave.

"Deku, why did you never tell me that this happened to you?" Kacchan snapped quietly. Izuku ignored his question and returned his attention to Aizawa's memories.

Aizawa is about to turn away, but he stops as Izuku watches himself grab his things dart into the crowd. *I've seen that kid somewhere...*

It changed.

This one is shorter than the rest. It depicts Aizawa standing on a building watching Izuku and Kacchan.

Just as Aizawa seemed about ready to leave, someone grabbed him by the arm. He whipped his head around and glared at the man, and Izuku was surprised to see that it was Chizome.

The guy that was with Midoriya in the nurses' office the other day? Wasn't his name Chizome or something?

"Eraserhead," He said gruffly. "What're you doing here?"

Shouta shrugged, "What do you think? I'm doing a damn patrol,"

"Don't play dumb with me. You were watching him," Chizome mumbled. *Is he talking about Midoriya?*

"What if I was? What's it to you?"

"Don't stop. Whatever you do, never keep your eyes off of him. Do your fucking job, and save him because I *can't,"*

Shouta could only gape for a moment, as Chizome went on. "You're a pro hero that teaches at Yuuei right? Make sure he makes it into Yuuei, and *save* him,"

His phone buzzed in his back pocket and he glanced down and reached for it. When he looked up, Chizome was gone. "Ah, shit—"

The scene changed to introduce a new memory. This time its Aizawa walking out of a store with groceries in hand and Izuku finds himself wondering what was so scary about that. Then Aizawa walks along a sidewalk, the sun just beginning to set. Not many cars are out and the same could be said about pedestrians. Izuku could recognize exactly where he was before the dirty beach even came into view.

Someone should really clean this place up. Maybe Yamada could start a charity and promote it over his radio station to help?

Aizawa walks along the trashed beach, and he seems really content until the sound of swords clashing. Izuku licks at his lips nervously as Aizawa moves to investigate. He nimbly climbs a mountain of trash, and peers over, his groceries forgotten on the sidewalk momentarily. Two figures clash together, swords slamming against one another, and Izuku covers his face with his hand.

Izuku's sword goes flying out of his hand, and Chizome-san rushes for him, sword ready to strike him, down, and Aizawa almost, *almost* moves. His breath hitches as he watches.

Izuku lunges in, and grabs Chizome-san's wrist and twists it. His sword falls into the sand, and Chizome shakes out his wrist. He approaches Izuku with a soft smile. "Good job,"

Midoriya and Chizome?

Everything flickers, and it's Aizawa coming out of another store. Izuku sees himself run past him, and Aizawa whips his head to watch him. His face is contorted into one of horror. "Is there something wrong?!"

Izuku sees himself disappear, his feet carrying him away, and he hears more mutters from his classmates. He ignores them. Aizawa's memory changes again. This time it's the U.S.J. The atmosphere in the gym changes, and suddenly the air feels still and full of anxiety. Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line, pushing down on the worry that clouds his own mind.

Shigaraki is the first thing to appear in the memories, just as creepy and ugly as before. At the moment he's monologuing to Aizawa-sensei, and Izuku already knows exactly what he's saying and who he's talking about.

"Midoriya Izuku, a spy for the League of Villains! Did you hear that Eraserhead!? He's our spy!" Aizawa gawked at Izuku in the memory, no doubt feeling rage, betrayal, and sadness, but most of all confusion. He had many suspicions about Midoriya, but he didn't think of *that*.

That kid was probably abused and traumatized, but I never thought— It never crossed my mind—

"He's been spying on Yuuei this entire time!"

He's a spy.

Izuku watched, his hands shaking in his lap as the memory continued. "It wasn't his choice," Dabi whispered angrily, and Aizawa glanced at the fire-wielding demon that had come from Izuku's sword. "Don't make it sound he did it willingly, you sick fuck,"

Izuku was grateful for Dabi in that moment. Honestly, he was always grateful for Dabi. He'd saved Izuku countless times since they'd known each other.

Midoriya has been the one leaving notes!

Aizawa's eyes flickered over to Iida. Iida was in Shigaraki's dangerous, dangerous grasp, and the class watches Aizawa's memory. His black, tired eyes lock on the demon that had been inching its way behind Shigaraki this entire time. Izuku had been using Shigaraki's monologue as a distraction to get Iida back safely. Aizawa watches closely, as the demon pounces, its cold, cruel hands pulling Shigaraki's hand away from Iida's throat. Izuku watches the memory play, as Iida wastes no time running for dear life, nearly tripping over his own feet as he does so.

"Iida find your other classmates and make sure they're safe!" Aizawa shouted, and a few seconds later Iida is running past them, off to follow Aizawa's orders.

Then a roar shakes the ground and Izuku finds himself fighting the urge to panic all over again, just from the sound of it. It takes memory-Aizawa a moment to catch his balance before he looks toward the Prototype-Nomu with wide, horrified eyes. Izuku could never forget the horns, the drooling, dripping mouth. The claws, sharp enough to tear anyone to shreds. He can still remember getting carted off by the monster, fear gripping his heart like a vice.

Izuku didn't hesitate to put his hand in Kacchan's squeezing tight. Kacchan squeezes back.

"Prototype-Nomu, it's time to play," Shigaraki said with an excited huff. And Izuku can feel goosebumps blossom along his arms, like the U.S.J. was happening all over again. "Inko, Hisashi, make sure your son doesn't escape it,"

Those are his parents...

Memory-Aizawa looks toward Izuku, and it was strange for him to see himself look so terrified. In that split second, he vanishes completely and Aizawa looks at the spot where he'd been. Shocked. Horrified. And Izuku hears his own scream rip through the air. So terrified, so scared.

Then Dabi yanks Aizawa off his feet, out of the way of an attack from the Nomu. Aizawa was forced to focus on the fight. The Nomu swiped its massive hand at him like it was trying to swat away a fly. It comes for them again, and they dodge. Izuku watches Memory-Dabi and Aizawa dodge impossibly fast blows, and suddenly Dabi falters. A roar screams through the air, and Dabi clutches his chest as if he was having a heart attack. Aizawa turns to him in the memory, concerned.

"What's wrong?" Aizawa asked, nimbly jumping out of the way of the Nomu's next attack. Dabi sucks in a deep shuddering breath.

"It's Izuku," he chokes out, and Aizawa fails to see the Nomu's next attack. He sees it out of the corner of his eye, a hand coming for him. He only feels himself getting lifted off his feet. Shigaraki's laugh rings out, and suddenly Aizawa is slammed into the ground, and out of a moment of desperation, Dabi releases a massive wave of blue fire that doesn't fail to singe

some of Aizawa's hair. The Nomu does, however, fall into a heap. Izuku hears some people in the gym give relieved sighs.

Aizawa crawls to his feet, and he hears a loud scream that grates against his ears. His head turns toward the sound and sees half of the U.S.J. get vaporized. Buildings that had been there mere seconds before were now gone. And cold fear contorts his face, like an ice mask.

Izuku watches as Aizawa's eyes widen. "He should be dead now," Shigaraki says casually, and Aizawa's face flips a switch. Anger contorts every part of his face. It's burning, burning anger that Izuku had never seen on his face before.

"What's wrong Eraserhead? I'm just telling the truth," Shigaraki grinned behind his hand mask. Aizawa glares at it and rushes recklessly toward him. Izuku almost slaps his hand against his forehead in exasperation. What a fucking idiot. he could disintegrate things with his hands!

He has a five-finger contact Quirk. Avoid his hands, and defeat him. The faster you defeat him the quicker you can help Midoriya.

Aizawa was careful to dodge the first hand that reached for him, and he slapped away the next. Aizawa activated his Quirk with a grunt, the world going red for a moment. Izuku saw Shigaraki flinch, but he kept going. He kept running at him, even though his Quirk wasn't going to work, like a fool. Aizawa's capture weapon whipped around him, grabbing onto Shigaraki and pinning him in place. This was his chance.

That was until the world shook again. Izuku watched with wary eyes as demons crawled up from the earth and began running. All of them seemed to be converging to one point, and Izuku knew exactly where they were headed. They were going for Izuku.

Dabi faltered again, falling into a heap on the ground. Aizawa watched helplessly and he realized too late that he'd become distracted. Izuku personally thought that he should've been dead, especially since he was fighting Shigaraki.

Aizawa turned back toward Shigaraki in an instant, and the man was already coming for him with his hands out to disintegrate him. But that never happened. What happened made no

sense. It made Izuku literally tilt his head in confusion.

A shot rang out, and Shigaraki's hand was suddenly bleeding, a bullet had cut through his flesh. He pulled his hand away and glared in the direction of the shot with a screech. His other hand was scratching at his neck like a wild animal. Aizawa's gaze followed, and Izuku finally got to find out what was going on.

A woman with a red scarf, so much like Stain's stood not too far off, a pistol in her hand.

"Don't take another step, Shigaraki," the woman snapped. Her eyes moved toward Kurogiri, challenging him as well, and neither of them moved as another figure with a massive sword made himself known. They both were wearing scarves similar to Stains.

"Who the *fuck* are you?" Shigaraki snapped, clutching his hand. Blood dripped from his wound, but he made no move to fully treat it.

"We're Stains followers," The man states simply as if that was an answer on its own. The man is angry, almost growling as he spoke. "He called us his Roses,"

"And why would Stain's followers be attacking the League of Villains?" Kurogiri asked, a growl in his tone. Aizawa watched, just as confused as Izuku felt. That's when the duo began to explain, and the woman gave a sad smile.

"He gave us a mission," The woman explained, but it still confused him. "To protect his apprentice, even if that means protecting his class as well. We've already notified Yuuei of the ongoing attack you've pulled, and they should be here any minute now,"

"Shigaraki," Kurogiri mumbled softly. "We should go while we can,"

Shigaraki scowled at all of them, but glanced at his wounded hand and relented. "Fine. Let's grab that traitor first,"

Aizawa watched as Kurogiri conjured a portal but they never got a chance to step through it. The man lunged forward and grabbed Kurogiri, throwing him over his shoulder. The woman didn't hesitate to join the fray. She danced around Shigaraki with a grin. She slapped his hands away easily as if she fought the man on a daily basis.

"Hey teach," She said, grunting as she twisted Shigaraki's wrist, "You know where Midoriya is, right?"

"Yeah, I do. Why?"

"Isn't it obvious?" The man snapped, his sword swinging as he gave Kurogiri not a single second to retaliate. "Save him!"

The woman twisted one of Shigaraki's arms that had been swinging toward her in a wild attempt to disintegrate her. The man's sword cut easily through Kurogiri's portal-like body, and Aizawa gave them one glance. He glanced back at his students nearby and saw another woman dressed in red. She wore the same scarf. She was bent over Thirteen, tending to their wounds. The woman looked up, her eyes flashing with worry.

"Hurry up and go! We'll protect your students!"

Honestly, Izuku thought that Aizawa should've lingered to make sure that these people weren't villains in disguise, but he was grateful all the same as Aizawa swiped up his katana and turned away. All Izuku could think of was that Aizawa could run *really* fast as he ran across the U.S.J. in his memory.

Yet, he was agonizingly slow. The ground beneath him shuddered for the umpteenth time, and Aizawa nearly slipped. By the time Aizawa arrived on the scene, Izuku knew it was already over.

In his memory, Aizawa skidded to a halt — his eyes locked onto Shigaraki's.

He was too late, and he watched in utter horror as Shigaraki lunged for Izuku's face. Then Snipe saved him with only a few shots of his gun. Shigaraki went down along with other villains. Izuku's mother included, but Izuku watched blankly as Kurogiri dragged Shigaraki away, and the heroes converged on Izuku. The memory ended abruptly as Aizawa's eyes locked onto Izuku's broken form. *I failed again.*

Then just as Izuku thought it was over and that everyone else could begin reliving memories, another one started. Izuku instantly recognized his mother's house. He had been studying Izuku's katana, looking confused when it happened.

In his memory, Dabi summoned himself eyes wide with concern. "Something's wrong,"

Bam!

It all happened so fast in Aizawa's memory, but it had felt like hours to Izuku. Aizawa, All Might, and Dabi came up the bloody scene, and Izuku saw himself. Battered and bruised. A knife to his throat.

"None of you move," Hisashi spat, with a smile that still sent chills down his spine. He could feel the phantom pain of Hisashi's hand against his skin. "Or he dies,"

Aizawa watched Izuku helplessly, and he looked toward All Might helplessly. "Now, don't do anything rash..." All Might began. *Are you fucking kidding me?! Don't talk to him, just fucking knock him out!* "He's just a boy—"

"Shut the fuck up! *Just a boy* my ass!" Hisashi shouted, and Izuku clenched his jaw. He sliced open his face. Thankfully it hadn't scarred. "Stop talking,"

Aizawa turned back to Izuku, and they could all hear Aizawa's ragged breathing in the memory. The only testament to his terror. Aizawa's eyes locked on Izuku's summoned hellflame, and he took a deep breath. No one in the gym even said anything as they all watched. Kacchan's hand came to hold Izuku's shaking one.

Not yet Midoriya. He's got a knife to your throat.

"He's coming back with me. He has plans for him," Hisashi continued, and Izuku saw his own power sputter out, and fear pull at his features in Aizawa's memory.

He?

"Who is he?"

"Don't you already know, All Might?"

Oh.

"He's your enemy. He's a mastermind, you know his name,"

All For One.

Aizawa did something reckless and stepped forward. Hisashi acted in turn.

"Don't *fucking* move!" Hisashi shouted. "I won't hesitate to kill him!"

"If you need him, why would you kill him?" Dabi asked, his flames dancing the dark.

"No one ever truly dies. Not when you know All For One," Hisashi smiled. "He has a reanimation Quirk. We could turn Izuku into a Nomu, and he could be an immensely useful tool with that Quirk,"

What the hell...he'd turn his own son into a monster like that?

Hisashi's hand came to Izuku's shoulder, and Dabi growled. "Erase his Quirk, Eraserhead."

And he did. He didn't fail to notice how Izuku relaxed slightly, with a relieved sigh. Hisashi looked confused for a moment, before glaring at Aizawa. He then turned to Izuku, trying his hardest to get the boy to come with him.

"I've always hated that fucking demon of yours, Izuku," His words were hissed angrily, referring to Dabi. "I hate your Quirk, and Stain was stupid to think you could *ever* be a hero. Such a stupid dream to have. You should've become a villain just like I told you. These heroes don't want to *help* you. They don't like you. You're nothing but a villain in their eyes, why not prove them right?"

He's lying to you.

"Don't listen to him," Aizawa replied, his eyes hard as stone and angry.

"Come with me, Izuku," Hisashi insisted. *Don't. Don't do it.*

And that's when All Might ended the entire situation. Hisashi was thrown back, and Aizawa was too busy worrying about Izuku to care that he got to his feet and disappeared within the portal.

"I knew I shouldn't have let you go on your own, I'm sorry,"

I'm so stupid. Every villain is probably after him now, and I let him go alone.

[No it's not your fault.]

"It was my fault. I'm an adult, and I let this happen to you,"

God damn it, I failed again.

[It's okay. I'm used to it.]

"We're going to talk about that mindset later, Midoriya," Aizawa said sternly. "For now I'm going to have Dabi get your things, and we're going to my house,"

Where I can keep an eye on you and make sure you don't get yourself killed.

The memory shifted, and Izuku was wondering just how *many* terrifying memories Aizawa had. This memory was also one he recognized. He was starting to realize a pattern. A lot of Aizawa's terrifying memories included him.

"First Question, did you ever physically hurt your son?"

“No, I didn’t. I would never hurt my child,”

Liar.

“T-true,” And then the Detective said, “Do you consider Izuku Midoriya to be your son?”

“He’s never been a son to me,”

"True," He mumbled, and Aizawa looked at Izuku. "Did you ever raise a hand to Izuku Midoriya?”

“Yes,”

"True. Can you tell me why?"

In the memory, Aizawa never heard the answer. As if he blocked it all out.

"Why did you force Midoriya to join the League of Villains?"

"He was interested in him and asked me to bring him." Inko spat, losing herself in her anger. She was saying too much, and Aizawa could see the sweat beading on Midoriya's forehead. "He decided Stain was a mediocre mentor and took him under his wing despite my best wishes. It was a waste of time to train *that.* He insisted and spent months and months training him in time for the entrance exam. I was honestly surprised that he survived half of the training he was given,"

"Can you tell me the name of this man? What kind of training did Midoriya receive?"

"His name is—"

But that's when Izuku himself stood in the memory, covering her mouth. *Damn it. Don't stop this now, Midoriya. We need confirmation from both of your parents. We need her to tell us his name. We need to be sure Hisashi isn't lying.*

Then the memory skips slightly as if he can't exactly remember what transpired. And now it's Inko speaking, a soft smile on her face. “He’s been alive this whole time, biding his time until the moment was right. He created the League of Villains while he waited. Now he’s ready to come back into the spotlight, and All For One is on the hunt,”

What is he hunting?

"You've finally seemed to realize what you're up against, haven't you?" Inko asked.

All For One is alive. Dear God save us all.

Just as suddenly as the demonstration began, it ended. Izuku was almost relieved as Aizawa-sensei and Yuki stood. The theater-like projection was long gone, and Yuki smiled at them all. "And that's how my Quirk works! With a simple touch, I'm able to project people's worst memories out of my eyes! I know it's kind of creepy..."

There was silence for a moment before she spoke up again. "My Quirk is called Cinematic Memory! Who wants to go first?"

Izuku fucking loved how no one stood up.

Chapter End Notes

IF ANY OF THIS IS CONFUSING, PLEASE TELL ME COZ IT MAKES SENSE TO ME BUT IT MIGHT NOT MAKE SENSE TO ANYONE ELSE <3

also: fanart by insomnia mum on our discord server! (IM GETTING SO MUCH I MIGHT JUST FALL OVER AND DIE FROM HAPPINESS!?!?!!?!~)

isn't it fucking AWESOME?!



also the discord server link, as per usual.

Chapter 30

Chapter Notes

> So I realized I never linked any images for his hero costume (WHICH I AM OVERHAULING A LOT LMAO.) Once his hero outfit is drawn (by my brother), I'll edit some of the scenes where he wears his hero costume. (GIVE ME IDEAS??? :D)
>
> I lost the art so I can't post it here lmao
>
> here's the discord server link, so as soon as there's some art of it (if my he draws it) everyone can see it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku watched Denki stand first, and take a seat at the seat that Aizawa had just vacated. Izuku was relieved that it was Denki of all people to go first. He would bet money on his most terrifying moments being hilarious. He had to be one of the single-most hilarious kids in Izuku's class, so he was eager to see some of his memories, even if they were supposed to be traumatic ones. Denki laughs as he makes his way over, and its a nervous laugh. He takes his seat, and Ms. Hirai takes his hand. His body goes stiff instantly.

The projection began, and it was Denki as a teenager in a hot spring with Sero and a couple of other people Izuku has never seen before. Most of the memory is light-hearted until Denki sneezes.

Denki freezes horrified afterward, and his friends stare at him as if he's crazy.

"What's wrong Denki?" Sero asked, concern obvious in his tone.

"I thought..." Denki began, sounding relieved yet immensely nervous as he speaks. "Well, this one time I was in the bath, and I sneezed and accidentally activated my Quirk. I thought I just electrified you guys,"

Izuku could hear Sero snort from in front of him. Izuku fought the urge to smile.

"What you can do that?" One of his friends asked, looking too excited. "Can you show us?"

"Excuse me, but I'd like to *avoid* getting electrocuted in a hot spring, thanks,"

"I'm not doing that," Denki grumbled, crossing his arms, "Y'all crazy,"

I have really crazy friends.

The memory flickered and changed. Izuku fought the urge to cover his eyes out of respect for Denki and Sero. Denki was smiling softly at Sero, and leaning in for a kiss. A kiss he never got because Sero shoved him away with a hand, his cheeks flaming a bright pink.

In the memory, Izuku saw Denki's face fall. He was shocked, hurt, and confused.

Oh shit. Oh shit. Is he not gay? Is he homophobic?! Dear God, I just tried to kiss Sero and he totally rejected me…

"What a fucking idiot," Sero grumbled, putting his head in his hands in exasperation as the memory shifted to something new.

From his spot against the wall across the gym, most likely trying to relax after all of the memories he just relived, Aizawa grumbled, "Watch your language Sero,"

Sero mumbled an incoherent apology and Mina grinned at him. “Why didn’t you kiss him?!”

“I— I don’t— Just freaking watch,”

“*Have* you kissed Denki before?” Mina asked, her curiosity caused her to forgo respecting Sero’s privacy. “I fucking hope so,”

“Why the fuck are you asking me questions like that?!” Sero exclaimed, utterly mortified. His voice was high, almost shrill with embarrassment.

“That means you did! Didn’t you?”

“Just watch the damn memories!” Sero told her, covering his face. Izuku felt bad for him, having Denki’s memories about him displayed to the entire class.

In the darkness, there was a flash of red and Aizawa glared at Mina and Sero. “Didn’t I tell you to watch your language? I won’t hesitate to give either of you detention if it happens again. Now watch Denki’s memories,”

Izuku was quick to listen, even though Aizawa wasn’t even talking to him. Denki was running. He was wearing a school-issued tracksuit, and he was running beside Sero.

He hasn’t talked to me in days! What the fuck? He probably hates me.

The memory flickered and changed once more. “—I didn’t kiss you because it was so sudden, and honestly I was nervous. I don’t fucking hate you, you idiot,”

“That’s a relief!”

Izuku heard Shinsou grumble from behind him, “Damn I wish my life was as easy as Denki’s was,”

A mood.

The next memory was the Denki riding the train home from school, and at first, it was a calm memory. He was scrolling through his phone, looking at hero articles. His phone dinged, and he smiled instantly.

Tape Arms: Hey, wanna go to the movies tonight?

Denki: Hell yeah! Let’s see that new All Might movie!

Tape Arms: How did I know you’d want to see that movie?

Denki: I’ll be at your house in a bit, I’m just now getting off the train.

Tape Arms: You know, if you didn’t have tutoring every freaking night we could go now.

Denki: It’s not my fault that the teachers can’t teach.

Tape Arms: They teach just fine! You just don’t pay attention!

Denki glared at his phone and left the train as the sliding doors finally opened. He stuffed his phone in his pocket as he left the train station and walked out into the streets. It wouldn't take him too long to get to Denki's house, but as he got closer and closer something happened. It was pure luck, really, that he happened to look up at his phone in time.

At first, it started with the squealing of tires, and Denki looked around. That's when he spotted a truck speeding down the road. Then, with pooling dread his eyes found the little girl chasing after a ball. Right into the street. And the truck was going *way* too fast to stop in time.

Izuku leaned forward, feeling like he'd *seen* that girl somewhere, but he couldn't remember from where. He pushed the thought away instantly and focused his full attention on the memory. There wasn't a moment of hesitation from Denki as he ran up to the girl and yanked her back onto the sidewalk just as the truck whizzed past.

"Holy shit," Denki breathed, eyes wide with panic before he turned to the girl. "Are you okay?"

This girl almost died.

The memory ended, and another began. The U.S.J. incident.

"Thirteen! Are you okay?"

Villains… There are villains in the U.S.J.

Denki rushed for Thirteen too and watched in horror as Kirishima and Kacchan went straight for the warp villain. A portal ripped open, and suddenly half the class was gone.

Shit. Shit. It's just me, Ashido, Uraraka, Iida and Midoriya…Holy shit! Did Midoriya just cut open his own hand!? What the fuck!?

"What…" Denki began, watching in awe as Izuku grinned madly at Kurogiri. He knelt down and pressed his palm to the ground, and black matter pulsed out of it, and suddenly there were black figures standing, and Denki's face drained all of its color.

Are those…?

But Izuku darted forward, and the demons went with him. *How can he face a villain like it's no big deal!? None of us have ever faced villains, how is he so calm!?*

But the fight didn't last too long, and Kurogiri disappeared, along with Iida. Denki turned his attention to Thirteen.

"W-what do we do?!" Mina exclaimed, her eyes wet with tears, and her hands shaking. Uraraka ripped off her Yuuei issued jacket. She had a tank top on underneath it. Denki was beginning to panic.

"Thirteen do you even have a body?!" Denki yelled, running his hands through his hair, eyes wide. "What are you going to do with that jacket if they don't have a *BODY?!"*

"...I have a body," Thirteen said weakly, coughing up blood as they spoke.

"Where are you injured?" Uraraka asked, tearing her jacket into thin strips. Denki was quick to help her, as she looked over Thirteen's body.

Thirteen didn’t say anything, only holding out an arm from their suit. Uraraka took the hand gingerly and Denki tightly wrapped the strips on Uraraka’s jacket around where he thought the wound was. Thirteen sighed. “My back is pretty messed up, but it doesn’t require medical attention. Thank you,”

The memory changed.

It was still the U.S.J., but Denki had been talking to Uraraka. “—Why would they attack us?”

That’s when it happened.

An ear-splitting roar. Demons crawling out of the ground, converging on one point.

“IS ANYONE ELSE SEEING THIS SHIT?!” Mina screamed, and Denki paled.

"Uh-huh," He mumbled uselessly, glancing around to make sure they were really alone, and a villain wouldn't randomly pop out from nowhere. He left himself relax slightly as Uraraka wrapped up a few more of Thirteen's injuries.

Then, when Denki thought he was safe, something else happened.

A purple portal opened up, and three people walked out of it. The same people from Aizawa’s memory. The woman with the gun. The man with the sword, and the girl who had been patching up Thirteen.

“Who are you?” Mina asked, instantly defensive, positioning herself in front of Thirteen.

“We’re here to save you,” One of the women said with a small smile. “I’m a nurse, and I can heal some of your teacher’s wounds,”

I should really tell her to go away, just in case she’s a villain, but Thirteen needs help.

It changed.

Oh my god. What happened to him?

And Izuku was looking at himself, and he winced. His leg was bent at an awkward angle, his arm was utterly *shattered* and twisted. There were deep cuts that looked like they’d been from the Prototype-Nomu. He looked like he’d gotten mauled by a bear. A huge one.

His eye and face were splattered with his own blood, and Denki watched as they rolled his body away on a stretcher. Recovery Girl was yelling loudly, and Denki only caught part of it.

“I need everyone to get out of my way, right *now!”*

How is he even alive?

The cinematic memory ends, and Denki takes a minute to stand. “How’re you feeling Denki?” Ms. Hirai asked gently.

“Fine,” Denki replies, shaking himself. From where Izuku sits, he thought he saw Denki smile slightly.

“If you don’t want to talk about it in front of the class that’s okay. We can have a one-on-one session after school,” Ms. Hirai's tone turned a tad bit concerned at his nonchalant behavior.

Denki shook his head, “I mean...the U.S.J. was scary, sure, but I never got attacked or hurt. I was lucky compared to some of my other classmates who literally had to fight for their lives…”

“I understand,” Ms. Hirai said with a smile, “Who's next?”

And Iida took Denki’s place.

The memory begins, and it’s Iida as a four-year-old. Running in the street, screaming for dear life. Denki was instantly laughing his ass off, and Izuku squinted at the screen. Obviously, Iida had lost control of his Quirk and was running in heavy traffic. Izuku heard Uraraka snort as Iida kept screaming and deftly dodging any cars that he passed.

“Tenya!” Someone shouted their voice laced with worry. “Don’t stop running!”

And Iida didn’t need to be told twice. He kept going, panting. Then everything took a turn for the worst. A semi was barreling toward him, and Iida’s eyes went impossibly wide. But someone grabbed him and ran.

Iida looked up, a relieved smile gracing his features. “Brother!”

“Don’t worry Tenya! I’ve got you!” Tensei exclaimed with a beautiful smile. Izuku felt his throat close up. He’d killed Stain to save that man. He hoped it was worth it.

The memory ended, and in the next one, it was literally the most wholesome thing Izuku had ever seen in his life.

“We have to make mom breakfast,” Tensei was saying with the biggest smile. “It’s mother’s day, come on Iida! Get up!”

“Fine, fine,” Iida grumbled, feeling for his glasses on his nightstand. “I’m up,”

The two of them went into the kitchen and Tensei grabbed the pancake mix from the cabinet. “Let’s make her pancakes!”

“Shh, you’ll wake her up Tensei,” Iida chuckled, as He watched Tensei get the mix ready. He filled the measuring cup full of water and added a few eggs in. He mixed it almost as fast as he could run, and Tenya went to the cabinet to grab the chocolate chips.

I hope he doesn’t mess it up.

He threw the bag of chocolate chips at his brother and grabbed two eggs. He cracked both of them in a bowl and whisked them. He glanced nervously at his brother who had gotten a pan out. “Don’t burn them, Tensei,” Iida told him a smirk.

“I only burned the pancakes *one time!”*

“Yeah, and *I* had to eat them!”

“You said they tasted fine!”

“I was *lying*. I’m your brother, and I didn’t want to hurt your feelings!”

“You’re such an asshole,” Tensei pouted, before elbowing Tenya. Tenya snorted and threw the mixed eggs in a different pan. He scrambled the eggs before adding salt and pepper and cheese.

Once he finished that, he placed the eggs on a plate and started on the bacon. He went into the fridge and grabbed some, carefully placing two slices on the pan.

“Shit,” Tensei huffed, struggling to flip over the pancake. Iida watched apprehensively. *Dear lord.*

Eventually, he finally managed to flip the pancake over, and Iida put some of the bacon on the plate. That’s when the pancake suddenly caught fire. The fire crackled, and smoke rised from the pan in a pillar of smoke.

“SHIT!”

“TENSEI! WHAT THE HELL?!”

“Oh my god, the pancake is on *fire!?”*

“Put it out!” Iida exclaimed, and when Tensei stared at him with wide eyes Iida grabbed the pan and threw it into the sink, running water over it. He let out a sigh of relief as the fire went out. The two of them stared at the burnt pancake that was now soaking wet. Iida gave a defeated sigh.

“Boys…?”

Tensei and Iida both turned around, and there stood their mother. “Did you catch a pancake on fire just now?”

“No,” Tensei said quickly.

“Tensei did it,” Iida sputtered, “I’m innocent,”

“You traitor!”

Iida’s memory got a few laughs and he saw Kacchan smiling out of the corner of his eye. Then the happy atmosphere was gone instantly.

It all changed. Izuku sucked in a breath of horror. This memory depicted a very familiar alleyway, and Izuku honestly didn't need to watch this memory to know why it was a traumatic one.

"The Hero Killer, Stain," Tensei breathed. Iida’s breathing was ragged. There was a loud screeching sound, and Iida realized it was just Stain taking his sword out. The sound was achingly familiar and nostalgic. It made him miss Chizome-san more than ever.

"Why are you doing this?" Tensei asked.

"Because the world of Heroes is corrupt, why else?" Stain snapped, "It's a blight upon us all, and only true heroes — like All Might -— deserve the title of Pro Hero!"

"Tenya," Tensei said stiffly, "Run for help,"

"No! I'm not running while you face this — this villain!" *I wouldn't be able to live with myself if you died.*

"Good because I don't plan on either of you leaving alive,"

Tensei ran for him, and Stain grinned. His moves were too predictable as sent a flurry of kicks Stain's way. Stain dodged them easily, managing to land a single cut. Iida stared at the two with wide eyes.

He saw his brother fall instantly, and Iida gasped. Stain lifted his sword, readying himself to strike when Iida tackled him.

"Tenya no!" Tensei screamed. It was an ugly, sob filled scream.

Except it didn't go exactly as he planned. Suddenly the world tilted, and he was slammed into the ground. Pain exploded in his arm, and he was paralyzed. He couldn't move.

He paralyzed me!

Then Stain went back to his brother and stabbed him. Iida watched with wide terrified eyes. Too shocked and horrified to even scream. He sliced him open. Stabbed him again. Tensei's screams echoed in the alleyway.

No, no, no! This can't be happening!

Then, as Stain positioned his knife in the air, ready to deliver the killing blow, something like a miracle happened.

Iida watched in awe as two knives went flying, embedding themselves in Stain's shoulder and stomach. Stain turned to his new opponent, eyes wide with surprise when he locked eyes with the man.

Iida watched the two as the stranger drew a sword. It wasn't a man, Iida realized. *That's a kid. A kid is fighting Stain.*

He could make out green curly hair and he couldn't tear his eyes away as the two danced in a deadly waltz of swords. Dark figures seemed to be watching too, but Iida blinked those figures away.

"Is—" Aizawa began, and Izuku looked away when Aizawa looked toward him. "Is that *you!?"*

I'm hallucinating.

"My own apprentice, trying to kill me," Stain said, looking sad and proud. Izuku could feel his hands shaking in his lap.

His apprentice?!

He vaguely remembered everyone coming to look back at him in the gym. He thought he heard Uraraka whisper, "Is that *you?"*

But he'd ignored her.

Izuku watched Stain's sword fly out of his hand as he kicked it in Iida's memory.

"He sure taught you how to fight better than I did, huh?"

Iida saw the kid shake his head. *Who taught him what?*

"No, you're right. Not even All For One can make fighting look like a dance like you can. You'll truly make a great hero,"

All For One? Who is that? Is that kid a hero? I'm confused.

Stain feigned going in for an attack, but the boy didn't notice. He struck. Fast and true, and it was like time stopped. His blade went straight through Stain's chest.

"Oh shit," Kacchan said instantly, and Izuku watched, his eyes stinging.

Izuku watched himself let go of the blade in horror. Watching his mentor fall all over again.

He just killed him…he saved me—

"You know," Stain began, before spitting up blood. There was so much blood. He'd killed him. That boy had killed him. All on his own. "I always knew you'd be the one to kill me,"

Iida watched them in silence. Stain sounded so gentle, so kind. *As if he's speaking to his own child.*

Stain reached up a hand, to touch the boy's cheek, as blood poured from his lips.

"I could only teach you so much. I couldn't protect you from *him*. You have such a big heart for a boy who's been through what you've been through. Become a *hero*, and *stain the roses red with his blood."*

Are they talking about that guy named All For One? Why is Stain being so nice to him?

Iida watched sadly as Stain took both of the kid's hands and guided them back to the blade. And Stain wrapped his hands around the weapon, holding the kid's hands in the process.

"Kill me, and then you find a way to save yourself."

Save himself? What does that mean?

The boy shook his head, and Iida could already hear the boy choking back sobs. "It's okay,"

This is definitely not okay. None of this is okay. Even if he is a villain who kills heroes, this isn't okay. This kid shouldn't be the one killing Stain.

"It's okay. Be a hero, son. Become the next symbol of peace, and show the world what you're made of. It's okay,"

And that's when the boy couldn't keep his tears at bay. Stain took the blade in his hands and yanked it out, and Iida grimaced at the blood that splattered. "You're my *hero*, Izuku Midoriya,"

Stain plunged the sword right back down into his chest, and Izuku's hand was still holding the sword. Iida watched horror-stricken for the boy as he covered his face with one hand. He yanked the blade out of Stain's chest. He bit back a sob and wiped at his eyes.

Suddenly another figure appeared and took the phone that Izuku gave him. *Oh. They're calling 9-1-1.*

Izuku took some of Stain's belongings, his katana, his scarf, and instantly went to check on Iida's brother. The boy made quick work of temporarily patching him up and looked toward Iida. Iida closed his eyes as he came over, and he heard him give a relieved sigh. He only opened his eyes when another voice spoke up.

"You saved both of them, Izuku," The man who'd called 9-1-1 said gently. "It's not your fault Chizome tried to kill Ingenium,"

Thank you for saving me.

The boy sent one last look toward Stain's body and left.

Izuku kept his eyes trained to his hands as the memory changed. It was him in the hospital with his brother.

"Will he be okay, doctor?" Iida asked, out of breath.

"Yes, thanks to that hero who killed Stain, you're brother didn't sustain any injuries that a healing Quirk couldn't fix!"

Then it changed again.

It was the U.S.J. predictably, and Izuku didn't pay much attention.

He was too busy thinking about Stain, and he could practically *feel* the blood coating his hands. He killed him. He killed him.

He glanced up only once at the projection when he heard one of Iida's thoughts. *Midoriya saved me once again...I should remember to thank him at some point.*

And then Iida's memories ended. He vaguely registered any conversation as they talked about his memories for a moment.

Then he looked up again, to see who had taken the seat once Iida had vacated it. He was startled to see Iida standing right in front of him, and he smiled at him.

He returned the smile, even if his was more nervous than kind, like Iida's. Iida took his hand, and Izuku fought the urge to pull away as Iida dragged him to his feet and crushed him in a hug.

Why is he hugging me? Why is he hugging me? Is he trying to trick me into thinking we're friends?

Then he whispered something in his ear, and Izuku threw all of his previous thoughts out the window. "Thank you for saving me and my brother,"

Chapter End Notes

I hope ya'll enjoyed~

Chapter 31

Chapter Summary

Shinsou and Todoroki's memories! Some of Kacchan's as well WITH SOME ANGST >:O

Chapter Notes

Please join my discord server! It's fun in there!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was strange, how easily Iida had hugged him even though he was technically a former spy for villains. How easily his eyes shined with gratitude. How easily he smiled at him as if Izuku was his little brother. As if Izuku could do no wrong.

Without another word, Iida returned to his seat, and Aizawa took his place in front of Izuku. “Do you have a second?” His teacher asked, and Izuku fought the urge to shake his head. He gave Aizawa a slight nod despite the worry growing in his gut and followed him as he made his way out of the gym.

He blinked back the sting in his eyes as he left the darkness of the gym and walked into the brightly lit hallway. He watched Aizawa worriedly as Izuku picked at the skin around his nails. Aizawa took a glance inside the gym. Izuku waited for a lecture. A frown. A glare. A disappointed sigh. Anything.

He got none of that. Instead, he got a question. “You were the one that killed Stain?”

Izuku bit his lip, tearing mercilessly into the soft skin anxiously. That was a pointless question, in all actuality. Everyone had seen what had happened. Aizawa knew for a *fact* that Izuku had killed Stain. Iida's memory was proof. After receiving a raised eyebrow from Aizawa, he nodded reluctantly.

“But he was your mentor. Why would you kill him?” Aizawa asked, and Izuku glanced at everything except for him.

[He was hurting people. I couldn’t just let it happen, and I wasn’t really thinking when I attacked. My feet moved on their own.]

Then Aizawa fixed him with those sad eyes. So much like Chizome’s eyes, and how he’d look at him after a particularly hard session with All For One.

Like he was lost and had no idea how to help him. Like he was *dying* to do something, but he wasn’t sure what.

“Midoriya...you did the right thing. Even if it was the hardest thing you ever had to do,”

Izuku didn’t bother to look at him as he answered.

[Is that all you needed?]

“I— I think it’d be good for you if you took the extra therapy,” Aizawa began softly. “I think I've seen enough to know that you definitely need it, and if you need to talk to someone you can trust, you can talk to me.”

Izuku glanced up at him, and he knew his jaw must’ve dropped in shock. *Someone you can trust?*

Can I trust him? Is it worth the risk?

“You can trust me, Midoriya,” Aizawa told him reassuringly, probably seeing the shock in his eyes. “If you ever need anyone to talk to please talk to me. I’m always willing to listen,”

The two of them sat in silence for a while, and Aizawa sighed heavily. "We should go back before everyone else goes already,"

Izuku nodded and Aizawa opened the door to the gym. Their conversation must've lasted a while, or not many people had very traumatic memories except for the U.S.J. Suddenly they were breezing through people's memories, and as Izuku took his seat.

Kacchan whispered to him instantly as he finally got himself comfortable. "Everyone else has gone except for Half-and-Half, me, and that mind control guy,"

"Who are you calling mind control guy!?" Shinsou shouted, offended. Some of their classmates snickered and gave Shinsou good-natured pats on the back.

"You, ya idiot!" Kacchan snapped. Aizawa cleared his throat loudly, and they both stopped talking. They watched the rest of Uraraka's memories, and then Shinsou went up to the front.

The projection began. And as Shinsou's memories began to play, Izuku realized that they may have some things in common.

"He has a *brainwashing* Quirk. I have no idea why we adopted him…"

"I know we messed up, but we can't just take him back! We've been caring for him for a year!" And Izuku could see Shinsou's face darken with sadness. He was sitting on his bed in the dark, his room lined with hero posters and pictures. "Wouldn't it look strange if we suddenly decided to bring him back?"

“You’re right, but what do we do?”

“We should just keep him. We don’t have to give him back,”

The memory changed, and this time it was Shinsou, but he was a little older.

He was bruised and running.

God damn it! I just want to go home!

But that’s when he ran into a dead-end, and Izuku felt a familiar pit open up in his stomach. *Are you fucking joking?!* Memory-Shinsou yelled.

Three kids wearing the same uniform as Shinsou appeared, and Shinsou sucked a breath between his teeth. Izuku felt a pang of sympathy for him. One of the boys laughed, and Shinsou pinched the bridge of his nose. Izuku could tell that Shinsou was used to this, and he was just trying to hide his fear.

“Can we save this for another day?” Shinsou asked, but Izuku knew they probably wouldn’t.

“Oh no,” The buffest of them smiled as they spoke. Izuku could hear him cracking his knuckles. “You fucking deserve this shit,”

I really don’t want to deal with this today…

“Go away,” Shinsou said heavily, almost looking sad. Stiffly their leader walked away, and the other two gave Shinsou one disgusted glare before going away too.

The memory turned into another one, and in this one, he didn’t manage to get those three to leave.

One of them punched him in the jaw, but Shinsou didn’t fight back. He only defended himself by covering up his face.

I deserved this.

It changed.

“You’re a freak of nature! That’s why you have no friends!”

“You don’t deserve to go to Yuuei!”

I’ll prove them all wrong. I swear I will.

It changed.

It was Shinsou training at a gym with an instructor, and he almost dropped a dumbbell on his toe. His instructor laughed at him but gave him a gentle pat on the back. "That was rather close, Shinsou-kun! Be a little more careful in the future,"

Shinsou let out a shaky breath.

It changed.

He was dodging punches in this memory, and nearly got knocked out when he lost his rhythm. The gym instructor gave him some tips from outside the boxing ring. The gym itself wasn't the most professional gym Izuku had seen, but the instructor looked happy to have Shinsou there. The buff man entered the ring and began to tell him exactly what he had done wrong, and how to correct it.

“You did really well Shinsou!” The buff man said with a smile, after a long-winded explanation. “You just need to be more confident in your movements and strike before the other person does!”

But I almost got knocked out...

Izuku grinned slightly.

"You've really improved in the last few weeks! Them bullies been giving you any more trouble since last time? I could show 'em a thing or two!" The man continued, and Shinsou shook his head in the memory.

"That would be terrifying!" He squawked. "Not to mention illegal!"

The instructor still shot Shinsou a kind smile nonetheless.

It changed.

He was taking Yuuei's entrance exam, bashing robots to death with a piece of metal he managed to scrape off of a downed robot. Izuku remembered watching him from a rooftop, and hoping he got into Yuuei.

Did I get enough points?! I hope so. I need to prove everyone wrong. Oh god, I hope I made it.

It changed. Again.

“Hey mom?”

“Don’t call me mom, Shinsou,” The woman said, “You know my name,”

“Right,” Shinsou said thickly, “Forget I said anything,”

He held his Yuuei letter behind his back, holding back tears.

It changed once more.

"I guess we're both pretty clumsy, huh?" Shinsou was saying, and Izuku recognized this memory. In the memory Izuku nodded before scribbling something in his notebook.

I forgot to tell you that I saw you during the entrance exam! ‘You didn't even use a Quirk at all! Do you have a Quirk? It's cool if you don't…’

You’re going to hate me now too, aren’t you Midoriya?

"Oh, um..." Shinsou began stiffly. "My Quirk is brainwashing..."

‘REALLY!? That's so cool! How does it work? Can you show me some time? So cool.’

"Y-you think it's cool?" Shinsou asked incredulously. Izuku nodded. "Thank you Midoriya, it means a lot,"

He thinks my Quirk is cool… No one has ever told me that before.

The memory changed.

And then suddenly it was the US.J. as Shinsou fought off a few villains, only to meet up with a bunch of his classmates. Izuku could see Kacchan, Kirishima, Tokoyami, and almost everyone who had been scattered by Kurogiri's portal.

They converged as one big group, trying to find their way back to the entrance of the U.S.J. They were met with a group of Stain's followers. It was explained once more their purpose of being here. They explained that they were here by orders from Stain to protect Izuku and his class.

The Roses led them all to where Thirteen was, but then Stain's followers disappeared.

The cinematic memory ended for good. Shinsou got up shaky from the chair, looking mildly paler than usual. Ms. Hirai helped him to his feet and crushed him in a hug. She smiled at him as they pulled apart. "Shinsou, don't let those people get to you," She said simply, "Your

Quirk is amazing, and you aren't a villain. Just being here is proof that you're on the right track. Would you like to schedule more meetings?"

Shinsou gave her a quick, grateful smile and he went and took his original seat. He didn't accept her offer.

Todoroki was up next.

It started off sweet, or Izuku *thought* so. It was a small Todoroki, clinging onto his mother. She was making something on the stove, a pot slowly coming to a boil. In the memory, Izuku could see long white hair and a sweet smile.

Todoroki said something, but this entire memory was silent, unlike any other memories everyone else had shown. She ruffled Todoroki's two-toned hair and went back to the stove. The memory went white, and it switched abruptly.

As if Todoroki blocked out that memory entirely.

"Your mother is sick, Shouto," Endeavour replied gruffly. His arms were crossed and fire danced around his face. "That's why she did *that* to you."

He motioned to the bandages covering half of Todoroki's face, and Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line and looked away.

It's not her fault. It's yours. I hate you.

“I hate you,” Shouto snapped, his child-like face contorting in disgust as if he was looking at nothing but a flaming ball of trash. Todoroki turned away and headed down a hallway into his room. He slammed the door closed behind him. And locked it.

This is all his fault. He made mom go crazy.

Todoroki plopped himself down on his bed and curled in on himself. He watched the door to his bedroom with a mix of disdain and fear. That’s when Endeavour slammed his fist on the door, and the door shook on its hinges.

Todoroki flinched but didn’t move from his bed at all. *He can break down that door for all I care.*

“TODOROKI SHOUTO YOU GET OUT OF THERE RIGHT NOW!”

I’m not leaving.

“Dad! What the hell are you yelling at Shouto about?” Someone said from the hallway. “Just leave him alone,”

Izuku pretended he didn’t recognize that voice. Pretended that he didn’t know exactly how Touya Todoroki became a demon. How exactly he ended up tied to his katana. He pretended he didn’t know, as Touya spoke.

“His face hasn’t fully healed yet,” Touya told his father, “You can’t possibly think of trying to train him right now…”

Endeavor was silent, and the memory ended.

The next one was a while later, maybe a year or two after the previous one. He was taller, and his scar was completely healed. Todoroki was sparring with Touya, and Izuku could see Endeavor standing a little ways away, watching them.

The fight ended pretty quickly, with Todoroki falling as Touya swept his legs out from under him. “You failed *again*, Shouto!”

Izuku could see Todoroki scowl, and look away. “How many times do I have to tell you? Use your fire!”

I don’t want to use my fire.

Todoroki let out a long sigh. “I’ll try again,”

And they started to spar again. The outcome was almost the exact same, and Endeavour looked even angrier than before.

Shit.

The blast of fire came at him fast, and he had no time to react. He stood frozen in horror, as a hot ball of fire barreled toward him. He breath hitched, but no matter how much he wanted to move, to escape it, he couldn’t. He was frozen.

But then blue fire exploded out of Touya’s hands and canceled it out.

I hate fire. I hate fire.

“Are you fucking serious!?” Touya yelled. “You were going to attack him with your fire? Are you crazy?!”

The memory changed. It was dark in this memory, and Todoroki was sitting in his room watching television.

“Touya don't you ever come back!”

Todoroki reached for the television remote and turned off his show to listen. He went to his bedroom door and opened it slightly. In the hallway was his father and Touya. Touya was covered in a couple of purple burns.

From his training from Endeavour. From Quirk overuse.

What’s going on?

“If I ever see you in this house again, I’ll—”

“I’ll kill *you* one day, Endeavour,” Touya snapped. He was older. Much older than Todoroki. Probably around nineteen, and Todoroki was thirteen. His face was devoid of emotion, and he gripped the straps of his backpack.

“Touya?” Todoroki mumbled softly, and Touya’s eyes softened. “What’s going on?”

Touya walked over to Todoroki, and ruffled his hair with a sad smile. “Dad’s kicking me out. No big deal. I’ll visit you,”

Todoroki frowned, tears pricking at the edges of his eyes. Touya leaned in closer and whispered in his ear. “I’m sorry. I couldn’t help you,”

Todoroki shook his head. *No. This can’t be happening right now.*

“Go back to bed, okay?”

Don’t leave me with him, Touya.

The memory ended.

A new one began.

Endeavour was beating his son. Like, kicking the shit out of him, screaming as his flames framed his face in the shape of a beard.

Izuku didn’t watch it. He couldn’t. He stood abruptly and left as quickly as he possibly could. Kacchan almost got up, but Izuku was gone too quickly for Kacchan to follow him.

He didn’t know where he was going. Anywhere but in *there*, with that memory playing. He couldn’t get the image out of his mind. The image of his mother doing the same thing to him. Hitting him again and again with no sense of mercy.

Again and again. In his rush, he bumped right into someone but didn't bother to stop and apologize. He needed to go somewhere quiet. He needed *peace*.

"Midoriya?"

He stopped, blinking away his tears, and turned around. Present Mic was following him, concern etched into his features. "Are you okay kiddo?"

No. I'm not.

He nodded and ran a hand through his hand through his hair. "...You don't *look* okay to me,"

[I'm fine.]

"You sure?" Present Mic asked. He reached out to place a hand on his shoulder but thought better of it at the last second. "You're doing the memory therapy with Ms. Hirai right?"

[Yes.]

"Did someone's past memories bring up bad memories for you?"

Izuku sighed, and Present Mic seemed to take that as a yes. "Is it okay if I hug you?"

He gave the slightest of nods and Present Mic didn't hesitate. Izuku really wasn't one for hugs, but Present Mic's hugs were comforting instead of constricting. He wouldn't admit it, but he liked this. It calmed him. He took a much needed deep breath.

It was easier to push away the memories that threatened to drown him. When Present Mic pulled away he was almost sad to lose the contact. “We should head back to your class Midoriya before it’s your turn,”

Izuku gave a reluctant sigh but returned to the gym even though he hated the idea of doing so. Fear coiled in his stomach like a snake. Tightening it’s hold on him until he couldn’t think about anything else.

Soon it would be his turn, and he’d show his entire class exactly how he became a spy. And who exactly All For One was.

He’d show them exactly how it felt to have demons watch your every move.

He didn’t want to. He didn’t want to live it all again. He didn’t think he could do it. But there was no way he could get out of this. Present Mic was following him, and if he even managed to leave he’d probably get killed the second he left Yuuei.

Every villain was probably looking for him. Waiting for the perfect moment to kidnap him. When they finally arrived Todoroki had already taken his seat, and Kacchan was sitting down next to Ms. Hirai.

The memories begin, and Izuku takes his seat next to Uraraka. And it’s like watching his life, through Kacchan’s eyes. It was strange, yet not an unwelcome experience.

“Mommy! What does Quirkless mean?” Kacchan asks, and they’re both five years old and Izuku can see himself playing cards with Masaru. He’s obviously losing spectacularly, and honestly, Masaru is doing most of the work.

Mitsuki is sitting on the couch, watching Masaru and Izuku with a certain fondness. She looks toward Kacchan as soon as he speaks, and her smile doesn't falter for even a second.

"Why do you want to know sweetie?"

"It's because someone called Deku a Quirkless loser, and they were laughing at him. I didn't know what they were talking about but I told them to shut up,"

Mitsuki's smile faltered, and her eyes flickered to where Izuku was. He was smiling and Masaru was laughing. "They said that to him?"

"Yeah!" Kacchan pouted, "What does it mean?"

"Well," She began with a wave of her hand. "It means when someone doesn't have Quirk, that's all,"

Kacchan tilted his head, and then with a gasp of realization, he started to yell. "D-does that mean Deku's gonna die!?"

I don't want Deku to die!

Izuku snorted from his seat in the gym, and Uraraka looks at him, her eyes shining with amusement. "It's so cute that he's so worried about you,"

Izuku smiles at her slightly. The memory changes after Mitsuki reassures him that Izuku isn't going to die.

This memory is a hazy one in Izuku's memory. He doesn't even remember this happening. He's walking home from school, and everything's fine until he turns the corner.

It's Izuku, cornered by two middle-schoolers. Kacchan doesn't hesitate to jump in the fray as one of them pulls their fist back to punch Izuku in the face. Kacchan beats them to it, and kicks the first guy in the stomach.

He goes down easily, and Kacchan turns to the second guy and breaks his nose with his fist. Kacchan wastes no time dragging Izuku away from the fight before turning on him.

"Deku, are you okay?"

He watches himself nod in the memory, and Kacchan lets out a relieved sigh.

The memory changes.

Another fight. Kacchan's protecting him again. He wins this fight too, but not without lecturing Izuku again.

The cinematic memory moves on.

Deku’s getting thin. I swear to god that kid can’t take care of himself. I’ll make him come over. My mom will make sure he eats.

They’re in middle school in the next memory.

Shit I forgot to do my homework! Maybe I can copy Deku's shit?

That memory ends, and Izuku can hear a few people laugh. The laughter is cut short as the next memory begins. Everyone waits in anticipation.

"Hey Auntie Inko, have you seen Deku around anywhere? He hasn't been answering my texts."

Kacchan is in his house, and he’s standing in the entryway. Inko is smiling and her face is filled with warmth and kindness. A mask that only Izuku can recognize.

"He isn't here right now," Inko merely says, her voice light and airy. Kacchan scowls and turns on his heel.

Then where the fuck is he? I can't ask Inko. She probably doesn't want me anywhere near Deku, that fucking hag.

Kacchan was almost out the door when the door Hisashi was standing in front of shook violently. Locks were painfully visible on the outside, and Kacchan stared at Hisashi suspiciously. There was a strange growl, and then a thump.

What the hell was that?!

"What was that, Auntie Inko?" Kacchan asked, sounding confused and concerned. "Are you sure you haven't seen Deku?"

"Oh I'm sure, it's just our cat. He likes to scratch strangers so we keep him downstairs when guests are here. He has a habit of making a lot of noise too," His mother explained smoothly.

They've got to be lying. Whatever that was didn't sound like a fucking cat.

Kacchan looked at the door again, and turned and left even if he felt sick doing so. *Something is wrong.*

The memory changed.

"Is...is Auntie Inko treating you good?" Kacchan asked, and Izuku watched himself lie. So quickly, so smoothly.

He watched himself walk away, and watched Kacchan stop him. “Deku wait!” Kacchan pleaded. “I-I don’t think she’s actually — god I’m just worried — you look like shit, like you got hit by a train or something. You couldn’t even stay awake in class and you didn’t respond to any of my questions all day! You’ve got bruises everywhere and your hands are all fucked up and ripped open. There are scratches on your throat, how is that not concerning? How is that not a red flag, Izuku?!”

How am I supposed to ignore all of that and pretend I’m not worried for you?

Izuku tore himself away and walked outside, but Kacchan didn’t relent.

"Izuku!"

Don’t fucking leave!

“Is it him?”

Is it your father?

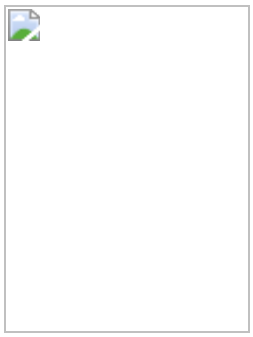
But Izuku left without a word. And the memory ended there.

The next one began.

And it began with Izuku covered in blood.

Chapter End Notes

More fanart btw!! This is what his new costume is going to look like!



by the lovely, the amazing, the artistic tressesopossum404 on the discord! (I FUCKING LOVE FANART). Though I have yet to decide if I want to use the mask drawn in there

(i still L O V E it)

Chapter 32

Chapter Summary

The end of Kacchan's memories, and the beginning of Deku's!

Chapter Notes

pls tell me any typos! (also his memories aren't in order just so you know! And they're jumbled as well, so its not supposed to make much sense yet)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Reliving his memories this way was strange. The second he had sat down and taken hold of Ms. Hirai's hand the world disappeared. Everything went dark for a moment before his memories began. It was like he was time traveling, going from a freshman at Yuuei to a four-year-old in just a second. It was like he was a puppet. Trapped in his body while someone else pulled the strings and controlled his every movement. Every thought. Every word.

This Quirk was strange. Everything about this was strange.

One moment he's speaking to his mother, and in the next, he's fighting off childhood bullies he hasn't even had the heart to think about in years. The next second he's worrying about Deku. Then the world darkens and a new memory begins. Another simple memory of him forgetting to do his homework, which is a rare occurrence. It moves on again, taking Katsuki by surprise that *this* is one of his most terrifying memories. Had he really not experienced anything that terrifying that this lady's Quirk chose this one?

Maybe it was a terrifying memory only after realizing that Auntie Inko really did abuse Deku. It was plausible, because every time he thought back to it, he felt sick to his stomach.

"Hey Auntie Inko, have you seen Deku around anywhere? He hasn't been answering my texts." Katsuki mumbled as the memory began. Everything was almost mechanic like he was programmed to do exactly this and he had no choice.

That's because it's a memory. His mind supplied.

And he accepted it as the memories came and went.

"Is...is Auntie Inko treating you good?" Katsuki asked in the next memory, sounding more desperate than he recalled.

Deku turned away, and Katsuki clenched his jaw. He ran after him determined to get an answer. Now that he was thinking about it, Deku did seem pretty uncomfortable at his line of questioning.

"Deku wait!" Katsuki pleaded. "I-I don't think she's actually — *god* I'm just worried — you look like shit like you got hit by a train or something. You couldn't even stay awake in class and you didn't respond to any of my questions all day! You've got bruises everywhere and your hands are all fucked up and ripped open. There are scratches on your throat, how is that *not* concerning? How is that not a red flag, Izuku?!"

How am I supposed to ignore all of that and pretend I'm not worried for you?

Deku tore himself away and walked outside, but Katsuki didn't relent. He needed answers. He oh so desperately wanted to help. To save him. *To do anything.* He was sitting idly by as he watched Deku deteriorate right before his eyes. Something was obviously wrong, and all he wanted to do was help.

"Izuku!"

Don't fucking leave!

"Is it him?"

Is it your father?

But Deku left without a word. And the memory ended there.

The next one began. With Deku climbing through his window in the dead of night, covered in blood. It was fresh, and not quite dried yet, but it wasn't his own. He refused to tell Katsuki whose it really was. It was a memory that Katsuki would never forget, as long as he lived.

The fear that had gripped him so tightly, so assuredly, and still lingered every time he thought about this. Whose blood was that? Did he kill someone? What exactly was going on with him?

He never got his answer. Not as he cleaned the blood off of Deku because he refused to move. Not as he stayed up for hours after that, worrying over Deku who couldn't even bear to close his eyes. He was shaking. He was breathing so fast, and his tears wouldn't stop. Deku looked so helpless and guilty, and *broken.*

And nothing Katsuki tried to do helped in the slightest. It was like Deku wasn't even aware of where he was at all. It was like he as trapped in his mind, and nothing could penetrate it. Like he had shrunk in on himself, and couldn't find the way out of his own turmoil.

The memory ended abruptly there. The next one was similar.

With Deku was climbing through his window, *again*. Around this time it was a month before the entrance exam to Yuuei, but he hadn't caught a single glimpse of Deku in a long while. Nearly an entire week had gone by, where Deku just avoided him.

They saw each other at school, but Deku had been distancing himself, whether it was intentional or not. Katsuki was determined to keep a close eye on him, and if he was being honest, he stalked him. He made sure Deku made it home safely every day after school.

Anyway, Deku was climbing through his window, nasty bruises and cuts on his face. It was a relief to see him. To know that at least he was still alive, and not dead somewhere. That had become an increasing worry for Katsuki.

Every time he saw Deku he seemed to be getting worse and worse. Weaker. Colder. Stranger. And every time Deku climbed through Katsuki's window, he let him in. He patched him up, and let him stay the night.

This time, he did the same. They were standing in his bathroom and Katsuki was just bandaging some of the cuts on his face, arms, and shoulders when it happened. When he saw the massive injury across his chest, and mentally did a double-take. It started at his right shoulder, and continued across his chest, crossing over his abdomen all the way down to his hip. It was jagged, thick, and shiny. Brand new. It was still pink. Still trying to heal.

Who did that to you?

He never asked. Never pushed. He didn't want Deku to run away again. He never wanted Deku to run from *him* of all people. Katsuki wanted to protect Deku with everything he had. He wanted to be beside Deku for the rest of their lives. He wanted him to rely on him. He wanted him to be safe.

The memory ended.

"'Zuku, why do you have a dog?"

Deku gave him a flat smile. Katsuki sighed. *You want me to keep it. Don't you?*

"Are you serious right now?"

He nodded. "And you want me to keep the dog?"

He nodded again. *Fucking Christ.*

Katsuki glared at him but took the dog anyway. If this was what Deku wanted him to do, he'd do it. He'd do anything for Deku. "Fine, I'll try to convince my mom to keep it,"

Deku hugged him, and Katsuki blushed slightly and grumbled, "Alright, alright you're welcome. Don't come to me with any more animals you got that? Just this once."

He smiled at him, and Katsuki rolled his eyes. "Do you... wanna come in? I'm gonna go back to bed if you wanna crash here all day,"

Deku's warm smile faltered, and he shook his head. Katsuki took a moment to really *look* at him. His eyes were rimmed red with tears, and nothing but regret lingered in those emerald eyes of his. Katsuki found himself looking at his sword. And…

There’s blood on that sword. That's blood. Whose blood is that? Izuku what the hell did you do? Who did you hurt?

Katsuki tore his eyes away from the blood weapon and looked Deku in the eyes. Trying to find a clue. A hint, to as what he’d been doing before he came into possession with this dog. Who exactly did he kill? For what purpose?

He wanted to ask. He *should’ve*.

I can’t bring myself to ask.

"Damn it alright, don't forget to text me an explanation about this damn dog,"

The memory ended. Another began.

He clicked the video again, trying to convince himself that he was wrong. *I'm wrong. I'm wrong. Izuku didn't do that. He couldn't have...*

"Just last night the Hero Killer Stain had attacked and critically injured the Pro Hero Ingenium and stabbed his younger brother. Luckily someone — neither of them know exactly who it was, or if they were even a fellow Hero, but this man killed Stain and saved the lives of both the Pro Hero and his brother. We give our thanks to this mysterious Hero, and we're all praying for Ingenium's speedy recovery. According to doctors, Ingenium was in critical condition but seems to be stable. His brother is to be released from the hospital in a few hours. Whoever that Hero was who put a stop to the terror of Stain, we are lucky to have him,"

Deku couldn't have... He didn't kill Stain.

With a long-suffering sigh, Katsuki looked at his phone screen again. There was no way. There was no *fucking* way. But it was possible.

He could've killed Stain.

A monster, tall and lean. Black fur covered it head to toe, and its skull was visible. White horns protruded from the skull, and sunken eyes were glowing ominously. It stopped for only a moment before running past them. Katsuki felt sick when he saw that the thing had Deku in its hand. Then he lost his voice entirely when he saw Inko and Hisashi.

Cold, fierce fear hit him like a wave. *Deku.*

He turned to follow it, but Kirishima put a hand on his shoulder to stop him. "W-was that thing taking Midoriya away?"

Then the memory skipped ahead, at the end of the U.S.J. attack. It was Deku getting carried away by on a stretcher. His arm was completely twisted. Blood had dried on his face, and his costume had been shredded up.

Katsuki could feel the world tilting under his feet. He couldn’t breathe. Couldn’t think at all. The only thing he’d even managed to do was follow the stretcher like he was lost.

I failed again. I couldn’t protect him this time either.

Watching Kacchan's memories, and watching him agonize over his well-being was hard. He'd always known that Kacchan cared for him deeply, but he didn't know that it was *that* much. It was a shock. He didn't even catch anything anyone was saying, as the memories ended and he was expected to go next. He blinked a few times, just to get himself out of his stupor before he had to reveal his memories to his classmates.

Well...could he even call them his classmates?

He was a former villain, and he doubted that any of them considered him to be *their* classmate. Honestly, he should think about it later.

He tore at his lower lip with his teeth. Aizawa and Present Mic were staring at him, and at some point, Nedzu, All Might, and Recovery Girl had arrived too. They were here to watch his memories. This was the final test.

Trying to quell the fear gripping at him from all angles he stood. Every eye was on him, everyone was staring, everyone was judging. He curled his shaking hands into fists, and walked quickly, too fast, to the woman who would show the class his worst memories. He wasn't too sure what would appear.

Probably every single memory he'd ever had. His breathing was quick and shallow. He was panicking. Would he feel all of the pain all over again? Would it hurt? Would he watch it like a movie?

He didn't know, and he didn't want to do it. But he sat himself down on the chair and looked at Ms. Hirai with wide, terrified eyes. His palms were clammy and cold with fear. His lungs shook with it.

“It’ll be quick, I promise,” Ms. Hirai said. “Just like a second,”

Later, Izuku would tell anyone who asked that she lied. *A dirty fucking liar.*

Her hand clasped his, and the world vanished.

He opened his eyes. Standing before him was Chizome-san, alive and well. And he quickly came to the conclusion this was the first time they ever met.

“I'm offering you a raft in the ocean that will surely drown you Midoriya, if you don't get on. I know how this road ends. It's a dark lonely road, boy and I can help you avoid that at all costs. What do you say?"

'Yes. I’ll do it. Please help me.'

“Midoriya!” Chizome-san told him. “Your form is off, widen your feet,”

Izuku rolled his eyes but adjusted his stance accordingly. Chizome-san smiled and gave him a thumbs up. “Lookin’ good kiddo! Keep at it, and one day you might just kill me with that

sword,"

She crossed her arms, her lips curling into a scowl. "It's your birthday,"

Izuku nodded, wringing his hands together. "Did you get a Quirk?"

'Mommy's mad. Mommy's mad.'

Should he tell her? It wasn't cool, or heroic in the least. She would hate it.

She'd be angry if he lied though. So he nodded, and she raised an eyebrow.

Lips trembling he said only three worlds. "I see monsters,"

Her hand came down faster than little Izuku could comprehend. "DID I SAY YOU COULD SPEAK TO ME?!" Her voice was shrill and made him shrink back.

He shook his head vigorously and backed up into the nearby wall.

"Exactly," she mumbled calmly, her hand coming to touch his face. Izuku jumped. "You don't have a Quirk," she told him sternly.

He furrowed his brow, confused. He definitely had one, even if he didn't want it. "You don't have a Quirk," She repeated.

'I don't have a Quirk,'

Izuku wraps himself in his blanket, sobbing. There's a demon reaching for him, mumbling dark words.

'No. No, stay away. Go away please,'

"So, Izuku," Mitsuki begins, looking uncomfortable. "Is your mommy nice to you?"

'No.'

Izuku curled in on himself, covering his head with his arms. He didn't move. Didn't fight back. His mother was screaming at him, and kicking him.

*“I don’t understand what I did to deserve this!” She was screaming. “What did I do to deserve something like **you?!”***

He could feel tears dripping down his cheeks. He fought the urge to cry like a child, but it wasn’t working. His body was shaking, and each kick renewed the pain in his aching joints.

“I hate you. God, I hate you so much,”

"Don't run away, kiddo," It's like there's gravel in his throat, the way his voice sounds.

‘God damn it. Go go go go. I’m late, I don’t have time for you right now.’

He hears his shoes slamming against the pavement before he registers that he's running. Izuku passes a few dark figures who watch him with fascination, but he ignored them.

It's sad really, how close he was to the street where tons of people walked. How close he was to escaping before he was grabbed, and slime entered every airway. His vision blurred almost instantly with tears. It was a strange sensation to suddenly stop breathing because slime was pushing its way into his lungs and stomach. Down his throat and nose, burning and making him gag.

He couldn't even close his mouth, and his jaw began to ache and add to the overall pain of everything. Every moment of pain in his entire life couldn't hold a candle to the pain he was experiencing right now. And the despair that coiled in his gut, and the sudden rush of thoughts that screamed at him.

Louder than the alarmed screams from his demonic entourage. This was the first time he'd ever had a thought such as this one. One so desperate and simple. Primal and uncontrollable.

A single thought.

'I don't want to die here.'

"My boy, I was wondering when you'd get home,"

'Stay away from me,'

Izuku chewed on his lip and glanced over his shoulder. "Turn around Izuku,"

It was like someone poured a bucket of cold water down his shirt. His mother had never called him that. No one called him that except for Auntie Mitsuki. And this man's tone was cold and devoid of emotion. Izuku carefully detached his hand from the doorknob and turned to face the man who he'd inherited his curly hair from. His freckles. It was like looking in a mirror. A scary, distorted one.

'Please leave me alone,'

He gulped, ducking his head. He could barely see the man through his bangs and eyelashes. But he could never miss that smile that pulled at his lips. His hands started shaking immediately, malice radiated off of that man, his teeth gleaming like fangs. Everything about Hisashi made Izuku want to stay far away from him.

Preferably light-years away, please and thank you. But no, he only had a wooden door with the lock on the outside. Suddenly he had a gut feeling that his room wasn't safe. Well, scratch that. His room was a prison cell, but now he knew it was a cell that Hisashi planned on invading. It was bad enough that it was shrouded in perpetual darkness, but now Hisashi...

Hisashi prowled.

"What were you doing? School let out a little while ago," Hisashi grumbled, his arms crossed. "Aren't you going to answer your father?"

Hisashi takes a step forward, and Izuku scrambles to take a step back. 'Don't touch me. Don't touch me—'

Hisashi places a hand on his shoulder, and suddenly the world gets too sharp, too in focus.

'This burns, this hurts. It hurts, it hurts, it hurts,'

He can see those god-forsaken wings fanned out behind Hisashi. He saw a cowering demon flicker and disappear.

The basement door he's leaning against shakes, and Izuku lets out a growl of pain. His hands shake, and his knees keeping knocking together as Hisashi's grip only tightened. A deep scratchy voice whispers faintly. A single word that has Izuku reeling.

"...God?"

“That’s my Quirk,”

“One side can cause pain, and the other can cause panic. You should be a very careful boy, Izuku.”

Izuku finally managed to get his feet under him, the hand finally pulled away from him. Relief rushed to him in euphoric waves. He used the basement door as support, watching Hisashi carefully. “Break any of your mother's rules, and I’ll make sure you pay the price, got it?”

Izuku blinked the vague pain away and nods eagerly. Hisashi grins. “I think I like you, my boy. I like my victims better if they’re quiet and complacent, like you.”

Hisashi’s calloused hands grab a handful of his hair, with his pinky lifted up and away from him. Izuku flinches back, his breath labored with terror. Izuku grinds his teeth together and ducks his head. Hisashi bares his teeth at him, his next words whispered into his ear. “Go in your room and don’t come out,”

It was around midnight when Hisashi got home. Izuku had stayed up all night, worried and terrified for his inevitable return.

His heavy footsteps slowed down when he reached the basement door.

‘Don’t come down here.’

Izuku covers his face with his hands and sucks in a deep breath. ‘Please don’t come down here,’

Hisashi continues on, into his own bedroom.

"Hey Auntie Inko, have you seen Deku around anywhere? He hasn't been answering my texts."

‘Kacchan…?’

But Izuku is frozen in place and he doesn’t move, his fingers digging into his delicate skin still. The darkness swirls and distorts before him as his mother's voice gently reaches his ears. The glow from under the basement door is the only meek source of light, and he can see the telltale sign of someone standing right in front of that door. Two spots under the door are dark, and as he quietly walks up, he catches a glimpse of shoes.

He stands a step below the door and listens. "He isn't here right now," Inko merely says, her voice light and airy. Izuku can practically see her blank face and tired eyes. Her empty words mean nothing when paired with her face. It’s painfully obvious to Izuku that his mother is a blank shell.

But maybe it’s a good enough act for Kacchan because Izuku can hear his familiar footfalls begin to retreat. Closer and closer to the door. Swift and confident but heavy due to his stormy sea of anger.

Then when the demons merged into one whole entity and attacked the door.

‘Fucking god damn it,’

And then suddenly he was pulling the demon away from the door, and he was falling down the set of stairs.

"What was that, Auntie Inko?" Kacchan asked, sounding confused and concerned. "Are you sure you haven't seen Deku?"

"Oh I'm sure, it's just our cat. He likes to scratch strangers so we keep him downstairs when guests are here. He has a habit of making a lot of noise too,"

‘Dirty liar,’

“You’re a monster,”

“You can never be a hero,”

"It took me long enough to find you again Izuku Midoriya, nice to see you. Maybe this time I'll kill you,"

The sludge villain lunged to attack him, but the demon that had been trailing Izuku pulled Izuku out of the way.

Izuku hissed at it.

"Don't struggle, it makes everything worse."

Izuku looked at the sludge villain, and scanned him for a weakness.

'I have to kill him. What's his weakness? His weakness? His weakness? The only solid part of him. His eyes. Go for the eyes.'

But he needed to weaken the villain enough to attack him. Izuku looked at the demon before him, and did the only thing that felt natural. He pushed his power into it.

Fire exploded.

Slime fell in wet clumps.

Izuku got the scissors out of his pocket, as the villain screamed. "WHAT THE HELL IS THIS THING!?"

Izuku raised an eyebrow before the Demon answered. Sounding concerningly more human than before. "...Demon...can...you see?"

He gaped at the Sludge Villain as he nodded frantically. "Greetings..." Came a guttural response that shook the very ground they stood on. Izuku felt every hair on his body rise in horror and astonishment. The Sludge Villain could see that monster? Maybe he'd been wrong. Maybe his Quirk was practical in combat. It was a horrible but thrilling idea.

'So was it the energy I pushed into it that made it stronger? No. No. No. This was very bad. This was a mistake.'

He needed to end this now before the sun set for the night. He needed to pretend this never happened. No one could know about his Quirk.

*'Inko and Hisashi will be absolutely furious if they found out his Quirk had **uses**.'*

He gripped the scissors tightly in his hands, his grip so tight that the scissors creaked and shook in his hand.

The lunge towards the Sludge Villains eyes was painfully easily. The scissors were sharp enough to cut through both eyes like water, but that might be because of the villains body being made of mainly sludge and slime.

"Ha ha...one of us..."

"One of us..."

"...Demon"

The demonic half of his face was speaking, forming each word with some level of difficulty. Izuku backed away, tripping when he stumbled slightly. He touched his own skin frantically, relieved that his skin was smooth and dry. The mirror was empty now, nothing stood in it or stared at Izuku. He stood with a shaking hands and wobbly legs.

The mirror was showing him an hallucination. 'No, no, no, what the fuck?!'

He resisted the urge to vomit.

'It was fake. It was fake. Don't think about it,'

"You're worthless,"

"You're Izuku Midoriya correct?"

Izuku nodded shortly and stared at him. "You don't look scared, and I can't decide if you're an inspiration or a fool," Izuku furrowed his brow. "Are you mute?"

He nodded again and crossed his arms. "I thought so. My name is Chizome, but I'm better known as Stain the Hero Killer,"

‘A killer. He’s a killer,’

"Will you become my apprentice and survive, or will you suffer long enough that you see yourself become a villain?" Stain asked.

"Why do you want to be a hero?"

‘ So I can have meaning. ’

“Fucking dark as hell in here...”

Izuku clutched his sheets tightly. Hisashi's footsteps were loud and heavy in the silence.

'No, no, no.'

Hisashi stumbled drunkenly around his room, and Izuku held his breath. The bed creaked with the added weight, and Izuku pulled his knees to his chest, wrapping his arms around himself. The two were silent for a while as Hisashi took long swigs from his beer, he slurred his words together mostly complaining about work and his mother. Izuku ignored him for the most part, as most of his words became unintelligible. Just then Hisashi's hand came up to cup his cheek, and Izuku jumped back as white-hot pain exploded in his jaw.

"...I really...hate you," Hisashi declared, "You're useless, you know that right?"

Hisashi placed his hand on the back of Izuku's neck and they were nearly nose to nose.

"You're the worst thing that's ever been born. I don't know why I deal with you, and that Quirk of yours,"

Izuku's world was nothing but searing hot pain and cold fear and panic. Every cell in his body was screaming in pain, and he could feel himself tensing up against his will as his mind developed tunnel vision, registering over and over the freezing cold on his neck where Hisashi touched him.

His teeth snapped together in his mouth loudly, and sharp pain skittered down his spine. His nails dug themselves into the soft skin on his neck, until warm sticky blood dripped from the crescent moon shaped cuts. Hisashi made no sign of moving, and Izuku tore at his lips with his teeth in his frenzy of pain. His breath is loud and labored as Hisashi laughed lowly at him.

"I'm thinking..." Hisashi whispers his hand petting Izuku's neck. His smile was dark and sinister. Crashing waves of agony seized him over and over. "Maybe my boss could help with that,"

Izuku's hands wring together, tangling with his blanket. "Would you like that?"

'No,'

Izuku nodded his head slightly, shaking.

'Just stop touching me,'

Hisashi stood quickly and scowled at him from what he could see in this pitch-black darkness. He almost gasped in relief as the pain dulled. "Good," he snapped, grabbing his beer on the way out of his room. "Don't forget to take the pills,"

"Come closer, my boy."

'Run, I need to run,'

"Izuku Midoriya. Stain's protégé, and son to my second in command, Hisashi. Your father has told me you want your Quirk removed?" Izuku was frozen to his spot, taking in the scarred face of a ***monster.*** *His suit fit him perfectly, even with his bulging muscles and broad chest.*

"Shall we begin with introductions then? I already know so you are, and it's only right you know who I am. I am the first man in history to get a Quirk. I've been alive for a very, very long time...I am known only by a few, namely All Might. You could say I'm the supervillain who almost tore All Might in half...'

Chapter End Notes

Also, I might be taking a break for a bit! My work schedule is changing next month, and with that i'll work mon-thurs which gives me more time to write. So until that changes I might update a bit slower since im not writing as much!

Chapter 33

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone! This is probably the longest note i've ever made on a SW chapter, and for good reason!~ ヽ(>∀<☆)ノ

Allow me to explain:

Unfortunately, due to the number of comments that I've gotten about me not tagging, or giving proper warning, I must issue a warning before you begin this chapter.

THIS ARC FEATURES VERY DARK THEMES, INCLUDING -- BUT NOT LIMITED TO -- CHILD ABUSE. SELF-HARM. FORCED THERAPY AND RELIVING PAST TRAUMA. DESCRIPTIVE THOUGHTS AND SUICIDE ATTEMPTS. TORTURE. THIS IS ONE OF THE ONLY WARNINGS I WILL ISSUE. PLEASE GO TO CHAPTER ONE OF SOMETHING WICKED TO SEE THE FULL WARNING.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I am All For One,"

'Monster. Scary monster,'

"WAIT DON'T!" Stain shouted, but All For One just grinned like a maniac.

And he was screaming. Low and tortured.

All For One had grabbed both of his hands and something in him tore itself to shreds. It was like everything was getting sucked out of him, and something vital was trying to escape. His vision flashed a blinding white, but as suddenly as it began it stopped, and Izuku fell to his

knees and threw up everywhere. Every muscle screamed in agony, and reflex tears sprung to his eyes as he emptied his stomach again.

“Why?” There was a tiny hint of fear in his voice. “Why can’t I take it from you?”

‘...He couldn’t take my Quirk?’

“Why...?” All For One mumbled again, moving Izuku’s head this way and that, glowering. “What exactly is your Quirk?”

Izuku looked at him hopelessly, but something strange happened. A golden glow flashed where All for One's eyes were supposed to be, and his face broke out into a wild grin. “I see...what a beautifully intriguing Quirk you have Izuku Midoriya. I think I like you, would you mind if I do an experiment? Of course, you don’t mind, my boy.”

Stain stiffened and watched wearily. All For One took a hold of his hands again, and Izuku fought the urge to pull away and almost didn’t stifle the reflexive hiss when they’re hands intertwined. He didn’t like the way All For One’s grip tightened and how he smiled at him darkly. “All For One...please,” Stain muttered weakly.

“Shut up, damn it.” Hisashi glared at Stain and crossed his arms, sick satisfaction obvious in his expression. Izuku turned his wide eyes to All For One, and that’s when it happened.

He heard the cracking and smelled the iron smell of blood before the pain hit him. It was like getting hit by a freight train again and again. His breath was caught in his throat as he stared at his bloodied and crushed hands. The bone peeked through the gashes. He realized the screaming he heard was his own, as blood squirted out of his completely destroyed hands. Large deep cuts littered his arms, but he didn’t care about that. His hands were unrecognizable and mutilated.

Izuku didn’t register anything happening around him. “His hands...”

“His...hands...”

”I smell blood...”

Warm blood covered everything. It was everywhere and his vision was red with it. Pain pulsed worse and worse with each passing second as All For One laughed, the cracking noise getting louder and more sickeningly wet. “Stop,” Stain snapped, over Izuku’s own excruciating screams as every bone in his hand broke again.“Please stop.”

He couldn’t hear anything over his own ragged screaming. His throat was raw.

“Do your hands hurt?”

Izuku nodded, and they throbbed in time with his heartbeat.

He sat in his bathroom, staring at his hands. They were healed slightly, from Dr. Tsubasa, but they were still deformed and pink with shiny scars.

‘I can’t do it,’

And he got his mother's razors out.

"Young Midoriya, shall we begin?" All For One suggests.

“Fear is a demon of its own, my boy. Don’t let it control you and debilitate you. You’re the consort of demons. They will bend to your will. You aren’t chained down by fear, young Midoriya,” All For One told him, but then he laughed. “Is that what you want me to say? God, I sound like All Might preaching like that. I don’t care if you’re afraid, and I don’t care how many beatings you take before you start moving,”

"Again,"

Another slip up.

"Again,"

A punch that broke his nose, and sent blood streaming down his face.

"Again,"

A simple sweep of his leg sent Izuku falling again, and he crawled to his feet again with shaking legs. All For One waited with his arms crossed, anger rolling off him in waves.

"Again,"

"Again,"

"Again,"

"Again,"

‘Again. Again. Again.’

He couldn't even bring himself to lift up his arms in defense for the next attack because he was so tired. He couldn't do it anymore, he just wanted to hide. He didn't want to be here anymore.

“This is Mysterio,” All for One told him, gesturing to a girl with straight black hair, cut just below her chin. “She’ll be in charge of teaching how to keep your mouth shut during interrogations,”

‘ Interrogations…?’

He didn’t want to think too hard about what that meant. He knew the best thing to do would be to just go along with it. Questioning things led to pissing All for One off, and he really

didn't want that.

"While you're spying at Yuuei you'll probably be discovered as a spy. If this happens, they won't hesitate to torture some answers out of you," All for One went ahead and explained. "I want you to be prepared. Failing to keep your mouth shut won't just result in your death but the deaths of your loved ones,"

'Kacchan, Auntie and Masaru, of course.'

Izuku nodded.

"I'm glad you understand. Furthermore, if you fail to comply with any of my requests, the results will be the same,"

Izuku gave him another terrified nod. A wave of terror seemed to reach for him from the darkest depths of his mind, and refused to let go of him. He knew this was wrong. Everything about this was wrong as Mysterio gestured dully to the chair in the middle of the room.

"Take a seat, Midoriya-kun,"

And so he did. The walls of the room were stark white like a hospital. But he knew this place wasn't as safe as a hospital. Not in the slightest. He didn't know it now, but he would grow to hate these walls. This chair, this woman, and All for One more than he hated anything or anyone.

But right now he was scared and cautious and unaware of the pain he was about to go through. Unaware of the nightmares he would face, and the terrors he'd kill, all inside his own head.

The metal chair he sat in was freezing, and Mysterio took the liberty of tightening the leather straps. He gulped back his frayed nerves and frantic thoughts. Whatever was about to happen, he could deal with it. He was strong enough.

But he couldn't stop his scrambled thoughts after all.

'What's her Quirk? How is this going to prepare me for interrogations?'

It didn't take him long to figure it out. Mysterio covered his eyes with both of her hands from behind. And then it began.

The world melted away, black and cold. Then, before his age-old fear of the dark could have him screaming, a room materialized before him. It was pretty much the same as the room he'd just been in, but instead of overhead lights there was just a single lightbulb dangling limply by a string.

It cast orange and yellow light on the scene before him, and he fought the urge to struggle in his chair as soon as he realized he was strapped down.

'No, no. No fucking way. What's going on? How the hell did I get here?!'

All Might, Nedzu, Present Mic, Ectoplasm, and Aizawa himself stood before him.

"My boy," All Might grumbled, his voice ragged and deep much like All for One's. "Shall we begin?"

'What…? Wasn't I just with Mysterio?'

Izuku didn't fail to let his eyes fall onto the tray of medical instruments. Scalpels, scissors, and more that he really didn't know the name of. There was a pair of pliers beside all the medical supplies, and All Might grabbed it.

“First question, why were you spying on Yuuei? What is your purpose? What did you intend to learn here?”

All he could think about was how Chizome-san told him to save himself no matter what. To find that opportunity, and grasp it tightly. 'Should I tell him?'

“Midoriya if you ever get the chance to escape, to save yourself, take it. Take it and grasp it tightly as if your life depended on it. Claw, fight and bleed for it. Don’t let it slip away, or you’ll die for sure. If the opportunity presents itself become a hero. Become a hero I would be proud of, and the world would be proud of,”

Izuku tried to open his mouth, to speak before what he knew would happen, happened. All Might was still holding the pliers pretty menacingly and Izuku had a feeling that he wasn’t afraid to use them.

But no words formed. No information poured from his lips like he wanted.

‘Fucking talk. Speak god damn it! Do something!’

It didn’t take long for All Might’s face to morph into an expression of anger and annoyance. An image of Hisashi filtered across his vision. And before he could blink he was missing a finger.

Blood splattered. He could taste it on his tongue. He could smell it, and he definitely could see it. The pain came a second afterward.

His finger throbbed as if lightning had struck him and burned him inside and out. He screamed. It was shrill, ragged, and rough.

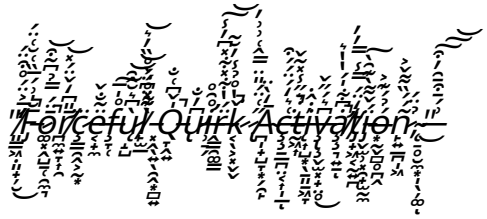
“That’s her Quirk,” All for One explained, as Izuku came to, as Mysterio took her hands off of his eyes. He was slick with sweat, and he was freezing. The urge to vomit was so strong that he almost puked all over himself.

“She has a simulation Quirk. She can show you anything from your biggest fantasy to your worst nightmare,”

Mysterio nodded and clasped her hands behind her back. “She’ll show you anything I tell her to show you. Do you want to experience another?”

‘No. Please no.’

“Of course you do,”



His vision was grainy. He could hear his own distorted screaming, but he couldn’t see. Couldn’t feel.

“We should start your Quirk training along with your training for spying at Yuuei,” All for One said as he paced around the training room. It was well-lit with bright fluorescent lights.

He’d used this room with All for One before, and he hated every time he had to come in here alone with him. “So, starting today we’ll be going over theories and testing experiments,”

Izuku waited tensely. He glanced around the room nervously, but all he could see that would indicate what kind of training he was supposed to do was a bucket of black paint, and way too many candles. He felt himself relaxing slightly. What could he possibly be doing with stuff like this?

All for One lifted up the small bucket and placed it in the center of the room. Izuku watched him closely as he activated a telekinesis Quirk, and placed all of the candles in a perfect circle around Izuku.

‘Why couldn’t you have done the same thing for the bucket?’

All for One then lit each candle with the lighter he had in his pocket. After they were lit he went over to the light switch and the room was plunged into darkness, save for the candles.

He swallowed back his fear for the time being. ‘Don’t panic. There’s still light in this room. You can’t get scared yet.’

“To start off I’m going to test every method of summoning a demon. We both know you can summon them with your hands, and that they’re immensely attracted to the smell of your blood. I want to see what else you can do. Now draw summoning circles, and try to summon a demon that way,”

Izuku hesitated. He glanced warily at the bucket of paint and looked at All for One with wide eyes.

‘I don’t want to.’

“What are you waiting for, my boy?”

He cast his eyes downward to the paint and didn’t dare look at him. He could do this. He could do this. He wasn’t afraid.

‘I’m not afraid’

He dipped his fingers in the paint and began to draw. His line was shaky at best, and not at all perfect. Within the thick circle of paint, he drew a pentagram and wrote words he couldn’t decipher.

He looked at All for One again, and the man stood by, watching with a crude and dark smile. “Do it, young Midoriya. Summon a demon,”

With shaking hands and a rapid heartbeat, he pressed a hand to the circle. All the warmth seemed to be stripped away from him as he pushed into it. His energy seemed to fade slightly, and the flames on the candles danced dangerously and almost went out.

The room creaked if that were at all possible. The flooring and walls were made out of concrete, but then as he blinked he realized the creaking wasn’t creaking at all.

A demon, with white eyes, and eight legs leaned down, right in his face, taking deep breaths in and out. Dry and rough.

His entire world swirled, and he realized he was screaming and falling backward. He clutched his face with his hands and screamed.

“Did I say you could stop Midoriya?”

“I want to see every wall, and the entire floor covered in circles. Don’t come out until you’re done. Summon a demon one time for every circle you draw, and send them back. Then draw a new circle,”

“Midoriya I want you to try to summon them without touching the circles,”

Izuku wasn’t too sure about that. He nodded, and focused on one of the many circles covering the room and cleared every thought from his mind. The only thoughts he allowed to occupy his mind were about the circle.

And it turned out that it worked.

“Try summoning them all at once,” All for One suggested one evening. “I believe you’re strong enough to achieve this,”

Izuku grimaced. Did he not realize how difficult it was to consistently summon and send back demons for hours on end? It drained him of all his energy and strength. "Don't look at me like that, boy. Know your place, and do as I say,"

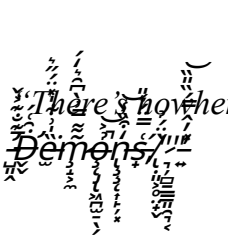
Izuku curled his hands into fists and stepped into the center of the room. It was dark and the only source of light was from the candles. He closed his eyes and took a deep breath.

He forced himself to relax completely. He gathered all of his energy into his breathing and focused only on the task that All for One had given him.

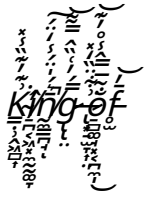
Izuku only had to think the thought, and it would work. But he'd only ever did that with one circle before. Maybe this time he could do it with every single summoning circle here.

He felt a sharp tug in his chest and opened his eyes. He flinched back, but they were everywhere. It was deathly quiet in this room, and they weren't standing and leering at him like usual. This time they were kneeling down on one knee. A hand over their hearts, and their heads down.

But he blinked, and they were gone. He doesn't think he really saw them at all if he was being honest. Maybe he was slowly losing his mind.



"There's nowhere for you to run," There was a low growl. "No one will save you, King of Demons."



Its voice was like metal scraping on metal. A choir of screaming demons. A chill skittered down Izuku's spine like a spider.

Izuku didn't listen to it's words. He could almost see the end of the forest. He was so close to the sunlight, to freedom. He could feel it in his soul. His body screamed at him to stop running, but fear kept him going. It muddled everything, his sense of direction, his logic. Everything. His fear distorted everything.

So he didn't notice the trap. He didn't notice that this entire forest was a trap and that the monster chasing him was one too. Izuku was running into the heart of the forest, where the monster waited, it's huge jaws waiting for him.

In Izuku's eyes he was running toward safety, where help waited. Once he reached out for the light and touched it, the world lost its glamour. He was standing right in front of a hunchbacked monster, this whole time he'd been running toward what he thought he was running from.

It's skin was hanging off it's arms in heavy wrinkles. The monster was covered up by a shredded blanket that covered its entire body. Only it's arms and feet were visible.

Its skin was dark, black even. It reached out to him with its thin arms, and Izuku kept walking toward it no matter how hard he tried not to. He wasn't in control anymore.

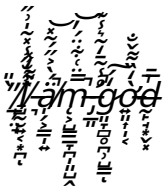
Its hand beckoned him closer, and his legs moved faster. Toward that monster.

A whimper escaped his lips as he drew ever closer. He only stopped when he was close enough for the monster to touch.

It reached up a hand to touch his face, and Izuku felt hot tears streak down his cheeks.

The smell of rot and death was stronger than ever, and it only made everything worse. It's sharp claws dug into his cheek, and the creature finally pulled back it's hood.

Izuku's heart plummeted in his chest, his eyes flashing with terror. Rows and rows of yellowing teeth greeted him, and the monster spoke.



It tackled him, and a gut-wrenching scream filled the forest. His own scream, low and painful. God didn't wait to start eating him alive.

Those jaws chomped down on his arm first, tearing his muscles and crushing his bones. Izuku kicked at him, his screams piercing his own ears as he fought to free himself. His arm was in agony. Blood squirted as God finally ripped his arm from his shoulder. It pooled around him quickly, sticky and warm.

And his screams echoed, like a warning in the forest.

“Open the doors,” All for One said over an intercom. The room he was in was small, but as All for One spoke, a huge iron door opened up in front of him. With slight hesitation he stepped forward, trembling.

Outside the door, he was greeted with an entire city within All for One’s warehouse. And he was standing in the middle of the road. A scream filled the air, a shrill tortured scream that had every hair on Izuku’s body sticking straight up in alarm.

A child’s scream.

‘It’s so dark.’

It was quiet in his room except for his ragged and wet breathing. His mother had taken his phone away, and all of his light sources had been taken away.

What did he do to deserve this punishment this time? He’d just come home from school, and she locked him down here. Tears obscured his vision and his throat ached from crying. He clutched at himself, curled into a tight ball.

‘I hate the dark. I hate the dark. I hate the dark.’

It was difficult to watch this. He kept expecting it to end soon, and he kept thinking that he’d seen the worst of it, but that was never the case. It was silent in the gym, save for a few sniffles.

Shouta saw Uraraka crying, and Iida grimacing as if he couldn’t even comprehend the things that he was seeing. Bakugou’s face had gone completely blank, and stayed that way for a long, long time. Shouta would have to speak to him later, to make sure he was okay.

As they watched Midoriya’s memories, they quickly came to the conclusion that Yuki’s Quirk couldn’t quite decide which memory was his worst, and was going through them rapidly and quickly. They were obviously out of order, and Nedzu had been the one to bring it up as they began.

“Ah,” Nedzu mumbled, but in the silence, every single one of Shouta’s students could hear him. “Yuki’s Quirk has gotten confused. It seems to me that It can’t quite choose which memory to choose, and is randomly selecting them. That could also be why his memories didn’t start off with his childhood,”

That had been thirty minutes ago. And the memories still weren’t in order for the most part, but Shouta had been able to piece them together.

It wasn’t a pretty picture.

Chapter End Notes

now for the fun part!!! HAPPY BIRTHDAY MICCHI <3 <3 <3 ＼(≧▽≦)／THIS CHAPTER IS FOR YOOOOU~

Also some FUCKING AMAZING ART BY SOBBYBEANU:



AND SOME BY FLUFFY:



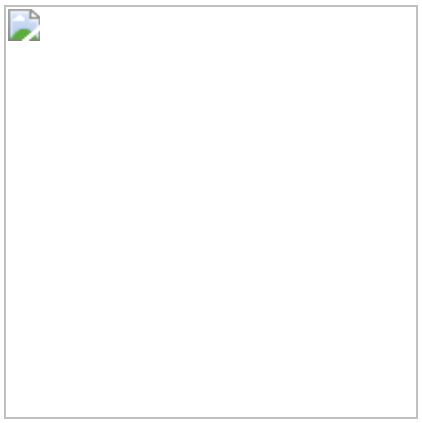
BOTH OF THESE PIECES LITERALLY MADE ME DIE ON THE INSIDE ꒰ঌ๑ƷƷ♡

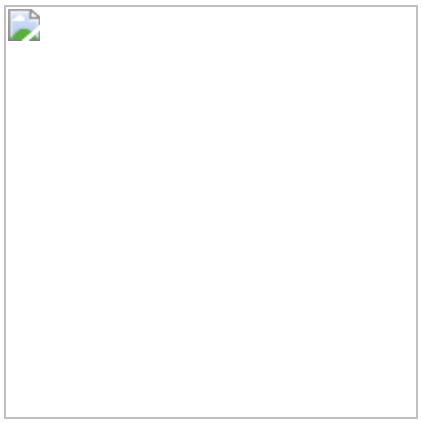
Chapter 34

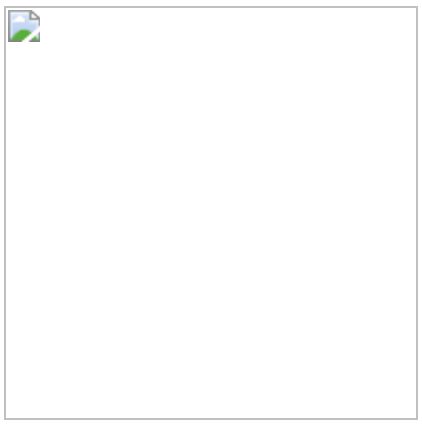
Chapter Notes

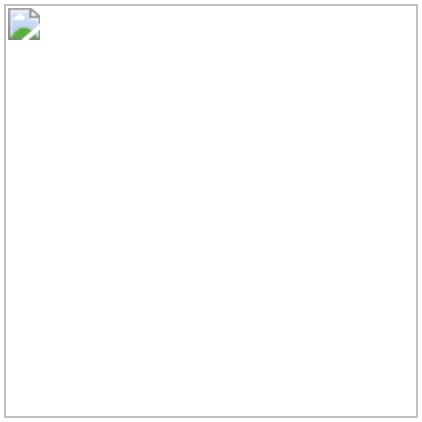
GUYS GUYS GUYS. WE HAVE MOREEE ARTTTTTTTT

Art by: Bia on the discord server!!!









Izuku was running through the dark city underneath All for One's warehouse. He'd heard a scream, a child's scream. It chilled him to the bone. He didn't hesitate to search for it and save whoever needed saving.

'Where's that screaming coming from?' He thought to himself as he ran, turning sharply into an alleyway, but nothing was there. Nothing but cold darkness, and the creeping sense of fear.

He weaved through the dark streets slicked with water. The screaming didn't stop, and he used that as a beacon to find the kid who was suffering. He ran through the streets and took the stairs two at a time as he searched. The only thing that didn't add up was why All for One would let a child down here, to get killed by a Nomu. He shook himself from his musings, as he turned another corner.

Everything was dark and wet. He couldn't see anything as he went, but he didn't stop searching. Didn't stop trying, and that's when he skidded to a halt in an alleyway. The screaming suddenly stopped, and Izuku looked around confused.

That's when his eyes adjusted to the dark a little more, and he saw the person causing the noise. But it wasn't a ***person*** *at all.*

A Nomu had made that noise to draw him here. And suddenly it was Izuku who was screaming.

It lunged forward, and with how many legs the thing seemed to have it didn't take but a second for it to reach Izuku. It's sharp claws dug into his skin, and he screamed.

The sound ripped his throat apart, and the pain bubbled in his arm like acid. Searing, burning, more than a mere flesh wound.

The hoodie he'd been wearing was torn in the shoulder where the Nomu scratched him, leaving deep gashes. Izuku covered his wound with a shaking hand, and watched as the Nomu moved back, like a cobra leaning back in preparation to strike again.

He needed to get away. He needed to escape.

The Nomu lunged again, and a scream filled the air. It was the scream of a wounded animal struggling.

It was his scream.

“Put him back into the simulation,”

And he died. Again and again.

“You’ve done well to survive all I’ve put you through so far, Midoriya,”

Izuku was sitting in the training room he’d covered in his drawings. The black paint smeared everywhere seemed to make the room more menacing than before. But the floor had been scraped of all the paint. All that remained was the paint on the walls.

He’d spent a lot of time in this room making those circles. A lot of sleepless hours. Why would they scrape it all away?

Today there was another bucket of paint and candles. It set him on edge, the way All for One was looking at him, and the way he spoke.

“I want you to summon another demon today, but not just any demon, from any summoning circle. I want you to summon the demon that sleeps in your sword. The sword Stain gave you,”

Izuku furrowed his brow as All for One got the sword out, and placed it in the center of the room. “Summon it however you like,” All for One told him. “I’ll be watching the camera’s,”

And then he left Izuku alone, locking the door audibly on his way out. Izuku stared at the sword in the middle of the room and looked at the bucket of paint. He lit each candle by hand

with matches and turned off the lights.

Izuku dipped his fingers into the paint and began to draw. He wasn't sure of what exactly he was doing, but his mind supplied an image for him. A summoning circle, slightly different from the one's he'd drawn before. Larger than ever before.

Swallowing his icy fear and instinct to run, he drew. It didn't take him as long as he thought it would. The circle was finished pretty quickly, and he sat in the middle of it. The candles danced and flickered around him, but he paid them no mind.

He crossed his legs and placed his hands on his knees, his palms facing up. He took a deep, shuddering breath. Nothing happened at first, as he slowed his breathing and concentrated on the sword.

Izuku seemed to sit there for a while, breathing in the silence.

Then he opened his eyes as the room suddenly got a lot hotter. The flames on the candles had suddenly turned blue, and the floor was shaking. The flames flared, casting the walls with dancing shadows.

Everything had a slight tinge of blue, but Izuku didn't move. Not even as the sword began to glow.

"Come forth, demon of cremation and eternal flame."

The voice who spoke sounded old and dry. It wasn't his voice, that was for sure, but as soon as that voice spoke something began to happen.

The candles went out as one, without so much as a whisper. Izuku swallowed the instant panic and sweat as he glanced around. There was no sign of any wind. The smell of burning wax permeated the air.

He forced himself to stay in the same position, even as the warmth was instantly drained from the room. He couldn't be scared yet. He couldn't let his fear make him weak.

He blinked, and he wasn't in that room anymore.

It was really bright, wherever he ended up. There was nothing around him. It was completely blank and white, there were no clouds, no sky, no ground. Absolutely nothing existed here.

He squinted to try and see anything, but he was alone. Or so he thought.

"Who are you?" A person asked, his voice hard with anger and confusion. "How did you get here?"

Izuku turned around and came face to face with a man. This man had purple patchwork scars all over him, but it didn't deter Izuku. He couldn't speak to tell this man his purpose, but the man seemed to already know. He sighed heavily in annoyance.

"You summoned me." The man asked. "Why?"

Izuku wanted to tell him, but there was nothing to write on to convey his words. But as he thought about it, a notepad and pencil appeared in hand. Writing his explanation didn't take as long as it usually did. Usually, he'd have to rewrite things because his hands would shake and make his words unintelligible. Usually, he'd be red in the face with embarrassment as he struggled.

But in this world, wherever he was, his hands weren't broken beyond fixing. The man looked at the note and his face changed. Before he'd looked pretty calm, and yeah he'd been a little surprised seeing Izuku here, but otherwise, he'd been calm. Now though, the expression on his face was anything but calm.

[All for One made me try to summon you.]

“He sent you?” The man asked, “All for One sent you?”

Izuku nodded, his hands cold and clammy with fear. This man didn’t seem to like him very much. Dread started to pool in his stomach, cold and heavy. This man — no this demon — was probably going to try to kill him. And honestly, from the way that demons eyes burned with eternal fire and anger, he’d probably do just that.

What would happen to him in the real world? Logically thinking, he’d probably die. The second that demon stuck his hand in his chest and yanked out his heart would be the second that he died in real life.

He needed to defuse this situation before it cost him everything. Before all his hard work to be free was all for naught.

[He’s forcing me to do this.] He wrote quickly. [I’m not his ally.]

The demon seemed to pause. He seemed to calm down. The demon seemed to think for a moment, before finally speaking. “I have a question,”

Izuku nodded.

“Do you want All for One dead as much as I do?”

[Yes.]

“Okay. Let’s make a pact. I’ll help you,” The demon told him. Izuku’s katana appeared out of nowhere, and the man sliced open his hand. Black blood dripped from the wound. Izuku didn’t hesitate to do the same when the man handed him the sword.

It was light in his hand, and it cut him as if his flesh was made of butter.

“My name is Touya Todoroki. The demon of cremation, rage, and eternal flames,” The man — Touya began. “And I bind myself to you, as Dabi,”

Dabi kneeled before him, and Izuku took his bloody, outstretched hand. “I will serve you to the best of my ability, Lucifer Morningstar, King of Demons, and the Underworld. Harbinger of evil, slayer of angels, the god of the Fallen,”

Izuku’s eyes widened in confusion before a single memory flashed before his eyes. A memory that wasn't his own.

“Touya!” All for One yelled, “Don’t stop!”

There was fire everywhere. It burned him, burned the entire room, burned his entire world. He had no idea how he ended up here, how he ended up with someone worse than Enji Todoroki. How he ended up with a villainous mastermind, who was trying to create demons out of people who had Quirks, he had no idea.

He was strapped to this chair, after months and months of training. Sitting in his lap was a broken katana. It didn’t burn along with everything else.

Touya had no idea what he had been thinking when he agreed to this. He just had to sit in this chair and activate his Quirk beyond his limits. Was he screaming? Was he burning himself alive?

“Become a demon and attach yourself to that sword,”

This was a mistake. He shouldn’t have agreed to this. The blue fire was burning everything. It was so hot in here. It was burning his skin.

The world was on fire, with ash and heat. The sword in his hands had been cursed by All for One, apparently. He didn't have the capacity to doubt that, as the metal lit up and burned in his hands.

He screamed his throat raw, as his body melted. As the world faded away. The only thing he could hear was All for One’s last words to him.

The world had changed, and everything had turned white. Completely white and silent. A cage. He was dead, but he wasn’t. The experiment had worked. And he remembered All for One’s last words.

And he’d fucking kill that man. Until there was nothing left.

Izuku blinked the receding memory away, and for some reason it was dark. For some reason, he couldn’t see anything until the candles lit themselves again. Dabi stood before him in the real world and held out the sword for him. Izuku was still reeling from the memory and Dabi's previous words. Had he really called Izuku Lucifer?

There was a tense moment, where Izuku stared at Dabi, and the sword before taking it.

Dabi grinned. “My King,”

It burned. It burned so much that he couldn't breathe. He kept coughing and air kept getting caught in his throat. Water was everywhere, and he was soaked in it.

"This is holy water," All for One explained. "I wanted to see what would happen if I covered you in it,"

It burned. It burned. It burned. "Does it hurt?"

"No, you're right. Not even All For One can make fighting look like a dance like you can. You'll truly make a great hero,"

Chizome-san came from the right this time, and Izuku was prepared to meet him knife for blade again, but Chizome left himself open instead. Izuku was too quick, and his blade went straight through Chizome-san's chest.

'What…? What did I — I did that— I killed…'

The world seemed to freeze. Izuku let go of his blade, watching Chizome fall. Izuku went to his knees, his face frozen in shock. He'd just killed someone. He'd just killed the Hero Killer.

‘I just killed him.’

He'd just killed his only father-figure. Chizome reached up a hand to touch his cheek, as blood poured from his lips. Izuku's eyes were wide, and he could feel every cell in his body freezing in shock. He found feel tears pricking at the edges of his eyes. He could feel horror and self-loathing crash into him in waves.

‘No. No, he was supposed to protect me from All for One. He was supposed to help me become a hero—’

Izuku hovered over him, shaking and barely breathing. "You know," He began, before spitting up blood. There was so much blood. He'd killed him. "I always knew you'd be the one to kill me,"

‘But you should’ve lived.’

Izuku blinked past his tears and sorrow and shook his head. No. This couldn't be happening. Why was he talking like this? Izuku could still call 9-1-1, he could save him. he could—"I could only teach you so much. I couldn't protect you from him. You have such a big heart for a boy who's been through what you've been through. Become a hero, and stain the roses red with his blood."

‘I can’t. I can’t.’

Chizome guided Izuku's hand to his blade that protruded from his chest. The blade had returned to its true form, broken and bent. As his fingers wrapped around it, the blade became pristine and brand-new. "Kill me, and then you find a way to save yourself."

Izuku shook his head again, his tears coming in waves. "It's okay," Chizome whispered, his hand on his face still warm despite all the blood he was losing. "It's okay. Be a hero, son. Become the next symbol of peace, and show the world what you're made of. It's okay,"

He gasped as Chizome wrapped his own bloody hand around Izuku's and lifted the blade from his chest. "You're my hero, Izuku Midoriya,"

And then he plunged the sword back down, and his eyes lost all their light.

If you asked him a few hours later, what he did after killing Stain he'd tell you he was in shock. He took his blade out and wiped at his tears again and again. He grabbed his phone and dialed 9-1-1, and summoned Dabi and made him speak into the phone for him.

He took a moment to grieve for Stain, and then he took Stain's knives and katana. He took his red scarf and held it in his hands for a moment. He looked over Ingenium, glad to only find his unconscious with a few cuts and bruises. But as he inspected him more closely he realized Stain must've gotten him pretty good. Blood was pouring from the wound in his stomach. With trembling hands he ripped apart Ingenium's bloody shirt. He ripped the cloth into thin strips and wrapped it around his abdomen, staunching the flow of blood.

As soon as he was sure that Tensei wouldn't bleed out, he looked around. His eyes went to Iida, and he headed over to make sure he was fine. The boy's eyes were closed, and he didn't look like he was hurt. He turned back to Chizome's body.

"You saved both of them, Izuku," Dabi said gently. "It's not your fault Chizome tried to kill Ingenium,"

Then Izuku heard the sirens, and he sent one last look toward Chizome-san's body. He was reluctant to leave it as it was. He wanted to be there when police found it, and found his victims. He wanted to be near Chizome as he was finally taken away. With guilt heavy in his heart, he left the scene, feeling nothing but agony and horror. He went to Chizome's apartment and locked the door behind him.

Izuku let himself slide down the door, and sit there with his knees hugged to his chest. He sat in complete silence for the longest time, even as Edgar came to beg for pets and cuddles. His body was wracked with hiccupping cries and sobs that ripped his throat apart. He sat for a long while, wiping his tears and trembling. He'd killed Chizome-san. He was in his apartment, covered in his blood.

He was covered in Chizome's blood. ‘I’m no better than All for One.’

He made no move to change or clean himself. For a while, he just sat there his eyes roving around the pictures of Chizome smiling with Edgar. He found a picture of himself and Chizome too, nearby to where he sat. He didn't make any moves to grab it. He just sat there silently, crying his heart out until Edgar started to lick his bloody hands with a snort. Then he had to change and clean himself up. He let Edgar follow him as he grabbed some extra clothes of his that Chizome took upon himself to steal from Izuku's room. He took a shower, scrubbing himself raw until he emerged.

Izuku wasn't even thinking about how fucking livid his parents were going to be when they found out. He didn't even want to think about what All For One would do. He wrapped his arms around himself and turned on the TV to check the news. He would go home once he was sure he hadn't killed his mentor for no reason. He was almost relieved at what he heard.

"Just last night the Hero Killer Stain had attacked and critically injured the Pro Hero Ingenium and stabbed his younger brother. Luckily someone — neither of them know exactly who it was, or if they were even a fellow Hero, but this man killed Stain and saved the lives of both the Pro Hero and his brother. We give our thanks to this mysterious Hero, and we're all praying for Ingenium's speedy recovery. According to doctors, Ingenium was in critical condition but seems to be stable. His brother is to be released from the hospital in a few hours. Whoever that Hero was who put a stop to the terror of Stain, we are lucky to have him,"

Izuku went through everything in Chizome's apartment, taking everything incriminating just in case the police investigated the place. He even took Edgar and his bloody clothes. He stuffed the picture of Chizome and him in a bag along with his other stuff. He took a picture of Chizome with Edgar. He stayed in the center of the apartment, soaking it all in for a moment.

This was the last time he'd see this place. This was the last time. He wiped away the tears that threatened to consume him again.

‘This is all my fault.’

Izuku had no weapon of any kind, as All for One closed the door behind him and locked it. He was alone in a dark room, with a massive door in front of him, waiting to be opened.

His heart was in his throat as the door opened without a sound. He'd had so many Nightmares that began exactly like this. Mysterio's simulations were difficult to separate from reality, but they were so realistic. For all he knew, this could be one too.

With nowhere to go but forward, Izuku began to walk. It was eerily quiet, as he swallowed hard and ventured into the inky black. Like so many times before, there was undoubtedly going to be a Nomu lurking around somewhere. Without his katana, he didn't have Dabi to back him up. It left him feeling nervous, as he listened intently for any sign of the Nomu.

His breathing was soft and shallow.

'Don't make a sound. Where is it?'

Up ahead of him was a flashing red light. It was his only source of light, but he still couldn't see too well. Blinking past the mounting headache the light was giving him he came to a fork in his path. Without too much thought he ended up going left.

He felt his way down the hall, his fingers grazing the wall. This entire area was freezing, and if he could see better, then he'd probably notice that his breath had turned into a white cloud every time he exhaled.

There was another blinking red light up ahead, and another choice to be made. Up or down?

He decided to go up, after hearing a chilling growl from down below. With a shaking breath, he climbed up blindly. The stairway was beginning to get increasingly narrow as he ascended.

‘Damn it. I can’t go up these stairs it’s too narrow.’

He turned around and took the stairs downward. It was drastically colder down here, as he took the stairs downward very slowly. He could hear wet clicking and a deep growl that made his chest sink.

Suppressing the urge to walk up the stairs and sit in the safety of the hallway upstairs, he continued on. They wouldn’t let him out until he did what they wanted.

He swallowed his fear roughly as if there were rocks lodged deep in his throat. Izuku reached the bottom of the stairs and there was another flashing red light to illuminate the complete darkness that the whole area was swathed in.

The walls were lined with huge cracks and holes. Claw marks marred the ceiling and floor, and Izuku knew he was close. Standing water made it impossible for his movements to be completely silent.

He could feel it like ice in his soul. Izuku tiptoed around the debris, and ventured further, finding that all the hallways he went into looked the same. He could hear dripping water, as his feet splashed each time he took a step. His feet were soaking instantly, but he was too focused on scanning every wall, every corner, for the Nomu.

There was another thundering growl, and Izuku stopped momentarily to listen. And then he wasn’t alone anymore. It seemed to come from the darkness itself, slinking into the light. Izuku could feel the fear clinging to him like a curse. The Nomu looked strange.

He almost couldn’t bear to look at it. It was crawling on all fours, it’s elbows sticking out sharply. The creature was so thin that its skin pulled tightly over its joints. None of that was the cause of Izuku’s fear and discomfort. Even from here, he could see how it’s back and spine was twisted and curved.

How it was even moving at all was a mystery that he never wanted to find out. He winced in sympathy as it tore across the ground, it's nails scratching—

'It sounds like Shigaraki—'

Its nails were black with dried blood. It was from dragging itself across the concrete only using its arm strength, and as a result, its nails had never healed. They were short, black, and cracked with use.

It moved faster than he thought possible, as he wasted time agonizing over its strange body. The Nomu left the darkness of the hallway, and Izuku scrambled to dart out of its path. There was a strange clicking sound as Izuku pivoted on his foot to keep his eyes on the Nomu. It turned fast, tilting its head up sharply to glare fiercely at Izuku, a deep growl ripping through its throat.

He swallowed hard, as the Nomu stood. There was the sound of bones shifting and cracking, and Izuku fought the urge to gag.

It wasn't standing up completely straight. It was bent at an odd angle, and it was reaching for him.

"Run…"

'That is not what I expected…'

Then he heard the growl from earlier. It was so much louder than it had been earlier. His throat bobbed, and he looked into the darkness the Nomu had come from. He looked back at the Nomu, his brow furrowed in confusion. This Nomu before him wasn't a threat. Whatever lurked deeper within the maze was what he needed to defeat.

If *he could defeat it. His victory was nowhere near secure. It curled his hands into fists, he would have to be smart to win. He was still so incredibly weak. His training with his Quirk*

had been going well, but he wasn't used to using his Quirk for battle.

For now, all he could do was summon demons and Dabi. Other than that he was defenseless.

Yet despite every part of him hating the idea of it, he felt his way through the thick darkness. The growl cut through the silence, and Izuku reeled back, as a red light flashed. Standing mere inches away was another, much stronger looking Nomu.

It rushed for him, closing the meager gap he'd created. He pivoted, water sloshing around him as he barely managed to avoid the swipe of its oversized paw. He kept low to the ground as the Nomu charged for him, looking to tackle him. He'd seen this Nightmare enough to know that his end wouldn't be pretty if he didn't dodge.

As soon as the Nomu went barreling past him in a mad frenzy, Izuku began to implement his plan of action.

He hated it, but he needed to defeat this Nomu. Unless he wanted to get ripped apart, only to be stitched up by Doctor Tsubasa. He didn't like how his body felt after getting treated by him.

And he has something to prove. He wanted to prove to himself, and to All for One that he'd gotten stronger.

Summoning demons had never gotten easier. Black writhing energy pooled out of his palms, freezing cold, as demons materialized from the circles carved into his hands.

Fear crawled up his spine, weighing down his shoulders. Their white eyes filled the inky black darkness, and the red light flashed again. It was always a gruesome sight to see the demons he *summoned rip something apart that had once been human.*

Something that had, at one point in time, wants, needs, desires, and dreams. Only to ripped away by becoming a Nomu. A create of wrath and war. Nothing but a weapon.

The demons, one impossibly tall, another that crawled on all fours, converged on the Nomu. The monster had a bird-shaped head, and he could see part of its brain peeking out from its head. Its muscles shifted underneath its black skin as it threw off every demon Izuku had summoned.

His demons disappeared into dust. He replaced them with a wave of his hand. This time they didn't hesitate to attack, and Izuku summoned more before the Nomu had the chance to attack. If he could overwhelm the creature then maybe he could win.

His hands ached, but he fought through it. Each time a demon disappeared into nothing, he summoned two more to take its place. Finally, two demons, one with long legs, and another one with fangs longer than Izuku thought possible had pinned down each of its arms.

The rest of the demons had lunged forward, but his small victory barely lasted. The Nomu roared, the ground trembling beneath Izuku's feet. He was quick to steady himself, as the Nomu broke free of his demons' grasp.

What happened next, happened so fast that Izuku didn't realize he was on the ground until the pain hit him.

The Nomu had come straight for him and wrapped a massive hand around his throat.

'Damn it— I have to—'

He couldn't breathe. He choked uselessly, his body desperately trying to find air. But it's grip was too strong.

The Nomu lifted Izuku up slightly, only to slam him to the ground. Stars swam in his vision.

Again.

Water sloshed everywhere. He was soaked to the bone, but he couldn't feel anything past the pain. Past the desperation that made his heart shrivel up in his chest.

'If I can't even defeat a Nomu, how can I escape all of this?'

His lungs screamed for air, but he could barely feel it. His eyes were getting heavy with exhaustion, and the world around him seemed to get even darker than it already was.

Then all he saw a brilliant blue.

And then he was gulping down air like it was water.

"Are you okay?" Dabi asked, helping him up.

He never answered. Dabi took the hint.

Tenya wasn't quite prepared for this. He didn't realize he was crying and wiping away tears until the projection blurred. At every corner, Midoriya was fighting something. He was soldiering through it like it was nothing.

If anyone else had the misfortune to be in his situation, then they would've given up. They would've let themselves die, long before this point.

No one else would've fought tooth and nail just to take another breath. He could tell that his classmates felt the same. No one was making any funny jokes. No one was even *talking.* Nedzu, All Might, Aizawa-sensei, and Present Mic were all silent too.

This was no time for jokes or messing around. Everyone else's memories hadn't been too bad — except for Todoroki's and Shinsou's — and everyone had realized that quickly. He watched in grief-stricken awe as he watched him mourn Stain as if the man was a father to him.

He watched him summon Dabi for the first time.

Tenya's only recurring thought through all of it was this. The world Izuku saw every day was scary. It was hell.

He listened to his every thought and honestly wanted to buy him a nightlight. Maybe a lot of nightlights.

"I hate the dark. I hate the dark. There's no light—"

And when he'd seen his parents lock him up like that in his room that he hated so much…

He couldn't stop the flow of tears that flowed down his face.

And then every time he thought his memories must be over, a new one started. Like a horror movie trailer. A horror movie he didn't want to watch.

Hitoshi had thought Todoroki's memories were bad. He was wrong. Very wrong. Midoriya's entire life was a shit show. Every time he should've laid down and taken defeat he didn't. He got back up. And every time he was so much stronger.

He couldn't believe that he'd been angry at Midoriya when he found out he was a spy. No *wonder* he was a spy, with all of the people forcing him into it.

He didn't think he'd defy All for One either.

The second that man had entered Midoriya's memories Hitoshi had seen every single teacher pale. This man was bad news.

"Shall we begin with introductions then? I already know so you are, and it's only right you know who I am. I am the first man in history to get a Quirk. I've been alive for a very, very long time...I am known only by a few, namely All Might. You could say I'm the supervillain who almost tore All Might in half..."

And it felt like all the air in the room had been sucked out.

Hizashi was glad he'd thought ahead. He had brought tissues for himself, and he really needed them.

"You can never be a hero."

"Just become a villain already,"

There was so much stacked up against Midoriya. So many reasons that he shouldn’t have escaped, or even survived all of this. Yet he was right here. He was breathing, he was safe. He was on his way to becoming a hero.

And Hizashi was willing to do *anything* to make sure he did it. If anyone deserved to be a hero it was Izuku. The only thing he regretted about this entire situation is that he didn't stop Nedzu. He should've at least tried. He should've told him that it was too cruel. But he didn't.

And he'd have to live with this mistake.

Chapter 35

Chapter Notes

This chapter starts off pretty bad...lol

mentions of suicide attempts, and self-harm bois

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Vaguely he remembered taking a seat in a chair, with Mysterio covering both of his eyes. He could remember the rapid beating of his heart and the sweat dripping down his spine. The fear that never seemed to leave him, like a crushing weight he couldn't quite shake.

'It's not real. It's not real.'

He wished it was true. This Nightmares felt more real than real-life sometimes.

This particular Nightmare took place in Kacchan's house. It was just like any one of the many nights he'd spent there. Auntie Mitsuki let them watch TV and play video games as late as they wanted. So far the Nightmare had been peaceful, and before he knew it Kacchan was asleep and everything was quiet.

'What's the catch?'

He was sleeping on the floor — or at least trying to sleep. The room was dark, save for one night light plugged into the wall. That was strangely comforting because Kacchan never had a night light before, but he couldn't let himself dwell on that.

What was the purpose of this particular Nightmare? What was going on? He needed to know what he was up against this time.

And then it really began.

He sat straight up out of his makeshift bed — which was just an assortment of blankets laid on the floor — but it was much more of a bed than the bed at his mothers house. It was immensely more comfortable.

But the problem currently was that he had no control over his body. It felt like he was being pulled by strings, like a puppet. When he looked, he could actually see *the strings on his limbs. His movements were jerky, clunky, and awkward. He held his breath, waiting to see where he went, and what happened.*

He clambered to his feet and walked slowly to the bathroom only a few feet away.

His feet met the cold tile floor, but he didn't flinch. Didn't even blink. He had no control at all. The door shut silently behind him on its own. There wasn't even a click. It was still so strangely silent.

The lights turned on by themselves, and Izuku placed his hands on either side of the sink. Each movement was carefully controlled by the strings attached to him.

He welcomed the cool feeling of the sink against his skin, but all too soon it was ripped away from him. He bent down and opened the cupboard under the sink. He rummaged through various types of supplies. There were basic medical supplies, like gauze, disinfectant, and Band-Aids. He pushed those aside, apparently searching for something very, very specific. He had no idea what it could be until he had wrapped his hand around it and ripped it open with frantic movements.

Izuku sucked in a terrified breath, his hands shaking. In his hands was an unopened pack of shaving razors, and he'd just ripped it open.

He didn't need to think too hard to know what this Nightmare was about. He grabbed a razor at random and pressed the metal to his wrist.

Izuku looked at himself in the mirror, and he saw his throat bob up and down. Tears spilled down his face, and it didn't even hurt when he sliced his arm open.

He positioned the blade right below the first one, and never broke eye contact with himself in the mirror. His image began to morph into something, someone *else. Slowly his face changed. His body got broader, and his face went shiny and scarred.*

And he was no longer looking at himself. He was face to face with All for One. "This is what you wanted, right?"

Izuku had enough control to shake his head rapidly. "Don't lie," All for One snapped, and reached out of the mirror to grab his bleeding wrist.

With his other hand, he grabbed the blade from him and carved a straight vertical line all the way to the crook of his elbow.

"You've always wanted to do this," All for One said, a small smile on his lips. "You want to die, don't you? You almost did it in your mother's bathroom. You almost did it in Stains, and in your own room. You remember those times don't you?"

He shook his head, blinking past the hot tears streaking down his face.

"You remember how much you wanted to jump off the building during the Yuuei entrance exam. You want *to die,"*

'No— I don't...I want to fight, I want to be a hero,'

‘I can’t do this anymore. I have nothing to fight for anymore. I’ve given everything I can. I have nothing left.’

He was sitting in his mother’s bathroom with a box of razor blades in his hands. A decision weighing heavily on him. The more tempting option seemed like the better option of the two.

‘I can control exactly how I die. If I do this now, then I can die without getting anyone killed. I can end it on my own terms, by my own hands.’

He took a single razor out of its box and stared at it for a long time. The blade rested coldly and shakily on the soft skin of his forearm, waiting to be dangerous and deadly.

It never was. He silently put the blade away and wiped at his tears.

‘There has to be another way out.’

That’s what he kept telling himself. It kept getting harder.

“Speak Izuku, or these children die.” All for One was holding a gun, and was pressing it to the temple of the second child. There were three of them. But not for long.

There had been four.

All he could see was the blood. Covering the walls, the floor, his hands. It wasn't his blood, but the blood of the innocent children that died because of him. All because he couldn't speak. All because All For One was angry with him, and wanted Izuku to suffer.

He could still the gunshots ringing in his ears as he desperately tried to wipe the blood off. Every time his hands came back more bloody than before, and the screams of terror pierced his ears. The first child lay dead near the second, who was already weeping.

"Save me, save me!"

"Please mister! Just say something!"

But all of this was a joke for everyone except Izuku and these children. His mother and father held him down onto his knees.

They all knew he couldn't speak — not because he was mute — but because they gagged him and bound his hands together. He couldn't even scream. He couldn't move. "Please,"

Please. Please. Save me. Save me. Izuku thrashed in his parents' grip, but they held tight. The Quirk suppressors around his ankles made it impossible to use his Quirk to save the children. He was useless.

Tears pricked at the edges of his eyes, and he flinched as the second child fell in time with the first shot.

The small girl next to the dead corpse of a boy vomited. Blood splattered onto Izuku's face, and he stood frozen to the spot, his eyes burning into the dead corpse before him. His fault. His fault.

‘All of this was my fault, and none of this would've happened if I just died—’

The girl was next, and more blood covered him. He felt himself go limp, as All For One reloaded his gun, and pointed it at the last child. There was screaming, and begging. There were tears and blood.

Four corpses of children. "You see Izuku?" All For One whispered, his shoes getting stained red with the blood of children. "You couldn't save those children. Their deaths are on your hands. What kind of hero are you now, my boy?"

'My fault, my fault, my fault.'

All For One waited for a response that would never come. Izuku stared blankly at the three small bodies in the room and he couldn't register anything. There was so much blood. And it was his fault. All For One grabbed Izuku's face and pulled him close enough that Izuku could feel his breath on his cheek.

"Exactly. You'll never be a hero. You are a murderer. You are a spy. You're a villain,"

'I'll never be a hero.'

He couldn't remember exactly how he got to Kacchan's house. He was covered in blood. He had sat in that room for a very long time, with the four corpses of the children. The blood had dried, and he kept shaking. He kept crying.

Maybe Kurogiri had helped him most of the way, but ultimately his own feet carried him here. He just needed Kacchan to help him. It had been so long since they'd seen each other, but Kacchan would help him. He always did.

“Izuku. I need you to tell me what happened,” Kacchan was saying. Izuku looked at him through his tears. He couldn’t say it.

After asking a few more questions — only to get no answers in response — he guided him into the bathroom. Kacchan cleaned him off, and then they laid in bed.

Kacchan kept looking at him, with worried eyes. Eventually, Kacchan sighed heavily and pulled him close. Izuku took a deep breath and took comfort in Kacchan’s familiar embrace and familiar smell.

Caramel. It was a side effect of his Quirk, and the smell nitroglycerin made when it exploded. Kacchan drew comforting patterns onto his back and talked to him, but Izuku wasn’t hearing any of it. It was like his entire world was on mute. It took him hours to fall asleep, and Kacchan was still whispering to him and drawing circles into his back.

Izuku gripped both sides of the toilet and vomited. He’d gone to Stain’s apartment for a while because home was never safe. His home never really felt like home, not like Chizome-san's house, or Kacchan's . He’d fallen asleep on his couch and had a nightmare about the children again. He found himself rushing to the bathroom. The third time this week. Nausea rolling in his gut like poison.

He almost didn’t make it.

Chizome-san came in as he was flushing the toilet, and watched him for a moment. “A nightmare?”

He gave him a curt nod. “Was it the children?”

He nodded again, and Chizome covered his eyes with one hand. "I begged Kurogiri to save them before All for One brought them to you. He said it was too risky, and that we'd get found out. We were so close *to taking them away. It's not anyone's fault but mine that those children died. It is* not *your fault,"*

'It's always my fault. If I was stronger, I could've saved them.'

But he wasn't strong. And he would never be a Hero.

The cell All for One had locked him in was cold and pitch black, again. The fear coated his tongue in iron. It had forced itself down his throat like ice and cement. He couldn't scream. He couldn't move. He was too afraid.

His irrational fear had grabbed him and chained him to this spot. He could practically feel the shackles around his wrists and ankles.

No demons lingered here. None had dared to venture inside. He covered his eyes with his hands, trembling. It was always too dark in here.

All he could hear was his own hiccupping tears and ragged breathing. His chest ached from not getting enough air. Dark. Dark. Dark. Dark. Dark.

"Izuku," A voice mumbled, and Izuku flinched. "Open your eyes,"

He shook his head feverishly. He recognized the rough, not-quite-human accent. A demon had found its way in here.

‘I can’t open my eyes. I can’t, I can’t, I can’t.’

“Please open your eyes, I made light for you. Don’t be afraid anymore,”

It was too tempting. The fear was ruthless and all-consuming.

Tentatively he opened his eyes. There was no light. But that couldn’t save him from seeing the demon inches from his face.

He’d seen something like this before when he was a child. Barely four years old. First of all, it was massive, hanging from the ceiling like a bat.

Its face was square and wrinkled with age. Its skin was ashen and gray, and the demon had no lips. Its teeth were black and glossy with rot. It had various missing teeth, and its eyes were completely white.

It had eight long arms that stuck out at odd angles like a spider. A really, really big *spider. It grinned at him, and Izuku froze. He didn’t move. He didn’t even blink.*

All he could do was scream.

He was standing next to All for One, a candle in his hands. “Imagine a flame just like that one Izuku, imagine the fire of hell coming from you,”

In all honesty, it wasn't hard. The room was dark, but there was enough light with the candle that he could see. But he didn't need to see.

As much as he hated the dark, he blew out the candle. He could smell the smoke floating from the extinguished candle, as darkness fully engulfed them. He only took a moment to think and create the flame in his mind. This kind of flame offered no light.

It wasn't hot. It was freezing. *It was the flame of hell. Black. Cold. And it could rip anything apart. The cross around his neck was warm against his skin, but even that went cold when the flames summoned themselves.*

Even in the darkness, his flames were blacker. Darker.

The ball of flame writhed around restlessly, circling around him over and over. He watched, awe-struck.

He was getting rapidly stronger. And for once? He wasn't scared. In fact, he was thrilled.

"Summon as many demons as you can," All for One explained, "And keep them summoned until you can't anymore. I want you to be able to summon demons for up to an hour or more, get started,"

They were back in the room lined with his summoning circles. But he didn't need them anymore. He could summon them with a single thought, through his hands of course.

He summoned all of them at the same time, and he could already feel the muscles in his back tense. He shook it off, and All for One started the timer on his stopwatch.

“Don’t leave this room until you’ve finally summoned them for an hour. I’ll know when you’ve completed my task. Anytime you have to start over earns you an hour in the cage,”

Izuku watched him leave, turn off all the lights, and lock the door behind him. The sudden darkness sent a wave of anxiety washing over him.

‘Don’t lose focus. Pretend it isn’t dark.’

He took a deep breath through his clenched jaw. His hands were tensed at his sides. Sweat beaded on his forehead, but he didn’t move to wipe it away. Every fiber of his being was focused on keeping these demons summoned until the timer sitting in front of him went off.

But not even twenty minutes in is when the pain began. At first, it had been dull, a soft ache in the middle of his spine.

It was manageable.

And then as the minutes ticked by it had become more insistent. More painful.

It was an explosion of pain right behind his eyes. But he couldn’t stop. He had to keep them summoned.

He didn’t stop even when his nose started to bleed, and the pain had traveled to every part of him.

Izuku was too afraid of the punishment he’d receive if he stopped. The demons he’d summoned had gone wild. They were grabbing him, screaming.

It pierced his ears like a gunshot, grating against his nerves like nails on a chalkboard. They flickered and disappeared.

He was retching on the floor before he knew it.

"One hour Izuku, do it again,"

Izuku growled, his joints aching with phantom pains. He tore off his sweat-soaked shirt and balled his hands into fists.

He reset the timer and began again.

Shooting pain pulsed through every part of him. It was like his muscles were being ripped apart. He curled in on himself, clutching at his shoulders.

Pain pulsed through him, and he tried to breathe through it. His hands were scalding hot on his skin, but he didn't stop summoning them.

He gasped through wave after wave of renewed pain. His nails dug sharply into his shoulders, to keep himself from stopping. He needed to do this. He needed to succeed.

He lasted a total of sixty minutes and two seconds according to All for One. He barely heard the timer screeching at him to tell him that his hour was up.

Blood dripped from his nose and eyes. His breathing quickened, and the pain and fear took him over. They clawed their way up his back. Like a monster finally showing its face after you've glimpsed it in the mirror time and time again.

The aftershock of overusing his quirk had him trembling and crying.

“You did well, Izuku,”

He vomited on All for One’s shining black shoes.

Izuku was in a maze again.

He didn’t run.

He didn’t hide.

Izuku was searching for the Nomu. He’d finally gotten the hang of using his hellflame in tandem with his sword. He wanted to start and finish this battle as quickly as possible.

He’d gotten stronger than before.

Izuku walked the dark narrow hallway, where dark red blood splatters lined the walls. There were massive cracks along the floor. The taste of iron lined his tongue, sharp with the taste of blood.

He ignored it and trudged on. His boots splashing through a puddle of blood in the middle of the room.

It was strangely quiet, as Izuku searched. His eyes scanned his surroundings, missing nothing. Not the incoherent writing on the wall. Not the human finger laying a few feet away.

He listened intently for any sign of the Nomu and heard nothing.

'That could only mean one thing…'

The only place he hadn't looked…was up.

He unsheathed his sword in one fluid movement, and his hellflame danced around it. He exhaled slowly, a white cloud puffing out of his mouth. The second he looked up was the second that shit hit the fan.

He pressed his lips into a thin line as the Nomu dropped from the ceiling, three times the size of him. The walls shook, and the ceiling creaked slightly. Then, with dawning horror Izuku watched as the ceiling became a spider web of cracks.

The ceiling was going to cave in. He needed to end this as quickly as possible.

Izuku charged forward, slicing and turning. Chizome-san had said more than once that he always looked like he was dancing when he was fighting with a sword. He wondered how he looked now.

Debris rained down on them, but Izuku didn't blink the dust out of his eyes yet.

The Nomu swung for him, but Izuku jumped right over it, pivoting as he landed and swung his blade again. It cut clean through its torso.

The Nomu didn't get up, but even if it had Izuku wouldn't have cared. With an angry growl, the ceiling began to cave completely, and Izuku was already running.

Shouto was shocked to say the least, about Touya. He was shocked, but not upset. He wasn't sad, or mad in any capacity. He had shed his tears for Touya long ago, and come to terms with his death. But this was a shock for him, as he watched the memories continue, each one more damning, and terrifying than the last.

He wasn't sad, upset, or angry at all. He was something else entirely. There was an overwhelming feeling of swelling in his chest. It was like a bubble was expanding in his chest, getting warmer and warmer.

Happiness.

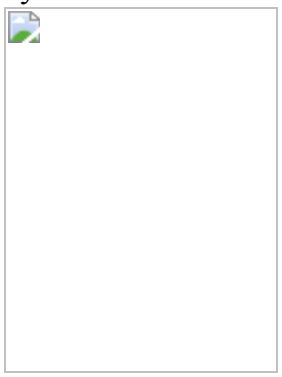
Something he rarely felt nowadays. There was so much of it, building and crashing through the mask he'd crafted so long ago. It shattered completely, and he had to resist the urge to smile. Touya was a demon, yes. He was technically a monster. He was bound to Midoriya. But most importantly, he was *alive* in some roundabout way.

Touya was alive.

Chapter End Notes

More art???? I feel like its every chapter and Im NOT mad XD

by Nehelennia in the Discord server!!



Here's the discord server link!

Chapter 36

Chapter Notes

> This arc is really repetitive lol. So I decided to speed it up and upload two chapters a week until we reach chapter 39!!~ That way, if people aren't interested (It's okay to be bored my boys) they can get to the good shit faster

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You can be a hero,” Stain smiled.

“Have you ever raised a hand against Izuku Midoriya?”

“Yes.”

“True.”

But it didn't matter. He was being hunted, and no one seemed to understand that at all. And with a predator like All For One chasing him, there was nowhere to hide. His mother reminded him of that. So he dropped his hand and stepped away. He couldn't save any of them. Not really.

He was useless. He was nowhere near strong enough to think that he stood a chance.

"Save yourself."

What a load of shit that was.

Inko cleared her throat and licked her lips. She was excited to see how they would react. "He's been alive this whole time, biding his time until the moment was right. He created the League of Villains while he waited. Now he's ready to come back into the spotlight, and All For One is on the hunt,"

Izuku fought the wave of despair that threatened to drown him. He could tell all of his teachers were trying to do the same.

"You've finally seemed to realize what you're up against, haven't you?" Inko asked.

'Even All Might didn't stand a chance, how could I?' If All Might couldn't save him, then no one could.

Izuku didn't even look at her. "Get her out of here," Nedzu said simply, and the door opened instantly. Ectoplasm entered the room and walked over to where his mother sat. She gave them all soft smiles as she was dragged out. "And make sure to gag her too, Ectoplasm,"

After she was gone there was a tense moment of silence. He touched the hilt of his sword, and Dabi vanished. His mind kept running in circles, panicked and disoriented.

'I'm no match for All For One. What's the point? Why even bother?'

He could end all of his suffering right now and go peacefully. He had a chance to control exactly how he died. It was so tempting to stab himself right now, while he had the chance. He stood in the center of the room, and couldn't bring himself to look his teachers in the eyes.

The temperature seemed to plummet as the sudden confirmation given by Inko began to sink in. The most dangerous villain in history was no longer dead and gone to them. He was alive and breathing fear down their necks.

The only person he could stomach looking at was All Might of all people. He was the only one who could truly scope how utterly doomed they were. He was the only one who knew that this was a losing battle. When he found All Might's electric blue eyes he noticed that those eyes were watching him. All Might's face was flushed of color, paperwhite. He looked like a ghost almost, and his face was grim, with his lips pulled into a frown. His eyes were dark with an emotion Izuku was painfully familiar with. Fear. Fear that Izuku was losing himself to.

All Might was just as afraid as Izuku was, and he found himself drawn to it. He couldn't bear to see All Might in all of his glory, looking gaunt and ghostly with horror. He hesitated slightly, debating if he should even bother. It was futile for them to try and defeat a man like that. It was impossible. Inconceivable. It was impossible. They would all die—

"Fear is a demon of its own, my boy. Don't let it control you and debilitate you. You're the consort of demons. They will bend to your will. You aren't chained down by fear, young Midoriya,"

Izuku faltered, confused as to why he would ever even think of remembering something All For One told him at a time like this. But All For One was right. Fear was Izuku's constant companion, and he didn't want All Might to let it be his.

The only problem was that he didn't know how to comfort the man. He was so out of his orbit, All Might was still like a legend in his mind. Someone he never hoped to actually meet, and never expected to interact with. He was untouchable, but seeing him look like this broke his already fragile heart. All Might held his head in his hands, finally breaking eye contact with him.

Detective Tsukauchi looked lost, as he looked towards All Might. Izuku felt that. The urge to leave him be was strong, but his heart twisted in his chest. He wanted to tell All Might that it would be okay and that he was the strongest hero in history. He wanted to lie and tell him everything he needed to hear. But he wasn't good at lying when he knew the truth. And he couldn't even hold a conversation with anyone, even if he wanted to.

But he'd seen mothers comforting children before, even if it was rarely. Maybe a simple gesture of affection would help him? He didn't know, but he made his way over to All Might nonetheless. The room was thick with tension, but Izuku ignored it entirely. He was scared and considering the coward's way out of things, but he didn't want All Might to be consumed like he was.

He wanted to give him the reassurance he so desperately needed. All Might didn't move or acknowledge his presence whatsoever as he stopped in front of him. He was drowning in fear. Izuku could see it in his shaking shoulders and bowed head. A position he often found himself whenever he thought of All For One. He ruffled All Might's hair without warning.

He pulled his hand away and smiled softly at the hero he had idolized almost the entirety of his life when All Might finally looked up.

[Fear is a demon of its own. You aren't chained down by fear All Might, no matter how much you think you are. There's still hope.]

All Might stared at him. It was deathly quiet, as everyone stared at him in awe or disbelief — he couldn't tell which. For a moment Izuku thought he did something wrong, and Aizawa wouldn't translate for him. But then he saw All Might's face break out into a huge smile. Izuku didn't get any warning as he was suddenly swept off his feet and crushed into a tight hug. All of the tension was sucked out of the room, and he was immensely grateful.

"You're very right, Young Midoriya!" All Might exclaimed. "He hasn't made a move yet, so we've still got time to prepare! There's still hope!"

The world tilted again as All Might set him down. "Thank you," He said with a relieved sigh, "I needed that,"

Izuku covered his face with two hands, trembling. His face was already stained with tears, and tremors wracked his body. He had haphazardly wrapped himself up in his comforter.

'It's dark, it's dark.'

His uneven breathing was the only sound, save for his occasional whimper.

Hot tears trailed down his cheeks, and his shaking hands went to cover his mouth and stop the sobs that would no doubt begin. His throat tightened, and his vision blurred.

You're Quirkless.

He sucked in the first hiccup, trying to as quiet as possible.

You can never be a hero.

His lower lip trembled, and he didn't hear his bedroom door open.

Stain was stupid to think you'd ever amount to anything. You should just become a villain. These heroes don't care about you.

You have to train much harder, my boy, if you hope to please me.

Spy on Yuuei.

His shoulders shook, and the tears didn't relent. They didn't stop, and he didn't want them to. He clenched his jaw to keep his sobs as silent as possible. His throat ached with the effort of keeping them at bay.

He choked on his fear. Drowned in it. Got consumed by it. His heart pounded in his chest, he could hear it. His hands throbbed in time with his heart, and he gripped the comforter around him. It was difficult to breath past the sobs.

Then like the flip of a switch, his sobs stopped. He froze. The door was open, and a hand was reaching for him. When did Hisashi get down here? He would've heard his footsteps. Out of a moment of desperation he grabbed the reaching wrist and twisted.

'Stay away from me!' His mind screamed, as he flinched back. His back slammed against the backboard of his bed. Then it all clicked. He blinked, and suddenly he was somewhere else entirely. And it wasn't Hisashi's wrist he was twisting.

It was Hizashi's, and the man was staring at him with wide eyes. Izuku released him instantly, his fear exploding in his chest with renewed vigor. He froze up completely, utterly horrified.

'I just hurt Hizashi.'

"I told you to leave," Dabi snapped, and Izuku wasn't breathing at all. He was so dead. He was going to die. They were going to kill him. "Leave, get out,"

'He's going to hit me. He's going to hit me, he's going to hit me.'

Hizashi opened his mouth to say something, but Dabi growled. "Get the hell out!"

After a moment of hesitation, Hizashi turned around and walked out, sparing Izuku a glance that Izuku ignored entirely.

'What the hell? Why wasn't Hizashi yelling at me? Or threatening me?' He didn't understand.

It scared him more than it comforted him. Dabi turned to him, his eyes softer than usual. "Are you okay?"

He shook his head, covering his face. He wouldn't be able to sleep tonight. Not after that.

'He just grabbed me, and I freaked out. I hurt him. I hurt him.'

Kacchan's hand squeezed his own, and he glanced at his best friend. "Are you okay?"

He nodded.

"You look really worried about something,"

Izuku shook his head and threaded his fingers with Kacchan's. "Alright, don't tell me then,"

"Don't tell you what?" Aizawa asked, rubbing at his eyes as he walked to his classroom with Present Mic in tow.

“Nothing,” Kacchan grumbled angrily.

“Are you ready for more practice, Midoriya?” Aizawa asked as he opened the door. Izuku nodded and Kacchan followed them inside.

All four of them pushed together two desks and pulled up a chair. The lesson began and twenty minutes passed easily. As Present Mic left the classroom he pulled Izuku outside with him for a moment. “Midoriya, about yesterday...”

[I can explain—]

“It’s okay,” Present Mic told him. “I just want to know how you’re associated with him,”

[I can’t.]

“It’s safe for you here, Midoriya,”

[It’s not.]

“If he’s forcing you into this, then all you have to do is nod,”

Maybe it was the fear in his eyes. Or maybe it was because he really did nod, but Present Mic gave him a pat on the head and whispered as he walked away, “I’ll save you, kiddo,”

‘I shouldn’t have come home.’

There were villains sitting on the couch.

They were in his kitchen, sitting on the floor, leaning against walls. In the center of it all was All For One. Dread filled all of him as he spotted his parents in the throng, talking animatedly with another villain.

He had a bad feeling about this. All For One smiled widely as Izuku entered, “Finally! Now we can start planning!”

‘Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.’

Izuku stopped himself from wondering exactly what he had just got himself dragged into. This was the dark and dangerous road Chizome-san had unwittingly led him down.

‘This isn’t what Chizome-san wanted for me.’

And he was trapped, with villains creeping in on all sides. No chance of escape. But maybe he could dig himself out, with the information he was being given. This was his one way ticket to salvation. He hoped.

All For One stood, and took Izuku by the shoulders. "My boy, you're in charge of taking notes. Get your journal, and when this meeting is over with, get me a full report on everything. Who should be positioned where, which student's Quirks to avoid entirely, and which students are easier targets. This plan cannot fail. I expect at least five pages from you,"

Izuku nodded. He could tell by the way All For One was looking at him that this was a test.

‘He’s testing me. He wants to see what I’ll do. He wants to know if I’ll leak this information. This is my chance.’

The man wanted to know if Izuku would run to the police with this information. This was risky, but he was willing to take this risk for his freedom. He sat himself down on the floor in the corner and wrote down everything. He committed everyone's faces to memory, half-listening to All For One and Shigaraki plan.

There would be a Nomu, the brainless monstrosities that All For One tortured Izuku with. They would split up the class, putting them where their Quirks worked the worst. They'd place the villains where their Quirks would shine.

Izuku quickly deduced that a lot of these villains were weak and easily taken down. He shifted his focus to the most dangerous of the bunch. He had a lot of people come up to him and tell him their Quirk.

Pretty soon he had a long list of names and Quirks to match them. A list he would somehow get to a teacher.

"The Nomu will kill All Might. That's our goal with our attack on the U.S.J.," All For One told everyone. "It's also to retrieve our spy, Midoriya Izuku. He's gathered plenty of information and his skills are needed elsewhere. Kidnapping a Yuuei student would destroy Yuuei's reputation forever, especially if they can't retrieve their lost student,"

‘This is my only chance. I need to get this information to Yuuei. I need to make sure they’re prepared. I need to make sure no one gets hurt. This plan needs to fail.’

"Then society will lose faith in their so-called heroes!" Shigaraki laughed, scratching at his neck.

He frowned, as he finished up his notes and began compiling a report. Who should he give this information to? Who would believe him? How could he avoid being thrown in jail?

His mind kept going back to a man with messy black hair and tired eyes. He could hide notes for the man to find. Then at least his teacher would know and do something about it. Hopefully.

But Izuku knew how reliable heroes could be, and he knew how they acted. With his luck, Aizawa-sensei wouldn't understand in time, or he would think it was a joke. No matter what he had to try, and rely on a hero he barely knew.

He swallowed his anxiety and silently continued his report, placing Shigaraki with the Nomu, and a few villains with water Quirks in the water zone. He also kept another page of notes, detailing the plan. He would keep this for himself, to make sure he could stop the attack before it escalated. Shigaraki, the Nomu, and Kurogiri would be the first to leave the portal.

Izuku would have to work quickly to stop this plan in its tracks. He would have to get rid of Kurogiri and kill the Nomu with Dabi's fire. Then Shigaraki would be the only dangerous villain left.

They would be safe, and hopefully, Izuku would be able to save himself.

Somehow he doubted it. Somehow he had a gut feeling that this plan of his would crumble. With a sense of impending doom, he knew deep, deep down that he would die for his recklessness. And he was okay with it if his classmates survived.

Nobody saved fallen angels.

Nobody saved villains.

'Nobody will save me. I have to do it myself or die trying.'

"It's okay. Be a hero, son. Become the next symbol of peace, and show the world what you're made of. It's okay,"

Find a way to save yourself.

And he'd found it.

'I need to save Iida. I need to save everyone. This is my fault.'

Izuku ran a shaking hand through his hair. They were on the bus going toward the U.S.J.

"Do you know what we'll be doing today? I'm excited!"

"Does it really matter? I heard Thirteen is teaching us!" Uraraka exclaimed, "They're like—my favorite superhero ever!"

'They're going to die. They're all going to die. I didn't want this to happen.'

“Keep being a good boy, and don’t tell your stupid hero friends about all of our plans okay?”

‘It’s too late for that.’

“Can I look at your hands?”

[Do I have a choice?]

“Yes,”

[Then no.]

“Why not?”

[Because.]

”I won’t judge you,”

[I don’t care.]

“I’ve already seen them, remember? What does it matter if I look at them again?”

[Ok fine.]

Izuku held out his hands, with his palms facing up. After a moment of hesitation Aizawa took held his hands and studied the scars. A summoning circle carved into each palm. His fingers were slightly crooked and lined with scars. All the way up to his elbows long lacerations littered his arm.

“Did you do that to yourself?”

Izuku yanked his hands away in disgust. He gave Aizawa-sensei a glare.

“Then who did? You can tell me,”

Izuku shook his head. [No I can’t.]

“Why not?”

[I just can’t.]

“Do you want to draw? Do you want to paint?”

Izuku pointed at the paintbrushes, and Present Mic set him up with an empty canvas and paints.

His mind zeroed in on the empty canvas before him, and he poured his fear into it.

He took a step back, what felt like hours later — and maybe it was — and saw what he had created. All For One's face leered at him from the painting, with a smile stretching the shiny scarred skin on his face.

All For One.

His pain, his sorrow, his fear. He blinked away the tears in his eyes and bumped into Present Mic who had been watching him.

"Hey, are you okay—?" And then those bright expressive eyes found Izuku's painting. And they darkened. "—How did you—? Do you know him? Do you know who you just painted?"

Izuku nodded fearfully. [Burn it. Take it away from me.]

"Midoriya—"

Izuku turned around, paint drying on his hands. "Midoriya don't run—!"

And then he ran. And he didn't stop until his feet ached and he was far, far away from Yuuei.

The look in Present Mic's eyes made fear curl up in his gut and fester. He didn't hesitate as he swung the door to his mother's house open. He deserved the inevitable screams and curses. He deserved any blows that came his away and broke him.

He was stupid. He was so stupid, drawing All For One in front of someone. A pro hero no less.

Shouta wanted to make it stop. He wanted to slap Nedzu right out of his chair, and drag his son — his *son* — out of here and give him a crushing hug. He wanted this to be over. Every time the world crushed him, he got back up. He clawed tooth and nail to survive. And he was still fighting. He never stopped fighting. Never stopped trying to become a hero.

And Shouta didn't feel like he was doing a very good job of helping him down that path. Right now, it felt like he was shoving Izuku backward, erasing all of the progress they'd made. It was like watching them go back to square one, where Izuku hid things and suffered on his own.

He knew he should've told Nedzu that this was a horrible idea. He was going to have to make it up to Izuku somehow, for forcing him into this. He should've known. He should've fucking known.

Toshinori was never good with things like this. He was never good at watching his students suffer like this, one by one. Living their trauma and fears like this. It was especially hard for him to watch during Young Midoriya's memories. It was like a knife was being plunged in his chest, and every time Young Midoriya got hurt it went in deeper and deeper. His heart ached, and he really, *really* wanted to pound Nedzu in the dirt right now. He wanted to—

But Midoriya had agreed to this, for the most part. It was this or risking getting caught by All for One. Toshinori didn't blame the kid for choosing this over what All for One would probably do to him.

But that didn't condone Nedzu's actions. God, he was the Number One Hero. He could've stopped this entire fiasco on his own. Nedzu would've listened to him. (Probably.)

Katsuki wanted to leave. He wanted to get out of this room, where Izuku never stopped screaming. But he stayed. He stayed because Izuku needed him. And he needed to learn the truth about everything. He needed to learn exactly what Izuku had been hiding all these years, and once these memories stopped, he needed to be at Izuku's side. He couldn't imagine how it felt to relive all of these horrifying memories.

An hour of nothing but his suffering displayed on the wall like a movie.

Most of all Katsuki wanted to fucking wring Nedzu's neck. He glared at the rat more times than he could count. He was definitely going to file a complaint about this shit. Maybe he should convince Izuku to sue.

That would be interesting.

But first, he needed to suffer through these memories.

Nedzu regretted this. He didn't like the way all of the teachers and students around him seemed to be glaring at him. Maybe this had been a mistake.

Maybe he should've had Midoriya's memories played in private. He felt bad for the boy, but what was done had been done. There was nothing he could do to stop it now that it had begun. Yuki's Quirk just didn't work that way.

He didn't make mistakes.

But this time, he was willing to admit that, this *entire* plan was a huge mistake.

Chapter End Notes

Here's the discord server link!

Chapter 37

Chapter Notes

Just a note because people seemed confused.

Shouto is not being happy about Izuku's suffering. The moment Touya showed up on the screen he practically disassociated.

But also:
Here's the discord server link!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku's sword was positioned to slice the metal in half. His deep voice met Izuku's ears, and he hesitated. "Stain the roses red, Izuku. Remember those who helped you,"

Kurogiri had helped him. He was a friend of Stain's.

' That doesn't matter. We're enemies as long as you're with All for One.'

"What's that?"

He could see the fear in those eyes, and he felt a pang of guilt. They'd gotten information on all of his classmates directly from him. If anyone got hurt or worse, killed it would be his fault. Aizawa-sensei turned around. Izuku could see from where he was standing that Aizawa looked just as worried as Iida, and Izuku felt his hand go for his sword.

Then the world went dark for a moment.

The Prototype-Nomu stood nearby, drool dripping from its fangs. It ripped him apart. It threw him around like he weighed nothing—

"Midoriya Izuku, spy for the League of Villains! Did you hear that Eraserhead!? He's our spy!"

‘I didn’t want to.’

"You fucking traitor!"

"Prototype-Nomu you can play with your new toy now," Hisashi said, "A game of cat and mouse,"

"You better start running!" Inko shouted from her spot on a rooftop.

He dodged those deadly talons again, but they still grazed him. Pain hit him sharply and throbbing. Blood seeped through the gash of his shirt, but shock started to set in and he couldn't feel it.

He scrambled to his feet.

'This monster wasn't part of the plan. Where do I go? What do I do? I can't bring this thing to anyone else.'

His feet pounded against the pavement, and it felt as if there was a fire in his lungs. Everything burned.

He couldn't think straight. He needed a plan. He tripped, and the monster ripped him to shreds. He felt something snap. Blood trickled down his forehead.

"Keep playing with your food Prototype-Nomu,"

It threw him with all of it's strength. He slammed into a building at a blinding speed and Izuku spat blood onto the pavement.

The world around him was blurry and swirling. Despite that he crawled to his feet.

He summoned his fire again and sent a wave of it toward the overpowered Nomu but it did nothing. He spat out a mouthful of blood and reached for the cross around his neck.

'Don't lose control. I just need to kill it.'

The Nomu grabbed him by the ankle and dragged him. Those huge claws cut through his skin like butter. Izuku blasted hellfire right in the thing's back, as he ripped off his Suppressant.

The buildings shook. The ground groaned. The Nomu roared in excitement, and let go of Izuku for only a moment. That single moment was all he needed as the full power of his Quirk greeted him. Demons rose from the ground, and without a thought, he absorbed them completely.

More and more of them ran to his aid as he sent a shock-wave of his demon-fueled hellfire. With their energy in his body, he was stronger. The special Nomu stumbled, and the buildings around them tilted uneasily.

"Prototype-Nomu, time to show him your Quirk!"

Izuku got to his feet, absorbing the demons that reached him. The power was hot in his veins as he glared at the Prototype-Nomu, but the monster stood still. He waited anxiously, and then it opened its massive mouth and screamed again louder than ever.

The U.S.J. building itself began to tremble and quake and a stream of white light exploded from the Nomu's mouth.

Izuku thanked his lucky stars that he managed to dodge it entirely. Everything that had been in the path of that beam had been completely vaporized. Half of the City zone, in one breath.

His body started to shake, and Izuku gaped in horror. He felt his knees go weak, and his heart began to explode in his chest with each beat. A Quirk like that— That monster had such a dangerous Quirk.

'I can't beat that.'

It screamed again, and Izuku rolled out of the way as another beam shot out. He scrambled to his feet and ran as he realized that the Prototype-Nomu's Quirk was still activated, and following him. Trying to vaporize him into oblivion.

He couldn't hear anything past the utter destruction that things Quirk was causing. He wasn't going to be fast enough. He could feel the heat of the beam on his heels. He could feel it burning his cloak completely. He kept running, faster and faster, undoing the clasp to cloak as he went.

Desperate, he shot fire at the Nomu as he ran in a circle around it. His body ached and burned. He couldn't keep this up for long.

The city around him was completely vaporized. Scratch that, almost half of the U.S.J. was vaporized.

'I have to kill it. I have to kill it or it'll attack my classmates.'

In frustration, the Nomu stopped his Quirk to scream and tear at its face. Izuku fell to his knees and gasped in lung-fulls of air. "Prototype-Nomu, kill him," Hisashi breathed, from his spot in front of the monstrosity.

With his Quirk all but forgotten, the Nomu charged at him. This time, Izuku didn't have the strength to dodge. His body and soul were tired. Even if he wanted to, he couldn't move. All the pain and exhaustion seemed to be catching up with him.

The thing tore him apart, and Izuku almost didn't care. As long as it killed him and no one else.

He could feel his ankle shatter, as the Nomu grabbed him and slammed him back into the ground. Again and again. His face burned against the asphalt, and the Prototype-Nomu ripped at his arm.

He heard himself scream. Low, guttural and tortured as his arm twisted. It was still playing with him, making his death slow and horrible.

Its claws ripped at his back, and suddenly it had its huge paw around Izuku's neck. His legs kicked uselessly as he was raised into the air. His lungs squeezed harshly in his chest as the air was cut off. It's grip tightened around Izuku's throat, and he was surprised his neck didn't just snap.

His vision darkened, and he ripped uselessly at the claws around his throat. He choked uselessly and barely heard the sound of Shigaraki shouting orders. "Take him! Sensei wants him back alive, that's our only objective since All Might refused to show up! He has to pay for his treason,"

'No. I don't want to go back.'

"Those stupid Roses ruined the whole operation! Let's go before the fucking heroes arrive!"

'The Roses? What the fuck is going on?'

The Nomu lessened its harsh grip, and Izuku sucked in a breath of much-needed air. He glanced down at Shigaraki to see that his hand was bleeding. Kurogiri put up a portal. They weren't paying too much attention to Izuku. He absorbed the demons that rushed for him. The power made his body shudder. So much power. Enough to kill that special Nomu. He spotted a particularly large one, the size of a building. That demon smiled at him and reached out.

"...I save...you..?"

Izuku nodded and absorbed that one too, and he felt sick. It was too much for him to handle. His body nearly seized up completely.

No one was watching as his fire greeted him again.

But the Prototype-Nomu was. It happened fast. One second he was in the air, and the next there was a talon in protruding from his face and he was on the ground. His scream cut

through the air, and Shigaraki whipped around to look at him. Izuku pulled out the claw — it wasn't in too deep, but it grazed his eye — and screamed again.

He clutched his face and got up on his shaking feet. Blood squirted from his face in between his fingers as he covered his eye. The Nomu came for him, but Izuku condensed all of his stored up energy and poured it into one attack.

He could see Shigaraki running for him. But he'd be too late.

His fire swirled and began to freeze even more than usual. It writhed with the power of the demon he'd absorbed, and Izuku shot it out in an explosion. His hellfire ripped through the Prototype-Nomu. Bone crunched and broke.

WHOOMP.

There was silence as the Nomu tilted, and fell. The ground shuddered, and Izuku vomited.

Shigaraki stomped over, seething. He grabbed a handful of Izuku's hair and dragged his over to the purple portal. Villains poured into the portal, and Izuku thrashed, digging his nails into Shigaraki's bleeding hand.

"Inko fucking help me with this brat!" Shigaraki snapped, and Izuku groaned as Inko delivered a quick kick to his abdomen. Shigaraki then grabbed his broken arm and twisted it behind his back.

Pain, agony, horror, terror. It hit him like a tidal wave, and he threw his head back and felt the satisfying crack of Shigaraki's nose. Shigaraki let go of him and spit out a string of curses. Izuku collapsed, and Inko lunged for him.

He blasted his hellfire in her face. It was weak, but it still sent her falling on her ass nonetheless. He almost laughed.

A pair of villains converged on him and pulled him to his feet. One of them moved to put a hand over his mouth, and he took his chance as they dragged him closer and closer to the portal. Most of the villains had already entered. All that was left were Kurogiri, Shigaraki, Inko and the two villains dragging him.

He bit the hand coming to cover his mouth. He tasted the metallic iron of blood. The villain cursed and dropped him. Izuku shot a stream of fire at the other one, blinking back the urge to pass out. His back throbbed. Blood still poured from his eye, and he could barely see.

His arm was a broken mess, twisted and bleeding. Every inch of his exploded in agony with each movement but he had to keep fighting. But he was so tired.

Shigaraki reached for his face, with all five fingers. Izuku tried to move, he really did. His ankle throbbed with pain, and he ended up staying put. Then the shots rang out. Blood splattered on Izuku's face. With wide eyes, Izuku stared at the bullet wound in Shigaraki's hand. Another round of shots rang in his ears, and he saw his mother go down. He saw Kurogiri grab Shigaraki and escape.

He tensed as the pro-heroes approached the scene. All Might was there, not smiling in the slightest. Izuku vomited again, still clutching at his eye. Aizawa, bloody and tired but otherwise okay, rushed over. Izuku locked eyes with Dabi and whimpered.

Dabi got him first, his blue fire flaring angrily as he positioned himself in front of him. Izuku felt a pang of gratitude. "Leave him alone, you assholes!" He shouted. With that shout, some demons crawled out of the ground. Izuku heard a gasp.

One of them with a smile waved at All Might. Another wandered over to grab Izuku's Quirk suppressor, and Izuku sighed in immense relief as it took the liberty of putting it back on for him. The demons vanished from the Pro heroes' view. There was another round of surprised gasps, and no one came near him.

Aizawa glared at Dabi. "He needs medical attention, now," He told Dabi, "I don't think you understand,"

Izuku blinked back the fog in his mind as Dabi stepped aside with a terrified look. He was so tired. He didn't even remember passing out.

“The power of Christ compels you, demon!”

Izuku threw himself against the bars of his cell, screaming. It was deeper than usual, more like a roar. More out of anger than out of pain.

There was a noose in his hands. It was heavy in his hands, and Izuku hesitated. No one was watching him. No one would even come down here into his room. It would be all too easy to tie the rope to the broken fan on the ceiling and hang himself.

He blinked past the sudden hot tears streaking down his face. He gripped the noose tightly and discarded it on the floor. He wasn’t strong enough to kill himself.

Not like this.

Izuku cursed himself for allowing Aizawa-sensei to take his sword. The stairs creaked with the weight of Hisashi, and Izuku frantically turned off his flashlight despite the fear the drowned him. The darkness swallowed him, but he pushed away the terror that threatened to doom him. Again the soft, sing-song voice reached his ears.

"Izuku..."

‘No...no way.’

"Where are you, Izuku?" Hisashi asked, and Izuku tried his damndest to move silently. "You can't run from me, or All For One. I don't know what went through your head when you decided you'd betray us. We treated you really well, and this is how you repay us?"

Fear coated his tongue like poison. He scrambled to grab a weapon. The wave of panic washing over him made it difficult to keep his breathing in check.

‘The knife. The knife. The knife.’

He grabbed it from its place under his bed. As an afterthought, he grabbed the gun in his dresser.

‘Today, I won’t be pointing this gun at myself.’

‘I don't want to be stuck here. I don't want to go inside. I hate the dark. I hate the dark—’

Through the darkness, he listened. He’d put his gun in his back pocket for now, until he truly needed it. His grip on his knife tightened.

Hisashi was lumbering through the dark. He wasn’t quiet or subtle in the slightest, and Izuku used it to his advantage. His knife struck true. They fought back and forth, until Hisashi pinned Izuku down.

Pain exploded every time they touched. Izuku had the gun tight in his grip and fired. It startled Hisashi, but that wasn’t Izuku’s goal.

‘They had to have heard that.’

Hisashi wrapped his hand around the gun, but Izuku’s grip was iron-tight. He’d fire it again if Aizawa didn’t hear it.

But Hisashi was strong and ripped it from his hands. “Get up,”

His father got off of him, pointing the gun at him. “Go into the portal,”

"Go!" Hisashi yelled loudly. "Fucking hurry it up!"

He barely flinched when Hisashi shouted angrily, and Izuku felt the cool metal of the gun pressed up to his forehead. "Go in the fucking portal, damn it!"

When Izuku didn't move, Hisashi grabbed him and started to drag him. The pain burned him as Hisashi's hand came in contact with him, and he pulled him closer and closer to the portal. Izuku pulled against him, and Hisashi cursed.

No. He wouldn't go. Not when he was so close to freedom that he could feel it in his soul. No fucking way. He was too close to let Hisashi drag him back.

'I'm too close to freedom to let him drag me back.'

The door blew open. Blue fire erupted, and Izuku had never been happier to see those flames in his life. Hisashi didn't miss a beat. He pulled Izuku to a sitting position and put Izuku's knife to his throat. Izuku froze, eyes wide. The gun had been completely forgotten.

Hisashi's other hand rested tightly on Izuku's shoulder. Pain throbbed in time with his heartbeat as Dabi, Aizawa and All Might ran down the stairs, only to stop. All Might didn't swoop in with his usual spiel, and he looked livid.

Dabi looked absolutely pissed, and Aizawa looked even angrier than the both of them. "None of you move," Hisashi spat, and Izuku felt the warm trickle of blood dripping down his neck. "Or he dies,"

He opened his mouth to speak. "Now, don't do anything rash..." He began, his eyes meeting Izuku's wide terrified ones. "He's just a boy—"

"Shut the fuck up! Just a boy my ass!" Hisashi shouted, and Izuku's breath caught in his throat when Hisashi yanked his head back and sliced his face just below his eye. Pain exploded from where Hisashi's hand touched his forehead. "Stop talking,"

Blood dripped down Izuku's face, as Hisashi placed that knife at his neck again, pressing ever so slightly. His hands twitched at his sides, and he watched as All Might clenched his jaw.

Hisashi was distracted. All Might was the only foe to him, so maybe he wouldn't be expecting Izuku to strike. His hand was free. Hisashi didn't expect Izuku to summon his hellflame.

Izuku forced himself to be as slow and unassuming as possible as he positioned his hands. The flames licked his hands, and he waited. "He's coming back with me. He has plans for him,"

Fear made his breathing ragged. He could do this. He could do this. He closed his eyes for a moment. "Who is he?" All Might asked.

"Don't you already know, All Might?" Hisashi said. Izuku could hear the smile in his voice. "He's your enemy. He's a mastermind, you know his name,"

All Might was silent. Aizawa took a quick step forward, his scarf coming to life. Hisashi hissed at him.

"Don't fucking move!" Hisashi shouted. "I won't hesitate to kill him!"

"If you need him, why would you kill him?" Dabi asked, his flames dancing the dark.

"No one ever truly dies. Not when you know All For One," Hisashi smiled. "He has a reanimation Quirk. We could turn Izuku into a Nomu, and he could be an immensely useful tool with that Quirk,"

Izuku went pale, and he could hear his breathing get ragged and shallow. All for One could revive him? Did that mean, all this time, that any attempt to end his own life would've been

useless? All for One could've just revived him, and forced him to continue with his training?

All this time, he'd never had any control. This whole time, Izuku couldn't have escaped. Even if he died.

Chapter End Notes

Please enjoy! The second chapter of the week is gonna be posted tomorrow!!! :D

Chapter 38

Chapter Notes

Art by Luna_Sage:



its fucking beautiful and i almost cried. Its art of Izuku's painting of all for one! Here's the link to their *Tumblr!*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dabi scowled, and Hisashi tightened his grip on the knife. His other hand went back to his shoulder, and the pain was renewed, stronger than ever. His body throbbed, and Izuku felt himself stiffen. He'd fought Hisashi, and he was fatigued. He was too tired and terrified to fight. Fear flashed in Dabi's eyes, and Izuku could see him shaking. "Erase his Quirk, Eraserhead,"

Aizawa was quick to comply, and red flashed as Aizawa's hair rose. The pain stopped, and Izuku felt himself relax just slightly. "I've always hated that fucking demon of yours, Izuku," His words were hissed angrily. "I hate your Quirk, and Stain was stupid to think you could ever be a hero. Such a stupid dream to have. You should've become a villain just like I told you. These heroes don't want to help *you. They don't* like you. *You're nothing but a* villain *in their eyes, why not prove them right?"*

Izuku fought the urge to agree. After all, he'd been thinking the same things in the back of his mind.

‘What if all of this was a lie? What if they didn't care at all? What if this was all a game to them, and I don’t belong anywhere?’

"Don't listen to him," Aizawa replied, his eyes hard as stone and angry.

"Come with me, Izuku," Hisashi insisted.

"Become a hero."

"Stain was stupid to think you could ever be a hero."

He wasn’t sure which one was the truth anymore.

"We all want to save you, I promise. So please cooperate with anything Nedzu wants you to do,"

He woke up screaming. It was too bright in the room wherever he was. His eyes burned, and his body ached dully. What hit him the most was the wave of terror that hit him. In his mind, he was still getting ripped apart by the Prototype-Nomu. His bones were cracking. His skin was being torn.

So he screamed.

He thrashed, and his heart monitor screeched along with him. He covered his face with shaking hands and screamed. His body shuddered, and voices reached his ears, concerned and frantic.

"Midoriya—"

My boy.

"Young Midoriya—"

Kill him. Kill him— you're a villain.

You're no hero.

Izuku trudged up the stairs, his shoulders heavy with stress already. Quickly he double-checked that his sword was strapped to his hip. He quietly crept through the living room, almost to the door when his mother snapped at him. “Where are you going?”

Izuku paled as he turned around. His mother’s cold voice but through his hoodie like he wasn’t even wearing it. His hands trembled, more than usual. He wrung them together and pointed to his blazer. Inko rolled her eyes at him. “Come here,” she snapped.

Izuku was quick to comply. Pain laced through his jaw and cheekbone. He recoiled as her hand struck him again, and again. He held his hands up in front of his face to block her blows, but she didn't seem to care. She slammed her clenched fists into his arms, and his wrists throbbed with pain. She would no doubt leave purple bruises along his arms, and on his face.

How could he explain something like that away? He fell? His mom had an episode of lunacy and hit the shit out of him? — Oh, wait. That was the truth.

He was pretty sure he didn't have the intelligence to outwit Aizawa-sensei. Nor the balls, if he was being honest. She grabbed him by his hoodie and shook him.

"Don't give me that shitty excuse. You're running off to betray all of us, and tell the teachers at Yuuei that you're a spy, aren't you?!"

Izuku shook his head rapidly. No. He wasn't stupid. If he was going to do that he'd need a plan. He'd need an army behind him.

Betrayed them was impossible, and not on his list of top priorities. He just needed to keep Kacchan safe.

He didn't have time to think for himself. "Don't lie to me!" She screamed shrilly.

Izuku hissed through his teeth as his mother grabbed a fistful of his green hair. "I knew I should've killed you the second you were born,"

He nodded slightly, ignoring the flare of sadness ripping at him. She let go of him, but not before cracking her fist across his cheek again. His mouth stung as he accidentally bit his tongue.

She turned away from him, muttering nonsense and gibberish. He didn't stay to decipher her words. He had to leave if he wanted to be there twenty minutes early. His face throbbed as he

left his house. His phone buzzed in his pocket, and he glanced at the time. He was late for class. On the second day.

And he had completely bailed on going to school twenty minutes early. Now he looked suspicious.

As he practically ran to school he cursed his mother and her moments of complete insanity. Anxiety pooled in his stomach as he raced down the sidewalks, and ran nearly the whole way there. He didn't stop until he was at the door of his classroom, silently catching his breath. He pushed his anxiety away as he pulled open the door.

Aizawa merely gave him a glance as he walked in, muttering. "It's only the second day of school and you're already late?"

Izuku didn't want to be a smart ass, but he couldn't resist. He gave Aizawa-sensei a nod.

"Be late to my class again and you'll be expelled," Aizawa told him, "And didn't I go over the dress code yesterday? No hoodies or hats. This is your only warning, don't do it next time."

It was surprisingly easy to get a hold of a gun. With that weapon in his hands he was eerily calm. The gun was a promise. A promise that if it got too hard he'd get to end it.

He didn't have to wait for All for One to murder him. It had been a rather rough training session with him, and Izuku wasn't sure if he could do this anymore. He was so weak hearted. He didn't want to live anymore.

‘I don’t want to fight everyday just to breathe. I don’t want to claw my way to tomorrow only to suffer even more. I don’t want to do it anymore.’

It wasn’t hard to load the gun with ammo, and point it at himself. The cold metal against his forehead calmed him slightly. He was standing in Chizome’s bathroom, but he’d gone to sleep a while ago.

He felt bad for him. He’d be the one to find his body. He’d probably wake up to the sound of the gunshot that killed him.

It’d be fine. Chizome-san would get over it.

There was a soft click as he turned off the safety on the weapon. Then, just as he was about to fire, the door flew open. His peace was shattered by Chizome, who didn’t even hesitate to take the gun from him. It was all too loud as Chizome started yelling.

“What do you think you’re doing?!” Chizome yelled, the gun had disappeared somewhere, and Chizome had grabbed him by the shoulders and shook him.

His eyes were wide with fear and relief. “Is it my fault? I know I haven’t been protecting you as I should…”

Chizome pulled Izuku to his chest. The embrace was tight and nearly restricting. “I promise I’ll protect you even more. Just promise me you won’t ever stop fighting to be a hero,”

He never promised.

They were in a dark, dark room with a single tub in the middle. His hands had been bound, like his ankles.

Then she pushed his head into the icy depths, cruel and grinning as he twisted and flailed.

His terror flared, as all the air in his lungs slowly left. His mother's cruel hands held him down as air bubbles surfaced, and he fought for air. Even just a second.

His face went numb after just a few seconds. Then she yanked on his hair, and sweet, sweet oxygen filled his lungs.

Then his head was thrust underwater again. An eternity seemed to go by as his body screamed.

His heart pulled in his chest, and his lungs spasmed in an attempt to find air. He swallowed a mouthful of the freezing water, and tears filled his eyes as all his oxygen escaped him.

His body seized and fought. 'I need air. I need air. I can't breathe.'

'Make it stop. Kill me. Just kill me.'

Izuku's mind screamed, fought and begged for it to end.

‘When you think you can’t go on anymore look inside. Remember why it is you clench your fist. Your past, remember where you came from. Keeping your origin in mind will help push you past your limits. ’

His lungs went numb, as the freezing water went still around him. His arms and shoulders went limp and put all his energy into pushing his head up. She would tire eventually.

Her hands gripped his curly hair tightly, but he lifted his head out of the water slowly and gasped gratefully as air filled his lungs.

Another pair of hands pushed him back down. Izuku couldn’t feel the pain this time, as he felt the rope around his hands loosen. His deception had worked. They’d been too worried about him breathing to notice he was freeing himself.

With his hands free, his Quirk would save him. The building pressure in his chest wouldn’t last much longer, he promised himself.

He quickly placed his hands on the tub, and let his power explode outward in a blast of inky black power. The tub exploded, and Izuku fell forward with his parents collapsing nearby.

He gasped down air and went to untie his feet. With trembling fingers, he loosened his ankles and got to his feet.

He whirled on his parents, his trembling hands ready to release a wave of power. He walked around them as they crawled to their feet. He went straight to the door, but two cold strong hands wrapped around the side of his head. They burned against his cold skin, and pain shattered him. Panic broke him, both mingling and stripping him bare of all thought and function.

So much pain, and terror.

Tears welled up in his eyes, as his knees gave out. He realized that ear-piercing noise was his own screaming. His own agony and fear, colliding in one primal noise that filled the silence.

Coherent thought was impossible. Moving was not even an option. He could do nothing but scream, low and tortured, as those hands held him firmly.

He only knew pain and fear. He woke up the next day, head pounding, and strapped to a chair. Izuku was delirious for a moment before he stared wide-eyed at Inko holding a pair of scissors.

He tried to move, but his restraints were iron clamps, stained a brownish color that reminded him of blood.

On the wall next to her were weapons, and Izuku whimpered quietly. She ripped open his shirt and set the scissors down. Izuku's labored terrifies breathing filled the air as the lights flickered. Inko looked unperturbed by it, and Izuku could suppress the terror that flickered through him as the world went dark for less than a second.

Her hand wrapped around a dagger, and she admired it for a second. "Blindfold him and cover his mouth," Inko demanded.

From behind someone gagged him and wrapped a blindfold over his eyes.

Then he felt the cold metal against his stomach. Fear drowned him, and Inko pressed the tip of the blade into his muscled skin.

He has originally thought she was going to stab him, but then she began to carve him like a piece of meat. His skin burned, sharp and excruciating. The pain settled in his core, tearing at him and ripping him apart. He had no way of knowing what she was carving into his skin, but he screamed. It was muffled by the gag, but it burned his throat, the sound rough and loud.

Hot blood poured into his lap, and he didn't stop thrashing and howling in pain.

For a moment the knife slid away, before plunging itself back into his flesh.

Again and again. A scream followed by a scream, letter after letter.

Blood and pain.

After what felt like hours, Inko set the knife down with a clatter. Izuku's stomach exploded with agony with each breath. He didn't dare breathe too deeply, as he tried to catch his breath in the midst of the pain.

For a moment, Inko seemed to just revel in his pain. Then, quick and sharp pain radiated from his hand. Horrible pain, as his hands seemed to remember every second of pain he'd ever had.

His hand jerked but stayed put, as Inko ripped off the next nail. Izuku bit down on his scream, as his fingers throbbed. Sweat dripped down his forehead, and he felt dizzy. "My turn, Inko,"

Izuku recognized Hisashi's rough voice and balled up fists, as he tried to ignore his mounting pain. Hisashi took Inko's place, and the door shut behind her with a soft click. Overwhelming panic crashed into him, as Hisashi touched his face. "What should I do with you today?" He asked himself.

He thrashed, trying to escape. "Stop," Hisashi snapped, "Stop!"

Izuku refused, as he slammed his wrists against the iron restraints. They were freezing, but Izuku didn't care. He just needed to leave, and never come back. He wanted out. He wanted out!

Panicking, he thrashed again. He didn't care about being a spy. He didn't care about Yuuei. He just needed to get out. At this rate, he was okay with sawing himself apart to escape.

He couldn't do this anymore. An ugly sob escaped through his gag, and Hisashi's hand retracted. Another voice joined them. "I think that's enough, Hisashi. He needs stitches, and he's losing a lot of blood. I told you to keep him alive,"

"You have to be very quiet,"

The man turned on the light, and Izuku relaxed. Whoever this person was didn't matter to him, as he stared at the needle and surgical thread. "I'll be as quick as possible,"

Then he walked to the side of the bed and set down his tools. He glanced nervously at Izuku but then got to work. Izuku couldn't watch. Not as this stranger began the painstakingly long task of stitching him up with unpracticed hands.

His wound stung, but the man was true to his word. It was painful, but it was quicker than he expected it to be. Izuku took a moment to stare at the stranger with the purple swirling smoke. It engulfed his entire body, but the man spoke even though Izuku couldn't see a mouth.

"My name is Kurogiri, hopefully, we don't meet like this again Midoriya,"

Izuku would never forget the word carved into his stomach. One single word.

VILLAIN.

“Submit yourselves therefore to God.”

Izuku screamed, his body burning, his soul on fire with pain and agony. He dug his fingers into the soft skin of his face, and blood dripped from the cuts he’d created. He ran his hands down his face, coming to rest just above his collarbone.

Pain exploded like lights in his eyes, fire seemed to lick down his spine, and he vomited on the floor.

“Stop! Stop! What the fuck are you doing to him?!” Chizome screamed, but Izuku groaned and the ground shuddered. It was hot. It was so hot in here. His head hurt, his eyes were watering. His spine screamed at him.

“Resist the devil, and he will flee from you,”

He heard something tearing, felt his back burning and boiling with white hot pain that made him scream louder and louder.

“What’s happening to him All for One?! What the hell have you done?!” Chizome yelled.

“I’m praying,” All for One merely said, before more verses fell from his mouth like living poison.

Izuku could feel goosebumps blossoming on every inch of him. He couldn’t help but puke again. He took a few deep breaths, the world swirling when he tried to move.

The ground moved to meet him, and he laid his forehead on the cold concrete. Fire was burning in his veins.

“And he called to him his twelve disciples and gave them authority over unclean spirits, to cast them out, and to heal every disease and every affliction.”

Izuku didn’t hear much, retching in agony. His body was pulling itself apart, he felt.

There was so much pain.

“When he saw Jesus, he cried out and fell down before him and said with a loud voice, “What have you to do with me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? I beg you, do not torment me.””

“But if it is by the Spirit of God that I cast out demons, then the kingdom of God has come upon you.”

“Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons. You received without paying; give without pay.”

“But if it is by the finger of God that I cast out demons—”

Suddenly the pain stopped. Suddenly All for One shut the fuck up.



It took Izuku a moment to realize what had happened. It took him a moment to realize what All for One had done.

It took a moment for him to realize that the pain in his back had been from his wings trying to come out. It took him a moment to realize the pain his head was from his horns growing. He realized he'd been crying because his eyes had changed.

And it took him a while to realize he *was the one stopping All for One. He realized he'd grabbed his sword, closed the distance between them, and nearly sliced off All for One's head. Nearly, because Dr. Tsubasa, Inko, and Hisashi had stopped him.*

And he didn't even realize he *was the one speaking.*

The silence that followed was tense before All for One spoke. "Lock him up, we'll do it again,"

Izuku was in a cell with one single light. His chains wouldn't allow him to move at all. His head throbbed, and he looked at himself in the mirror.

They'd put a mirror in his room on purpose. So he could look at himself, and see exactly what he'd become. His wings — merely bones. They weren't bat wings, or feathered wings. Just bones. — were fanned out against the wall, and his horns were curled. His eyes had turned black and gold, and he didn't know how to turn back.

All for One had left to get a few things before doing another "experiment."

That had been ten minutes ago, and Izuku felt himself suck in a terrified breath as All for One walked back in. A bible was clutched in his hands, a cross, and a bottle of holy water had also made their way into his hands.

Izuku couldn't stop the shaking that wracked his body.

'No. Please not again. Please.'

"What is that, All for One?" Chizome asked.

"It's his Quirk suppressor,"

'Give it to me. Please.'

"That's a cross,"

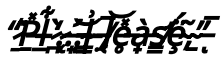
"I thought it was ironic,"

Izuku got to his feet, shaking. He was so tired. His skin was burning from the holy water. His body's transformation had him dizzy and drained. "This will change you back to your original form, Izuku,"

‘Give it to me. I’m begging you.’

He reached in between the bars of his cell for it. His body begged for it. He was so scared. So scared of what he’d become. Scared of how the demons surrounded him day and night now. Scared of himself. Scared of his Quirk.

‘I’m scared. Give it to me. Make it end. Turn me human.’



And when All for One put it around his neck it had worked. His estranged appearance melted away.

“There’s still the matter of your punishment,” All for One said, as he let Izuku out of the cage. “But we can do that later,”

“He has plans for you. He wants to make you his heir, and you don't have a choice in the matter! You will do exactly as he says, and I'll do anything to bring you back to him,"

‘His heir?’

All for One had wrapped his hands around Izuku's throat, and Izuku kicked uselessly in the air. "Do you understand All Might's power now? Mine is the exact opposite, my boy. I could give you my Quirk right now if I wanted to."

"I can only give my power to those who are unwilling to receive it. You could never be a hero if I gave you my power. Wouldn't that be sad?"

"One drop of blood is all it takes, my boy. You'd be the most powerful villain in all of history."

"Be my heir,"

Chapter End Notes

To clarify, the words Izuku said was: "Stop fucking praying,"

and

"Please" if you couldn't read it :))

But also:
Here's the discord server link!

Chapter 39

Chapter Notes

> This marks the end of his memory chapters! This chapter and the next ones are going to be about his classmates reactions (like everyone's been begging me to do. I gotchu fam)
>
> Here's the discord server link as usual!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dark clouds were swirling around his heart, rumbling with thunder and agony. His memories, like a grainy old movie played just behind his eyes. Burning, burning, burning. Terror branded his skin, until his skin was bubbling and swelling.

Every fear had become more than just smoke and mirrors hiding in the depths of Izuku's mind, where he locked them. They were more than just long-forgotten memories, repressed out of desperation. He relived each moment. Every hour, every minute, every second.

No stone was left unturned. Everything he had chosen to forget had been brought to light once more. He was drowning. The memories had ended, but he was still surrounded on all sides by darkness.

There was a violent ocean around him. An ocean of fear, of terror. And something was pulling him under, attempting to drown him with his own fear. Something was grabbing his ankles—

With a sharp tug, he was pulled within the icy depths of despair. He didn't even have time to scream, as his mother's high, cruel laugh rang through the air.

When the real world materialized around him, it didn't even register in his mind. Not how a demon across the room summoned itself and tried to turn on the light, and end this eternal

darkness.

Not as the lights exploded instantly, and his classmates screamed. Not as he threw himself to the floor, shoving away the hand that had been wrapped around his own.

There was nothing but his mother's laugh, Hisashi's pain and panic, and All for One's sinister, horrifying power. All his mistakes laid out before him, like shattered pieces of glass. His shaking hands reached to cover his ears, as fear devoured him.

She seemed to wrap around him like a snake, coiling around him and tightening. Trapping him. Constricting him.

Izuku's armor had crumpled like paper. His walls had been deconstructed. His fortress of solitude had been eradicated. There was nowhere to hide. No secrets to hide behind his armor.

No shield to save him from this cruel world. His life had been laid bare for all of them to see. Every thought. Every move. Every mistake, and death that had been *his* fault. His mountain of sins were brought to light.

Tears blurred his vision, but he still saw a man approaching him. But it wasn't one of his teachers. No, it was a monster. All for One, in his impeccable suit, with his wide smile. His hand reached for him, but Izuku slapped it away, struggling to breathe.

He blinked past the tears, and realized belatedly that it wasn't All for One reaching for him. It was All Might. Concern was etched on his features, as he looked at Izuku.

"My boy—"

Blue flames lit up the room momentarily.

“Back the *fuck* up!” Dabi snapped, shoving All Might harshly in the chest when the man unknowingly took a step forward. Izuku curled in on himself, not daring to close his eyes. Every time he closed them, he saw his mother.

I wish you were never born.

Every time he blinked, he imagined himself standing atop a pool of water, staring at his reflection depicted on it. But it wasn’t him. It couldn’t be…

The monster with skeletal wings, golden eyes, and horns curling out of his head wasn’t him. It wasn’t. There was no *way.* That had been an accident.

He wasn’t a monster… was he?

He didn’t know. Those memories just served as a reminder of everything he *really* was. And everything he could never be.

He couldn’t breathe. His chest heaved, and tears flowed freely from his eyes. His breaths were erratic and shallow. He was going to throw up. Nausea hit him suddenly, rumbling in his stomach threateningly.

“My boy, you’ll spy on Yuuei for me, won’t you?”

“You’ll destroy Yuuei won’t you?”

“Useless. I don’t understand how he could’ve chosen you for this.”

He had never been good enough for anyone. Some day, even the Heroes would see it. It would be so glaringly obvious.

Dabi was yelling at someone, but Izuku couldn't hear a thing. The noose around his neck was tightening, and tugging harshly. There seemed to be a yawning fissure in his chest, like every wound, mental or physical, had converged on that point, churning his stomach in awful ways.

He only got a split second warning — enough time to lurch forward — before vomit climbed up his throat, burning and acidic.

"Pathetic."

The strong smell of vomit did nothing to cure the nausea burning in his stomach. On reflex, his body began to shake, and tears sprung to his eyes. His hands clutched his shoulders, and he didn't dare look at anything in particular or anyone.

The ocean of fear was spilling from the ceiling, from the cracks in the walls. It was filling the room, attempting to drown him where he sat.

The water sloshed around his ankles, and the water kept rushing in. Getting higher and higher. Fear burned his skin and made his eyes sting.

"Izuku,"

Couldn't they see he was *drowning* ? Couldn't they see him dying?

"Izuku please,"

Couldn't they see he was drowning?

"You're okay now,"

Couldn't they see he was drowning? Couldn't they *see? Couldn't they see he was drowning? Couldn't they see he was drowning?Couldn't they see he was drowning?Couldn't they see he was drowning? He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.*

He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.He was drowning.

Why? Why had Nedzu done this to him? Why did he agree to this? This had been a mistake. He couldn't handle this. He couldn't handle All for One's voice, so fresh in his mind. He couldn't handle remembering every bad thing that had happened to him.

There was an incomprehensible weight on his shoulders now. Every memory, as if it had just happened. Every scar had been ripped open, and he was bleeding to death.

He choked on the water around him. The never-ending ocean of anguish and terror. There seemed to be heavy weights on his limbs, trapping him to this spot.

Why? Why? Why? Why? *Why?!*

There were strong hands holding his shoulders. Holding him together like glass on the verge of shattering. "God. Fucking damn it Deku, fucking breathe,"

But it just wasn't possible. There was a churning ocean of agony surrounding him, cutting off his air. His lungs begged for air, but there just *wasn't* any.

"In and out slowly dearie," He hardly recognized the voice, and barely heard the words due to his loud breathing. "Just relax, honey,"

But it was like his muscles themselves refused to comply. He couldn't do it. The memories flashed behind his eyes, forever engrained there. Driving the fear home in his heart.

He just wanted to lock himself in his room alone, to wallow in his terrifying memories. He didn't want to be here surrounded by Pro Heroes who decided that this was a brilliant idea. He didn't want to be anywhere near his classmates, who were no doubt either looking at him in disgust or pity. He didn't even want Kacchan anywhere near him.

He was a monster. He was a villain. He deserved the treatment his mother and father had given him. It was normal. He just wanted everything to be normal and *familiar* again.

The water seemed to rise higher, but there were no exclamations of shock or worry from his teachers. He was too busy looking at the floor and avoiding eye-contact with anyone. It was eerily silent.

There was no sound. There was no light. There was no hope.

Darkness haunted him the way it haunted a house. It followed him, and terrorized him in the way that his demons did. It wouldn't leave him, no matter how hard he tried, and now it seemed to be creeping in on him.

The edges of his vision seemed to darken, and Izuku couldn't keep it at bay. Hands reached for him, heavy and firm on his shoulders. There were whispers, so soft and unintelligible that fear ripped through him.

So similar to the cacophony of the screaming demons he often dreamed about.

No. No. No. No.

The panic was too much. It never registered in his mind that those hands were Kacchan and Dabi's. It never registered that the whispers were Recovery Girl's soft orders for his other classmates to leave.

All Might, Nedzu, and Recovery Girl had stepped out of the gym, but he didn't notice. The room felt full, and dark.

Even though it was just Hizashi, Shouta, Kacchan and Dabi.

He shoved all of them away, and Dabi took a step back, a look of concern flashing across his face. Izuku didn't see it. He didn't realize he was shoving *people* away.

He was trying to claw his way away from the growing and festering darkness and ocean that seemed hellbent on drowning him.

You shouldn't have been born.

The darkness reminded him too much of the basement. He could feel the bitter cold of his bedroom. The uncomfortable mattress beneath him. The creaking of the floor where Inko was stumbling around their house.

"Izuku…"

He twisted his hands in his sheets and glanced up at the ceiling. Izuku could hear her stumbling blindly down the stairs, searching for him. He could feel his fear weigh down on him, and her low laugh as she reached the bottom of the stairs.

"Izuku…"

He saw her. The way her dark green hair stuck out in all directions, hardly even tamed by the ponytail she'd pulled her locks into. Her eyes were glimmering dangerously with malice and excitement.

There was a glint in the darkness and it was enough to have Izuku glance down to the object in her hand.

A weapon. A butcher knife that flashed menacingly in the darkness. His eyes locked onto it, and he felt his body tense in preparation to run. The fear grasped him and suffocated him instantly as his mother lunged for him. Her knife was brought up swiftly, glinting horribly in the darkness even though it shouldn't be possible.

Her cruel, bubbling laugh cut through the silence.

The pain came a second later. The tears, the screaming. Blood was slick and hot on his fingers and palms, and he looked down at his chest to see the knife protruding from his chest.

The blood staining his sheets, his clothes, his arms. Erratically he touched his chest, but couldn't bring himself to pull the offending thing out of his chest.

He could hardly breathe.

Under the crushing weight of his fear and horror, Izuku didn't notice the sickly sweet scent filling his nose until it was too late.

Shouta sat next to Izuku in the infirmary. His husband, Hizashi, took Bakugou to go get something to eat and to call his parents. Recovery Girl was reprimanding Nedzu currently, and All Might stood outside and was making sure no one came in here to disturb Izuku's slumber.

He grasped Izuku's hand, his grip tight and firm. Regret churned his stomach and made his skin hot with rage. He should've stopped Nedzu. He could've. He could've put his foot down and made sure his son was safe.

That had been terror when he stood up to sit next to Yuki Hirai. It had been terror when the woman whispered encouraging words to him, and she finally grasped his hand.

He should've stopped it then. As soon as possible. He should've taken Izuku and dragged him home, where he'd be safe and protected. Where he wouldn't be forced to go through *all* of his trauma again.

They had done unspeakable things to his child. They tortured him, drowned him, and poured holy water all over him just to watch him suffer. They picked apart his Quirk and fears, and forced him to face them over and over again until it traumatized him all over again.

They had put him in simulations and killed him again and again. They hurt him until he transformed into a beast that had no qualms about nearly killing All for One. It had been heartbreaking to watch.

Rage swirled like a storm in his chest. He would protect this child with everything he had. Izuku hadn't deserved anything that had happened to him. Shouta was determined to tell the boy exactly that. What he'd gone through was traumatic. What he'd seen was horrific. The blame they placed on him was illogical.

He hadn't killed those children. He had been forced to watch. He hadn't been a traitor by choice. They'd forced him into it through blackmail and threats.

He wasn't a villain like All for One wanted him to think. He had no choice but to kill Stain in order to save Iida and Tensei.

Shouta would make sure his boy understood that. Izuku could be a hero. He was safe now. All for One couldn't reach him here, as much as he might want to. Shouta squeezed Izuku's hand again, but the boy didn't even twitch.

Nemuri had sedated him with her Quirk, and Shouta had been immensely grateful for it. He wasn't sure he could watch Izuku go through a flashback like that for much longer. He had been a mess by the time the memories were even over, but once he saw Izuku trying to run away, terrified and trembling, Shouta had lost it.

The tears had obscured his vision, as All Might rushed forward to comfort *his* child. But Dabi shoved him away hard enough to have All Might stumbling.

Bakugou and Recovery Girl tried next. The school nurse had given up after a few seconds, instead prioritizing giving Izuku privacy. She seemed to realize that if *anyone* could help Izuku, it was Bakugou.

Together, Bakugou and Dabi reached for Izuku.

But he shoved them away and scrambled backward, nearly slipping in his own vomit. Shouta had rushed forward then, erasing Izuku's Quirk as he hyperventilated and shrieked. At least his child wouldn't be seeing monsters.

Or at least he'd thought.

Izuku seemed to nose dive into a flashback, his eyes darting up to the ceiling in terror. Then his eyes seemed to track movement, but there wasn't anyone in the room anymore. Hizashi had demanded that Nedzu leave, alongside Recovery Girl and All Might.

It was just them, and Bakugou. Dabi looked lost for words, his eyes shining with worry.

His breathing had gone unbelievably soft and shallow. His eyes looked glassy and far away. He kept looking at something Shouta couldn't see, but he knew it couldn't be a demon. He was currently erasing his Quirk.

Vaguely, Shouta heard Nemuri whisper softly to Hizashi. Izuku suddenly lurched then, and Shouta was expecting more puke. But that wasn't what he got.

Izuku's eyes widened, and he looked down at his chest as if he expected something to be there. And he *screamed.*

Izuku screamed, and his hands went to touch his uniform frantically, and Nemuri stepped forward silently.

“Hey kiddo,” Her voice was soft, and her face was wet. Like Shouta’s. “Kiddo?”

He *screamed.* Shouta couldn't take any more of this. And Nemuri seemed to have the same train of thought.

She ripped a small hole in her costume, her Quirk instantly emitting sweet anesthesia, and his wailing came to an abrupt halt. Nemuri glanced up at Shouta, Hizashi, and Bakugou.

His sadness was reflected in her eyes. From there, they’d brought Izuku to the infirmary, and All Might actually *volunteered* to clean the gym. His deep, ancient eyes seemed to be gleaming with regret too, and Shouta didn’t protest that they had janitors who could clean the gym for them.

All Might was already trying to repent. So Shouta had spent the rest of the day sitting in the infirmary, while Ectoplasm took over his class for the day. He hadn’t moved since they put Izuku on this bed. There was a night light plugged into the wall, created by Yaoyorozu as soon as the whole fiasco was over. She’d apparently given it to Recovery Girl as soon as she had escorted them out of the gym.

Apparently Iida had asked her to make it. He was grateful for his horde of children he called his students. They understood more than he thought they would about Izuku’s situation. It was a relief honestly, after what happened today.

There was a glass of water waiting on the bedside table, untouched. Izuku was still sleeping peacefully. The door to the infirmary opened slowly, and Shouta looked up. It was All Might, who still hadn’t moved since he finished cleaning up the vomit.

“Would you like anything to eat or drink, Eraserhead?” He asked, and Shouta could see the worry written in the Number One’s words. He shook his head.

“I’ll eat once I know he’s okay,” Shouta told him, looking down at his son.

“I-if you say so,” All Might mumbled softly, before letting the door click closed. Shouta slumped down into his chair.

His phone buzzed in his pocket.

Hizashi: *I just finished getting Bakugou something to eat. I also called his parents, but he insisted on talking to Izuku before he left.*

Shouta: *He should wake up soon. It’s probably a good idea if Bakugou stays just in case Izuku isn’t okay.*

Hizashi: *Is the little listener doing ok? He isn’t having any nightmares, right? Are you okay? Do you want anything to drink? Or eat?*

Shouta: *He’s sedated, I doubt he’s dreaming. And no, I’m not fine and I don’t need anything. But you should probably get Izuku something.*

Hizashi: *You got it babe! Love you!*

Shouta was about to respond when Izuku shifted. He placed the phone quietly on the bedside table, and watched Izuku carefully. He shifted again, a low whine passing from his lips. Shouta stood quickly, carefully squeezing Izuku’s hand reassuringly as the boy blinked rapidly.

“You’re safe,” Is the first thing he says, “You’re safe Izuku,”

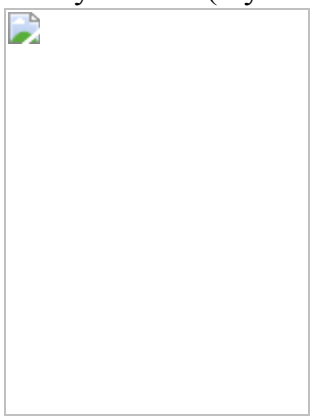
That seemed to calm him instantly, as he tried to blink the tiredness from his eyes. Shouta knew it was probably a bad idea to move quickly in front of Izuku at the moment, considering all that had happened. He knew it wasn't the best idea to hug him, but he couldn't help himself.

He crushed Izuku Midoriya in a hug, and for once, Izuku didn't even flinch.

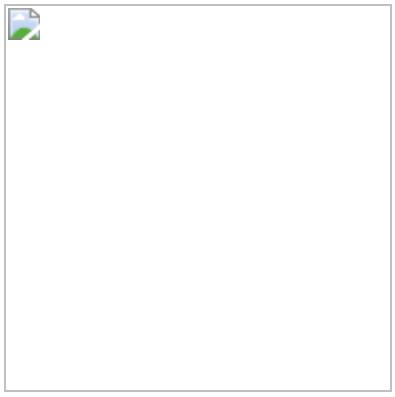
Chapter End Notes

I've got more art guys!! (I cry every time people make me art, I swear!)

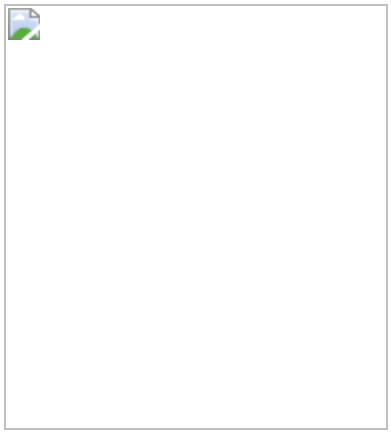
Art by Mochii (my childddddd) on the discord server:



Art by the wonderful Bia!











Chapter 40

Chapter Notes

Sorry that this is late! (It's also short, because it's a filler chapter ;^^ but also it isn't??)

Here's the discord server link as usual!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hitoshi and the rest of class 1-A stood in their classroom for a long, long time after the strange — and downright cruel — “therapy session” they’d had together. As a family of sorts.

Experiencing everyone’s terrors first-hand would do that to a class. Hitoshi watched them all as they milled around almost silently in the classroom, consoling each other. Momo was stroking Todoroki’s hair gently, whispering something softly to him. Iida and Uraraka seemed to flock to him as well.

After a few moments, Denki and Mina joined Hitoshi at his desk. He watched them wearily. They both had their brows furrowed in concentration or concern. It took both of them a moment to speak, as they fumbled on what to say.

He could practically see the words forming in their minds before they spoke them out loud. They both had similar looks of pity on their faces, but also a profound understanding.

It was Denki who spoke first. “We know what it’s like for people to hate you for your Quirk,”

“Yeah,” Mina pushed on, as Denki lost his resolve. “All my classmates have been terrified of my acid. I… I never really made *any* friends until I got to Yuuei,”

Hitoshi watched both of them closely. They both seemed to be speaking genuinely, but Hitoshi couldn't bring himself to believe that Mina hadn't had friends until high school. She was too outgoing and kind for that.

"Uh, why are you telling me this?" Hitoshi asks, and he doesn't care that he sounds bitter and closed off.

"Because we don't want you to be alone," Mina answers, and Denki nods.

For some reason, it really pisses him off. All of this does. Everyone is sitting around comforting each other, but no one is talking about the elephant in the room.

"Okay, but what about Midoriya?" He finds himself spitting at them. He's angry. Angry at the villains who crushed Midoriya under their feet. Angry at Nedzu for making Midoriya relive such horrible memories.

He looks around at his classmates and realizes most of them have their heads down, staring at their empty hands. All the soft conversation is like dead weight in the air. "We're not going to talk about the shit he went through? You're just going to lick your wounds and ignore what we all just saw?"

"Shinsou," Momo begins, "There's nothing we can do! The teachers are taking care of it! For now all of us should learn to cope with our own trauma,"

"You've had your *entire lives* to cope! I've long since accepted that my foster parents fucking hate me! Todoroki and Midoriya are the only ones who haven't had that luxury, and I understand that trauma is different for everyone, but I don't really think any of us have been through *shit* compared to those two." Hitoshi began, feeling that he's being irrational about all of this. But it needs to be said. "I see all of you comforting Todoroki — which is honestly amazing, — and Todoroki you're dad is seriously an ass. I'll fight him myself, but who is helping Midoriya? You think *Nedzu* is? Or All Might? I wouldn't be surprised if all of them are looking at him like he's a fucking villain,"

There's nothing but silence. No one says anything for a long time. They sit in silence, until Todoroki speaks up.

"My mother loves me," He said slowly, drawing the attention of their classmates. "Even after burning my face, she still loves me. My siblings love me too, and they protected me from my father when it mattered the most. Everyone who wanted to help Midoriya has died, or isn't even *human* anymore. Or they're like Aizawa-sensei and Hizashi. They're trying, but he's in too deep. The only person Midoriya even trusts is Bakugou. And Bakugou has been trying to help him their entire childhood. I can't imagine the kind of suffering Midoriya went through,"

There's another lull in this strangely one-sided conversation, and Hitoshi can feel his respect for Todoroki increasing by leaps and bounds. "Can you imagine it? Any of that? Growing up with a mother who won't even let you speak? A father who uses his Quirk to keep you from running away? I don't think any of you can imagine that pain. His parents who were *supposed* to protect and help him, were villains. They tried to get an immortal supervillain to steal his Quirk, and when that villain couldn't, they forced you to become a villain, when all you ever wanted was to be a hero? And the only person who knows all of this is a *Hero Killer,* who you end up killing a few months later because he attacks Ingenium? Imagine being Midoriya, killing your only father figure because he was trying to hurt a Hero. And then, your only friend is trying to help you, but you're terrified to get him hurt. All avenues of escape are closing in on you, and it gets *so* bad to the point that you think your only viable option is to *kill yourself,* but you can't. You can't because you still hold even the smallest amount of hope, even though you shouldn't. Have any of you even felt something *similar to that?"*

The silence is an answer on its own. Before anyone can break it though, the door to their classroom slams open. They expect All Might, Nedzu, or Aizawa. They don't expect Bakugou, looking like he just watched someone die. Hitoshi opens his mouth to comfort him, but Present Mic trails in after him.

The blond Pro Hero pauses in the doorway, obviously noting the quiet atmosphere. "Where's Recovery Girl?" he asks instantly.

"She's grabbing a counselor with a calming Quirk," Iida said softly, like he didn't dare break the silence. And just then, the school Nurse arrives, with a counselor in tow. Her hair is neon blue, and her eyes are unnaturally wide and gleaming.

Bakugou storms into the room, his blood red eyes swirling with a storm of emotions. “A-Are you okay, Bakubro?”

It’s Kirishima who asks him, and Hitoshi is surprised by Bakugou’s answer.

“What the *fuck* do you think, huh?!” He snarls, like *actually* snarls. He grabs his bag, and Izuku’s bag. “Fuck all of you!”

He slams the door with a resounding slam that has Iida jumping a foot in the air. Hitoshi swears there were tears streaming down his face.

Chiyo sits in her office after school is long over, and stares at the empty bed beside her. She can still remember a young Toshinori walking in and exclaiming that he’d accidentally injured Enji, dragging the half-conscious boy into the room.

She can still remember how Chizome — no, his name was Stain. He was the *Hero Killer* — would call her late at night, and she’d heal him in her small apartment. He would thank her with a soft smile, and Chiyo would give him a glare that lacked any real malice.

She had met him half-dead in an alleyway years ago. She had gasped, clutching her heart in horror at the state of him. There was a thick gash across his chest, and blood dripping from his mouth. In a split second, she had made an assessment of the situation.

Chiyo could tell that he’d been mugged, considering that his wallet was sitting a few feet away, empty of any and all cash. But she hypothesized that the thug who mugged Chizome hadn’t gotten a good amount of cash, considering how Chizome’s clothes looked old and worn.

He looked homeless. So Chiyo did the most reckless thing of her entire hero career and took Chizome — half dead and nearly unconscious — to her apartment to heal him.

“Would you like anything to eat, young man?” Chiyo asked, after giving him a soft peck on the forehead. Not all of his wounds healed completely, but she easily patched him up. “You look like you could benefit from gaining a few more pounds,”

She was right of course. She was technically a doctor, and even with her aging eyes, she could tell that he was thinner than a stick.

“I’m not hungry, ma’am,” Chizome said, and Chiyo laughed.

“Is rice and fish okay with you?” Chiyo asked him, as she stood from her chair and headed into her small kitchen. Despite its small, quaint size, she had managed to cramp a load of things in the cabinets and drawers. She glanced at the man again, and he gave a hesitant nod.

She smiled gently, and a few minutes later emerged from the kitchen with steaming rice and cooked fish atop it.

There was a pause, before Chizome accepted the food before him, and practically scarfed it down. Chiyo grinned, before going to her own meal.

Years later, he’d be a regular part of her life as a Yuuei student. And practically like her son. Until she goes to his apartment one night, and finds it empty and unnaturally quiet.

Chiyo hardly notices the tears streaming down her face, and her throat constricting with unimaginable sorrow.

Katsuki feels like a ghost drifting through his house. His mother and father try to ask about his day as he trudged up the stairs, but he barely even mutters a response. He doesn't know what to tell them.

He hardly even knows what he had witnessed today. Katsuki can't even remember how he got home.

He keeps seeing Izuku change into a monster, and he can't help but feel an inkling of fear whenever he thinks about it. But it's not fear of the monster. It's fear for Izuku, and it just seems to spark the all-consuming need to protect him at all costs.

And then, whenever he thinks about protecting Izuku, he falls down a hole of guilt and despair. He hadn't saved or protected Izuku at all. At *any* point in his life because Izuku always went home to that *monster* of a mother.

So he sits at his desk, with all his school work thrown about —homework he has yet to touch — and stares blankly at the wall. He doesn't know for how long.

The next day, when Katsuki arrives to class, it's stiff and quiet. The atmosphere is heavy, and thick with tension. Katsuki finds himself looking for a mop of green curly hair, but predictably, he doesn't see Izuku. And honestly, he doesn't blame him.

With all the memories he'd just relived, Katsuki would never blame him. They had been painful to *watch,* and he couldn't imagine *feeling* them.

But Izuku was the only one missing, and the damn extra's fucking noticed it as well. As soon as Aizawa-sensei stepped foot through the door looking more haggard and gaunt than usual, the class as a whole began asking questions and shouting.

"Aizawa-sensei, is Midoriya-kun okay?" Iida asked, standing up from his seat and chopping his hands in a robotic motion.

"How's Mido doing?" Mina asked, wringing her hands nervously.

"Is Midoriya coming to class today?"

"When is he coming back?"

"We should write him cards!"

Katsuki could see the irritation written across Aizawa's face and decided to remain silent about his questions.

"I hope he gets better," Todoroki murmured.

"Can we go visit?"

"We should leave him alone, honestly. I wouldn't want my nosy classmates crowding in my house,"

There was a flash of bright red that engulfed nearly the entire room, and all the conversation and questions ceased. Aizawa sighed heavily, as if the world itself was balanced on his shoulders. After a moment of thick silence, he spoke.

“Listen,” He mumbled, sounding more defeated than Katsuki has ever heard him. “Midoriya isn’t coming to class, but he’s better than he was yesterday, but not by much. Now, all of you take your seats, and I’m going to put a movie on while I sleep. If any of you feel like you need counseling after what transpired yesterday, don’t hesitate to wake me up,”

Katsuki watched as Aizawa pulled down a screen and turned on a projector he didn’t even *see* before. Almost instantly the wall was covered with the projection of Frozen.

He could hear Todoroki chuckle. Katsuki rolled his eyes and pulled out his phone.

Kacchan: Hey nerd, ya there?

Kacchan: Are you okay? I’m worried.

Kacchan: Please don’t ignore me.

He never got an answer.

Toshinori sat in Nedzu’s office, glaring at the rat like he was glaring at All for One himself. Nedzu’s hands were steady as he took a sip of his tea.

“You should apologize, Nedzu,” Toshinori told him.

“I admit, that this entire situation was a mistake on my part,” Nedzu mumbled, looking down into his cup of tea glumly. “Even I can be wrong sometimes,”

“You’re damn right about that,” Toshinori jumped about a foot in the air. Whipping around, he stared wide-eyed at Aizawa, who had snuck inside at some point. It was an hour or two

before the school day was set to start, so it wasn't entirely strange that Aizawa had come here for the same reasons Toshinori had.

Nedzu's paws were suddenly shaking against the porcelain of his teacup. "Ah, Aizawa,"

"No amount of apologizing will ever fix what you've done, Nedzu," Aizawa continued, giving Nedzu the same glare Toshinori had just been giving him. "Midoriya might forgive you if you ever decide to apologize, but God knows I won't,"

All for One wasn't going to let Izuku just slip through his fingers. He may have failed to retrieve him at the USJ, but that didn't deter him in the slightest. There were plenty of chances to get the boy back, and punish him thoroughly for his treachery.

And then of course, he could alter some of his memories if the punishments didn't work to change his mind. He was already thinking twelve steps ahead, and Izuku was a required piece to successfully kill All Might.

But that wasn't why he wanted Izuku Midoriya so badly. It was the boy's mystery and allure that made All for One want to trap him in a cage like a bird. He wanted to puppeteer such a powerful being such as Izuku.

It would give him a sick sense of satisfaction. All for One stood from his chair as the Doctor opened the door and entered the room. What he pushed on a cart was what caught All for One's attention.

"It's done? You've completed it?" All for One asked, as he looked at the green, glowing vat that was much bigger than the other Nomu vats in this facility.

The Doctor smiled, and the action was slow and cruel. “Yes, I have,”

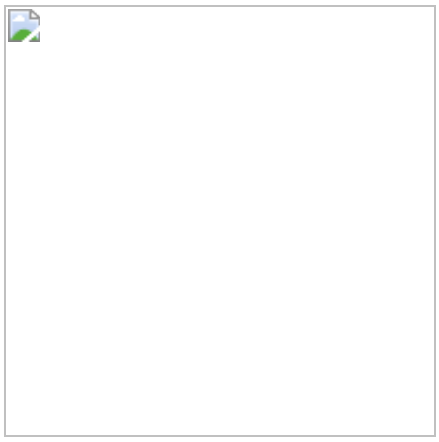
“Perfect,” All for One mumbled, as he pressed a hand to the glass of the vat. Inside was a Nomu more advanced and dangerous than any other before it. It was one of the many experiments All for One had been running as of late. It was even stronger than the original Prototype-Nomu.

A Nomu that most definitely would be able to bring Izuku back to him.

Izuku Midoriya would be his, once and for all.

Chapter End Notes

Wonderful art by Sylphlez on the discord server: (im in love with it tbh <333)



More art, by Amber: (I love this one too!!)



Also, side note: If you'd like to submit art without joining my discord server, please put a link to the art in the comments and I'll feature it here!

Chapter 41

Chapter Notes

Here's the discord server link as usual!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He didn’t leave his room. Not even when his alarm blared, the next morning — he didn’t sleep. The shadows kept moving. — screeching in the dark silence of his room. He hated the dark. He hated and despised it above all else. Izuku was terrified of it, horrified by the creatures that lurked there, stealing his warmth and happiness. The creatures that followed him, whispered to him, and never left his side.

He shouldn’t be afraid of his own Quirk, and he shouldn’t be afraid of the dark. He wasn’t a baby. He was fifteen years old, and afraid of the dark while everyone else had completely justifiable fears. His fears weren’t. They were irrational, spine-tingling fears that sent tears streaking down his cheeks like ice.

They made him want to hide. They made him want to burrow himself in his bed and never come out. He didn’t deserve to have his lights turned on.

And *oh god,* his classmates. Izuku shrunk in on himself, lips trembling, heart thumping. What did they think of him now? Did they hate him? Were they *scared* of him?

They probably were. They would never forgive him for betraying them like that, by giving the League information. It didn’t matter that he risked his life to save them, and *keep* them safe. They probably hated him.

And he deserved it. He without a doubt deserved it. Every ounce of hatred and disgust because even if he hadn’t done it willingly, he put his friends at risk. Izuku didn’t make a single move to turn off his alarm. He didn’t move when Hizashi crept inside and turned it off for him. Izuku tightened his hold on his blankets and tugged them closer.

The shadows shifted as Hizashi came to sit on the edge of his bed. Izuku's fear ate at him like a never-ending torrent. But he didn't deserve the light. The comforting light that was just a light switch away.

He didn't want it. He should suffer in fear because his classmates had seen everything. Because he was a freak, and his Quirk was scary.

"Izuku," Hizashi began, not moving an inch as he sat at the foot of Izuku's bed. He looked straight ahead, not turning his head to look at him. "You don't have to go today, if you don't want to. Nedzu already agreed to waver your absences, and allowed me to stay home so I can be with you,"

Izuku didn't move, but Hizashi kept talking. "I know what happened yesterday was…" He swallowed thickly, and Izuku watched him wring his hands together. He could feel the tension in the air. "I know you probably wanted to keep most of your memories to yourself, but no one blames you for anything that happened. I know it doesn't feel like that, but I'll be in the other room if you want to come out at any point, okay? Do you want any breakfast?"

Finally, Hizashi turned to look at him. Izuku gave a weak shake of his head. "Okay, buddy. Just know I'm here for you, okay?"

Izuku didn't respond to that. Mostly because he didn't know how to respond. Hizashi let the tension melt out of his shoulders and he sighed. It was a defeated sound, like he was at a loss as to what to do, but Izuku couldn't help him. Hizashi left his room after a few minutes, leaving the door slightly ajar, and Izuku was left alone with his self-loathing, and fear.

Izuku let himself drown in his fear. He let himself get cocooned inside of it, let himself sink into it like quicksand. There was nothing else he could do. He couldn't find it in himself to pull himself out this rut, this darkness.

His tears were silent, like everything about him. They soaked his pillow where his cheek rested, and the corners of his eyes stung and itched. He heard Aizawa shuffle into the kitchen, but he paid it no mind. Not until he and Hizashi started talking. He was only half paying attention.

“So he’s not coming?” Aizawa asked, knowingly.

“I’ll keep an eye on him, Shouta.” Hizashi told him softly. Izuku nearly missed it, as goosebumps blossomed along his arms. “I’ll make sure he’s safe,”

“I hope so,” Aizawa mumbled, and Izuku was probably imagining how his voice seemed to break. “How was he when you checked on him?”

“His lights are off, if that tells you anything,” Hizashi sighed, that defeated sigh again. “You and I know how much he’s afraid of the dark. He’s not doing good, but I’ll try again in a little bit,”

Izuku tuned out the rest of it, not eager to hear anymore. He just wanted to hide. From himself, from his classmates, and from his dads. Everything was too fresh in his mind, all of the memories of Inko’s house, and the things she did to him. He was doubting Aizawa’s and Hizashi’s sincerity when it came to wanting to comfort, or help him all over again. He felt like he was back *there* . With Inko, and Hisashi, who didn’t care about him. Who hurt him at every turn, and didn’t apologize. They didn’t try to help him heal.

In some ways, living with those two had been easier. Izuku had known what to do, and what to expect. Sure, it was terrifying, and he spent years upon years walking on eggshells around them, but that was familiar.

This, however, was not. No matter how hard he tried to understand this new set of rules, he just couldn’t absorb the information. What was good? What was bad? What didn’t he do? What could he do? What were the limitations? It was a jumbled, incoherent mess.

Izuku swallowed his rapid-fire thoughts and inner-ramblings, as the shadows swirled and shifted. White, wicked eyes stared back at him, and Izuku whimpered.

Weak. I’m just weak.

He whined, tugging at his curls as the monsters reached for him, claws feeling for his warmth beneath his sheets. His katana twitched on the floor where he'd left it, but he ignored it. If Dabi summoned himself, Izuku would send him back.

Body and lungs trembling, Izuku squeezed his eyes shut. Raspy rumbling reached his ears like screeching gears, but he didn't shoo them away. He wallowed in the fear, in the heart-wrenching, instinctive, visceral horror.

Izuku curled into himself and hid under his blankets. Dabi's fire went unnoticed by him, as Dabi silently ushered his entourage away. As soon as they were gone, for now, Dabi took his silent leave.

With a ragged sob, Izuku covered his eyes. Eyes stinging and wet. His chest was impossibly tight, and his throat constricted with ugly sobs. He bit down harshly on his lower lip, and rode through the sobs. God, his mother was right. He was useless. He was weak.

If he would've had his face uncovered, he would've noticed Inko's echo, like a ghost standing in the corner. A side-effect of Ms. Hirai's Quirk.

Izuku ignored Hizashi each time he came into his room even though Hizashi was just trying to help him. It didn't feel genuine, even though Izuku knew deep down, that it was.

He ignored the sound of his door opening slowly. The demons had returned at some point, watching him again. Maybe it was another one, hoping to join the pity party. Or maybe it was Aizawa. It was probably the afternoon by now.

He made no indication that he was awake, as whoever it was ventured deeper. There was a moment or two of shuffling, and then silence as the door shut softly again. His bed dipped with newly-acquired weight.

Definitely Aizawa.

He pressed his lips into a thin line, fisting his hands in his sheets. He didn't want to sit through Aizawa's attempt at comforting him. It hadn't worked with Hizashi, and it wasn't going to work with him. He just wanted to hide, and never come out.

The silence was thick, and tense. Izuku refused to break it. "I know you're awake, Izuku,"

Izuku realized two things in quick succession. One, that it wasn't Aizawa in his room. Two, that Kacchan was sitting on his bed, and Izuku couldn't stop his ragged sobs in time. His blanket was ripped off his face in an instant, and Izuku tried his best to blink past the blurriness of his tears. It didn't matter how many times he blinked, or how many times he tried to wipe them away.

The tears kept coming, and the knot in his chest, curling around his heart, tightened. Kacchan winced, as if seeing Izuku in such a state was physically painful.

"Come here," Kacchan whispered, voice thick with emotion and Izuku watched him for a moment before moving. After a second or so, he moved into a sitting position, watching all the while as Kacchan moved so that they sat right next to each other. He held out his arms as an invitation, and Izuku only hesitated for a second before crawling in his lap. Kacchan wrapped his arms around him in a warm, gentle embrace. "I'm right here, okay? You don't have to be alone,"

A whine ripped from his throat. Kacchan's arms tightened in response.

The knot pulled impossibly tighter, but Izuku ignored it in favor of breathing in Kacchan. The light, sugary scent of his nitro-glycerin sweat. He rested his head on Kacchan's shoulder and clung to his hoodie. Tears pooled and stung at his eyes.

His lips wobbled and his chest shuddered. Agony and sorrow hit him like a freight train. So violent, and all-consuming. Memories flashed like pictures behind his eyelids. Memories

he'd long-since buried. Things he'd much sooner forget rather than remember.

A profound sadness had wound its way around his heart unbeknownst to him. Kacchan ran his fingers through his hair gently scratching his scalp as he tugged gently at the knots in his curls. Izuku's breath hitched with an ugly silent sob. The knot twisted in his chest, squeezing, squeezing, *suffocating* . His shoulders felt so heavy. His chest felt like lead.

Kacchan's arm tightened around him, like he believed he alone could fend off everything that had ever hurt Izuku. He could, and he *did* .

Izuku buried himself in Kacchan's arms, seeking a place away from all the fear, all the pain, all the self-loathing, and the sudden self-deprecating thoughts. "I'm right here," Kacchan whispered, "You're safe with me, Izuku. You can cry,"

Safe.

His hands trembled. Gentle hands, calloused from explosions, pulled him close. "You're safe with me," He repeated, one of his hands drawing circles into his back. Tears sprang to his eyes, and sobs bubbled up his throat. His body shook, as his tears streamed down his cheeks but Kacchan's embrace was strong and warm. He sniffled loudly in the dark, and Kacchan rubbed more soothing circles in his back.

"It's okay," He murmured gently, every time Izuku took a shuddering breath, only to sob uncontrollably. His tears fell one after another, fat and ugly. He chewed on his wobbling lower lip uselessly. Kacchan ran a hand through his hair again, and the action was oddly soothing. "It's okay to cry,"

Izuku swallowed past the lump in his throat and slowed his breathing. His chest burned and his eyes were still shining with tears, but the pain around his heart seemed to fade. He pulled away, and Kacchan let him. Izuku blinked the tears out of his eyelashes.

Kacchan brought his hands to cup both sides of Izuku's face, and Izuku let his eyes flutter closed as his thumbs brushed away the last of his tears. His hands were warm against his face, and Izuku couldn't help but melt into it.

Kacchan gave a soft laugh, sounding relieved. They sat like that for a long time, Kacchan holding his face as Izuku sat completely still in his lap. Kacchan was the one who broke the silence. He was always the one breaking the silence.

"Wanna eat something?" Kacchan asked, his voice soft in the quiet. Izuku's eyes snapped open, and he looked away. His eyes caught on the dimly lit night light that *definitely* hadn't been there before. He pointed to it curiously, as a way to dodge Kacchan's question. "I bought it for you, don't dodge my question."

[I'm not hungry.]

"Please?" Kacchan tried, and Izuku's resolve crumbled like a house of cards. He couldn't tell Kacchan no, no matter how hard he tried.

[Fine.]

"Come on," Kacchan said, and they both got up. Izuku paused at his door, almost afraid to open it. Surely he'd be met with disappointment from both Aizawa and Hizashi. Or maybe they'd mock him. He wasn't sure.

Kacchan grabbed his hand and opened the door for him, pulling him along. The apartment was strangely quiet as Kacchan dragged him into the kitchen, and found a plate sitting out. He warmed it up in the microwave after pushing Izuku into a chair at the dining table. Izuku watched him grab a cold glass of water, and blinked when Kacchan shoved it toward him.

Izuku tentatively took a sip. The microwave beeped, and Kacchan returned a few seconds later with a steaming plate of rice and fish. He placed in front of him, jerking his chin.

"Eat?" He said it like a question, but Izuku knew it was a demand. He could tell from the way Kacchan's eyes *dared* him to challenge him.

Even though he didn't feel hungry, or thirsty, he drank all of his water and ate all of the food. Kacchan put the empty dishes in the sink and Izuku watched him, slightly wary. He washed the dishes quickly, before turning to Izuku. Kacchan's entire face seemed to soften, as he leaned down into a crouch. He took a hold of both of Izuku's hands and squeezed them.

"Shower?" Kacchan asked again, tugging his hands slightly. "Please? Then we can sleep,"

With a heavy sigh, Izuku shot him a glare and hopped in the shower.

It was like watching Bakugou do magic. That's the only way Shouta could describe what the fuck was happening in his apartment right now. Hizashi seemed to be trying his best to pretend like Izuku hadn't come out of his room, just to give him space.

Shouta was watching them closely as Bakugou got down low on the ground to look Izuku in the eyes. He watched as he slowly, and deliberately made it obvious that he was going to grab his hands. Every movement, whether he realized it or not, was made for Izuku's complete comfort. His voice was naturally softer, his words less harsh, his movements slow and gentle.

And then when Izuku disappeared into the bathroom, Bakugou seemed to deflate like All Might out of his muscle form. He ran his hand down his face, with a heavy sigh.

"Thank god," Hizashi breathed, his hands shaking.

"Are you okay Bakugou?" Shouta asked softly, eyeing his student worriedly.

“He’s right here, and I can’t *help* him!” Bakugou exclaimed suddenly, running his hands through his unruly hair. Shouta never thought he’d see Bakugou cry, but it was happening right now. Right here. In his fucking apartment. *“He’s right here.”*

“Bakugou—” Shouta began, closing the distance between them, placing a hand on his shoulder. He chose to pretend not to notice the single tear trailing down his face. “You’re doing more than any of us can right now,”

“H-how am I supposed to be a hero? How? He’s literally right here, and I can’t *reach* him!” Bakugou yelled, his voice brittle and broken. “He’s safe physically, but in here—” He tapped his temple aggressively. “—in his *mind,* he’s not safe! He’s in pain and I’m right here! But he’s so far away. He’s so far away, somewhere I can’t reach him. I could reach out my hand my entire life, and I would never reach him. *I can’t do anything to save him, Aizawa!”*

Shouta was at a loss for words. Bakugou was standing in his kitchen, heaving broken sobs. He knew what to do with an angry Bakugou, a fiery Bakugou, but he didn’t know what to do when Bakugou *cried.*

It was like holding a baby for the first time. He was, in simpler terms, terrified. He did the only thing that seemed to come to mind. He crushed his student in a hug. It was awkward, but Bakugou did manage to take a few deep breaths before Shouta pulled away.

“We’re all trying to help him, Bakugou. We can’t erase years of trauma, nor can we force him to heal. We just have to help him along, and pick him up when he falls.” Shouta squeezed his shoulder, swallowing around the lump in his throat. “It may look like he’s far away and out of reach, but we have to keep reaching. We have to keep holding out our hand until the day he finally takes it,”

“Fighting villains has always been only half the battle.” Hizashi told him, “We have to save their spirit too, and I think you’re doing a wonderful job, Bakugou.”

Bakugou didn’t look convinced, and Shouta didn’t blame him. The bathroom door opened and Izuku popped his head, shaking out his curly hair on his towel. After a second or two he frowned.

[What?]

“Nothin’” Bakugou mumbled smoothly, “Wanna go to bed now?”

Shouta, being a parent, should’ve stopped them from sleeping in the same room, but he didn’t want to risk the little progress they’d made. The two ventured back into his room, Bakugou keeping the door wide open. Shouta and Hizashi raised an eyebrow as he watched Bakugou and Izuku stop in the middle of the dark room.

Bakugou crossed his arms, snarling. “Get out, ya damn stalkers! You freak him out when he’s tryin’ to sleep! Maybe if you stay out of his room he’d like you better! Out!”

It took Shouta a second to realize what Bakugou was doing. He blinked and then blinked again when five demons ran out of the room, looking like kicked puppies.

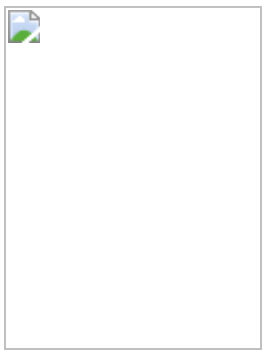
“Rude.” One of them stated simply, going into the kitchen to hide in a cabinet, opening the cabinet, and then shutting it on itself. Weird.

“You saw that too, right?” Hizashi asked, pointing at the now-closed cabinet. “I’m not going crazy?”

"Yeah..." Shouta said, grinning slightly. "I saw it,"

Chapter End Notes

Some wonderful art by stressesopossum404 in the discord server: Im fucking in L O V E with it

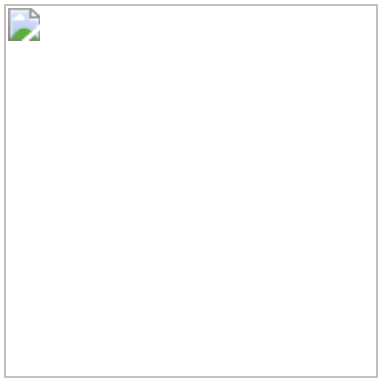


Chapter 42

Chapter Notes

Another filler chapter?? But its so sweet (and hella short, hence the double update)

Here's more art by the wonderful (and adorable) Sylphlez on the server!



See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku woke up calmer and warmer than he had in his entire life. He didn't wake up to his blaring, intruding, alarm clock that always woke him up with a start. He woke up rather peculiarly. An arm was slung around his shoulder, resting on the back of his neck. The hand was warm, and calloused with constant explosions.

Kacchan.

He blinked a few times before his vision cleared of sleep. His room was dimly lit thanks to the nightlight Kacchan had given to him the day before. The blond shifted slightly in his sleep, and Izuku smiled. Wrapped up in Izuku's covers, Kacchan looked relaxed and at peace for the first time in a long time.

Izuku took a moment to admire how his brow was smoothed out and free of the perpetual pinch that had become a permanent fixture on his face. His mouth wasn't an angry thin, white line. All in all, Kacchan looked his age, without the worry and the stress that Izuku undoubtedly put him under just by being *there* .

He committed all of this to memory, before his alarm clock began to shriek through the air. Kacchan groaned in displeasure, as he cracked his eyes open. He got up from the bed, though he seemed to think it over for a few seconds.

He turned the alarm off and looked back at Izuku with an eyebrow raised. “Do you wanna go to class today?”

Discomfort pulled at his chest, making his heart squeeze. He really didn’t want to face his classmates, but he couldn’t keep missing school. He had to scrounge up some courage and just do it. He sighed heavily, sitting up in his bed.

“You don’t have to go, yet,” Kacchan told him kindly, “We can always take one more day,”

He shook his head. [If I don’t do it now, I never will.]

His friend gave him a soft smile. “If that’s what you really want,”

It wasn’t, but he really didn’t have much of a choice. He would lose his nerve if he didn’t do it today. So he got up from his bed, even though his mind begged him to go back to bed and sleep for a week. Kacchan yawned and grabbed his bag from where he’d discarded it the night before.

Izuku grabbed his school uniform, and they both changed. After that they ventured into the kitchen where Aizawa and Hizashi were already making breakfast. Aizawa yawned and put his head on the table with a soft groan.

“I don’t want to go to school,” Aizawa grumbled, and Izuku noticed that there were already four empty mugs sitting at the table beside him.

“We have to go, honey,” Hizashi muttered softly, “It’s our job,”

Kacchan took a seat at the table, and looked as fresh as a daisy when compared to Aizawa's current state. Izuku wanted nothing more than to mirror Aizawa's position and go to sleep, but Hizashi placed a mug of tea next to him, and a mug of orange juice next to Kacchan.

"It's peppermint tea," Hizashi explained, giving him a warm smile. "It'll help you stay calm,"

Izuku felt his heart tug at the notion, and Hizashi waved his hand over at Aizawa. "Shouta bought it for you last night after you fell asleep,"

"Hey!" Aizawa said suddenly, his head shooting up to glare at Hizashi. "I have a reputation, you know!"

"He cares about you," Hizashi whispered, with a conspiring smirk as he handed out three plates of eggs and bacon. Kacchan took a dainty sip of his orange juice as he watched the two go back and forth. Izuku took his time eating, as Hizashi plopped down at the seat across from him.

"You guys are going to be training your Quirks today," Hizashi began, making an easy transition to a new topic. "What are you thinking about improving, Bakugou?"

The boy in question shrugged. "I'm not sure,"

Aizawa got up from his seat and poured himself another cup of coffee. "You need to get better at making bigger explosions without your gauntlet,"

Kacchan took a moment to chew over the information before he nodded slowly.

"Midoriya," Aizawa began, coming to sit back down. "As much as you probably don't want to train the part of your Quirk that transforms you, you have to. That's what me and All

Might will be trying to do today, which is the whole reason why we're making Class 1-A train instead of getting ready for the Sports Festival,"

Izuku slowly put down his fork and stared intently at his eggs like they were the most interesting thing in the room. Fear gripped his heart forcefully, but he forced himself to see the logic in Aizawa's statement.

One day, his Quirk suppressor would stop working entirely. He could already feel himself getting stronger by the day, and it was only logical after seeing his memories that Aizawa would want him to learn how to use his Quirk.

It was the best course of action. It was something that needed to be done, but not something he *wanted* to do. Clenching his jaw, he looked up at Aizawa. He knew his fear was reflected in his eyes.

"If at any point you want to stop, we will," Aizawa promised. He needed to do this, and not because Aizawa suggested it. He needed to do it so that he wouldn't accidentally hurt the people he loved. If he wanted to be a Hero he would need to learn control, even with the darkest part of himself.

He took a big drink of his tea.

[I'll do it.]

Standing outside the door of his classroom, he was unbelievably nervous. His hands were shaking, and his throat seemed to be closing.

Anxiety bubbled up his throat and made it hard to swallow. Aizawa and Kacchan stood next to him, both of them silently urging him to open the door. How would his classmates react? Would they accept him and everything that he'd done?

Or would they look at him like some sort of monster, who deserved to be in jail with his villain of a mother? He really didn't want to find out. Against his better judgement, he slid open the door, and ventured inside.

For a moment, he stood in the doorway and there was nothing but silence. He kept his head down, refusing to look up and make eye-contact with his classmates. He clenched his trembling fists, and went to make his way to his seat.

"Midoriya," It was Todoroki who spoke, his voice soft with a hint of understanding and pity. Izuku looked up hesitantly, and stopped in his tracks. Todoroki was holding out a box with both hands. The package was wrapped in wrapping paper, and Izuku stared at it in confusion. "It's for you,"

Izuku took the gift and unwrapped it with a hint of uncertainty. He looked up at Todoroki in confusion once more. "Uhh," Todoroki began awkwardly, pointing at Shinsou who had been shuffling his feet the entire time. "Yesterday me and Shinsou stole my dad's credit card and we didn't know what to get you… so we got you chocolate?"

"Everyone likes chocolate," Shinsou affirmed, "I hope?"

Izuku could feel his eyes stinging, and the rest of his classmates got to their feet as well. "Oh, I wrote you a card Mido!" Mina exclaimed, with a wide smile. "Everyone signed it!"

"I baked you cookies," Satou mumbled, holding out a bag of cookies.

"I made you a new, state of the art phone, with a built-in tracker! It even has a flash-light, and a meditation app already installed!" Yaoyorozu exclaimed, "You don't have to accept it if you don't want to,"

“I know it’s not much!” Iida said, chopping his hands. “But I made an extra copy of all the notes you missed!”

“Me and Dark Shadow got you a weighted blanket,” Tokoyami said, and Dark Shadow nodded enthusiastically. “Kouda helped us pick it out,”

Izuku could feel tears streaming down his face as each and every one of his classmates offered him a gift or a card.

“Aw, why are you crying?” Uraraka asked.

“Have we offended you, Dark One?” Tokoyami asked frantically.

“Oh no! He’s crying, Fumi! *He’s crying!”* Dark Shadow sounded horrified.

“It’s because he’s happy, ya damn extras!” Kacchan exclaimed, “Now back the fuck up before you freak him out!”

Izuku sucked in a deep breath, wiping at his endless tears. Maybe… just maybe he could finally start calling his classmates his friends for the first time in his life.

But, a nagging voice in his mind mumbled, *for how long?*

Chapter End Notes

Here's the link to the discord server link if you're interested!!

Chapter 43

Chapter Notes

>:DDDDDD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took Izuku a moment to compose himself after what had happened in the classroom. But afterward, the warm fuzzy feeling in his chest dissipated and was replaced with something else.

Dread.

As a class, they headed to one of Yuuei's gym, gym Gamma to train their Quirks. Everyone was dressed in their hero costumes except for Izuku. His had been completely destroyed during the U.S.J. and he was honestly debating changing it. Drastically. It wasn't his hero costume, it was All for One's. He wanted to create his own. He wanted to leave everything pertaining to All for One behind if he could.

But he could think about that later. He realized too late that class had started. Aizawa and All Might were directing the rest of his classmates, and he'd been staring off into space like a complete nutcase.

"Alright, what should I work on, All Might?" Shinsou asked although it seemed pretty obvious. He needed to figure out a way to keep his opponents from knowing how exactly his Quirk worked. Or maybe he should see if other ways of using his Quirk were viable, like an emotional response, or maybe if signing counted. All Might seemed to think for a moment, stroking his chin. He told Shinsou exactly what Izuku had been thinking.

After almost everyone had gotten a piece of advice from the Number One hero, their training began. Ectoplasm created clones of himself for all the students and scattered them across the gym to start their individual training. Izuku was the only one they hadn't talked to, and his classmates were beginning to notice.

“What kind of training is Midoriya-kun doing?” Iida asked, looking curious.

“Yeah! What kind? His Quirk is already so strong!” Uraraka pitched in. She looked excited to see what he would do. All she was going to do today was make herself float until she got too nauseous. Izuku could sympathize with her disappointment. She had probably been hoping for a more fun way of training herself. Like floating other people.

She was probably hoping she could watch him train. He didn’t want *anyone* to see what he could become.

“He’s going to be training with me and All Might,” Aizawa told her, sternly. “It’d be safer if you stayed a safe distance away. Just in case,”

“Oh, okay,” She mumbled, sounding a bit dejected, and concerned. Iida took that as his queue to leave as well, but not before shooting Izuku an energetic thumbs up. Izuku tried not to blush at the gesture. He still wasn’t used to people handing out kindness like candy. It took him a second to recover, as Kacchan got some advice from All Might.

While he waited, he took a second to admire the gym. It was huge, but that was no surprise, considering that this was Yuuei. *The* best hero school in all of Japan. The gym itself was made completely of concrete which Cementoss could manipulate by using his Quirk. Apparently he’d already come and gone, if the concrete structures were anything to go by. There were a number of mountains and walls. Cementoss must’ve been busy, and quickly conjured generic all-purpose structures.

There was the rumble of Kacchan’s explosions cutting through many of these concrete walls, and the smell of burning electricity in the air from Denki. Everyone was scattered throughout the gym, doing their own training. Iida was practicing his special move — a huge burst of speed through his engines — that he had yet to find a name for.

Mina and one of Ectoplasm’s clones were sparring. She was throwing acid around haphazardly, and Izuku could already imagine what kind of disastrous thing would happen if she didn’t chill out with the acid. After a few close calls with almost burning Aoyama’s

cloak, Ectoplasm stopped her and helped her figure out a better way to utilize her Quirk, and aim it more precisely. Izuku looked away, suddenly nervous.

Anxiety wrapped around him like a snake coiling around him, sizing him up in anticipation to eat him alive. All of his classmates had been placed a good way away from him. Aizawa and All Might were being cautious, he knew that. But his mind supplied different theories. Darker reasons, that honestly weren't true. But he believed them nonetheless.

They're afraid of me. They're afraid of what might happen if I lose control. I'm going to lose control, I'm going to lose control— it's inevitable. I'm going to hurt someone on accident—

"We should probably start with you taking your suppressor off, Young Midoriya," All Might said awkwardly. Had he been too caught up in his thoughts? All Might looked like he'd been trying to get his attention for a while.

Whoops.

Izuku hesitated, wrapping his hand around the cross itself. It was hot against his skin, but not uncomfortably so. It warded off demons, for the most part, unless Izuku needed them. It also kept him from losing control of his Quirk. And now he was about to take it off.

"I-If you're not ready yet—"

Just like ripping off a Band-Aid.

The ground trembled, and out of the corner of his eye he saw Iida trip while in the middle of practicing his new move.

The wave of searing hot power woke up beneath his skin.

It's hot. Fucking Christ.

He was sweating almost instantly. He'd been right. He was getting stronger and stronger, faster than his body could handle. There was so much pressure pressing in on him. He felt heavy and hot, like fire was burning him from the inside out.

He kept clenching his fists and jaw. Aizawa was talking but he was too busy trying to acclimate to the power. "—Midoriya,"

He wiped the sweat off his brow. Shuddering.

[What?]

"Do you need to stop?" He asked, and Izuku shook his head. Aizawa gave him a strained smile. He wasn't annoyed or angry. He looked worried. "Okay, then try to transform,"

Right. Like it's just that easy.

He had no idea how to transform. He'd never done it on his own before. All for One had just tortured him to make him do it. There was no method. No way of knowing exactly *how* and *why* he transformed. He just got angry, or scared and it happened all on its own.

"It's okay if you don't figure it out today," All Might assured him.

But Izuku didn't have much time. That could just be his anxiety talking, but his power was increasing at an alarming rate. He'd pushed himself during the U.S.J. incident. More than he had ever before.

Granted, he didn't *transform* , but he *never* wanted to transform. He wanted to avoid it as much as possible. He didn't want to be that *monster.* Izuku couldn't control that. He couldn't even control his Quirk when he *wasn't* transformed.

The demons did what they wanted most of the time. They tormented him. The only one he'd managed to truly befriend was Dabi.

He hated his Quirk. He hated the demons he could see. He hated himself, and he hated the thing he could become. But he needed to be able to control it, if nothing else. That form could easily kill anyone if Izuku didn't learn how to control it.

He just didn't know how to transform. "Try to relax," Aizawa instructed, his voice was calm and soothing. "Don't worry too much about what might happen,"

Izuku tried. He softened his jaw, and let his hands go slack at his sides. He slowed his breathing, trying to calm his rapidly beating heart. He was in control.

I'm in control. Right here. Right now.

It started with a soft, raspy whisper in his ear, as he shut his eyes. He didn't want to see All Might and Aizawa's reactions.

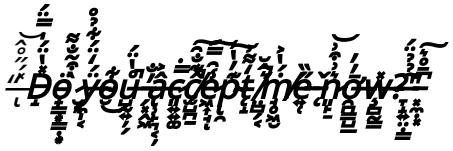


It sent chills down his spine, like someone had dumped a bucket of ice-cold water down his back, and he pressed his lips together. The air went cold, and goosebumps blossomed on his skin. A pair of cool, strong hands held either side of his face. Unable to resist the temptation he opened his eyes. It was like seeing his echo. If he were a demon.

Just like looking in a mirror.

The outline was grainy and black. But it was definitely him. There were subtle dark hints of color on the demon holding his face. He could see his black and gold eyes, he could see the wild curly hair that could only belong to himself.

The figure came into complete focus, as Izuku blinked but it was still like he was standing in a dark corner. Even though it was bright in the gym, and he could see All Might and Aizawa a few feet away, clear as day. He could see the paleness of his skin. He could see the curl of his horns, but not much else.



He gave a short nod, and the demon-like version of himself kissed him on the forehead. And suddenly he was hot all over again. Pain shot down his spine, and suddenly he was on his hands and knees, gasping at the agony.

“Midoriya!” All Might exclaimed, and Aizawa moved to come to his aid. “Do you need to stop—?”

He held up a hand, and neither of them moved. His head throbbed, and blinked away the tears in his eyes.

He’d done it.

He could tell by the looks on All Might and Aizawa’s faces. Demons were creeping in on him, and some of his classmates had stopped their own training to watch.

He didn’t remember anything after that. He just remembered being terrified.

At first, Toshinori didn't know why Aizawa would want him to help him with his lesson today. Usually Aizawa wouldn't be able to stand Toshinori's presence. He almost never wanted to involve Toshinori in any of his lessons, but earlier this morning he'd called him.

"All Might I need you to help me teach my class today," Aizawa said as soon as Toshinori answered the phone. He didn't even phrase it as a question. It left no room for argument, the way he said it.

"Why?"

There was a short pause on the other side of the phone, and for a second Toshinori was convinced that Aizawa hung up on him. "Because I'm training Midoriya tomorrow on how to control his transformation. It's safe to assume that he has no control over his other form, if his memories were any indication. And one day his Quirk Suppressor will stop working. He needs to learn how to control it before that happens,"

"What makes you think his Suppressor will stop working?" Toshinori asked. "All for One made it, I'm sure it will keep his transformations from happening,"

"His power is already increasing. And what if someone takes it from him? What will he do if he loses control? He's terrified of his own Quirk. I need you to help me, just in case he loses control,"

That's right… he almost killed All for One using it. Even if it was just a fluke.

"I'll help you,"

But he wasn't expecting this. He wasn't expecting to actually see him transform. He figured it would take a few days, or even weeks. His eyes had changed first, glowing slightly. Then the horns had sprouted.

In Midoriya's memory, he had wings, but right now they were nowhere to be seen. He saw Aizawa swallow thickly, looking weary. Midoriya rolled his shoulders back, and All Might could hear his back and neck popping from way over here.

Midoriya didn't move or say anything for a while. He didn't even seem to see him or Aizawa until Toshinori spoke.

"Young Midoriya?"

Midoriya's head whipped over into his direction, an eyebrow raised. A smile quirked at the edges of his mouth. A cruel, ugly smile.



Toshinori thought it was a weird thing to sign. Just then Aizawa whispered something incoherently, but Toshinori head the tail end of it.

"...I think we just woke something up, All Might,"

The temperature in the gym seemed to drop dramatically. It all happened so suddenly. One second, Midoriya was a few feet away, and in the next he'd closed the distance between them and knocked Aizawa out.

Toshinori's first reaction was to reach out and grab Midoriya around the neck. Midoriya laughed at him, his face twisted with emotions that didn't belong to him. The sound was deep and grating. Raspy and smooth. A cacophony of voices that didn't belong to Midoriya.

He'd lost control nearly as soon as he'd transformed.

He'd become something other than human. A monster. *This* was exactly what Midoriya had been afraid of. *This* was the monster he wanted to suppress and hide. *This* was the monster he'd been terrified to become.

He's terrified of his own Quirk.

He hadn't really understood, but now he knew.

Midoriya ripped Toshinori's arm away, and black flames exploded out of his palms. It hit Toshinori square in the face, but it didn't burn as much as he thought it would.

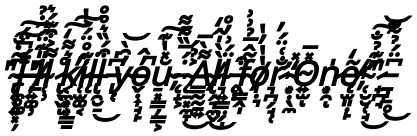
Maybe he really did have at least a semblance of control. At least enough not to burn him alive. Or maybe he wasn't fully transformed.

Midoriya lunged for him, his claws slicing open Toshinori's Golden Age hero costume. He'd managed to dodge, but blood still seeped through the small cuts Midoriya had managed to deliver.

He rushed for him again, flames licking at his hands, begging to be released. Toshinori blocked a well-aimed punch for his jaw, and jumped back when Midoriya tried to sweep his feet out from under him.

They traded blows faster than any normal person could follow. Toshinori managed to get a few successful blows, but they proved to be useless. Midoriya wanted blood. Whatever thing was possessing him didn't want to be peaceful. He wanted a fight.

I need to restrain him until Aizawa wakes up.



"What?" He blurted out, but it cost him.

He didn't see Midoriya even move, but suddenly Toshinori was shooting through the air. Pain throbbed in his stomach. Another grating laugh filled the air, as Toshinori landed. All the air left his lungs in an instant. Choking, trying to remember how to breathe, he clutched at his chest.

Midoriya pounced, pining Toshinori down with one hand, his claws mere inches away from Toshinori's exposed neck. He flinched, but then he realized that Midoriya never hit him.

Toshinori let out a relieved sigh. For a second he thought he'd been done for.

But why didn't he kill me?

Then he saw that Midoriya's other hand was stopping it, cutting deep into the skin of his scarred arm. He heard the ragged breathing, the panicked pants. Toshinori didn't dare move.

"Izuku," Bakugou mumbled suddenly, putting a hand on Midoriya's shoulder. Fear slammed into him like a freight train.

"It's not safe, Young Bakugou!"

Toshinori watched as Bakugou blatantly ignored him. “What are you doing?” He asked.

His voice was so soft, so caring, so worried. It wouldn’t work. It wouldn’t do anything because Midoriya had lost all control. He didn’t know anyone here while in this form. He wasn’t human, and Bakugou’s touches and words wouldn’t get through to him.

Horrified he watched as the rest of class 1-A got *closer* . Ectoplasm tried to keep the students away, but they kept inching closer, worried. Apparently they’d been making a lot of commotion.

“Stay away!” Toshinori exclaimed, still pinned down by Midoriya’s body. “He’s not in control! Ectoplasm get them out of here!”

Ectoplasm nodded, and Toshinori could hear him instructing the class. “We need to leave the gym. It’s not safe here,” He was saying, but his voice was trembling.

“But Deku—”

Midoriya had completely froze. He was looking over his shoulder at class 1-A. He didn’t seem too interested in Class 1-A at all, but Toshinori didn’t want to risk it.

“FUCKING GO YOU DAMN EXTRAS!” Bakugou yelled, whipping around to glare at his classmates. Toshinori watched Midoriya closely, who didn’t even blink. His hand was twitching, reaching for Toshinori’s neck. Hoping to rip it open and drain him of all his blood.

Somewhere in there he was fighting to keep himself from killing him. Just as Toshinori had been holding back to make sure he didn’t seriously injure his student.

“Midoriya,” Toshinori began.

It was the wrong thing to do.

Midoriya growled at him, and slammed his fist into the ground right next to Toshinori's head. A scream ripped from his throat, raw, raspy and deep. Angry, he pulled at his own hair and stood. He screamed again, dragging his long claws down his face.

"Izuku," Bakugou began again, as Ectoplasm guided the other students out of the gym with haste. Toshinori could see some of his classmates looking at Midoriya in horror. "I know you're in there, dumbass,"

Midoriya looked at Bakugou with a strange look in his eye. Toshinori scrambled to his feet, but he wasn't fast enough. Izuku had already grabbed Bakugou, but this was strange.

There was no malice radiating from him anymore.

He was looking at Bakugou, tilting his head this and that as if he was looking at an alien. Or like he was looking at something he didn't understand. But he never moved to attack him, and Bakugou didn't seem scared in any capacity. His hand reached up to touch Bakugou's cheek, so gentle that it was hard to believe he'd been going on a rampage not even five seconds ago.

Toshinori watched them closely, in awe. There were tears sliding down Midoriya's cheeks, but Midoriya didn't seem to notice. Bakugou wiped his tears away with his thumbs, looking so gentle and soft as he did so.

Toshinori had never seen Young Bakugou look like that before. *"Who are you? Why do you feel familiar? What is this feeling?"*

"Izuku please change back," Bakugou replied, ignoring Midoriya's questions entirely. He had Midoriya's Quirk Suppressor in his hands and held it up for him to see, and it was like Bakugou was giving a starving man food.

Midoriya took one look at it, and grabbed it like he was going to die if he didn't and put it back on hastily. The change was so quick, that Toshinori thought he missed it.

Aizawa groaned, clutching his head. He blinked a couple of times, before sitting straight up. “Where’s the kid? What happened? What’s—“

“He’s fine,” Toshinori assured him, rushing to Eraserhead’s side as soon as he was sure that Midoriya wasn’t going to turn back into that *thing.* “Are *you?”*

Eraserhead nodded, getting to his feet instantly. Toshinori felt awkward. Midoriya was practically Eraserhead’s child, and Toshinori always felt awkward when people showed affection publicly. He just felt like he was seeing something he shouldn’t.

But he couldn’t help it. He watched them anyway, feeling a little envious.

Aizawa was at Midoriya’s side almost instantly, practically breathing apologies. He was hovering over him like a mother hen, not quite touching him at all as he worried over him. Like he was too afraid that if he touched him, Izuku would push him away.

“I’m sorry,” Aizawa breathed, bending down to look at Midoriya. “I’m so sorry,”

Midoriya was quiet. Well, he was always quiet, but that’s not what Toshinori meant. His emotions made him loud, his bright smile, his always moving hands as he signed to Bakugou or Aizawa. Even his eyes were screaming *don’t look away.*

But right now? His eyes and face had gone blank. So delicately blank, and he didn’t even look like he was breathing. His hands were gripping his cross, and his shoulders were tense. He could see his jaw clenching from where he stood. “I’m so sorry,”

Midoriya tried his best to keep himself from looking at anyone, but Toshinori could see how much Midoriya wanted to accept the apology. How much *he* wanted to apologize. For something they, in-all-honesty forced him to do.

Yes, Young Midoriya has agreed *initially* to the idea, but anyone would have noticed his moment of sheer panic. It had been as soon as he'd taken the Suppressor off. The ground had trembled, and Midoriya had given Toshinori a single terrified look. And then he transformed.

Toshinori felt responsible. He felt guilty. They shouldn't have pushed him if he wasn't absolutely comfortable.

Maybe they should've taken it slow, by starting with just taking the Suppressor off until he was comfortable with his full power.

Then they should've moved on to the transformation. It was their fault this happened. Not Midoriya's.

Finally, Midoriya caved and looked Aizawa in the eye. It was the saddest thing Toshinori ever saw. Midoriya has always been like a terrified little kitten to Toshinori, but he'd never seen Midoriya so scared. Not scared of himself, or his Quirk.

But he was utterly terrified of Aizawa. He was searching his face like he was waiting for something. And it took him a moment to realize exactly what it was.

He was waiting for Aizawa to get angry. To yell. To scold him. To hit him.

It was his programmed reaction for when anything bad happened, Toshinori knew. He'd encountered many swaths of people who grew up in an abusive household during his Hero career. He knew a thing or two about victims of abuse, and it hurts to see the signs of his trauma so clearly.

The way his entire body tensed, ready for any pain, any retaliation, that he didn't realize was never coming.

It was heartbreaking. And he could see it in how Aizawa frowned. Hesitantly he reached out to hold Midoriya. "I'm so sorry,"

Midoriya seemed to melt into Aizawa’s arms as he cried.

Chapter End Notes

Here's the link to the discord server link if you're interested!!

also what he says in order:

Hello

Do you accept me now?

Good morning.

I'll kill you All for One. -Izuku mistaking All Might for AfO which is why he went crazy. You could say that AfO and OfA have very similar power signatures.

Who are you? Why do you feel familiar? What is this feeling?

Act Five: The Prince of Darkness

Chapter Notes

edit 12/7/2020: His hero name to Morningstar :))

Izuku was exhausted, his joints seemed to creak with his every movement. Everything hurt. It was kind of his fault for losing control, and attacking All Might. He had no one to blame his exhaustion other than himself.

He didn't even make it to his room, once he got to Aizawa's apartment. He passed out on the couch, Eclipse purring on his chest. That's when it happened.

His dream — the first dream he'd had in months — was dark and strange. Wherever he was, it was hot. And dark, so dark.

He could feel sweat beading on his forehead and pooling in his palms like poison. Izuku's breathing hitched and quickened. He had a feeling, an inkling, of where he was. Of what he was dreaming of.

No, no, no.

His heart was ready to burst in his chest, and he could feel fear clawing at the very core of him. Every inch of his skin was crawling and set aflame with terror.

He couldn't stop the shaking.

It's so dark.

A cacophony of screams sounded all around him. Tortured screams, of those who were damned for all eternity to burn within the pits of hell. His voice joined the fray. Shrill and shrieking.

He was burning. Burning, burning, burning. This was Hell. His skin seemed to blister and pop in the pitch black darkness.

"Dear child, you are Lucifer Morningstar. King of Hell, cast out of the most holy place of all, Heaven. By God himself. Musician of death and destruction. Harbinger of doom and death. Leader of the armies of hell. The Dark Lord of all things unholy, and tainted. Heavy weighs the crown, dear boy. You've accepted me, and so you've accepted your power, don't forget that. Cast away your false wings from God, and adorn the crown forged in the pits of hell,"

I don't want it. I don't, I don't—

"Izuku…"

No. Stop. No, no!

"Lucifer…"

He thrashed and screamed. Something grabbed him, and—

He woke up gasping, what felt like seconds later. It must've been hours, though because when he'd gone to sleep the sun had set. Now it was rising again. With a heavy sigh, he pushed the dark visions of his dream from his mind.

Trembling, he sat up. Everything was swimming, but he still managed to get to his feet. The apartment was quiet as he went into his room to get dressed. He still wasn't used to living here with Aizawa and Hizashi, but it wasn't unpleasant. They were *nice* to him, unlike his parents. They didn't hit him, or curse at him. For once he was somewhere safe, away from the constant ever growing pressure that came with living with his mom.

The only con he could think of about this place was that his room was always dark, like his room at home had been. Yes, he could easily turn on a light and solve that problem once and for all, but he couldn't sleep with the lights that bright.

He closed the door behind him and flicked on the lights. The muscles in his back relaxed slightly, as he went straight for the dresser positioned next to his bed. It had his dress shirts and pants inside, along with his pajamas and his assortment of hoodies. He grabbed a dress shirt at random, and a pair of pants. They were all the same.

He went into his closet and grabbed a blazer and tie. For a second he debated getting dressed in his room, but he ultimately decided that after yesterday's incident he needed a shower. Desperately.

Izuku felt strange ever since he transformed. His body felt lighter, and his power increased even *more.*

It was like he plugged into a battery. A very large, and powerful battery. One that he had yet to unplug from. And nothing could stop the power from flowing into him. Not even as he wore his cross around his neck. It wasn't as nearly effective as it had been. The power slept usually beneath his skin, begging for release and ready to destroy. Now? It was awake, and angry.

Maybe transforming had been a mistake. He had attacked All Might, and knocked out Aizawa before he came back to his senses. So Izuku wanted to wash away all of what happened yesterday, as best as he could. He went into the bathroom, passing by a small dark figure on the way. A demon, no doubt.

He ignored it, even as it tugged on his sleeve.

How long ago had it been since they gained the ability to touch him? Were they also getting stronger as he got stronger? Maybe that was why they'd become corporeal without his help.

Scared, he pushed those thoughts away, into the deep depths of his mind until he could stand thinking about them. He couldn't even take his cross off without being terrified. How could he think about anything else pertaining to his Quirk? He was too scared.

Eager to stop thinking, he jumped in the shower, letting the hot water soothe his aching muscles. His small paradise inside the shower was short-lived however. He needed to get dressed.

Aizawa and Hizashi would probably be getting up soon, and he didn't want to be caught hogging the bathroom. He dried himself off and got halfway dressed when he saw it in the mirror.

At first glance, his reflection had been normal. The ghostly pale skin, the bags under his eyes, the haunted, horrified look he always seemed to wear.

But there was something wrong. Something strange. Something he hadn't noticed when he went into the bathroom, even though he should've. It wasn't easy to miss, at all.

His fingers brushed his forearm, tracing the tattoo-like markings. Swirling light grey markings covered a lot of his skin. His arm, his shoulder, and when he turned around to look at his back, there were some there too.

How did I not notice them?

He was quick to get dressed, not eager to know the answer. He also didn't want to risk Aizawa or Hizashi waking up and seeing them. He pulled on his shirt, and tied his tie to the best of his ability.

He grabbed his blazer —he would put it on in the car— and left the bathroom. Aizawa was in the kitchen, with *two* entire cups of coffee. As he got closer he realized he'd polished off the first one, and was nursing the second one.

“You’re up early,”

[And that’s a lot of coffee.]

“Do you want a sip?” Aizawa offered, lifting up the mug. “You look exhausted, Midoriya,”

[No.]

Aizawa downed the rest of it one go. “It’s four a.m., and school doesn’t start until nine. What’s wrong?”

[Nothing.]

“You sure?”

Izuku nodded. [Why are you up so early?]

“I saw you leave your room and I was worried. Yesterday...it didn’t go as planned. I was afraid we went too far. You obviously weren’t ready.”

[It’s fine.]

“I promise we’ll go slow next time.”

Izuku could feel his chest tightening, and his face flush. *Next time? There was going to be a next time?*

[Next time?]

“You have to learn how to control it,” Aizawa said as a way of explanation. “Nedzu already agreed to help us. He has rooms underneath Yuuei that he’s allowed us to use. It’s perfectly safe. You won’t hurt anyone next time,”

[I don’t want to.]

“We won’t start working on the transformation yet. With some guidance from Nedzu we’re starting to come up with a plan for you. We should never have started with your transformation first. You haven’t even mastered the basics of your Quirk yet without the suppressant. If I promise never to force you to transform, will you try?”

But what if he couldn’t do it? What if there was too much power, more than he could ever hope to control and master? What if Nedzu was wrong, and those rooms weren’t safe? What if he ended up hurting someone?

But… maybe he should put his trust in Aizawa for once. Maybe he *could* do it. Maybe he really could use his power, as evil as it was, to do some good. Even Lucifer used to be an angel. Maybe it wasn’t all evil? But he had to master it to find that out.

[Okay. When do we start?]

“As soon as you're ready,” Aizawa replied. He stood from his seat and walked over to the coffee maker. He poured more coffee into his mug, but didn’t add anything to it. Not any creamer, or sugar.

He drank it straight black.

“So, since we’ve got some time… Would you like to spar with me?”

His grin was an answer in itself. They went into the training room that he and Aizawa sparred in when he first moved in. When he'd been here last time he'd been worried about Hizashi. It was the day after he twisted his arm, and he was scared that Hizashi was angry.

This time he was just exhausted, and his mind wouldn't let him sleep. His power was beating through him like a drug, his body was tired, but he was too awake. He rolled his shoulders and Aizawa watched him for a moment.

Izuku watched him too, waiting for Aizawa to make the first move. He was eager to forget about these nagging thoughts, even if it was for a little while. It was better than nothing.

Izuku was thoroughly exhausted by the time he made it to class, Aizawa trailing behind him trying to stifle a yawn. He could relate. All he wanted to do was go to bed, and not wake up for days, if he had the option.

"Oh shit," Aizawa grumbled, stopping suddenly. "I need to go talk to Nedzu about your training. Go ahead to class, I'll be a bit late,"

Izuku nodded, and left him. When he got closer to the classroom Izuku caught parts of conversations that his classmates were having. He wished he hadn't.

"He was so scary yesterday…"

They had to be talking about what happened yesterday. He bitterly thought back to yesterday, where everyone seemed to be on his side. Izuku's frown deepened. Of course he couldn't trust them to be his friends. Of course. He was the devil.

“Did you see him knock Aizawa-sensei unconscious without breaking a sweat? I can’t believe his Quirk is so out of control,” Sero.

“You can’t blame him though!” He could recognize Uraraka’s voice easily. “His entire life he’s been afraid of what he can do. And the *one* time he actually feels safe enough to try to use it at its full potential, he hurts someone by accident!”

A swell of gratitude filled his chest.

“It’s a villain's Quirk,” Denki mumbled softly. “It’s evil,”

“*Shut up*,” Shinsou said. Izuku could recognize his bored, monotone voice. It reminded him of Aizawa a lot. He strained his ears to hear what he said next. “Why would you say that about someone? He’s our classmate, and just the other day you told me you know how it feels for people to hate you for your Quirk, you’re being hypocritical,”

“You’re only saying that because you’re afraid of what he’d do if he found out we were saying stuff like this about him,” Mina replied, “Aren’t you?”

“Why is this important?” Todoroki asked, “I’m wondering where Aizawa-sensei is. He’s late, and so are Midoriya and Bakugou.”

“Midoriya probably got expelled for what he did.”

“Why are you guys being so mean?” Kirishima asked, “It was obviously an accident. He’s never had much training with that aspect of his Quirk. Can’t we just respect him for being manly enough to try?”

“But that was scary...you have to admit. He almost *killed* All Might,”

“Have you ever thought about how scary it must’ve been for Midoriya?” Iida asked, and Izuku could just imagine him making quick chopping motions with his arms to emphasize the point. “We have no idea what it’s like to be Midoriya. When he transformed he had no *control.”*

He couldn’t help feeling a wave of gratitude for what Iida said. They weren’t that close, but he still stood up for him even when he didn’t have to.

Against his better judgement, Izuku opened the door only slightly to look inside the classroom. He wanted to see exactly what was happening.

Everyone was standing around Denki’s desk, in a group. Talking about *him* . Iida was red in the face, obviously angry. Uraraka was in a similar state, while Shinsou looked ready to pick a fight.

“Then he shouldn’t have transformed at all!” Now Mina was yelling. She threw her hands up in the air.

“You’re saying you want him to suppress his own power? Quirks are a *part* of a person. You can’t just ask him to do that,” Uraraka mumbled.

“We should just drop it,” Todoroki commented, his eyes flashing with fire. And so much dangerous, dangerous anger. “We’re all training to become heroes, and all you guys want to do is talk shit on Midoriya?”

“Fine. I’ll shut up,” Mina grumbled, and Izuku waited until she was in her seat to actually come inside the room. It was deathly silent. No one said a thing, not that he expected them to. Conversation wasn’t really one of his strong suits. It was probably too much of a hassle for anyone to talk with him.

He pushed the feelings of hurt away to the back of his mind. He would be fine. This was fine. It didn’t hurt. He was used to it. When had he not been stepped on, ridiculed, and hurt? This feeling was familiar. It was home.

“Speak of the devil, and he shall appear,” Mina whispered softly, but Izuku still heard it. He pretended he didn’t. It was like getting slapped twice. He thought what she said before stung, but her saying something like that almost to his face hurt worse.

The silence resumed, more tense and awkward than before. Izuku played with his pencil in his hand, twirling it around his fingers.

Kirishima was the first to approach him. He gave Izuku a warm, genuine smile, as he came to stand next to his desk. Izuku returned the smile, though his was a little more wary.

“Hey Midoriya!” he said, finally breaking the silence. “How are you? After yesterday, I mean. It must’ve been scary,”

Izuku awkwardly reached for a piece of paper before he wrote his response. Kirishima was blessedly patient, and eager for a response. He bounced on the tip of his toes lightly and gave Izuku another one of his smiles.

Izuku handed him the piece of paper.

Tired. And it was scary. I hurt All Might and Aizawa-sensei. I shouldn’t have done it at all. I knew I wasn’t strong enough to control my Quirk.

“Don’t beat yourself up about it! It would’ve happened to any of us if we had a Quirk like yours.” He paused for a second. “Anyway, have you seen Aizawa-sensei? He’s really late—”

“Sit down, kids,”

Ah. There he was, looking even more exhausted than he had been previously. Nedzu probably talked his ear off about theories, and lost track of time. That’s why he was later than Izuku thought he’d be.

Everyone took their seats quickly, afraid of what Aizawa-sensei would do. Izuku watched as Aizawa made his way to the front of the classroom. “So, as many of you know, the Sports Festival is coming up fast. Today we’ll be coming up with hero names for all of you, except for Bakugou, who seems to be absent today,”

At the last bit, Aizawa looked at Izuku. He shrugged. Kacchan hadn’t texted him or anything about being absent today. He couldn’t help but be a little worried. What if he was hurt? What if he was sick?

He decided he’d text him at lunch. Just to check up on him. He was probably fine. Kacchan was fine.

“Unfortunately, I'm no good at Hero Names, so Midnight will be helping you choose,” Aizawa continued, despite Izuku’s wandering thoughts. It was kind of hard to focus on what he was saying when he was busy worrying about Kacchan.

He barely noticed Midnight as she entered the classroom. Her scandalous outfit made him a little uncomfortable, but he admired her confidence to pull it off. He could never manage something like that. Not that he’d ever dress like that, he was too conservative.

A little ironic considering he was the devil in disguise.

“Hello, little kittens!” She exclaimed, holding her whip in a *very* suggestive way. Gross. He could tell that it made Aizawa second guess everything he’d ever done in his life. “As Aizawa so kindly put it, I’ll be helping you out with your hero names! You have five minutes to come up with an idea and present it to the class! Begin!”

Five minutes later, Denki was the first one to go up.

“Ahem! My hero name is...!” He paused, before turning his board around to face everyone. “Charge-bolt!”

“Should’ve been Pikachu,” Sero murmured, sounding slightly disappointed.

“Sero you’re up next!” Midnight said, pointing at him with the whip in her hand. He picked at his nails. His heart twisted in his chest, sick with a nagging feeling that he'd been betrayed. Sero, Denki and Mina didn't like him. They feared him, and they were acting like they hadn't been talking about him mere minutes ago.

“Okay, okay.” Sero took a turn at the front of the classroom. Izuku didn't even look up. “My hero name is Tape Arms,”

Denki was cackling. Full-on holding his stomach, doubled over, crying.

Everyone took turns, with Iida’s name being Izuku’s favorite by far. Emergency Exit. Shinsou’s was particularly interesting. Control Freak.

Next thing he knew, he was the last one. Midnight gave him a grin, and he could tell she was excited to see what he came up with. “Midoriya, you’re last! What did you think up?”

It was strangely tense, as he stood. People in this room were scared of him. Of what he could do, and the monster that slept beneath his skin. Something wicked.

He held his dry-erase board close to him, as he came to stand in the front. His hero name wasn’t a name a hero should have. It wasn’t the name of a hero. Definitely not the name of a hero who could possibly surpass All Might.

It was his nonetheless. His name. His true name, the name God gave him when he fell from paradise. When he fell from Heaven.

He turned the board around to face his classmates, and waited silently for their reaction. If they called him the devil, then he would embrace it. Just not in a way that anyone would

recognize right off the bat.

THE BRINGER OF LIGHT: MORNINGSTAR

“I love it!” Midnight exclaimed, “It’s beautiful, it’s meaningful, it’s— it’s—”

“Damn I wish I came up with something that cool,” Tokoyami grumbled, and Izuku smiled slightly.

Izuku was the harbinger of Light. God’s Favorite Son. Or at least he used to be. Now he was the symbol of all things evil. Of all the sins of mankind. He was the Devil, the ruler of the flames. Leader of the Legions of hell. But that didn't mean he was a villain. They may scorn him, and berate him for his power, but he had always wanted to be a Hero. He *was* the Prince of Darkness, but he'd been a bringer of light at one time too.

Even Satan used to be an angel, right?

Chapter 45

Chapter Notes

> So, I'd like to start off by apologizing for my (completely unintentional) break from writing! Worry not, for i've been editing while i've been on this break. I should be done soon, and back to writing. :DDDDD (I was totally not playing the Spirit Blossom Event in LoL...)
>
> **Edit: I changed Izuku's hero name!! Thank you everyone who gave me ideas!**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After they all chose their hero names, they went to lunch. It was horrible going to lunch without Kacchan by his side to be his buffer. Now he *had* to deal with everyone in the cafeteria. Now he had to face his classmates, who obviously hated him, and were afraid of him. Or he could ignore them, and continue on with his day like his entire class hadn't said anything. But was that really an option? What would they think if they saw him isolating himself?

They'd think he was even creepier than before. They'd find more reasons to talk behind his back about everything he did, or tried to do. They just needed to direct their fear at something, and conveniently enough, Izuku was the perfect candidate. All of them had seen his past, seen what he'd been through, and seen the things he'd seen.

Personally, in his humble opinion, that should've been enough to make them less afraid of him. But yesterday's spectacular fail ruined any chance of them seeing him as a friend instead of a foe. He *had* been a villain for a time, technically. He was under All for One's command, and he'd done anything the man asked of him, but when it mattered the most, he pulled away from it. He saved himself.

But that would never be enough. They would still talk about him like he was still a villain, still dancing this dangerous dance with a villainous mastermind.

And he had to go into the cafeteria, and deal with them. The entire thirty minutes of lunch would be painfully awkward. He almost didn't leave the classroom when Aizawa dismissed them. He nearly laid his head down on his desk and took a nap.

But then Aizawa would question it. And then he would eventually find out the truth, and who knows what his reaction would be? Would he agree with them? Would he be angry at them, or angry at Izuku?

It was a gamble. And he honestly couldn't be bothered to make it worse than it already was.

Maybe he could nap in the lunchroom. Or maybe the bathroom. He'd done it once or twice before when Kacchan had gotten sick and missed school.

As a class, 1-A left to head to the cafeteria. Mina, Denki and Sero were talking in hushed whispers. Probably secretly carrying on their earlier conversation.

Izuku really didn't want to spend his lunch in the bathroom, hungry out of his mind. But maybe that was the better option. Maybe—

"Hey, Midoriya!" Kirishima called, his voice carrying easily due to his volume and lack of an inside voice. "Wanna sit together?"

"Hey, I wanted to ask," Uraraka pouted, grabbing Izuku by the arm as she passed, and dragged him into the lunch line.

"We can all sit with him, can't we?" Shinsou said, "There are plenty of empty tables around."

"He's right!" Iida pointed out, using his pointer finger to slide his glasses up his nose. "I brought my lunch, so I can go ahead and get us one,"

“Yay! Thanks, Iida-kun! You’re the best!”

This was weird. He wasn’t used to this. Why were they coming up to him and talking to him? Why were they wanting to sit with him at a table? This was *strange.* This wasn’t what he was expecting, at all. Maybe this wouldn’t be so bad after all.

The line went pretty quickly, and they ordered. Shinsou asked him what he’d like, and then they all sat down at the table Iida had claimed for them. They all kept the conversation flowing, and never left him out for a single second. Someone would ask him about his opinion on something, and Shinsou would translate his signing into speech.

It worked pretty well, honestly. They were strangely engaged in everything he had to say.

“So,” Todoroki began, speaking for the first time in a few minutes. “You heard everything everyone else said about you,”

Izuku looked at him with wide eyes. Uraraka opened her mouth to say something, but closed it in the end. After a second, Todoroki elaborated. “I could tell you heard it. You looked upset when you got to class,”

Izuku shrugged. [It’s fine.]

“No, it’s not.” Shinsou snapped, catching Izuku by surprise at his firmness. “They have no right to talk about you like that. We *all* got a front-row seat to what you experienced. They should’ve been more understanding,”

“Yeah! They were being ridiculous, honestly. They didn’t think for one second what it feels like to be you,”

“It was honestly manly. Even if you were afraid of your own Quirk, it didn’t stop you from trying to control it,” Kirishima told him, “So don’t stop trying your best Midoriya!”

That night Kacchan texted him. It was really late at night, and Aizawa and Hizashi had gone to bed a few hours ago.

Kacchan: I lost Edgar.

Deku: What?

Kacchan: He got out of the house and we can't find him. He ran away.

Deku: Oh. Is that why you weren't at school today?

Kacchan: Yeah. My mom and dad won't stop looking for him, I promise. We put up flyers and everything. We should find him soon.

Deku: Okay. Goodnight.

He was *angry* . And sad. Chizome-san's dog was lost. He turned off his phone and threw it on his bed. His throat ached. That dog was one of the few things that he had left of his former mentor. It was a living, breathing reminder of what he'd done. Of who he killed.

Now he'd *lost* it. Lost Edgar. It shouldn't have hurt as much as it did. He shouldn't be wiping away tears from his eyes. He should be stronger than this. He shouldn't be upset.

Izuku couldn't help the shaking, or the silent tears. The silent sorrow. Technically it wasn't even his dog, nor his responsibility. Eclipse, the black cat that Aizawa and Hizashi owned somehow found her way into his room and onto his bed. He could hardly see her through the tears.

Her purring was soft, and comforting. She plopped herself down on his lap, and curled into a tight ball. He reached down to pet her, but he ended up watching her breathe. In a slow, up and down motion.

It was somehow calming. He left his phone on the opposite side of the bed, even as it pinged loudly in the silence. He knew it wasn't Kacchan's fault that Edgar got lost, but he couldn't help but feel angry at him.

He was supposed to be taking care of Edgar. And he fucking *lost* him. He sighed heavily. Maybe he should look for Edgar himself? But that was a dangerous idea. All for One had his minions searching for him. He knew it. Deep down.

He still wasn't safe. Even surrounded on all sides by heroes day and night wasn't enough to reassure him that he was safe. He would never be safe. Not for as long as All for One lived.

Damn. Now he was just making himself worry. He finally reached for his phone.

Kacchan: I'm sorry.

Deku: It's okay. Me too, I'm being unfair.

Kacchan: Well that dog is really important to you, isn't it?

Deku: Yeah.

Kacchan: I'll find him, I promise.

Deku: I know you will.

Kacchan: So...are you excited for the sports festival?

Kacchan: We have to do a speech.

Deku: We do? No thanks.

Kacchan: I'll do all the talking. Obviously.

Deku: Jeez thanks.

Kacchan: So what did I miss at school?

Deku: Sero, Ashido, and Denki are scared of me apparently, but other than that you didn't miss much.

Kacchan: Are you fucking serious?

Deku: Deadly.

Kacchan: I'll kick their asses.

Deku: Don't. Todoroki, Iida, Uraraka, Kirishima and Shinsou dealt with it.

Kacchan: Since when were we friends with the Nerd Herd?

Deku: Nerd Herd? idk.

Kacchan: Alright my mom is yelling at me. Gtg, see you tomorrow.

Deku: Kay

He ventured out of his room, restless. The apartment was dark and quiet, but he didn't care. It wasn't like he was going to be doing anything that would possibly make any noises. He wandered into the kitchen, passing a demon who was standing in the bathroom. Creepy.

He rubbed at his eyes, and he debated grabbing a glass of water. He was too awake to go to bed. He needed to distract himself, or at least make the most of his time. Maybe he should train?

Izuku ventured into his room. He found his sword on the floor and was about to leave his room when his closet door opened. It was slow, so slow he almost didn't notice it. His limbs froze. His mouth went dry, and he could feel his heart nearly stop dead in his chest.

Just a demon. That's all it is.

He was wrong. What came out wasn't a demon. It was worse. Every single thought left him, the air got sucked out of his lungs. He could feel every inch of him shaking.

He couldn't even scream.

“You can’t escape me, my boy.” his voice was exactly as he remembered it. Rough and falsely sweet. “You’re *mine.”*

He couldn’t tear his eyes away from All for One and his broad shoulders. His scarred face. His impeccable suit, never out of place. All for One closed the distance between them, a cruel smile pulling at his lips.

“Don’t forget that. You’re a villain,” All for One whispered, leaning down slightly to be level with Izuku. Izuku took a tentative step back, his sword forgotten on the ground. “Aren’t you?”

He blinked, and All for One was gone. But… Just a second ago he’d been right in front of him…

“Honey, what’re you looking at?”

Izuku jumped out of his skin, whipping his head to the source of the voice. It was Hizashi, standing in his doorway, looking concerned. He flicked on the lights, and Izuku felt all his muscles relax.

[Nothing. It’s fine.]

“Are you sure?”

He nodded, and Hizashi smiled at him. “Okay. Let me know if you need me,”

I won’t.

He took a deep breath, and plopped down on his bed. What happened? What *was* that? It couldn't have been All for One in the flesh, that was for sure. If it had been, he would've been dragged back to the villains in an instant. He would've been *dead* .

"Are you sure you're okay?" Hizashi asked, his voice soft with a hint of concern. Izuku had completely forgotten he was there. Hizashi had taken upon himself to take a seat on the edge of his bed. It made him nervous, it made the hairs on the back of his neck stand up.

He still wasn't completely used to being around people who *didn't* want to hurt him. He really didn't know how to act, or react to anything Aizawa and Hizashi did. It was foreign territory, and he still hadn't had the chance to acclimate.

He nodded again, not daring to look at Hizashi. He was afraid the lie would show on his face, and Hizashi would notice. Maybe he'd *already* noticed.

Come to think of it, did Izuku wake him up? Had he made a noise when he saw All for One? Maybe he was angry, and he was probably waiting for him to let his guard down before he hit him. *Damn it.*

"You saw something, didn't you?" Hizashi asked, "Yuki's Quirk does have that side-effect, actually. Did she forget to mention that?"

Izuku looked at him with wide eyes, and Hizashi took it as confirmation.

"What did you see?" He asked.

[All for One.]

Hizashi took a sharp intake of breath, and suddenly crushed him in a hug. "Oh, honey. It's okay. You're safe here,"

The feeling of arms around him — arms and hands that had no intention of hurting him — was unfamiliar, but not unwelcome. He melted into it, albeit hesitantly. “You’ll always be safe here,”

Shouta knew this was far from overdue. Of course it was. It had been a while since the entire memory incident, and the reveal of Shinsou and Todoroki’s horrible and honestly *unacceptable* home life.

Shinsou, with his neglectful pair of foster parents, who seemed to fear him just because of his Quirk. Todoroki, with his abusive father, the Number Two hero Endeavor. Of course, Nedzu had pulled them both out of their homes, putting them temporarily in the Teachers Dorms as they finally finished furnishing the Class 1-A Dorms.

The Dorms themselves wouldn’t be open to Class 1-A until after the Sports Festival, but Shouta and Nedzu had decided to make an exception for Todoroki and Shinsou. They needed a place of their own, alongside their classmates when they finally moved in.

For now Shinsou and Todoroki would have each other for company, aside from Hizashi and Nemuri, who promised to visit them constantly. Nemuri had said her reasoning behind this was due to the fact that she couldn’t trust them to not burn down the building trying to cook something.

Hizashi had been outright with his reasons for volunteering to take care of Shouta’s students. He’d said almost word for word that he would love to father them and force them to play board games.

Shouta rolled his eyes at the thought of his husband being quiet long enough to sit down and play a board game. Much less act as a fatherly figure for two students.

Shouta would just have to check on them occasionally. Or maybe he'd make Power Loader do it. He was much better with kids than Shouta was.

Either way, here he was, standing outside the dorms, waiting for Shinsou and Todoroki to arrive from the Teachers Dorms.

When they finally did, Shouta instantly felt a form of kinship between him and Shinsou, who looked like he just woke up.

"Well, as both of you know, Nedzu has finally allowed both of you to enter the Class 1-A dorms while we decide on more permanent housing outside of school,"

Shinsou just yawned, and Todoroki watched both of them with a bored stare.

With a sigh, Shouta gestured for them to go inside and he showed them around the building briefly. Then he showed them their rooms, which he went ahead and placed next to each other.

"Power Loader and All Might are going to help you move in today, and Present Mic and Midnight will check up on you both before it's lights out. I expect both of you to be asleep by midnight," Shouta told them, "You can go ahead and start unpacking. Power Loader and All Might should be waiting at the Teacher Dorms for you,"

As the two of them left, Shouta let out a relieved sigh. He was glad that his students were safe now, and away from their abusers.

He was glad he was part of saving them.

The day of the Sports Festival finally arrived. Izuku didn't know whether or not to be excited about it, honestly. He didn't want to participate, but he didn't want to disappoint Kacchan, who was *really* eager for them to partake in it together.

They were changing in the locker room — Izuku changing as fast as he could manage. He didn't want anyone to see his scars — and he was standing around waiting for Kacchan. They were all supposed to gather at the stadium in a few minutes, and the both of them were supposed to give a speech. Well, Kacchan would give the speech.

It still made him antsy and nervous. All eyes would be on them. Everyone would be looking at him—

"Nerd ya ready?" Kacchan asked, tapping him on the shoulder to get his attention. Izuku blinked and cleared his thoughts. Kacchan would be the one talking, and with any luck, Kacchan would be the one winning too.

Izuku nodded, and the two of them left to hang beside Aizawa-sensei while they waited for the rest of the class. "Are you excited?" Kacchan asked, "We'll be on live television!"

Izuku's face soured, and he saw Aizawa's lips twitch upward into a smile. "If he's anything like me, he's going to hate every second of today," Aizawa told him.

"C'mon Deku, how are you supposed to show yourself to the world if you hate being on TV?" Kacchan asked, slinging an arm around his shoulders. Izuku smirked.

[I'll just hide behind you the entire time. People are bound to notice me.]

"You can't just hide behind me all your life," Kacchan grumbled, "We're gonna be heroes, Deku. You need to tell the world that today,"

“Unfortunately, he’s correct,” Aizawa mumbled, “Right now is a really good time for you to get some attention from Pro Heroes who will want to take you on as their sidekick.”

“Oh? Are you not excited?” Uraraka asked, appearing out of the women’s locker room first. She was chipper as ever, her cheeks a rosy pink as she spoke to him. She was soft, comforting.

Izuku shook his head. “Aw, why not? Are you nervous?” Uraraka asked, but without waiting for an answer she kept chatting. “I’m nervous too! Everyone in Japan will be watching us!”

Everyone in Japan… That would include All for One, too.

He felt even sicker than before. *Shit. Shit. Shit. All for One will be watching…*

“Uh, Deku are you okay?” Uraraka asked. “You look ready to pass out,”

He nodded, despite how nauseous it made him feel. [Fine.]

“He said he’s fine,” Kacchan told her. “You do look really pale though…”

[Fine.]

“—I’m excited!” Denki exclaimed. “We get to compete in front of everyone!”

“I know right?!” Sero replied, “I finally get a chance to show off!”

Izuku let his hands rest slack at his sides, and looked anywhere but at his classmates. He couldn’t forget what they’d said about him the other day. Not even if he tried. It was stuck to him like a plague.

“It’s a villain’s Quirk. It’s evil.”

“He was so scary yesterday…”

He couldn’t forget. His Quirk was dangerous. *He* was dangerous. Honestly, could he blame them? He *had* hurt Aizawa. He almost *killed* All Might. All of that was true. There was no reason that they *shouldn’t* be afraid of him.

Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line, pushing past the heaviness in his chest. One day he’d get control. One day they wouldn’t be afraid of him. Maybe this was his first *real* step. Even if he was terrified to step out into the sight of the cameras, he had to make the most of his chance. He had to get the attention of a Hero who could help him get that control he so desperately needed. He had to rip apart the fear holding him down. He had to embrace the horror of his Quirk.

He had to do it.

“Is everyone ready to go?” Aizawa-sensei asked, his tired eyes glancing back and forth between his students. There were a handful of nods, and they were on their way.

The stadium was already thundering with roars of excitement and applause when they got there. All the seats were full, and there were already Heroes watching. The other classes had already gathered, so Kacchan and he were directed to the stage, where they’d make their speech.

“And finally, the two who tied for First Place in the Entrance Exam shall make their speech!” Midnight exclaimed. Izuku could feel his eye twitch. She was holding that scandalous whip again, playing with it like a toy.

Izuku hesitantly climbed the short steps up onto the stage, and stood before the microphone with Kacchan. The stadium went deathly quiet, and Izuku could already feel the heat of a blush blossom across his face.

Too many people. Too many eyes. Too much attention. Kacchan took the microphone rather roughly, and smirked at the crowd. “There will come a day,” Kacchan began intensely, “Where All Might falls, and a new Symbol of Peace will take his place.”

The stadium was utterly quiet in awe. Izuku didn’t think that *this* was what he was going to speak about in his speech. What was he *saying* ? Was he going to tell everyone that he was going to fill that role? He could easily see Kacchan doing that.

It was in his blood, in his soul. It was his *dream.*

“Right now, you may not know who it will be,” Kacchan said, “But I do. I've known for a long time. Some may say that this person’s Quirk is a Quirk fit for a villain. Some may say that he *should’ve* been a villain. I know you all might think the same thing, but by the end of today you won’t be able to deny his strength.”

Is he talking in third person?

“The name of the next Symbol of Peace is… *Izuku Midoriya!”*

I’m gonna kill him.

Kacchan slung an arm around his shoulders. The cheers were instantaneous. Hungry and exhilarated. They saw it as a direct challenge — and a bit of a middle finger — to All Might. They wanted to see if Izuku would live up to it. They wanted to *see* what Kacchan was talking about.

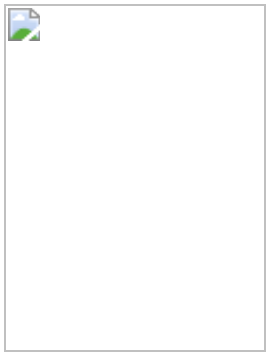
They wanted to see the next Symbol of Peace. They didn’t know yet that Izuku was *nothing* like All Might.

Chapter End Notes

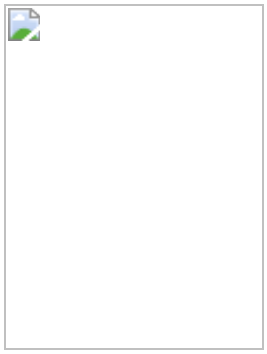
By the amazingly talented shinsou stan in the discord!!



Made by reghin in the discord :DD



By qween :0000



Thank you to everyone who takes time to make fanart for this wonderful fic!!!

Chapter 46

Chapter Notes

The beginning of the Sports Festival! Hope you like my canon divergence?

After their speech — as one-sided as it was — was over, he and Kacchan joined the rest of their class. Everyone was looking at Kacchan, at *him* , in awe. Some looked pissed off. Some, mostly people from other classes looked utterly confused.

Izuku glared at Kacchan too. [Why did you say that?]

“Because it’s the truth,” Kacchan replied, smiling. “And… to warn our classmates that I know what they said about you. They know I'm coming for revenge,”

[That’s ominous.]

“Good. I’m channeling my inner Deku,” Kacchan told him, with a soft laugh. “I’ll make sure they know who to *really* be afraid of,”

[Be nice.]

“They’re the ones who need to be nice,” Kacchan said icily, “They’re being mean to you, Deku. I won’t stand by and let them.”

“Ya know,” A voice said, full of a smile. “I’m starting to like your boyfriend, Izuku,”

Izuku could feel the embarrassment coating his face in a red, angry blush.

Dabi had summoned himself, without permission. He couldn't do that without the sword being nearby, which could only mean one thing. Aizawa must be close by then, with his weapon. He glared at Dabi, his mouth slightly open in surprise. Did he *really* just say that?!

Kacchan choked, and whipped his head around to glare at Dabi. "Are you fuckin' serious, scarface?"

"And there goes all my respect," Dabi drawled. Izuku sighed heavily, and Dabi disappeared into thin air. Great. What a way to ruin the moment.

The screen behind Midnight suddenly flickered on, and it filtered quickly between different options: an obstacle course, a race, and even a puzzle. Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line, waiting. What would the first one be?

He hoped it wasn't the obstacle course. He absolutely *loathed* them. Plus, with his luck, Todoroki would excel at it. Maybe he'd do better in an event where they had to fight head to head. Midnight took her spot in the center of the platform again and started up her introduction. "Without further ado, let's see what our first event is!"

He watched the screen anxiously, and finally it stopped. He could already feel sweat pooling in his palms. The event selection was probably rigged. Midnight was probably happy to watch them all squirm and worry. Izuku pushed away his anxiety. He needed to channel his inner-Kacchan. He shouldn't worry, and he shouldn't hold back. He needed to show the world his strength.

He needed to show everyone that Kacchan was right. He could do at least that, or try his hardest. All he had to do was pretend there weren't any cameras. He could do that.

While he'd been thinking, the screen had finally selected the first challenge. It was a picture of a thick forest, and over the image of the forest was two words.

Battle Royale.

“Alright everyone, listen up!” Midnight exclaimed into the mic, silencing any and all conversation between the students. “This Battle Royale challenge is relatively easy to explain. All of you will be placed in the forest with three objectives. The first one is to survive until the end of the challenge, which will be when there’s only ten of you left. The second objective, and this is optional, is to “eliminate” your fellow classmates,” There was a collective, horrified gasp.

“You have two ways of “eliminating” classmates. Either you can restrain them, and they’re automatically disqualified, or you can simply knock them out. The first option is more preferable. Eliminating a classmate grants you one point. It’s not rewarding to eliminate your competition. That’s why there’s a third objective. Collect as many points as possible, and there are two ways. We already talked about elimination, but there’s another, more rewarding route. Scattered through the forest are Teacher Cards. They’re hidden, but if you find some you’ll gain three points each.”

The screen behind her showed an example of a teacher card. The back of the card was gold, with PLUS ULTRA written in big bold letters. On the front side was a picture of All Might posing.

“Why do we need to get points, if this is a Battle Royale?” Someone in the crowd asked.

“LET ME EXPLAIN FIRST!” Midnight shouted, and nearly everyone in the stands jumped. “Ahem. At the end of the Battle Royale, the ten will be sorted according to how many points they acquired. Based on how you place, you’ll be rewarded additional points, but we’ll talk about that later, after the event.”

“Wait! Why aren’t elimination points worth more?” Bakugou shouted. Midnight grinned, and pointed at him.

“I’m glad you asked!” She answered. “It’s due to multiple reasons. It’s to give students with a less physical Quirk a chance to get points, other than fighting. It’s also to teach all of you that fighting isn’t always the most effective way of winning. Does that make sense?”

“That’s dumb—” Izuku elbowed him, and Kacchan snapped his mouth shut.

“Any other questions before we begin?”

“Yeah!” Uraraka exclaimed, “ *Where’s* the forest?”

“Under your feet,” Midnight told her, with an amused smile. “All of you please come to stand behind me, while the arena changes.”

It was fast. A hero — a hero Izuku didn’t even know, which is surprising on its own — took the spotlight.

She was tall and slender. She wore a deep emerald gown, with gold detailing. Her dress had slits on all the way up to her thighs on both sides, and tattoos of vines wrapping around her legs and arms. She even wore a crown of flowers that clashed with her deep red hair.

“Who is *that* ?” Tsuyu asked.

Midnight was the one who answered, a slight blush coloring her cheeks. “She’s a new hero, named Mother Earth. She has a Quirk called Forest that gives her the ability to create an entire forest within seconds.”

“Allow me to demonstrate,” Mother Earth said with a soft smile. The ground rumbled beneath Izuku’s feet, and he nearly face planted. It was almost like they were having an earthquake.

She knelt down, brushing her red hair behind her ear. She pressed her palms to the earth, with a warm smile. It started out with grass. It grew between her fingers, and spread across the entire floor. Then came the trees, just small saplings for now.

The woman raised herself up to full height, and the trees grew too. They creaked and groaned as they grew faster than what should've been possible. Their branches sprouted outward, growing leaves right before his eyes.

It was like magic. Real, tangible magic right before his eyes. Where there was nothing before, there now stood a forest. "Alright! Thank you for your assistance Mother Earth!" Midnight exclaimed, the slight blush on her cheeks deepening. "Aizawa-sensei will scatter the Teacher Cards, and then we can begin!"

Right on time, Aizawa joined them with an abundance of cards in hand. He gave Midnight a slight nod, and entered the forest. He emerged a few minutes later, without them.

"All of you please enter the forest," Aizawa grumbled tiredly, like he hadn't got any sleep. "You have ten seconds, before the challenge begins."

The woods were silent. There was no birdsong, or the soft sound of rabbits running through the undergrowth. Or even the soft whistle of the breeze through the branches. It was unnaturally still and quiet here, but it made it easier to hear anyone coming. He used that to his advantage. He could search for his classmates, and look for the cards at the same time, while maintaining complete silence. If he was quiet, no one would know he was there.

Izuku had mastered the art of silence long before he started training with Stain. It had been his childhood that taught him utter silence before he even started school. But his training with Chizome-san only enhanced his ability to move quickly and silently. They'd spent ages on it, mastering his footwork in such a way that he'd be silent no matter what. He could be running, or fighting, and he would be silent.

It was all thanks to Chizome-san, that he could excel in this challenge. He found his first card in the undergrowth as soon as the challenge had started. He already had three points under his belt.

Plus Ultra! Teacher Card:

Aizawa-sensei

On the card was a little illustration of Aizawa-sensei perched on the edge of a rooftop. His capture weapon rested harmlessly against his shoulders, and his goggles were covering his eyes in the drawing. It looked just like him.

“Bakugou has eliminated yet another student, putting him at three points at last!” Present Mic exclaimed, startling Izuku out of his train of thought. He listened intently, as he used Present Mic’s commentary to his advantage as well. It helped him keep track of who had Teacher Cards. Uraraka had one, and so did Tsuyu.

So far, they were his only targets. He could easily surpass Kacchan and Todoroki if he got two more cards. They both had stagnated at three points for the time being. No one had the balls to face either of them, seeing as the two of them easily took out three classmates within the first ten minutes of the game.

Izuku, however, had no qualms about fighting Todoroki. Kacchan was a different story. He and Kacchan were supposed to be the best hero duo in the world, and he couldn’t very well attack him. Not without some level of guilt. And he was feeling really guilty lately. He didn’t want to add on to it by destroying Kacchan’s chances at moving on to the next event.

Something rustled in the bushes nearby, and Izuku froze, forgetting all about his wandering thoughts. His focus zeroed in on whoever was making their way over to him. He took this chance to hide behind a tree, and peer around it.

“I’m telling you,” Denki was saying, as he walked through the bushes, making an unbelievable amount of noise. “Working together isn’t against the rules,”

Sero followed him, looking uneasy and wary. “Denki! Be quiet, someone might hear you!”

Too late.

From his spot behind the tree, he summoned a demon. And then another one. With a wave of his hand, he shooed them away, with only one order in mind.

Restrain them both.

He peeked at them from his hiding spot, and quickly realized that he had underestimated them. Sero had both of his demons wrapped up in tape in an instant. “Midoriya-kun?” Sero exclaimed in silence. “Are you there?”

It was like Sero expected him to answer, or to reveal himself. No way in *hell* . He had a sports festival to win, and people to prove wrong. Most importantly he wanted to prove himself wrong. He *could* be a hero. He *could* be the next Symbol of Peace.

So he needed to win. He needed to be first.

And to do that he needed to not hold back. Izuku pressed his hand to the earth, and summoned four new demons. This time they were more powerful than the last. He’d put more energy into their summoning this time around.

“MIDORIYA IS FACING OFF AGAINST SERO AND DENKI! SUMMONING FOUR DEMONS TO FIGHT ALONGSIDE HIM THIS SHOULD BE AN EASY WIN!—”

“Are you being biased, Present Mic?” Aizawa asked.

“No, why would you say that?”

“You seem quite certain that Midoriya is going to win,”

“He can summon the legions of *Hell*, Eraser.” Present Mic told him. “How could he not win?”

“At least have a little faith in Sero and Denki,” Aizawa grumbled, “I’m going to sleep, stop being so loud,”

Izuku cursed himself. There wasn’t really a point to hiding, was there? They knew with absolute certainty that Izuku was hidden somewhere nearby. Why not face them head on?

But… he’d underestimated how scared of him they were. As soon as he emerged from his hiding place, Denki took off screeching. Izuku watched him, his brow furrowed in confusion. He looked at Sero, and gave him the same look.

“Well…” Sero began, scratching the back of his neck, “I-I should probably get going,”

“DENKI RUNS AWAY?! SERO LOOKS READY TO JOIN HIM IN RETREAT, BUT WILL MIDORIYA LET HIM GO?”

No. I won’t.

Sero tried. He really did. He ran through the trees like a bat out of hell. But Izuku was faster than him, even when he used his Quirk. He used his tape to catapult himself forward, but Izuku still kept up with him.

If he had his sword he could’ve ended it right there. He could’ve simply cut the tape, and used it to restrain him. But without his katana he had to think more creatively. His heart was thundering in his chest like a caged animal. It was kind of exhilarating to be on the other end of the spectrum. Refreshing to be the one hunting rather than being hunted. It was *finally* his turn to the predator.

Sero managed to dart out of his reach again, just barely. Izuku rocketed past the trees as they weaved between each other.

“MIDORIYA IS CHASING HIM DOWN! WILL SERO ESCAPE?!”

Izuku couldn’t allow it. Sero ran, flat out sprinting as fast as his body would allow, trying to escape. There was a single moment where Sero slowed down only for a second, but it was enough for Izuku.

He slammed him to the ground, and wasted no time restraining him with his own tape. “MIDORIYA SCORES ANOTHER POINT! SERO IS OUT! MONOMA HAS FOUND A TEACHER CARD!”

Izuku smiled to himself, and climbed off of Sero. “Damn,” Sero mumbled breathlessly, as he climbed to his feet. “You’re really fast. And you get this really scary look in your eye too, when you’ve set your sights on something. That’s why Denki ran. He knew you would be determined to take us down. I guess we kind of deserved it, didn’t we? We said all those mean things about you, and somehow you found out, didn’t you?”

Izuku shook his head. Of course they deserved it, just a little. But he wouldn’t be as mean to tell Sero that.

[You did a good job.]

“A-ah,” Sero began awkwardly, “I don’t know sign,”

Izuku nodded, and flashed him a thumbs up. He helped Sero undo the tape around his arms, and then Sero left him, to get out of the forest. Izuku was alone again, but not for long.

Monoma burst through the trees. Izuku jumped back, summoning two demons as he created some distance between them. He knew his Quirk, Copy. It allowed him to Copy anyone’s Quirk as long as he came in contact with the respective user.

Monoma couldn't come in contact with him. It was dangerous. He couldn't say for certain what would happen to him, if he copied it. It was too risky.

"Izuku Midoriya?" Monoma asked, "You're one of the one's with a card, aren't you?"

"AND RIGHT AFTER HIS VICTORY, MIDORIYA IS FACED WITH A NEW OPPONENT, MONOMA!"

This is bad. He can't touch me. It would be really, really bad.

Monoma didn't seem to understand that. He didn't understand the risks he'd be taking if he copied Izuku's Quirk. Monoma would become a monster. He'd probably lose his mind.

I need to run.

But Monoma didn't give him time to breathe. He lunged for him, his arm swinging wide to get some contact between them. Izuku blasted a hellfire in his face. "MONOMA LUNGES IN TO GET CONTACT. MIDORIYA RETALIATES WITH A BLAST OF HELLFIRE! MONOMA IS UNPERTURBED, AND GOES IN AGAIN FOR ANOTHER CHANCE AT CONTACT! BUT MIDORIYA WON'T ALLOW IT!"

Monoma was relentless, but Izuku was fast. He dodged every hand that came his way, and consistently tried to keep Monoma far away from him. But it didn't *work.* Monoma was determined and reckless.

Izuku had blasted him in the face again with more fire, but he still reached for him, and *touched him.*

Izuku froze.

“MONOMA HAS SUCCESSFULLY COPIED MIDORIYA’S QUIRK—!”

Nothing happened, not for a long time. Izuku looked at Monoma, who had stopped moving. Stopped breathing. There was nothing but terror in his once bright, mischievous eyes. Nothing but horror, and disgust.

And then he started to *scream.* Really scream. He dropped to his knees, and grabbed the sides of his head, thrashing. Screaming, screaming, *screaming.*

“YOU MONSTER! HE’S THE DEVIL!”

Izuku took a step back. He could feel the blood draining from his face. “CAN’T YOU SEE THEM? CAN’T YOU SEE HIS HORNS?! H-H-HE’S GOING TO KILL ME! SAVE ME!”

He went back to screaming and crying. Izuku took a step forward, in an attempt to calm him, but he shouldn't have. Monoma wailed, covering his face with his hands, screaming at him.

“S-STAY AWAY FROM ME!” Monoma bellowed, his voice full of heart-wrenching terror. Terror Izuku knew all too well. “YOU’RE A VILLAIN! GET AWAY FROM ME! GO AWAY!”

You’re a villain.

Can’t you see his horns?

Sadly, Monoma wasn’t wrong. He was a monster. He was the devil.

“Intermission,” Present Mic said into the microphone. “Monoma is disqualified, after encountering Midoriya. Due to Monoma being in possession of a Teacher Card, Midoriya receives four points by default.”

Izuku was frozen where he stood. Monoma was howling in pain, and terror. He couldn't do anything except watch. All he could do was listen to every word spat venomously at him. He couldn't seem to move. He could hardly breathe. He could hardly think.

This was what his Quirk did to people. It terrorized them, and broke them. Ripped them apart, and hurt them. It was a villain's Quirk. It was his Quirk, and he should've been a villain. He was a fool to think he could be a hero. That he could be anything more than what he was meant to be.

All for One had been right. He was a villain. His Quirk was an obvious indication. He should've embraced it, even if it killed him. Even if it was the last thing he wanted.

Monoma was right.

"He's wrong," Izuku jumped a foot in the air, and whipped his head to the side. He was surprised to see Aizawa-sensei standing next to him. "You're not a villain, kiddo."

Izuku blinked at him.

[No one else seems to think that.]

"Then prove them all wrong," Aizawa said simply, leaning down to cancel Monoma's Quirk. He helped him to his feet. Monoma had finally stopped screaming, but he looked like he'd seen a ghost. He was pale and scared. He wouldn't even look at Izuku.

But that didn't stop him from spitting venom at him. "You're the *devil* ."

Aizawa glared at Monoma in response.

Chapter 47

Chapter Notes

> Sorry guys! I was waiting for this to be looked through before I uploaded and then I got sick. (i still am sick, but i wrote this like 3 months ago so :DDDD)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After fighting Monoma, Izuku had a total of eight points. Not that it mattered. He didn't feel like winning. He felt like throwing the entire competition and hiding in the bathroom until it was all over.

"There are fifteen students left inside the forest! Our first event is drawing to an epic conclusion!"

"I'm seriously taking a nap after this," Aizawa commented. "This is exhausting."

He had to agree. Whatever happened today, he deserved a nice long nap afterward. He was tired right down to his soul. His heart was too weak to handle the poison the world hit him with. It ripped right through him every single time, stripping away his carefully constructed armor. With every jab and insult, his armor got weaker and weaker.

It was a shock that he had any left. With everything the universe threw at him, he should've long since been bent and broken. Maybe he was. Maybe every time someone spat at him, it was like receiving a fatal blow, and he had to build himself up all over again.

His foundations were weak. *He* was weak. No amount of training could help that. His heart and soul were weak. Nothing could fix that. His mother had made sure of it.

He traversed the forest, finding only one Teacher Card as he went.

Plus Ultra! Teacher Card:

Present Mic

The illustration was adorable. It was Hizashi sitting down in front of a canvas, painting. His subject was none other than Aizawa. If he could speak, he would've squealed.

"KIRISHIMA HEADBUTTED SHINSOU INTO OBLIVION! FOURTEEN ARE LEFT! URARAKA HAS ALSO DEFEATED TSUYU! TODOROKI HAS TAKEN OUT DENKI! TWELVE STUDENTS ARE LEFT!"

He shook himself out of his thoughts. He needed to get more points before this was over if he wanted to get first place. Kirishima had one point. Uraraka had two Teacher Cards, and one point from defeating Tsuyu. In total she had seven. Todoroki had four, and Bakugou had three.

Maybe he should just give up. Maybe he should throw this all away. After all, everyone expected him to be a villain. No one *really* had faith in him. They were all just acting. At least that's what his heart told him, every time he ventured farther and farther down this path. Every time, something happened that warned him he wasn't made for this.

But he kept fighting. Kept pulling against the shackles of destiny and fate. Even if one day, he'd drown. Now though? It probably wasn't worth it. It would probably drain him. They'd all wait for the day that he made a mistake. Then the Pro's would tear him apart.

And he'd let them. Because one day, even if it was only for a short while, despite the poisonous words of his mind, he'd be a *fucking* hero.

Or maybe he shouldn't. Damn he couldn't choose. He yawned tiredly, and considered looking for another card.

“TOKOYAMI HAS TAKEN OUT MINETA OF THE GENERAL ED CLASS!”

One more of them had to be eliminated for this round to end. Maybe—

“Izuku?” That voice was familiar. It was home. It was Kacchan. “Where are you?”

He didn’t hesitate to follow that voice and get to the source. Kacchan looked rugged, and just as tired as Izuku felt. His red, fiery eyes were searching for *him* . Izuku’s face broke out in a wide smile.

He emerged from the trees, and Kacchan caught sight of him. “MIDORIYA AND BAKUGOU HAVE COME FACE TO FACE! WILL THEY FIGHT EACH OTHER, EVEN THOUGH THEY’VE VOWED TO BECOME THE BEST HERO DUO EVER?— Oh wait, they’re hugging.”

Okay, Kacchan was the one doing all the hugging. It was all very sudden, and Izuku froze. He was probably blushing like an idiot and making a fool of himself.

“Predictable,”

“I wasn’t expecting that,” Present Mic commented. “How did you know, Eraserhead?”

Izuku could practically *see* the annoyed glare Aizawa was probably giving Hizashi. “They’re my students, Hizashi. I know everything about them.”

“Aw, so they’re your kids!”

“That’s not what I said—”

“You’re so cuuuute!~”

“Mic I *swear !”*

“OH SHIT— TOKOYAMI HAS DEFEATED THE ELEVENTH STUDENT, HATSUME MEI. WITH THAT, LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, THE FIRST CHALLENGE IS—!”

Present Mic’s voice cut out.

Everything went quiet suddenly. Hizashi didn’t say anything, and neither did Aizawa. The forest suddenly went dark too, and Izuku pulled away from Kacchan.

“What the hell…” Kacchan began. “What’s going on?”

“Thank you Present Mic and Eraserhead, for allowing me to take the spotlight!~ Hahaha!” The woman took a deep, shuddering breath. She seemed thrilled. “My name is Toga Himiko, and I’m your new announcer!”

Izuku felt a chill run down his spine, and goosebumps blossom along his arms. “As of now, the League of Villains has taken control of this arena!~ Please sit back and enjoy our show! Starring the ten students left in the forest!”

“Did...did villains just crash our Sports Festival?!” Kacchan exclaimed. Izuku’s heart seemed to stop dead in his chest. This couldn’t be happening… This couldn’t be *real.*

No. No. *No.*

They needed to get out. They weren’t *safe.* This place was about to be a hunting ground. They were sheep. The villains were wolves, hellbent on murder. They were going to be *slaughtered* .

But he wasn’t moving. He wasn’t running like his body begged him to. He was frozen. He wasn’t breathing. Tears blurred his vision, and he could feel tremors wracking his body.

Fear. Fear, fear. So much fear. Not for himself, but for his classmates. He had to save them. He had to protect them. But he couldn’t *move.* He was drowning against the panic. The all-consuming fear that he wouldn’t be strong enough to find the rest of his classmates and protect them in time.

“Izuku,” Kacchan said sternly, shaking him. “Deep breathes,”

But how could he *breathe* ? How could he even *move* , when all he could think about was how he needed to find everyone and save them? Protect them. Even if it was reckless and foolish and impossible. Even if it got him hurt. He needed to protect them. Because no one else would. No one else *could* .

He didn’t want them to beg for a hero that would never come. He didn’t want to leave them to feel hopeless and alone, like he had his entire life. He wanted to give them hope.

Izuku didn’t want them to feel how he felt, every single day. He didn’t want them to feel the fear of becoming prey.

[I have to protect everyone. We have to find them.]

“Okay,” Kacchan said softly, “But you’re not breathing. I need you to breathe,”

He tried. His breath was shallow, and short. Definitely not enough, but he couldn’t manage any more than that. He couldn’t breathe easily until he knew exactly where his classmates were. He needed to know they were safe.

He needed to be the one in between them and the villains. Trembling, he ripped himself away from Kacchan. The demons practically summoned themselves, six of them. They couldn't very well travel on their own with villains lurking. Izuku had the perfect solution, placing one demon in front of them, two on each side of them, and one behind.

He had a vague idea of who he was searching for. Todoroki, Uraraka, Tokoyami, and Kirishima had made it on the announcements. He knew for a fact that those four were in this forest.

His whole body seemed to be vibrating with anxious energy. He was itching to rush ahead, and find everyone on his own, but that would be utterly reckless. He needed to stay calm for now. He had to have faith that his classmates were strong enough to handle themselves for now.

He hoped. "As all of you can see, the forest is covered by a huge barrier, preventing anyone from getting in, or *out*... " Toga mumbled, her voice going low and husky at the end. "We've also taken the liberty of hacking all of your drones, so everyone can see the show! How exciting! But before the show begins, there's a message from Sensei,"

There was a loud screech of static, and a nearby drone flew over to them to display the video that was probably playing on the huge screen. They wanted all ten of them to see it too.

This message was important. The video's quality was absolutely horrible, but All for One's face was unmistakable. He sat in that infernal chair, his leg crossed over his other one. His elbows rested on the armrests, and his hands were weaved together. He smiled wickedly at the camera.

"Izuku Midoriya," He began, his smile widening. It was a slow, horrifying smile. **"The only one to ever betray me, and live to see another day. You are truly an enigma. So I've been watching you, ever since you left my side…"**

"Every move you've made...every *breath* you've taken…" All for One said slowly. **"I've watched you. I've been right there, watching. You've *never* been safe. You never *really* escaped me. I'm coming for you. This is all just a display of my power. To remind you who you *betrayed.* To remind you of who is *hunting you down.* Everything that happens today will be your fault."**

“Every tortured scream will be *your* fault. Every ounce of spilled blood will be on *you*. What kind of hero will you be *then?”*

Izuku clenched his fists, and to his surprise it wasn’t terror that gripped him. It was anger. Pure unadulterated anger, that rivaled the iciness of his Hellfire. He was freezing with anger, and burning to death with it at the same time.

If villains laid one fucking *finger* on one of his classmates he’d snap their necks. He’d drag them to hell *himself.* And he wouldn’t care. He wouldn’t care what became of them, as long as his friends were safe. He needed to find them.

He wouldn’t allow them to get hurt. They could torture him, but dear God, only he would know what would happen if villains touched his friends. His *family.*

“Alright! With all of that done, let’s begin the game!” Toga exclaimed, her voice rough and elated. “This game will be *so* fun, for me at least. Would you like to know what the game is? I call it, Can Midoriya Save His Classmates? How far will he go to protect them? Will he save all of them? What will he sacrifice? Would he *kill* if it meant keeping his friends safe? We’re all going to find out today!”

Izuku cut his gaze over to Kacchan. His fierce red eyes matched Izuku’s burning viridian ones. They were both *pissed.* He started running, and Kacchan didn’t miss a beat. They had eight people to find and protect. Escape wasn’t an option. They had to fight and survive.

They were on their own. They needed a plan. But for that, they needed to meet up before the villains found them. Trees whipped past them, but Izuku’s eyes missed nothing.

“The race has begun on both sides!” Toga exclaimed, “Midoriya-kun and Kacchan are looking desperately for their classmates, and so are my friends! Who will find them first?”

It has to be us. We need to go faster.

But their search was futile. They couldn't find them. Not like this. Not in time. He needed more demons. A whole lot of them. They could guide his classmates to him, and keep them safe at the same time.

His body burned with sizzling hot fire, as he summoned them. They howled in amusement, as Izuku brought them from the pits of hell. He welcomed the infernal heat, even if it hurt. Even if it felt like he was bathing in fire.

He didn't matter. His life didn't matter as long as everyone was fine.

I don't matter, as long as everyone is safe.

The cross around his neck burned the most, but he pushed past it. Demons rose from the earth itself, and he gave them one mission.

FIND THEM. BRING THEM TO ME.

They ran to complete their task, whispering through the forest like smoke. The forest was hot and dark. Everything was hot. Everything seemed to be burning with heat. Or maybe it was just because of his Quirk. That was probably it. Maybe he was already at his limit?

Even if he was, it didn't matter. Todoroki emerged from the trees, as stoic as ever. "Hey guys, I found you."

"Half-and-Half?! How'd you find us so quickly?" Kacchan asked, "We've been looking for you, asshole."

"I just walked around…until I saw Midoriya-kun's demons," Todoroki shrugged. "It wasn't too hard."

[Have you seen anyone else?]

“I don’t know sign language,” Todoroki stated simply.

“He asked you if you’ve seen anyone else,” Kacchan snapped, “Well? Have you?”

Todoroki shook his head. “I didn’t see our classmates, but I did see a weird guy who was carrying around a cross. Creepy.”

Izuku didn’t care about that. “Whatever. Let’s look for everyone else,”

“Okay.”

Hours seemed to go by, without any sign of anyone else. Toga quietly commented on a few things, but she remained silent most of the time. It only added to the stress of the entire situation. He had no idea what was happening to his other classmates.

It made him tremble. It made him feel sick. Then, slicing through the silence like a blade, a shatter scream filled the air. High-pitched and pained. Fear and anger shot through him, pulsing in him, in time with his own heartbeat.

He was the first out of all three of them to move. He wasn’t thinking. His body just moved, running to the source of the screaming. It permeated the air, thick and hair-raising. It wasn’t difficult to find out where they were, and who was screaming. The three of them entered a clearing, and there they found blood.

Blood was splattered on the earth, on the trees. Everywhere he looked, Uraraka’s blood was splattered. Her shrill scream grated through the air again, and Izuku found her.

And he found the villain responsible for her pain, towering over with bloody daggers in both hands. The man’s hair was long and black. His black, beady eyes were hungry for blood.

Uraraka's jacket was in shreds, cut up from the daggers. The cuts only seemed to be superficial, and not life threatening. But that didn't make Izuku any less angry. It didn't make him any less *feral* .

A growl ripped through him, and his Hellfire greeted him, cool against his hot skin. It was time he delivered *punishment* . His flames licked at his hands, curling around his knuckles and fingers. It begged to burn. And he planned to let it.

He wouldn't shoot fire at this villain. No. He would make sure it hurt. He would make sure it *burned.*

His smile was slow. Wicked, and dark. Eerily similar to the smile the demons he summoned wore. He couldn't wait to burn this sinner in hell.

No one stopped him, but not even Kacchan offered to help. He grabbed the villain and threw him with all his strength. He stood between Uraraka and the villain. This villain would know the fire of hell. He glared at the villain, his smile still in place.

The villain rushed for him, and Izuku was ready. "MIDORIYA HAS RESCUED URARAKA, LEAVING SIX MORE CLASSMATES TO FIND, BUT WILL HE MAKE IT OUT OF THIS FIGHT?!" Toga stopped yelling to giggle, "Did I do it right, Present Mic? I sounded a lot like you,"

"You did," Present Mic said tensely.

Izuku wrapped his hand around the villains' throat and threw him to the ground. The smell of burning flesh wafted through the air, but Izuku hadn't burned him enough to mortally wound him. Only enough to scare him, and rough him up a bit.

Too bad. Izuku glared at the man, and knocked him out with a swift kick to the head.

"Uraraka-san," Todoroki began softly, "Are you okay?"

“Yes!” She exclaimed, and Izuku turned to face her. “Thanks guys! You really helped me out,”

“No fuckin’ problem Round Face,” Kacchan said, though he sounded annoyed by it. “Any idea where anyone else could be?”

“I saw Aoyama in a tree earlier, before all of this went down...maybe he’s still there?”

“A-are you serious? Aoyama was in a tree?” Kacchan asked, looking shocked. “What a pussy,”

Izuku glared at him and elbowed him swiftly in the stomach. Kacchan sputtered and glared right back at him. “What?! It’s true.”

“You’re a dick,” Todoroki told him, “Why was Aoyama in a tree?”

“I asked him and he said he was going to hide up there until the event was over!” Uraraka told them, “I’ll show you!”

Curious, Izuku couldn’t help but follow her through the trees and deeper into the forest. He scanned the treetops for a sign of Aoyama, but he didn’t see anything. Uraraka led them to the biggest tree in the entire forest.

As they neared it, they could hear someone talking. “Aoyama…” Tokoyami began, “Why are you in a tree, at a time like this?”

“I-I-I’m scared,” Aoyama began. “A-a-and I’m stuck.”

Dear lord up in heaven. Tokoyami laughed. Like really *laughed* . He was completely doubled over, clutching his stomach and laughing. Todoroki looked blankly at the entire situation. Kacchan squinted at them, utterly flabbergasted.

“Are you fuckin’ serious?”

[He really was in a tree…]

“Sero is going to make so many memes about this,” Uraraka snorted.

“CAN Y'ALL JUST TAKE THIS SERIOUSLY?! WE’RE BEING TARGETED.” Kacchan yelled, startling even Izuku himself.

“Shhh!” Uraraka snapped, “You’ll attract their attention!”

“Oh for Christ’s sake! Aoyama get your ass down here!” Kacchan growled. “Don’t make me come up there.”

“Please do,” Aoyama whined, “It’s too high.”

“Too high, my ass. You can just jump down,” Kacchan told him. “Even Deku could do it, and he’s afraid of *everything* .”

Izuku flipped him off. Kacchan shrugged.

“I could float myself up there and get you if that’s okay,” Uraraka told him, and Aoyama gave a hasty nod. “Okay! Here I come!”

She tapped on her clothes, and she floated up to where Aoyama gripped the tree with an iron-clad grip. Uraraka had to pry him from the tree, and he clung to her and cried.

“Thank you, mi amor!”

Izuku stared at them, completely baffled. Aoyama — a Hero course student — had gotten himself stuck in a *tree.*

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed! Also, this is so random but has anyone shopped on Redbubble for obscure anime merch? coz im thinking about buying stuff from there :PP

(ALSO IM SO GLAD SOMEONE ADDED MY FIC TO THEIR COLLECTIONS?!?!? LIKE WOW IM SO HAPPY ;-;)

Act Six: FORGIVE US FATHER, FOR WE HAVE SINNED

Chapter Notes

So last weekend I didn't have my computer, which is why Im late updating~ Sorry!
(ALSO ITS THE ONE-YEAR ANNIVERSARY OF MY SERVER ; - ;)

the discord server

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aoyama would *not* stop sobbing. But who could blame him? They were being hunted down like sheep, and they couldn't escape. Villains were surely closing in on them, and conflict — real, bloody conflict — was inevitable. It was only a matter of time before they were attacked, and Izuku was forced to find out *exactly* how far he'd go to protect them.

The only possible solution he could conjure up was that he needed to gather all ten of them and formulate a plan of escape. There was undoubtedly a villain with a technology Quirk who hacked the drones. For now, they should get rid of that villain and the drones tracking their movements. Then, as much as he hated the idea, they should split up into teams of two. They should track down the villain who was creating the barrier between them and all the pro-heroes outside.

After that, they were free. But Izuku had a feeling it probably wasn't that easy, and that it would probably fail. The villains would expect that. They would know that they'd try that. Unless…

He could be a distraction. He could keep the other villains' attention until one of his classmates found the villain responsible for the barrier, and took him down. He would have to. He couldn't let anyone else do this. *All* of this was his doing. His fault.

So he had to be the distraction. He just needed to find Kirishima and the others, whoever they were.

[Does anyone know who else is in here?]

Kacchan translated it for everyone.

“Ummm,” Aoyama began, slowly. “I saw Tetsutetsu and Kirishima a while ago…”

“I saw Shiozaki,” Tokoyami grumbled. “A child of the light.”

Right. So that left one person unaccounted for. They had him, Kacchan, Todoroki, Uraraka, Aoyama, Tokoyami, Shiozaki, Kirishima, and Tetsutetsu.

Who was the last one? It could be anyone, really. Whoever it was never got the chance to get any points — or maybe Izuku hadn’t been paying attention — so it was impossible to know who it was until he found them. For now, he needed to focus on finding everyone he knew for certain to be in this forest.

They couldn’t stop now when people still needed to be saved. Izuku wouldn’t stop. He wouldn’t rest until he found his friends. He was prepared to do *anything* to keep them safe. “We should get moving,” Tokoyami commented, “Midoriya-kun looks ready to explode.”

“Oh yeah! We need to save the others!” Uraraka exclaimed.

We. We need to save the others.

Not him. Not him alone, all by himself. They wanted to *help* him. They wouldn’t allow their friends to get hurt either. He wasn’t carrying all of this on his own, like All for One had implied. He had underestimated them, and so had Izuku. They were heroes in training. It was going to be their job one day to put their lives on the line to save people.

This was just ten times more risky because the people they were saving were their friends. They had so much more to lose if they failed. He wouldn’t let anyone die. They were going

to succeed no matter what.

They didn't have room for failure. Not now, not with the lives at stake. Kacchan was probably the only one who understood the unbelievable stress Izuku was putting himself under. He was responsible for everyone's lives.

They continued their search, and Izuku could barely feel the lack of air burning in his chest. He could barely feel the heat in his legs from running so much. He was surprised that anyone could keep up with him. Maybe his friends were just as worried.

"Forgive us, Father, for we have sinned…"

Izuku slowed his pace. The words were whispered softly. So softly, he almost didn't catch it. His friends stopped too, but they seemed confused. "Deku...why'd we stop?"

"May your golden light shine down on us, oh Lord in heaven…"

He furrowed his brow in confusion, listening for more. Someone was praying, and he could hear it. It was like a punch to the gut every time they spoke, but Izuku felt the unbearable urge to follow it. And if he was lucky, he'd hopefully come across a classmate.

He tore through the undergrowth, feeling drawn and enchanted by the words that whispered coolly against his ear.

"In the morning, Lord, you hear my voice…"

Izuku picked up his pace. "Deku! Where are we going?!" Tokoyami asked, "Did you hear something?"

He gave Tokoyami a curt nod. The darkened forest moved past them at an alarming rate, and the praying got louder.

“The peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your thoughts in Christ Jesus,”

The verses made him feel sick. He could feel a migraine building, pulling his muscles taunt with stress. It was to be expected, with the amount of anxiety that seemed to be bubbling within him. This entire thing was his fault, and if anyone got hurt, or worse, *died*... Not only would he blame himself, but the *world* would too.

“We should come up with a plan,” Todoroki whispered suddenly, stopping them. Izuku nodded, even though he was eager to find the source of the praying. “We can’t just go around finding our classmates and then not have a plan.”

“You’re right,” Uraraka replied, turning to Izuku. “What should we do Midoriya?”

Sweat dripped down his forehead. They were expecting *him* to come up with the plan? Damn it. Damn it, *damn it.*

[There’s got to be a villain with a Quirk that can control the drones. We need to destroy them first so the villains can’t pinpoint our location.]

Kacchan was quick to translate everything he was signing into real speech. “So basically, we need to destroy these fuckin’ drones that keep following us. They can hear everything we’re saying too,”

Izuku grabbed one that hovered nearby, and threw it to the ground. The drones Yuuei had used were small, circular little camera’s, and they were really fragile.

He threw it to the ground and smashed it under his shoe. Following his example, Kacchan grabbed the other one that watched them.

Once there were no more drones, Izuku started to sign again. [We need to find our classmates most importantly. After that, we need to escape. There must be a villain with a Quirk that created the barrier around the forest. If we knock him out, then the barrier should come down, and the Pro's can help us. That's our only hope.]

"Alright, sounds easy enough," Todoroki commented, "But how are we going to keep the villains from finding us?"

Izuku's smile was an answer in itself.

Izuku was alone. The forest was even quieter than before now that his classmates were gone. For their plan to succeed, they needed to split up. Luckily, that meant Izuku could follow the voice without having to worry. He would be walking into a trap on his own, responsible for himself, and not other lives.

He kept following the soft praying, hoping he'd find that it was Shiozaki.

And then he heard the screaming. The shrieking, heart-wrenching, fearful, cold cutting screams of his classmates. For a second, he seemed to freeze with horror, with worry.

"Stop!"

Yaoyorozu.

"Please!"

She was the one unaccounted for. She was the tenth student here, trapped. Getting *tortured* , if her screaming was anything to go by. It sent him falling into a rage, similar to the one he'd had with Uraraka less than an hour ago. He couldn't hear it anymore. He wanted it to stop.

So he quickened his pace until he was running. The anger seemed to fester like fire in his gut. The worry ate at his thoughts and heart.

He pushed all of his emotions away. Every. Single. One.

For what he needed to do… he needed to feel nothing. It would be ugly. It would hurt. It was reckless, but it was his plan. Even if it didn't work.

When he finally found her, he couldn't stop the wave of absolute fury that washed over him. He stopped dead in his tracks.

The scene was horrific. He had no words…

She was pinned to a tree, but not by conventional means. They hammered nails into her forearms. And they weren't even *done.* But he could tell she was in *agony* . Her breaths were coming in quick, and shallow.

Her face was drained of all color. Blood dripped down her arms, and she screamed. *Screamed* as they hammered in another nail, and her bones snapped. He heard it.

He moved without thinking. One moment he'd been surveying the scene, and in the next he was in the thick of it. Three villains were facing him. All of them radiating bloodlust he could *taste.*

But they weren't the only one's calling for blood. He wanted to splatter their blood all over this forest. He wanted them to feel *his* bloodlust. *His* agony. *His hell* .

He wanted them to scream, but he knew it wasn't a fair fight. He knew he was out numbered and weak because of his need to protect his friends, and family. He had something to protect, and they didn't.

Izuku knew for certain that he would be the one screaming, by the time everything was over and done with. He could feel it in his soul. But first he needed to get Yaoyorozu out of here. He needed her to find the others and join them.

It was as easy as breathing to summon them, his demons. With them, they brought the fury of hell.

Or maybe it was because Izuku was dripping with it. Anger, anger, anger. So much that it set him on fire. Burned his skin, and his thoughts until he couldn't even fathom thinking anymore.

With a wave of his hand, he sent them not toward his enemies, but toward Yaoyorozu. They could free her in seconds, while it would take him minutes.

Free her, and take her to Kacchan.

He would protect her until she was long gone. His flames were cold to the touch, but they would be enough to keep them away as his demons freed her.

The first one rushed for him, and he smiled. He really wished he had his katana, but he wouldn't have used it anyway. Not for this plan.

They didn't even get a chance to stop him. Yaoyorozu was free before they could even try to retaliate, and his demons were dragging her far away from here. He could barely hear Toga commenting on the situation. He didn't listen.

He didn't even use his Quirk to knock out all three of them. They were low-level thugs. But that would still get the villains attention.

With Yaoyorozu finally safe, for the time being, he could finally begin his part in the plan. The dangerous, most reckless part of the plan. He looked at the drone floating next to him.

He was a distraction.

Katsuki hated this plan. It was stupid, but clever. Izuku was a perfect distraction. The villains were after him, so if he revealed himself they'd come to him. They wouldn't even realize that everyone else was working toward their freedom.

They needed to find the villain that created the barrier. Or they just needed to destroy it as quickly as possible. Tokoyami was in charge of destroying the barrier if they failed. So he was staying out of sight.

Half-and-Half Bastard and Aoyama were in charge of finding Kirishima, Tetsutetsu, and Shiozaki. That left Round Face and Katsuki to try to find the villain making the barrier.

He just hoped Izuku would make it out of this in one piece.

Fumikage had a bad feeling about this plan. Midoriya knew it was a horrible plan, and spent a good amount of time trying to convince them that he'd be okay. That he wouldn't let them hurt him too much. That he'd fight back, for as long as it took them to escape.

He was sitting high up in a tree, at the edge of the forest, where the barrier began. He was well-hidden, far away from any lingering villains. Or at least he'd thought.

Below him was a weird man, dressed as a priest. He had the white band around his collar, and a cross around his neck. Fumikage froze, keeping his breath shallow and soundless as the man walked beneath the branch he was perched on.

Static cut through the silence. "We found him,"

The priest smiled. "Good, I'm coming."

He wanted to move. He wanted to help, he wanted to warn Midoriya. But he had promised. Had *sworn* that he would do his job, no matter what happened.

And he'd do it as fast as he could, if only to spare Midoriya any unnecessary pain.

Shouta saw his student — *his son* — save Yaoyorozu, and make her leave without him. It took him a moment to understand what Midoriya was doing. To understand the lengths Midoriya would go to save his family.

He'd throw himself head first into danger, and become a distraction. He would submit himself to pain to save them all. He would once again become someone else's punching bag.

Shouta swallowed thickly. That was his *son* .

His chest was tight with mounting horror and worry. He should be down there. He should be slamming his fists on that infernal barrier until his hands bled. His students shouldn't be *suffering.*

"No, no." Toga grinned as she spoke, swinging her knife around violently, "Don't move Eraserhead. The show hasn't even started!"

But he wanted it to end. He didn't want to hear his children scream anymore. He didn't want them to be in pain anymore.

He couldn't even *look* at the screen. He tried to block out the sound of Midoriya's pain. He tried to stop the tears pricking at the corners of his eyes.

"...Izuku Midoriya. It's nice to finally meet you," Shouta couldn't help but look this time. Midoriya was bruised and bloody, but he still stood tall. Anger festered within those dark eyes. So much power hid in those dark, green depths. *"They call me the Priest."*

He was tired. Tired right down to his bones. They'd found him fast. Bruises were already forming on his jaw, and he could feel blood dripping down his face. There were a lot of them around him, on all sides.

He knew it would come to this. He knew the position he'd put himself in, and he wasn't about to run away. They still needed time. They needed him to distract them.

So he didn't run, even when every bone in his body begged for it. He didn't run, even when a *priest* joined them. He bit down on the fear that exploded in his chest, so similar to Kacchan's explosions. Yet completely different.

"Leave him to me," The man said, with a slow, cruel smile. It sent chills skittering down his spine. "Just make sure he doesn't escape."

I won't escape. I won't run.

But he wanted to. He wanted to escape. He wanted to run. He wanted to run. *He wanted to run.*

"Do you want to know my Quirk?" The Priest asked, his voice surprisingly gentle. "Do you want to see it?"

No. He didn't. He had a feeling it was vile, ugly and dark. Darker than his. And that was saying something. He could feel himself tensing up. The bloodlust he'd been feeling merely minutes ago before all these villains surrounded him was nothing compared to the killing intent that this man gave off.

He was going to die. This man would *kill* him. He should be running for his life. But he couldn't move. He had to stay put.

The Priest grabbed the closet villain. Izuku felt frozen, like ice was in his veins. Like someone had reached into his chest and grabbed his heart with their bare hands.

The man grabbed the villain, and Izuku couldn't fathom what happened next. The body fell. Everything was quiet. Too quiet. There was no blood. No screaming, no pain. But death. Nothing but dark, black, horrifying death that made Izuku sick.

He could tell immediately. How the body fell, and didn't move. How those eyes, once filled with bloodlust and hatred for all things hero, were empty and glassy. Blank and cold. Wearing

the mask of death so obviously, that he couldn't even think. How could someone have this powerful of a Quirk?!

"My Quirk…" He began, rolling his wrists until they popped audibly. "Is called the Hand of God. With both of my hands, I can kill anyone instantly. God has given me this gift, and for a long time I was scared of it. Just as you are scared of yours. I thought God had cursed me, as he cursed you. I thought he did this so he could hurt me. Punish me. It wasn't until I saw *you* ."

Izuku couldn't take his eyes off of the corpse. That villain had been a *person.* An evil person, but a living, breathing being nonetheless. And his life had been cut short, just so this man could show off his Quirk. Just so this Priest could go on a monologue, about how *God* had blessed him with such a Quirk. Such a power.

"I never knew my purpose on this Earth until I saw you, with All for One. Training deep underground, demons around you like an armada. I had been hesitant to join his League until then. God has shown me what I must do. He has shown me why I was born. Why he gave me this power. All of those questions are now answered. Finally I can live my life with purpose. God put me here, to kill the Devil. To kill *you* ."

"It has to be me," The man continued, his face wild. His smile was too wide, his eyes too bright and angry. He threw his arms open wide, ignoring the body beneath him. "No one else has the resolve to do it. No one is as strong as I am. I am not afraid of you, and I won't hesitate to complete my mission. I will kill you, Lucifer Morningstar, even if I have to kill everyone on *Earth* to do it."

And his smile made Izuku go pale.

Chapter End Notes

Hopefully you all enjoyed!!

the discord server link in case you missed it because i also ignore chapter notes unless they're at the end

Chapter 49

Chapter Summary

Sports Festival Continued!!

(trigger warning for violence and bloodshed! Proceed with caution my young babies.

Chapter Notes

Also, sorry I haven't updated recently! I've been hopping between houses as of late, and my laptop can't go everywhere with me. And I also hate using a desktop mac (my mothers) to update because her mouse sensitivity isn't high enough for me (even when I mess with the settings).

Soon enough I should be able to settle down at one house and bring everything over and stuff so I can write more and update on schedule lol (thank you tali for reminding me!!)

(I'll also post fan art in the next chapter, seeing as this isn't my computer and my images aren't on here)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

So tell me, where does the Devil go when he dies?

It all happened so fast. The Priest was standing over a corpse, the body already cooling and getting ridgid with rigor mortis. The body wouldn’t completely undergo that for a few more hours, but it definitely was beginning. Within the blink of an eye, he was striding forward, a grin that could rival Nedzu’s pulling on his lips. It was a scary sight, but Izuku held his ground. All he had to do was keep him from touching him.

That was how he’d win this fight, or at least come out of this alive. He would deny this man the chance to use his Quirk on him. He could do this. It was just one man. What could he *really* do all on his own?

He knew he was being too optimistic and hopeful, but it kept him from shrinking away when the Priest finally closed the distance between them. Izuku could really do this. He could really fight him, and win. All he had to do was treat him like Shigaraki.

Shigaraki could kill too, through discengrating objects and people. There was virtually no difference between them. The only noticeable difference was that he'd only have to cut off *one* finger, instead of two. If he looked at this situation like that, then he was the one with the advantage here. He may be surrounded by villains, by enemies, but he was strong enough to face this one man. It wasn't like he had to fight all of them just yet. He spread his legs apart, bending them at the knees. A basic stance that Stain had ingrained into his senses, an instinct all on its own. His flames burst from his hands, burning, freezing, infernal and licked up his arms all the way to his elbows. He was surprised he wasn't burning his own skin, but he shouldn't be. His Quirk wasn't designed to hurt him physically.

The Priest didn't seem even a little surprised, and if Izuku's hypothesis was correct, he probably knew everything about Izuku's Quirk. Right down to his ability to transform into a monster. A demon. But he'd been kind enough to reveal his own Quirk, which he should've kept secret if he hoped to keep the advantage.

Now they were on an even playing field. It all came down to who was smarter, faster, and stronger. They were about to find out. And Izuku wasn't going to lose. He had too much on the line. Too many things to worry about, and complete. Too many people counting on him. Too many burdens weighing him down to lose.

Izuku let the power fester and burn within him. The Priest lunged forward, his hands outstretched and overextended. Izuku was overly cautious, and jumped back a few paces, only to shift his stance and prowl closer. "Good, good." The Priest gave him a praising smile. "No openings…perfect stance..."

Izuku ignored his ramblings. He gulped down his hesitancy, his throat bobbing. He could feel the blood drying on his face from his previous fighting with this man's colleagues. He could feel exhaustion whispering against his skin like a broken record. *Tired, tired, tired.* He was always tired. But he needed to forget it. Forget exhaustion. Forget the wounds.

He needed nothing but power. His friends still needed him to be a distraction. The barrier was still over them. Hopefully not for long.

The Priest rushed for him again, faster this time. Izuku dodged, twisting his arm while he was at it. The man hissed between his teeth, but didn't relent. His hands kept reaching for him, begging to stop his heart dead in his chest. A well aimed kick to the abdomen was all it took to send him careening into a tree. The air was shoved out of his lungs with the force of it. It *should've* knocked him out. But he was still conscious, and he didn't even hesitate to get back on his feet.

He wouldn't lose.

His flames seemed to burn hotter, to ravage the air with heat more than usual. His cross hissed against his skin, but he ignored it. The Priest grabbed him by the collar of his shirt, and Izuku could hear his own big, heaving breaths. His feet swayed uselessly in the air, as the man lifted him off his feet.

"Try harder."

And then he was thrown. He body skittered across the forest floor, rolling, rolling, *snapping* . He didn't stop until his back slammed into the trunk of a tree. A feeling surged beneath his skin like fire. Like a tidal wave. Fury.

He followed after him, his pace leisurely and calm. Izuku got to his feet, teeth bared. "Still not good enough. I want you to *fight back."*

Not good enough. I'm never good enough.

Something dark was gripping his heart like poison. A furious tidal wave that made his hands shake even more than before. "Are you afraid of me? You're shaking,"

His laugh was cold and grating. Like glass shattering and ice cracking. "All for One did tell me you got scared easily…"

He was shaking. He was afraid. But he wasn't afraid of him. He wasn't afraid of this Priest, or his Quirk, or even *God* . Not right now. Right now, he was afraid of the rage, the roaring, all-consuming rage. Fury that made his eyes burn and his back ache with the temptation, the need to transform. A dark, alluring *need* that made his skin crawl.

The cross around his neck was burning his skin, and he could smell his own flesh burning. He could feel his power eating away at his thoughts. And what scared him the most was that he *wanted* to give in to the feeling. He wanted to lose control. But it was dangerous. Way too dangerous.

"Or… Could it be that you're afraid of *yourself* ? Your power, your Quirk?" His cruel smile grew, and he leaned down to caress Izuku's cheek. Izuku felt locked in place. "How *pitiful.* You're afraid of the monster you *really are* ...aren't you?"

He clenched his fists, his nails biting into his palms like daggers. The Priest was right. He was afraid of himself. But he had to move. He had to do *something,* before the man decided to end it all right here. Izuku swung at him, his flames around his fist. He knew it had to burn like hell, as the man fell back, his feet scrambling for purchase below him as he clutched his face.

Izuku could feel his power rising to greet him. So much heat. So much fire. Nowhere to go but out. The Priest was quick to recover, and to retaliate. His face was twisted up in anger, and burned. "Grab him."

Izuku's eyes went impossibly wide with *fear,* the abrupt switch of emotion left him feeling sick. That cold, sickening fear had all of power draining from him. His breath hitched and caught in his throat. They converged on him like a pack of wolves. He slammed his forehead into the face of the first person who approached him. The poor soul groaned, clutching their now pounding head.

He growled and hissed. Izuku clawed and shredded skin, and fought. When they came to grab him, in waves, he fought them. A blonde woman reached for him, and he bit down on her hand, his teeth digging into her skin until he could taste iron on his tongue. She screamed, and pulled her hand away. A man took her place, and Izuku didn't even hesitate to twist his wrist until he felt it crack.

He was a storm of anger and power. They fell before him—howling in pain before licking their wounds a few feet from him. He could feel their burning glares and terrified glances like knives against his skin.

"MIDORIYA TAKES DOWN VILLAIN AFTER VILLAIN!" Toga exclaimed, her squeal making the mic go crazy with static. He honestly forgot everyone could see him. He forgot that people were outside of the barrier, probably in the same position as he was. Fighting, or held hostage.

"Can he take them all down? If he does, can he defeat the Priest?!" Toga asked, "What do you think, Present Mic?"

"He can do it." The way he said it left no room for argument. "He's a *hero* at Yuuei. He can do this."

His voice was shaking, and fearful. Izuku must look ragged and beaten down. Or maybe he looked like he was about to lose control. Either way, Izuku ignored it and tried to keep the villains from restraining him. It was all in vain, though. Not even a second later, he was overwhelmed by a swarm of low-level villains. The Priest popped his knuckles with a slow, cold smile growing on his face. The joints in Izuku's wrists ached from the way that the villains held his hands, just far enough back that his shoulder blades ached with a dull, throbbing pain.

Izuku clenched his jaw, his teeth grating together. He could feel the muscles down his neck working and straining with stress. What would he do, now that he got Izuku restrained? There was a moment or two of nothing, of silence as The Priest stared down Izuku, and Izuku stared back. His expression is carefully blank and empty of any and all emotion. Not even a glimmer of the fear he was feeling—like a knife to his throat, cold and all-consuming—reached the surface.

"Finally," The man said, his grin still in place. He leaned down to be eye-level with him. One hand drifted to caress Izuku's cheek, and Izuku could feel himself flinch under the touch. "Unfortunately, All for One won't allow me to kill you just yet." His eyes darkened with annoyance as he spoke, but then he chuckled lowly. All the annoyance vanished from his tone, and he pulled away from Izuku.

He reached into his pocket, and Izuku pressed his lips together. “But he never said I couldn’t have my fun with you,”

His chest tightened with worry. What did that even *mean* ? He didn’t like that cruel look encompassing his features, his lips pulled taunt in a smile, his eyes impossibly wide and concerningly excited. More excited than he’d been just a few seconds ago. The fear was still ever-present, and he could hardly breathe. It was like something heavy was weighing him down, pulling at his chest uncomfortably.

Out of his pockets, he produced a dagger. He sucked in a shallow breath as the Priest twirled it between his fingers. “But what should I do first?”

He hummed softly to himself, before turning round slightly to look at his comrades. “Got any requests? Ideas?”

The crowd of villains looked at each other, before shrugging. The Priest seemed a little disappointed until a woman with a large sword that was practically as long as her torso, and thicker than her waist. The sword was strapped to her back obviously not taken care of very well, but that didn’t matter to Izuku. What mattered is what she said. Her words had him curling his hands into fists.

“We could start with his back...” She said, running a hand through her long, inky black hair that fell just above her waist. “I’ve always wanted to see someone get carved up like a piece of meat. If you know what I mean,”

Her eyes flickered to the dagger in The Priests hand.

Izuku swallowed thickly, his hands shaking behind his back with renewed vigor. He could feel his power begging to get out to *protect* himself. He felt the heat rise to his skin, like boiling water, only hotter.

The Priest clicked his tongue, piercing loud in the silence. He walked around Izuku in a slow circle. A predator circling its prey. “Use your Quirk one time, and I’ll kill you in an instant.”

He pressed one hand to Izuku's back as proof. One more hand and this man would kill him instantly. Izuku shoved his power deep down, ignoring how his body broke out into goosebumps as soon as that heat was gone from his blood as he did so. He needed to remind himself what his role was in all of this. He was the *distraction* . He needed to keep all eyes on him. All the attention on him. He couldn't let them turn their attention to his classmates who were searching for a way to free them all. The longer they tortured him, the more time he gave his friends.

He either needed to fight them until the very end, when the barrier was destroyed, or bide his time, enduring the pain. He was used to pain. He was used to torture.

All eyes were on him, and they needed to stay that way. He barely flinched as his shirt was ripped off his back. He barely made a sound as the Priest chuckled softly, and let his hand slide down his spine.

"This is going to be fun."

Ochako couldn't keep up with Bakugou. He was running too fast, and she couldn't even breathe, much less keep the pace. The trees whipped past them as the two of them ran through the forest, trying their hardest to find this villain—if there even was one—and escape this barrier. Ochako knew Bakugou was probably running himself ragged because he was worried for Midoriya. They all were.

To subject yourself to pain for god knows how long… just so your friends could find a way to escape? It was stupid. Reckless, irresponsible, suicidal even. Yet, they really didn't have a choice. They had to escape *somehow,* and they couldn't do that if all the villains were threatening to swarm them from every direction. And Midoriya was their target, so naturally Midoriya knew that if he was within their sights, they'd forget about everyone else. They'd fixate on him. But that meant he was at the mercy of villains.

Ochako knew it was probably scary. Painful, terrifying, and traumatic. Every time she heard Toga spit out commentary like it was some kind of game, she could feel herself pale. Every

time she heard his screaming, she could feel herself tense. She felt sick every time his fear and pain echoed through the trees like a song long forgotten.

She wanted to run back and save him every time she heard Toga laugh and mock his pain. She knew Bakugou had to be feeling worse than she was. Midoriya was his childhood friend. He'd been there throughout Midoriya's life, unable to help him, even though he was *right there.* He'd always been so close. So close to saving him. It must be a terrible reminder, that even now, right this second he could be helping him. But fate had other plans for him, apparently. So she understood his urgency. She understood his all-consuming need to hurry up and end this before Midoriya was seriously injured, or worse. Dead.

That's why she stopped him. She yanked hard on his shirt, pulling him back a few paces. "Bakugou," She snapped, her voice hard. "Go,"

"What? What're you talking about, Chubby Cheeks?" Bakugou grumbled, looking much angrier than she expected. "Let's hurry the fuck up!"

"No." She said firmly. "Go to him,"

It took a moment for understanding to blossom in his expression. "I know he said we need to stay away, and bring down the barrier so Heroes can help us…"

"But that's a shit plan, if you ask me," Bakugou snapped. "Are you sure you can handle it on your own?"

"Oh come on. We *both* go to Yuuei. I'll be fine." Ochako promised, "Now hurry up and save him,"

Bakugou took a moment to look at her. Really look at her, and then he turned and ran into the forest. And suddenly Ochako was alone. She sighed heavily, but refused to regret her decision. Midoriya needed help. All she had to do was find one villain, and defeat him. With a deep breath, she plunged into the forest, the only sound were her footsteps and her breathing.

She couldn't fail. She *wouldn't* fail. Not with Midoriya's life on the line. Not with *everyone's* life on the line. Even people outside might be in trouble. What if it was worse outside? What if there were even more villains, more dangerous than the ones in here?

No. She couldn't think about that right now. She needed to focus on her task. But it was too late. Ochako wasn't alone anymore. She slowed her pace until she was walking. Just ahead, in a clearing, stood a man. He was taller than she was, but that wasn't saying much. She was pretty short, even for a girl. The man was rather thin, too. His hair was slicked back with gel, and his eyes were *glowing.*

It reminded her of Aizawa-sensei whenever he activated his Quirk. "Ochako Uraraka?" The man asked, with a pleasant smile. "You're a student at Yuuei, aren't you?"

She hesitantly nodded, not trusting herself to speak. He was a villain, but not just any villain. He was probably the villain she was looking for. "Good," the man said, sounding only a little guilty. "Then I won't regret what I have to do to you,"

It was at that moment that the man pulled out a gun. And in that moment he pointed it at her. The silence was loud in her ears, and she could *feel* her blood running cold in her veins like ice. She didn't even have time to move, or scream, when the man pulled the trigger and the air wasn't silent any longer. The piercing ring of the gunshot rang in her ears.

She'd failed.

Hitoshi had to do something. He had to help them. Yes, he'd been taken out of the exam faster than he'd like, and yes, he was on the *outside* of the barrier. But that didn't stop him from wanting to help. That didn't stop him from thinking of a plan.

The villains had arrived fast. Faster than Hitoshi had thought possible, but in all honesty the heroes had the advantage. They had numbers. There were villains crawling through the place. Some of them were patrolling the stands, walking up and down the stairs, watching them. A

great number of them were guarding the announcement room. For now, he needed to get his classmates to help him get rid of the villains in the stands, and the villains guarding the stadium in general. He could send the pros to help Present Mic and Aizawa-sensei.

Then they could find a way to break the barrier. He swallowed thickly, sweat beading on his forehead. Iida was sitting next to him, pale and silent. Hitoshi bumped his shoulder just slightly. Iida glanced at him sharply, and Hitoshi leaned closer to him. His whisper was soft, but loud enough for Iida to hear clearly. He hoped.

“I have a plan,”

“You do?” he asked, an eyebrow raised, and a relieved smile curling his lips. “What is it?”

It was simple. So simple, it was reckless and almost foolish. But Midoriya and everyone else stuck in there was suffering. He wanted to help them. But before he could do that, they needed to help themselves.

So after he explained, Iida whispered to the person next to him. It was like a huge game of telephone. Not *everyone* needed to know the plan, but as many people as possible needed to know for this to work. And even if he didn’t have people at his back, ready to support him, he’d still do it.

Hitoshi stood from his seat with a feigned yawn. He needed to act natural. A scream crackled through the video playing on the huge screen. He didn’t look at it. He blocked it out. The sobbing, the pain, the shrieking. He had no idea what Midoriya’s plan was, but it was a stupid one. He couldn’t take the screaming anymore. He wanted it to stop.

He needed to hurry. The first villain he came into contact stopped him as he tried to leave the stands. It was a burly man with barely any hair. He looked mean, but that didn’t stop Hitoshi. “You can’t leave the stand—”

“Move.” Hitoshi growled, his glare cold and hard.

“I’m not gonna move, ya dumb—”

“You’re going to escort me to your comrades, and act normally.”

Chapter End Notes

DOES ANYONE WATCH MO DAO ZU SHI BECAUSE I FUCKING RECOMMEND THAT U DO MICCHI AND TALI IN MY SERVER GOT ME HOOKED ON THAT SHIT

Chapter 50

Chapter Summary

Sports Festival Continued! (feat. Todoroki, All Might, Shinsou and a scary lady who I definitely didn't get inspiration from Demon Slayer and LoL for.... haha)

Chapter Notes

AYEEEEE GUYS I FINALLY HAVE MY MAC AT MY HOOOOOUSE!!! (and I bought my gaming pc parts and I'm terrified to put them together...???)

I ALSO DECIDED ON MORNINGSTAR TO BE DEKU'S HERO NAME FINALLY LOL (so i should go back and fix that.... haha)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Toshinori was sitting in Nedzu's office, watching the Sports Festival from the comfort of the couch. They had a little time before they had to head over there. Soon enough they'd be giving out the medals to whoever won the Sports Festival. Toshinori secretly hoped it would be Midoriya. He deserved to win for once. But it wasn't long before Toshinori saw everything fall apart.

The villains came from the crowd, like a snake shedding its skin. They came from the streets, and most of them came from the numerous purple portals that popped up everywhere. Villains swarmed the commentators stand, where Aizawa and Present Mic were.

From there, they locked down the stands and patrolled the stadium as a whole. Within minutes, they erected a purple barrier over the forest, and All for One's face popped up on the screen that had just been displaying the children left inside the forest.

"Oh dear," Nedzu mumbled softly, and Toshinori couldn't ignore how his tea cup was shaking in his paw. "Oh dear, oh dear."

Toshinori felt sick. Like someone had shoved acid down his throat, and his body was rejecting it. He needed to *move.* He needed to *save them.*

Power flickered just beneath his skin, like fire. A burning, raging fire that burned him inside out. One for All. He needed to transform and save the day, like everyone was begging him to. He was their symbol of Peace.

When people thought of a hero, of a savior, it was always All Might. It was his wide smile, his blond hair, his bulging muscles, and deep blue eyes that were so similar to the ocean. He needed to be there. He needed to stop this.

“Toshinori-san,” Nedzu murmured in the tense silence. His eyes were cold and hard. Devoid of all happiness. “You need to help them. You need to *save my children.”*

Toshinori took a deep, sobering breath. Even Nedzu was counting on him. He felt himself melt into the warm sensation of his Quirk. Warm and welcoming, like a hug. Like a kiss.

He could feel his muscles and bones shifting. He could feel himself get slightly taller. “Have no fear, Nedzu!” He said dramatically, as he shifted into this new form. His hero form, the only form of All Might anyone had ever seen. He wasn’t the thin, gaunt looking Toshinori he’d been a few seconds ago.

Now, he was the Number One Hero in Japan. He was All Might. And he was going to save the day.

He was in full Hero mode. Ready to risk his life, again and again for the children of tomorrow. Toshinori was the strongest hero in Japan. Perhaps the entire world. Everyone looked to him when things went wrong, and villains threatened the peace and calm of daily life.

“For I am here!”

The first thing a hero needed to know about plans, was that the plan almost always failed. Hitoshi knew this. He predicted it. He wasn't stupid, so he'd come up with a backup plan in the process of creating his original plan.

His original plan had been to slowly, methodically, take out all the villains in the stands one by one. Then he'd send *professional* heroes to save Aizawa-sensei and Present Mic. It was going to take time, sure, but in the end he'd finish in time. He even had Iida slowly spread the message around, so others could join and help him.

They'd barely told two other people by the time a villain came around, and separated them. Hitoshi had already begun knocking out villains and tying them up by this time. The only way he knew what had happened was because Tsuyu had texted him from the stands, one of the lucky few they'd been able to tell.

Hitoshi was on his own. But it didn't deter him. It made him more determined, but also extremely reckless. He had to throw away his plan. Midoriya's screams followed him like a siren, echoing and begging him to come to him. Begging him to save him. Midoriya was the only person who had *ever* told him that his Quirk was cool. Impressive. Amazing.

He owed it to Midoriya to at least try his damndest to save him. He was a hero in training, god damn it. It was going to be his *job* to save people. Fear clawed at him, like a starving beast. He swallowed it deep down as he ventured up the stands slowly. He'd been lucky enough so far to not get caught, but that was mostly thanks to his Quirk.

This cursed Quirk he'd hated for years. The Quirk that earned him more than a few bloody noses, and nasty words thrown his way. A Quirk that could now be put to good use. With his power, he could save Aizawa-sensei, Present Mic, and his classmates.

With this power, he could show the world he was worthy of being a hero, and he could show these villains that *Yuuei* wouldn't tolerate villains crashing their sports festival. Hitoshi abandoned all rationality, as he suddenly broke into a run, sprinting up the stairs of the stands, all the way up to the booth where his teachers were being kept. Toga would be talking when he entered the room, for sure. He could brainwash her easily. And then he'd have two pro's on his side. He could rally the Heroes around them, and make them take action. He didn't care if he had to brainwash the entire stadium to do it.

Hold on...

That was it. *That's* how he could get rid of all the villains instantly. All he had to do was take the microphone from Toga, and manage to mind-control all the villains in the stadium. He just had to make it up there. He only had one chance, but it was better than nothing at all.

He passed by a villain, narrowly avoiding getting caught as he vaulted himself by the last of the steps.

Luckily, the door was left unlocked.

Hitoshi blew through it like it was nothing, the door slamming into the wall behind it, that's how roughly he'd shoved it open. Toga, who had been mid-speech, cut herself off in surprise.

"And Midoriya gets another punch to the face! That looks like that hurt—!"

"Who're you?" She snapped, forgetting for a moment that the microphone was still up to her lips. Hitoshi shrugged.

"I'm the guy who's gonna kick your ass," Hitoshi said, with a smirk. Toga's face went red, from rage. Or maybe it was red because she was blushing. Maybe she was weird like that. Hitoshi didn't want to bother thinking it over in his brain. He needed to stay focused on his mission.

"Really? You think you can beat—"

Bingo.

“Free Aizawa-Sensei, and Present Mic. Hand me the microphone,”

Her body had gone disturbingly rigid, like every single time Hitoshi used his Quirk. She complied quickly and silently, and within seconds he had the microphone in hand. He muted it for a second, before turning to his teachers.

“Aizawa-Sensei—“

“That was reckless!” Aizawa shouted, and it had not been what Hitoshi was expecting. He hadn’t expected Aizawa to be so angry that Hitoshi had succeeded. His teacher was pale, and shaking.

“What? I don’t—“

“You could’ve gotten yourself killed. You’re so lucky your plan worked!”

He was yelling, but not because he was angry. He was worried. He was pale with it, and shaking. His voice was breaking, and thin. “Do you *understand* how dangerous that was?”

Present Mic had tied Toga up, so Hitoshi didn’t see the problem. He pressed his lips together in a thin line and glared at his teacher. “Yeah, I could've died. But if I don’t do *anything* everyone in that forest would’ve died for sure,”

“Shouta,” Present Mic said gently, “He’s only trying to help.”

“I know he is,” Aizawa said softly. Almost too softly for Hitoshi to hear. “I want to help everyone too, but he could’ve gotten killed,”

“We have to save them,” Hitoshi reasoned.

“What about the villains *outside* of the forest?” Aizawa asked, crossing his arms. He gave Hitoshi a critical look, and Hitoshi reasoned it must be because he was testing him. How well could he think on his feet in times of crisis?

Very well, thank you very much, Aizawa-Sensei. Without missing a beat he explained. “I’ll brainwash the entire crowd,”

He made it sound easier than it was. Honestly he wasn’t sure if he could do it. He wasn’t sure his Quirk was strong enough, or if *he* was strong enough. But he had to be. Right now, his friends—his *family* was in danger.

He didn’t have time for self-doubt. He didn’t have time for meticulous thinking, or a rational plan. “The entire crowd? Even the people who aren’t villains?”

“Yes,” Hitoshi said, his face set into a determined expression. This was his chance to prove himself. It was his turn to be the hero. Aizawa gave him a slight nod, and Hitoshi unmuted the microphone. There was a bit of static.

The only problem was, he didn’t know what to say. Something that would catch everyone’s attention. A single sentence that would get everyone responding in one go, so he could capture them with his Quirk.

But… What did he *say?*

It took him a long, painful moment to begin speaking. “You villains think you’ve won. You’ve managed to sneak into the Sports Festival, right under our noses. You’ve managed to hold some of our classmates hostage in the forest. You’ve locked this entire place down, but that doesn’t mean you’ve won. In my opinion, you’ve completely fucked yourselves over.”

This was *not* where he thought this was going to go, but he couldn’t stop now. He had to get as many of the villains, and even the heroes riled up. “Did any of you even *think* before you decided you were going to crash *Yuuei’s* Sports Festival? Oh wait— that’s *right!* Villains don’t think. You all just thought you’d waltz in here, with no resistance? With no fight? No consequences? Yuuei is the most prestigious Hero school in the nation. It pumps out pros

yearly without fail. This is a haven for Heroes, and I don't think you guys belong here. It's time for retribution, baby."

By now, the crowd outside was roaring. It was thunderous, loud, and Hitoshi could barely think. But this is exactly what he'd been working toward. The voices had reached a crescendo. **"Everybody freeze."**

Yuga Aoyama wasn't used to traversing a forest with a hot-and-cold babe like Todoroki Shouto. Granted, this was a dangerous situation, with villains milling about like spiders under his bed, but he didn't want to think about that. It sent shivers skittering up his spine. He shouldn't be thinking about Todoroki like that.

It had been lucky for him when Midoriya told him that he was going to work with Todoroki. Yuga would *never* complain about being near someone so gorgeous. And so *strong.*

Todoroki was one of the strongest — if not *the* strongest — person in their class. Fire? Ice? Both of them together? He was perfect. He was a *crime-fighting machine.* He'd proved that during the U.S.J. Incident. He was knocking out villains left and right the entire time, and he didn't cry. Not *once.*

The only person — or people, even though the both of them might as well be attached at the hip — that could rival Todoroki in his strength was Bakugou and Midoriya. Out of those three, it was almost impossible to tell who was stronger. But honestly… it was probably Midoriya.

His Quirk was insanely scary, but Midoriya-kun has a past to match it. Yuga felt bad for Midoriya. Pitied him. His entire life had been nothing but hell, and once again, here he was, in the thick of it. Amongst the evil he had tried so hard to run away from.

Yuga could almost cry over it. “Aoyama-kun,” Todoroki murmured flatly. “You’re spacing our again,”

“Sorry! But your face is so beautiful you distracted me,”

Todoroki grunted. “Who’re we looking for again?”

“You can’t be serious,” was the first thing Yuga said. “Kirishima, Tetsutetsu, and Shiozaki! Our classmates?”

“Just double-checking,” Todoroki promised, as they walked. “Where do you think they are?”

“Honestly? I’m pretty sure they’ve been captured by villains by now. Or maybe they’re looking for us, thinking we’re in trouble too.”

Todoroki was quiet for a moment. “I guess we just have to keep looking and hope we’re lucky.”

Yuga sighed heavily. The forest was deathly quiet. Unnaturally so, save for the occasional drone that hovered around. Todoroki always made quick work of them without either of them being spotted. They hummed as they flew in the air until they were destroyed.

The only other sound was Toga’s commentary. Completely unnecessary, and nerve-wracking. Almost sadistic, in a way. She’d comment on Midoriya’s condition and laugh. A high-pitched, cruel laugh that had Yuga shaking off goose-bumps each time. He couldn’t understand how villains could be so blatantly cruel to other human beings. How could you hurt another living thing — and possibly kill them — and go on living without any regret? How could you even stomach rising a hand against someone who couldn’t defend themselves? Or someone who wanted nothing more than to be a hero and help people? Or someone who was just a normal person? How could villains hurt people who didn't *deserve* it in the slightest?

It drove Yuga absolutely insane. But for now, he could do nothing. He was ordered to do nothing but search for their classmates. He'd make sure to do his part.

They continued searching the forest to no avail. Tetsutetsu, Kirishima and Shiozaki were nowhere to be seen yet. Todoroki seemed intent on their mission, and didn't seem discouraged in the slightest. Even as minutes ticked by, and Yuga grew anxious. They could be captured by a villain. They could be getting tortured. Or worse…

They could be *dead.*

It made his heart stop in his chest and squeeze. It made his blood pump and heat up with adrenaline. He matched pace with Todoroki, and they flew past the trees. Past countless drones, in search for their friends. As they ripped their way through the gnarled roots of trees, and pushed their way between tree trunks, they began to notice something.

White threads were thrown about everywhere. Like a spider's web. No, Yuga was wrong. This *was* a spider web. With that realization Yuga stopped dead in his tracks, pulling Todoroki to a stop as well.

They had reached a clearing of sorts. It was small, but it was a decent enough gap between trees. The webs intertwined here, cutting through the air, connected to branches and the ground. A maze. They were right in the middle of the spiders web.

And Yuga was *terrified* of spiders. "Aoyama-kun…" Todoroki began, his already pale face seemed to pale further as he looked up into the branches. "L-look up,"

He didn't want to. He didn't want to see what Todoroki was seeing. He didn't, he didn't, he didn't.

The fear was too much, like a monster trying to drag him under. It rooted him to the spot. He didn't want to see what was making *Todoroki Shouto* tremble with fear. He didn't want to see what was making him pale like that.

And then something dripped on his shoulder. Something warm and wet. Sticky. Yuga swallowed thickly, before staring at the red spot on his previously clean uniform. Blood.

Reluctantly, Yuga Aoyama looked up. There was more web. But this time… there was something in it.

Not some *thing* … he realized with mounting horror. It was someone.

Wait. He was wrong once again. It was more than one person trapped within the webs. More than one person bleeding, their blood dripping slowly down to the ground. He knew all three of them.

Tetsutetsu, Kirishima, and Shiozaki. All wrapped up in the slicing webs, restrained and unconscious. But one question remained. Where was the villain who trapped them?

Where was their enemy? *Who* was their enemy?

"Ah," came a voice from way above. A deep, feminine voice, velvety and soft. *"More flies have wandered into my web?"*

"What've you done to our friends?" Todoroki spat, and Yuga colored himself surprised. Todoroki had just said *friends.* He was *concerned* for them. Yuga had thought Todoroki was heartless, like his father. He thought his classmate couldn't feel anything at all, colder than the ice he could conjure. He never attempted to make conversation with anyone, nor had he *smiled.*

Yuga took one glance at Todoroki Shouto, of Class 1-A, and felt his skin crawl. It was like claws caressing his skin, cold and cruel. The look on Todoroki's face wasn't joy. Or even fear. It was unlike anything Yuga had ever seen.

A deep seated *fury* . A fury that was so hot that his flames had burst from his skin, burning one side of his uniform to nothing. Fury so cold that ice exploded from the ground, and

creaked. Groaned. The temperature seemed to rise and drop dramatically. The ice reached so high that it was taller than the forest.

And suddenly, Yuga seemed to share that burning, brutal fury. A fury and hate so strong, that his skin *burned* . His blood was on fire, and his beautiful face was contorted and ugly with anger. He curled his hands into fists, and the joints popped. The lady said nothing. She just *laughed.*

And Yuga was so *angry* . He was burning and freezing. He was on fire. He was coated in ice. There was nothing to grasp. No words, no thoughts. Just that raw emotion that tore through him. It yanked his heart out, and set him ablaze like the fires of hell.

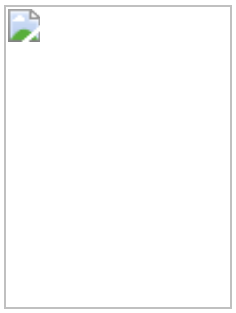
The hate had left no room for fear. For doubt. For anxiety. All that was left was the need to fight and save their family.

If they didn’t die first.

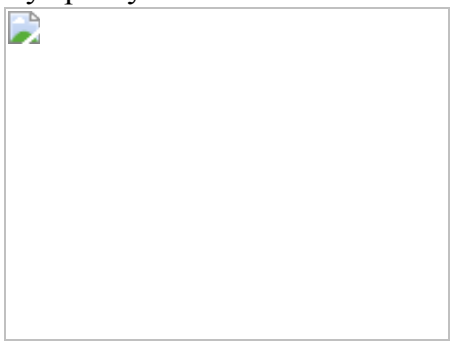
Chapter End Notes

So~ For the past few chapters I haven't put the fanart in here, so FINALLY here we go!

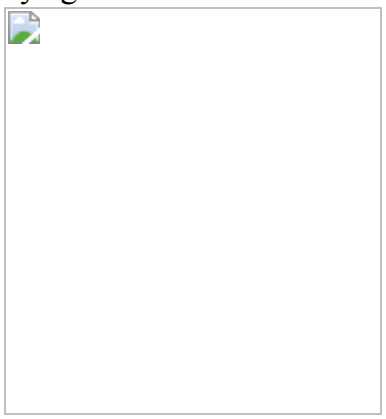
by Bobby Pins:

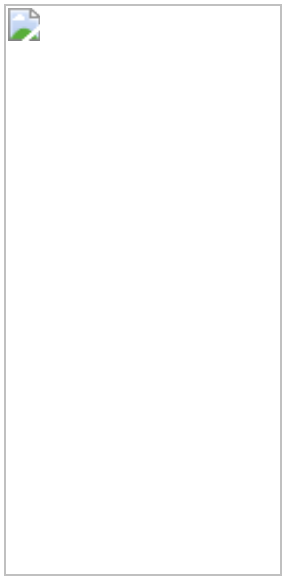


By spokryr



by agata





Chapter 51

Chapter Summary

Spider lady fight >:0

Chapter Notes

So um, I've decided to change the format of my chapters with more spaces between paragraphs because that's how it pastes from google docs and I'm too lazy to change it :DDD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“This is going to be fun.”

He never knew what hit him. All he could feel was the pain. The steel slicing open his skin. Tearing it open, bleeding him of everything. His blood. His strength, and his will. His power. Izuku was tired. So tired, and exhausted. He wanted to stop fighting entirely. He wanted to curl up and let himself disappear. He wanted to accept death and her icy grip. Anything was better than this continuous pain. *He couldn’t do it. He couldn’t last. He wasn’t strong enough.*

Izuku had no idea what this man was carving into his spine. Words? Phrases? Or was it pure sadistic rage and harsh lines, up and down his spine? From this day forward, scars would line his back, hot and angry. But that was if he *survived.* He was so tired. Izuku wasn’t even fighting anymore. He was limp, and at some point the villains holding him in place had let go of him. He’d stopped screaming after ten minutes of this. Never-ending pain. Pain beyond his imagination. It was like someone was peeling off his skin, very slowly. He was cold. The pain was so cold, and he was freezing. It had him clenching his jaw, and pulling his muscles taunt.

And yet, there was so much more pain to be had, he knew. The Priest was having too much fun. The man wouldn’t let it end here. He hadn’t been satisfied. Even right now, the dagger in his hand dug into his back, as he carved up more of his flesh. The man watched him bleed. He listened to Izuku grunt and pant with silent pain. So much pain. Pain that burned through

him like nothing but paper. Pain that electrocuted him, setting every single cell of him on fire. It made him shake. He couldn't move. He couldn't move. He couldn't fight.

There was just too much pain. *It was killing him.* His head pounded, blood dripped down his nose. Coated his lips, until he could taste nothing but iron. It was explosion after explosion of agony that had him nearly seizing each time the blade cut him open.

"Do you want to know why it hurts so much?" The Priest asked, finally reaching the base of Izuku's spine. Hopefully it would be over soon. Hopefully his classmates found a way out. Izuku didn't even bother to acknowledge the man's question. He spoke anyway.

"It's because this dagger was blessed, and coated in Holy water. It was specifically designed with your Quirk in mind," The man explained, and Izuku could feel his hot breath on Izuku's neck. He didn't even move a muscle, even as his skin went cold. "All for One gave it to me as a gift. Among other things. He told me to use this chance to test every weapon he designed on you, and I think it's time to move onto part two,"

So he wasn't done. All of that had only been one part of his plan. Of his experiment.

Izuku didn't think he could last much longer. He didn't even think he could stay awake right now. His eyes were getting heavy, and it was so tempting to let them shut. So tempting to go to sleep, and possibly never get up again. His body begged for it. *He* begged for it.

Katsuki was running. He wouldn't let anyone stop him this time, from protecting and saving Izuku. He had been stopped so many times before. So many things had gotten in his way, and prevented him from helping his childhood friend. Today, he refused to be stopped. He refused to get caught up and rendered no help to Izuku. Katsuki refused to get so close, just to be out of reach.

The trees whipped past him, their thick tree trunks all blurring together. He was getting sick of this forest and it's still, unnatural atmosphere. The sun was beginning to set, which set everything in a gold, orange glow. Soon it would be dark, and they'd be at *another*

disadvantage. He needed to save Izuku fast. They needed to get out of here as soon as possible.

He just hoped someone was trying to save them. He hoped All Might was on his way, ready to save the day like he usually did. He'd have his signature smile on his face and he'd be flexing his muscles as he spoke.

"Have no fear, for I am here!"

That's what he'd say, puffing out his chest. He'd destroy the dome with one punch and save the day. He just knew it.

But just in case, Katsuki would save Izuku before it was too late. Before it was too much for his friend. He knew Izuku had to have an insanely high pain tolerance, thanks to his training with All for One, but he wasn't sure if Izuku could last much longer.

It was Katsuki's job to save Izuku when he refused to save himself. And it would be no one's fault but Katsuki's if his childhood friend died here. He couldn't let that happen. He couldn't allow it. If anyone deserved to be a hero, it was Izuku.

No one was as determined to become one. No one else in their class had to fight every step of the way to get themselves here. Izuku had to risk it all. He had to put his life on the line, just so he would have a *chance.* He wasn't even guaranteed to become a hero, but he proved himself worthy every single day. With or without knowing it, Izuku was saving people every day.

He was inspiring everyone in his class. He put himself in the direct line of fire whenever there was danger. Izuku was a true hero. Unlike everyone else, who got scared, and ran away with their tails between their legs. He was the closest out all of them to becoming a hero.

And honestly, in Katsuki's humble opinion, he was the only one who *deserved it.*

But fate wasn't on his side. "Bakugou Katsuki," A voice said, emerging from the trees. Katsuki didn't even realize he'd stopped running. The voice belonged to a tall lanky guy, with messy black hair. "Your Midoriya's best friend, aren't you?"

And somehow, Katsuki knew he wouldn't get to save Izuku, as the man lunged toward him.

Toshinori wasn't even aware of how fast he was running. Or how fast he was jumping rooftop to rooftop. He didn't notice how he was cutting through the air, and left chaos in his wake. He was too focused on getting to the stadium on time. He needed to save everyone. Toshinori was already unbelievably late to this party, and at this exact moment his students were being hurt. Being slaughtered. Being tortured.

It sent fury coursing through his veins like ice. It took longer than he'd hoped to get to the stadium. He jumped through the air, tucking in his legs as he soared through the air, right into the stadium. He landed softly on the ground, but his presence didn't go unnoticed. Iida turned to look at him, his eyes wide, and face pale. He didn't move from his spot on the stands, but this whole scene was strange. Only a few people were moving around, and looking at him with hopeful eyes. Everyone else seemed to be frozen in place, pumping their fists, mouths open wide, with no words leaving their lips.

Some were just sitting, as still as a statue. All Might glanced around, confused for a moment, before Shinsou, Present Mic, and Eraserhead exited the booth, and All Might came to his own conclusion of what was happening.

It was highly probable that Shinsou had attacked Toga, and used the microphone to brainwash the entire crowd. All Might felt a swell of pride bubble up in his chest for his student. But then he looked closer at the three of them. Aizawa was supporting Shinsou on one side, while Present Mic took the other.

He realized at that moment that it was taking a tremendous amount of strength to keep his hold on all the mind-controlled people in the stadium. All Might knew what to do, and he didn't hesitate to begin. The villains weren't able to move in this state, so he made quick work tying all of them up one-by-one.

Eventually Iida got up and began to help him, but it still took up a lot of time. It made him anxious. He felt like he was constantly swallowing a lump in his throat that wouldn't go away. Midoriya's screaming was the only sound outside the dome. Everyone who *wasn't* frozen, seemed to be. They seemed to be watching the screen with a sense of hurt and disgust. They were too frozen by his screams to get up and attack the dome in hopes of stopping them.

All Might didn't even want to know what they were doing to him, as he tied up the last villain, and Shinsou could finally release his control on them. All Might turned toward the dome, his fists ready to destroy it in one blow.

He put all of his power, every ounce of it, every bit of it, into his body until he was exploding with the power of his predecessors. He clenched his jaw, grinding his teeth together. The power that exploded from his fists was all of his power he could muster. One hundred percent of One for All.

And yet, when the dust settled, the dome was still there. It stood just as sturdy as before. Angry, he unleashed another set of blows. And then another, when they too, proved to be as ineffective as the first.

His chest was rising and falling rapidly. His anger seemed to multiply, until someone put their hand on his shoulder.

"It's not working, All Might," Shinsou said softly. "It can't be broken from the outside."

"Are you ready to begin, Midoriya?" The Priest asked on the screen. "Oh. Are you passed out?"

All Might looked up at the screen, broadcasting the footage for all to see. Midoriya's back was in bloody ribbons, and he was bruised in countless places. All Might clenched his fists together.

"We have to save him!" He exclaimed, his voice booming. "We can't just watch him suffer!"

“I have to agree with All Might.” Aizawa grumbled, and he took one look at him, and Toshinori knew that Aizawa wanted to tear someone apart for hurting his son. “Does anyone here have a Quirk that can dig *underneath*—”

But he never got the chance to finish the thought as the dome issued a loud cracking noise. All Might looked up at it, and could see a spider web of cracks. And then they heard the roar of a monster within it.

Fumikage Tokoyami couldn’t bring himself to wait any longer. He was sick of hearing Midoriya scream. He was sick of waiting for Uraraka-san to accomplish her mission. She must’ve run into trouble.

He needed to end everyone’s suffering here. He needed it to be over. He couldn’t take the stress any longer. He just hoped it could *be* destroyed, as he unleashed Dark Shadow. It was getting darker, and harder to control him. But it didn’t matter to Fumikage anymore. He could use it to his advantage. He would let Dark Shadow *rampage.*

To save his friends, he would tear this accursed barrier down, no matter what. Dark Shadow ripped through him, a force to be reckoned with. A devil within, begging for release. It was easy. It was effortless, letting Dark Shadow tear the barrier to shreds, screaming as he did so.

His large black claws ripped and clawed. The monster within him bellowed, in anger. In agony. In pity, for Fumikage’s friends. Fumikage paused, noticing the hairline fractures in the structure. He smiled, before Dark Shadow roared, shaking the ground with the force of it, and the dome shattered. It screamed through the air, like shattering glass.

The dome was broken.

The lady called herself the Black Widow. Her Quirk, after her rather unnecessary explanation, as she lowered herself from her webs, was Spider Web. At first, it didn't seem all that dangerous to Shouto. She could make webs shoot out of her hand. So what?

But then as he inspected her webs more closely, he realized that her webs had to be stronger than regular ones. They could hold Kirishima, and wrap around his body so tightly that it sliced open his skin. He and Aoyama could easily get caught up in them, and the fight would be over before they knew it.

They needed to save their friends, and make it out of here alive. Shouto was already sweating from the pressure, but he refused to let it hinder him in any way.

"Are you prepared?" the lady asked, her long black dress trailing behind her as she walked toward them. Her pace slow, and leisurely. Her smile wasn't friendly, but neither was Shouto's.

Shouto heard Aoyama suck in a breath behind him, but Aoyama didn't move to run away. In fact, as he gave him a concerned glance, he noticed that Aoyama's expression was hard and cold. He wasn't about to let the woman get away with hurting their classmates either. He wasn't ready to fight her, but it didn't matter. No one was ever *really* ready to fight for their own lives, much less the lives of their classmates.

His ice was rocketing toward her seemingly on its own. It ripped through the ground, groaning and creaking as it closed in on her. He needed to see how she would react. He needed to see her reaction time, and what she would do. Shouto needed to see if she was heavily reliant on her Quirk or not. That would give him an idea of where this fight would go. Either he needed to use his ice, or use his fire.

It was all down to her reaction. And then he also had Aoyama to think about. How could his Quirk fit in all of this? He was beginning to kind of feel like Midoriya, his thoughts and theories running wild in his head. He desperately tried to channel that. *Think like Midoriya. Think like Midoriya.*

He watched her closely as she shot webs out of her hand and used it to dodge the attack entirely. The thread wrapped around a branch high in the air, and she swung on the thread, before swinging herself forward, past the ice. She dropped lightly on her feet, and brushed

imaginary dust off her long dress. It had all happened pretty fast, but Shouto wasn't going to be deterred just yet.

He just needed to be smart about how he approached this. She was obviously Quirk reliant, and if Shouto could cancel it out, he and Aoyama would gain a hefty advantage against her. But they'd have to work together in perfect harmony, he and Aoyama. He also needed to know how strong the webs could be, and if he could cut them. If *he* couldn't, then maybe he could have Aoyama try it with his navel beam.

She was quick to counter-attack, shooting webs out of her hand, aimed right for Shouto's ankles. She was trying to keep him from closing the distance between. *Oh. So she doesn't want me to get closer? Is her Quirk not suited for close combat?*

That could be it. He just needed to get closer to find out. He used his ice to throw himself forward, making a path of ice behind him as he went. The air cooled, thanks to it. But the spider woman, Black Widow, still managed to create distance. She used her webs to create a wall of web between her and Shouto's ice. "Hey, Aoyama, try to use your beam to destroy the webs!"

The only sound he made that indicated that he heard, was the sound of his beam firing up. And suddenly the forest around them swelled with light from the beam. Once the air settled, and Shouto's eyes adjusted to the total darkness once again, he noticed that the web was the same. He grit his teeth angrily. For him to be able to use his fire, he'd need to get Aoyama and his friends out of here. He couldn't risk accidentally hurting his friends.

"Aoyama-kun," He said, his voice deceptively calm, maybe even soothing. "I need you to free our friends and run away with them,"

"But Todoroki-kun you'll—"

"Just do it," Shouto spat, clenching his fists angrily. "I can't use my fire side too well. I don't want to risk hurting you,"

“O-okay,” Aoyama mumbled, and Shouto didn’t look to see if he’d followed his instructions. For now, he needed to keep the attention on him, so Aoyama could escape once he freed their friends. Midoriya was fighting his own battle, and *this* was Shouto’s.

And he was determined to win it.

Black Widow came at him again, the indestructible web now gone. She swung through the air, her webs tethering her tree branch to tree branch. She shot another stream of web out of her free hand, aiming straight for Shouto’s face, but he dodged it. He rolled out of the way, repositioning himself.

She frowned, a rather ugly look on her face, and produced more web, using it as a whip. It cut through the air, whistling dangerously, and Shouto felt hot searing pain cut through his chest. It had been too fast for his eyes to follow. His chest stung, but he pushed through it.

Then he heard the soft snapping of Aoyama freeing their classmates, and he knew he had to distract her. He rushed forward, bringing his hand out, and thrusting a block of ragged ice out at her like a projectile. She swiftly ducked. They danced around each other, Shouto doing most of the poking.

He was beginning to get cold. But Aoyama had found a way to get his classmates out of the web, and Tetsutetsu seemed to be the only conscious one out of the three. Frantically Aoyama was trying to get him to help him carry the other two, and Tetsutetsu nodded numbly.

Shouto let out a soft, relieved sigh as he took in his classmates for only a second. Tetsutetsu seemed to be fine, except he had a deep gash in his arm. Luckily it didn’t seem to bother him too much as he hefted Shiozaki into his arms, and the four of them made a break for it.

He returned to the battle at hand. He didn’t even hesitate. It felt so natural. So effortless, to let the burning, all-consuming rage burn brightly in the form of fire. It blazed hot. It burned, and made him sweat.

Now he could get serious. And she sensed it. Webs shot out from every direction, trying to pin him in place, but he was using both sides now. He wasn’t afraid to burn this forest down,

as long as he got *her* .

It was finally his turn to get some revenge. It was finally his turn to regain some control over this situation. *Finally.*

He skidded across his ice, as he narrowly avoided the threads. He shot out a stream of fire, burning her webs. He allowed himself a small smile. He had been right. Fire was *really* effective. But she didn't even break a sweat, as her whip came toward him again. This time instead of striking him, it wrapped around him, and he barely even had a chance to dodge. He struggled to get out of her hold, but ended up falling off his bridge of ice, and onto the ground. He growled.

Fuck. Fuck. Think like Midoriya.

Fire burst from his skin, and he scrambled to get to his feet as the webs melted away. At least he had a slight advantage. He could do this. He could win.

"God damn you, you little pest!" She shouted, creating a massive wall of web, that came crashing down on him. With the flick of her wrist, the webs around him tightened and shifted. If he didn't act now, they'd slice him to bits. But his movements were slower and groggier than before.

She let out a shrill laugh. "Did I forget to mention that my Web Whip uses poison to slow down my opponents? Judging by the look of confusion, I probably forgot to mention it."

The webs shifted and cut through the air, impossibly fast. Pain bubbled to the surface of his skin like fire as the strings cut into him, but he wouldn't allow himself to get cut up into pieces. Even if he was poisoned, he was going to end it *now* .

His fire burned through the webs, but he noticed a little too late that it had been a distraction after all. Her hand was wrapped around his throat and squeezing before he could even blink.

But he smiled. Something wicked, slow, and cruel. He laughed, even though it sounded weak. “I’ve finally got you,”

And she laughed too, “What do you mean?”

Shouto huffed out a weak laugh, grabbing her wrist and ice encased it. She screamed and withdrew, but that’s when she realized what she had been talking about. Euphoria pumped through Shouto’s veins.

Her ankles, her calves, and her thighs were trapped in ice. And now? Her hands had ice growing on them too, and now she couldn’t use her Quirk.

“Looks like you’re the fly in the web after all, Black Widow.”

Chapter End Notes

Did u enjoy?? I hope so!

Chapter 52

Chapter Notes

Hmm the sports festival should be overrrrrr in like 2 chapters???? (also im sorry for being a day late yall, but here it is!)

aLSO trigger warnings, considering the nature of this chapter (and because i proofread it before posting. ~~Im currently writing 11 chapters ahead at all times, so I do get disconnected in terms of whats happening in the fic, which is why i rarely tag triggers in notes)~~

Self-harm, depressive & suicidal thoughts, torture, self-inflicted torture, graphic descriptions of violence. (please feel free to tell me if i missed anything for this chapter)

IM RLLY SERIOUS ABOUT THE GRAPHIC DEPECTIONS OF TORTURE YALLL

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Yuga was running through the forest with Tetsutetsu when they found her. Uraraka-san. She was sitting up, clutching her bloody shoulder with one hand, and staring wide eyed at a stranger in front of her. The stranger —a villain —took one look at Yuga and Tetsutetsu before making a run for it. Yuga felt himself relax slightly.

Uraraka let out a sigh of relief and slumped to the ground, groaning slightly. “Uraraka!” Yuga exclaimed, “Are you okay, mi amore?”

“Yeah…”

“But you’ve got a gunshot wound,” Yuga noted, his voice shaking only slightly. “Let me help you.”

He placed Kirishima gently on the forest floor, and took off his Yuuei issued shirt. Underneath he wore a tank top, but that didn’t matter right now. He needed to stop the

bleeding before Uraraka bled out. He ripped his shirt up, and used it to wrap up her injury, and put pressure on it. Uraraka mumbled a small thanks, and Yuga nodded.

“Of course!~ We’ll be out of here soon enough, so don’t—”

And then he heard the loud cracking noise. Like shattering glass. And he knew that they had finally been saved.

It felt like it had been days since all of this had begun. It felt like weeks had passed, when he was roughly shaken awake. When had he gone to sleep? Where was he?

He didn’t know. Izuku could feel his bones creaking, as someone yanked on his hair and pulled him up again. He growled, pain throbbing in his back as they jostled him around.

“Wake up,” a man said. “I haven’t had the chance to experiment on you,”

He didn’t want to be experimented on. He couldn’t even remember what he was doing here. Or where *here* was. His mind was foggy with exhaustion, and he kept needing to swallow. His throat was dry. He’d been screaming. Izuku finally opened his eyes, the sky too bright, and the air too thin. He struggled to fill his lungs. Everything hurt. His back was screaming with agony, his head was throbbing. Every cell in his body was screaming at him in pain.

He didn’t dare move. But this man had other plans — The Priest. That was his name wasn’t it? — as he yanked him up again. Izuku squinted through the brightness, and everything finally came into view. The sky, darker than he’d originally thought.

The forest, with its green grass. Probably cool to the touch, if he dared to reach out. He could see trees, with the thickest tree trunks he’d ever seen, covered in moss and there were healthy green leaves on the branches. Right. He was in a forest, trying to gather points and cards before all of this happened. It had been light out when the sports festival began. He had

ventured into this forest, anxious but ready to prove himself. They'd almost finished too, when the villains erected the dome, and they were trapped inside, with countless villains. Now, all of his classmates in *and* out of the dome were suffering. They were probably worse off than he was, honestly. Compared to their pain, he doubted he even came up to par with theirs.

But it was his fault. It was always his fault. He had been the reckless one, who fought against his fate. Fought against the cards that the universe had dealt him. Screamed, cried, and broke himself just to get here. He had been so adamant in becoming a hero, that even when the universe gave him every sign that it wasn't meant to be, he fought harder. He tore himself apart. He accepted, yet feared his Quirk. He let a swordsman who was way too trigger-happy with killing corrupted heroes train him. He let that very man wiggle his way into his heart and create a home there. He let himself hope. He'd let himself trust, for the first time in his life. He let himself fight and achieve his dream. But in the end he killed the person he'd trusted the most. Izuku had let himself betray the strongest villain in the history of the world. But he'd gotten what he wanted, hadn't he?

But at what cost? Was it really worth this? Was it worth the pain that everyone's suffering through? Was my dream really worth this? Was my freedom worth this?

He didn't have an answer, he couldn't find one, and even if he did... It was his fault. All of this. It kept repeating in his head like a mantra. *My fault. My fault. My fault. I should've accepted my fate. If I knew I would do this to my friends, I would've become a villain to save them from it. My fault. My fault. My fault. My fault. My fault.*

He deserved this. All of the pain, all of the torture. They were in the same clearing as before, but it was stained red. It was his blood. Maybe that's why his mind was so fuzzy? He'd lost a lot of blood. At this rate, he was definitely going to pass out again before this was over. His gaze flickered to the other people in his line of sight.

On the edges of the clearing were villains, all enjoying the show. The woman from before, who suggested his torture, was leaning back, looking content. Around him was a circle of salt, and within the circle was the man from before—the Priest—with hands that could kill. Laying on the ground beside the man was an array of tools. Or, at least they were tools he could use against Izuku.

He sucked in a sharp breath. "You're finally awake,"

He didn't want to be. In his hands was a bible, and Izuku grimaced through the pain enough to shrink away. No. *Please no. Keep that thing away from me.*

He made quite a show of opening it, looking down at Izuku, and then back at the book. It was painful to wait. To tense his body, and prepare himself for the pain. For the fear. For the anxiety. He could barely breathe. He tried to stop his shaking hands, and his shaking breath. He was panicking. He felt faint, and his heart was squeezing in his chest each time it pumped blood into his system. God he was going to pass out just from fear.

He could feel fear seeping into his skin, crawling all over him like spiders, and he couldn't think about anything else. The feeling of impending doom was too strong, it chained him to the spot. He couldn't. He couldn't. *He couldn't.* It tore through him. Annihilated him. He was so *terrified* . Izuku couldn't even swallow the lump in his throat. His entire body was breaking out into a sweat and shaking. He was long since past the petty fear. He'd launched himself head first into the fiery emotion of terror. The Priest was beginning to remind him strongly of All for One.

What was happening to him? His hands were going numb. Tears blurred his vision, until the Priest looked blurry to him. They spilled down his cheeks and he didn't bother to wipe them away. Plus, he couldn't move even if he wanted to. He was frozen to his spot. His breath was coming out fast and shallow. He was barely breathing at all. There was too much pain. Too much terror.

"I haven't even started yet," the man grumbled, but he didn't sound too disappointed. "And you're already crying."

He didn't stop, not even as his cheeks were colored with shame. He was supposed to be a hero one day, but he was *crying.* But he couldn't stop it. His heart was beating too fast in his chest, as the man shook his head and procured a small jar full of water. Then he looked at Izuku with hard, cruel eyes. "Holy water," He explained, before placing it on the ground next to the other tools.

A crucifix, larger than the cross around Izuku's neck. A bundle of herbs that Izuku couldn't recognize. And then, the Priest put his full attention into the bible in his hands. And began to recite. The Holy words, straight from God himself.

And Izuku *screamed.*

The words burned his skin. Cut him open. His skin felt like it was peeling off, layer by layer. He was freezing. All of the power remaining in his body seemed to be leaving him. It felt like the Priest himself was pulling it out of him with his words. Siphoning it off or something. All he knew was that his skin was tingling and numb. The tears rolled down in earnest. Hot and fat, obscuring his vision even further.

"We exorcise you, every impure spirit, every satanic power, every incursion of the infernal adversary, every legion, every congregation and diabolical sect,"

It hurt. It hurt so bad. He was ripping his throat raw in agony. He wrapped his arms around himself, trying to hold himself together by sheer will. He ground his teeth together, clenching his jaw. He needed to stop *screaming* . He needed to ride through the pain, and breathe. He couldn't drown. Not now. He needed to keep his head up above this poisonous ocean of pain. He needed to keep himself here, in the present, and face the music.

Or rather… the endless pain.

Words spilled out of the man's mouth, each more painful than the last. It branded his skin, invisible to the eye, but there. Each word, more holy and horrible than the last, tore him apart. They shattered his delicate, already spiraling mind. He was already so tough on himself about everything. Every move he made. Every breath he took. He judged himself, hated and berated himself. He always wished he'd done something different, or blamed himself for everything that went wrong. The words seemed to make him feel even worse.

It reminded him again and again that he was a monster, and the words of God *hurt* . They were a physical reminder that he wasn't normal. That he was probably better off becoming All for One's heir. That he should probably be a villain, and do as exactly as All for One wanted, even if it killed him on the inside. Even if every fiber of him wanted and dreamed of being a hero. But he deserved to suffer. He deserved every second of pain, and turmoil. He deserved *nothing* good. Izuku didn't deserve happiness and a fulfilling life. More words, phrases, and verses passed from the man's cruel lips. Izuku was shattered, and broken again. Again.

Again. And again. *And again* .

He could practically feel his mother and father's breath breathing down his neck. Reminding him of the hell he'd ran from. Reminding him that he was an unwanted product of their love.

"May the power of Christ compel you!"

"DID I SAY YOU COULD SPEAK TO ME?!"

Monster. Ugly, destructive, abnormal, monster. I deserve this.

"He doesn't even talk, he's kind of creepy,"

"Are you ready to move on?"

He wasn't. He would never be ready for more pain. Not if it was only going to get worse. Not if he was going to burn him with that cross, and do who knows what else. He wasn't strong enough to push through it. He really wasn't.

He was sweating bullets, and crying so much that the world around him was nothing but a blur of blue, green, and white. Izuku was too weak. Any more, and he might die. He probably was well on his way down that road either way. He let out a groan, slow and slurred. The man before him took it as confirmation. At least he didn't hear anymore verses being spat at him. The pain in his head seemed to ease almost at once. And he managed to take a deep breath for the first time in hours. He couldn't, however, push away the nagging pain that sent sparks circling in his vision each time he moved. Trembling, he waited for the next round of pain. He waited, even though he couldn't take this any longer without grabbing that man's infernal dagger and stabbing himself in the throat with it.

Make it end. Please.

But he never got his wish. It just started over, like the world had been reset, but he was still hurt and damaged beyond repair. The pain began again, searing his chest. He couldn't even tell what was going on, or why he was hurting. It took a few more seconds of pain before he could blink his tears away enough to get a good look at his hopeless situation. He could smell his burning skin, could feel the crucifix against his skin, like a poker on fire. He'd thought he'd been getting branded before — even if they were invisible — but *this.* This burning, scorching, brand was visible. People would be able to see this. People could touch this, and they would know exactly where it came from.

They'd know this deranged villain attacked him in the forest, and tortured him on live television for all to see. He could hear his skin sizzling.

He could hear his assailant laughing, and Izuku finally forced himself to see what was happening. The man was pressing the damned crucifix to his fucking chest, watching his skin burn and burn. And there was a sick, twisted, cruel smile on his face.

It took all of his strength to grab the man's wrist and push it back. The world swirled around as he shifted. Pain spasmed down his back, but he had to *move* . He couldn't take any more.

He was going to die, and if he did, his classmates would be in danger. He needed to prevail until this infernal dome was gone. He could barely see, but vision was tunneling, getting darker and darker as he scooted himself away. But he gave the sky another glance. The purple dome surrounding them was still standing tall.

"Trying to run away, are we?" The Priest asked, with a soft chuckle. "But we're almost done! You're so close! You've been doing *so* well,"

His footsteps were slow, but Izuku kept moving. Until he couldn't anymore, until he hit an invisible wall, and glared desperately at his hands that gripped the grass below him.

The salt circle. That's why he couldn't go any farther. "Now…" The Priest said, holding that familiar jar from before. "Drink this,"

He shook his head, and he nearly passed out. Soon enough he'd be laying in this forest. As a corpse, and he didn't want to speed up the process even more by drinking straight *holy water* like it was a tall glass of fucking vodka. He knew for a fact that drinking holy water wouldn't get him drunk. It'd probably act like acid, and eat away at his organs and stomach. If his hypothesis was correct, he'd drown in his own blood, or his heart would simply stop. And he'd die.

Vomit spilled from his lips suddenly, catching him off guard. But then he looked at it… and it wasn't vomit he just threw up. It was blood. *His blood.*

I'm already dying. I'm dying… and I deserve it.

Tears threatened to fall, but he blinked past them. He deserved this. He shouldn't be sad. He shouldn't be crying. He should be accepting it, and the lack of pain it would offer. He was defeated. This was the end of him. It was finally over. He should be counting his lucky stars that he even had the chance at life. He should be grateful for the time he'd had here. But he couldn't.

He couldn't find it in himself to accept death, or accept that his time here was done. All he could think about was Kacchan. He wanted to watch him grow. He wanted to see him become a hero, and save the world one day. He wanted to see it happen. He wanted to be *alive* and by his side when he finally did it.

He couldn't even fathom dying before he saw that dream come to fruition. So he mustered together a will to fight. It was so small, his want, his *need* to live. To keep marching on. Just a tiny spark in his chest, but he kept kindling it, begging it.

Not yet. Not yet. Not yet. Please not yet. I still have to see Kacchan become a hero.

The spark was a small flame now, but it was enough. Crackling like a firecracker just beneath his skin. His vision swam once again, as he turned his head to glare at the Priest. The man just gave him a grin in response, before grabbing him roughly by the throat.

"Drink it."

Izuku flipped him off. The jar full of holy water shook dangerously in his hand, and Izuku resisted the urge to flinch. Poison in a jar, more deadly than any other poison the man could present him.

He sucked in a shallow breath. The Priest wasn't exactly choking him, but he wasn't being gentle either. His vision got blurry again. Izuku blinked away his bone-deep exhaustion and that's when things got even *worse.*

He saw Kacchan first, before he saw the villain pointing a gun to his head behind him. "Perfect time, Takashi," The Priest exclaimed, with the widest smile he'd ever seen. "Izuku-chan wasn't following my order."

Dear god, please no. Not him. Please don't kill him.

The man—Takashi—gave the man a slight grin. "Found him not too far from here, actually."

"Good." The Priest laughed, and Izuku tensed. He turned his gaze to him, and Izuku licked his lips, but it didn't help. His lips were still dry, and he had a feeling he'd be drinking that holy water any second now.

"Now Izuku," He snapped, setting him gently on the ground, shoving the jar in his hands. "Drink the water god has so gratefully given you,"

Izuku looked at Kacchan, and then back to the jar. And then he was sobbing. He didn't *want* to drink it. He wasn't even sure he could. He'd probably spit it out on reflex.

"Drink the damn holy water, or this fucking brat dies." Takashi growled, and Kacchan growled right back at him.

"You don't have to, Deku," Kacchan told him, his voice rough. "I don't matter."

But you do. You matter so much to me. I would do anything for you. I would die for you.

And if he thought of it like that, then drinking holy water wasn't so hard. At least on paper. He popped off the cap on the jar, and brought it to his lips. He couldn't stand and fight. He couldn't speak. He couldn't be of any *help.* But at least right now, right this second, he could keep Kacchan safe by drinking poison.

He would drink it a thousand times, and die a thousand times if that's what it took to save Kacchan. It burned like fire, like acid, down his throat. His mouth was thick with blood almost instantly. He retched, and the water spewed out of his mouth. Blood mixed with water, and splattered on the forest floor.

"Don't stop. Drink the entire thing."

And he brought it to his lips again. And again, drinking fire and swallowing the urge to seize and throw it all up. His body screamed at him to reject it. He had to stop, just to spit up blood. Large, clumpy chunks of it. He was getting cold, and he could feel his skull pound. He could feel his skin tear, and his bones snap. There were stars in his vision. Explosions in his ears, but he drank more, and hurt even more.

He blinked away the blurry redness in his vision, and watched numbly as the Priest accidentally stumbled for some reason, and kicked up the salt, just enough for him to be able to escape. But it didn't matter. He felt heavy, and he could hardly lift the poison to his lips and drink it down.

Thank god he'd drunk all of it. He blinked slowly, so slowly that he thought he'd nearly passed out just from that. Pain throbbed in time with his heartbeat, exploding each time. He only looked toward Kacchan, who was looking up at the sky in relief.

Izuku didn't take his eyes off of him, even as Kacchan glanced around after a second and noticed that all the other villains were distracted. He used that moment to free himself, successfully knocking out the villain who had a gun to his head.

Izuku wondered for a second why he'd been looking at the sky, but he was too tired to look up. There was too much pain. He barely noticed the explosions coming out of Kacchan's palms as he blasted away villain after villain.

He didn't even notice the blood running down his own face. Dripping from his eyes, his ears, his nose, and his mouth. He didn't notice the sirens of police cars and ambulances. He didn't notice Kacchan screaming at him. He only saw one thing, as he looked around for his original enemy. The Priest. Coming up to Kacchan from behind, hands outstretched and ready to kill.

He didn't even notice how All Might was rushing inside the forest at this very moment, with Aizawa in his arms, both of them ready to unleash hell.

He didn't even know the dome was even *gone.*

He coaxed that flame of willpower from before, and stood onto his own two feet. Pain like no other exploded down each notch in his spine. The pain was one of the few things he noticed as he got to his feet shakily, it vibrated through every cell of his body. It scraped it's poisonous claws down his chest. He couldn't even breathe, it was so intense. He couldn't scream, like he knew he should've.

He just moved. Reacted before his brain could catch up to his actions, and what would come of them.

I'll die for you.

He didn't think it would've been happening so soon, this dying for him thing, but he was moving impossibly fast. His vision had already gone black. He couldn't feel a thing, not a solitary thing. He couldn't hear Aizawa—practically his father—screaming like a banshee as he saw what was going on. He couldn't hear his own heart beat. But he could feel two cold, calloused hands come in contact with his neck.

Two very dangerous hands, hands that could kill with one touch. And then, finally, the pain was gone. Everything was gone. *He was gone.*

Chapter End Notes

ALSO A DISCLAIMER: (for the worried ppl)

SPOILERS BELOW!!!!!

I HAVE NOT TAGGED MAJOR CHARACTER DEATH SO BEFORE YALL HAVE A HEART ATTACK, Izuku is alive.

Chapter 53

Chapter Summary

not @me posting at one am.. haha..

but rlly.

Shouta being a dad for thirty minutes.

Chapter Notes

the song that this chapter is named after:

DEELYLE - Devil's Den

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shouta had never thought he'd be so terrified to see his son being a hero. He never thought he'd be screaming bloody fucking murder in the middle of a forest full of injured students and villains alike. As soon as the dome broke, he *demanded* that All Might carry him into the forest at full speed so they both could get to Izuku as fast as possible.

He had a bad feeling, a feeling that pulled on his chest and heart. It swam around his mind, telling him over and over that something wasn't right. Something had gone horribly, horribly wrong. He wasn't sure if he could face it. He wasn't sure he was ready for the guilt that was bound to drown him in crashing waves if his son didn't make it out alive.

Something's wrong. Something's really, really wrong.

All Might's feet didn't seem to be moving fast enough. They weren't going to get there in time. He knew it, deep down in his gut, where the feeling manifested itself. They were far too

late, if that video was anything to go by. Izuku had looked absolutely *mangled,* utterly ripped apart and destroyed, inside and out.

Shouta knew the look of hopelessness and despair well. He himself had looked like that too many times than he could count. His mind, along with his body, had nothing left to give, no strength to get up. He'd been beaten down too many times, in the hours that had passed.

And all Shouta wanted to do was save him, and help put him back together painstaking piece by painstaking piece. And hope that he'd grow back stronger and did not break again.

He also wanted nothing more than to break this villain's face and make sure he never got up, ever again. But they were going so slow, and Shouta was loosing his fucking patience. They needed to go *faster.*

But before he could voice his frustrations, All Might was skidding to an abrupt halt, and Shouta got a good, grim look at the battlefield before him. And he didn't feel anything. Not sadness, not anger, not fear. He didn't even know that he was screaming, screaming his throat raw. All he could see was that *fucking* Priest, and his son, limp and bloody on the ground below him.

And he didn't look sorry. But he should've been. He should've been running, and long gone from here if he wanted to avoid the beat down of his fucking *life.*

Shouta couldn't feel anything, and that made him all the more dangerous than any villain in this infernal forest. It made him more dangerous and terrifying that All Might, the number one hero. Someone had hurt his child, his *children,* and they were going to learn the hard way just how ruthless a Yuuei teacher could be.

It didn't even hurt, when he punched that very man square in the face. However, he did feel a crack, but it wasn't his knuckles. It was the Priest's nose, and blood dribbled down his face. Shouta didn't care. He just kept punching. He kept his Quirk activated, as he punched him again. He didn't bother with his capture weapon. He didn't bother with assessing the situation before he jumped right into the thick of it.

He just wanted these villains to feel the wrath of an angry father. He wanted these villains to remember his face, even as they rotted in prison. He wanted them to taste fear, every single time they decided to even *think* about Midoriya. He wanted to pound it into the very fiber of them and send them screaming.

Shouta wanted to be sure that his message had been delivered, even if it was ruthless and a bit, well, *feral* . His rage was boiling, boiling, and overflowing like a dragon roaring fire in his gut. Midoriya's corpse was a few feet away, Shouta's punch had sent the Priest reeling.

He was clutching his face, blow after blow, and laughed. It was rough, and emotionless.

All Shouta could see was red. All he could see was his son's dead *corpse* staring up at the open sky with glossy, dead eyes. Death's sharp, cold claws had dug its way into his son's soul. It sent sharp, stabbing, tears streaming down his face. It felt as if God himself, in all his holy glory, had come down to Earth and ripped Shouta's heart out. *And ate it.* Right in front of him, with a grin.

He'd do anything to chase him down and demand that the man thrust Midoriya's soul back into his body. He'd hunt down the Almighty himself. With this infernal rage, making his bones creak, and his skin burn, he was sure he could do anything. Shouta Aizawa was on the warpath, and he'd leave nothing except pain and retribution in his wake. He'd find him, he'd hunt him down himself, and he would kill this *God,* who turned his back on Shouta's son. The God who forced Izuku to live with Inko and Hisashi most of his life. This cruel God who let All for One destroy him again, and again.

And when Shouta finally landed eyes on God, and got his chance… he hoped it *hurt* . Fucking scratch that. He would make *sure* it hurt. He'd make it *slow* . He'd make it worth while, and by the end of it, that accursed God would know the wrongs he committed.

But right now, there was only one thing in front of him. That *stupid* fucking Priest, and Shouta kept going. Kept punching. Kept pulling him back for more, even though the man's face was bloody and unrecognizable.

The fear, the pain, the rage. All of it was swirling inside of him, making his stomach tie itself in knots. And then there was soul-crushing guilt, that whispered to him within the darkest

part of his mind, and said it was all his fault. He'd done this to his own child. He hadn't tried everything in his power to save him.

He had spent most of his time in that booth with Toga, just watching. He was no better than those heroes who were still outside the forest, sitting in their seats. He wasn't superior to them, those who still sat frozen. Doing nothing. Saying nothing.

He was no better than them, but god be damned, he'd make sure *this* villain, the Priest, never made it out of here alive.

Yamada didn't know why he got left behind, but it was honestly to be expected. Shouta had been the one to recommend that All Might carry one of them. Plus, if Izuku was in a life-threatening situation pertaining to Quirks, then Shouta was the safer option to accompany All Might.

Still, as he ran through the forest, this forest that was coated in the blood of children, he was worried. Beyond worried. His heart was racing in his chest, and there was the looming feeling of strangeness in the air like poison. Something was wrong.

As he ran, his thoughts swirled round and round in his mind, creating the worst situation he could think of. His son, lying face down in the grass. His husband, dead at the hands of a monster of a man.

Desperately, he pushed those thoughts away fiercely. He couldn't think like that. He couldn't depress himself like that. Izuku was probably okay. He was probably fine, bloody and beaten, but fine.

But that all shattered, like glass, as he finally arrived on the scene. The first thing he noticed, or rather heard, was Bakugou's explosions. Ripping through the air like a war cry, again again without a break. Then he saw the puddles of blood. The thin slashes of it, splattered

everywhere. He could smell it in the air, a deep iron smell. It was Izuku's blood. His suffering and pain, so publicly displayed. Left for Yamada to see, to mourn over. He saw the flying drone, still getting footage of everything. He didn't care, even if that meant there was still a villain left unaccounted for.

And lastly, he saw the body. So small, yet so strong, but broken. Mangled, ripped and shredded apart. He couldn't process anything else, but he did see All Might helping Bakugou knockout villains and restrain them. There was no need for him to fight, and he was grateful.

His face was wet with tears, hot and heavy. Heavy with his guilt and self-loathing, as he shakily made his way over to his child. His cold, *dead* child. He hiccupped, and fought the tightness of his throat. Fought the sobs working their way up his throat.

Before he could grieve, he needed to stop Shouta. The man's face was dark, and dangerous. He was angry, so angry. And Shouta was smiling. He never smiled.

Yamada felt something sick roll in his stomach like coals. Izuku needed to wait a little longer, as he reigned in his husband. He made his way over, as Shouta slammed his bleeding fist into the man's face again. And again.

"Shouta," Yamada murmured softly, so softly. He didn't think he could be any louder without sobbing. "I think you've proved your point, love. L-let All Might take care of him. Let's go see our son,"

It seemed to get through to him, even though Yamada had to repeat it twice. Shouta didn't seem to be all there. But he didn't move his eyes, or stop using his Quirk. He stared the man down, his eyes like ice and just as hard as they had been before.

Yamada could see the trail of tears streaming down Shouta's face. "Come on, Shouta, let All Might take care of him."

"He can kill people with a touch of his hands, I'm not letting him use his Quirk. I'm *not letting him kill anyone else,"*

“I could knock him out,” Bakugou grumbled, but didn’t wait for an answer. “I’m knocking him out.”

The Priest laughed, although it was a wet one. Bakugou’s fist swung, connecting with the man’s temple sharply. The Priest’s feet buckled underneath him, and he didn’t get up.

“Good work, Young Bakugou!” All Might exclaimed, with a smile. But it didn’t reach his eyes. It wasn’t even his usual smile. This one was wobbly, shaky, and strained. “Alas, I must go find and help your remaining classmates, and defeat the villain with the broadcasting Quirk.”

With that, All Might was gone, but Yamada barely noticed. Barely even cared. He tugged on Shouta’s sleeve, and *finally* , he moved. He turned, eyes shining and wet with sorrow, eyes on one thing. Eyes on the body, the small, broken body of their child.

It was like a spell was broken, with almost an audible snap. With a shuddering breath, he bit his lip and squeezed his eyes shut. It was heartbreaking. Shouta was a very overprotective husband, very worried, and concerned about everyone’s wellbeing. He always felt like it was his fault when a civilian died.

He always felt like it was his fault when Yamada came home from work, injured, but alright in the end. He always carried the invisible weight of everyone’s lives. He always felt responsible, and Yamada always felt the same.

They were heroes. They were protectors. It was their job to make sure people lived happy, healthy, villain-free lives. It was always *their* fault when someone didn’t make it out alive. Even if the press praised them. Even if the world held them in high regard. It was always their fault, and this time it was their own son. Their own son that they failed to protect and teach. Their own son they couldn’t save.

Yamada couldn’t breathe, much less comfort his husband. Grief had wound itself so tightly around his heart, that he couldn’t feel anything else. It crushed him, and took away any happiness he could ever feel.

The three of them made their way to the body. Bakugou was oddly quiet as they settled themselves down on the grass beside the body. He'd never even got the chance to become a hero. He had never got the chance to prove to himself that he wasn't evil. That he wasn't a villain. That he was worth more than his mind told him. That he was worth more than his mother and father told him. He *never* got the chance.

Shouta — god Yamada couldn't even look at him in the eyes — sniffled, his tears and sorrow so silent. Yamada's grief was silent too, and that was so unlike him, so out of character. Present Mic, the hero was supposed to be loud. And yet?

He couldn't make a sound as he ran a hand through Izuku's hair. He couldn't take his eyes off the body for a second. He was terrified it would disappear.

He watched, as Bakugou took Izuku's hand and threaded their fingers together. He was the first one to speak. "I was *right there."*

The words, *I failed. It's my fault. I should've saved him.* Were left unspoken. But Yamada heard them as clear as day in Bakugou's rough, horrified tone.

"There's nothing you could've done," Yamada managed, voice thin and cracking. "None of us could do anything,"

"He died *protecting* me. It's–it's—"

"It's my fault, not yours," Shouta ground out, like it physically hurt him to speak. To fight past the sobs, and the tears, and the sniffling.

"You're wrong Shouta," Yamada replied, as the man gingerly moved to the other side of Izuku's body, so he could lift the boy's head and rest it in his lap. "It's All for One's fault."

And it's my fault, too. I did nothing. I didn't even try to attack Toga. I did nothing.

Shouta said nothing, as he wiped his tears away furiously. He kept looking at Izuku like he couldn't believe his eyes. He ran his fingers through his hair, and more tears dropped from his chin.

Yamada didn't even try to get rid of the tears staining his cheeks. He didn't even try to suppress his sobs, and shaking sniffles. He hardly noticed that the drone nearby shorted out, and fell to the ground.

"Excuse me," A deep, rough voice sounded nearby. Shouta didn't even move his gaze from Izuku's face, but Yamada did. Bakugou did. Kurogiri, in all his purple shadow-like glory, stood nearby. The Priest was long gone, inside the purple portal beside Kurogiri. Yamada just stared. He didn't have any fight left.

"Why are you here?" Shouta asked, and Yamada knew he still hadn't looked away from Izuku. Still hadn't gained the strength to move.

Kurogiri's voice was strained, and hurt. "I'm here to gather up the Priest, as you guessed. But I'm also here to pay my respects," He stated simply, his voice thin with grief and regret. "Stain made me promise to protect his apprentice, and I failed. I'm here to apologize."

No one stopped him as he made his way over to Izuku's body. The man kneeled down beside them for a moment, and with all the swirling purple around his face, Yamada couldn't tell if he was crying. Or if he was even upset.

His respects were kind, and borderline depressing. "You would've made a beautiful hero. You would've saved so many lives, and you would've taught this cruel, cold world a few things about compassion and kindness. The world has lost someone great today, Izuku Midoriya,"

"All for One could never break you. He could never destroy your want, your drive, your *need* to become someone who saved, rather than someone who killed. He could never stomp the savior out of you. You infuriated him, but you inspired me. You made me believe that, if I had met you sooner, maybe I could've been a hero too..."

With that, he turned and walked into that portal. Yamada watched him go, with a mix of respect and worry.

“You know,” Bakugou said before the man could fully leave. Kurogiri paused. “It’s never too late, Portal Man.”

“Maybe someday,” Kurogiri mumbled, before finally disappearing. And suddenly it was silent once more.

As soon as the portal closed, the drone flickered back to life.

The chains clanged together in the blackness. They were hot against his skin, but the pain was dull and insignificant. He pulled against his restraints, but nothing came of it. They were sturdy and didn’t give.

Anxiously, he pulled at them again, and blinked as if he thought the darkness would dissipate. It stayed, and there didn’t seem to be any light coming to engulf him any time soon. It was pitch black.

And it was going to stay that way.

Izuku sucked in a sharp breath, shuddering in the abysmal black. His fear gripped him tightly, unrelentingly, and Izuku succumbed to it.

His hands shook, and his heart rate increased tenfold. Surrounded by nothing but his greatest fear made him spiral.

Izuku's chest squeezed, and he yanked roughly on the chains that bound him. He tried to blink past the darkness again, his eyes burning with unshed tears. His throat seemed to go tight with fear.

Where was he? Why was it so dark? Hadn't he died?

Izuku's thoughts stopped short. *He'd died.*

He knew where he was, in that instant. It explained the heat and the unyielding darkness that covered the world like a thick blanket. He was dead.

He pulled on the restraints with a little more desperation, but all it did was make pain spark in his wrists. Izuku was trapped here, down where the hopeless dwelled. He clenched his jaw, and pulled with all his strength.

The chains remained intact, and Izuku growled. He didn't want to be stuck here forever. He wanted to go back to Kacchan, Yamada, and Shouta. He wanted to become a hero.

But He reminded himself bitterly, *I'm dead. Even if I do manage to break free, what does that really do? It won't bring me back.*

Uselessly he pulled at the chains again. It was followed by nothing but silence. He pulled again. Nothing came of it. Izuku fell to his knees, surrounded by the blackness that terrified him and let the silent tears run down his cheeks.

He was stuck. For all of eternity, in his own personal Hell. His shoulders shook with sobs brimming with terror.

It was so dark. He couldn't see a thing. He was alone.

Chapter End Notes

ASFDFDSFADSASD

the link to my discord that ppl probably ignore (same man) unless its at the chapter notes at the end

Chapter 54

Chapter Summary

ahem, as some people so eloquently put it

The Priest: *kills izuku*

Izuku: *rapidly signing* I'm a bad bitch you cant kill me!

Chapter Notes

IM DEAD ASF THAT YALL WANT GROUP THERAPY XDDD (can i come??)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kurogiri sat at the bar a few minutes after saying his goodbye to Midoriya for good. Everything was quiet for now, as Shigaraki and the rest of the League went to check up on the Priest. The Doctor had taken him instantly as soon as Kurogiri had shoved him through the portal and began to heal him.

Kurogiri had stayed behind and said his goodbye to Midoriya, and now he was watching the news as the Pro Heroes cleaned up the mess the League had created. All Might was shown numerous times, escorting villains out of the forest, and the camera zoomed in on the broadcast still airing on the huge screen above the stadium.

Ah, then he'd forgotten to pick up Roku, one of their newest recruits. Oh well, he deserved jail-time. Kurogiri distracted himself with a tall glass, polishing it until it gleamed and reflected his features.

He watched the footage on the TV as Izuku Midoriya's form shifted and changed entirely. His mangled back healed itself, and it was safe to assume that his other injuries did the same.

Kurogiri felt an invisible weight drop of his shoulders, and his eyes widened. Black, feathery wings sprouted from his back, and Midoriya sat straight up, gasping for air.

Needless to say, Kurogiri dropped the glass he was holding, and it shattered onto the ground.

Izuku sat in the darkness for a long time. The chains at his wrists were hot, but not in a scalding way. His fear was a cage surrounding him on all sides, but he'd long since stopped crying about it. There was nothing he could do to change his situation as of now.

He was dead. And he was trapped here, for who knows how long. He stared blankly into the darkness. At least he wasn't in pain anymore. At least he was far, far away from the villains that threatened him day in and day out.

He thought back briefly to Shouta, Yamada, and Kacchan. They were probably heartbroken over his death, but they'd get over it. They had to…

Where he'd gone was somewhere they couldn't follow. And Izuku didn't know how to get home on his own, if it were even possible. He chewed on the inside of his cheek.

This wasn't what he'd wanted. Izuku didn't want to die, but at the moment there had been no other way. There had been no time to think of anything else that would leave him *and* Kacchan unscathed. The Priest had been gunning for Kacchan in an attempt to kill Izuku's desire to be a hero.

The man had known, in that moment, that Kacchan was Izuku's everything. It would kill Izuku to have Kacchan cruelly taken out of this world, but the Priest hadn't thought that Izuku would put himself in harm's way.

Izuku blindly ran his fingers across the warm metal of the chains around his wrists.

He wanted to at least tell his family goodbye. Izuku looked around at the darkness again, hoping to find an inkling of light, only to find none. Like usual.

But at least he wasn't surrounded by demons of his own making. At least he could close his eyes and pretend that this was all just a dream. Even if, deep down, he knew that this wasn't a dream. It wasn't a life, and there was nothing he could do to fix it.

He was unequivocally dead. Izuku chewed uselessly on his lower lip.

"Izuku…"

The voice was soft, nearly unintelligible even in the silence. Izuku barely caught it, whipping his head to the side where it seemed to originate. *"Izuku…"*

The voice whispered again, this time from behind him. Closer this time.

"Izuku…" A brush of air against the back of his neck, cool and comforting. Something tugged in his chest violently, and the voice became more urgent.

"Izuku!"

Izuku thrashed against his chains, trying to turn to face the voice. It seemed to be right behind him. *"Izuku!"*

He pulled against the chains, recognizing the voice as Shouta's. When the chains didn't snap instantly, he growled. The voice yelled again, this time even louder and desperate. He summoned his power, and tugged again, this time with fire licking up his hands and wrists.

He needed to see his family one more time! Izuku couldn't sit here for all eternity alone. With a sharp yell, he pulled with all his strength. With a resounding crack, his right hand was free of the chains. They clanged against the ground as they fell, and he moved onto the next one.

Or he'd planned to.

"Izuku!"

Power surged beneath his skin, and there was a bright flash of light. He blinked numerous times. Pain pricked at the back of his eyes.

The world swam and tilted and he was much, much heavier than he'd been before. His vision went blindingly white, and for a few seconds, he couldn't see anything. And he was exponentially more tired than he had been.

His bones and very soul ached with pain and unyielding exhaustion that he couldn't hope to shake. He was gasping, like a fish out of water, and his body went rigid and tight. His power came to greet him, much more powerful than it had been. He was burning. He was on fire, it burned through him like he was nothing, like he was made of paper, only twisted and contorted to *look* human. He was seizing, gasping, burning, and shaking so hard he couldn't stop.

The people who had been sitting around him jumped away — he had no clue who was around him. He was honestly too preoccupied to care. He was choking, gasping, and everything was entirely too bright. He tried to blink it away. He couldn't. He was shaking, twitching and seizing.

He didn't notice the drone that had been hovering around exploded.

Too bright. *Everything* was still too bright. Someone helped him onto his side, and blessedly felt less like he was liable to choke on his own spit.

Soft voices reached his ears. But he could hardly decipher what they were saying. He couldn't shut his Quirk *off* . It was spilling out of him, like he was a glass of water under a tap. And the tap kept pouring water into the cup, and it was overflowing.

He was burning alive. *It was too much.*

Someone started rubbing circles into his back, but it wasn't comforting. His breath hitched, a strange sensation skittered down his spine, and his skin blossomed with uncomfortable goosebumps.

And then it stopped. As if the tap had been abruptly turned off, and Izuku could finally *breathe.* He could finally focus on everything around him. The film of blur disappeared just in front of his eyes, and he could see. He could see Shouta, activating his Quirk to cancel out Izuku's.

He could see Kacchan standing a little ways away, shaking, pale, and in tears. That could only mean that Hizashi was the one continuously rubbing circles into his back. A welcome comfort now that the weight on his back had suddenly disappeared.

He took a couple of deep, shuddering breaths. His pounding heart seemed to slow, and his joints seemed to unlock. He wasn't as heavy as he'd been mere minutes — or seconds — ago. A blessing. For a moment he focused on his breathing, focused on calming his body and mind before he even *thought* of moving. He was afraid that if he moved and passed out, that he wouldn't wake up. At least not here, not on Earth.

With his luck, he would end up back where he'd been, with the darkness and the chains.

The fear gripped him, digging deeper and deeper into his skin. Coiling itself around him, tightening, and tightening like a snake, getting ready to devour its latest catch whole. Depriving him of air, and all rational thought. He clamped down on it, breathing deeply. He was better than the fear. The fear did not control him.

In and out. In and out, until the fear was trapped within the recesses of his mind. He was slow to move. Slow to sit up, and slow to look around. Everything he did was slow, but that was

due to the fact that he wasn't trying to pass out. After something like *that,* the being in that unending darkness, the seizure, he wouldn't be surprised if he passed out. But he wouldn't allow himself to do that. He *couldn't* allow himself to do that.

There was still too much to do and too much to worry about. Izuku was desperate to know if his friends were okay. He needed to know they were safe and getting treated, before he did anything else. The need to know his family was okay, and alive, was instinctual. It was not something to be oppressed and ignored. It itched at him, asking, asking, asking. *Is my family okay? Are my classmates okay?*

Suddenly, a weight settled on his shoulder and he realized he'd been glancing around frantically, searching. He was searching for his classmates, his mind begging the question of whether or not they were even *alive.* It was Shouta's hand resting on his shoulder, gentle but firm. It grounded him, telling him that he didn't need to worry.

"Izuku." He stated, his voice raspy and hoarse. His hair fell around his face, more messy and greasy than Izuku had ever seen it. "Everyone's fine. No one else is hurt, and All Might is taking care of any of the villains left. You're safe. It's okay."

It took all of his discipline not to rocket to his feet and *make sure* that Shouta's words rang true. But he shoved it down. Deep down. He locked eyes with his father, his eyes hunting for any lie that was hidden within those tired eyes. When he found none, he felt himself relax.

"We need to get you treated by Recovery Girl," He continued, his voice never getting louder or softer. Just so reassuringly gentle and unwavering. Something Izuku could latch onto after going through… *everything* he'd just gone through.

"But Shouta…" Hizashi began, his voice thick with confusion. He stopped rubbing circles into his back. "His wounds… they're already healed…"

Izuku felt himself tense up all over again. His shoulders hunching, his hands curling into fists. Hizashi's finger gently ran up his spine, from the middle all the way up to the nape of his neck. He feels no pain, and no discomfort in the slightest. Though… being bare chested is making him cold, and uncomfortable.

“Hah?!” Kacchan exclaims, and suddenly it’s like Kacchan had rebooted himself. He was there in an instant, worry etched across his face like a cold hard mask. “Move it! Let me see!”

Hizashi, not one to get caught up in Kacchan’s rigid mood, backs off. And suddenly there are warm, calloused hands on his back, and Izuku can feel his muscles relax under the touch. He almost couldn’t stop the content sigh from passing through his lips.

Shouta, to his credit, keeps his eyes trained on Izuku, his Erasure activated for just a little while longer. Kacchan moves away from his back, and Izuku instantly misses the heat, the comfort. There’s suddenly a lump in his throat where there hadn’t been one before, but he ignores it.

Kacchan circles around him, his eyes wandering, sharp and calculating. More astonished and relieved than anything. There’s so much relief, in those red eyes, and a softness Izuku can’t quite decipher.

“The injury on your back is completely healed, but there’s severe scarring,” he mumbles, and Izuku is sure if he could speak, this is what he would sound like. Mumbling, mumbling, mumbling. Every possible thing he could analyze just tumbling, falling, spilling from his mouth without a chance of it ever stopping. “And your throat doesn’t hurt? Your stomach isn’t burning?”

It takes him a moment to realize Kacchan is asking him a question, and he hastily shakes his head. He’s on the verge of a mental breakdown, he can feel it. The way his nerves are completely shot and nonexistent. The way his throat is constricting, tight, and painful. The way his eyes keep stinging, and tears keep pricking at the edge of his eyes. But he doesn’t let it show.

“Then,” Shouta grumbled, finishing Kacchan’s train of thought easily. “You’ve healed yourself? That’s the only way I could possibly see you waking up after a Quirk like that being used on you. You were *dead* .”

And he didn’t want to be reminded of it. He was already teetering on the edge, pushing back the heavy emotions weighing down his chest. There was too much going on. Too much had happened. He wanted the Earth to swallow him up and let him sleep for eternity. He wanted

to hide. He wanted to leave, and go home. Izuku couldn't stand being in this forest any longer, where the memories were too fresh.

His heart, his *soul,* couldn't take much more. Izuku was out of things to give. He'd run completely dry. He was falling apart at the seams, and soon, the floodgates would open. Soon, he wouldn't be able to pull himself out of the black, writhing mass in his gut. It was something that had been festering since he woke. He didn't want to think about how he'd technically been dead. He didn't want to think about the Priest or what transpired here. The pain, the suffering, the torture. He just wanted to make sure everyone he loved was okay and go home. That's all he wanted.

Whatever was wriggling in his gut was going to explode. Every pent up thing in his system— the fear, the pain, the suffering, the terror, the horror, the worry— had gathered there, black and ugly. And the second he got home and slammed the door behind him, the monster would strike and pick him apart piece by agonizing piece until he let it all out. Until he was empty, and colder than before.

Because he had *died* . Because to survive the Priest he had to push everything deep, and now it was ugly, it was angry, and it wanted *out.*

"Can— can we not talk about it?" Kacchan ground out with difficulty after a tense moment. "Please?"

Bakugou Katsuki *never* said please. It had the desired effect almost instantly. And Shouta gave a curt nod, and he stood. Hizashi did too, and after a painful moment, he realized they wanted him to get up too. He swallowed past the lump in his throat and found a hidden strength to finally get up on shaky legs.

It's already an unfair fight just trying to move, but it's even worse when he's putting all of his weight on his unsteady legs. His body is fatigued and he's mentally exhausted, but he manages. For a few seconds, that is. His knees are shaking, and nearly buckling under him before he realizes it. But it's not Hizashi or Shouta who catches him before he can completely make a fool of himself and face plant right into the ground.

It's Kacchan, who looks more or less like he wants to rip someone's throat out with his teeth. Blessedly, he doesn't look mad at Izuku specifically, which is always a relief. He looks more

mad at the world, like it had personally offended him in every possible way. And, perhaps it had, in a way. He'd just got attacked by villains. But he had quickly dispatched them with explosions. Then, as if he hadn't had enough to last him for a lifetime, he watched Izuku resurrect after thinking he was gone forever. Of course he'd want some serious cosmic revenge.

Kacchan lifts him like he weighs absolutely nothing at all and cradles Izuku to his chest. Izuku doesn't try to hide the blush that instantly covers his entire face, all the way up to the tips of his ears. Even as his face burns, the rest of his body is cold, and it's not long before Izuku is drawn to Kacchan's natural warmth that he always seems to radiate like some human space heater.

Shouta trails behind them, his Quirk trained on Izuku as they're walking through the forest. As they get closer and closer to the stands, countless police officers are entering, guns drawn and sweeping the area. Countless Heroes are accompanying them. Hizashi gives them a very genuine thank you, and they continue on.

Once they break from the trees, Izuku can hear shrill, familiar yelling. "Move! *Move!"*

It's Recovery Girl, and she looks like a force to be reckoned with, she's elbowing her way through the crowds, treating a number of students laid onto the ground. Izuku's eyes scan, missing nothing, noting Uraraka, Kirishima, Shiozaki, Tetsutetsu, Todoroki and Yaoyorozu. As they get closer, he breathes out a sigh, as he realizes that most of them are tired, but mostly healed. Uraraka is worse off than anyone else, but Recovery Girl is already on the move, with a pair of paramedics, placing her on a gurney. A gunshot wound to the shoulder.

The heroes were wandering around, alert and at the ready to make sure that no villains got in or out. Police are there too, gathering up the villains that Sero had helped restrain. Izuku can see Aoyama and Tokoyami a little ways off, draped in blankets and getting questioned by Detective Tsukauchi.

All Might is nowhere to be seen, but he's probably still in the forest, sweeping it again and again to make sure there are no villains left.

"Midoriya-kun! Bakugou!" Iida exclaims, worry evident in his tone. "You guys are okay!"

Kacchan’s arms seemed to tighten around Izuku a little more as Iida approached. Iida pretended not to notice. “He needs to go to Recovery Girl,” Kacchan says roughly, and Iida nods so fast Izuku is worried his head might fall off.

“Don’t forget to take care of yourself as well, Bakugou!” Iida admonishes gently, hovering as Kacchan quickens his strides to get to Recovery Girl faster.

The woman turns on both of them, her eyes flashing something fierce before her features soften. “Set him there. Even if his injuries are miraculously healed he needs to be hospitalized just in case.”

She pointed to another empty gurney, despite her eyes catching on his already healed wounds. Kacchan complied quickly, and Izuku could feel his joints pop as he laid down. He already feels himself getting colder again as Kacchan’s body heat fades from his freezing skin. Recovery Girl gives Kacchan a small peck on the forehead, and gestures to Izuku. “I know you want to go with him,” is all she says, as Izuku is lifted by two paramedics.

Their words are kind and soft as they reassure him, but Izuku is more focused on Kacchan, on Shouta and Hizashi who have no intention of leaving his side as he’s hauled off.

Chapter End Notes

>:U yall were rlly hard pressed about izuku dying lol

Chapter 55

Chapter Summary

that good old dadzawa and dadmic

In all the millennia that he'd been alive, he'd never heard of something quite like this. In all of his years building his masterful reputation as a villain who should not be messed with, he had never thought something like that was possible. And a lot of things were possible, immortality Quirks, blood Quirks, self-healing Quirks, mind control, but never had he thought that a Quirk like Midoriya's could exist. When he met him months and months ago, he'd been surprised. Shocked, and dare he say, *excited.*

A Quirk like Midoriya's was especially unique. It was unprecedented and so *strong* that All for One couldn't live without it. He wanted it, he wanted it so bad, so earnestly, so desperately that he would rip it from this boy, even if it left him an empty shell. This small broken and beaten boy. But try as he might, the Quirk was so intertwined, so deeply connected, so woven deep into his very being — his very *soul* , that it wouldn't budge. It sat so snugly next to his heart, black and writhing and *deliciously* powerful.

But it was so much more than a demon-summoning Quirk. It made Midoriya a God, and if All for One couldn't take it, then he was going to take *Midoriya.* He would make sure Midoriya became a villain and got his Quirk. Even if he had to force him into it. Even if the boy screamed, cried, and fought against it. All for One always got what he wanted. He was the greatest villain of all time, and the greatest villain of all time wasn't going to be denied.

One day very soon, if his scheme went according to plan, Midoriya would be his. His prized possession who would destroy the world beside him, even if he had to *make* him. Even if he had to *break* him. Even if he had to kill everything and everyone he loved, right before his eyes.

Besides, the boy should get used to it. With a Quirk like that, he was going to see very dark, dangerous things. He was going to go to dangerous places, like he'd done during the sports festival. All for One was enthralled by this a Quirk, this raw power that made Midoriya the

devil incarnate. He could not only see and summon demons at will, but he could make them stronger by transferring his stamina into them. And that wasn't everything.

The demon Dabi —he created Dabi himself, actually— was an excellent example. He was trapped in a sword, a cursed item, but Midoriya is able to free him and summon him without so much as a thought. And there was *more* . He had hellfire, much like regular fire, but stronger. There was his ability to transform into an otherworldly form. This was one of the most intriguing parts of Midoriya's Quirk, and he hadn't even mastered that yet. But All for One has gotten a glimpse of it.

The black wings, feathered and heavy. The sharp teeth, and black and golden eyes. Most importantly the crown, shiny and black, and shaped like flames. His horns were still there, but smaller and much less feral.

And there was *still* another part of his Quirk left unexplored and unexplained, it seemed. Resurrection. Self-healing. He smiled devilishly as his Analysis Quirk worked itself to the bone. Probing, searching for an answer as to Midoriya's limits as he watched the footage again, even though he had no eyes.

He had defied death. And it made All for One all the more hungry.

All for One knew that his feral hunger for this boy was more needy, more ferocious than before. Dying had heightened his power. It had made him stronger, and All for One wanted to see just how strong he'd become. He wanted to see if holy water still burned, if bible verses still poisoned his blood, or if crucifixes still melted his skin, or if sage burned the very oxygen in his lungs. He wanted to know if his weaknesses were the same. On a most basic level, All for One just wanted to hear him *scream*.

He wanted to hear him beg for death. To beg for mercy. To beg for it to end.

And he had a plan on how to get him back. But before he could do that, he needed to get rid of Stain's ever loyal vanguard of villains who were hell bent on protecting him. Or maybe he could convince a few to join *his* vanguard. Either way, he needed to get them out of the way for good before his plan was good to go. And right now, as he pondered his thoughts over Midoriya, they were based in Hosu. And Shigaraki had been itching for action.

All for One was happy to comply and give him a side-quest. Hosu was going to burn, and Midoriya would finally come home, whether he desired to or not. His new advanced Nomu would make sure of that.

Izuku doesn't *really* need to be in the hospital. He's miraculously healed for the most part, but there are still dark bruises and lacerations on his arms, legs, and torso. Like his Quirk had prioritized healing only the most deadly of his injuries and left the more minor ones to heal on their own.

Wave after wave of Quirk Analysis Specialists came to him, trying to figure it out. They poked and prodded him until Shouta was yelling at them to leave his goddamn son alone. Izuku had blushed, and he was still blushing even when Hizashi —his other dad— came in bearing snacks. Juice pouches for all of them and chips. He's smiling brightly, but he can tell that it's strained.

He can tell Hizashi is worried about something, but he hasn't told him about what yet. He doesn't dare ask, either. His dads are probably mad at him, and he doesn't want to make them any more angrier than they probably already are. He'd been reckless, overly reckless, during the Sports Festival.

Izuku had made himself a distraction to help his classmates. He'd broken himself time and time again to save his friends, and he knew that Shouta and Hizashi were probably angry about it. He had *died.*

He shifted awkwardly in the silence, his eyes never settling on one thing. Anxiety was itching at his skin like an insatiable itch that he could never seem to scratch. His mind was running in frantic circles as the silence stretched on. Shouta said nothing as he accepted the juice pouch from Hizashi, and finally Hizashi turned to him.

"How are you feelin, kiddo?"

Such a simple yet loaded question. He could give him a vague answer, like saying he was fine. Just fine. Nothing wrong here, he wasn't traumatized and numb. No way. But that would be suspicious. They'd question the sincerity of it, and then question his *sanity* . And then, of course, he'd get thrown into a mental institution before he could blink.

He didn't know how he was expected to answer, yet he didn't want Hizashi or Shouta to worry. He just wanted everything to go back the way things were, even if that was impossible. He wanted to pretend that none of this happened. But there was no going back from that. There was no pretending and pushing down feelings.

[I don't know.]

He didn't look at Hizashi as he signed, and he didn't really expect an answer. "What do you mean?"

He pressed his lips into a thin line, his mind working through it. He just didn't know how he was supposed to feel. Izuku was tired, so tired. Scared, and traumatized, but was that how he was supposed to feel?

[How am I supposed to feel?]

Again, a simple question, but a heavy one. This time he gave Shouta and Hizashi a glance, and was surprised to see that both of them were looking at him intensely. Shouta's black, dark eyes were swimming with something akin to concern. But it wasn't *exactly* concern showing there. It was sympathy and pity.

Hizashi's eyes that were usually alight with energy were darker. He was worried. Beyond worried, but he smiled nonetheless.

"Well," He said brightly, completely at contrast to the emotion swirling in his eyes, "Usually people that survive situations like yours are very anxious and sad. Some even have PTSD. So… whatever you're feeling is natural, Izuku,"

Izuku went quiet for a moment. He wrung his hands together, hands shaking. It took him a moment to form the words with his hands.

[I’m scared.]

“I’d be surprised if you weren’t,” Shouta mumbled softly, and he dared to put his hand on Izuku’s shoulder. It was a gentle action, and Izuku couldn’t help but lean into it. The weight was comforting, and warm. “You’re safe here.”

Izuku let Shouta’s voice wash over him and settle the anxiety in his stomach.

“Do you want a juice pouch and chips?” Hizashi asked, holding out both of them for him to take. Izuku nodded. He took the items and ripped open the bag of chips easily. They were salty, and the juice was sweet. It didn’t take him long to drink and eat everything he was offered. It was only once he ate everything that Hizashi spoke again.

“You have some visitors. Would you like to see them?” Hizashi asked, his voice soft. Izuku nodded eagerly, and Hizashi went over to the door and poked his head outside. “He’s good to see you guys now,”

And it wasn’t his classmates, as he'd initially thought. Masaru and Mitsuki Bakugou were at his bed in an instant, tears springing forth. Mitsuki looked angry as she cried, but she was always angry in one way or another.

“Oh Izuku!” Mitsuki exclaimed, wasting no time reaching over and squeezing him in a tight hug. “I was so worried about both of you!”

Izuku gave her a strained smile that didn’t quite meet his eyes, but she didn’t seem to mind. She just held him tighter and said nothing. Masaru even joined in, wiping uselessly at his streaming tears that never seemed to stop.

“I-If you ever do *anything* that reckless again, I'll tell those two your grounded.” Masaru choked out, pointing to the two teachers still at his side. Izuku smiled slightly, and the two of them finally pulled away, sniffling. Izuku couldn’t stop the wave of guilt drowning him in that moment. He hadn’t even spared a moment to think about how his Auntie and Uncle would feel.

“But you saved Katsuki,” Mitsuki said thickly, and Masaru places a comforting hand on her shoulder. “So you’re off the hook for now,”

“You fuckers talkin’ about me?!”

His voice was rough and annoyed, but Izuku recognized it instantly. The vestiges of guilt swirling in his gut simultaneously vanished and increased. Kacchan walked in the room with a bag of cookies in hand, and a signature scowl on his face that lacked heat.

[Yes.]

“What were ya talking about?” He asked, not bothering to ask his parents. His eyes seemed to be glued to Izuku. Worry swirled in those red eyes that were usually so full of confidence.

“About how he saved you,” Mitsuki finally said, taking the cookies out of Kacchan’s hands. Kacchan looked a little disgruntled about the action, but didn’t do anything to change it. Mitsuki turned to Izuku and offered him a cookie, which he politely took.

“Next time I’ll be strong enough so he doesn’t have to save me,” Kacchan grumbled, looking at anything but Izuku. Shame colored his cheeks, and Izuku felt a twinge of guilt in his heart. That’s when he noticed that Kacchan looked a little disheveled. He’d probably started upping his training regimen right after the Sports Festival. Izuku balled his fists up in his sheets, and Kacchan finally looked at him. He was going to do his best to be strong too.

[I’ll get stronger too Kacchan.]

“You fuckin’ better!” Kacchan exclaimed, and Izuku couldn’t help the smile pulling at his lips. “We’re gonna be the strongest Hero Duo in history, so you better get fuckin’ strong as hell!”

Hell. Was that where he’d gone? Was that the place of chains and darkness?

Izuku plastered a weak smile on his face, but he wasn’t paying attention anymore. He wasn’t watching the TV that was on, with the volume slightly turned down so everyone could talk. If he had been, he would’ve known that Stain’s organization, otherwise known as the Roses, was on the move in Hosu, killing “corrupted” hero after hero. He would’ve felt a pang of guilt, knowing that those murderers were protecting *him* but killing others. But he wasn’t watching the TV or looking outside.

He was looking down at himself, at his shaking hands and the circles etched there as a constant reminder. He was not a creature of this world. He was not meant to be here, it was unnatural. His true place, the place he really belonged but was terrified of, was Hell. His death had confirmed that in his mind.

When he died here, for real, forever, he wouldn’t go to Heaven. He wouldn’t go to the perfect paradise where Kacchan, Shouta and Hizashi would go. He wouldn’t be greeted by God with open arms. He’d be going to *Hell,* where All for One, Hisashi and Inko would be waiting.

He would be surrounded on all sides by sinners and demons alike, listening to the shrill, agonized screams of those who weren’t perfect in the eyes of God. He would be the warden of that burning Inferno, and he didn’t have any other choice.

One day he would die and be stuck there for eternity, like he’d been stuck in the darkness. Izuku pushed away the thoughts of that place. He ignored how his mind seemed to remind him that he wasn’t *truly* free from that darkness.

He had only broken one chain, after all.

Izuku wrung his hands together. Should he tell them? He pressed his lips together, knowing the answer instantly. No. He shouldn’t. No one even *needed* to know. He would keep it a

secret. He would bury it deep down and forget it ever happened. Or at least, he'd pretend to forget.

"Anyway, when is school starting again? We were supposed to choose who we're going to intern with after the Festival," Kacchan grumbled, looking at Shouta for answers.

Shouta sighed heavily, "It should be soon. Next week probably, but choosing your internships will have to wait. We need to give everyone time to heal after what happened, and Nedzu is planning to open up the dorms some time this week."

Kacchan didn't seem too happy about having to wait for the internships, but he just crossed his arms and nodded. It all seemed pretty reasonable to Izuku, but Kacchan was an enigma.

"Just use this time to relax, Bakugou!" Hizashi told him with a smile. Kacchan scowled, and Izuku smiled. "Why not go shopping for stuff for your dorm room?"

They let him out of the hospital the next day, and Izuku found himself hiding away in his room. Dabi had bombarded him with questions and practically suffocated him with hugs and comfort until he couldn't take it anymore.

He just wanted to be alone for a while as he processed everything. There was a void in his chest since the Sports Festival Incident. Every little thing seemed to make him want to break down into tears, but he didn't want his dads to see him like that.

For all he knew, they'd get mad at him, or they'd take pity on him and never leave him alone to come to terms with his own death. Yes, of course it had been a temporary death, only lasting a few minutes or so, but he felt different.

Izuku felt sad. A deep, unexplainable melancholy that he couldn't shake. It tugged at his heart and made his eyes sting. He closed the door behind him, leaving his katana in the kitchen so that Dabi wouldn't bother him.

Shouta and Hizashi had watched him retreat to his room but hadn't said anything. They seemed to be trying to give Izuku space, and he appreciated it immensely. He left the light on as he crawled beneath the covers and let himself fall apart.

Piece by piece, the shaky mask he'd been wearing crumbled into dust. He brought his hands to his face as his throat closed up, and the tears stung at his eyes. A silent sob shook his shoulders, and he bit his lip to keep himself from making any noise.

Tears rolled down his cheeks, and he wiped them away with the back of his hand, but it was useless. They kept coming and obscured his vision. His entire body shook with tears and sobs.

He had been dead.

He uselessly reminded himself that it had only been for a few minutes, but it was enough for him. Enough for him to be scarred by it.

Izuku had been *tortured* by the Priest, and beaten down. He stifled another soundless sob. He could remember the phantom pain of the dagger against his skin. Izuku thought back to the picture the doctor at the hospital had shown him. The words carved into his spine by that *monster* .

ALL FOR ONE. Down each notch of his spine.

"Izuku?" Shouta said softly, inching the door open. Izuku glanced up and instantly ducked his head to hide his tears. "Are you okay?"

He nodded shortly, his throat bobbing as he swallowed past the lump in his throat. There was a heavy sigh and an added weight to the edge of his bed. Izuku sniffled loudly in the following silence.

“You know,” Shouta mumbled, patting the spot next to him on the bed. “It’s okay to be sad, even as a hero,”

Izuku detangled himself from the bed and sat down where Shouta had indicated. “It’s okay to cry after something like this, too,” He added, wrapping his arms around him suddenly. Izuku melted into the touch. “All heroes cry. That doesn’t mean you’re weak,”

Izuku wiped at his tears, and Shouta’s hold tightened. “I love you, kid.”

Chapter 56

Chapter Notes

uuhhhh so my sister had my computer and that's why this took so long?? :DDD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Four days before school began again, Kacchan had somehow convinced Shouta and Hizashi to let him go out with him. They had, however, made him promise that he'd call them if he was in danger. He doubted he'd get in any trouble while helping Kacchan shop for the Dorms.

All Kacchan really needed was a new desk, and Izuku had an inkling of a feeling that this was just an excuse to hang out with him outside of school. Either way, he followed Kacchan with their hands intertwined together as he *finally* bought a desk that looked almost exactly like the one he had at his mother's house. Go figure.

Auntie Mitsuki and Masaru had been reluctant to let Kacchan stay in the school dorms. But in the end, they had relented. Especially after a few words from Shouta, who promised that Kacchan would be safe. And then — according to Kacchan's depiction of the events — his parents and Shouta spent the rest of the time talking about *him* .

About how he was doing, and if he was completely healed after the Sports Festival. Of course, Shouta reassured them that he was doing perfectly fine now. Izuku wasn't going to comment and tell his dad that he, in fact, still wasn't doing so well in the mental department.

Some nights he'd dream of hellish nightmares he wouldn't wish on anyone. His mother and his father usually starred in these nightmares, and he was hardly getting the sleep he needed.

But he didn't want Shouta to get mad, or worry about him. Izuku half listened, half dissociated as Kacchan told the service lady to ship the desk to Yuuei, and her eyes nearly popped out of her head in surprise.

He paid for the desk, and the both of them left. Once they left the department store behind and entered the throng of people in the streets, Kacchan turned to him. The sun caught in his red eyes in the most strange ways.

"So, what do *you* want to do?"

That was the million-dollar question, now wasn't it? He took a moment to respond, grasping for any activity that would interest Kacchan. After a moment he came up empty, and Kacchan seemed to notice.

He bumped his shoulder against Izuku's, and pointed to a building across the street. "We could go in there, and get ice cream afterward," He looked at it curiously, before realizing belatedly that it was a store that seemed to sell art-related products.

He gave Kacchan a nod and they headed off in that direction. He didn't miss the way Kacchan's face had gone soft and the smile on his face was peaceful. As if this was the first time he'd relaxed in a long time.

Izuku wanted it to last forever, that soft smile.

Katsuki bought Deku nearly everything he looked at. He just couldn't bring himself not to, seeing as he almost died during the Sports Festival. If buying Deku everything made Katsuki broke, then maybe it was worth it.

No, scratch that. It was *definitely* worth it. He also carried everything, determined to be a gentleman. Deku puffed out his cheeks at this, but didn't say anything about it. *Not that he could, even if he wanted to,* Katsuki reminded himself.

They got ice cream afterward. And then they went to the park and Katsuki watched as Deku drew something new. Both of them were standing together in their Hero costumes, but Deku's was much different.

He loved it. "Why don't you change your costume to look like that one?" He asked, and Deku looked up at him.

He tilted his head to the side before signing. [I was thinking about it.]

"Why don't we go now? I'm sure there's someone in the Support Department who'd be happy to change it for you," Katsuki told him, and Izuku lit up. "Just don't forget to tell Aizawa-sensei. He might have a heart attack if you don't."

And he wasn't exaggerating either. Aizawa-sensei seemed a little *too* protective of Deku sometimes, but he wouldn't have it any other way. Deku needed that kind of firm protection in his life at the moment.

Deku pulled out his phone and texted him real quick, getting an instant reply. Katsuki smiled as Deku stood up, his fingers signing rapidly.

[He said it was fine if we go.]

"Hell yeah, nerd, let's get our asses moving!" Katsuki told him, grabbing onto his hand as he dragged Deku in the direction of Yuuei.

Deku's small, almost inaudible laugh was worth every second.

Hitoshi was wandering around Yuuei's campus, not too keen to stand around in the dorms awkwardly anymore. He and Todoroki had already shared a heart-to-heart about their trauma, and now it was getting awkward with nothing else to do.

It would be another week until Todoroki's Xbox shipped to Yuuei, and yes, he used Endeavor's credit card for it. And his classmates were going to move into the dorms as well tomorrow. Until then, both of them were stuck sitting around playing Scrabble and he was not about to argue about what was a *real* word, and what wasn't.

Because yeet was *a fucking word, okay?*

Anyway, he was passing by the Support Department when he spotted the familiar fluff of green hair and Bakugou's usual "fuck-off-I'll-kill-you" stance. He didn't hesitate to butt in on whatever they seemed to be doing.

"Yo, Midoriya!" He exclaimed, uncharacteristically, but who could blame him? Midoriya was one of the first people to accept his Quirk and call it cool. "You're looking a lot better since the Sports Festival. I'm glad."

Midoriya turned to face him, and Bakugou glared at him for stealing his soon-to-be-boyfriend's attention. Hitoshi knew the fucking tea. He wasn't stupid. He reveled in that glare.

[I'm doing a lot better, thank you.]

"That's great," He said as he drew closer, and that was when he noticed Hatsume Mei. "Are you here to get your costume changed?"

Midoriya nodded and handed him a drawing. "Oh, that's fucking *cool,"* He breathed, "I wish I would've thought of something this cool."

Midoriya shook his head violently, as Mei snatched the paper out of his hand and started to study it. He held up his hands to sign shakily. He was always shaking, and it made Hitoshi feel bad.

All for One's cruel face flashed behind his eyes. He suppressed a shudder.

[Your hero costume is actually super cool! You look like sensei!]

Hitoshi blushed, and covered his mouth, glancing away. That's when Hatsume interjected. "Well, Midoriya, I think I can work off of this pretty well!" She told him, and Bakugou slung his arm around Midoriya's shoulders.

Hitoshi listened on as Hatsume and Midoriya bounced ideas back and forth. Of course, he and Bakugou jumped in to translate his sign language, but other than that… It was terrifying to watch them converse terrifying topics like they were talking about the weather.

After a half-hour of this, Hatsume smiled and gave Midoriya a very sudden hug. "I think you're my favorite Hero Course kid, now," She mumbled, ignoring how Midoriya had stiffened.

"Ever heard of personal space?!" Bakugou yelled, and Hitoshi gave them a horrified look. Even Midoriya seemed to taste danger in the air.

"Oh, do I have a baby I could test out on you," Hatsume mumbled, finally releasing Midoriya. Hitoshi didn't like how her eyes glinted with mischief.

For the next hour, nothing but explosions and laughter could be heard from the Support Department.

That night, Izuku dreamt of chains. He dreamt of heat and shrill screams.

And he screamed too.

Shouta heard the screaming, but the door was always locked. Dabi was always standing in front of the door when he got there, begging to get inside.

They never did.

All for One was biding his time.

With time, he promised himself. *He will be mine again with time.*

The beast sleeping within the warehouse was in pain.

It remembered… things. About who it had been previously, but they were fleeting things. They washed away, like a breeze. The beast forgot. It didn't want to forget, but it was not the person it used to be.

But that wasn't its fault. It was All for One's.

The next day, Shouta had to help all of Class 1-A, with the exception of his son, Todoroki, and Shinsou, move into the dorms.

Needless to say, it was an absolute disaster. Uraraka had used her Quirk to carry everyone's luggage to their designated rooms and nearly dropped them four times. (She actually dropped them the first time and Kirishima had to harden his skin to save her from more than a few bruises.)

Shinsou and Todoroki were playing scrabble and screaming in the common room about whether or not yeet was a word. Then it turned into Shinsou throwing all of it off the table.

Todoroki made him some tea afterward.

Sero and Denki nearly destroyed Bakugou's gaming console and he could hear the popping explosions from where he stood.

A fucking disaster. He didn't drink enough coffee for this.

Izuku went to school a week after the Sports Festival Incident, insisting that he was way too energetic to stay home, even if it was a white lie. And apparently, his classmates felt the same way because not a single person was absent when he entered. Shouta trailed behind him, yawning.

They were already yelling, and talking really loud before he entered, but suddenly it was impossibly *louder* when they noticed him. “Oh my god, Midoriya-kun!”

Iida was at his side in a second, his hand chopping and swinging wildly. Uraraka was there too, talking so fast that he could barely understand. What he did get was: “Brilliant plan;” “saved us all” and “you’re way too reckless, Deku!”

In that instant, more and more of his classmates were yelling over each other to be heard, talking about the Sports Festival and how brutal it had become.

Izuku didn’t want to talk about it. He didn't want to even hear about it.

“They didn’t even announce a winner!” Denki exclaimed, and Sero smacked him upside the head, exasperated.

“Of course not!” He told his boyfriend, “We were *attacked.”*

“True that,” Denki relented. “I think Midoriya should’ve won by default though,”

“I second that!” Ashido exclaimed, “If what everyone else is saying is true, then you planned the escape, even if it was really, *really* self-sacrificing. It worked out in the end, though!”

Izuku scratched the back of his neck, before pointing at Shinsou. He had heard from Shouta what the other boy had done. He’d saved so many more people than Izuku did. And he hadn’t

killed himself to do it, either.

[Shinsou saved more people than I did. I shouldn't be getting credit for everything.]

The said man turned red at Izuku's hand signs. Immediately he was backpedaling and sputtering something about just wanting to save Izuku. "W-well, I wanted to get you help as soon as possible,"

"If you ever do anything that reckless again, you'll be grounded for the rest of your life," Shouta grumbled from his spot on the ground, in his signature sleeping bag.

"I'll fuckin' kick your ass myself, Deku," Kacchan growled, but he didn't look too mad. He looked fond, and calmer than usual. He was probably relieved that he was okay. He did in fact, watch him die.

"Alright, enough chit chat," Shouta grumbled, and his classmates went quiet almost instantly. "Since we have an entire week before your internships begin, we're going to make the most of it."

There was a unanimous groan, and Shouta pretended not to hear it. He stood in his sleeping bag and Izuku couldn't help but smirk slightly. Shouta had evolved. "Most of you will be training your Quirks in Gym Gamma."

"Most of us?" Tsuyu asked, pressing a finger to her chin in thought.

"Yeah. Midoriya will train with me, All Might, and Nedzu." Shouta told them, giving Izuku a single glance. "Ectoplasm and Present Mic will be helping all of you. Villains are getting stronger and stronger everyday, and by extension, all of you should be getting even stronger. If you don't, you'll die."

Izuku resisted the urge to scratch the back of his neck and apologize. The class had gone impossibly quiet as Shouta said that, and he could feel eyes on him like fire. Like molten

lava. He swallowed thickly as Present Mic and Ectoplasm finally entered the room.

That was his queue to follow Shouta out of the room. Suddenly nervous, he played with the cross around his neck. It was hot around his throat and burning on his fingers, but he didn't take it off. He was barely holding back his power with it on. How would he fare if he took it off?

He was afraid to find out. He was *so* afraid he could taste it on his tongue. Sour and heavy. By now, fear was just a part of him. So deeply woven into his being that it would be strange if he wasn't scared about *everything.*

Shouta seemed to notice as they went down the stairs towards Yuuei's basement, where Nedzu had created a training room that could withstand his Quirk. Aizawa placed a comforting hand on Izuku's shoulder, his next words soft and comforting.

"You'll be okay. As soon as you lose control, or you want me to stop it, I'll erase your Quirk," Shouta told him, and Izuku felt a little lighter. He felt less like he was waiting to drown. His hand went to the hilt of his sword on instinct.

It was going to be fine. Shouta would stop it as soon as it was too much. He was going to be fine. This was going to be fine.

He repeated it to himself as they walked down the dingy corridor. Yuuei's basement was essentially a long hallway with many different doors leading to different rooms. The rooms were mostly used for storage, or in Izuku's case specialized Quirk training.

It looked kind of creepy down here, though. The walls and floor were made of rough grey concrete. The only light was from light bulbs hanging on flimsy strings, swinging only slightly. The lights cast the whole hall in a warm, yellow light that didn't quite light up all the shadows.

Before he could freak himself out anymore, Shouta stopped at a door. He pulled it open and Izuku went inside, apprehensive. The room was blessedly well-lit with fluorescent lights. There were no shadows here and Izuku felt himself relax slightly.

This training needed to happen. It needed to succeed. He could feel his power growing exponentially, more potent than before. He could feel it itching at his skin, begging to be mastered and used. Something dark and writhing.

And he'd learn. If only for his own sanity more than anything else. And he definitely couldn't let Kacchan get stronger than him.

Shouta went into the next room, where there was a glass window for Nedzu, All Might and him to look out of. The window was really thick, and so were the walls.

The three of them were sitting at a desk in the room and Nedzu was holding a little microphone. "Are you ready?"

[As ready as I'll ever be.]

Chapter End Notes

ALSO THIS IS MY FIRST CHAPTER OF 2021 HOLY SHIT??? (this fic is getting OLD)

Also, for those who're wondering why this chapter has so many cuts, it's because this is technically chapter 55.5, which is a filler chapter that I wrote for no reason?? I mean its not filler but it is...?

and im trying to change my summary to be more accurate! anyone got ideas?

Act Seven: Devil's Den

Chapter Notes

ahahahahaahaa :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku had always been afraid of the power festering in his skin. He had always been afraid of the destruction this power—a Quirk like this—could do. He had been terrified of using it, of fighting with it, of losing control of it.

But to be a hero, he needed to control it. To achieve his dream of becoming a Hero Duo with Kacchan, he needed to master it as soon as possible, lest he injure someone or himself with it. He recognized the importance of mastering this. So when Nedzu asked him to place his Quirk Suppressant on the floor, and activate his Quirk, he had complied.

The power burned through him, begging for air, for release. It crackled as it reached the air like burning, scorching fire. Pure, raw power from hell itself. It manifested itself as black flames, as his fire. It writhed between his fingers, swirling and licking at his skin. But it wasn't hot. It was always cold, and unrelenting.

He eased himself into the feeling of his power, so dark and dangerous. Ruthless and cutthroat. A power only the Devil could have. The power burned but he forced himself to embrace it, albeit slowly. He would take his time. He would make sure he didn't overwhelm himself.

The power is black, and the room around him swims and swirls. He can't focus on the mirror in front of him, or the words that seem to be falling from Nedzu's never-ending smile. They're probably rapid-fire instructions he can't hear.

"Amazing, truly amazing. Keep going Midoriya-kun."

In his mind's eye, he can see the inky black of his Quirk rising to his skin, pounding, pounding, pounding. Screaming, screaming, screaming. He can feel his back tensing, he can feel the delicate muscles around the nape of his neck tightening.

He's slick with sweat, but he holds onto it. This fiery Quirk that didn't *want* to be controlled. But… maybe it didn't want to be controlled. Maybe it wasn't about *control,* but rather, acceptance.

His power was accepting him, but was he doing the same? Was he accepting it as part of him? As an integral, instinctual and visceral part of him? As something so woven into who he was, that it would never leave him? No. If he was being honest, he was still rejecting it. Hating it. Fearing it. Treating it as if it was nothing more than a burden and a curse.

Well, fear was always a part of him, so he couldn't fix *that* particular problem. But maybe…

Maybe he could stop hating and rejecting this power he was lucky enough to have. Some people were Quirkless, and therefore in the eyes of society, useless. At least he had a Quirk. And he might as well embrace it. Use it for something good rather than looking at it as something horrid.

The power practically burst from his skin like a raging fire. Excited, and uncontrollable. He shouldn't concern himself with control and mastery right now. All he should think about is acclimating to it and accepting it. That was the first step. The other steps came afterward. Right now he needed to reach for it, and let it breathe to life.

He could worry about learning to *stop* later.

The room was hot. So hot that his skin burned, but he reveled in it. He reveled in the delicious darkness of his own power. Tokoyami would be fucking jealous. Revelry in the dark was totally his thing, and Izuku went and stole it.

He resisted the laugh that was bubbling up in his throat. He probably looked pretty creepy, with the fire crackling around him, at an absolute contrast to the temperature of the room. His flames were freezing, but everything else was burning.

The power surged, begging. His muscles went taunt. Tighter, and tighter, and he was gasping as white light exploded behind his eyes. He was reaching his limit faster and faster. It came in waves, drowning waves, and he couldn't keep up. It was like a forest was on fire inside of him, everything burned, everything was cracking and spider webbing like delicate glass. His body wasn't strong enough to withstand the sheer amount of power.

It sent him to his knees, and his arm burned. "Do you need to stop?"

It was the only thing that cut through the roar of flames. Cut through his panting and desperate gasping. He squeezed his eyes shut, and his nod was curt. He took a shuddering breath, and the fire encircling his hands pulsed.

Shouta was there in a second, as soon as he had nodded. His piercing eyes had cut through Izuku's daze, and the power flickered out like a candle. He took a deep breath, as Shouta gave him his Quirk Suppressor and a bottle of water. Nedzu's voice crackled through the microphone.

"Due to my calculations, if you continue to train like this, you'll master your Quirk!" Nedzu exclaimed, and Izuku could tell just by his tone that he was smiling widely. "Furthermore, if you intern with Aizawa, then you'll increase your control quicker than you would with any other teacher."

Izuku took a long drink of his water, watching Shouta out of the corner of his eye. The man in question nodded slightly, and Izuku couldn't help but grin. He'd be interning with his *dad* . Maybe he'd teach him a few things about being an Underground Hero. After all, Izuku's Quirk was well-suited for the Underground. His Quirk was so versatile, but…

Kacchan wanted to be a duo with him, and he couldn't let Kacchan down. So maybe he wouldn't ask about Underground Heroes. But he was so *curious*.

"Do you want to try again?" Shouta asked, as soon as Izuku had relaxed.

He nodded, and he pulled off his Suppressant. Carnage and fire met him again, cold and hot, mixing together in a deadly dance. Like blades bouncing off of each other, sparks flying. Almost like two lovers, polar opposites, but nothing without each other. Okay, that analogy kind of got away with him… but whatever.

It burst from him, in the form of black hellflame again. So much power, thundering beneath his skin. Begging him to summon demons and devils. Begging him to unleash more explosions of power. Begging him to fight with it, to punish sinners with it. His Quirk begged to be used for its intended purposes.

It wasn't some curse. No, it was the power he'd taken with him whenever he got reborn here, on Earth. It was a power that he was *destined* to have. Even if he was scared out of his mind, he needed to master it. To accept it, so he could become a hero.

It burned through him, but it was a welcome feeling. The fire consumed the air, crackling.

It was *his* power.

The second half of his day was spent going to his first therapy session with Ms. Kaori.

She was a woman with cat ears and long, inky black hair. She seemed much more qualified — or at least less likely to tell everyone his trauma —than Mr. Hirai had been. Her Quirk was called Minor Empathy, that let her feel someone of his feelings if they were potent enough. At least that's what his dad had told him.

"Good afternoon, Midoriya, take a seat." Ms. Kaori greeted, as soon as Izuku closed the door behind him. She already had a steaming cup of tea on the coffee table in front of her chair, and the shades were open wide, allowing natural light. The room was bathed in it, and Izuku

found himself relaxing. “My name is Ms. Kaori, though I’m sure Principal Nedzu has already informed you about me. I’m glad you’re here, and it’s nice to meet you,”

He took a seat at the couch opposite of hers as she introduced herself. [Nice to meet you, too.]

She smiled in response, before pulling out another saucer and cup.

Izuku distracted himself by thinking about the room, desperate to avoid direct eye-contact. The chair he sat on was plush and made of expensive leather, but Izuku was never one to analyze chairs. He looked around the room, drinking in the bookshelves and the many books organized on them. There was a book on Quirk Theory, and another on human anatomy. The only exit in the entire room was the door he entered through.

While he scanned the room, Ms. Kaori poured him a cup of tea and scooted it closer to him. He took it gratefully. Was making tea about to be a regular thing with her? Was it even effective? He wasn’t sure if it even helped him, but maybe it was more of a psychological thing. To believe whole-heartedly that the tea calms you causes you to naturally calm yourself.

He definitely needed it as she brought out her notes and her reading glasses. She smiled, and it was small but no less genuine.

“Shall we begin? Do you want to talk about anything that’s happened recently?”

Izuku was hesitant. He’d never done a therapy session before that was *actually* private. He wasn’t really eager to talk about his problems. He didn’t want to bother anyone. He was still shaken from everything, too. If there wasn’t enough on his plate as it was.

Sometimes in a fit of terror, he was back there like he never left. It always felt like he was pulling on his leash, on the chain, only for it to tighten every single time he took a step forward. He was slowly choking and dying, and he didn’t know how to make it stop.

Everyday, it seemed like he was trying to push it deep down. The fear, the panic of being at the mercy of his parents and All for One. One day, they'd find him. *One day, they'd find him.* And he'd be dead. There was no saving him. There was no way out.

Or sometimes, he was thinking of the Darkness—

Izuku gulped, not realizing he was holding his cup and it was shaking. But Ms. Kaori had noticed, no doubt her Quirk was telling her that he was stressed. "We don't have to talk, Midoriya. You can fill out paperwork for your internship if you'd like."

He shook his head. He *should* be able to do this. He shouldn't be terrified all of the time, about people who weren't anywhere near him. He should be stronger than this. He shouldn't be this weak.

He was going to be a hero who saved people. He shouldn't need saving. Not now. Not when he should be fine, when he should be free.

But he couldn't help dreaming of the basement and his father. He couldn't stop dreaming about his mother using her Quirk on him, or All for One forcing him to use his own. He couldn't stop waking up in tears, hyperventilating and stifling sobs.

Izuku couldn't escape. He could never escape. Not until that man was dead, and *both* his parents were behind bars. He stared blankly at his tea for a long moment, focusing on the murky leaf water. This therapy was supposed to help him overcome all of it.

But it just made him spiral. And he always felt like he was falling, faster than he could even comprehend. Falling so swiftly and hauntingly toward the arms of the villain he tried so desperately to escape from. He'd crawled and clawed his way here, breaking and fighting with every step.

There was never anything to grab to catch himself, to stop his terrifying descent. Fear held him in its vice grip. His cup was shaking even more, and his chest was rising and falling rapidly.

I'm afraid. I'm afraid. I'm afraid. I'm so scared.

He tried to stand, to leave, to escape. To run from this feeling until he was somewhere safe, preferably alone. Or maybe he'd find Kacchan. Kacchan could always distract him. Maybe even Shouta.

"We don't have to talk today. It's our first session, after all." Ms. Kaori said, blessedly not moving from her spot on the couch. "If you're not ready yet, you can just relax here for a while. Would you like me to leave? Or bring you something?"

[Please leave. I'm sorry.]

He can already feel the sting of his tears. He doesn't even hear the door close as Ms. Kaori made her exit so he could panic in peace. He should've been Quirkless. *He should've been Quirkless.*

His life wouldn't have been any easier, but at least All for One wouldn't have been chasing him. At least his mother and father would've left him alone and pretended he didn't exist. That was better than the pain. It was better than the abuse.

I should've been Quirkless.

He wiped at his stinging eyes, finding his cheeks wet with sorrow. *Weak. So weak.*

Heroes didn't cry. Villains didn't cry. What did that make him?

He couldn't stop the shaking or how his breath quickened in tandem. *Quirkless. Quirkless. I'm so weak.*

He wasn’t a hero and he wasn’t a villain. He was nothing. Worth nothing.

And he was back to square one, with nothing but fear and hate to guide him. He’d come full-circle.

The rest of the week went by quickly, and his classmates were gushing about who they were going to intern with. Todoroki ended up interning with Best Jeanist. He had originally tried to go with Endeavour, but after the memory viewing fiasco he wasn’t even allowed in the same *room* as his father. Izuku was glad.

Shinsou hadn’t had to contact his parents, but with the dorms having opened up early, Izuku didn’t have to worry about Shinsou being trapped in a household that didn't love him. Shinsou ended up interning with Gunhead, looking pleased.

Kacchan ended up interning under a hero named Dragon, who could breathe fire. Uraraka went with Gunhead like Shinsou had, and Iida was going under Ingenium. Tokoyami decided to intern with Hawks, which Izuku thought was really fitting.

They were all going to the train station, and they were probably the loudest people in the entire station.

“So, Midoriya,” Iida began, his arms swinging in its usual chopping motion. “Who are you interning under? You haven’t told any of us.”

“Yeah, Deku. Who is it?” Kacchan asked, coming to rest his elbow on Izuku’s shoulder. Izuku shuffled, suddenly nervous about their reactions.

“He’s interning under me,” A gruff, tired voice mumbled out. Shouta’s voice was impossible to misplace. Izuku whipped around with a smile.

“You’re interning under Aizawa-sensei!?” Uraraka exclaimed, her cheeks puffed out in jealousy. “Not fair!”

“What’s not fair is that his Quirk is nigh impossible to control, and he can’t intern with anyone *but* me.”

Uraraka went quiet at that, and gave Izuku an apologetic look. [I would’ve interned with him either way.]

“I wouldn’t have taken you,” Shouta mumbled, and Izuku grinned. He gives Izuku a glance that he definitely sees. “Okay… maybe I would’ve.”

And then everyone boards the train, but it’s too crowded for all of them to stand together and talk. It kind of makes Izuku mad because he definitely wanted to listen in on everyone’s conversations and excitement about their internship. He wanted to know what they were expecting and what they hoped to learn. He was utterly fascinated, considering he was probably going to spend the *entire* time learning how to control the excess power beneath his skin.

He’d spent plenty of time working on each part of his Quirk separately with All for One. The Summoning, the Hellflame, and Dabi. He polished them to perfection as *separate* aspects of himself. He rarely used them all in tandem, as one Quirk. He was too afraid to use it to its full power anyway, and that’s what he’d spend his internship doing. Breaking it down invisible barrier by invisible barrier until he could use it without fear chaining him down.

And then…

He’d turn to mastering his *other* form, as much as he was terrified of it. To survive the man who was surely hunting him, biding his time until Izuku was vulnerable…

He needed to vanquish fear and learn to accept his power. Just thinking about it made his throat tighten and constrict with sudden worry. What if he couldn't?

What if All for One got to him first, and he just died? What if his *mother* got out of prison and took him to All for One? There were too many unreliable variables that he couldn't wrap his head around. He clenched his fists, his lips pressed into a thin line.

He couldn't have a panic attack on this fucking train. It would paint a bad image of Yuuei students, and then people would *look* at him…

Izuku risked a few cautious glances around the train and blood roared in his ears like a siren. People were *already* staring at him. And it seemed to be just then that he heard them start muttering to themselves. Small things, about him being *that kid* from the Sports Festival. He sucked in a breath between his teeth like he was in pain. He could feel the sinking feeling of dread settle over him like a thick cloud.

They were judging him. They were talking about him and hating him already…

"Hey," and Izuku jumped out of his skin. "You're that hero from the Yuuei Sports Festival right?"

And it was like she unleashed the vultures. People's murmurings got louder, and they stared more openly than before. It made his skin crawl with anxiety.

Nervous, he managed a single look at the girl who had initiated this impromptu conversation. Granted a lot of conversations with him were impromptu ones. Her hair was golden blonde with a bubblegum pink streak that was cut harshly at her shoulders. Matching her pink streak, she popped bubblegum in her mouth. Her eyes sparkled with interest, and he couldn't find any malice there, no matter how hard he looked for it. He gave her a hesitant nod.

"Dude!" She exclaimed, "You were super fucking cool! Oh my god, and when you raised from the dead like some god—I lost my shit! You're so cool I could die! You're gonna be a great hero!"

He risked another look at her, and now she was bubbly and smiling like she hadn't just made Izuku's world do backflips. Like she hadn't just complimented him and made his entire week. She just kept smiling even as he said nothing. That's when Shouta decided it was time to intervene and distract him. Surprisingly, they'd been on the train for a while—he spent a lot of it panicking slightly—and they were at Hosu.

Shouta put a gentle hand on his shoulder. "It's time to go, problem child."

Izuku nodded eagerly, latching onto Shouta's sleeve like a baby duckling as they fought their way to the automatic doors. As Shouta leads him through the station, all the way to the city, he can't help but think about his meltdown in Kaori's office. He *knew* he'd been conditioned to feel that way, and that it was simply a moment of weakness that had allowed such thoughts.

He knew he wasn't useless. He knew that his life wouldn't have been any better if he had been Quirkless. In fact, it would've probably been worse. Izuku knew it was unhealthy, but he pushed the thoughts away. He pretended he hadn't even thought of it as the city sprang forth, all tall buildings and bustling bodies.

Hosu.

What could possibly go wrong?

Chapter End Notes

as usual: [discord invite!]

Chapter 58

Chapter Notes

Shi is an OC and he's honestly not that important lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shi got the group text three hours before he was supposed to get there. He was just finishing up his essay for class in this random internet café, reveling in the soothing smell of coffee and sugar that lingered in the air. He mostly attributed the strong smell of coffee to his three mugs sitting beside his laptop. He'd practically chugged them, gulping them down like energy drinks. Shi had been hyped on coffee and typing away until ten pages of rambling sat before him.

He wasn't smart, but *damn* he could bullshit an essay on how society has yet to catch up to accommodate Quirks. Damn, after spending nearly four hours trying to find evidence, he'd found a few interesting things.

Society had not changed it's laws on Quirks since after they manifested. In his essay for class, he was supposed to write an argumentative about how society was perfectly fine. They were *supposed* to write about how the world was essentially perfect, but Shi didn't think that was accurate.

Society was crumbling to pieces. Its foundation was false and cracked. It continued cracking and getting weaker by every passing year. All Might could only hold up the world for so long before the pillar fell. Before the sky broke and the villains seized control. Before the world imploded itself because Japan decided it needed only one *man*— not a god. All Might was no god—to hold society together by the seams.

So he decided to say fuck it to this essay and get a failing grade on it. He was going to write the opposing view and prove to his classmates, to his dumbass teacher, that society wasn't perfect. It was far from it, honestly. Quirkless children were ostracized, abused, and torn apart. Suicide rates skyrocketed each year, and no one seemed to care.

Quirk Marriages were still done under the table, like with Endeavor and his wife, but don't ask him how he drew that conclusion. That was a secret.

There were people who were rejected from society, much like Quirkless people, whose Quirks were scary, creepy or villainous. Much like Midoriya Izuku, the Yuuei student, who was abused by his parents. And how does he know this?

It's because Stain chose him to change society as they knew it. Stain wanted them to show the people of this world how broken and unfair the world around them truly was. He wanted to destroy the false lens that everyone seemed to be looking through. The world was corrupt. Some heroes were corrupt. The Laws were outdated, and frankly, useless. It favored a way of thinking that had gone out of style years ago.

At the very least, they should've changed the laws to allow for public use. Especially if a person's Quirk could be of use at their job. Or potentially save someone. At the very least, they should have laws against Quirkless discrimination; or they should at least have a system in place to aid the Quirkless so that they wouldn't think that the only way out was killing themselves.

It didn't matter that they only accounted for less than five percent of the population. That didn't matter at all. They were still *human.* They still had feelings, thoughts, and dreams like anyone else. Being Quirkless didn't make them weak or lesser. So Shi decided he was getting an F on this essay, and he had almost been done when the message came through.

He had been expecting it, of course. Kurogiri had been warning them for days that something was happening. That the League was planning something.

Shi looked at the message, but beyond that, he didn't acknowledge it.

???: *Warehouse in three hours.*

That's all he needed to know before he turned back to his essay. He still needed to attach the links and cite his sources before he was done completely. He went to the front of the café and asked for another cup of coffee before returning to his table with the cold cup in hand. An

iced Americano, just how he liked it. He couldn't really stand anything else. Especially not the excessively sugary drinks that some of his friends always got. For some reason they just didn't do it for him. He needed something *strong*.

He read through his paper at breakneck speed. It was his Quirk, but the only tell it gave was the glowing of his eyes. And even that wasn't all that noticeable. He called it Speed Reading. Not creative, but it was the only thing he could think of.

Once he determined that there were no simple mistakes, he closed his laptop and nursed his coffee. The café he chose was positioned on a really busy street near the train station. It was truly luck that he looked up at that time to the wave of new arrivals.

He couldn't help the bright smile and the rush of excitement. *Midoriya Izuku* was walking down the sidewalk with Eraserhead, probably doing his internship. One step closer to the Light, to becoming a hero he was meant to be. Going on to be what Stain wanted him to be!

He was also fighting to continue Stain's Legacy in his own way, just like Shi was. Shi just wanted to help people that the Heroes didn't know needed helping. He just wanted to keep society from crumbling. That's why he followed Stain.

That's why Stain taught him how to kill with nothing more than the dagger hidden in his backpack. He felt a strange kinship between him and Midoriya, and he wished the boy the best as he left the café for good. He hoped one day he'd see him on TV, saving lives with a smile.

He slung his backpack over his shoulder, being careful not to jostle the laptop inside as he walked. The sun was just beginning to set, casting the area in a filter of golds and oranges. He pulled up his hood as he walked, his eyes finding the curly green hair that could only belong to Midoriya.

Maybe he'd leave him some words of encouragement. He grinned as he caught up to them, ignoring how the sun was at the exact angle that it blinded him.

Shi quickened his pace until he was just about to pass them. He placed his hand on Midoriya's shoulder, noticing how he flinched. He turned around almost instantly, but Shi was already walking away.

"Stain the roses red," He whispered, still loud enough for him, and probably his teacher to hear.

He was quick to disappear into the crowd, not noticing that he was being followed.

Izuku didn't know what to make of his encounter on the street, but he certainly hadn't expected it. Not in the slightest. He had been in Hosu for only a handful of minutes, and a complete stranger had come up to him, whispering such heavy words. With such meaning and care. Like he was rooting for him, and only for him.

Another one of Stain's Roses, lost in the crowd quicker than he could see. He had barely looked up before he—or she—had run away, most likely to avoid getting captured by Shouta. Izuku had searched the crowd for a few fruitless seconds before giving up. If a follower of Stain didn't want to be followed, then they wouldn't leave a sign of them ever being there. There would be no way for Izuku to find them, unless they wanted to be found. And it was pretty apparent that he didn't want to be found.

"What was that all about?" Shouta asked, placing a hand on Izuku's shoulder. He'd gotten used to the action in the last few days, and it turned out that Shouta had noticed it and kept doing it. It was probably the only form of contact that Izuku didn't flinch from.

[I don't know.]

"He said Stain's motto, didn't he?" Shouta mumbled, giving Izuku a quizzical glance. "I'm guessing he's trying to encourage you."

[I guess so.]

“Just accept the compliment, problem child. Even vigilante’s think you’re going to make a great hero.”

[I’m not sure…]

Shouta glared at him, and if he hadn’t been paying attention, he would’ve thought that he erased his Quirk with just his glare alone. “You’re well on your way to it, kid. We just need to get control of your Quirk.”

Izuku risked a small smile as they continued on. If anyone could help him get control of his Quirk without worry, it was Shouta. He could erase his Quirk as soon as it became too much or if he risked transforming. He was the best option for now. There wasn’t a hero in history who had a Quirk even remotely similar to his. He was left to figure it out on his own, without much guidance.

“Speaking of which, we’re probably going to keep going with the training you did a few days ago. You’re already showing improvement that way, and once you master that, we can safely move on to transforming if you want.”

[It’s too dangerous to not master. I need to learn how to control it before I hurt someone.]

“Exactly.” Shouta agreed, but he was frowning. “But while we’re working on your Quirk, we’ll also be working on a case here.”

[What kind of case?]

Shouta goes silent for a moment, before speaking. “We’re hunting Stain’s followers. We’ve had many reports that they’ve been hanging around this area for a while. And the detective I spoke to earlier said that they have reason to believe that the League is after them. Shigaraki has been spotted in the area a handful of times.”

[Are we the only one's working on the case?]

"No, Ingenium and Dragon, a new hero, are going to be helping us."

Izuku nodded, wringing his hands together. That meant he'd be partnering up with Iida and Kacchan in the process. At least he'd be working with his friends. He knew at least Shouta, Kacchan, and Iida would have his back no matter what.

[Okay.]

"We'll be staying at Ingenium's agency so we can help solve the case, since Ingenium was the one to ask us for help. In the morning, we'll be training your Quirk, and at night we'll be patrolling to find the Roses before the League does."

Because if the League found the Roses first, they'd have a war on their hands. Or a massacre. Either way, Izuku was eager to be a part of trying to prevent it.

[Are we headed to Ingenium's Agency now?]

"Yep, almost there."

Izuku followed his father a little farther before they reached the agency. The building itself was huge; a tall skyscraper with the a sign that said: INGENIUM AGENCY

It seemed to reach to the heavens, its tall glass windows glowing like gilded gold against the oranges of the sunset. He was about to go into the agency of *Ingenium.* The hero that Chizome-san had tried to kill. The hero that he'd killed his mentor to protect. Did he know? Had Iida told him about how Izuku had saved him?

Did he not know at all? Did he think it was some random vigilante trying their hand at justice?

“Midoriya?”

He froze, clutching his shirt in his hands. He could feel all of the blood in his face draining, and he could hear his own gasping breaths. Standing at Iida’s side was Ingenium, in full costume. He was going to puke right in front of the agency. But oh God, that would look horrible. He was pathetic.

His blood was like ice in his veins, cold and cracking. Freezing him to this spot. He couldn’t move. It was like Todoroki himself was using his Quirk on him. It vaguely reminded him of how he felt when he saw All for One the first time.

“Are you okay Midoriya?”

Ingenium, in all his gleaming, heroic, glory, was standing right before him. He didn’t deserve this. He didn’t deserve to see such a man like Ingenium. His parents were right. He was just a villain. He should’ve been a villain. If Ingenium was the image of Heroics—All Might was overrated, honestly—then how was Izuku supposed to compare? How was he supposed to measure up with a Quirk like his?

This man he had saved… He was the spitting image of all things Hero. In contrast, with a power such as Izuku's, the world would dub him a villain if it hadn’t already. One day, All for One would prove to him how fruitless his dreams were.

He fought the sobs working their way up his throat like fire. He pushed back the stinging tears in the back of his eyes.

And worst of all…

All he could imagine…

All he could see…

All he could feel…

The hilt tightly gripped in his hands. His hands slick with warm, sticky blood that wasn‘t his own. It was never his own, no matter how much he’d dreamed and begged that it was. Cold, dead eyes of his mentor. Of his first father figure. Of his savior. Of his light in the darkness, when he’d pushed Kacchan away, and he was nowhere to be found. Stain. Chizome-san.

Those dead eyes were watching him, lifting up a cold hand to caress his cheek. It was like he was standing right there, wound bleeding and dripping from his chest. Right in front of Iida, inches away, but transparent like a ghost.

I killed him. I killed him. I killed him. I’m a villain. I’m a murderer. I can never be a hero. I can’t. I can't—

“You’re my hero *, Izuku Midoriya.”*

Tears sprang to his eyes without his consent. His heart twisted in his chest with every beat, constricting and crying out in pain. In sorrow, for the blood he’d shed.

He was there again. Blood like treacherous poison drenched all over him. Screaming and begging for it to stop, but he couldn’t. He couldn’t stand by and watch a hero die. He couldn’t just do *nothing* while Chizome-san had his blade positioned to kill, once and for all. Death was eternal. Death was immortal, and Izuku couldn’t let another life get cut short that didn’t deserve it.

His stomach flipped sickeningly, like he was falling. It sure felt like he was falling.

“Hey kid, are you okay?”

He could see Ingenium's mouth moving, but he couldn't hear anything. There was only the sound of blades shivering through the air and colliding faster and faster. The scream of metal on metal, again and again, until there was a heart-lurching squelching sound. The sound of Izuku's blade cutting through Chizome-san's chest like it was nothing.

So fragile. Humans were so fragile. Chizome-san hadn't been an exception, but he had been so *strong,* so invincible in Izuku's mind, that when he died… When Izuku *murdered* him… It didn't feel real. He felt lost.

His world had come to a very abrupt stop. The gears screeched to a stop, and Izuku personally thought that they had never started moving again. He was still there. Every *single* day. He was there. He was there. *He was right there.*

Stain was dying everyday. On repeat in his mind's eye, on loop. His entire world—his *universe*— was still frozen, the gears of time rusted. The tears just on the verge of falling but never quite doing so. The life draining out of his eyes, just to rewind and do it again. Again and again.

And every time, Izuku watched. And he screamed. He cried. It tore him apart. It *destroyed* him, and time still did not go on. Time did not go *forward* . It was like an error, and nothing was working like it was supposed to. Nothing was moving forward. Only backwards.

It was like he was trying to run forward, only for his pace to slow, only for the hallway to get longer. The door labeled freedom. The door labeled happiness. The door labeled *hero* was too far out of reach. And with every breath, with every step forward, he was dragged back toward the door he desperately wanted to flee from.

The door labeled danger. The door labeled monster. The door labeled *villain* .

He was always going backwards. He was never going forward. It was all just an illusion. His world was a lie. He was still watching Stain die by his hands. He had never *really* left that alley, and Ingenium had just proved that to him.

The tears flowed freely, and all he could process was the alleyway. The slumped bodies of Iida and Tensei. The carnage and destruction that *he* had done.

It was all his fault. It was always his fault. He did this. He created this illusion of moving on with his own two hands. Brick by brick. And now?

Pain and sorrow were seeping through the cracks. The foundation was crumbling all around him, like an avalanche. There was no sunlight. There was no happiness. There was nothing. Only inky blackness all round him, like the depths of the ocean.

Such a beautiful illusion built on a foundation of lies and self-deception.

His chest heaved. There was nothing.

His eyes stung. There was nothing.

His hands shook. There was nothing.

Sorrow drowned him. There was nothing.

Fear choked him. There was nothing.

He was nothing.

This false castle of dreams, of hopes that he'd created so hastily was cracking. And there was *fucking* nothing. On all sides there was nothing. Not Shouta. Not Kacchan. Not Chizome-san. He was alone, as his castle of glass shattered so violently and completely, like his heart.

Time did not move forward. The clock had stopped ticking long ago. The world didn't even exist. And now he was alone, in this dark, frozen, terrifying blackness that seemed to rip him apart. The same blackness from the sports festival.

"Midoriya!"

It was just an echo. So soft, that he almost missed it. But he was so lost. How was he supposed to move when there was nothing to move toward? How could he find that echo and latch on to it?

But why should it matter? He was a *murderer.*

He pressed his hands to his eyes, and his violent fall began. So quick and unexpected, this fall. Like falling from paradise. The darkness whipped around him, as he lost his footing in this empty world.

He wasn't a hero. He was a villain. He was a…

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Chapter End Notes

Did you enjoy? I hope so!

As usual here's the discord invite!

Chapter 59

Chapter Notes

Hi guys! I totally didn't mean to take an ENTIRE MONTH to update but the last week or two I've been editing A L L of something wicked! (it took lots of coffee) Here is a list of all the edits I've done to Something Wicked:

1. So in the story Inko, Hisashi, and Izuku live in an apartment. Which, considering they have a basement, shouldn't happen. I changed EVERY SINGLE mention of apartment and changed it to home to keep my OCD from exploding.

2. I did a lot of grammar and spelling checks, but I don't know if I was completely thorough. It's much better than it was tho!

3. At some point I had decided to give Izuku OfA? Im stupid. He'd be so OP so I deleted it.

4. I also changed the Wendigo, and made it a Prototype-Nomu. Basically I just changed its name. It doesn't affect (effect???) the story whatsoever. The reason for the change is to make the USJ fit canon more and to make myself understand where the HELL I was going with that name lol

5. For future chapters I took out an arc y'all will never hear about lol. it just wasn't working.

that's it!

Midoriya was stumbling blindly into a panic attack. A very, very, violent panic attack it seemed. From what Tensei could tell, Midoriya was falling head-first into it. Or more accurately, he was drowning in it. It was like he wasn’t even with them. It was like he was in a different world altogether, with how his eyes were glossy and glazed over with guilt.

His eyes seemed to stare at nothing. At no one. Maybe he was having a flashback. That seemed more accurate.

This small boy who, according to Tenya, had saved his life. He was clutching his shirt tightly with both hands, tremors wracking his body. And that’s when he made a sobering realization that Midoriya was staring wide-eyed and terrified at *him.*

He'd tried to call his name many times, but it's like he was a statue. Eraserhead looked just as frozen as his student for a moment, his eyes shimmering with worry and guilt.

Before he could even reach out to him to offer comfort, the kid was running. He was tearing past him, black flames licking at his skin like living shadows and smoke. Like some infernal monster.

He moved to follow, but he was long gone before he could even move. He ran past them, past the agency, disappearing from view before he could even catch up. He wasn't sure if he should even follow because if he was triggering Midoriya… then it wouldn't make sense to chase after him and make it worse.

Eraserhead was the first to move, running full-speed in the direction his student had just gone. Tensei let out a relieved breath, hoping Midoriya would be okay.

Horror burned through him as the world around him finally came into sharp focus. The sun had fully set, and the milky cool fog of the night had settled over the world. Izuku didn't remember getting to this alley. He didn't remember running. All he could recall was seeing Tensei Iida, a.k.a. Ingenium, and promptly losing his mind over it.

Everything seemed to shatter. The very world around him became smoke and mirrors and there was nothing. There had been nothing for so long, that when he finally could see… He wasn't sure if it was real. He was sure it was all an illusion, until he saw the alley way, and realized he wasn't alone.

Standing before him, with his hood drawn up to hide his features, was the boy from before who had stopped him. Who had spoken to him needed words of encouragement. The said boy was currently shaking him by his shoulders.

"Hey, kiddo." He said loudly, probably because he'd been trying to get his attention for a while. "Hey, are you alive in there?"

Izuku blinked, the dried tear tracks pulling his face taunt. He gave a curt nod, and the boy smiled nervously, his lips trembling. “Good. What’s got you so worked up, huh?”

He doubted the man knew sign language, so he tugged lightly on the red scarf around the boy’s neck. The boy glanced down at the scarf, and then back at Izuku. Understanding flickered in those eyes. “You’re thinking about Stain?”

I’m always thinking about Stain.

He nodded again, his lips downturned into a deep frown. Seeing Ingenium had shaken his world, sending him falling and falling. And this is where he’d landed. In a dark alleyway with one of Stain’s most loyal followers. “I think about him too, sometimes. I think about how he could’ve changed society as we know it if he wasn’t so violent.”

That made him smile. A small, timid smile. Chizome-san was definitely too violent in his way of doing things, but his ideology had struck the hearts of many. He had moved and inspired so many, in good ways and in bad. He made heroes work harder to be more selfless, but he also gave the more deranged villains purpose.

He fueled their drive to harm others, for reasons Izuku couldn’t understand. But that was the natural order of the world. There can be no light without the darkness, and there could be no Hero without a Villain. They were different sides of the same coin, and to work well, to work *efficiently* , Heroes needed Villains. And Villains needed Heroes.

Society itself was built on this relationship. Such a dangerous and weak foundation, but the world’s foundation nonetheless. It was just another one of the world's rules that Izuku couldn’t ever hope to change. But he wanted to change things. So desperately and eagerly, he begged for change.

He wanted Quirkless people to be able to do whatever they want. He wanted people with villainous Quirks to not be shunned anymore. He wanted society to change, but was he strong enough? Was he good enough to bring about change that the world — whether it knew or not — needed?

Stain was trying to do it in his own convoluted and dangerous way. Could Izuku do that too? Could he become that Symbol Stain had talked about?

He wiped at his face, even though his face had dried. “You good kid?” The boy asked, “Do you need help finding your way back? I’ve gotta meet up with the other Roses, but they’ll understand if I’m late.”

Izuku turned away from him for a moment to survey the area. With anyone else he would’ve been more cautious, but this was a Rose. They had sworn to protect him and Stain’s dream. For now, their intentions were clear and Izuku had nothing to fear.

He didn’t recognize any landmarks from his position and he had never been in Hosu at all until now. He’d be really, really lost. But maybe he could send his location to Shouta and Kacchan? He *could* do that, but he really didn’t want a lecture about running away.

He glanced at Shi and the boy smiled back at him.

“So you do need help?” He pulled his hood off and Izuku was met with slicked back curly brown hair, and vibrant hazel eyes. His smile was warm, and kind. So soft, for someone who followed Stain. From what he had said, maybe he was more of a vigilante? “Let’s go, kiddo! You were with Eraserhead right?”

His smile was infectious, and Izuku couldn’t help but smile a little wider. The boy grabbed his shaking hand and started to walk forward. “My name is Shi! Stain loved you, ya know? He never stopped talking about you! I’m so glad I got to meet you!”

He veered out of the alleyway, swinging their hands together, and now they were out on the streets. Lights illuminated the night in a white light. They passed a hardware store and crossed the street. Shi didn’t let go of his hand, but Izuku didn’t really mind.

“He told me that you’re going to be a hero one day! Once I saw the Sports Festival I knew you could do it, even if the League was going to be after you at every turn. You’re really

strong and protective, and when watching the Festival, while it was *terrifying* —Kurogiri didn't let us help, he said it would draw too much suspicion—it was also so cool! You make me want to be a hero, Midoriya! You're so fucking cool, like whoom! Your Quirk is so unique and unprecedented! One day, I hope I can help people like you have."

He thinks my Quirk is cool? He thinks I've saved people? He thinks I can do it? Izuku didn't know how to feel about someone being so *sure* about Izuku's future other than his dads.

"I've got a Speed Reading Quirk, so I essentially fight Quirkless. Eraserhead is kind of the same way, but he has the means to even the playing field by canceling out Quirks. Anyway, no matter what happens, no matter how much shit the world throws at you, I know you can do it! You're going to be a hero! And I think this is where you were supposed to be? Sorry, I rambled too much! But I hope you feel better! I just know Stain-san is watching you grow. I'm sure he's very proud of the young Hero you've become!"

Izuku looked up at Shi, this random follower of Stain, who had unintentionally dragged him out of his own dark mind. Out of the sick and twisted guilt that had him in its vice-grip. Stray curls framed his soft face and a smile was plastered there, so genuine and kind. Izuku couldn't be a hero like Ingenium, but he could be a hero like Shi.

He could save the people that the world didn't know *needed* saving. He could help people smile and work toward their dreams. He could inspire people with scary Quirks to chase their dreams. He could inspire people without Quirks that they could do whatever they wanted. He could put every ounce of his work into saving the people that no one wanted to save.

He would be the Symbol of Hope for the hopeless. For the Quirkless. For the forgotten. For the people labeled useless thanks to society.

He might not be able to change the world, but he could definitely give people hope. He could give them light and a path to follow that wasn't riddled with villainy or darkness. He would be their light in the dark.

He could do *that* . He could be a hero of his own making. He didn't need to be an All Might, or an Ingenium. He didn't need to be number one.

He looked toward the building they'd stopped at. Shi was right. They were at Ingenium's Hero Agency.

"Izuku!" Shouta exclaimed, rather loudly. "Where have you been? I've been looking everywhere for you!"

Izuku rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. "It's okay!" Shi replied, "I found him before he could get himself into any serious trouble Aizawa-san!"

That's when Shouta's eyes hardened and went cold with anger. "You—"

He lunged forward, but Shi danced out of the way with a little pout. Izuku watched with wide eyes, hands signing out words that Shouta wasn't reading. "I only guided him back here, nothing else!"

[I was lost! He helped me.]

"Eraserhead I swear I was only helping!" Shi cried, rushing to hide behind Izuku in an effort to avoid getting kicked square in the face. "Save me Midoriya-chan!"

Izuku couldn't stifle his laugh in time, and for some reason it made Shouta freeze. But he couldn't help the swelling feeling of warmth, and the bubbling laugh in his throat. He covered his mouth and tried to stop it, he really did.

For some odd reason he found himself laughing, when he usually wouldn't have. It bubbled in his chest, and burst forth with such warmth. "Y-your laughing…"

Shouta was right. He was laughing with no sign of stopping. This was just too funny. Maybe he'd run out of sadness, and all that was left was happiness? Maybe this was his body's way of coping?

He didn't care, not right now. He wanted to revel in the feeling of this unexpected happiness that he hadn't felt in so long. He wanted to hold on to it forever, and never let it slip between his shaking fingers. The world around him was always so bleak. So dark. So evil.

He wanted to cherish this small amount of happiness that seemed to originate from nowhere. Merely hours ago, he'd been having the worst panic attack he'd ever had. But now that he was exhausted mentally, his body decided to fill him with this warmth. This beautiful, soft feeling, like sunlight against his skin after a long cold night.

Maybe Shi's words had finally placated his guilt. Maybe he was finally taking that first step away, out of the darkness of villainy and destruction. That first *real* step out of that alleyway and the sun was just out of reach, but he could feel the warmth.

Maybe he was getting closer to his dream.

"Does he not laugh often?" Shi asked, peeking over Izuku's shoulder. "That's sad Midoriya! You should have more fun!"

Izuku's face was starting to hurt from smiling so much. There were arms around him before he could blink. The familiar cologne that Shouta wore assaulted his nose. He melted instantly into the touch, and Shouta laughed against his shoulder. He squeezed him tighter before he pulled away. Izuku was almost sad at the loss.

"I don't think I've ever heard you laugh like that,"

[Like what?]

"Like you were actually happy," His dad replied, looking happy and relieved.

"Well, see ya around guys!" Shi exclaimed, turning to go before Shouta decided to kick him in the face after all. Izuku watched him leave and disappear into the dark shadows of an alley.

He probably wouldn't see that boy ever again, but he would never forget the words he said to him.

Izuku looked back at Shouta and he beckoned him inside. "Let's go get briefed on the mission, problem child. Bakugou is already here, and Ingenium had to stop him multiple times from looking for you."

His words were warm, and comforting. He placed a hand on Izuku's shoulder, and walked him inside the building. He wished this feeling would stay forever.

But of course happiness was always short-lived. The darkness was always looming, and villains were always lurking.

Tomura Shigaraki was never a patient or intelligent man. He was more a man of action than anything. He proved himself to be that during the U.S.J. incident. Sensei had told him to wait a day or two, but he at least wanted some bloodshed before the Nomu's were unleashed upon Hosu.

He wanted Hosu to run red with the blood of the Roses. He wanted death and carnage like no other. It was addicting. It gave him a rush that no drug could provide, such a high that he craved it more and more each time. And it was only fitting that the Nomu he was bringing with him was the former leader of the Roses.

Stain the Hero Killer had never really died.

He was an advanced Nomu. A Prototye-Nomu. And he would be the one to drag that treacherous snake Midoriya back to them. Personally Tomura didn't care about Midoriya. They *could* just kill him and be done with it, but whatever. He would follow Sensei's orders for now. After all, Sensei had yet to steer him wrong.

“Kurogiri,” Tomura rasped, like he hadn’t spoken in days. It was probably just a side-effect of scratching his neck all the time and yelling. “Open the portal near that warehouse.”

“But Sensei doesn’t think doing this is a good idea…” Kurogiri mumbled, “It’ll have more impact if we wait.”

“I don’t care. I want them dead. I want their *blood* .”

“You’ll do it whether or not I teleport you, won’t you?” Kurogiri sighed. “Fine. I’ll teleport you.”

The purple portal appeared a second later, and he and Nomu stepped out into the alleyway. It was already dark, and no one dared to be out when it got dark in Hosu. Not after the police had warned the public about the Roses’ presence here. They didn’t want to become another corpse to add on to the death toll.

Smart people. But the Roses weren’t as smart. If they’d been smart they would’ve made sure the media didn’t know about them moving their location. But they were fools. Every single one of them.

They wouldn’t know what hit them, not until it was too late.

Katsuki was allowed to watch Izuku train with Aizawa the next morning. It hadn’t been what he was expecting. He expected him to become that badass beast like he’d done before. However, he hadn’t expected *this* .

The three of them were in the basement of Ingenium’s Agency, in one of the many training rooms. This one was brightly lit—thank god because Katsuki knew that Izuku was afraid of the dark—and made entirely from concrete. The walls, ceiling and floor were made of it, and it's a good thing they were.

Izuku had entered the room, with Aizawa-sensei behind him, and they began almost instantly. Aizawa had been very strict about Katsuki remaining a good distance away, and as soon as he was a safe distance away, Izuku took off the cross around his neck. The room shuddered, but settled soon after.

Katsuki watched with wide eyes as black fire, like dancing shadows swirled around his childhood friend. The power burst from his skin in waves. That alluring black magic that left Katsuki speechless each time. A Quirk so beautiful yet haunting. The Quirk that instilled so much fear in his friend, but captured Katsuki's heart.

This was his best friend's Quirk, and he was well on his way to controlling it. Black flames danced in his hands, but the room was freezing.

"Can you see if you can control the amount of power you're putting out?" Aizawa asked gently, from his spot closer to Izuku. "If you can get it to a controllable percentage we can slowly work up from there."

[I'll try.]

Katsuki crossed his arms and rubbed them, if only to get more warmth into them. It was *really* cold in here.

He watched Izuku closely, to see any changes. To watch as his power fluctuated as he attempted to tame it. It started off small. A miniscule change. Power stopped rumbling through the room, like an earthquake.

Izuku's shoulders rose as he took a deep breath. The violent writhing of his power calmed down, until the flames danced lazily in his hands. "Now go full power again for a few seconds. And then reel it back in."

The room shuddered, and the flames seemed to explode outward. If he'd been blind folded, he would've thought Half-and-Half was here, using his ice. The temperature dropped

dramatically again. And then it went calm again. “Can you continue?” Aizawa asked, his voice gentle.

Katsuki was grateful that Aizawa seemed to care about Izuku so much. If Izuku couldn’t live with him and his parents, then he was really glad that he was stuck with Aizawa-sensei. The man never seemed to push Izuku too hard, and he really seemed to care about Izuku. The boy in question nodded and the cycle continued on and on until his muscles tensed.

“You’re getting tired,” Aizawa noted. “Are you still okay to keep going?”

Izuku gave him a determined nod. It was probably the hottest thing Katsuki had ever seen as he was embraced with black curling flames. He grinned.

One day, his best friend was going to be a hero. It didn’t matter that his parents were villains and forced him to do bad things. His past didn’t matter, and honestly it didn't change Katsuki’s point of view on the boy.

It didn’t matter because one day, he and Izuku would stand together. They would be the world’s best Hero Duo to ever bless the industry, and that was a *fact* . They were a pair. They were meant to work together and be together. He wouldn’t have it any other way.

Chapter 60

Chapter Notes

>:DDDD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was after a particularly hard training session that Shouta recommended they take a break and go out. They had spent the entire night patrolling and then jumped right into another session, and now Izuku was sitting on the floor, sweating.

His arms and knees were shaking and his breath was coming out short. Quirk overuse, at its finest. But it felt good, taking another step toward mastery of his power. It felt good to be working so hard so he could fulfill his dream.

“We should take a break,” Shouta mumbled as he helped Izuku to his feet. “Do you want to go to a cat café?”

He brushed the dust and grime off of his pants as he got to his feet. He gave Shouta a quick nod and a bright smile. Smiling was getting easier everyday after what Shi had told him. There had been a moment during his breakdown that he thought he’d never smile again.

[I like cats.]

“Me too, problem child.” Shouta told him as they made their way down the dark corridor. There were places that the light didn’t reach, leaving a lot of shadows in the corners of the halls. He ignored them. Fear blossomed along his skin, but he pushed it down. He would be fine when he got outside. He wasn’t trapped down here.

But he really should get used to it. The darkness followed him wherever he went, without fail. His army of demons was made of it. They thrived in it. So he really should get over that fear, but it was so deeply ingrained in him that there was no hope of that.

He was always a slave of his fears, no matter how hard he tried to face them. He hadn't mastered a single one of his fears, except maybe the fear of his Quirk. But that was slow going. He was still working on it. Izuku followed Shouta faithfully as they made it upstairs into the brightly lit lobby. As they exited, the doors automatically sliding silently, Iida and Inegenium were leaving.

"You guys goin' out?" Ingenium asked with a tired yawn. Izuku tried not to yawn too, but it was fruitless.

"Yeah," Shouta grumbled, "We're gonna get something to eat and then go to bed before we have to go on patrol again."

"You work too hard Aizawa-sensei…" Iida mumbled, but Izuku could hear the smile in his tone even behind his costume. Shouta gave him a wide, slightly deranged, grin then they all went their separate ways. Shouta led him down the sidewalk, not wasting a second of the morning light. If they wanted to get an ample amount of sleep, they needed to arrive there soon. But sleep didn't really matter to Izuku, and now that he was thinking about it, Shouta didn't really care for sleep either.

So what was the rush?

It took him almost a full minute trying to figure it out before he realized. Oh, right. *Cats.*

Izuku grinned, before matching pace with his dad. Of course Shouta would be in a hurry to see some cats. Cats were a part of his entire being. He could probably be mistaken for a cat due to some of his cat-like tendencies, like having the ability to nap anywhere at any time.

Even right now as they walked, he looked like he was ready to just lay down on the sidewalk. He looked almost as tired as Izuku felt. They had both stayed up really late and had yet to go to sleep. He doubted Shouta would even sleep, even if they had plenty of time. Maybe that's why they were going to the cafe, so Shouta could have some time to relax.

It was plausible, as they finally reached their destination. The building was small and quaint, with a wood-burned sign hanging above the door. It was in English, so he couldn't really make out the name of the establishment, but he doubted it'd be detrimental to their visit in the end.

The door was curved, and had a small four paned window on it. Next to the door, nearly on the sidewalk, was a little chalkboard that read: *Today's Special is coffee cake!*

The building itself looked like a house you'd find in America, with the triangle roofs, paneled siding and a multitude of four paned windows. But looking through the window, he saw that the tables and chairs weren't as old fashioned as the building itself and he could see a crowd of cats walking around. Shouta must've seen the look of excitement on his face because he pulled Izuku along and got them a table pretty quickly.

The table they sat at had room for two more, but they were going to remain empty. A very soft, kind lady with purple hair came up to their table as soon as they settled down. The table itself was made of polished wood, but there were scratches in it. Probably from the cats.

"Hello!" the lady with purple hair exclaimed as she got a notepad out of her apron. She clicked her pen gently, and glanced at both of them with a sweet smile that didn't reach her eyes. Her eyes were tired, but not unkind. "What drinks would you like?"

Shouta ended up ordering for him and Izuku, getting them both iced coffee with milk and coffee cake. Izuku had really thought he'd get black coffee, but maybe he was having an off day. The lady scribbled it down, repeated it back to them to double check and walked away, her hair bouncing with each step.

Cats loitered around, most of them napping on pillows thrown around the place. Just being in the same room as these cats helped calm him. His constantly hammering heart slowed, and the shaking in his hands eased up. A cat found its way into Izuku's lap almost instantly, a fluffy persian cat. Its coat was completely white and long, and Izuku gave it a gentle pet. The cat purred and nudged its head into Izuku's hand to demand for more pets. He gratefully ran his hands through the cats fur and the cat purred louder.

"So," Shouta began softly, and Izuku glanced up from the cat in his lap. At some point Shouta had procured two cats. One tabby, and a siamese. His face was set and determined as

he spoke. “I heard from Ms. Kaori that you haven’t been talking to her.”

Izuku cast his eyes down to the cat and gave her more pets. Shouta plowed on, not one to be deterred by his reaction. Or his lack of thereof. “Are you not comfortable with her? Would you rather talk to me?”

Izuku glanced up again from the cat and noticed that their cakes and coffee had arrived. It remained untouched by both of them. The unanswered question weighed heavily in the air, and Izuku couldn’t bring himself to look at Shouta. “You know you can trust me, Izuku.”

Izuku placed his hands carefully on the table and kept his head down. He really didn’t want, or need, this conversation. He could deal with everything on his own in his own time. He didn’t need help. He didn’t want it. He really didn’t want to bother people with his problems. It wouldn’t be fair of him. People shouldn’t have to deal with his pain and trauma—

Shouta’s hand came to rest on his own shaking ones. His hands seemed like ice against Shouta’s, but the other man didn’t seem to notice or mind. “You’re my son. I’m supposed to take care of you and make sure you’re safe. That includes being safe from your own thoughts.”

[I know.]

“Do you really? You haven’t come to me for anything. I know you’re suffering, but you never ask for help.” Shouta heaved a heavy sigh. Was he annoyed? Angry? “Help may have not been there for you when everything was happening to you, but it’s here now, Izuku. Let me help you. I can’t watch you drown anymore.”

Shouta was right, but could he trust him? Could he spill everything? Could he tell him about how weak he felt when fighting the Priest? Could he tell him about how he could barely breathe everytime Ingenium was within his line of sight? Could he tell him about his terrifying experience during the Sports Festival? About how he almost hadn’t escaped the chains? He risked a glance up, his lips pressed into a thin line.

“You don’t have to be alone anymore, Izuku. You can trust me with anything.”

He searched Shouta's tired eyes and couldn't find a lie there. He was being genuine. Of course he was, this was *Shouta,* who had saved him more times than he could count. Who would jump in front of a train for him if it meant Izuku would survive. It took him a moment, but eventually, he pulled his hands out of Shouta's and lifted his hands to sign. There was a stretch of silence as Shouta watched his hands, and Izuku debated on what he should say.

[The Sports Festival was scary.]

That probably wasn't the best way to start this. Definitely not the problem at hand, even though he swore he could still taste the Holy water on his tongue like acid. He swore he could feel his back burning… but he should be worrying more about how he still wasn't over Stain's death.

It was still a gaping hole in his chest, where his heart should be. It was a wound invisible to the human eye, but just as deadly as a physical one. He should've started by talking about that, but the first thing he had signed had been that.

"It was," Shouta admitted, and Izuku didn't miss how Shouta buried his hand into a cat's fur. He watched as the muscles in his shoulders tensed, and his eyes avoided Izuku's. "What happened that day was unacceptable. As your teacher and guardian I should've protected you. We're lucky that you survived…"

[I didn't.]

"Didn't what?" Shouta asked, his voice shaking with anxiety. From the sharp look in his eye, Izuku knew that Shouta already had an idea of what he was implying. He'd tried to talk about it with him before, but Kacchan had stopped him. It looked as if Shouta didn't want to acknowledge it.

[I didn't survive.]

Was he really about to do this? Was he really going to tell Shouta what happened? He took a timid sip of his coffee, nervously casting glances his way. If anyone deserved to know why he resurrected on live television, it was Shouta. And Hizashi. And Kacchan…

But the thought of revealing something like this sent ice shooting into his veins. How would Shouta react? In this world, people with Quirks like his own were rare. And since they were rare, people tended to want to experiment on it. People wanted to find out exactly how a Quirk like his worked, especially since he could theoretically resurrect. Now that he was thinking about it… he didn't really look at the news since the incident.

There had been too much going on and he was too afraid of what he would find. He swallowed around the lump in his throat as Shouta opened his mouth to respond.

"What do you mean?" Shouta asked gently, so gently like he was afraid Izuku would run away if he raised his voice. Izuku swallowed the white-hot fear festering beneath his skin like crackling fire. He kept his eyes on his coffee for a minute, seeking comfort from the cat in his lap.

He reigned in his crippling fear. He shouldn't keep his father waiting. He could feel his eyes on his skin, hoping that Izuku would answer him.

He needed to do this. He needed to explain. He had to trust Shouta.

[I went somewhere strange, after I died. Wherever I had gone, it was dark. Hot. I was trapped there, until I heard your voice.]

Izuku willed himself to look Shouta in the eyes. He deserved Izuku's full attention, no matter what his reaction was. A number of emotions flickered across his face, anger, confusion, fear, and concern. He seemed to cycle through confusion and concern the most, as he waited for Izuku to elaborate. He chewed on the inside of his mouth and brought his hands up again.

[That's why I came back with wings.]

“What do you mean…?” He asked, eyes searching for answers. He looked pretty pale and sweaty. Izuku had expected that. His mind seemed to run through everything he’d seen at the Sports Festival. “By somewhere strange, do you mean…”

He paused, unwilling to voice his suspicion out loud.

[I don’t know.]

“I’m sorry,” Shouta replied, watching his uneaten coffee cake like it would suddenly grow legs and run away. “If I would’ve been a better teacher, none of this would’ve happened. If I would’ve been a better *parent...”*

[Villains are always attacking heroes. You couldn’t have predicted it or prevented it, and it’s part of a Hero’s job to defeat villains. It’s my fault I didn’t use my Quirk to protect myself.]

“You know, for a kid you're pretty mature.” Shouta grumbled with a humorless laugh that hung in the air. “But as much as I want to tell you that you should learn to rely on your teachers, I can't. We’re here to protect and teach you, but time and time again the world has shown you that you can’t rely on us. I understand why you think it was something that was bound to happen to you, but I can’t accept that I couldn’t protect you.”

[It’s okay.]

That was when Shouta slammed his fist into the table, not only shocking Izuku, but a number of cats as well. Izuku gulped the fear that had reflexively filled him. He didn’t need to be scared of Shouta. But the voice in the back of his head always told him to be fearful, to be wary of anyone who made sudden movements and outbursts.

Shouta glared up at him, his eyes burning like coals straight out of a fire. Izuku clenched his hands under the table, and Shouta stared him down.

“It’s *not* okay.” He choked out. Izuku could see the shining tears in his eyes. Shouta’s throat bobbed but his glare didn’t relent. “It’s never okay to fail at protecting you. It’s my *job* . And I've failed you more times than I can count this year!”

He wanted to tell him that everyone failed. No one won *every single time,* not even All Might. All Might had failed to save people before, and no one hated him for it. They were only human after all, and Shouta had seemed to forget that. No one expected him to be perfect, except maybe himself.

[You saved me when I didn’t know I *needed* to be saved.]

Shouta went quiet.

[You save me everyday. Every day I’m away from my parents is a day that I’m saved by you.]

Every day that I’m not surrounded on all sides by people who want to kill me is a day that I’m saved. Every day I’m in Yuuei is a day that I'm saved. Every day that I’m with Kacchan and Hizashi and you, is a day that I’m saved.

[Without you and everyone else who helped me, I would either be dead or worse. A villain.]

“I brought you here so I could comfort you, but you ended up comforting me instead,” He grumbled, but he didn’t look too mad about it. “I guess I should’ve expected that from a future hero.”

Izuku gave him a timid smile, and quickly shoved his coffee cake into his mouth. Shouta followed suit before paying for everything they’d bought. As they got up and left, Shouta crushed Izuku in a very fierce hug. “You know you can talk to me about anything else on your mind, right? We can talk more about what happened at the Sports Festival once internships are over. I think it’s something me, you, and Hizashi should talk about together.”

Izuku nodded against his shoulder, pushing away the emotions that threatened to burst from his skin. “Alright, we should head back and go to bed before we go patrolling.”

Shouta and Izuku were patrolling the back alleys of Hosu for any sign of the League or Stain’s Roses. So far they hadn’t been successful in the least, even with Kacchan and Dragon helping them out whenever they could.

It was strangely quiet tonight just as it had been the night before. Izuku kept a hand on the hilt of his katana the entire time, determined to be ready for action at any moment. Something was happening or going to happen. Hosu was never this still or this silent.

“Um, Eraserhead?” The walkie talkie strapped to Shouta’s hip buzzed with static. “You think you could head over to my location? I think I just found the Roses…”

Izuku felt the hairs on his neck rise with dread and suspicion at Dragon’s tone. The sensation spread like ice through his blood, straight to his heart. His chest tightened and Shouta grabbed the walkie talkie and pressed a button before speaking.

“What did you find, Dragon?”

“Corpses.”

Hitoshi sat in front of the television a few days after his internship began, gawking at the scene unfolding before him. Fire raged on the screen, red, orange and angry. Hosu was going up in flames. He clutched the cup of coffee he’d gotten in his hands. It had long since gotten cold because as soon as he sat down, the emergency news station had interrupted what he was watching.

Strange creatures similar to the Nomu from the USJ seemed to be wreaking havoc everywhere, destroying buildings and starting fires. From what he could tell, Heroes from the area were attempting to take them down and stop the fires. Uraraka was sitting beside him, pale in the face and shaking. Her coffee, too, went untouched.

A guttural roar cut through the din of crackling flames and fighting. The cameraman zoomed in to wherever it was coming from, and Hitoshi shot to his feet with a gasp. There was someone…

High in the sky, was a Nomu unlike any other he'd ever seen. The cameraman gasped, the footage shaking and nauseating to watch as it jerked around. But the Nomu wasn't the only thing in the black sky. Clutched in its claws was a person. The monster went up high into the sky and higher. And then the monster let go.

And they plummeted.

Chapter End Notes

If you're interested, here's the discord invite!

Chapter 61

Chapter Notes

Here we gooooo! (im uploading at midnight lol coz I KNEW I wouldn't wake up at 10:35am to update lol)

edit: I changed the titles of my chapters to fit each arc of the anime and my non-canon arcs (new changes are marked with two stars on either side)

Act One (1-14): Before UA

Act Two (15-21): Entrance Exam/Before USJ

Act Three (22-28): USJ/Aftermath/Moving in with Dadzawa

Act Four (29-39): My Controversial Therapy Arc that got me the most hate I've ever received

Act Five (44-47): Hero Names/Sports Festival

Act Six (48-55): Where my sports festival goes YEET with canon

Act Seven(57-??): Hosu Incident

See the end of the chapter for more notes

On some level, you have to be suicidal to become a Pro Hero. Izuku always personally thought that was a given. You fight to protect people with your Quirk. You face criminals and villains daily. It was a high-risk job, and of course you'd have to be at least a little suicidal to choose a career such as this one. Maybe that's why he wasn't really surprised about the lengths the League would go to, to get their point across. Maybe that's why he didn't throw up instantly when he laid eyes on the corpses strewn around the otherwise empty warehouse.

He definitely felt sick and disgusted. There were four bodies in total, gutted and torn apart. Blood was splattered like paint along the walls, and it wasn't completely dry yet. There were deep gouges in the concrete floor and along the walls, like a monster had ripped the victims up with their claws. Guts were thrown around the space and the corpses were slumped around like they'd been thrown even after death.

Dragon and Kacchan stood at the entrance of the warehouse, looking pale and just as sick as Izuku felt. His father's face was delicately expressionless, but his eyes weren't. There was a storm raging within Shouta's eyes, dark and vengeful.

"How long ago did you find them?" was Shouta's first question, coming to stand by them. Izuku studied the bodies more closely, risking getting up pretty close, but he didn't touch them. He didn't want to tamper with a crime scene.

The first corpse was that of a woman, with long black hair. She was laying face down, her arms twisted in all the wrong directions and her clothes in shreds. Her back was an array of huge, deep gashes, obviously from claws. The gouges further solidified his theory, and he could see the white of her spine peeking through her wounds.

Blood was pooled beneath the woman's form, and he noticed the red scarf around her neck. One of the people who had saved Shouta at the U.S.J. With a silent frown, he moved onto the next victim as he listened in on Shouta's conversation.

"Not long ago," Dragon mumbled. "I tried to get a hold of the police so they could investigate, but my phone doesn't have service. I tried to get them on the walkie talkie, but nothing came through. That's why I walkied you. You're the only one who answered."

The next body was a man with a massive sword strapped to his back. His cold, dead blue eyes were locked onto the ceiling, unseeing. His curly red hair was stained darker with his blood, and blood still leaked from his mouth. Izuku studied him and saw that his stomach was gouged open. That explained the innards strewn around the warehouse.

He moved to the third body: a girl with dark blue hair, cut rather short. She was missing her eyes and her face was caved in, probably from the impact of an attack from whatever had attacked them. Bile rose up in his throat, coating his mouth. All three of these bodies had red scarves, and they had previously been at the U.S.J. if Shouta's memories from the group therapy session were to be trusted.

They had helped save his classmates and teachers.

Reluctantly, he moved onto the fourth and final body, finding himself hoping that it wasn't Shi, the boy who had led him to Ingenium's Agency after his panic attack. It wasn't. He absently wiped away a stray tear that had fallen without his knowledge. The last body wasn't even an adult. It was a *child.*

He hadn't been at the U.S.J. thankfully, but he still hadn't been able to avoid his fate. He was barely seventeen, by the looks of it, probably a little older, but he was still a *child.*

His arm was ripped off and rested across the room, along with his foot. His throat was slit ear to ear; but it was savage, as if a beast had ripped its claws through the boy's throat. A horror had been here and tore them all apart.

Izuku stood and joined the other three at the entrance. Something about this whole scene was... off. The sheer amount of blood at the scene didn't match the number of corpses and their injuries. And Shi had told him about going to meet the Roses after helping him to the agency, yet he didn't see his body anywhere. It was safe to say that either Shi had survived, or that someone *took* the corpses.

And someone left the bodies of the ones who'd been at the USJ for *them* to find. On purpose. The only outlier was the last body. The body of that kid, but the message was still there.

"What do you mean no one answered you?" Shouta asked, crossing his arms and leveling the pro with a withering glare.

Izuku came to stand next to Kacchan, who had yet to even speak. He was still staring at the bodies. His hands were shaking and his throat bobbing every time he swallowed. Izuku grabbed his hand on instinct and Kacchan broke out of his daze, his red eyes finding Izuku's. Usually, his eyes were extremely expressive, like a window to Kacchan's soul. But right now, they seemed clouded and muddled and empty all at the same time.

Kacchan squeezed his hand and Izuku squeezed back comfortingly. Izuku brought his other hand up to Kacchan's face to wipe away his sudden silent tears. He wasn't too sure if Kacchan wanted comfort at the moment, but he pulled the taller boy into a hug.

“The walkie talkie wasn’t working, so I radioed everyone until you answered. Bakugou—Is he okay?” Dragon asked, and Izuku glared at him over Kacchan’s shoulder.

Kacchan took a moment to collect himself in the safety of Izuku’s embrace. “It’s your first time seeing a body, isn’t it?” Dragon murmured quietly, finally coming to the realization. “We should probably go outside for a minute and I’ll try to contact the police again.”

Kacchan, to Izuku’s surprise, followed him after pulling himself out of Izuku's arms. Shouta watched them go before turning to the scene, giving Izuku a side-glance. “Are you okay?”

The question was spoken softly, with a hint of concern. Izuku nodded resolutely, and clenched his fists before bringing them up to sign.

[I’ve seen bodies before. Just not as gruesome as this.]

“I’m sorry,” Shouta mumbled, before resting a hand on Izuku’s shoulder in a very father-like way. “Sometimes I forget… the things you’ve seen and experienced while in All for One’s care.”

The images of the fallen children flashed through his mind. All three of their cooling, dead bodies. Just children with their entire lives ahead of them, gone… It was his fault. All of that was his fault, but for now, he shouldn’t lose himself to the past. Besides, he needed to tell Shouta that this crime scene was shady.

[There’s something weird about this crime scene. There’s too much blood here for the number of corpses we found, and their injuries don’t match the number of puddles of blood. The guy who helped me get back to Ingenium’s Agency said he was going to meet them here, and his corpse isn’t here. Either he never arrived and survived the attack, or there are more corpses somewhere.]

“Are you sure—”

At that, the world trembled beneath their feet like an earthquake. Izuku braced himself, and managed to keep himself upright as the ground shuddered. The warehouse creaked ominously above them and Shouta's eyes widened. "What the hell's going on?!"

Izuku tumbled out the door to look outside. Nearly falling over as the world quaked violently beneath them and gaped. Nothing in their immediate vicinity was happening, but it only took one look into the smoke filled sky to realize something was wrong. Fires were raging somewhere, and they needed to help. His father came barreling behind him, and the group of four looked to the burning sky.

"We need to go help!" Dragon shouted as another quake ravaged the ground they stood on, clenching his fist with a grim frown. Smoke curled out of his mouth as he spoke, and Izuku saw Kacchan nod.

"What're we waiting for?!" Kacchan exclaimed, "Let's fucking go already!"

"Bakugou stick close to me!" Dragon yelled as they sprinted out of the alleyway and into the burning streets. Izuku looked at Shouta, awaiting instruction.

"Let's go." He stated grimly, before using his capture weapon to catapult himself onto the nearest roof.

Izuku followed suit, but he climbed the building unlike Shouta. Once they were both on the rooftop, the two of them peered over the edge looking out into the cityscape. It reminded Izuku vividly of what he thought hell would look like, with the swirling, crackling flames and the shattering screams. They could see everything from the vantage point. The ten or more Nomu wreaking havoc, throwing themselves into buildings and destroying them. Some Nomu were targeting anything that moved, including other Nomu.

And that's when he saw the corpses hanging from the rooftops of buildings. Mauled corpses of people that were long dead before they were placed there like some sick sort of decoration. The corpses hung from every building it seemed, some of them missing a limb here and there. *The rest of the Roses* .

Civilians' terrorized screams shattered the air like glass, and Izuku glanced around helplessly looking for them. He scanned everything: the flames, the Nomu, the Heroes. He couldn't seem to find the civilians—

"There!" His father exclaimed, pointing. Izuku followed with his eyes and found exactly what Shouta was pointing at. Two girls running from a massive Nomu, not too far from them. A street away. The Nomu chased them down the sidewalk and they screamed. Shouta was the first to move, grabbing Izuku by the waist as he used his capture weapon to swing down from the building at a breakneck speed. The air whipped past them, pulling Izuku's bangs out of his face.

They made it to the ground and cut through an alleyway to get to the street. Fire illuminated everything as they burst out into the next street where they'd seen the Nomu. Cars were flipped over and burning. The sharp smell of metal melting assaulted his senses as well as the distinct smell of fire. Izuku unsheathed his katana as they got visual on the Nomu and the two civilians again.

They tore their way through the rubble and debris, careful to avoid the burning cars and buildings. The Nomu let out a savage roar, lumbering after the two girls. Shouta's capture weapon wrapped around Izuku's waist, and Izuku glanced down at it curiously.

"I'm going to launch you at the Nomu, okay? It doesn't seem to be like the one at the U.S.J." He clarified, and Izuku nodded. He braced himself as he flew through the air like a canon. He saw Shouta use his capture weapon to keep up as Izuku rocketed through the air. They were closing in on the Nomu, and Izuku ignited his sword with his black hellflame. It was something he'd been practicing during his training sessions.

He never thought it'd come in handy so quickly, as he descended right on top of the Nomu. The landing was rough, but he managed to land on it's back, and stab it in the spine to gain some balance. The Nomu let out another piercing roar and reached its arms back to try to grab Izuku.

Izuku pulled his sword out and dropped to the ground with his knees bent. He swiped at the Nomu's legs, and instantly noticed that it's wound didn't regenerate. Izuku slid between its legs so he was facing it head on. Shouta landed beside him, and gave a curt nod. "Can you handle it while I make sure those two are okay?"

Shouta jabbed his thumb behind him at the two girls who were crying and holding each other. Izuku nodded and focused his attention back on his target. The Nomu wasn't as large as the one at the U.S.J. had been and it wasn't the same color. He knew that the black ones were the only Nomu that could regenerate. Izuku bared his teeth and summoned Dabi.

"Don't mind if I do!" He exclaimed, holding out one hand as blue flames erupted from his skin. He incinerated the Nomu in a second, and the charred monster fell like a sack of potatoes. Izuku turned around to watch as Shouta tried his best to calm both girls. He made his way over to them, as Shouta patted one of them on the back awkwardly.

They looked up as Izuku approached with Dabi in tow. The tallest girl broke out into a wide grin, her hair curling at the ends as she did so. "Thank you so much for saving us!"

She tackled him in a hug, and Izuku tried his best not to jump out of his skin. The contact was sudden, but the girl didn't cling to him for long. She pulled away and grabbed her sister's hand.

The other girl grinned too, but it was wobbly.

"Alright, let's get you guys out of here." Shouta grumbled, guiding them out of the flames and ruins. They were lucky enough to avoid all the Nomu as they made it to a safe part of the city, handing them off to paramedics and the police.

His father questioned the officers for a moment, trying to glean any information about the situation. An officer spoke up after Shouta asked him what the hell was going on. "They appeared out of nowhere, but we managed to secure the entire area. There are other heroes making sure the Nomu don't leave the area as we try to evacuate."

"Which heroes are on the scene?" Shouta asked, crossing his arms. "Are there policemen in the city trying to help with evacuations? Are there paramedics?"

The officer cleared his throat before speaking. “Endeavor, Ingenium, Dragon, Best Jeanist, Mt. Lady, Gran Torino, Manual, and their interns are in the city. Their sidekicks are there too, and there are probably more heroes that we just don’t know about. There are policemen inside the city as well as firefighters. We need to eliminate the Nomu and stop the fires before we can be sure that we’ve gotten everyone out.”

Seeming satisfied with the answer, Shouta turned back to Hosu.

“Let’s go back. There are more people to save and Nomu to destroy.” Shouta stated as they ventured back into the smoldering city. Izuku nodded and they threw themselves back into the thick of it.

Tomura watched the scene from his spot next to Kurogiri. The fires were blazing, burning through people and buildings alike. Tomura scratched the sensitive skin on his neck mercilessly. He watched as Nomu tore buildings apart and as Heroes downed all of them, one-by-one.

But Tomura had more Nomu. Flying Nomu, that he could use to pick off a few heroes and terrorize the country. They would lose faith in their so-called Heroes; and in the process, they could get that traitor back, alive and kicking. Just how Sensei wanted him.

He had already set the trap and laid down the bait. All he had to do now was wait for his plan to come to fruition. It wouldn’t be long now. He had placed *that* Nomu where Midoriya would have to fight it. He’d made sure of it.

Izuku Midoriya was going to be theirs, no matter the cost. Sensei had made sure of that by making sure their plan was foolproof. The only part he hadn’t understood was why they had to make him face the Nomu first. Wouldn’t it be easier if they just used a portal to teleport him into the League’s bar?

Tomura frowned. Wouldn’t it be easier if Midoriya died? Tomura really didn’t care if Midoriya made it back alive. Maybe… maybe he’d let the advanced Nomu tear him apart.

“Midoriya should be in range soon.” Kurogiri stated, readying himself to use his Quirk.

Hours of grueling work had passed, but Izuku was careful to conserve his energy. Nomu kept appearing as quickly as they destroyed them, but they didn’t stop. The flames raged and licked at them and Izuku was sweating profusely.

But they did get reports that the Nomu were on the verge of being eradicated. He and Shouta had saved plenty of people at this point, and mainly stuck to the side of the firefighters after a while to protect them from Nomu as they doused the fires and cleared buildings.

There seemed to be no end in sight as they picked their way through rubble and danced around the fire. There were plenty of people to save as they cleared block after block of the city. Izuku and Dabi had taken care of any Nomu in their path, but there were still so many to save.

One of the firefighters had a human detection Quirk, which was how they were able to discern whether or not a building was clear or not. Another firefighter had a weak strength augmentation Quirk, but he could lift things well enough so they could get to trapped civilians.

Izuku trudged on, wiping the sweat from his brow. Soon enough, all of this would be over, and he could sleep. Shouta patted him on the back. “You’re doing good, problem child. They said there shouldn’t be that many Nomu left. Endeavor, as much as I hate to admit, took care of a lot of them. Now, all that’s left is rescue efforts and to put out the fires.”

Izuku nodded, his eyes heavy with exhaustion. It was probably around one in the morning and he definitely hadn’t gotten enough sleep before this whole ordeal. He sighed and let his shoulders drop.

The firefighters cleared another set of buildings, and Izuku watched them wearily before he felt a chill run down his spine. Goosebumps blossomed along his arms and legs as his hair

stood on end.

Izuku glanced around worriedly before he tapped his father's shoulder hastily.

[Something's wrong—]

But he never even got the chance to finish his sentence before the ground beneath him yawned open and consumed him. A purple portal deposited him across the entire city in an instant where the fires raged even hotter than before. In fact, he was surrounded on all sides by raging, angry fire. He glanced around hastily, trying to gain his bearings. The world tilted, but he managed to stay up right as vertigo hit him.

Cars were flipped over and burning on all sides, and he seemed to be at a huge intersection. He was in the center of the attack and the sky was filled with flying Nomu. He scanned the rest of his surroundings, trying to discern where the hell he was in Hosu.

Shouta was nowhere to be found. And worst of all, the intersection he was trapped in wasn't empty. He wasn't alone.

Standing in the very center, was a Nomu bigger than the one at the U.S.J. but with the same black fur. It had *six* arms and long, jagged teeth. Its smile was deranged and broken and its brain was exposed much like the other Nomu. It was buff too, but something about it threw him through a loop.

In each hand, the monster had a katana; for a total of six swords. A red bandana was wrapped around its eyes with eye holes poked out of them. And a red scarf was wrapped around its throat. Just like Stain.

Izuku shuddered but drew his sword nonetheless. From above, he heard a high, ragged laugh. A laugh that could only come from Shigaraki. "Do you like it, Midoriya?! Say hello to Sensei's newest Nomu, Stain!"

Chapter End Notes

If you're interested, here's the discord invite!

Chapter 62

Chapter Summary

izuku fights Stain. I wonder how well that goes?

Chapter Notes

:))) there's an OP Midoriya Izuku tag for a reason and this chapter is why

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Backdraft couldn’t put all of the fires out. This particular fire—the one that almost covered an entire block—was impossible to control, and he could already feel himself start to sweat. Sirens blared like alarm bells all around and Nomu still terrorized the city; but all he could do was put out the fires. Hosu was lucky that he’d come here to visit some family members or he wouldn’t have been here to help.

He had finally reached the center of the attack— where all the fire was coming from—but no matter how much he tried, the fire didn’t relent. It didn’t matter how much water he doused on it, it wouldn’t go out. The best he could do was prevent it from spreading until more forces arrived.

Backdraft spewed more water onto the flames and scanned his surroundings uneasily. He couldn’t afford to have a Nomu sneak up on him. That would be bad for him, really bad. He wasn’t a power oriented hero in the slightest. He was definitely a rescue hero. His Quirk wasn’t suited for combat.

He peered through the curling, burning flames and paled. Within the inferno of flames—surrounded on all sides—was a monstrous Nomu unlike any he had seen. It was *massive* compared to the one he’d seen on television after the USJ Incident. It had six arms in total with a katana in each hand. The swords were already bloody and dripping red with it. Its teeth were so long and sharp that they stuck out of its mouth.

Its back was slightly curved forward and the monster readied all of his swords. “Do you like it, Midoriya?! Say hello to Sensei’s newest Nomu, Stain!” There was a ragged laugh and the voice spoke again, but Backdraft couldn’t tell from where. He was too focused on the monster within the flames and apparently the person who was stuck with it.

But who the hell is Sensei?

“Are you ready to fight your mentor for the second time?” There was another shrill laugh, devoid of any real joy and happiness. Mentally, Backdraft tried to remember where he’d heard the name Midoriya before. He could feel the familiarity itching at the back of his mind telling him he knew exactly who Midoriya was. But he couldn’t put a finger on it as he scanned the fire.

And then he laid eyes on him and it all seemed to click audibly in his brain. His sword—katana —was already out and black flames licked up the blade. His mess of green curls were sticking to his face thanks to sweat and he seemed worn out.

Midoriya was panting already and he brought a hand to wipe the sweat from his forehead. His grip on his katana was tight, and Backdraft’s eyes veered back to his face. His viridian eyes were bright with the fire, blazing with an emotion Backdraft had trouble naming. Those eyes were crackling with rage, Backdraft decided. Rage and fire. And so much guilt, so much. But his eyes never left the Nomu before him—apparently it was Stain?

Backdraft wanted to help but the flames raged, whipping and cracking as Backdraft watched the two instead of focusing on the flames that threatened to swallow Hosu if he did nothing.

The best he could do was radio someone about his current location and warn them about the fight. Maybe Endeavor could help.

He grabbed his radio and switched it to a channel he *hoped* that some heroes were on.

“Backdraft requesting backup. Midoriya Izuku is facing a dangerous Nomu, and I can’t reach him due to the fires. I repeat, Backdraft requesting backup.”

There was white noise for a moment, ripping through the sound of the roaring flames. The radio was silent for a few seconds and he was about to switch it when a voice crackled through.

"Where's your location?" Backdraft could recognize that voice anywhere. He'd met Eraserhead only once, but that one time had saved his life back when he'd first debuted and got caught in the crossfire of an attack.

Backdraft was quick to reply to him, repeating his location. "There are too many flames to get to him, he's trapped with the Nomu."

"What color is it? What does it look like?" Eraserhead asked, and he sounded out of breath. Was he running?

"It has black fur. It's *huge,* and it has six arms with a sword in each hand."

"Is there anyone else there?"

"Someone was talking to him, saying that they'd created this Nomu, and it was named Stain. Actually… I don't think it's just a name. I think it's *really* Stain the Hero Killer. But wasn't he dead? I don't know who's talking to him I can't see—"

"Thank you. I'm on my way. Focus on the fire, Backdraft."

"Alright."

Backdraft peered through the flames again, and there was another cruel laugh before the screech of swords clashing. Against his better judgement, he focused on the fire. He threw more water on it desperately. His body had begun to ache in every joint from Quirk Overuse.

He paid it no mind as he continued on, hoping the fire would be out by the time Eraserhead got there.

Swords clashed again, ringing loud even over the sound of the sirens in the distance. The Nomu groaned, the sound deep and slow, as it clicked its teeth. Backdraft peered through the fire again, worry eating at his gut.

The huge mouth yawned open and it groaned again, something in the back of its throat clicking sharply.

That's when Backdraft looked up, and what he saw made him gawk and pale.

There were Nomu in the sky. And once they had heard the clicking sound, they swept down and clawed at Midoriya, tearing his skin and costume before they flew back up.

"Eraserhead, we have a problem…" Backdraft radioed again. "There are Nomu in the sky, too."

The only reply he got was a loud curse on the other end.

Izuku's hand wrapped around his katana was shaking. His whole *world* was shaking, shuddering, and breaking. There seemed to be a chasm growing in his chest, tearing through his carefully crafted walls. Those words alone seemed to rip him apart, and open the yawning chasm within him that only seemed to get bigger with each tragedy he witnessed. His chest tightened with horror and his vision was blurred with silent tears.

Stain hadn't been dead. Not really. Not physically. And this Nomu was living proof of it, an abomination created by vicious human hands. He knew he probably shouldn't trust Shigaraki's words, but they held so much weight and truth to them. There was no way

Shigaraki would lie to him about something like this, just to mess with him. It was true. This Nomu standing before him was his former mentor Nomufied.

He felt frozen right down to his bones, even with fire surrounding him on all sides like an infernal cage. There was no heat where he stood, only cold ice-like dread. “Are you ready to fight your mentor for the second time?”

He wasn’t. He wouldn’t ever be ready to face Stain again, not after the first time. But it didn’t matter if he was *ready.* It was going to happen, right here, right now. The sirens sang through the air like a shrill scream. The fires around them crackled, leaving smoke curling up into the sky in its wake. There would be no escape from this unless he killed Stain again.

He swallowed the fear and sorrow that seized him in its iron-clad grip. He took a deep, shuddering breath. His hellflame licked at the blade and for good measure, he summoned Dabi. To finish off this monster he needed Dabi’s Cremation Quirk.

Those brilliant blue flames could incinerate anything it touched, and he definitely needed all the help he could get before help arrived. *If* it arrived.

A helicopter zoomed by, getting footage of the wreckage that was now Hosu city. A white spotlight whipped around the city, before coming to stop on Izuku and the Nomu. Izuku ignored it. Ignored how the helicopter got lower to catch some footage of their fight that hadn’t even begun yet.

With a single, calming breath, he was the one to rush forward. The Nomu groaned, and Shigaraki screeched out an order. “Stain, attack!”

Nomu Stain rushed to join him in the middle, not seeming to be bothered in the slightest by the raging flames surrounding them. Dabi followed through too, and blue flames burst from both of his palms in a display of deliciously beautiful power. That didn’t seem to faze him either, but Izuku wouldn’t relent. Stain’s six swords clashed against his own, but Izuku managed to block it successfully, even if his knees trembled from impact. The swords retreated and Stain swatted Dabi out of the air with his lower right arm.

The lower sword sliced clean through Dabi's form, and Dabi winked out of existence for now. Izuku grit his teeth and Stain came for him. All six swords went swinging and shivering through the air faster than Izuku could follow with his eyes.

But he let his instincts do the talking, as his blade connected with and parried six other blades that were hellbent on his destruction. He took a breath, jumping out of the fray for a moment. He needed to be faster. He needed to be quicker. He needed to be better, right now.

Holding his katana out defensively, he took a deep breath, willing his shaking to subside. He summoned some of his infernal power from down below and he picked up his pace as Stain collided with him in a shower of blades and malice. Stain moaned again, his mouth yawning open, his sharp teeth sticking out rather threateningly as a clicking sound issued from his throat.

Izuku pulled away hastily, wary of the call, but confused.

What is he doing?

And then he remembered the Nomu in the sky. He risked an experimental look upward, into the blackening sky. The Nomu swarmed down, caneering right into him to throw him off balance, or worse: pick him up and tear him apart in the air like he was roadkill or something. He blasted hellfire out his free hand, hoping that it would deter them.

It worked for the most part, the flames so cold they *felt* hot. Some of the Nomu retreated instantly, but some stayed. One of them grabbed onto his free arm and sliced through his flesh and bone with it's exponentially sharp claws. Izuku hissed through his mouth before slamming his blade right into its exposed brain. The monstrosity of a creature went limp and fell to the ground at Izuku's feet.

Izuku let his flames consume the rest that hadn't retreated, but Stain Nomu took the opportunity to catch him by surprise.

He grabbed Izuku's wounded arm with one of its many arms and threw him. Caught unaware, Izuku was sent flying directly into the flames surrounding them. But Stain Nomu was there in

a second, sword swinging, preventing him from falling. Izuku, though he was flying through the air, parried. The sheer force of steel meeting steel sent Izuku flying in the other direction, but he tumbled, rolling, before his back slammed into a slab of asphalt that had been sticking straight up.

Blood rushed up his throat and it splattered out of his mouth with a wet smack. His back was throbbing with pain, but he scrambled to his feet as Stain Nomu approached. He readied his sword, panting with the effort of even rising to his feet.

Stain's six swords shivered through the air and Izuku rolled out of the way entirely, popping up to his feet directly behind Stain. Izuku swung his katana down in a horizontal slash, putting all of his weight behind it. The skin sliced open, but Stain didn't bleed. He merely turned around, roaring, before swinging at him again and again, with a barrage of blades. They screamed through the air, and Izuku pivoted and side-stepped the first three, but not without one of the blades slicing his cheek.

His lower lip was trembling. His knees and back ached with every movement, with every dodge and sloppy parry. Fear curled in his gut like a snake, tightening and coiling like a spring. He couldn't fight Stain.

He was my mentor. I can't kill him again!

There was another round of groaning and clicking, as the two fought toe-to-toe, blade for blade. Dabi materialized instantly, yelling as he flew through the air. "I'll take care of the flying Nomu, just focus on Stain!"

I have to kill him again. For good, or people will die. I will die.

Izuku gave a curt nod and returned to the fight at hand, managing to block some of the swords that slashed their way towards him. One did manage to find it's home in his shoulder before Stain Nomu pulled it out. Blood splattered on the ground as Izuku stumbled back in shock. Sharp pain cut through his haze of thoughts.

The world came into sharp focus and he sucked in a breath. He pushed past the pain and coughed as he inhaled smoke. Stain's swords sliced through the air again, and Izuku's defense held solid as their blades sang against one another in a deadly tango of blades and blood.

He chewed the inside of his cheeks. Should he do it? Should he release more power? Was his current power level too little? Could he risk more?

He didn't get a chance to decide as more blades whipped past him in a frenzy. Though his body was aching and sweaty, he dodged deftly, stepping back. Their blades clashed in a shower of sparks, and Izuku was pushed back. Again. And again.

The spotlight from the helicopter above never left him. Not for a second, as Stain savagely continued the fight. He swung, Izuku parried, and sank his blade into Stain's muscular abdomen like a hot knife slicing through butter. He cut it clean through, and blood spewed like rain. Smoke stung at his eyes and the flames drew nearer and nearer. But the fight was far from over.

Stain, seemingly done with fighting with his swords, grabbed Izuku by the throat—or more accurately, by his Quirk Suppressant—and wings unfurled from behind him. Thick, leathery bat wings that Izuku hadn't noticed before.

And the ground beneath them was long gone as Stain's wings snapped into the air and took them to the skies. He could feel the chain starting to snap. With a silent gasp of terror, Stain's grasp slipped as his necklace broke. He only started to fall for a second before Stain grabbed him again, readjusting his grip to wrap around his throat. His massive hand encased his entire throat, jaw to shoulders. Nomu Stain squeezed, but not enough to snap his neck like he was definitely capable of. They soared higher and the wind whipped at his hair. Izuku, against his better judgement, looked down. The city was raging with flames still but not as much as before.

Few Nomu remained, but he watched with wide eyes as Endeavor dispatched one. At the center of the attack where they had just been, was a group of firefighters surrounding the ring of fire, trying to put it out.

He could barely see Shouta from here, but he was roaring in rage. Ingenium was holding him back as he reached *into* the flames, trying to get to him. Shouta's eyes went to the sky, and he seemed to go even paler.

He could hear him screaming from there as they soared even higher, and Izuku dropped his katana on accident. The blade disappeared in the billowing smoke and Izuku choked as his airflow was cut off completely. He wheezed, his eyes blowing wide with fear that exploded from his chest like a blazing fire. Izuku blasted fire in Stain's face but nothing came of it. Stain went higher, and the spotlight followed, much to Izuku's disdain. The news was capturing the *entire fight.*

Izuku was shaking right down to his bones and risked another look down as they ascended. He felt sick, he could feel his stomach doing backflips, and his head throbbed. Bile coated his mouth and tongue, and *God* he hoped he didn't throw up.

Right now was not a good time to throw up or piss himself. But he definitely wanted to. He'd never been up this high in his *life* . Sure, he'd been on top of buildings with Shouta beside him, but he'd never been higher than that. The city looked small and he choked as he tried to suck in a breath.

His vision was going black, but he tore at Stain's hand nonetheless. He didn't even flinch when Stain's sword cut through his shirt and cut open his chest. Blood flowed from the wound steadily, but he didn't care. He needed to focus on killing Stain before he focused on anything else. He vaguely noticed how the wound in Stain's stomach never healed. That meant that Stain didn't have a regenerative Quirk. If he could just grab one of his swords and cut his head off, he'd win.

But then what would he do when he fell?

Fuck, fuck, fuck! Think!

Stain heaved a sigh, before he let go. Completely.

With a scream that ripped through his throat, Izuku fell. The air whipped past him at an alarming rate, and he whirled around and around like a tumbling doll.

The city was coming up fast and Izuku couldn't fucking *stop!*

No, no, no, no—

His ankle snapped completely and his rapid, horrifying descent stopped short. Pain pulsed from his back, his shoulder, his chest, and now his foot. Izuku looked up. Stain had grabbed him by the foot and was hauling him up into the sky, *again.*

This time it was higher. Blood dripped from his wound in his chest, splattering on his face. He could feel it creeping up his neck and jaw in a steady stream. Hanging upside down was making his back ache, and he could barely keep his eyes open.

What time could it be now? Surely closer to the morning because last time he had checked, it was one in the morning. How many people were watching him bleed? Watching him fight? Watching him lose?

He plummeted again, and his throat went raw from his screaming. It was something in his thigh that snapped, rather loudly this time. Pain cut through him like a storm, radiating, pulsing, cracking, ripping. A low, tortured wail reached his ears, and he realized it was his own. His own agony projecting itself as an uncontrollable and involuntary wail that seemed to rip through the unending silence.

He panted, trying to desperately catch his breath. Blood coated half of his face as Stain brought him up higher still. He had gone limp, squeezing his eyes shut to block out the black sky. The smoke. The flames. The pain. The blood. His shrill, banshee-like screams.

His stomach dropped to his feet as he was dropped again. He snapped his eyes open terrified of what he found.

The flying Nomu from earlier had decided to attack everyone who was now trying to save him. He was falling again and this time, Stain Nomu didn't seem to care. He didn't swoop in and catch him. He fell. *And he kept falling.*

He had to think of something. *Anything* . He was going to fall head first into the asphalt if he did nothing. He was going to *die—*

I'm going to die. I'm going to die—

The ground was getting rapidly closer, and rapidly more dangerous.

He was—

There was a terrified, ear-splitting scream that didn't belong to him. It sent chills down his spine, like ice. Kacchan.

He spotted him with Ingenium, Iida, Shouta, and Dragon. Even Endeavor was there now, mowing down the last of the flying Nomu.

His costume looked worse for wear, but he didn't seem to be hurt. But his red eyes were locked on Izuku as he fell. For the final time.

I'm really going to die. Right here. On live television, before I could ever become a Hero—

And then he was caught again, and this time he was *certain* the crowd of Heroes heard his shrill wail of pain, as one of his ribs snapped. *"God damn it, someone fucking help him!"*

He had to make this stop. In reality, if this kept up, he would be nothing but a bag of broken bones and skin. He needed to think of a way out. He needed to find a way to get rid of the Nomu, but not fall to his death in the process.

Stain's hand wrapped around his torso, aggravating his pre-existing wounds. He shuddered out a gasp and Stain grabbed him by the throat again, switching hands. Izuku needed to *think.* But he could barely keep his eyes open. He could hardly breathe. How could he catch himself? How could he kill Stain? What was he going to do?

And then he remembered, eyes widening at the realization: one, his necklace was gone, shattered to pieces; two, when he'd been trapped in that strange place—he refused to think that he actually went to hell, it just didn't make sense to him—he'd come back from the dead with *wings* .

Maybe he could manifest them here? Again?

There wasn't really any other option. There was no backup plan, or a plan in general. He needed to do this, or die trying. He needed to master his Quirk before he could get stronger. *All* aspects of it. He needed to accept it all, and right now, he was willing to. *Dying to.*

Izuku squeezed his eyes shut, imagining the image of himself. Not the half-assed demon-esque of himself. No. The version of himself he knew deep down he was supposed to look like. The curling horns. The heavy crown. The black, feathery wings that were longer than his entire arm. He felt the pain in his head first, like a throbbing migraine, and the stinging of his eyes as they transformed.

His shoulder blades snapped with pain and his head was heavy. His back was heavy. His eyes snapped open, just as the sun was cusping over the horizon. He didn't look down. He didn't acknowledge his bleeding, aching body. His hero costume was torn to shreds, destroyed by Stains attacks.

The clang of a single chain pulling taunt in his desperation to escape—

His black wings unfurled and demons poured from the circles in his hands. He felt strangely at peace. He felt no fear, no disgust. He smiled widely, his teeth sharp and dyed red from his own blood.

Izuku pulled on the monsters streaming from his hands, pulling in their energy until they disappeared. Their power burned beneath his skin. Like hellfire.

He let it build and boil before he grabbed Stain's wrist. He crushed it, like it was nothing. But the power was building, building, building. And it had to go *somewhere.*

Izuku wasn't ready for this. He wasn't strong enough to handle this scale of power yet. He shouldn't be doing this. His control slipped just enough.

An unearthly growl rumbled through the air, coming from him involuntarily. His wings moved on their own and his hands ripped through Stain like he was made of paper. Blood splattered and Izuku heard himself laughing. Stain's hand was no longer wrapped around his throat. Stain didn't even have *any hands.*

He had no control.

His heart pounded in his chest like a wardrum.

I'm not in control. I'm not in control. I'm not in control—Oh God, oh God.

And they were falling as the sun set them on fire. Izuku's black flames sprouted from seemingly nowhere, encasing them in a cocoon of blackness. It burned through Stain's skin and Izuku wrapped his hand around Stain's neck against his will as his other one covered his own face, ripping open the skin.

Fuck. Fuck!

Izuku's face contorted into an expression that was wicked and cruel. Against his will, it twisted and twisted into a look of cold glee that only an ugly monster could pull off.

I need to get control.

There was nothing to grab onto, nothing to reel in. There was just power. Pouring out of him like a flood. They plummeted through the air at breakneck speed, and all Izuku could do was *watch* .

The ground was getting closer. The flames and Nomu were gone. The Heroes were gawking and silent. That infernal helicopter was still filming. The ground was coming up fast—

Too fast—

Too fucking fast—

"I-Izuku…" Stain ground out, pathetically, and Izuku felt his entire body lurch with self-hatred. His hands burned with the black, licking fire. Burning, burning, burning."K-K-K-Kill me,"

No, no, no, no, no, no. Not again. NOT AGAIN.

He snapped into control, desperately, reeling in everything at once, his horns, his crown, his entire transformation except for the wings—

He pulled it all in, in a single second. *I can't! I can't kill him again. Please. Please!*

It all happened so fast. He couldn't stop it. The world shattered around them. There was nothing he could do to stop it. Stain slammed into the ground first and the ground crumbled. It cracked and groaned. A crater had formed from the impact, and Izuku took a shaky, horrified step back. He wasn't sure how he was standing, with how his ankle and femur were broken. He wasn't sure how he was even hyperventilating, with a broken rib or two. His wings twitched and curled in slightly.

He did that. He did that. He didn't stop it. He did it again. He killed Stain again. He murdered someone. On live television. He didn't stop it. He didn't stop it. He didn't stop it. He didn't stop it. He didn't stop it.

My fault. My fault. My fault. My fault. My fault. I killed him. I killed him. I killed him. I'm a murderer. I should just die. This is my fault. It's always my fault. I did this. Fuck. Fuck. Fuck. Fuck—

He couldn't take his eyes off the limp form of Stain. His hands were missing, and there was a gaping hole in his gut where his flesh had been. Izuku could peer through it like a window, and Izuku couldn't stop the vomit— *no blood* —from spilling from his lips.

I lost control and did this.

"Someone go get Recovery Girl!"

I killed him.

It was like he was back in Chizome-san's apartment. Curling in on himself, covered in his blood. Sobbing.

A shrill laugh, cruel and cold cut through the haze. "Now you've killed Stain twice!" Shigaraki screeched, and Izuku tore his eyes from his mentor's corpse to look up at the building in front of him. Shigaraki stood there, arms open wide, a hand covering his face. His eyes glinted with malice and anger. He didn't sound happy.

"How does it feel?!"

I should just die.

"Kurogiri grab him."

I should just die.

“We can’t.” Kurogiri replied coolly, but he didn’t look sad about it in the slightest. “Do you not see the countless Heroes down there with him? We’ve gotten orders to retreat.”

I should just die.

Izuku watched numbly as Kurogiri summoned a portal and dragged Shigaraki through it. He was screaming, ripping at his skin as he fought, but Kurogiri’s grip was firm.

“You stupid brat! We were supposed to bring you back! We were supposed to snatch you right under the Heroes' noses! *Fuck!* Sensei’s not going to be happy!”

With one final tug from Kurogiri, Shigaraki was sucked into the portal and it disappeared before anyone could get to them. Izuku looked back at the corpse before falling to his knees. His wings were heavy and he couldn’t stand for a second longer. He couldn’t tear his eyes away from his mentor and the beast they’d made him into.

Stain didn’t get up. He didn’t move, didn’t breathe. And Izuku didn’t know why *he* was. Why wasn’t he the one laying limp on the ground? Why did he need to survive? Why didn’t he just want to die?

He should. He was horrible. He was a terrible person. He just let himself lose control and slaughtered Stain. He couldn’t bring his hands to cover his face. He couldn’t tear his eyes away.

A sob wracked his body, aggravating his bleeding wounds. Ugly, fat tears rolled down his cheeks but he didn’t wipe them away. He killed Stain. For good this time. There was nothing to revive. There wasn’t anything he could do.

There were arms around him, but he just stared blankly, numbly, at the dead Nomu before him. He was a terrible person. He—he—

“Look at me.”

He couldn’t look away from Stain. He couldn’t.

“Please look at me.”

How could he, when Stain’s lifeless body was right *there?* He stared at it for a moment longer before something in Stain’s pocket glinted in the growing sunlight. With shaking hands, he took the object only to realize it was Stain’s limited edition lighter. From so long ago.

He gripped it tightly in his hands. Everything was silent for too long.

“Izuku…” It was Kacchan. Kacchan’s arms. Kacchan’s voice. Kacchan. “I need you to look at me.”

It would tear him apart, to look away. It would be his undoing. He couldn’t, he physically couldn’t. A pair of hands cupped his face and forced his eyes away. His vision was full of nothing except for Kacchan’s face. His red eyes that were streaming with tears of his own. His jaw, sharp and rugged. His hair, that looked even more unruly than usual. His lips, red from his never-ending nervous chewing. He always chewed on his lips when he was nervous. Izuku’s whole body shuddered with another sob that broke from his lips. “Izuku look at me.”

It was a pathetic sound. He looked the boy in the eyes. He blinked away his tears, only for more to form.

“Look at me. Don’t look at anything else.”

Chapter End Notes

If you're interested, here's the discord invite!

Chapter 63

Chapter Summary

Dadzawa and Izuku in the hospital vibing c:

Chapter Notes

Enjoy >:UUUUU

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku didn't exactly remember falling asleep. He didn't remember ever leaving Stain's Nomufied corpse in Hosu city. The last thing he seemed to remember was staring at the corpse, refusing to look away. His heart had metaphorically been ripped out of his chest, still beating and bleeding. His hands had been unsteady and warm with Stain's sticky, thick blood. His sword was somewhere on the ground near him, and his costume had been in shreds.

He had been broken and bleeding on the asphalt after tearing Stain apart. He had gone to his knees, eyes wet, heart dead in his chest and hollow with sorrow. Izuku was sitting there, empty and cold, despite the burning of his skin and hands. Despite the burn of pain that had ripped through every bone in his body. Stain's lighter was clutched in his hands tightly.

And then there had been Kacchan, his hands firm, warm, and calloused. His sharp, intelligent, red eyes that broke through his walls like a sledgehammer. His cutting jaw, that he placed his burning hands on, as soon as Kacchan forced him to break his endless, empty stare. He was the burning beacon in the sea of cold nothingness. An explosion of air that he had desperately needed.

That's all he remembered.

But when he awoke, he wasn't in the hospital.

It was dark and hot.

He was screaming. The voices reached their crescendo, like nails against a chalkboard. The last chain remained firmly in place.

The darkness pressed in on him from all sides and he pulled uselessly at the chain. His wrist burned and ached each time, but he was desperate to escape.

The chain remained in place, and so did Izuku. His hands burned. Izuku needed to get out of here, he realized. Before he lost himself here, like the last time.

There was a blue flame in the distance. He reached for it with trembling hands, before he woke up.

“Ah, you’re finally awake!” A nurse said as Izuku blinked rapidly, feeling light-headed as he looked around. The woman smiled warmly at him and glanced down at her clipboard. “Are you feeling okay? You broke a number of bones, pulled some muscles, and passed out after Recovery Girl healed your wounds, but that was to be expected…”

Izuku glanced around the room again, realizing he was alone. His room was empty, save for her. His heart monitor started to beat a little faster. She noticed it.

“Your dads and your friend went to one of the vending machines a few minutes ago,” She explained calmly, “They should be right back, Midoriya.”

But he couldn’t breathe. He couldn’t force air through his lungs. Why was he shaking? What was that loud beeping noise? Fuck.

Izuku grabbed the face mask over his mouth and nose and pulled it off, annoyed. He pushed himself to a sitting position and the nurse watched him nervously.

His back felt heavy. A single glance over his shoulder revealed that the wings had remained. They unfurled behind him, and the nurse was suddenly sputtering unintelligibly for a moment before she composed herself. Izuku struggled to breathe.

“Midoriya you’re going to be fine, they’ll be right back,” The nurse began, her voice wobbling with worry.

He didn’t want to be alone right now. For some reason, he just couldn’t breathe. He wanted to find them himself. He wanted to be with Kacchan or Dabi.

And as if summoned, Shouta, Hizashi and Kacchan appeared in the doorway. All three of them looked utterly exhausted. Izuku sucked in a deep breath, looking down at his thick bandages around his hands. “Oh thank God!” The nurse exclaimed with a relieved breath. “I thought he was going to pass out.”

His chest heaved with air and Izuku put his head in his hands. His body ached and he was freezing. Compared to the darkness he’d been trapped in again, this hospital was freezing cold. He stared numbly at his bandaged hands.

He’d killed *Stain. Again.*

“You’re okay,” Kacchan said softly, placing a hand on his shoulder. “You’re okay now.”

Izuku’s head snapped up and Kacchan smiled at him slightly. It didn’t quite look like a smile —more like a smirk—but Izuku would take what he could get with him. Izuku took his hand instantly, his icy fingers curling around Kacchan’s eternally warm ones. The other boy let it happen, cringing only slightly when he felt how cold Izuku was.

“Damn! You’re freezing!” Kacchan remarked, tightening his hold on Izuku’s hands. Kacchan pulled his chair closer and frowned at him. “You should’ve told us you were cold.”

“You’re holding his hands,” Shouta pointed out. “He can't sign anything.”

The nurse smiled again. “I’ll grab him a few more blankets and tell the doctor he’s awake.” She disappeared with a smile and Shouta sighed heavily.

“Are you okay, kid?” Shouta asked, his brow furrowed in concern. Izuku nodded, hiding his eyes behind his bangs. “That was a dumb question. Of course, you aren’t.”

Hizashi reached over to ruffle his curly hair and for once, Izuku didn’t feel like stiffening. “You’ll be okay soon, though.”

Izuku pursed his lips together, looking away. The nurse returned with some blankets and with the doctor.

The doctor smiled at all of them while the nurse put more blankets over Izuku.

“I have a bit to cover,” The man began, his voice muffled behind his mask. “First, I'd like to address all of your injuries and how long you’ll need to recover fully. You broke your ankle, shin, femur, and a couple of your ribs from your fight with the Nomu. There were stab injuries too, but they won’t scar and Recovery Girl healed them. In fact, you should heal completely in a few weeks without the need of Recovery Girl’s Quirk. But if you’d like to go back to class quicker, you can get healed again later when you’re dispatched.”

“When *will* he be dispatched?” Shouta asked.

“Tomorrow,” The doctor said, pointing with a pen to Izuku’s hands that were grasped in Kacchan’s hands still. Kacchan didn’t make a move to pull away. “There were concerning black burns on your hands. I wanted to make sure they healed alright.”

He furrowed his brow in confusion. “And there are similar black marks along your body as well. Almost like tattoos.”

This Izuku could confirm, but at the time—all those weeks ago—he hadn’t had an explanation for them. Now he did, and it would also explain the black burns on his hands. It was a side-effect of a *real* transformation.

He’d have to ask Dabi to confirm, but he was *certain* that it was the cause. He told the doctor exactly that through sign language. The man nodded shortly and scribbled something down on his notepad.

Izuku tried not to squirm at the awkwardness permeating the air. After a moment, he snapped his notepad closed. Izuku couldn’t see his facial expression behind the mask, which was a little disconcerting.

“Alright,” He said, and Izuku could hear the smile in his voice. “I’ll leave you to get some more rest, Midoriya-kun.”

He turned on his heel and left, the nurse following suit. But not before she flashed him a blinding, reassuring smile. Izuku couldn’t bring himself to return it.

Izuku didn’t even remember falling asleep, but it must’ve been from the number of medications being pumped through his veins.

The blue flame got brighter as Dabi reached him. He crouched down to meet Izuku’s eyes and smiled softly. Izuku had never been more relieved to see him in his entire life.

“You need to wake up,” Dabi said simply, cutting off the rising screams ricocheting around them. “It’s too early for you.”

Izuku looked up at him. With the help of his brilliant blue flames, he chased away The Darkness all around him. The rapid pitter-patter of Izuku's heart seemed to calm down almost as soon as Dabi had appeared.

He always chased away the dark shadows whenever Kacchan wasn't there. However, he furrowed his brow in confusion.

Wake up? What does he mean by that?

"You need to wake up," He said again, firmer this time. But Izuku didn't know what he was talking about. This place wasn't a dream, it was a prison.

"You need to wake up."

It wasn't Dabi.

It wasn't Dabi.

His face morphed. It melted, leaving nothing behind but the familiar dark silhouette of any other demon. Its smile was too wide, and something dripped from its lips in lazy ropes.

The blue fire was gone. With its disguise shed like snake-skin, it grabbed Izuku by the throat.
"Wake up."

Its long, thin claws dug into the soft flesh of his throat and he could feel it burn. And God, did it *hurt* .

His muscles seized up suddenly, pain flashing in waves of heat against his skin. Something warm dripped from his neck, and he found that he couldn't breathe.

With his free hand, he grabbed the monster's wrist and tried to pull it away. Izuku yanked and pulled, but the Demon's strength was too much. And Izuku was too tired.

Black spots popped up in his vision as he tried to suck in a breath. His lungs ached in his chest. Sharp stabbing pains sparked along his chest and neck.

He couldn't even scream. He couldn't fight back with just one hand. Izuku thrashed in silent agony and the Demon didn't relent. Izuku dug his nails into the freezing flesh of the monster, but it didn't seem to notice at all.

Izuku could feel himself slipping away as tears sprung to his eyes. He blinked them away. With a scream trapped in his throat, the darkness slipped away.

It was dark when he woke up. The lights in his hospital room had been turned off, but Izuku still couldn't breathe. His neck and throat burned, and it still felt like someone was choking him to death.

Fear crawled down his spine.

"Izuku?"

He still couldn't breathe. His heart monitor was beeping rapidly, yet there were no doctors rushing into the room. Suddenly, there was someone standing by him, holding his bandaged hand.

"Izuku?" Shouta whispered, like he was trying not to scare him. "What's wrong? Are you okay?"

The pressure around his neck finally released and Izuku sucked in a much-needed breath of air. He shot up into a sitting position, clutching his neck as sweat dripped down his chin.

Slowly, his heart monitor slowed and his oxygen levels regulated on the tiny screen. There was a beat of silence where Shouta said nothing. He was just rubbing calming circles into his back until Izuku pulled his hand away from his throat.

“What happened?” He asked, softly. Izuku turned to him and he went pale instantly. His next words were dripping with concern. “Izuku, what happened to your neck?”

He shook his head, refusing to say anything. He was fine now. It was fine. He wasn’t trapped in that dream with that *demon* who pretended to be Dabi.

But Shouta wasn’t having any of that, as Izuku tried to calm himself down even further.

“Izuku,” He said firmly, “Tell me what the hell just happened.”

[Nothing.] He managed to sign, but Shouta looked skeptical. [I’m fine.]

“You’re bleeding,” Shouta shot back. “And there are bruises around your entire neck that weren’t there before.”

Izuku clutched his white, sterile bed sheets and shook his head vehemently. He wasn’t about to tell Shouta that he’d been dreaming. That he got attacked by his own Quirk. That the aftermath transferred over to the real, waking world.

But that hadn’t been any ordinary dream, either. The Darkness was a strange place, he began to realize. He sighed heavily. Maybe it was due to all of his recent stress, with the Sports Festival, Hosu, and now this.

He broke down in tears. His shoulders shook and he looked at Shouta helplessly as he sobbed. Shouta seemed shocked to say the least, and confusion flashed across his features before his face softened a second later.

He wrapped his arms around Izuku's shoulders and pulled him close. "I'm sorry," Shouta breathed, sounding like he was in agony. "I'm so sorry you had to face Stain again."

I know he was like a father to you, went unsaid. Izuku buried his face into Shouta's chest and cried. They stayed that way for a long time before Shouta pulled away.

He grabbed Izuku's shoulder gently, and spoke. "Can you tell me what happened?"

He gestured to Izuku's throat, which was marred with bruises and scabbed over crescent moon cuts. Izuku took a deep breath, if only to calm himself. For all he knew, The Darkness could be nothing but a figment of his imagination.

Merely a nightmare that he'd created to cope with the trauma of the Sports Festival. Or at least, he hoped it was the case.

But it wouldn't explain why or how he resurrected. During the Sports Festival, he had broken one of the chains and found himself back in the forest. He had been healed for the most part. And it wouldn't explain how he got all the bruises on his neck.

So it couldn't be a dream. It had to be real, but that didn't mean that he wanted to tell Shouta about it. He didn't want to tell *anyone.*

He hated the dark. He hated the screaming, and he hated the heat. He hated being trapped. Izuku didn't want to talk about it at all, but Shouta was watching him carefully.

He couldn't very well lie to him or refuse to tell him. Shouta would find a way to get it out of him eventually. Izuku sighed heavily before raising his hands to sign.

[During the Sports Festival I —]

His hands were shaking. Izuku hated remembering the Sports Festival and how useless he'd been. He was so terrified of the dark, and even trying to tell him about that Darkness set off his lifetime fear of it. There was no escaping how his throat seemed to close up in fear or how sweat beaded on his eyebrow.

There was no ignoring it either, for Shouta it seemed. He rubbed comforting circles into his back. And at some point, he'd climbed into Izuku's bed with him. They were sitting side by side.

"Take your time," Shouta told him in that usual, I'm-always-here-for-you tone. He could remember the burning sensation in his throat from the Holy Water that had been forced down his throat like acid. Izuku pushed those thoughts away hastily.

He took Shouta's words to heart and looked around his hospital room to ground himself.

There were papers sitting at a tiny table next to his bed, and on that table was probably their work from class that Shouta was finally getting around to grading.

His capture weapon and goggles were resting atop the pile of papers, forgotten when Izuku had woken up. But in all this, Hizashi seemed to be absent. Shouta seemed to realize that's where his mind had gone.

"Hizashi had to get up early in the morning for his radio show," He explained, never ceasing in his comforting circles that he was drawing on Izuku's back. "Would you like to listen while we talk?"

Izuku took a glance at the clock sitting near his bed. Hizashi's morning radio show began around five a.m. which would mean…

6:00 a.m.

He turned to Shouta and gave him an eager nod. His father smiled and pulled up the radio station on his phone. He set his phone on a low volume and Hizashi's excitable words turned into soft background noise.

"Hey Present Mic, what's it like teaching at U.A.?"

[I woke up there again.]

He paused, trying to find a way to word this that didn't make him out to be insane. Present Mic's response to the question over the radio was soft as he tried to think it over for a moment.

"I love teaching kids! They're little hatchlings for now. But one day, each and every one of my students are going to be Pro Heroes. I can't wait to see that."

[That place I went to after The Priest killed me. I was trapped again.]

"Again?"

He didn't look at Shouta, not yet. He decided to backtrack and explain.

[The first time I was there, there were chains. I tried pulling on them to get free but nothing worked. I sat in the dark until I heard something.] He looked up at Shouta as he signed this. [It was you.]

Something gentle encompassed Shouta's features. Something warm. [I didn't want to be stuck there anymore so I just… I used my Quirk to break one of the chains. After that, I just woke up. I didn't get enough time to break the other one. I've been dreaming about it every night. Sometimes, I can't tell the nightmares apart from the real thing.]

He brought his hand up to brush along the bruise on his neck. As insignificant as this event might've been in the grand scheme of everything he'd been through, it was one of the only mysteries he couldn't quite figure out. And he was *terrified* of that place.

His dreams were getting more and more vivid. More dangerous. And his fear of the dark seemed to increase every night. He couldn't shake it away, no matter how hard he tried.

Shouta was silent throughout all of this. Izuku continued on, albeit reluctantly.

[Tonight I dreamt about it again, but I wasn't alone.] He clenches his jaw, ignoring the festering fear in his gut. [There was a monster there, telling me to wake up. He did this to me.]

Shouta's eyes flash with concern. *"What?"*

[He said it was too early for me to be there.] He explained quickly. Now that he'd had plenty of time to calm down, it seemed that the monster had gone there to make him come back. He shouldn't have gone there in the first place, but he'd somehow ended up there. [I'm not sure what it means.]

He pauses. For the umpteenth time.

[I call this place The Darkness.]

Chapter End Notes

If you're interested, here's the discord invite!

Chapter 64

Chapter Notes

> Sorry this is late in the day (it was supposed to be posted at 10am but its 8pm that's totally my fault lol) NOT GONNA LIE I WAS THINKING OF D.GRAY-MAN YULLEN ONE SHOT PROMPTS TOO SOOOOO >:DDD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shouta didn’t sleep at all, but it was worth it in the end. It was always going to be worth it for Izuku. They stayed up after Shouta listened to everything Izuku had explained.

He wasn’t sure how he felt about The Darkness and how it could be affecting his kid. But he did know one thing: if he ever saw the demon who decided to *strangle* his kid, then he wouldn’t hesitate to kill it.

And he was pissed that he couldn’t prevent it from happening, if Izuku got trapped there again. He just vowed to be there for him during his waking hours, where he could chase away his demons—physical ones and mental ones alike—and fears.

Because that’s what parents did. They protected their children no matter what. Through thick and thin. And he was going to be the best possible parent for his child. Maybe he should buy more nightlights? Yeah. That always made the kid really happy.

He glanced at the kid in question. He had the smallest of smiles playing on his face as he watched the movie play on the TV screen.

Earlier in the morning, he turned on a Disney movie for Izuku while he finished grading papers because Hizashi’s shift at his radio show had long ended.

Izuku seemed enraptured with Frozen and Frozen 2. It was adorable. He seemed to empathize with Elsa and her struggle to gain control of her power.

Shouta returned his attention to the homework in front of him. Shinsou's homework, which he'd completely bombed. Maybe he should ask him if he needed extra tutoring with Midnight?

That could always be an option.

He sighed heavily before glancing at the paper at the bottom of his other stack of homework. The adoption forms were tragically empty, but the implications were there. He glanced at the boy he already considered his child.

Hopefully one day soon, he'd officially be his son within the eyes of the Government. Shouta couldn't help but smile at the thought.

He lazily worked his way through each piece of submitted homework until the door to Izuku's room opened very suddenly.

"Hello, little listener!" Hizashi exclaimed with a four slot cardboard cup holder in hand, his eyes finding Izuku instantly. There were two steaming cups of coffee and two iced teas. "How are you doing?"

Izuku smiled brightly and it made Shouta's heart tug and his chest fill with parental warmth. [Good, Dad's watching movies with me.]

"Awww, Shouta!" Hizashi squealed, hopping around slightly before remembering that he was holding drinks. "Oh yeah!"

He took the coffee out of the holder and held it out to Shouta. "Here you go," And then he turned to Izuku and handed him one of the iced tea drinks. "It's peach tea."

Izuku took the drink gratefully and began to drink it.

Shouta raised an eyebrow at Hizashi as he took a sip from his own tea. “What’s the other cup of coffee for?”

“That would be me,” Detective Tsukauchi said, walking through the doorway while rubbing the back of his neck in an abashed way. “He spotted me on my way here and asked if I’d like some… I couldn’t resist.”

“Here you are,” Hizashi said, handing off the said drink to the Detective.

“I’m assuming you’re here to get Izuku’s version of the Hosu Incident?” He asked, taking a long sip from his own drink.

The Detective nodded, “Yes, and it won’t take too long. Is that okay?” He turned to Izuku and Izuku nodded in response.

Tsukauchi took out his notepad and sat down on one of the vacant guest chairs. “Before I begin, how are you doing after getting attacked by Stain?”

[Good, the doctors here have really nice healing Quirks.]

Shouta translated easily for him, and Tsukauchi’s smile was warm and relieved.

“I’m happy to hear that, Midoriya,” He replied, “Now, I only have a handful of questions for you if that’s alright?”

Izuku nodded again, and Tsukauchi began.

“The Nomu you battled was, in fact, Stain?” Tsukauchi asked softly, his voice tinged with sorrow. He could remember the interrogation he’d done and that Stain was his mentor.

[Yes.]

That sign, Tsukauchi seemed to recognize, it seemed, as he wrote something down before continuing.

“I’ve gotten a lot of eye witness reports that Shigaraki and Kurogiri were present during the attack. I’ve also heard that they were planning on abducting you. Do you have any idea why they wouldn’t have done it as soon as they warped you to the center of the attack?”

[They probably wanted me to fight Stain. I don’t think they accounted for my winning, though. By the time they had a chance to take me, the Heroes had arrived.]

“I see,” He mumbled after Shouta translated again. “One last question. Are you excited for your finals?”

Izuku let out a groan and covered his face with one hand. Hizashi laughed heartily, and Tsukauchi chuckled.

Shouta suppressed a smile.

Kacchan visited before the doctors allowed him to go home. He brought sweets and soft smirks and the smell of nitroglycerin. A familiar, welcomed combination.

Katsuki had visited Izuku in the hospital a few hours before he got discharged the next day. The wings—which were soft to the touch, Katsuki noticed—had stayed. Aizawa-sensei theorized that it was because Izuku had a new amount of control over his Quirk.

Katsuki didn't mind how they'd come to stay and he wasn't complaining. They'd be useful as a Hero and they made him look flashier than before. They somehow fit him, too. He'd sent a picture in the groupchat after a while of those stupid extras begging. The groupchat had been made by fucking Glasses after the entire Hosu incident so they could keep in touch.

Katsuki fucking hated every second of the bullshit, but the spam had been too much for him at the time so he caved and snapped a picture. The fucking extras were still talking about it even as he headed to the dorms.

Pokéboy: Dude do you have any other pictures of Midoriya??? I think I'm in love.

Control_Freak: Do you want Bakugou to blow you up? I don't even think you should be in this chat after what you said.

Pokéboy: No, but I want to see!

EXPLODO-BOY: I'LL BLOW YOUR DAMN HEAD OFF YOU MOTHERFUCKER.

Alien Queen: But Mido is so super adorable!

GravityGirl: Yeah! Yeah! I want another picture

EXPLODO-BOY: He went home already.

Fast_boi: Will he be returning to school tomorrow? The teachers will be telling us about our practical final exams soon, though I have heard it will probably be robots! We should probably do a study session for our written portions. We could have it in the dorms and invite Midoriya-kun!

Control_Freak: Oh god I totally forgot about our fucking exams, I'm going to fail. Goodbye everyone. High School was good while it lasted.

EXPLODO-BOY added Izuku Midoriya to the Class 1-A group chat.

Tapearms: Oh god, we forgot to add him, didn't we?!?!

God (Yaomomo): No. None of us added him because only Bakugou-kun has his phone number. He refused to add him until he was out of the hospital. How are you doing Midoriya?

GravityGirl: I heard they turned Stain into a Nomu and you destroyed it! SO COOL!

Pokéboy: BRUH I THOUGHT YOU WERE GONNA SPLAT ON THE PAVEMENT.

Izuku Midoriya: Hi this is Dabi, he's too nervous to talk. > _ >

GravityGirl: Proof.

Izuku Midoriya: Dabi.jpg

Tapearms: Ok I believe you

God (Yaomomo): You don't have to be nervous Midoriya!

Tsuyu: Yeah, kero. We don't bite

Izuku Midoriya: So why was he added to the group chat?

Fast_boi: We wanted to know if he'd join us in the dorm after school tomorrow to study.

Izuku Midoriya: He asked if Kacchan will be there to study too

EXPLODO-BOY: FUCKING FINE. I WILL. WHATEVER.

Izuku Midoriya: Bet. He'll go, i'm going back to hell. Gn.

Pokéboy: Is he being serious?

Control_Freak: Bro I think he is

Katsuki grumbled in annoyance as he finally made it to the Yuuei entrance. The sun was beginning to set as he walked in yawning. Izuku had looked much calmer than yesterday. He even smiled at him when Katsuki handed him a few snacks his mom had made him get.

His mom had been worried ever since Aizawa "adopted" him. And one of these days, he wouldn't be surprised if she figured out where he lived and showered him with hugs.

Katsuki went ahead and sent the picture of Izuku to her and swung open the door to the dorms. They had moved into the dorms after the entire Sports Festival Incident ended, but no one said anything about Izuku joining them. But there *was* a room left empty for him.

He was met with shrieking chatter and loud laughter as everyone made dinner. He scowled.

“Welcome back, Bakubro! How was Midoriya?” Kirishima asked, looking rather curious. “I saw the fight on the news, it was *insane* !”

Tch.

“Deku’s gonna be fine,” Katsuki told him, shoving his hands into his pockets.

Physically he’s fine, but I don’t know about mentally.

It worried him.

His dreams were strange. They were haunted.

He recognized the cold, dark blackness of his room. He fisted his hands in his sheets, twisting them around his fingers, feeling the rough, overused fabric between his fingers. The floor creaked just above him, and he tore at the soft flesh of his lips with his teeth until he tasted iron.

He could see the monsters shifting within the darkness, reaching for him. Their claws passed through him, but they didn’t relent. The black hands, with wicked smiles and rotting flesh between their teeth, kept trying to drag him. Drag him down. Deep, deep down.

Izuku was frozen on his bed, twisting the fabric, his eyes wet and tears freezing as they fell from his face. The fear had him in its vice grip, and his shaking didn’t stop.

The floor above him creaked again and neared his bedroom door.

“Izuku?” the voice called, sickly sweet and kind. Mother’s voice. “Come up here.”

His limbs felt frozen, the ice crunching in his joints as he tumbled out of his bed hastily. It was terror that drove him to shove the demons away from him as they reached for him. He went up the stairs two at a time and arriver at the door.

He stopped short, sweat trickling down his brow as he stared at the doorknob. Mother lay waiting on the other side, and who knew what she would do to him…

With trembling hands, he tugged on the hem of his shirt. He had to go out there. Mother wouldn’t be happy if he kept her waiting. She wouldn’t be happy if she had to wait on her worthless, useless, broken son. With a shuddering breath, he opened the door and closed it behind him as he left his room. Mother crossed her arms.

“Well? What do you have to say for yourself?” She snarled, lunging forward to grab a handful of his curly hair. She tugged on it harshly and Izuku went limp. “Huh? What do you have to say?”

He looked at her belatedly in confusion. He opened his mouth to ask her what she meant, but nothing came out. Nothing ever came out when he tried to speak. Not, “I’m sorry mom!” or “What did I do wrong?”

He didn’t speak. Inko growled, seemingly angry that she got no answer. Izuku tugged on her wrist, desperate to be free of her grasp. “Stop struggling, Izuku!”

He didn’t want to, but his body just stopped moving. Stopped resisting, even though he wanted to run.

She dragged him to the kitchen and tugged on his hair again to force him to look at her in the eyes. Izuku’s jaw dropped in utter horror when he noticed something that he hadn’t seen before. It probably hadn’t even been there in the first place, but once he saw it, he couldn’t unsee it.

Every muscle in her face was pulled taunt as she smiled. It was a smile that didn't fit her face. As in, it was too big. Her lips were pulled tight and stretched over her face, and her teeth were sharp. Her eyes were dark, almost black, as she looked at him, her smile taking up half of her face. ***"Turn around."***

She didn't sound human and her mouth didn't even move when she spoke. She didn't blink. Izuku, terrified, turned around.

Suddenly, there was weight on his back, a familiar weight. His wings. There was the sound of a knife being pulled out and Izuku sucked in a sharp breath. He tried to turn around, but it was like he was paralyzed.

He couldn't move as his mother came back to him, now wielding a weapon. The pain exploded like fire in his back as he heard the sound of the delicate, hollow bones in his wings snapping and splintering. A scream got caught in his throat as his mother—no Inko—sawed the knife back and forth. The sharp and wet sounds of his wings breaking and bleeding filled his ears.

Pain splintered in his vision; white spots of burning, all encompassing pain. This time, he did scream, and thrashed as she ***pulled*** *on his wings. And they cracked. The flesh connecting his wings to his back was peeled in wet strips, and excruciating pain pulsed through him.*

It burned. It burned. It burned. He couldn't stop her—

He couldn't make the pain go away—

He screamed, something low and tortured, and ragged—

He heard the first wing fall to the floor, with a wet slap and she started on the next one—

Pain. There was nothing but burning hot pain. "Stop! Please! Please stop!"

But she didn't stop—

"Izuku!" someone yelled, shaking him from the utter terror of his dream. "Izuku, wake up! You're dreaming!"

He blinked blearily, coming face to face with Dabi in the harsh light of his room. Dabi had turned on the light, he realized. He must've summoned him by accident during his nightmare.

Izuku fought the bile in the back of his throat, heaving in shallow breaths as he shook. There had been so much pain and it still throbbed dully in his back. His blanket was tangled around his legs and sweat was making his sheets damp. A demon popped its head up from the corner, peering at him with white eyes.

"You're okay," Dabi insisted, pulling him up so he was sitting up, forcing his wings to press flush against him. "You're okay. You're not hurt."

The demon came over and mechanically patted his head, ruffling his curls slightly. Izuku burrowed himself in Dabi's arms, sniffing.

"Sad?" The demon asked, *"Scared?"*

"Go away, please," Dabi whispered gently, and it disappeared. Dabi wrapped his arms around Izuku and held him in a tight, brotherly embrace. Tears streamed down his cheeks and he gripped Dabi tightly. "You're safe."

His door swung open and Izuku flinched at the loud sound. Dabi's arms tightened around him and he shot Shouta and Hizashi scalding glares. "Quiet!" He snapped, but there wasn't any real heat to his words. Only concern. "It was just a nightmare."

The tension in both of his dads' shoulders dissipated, and Hizashi let out a long sigh of relief before speaking. “You scared me.”

“Sorry,” Dabi muttered, rubbing soothing circles into Izuku’s back. “We didn’t mean to wake you up.”

Shouta gave them a weak smile, slowly making his way deeper into Izuku’s room. “You didn’t wake us up, we were grading tests.”

“At one in the morning?” Dabi asked, looking doubtful, and Izuku attempted to wipe at his tears.

“Yeah,” Shouta replied, yawning. “Denki wrote the most horrific essay I’ve ever seen in my entire career.”

“Dear God, don’t get him started,” Hizashi groaned before plopping himself on the edge of Izuku’s bed. Izuku watched him with his eyebrows raised. “Wanna sleep in the living room and watch an old All Might movie until we pass out? I’ve gotten far enough in my grading to call it a day.”

“I hate All Might movies,” Shouta told him, lacking any venom.

“Don’t lie, Shouta. They’re cheesy but amazing,” Hizashi pointed at him, narrowing his eyes. “They’re *amazing.”*

“That’s your opinion. I have mine.”

“C’mon Shouta, I’ve seen you smiling during those movies before! You’re just lying to yourself,” Hizashi accused, looking utterly scandalized that Shouta didn’t like cheesy *All Might* movies. Utter lies.

Izuku grinned at their distracting bickering, even if they were probably doing it on purpose to get his mind off of his terrifying dreams. Dabi slowly detached himself from Izuku and ruffled his hair. “Movies? I’m coming. What about you, Izuku?”

Izuku getting out of his bed was an answer in itself, and Dabi gave him a toothy smile as the two of them went into the living room. Shouta stayed behind to turn off the light in Izuku’s bedroom. Hizashi went to grab extra blankets and pillows, and Izuku watched as Hizashi threw the blankets haphazardly onto the floor. He eventually straightened them out and placed a pile of pillows at the top of them. Dabi headed into the kitchen and grabbed himself a drink of water.

Izuku watched them, taking deep calming breaths as he chased away the dredges of his dream. Shouta emerged from the hallway with Eclipse curled up in his arms, purring. Shouta plopped himself down in the middle of the mess of blankets and yawned as Hizashi set up the movie.

Izuku nervously approached before settling himself down on the blankets too as the movie began.

“Oh wait, hold on,” Dabi mumbled, before heading back into Izuku’s room. He emerged with the night light Kacchan had given him and plugged it into the wall nearest to Izuku. “There we go.”

He moved to turn off the lights a few seconds later and settled down next to Izuku. He was snoring almost as soon as his head hit one of the pillows, and Shouta was yawning again. Hizashi threw himself under the blankets, snuggling up to Shouta.

Eclipse, finding her current situation not suitable for her to be able to sleep, ventured over to where Izuku laid and curled up right on his chest with a rolling pur.

An hour after the movie had been on, Shouta turned it off, finally tired enough to sleep. Fortunately, Hizashi was still scrolling through his phone, yawning occasionally. He shoved his husband slightly and pointed over at where Izuku laid.

Eclipse was curled up on his chest, fast asleep. His wings were neatly tucked against his back at the moment, so they weren't visible, but that wasn't why he pointed at his son. It was the fact that Dabi had thrown his arm over the boy's eyes in his sleep, and Izuku was definitely also sleeping.

Dabi shouldn't be there, but he was. "You think we should mention that?" He asked, looking at Hizashi.

The blond shrugged. "He's getting stronger, isn't he? It's possible that he gives off enough energy to keep Dabi here. I think it's fine."

Shouta had to admit that they were pretty adorable, and Dabi had protected Izuku more times than he could count. He was like Izuku's overprotective brother or something.

He smiled.

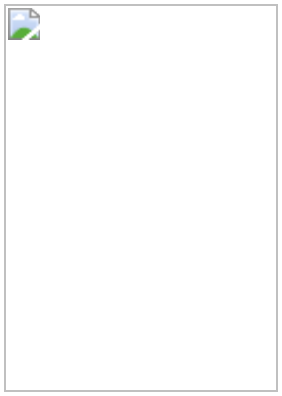
Chapter End Notes

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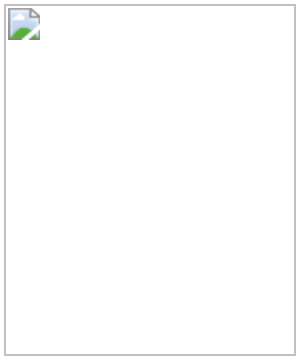
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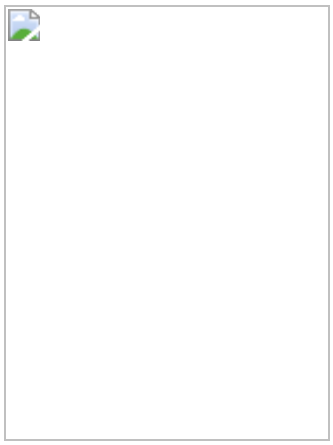
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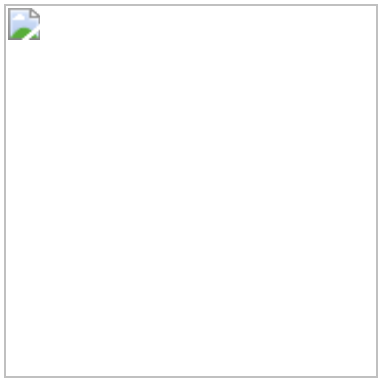
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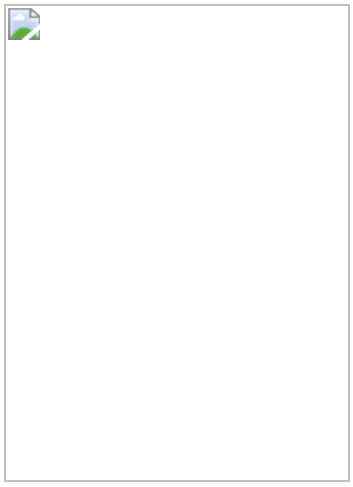


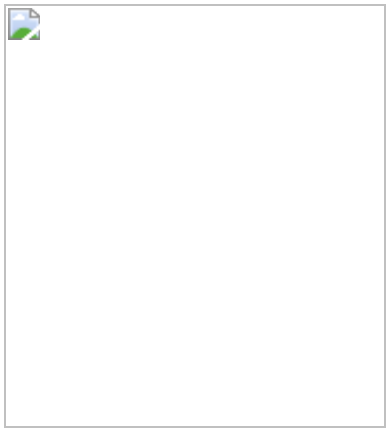
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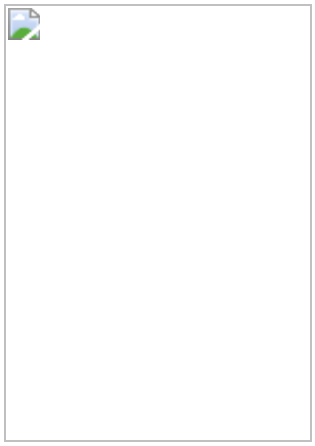


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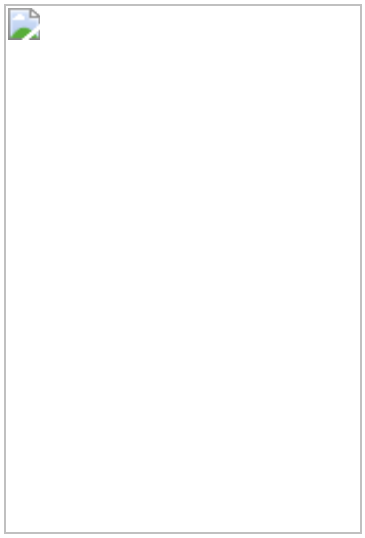




by: Poppy'ndFriends



by: Bun



And as always here's the discord invite if you want to join!

Chapter 65

Chapter Summary

Double chapter update coz I missed it last week!!

Izuku went to class the next day, his joints still sore from his altercation with Stain. Shouta was weary to have him go to school so soon after the whole incident but Hizashi had finally gotten through to him, saying that Izuku needed to be there so he could hear about the practical exam.

He'd heard from the group chat—which he pointedly ignored almost all of the time—that it was going to be robots. Ashido had been adamant that everyone could pass if they just had to repeat the entrance exam all over again.

He tapped his fingers against his desk nervously as the rest of the class trickled in. Iida and Uraraka had gotten to class early, but Izuku didn't really know why. Well Iida was obviously studying, but it was Uraraka he was more confused about.

She was staring a hole into the chalkboard, and every few seconds she'd look over at him and open her mouth like she wanted to say something. She always seemed to stop herself every time, with a heavy sigh. And every time she did that, Izuku felt his body tense. He kind of wished that Shouta was here, at least in his sleeping bag. So that if she tried to ask him a weird question, Shouta would tell her to leave him alone.

But Shouta was talking to Nedzu right now before classes began. Iida was also sending him sympathetic looks, and Izuku felt like he might melt into the floor. Of course everyone had seen his fight with Stain on television. It was inevitable. It was all the news had been talking about until today, showing videos of Izuku falling to the ground with Stain in his grasp, his wings black against the sunrise.

It was jarring to see himself look like that. With his curling horns, golden eyes, pointed ears, and black wings. It had been a complete transformation—unlike the other times. His hands were still a little black but it was definitely fading, like Dabi told him it would. Hizashi had

helped him wrap up his hands to avoid even more questions from his overly-concerned and overly-protective group of friends.

Iida and Uraraka were trying very hard not to ask him questions, but he could feel the heat of their collective gazes. The only other person in the room so far was Tokoyami, and he was too busy feeding Dark Shadow some bits of bread. He didn't seem too keen on pressuring Izuku into answering questions.

Uraraka let out a huff and turned toward him. She glanced at Iida and she finally stood, practically tripping over her feet to get to Izuku's desk. She slammed both of her hands down on the edges of his desk, careful to keep her pinkies up. She gave Izuku a rather intense look, and Izuku shriveled under it.

[Hi.]

Her face softened, and she grabbed his hands without thinking. Izuku swallowed thickly, not used to normal human contact.

"Deku," She began, her voice oh so gentle. "Your fight with Stain was super cool! I mean I know he was kind of your dad and everything, but it was so cool! When you were falling, me and Shinsou almost had a heart attack—we were both interning under Gun Head—and Shinsou nearly spilled his coffee on me! But that was probably the coolest, and scariest fight I've ever seen! I'm so glad you're okay! And I really like the new wings!"

Izuku was gaping like a fish. He snapped his teeth together and pulled his hands away so he could reply.

[Thank you.]

Iida had joined them at some point and he took Izuku by the shoulders, shaking him back and forth.

“Midoriya, I was so worried when I saw that on the news! My brother and I were helping with the rescue efforts, so we didn’t really run into any Nomu!” Iida took a deep breath to steady himself, before bringing Izuku into an awkward hug around his desk. “And I’m so sorry you had to do *that* to him again. I know what Stain meant to you, even if he wasn’t the kindest person.”

Izuku had stiffened as soon as Iida had put his arms around him, but he tolerated it. They were only trying to comfort him, as weird as that sounded to himself. He wasn’t used to this kind of physical affection, and it bothered him. He only really trusted Kacchan enough to let the other boy hug him. And Mitsuki and Masaru.

And Shouta and Hizashi now that he was thinking about it.

Izuku gave Iida a grateful look as the boy finally pulled away, pushing his flashing glasses up the bridge of his nose. Iida patted him awkwardly on the shoulder.

“Aye, Midori!”Ashido exclaimed as she pushed her way through the doorway. Her electric pink backpack was slung on one of her shoulders, and she was so excited to see him that she dropped it on the ground instantly. He tried to hide how his face turned sour. He recalled the incident in the classroom where she’d said he was terrifying. “I saw that fight with the Stain Nomu! So cool! Now you have wings, don’t you? Can I see? Can I see?”

Izuku blushed furiously, confused at the quick change in his classmate’s attitude toward him. Of course he’d done a lot during the Sports Festival, but he hadn’t done anything special. He’d only distracted the most dangerous of all villains within the forest until Tokoyami destroyed the barrier. Why was she acting like she cared for him?

He ducked his head, and Sero entered the room with a smile, heading straight for his desk. “Oh, you really do have wings?”

“Dude, your fight was so badass,” Denki explained, trailing in after.

“HEY YOU FUCKING EXTRAS!” Kacchan yelled, shoving his way around the crowd that had quickly formed around Izuku’s desk within seconds. “DON’T THINK YOU CAN JUST

TALK TO DEKU LIKE YOU'RE FRIENDS!"

Izuku glanced away as his classmates exclaimed, sounding betrayed. "What do you mean Bakubro? We're classmates!" Sero exclaimed, looking absolutely horrified. "We're friends, right Midoriya?"

Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line, and Sero went silent. Ashido and Denki had gone quiet. Shinsou, from his spot nearby, laughed harshly. "You guys weren't subtle in the slightest about what you really think about him," he told them, "We tolerated your fake kindness after the Sports Festival, but you can stop being fake now."

Izuku watched Ashido open her mouth to deny it, but she glanced at Izuku and deflated. "I __"

"So what I'm hearing is that I need to have a talk about Quirk Discrimination? Or maybe I should expel all of you? Just so you know, I'm leaning toward the latter," Shouta snapped from his position in the doorway. Nedzu was beside him, and he didn't look happy at all.

"I could start calling their parents now, if you'd like?" Nedzu asked, turning to Shouta with a sharp glint in his eyes. "I definitely don't think anyone who discriminates against people can be heroes."

The silence after was thick and unbroken for several minutes. Izuku felt a warm feeling swell in his chest at Shouta's protectiveness, though he didn't know how to feel about Nedzu. Shouta sighed and headed to the front of the class. "I will be having a one-on-one talk with all of you about Quirk Discrimination at some point today, apparently. I'll take that time to decide if *any* of you who acted like that towards Midoriya should stay in the Hero course."

The silence continued. "Take your seats," he snapped, his eyes flashing red with anger. "Class starts now."

"Ah, Midoriya!" Nedzu chirped from his spot in the doorway. "Could I speak to you for a moment?" Nedzu asked with a strange glint in his eye. "It won't take long, and I've taken some time to learn sign language."

Thirty minutes before the school day began, Shouta dropped off Izuku to his classroom. Usually, he'd stay in there, grading anything he hadn't got to the next morning, but he had to speak to Nedzu about something important. Especially after the Stain incident.

He figured that Uraraka and Iida were the best people to leave his kid with, besides Bakugou and Shinsou. Maybe even Todoroki.

He knocked on Nedzu's office door and the mammal gave him a cheery greeting. "Come in, Aizawa!" Nedzu said while smiling as Shouta entered. "Have a seat! Do you want any tea?"

"No thanks," Shouta mumbled, coming to take a seat in front of Nedzu's desk. His office wasn't as big as Shouta thought it would've been when he got to Yuuei as a student. It was one of many things that had surprised him.

"So, what brings you to my office, Aizawa?" Nedzu asked as he brought his tea to his lips. Shouta watched him critically. "Is it perhaps about Todoroki and Shinsou, and their memories?"

"Yes actually," Shouta began, taking a deep breath. "Luckily we took immediate action with Todoroki, seeing as his abuse was physical and he came to us after the memory session. Both he and Shinsou got special permission to go to the dorms early, but I want to bring both of their parents to justice for what they've done."

Nedzu clapped his hands together, bringing out two manila folders. Shouta eyed them carefully.

Currently, Todoroki has been staying in the students' new dorms ever since they pulled him from Endeavor's custody. The man had put up quite a fight, but Nedzu shot it down in an instant, threatening to destroy his entire career if he stepped one foot inside Yuuei. He failed

to tell the fire-user that he was going to do it anyway, unless he miraculously changed. Shouta didn't see a redemption coming for that man.

"Luckily for Todoroki-kun," Nedzu began, patting the first folder. He opened it, showing a file on Rei Todoroki. After some prompting from the Principal, he grabbed it and skimmed through it. "Rei has been on medication for a long time since the incident where she burned Todoroki-kun. Truthfully, I went to speak with some of the doctors there, and they said *usually* they would've released her to go back home."

"Why didn't they?" Shouta asked, not liking how his stomach seemed to drop to the ground as if someone had dropped rocks into his gut. "Though I doubt she would've stayed with Enji if she did go back."

"Originally, I assumed the same thing, that Rei had requested to stay so she could avoid her husband. That isn't the case, however. When I asked the doctors—with a *lot* of persuasion I might add—they admitted that Enji had bribed them to keep her locked up. She's perfectly healthy, and she even reached out to Todoroki recently. We can easily get her discharged. She has plenty of her own money and can take in all of the Todoroki children at a moment's notice. We just need to get her out of the hospital and allow her some time to acquire a house."

"But how will Enji react?" Shouta asked, setting down the file. "How can we keep her safe?"

"There are plenty of organizations that specialize in keeping victims of Quirk Marriages safe. They'll even help her get a restraining order against him," Nedzu explained. "All we need is time."

"That's good to hear," Shouta said, sighing in relief, "I'll have a talk with Todoroki and his siblings."

"And I'll get everything ready. Hopefully, one day we can just arrest Enji and call it a day," Nedzu mumbled angrily. "The man is still too elusive and All Might is on the verge of retirement."

“That doesn't mean we can’t spend this time compiling a case against him. When the day comes, we can lock him up with all of the evidence we gather now,” Shouta proposed and didn’t reject the offer for tea this time.

“Ah, I see. Good idea, Aizawa,” Nedzu chirped excitedly. “The more damning the evidence, the more the Commission can’t ignore this when we finally bring it to court.”

Shouta smiled, taking a sip of the tea. It was subtly sweet, but still pretty bitter. He fought to keep his face from souring as he swallowed and quickly grabbed a cracker. Nedzu plowed onward like nothing had happened, and Shouta was grateful.

“Now, as for Shinsou…” He pointed to the last file, his face set in determination. Shouta felt his hands tighten around the handle of the teacup. Those memories had made him unbelievably angry, almost as much as Izuku and Todoroki’s memories had. The way his classmates had treated him, just because of his mind control Quirk. Or how his parents had flat out ignored him. “I want to get him out of his foster home as soon as possible. I know neither of us wanted to disturb him during the Sports Festival or the internships, but now would be a perfect time. If his parents still act the way they did in his memories, I doubt they’ll be angry if someone takes him away,” The mammal placed a paw on his face, deep in thought for a moment. “But who would adopt him?”

Shouta placed his teacup down. This is what he’d been waiting for. He’d already talked to Yamada about it a few days after the memory incident. He had already agreed, but he had yet to ask Izuku about it. He cleared his throat uneasily, worried that Nedzu wouldn’t accept what he was about to say.

“Well…” Shouta began, staring into the warm tea in his cup. “Nedzu, I’ve actually been thinking about that for a long time.”

Nedzu raised his eyebrows and leaned back in his seat, his beady eyes sparkling. “Go on, Aizawa.”

“I want to adopt Shinsou,” he began, sighing shortly and his chest heavy with worry. “And I want to adopt Izuku.”

“I knew you were going to adopt Midoriya,” Nedzu said with a smile. “And I figured you’d probably want to adopt Shinsou too.”

Shouta let his shoulders relax as Nedzu pulled out another adoption paper for Shinsou. “I support your decision, Aizawa.”

“Thank you,” he breathed out, cracking a small smile.

“Class should be starting soon,” Nedzu noted, glancing up at his clock. “I’ll come with you, I’d like to get a glance at Midoriya-kun’s new appendages and apologize for my behavior after the U.S.J. all that time ago.”

Shouta felt his eye twitch at the mention of the U.S.J.. His behavior had been horrible. He nodded shortly. They both headed to his classroom, but Nedzu held his hand up before he could open the door. He raised an eyebrow at the mammal, but he brought his paw to his lips.

“HEY YOU FUCKING EXTRAS! DON’T THINK YOU CAN JUST TALK TO DEKU LIKE YOU’RE FRIENDS!”

Shouta frowned. *Weren’t* they friends? Nedzu inched the door open slightly so they could peek inside. He saw Sero, Denki, Ashido and a gaggle of his other students standing nearby. Uraraka, Shinsou, Iida, Kirishima, Todoroki, and even Tokoyami seemed to agree with what Bakugou was saying.

Yaoyorozu seemed deeply uncomfortable, as did the rest of the class.

“What do you mean Bakubro? We’re classmates!” Sero exclaimed, looking absolutely horrified. “We’re friends, right Midoriya?”

The way Midoriya looked away, looking hurt and betrayed, told Shouta all he needed to know.

“You guys weren’t subtle in the slightest about what you really think about him,” Shinsou spoke up, his face red with rage. “We tolerated your fake kindness after the Sports Festival, but you can stop being fake now.”

Ashido, Sero, and Denki looked guilty. It was Ashido who finally spoke, but Shouta was pushing his way into his class, unable to hear more. “I—”

Shouta had heard everything he needed to.

“So what I’m hearing is that I need to have a talk about Quirk Discrimination? Or maybe I should expel all of you? Just so you know, I’m leaning toward the latter,” Shouta snapped, unable to mask his obvious rage. Hero students were spitting Quirk discrimination like it was *nothing* .

“I could start calling their parents now, if you’d like?” Nedzu asked, turning to Shouta. And he was tempted to nod, that’s how pissed he felt. “I definitely don’t think anyone who discriminates against people can be heroes.”

“I will be having a one-on-one talk with all of you about Quirk Discrimination at some point today, apparently. I’ll take that time to decide if *any* of you who acted like that toward Midoriya should stay in the Hero course,” Shouta pointedly glared at Sero, Denki, and Ashido. Depending on their answers, they very well might be packing their bags and going home.

The silence continued. “Take your seats,” he snapped, his eyes flashing red with anger. “Class starts now.”

“Ah, Midoriya!” Nedzu chirped from his spot in the doorway. “Could I speak to you for a moment?” Nedzu asked, with a strange glint in his eye. “It won’t take long, and I’ve taken some time to learn sign language.”

Shouta watched as his son stood from his seat, looking a little pale as he did so. He gave Shouta a look of utter betrayal, like Shouta had condemned him.

He felt bad. Nedzu was pretty scary.

“I would like to start by apologizing about what I did after the U.S.J. incident, Midoriya,” Nedzu began, pouring the trembling boy a cup of calming tea. He even placed cookies next to the steaming cup, but Midoriya just stared at them. “Go ahead, Midoriya. You can eat them if you like.”

Midoriya glanced down at the cookies before glancing at him again. He grabbed two of the cookies and ate one slowly.

“As I was saying…” Nedzu began softly, trying his hardest to portray his regret. During the U.S.J. incident, his judgement had been clouded. He had been so worried about Midoriya being a spy that he didn’t notice Midoriya was extremely uncomfortable with him. He had even asked really inappropriate questions, such as suggesting that he would torture his mother. “I sincerely apologize for my actions up until now. There’s no excuse as to why I pushed you like that after the U.S.J. incident, which was a very traumatic experience for you. I realize that there’s nothing I can do to fix that and you must dislike me, but I just wanted you to know that I don’t hate you. You being an unwilling spy should’ve deterred me from such behavior, and considering what I saw of your memories… It was unacceptable. I wanted to make it perfectly clear that I won’t ever question you like that again.”

Midoriya took a timid sip of his tea before chewing thoughtfully on his cookie. He didn’t look at Nedzu for a long time, but Nedzu knew when to be patient.

[I accept your apology. Given the situation I should’ve expected it.]

“Regular questioning is always to be expected, Midoriya-kun. What I did to you was unforgivable. I asked questions no normal police officer or Hero would’ve asked. And for that, I must apologize.”

Midoriya ducked his head and tugged lightly on his hair.

[Thank you. I accept your apology.]

“You’re welcome,” Nedzu began, even though he doubted that Midoriya actually accepted the apology. “Now, onto a lighter topic! You’ve manifested wings!”

Midoriya seemed to lose a bit of tension in his shoulders.

“We could add learning to fly to your private training, if you like? We could even have you do a work study with Hawks later in the year as well. He’s already asked us,” Nedzu told him, smiling as he watched Midoriya’s head snap up at the mention of the Number Three Hero.

He nodded vigorously in excitement, and it warmed Nedzu’s small heart. There was the smallest of smiles on his lips. “Good. Would you like more tea?”

He looked hesitant, but ultimately held out his cup with shaking hands. Nedzu filled it with more of his special soothing tea, and Nedzu kept the boy out of classes longer than he originally planned. He hoped Aizawa wouldn’t get angry about Nedzu stealing his child for a little while.

Shi barely survived the burning of Hosu City and the eradication of the Roses. And by barely surviving, he meant that he’d been late to the death party, apparently. Saving Midoriya had served to save his life.

He hadn’t been paying attention as he entered the warehouse, only a little bit late. But dear God had he smelled the iron in the air.

And then his entire world had begun to burn, the images of his fallen comrades forever seared into his mind. Their bodies had been torn to shreds, leaving puddles of blood throughout the building. He knew one thing:

The League will pay.

Chapter 66

Chapter Summary

Second chapter for the day! Ashido and gang get a lecture from dadzawa about their behavior!! Also Shinsou gets adopted! Why? Because i said so.

Chapter Notes

Enjoy!! Also, just a side note I appreciate everyone's comments!!! I've gotten the funniest hate comments saved to camera roll! Thanks >:)) Some people get so salty and its fun to see

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shouta rubbed his temples as Iida left. He'd gone through almost everyone in his class, even the ones that hadn't been talking behind his son's back. He just needed to be thorough, of course. His students were being discriminatory and he wasn't about to slack off on that. He had gone through most of the class now, and all he had left were Ashido, Sero, Denki, Todoroki, Shinsou, and Izuku himself.

Well, he wasn't having the Quirk Discrimination talk with the last three, but rather a talk about other things with them. Shouta took a long drink of his cold coffee—it'd been warm when he received it—and stood to call in the next student.

"Sero," He called, and the boy with the tape arms stood, looking rather nervous and sweaty. Good. Maybe he'd actually learn a lesson for once. He guided Sero into the room. In the middle of it was a couch in front of a coffee table, and on the other side of the table was a plush chair.

Usually, this was where therapy sessions were held, but Shouta *definitely* wasn't using it for any therapeutic services. He motioned for Sero to take a seat on the couch and Shouta sipped on the coffee again. Sero sat down, wringing his hands worriedly.

Shouta sighed and took a seat on the empty chair across from him. He took another long drink from his cup. “Do you want to explain yourself?” He snapped finally, leaning back into the chair.

Sero pursed his lips together and ducked his head low, ruffling his hair uneasily. “I—” He began, his tone thick with guilt. “His Quirk is so…”

Shouta rubbed his temples, trying to repress the horrible burning in his chest. “He’s so terrifying Aizawa-sensei.”

“Villains are scarier than he is,” Shouta put his head in his hands. “It’s not the Quirk that makes the Hero, Sero. It’s their heart and their drive to save people. I don’t understand how you can hate him for his Quirk he hardly learned to control.”

“I don’t hate him—”

“But he thinks you do!” Shouta couldn’t help but shout, putting his half-full coffee cup on the table between them. He cursed softly under his breath. He hadn’t meant to blow up like that. Sero ran a hand through his hair.

He took a calming breath before resuming. “Were we not watching the same memories? Did you not see the absolute horrors he experienced?”

“I did—”

“Then you know that he never had a chance to love his Quirk the way everyone else does. He never got the chance to experiment with it. He never got Quirk counseling. At every turn, the world has shown him darkness, Sero. It has shown him even what I haven’t seen. It has shown him evil, and you want to be afraid of his Quirk? You don’t want to show him the kindness he deserves? You don’t want to save him? Don’t you want to be a Hero? Can’t you respect his drive?”

“I— I want to be a hero,” Sero admitted. “I want that more than anything.”

“Then why do you think this is acceptable?” Shouta asked. “Is this behavior toward a classmate heroic to you?”

“No,” Sero said thickly. “No, it isn’t.”

“Are you going to do anything about this? Are you going to try your hardest to understand his battle to control his Quirk?” Shouta asked. “If you don’t clean up your act, I will not hesitate to expel you on the spot. The only reason I haven’t done so already is because I doubt Midoriya would be happy about it.”

“I won’t do it again, Aizawa-sensei. I promise. I— I need to apologize, don’t I?”

“Yes, you do.” Shouta mumbled. “Also, you won’t be going to the dorms after this. I have something you need to see,” Shouta told him, motioning him to stand. “Go back to the classroom. Denki and Ashido will join you if they don’t get expelled. I’ll come to get you when I’m done with the rest of the class.”

Sero nodded hastily and practically ran out of the room. Shouta was exhausted, but he called Denki in any way.

“Aizawa-sensei, I really didn’t mean it—” Denki began instantly, already in tears.

“If you didn’t mean it, why did you say it?” Shouta asked, crossing his arms. He hadn’t even had a chance to sit down before this conversation began. “Why would you say he was scary? Why would you say he should repress a part of himself?”

“Fear makes people stupid,” Denki mumbled in a moment of pure clarity. He tugged on his blazer. “Fear of the unknown drives people to do dumb things, and I should know that first-hand because people used to be afraid of my Quirk when I was really young. My classmates

didn’t bully me or harass me, but they didn’t hang out with me. I—I should know what Midoriya’s going through… but instead, I hated him, as everyone hated me.”

Shouta stayed silent, only putting a hand on the boy’s shoulder to console him as he continued. “I feel so bad…” He chewed on his lip, and Shouta belatedly realized that Denki’s eyes were shining with tears. “He doesn’t deserve that. I don’t know if my apology will be enough.”

“I recommend that you apologize, Denki.” Shouta began slowly, “But actions prove more than words do. It may take time, but he’s one of the kindest people I know. He’ll forgive you faster than you deserve.”

Denki sniffled and wiped at his eyes. “O-okay.”

“Head to the classroom when you leave,” Shouta said, leading him to the door. “There’s something I need to show you before you go to the dorms.”

“A-alright,” Denki stuttered as he opened the door. “Is Sero there too?”

“Yeah,” Shouta sighed heavily, and Denki perked up a bit as he left in the direction of the classroom. “Ashido, you’re next.”

She was a lot more subdued as she entered the room. She took a seat on the couch and she was already crying. Shouta pushed a container of tissues toward her as she covered her eyes with her hands.

“I assume you already feel bad?” Shouta mumbled when she hunched over and let out a sob.

“I do,” she said in a broken voice, staring up at the ceiling. “I feel so, *so bad.”*

They sat in silence for a long moment. A very long moment. She looked like she wanted to continue, like she had more to say, so Shouta waited.

“My best friend killed herself because she had a mind-reading Quirk, and everyone hated her,” she croaked out. Shouta held himself very still, swallowing thickly. The hair on the back of his neck had risen instantly and he felt the dread pool in his stomach like acid. “I was her only friend, and when her parents called me to tell me about it…”

Yes, Shouta had seen that in Ashido's memories. He had wanted to talk to her about it, but she’d scheduled extra sessions with Ms. Hirai so he hadn’t asked. It wasn’t his business and those sessions were private.

“I vowed that I would always help people. I vowed that I would support everyone, no matter their Quirk,” she sucked in a deep breath, “But I did exactly what I told myself I wouldn’t. I did to him… what everyone did to her. I hurt him, and I can’t fix that. God, I didn’t even realize I was *doing* it!”

Shouta stood abruptly and wrapped his arms around her. “All that I ask is that you never do it again,” he told her. “Please never do that again.”

“I won't,” she told him, taking a few steadying breaths. “I won’t. I’ll apologize to him.”

He let out a breath of relief. He really didn’t want to expel his kids, but he really didn’t tolerate bullying or discrimination either. It went against every part of his being. He was lucky that these kids realized their mistakes and wanted to change. And if they didn’t, he wasn’t going to hesitate. He slowly let go of her as her breathing evened out.

“Go on ahead to the classroom, I’ll be there in a second after I talk to Shinsou and Todoroki.”

Ashido nodded as he opened the door for her. She wiped at her remaining tears, but she looked like a weight had been lifted off of her. He felt relieved as he called for Todoroki and Shinsou to come into the office.

Todoroki was the first of the two to enter, followed closely by Shinsou, who looked like he just woke up from a nap.

“Both you take a seat, please,” Shouta mumbled, sounding just as tired as he felt.

Shinsou instantly opened his mouth to protest. “I never said anything hurtful to Midoriya about his Quirk, though!”

“Neither did I, Aizawa-sensei,” Todoroki mumbled, wringing his hands together. “Is there another reason you called us here?”

“Yes,” Shouta said, leaning forward so that his elbows rested on the table between them. “I actually wanted to discuss your family situations. Would you rather do this separately, or right now, together?”

“Hm,” Shinsou mumbled, “I don’t really mind. Since we moved into the dorms before everyone else we’ve had time to talk about things. I don’t see a problem.”

“Neither do I,” Todoroki said coolly, “We all know Endeavor is nothing but burning trash.”

Shinsou snorted. Loudly. “He certainly smells the part too,” he remarked, and Todoroki pressed his mouth into a thin line to keep from laughing.

“Alright,” Shouta began, but he was trying his hardest not to let his amusement show. “I would like to know if either of you would be opposed to pressing charges against your respective parents.”

Shinsou’s eyebrows practically shot all the way up to his hairline in shock. “W-what?”

“Really?” Todoroki replied, looking *eager*.

Shouta nodded. “Unfortunately, Todoroki, we’re going to have to wait until we have more than enough evidence to get him in jail. We don’t want to leave any room for him to walk away from this. We’re not sure how long it’ll take, actually.”

“That’s fine with me.” he stated. “As long as it happens, I don’t care how long I have to wait.”

Shouta let a soft smile play on his face. He placed a file on the table and nudged it toward Todoroki. “Nedzu also contacted the hospital where your mother, Rei, is staying. He’s come to find out that Enji is paying the institute to keep her there, but it won’t take much persuasion to get her released. She’s perfectly healthy as far as the Doctors can tell, and she has more than enough money to take you and your siblings in. How would you feel about living with your mother?”

He looked at him, surprised to see his student’s eyes shining with tears. Shouta resisted the strong urge to crush his student in a hug. At least for right now. “B-but… what about Endeavor—”

“We’re working on getting her a restraining order, and she’s looking to buy a house before she’s released. All you have to do is say yes, Todoroki. We’ll deal with your father.”

“R-really?”

And Shouta wants to cry because of how small Todoroki’s voice sounds. So small and so incredibly hopeful.

“Of course,” Shouta said. “Do you want this?”

“Yes,” And Todoroki’s voice is cracking with emotion. Emotion Shouta hasn’t heard from him in his entire time of teaching. *“Yes.”*

Shinsou had the widest smile on his face and shot up from his seat. He crushed the other boy in a hug and Shouta watched them with a soft smile.

The two of them took a moment to calm down. When they finally did, Shouta moved onto Shinsou's situation.

"So, Shinsou," Shouta began, "How do you feel about pressing charges against your foster parents?"

"I... uh," He tugged on his sleeve anxiously and bit down on his lip. "I— I don't blame them for what they did, really. But I do know that what they've been doing is wrong. Especially after seeing everyone else's memories and how happy they are with their family…"

Shinsou took a deep breath. "I just… If we press charges on them, it wouldn't be fair. People are always going to hate people with Quirks they see as villainous. That's just how society is. That's how people are made, and my parents were never told what they're doing is wrong. They're adults, and they *should* know better. But I can't press charges on them because then, we'd have to press charges on everyone who discriminates and neglects children due to their Quirks or it wouldn't be fair. That's way too many people honestly, and I don't have the energy."

Shouta chewed on his lower lip and sighed. Of course that's how Shinsou would see it, but that didn't mean Shouta couldn't adopt him still. "Alright, I respect your decision." He looked at Todoroki. "You can head back to the dorms now. I still have to talk to Midoriya and Shinsou about something else."

Todoroki nodded. "Thank you, Sensei," he said as he left, his eyes practically brimming with happiness he'd never seen before in the boy's face. "I'll send in Midoriya."

"Thank you."

As soon as his sons stepped through the door, Shouta pulled out the two adoption forms that he had yet to fill out.

Izuku paused in the doorway before finally taking a seat beside Shinsou. Shouta took a deep breath to gather himself. He placed the forms in front of both of them and pressed his hands together like a prayer.

“I want to adopt both of you,” Shouta started slowly. “I’ve already talked to Hizashi about it and he’s already agreed. All that’s left are both of your decisions.”

There’s a moment where nothing happened. There’s silence, and both of them look frozen in shock. Shinsou was the first to say something.

His voice came out thick with emotion and wobbly. “A-are you serious?”

At this, Shouta nodded. Izuku was staring down at the paper for a long moment while Shinsou readily agreed. “Yes,” he said, wiping away his silent tears.

And Shouta’s chest swelled with warmth and happiness. He smiled and turned to Izuku, who was sobbing into his hands. It took Shouta no more than a second to crush him in a hug.

“Please,” Shouta started while he rubbed soothing circles into his child’s back. “ *Let me be your father, kiddo.”*

Izuku nodded against his chest, and Shouta could feel his clothes getting wet as he sobbed harder. He opened his arms to Shinsou, who didn't hesitate to join in.

If Shouta was shedding a few tears of his own, well…

They didn't need to know.

He was still reeling from Shouta adopting him by the time he returned to the classroom.

Izuku didn't think that he'd be training so late into the day, but Shouta had insisted on it as they headed back to the classroom. And he was surprised to see that Sero, Ashido, and Denki were still there as well. Izuku gave them all a nervous glance before looking back to Shouta.

That's when his father started to explain what was going on and why some of his classmates were there.

"All of you are going to watch Midoriya train for a little bit. You'll all get front row seats to how much he's grown, and you three—" he looked at Sero, Denki, and Ashido as he spoke. "—will write an essay on the effects of Quirk Discrimination on a person, and how you're going to condone for your actions. If you get anything less than an A you'll get a week of detention."

The three of them—surprisingly—didn't argue or groan in despair like Izuku thought they would. They all nodded shortly, looking immensely guilty. Izuku kind of felt bad for them.

"And Shinsou," Shouta began, "I want you to see Midoriya's Quirk in action if you're going to be living with us."

Izuku watched Shinsou nod before being given a smile. "Your Quirk doesn't scare me Midoriya, don't worry about it."

He eyed Shinsou critically, unsure if he was being genuine. He'd stood up for him all those days ago when all of this had begun so he shouldn't be doubting Shinsou's words, but he was.

There was always a voice in the back of his head telling him that all of this was a lie. That all of this was some sick sort of game; and one day, All for One would drag him away from this haven he'd created. He couldn't escape the man forever, and surely the man was looking for him right now or trying to come up with a plan to get Izuku back. That's why he didn't want to believe Shinsou. One day, this whole charade would be over and there would be no Heroes coming to rescue him. There would be no escape from that man, nor would he be able to escape his parents again.

He shook himself out of his dark thoughts. Even if that would be the case one day, that didn't mean he had to sit in terror waiting for it to happen. He should enjoy the peace while it lasts.

Even if he wanted to lock himself in his room, terror coiling around him like a snake, he shouldn't. Izuku wanted to look back on his time at Yuuei and remember all of the good things that happened here. He wanted to remember all of the people he befriended and the teachers who protected him.

One day, it would end. But that day was not today. So he gave Shinsou the benefit of the doubt. He ignored the nagging voice that was echoing his true thoughts.

Izuku gave Shinsou a slight nod, and the boy smiled at him.

"YOU'RE GOING TO BE LIVING WITH AIZAWA-SENSEI!?" Ashido screeched, jumping up and down in excitement. Before she could work herself into a hyperactive frenzy, a red flash made her freeze. She glanced at Shouta with a weak smile.

"Alright, we should get going," Shouta told them, stuffing his hands in his pockets with a lazy look. He turned and began to lead the way to the lower floors of Yuuei, and Izuku followed just behind him fiddling with the cross around his neck. Recovery Girl had fixed his old one.

One glance back showed him that Sero, Denki, and Ashido were trailing behind them a bit. All three of them still looked really guilty about their actions, and he felt bad for them all over again. Shinsou was keeping pace with him easily, yawning when Izuku turned to look at him.

It only took them a minute or two to arrive in the room, and Shouta told them all to stand in the other room with a one-way window.

Shouta came to stand next to him, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. “Are you ready?” he asked, with thinly-veiled concern. Izuku gave him a curt nod before ripping the cross from his neck.

He handed it to Shouta and the man went to lean against the nearby wall. “Show them what you can do.”

The effect was instant, as the floor shook beneath his feet. The power rushed to his skin, eager, and burning. He greeted it with his black fire. It writhed between his fingers and the power purred within him.

He was getting much better at this, ever since he started training with Shouta during his internship. It felt less like he was fighting a beast, and more like welcoming the warm heat of a burning inferno. Black figures manifested themselves around him, reaching for him. Their words were unintelligible, in an ancient language that sounded a lot like gibberish.

He tried giving them a bit of his power, something he didn’t do often.

The figures started to look less grainy than before, and more human-like. The power surged within him and he took a deep breath to center himself. Sweat pooled in his hands that held the fire, but he didn’t stop.

“That’s ten minutes,” Shouta told him softly, or at least it *sounded* soft. Or maybe it was just muffled. “Can you keep going?”

Izuku nodded, letting the fire flare higher as heat washed over him. His longest time of holding half of his power within him was around twenty minutes. His power would probably be more manageable in his Other form—as he was so kindly beginning to call it.

Maybe if he transformed he could use one hundred percent? But if he couldn't hold all of his power within this form, he couldn't hope to *control* it in his Other form. This was progress.

"You're doing really well, do you want to stop for today?" Shouta asked, pulling him back from his thoughts. Izuku considered it for a moment, before slowly reeling in his power. The flames flickered out, the demons before him vanished, and the power was sent to sleep beneath his skin.

If only he could master his transformation…

Then he wouldn't have to wear his suppressant. Then he could live without fear of accidentally killing people.

Shouta came over and handed him the cross. He took it gratefully, clasping it around his neck before his classmates joined him again.

They didn't look scared like he thought they would. In fact, Ashido's eyes seemed to be sparkling with excitement. "Midori, you've gotten so much better!"

"Yeah, man! You didn't look half as scared as I remember! Do you think Midoriya could join our training sessions soon, Aizawa?" Sero asked, "It's kinda sad he has to do them alone."

Izuku watched Shouta closely, ignoring the way his heart swelled with hope in his chest. He wanted to train alongside Kacchan! But he doubted Shouta would let him.

"He has a ways to go before it's safe for him to train independently with all of you," Shouta explained. "But he's gotten much better. It should be fine if I'm with him to make sure he doesn't push himself."

[Really? I can train with Kacchan?]

“Yeah,” Shouta told him, scratching the back of his neck with a slight smile. “You need to do a bit of training with your classmates before the final exams.”

Izuku tried to hide his smile, but Shinsou smirked at him knowingly. “Bakugou will be happy about that,” he remarked, and Izuku elbowed him.

Finding Inko’s cell was easy for Hisashi. They had kept her in the Musutafu prison but Hisashi had no trouble getting inside. All for One had granted him with a permeation Quirk just for this job. So Hisashi had simply walked through the walls and knocked out any roaming guards with his Pain and Panic Quirk.

Earlier in the week, he’d broken out a couple of criminals, but that wasn’t important right now. Those criminals were important for later on. Right now, he needed to get Inko and get the hell out of here.

Hisashi roamed the halls, trying to find the cell they had put her in. A lot of them had buff men lounging around; and as he passed, they tried to get him to release them. He ignored their desperate begging as he checked his phone again.

Her cell was supposed to be around here somewhere. He eyed the fluorescently lit halls lined with cells. And then he saw it.

He rushed over and smiled at his wife who was trapped on the other side.

“Ah, nice to see you again, Hisashi.”

Chapter End Notes

And as always here's the discord invite if you want to join!

Chapter 67

Chapter Summary

All for One being fucking creepy and the media being dicks

Chapter Notes

Sorry I took a break for a bit because my wrist really hurt... ouchie. Also, I MADE A LOT OF PRIDE PFP ICONS FOR DISCORD SO IF YALL JOIN MY DISCORD AND WANT A CUSTOM ICON I THINK I CAN MAKE YALL SOME. I MADE A LOT FOR D.GRAY-MAN SO!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

All for One listened to the soft mechanical inhale of his medical machinery. It was only one of the few reasons why he was still breathing in the first place. His condition was worsening by the day, just as All Might's power was dwindling. But even back when he was training Izuku—who *still* had yet to fall back into his embrace, the stubborn child—All for One hadn't needed to use the mask to get around. He needed to find a way around this eventually.

But at the moment, he had more pressing matters at hand.

He tapped his fingers on the armrest of his chair. Hisashi was taking a bit longer than he originally expected. It was a simple mission to get Inko freed, to liberate her from the small prison they deemed enough to stop *them,* the League of Villains. It was almost too easy. Mere child's play in his eyes as he sent one of his pawns to retrieve his Queen.

The board was set, his Queen would soon be safe, and the game could begin. It would only be a matter of time before he caught Izuku again and twisted him to fit the mold. All for One stopped tapping his armest and dug his nails into the wood.

It was only a matter of time before Izuku became the new King, and All for One would watch from the shadows like a doting father.

But first, he had to fix Izuku's little *problem* . He was reliant on Heroes and he wanted to *be* one. It didn't make sense to him. His Quirk was beautifully perfect for villainy. There was no way in hell that the world would accept him and that Quirk of his.

All for One had already seen the Sports Festival forums for this year, and it was nothing but videos of Izuku raising from the dead on live television.

The internet was thrown through a loop. They were demanding answers, and Yuuei wasn't giving them. It was breeding distrust and concern. And with the fiasco that was the Stain incident in Hosu, the people were getting restless.

They were beginning to ask interesting questions about Izuku Midoriya: What was his Quirk? How did he revive himself during the Sports Festival? What kind of monsters do they let into Yuuei?

He couldn't wait to see how Yuuei would react. He couldn't wait to see how *Izuku* would react to their harsh words and questions. How far would Yuuei go to protect him? Were they aware of what kind of monster they were harboring?

He even added to the fire by posting the classified file online about Hisashi and Inko being villains.

Soon enough all their questions would be answered. He just had to wait and see how everything panned out. If his speculation was right—it always was—then the world would be turning its back on Izuku soon enough. And that would be the moment where he could snatch him.

That would be the moment where he could finally pass on his power. He could finally crush Izuku's dreams into the dirt once and for all.

He would be forced to become a villain and All for One couldn't wait to see what the boy would do. He couldn't wait to see the world regret turning its back on him.

This boy could end the world. He didn't even need All for One's Quirk for that, but it would surely be interesting to see the boy crumble under the weight of such a dangerous Quirk.

Or maybe he would rise to the challenge and become something even darker than All for One had been. The boy was practically a god. He could call upon the demons of hell with less than a thought. His sheer raw power was too much for Izuku himself to contain, seeing as it was growing every single day.

The longer he used it, the more power he subconsciously siphoned from the Underworld. Either he would learn to control his growing power, or it would consume him.

He would become a beast and wreak havoc on the world like some divine punishment. All in all, he thought Morningstar would've made a better villain name than one for a Hero.

He smiled.

They still had plenty of time to fix that. It wasn't like he was about to keel over and die at any given moment. He still had years. That was plenty of time to shove that boy into the mold, even if he had to break him to do it.

No one else was worthy of such a power.

Even Shigaraki was too hard-headed and impulsive to do much with it. But for Izuku…

It would be a wonderful *punishment* .

Nedzu wasn't sure how he was going to deal with this problem. The media had started a rather harsh uproar after Midoriya's fight with Stain. They were demanding formal and public answers from Nedzu himself.

They wanted to know what kind of "monster" Yuuei had let into it's school. Videos of Midoriya falling from the sky, tearing Stain apart like some vengeful God had gotten around, and people were once again trying to get an explanation for Midoriya's miraculous revival at the Sports Festival.

They were itching for answers, and soon enough they'd try anything to get them. Word even got out that his parents were villains, and that seemed to make the situation even worse. It was a disaster.

That's why he decided he should probably hold a public conference to clear everything up, but it wouldn't be enough. He would need real proof that Midoriya wasn't a threat.

And he knew that All Might had a strange relationship with one of the only people who could provide such proof. He couldn't afford to have the media demonize Midoriya at such a peaceful time. He wanted to protect this boy with everything he had, and God be damned if he let Midoriya suffer through the scrutiny of the media.

It was truly one of the many reasons why the turn-over rate for heroes was so high. That's why he called All Might into his office long before school was set to begin.

"What is it that you would like to speak to me about?" Toshinori mumbled as he shifted awkwardly in his seat. Ah, yes. He'd probably been sitting here for a while with a strange look in his eyes, as Toshinori was looking at him strangely.

"Oh yes," Nedzu began, clearing his thoughts for a moment. He'd gotten rather distracted. "I think you've noticed the sudden surge of attention directed toward Young Midoriya. The media has suddenly become restless since Midoriya fought Stain…"

Toshinori nodded, taking a thoughtful sip of his tea. Nedzu could tell, because Toshinori furrowed his brow and sipped his tea like he wasn't really tasting it at all.

“The forums have been about nothing but him lately. And it’s nothing good either,” Toshinori mumbled. “That’s what you brought me here for? You think I can fix it?”

“Unfortunately, no. That would be nigh impossible,” Nedzu grumbled. If only all the world’s problems could be solved by All Might’s words. “I would like you to help me contact Sir Nighteye.”

Toshinori choked on his tea, spilling it in his lap and letting out a string of curses. Nedzu dutifully passed him a few napkins. Toshinori avoided answering him by attempting to dry himself off for a few moments.

Nedzu waited patiently, with his paws resting on his desk.

“W-why Sir Nighteye, of all people?” Toshinori asked, and Nedzu noted that he looked paler than before. “I’m not sure how he could be of any help in a situation like this.”

Nedzu gave him a wide smile and that made the Symbol of Peace even paler than before. “Well, logically speaking, Sir Nighteye could dispel every rumor pertaining to Midoriya. Theoretically, he could look into Midoriya’s future and give the public proof that Midroya will have a Heroic career. He could easily end this mess before it even has the chance to begin, by reassuring the populace that Midoriya will use his Quirk for nothing but good. Right now, it’s not good for Midoriya to be subjected to any public scrutiny. He finally seems to be settling in well with Eraserhead and Present Mic. Eraserhead even adopted him. He still has a long way to go in terms of healing mentally from everything his parents did to him. I can’t imagine how disheartening it would be for him if he was questioned by a mob of reporters about his true intentions.” Nedzu laced his paws together, feeling a surge of anger.

At himself, for his unprofessional behavior all the way back at the USJ. “He’s spent his entire life trying to become a hero, despite his less than favorable environment. Even I questioned his intentions. To hear that the world doesn’t believe in him and that they’re scared of him will only result in a massive slide backwards in terms of healing and in the progression of learning to control his Quirk.”

“Right now is a very, very delicate time for Young Midoriya it seems,” Toshinori agreed, nodding slowly. “And you’d like me to contact him, wouldn’t you? That’s why you’re telling me all of this.”

“Exactly. I feel like we’d be killing two birds with one stone if *you* were the one to reach out to Sir Nighteye. Of course, I’d allow an ample amount of time for you two to reconcile after such a quarrel from all those years ago. And of course, I’ve been trying to recruit Nighteye into teaching here at Yuuei, so there’s a chance of me finally getting through to him on that.”

“I see, so you have multiple reasons as to why you want him to come to Yuuei,” Toshinori grumbled as if he’d been expecting it the entire time.

“Of course I do, but I’m more concerned about keeping Midoriya’s name from being slandered before he can even debut,” Nedzu told him firmly. “I don’t take kindly to people trying to sully the name of one of my children before they even have a chance to prove them wrong.”

“I do have one other concern, Nedzu,” Toshinori began, fiddling with his sleeve. “You never mentioned how the Hero Commission has reacted to Young Midoriya. His Quirk is an anomaly even among the weirdest of Quirks. I know first hand that the Commission can be cruel to those with threatening Quirks.”

“I’ve been dealing with them,” Nedzu told him, looking down into his cup of tea thoughtfully. “They won’t be a problem for much longer, once we clear up this mess,” Nedzu mumbled, “So will you be contacting Sir Nighteye soon?”

“Yes, of course,” Toshinori told him, beginning to stand.

“That's good to hear,” Nedzu replied, “I’m sorry to keep you for so long.”

“It’s no problem. I’m just glad that you’re looking out for Young Midoriya,” Toshinori said as a way of saying goodbye. He closed the door softly behind him, and Nedzu sipped at his now cold tea.

Nedzu leaned back in his chair and sighed rather heavily. “Not enough people are on Midoriya’s side at the moment,” he said to himself, dragging a paw down his face. “This could be bad.”

This entire plan could be a disaster if it isn’t done soon. Very bad indeed.

He was glad that Midoriya had fully recovered from the Hosu Incident.

Nedzu had been watching Midoriya train for the past few days with his classmates. It was merely out of curiosity and concern for his physical health after what happened at Hosu. He was progressing faster than Nedzu had thought possible. His control was near-perfect, but the power was continuously building and growing.

He would have to continue to work at it until the power stagnated, but Nedzu wasn’t sure if that was ever going to happen. It was a dangerous thought to have. It was likely that possessing that much power, with nowhere to go, would put a toll on Midoriya’s mind and body.

But maybe…

Maybe since Midoriya’s Quirk wasn’t *actually* a Quirk anymore, then maybe Midoriya could handle it. That was another thing entirely. Maybe he should speak to Aizawa about it at some point?

Midoriya’s power was constantly growing and changing. Perhaps there was nothing to worry about. But Nedzu would keep an eye out for Midoriya, just to be sure. With a power that dangerous, Midoriya would definitely need help.

Brushing off his thoughts, he turned his attention back to the training gym.

Nedzu stood next to All Might, who was overseeing the other students' training. Midoriya was working with Aizawa and Tokoyami at the moment.

He'd been watching how Aizawa slowly integrated him back into training alongside his class. Earlier it had been Bakugou over there, and after that, it had been Iida.

He'd also watched as Midoriya methodically went through random sword stances, and was once again reminded that Stain had been his mentor. That he had to kill his mentor twice over. He had to feel that agony *twice* , and the media wanted to paint him as a terrifying god of damnation for it.

Nedzu couldn't allow that. "So," He cleared his throat, glancing up at the hulking form of All Might. "How is trying to contact Sir Nighteye going?"

All Might sighed heavily, and Nedzu had a feeling he knew his answer. "He has been ignoring my calls."

"I see," Nedzu chewed uselessly on his lip. "Keep trying. We're running out of time."

The night that Sir Nighteye refused to help them was also the night that Inko Midoriya broke out of prison. It was the night that everything exploded and the internet practically broke over one single picture taken by the woman herself.

Nedzu was sitting in his chair in his office at five in the morning with Present Mic, Eraserhead, and All Might sitting opposite of him.

They all sat in silence, a computer screen illuminating the room with its soft light.

IZUKU MIDORIYA IS REALLY A VILLAIN? HAS YUUEI MADE A TERRIBLE MISTAKE?

The first-year student, Izuku Midoriya, started this school year along with everyone else in his class. He scored highest on the entrance exam, making him the top of his class alongside Bakugou Katsuki, who also attained the same score. Up until now, there has been no reason to doubt the intentions of Izuku Midoriya.

Up until the Sports Festival, he seemed like a regular student. During the Sports Festival is when our suspicions began.

Look below for the entirety of Bakugou Katsuki's speech:

"There will come a day where All Might falls, and a new Symbol of Peace will take his place. Right now, you may not know who it will be. But I do. I've known for a long time. Some may say that this person's Quirk is a Quirk fit for a villain. Some may say that he should've been a villain. I know you all might think the same thing, but by the end of today you won't be able to deny his strength. The name of the Next Symbol of Peace is… [REDACTED]."

Despite Bakugou's heartwarming—even if we now realize all of it is a stack of lies a mile long—speech, it doesn't change the fact that Midoriya is a villain.

Neito Monoma seemed to reach this conclusion before we did, by dubbing Midoriya as "the devil," after copying his Quirk. What seems to be an even more damning piece of evidence is that All for One solidified our suspicions with his speech.

"Izuku Midoriya… The only one to ever betray me, and live to see another day. You are truly an enigma. So I've been watching you, ever since you left my side…"

"Every move you've made… every breath you've taken… I've watched you. I've been right there, watching. You've never been safe. You never really escaped me. I'm coming for you. This is all just a display of my power. To remind you who you betrayed. To remind you who

is hunting you down. Everything that happens today will be your fault. Every tortured scream will be your fault. Every ounce of spilled blood will be on you. What kind of hero will you be then?"

The speech obviously points to previous villainous activity. It also points to the entire Midoriya family consisting of villains, and that his parents were involved with the man. This proves that he's a dangerous individual.

All for One makes his purpose very obvious as well. He's eager to get Midoriya to turn back to his side. Even more damning is his fight with Stain.

At the moment, we're unable to find clear footage of the fight, but many witness reports state that Midoriya was unnecessarily cruel. According to the incident's file, Midoriya tore Stain apart as they were falling from the sky.

It was also noted that he had horns and wings, like some sort of devil. Lastly, earlier tonight, it was reported that Inko Midoriya has broken out of prison. Written on the walls of her cell is even more solidifying proof.

IZUKU MIDORIYA IS A VILLAIN.

How will Yuuei respond to our evidence, if they acknowledge it at all? Izuku Midoriya is a freak of nature and a villain biding his time until he can destroy Yuuei from the inside out.

Has Yuuei made a horrendous mistake that will haunt them for years?

-Hero Journalist Taneo Tokuda, from Juzo News.

Nedzu let that article sink in. He straightened his spine and glared at the infernal screen. Of course this article had twisted it's words around to favor their point of view. He pressed his lips into a thin line, watching as All Might deflated right before his eyes.

Eraserhead and Present Mic looked near murderous. Nedzu slammed his laptop closed and gave them a smile he never thought he'd have to use.

"Something *must* be done."

Chapter End Notes

Discord link: the link, my dudes

Also, I've come to the point where I have to moderate my comments?? Like I get a lot of hate comments about how the plot is too dark and disgusting and it's gotten to the point where I'm just going to delete those comments! So it might take me a while to answer you guys... but I'll try to keep up! Also, I love the constructive criticism I'm getting too! Someone said Izuku has regressive character development and honestly, I can see it LMAO I would fix it but that would involve changing so much of the fic so hopefully, you guys stick around despite that. Also I started TGCF (the Heaven Official's Blessing Novel which TOTALLY didn't make me completely forget to update too, aside from my hurt wrist... I love HuaLian oh my fucking god)

Chapter 68

Chapter Summary

Dadzawa for the soul, and Midoriya's classmates reacting to the media's slander of Mido.

Chapter Notes

I hope you enjoy this chapter!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tenya was coming to school from a particularly relaxing weekend at home when he noticed that something was off. Everything seemed to be slightly tilted and strange as he walked closer and closer to the gates of Yuuei.

A lot of the people he passed seemed to have their heads ducked together, whispering about something. He even saw a few fellow students acting strangely. Even more so when they finally noticed him, breaking out into harsh whispers and burning glares.

He didn’t understand, not even when he finally made it to the gates and figured out what was so strange. It filled him with a burning rage he never thought he’d feel.

Fumikage was nearly mobbed on his way through the Yuuei gates.

The reporters were asking him about Midoriya, which he thought was strange. They asked him strange questions, but he answered them honestly.

Did he trust Midoriya? Of course he did. Did he think Midoriya was a threat? Absolutely not. Maybe he was missing something important? He glanced back at the gates and saw it.

He pulled his phone out hastily and Dark Shadow nearly took over his body in the blinding sunlight. Anger seeped into his skin like fire and he glared at the device in his hand.

If you would've asked Hanta's opinion on Midoriya a few weeks ago, the answer would've been flat-out cruel. He would've told anyone who listened that Midoriya was dangerous, callous, and evil. All because he could hardly control his Quirk.

Now, though… His answer wasn't simple. He still had rather mixed feelings about Midoriya's powers, but he no longer felt like he was in danger. Midoriya had gotten enough training to control his Quirk rather well, in Hanta's opinion.

He was actively trying to be less of a danger to those around him, and it showed. Especially when they were training together in class, Midoriya spent a lot of his time trying to maintain his control while getting attacked from three different directions. It had been an exercise Aizawa had created on the spot, so multiple people could practice their Quirks all at once.

It was Midoriya's job to fight while maintaining impeccable control over his raw power. His internship with Aizawa-sensei had improved his skills exponentially. So he wouldn't exactly say that Midoriya was threatening anymore. He wouldn't say that Midoriya was a villain either. So when the press asked him that, as he tried to squeeze his way through the gate, he squashed the rumor.

"Is Midoriya a villain?"

"No," Hanta snapped, pulling tighter on his backpack strap. "He's a hero."

But the way they seemed to snarl at him set him on edge.

He checked his phone once he got to class, and was *not* pleased with what he'd found.

Hitoshi was never one for violence, but at this moment, after waking up in his dorm, he was ready for war. It was everywhere.

There were already YouTube videos about it. There was fucking *propaganda* about it. Hitoshi bolted out of his bed, ignoring how rude he was probably being to everyone who was still sleeping. It didn't fucking matter. This was too important. Especially for Bakugou.

He was surprised when the door to Bakugou's room was unlocked and opened easily. He only hesitated for a second, before ripping the covers off of the explosive blond. He of all people deserved to know what was going on.

"Why the fuck are you in my room?" was Bakugou's immediate response, as he glared at Hitoshi while grabbing around for his blanket. "What the fuck's going on?"

"Have you seen it?" Hitoshi asked, sounding a bit snappish as he spoke. He didn't care. Bakugou needed to know as soon as possible. This was fucking *serious.* This was *bad.*

Bakugou blinked three times before dragging a hand down his face. "Seen what, Control Freak?"

Hitoshi fished his phone out of his pocket and unlocked it, practically throwing it at Bakugou. He crossed his arms and watched as Bakugou's face morphed into something murderous. The boy took a few minutes to scan the article again and then thrust it back into Hitoshi's hand.

"How the *fuck* did this happen?" Bakugou asked, practically spitting venom, and the promise for vengeance. "Fucking… and Inko…"

Seemingly overnight, a number of things had happened. Firstly, Inko Midoriya had somehow been broken out of her cell and a message had been left for the world to see. Secondly, Juzo News had released an article a few hours afterward, spewing utter bullshit about Midoriya being a fucking villain. Information had been leaked that Hisashi and Inko were in cahoots with All for One.

Then, as if the world wanted to punish Midoriya even more, someone had created a forum with depictions of Midoriya as a *satanic monster.* It had gone viral. All of it. People were posting about it *everywhere.*

"I'm not sure," Hitoshi began, scrolling through all of the posts that had been created. "Last night at some point, and now *everyone* knows and seems to agree."

They all seemed to think Midoriya was some kind of monster, hellbent on killing all of them. Like they were just lambs to the slaughter. Like they expected Midoriya to drop out of the sky like some angry god and kill them all *just because he could.*

People had already compiled photos of Midoriya with his wings and horns during his Stain fight. Somewhere along the line, someone had posted a video of Midoriya *falling out of the sky,* and using it as further proof.

There were already forums dedicated to his weaknesses and fears. The population had already decided that Midoriya was the devil and he needed to be wiped from the Earth. It was like he was getting persecuted.

Almost as if someone behind the scenes was orchestrating the whole thing…

Katsuki was, first and foremost, pissed. Not only was the internet agreeing with everything the media had done to slander Deku's name, but Deku hadn't even shown up to class. Neither had Aizawa-sensei, and Nedzu had to fill in to teach them for the day. It was a nightmare, and worst of all, Deku wasn't answering his texts.

It was pissing him off.

Izuku felt like someone dumped a bucket of freezing cold water down his back. All of the blood in his body had seemed to freeze and creak in his veins. He couldn't even hold his spoon correctly when he attempted to bring it up to his mouth to eat his cereal. He ended up staring at his breakfast as if he dissociated while milk gathered on the bottom of his spoon and dropped silently back into his bowl.

Numbly, he looked up at Shouta, who still had yet to say anything. He was holding his head in his hands and he sighed heavily again. He'd been doing it for the past five minutes and Hizashi was in the living room pacing like a concerned mother.

But they had yet to tell him what was even going on. The both of them were just sharing concerned looks, acting as if the world was ending or something. It was terrifying, and they were an hour late to school. At this point, he figured he wasn't going today, but it set in on edge. The silence was thick, and every so often, his cereal would become extremely interesting.

But now he was sweating and his worry was making his mind frantic. Had he done something wrong? Were they angry? Were they thinking about telling him that they weren't going to adopt him? What was wrong with him?

They didn't look like they'd ever answer him. With trembling hands, he ended up signing to Shouta in an attempt to get him to explain.

[What's going on?]

The question seems to make Shouta flinch. Automatically, fear seemed to coil around his heart like squeezing vines, constricting his chest. He swallowed thickly and watched Shouta carefully. An unbearable weight appeared to be weighing him down.

Like there's some sort of secret he carried that dragged him down. And it's nothing good. Shouta's eyes flashed with pity and worry, and Izuku found himself wringing his hands worriedly. Something was very wrong with this entire environment, but he couldn't, for the life of him, figure it out.

His mind reeled, trying to frantically grasp onto any possible reason as to why this could be happening. Every mistake he'd made up until now flashed just behind his eyes; but none of it fit. It didn't click.

There's a long pause before Shouta stood, coming around the table to squat beside Izuku's chair. In response, Izuku shifted to face him, and Shouta slowly grabbed his hands, just like Kacchan did.

His voice was soft and gentle. He squeezed Izuku's hands again. "Listen, Izuku. Last night… something happened," Izuku pressed his lips together and tried to pull his hands away. Shouta held firm, looking up at Izuku slightly.

Fear's gleaming claws were already wrapped around him like a cage with no key. Whatever it was, he didn't want to hear it. Not if Shouta kept looking at him like *that.* Like someone *died.*

"No," Shouta told him gently, his thumbs ghosting over his scarred knuckles. "You need to listen, Izuku. Inko broke out of prison last night."

His ears were ringing. The world felt muffled and quiet, like he's underwater. He blinked and watched Shouta's mouth move but no words came out. He wasn't registering anything. His brain stopped working and he could already feel the tears stinging his eyes. And—oh God he's *weak* and *pathetic.*

The mere mention of his mother somewhere out there in the world, being free, had his brain shorting out and tears shining in his eyes. The foundation on which his world sat was cracking and he can hardly breathe past the lump in his throat.

He didn’t realize he was scratching his neck violently until Shouta pulled his hand away. “It’s okay, Izuku,” he tells him, even though he can hardly hear it. “You’re safe with us.”

But how could he ever be safe when *she* could be anywhere at any given moment? How was that even possible, with the people he’d gotten himself involved with?

All for One had been right. He wasn’t safe anywhere and they were hunting him. That man was beginning to move his pieces and set the board. And Inko was free. She was *free,* walking the streets of Musutafu like she owned them. It was only a matter of time before All for One revealed his pieces, and Izuku needed to be prepared.

He shouldn’t let this all-consuming fear control him, but his mind was buzzing too loudly to do much less. He should plan, but he was drowning with anchors on each foot, pulling him down, down, down.

He wasn’t safe *anywhere* . He would never be safe. With his mother back in the game, Izuku was sure to lose. Izuku was terrified.

And he was sinking fast.

He brought his hands to his face, blocking his vision of everything around him. He *shouldn’t* be spiraling, yet he was. He should be planning and thinking of All for One’s next move, yet there was nothing but fear and terror. He was choking on it.

It surrounded him on all sides like a fortress. He couldn’t claw his way out and it was getting *dark* . The inky black of impending doom was rushing for him, and there was nothing he could do to stop it.

There was no way out. There was no way out. *There was no way out. He was going to die—*

“Izuku.”

He could barely breathe.

“Look at me,” Dabi said firmly. “Don’t look at anything else. Just look at me.”

He shook his head. He couldn’t be wasting time trying to calm down, not when All for One could strike at any moment.

He needed to train. He needed to get stronger. He needed to master his transformation. The only way he could win against All for One was if he trained. That man had two hundred years of experience on him, what with running an underground villain organization since the dawn of Quirks and all.

Not today. I won’t be ruled by fear today. I need to get stronger. I don’t have time to be terrified.

He pushed away the feeling of impending doom that followed him like a lost puppy. He pushed away the fear—shoving it deep into the darker depths of his mind—and ignored the ache in his chest.

Fear would shackle him and hold him back. He needed to break free of these chains and master *all* of himself. And he was beginning to realize exactly how he could master the infernal power within him. He just needed to do what he did during his internship.

With a deep breath, he pulled himself together haphazardly; he pushed the pieces back together, even if they didn’t quite fit. He snapped his eyes open and was surprised to see that Dabi, Hizashi and Shouta were all watching him with varying levels of worry.

He wiped at his drying tears, shoving all of his emotions down.

[Is there anything else you need to tell me?]

“Shouta,” Hizashi mumbled softly once Izuku retreated to his room with Dabi. “Tell me I’m not the only one who saw that.”

Shouta nodded, threading his hands together with a heavy sigh. “He’s bottling up his emotions. That’s not healthy.”

“Should we, I dunno, say something to him about it?” Hizashi asked, running a hand through his hair, slumping in his chair. “If he keeps it bottled up, he’ll explode.”

“Not right now,” Shouta mumbled, taking a hold of his husband’s hand. “Let’s ask him later.”

“Okay,” Hizashi relented, before sighing heavily again. “I think we should’ve told him about the media though.”

“We can do that tomorrow,” Shouta put his head in his hands. The boy was already going through so much. “I don’t think he could handle *that* on top of everything else. Plus, Nedzu’s dealing with it.”

Nedzu was not dealing with this well. Teaching an entire class on his own about Quirk Theory was not as easy as he had originally imagined. A lot of Class 1-A had fallen asleep, and Young Bakugou kept looking around as if Midoriya would pop up out of nowhere.

It was a relief for everyone—himself included—when All Might took over the class. He trudged back to his office, anger bubbling just beneath his skin. He’d tried to contact Sir Nighteye himself this morning, but the man flat-out refused to even meet with him.

It was infuriating. The man was petty, but Nedzu was prepared to be even pettier in response. That's why he called Mirio Togata to his office as soon as he closed the door.

If Sir Nighteye wouldn't listen to Nedzu, then maybe he'd listen to his pupil. He didn't bring out his tea as he usually did. He didn't even sit at his desk.

He was too angry with the media for that. He wanted to get straight to the point and recruit Sir Nighteye as soon as possible. This entire situation was ridiculous. He took a seat on the couch he rarely used, placed his paws on the coffee table, and waited for Young Mirio to arrive.

Waiting was agony, but eventually, the bubbly boy entered his office, looking more worried than usual. "You wanted to see me, Principal?"

"Do come in, Young Mirio," Nedzu began, pointing to the couch opposite of him. "We have a lot to talk about."

Mirio looked pretty concerned, but Nedzu paid it no mind. Nighteye was going to help Midoriya even if he didn't want to. He refused to allow Nighteye to sit on the sidelines any longer.

That man was supposed to be a Hero, yet he wouldn't even help one of Nedzu's students. Pure idiocy.

He watched as Mirio took a seat and got comfortable. He waited a few more seconds before he began to speak. "You've seen the news of Young Midoriya, haven't you?"

Mirio's mood seemed to darken. "Yeah," he mumbled, fiddling with his sleeves. "I think it's crazy that people are actually believing it. Even some of my classmates believe it."

Ah, so it's worse than I imagined. I'm going to have to get the names of his classmates and have a talk with them.

"There is a shred of proof in their statements, however," Nedzu began, "His parents *are* villains, and they *are* affiliated with All for One. But rest assured that I've already come to the conclusion that Midoriya is going to be a Hero. It's his life's goal, and I'm not about to allow the media to crush that dream."

Mirio smiled slightly and tugged at his sleeves again. "But why did you call me here? What can I do to help?"

"I need to have a public conference with some reporters. Unfortunately, my word alone will not be enough to placate the populace. For it to be effective, I need Nighteye's assistance. If he can look into Midoriya's future and see that he will be a Hero, then we can use that at the conference to put everyone at ease."

Mirio stroked his chin, putting the pieces together on his own. Nedzu could practically see the gears turning in his mind. "You want me to convince Sir Nighteye to help you, right?"

Nedzu's smile was an answer all on its own. "Yes. Will you do it?"

The boy leaned back into the cushions of the couch, his brow furrowed in thought. Then he leaned forward and scratched his head, sighing heavily. Nedzu clasped his paws together and watched the boy closely.

"I'll do it," he said finally, crossing his arms. "Do you have a plan?"

Nedzu then looked at the thick folder sitting on the table between them. He pushed it closer to Mirio and gestured to it.

"Yes, of course I do, Young Mirio."

Shouta knew Izuku wanted to be left alone but he really didn't care at this point. He opened the door to his son's room slowly, finding Izuku curled up in his bed.

Izuku looked up at him as he walked inside. Shouta felt his heart break at the thinly-veiled fear in his son's expression. He took a seat at the edge of Izuku's bed and sighed heavily.

And he just started talking. The words tumbled out.

"I know you're scared," is what he said to start off. "I know it may seem like she's creeping around every corner and as if the world is caving in on you, but I want you to know that as long as I'm here, she can't touch you. As long as Hizashi is here, she won't get anywhere near you. You probably won't believe what I say, but I promise you it's true."

He turned to look at him. Tears were silently falling down Izuku's face and Shouta opened his arms to offer a hug.

Izuku didn't hesitate and Shouta wrapped his arms around him tightly. "You're safe here. I promise you."

His son didn't nod, but at least he's not alone anymore.

Chapter End Notes

Here's the Discord link homies: clickie click here

Chapter 69

Chapter Summary

CHAPTER 69 LMAO

Chapter Notes

ok there's no reason why I didn't update, aside from the small project I've been writing for D.gray-man!! :DD (its a Yullen Howl's Moving Castle AU if there are any yullen fans reading this.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mirai was beginning to feel a headache building. Toshinori wouldn't stop calling him and even Nedzu was begging for his assistance. He really didn't want to get involved with a student who wasn't Mirio Togata.

He had too much work to do with there not being enough staff to divide it equally, so he ended up with most of it. That's just the man he was. He didn't want to overwork his sidekicks and interns, and as a result, he couldn't afford to help Nedzu and All Might. He was drowning in a sea of paperwork he had created for himself.

Besides, he and Toshinori—All Might—weren't on good terms. Ever since their split, they hadn't been the same. Toshinori was too afraid to contact him, and Mirai was too afraid of what he might accidentally say to the man. Anger was an unbelievably strong emotion.

He might say something he could never take back, like he did all those years ago. He might do more damage than good, and that's what terrified him the most. Plus, he didn't feel like he deserved a second chance at all.

And how could he even help this child that supposedly *needed* saving? He'd seen the horrendous posts about Midoriya online, and he was sad to say that he couldn't do much.

Sure, he could look into his memories and see a Heroic future, but would the media even believe him or acknowledge it? Probably not.

Midoriya would have to prove himself to the media on his own. He couldn't rely on the school to save him from every threat, and it was a Hero's job to deal with scandals created by the media and blown out of proportion. Mirai didn't really understand the need for *him* to save Midoriya. It was a waste of time and resources.

He should learn to do it on his own. The world of Heroes was pretty cut-throat.

Mirai ran a hand through his hair, skimming the report Mirio had submitted a few days ago about stopping a petty thief. It was a pretty thorough report, but Mirai didn't have the brain power to actually bother reading it over. He went ahead and stamped it, completely confident that it was up to standard.

Mirio was pretty good about following protocol.

There was a knock at his door suddenly, and Mirai nearly fell out of his chair from being so absorbed in his thoughts. He cleared his throat, and licked at his lips hastily.

"Come in," he mumbled, just loud enough for whoever was on the other side to hear him. He was expecting Bubble Girl out of everyone in the agency. Mirai and her were beginning to work on the Kai Chisaki case and she often came to him for advice.

It wasn't Bubble Girl who entered his office. It wasn't even Centipeder, who often offered to help him with his mountains of paperwork. It was Mirio Togata, with his usual chipper attitude and blinding, heroic smile.

Just seeing it made Mirai swell with pride. This was the Hero *he* had helped create.
Lemillion. The hero who will save a million. The next All Might.

This was a hero worth his time. This was a student he cared about, not Midoriya, whose image had already been dragged through the dirt. If Midoriya couldn't pull himself out of this one, then maybe he didn't need to be a hero.

The speech from their Sports Festival still rang in his ears. Young Bakugou at the time had it in his mind that Midoriya of all people would become the next Symbol. But he'd been wrong. So very, very wrong. Mirio was next in line to hold the world on his shoulders, and if the media saw Midoriya as the devil incarnate—as his *Hero Name* suggested—then who was he to disagree?

Who was he, to prove the world wrong when he wished for Mirio to become the Pillar? Who was he, to help someone who could potentially take Mirio's place?

He didn't want to ruin everything he'd built. After all, Rome wasn't built in a day, but it was burned in one. He couldn't risk helping Midoriya if it meant dismantling his masterpiece. Mirio was worth ten of Midoriya.

Their value just wasn't the same to him. He didn't have the time, nor the drive to help Young Midoriya, even after getting calls from Nedzu and Toshinori.

"Sir?" Mirio mumbled softly, to get his attention. How long had he been spaced out, thinking of nothing but how Mirio would surpass Midoriya for sure? "A-are you listening?"

He shook himself out of his reverie and pushed his glasses up the bridge of his nose. "My apologies, what were we talking about?"

Mirio licks at his lips nervously and wrings his hands. A bad sign. "Well…" he began, looking a little worried, as he decided how to word all of everything. "I was wondering if you'd help Midoriya-kun? I've seen the news, Sir, and I don't think it's fair that they're treating him like that just because of his Quirk."

It took an act of God to keep his composure. The anger flared like a crackling fire beneath his skin begging to burn and decimate his entire building. Again with that useless act of helping

Midoriya. He let out a deep, suffering sigh. Of course Mirio would beg Mirai to do something about this; he was a hero in training.

That's just the kind of Hero Mirio was becoming.

Mirai straightened his spine and threaded his fingers together as he pretended to give it a thought. He'd already decided, long before Mirio decided to have this conversation. Midoriya didn't need, nor deserve, Mirai's help.

"Mirio," he began, and Mirio seemed to look hopeful. "I don't think it's a good use of my time to help Midoriya."

At this, Mirio looked perplexed, maybe even a little angry. But Mirai would be glad to see Midoriya fall if it meant that Mirio could rise to greatness.

Maybe that made him a horrible person, but he didn't care.

Nightmares chased him, trying to pull him in with their beautiful exterior only to reveal their ugly, monstrous faces as soon as they had him in their grasp. Even in the most beautiful and alluring dreams, there seemed to be darkness hidden there somewhere.

Darkness that hid behind a carefully crafted veil.

In short, Izuku didn't sleep very well.

He dreamt of a caring mother, with a smile as bright as the sun. He never noticed the knife she held behind her back, or how her smile was made of glass. He only noticed when she buried the knife in his chest and he woke up panting in his bed.

Every time he went to sleep, he dreamt of gilded hopes, only for the illusion of beauty to fade. It was worse than having a truly terrifying nightmare. He was constantly waiting for the other shoe to drop as he watched the happiness fade away.

He tossed and turned all night. And staying awake wasn't ideal either. Every creak of the house settling had his entire body tensing in preparation to fight. His mother could be anywhere. She could be hunting him right this second, and the fear came rushing back like a surging tide.

Izuku could hardly shut his eyes after a while. He couldn't stop thinking about how she could do all sorts of things with her Quirk. All of them deadly, and none of them good. She could potentially stop his heart in his chest without leaving any evidence that *she* was the one who did it.

The impending doom was too great. The fear of her wrath froze him to his position on his bed. How could he possibly go to school like this? He couldn't even blink, for the fear that Inko would just *appear*.

"Izuku," Dabi said gently, his voice hardly above a whisper. Izuku didn't uncurl from the ball he'd wrapped himself in. He just stared blankly at the wall directly in front of him, and the soft, warm light of Kacchan's night light.

Dabi spoke again, his voice just a touch louder. "Look, I'm guarding the door, okay? No one will get in. You can go to sleep."

He shook his head. Even if Dabi was guarding his door, that meant nothing to his insomnia. Especially when he could hardly breathe through the fear. "Please," Dabi begged, "you need to sleep, you have school tomorrow."

But he didn't want to leave his room, much less leave the apartment to go to school. He shook his head vehemently.

He couldn't do this. He couldn't face *this.* It was like facing down All for One all on his own. It was impossible. This was impossible.

He didn't sleep at all. He was awake even as his alarm went off. He was trembling with exhaustion as he got dressed for school. Trembling with *fear.*

Heels clicked against the shiny tiles of the U.A. Halls. Nedzu could hear it from his office and he felt himself go impossibly pale. There was *no way* that *she* was here.

The head of the Hero Commission.

Shouta tried to explain to him as he walked into the kitchen about what had happened. What the media was doing to his image, but he was too exhausted to comprehend any of it.

It isn't until Izuku saw the Yuuei Entrance through Hizashi's car window that he remembered the conversation. He swallowed hard and felt like passing out. There's practically a mob there, holding up signs and yelling. A lot of them had a picture of him from the Hosu incident, falling from the sky.

VILLAINS DON'T BELONG AT YUUEI!

Nedzu, All Might, and Ectoplasm were trying to get the protestors to leave, but it was proving difficult.

It was a punch to the gut, swiftly knocking all the air of his lungs. Wisely, Hizashi led the car to the back entrance of Yuuei to avoid the press entirely.

All the while, he seemed to be cursing under his breath, “Fucking press…” followed by, “Fucking animals…”

Shouta seemed to be just as angry about it as well if his clenched jaw was any indication. Izuku swallowed thickly, trying to quell the overwhelming thoughts in his head.

Like how they weren’t *really* wrong. How they had every right to try to get him kicked out of Yuuei because he *was* a threat to their children if he didn’t master his transformation. He had no reason to get angry at the press or the concerned parents that decided on having a protest right in front of Yuuei’s gates.

After all, A small voice mumbled in the back of his head. *I’m the most dangerous person in this building.*

He had no idea how wrong he was, as he entered Yuuei’s halls and made it to class with Shouta beside him.

No idea. Shouta squeezed his shoulder firmly and he looked up at him. “Don’t think about the press, okay? Nedzu’s dealing with it as fast as he can.”

Izuku nodded, but still wrung his hands together nervously. He didn’t really trust Nedzu yet, but maybe now was a good time to try?

Yeah. He’s my principle, I should give him the benefit of the doubt. Especially after he apologized.

Shouta’s hand didn’t leave his shoulder and he was grateful. It grounded him and steered him away from the pressing thoughts in his head.

“Besides,” Shouta continued, “you should be thinking about your final exams. We’ll be doing them in a few days. Maybe you could stay in the dorms for a little bit so you can study and get to know Shinsou?”

Izuku smiled at that. It reminded him about the conversation they'd had a little while ago. Shouta and Hizashi were really adopting him *and* Shinsou.

Shouta glanced at him and smiled softly at him in return. "And of course you can spend time with Bakugou."

Izuku giggled softly and Shouta's smile got a little more pronounced and warm.

Nedzu licked his lips nervously as the woman finally made it to his door and threw it open. Her smile was sharp and it didn't seem to fit her graceful features.

He learned long ago to fear that smile. He'd lost too many students already. Too many.

She took a seat at one of the chairs positioned right in front of his desk and got straight to the point. "I've seen the news," she began, picking at her long nails.

Nedzu swallowed thickly, trying to stamp out the fear coiling in his gut. All that was on the news as of late was Midoriya. He put his trembling paws in his lap and gave her a steely glare.

"I'm sure you have," he told her. "What does it matter? Midoriya is a perfectly heroic student despite the monster the media tries to portray him as."

The woman looked up, her long, straight purple hair pulled back into a tight bun. She tapped her long, shining nails on the desk, painted a soft purple that matched her hair. "I'm aware of that, but what interests me and the rest of the Hero Commission is his Quirk."

It took all his self-control not to launch himself at her and stop this madness before it can begin. Before she can take one of his children away from him again. It had been so long, *so long* since he failed a student like this. Except for maybe his blunder at the U.S.J., which he was still apologizing for.

So many students had been taken by the Hero Commission. Of course all of them survived the program, but none of them actually pursued becoming a Hero afterward. Nedzu didn't have the heart to find out exactly why, but he paid for their therapy. It was the least he could do after failing them so spectacularly.

He was determined to do right by Midoriya. He didn't like this maddening glint in this woman's eyes. Nedzu didn't want to dwell on what would happen to Midoriya if he failed.

With a Quirk like Midoriya's… they might experiment on him instead. It made his fur stand on end.

"I am his *principle* ," Nedzu began, his tone sharp and so very, very dangerous. "I don't intend on losing another student to your sick and twisted 'Hero Program', I won't stand for it."

"We have this exact conversation each time," she said casually. "And I always get them in the end. They always come of their own free will. Why fight to protect them, Nedzu? Besides, he won't be a part of our Hero Program. A Quirk like his... " she brings her nails to her lips and smiles.

It's ice-cold and bone-chilling. But Nedzu refused to show his fear. His horror. "We're *curious* as to how it works. That is a Quirk unlike any other I've ever seen."

"You mean to torture him," Nedzu clenched his jaw. He'd had *enough.* This was the last time the head of the Hero Commission tried to take one of his children. He slammed his paws on his desk with all the force he could muster. "Get out. Get out of my school, you *heathen.* Midoriya is my student, and *over my dead body* will you take him and experiment on him as you did to *ME!"*

Her eyes were wide and Nedzu felt a hint of satisfaction as fear flitted across her features for a split second. She stood abruptly, her heels clicking as she left his office. As she pulled the door open, she turned to face him one more time.

“I’ll be back Nedzu, just you wait.” And with those words weighing heavily in the air, she left. Nedzu sighed, his relief palpable as he scratched at his scar. It was itchy again.

He poured himself a cup of chamomile tea and promised himself that he’d do whatever he could to save his student from her grasp. Even if it killed him.

“Sir?” Mirio began again, and Mirai sighed heavily. He'd forgotten he was even here. “Would you come to Yuuei to watch me train?”

Without thinking, he spoke. “Sure, I don’t see why not.”

He didn't see Mirio’s wide grin.

Nedzu got a call an hour after the conversation with the Head of the Hero Commission. He wasn’t expecting a call from Mirio Togata so soon, considering he figured it would take Young Mirio more time.

Maybe he underestimated his students? He really needed to stop doing that. He took Mirio’s call as a welcome distraction, taking it as a chance to get his mind off the conversation he just held.

“Hello?” he mumbled, stirring more sugar into his tea. He needed it.

“I did it,” Mirio said, bubbly with excitement. “It’s happening tomorrow.”

Nedzu smiled. At least one thing was going right today, he mused. “I see,” he said cryptically. “I’ll make sure Midoriya is near that area when you’re with Nighteye.”

“Perfect!” he exclaimed. “I can’t wait to see the little guy!”

“Good work Mirio-kun,” Nedzu said, taking a sip of his tea. “Leave the rest to me.”

“I’m just glad I could help, Nedzu-sensei,” Mirio told him, his tone dipping and becoming somber. “I can’t stand what the media is painting Midoriya-kun out to be.”

“With any luck, they’ll see their mistakes,” Nedzu said darkly. “Have a good day at Nighteye’s agency.”

“Will do!”

Nedzu ended the call and downed the remainder of his tea. He turned to his intercom and debated calling Aizawa in for a moment. Right about now, Class 1-A should be in class with All Might, so Aizawa should be taking a nap in the Teacher’s Lounge.

He pressed the button on the intercom. “Aizawa to my Office, please. Aizawa to my Office.”

He needed to discuss the problem with the Hero Commission as well, but that could wait until Aizawa settled Shinsou-kun into his home. He got another cup of tea and stirred more sugar into it.

Aizawa arrived a few moments later, looking utterly exhausted. Luckily, he picked up some instant coffee the other day, so he just poured hot water into the cup. “Here,” Nedzu said simply, and Aizawa took it with weary eyes. “It’s just instant coffee.”

“Oh,” Aizawa took a sip of it and stared at Nedzu. “Why did you call me here?”

“Sir Nighteye will be here tomorrow to watch Mirio train,” he began with a smile. “If we can somehow get him to use his Quirk on Midoriya, then he can see his future. After that, I think it’ll only take a little persuasion to get him to join my conference with the press.”

Aizawa looked at him like he had two heads. “How the hell are you going to manage that?”

“I have my ways, Aizawa. I have my ways.”

Aizawa looked horrified.

Chapter End Notes

I promise Nighteye gets what he deserves later,,, just not right now! Also I just started writing the Training Camp arc!! <3

The Discord link: click me!

Chapter 70

Chapter Summary

Filler chapter, sorry!! (I'll update tomorrow??)

Chapter Notes

So if you're wondering why I took so long to update again, after I told my discord I'd do it every Tuesday again... well I was getting a pan out of the oven and MY DUMBASS only had one oven mitt on and the pan was heavier than I thought. SO WITHOUT MISSING A BEAT I GRABBED THE HOT FUCKING PAN WITH MY UNPROTECTED HAND—

Yeah. I'm stupid. So my hand was burned (not that badly tho!!) and I decided to wait until the burn and blisters were mostly healed before I updated the fic. Sorry >_<

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the end, it took a lot of convincing from Shouta to get Izuku to actually stay at the dorms for a few days until the final exams ended. All in all, it would actually amount to three days, seeing as they'd be taking the exams on Tuesday.

But Izuku had a feeling that the reason Shouta had asked him to stay at the dorms wasn't because of the exams coming up or getting to know Shinsou before he moved in with them—or even hanging out with Kacchan. It had everything to do with the press and the increasingly alarming unease he'd sensed while looking at the growing mob.

They were worried that the press would try to assault him on his way inside the school. They were simply looking out for him, Izuku noticed.

And he was so, so grateful for that. So here he sat with all his classmates, in the common room watching as Denki's head nearly exploded in confusion. Kacchan was hitting him over the head with their homework review packet, and Kirishima was holding back tears of frustration.

The “Deku Squad”, as Izuku learned they called themselves, wasn’t doing much better. Iida was trying his hardest to explain Quadratic Functions to Uraraka, who was floating her pencil absently. She was definitely disassociating. Asui was tapping her pencil against her cheek, and Shinsou had his head on the table.

Izuku was watching all of this silently, and Todoroki, who was beside him, was also watching stoically. “Hey, Midoriya,” he said suddenly, “can you help me with this problem?”

Surprised to be addressed, he tilted his head to the side. Why was he asking *Izuku* of all people to help him? Izuku couldn’t even speak to explain it. It honestly didn’t make much sense to him, which was why he resolved to just do his homework while in the company of his classmates instead of helping.

But Todoroki was giving him the most pleading look he could manage without breaking his stoic demeanor.

Fine. He would try.

He turned to a new page in his journal, and wrote: *Which one? What are you confused about?*

Todoroki gestured to one of the harder questions in the booklet of review questions, and Izuku leaned closer to get a better look. Todoroki seemed to stiffen, and Izuku cursed himself for being stupid.

He’d only seen a few seconds of Todoroki-kun’s memories back when they’d done that accursed “session” with Ms. Hirai, but it was enough to have Izuku nearly have a panic attack in the hallway outside.

He pulled away slightly to give the boy more space, and Todoroki’s posture softened a bit. He examined the problem and worked it out in his head before Todoroki spoke again.

“I can’t seem to get the right answer no matter how many times I try.” Izuku could tell by the way his eyebrows furrowed that he was frustrated. His tone gave no emotion away, however.

Izuku looked at Todoroki’s sheet again and noticed how the page was filled with his attempts. It took him only a few seconds to realize Todoroki-kun’s mistake.

He had mixed up two of the steps, and that’s why he kept ending up with an incorrect answer. Izuku wrote the basic equation used for this particular math question and wrote down each step. He then plugged in the question at hand and came out with the correct answer. He then wrote out a lengthy explanation for exactly what he did and why.

Todoroki groaned and ran his hands through his hands in realization. “I didn’t even notice that I was doing it all wrong…”

[But now you know what went wrong Todoroki-kun] Izuku signed with a smile, and Todoroki’s face fell.

“I—I don’t know sign language,” Todoroki mumbled guiltily.

Oh right. None of his classmates knew sign language, except for Kacchan, Shinsou, and Kouda.

“H-he said,” Kouda mumbled, catching their attention and putting air-quotes around his next words, “‘but now you know what went wrong, Todoroki-kun.’”

“Thank you Kouda,” Todoroki said politely before turning back to Izuku. “And thank you for explaining it to me.”

Izuku shot him a thumbs up and Uraraka turned to all of them rather abruptly. “You know what?” she said, addressing the entire class. “I don’t think we ever asked Deku if he wanted

us to learn sign language."

"Yeah," Jirou commented, giving him an apologetic look. "We never really bothered, huh?"

"He could teach us!" Ashido exclaimed excitedly. "I'm sick of studying! Teach us some sign language, Midori!"

Izuku shrank at all the attention. Everyone was looking at him, expectant. Waiting for him to start a spontaneous lesson, like he was qualified to teach such things. He looked to Kacchan, Shinsou, and Kouda. Hopefully one of them would save him?

Shinsou was, unfortunately, sleeping—or blocking out everything around him. Kouda looked like he was getting second-hand embarrassment just watching Izuku.

Kacchan was glaring at Ashido like he questioned her intentions towards Izuku. He couldn't fault Kacchan for doubting their classmates; after all, they had been quite prejudiced towards him. But Shouta had talked to them and they promised to be better.

They were doing better. They had yet to apologize formally, but Izuku didn't mind. He had been absolutely terrified of his Quirk too.

Kacchan crossed his arms and huffed loudly. "Ask Aizawa-sensei to teach you, extras. Or maybe Present Mic. If I have to spend one more minute trying to explain something to you dumbasses I'll kill you all."

"Aw, you love us, Kacchan!" Denki exclaimed, "You're so sweet."

Kacchan's eyes flashed with malice and Izuku fought the urge to laugh. *"You haven't earned the right to call me that."*

He really hated it when anyone else called him Izuku's special nickname. It was adorable. Kacchan hardly ever got this heated. Denki dived over the table and into Kirishima's arms. "Save me, Kiri!" he screeched as Kacchan's palms popped with explosions.

"Anyway!" Hagakure said loudly, "I agree with Ashido, I'm sick of studying. What should we do?"

Yaoyorozu tilted her head in thought. "I guess taking a break would be good. I'm just not sure what you all would like to do."

"What do you wanna do, Deku?" Iida asked, turning his analytical eyes to Izuku. He was once again in the spotlight and overwhelmed by it.

The first thing that came to mind was watching movies, but that would involve turning off the lights… And he hadn't thought of bringing his night light.

He hated himself for his fear of the dark, but he couldn't seem to get over it no matter how hard he tried. It was honestly embarrassing considering that being afraid of the dark was seen as a childish fear. He shifted awkwardly where he sat and Kacchan threw his arm around his shoulders.

"Wanna play mario kart?" Kacchan asked. "We can use Sparky's switch."

"Hey! You're just going to use my stuff without asking?!"

"Or we could bribe Half and Half to let us use his Xbox." Kacchan turned to Todorki and raised an eyebrow.

"I don't care," Todoroki told him. "I bought it out of spite."

Kacchan smirked. "Endeavor's credit card, I take it?"

“Yep.” The usually stoic boy grinned.

The next two hours were filled with Kacchan and Izuku trying to one-up each other in many different games—before all of their classmates took turns trying to knock Kacchan off his high horse. Izuku had been the only one to win anything so far, but he knew it was probably due to Kacchan’s soft spot for him.

Or maybe he was better at video games than he thought. He smiled as he watched Kacchan snipe Todoroki from across the map in the current round.

But then everyone got bored of that, and Ashido brought a handful of movies down from her room. “Who wants to watch movies and eat popcorn?” she asked.

There were resounding exclamations of excitement. “Okay, okay,” she said once everyone calmed down. “We have the Conjuring, Frozen 2, and—”

[The Conjuring]

Kacchan grinned, and the rest of his classmates looked taken aback as Kacchan translated. “He wants to watch the Conjuring.”

“But…” Yaoyorozu began. “Are you certain? It’s scary.”

“Oh come on,” Shinsou mumbled, deadpan from his position on the couch. When had he moved? “Midoriya’s a badass. He probably watches that to go to sleep.”

Izuku smiled slightly. “If it’s too scary we can turn on Frozen,” Ashido offered. “Just let us know, okay?”

He nodded encouragingly and Ashido put the movie into Todoroki's Xbox and hit play. Iida went to turn off the lights but paused. It was that moment of hesitation that had Yaoyorozu giving a small gasp.

"Midoriya, do you want me to make you a nightlight?" she asked, but she had already made one and it was resting in her palm. He nodded anyway, just for her sake. She brightened and plugged it into the nearest outlet before Iida turned the lights off.

He loved his classmates.

They all settled on the couches together and Yaoyorozu made them a huge blanket to snuggle under as Kacchan went to make popcorn for everyone. Kacchan had seen this movie a million times at Izuku's request.

Izuku had no reason to be scared of this movie and that's where his Quirk came in: to terrorize his classmates. He smirked as Kacchan returned with three bowls of popcorn. He divided the bowls amongst the huddles of people and plopped one right into Izuku's lap as the American movie began.

Of course, there were subtitles in Japanese, but Iida pointed out that it would be a good time to brush up on their English for their written tests. Izuku's English wasn't his strongest point, so he definitely didn't waste time trying to decipher the words being said.

They had Tuesday until the exams. He had plenty of time to study each subject and come out on top. He had always been diligent in his learning. It had been one of the few things he had absolute control over while he'd been stuck with his "family".

He could take this time to finally relax and watch a movie with his classmates for once. To pretend to be normal for a few days, and at the same time…

Izuku could terrorize his classmates a little with his Quirk. He'd never actually used his Quirk to scare people before on *purpose,* so maybe he'd finally give it a go. After all, they'd seen the worst he could do with it. Why not have some fun for the first in a very, very long time?

Kacchan sat down next to Izuku, slinging his arm over Izuku's shoulders and pulling him closer. Izuku blushed but didn't react otherwise. Kacchan was always pulling him close. He should be used to it by now after all these years, but it always made his stomach clench and his heart tighten. His cheeks seemed to be permanently dusted pink when Kacchan was anywhere near him.

And it definitely didn't help that Kacchan was probably the hottest person in their class when he wasn't snarling like a wild animal. But even when he *was* , Kacchan was still cute to him when he was scowling and spitting like that. Call Izuku weird, but that was the truth.

Everything Kacchan did was cute and manly and—

Oh right. He was supposed to be scaring his classmates, right? Yeah. Time to work some magic. It was simple for him to summon a handful of demons that would move around within the darkness surrounding his classmates. If Kacchan saw, then he didn't say anything about it as he thoughtfully chewed on his popcorn.

The movie progressed, getting darker and darker as time went on. And Denki was the first to notice the figures lurking around them.

"A-am I seeing things, or are there…" Denki whispered to Kirishima, who paled. He never finished his thought.

The climax of the movie was happening, and as the mother thrashed in the chair and screamed, a demon that Izuku had summoned jumped through the TV right onto the table screeching.

In response, almost everyone got up and started *screaming,* throwing their popcorn onto the ground and grabbing onto each other for dear life as Denki wailed in horror. Shinsou was the first to turn on the lights, and Izuku couldn't help but laugh.

Kacchan was smirking silently at the chaos, not phased at all by Izuku's little stunt. In fact, it looked like he enjoyed it if his small, growing smile was anything to go by. With a wave of his hand, all the demons he'd summoned vanished in a puff of black smoke, and Denki turned to him with tears streaming down his cheeks.

"Not cool, Midoriya! I almost peed my pants!" Denki whined, wiping at his tears. Izuku's grin widened.

"It's payback for all the shit you said about him," Kacchan told him. "Consider this a *fucking* warning, from him and me."

His tone suggested that he wasn't being completely serious, but there was the undercurrent of anger that his classmates should watch out for. "Say anything about his Quirk again, I'll explode your face off!"

"I could help," Shinsou offered, with a sleepy smile.

"P-p-point proven, Bakubro! I won't ever do it again, none of us will! You should've seen how mad Aizawa-sensei was," Denki promised, sweat beading on his brow.

Izuku patted him on the head, a lame attempt to comfort him.

[It's okay. I forgive you.]

"You're lucky he's nice," Kacchan grumbled. "He said he forgives you."

"We definitely need to consider learning sign language," Iida mumbled as he picked up pieces of popcorn off the ground. Yaoyorozu decided to help him and created a small handheld vacuum. Between the two of them, the carpet was free of any discarded food.

The blankets were also folded neatly and put on the armrest of the biggest couch. Shinsou yawned lazily and pointed at the clock displayed on the stove nearby. “It’s two in the morning, Midoriya, and you look exhausted.”

Izuku blinked slowly and nodded. “It’s probably been a rough few days for you, kero,” Tsuyu mumbled. “With your mother breaking out of prison, and the press demonizing you…”

“But it’s okay because we’re always here for you, Deku-kun!” Uraraka exclaimed. “Plus Ultra and all that!”

Izuku loved his classmates. Did he already mention that?

“You should probably go to bed,” Yaoyorozu told him. “Would you like some tea beforehand? I have a calming chamomile blend I’ve been wanting to use.”

Before Izuku could even respond with a shake of his head or a nod, she’d turned away and started making it already. A few minutes later, she returned with a warm cup of tea and something else in her hand.

Another night light. She shifted on her feet nervously as Izuku took the cup and night light without a word. “I just figured you’d feel better with a night light in Bakugou’s room,” she explained, “I’m going to make a few more and plug them into the outlets around the dorms. It was Iida’s idea actually, and when I asked Bakugou if it was a good idea, he agreed.”

Izuku could feel the tears stinging just behind his eyes and he squeezed his eyes shut. *They were all so nice to him. Even after everything he’d done.*

“D-did I say something wrong?” she asked Kacchan worriedly, “I didn’t mean—”

“Nah,” Kacchan mumbled, “he’s just a crybaby.”

“That’s kinda mean, Bakugou…” Kirishima told him, scratching the back of his head.

“It’s the truth,” Kacchan waved him off before standing. “C’mon, Izuku, you’re tired right? We can go to sleep.”

Izuku downed the rest of his tea and gave Yaoyorozu a small smile of thanks before he set it in the sink. He then turned to Bakugou and followed him to the elevator that would take them up to his room. His eyes felt heavy and the fear from this morning was edging its way back into the forefront of his mind.

His mother had escaped prison. The press was practically calling for his head, and his final exams were right around the corner. And not to mention his father was out there somewhere as well. And All for One.

Villains were lurking, waiting for the perfect time to strike. Izuku just hoped he’d be ready for when they did. He just hoped they all survived it.

Kacchan must’ve noticed how stiff he’d gotten, so he ruffled his hair. “Don’t worry so much, Deku,” he mumbled, “everything’s going to be fine.”

As the elevator came to a stop on Kacchan’s floor, Izuku tried to believe in his words. Kacchan guided him to his room and they both promptly threw themselves under the covers and passed out.

They had no idea what kind of chaos Izuku’s presence would bring in the following days.

The Apologizing to Deku For Real This Time Squad

Ashido added Sero, Denki and one other to the chat.

Ashido: We should seriously come up with a way to apologize to Deku

Sero: Agreed. But what should we do?

Denki: Get him a cat?

Sero: Doesn't Aizawa have like twelve tho

Ashido: He totally does, and what kind of apology gift is a cat anway?

Denki: Fuck idk. We just need to think of something.

Ashido: We could make a cake.

Sero: We'd probably burn the dorms down, tbh. I don't feel like getting yelled at by Aizawa.

Denki: Straight facts. I don't ever want to see his bad side again.

Sero: Flowers?

Denki: Pass. I don't think Midoriya is the type to really appreciate flowers. They're too much work to keep alive.

Todoroki: Why don't you guys just apologize like normal people and buy him new art supplies?

Ashido: That's actually a really good idea!

Denki: But who added Todoroki to the chat???

Todoroki: I don't know. Don't ask me.

Sero: Mina you really need to pay attention to who you're putting in chats from now on, coz this could've been *so* awkward if it was anyone else.

Ashido: True, but Todoroki totally just helped us out, thanks a ton!

Todoroki has changed his name to *What Can I say Except You're Welcome*

Ashido: GSGSFDFDFSGSFGADFS

Sero: Have you been watching Disney movies again without me, Todoroki?!?!

What Can I Say Except You're Welcome: Quite possibly.

Sero: You traitor

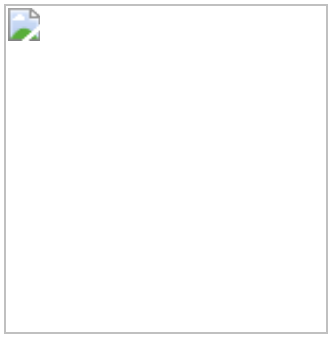
What Can I Say Except You're Welcome: :)

Chapter End Notes

The Discord link: click me!

Also fanart!! It's been so long!!

by: WhatDoYouWantFromMe



Chapter 71

Chapter Summary

Nighteye gets what he deserves ;) you're welcome guys.

Chapter Notes

I updated again so I would be back on schedule!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku woke up from an incoming text that made his phone vibrate really loudly on Kacchan's nightstand. Izuku felt all warm and calm inside, more than he had for the past fews days. There was only one explanation, or maybe it was two as to why.

It was either Kacchan, or the fact that he was finally settling in with Shouta and Hizashi. This time, he knew for certain that it was Kacchan, considering the fact that he was currently staying the weekend at the dorms.

They were tangled in the sheets together, with Kacchan on top of him still snoring. Izuku sighed softly before reaching for his phone that was resting just within his reach. Kacchan grumbled in his sleep as Izuku finally grabbed it and turned it on.

He winced instantly at the blinding brightness before he lowered it. It was five a.m. and he already had a text from Shouta. It made his heart beat faster in his chest as he began to imagine all the possible reasons as to *why* .

It's early as hell and we don't even have classes. Is something wrong? Did something else happen while he was asleep?

Dadzawa: Meet me in the common room in ten minutes.

Oh. That was vague as hell.

Smol Child: Why?

Dadzawa: I want you to meet someone, Problem Child

Smol Child: Okay, but who?

Dadzawa: Someone who might be able to prove to the press that you're going to be a great hero. I think it's safe to assume that you've heard of All Might's former side-kick, Sir Nighteye?

Sir Nighteye.

Izuku's eyes widened in shock. Sir Nighteye's Quirk was called Foresight which gave him the ability to view someone's future with prior contact. But the quirk only worked for an hour. *However,* he could see really, *really* far into the future.

Were they really going to use Nighteye's Quirk to prove to the public that he wasn't a threat? Would it really work?

Canary: I can practically hear you fanboying about his Quirk from here, little listener!

Canary: Also your classmates told me they want to start learning sign language so they can talk to you much easier! They're such sweethearts!~

Smol Child: *(//•/-/•//)/*

After a moment where neither Shouta or Hizashi said anything, he turned off his phone and wriggled underneath Kacchan’s weight. He didn’t move in the slightest, not even when Izuku poked his cheek. He huffed out a sigh and managed to maneuver his way out despite his wings' extra weight. He was a little surprised that they didn’t get caught underneath him as he did so.

Kacchan didn’t even stir and Izuku grinned slightly as he turned away. He quickly grabbed his bag full of clothes—that Hizashi packed for him—and darted into the bathroom nearest to Kacchan’s room.

Once locked in the safety of the bathroom, Izuku changed out of his pajamas and into something more presentable. It ended up being a pair of jeans and a hoodie from Hizashi’s radio show. It was an atrocious orange color with a logo on it, but he liked it.

It made him feel much closer to his dads and it was easier to put on over his wings.

He stuffed his phone in the back pocket of his jeans and carefully placed his bag of clothes back into Kacchan’s room before he slipped on a pair of socks and headed downstairs.

Shouta was already waiting for him, with two cups of coffee in hand as Izuku silently crept down the stairs to avoid waking his classmates.

His dad hid a smile behind his capture weapon when he finally saw Izuku at the foot of the stairs.

“Good morning, kid,” he said, holding out the second cup of coffee out toward him. “Are you excited to meet Nighteye?”

Izuku took a timid sip of his coffee before shrugging. He didn’t know what Nighteye would be like and it scared him a little.

[I just hope he isn’t mean.]

“Don’t worry,” Shouta told him with that smile that Izuku had come to call the Logical Ruse smile. “I’ll happily punch his face in if he says anything to you.”

[That’s a little excessive, Dad]

Shouta hid his smile behind his capture weapon again, his cheeks redder than usual, and Izuku smiled at him.

“Okay, maybe it is,” Shouta relented, “But I definitely mean it. Let’s get going, okay?”

Izuku nodded enthusiastically as Shouta led him out of the Dorms and onto Yuuei’s campus where Nighteye was waiting for them. Izuku almost stuffed his free hand into his pocket when Shouta held out his hand in a silent question.

Or maybe a plea.

Izuku wasn’t one for physical contact, but if it was one of his dads silently asking, then he’d do it. His hand twitched as he hesitantly reached out to his dad.

He tried not to fidget as soon as his hand wrapped around Shouta’s, but his hands were always trembling. Broken beyond repair.

Shouta didn’t seem to mind at all though. Izuku sipped on his coffee as Shouta led him to one of the training gyms on campus. The door was left slightly ajar and he could hear an overly cheerful voice and a more monotone one.

Shouta slowed as they neared and peeked inside. Whatever he saw inside made him swing the door open and step in. Izuku paused for a moment before following him, unsure as to *why* Shouta had to look inside first.

They were supposed to be meeting Nighteye, not sneaking around like they were undercover or something. Izuku took another sip of his coffee as he entered.

“Sir Nighteye,” Shouta began, “Can I speak with you for a moment?”

Nighteye looked over from where he’d seated himself. He looked at Shouta first, before his sharp gaze cut over to Izuku.

His grip on his cup of coffee tightened. He pulled his hand away from Shouta’s and swallowed thickly when he noticed the thinly-veiled annoyance on Nighteye’s face. His wings twitched against his back.

“No, you cannot,” Nighteye spat. “I won’t look at his future.”

“But—”

“I won’t hear it!” Nighteye shouted, throwing his hands up in the air. “I don’t care what you have to say about it!”

“But, Sir!” Mirio exclaimed as Nighteye got to his feet and headed for the door. “Please. For me, please do this for me.”

Nighteye pushed his glasses up the bridge of his nose. He sighed heavily and seemed to debate it. Mirio’s eyes were brimming with hope, and Izuku suddenly found himself wondering how Mirio fit in all of this.

And really, what the hell was going on? Whose future were they talking about? Shouta’s? Mirio’s? Izuku furrowed his brow in confusion. He didn’t understand why he’d been brought here.

With how Nighteye was reacting, it was plausible that they were never really *meeting* Nighteye in the first place. It was more like they were ambushing him and demanding he do something for them.

“I have an offer you couldn't possibly resist, Sir Nighteye,” Nedzu said from his position, which was from Shouta’s scarf. Izuku had long since learned to no longer be surprised by this. “We can discuss it later. But for now, I’d appreciate it if you’d take a look at Young Midoriya’s future.”

Nighteye narrowed his eyes before closing them. He pinched the bridge of his nose, causing his glasses to move down to the edge of his nose.

“Fine,” Nighteye grumbled, crossing the room as soon as the words were out of his mouth. His expression was blank and one of boredom when he reached Izuku, yet the furrow in his brow suggested that he was concentrating.

He slowly and deliberately put his hand on his shoulder, then his eyes flickered for a moment when they made eye-contact. He blinked.

Nighteye said nothing as he turned to leave. Everyone present watched him with concern as he halted in the doorway.

The man sent one backward glance at Izuku, and the fear in Nighteye’s expression was potent. “You have no future, Midoriya. I saw nothing but endless black. A sea of absolutely *nothing.”*

Mina Ashido was sick and tired of studying for the finals that would be coming up next week. Sure, she was almost ninety percent sure she’d fail, but come on. If there was no fixing it now, then why bother with trying to force it?

Sero and Denki were bound to fail as well. They'd discussed it multiple times over the course of this weekend. So when Iida finally told them they could take a break, Ashido almost collapsed with relief. She threw herself on the couch next to Denki and Sero as soon as the news was broken to them and let out the most dramatic sigh she could muster.

"Thank God," she said, and Sero chuckled from Denki's side. "What do you guys wanna do?"

She watched Sero and Denki's expressions closely while they both contemplated their answers. Sero ended up shrugging, but Denki's eyes suddenly brightened and he snapped his fingers. "We could go get Midoriya our apology gift since he's finally out of the dorms for a bit with Aizawa!"

Mina smiled and jumped up from the couch. "Then let's hurry up and go! He could be back at any minute!"

The three of them left, but not before they signed themselves out on a sign out sheet Aizawa-sensei made them use whenever they left the dorms.

"Where do we even buy art supplies though? Should we get him something else too? Like scented candles? Or tea? I heard those can be relaxing…" Sero asked, turning to Mina and Denki as soon as they left campus.

"I mean, I'm pretty sure there's an art store near here somewhere. And I don't think Mido would mind if we got him some candles and tea," Mina said with a smile. "Do you guys have any other shopping to do while we're out? I kinda need some new nail polish."

"No, not really. There's nothing I can really think about right now," Denki told her, but then his cheerful expression fell away. "But dudes, we should really talk about what we did to Mido. Like… we were *assholes* . Like complete and utter assholes. We know better than anyone else what he went through, and we were *scared* of him! And we basically bullied him! We're no better than his parents…"

That sobered Mina up pretty quickly. “Then we should come up with an apology speech too, along with the gift.” she mumbled. “I just really don’t want Midoriya to think we’re doing this just to make Aizawa-sensei happy, ya know? We did something really fucked up.”

“But what the hell should we say?!” Sero exclaimed, running his hands through his hair. “I have no idea how to apologize to people!”

“We just gotta be honest! We gotta go Plus Ultra with this apology and this present! What else do you guys think we should grab for him?”

“Oh, oh!” Denki exclaimed. “We can get him a coloring book! Or a stress ball, or maybe a music player that we can add calming music to? How about all of those?”

“I really like that idea,” Sero replied. “Damn, sometimes you do have good ideas Denki.”

“Hey!” he grumbled, “Are you calling me stupid?!”

Sero’s maniacal laughter was the only answer.

Ochako was sure she was the only one hearing things go bump in the night. She had never been afraid of ghosts or ghouls, or even demons. But that was before these *things* began to happen.

She should’ve seen it coming, considering that Deku had been staying at the dorms for the past few days, but she honestly didn’t think about it. Not until she kept hearing people walking around the dorms at all hours of the night.

Not until she thought she heard a child laughing in the bathroom closest to her room, only to go investigate and find nothing.

She hadn't slept since they'd watched The Conjuring. She honestly felt a little crazy, and it didn't help that no one else had brought anything up about these strange occurrences. Ochako was almost one hundred percent sure she was the only one hearing these things at night.

But then again, she hadn't brought it up either. But who would've heard any of this at night? Who would be up all night to see anything?

And then it came to her. Shinsou was Class 1-A's insomniac, right? If anyone else was hearing these things, then it would be him.

Chewing on her lower lip, Ochako left her room and headed for Shinsou's, which was on the other side of the Dorms. She hoped that he'd have some information or proof.

She really hoped she wasn't losing her mind.

"I hope he's awake," she mumbled to herself as she finally stopped at his door. Her hand stopped midway through the action of knocking. She hadn't considered that Shinsou might be asleep, as he usually was this early in the morning… But…

She really needed answers. She really needed to know if what she was hearing were Deku's demons or just her imagination.

Ochako hoped it was the latter because demons were still scary if left to their own devices at night.

In the end, she timidly knocked on his door twice. At first, there was nothing but silence that followed, but then there was the soft telltale sound of something falling. And then footsteps.

"What—" Shinsou began as he threw his door open with more force than necessary. When he saw Ochako, his face softened and he grinned sheepishly. "Oh hey, Uraraka. What's up?"

She decided the best course of action was to come right out and say it. “Hey, Shinsou,” she replied, twisting a lock of hair around her finger nervously. “I was just wondering, since you usually stay up really late, if you’ve heard anything weird lately?”

“Define weird. Do you mean Denki playing a trumpet at two a.m. weird, or something else?” Shinsou asked, rubbing his eyes. It was just then that Ochako realized she must’ve woken him up from sleeping. Guilt twisted in her gut and she decided to make this quick so he could go back to sleep.

His eyes almost seemed bruised from the eyebags he was sporting. He definitely needed as much sleep as he could get right now.

“Well, I was thinking more along the lines of ghost activity?” Ochako mumbled, shifting on her feet nervously as she watched his reaction.

“Oh,” he started with a slight nod. “Yeah. I’ve heard some of that, but I’m pretty sure it’s just Midoriya’s Quirk. You honestly shouldn’t worry too much about it. They’re only trying to play.”

“I’ve watched enough horror movies to know that’s *not* true.”

“No, really. I’m dead serious,” Shinsou told her with a wide smile. “Just last night I was getting a cup of coffee, and I nearly had a heart attack because one of Midoriya’s demons had fallen asleep in the drawer!”

“What the fuck!?”

Okay, note to self… Midoriya’s demons are children at heart.

Mirai had never experienced this with anyone before. Never in his life had his Quirk simply shown him darkness. Nothing. Emptiness.

There was always something to see in someone's future. There was always a glimpse of something when he looked to the future. There was *never* simply nothing. Even though he hated Midoriya and the possible future he had as the next Symbol of Peace—even without All Might's Quirk—he felt bad.

Because that blackness, that endless sea of nothing, could only mean horrible things. And Midoriya didn't actually seem like a bad kid. Whatever was coming, Midoriya didn't deserve it. The darkness had chilled Mirai to the bones.

"What the fuck does that mean?" Aizawa asked, coming to stand next to his student. But the fondness and overprotectiveness seeping into expression told Mirai that it was more than that.

Midoriya was Aizawa's son. He could see it in how Aizawa put a comforting hand on Midoriya's shoulder.

Mirai let out a long, suffering sigh. "I'm not sure," he admitted. "It's only safe to assume that either he has no future or that my Quirk just doesn't work on him. Both possibilities are on the table, and I'm just not sure."

Aizawa scowled at him and Mirai narrowed his eyes. "What?" he snapped, crossing his arms. "I'm telling you the truth."

"Well, what're we going to do about Izuku's situation with the press if he apparently, *according to you,* has no future?"

Mirai shrugged. "Don't try to involve me in *your* endeavors, Aizawa. I have enough on my plate as it is!"

“He’s just a child!” Aizawa shouted back, waving his arms in the air in exasperation. “You’re willing to just let the press tear him apart because of his Quirk?! What kind of Hero are you?!”

“I’m a hero with priorities. That is all.”

“No,” Aizawa spat, grabbing Midoriya’s hand and turning away. “That just makes you a bigger fucking dick than Endeavor.”

“What?!” Mirai said lowly, glaring something fierce at Aizawa. How *dare* he speak to him like that?! “You literally have the Devil incarnate as your child! How dare you say something like that to me?!”

He realized a second too late that he had said the exact wrong thing.

Before he could even blink, pain exploded in his cheek and he was knocked on his ass. Clutching his surely bruising cheek, he looked up at Aizawa with an expression of utter shock.

“D-did you just—?” Mirai began, his face turning red with rage. “Nedzu, how can you allow this— this teacher to hit me?! You’re the principal! Do something about this *heathen!* ”

Nedzu, from his perch in Aizawa’s capture weapon only glared down at him as if he was the most disgusting trash he’d ever laid eyes on. Like Mirai wasn’t worth any time or effort. Like he was nothing but a lowlife villain.

Midoriya looked just as shocked as Mirai felt.

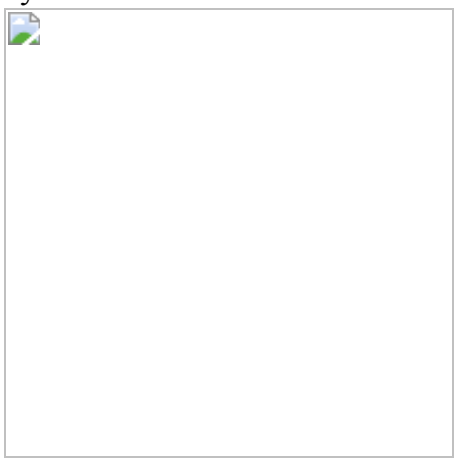
“Get out of my school, Nighteye. And if I *ever* see you again, Aizawa-kun won’t be the *only* one punching you in the face.”

Chapter End Notes

The Discord link: click me!

More Fanart T^T thank yooooou:

by boo



Chapter 72

Chapter Summary

> Mirio is shook by Nighteye's words, and Izuku is just trying to come to terms that his dad isn't afraid to punch people in the face for him. And then,,, ya know,,, the press ruins everything... but they get whats coming to them when Izuku finally shows them that he's gonna be a badass hero later on in the fic

Chapter Notes

> I would've updated yesterday late last night but my server was asleep and I would feel bad for pinging the squad so late lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku was utterly shocked when his dad point-blank punched All Might's former sidekick in the face. He was even *more* shocked when Nedzu looked absolutely murderous and ready to kill Nighteye for the things he'd just said.

He knew deep down that Nedzu was trying his hardest to make up for the things he'd done to him, but he didn't know Nedzu was *this* serious about it.

Izuku had never seen the rodent this angry on his behalf. Nighteye's face twisted into something even angrier than Nedzu's already horrifying expression as he scrambled to his feet and dusted himself off. His eyes were dark with rage as he pushed his glasses up the bridge of his nose, yet he didn't say a thing.

He turned on his heel without even a huff of annoyance and left the training room. Izuku watched him go, silently shocked. The door clicked closed behind him. There was a heavy moment of silence where no one said, or did anything. Izuku was still trying to realize that his dad *literally* punched Nighteye square in the face. He didn't even have time to be upset about Nighteye's words because *wow.* His dad just punched another Pro Hero in the face! Because he said something mean to *Izuku!*

“Damn,” Mirio mumbled, looking pale in the face. “I never thought Sir would say something like that to you, Midoriya-kun! I’m so sorry!”

Shouta crossed his arms and shook his head. “You shouldn’t be apologizing for your teacher's mistakes, Mirio-kun. Thank you for helping us, even though it didn‘t work out.”

From his spot perched on Shouta’s shoulder, Nedzu nodded affirmatively. “His behavior was unacceptable. Thank you for helping us either way, though. It’s appreciated.”

“No problem!” Mirio brightened up almost instantly at the praise. He then turned to Izuku, and smiled even wider. “But what are we going to do about the situation with the press? How will we save Midoriya-kun’s reputation?”

Nedzu sighed heavily in response to Mirio’s question. Izuku felt his mood deflate at the mere mention of the press’s less than favorable opinion of him. “There isn’t much we can do except try to placate the citizen’s and make sure the press stays far from Yuuei.”

“As long as they leave my kid alone, I don’t care what the press says.” Shouta told Nedzu, crossing the room to be at Izuku’s side. “What they’re saying is a blatant lie about Izuku’s character, but if they refuse to listen, then they’re digging their own grave. As long as my kid is safe, I don’t care about them at all.”

“Well said, Aizawa-san, but I’ll still do everything in my power to keep Izuku safe,” Nedzu replied, before grinning like he already had a plan. Maybe he really did? The principal always seemed to have a plan ready for anything.

“Mirio, please continue your training if you’d like. We’ll take care of the situation with the press on our own. Again, I’m sorry we dragged you into it.”

“It’s honestly fine! Midoriya, do you wanna train with me?” he asked, and Izuku hesitated. He’d just started working with his classmates and using his Quirk in their presence, so he wasn’t confident with using the full-power of his Quirk yet. As if realizing his mistake, Mirio

waved his hands around quickly. “We can just do hand-to-hand combat! We don’t need to use our Quirks!”

At that, Izuku felt his shoulders relax. If they weren’t using their Quirks, then Izuku had no reason to deny Mirio’s request. He sent a side-ways glance at his father, and Shouta nodded once. “I don’t see why not,” he told Izuku with a slight smile. “You’ve studied plenty for your finals. It wouldn’t hurt to get some training in as well.”

Izuku grinned, and Mirio matched his expression exactly as he pumped a fist in the air. Where did Mirio get so much energy? “Alriiiiight! Let’s get started!”

Izuku watched Mirio carefully shift into a fighting stance. Nedzu remained on Shouta’s shoulders, apparently eager to watch them work. Shouta moved farther away to give them space as he spectated.

Mirio’s stance was strong, with his knees bent and his feet planted solidly on the ground, Izuku observed. Izuku instantly began to analyze Mirio as a fighter. He was more muscular than Izuku was, hinting at his extensive training he’d received under Sir Nighteye’s tutelage. The way he held himself, like an impenetrable wall, told Izuku that Mirio would probably rely on pure power to take Izuku down.

But, if Izuku was *faster* than him, then it didn’t matter how strong his opponent was. If he could slip past Mirio’s defense, it would all be—

A swing at his face startled him out of his thoughts as he dodged on reflex. “Now you’re paying attention! I thought you disassociated, little guy!”

Izuku smirked and for a horrifying moment, he reminded himself of Shouta.

Mirio swung at him again, aiming for his stomach, but Izuku blocked it with terrifying efficiency. His opponent's expression sharpened with focus, and Izuku felt himself falling into a relaxed state.

It had been so long since he did nothing but focus on his hand to hand combat instead of his Quirk. And the last time he'd done it, it had been in the presence of All for One. But now? He was with people he knew only wanted to help him, instead of manipulating him.

Well, he wasn't completely sure of that, but All for One was pure evil. These people were heroes. He could trust them and train with them without worry.

So he let himself fall into the rhythm of battle that Stain had taught him.

Nedzu watched Mirio and Midoriya spar before he silently turned to Aizawa and whispered to him. "We'll talk about the Press Problem, if you'd like to take him to my office after this?"

Wordlessly, Aizawa nodded, but his eyes never left Midoriya. Nedzu smiled slightly and turned his attention back to the two students in front of him. Currently, Mirio Togata had seemed to figure out Midoriya's plan of action.

Midoriya was the type to use speed and agility rather than pure strength, and Mirio-kun seemed to have realized this as well. He was trying his best to block all of Midoriya's advances and gain the upper hand. Unfortunately, despite all of his extensive training, Mirio's stance slipped.

After all, first-hand experience with villains such as All for One made Midoriya a *very* formidable opponent. Even against a third-year, he still seemed to be able to win this fight. When Mirio broke his stance, falling backward slightly, Midoriya struck much like a predator that had been playing with its food for far too long.

He slammed himself in Mirio's prone form, tackling him to the ground with more strength than Nedzu thought Midoriya had. But at that precise moment, Mirio phased through the ground. Any normal teenager at Midoriya's age would have been caught off guard by this move.

They would've slammed into the mat on the floor and looked around in surprise until Mirio appeared again.

Midoriya did no such thing. He caught himself and got to his feet instantly. Mirio appeared from under the ground, but Midoriya was ready for him. The two of them quickly exchanged blows, neither of them gaining ground, but Mirio didn't even seem tired.

Then again, neither did Midoriya. In fact, both of them seemed to be enjoying themselves immensely. It took Nedzu a moment to realize that Mirio hadn't had someone to spar with like this in a long time. Tamaki Amajiki had been busy for a while at Fat Gum's Agency, and Neijire was also busy as of late.

Had he been lonely? Nedzu thought to himself as they separated only to jump back together and start all over again. *Probably.*

They continued on like that for a while, going back and forth with no real winner in sight.

Nedzu just took this time to analyze Midoriya further. The Press had decided to make this child out to be a monster. And Nedzu decided he would protect this child, even though he had no right.

He had interrogated a traumatized *child,* and yet here he was, trying to right his wrongs. Even the Hero Commission was currently against him, but Nedzu still refused to back down.

He firmly believed that Midoriya was nothing short of a saint. He had the soul of a Hero, even bigger and brighter than All Might's. He was destined for beautiful, heroic things, yet everyone was turning their backs on such a wonderful boy. Nedzu couldn't even begin to fathom *why* , not even when Midoriya finally managed to end the sparring match by wearing Mirio down until he couldn't use his Quirk to escape him.

Surely, there were plenty of Quirks out there that were scarier? But as suddenly as he thought it, he shook his head. Midoriya's Quirk wasn't *scary* . He needed to stop that treacherous train of thought. But still, surely there were scarier things out there other than Midoriya? Why hyperfocus on one innocent boy?

But at the back of his mind, he kept thinking about All for One and Midoriya's parents. They'd tried to kidnap Midoriya time and time again, only to fail in each attempt. First, it had been the USJ, then the Hosu Incident. Nedzu would have added the Sports Festival to the list of attempted kidnappings, but it had never been confirmed by any of the villains captured that it was their goal.

All for One must've realized that *capturing* Midoriya was virtually impossible, so he moved on to a plan that involved manipulating Midoriya. He was probably thinking he could coax Midoriya to join him willingly through demonizing him. Nedzu had to admit that the tactic had some merit to it.

By destroying Japan's view on Midoriya, he could, by extension, destroy Midoriya's progress. By doing so, he'd make it easier to convince the kid to join them again. But All for One hadn't made all the correct calculations. He hadn't even taken into account the Heroes in this particular equation.

Nedzu himself was determined to keep Midoriya at Yuuei where he could fulfill his dream and he was sure the rest of the staff felt the same way.

And then there was Present Mic, who adored the boy and showered him with love.

Eraserhead, who would sooner die than see his kid be manipulated by villains.

But that wasn't all. He had miscalculated Midoriya's drive to be a hero as well. Sure, Midoriya was bound to be affected by how the press felt about him, but that didn't mean anything when it came to his dream. He had fought so hard to get here, to the safety of Yuuei's halls and Nedzu doubted that he'd give it up easily.

But still, this was All for One he was talking about. The man's motives were always hard to pinpoint, and a lot of the time he could count on being wrong. And he couldn't forget that All for One had been alive for a very long time and had more than enough experience to outwit the current heroes of this age.

Nedzu repressed the urge to sigh in despair. This was exactly why he needed to speak with Aizawa and formulate a plan. Maybe he should even speak to Midnight, who had previously dealt with backlash from the press?

He still had options. There had to be a way to get the press off of Midoriya's back. He needed to approach all of this very carefully.

Unfortunately, his thoughts were cut short when Mirio burst out laughing. "You're even better than I am, Midoriya-kun! We should spar more often!"

Midoriya looked slightly uncomfortable, as Mirio praised him like he'd raised the moon himself. Mirio was holding his hands and swinging them animatedly as he spoke, each word sunnier than the last and even kinder.

He too had the soul of a Hero, Nedzu could see. The two of them would definitely make a name for themselves.

He grinned to himself and tugged lightly on Aizawa's scarf. The grumpy man was watching his silent, shy child purse his lips and accept the high praise he was being given. There was the smallest of smiles on the man's face and Nedzu pretended not to see it as the man turned toward him.

"Shall we speak in my office now? I'm afraid the talk can't wait."

Aizawa nodded curtly and, in turn, cleared his throat. "Mirio, could you take Midoriya back to the dorms? Nedzu and I have something important to talk about."

Mirio agreed with a silent nod and he promptly started dragging Midoriya out of the training room all while he spoke about Midoriya's "cute little first year" classmates.

Aizawa turned to him with a grave expression.

Ah, so he realized it was going to be a very serious talk on Midoriya's situation, Nedzu noted. Good.

"We should probably head to my office now, Aizawa-san."

As soon as Shouta settled on the armchair across from Nedzu, he mentally prepared himself for Nedzu's ideas on how to handle all the backlash his kid was receiving.

The principal made himself comfortable on his chair first. Then, he began.

"I think it would be best to prevent the press from seeing Midoriya. Either by preventing the press from getting anywhere near Yuuei, or by keeping Midoriya in the dorms."

Shouta immediately shook his head. "Moving him to the dorms wouldn't work. He just got used to living with me and Hizashi."

"Then I'll make the press leave Yuuei's campus at once, for starters." Nedzu proposed, setting his cup down. "There's little we can do in such a situation. I'll be the first to admit it. We could hold a press conference, but what good would that do if no one listens to anything we say? People are always afraid of what they don't know. Just like when Quirks were first manifesting, everyone became afraid of the Quirked. There was nothing they could do to prove they weren't dangerous other than showing them with their actions…"

"So what I'm hearing is you don't have a plan," Shouta replied, feeling old anger rising to the surface of his skin. He pushed it down, determined to keep calm. Logically, it wasn't Nedzu's fault that any of this was happening in the first place. Shouta also needed to realize that what Nedzu was saying was *right* .

Their plan involving Nighteye was flimsy at best, and that had all hinged on whether or not Nighteye would help them at all.

It would be a much easier situation if they could run a campaign to help Izuku gain popularity and *show them* that he wasn't a threat. But Izuku wasn't a Pro Hero yet, and they weren't PA's either. He was still just a kid.

After a moment of relative silence, Nedzu spoke up. "I can see now that this is a problem not easily mended," he said, looking down at his teacup, seemingly dismayed. "The only way I could see this getting fixed is if we play the long game and let Midoriya prove himself. It's likely that the press won't believe anything I say, especially with back-to-back errors on my part—"

"You're not omnipotent, Nedzu," Shouta cut in, bringing his hands up to rub at his eyes. "You couldn't have possibly predicted the USJ, nor could you have predicted the Sports Festival or even Hosu. Yeah, maybe they're right to question the way Yuuei does things, but that doesn't mean you're terrible at your job. The only thing their criticism means is that there's a change to be had. Villains are getting stronger, and in turn, so must we. It's their own problem if they refuse to listen to facts, but if you don't want to publicly speak on the matter, that's fine. I don't want to involve Izuku's name any more than it already is."

"Thank you, Aizawa-kun. Now to get the press to believe Midoriya is hero material, we just have to show them he's a hero!" Nedzu replied, suddenly looking a little brighter. "That will be pretty easy after the Provisional License exam."

"That's pretty far off, though," Shouta mumbled, feeling unsure.

"Well yes, but hopefully by that point, the press won't be demanding his head…" Nedzu told him. "Besides, there won't be many opportunities before then to clear his name. They do have the final exams coming up, then their Provisional License after that—"

The door to his office flew open at that exact moment, slamming against the wall with the force of how harshly it was opened. It was a second-year, looking rather disheveled, and Shouta jumped in his chair.

The panting student looked at Nedzu with wide eyes. “Principal Nedzu! The press is trying to break into Yuuei—!”

And then the alarms blared. They cut through the air like a frightened scream. Shouta was up from his seat in an instant, worry written across his face. “Where’s Izuku?”

The student swallowed thickly, “He was walking with Mirio-kun to Class 1-A’s dorm! They had just been walking by the front gates when the gates started to disintegrate!”

“The gates had been *disintegrating* ?!” Nedzu exclaimed, his teacup trembling in his grasp. “Why didn’t you mention that first?!”

The student looked like he was at a loss. “I-I didn’t think it was important!”

“We’ll deal with it.” Nedzu said, his tone dangerously cold and calm as he and Shouta ran for the Yuuei gates.

“It’s Shigaraki,” Shouta said, grim-faced and terrified.

Nedzu nodded in response. “We’ll pick up our conversation on a later date, Aizawa-kun.”

Shouta said nothing in response. He was too busy worrying about Shigaraki.

What was he doing here? Was all of this part of an elaborate plan to kidnap his kid? Or maybe make the situation with the press worse than it already was?

Shouta didn’t want to know. He just wanted his kid to be safe.

Chapter End Notes

Sometimes I wonder how many marshmallows I can shove in my mouth at once and then I remember I don't like marshmallows unless they're on fire-

The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 73

Chapter Summary

Don't fuck with dadzawa. Lesson learned :))

Chapter Notes

FOR SOME REASON MY BRAIN FINALLY REALIZED THAT AOT IS OVER AND IM V DEPRESSED ABOUT MY SHIPS-

Anyway, here's the update!! (Im sorry days just blur together and I forget what day it is.) For some reason, I'll turn off my alarms to update every once in a while (they go off in the morning, and sometimes I don't plan on updating so that's why I turn them off) and I'll forget to turn them back on... lol ^^;

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku wasn't in the mood to talk to someone as excitable and cheery as Mirio Togata. Their sparring match was interesting and fun, but Mirio was too much all at once for him. He gestured with his hands as he talked and projected every word a bit too loudly for Izuku's comfort.

He reminded him of All Might in almost every way. It was creepy, almost like looking into a mirror. Mirio had been brought up by Nighteye to *literally* be the next All Might.

It was concerning, to say the least. Was he even his own person? Izuku couldn't be sure of the answer as he listened to Mirio ramble on about someone named Tamaki Amajiki, his...boyfriend? He'd missed that part of the conversation.

"And then he tried to eat a Lego to see if he could manifest it with his Quirk!" Mirio exclaimed, clutching his stomach as he laughed. "And! And that's not even the best part! Our teacher *let* him! He was curious too, and when he couldn't make a Lego with his arms or legs, both of them were so disappointed!"

Izuku smirked as the story drew to a close and Mirio didn't look too ruffled about it. Was he used to silence? Was he used to having a nearly invisible person beside him? Was this Tamaki Amajiki quiet and reserved as well?

He was curious, but he didn't ask. He didn't even stop Mirio to sign the question out. They just kept walking until they reached the Yuuei gates, where they could hear the sounds of people protesting rather loudly on the other side.

He didn't bother to even listen to what was being chanted. He knew it would only serve to make him feel horrible and he's honestly sick of feeling like that every day.

Mirio, on the other hand, seemed to be listening because his face paled and his fists clenched. A flash of rage encompassed his features for a second before he forced it back. He turned to Izuku fully and gave him an assuring smile that was too warm and too soft. As if Izuku needed to be protected at all costs.

"Let's get you back to the dorm—"

The sound of the "protesting" got very loud, very suddenly. Izuku turned back to the Yuuei gates they'd just passed and froze entirely. His breath caught in his throat and all he could see was the familiar, pale-skinned arm of Shigaraki reaching outward where the Yuuei gates used to be.

And that insane, high-pitched laughter that even haunted his dreams beside All for One. His heart pounded in his chest, squeezing with fear. There were demons at the edge of his vision, cowering.

"Mi-dori-ya…" Shigaraki rasped, but he never stepped across the gateway. He just grinned without his hand-mask to cover his face. His lips were chapped and broke harshly as the skin was pulled taunt. The crowd of protestors didn't even notice Shigaraki as they surged forward.

They're shouting, but what they're saying to him was blocked out from the loud buzzing in his ears. Shigaraki was lost in the sea of bodies pressing in on him at every angle; some were

reporters, with their cameraman behind them recording as they shouted.

Mirio was *also* shouting. But this time, he actually heard what's being said. "Midoriya!"

He tried to make it over to Mirio's side, but the protestors shoved him from every direction, jostling him around. A girl with clouds for hair *spat* on him. He scowled and there were instantly screams and claws raking across his face.

His face stung and he could feel heat rising to his skin, as well as wetness dripping from his face. "Demon!" someone screamed. "Yuuei never should've allowed you in here!"

It's like pushing glass into his heart then twisting it.

"You know this school is for *heroes,* right?"

"There's no place for you here!"

"You should just drop out. No one wants you here!"

He feels cold. All the feeling in his hands faded, and the fuzz in his mind came back. Everything felt cold, grey, and muted. They were right, weren't they?

Yes, a dark part of his mind replied. *They're right, they're always right.*

Glass seemed to be shattering, but that might just be his heart. It's stupid. All of this was stupid. He worked so hard for this. He fought fate. He fought fear. He fought *death.*

He worked so hard… Only for this in reward.

And Izuku knew he deserved this, but there's still a part of him that felt utterly betrayed and angry. There's a part of him that hated everyone and their ignorant hatred of things they didn't understand or things that they found strange.

He hated it. Hated *them* .

Izuku couldn't hear what they were screaming anymore, and hardly felt it when he fell down and someone slammed his face into the ground. He didn't feel a damn thing. His wings twitched against his back but he resisted the urge to escape.

It would only make him look worse. They would twist it, blacken it, and make him suffer even more.

Hands are everywhere. Tearing, scratching, ripping.

And then there's a deadly cold voice that cut through all of it. The numbness. The cold. The fuzziness. The silence.

"Stop." The voice was hard like ice. *"Before I do something I won't regret."*

Maybe it's the coldness of his voice—or maybe it's the fact that he cancelled out their Quirks—but the reporters all froze at once. Fear seeped into their expressions while Izuku uncurled himself from the ball he'd created. *When had I done that?*

His dad cut through the crowd like a force of nature, his expression harder and colder than Izuku had *ever* seen. His pace was slow, deliberate, and the feeling of rage burned in the air. He stopped right before Izuku, his expression going unbelievably soft for a fraction of a second. The feeling in his hands came back.

Slowly, he could feel sensation come back to him, and his skin burned with scratches and bruises that were already forming. His eyes were stinging too, as Shouta ruffled his hair. “I’m sorry I’m late, Izuku.”

And just like that, Izuku could feel his lower lip trembling as he’s hit with the reminder that Shouta cared for him. That Shouta would protect him from the world if the need ever arose. His throat tightened with a wave of emotion that he stamped down on. Hard.

The press was still here and they’re still recording.

“Hey! We weren’t doing anything wrong!” someone shouted, and even Izuku flinched at the glare that Shouta threw over his shoulder.

There’s a harsh laugh from nearby and Izuku looked over to see who it was. Nedzu was standing on All Might’s shoulder, his knuckles cracking. His grin was sharp and borderline feral. Standing behind him was Recovery Girl, Ectoplasm, Hound Dog, Present Mic, Midnight, and the rest of the Yuuei Staff.

None of them looked the least bit happy.

“You weren’t doing anything wrong?” Nedzu repeated, rage rearing its ugly head as his smile turned into cold laughter. “You really think so? You just broke into my school, insulted, berated, and *attacked* one of my precious students. All of you just assaulted a *minor.* You got it on *camera.* And before any of you think about destroying the evidence, my Yuuei cameras caught it as well. And yet you have the audacity to say you’ve done nothing *wrong?!”*

Izuku watched their expressions go from sour to terrified in a matter of seconds. He would’ve watched the whole thing had Shouta not turned his attention away. He cupped his face in his hands and turned it this way and that.

His expression darkened before he pulled away and stood. “Recovery Girl,” he grumbled, and the nurse was already on her way over.

He received a peck to the forehead and he instantly felt the stinging go away. Shouta then turned to Nedzu. “I trust that you’ll deal with this?” he asked, and Izuku could hear police sirens in the distance. Nedzu gave an enthusiastic nod that was utterly *terrifying.*

“Yes,” Nedzu growled, and Izuku knew that everyone had gone pale with those words.

“C’mon Izuku,” Shouta told him, helping him up without any prompting. “We’re going home today. I can’t stand the press.”

“I’LL COME—” Shouta glared and Present Mic settled down. “Ahem, I’ll come too!”

With that, Shouta and Hizashi led him away from the scene and Izuku spotted Mirio on the sidelines. Mirio was watching him closely, and as they got closer, he grinned.

“I’ll let your classmates know you’re going home, Midoriya-kun!” Mirio told him before turning away. But Izuku could see the guilt etched into his expression.

Shouta patted his head. “We’ll talk to him later, okay? Let’s just go home for now.”

Once they were home, it all came rushing back at once. A tidal wave of emotion that he didn’t even see coming. He stepped through the doorway, Hizashi locking the door behind him as they all piled inside their home.

Izuku couldn’t even hope to suppress the dripping tears that burst from his eyes. He tried to wipe them away but it was fruitless. They just kept falling.

“Izuku?”

It was Hizashi, crouching down before him with his hands on his shoulders. He looked concerned. He couldn't stand to look at him, immensely embarrassed that he was crying over something like this. He'd been attacked by villains before, and yet he's crying over this?

"Hey hey," Hizashi said gently, brushing away some of his tears with his thumb. "It's okay now."

"Nedzu will never let that happen again," Shouta promised, from where he leaned against the wall nearby. "If they even *think* of trying that again, I will personally make sure they *suffer."*

Izuku sniffled and managed a shaky smile.

"...promise…?" a demon asked from behind him. Shouta didn't even jump in fright.

"I cross my heart," Shouta mumbled, his tone flat. "Now, what do you guys want for dinner? We can get takeout if you want."

It took him a second to realize that Shouta was giving him the chance to choose. He paused for a moment to ponder his answer. What *did* he want to eat?

Rice bowls sounded nice, something easy to make. Something that didn't require Shouta to slave over a stove for hours, just to make Izuku happy. He signed out his answer and Hizashi brightened considerably.

"I *love* rice bowls, Shouta! Make them please?"

"You say that as if I was going to tell Izuku no…" Shouta grumbled, looking rather offended. "Since Izuku asked, I'll make them."

"Aww! Shouta, you're just a big softie, aren't you?"

“We’ve been over this, ‘Zashi.”

“It’s still so cute everytime!”

Izuku watched as his two dads—honestly it was just Hizashi—glomped onto each other and laughed.

Hizashi’s smile was so bright that Izuku almost shielded his eyes. Shouta’s face had softened considerably, and he let his husband nuzzle him and giggle.

Cuuuute! Was all Izuku could think as he watched them. After a moment or two, Shouta half-heartedly shoved him.

“Alright, alright. If you want dinner you’ll have to get off of me,” Shouta told him.

“Oh, I can help!” Hizashi exclaimed, but Shouta glared over his shoulder as he made his way over to the kitchen.

“No.” he stated, with the slightest twitch of his lips. “You always ruin the rice. Izuku can help me, if he wants to.”

Izuku blinked owlishly before nodding vehemently. He followed Shouta into the kitchen, much like a little duckling, as Shouta taught him how to use the rice cooker, which only led to Izuku wondering how Hizashi could ruin rice if they had a *rice cooker.* He decided he didn’t want to ask.

He and Shouta both pretended not to notice Hizashi taking pictures of them from the living room, cooing as if he was watching two baby animals who were unsure of themselves interacting.

Shouta was very hesitant to let Izuku use the knife to cut the chicken up into slices, but Izuku just narrowed his eyes.

[I've fought villains using a katana yet you want to hesitate when giving me a knife?]

Shouta gave him that *I'm-your-dad-and-you-shouldn't-be-fighting-villains-at-all* look accompanied by *I-shouldn't-be-giving-my-child-a-fucking-knife* . In the end, Shouta just let him watch while Izuku pouted.

Soon enough, dinner was ready, and Hizashi snickered while typing vigorously on his phone. From his spot at the table, Shouta glared at him. "You sent that to Nemuri, didn't you?"

Hizashi's smile widened. "Um, not exactly?" he answered, hiding his phone. "I kind of made a group chat without you in it and sent it to everyone?"

Shouta just huffed and returned to his food without a word. And it was the most terrifying thing Izuku had ever seen.

Later that night, once everything had wound down, Shouta and Hizashi went into his room. Dabi was doodling in one of his journals while a demon creepily opened the closet door and closed it over and over.

Izuku had been staring a hole into the wall, compartmentalizing everything. It had been a long time since the U.S.J. Incident, and his entire life got flipped upside down. Izuku didn't stroll down memory lane on purpose, most of the time. It often left him anxious and spiraling.

But today felt like a day to dwell on past experiences.

The U.S.J. Incident, as bad as it was, was the pivotal part of how his life changed and became what it was today.

He had been saved that day if he was being totally honest. If he hadn't fought against Shigaraki and All for One's plans then, he'd probably be locked away and experimented on like one of the Nomu.

All for One would've forced his Quirk onto him and molded him into an invincible villain. Izuku wouldn't have been strong enough to go against him at that point. He never would've become a hero-in-training.

And if Shouta and Hizashi didn't take him in and provide him with a safe environment, then his mental state would've never improved. He would've never gotten used to using his Quirk to its fullest. He never would've come to the realization that your parents shouldn't hurt you. That they should love you, nurture you, and keep you safe.

He would've kept going about his life, surrounded by evil people with blackened hearts. He would've continued on, never knowing that there was a better alternative.

"Izuku," Shouta said suddenly, breaking him out of his train of thought. Izuku turned to look at him curiously. "Do you want to train some more before the final exams?"

Shouta wasn't smiling, but there was the faintest hint of a smirk on his face. Izuku noticed that he was wearing a beat-up tracksuit, much like his hero costume.

Izuku, never one to skimp on his training, nodded enthusiastically. Hizashi jumped up in excitement, also wearing a tracksuit just like Shouta's but nicer. He held one out for Izuku. "Alriiiiight! We're all going for a run!"

Izuku's face would've soured at the thought of running, but then saw how excited both of his dads looked to train with him. Instead of scowling, he grinned.

Something was lurking. Deep within the darkness, there was a monster. He could hear it groaning, moaning, and coming closer. He couldn't see anything, trapped within the darkness of the basement.

He knew it was the basement. He didn't know how he knew, but he just did.

It's freezing even beneath the blanket, and the monster makes the air even colder. Its freezing ice-encased hands reached for him under the blanket. Its claws raked through the fabric, and Izuku was up in an instant to run from whatever abomination his mind had created.

He felt his way through the darkness, stumbling and fearful of this familiar nightmare. It's one he had experienced many times since leaving the grasp of his mother and father; and each time, it found new ways to dig beneath his skin.

Sometimes, it was his mother coming down into his room to beat him. Other times, it was his father, drunk and stupid. But… there was always one variation of this nightmare that terrified him the most.

A monster in the darkness, close enough to feel, but not enough to *see.*

Izuku scrambled up the creaking stairs, taking them two at a time in his haste. His nails dug into the walls as he propelled himself upward, reaching blindly for the door. The door that had scratch marks all over it, the door that had been the wall between him and freedom so many times.

His hand wrapped around the cold metal of the doorknob and twisted it with too much force. Despite that, the knob stopped just short of sliding open. Izuku could feel the cold inklings of fear crawl up his skin like nails caressing his skin. Goosebumps blossomed along his arms and legs, making all the hairs on his body stand up at once. His throat tightened as he tried to open the door again. Locked. The door wouldn't open.

He sucked in a harsh breath, jostling the knob loudly in absolute desperation.

The monster at the bottom of the stairs groaned. Its tongue clicked mechanically and Izuku was sure that if he looked over his shoulder, he would see the white eyes of a demon. *A monster—*

The wood of the stairs creaked with new weight as the demon ascended. Sweat pooled in his palms and gathered at his brow.

I need to get out.

But the door was locked. *The door was locked.*

The creature made of smoke and shadow crept ever closer. The air in his lungs shuddered out and he clawed uselessly at the door. He could hear the locks on the other side groan. Freezing tears spilled from his eyes.

He pounded his fists against the door as claws wrapped around his ankle. His nails were hot and stinging and his knuckles throbbed with pain.

Izuku was too terrified to reach down and pry away the hands made of ice. If he could just get out, then he would be fine! The demon wouldn't pass the threshold of the doorway. He just needed to get out. His mother couldn't keep him locked down here forever, right?

And now that he was thinking about his mother… Where was she? Where was Hisashi?

He shook his head and more tears fell. *No.* They *won't come for me. Where is Shouta? Hizashi?*

His legs were going numb, prickling and tingling as the demon embraced him. The claws ventured further up, wrapping around his shoulders. Izuku was certain his breath was a small, white cloud of smoke from the bitter cold.

Even in complete darkness, Izuku couldn't resist the urge to look back as an icy hand gently placed itself on his throat.

A pair of white eyes peered at him, and he could barely make out the outline of a long, sinister face of a demon. The demon had put its head on his shoulder, and its blood-red teeth reflected even in the swath of eternal darkness.

"...trapped..." the monster rasped with a widening smile. *"Forever..."*

The other hand wrapped around his left wrist, and the monster cackled. The laugh was like shattering glass. It grated against his ears and Izuku flinched in surprise at its volume.

And then the two of them were falling. Air swept past him as they both went airborne and the monster didn't stop laughing.

Izuku thrashed in the demon's hold, screaming his throat raw with horror. Faster than he could comprehend, the demon dragged him into the darkest part of his room, and all he could hear was clanging.

The clanging of chains.

Chapter End Notes

Lately, I've been bang dream again (after years of dropping the game) and I just keep playing it and playing it because they added a rehearsal function. send help. I've been distracted and not writing. (that's a lie I literally have a d.gray-man one shot up on my google doc rn lol)

Sorry I Rambled This is The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

A message: I feel like this is obvious but meh. Sayin it anyway. Just to put writing SW into perspective for a lot of ppl (who complain about Midoriya's non-linear character development, which is valid), I've been writing this for YEARS. So I've taken breaks

between arcs, like MONTHS worth of a break or I write other things. That means some of my chapters and character arcs have been in the works for years, and when I started this fic I had no idea where it would go. (I know it shows. Don't call me out lol) It also means that I'm learning as I go, so the early chapters and stuff are kinda weird. I don't think I'd change anything about the story though because it would honestly take so much work. Once I finish the story it's over. No revisions. There will be extra chapters too, to see what happens after the story is completed but I don't plan on rewriting this fic. If it was 100k then I would go for it, but this one is tooooooo long for my health.

Chapter 74

Chapter Summary

Final exams!!! <3 (written test lol) (also soft Class 1-A!!!)

Chapter Notes

Here's a new chapter! I know I keep saying I'll stick to my schedule, but the friend that's been proof-reading my fic has been stressed and overworked lately so I decided to give them a much needed break! (YOU KNOW WHO YOU ARE. I LOVE YOU. QUIT OVERWORKING YOURSELF HOE.) So I got another amazing friend to beta for me instead, so my OG beta can finally rest as much as they can! Also my beta has proof-read pretty far ahead so my updates will be regular again!! Much love to Tali and Raven for taking time out of their lives to tell me when I misspelled Midoriya 20 times. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He didn’t scream when he awoke. Sweat coated his skin in a thin layer, and his heart was hammering in his chest. Fear raked her claws down his spine, leaving goosebumps along his skin in her wake.

Izuku lay frozen on his bed, wrapped in a heavy layer of his weighted blanket that he’d received from Kouda and Tokoyami, oh so long ago. Not that basement, not that cold, cruel house that he’d lived in all of his life. He was home. And he was safe.

He repeated it over and over, attempting to drown out any other overbearing thoughts. *I’m safe. I’m safe.*

It worked, but not as well as he’d liked. He thought of the monster creeping up the stairs, hunting him. He thought of the hands made of ice, and the clicking.

White eyes. Rotting flesh. Fear. So much terror.

He brought a hand to his face and grabbed a handful of his hair. *Stop thinking about that. Don't think about it. It wasn't real.*

But, a part of him whispered in the darkness, *what if it was real? What if it wasn't a dream at all?*

Izuku pressed his lips into a white thin line. Even if it wasn't a dream, and it was in fact, real life, then what could he even do about it? Who could he tell? Well… Shouta and Hizashi were always options, but what then? What could be done? Could they even fix it, or prevent it?

He doubted it. So he sat up in bed and sighed soundlessly. A demon was standing in the closet again, Izuku noticed dully. It's white eyes peered at him, and he could hardly make out its wispy outline thanks to the nightlights. The demon didn't move and Izuku ignored it for now. Unless it started trouble, but this one seemed pretty docile.

He kicked off his sheets and weighted blanket. The air-conditioner was running, considering how close it was to summer and the cool air kissed against his sweat-slicked skin.

The clock on his nightstand read three a.m., but Izuku had no desire to go back to bed after that kind of nightmare.

The darkness that blanketed everything like ink. The cold, dead hands of a demon, a *monster,* that dragged him deep within the recesses of the basement where all his fears dwelled like a sleeping Goliath—

Izuku shook himself out of his running thoughts. He could do something else with his time other than trying to go back to sleep. He didn't need to train for his tests today, and he definitely didn't need to train for the practical, so he needed to think of something else.

Izuku was reaching for his art supplies before his mind caught up to it. His sketchbook — the one Kacchan had bought him recently — was empty and in need of filling. He usually didn't

draw with pencils, but he didn't feel like getting his hands dirty with charcoal so early in the morning.

The first thing he drew was Shouta, wearing his hero costume, with his capture weapon around his shoulders. His goggles were covering his eyes and his hair was floating by itself, his Quirk having been activated.

After that he drew a quick sketch of Hizashi on the next open page, wearing his hero costume as well and shouting. 'YEAAAH!'

The last drawing he did was of both Shouta and Hizashi. They were in matching tracksuits. The one's they'd been wearing when they went for an afternoon run just earlier in the night.

Izuku let the smallest of smiles grace his lips, before he remembered the cold hands against his skin.

Shouta knew something was wrong with his kid the second he came out of his room. There were dark bags beneath his eyes, suggesting that he didn't sleep at all, or woke up in the middle of the night.

Shouta was leaning toward the first option, if he knew Izuku at all. He was always having nightmares, or overthinking something. It wasn't unusual for Izuku to stay up all night.

But he was worried. Even more worried than usual, when he sees the dark bruise encircling Izuku's wrist.

"What's that?" Shouta asks after a sip of coffee. Izuku startles instantly, giving himself a once-over in confusion.

His eyes widen just a fraction as they land on the dark purple bruise around his wrist. Shouta vividly remembers the conversation they had about the bruises around his neck so long ago. And Izuku's explanation.

A monster had done that to him. He'd been dreaming of "The Darkness" and a monster had wrapped its hands around Izuku's throat until he woke up. It couldn't be…

But what other explanation was there? "It happened again." Shouta states, putting his mug of coffee down. "The Darkness?"

His kid looks startled all over again, as if he expected Shouta to forget about that incident entirely. Surprisingly, Izuku shook his head.

"Then what?" Shouta asked, dreading the answer. If his son was being attacked in his dreams, then what could Shouta do to stop it?

He could do nothing. He was useless. There weren't any quirks that could venture into people's dreams, and Shouta definitely didn't possess one. Izuku presses his lips together and ducks his head. Shouta hates it every time his kid does this.

His kid is always so afraid. Always quick to hide himself and shrink into nothingness, as if Shouta would think of raising a hand to him. *Ever* .

He crouches down to be level with Izuku, as he's seen Bakugou do so many times. Too many times because he's the only one that can calm Izuku down most of the time.

Shouta begs for a day where Izuku is calmed by his presence. A day where Izuku trusts him fully, without any hints of doubt.

"You can tell me anything, Izuku. I promise."

Izuku gives the tiniest of nods, and finally, blessedly looks up at him and begins to sign.

[It was the basement this time.] was all that he signed, and it was enough to have Shouta's throat closing.

The basement.

The place where Inko and Hisashi Midoriya had trapped their own child. Their own flesh and blood. He stamped down on the rising fury burning through his thoughts. "I'm sorry kiddo,"

Izuku shook his head and signed again. [It's not your fault. There's not much that can be done to fix it.]

He also hates one other thing about his kid. He's *always* right. He's too smart, and Shouta hates that sometimes—he's joking—Shouta actually loves it. He loves that Izuku isn't the next All Might, with a brain full of cotton and cobwebs. Shouta is immensely grateful that his son is smarter and more resourceful than any other kid Shouta has ever encountered.

Shouta wouldn't know what to do with another mini All Might. He might have a stroke. Or a heart attack on sight.

But Izuku is right. There's nothing to be done about his dreams and the injuries that cross over. There's no technology or Quirk to stop the transfer of pain. All he can do is hope that every morning Izuku wakes up with no unexplainable bruises or lacerations.

He doesn't let himself dwell on the what ifs of this situation. He doesn't even stop to think about how it could probably kill Izuku. He totally didn't think of that at all. It isn't wrapping around his throat like a noose. The what ifs didn't terrify him.

Not one bit.

He just pulled Izuku in for a hug and ran a hand through his curls, as if this was the last time they would ever make contact. A parent should always cling to their child as if it was their last moment together.

Because one day— *one day it would be.*

Shouta was always pessimistic and thinking the worst out of every situation. But not with Izuku. *Never* with Izuku. It would be fine. Izuku would stop dreaming of what he feared most, he'd pass his exams, and he'd come home each day more healed than the day before.

But he still reached for Izuku and hugged him like it was the last time, every time. He wanted Izuku to know that Shouta loved him. Loved him so *much.*

They pulled apart after a moment or two, and Izuku looked up at him with a slight smile. It was barely there, but every time Shouta saw it he felt something loosen in his chest.

"When you're trapped in The Darkness, or any kind of nightmare you can count on me to save you, okay? I'll always protect you, even in your dreams. You won't need to be afraid," Shouta told him. "All you need to do is call my name,"

[Promise?]

"I cross my heart, kiddo," Shouta breathed, "Have I ever lied to you, Izuku?"

Izuku's smile brightened and he shook his head. Shouta would never admit it out loud, but that smile, aside from Yamada's, always made him feel warm inside.

There was a lull in the one-sided conversation before Yamada walked in from his shower, gelling up his hair.

“So are you excited for your finals today?” He asked, with a blinding smile. Izuku’s expression instantly dropped in utter horror, and Yamada chuckled. “I’m sure you’ll do just fine kiddo! You’re really smart, and your Quirk is strong too!”

“You studied and trained for this, it’ll be fine,” Shouta added, “And you’ll even get a break before the summer training camp,”

Izuku tilted his head to the side in question. [Is that when Shinsou will move in?]

Shouta nodded. “Yeah. Would you like to help us set everything up for him once finals are over?”

Izuku nodded enthusiastically, and Shouta found himself smiling again.

Everyone seemed more nervous than usual when Izuku got to class. Whether it was because they heard about what happened at the gates, or it was because of finals, he probably wouldn’t know.

Luckily for him, Nedzu had managed to keep the press well away from the gates. There were even a few police officers stationed at the gates, to ensure that none of the press got remotely close to the campus.

It brought him immense comfort to know that he’d be safe from the flash of cameras, and the unrelenting cruelty of the questions they’d undoubtedly ask him.

Kacchan was the first to approach his desk, his eyes searching for something. For distress. For wounds, bruises, lacerations, and red-flags. Perhaps he was a little too protective?

But after a few seconds of that staring, Kacchan didn't seem to find anything to worry about. The silent question on his lips burst forth, "Are you okay?"

Izuku grinned slightly, and nodded in response. Kacchan's face softened immeasurably, and Izuku definitely noticed how Uraraka, Iida, Todoroki, and Shinsou seemed to relax. In fact, most of his classmates relaxed at his response, the tension in their shoulders dropping.

Had they all worried about him? That was weird… but not unwelcome. "I was so worried about you Mido!" Ashido exclaimed, looking like she hadn't slept in the slightest since the last time he saw her.

Her hair was more wild than usual, sticking out in all kinds of directions. There were even bags under her eyes, which onto itself was a strange, unusual occurrence. She always looked put together and runway ready, to Izuku.

To see her like this, looking a little more messy and natural than usual was... weird? Denki and Sero looked to be similar states, and it only served to make him more anxious. Had they worried *this much* about him?

"Yeah, I couldn't sleep!" Sero adds, before pulling on Denki's collar. His boyfriend—Izuku remembers Sero's memories, okay? Sue him—nodded along.

"Yeah, yeah! We didn't even get to give you our apology gifts!" Denki whined. "We even made a speech and everything, and then the whole thing with the press at the gates happened and you left so— I'm just gonna say it!"

For a second he smacked his cheeks and pumped himself up, and Ashido steeled her resolve. Sero pulled a bag off the floor and unzipped it.

From the corner of his eye he saw Shouta yawn, and look at the interaction with mild interest. Finals were going to take up the majority, if not all of their day today, but Shouta let them continue.

In sync all three of them spoke, bowing slightly. “We’re really sorry for the things we said about you Midoriya-kun! We don’t expect you to forgive us, but we wanted you to know we really feel bad about the things we did— and we got you gifts!”

It’s then that Sero shoves a lot of things into Izuku’s arms, and Izuku can feel his face heating with embarrassment as he sees the art supplies, a coloring book, a music player, candles and tea. All meaningful gifts.

All to cement their apology, which already had his eyes stinging because he rarely ever got apologies from classmates. He was weak for them, and easy to forgive in most situations. He swipes at his tears uselessly, and Ashido throws her arms around him in what is meant to be a comforting gesture.

For him though, hugs will probably never be comfortable unless they’re from Shouta, Shinsou, or Hizashi. Or Kacchan. His hugs are always warm, but he allows Ashido to hug him while trying his best to not look uncomfortable.

She lets him go after a few seconds, and he sets his gifts on his desk. “You don’t have to accept our apology but—”

“The damn nerd forgave you already, so just chill out Pinky,” Kacchan snapped from his desk, and Izuku nods to confirm this. The trio before him seems to melt at the action, and they most importantly, look relieved.

After that they all settle down, and his dad yawns tiredly again. Was he up as late last night as Izuku was? It was just like him to stay up all night grading.

“Alright,” He begins, gesturing to the packet on his desk. It’s really thick and Izuku chews the inside of his cheek, wondering if he studied enough for this. He should’ve studied more. “First you’re all going to take the written exam. It has three sections that will take you an hour to complete, with fifteen minute breaks in between each section. After that we’ll have you all change into your Hero Costumes to start the practical,”

Shouta puts a packet on all of their desks, and goes back to his desk—having gathered Izuku’s gifts in the process—and looks at the clock.

“Okay. You may open your tests and begin,” He mumbles. “I’ll tell you when time is up,”

And then he puts his head on his desk after taking a long sip from his coffee mug. Izuku blocks out the sound of Denki *already* despairing, and focuses on his own test.

Naturally he stomps the math section, answering the questions easily. The three hours pass by without any internal panic from Izuku, and then they go to lunch. He sits next to Kacchan and literally *all* of his classmates.

They all decided to push their tables together and sit as a massive group. There’s some grumbling from Class 1-B, but it’s *Shinsou* who shuts them down.

“Oh! Class 1-A thinks it can do whatever it wants since the USJ and Sports Festival, huh? You guys are so loud I can hardly hear my own thoughts!” Monoma exclaimed from across the room, before walking closer.

Shinsou glares over his shoulder, and Izuku swears it could give Monoma third-degree burns. “I’m sorry we just want to *bond* together. Can’t say the same for you though. You and your classmates don’t seem half as close as we are. Maybe *that’s* why we’re better than you!”

Monoma’s face twists into something ugly, and his eyes cut to Izuku. “W-well at least I'm not evil! Like him!”

He’s pointing right at Izuku. “He’s the *devil!”*

And before Izuku’s brain can even conjure up any self-deprecating thoughts all hell breaks loose. His ears are ringing from the screaming that bursts from most of his classmates lips, and his eyes are wide as Shinsou jumps up from his seat to hold a *very angry* Kacchan back, who looks like he’s about to foam at the mouth.

“SAY THAT AGAIN FUCK FACE!” Kacchan bellows, bucking like a wild animal in Shinsou’s hold. To his credit, Shinsou doesn’t let go, and he holds firm.

“Bakugou I know Monoma’s an ass but—”

“But *what?!* We’re just gonna let him shit talk Izuku?!” Kacchan growls, and spittle flies from his mouth. *“Fuck that!* It’s about goddamn time I kicked Monoma’s pussy ass—”

An awkward cough cuts through the air. “Well,” It’s Nedzu, and his presence is enough to have the temperature in the room dropping. Or maybe it’s Todoroki’s ice. “I’ll add your name to the list of students I have to speak to, Monoma-kun. Would you like to come with me?”

And just like that, Monoma’s eyes go impossibly wide and his skin blanches. Nedzu is *smiling* which is terrifying on its own on a good day. He gives Izuku a wink before turning to address the entire lunchroom.

“If I hear even a *whisper* of Quirk Discrimination against Midoriya or *any* student within my halls, you’ll be expelled. Consider this a *warning* , my dear students.”

With that he walks out of the lunchroom with a terrified Monoma trailing after him. Izuku looks at his classmates in exasperation. All of them had stood up from him, ready to bite Monoma’s head off for a single comment.

He doesn’t realize his jaw has dropped until Uraraka giggles. “If you keep your mouth open like that Deku then you’ll catch flies!”

He finds himself thinking that he’s not the one everyone should be scared of. It’s his crazily over-protective classmates, who for a moment there looked ready to commit murder in broad daylight.

“Oh! Oh!” Ashido exclaims very suddenly, “We all had Present Mic teach us some sign language the other day, when you left the dorms! Wanna see?”

Ashido sloppily signs out a few basic signs, and beams. “Soon we won’t have to rely on Aizawa-sensei translating for us to know what you're saying!”

He’s crying before he can stop it.

“Don’t cry, kero,”

“Here’s a tissue Midoriya!” Yaoyorozu told him, with a motherly smile.

Chapter End Notes

Also y'all self-care rlly do be important. I started meditating again and doing yoga and it's finally working??? Like every other time I tried it I went into it with a mind-set of "this isn't going to work for me," so of course it didn't. But this time I was just so tired of not loving myself (body image issues, social anxiety that made me quit my job and stay unemployed to this day, and insomnia) that I promised myself it would work this time! I'm much calmer than I've been these past few weeks.

Idk why I'm randomly ranting about it, but ig what I'm tryna say is: It doesn't matter how much *time* you spend on yourself, as long as you do self-care. 10 minutes? 5 minutes? Doesn't matter. take care of yourselves guys, gals and non-binary pals >:DD

Sorry I Rambled (AGAIN) This is The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 75

Chapter Summary

Here's the practical part of the exam!! <3

Chapter Notes

What's this? Me updating for two weeks in a row? Yes!! <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were all dressed in their Hero Costumes and outside. Izuku's was freshly made by none other than Hatsume Mei, and it was a major improvement from the last one. It looks much more badass than his previous one, and he finds himself smiling slightly.

His new costume consists of a black bodysuit and body armor that looks like claws and scales. Izuku has a mouth guard settled around his neck that has a toothy mouth etched onto it. There are pieces of armor at his shoulders, where a cape is attached, that hangs all the way down to his mid-thigh. The shoulder guards themselves are smoother than any other piece of armor strapped to him, but they're still rough and scale-like.

Attached to his cape, however, is a hood that he can pull over his eyes that has menacing demon-like eye holes. When combined with his mouth guard, it makes for a pretty intimidating picture.

Down on his arms are gloves that stop right before his elbow. The gloves themselves have an outer layer of armor too, in the shape of sharp claws. On the underside of the gloves at his forearms are daggers, secured safely in their sheaths.

There's a belt around his waist that has more daggers strapped to it, as well as his beat-up katana.

There's a sheath strapped to his right thigh, and there's another dagger there. Going down his legs, there are shin guards that match the aesthetic of the other pieces of armor and his reinforced shoes.

At the back of his hero costume, hidden by his cape are two slits for his wings. It's a struggle to get them through the slits, but he manages with the help of Dabi.

Overall, he thinks he, Kacchan, and Hatsume did a good job of fixing up his costume, being less of All for One's creation, and more Izuku's.

He doesn't want to admit it, even to himself, but he looks pretty cool.

Once he had been completely ready he turned to Kacchan for approval. Kacchan looked him over once, and his mouth twitched upward.

"Lookin' good for a nerd," He'd said when they were in the locker room.

Now they're all standing outside Ground Beta, and all their teachers are standing in front of them. Their practicals are just about to begin. And then afterward is their summer vacation and then the training camp.

Nedzu popped his head out of his dad's capture weapon, and Izuku raised an eyebrow in response.

"Hello Class 1-A!" Nedzu exclaimed, his beady eyes being the only part of his expression showing any excitement. His face wasn't meant for smiling. "As most of you heard, the final exam is usually the Robots like from the Entrance Exam, but seeing as the landscape of Heroism is ever-changing and unique, I've thought it's time to switch things up a bit! Villains are getting stronger, and in return, we must nurture all you little chicks to be stronger as well. We can't have our future generation falling behind, now can we?"

Nedzu takes what Izuku considers a much-needed breath before continuing on.

“As a result, you won’t be facing off with Robots today!” And *now* he’s really smiling. He sees Denki shudder out of the corner of his eye. He gestures to himself and all the teachers present. “You’ll be fighting us!”

And if *that* wasn’t utterly terrifying, Izuku didn’t know what was. He’s not the only one to go pale, as his jaw drops to the floor. Kirishima looks just as shocked, and Uraraka mumbles something about wanting to pass out.

Izuku quickly schools his expression. “We’ll have you form teams of two to fight against one teacher!”

“Against…” Iida said under his breath, swaying on his feet, “...Our teachers?”

“In addition, the pairs and who each pair will be have already been decided.” Shouta piped up, not at all helping with the situation. “These pairings were determined at my discretion based on various factors, including fighting style, grades, and interpersonal relationships, so here they are. First, Todoroki and Yaoyorozu are a team, and they’re fighting me,”

“Kirishima and Bakugou are a team, facing off against All Might. Satou and Shinsou against Cementoss. Uraraka and Aoyama against Thirteen. Iida and Ojiro against Power Loader. Koda and Jirou against Present Mic. Shouji and Hagakure against Snipe. Sero and Tsuyu against Midnight. Ashido and Denki against Ectoplasm. Midoriya and Tokoyami against Nedzu,”

After that Nedzu spoke up again. “The time limit for the exam is thirty minutes! Your objective for this final is either to put these handcuffs on the teacher you’re up against, or to have one of you escape from the stage!”

“Escape?” Uraraka echoed, “Is that really okay?”

“Yes!” Nedzu responded. “You’ll be facing off with people much, much stronger than you who have more experience!”

Thirteen nodded. “This exam is very similar to a real battle. So please think of us as villains during the exercise.”

Snipe was the next to jump to explain. “Assuming you come across the enemy, if you’re confident in your abilities to defeat and subdue them, then fighting is perfectly fine. However —”

Shouta crossed his arms and gave Izuku a firm *dad look.* “In cases where there’s too big a gap between you and your enemies abilities it would be smarter and more beneficial to back off and get help rather than trying to fight a villain you can’t beat. And yes, there will be times where running away is impossible, and you must overcome the obstacles left in your way. But if there’s an option for escape when an opponent is too strong, take it. There’s no use in dying in vain,”

“You’re all probably thinking that running away is the only feasible option, which is why we had the support department make these!” All Might exclaimed, drawing something out of his pockets. “Compressed weights! It's a handicap to even the playing field, as old-fashioned as it is. But it’s effective!”

“To make us consider fighting you, huh?” Kacchan mumbled, and All Might nodded.

“All right, each team will take the practical exam in the order that your names were called out! Todoroki and Yaoyorozu— please get ready! Those waiting for their exam can meet up with their partners to discuss strategy, or you can watch everyone else's exams!”

Izuku turned to Tokoyami and raised an eyebrow in question. Were they going to talk strategy? Tokoyami just closed his eyes and mumbled serenely, “What a mad bouquet of darkness we make together,”

Just as Izuku was about to despair over his possible failure of finals, Tokoyami grabbed his hand. “Let’s start planning our strategy, oh Dark One,”

Izuku didn’t know what to think of Tokoyami’s nickname, but he wasn’t complaining. At least they were making a plan, which, based on Tokoyami's first statement hadn’t seemed likely.

They entered the viewing room on Ground Beta and sat down at one of the tables. Tokoyami had gotten a pencil and paper from *somewhere.* “Sorry,” He mumbled sheepishly. “My sign language isn’t good enough for us to hold a conversation yet…”

Izuku just shot him a thumbs up, and they started to plan the fall of Nedzu. Or in Tokoyami’s words—not his own—the fall of the Rat God.

The plan wasn’t fool-proof, or even that *good* of a plan. It was a strange occurrence to say the least, considering that when he had the chance—aka, wasn’t getting jumped by villains—he tried to plan things meticulously.

However, without knowing what the terrain of their own exam was going to look like, and what Nedzu would be using to his advantage, it was difficult. It mainly had to do with the fact that Nedzu had an intelligence Quirk, and was probably already aware of any plans the two of them could conjure up.

Izuku wasn’t sure if they’d win against Nedzu with this plan, or even pass the exam, but hey. It was worth a shot. And he wouldn’t be lying if he said he wasn’t curious to see if he could outwit Nedzu himself.

“Are you ready, Midoriya?” Tokoyami asked, triple checking that his disguise was in place underneath his hero costume. Izuku nodded as they were allowed into the training facility, and Dark Shadow made itself known, and Izuku smiled as he pulled up his own hood and mouthguard.

“Midoriya and Tokoyami practical exams begin! Ready? Go!”

Hopefully this was successful. The two of them entered the facility and Izuku immediately noticed how the terrain consisted mostly of buildings with pipes. It almost looked like a maze.

Once they’re in one of the blindspots of the cameras for the exams, they stop.

Tokoyami sheds his cloak that is a trademark of his hero costume. Izuku touched the hilt of his sword and summoned Dabi who took the cloak and threw it around his shoulders. He drew the hood up to obscure his features, and he and Tokoyami parted ways.

“Good luck, oh Dark One,”

Izuku nodded.

The *real* Tokoyami would search for the exit while he and Dabi faced off with Nedzu for as long as possible.

While they had been going over their plans, he told Tokoyami to find the nearest wall in the facility and follow it until he came across the exit gate, which wasn’t a bad strategy. The hardest part was keeping Nedzu unaware that Tokoyami wasn’t actually present during their battle.

“Think this’ll work, ‘Zuku?” Dabi asked. “We can replicate Tokoyami’s Quirk using demons, but are you sure he can find the exit in time?”

He gave a curt nod.

“Where even is Nedzu?” Dabi muttered to himself as they walked. The mock city was quiet. Too quiet.

That was the only wild card. Where would Nedzu be? What would he do? Izuku couldn't predict him.

But that was fine. He could certainly bait Nedzu easily enough. He signed as much to Dabi. "How?"

[I thought we went over the plan.]

"Okay, okay. We run for the exit gate? Or where it might be?"

Izuku nodded and they both started running. They cut down an alleyway that was crowded with more pipes and warehouses. They skidded out into the main street of the training ground and were suddenly stopped by a very *loud* crashing noise.

Standing in the middle of the street was Nedzu, who was riding a remote control robot. "Tsk, tsk. I thought you'd be smarter than this, you two!" He told them. "You didn't even bother to split up."

So he didn't need to bait Nedzu after all, huh?

Izuku was glad his face was covered because his grin would've given him away in a heartbeat.

"It's just as well," Nedzu said from his seat, producing a cup of steaming tea from out of thin air. "I'm intrigued to see how you two manage to pass this. *If* you pass,"

The smile that's on his lips is cold and calculating as he takes another long sip of his tea until it's empty. Then he throws the porcelain cup and it shatters on the concrete. His expression darkens and he takes a hold of the controls on the robot.

It happens very quickly. Nedzu uses the massive robot to cause a chain reaction in the surrounding buildings, successfully getting rid of any viable options to escape. He's playing right in the palm of Izuku's hand.

It's almost laughable.

Dabi—who has disguised himself as Tokoyami—rushes forward as an exact replica of Dark Shadow darts out from under the black cloak. The fake Dark Shadow collides with the robot, and Izuku maintains impeccable control of the demon's actions, imitating Dark Shadow exactly.

Dark Shadow can't get bigger because it's still light out, so he keeps the demon's size the same, even though the urge to make him bigger than Nedzu's robot is strong.

But all he's doing in this situation is being the distraction, like during the Sports Festival… Just less gory and less life-threatening. A major improvement, if you asked Izuku.

Izuku rushes in right behind Dabi, his sword is already in his hands as he darts forward. He swings his sword in an arc, and the steel screams as the robot and his blade clash.

Nedzu's maniacal laughter follows. "Since your presentation of power at the Entrance Exam I've been experimenting with stronger robots! It seems to me that this one is much more powerful than the Zero Pointer!"

Izuku's grip on his katana tightened. There's not even a scratch on the robot. "Dark Shadow" roared loudly, and released another round of attacks against the metal.

Nedzu's robot swatted at them. Izuku didn't move out of the way fast enough, and the robot arm swats him like a fly. As a result he slams into an entire *building* . Concrete and glass shatter around him, ripping through his body suit and digging into his skin. Sharp, white-hot pain hits him like a freight train. His hand is sliced open, and bleeding. His head is pounding and he's definitely dizzy, but he gets up anyway with hardly more than a groan.

He stumbles out of the building and shakes the glass out of his curls as he reorients himself. Dabi is distracting Nedzu for now, but Nedzu looks kind of bored. He swings at Dabi, and he retreats from the arm. Izuku joins him.

Dabi turned to look at him, and Izuku nodded. Okay, so maybe Izuku was being pessimistic about his plan.

If he couldn't attack the robot, then he'd attack Nedzu directly.

They could do this. They took off together, and as they neared the robot again Nedzu swiped at them again. But Izuku wasn't planning on staying on the ground for much longer. Izuku was nowhere near a building to vault off of, so Dabi and the fake Dark Shadow would have to do.

Dabi skidded to halt before the robot hand could hit him, and Izuku used his back as a springboard—knowing that later Dabi would be clutching his back painfully—and jumped. Dark Shadow was there a second later to vault him up higher. He uses his wings the rest of the way, and comes face to face with Nedzu, who looks pleased at the turn of events.

And then Izuku throws his katana like a javelin directly at Nedzu's head with all his quirk-induced strength. Nedzu barely dodged, but his sword kept flying until it hit the ground and created a small crater from the impact.

Izuku clicked his tongue audibly as he descended, but Dark Shadow caught him before he could splat against the pavement.

With a growl he got to his feet again and glared up at the rat on the robot. Nedzu was laughing again.

"Ha ha ha!" Nedzu gripped his face with one of his paws and he looked absolutely *thrilled* . "I guess it's time to use *that,"*

Izuku's brows furrowed in confusion. Nedzu pressed a button on his control panel and the robot shifted and transformed. It was *huge!* And there were *missiles* on it. Izuku tried his best not to let his shock freeze him to the spot.

He needed to *focus* ! He needed to pass and make his dads proud! He couldn't afford to fail. Not after everything he's had to deal with since before attending Yuuei. Izuku needs a win.

It's been so long since he's won anything, or done anything right. It's been *too* long. He wants to feel good for once without being sent to hospital because of it. His eyes sting as he immediately begins to despair.

Fucking missiles?! Are you fucking kidding?

Nedzu doesn't notice his inner turmoil, and fires them. Izuku doesn't even notice as he deftly grabs Dabi and flies through the air onto a rooftop. Nedzu follows, destroying the buildings in his path.

Izuku's eyes widen even further as Nedzu presses the button to fire *again.*

"Oh, Aizawa's gonna have a *fit* ," Dabi wheezes as Izuku drags him.

Izuku uses a technique he's only ever seen Hawks do *once* . He uses his wings to propel himself back as he runs, refusing to take his eyes off Nedzu for one second. The buildings he jumps off of explode in a shower of rubble and debris, but Izuku keeps going backwards, coasting in the air for a moment one time, to avoid a missile that had gotten too close.

"It's time?" Dabi says, struggling to keep up with Izuku's speed. Izuku smiles, even though Dabi can't see it.

"It's time," Dabi repeats to himself, and Izuku launches into the air with Dabi in his arms. They fly through the air, even though Izuku is already feeling an ache in his back muscles.

“DODGE!” Dabi suddenly screams, “DODGE THE MISSILES!”

Izuku does the only thing he can think of without wasting time turning around. He snaps his wings closed and free falls as the missiles whiz by his head. “Oh sweet baby jesus...” Dabi whispers to himself.

Dangerously close , Izuku thinks to himself, as he opens his wings and they’re airborne again.

“This is high enough,” Dabi says after a moment, and Izuku whips around to face Nedzu, who is still on the ground, looking up in confusion as Izuku drops Dabi.

The cloak comes off.

“BOMBS AWAY!” Dabi bellows, as he free falls. Nedzu’s look of utter shock is worth every second.

Blue fire *explodes* outward as soon as Dabi is close enough to Nedzu. Izuku can feel the heat from up in the air, it's so strong. He flys down to the scene to assess the damage. The robot is destroyed, and Nedzu is standing perfectly fine—free of any burns—on the street below.

“My, my, that was impressive!”

A shrieking alarm goes off.

“TOKOYAMI AND MIDORIYA HAVE PASSED!”

Izuku highfives Dabi, and Nedzu taps his chin thoughtfully. He’s not really looking at either of them. After a second he comes up to Izuku and grins.

“You’re smarter than I thought, Midoriya-kun. Having Dabi disguise himself as Tokoyami is pure genius! I didn’t even notice until he took off his hood! Using yourself and Dabi as a distraction to give Tokoyami time to escape is pretty well thought out too. Every move you made was planned in advance, and I couldn’t have done it better myself, especially the part where you jumped in the air to find the exit! Throwing your sword was not only to distract me further and make sure my attention was on you two, but to show Tokoyami where the exit was! Pure genius!” He was foaming at the mouth now, and Izuku felt the urge to back up a bit. “Pure genius. Pure genius! If Aizawa wasn’t a terrifying father I might suggest that you become my personal student, but Aizawa-san wouldn’t be too happy about that. Now… let’s get you patched up, yes? You hit your head pretty hard when you hit that building. I am truly sorry about that… But an exam is an exam!”

God, did Nedzu even *breathe* half the time?

“To answer your question that you’re no doubt wondering about—No! I can hold more air than humans can, but I’m not sure why!”

Izuku felt himself pale. Nedzu was truly scary sometimes.

Chapter End Notes

Hopefully, you enjoyed this chapter! I'm currently writing the end of Kamino ward so look forward to it :DDD

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 76

Chapter Summary

Getting custody of Shinsou and getting the Todoroki family away from Endeavor!!! <3
(Shinsou's parents are surprisingly cooperative about giving up custody lol)

Chapter Notes

So for this chapter, I'm pretty sure I looked up how to make pancakes because PANCAKES ARE GROSS AND IDEK WHY I WROTE THAT SCENE BUT ANYWAY-

Enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

His dad is understandably angry with Nedzu, but it's not as bad as he thought it was going to be. He made it to Recovery Girls' office with the aid of Nedzu and Tokoyami, who seemed relieved that they passed, but also guilty because he "didn't do anything"

Yeah. What a load of shit. Tokoyami was the *reason* they passed! He told him this through sign, and Shouta translated for him. Eventually, Tokoyami accepted that he was pivotal to their success as Recovery Girl gave him a kiss on the temple.

Shouta shot Nedzu a fiery glare and crossed his arms. "Shoot missiles at my son again, and see if you walk out of Yuuei alive," He spat, and Hizashi's eyes widened in horror.

"Shouta!! It's just an exam," Hizashi tried his hardest to placate his husband, but it didn't seem to work. "Our little listener is fine!"

"I had already made the calculations before the exams had even started, Aizawa. Your son was never in any danger, I promise you."

“Try to be a little more convincing,” Shouta spat, but it wasn’t as venomous as it previously had been. “You shouldn’t be firing missiles at him at *all,”*

Nedzu just waved his hand in response, with a glint of amusement in his beady, black eyes. “All Might went all out on Bakugou-kun and his partner, remember? Midoriya isn’t the only child you should be watching out for, but this *is* training. This is Yuuei, and villains are getting stronger by the day, Aizawa-kun. We’re all trying to prepare the heroes of tomorrow for the trails they’ll face. I know it’s difficult to see Midoriya-kun in high stress situations, but please be assured that I never intended to actually hit him with a missile.”

Izuku didn’t want to break the moment by saying that he was *terrified* that Nedzu would actually hit him. It wouldn’t end well for Nedzu at all, so he pressed his lips together in a thin line as Shouta’s shoulders finally sagged at Nedzu’s very logical explanation.

“I suppose you’re right, as usual,” He grumbled, and turned away. His tired eyes caught Izuku’s and he glanced at Hizashi. “You’re good?”

Izuku nodded as Shouta looked over him once again. He flashed a thumbs up, and his dad gave his own version of a smirk. They left the nurses office, and Tokoyami left them in favor of heading back to the dorms.

“Oh oh!” Hizashi said suddenly. “Should we start making plans with Shinsou to move his stuff into our place? Have we even spoken to his parents about it yet? I don’t really see them denying anything and resisting to a change of parental rights,”

Shouta seemed to pause at that, as if he hadn’t thought about even talking to Shinsou’s parents. Maybe he just decided on his own that he was stealing Shinsou, without even speaking with Shinsou’s foster parents? Izuku could help.

“Oh. I guess I do have to talk to his parents…”

And that right there solidified Izuku’s theory. “We can’t just steal a child Shouta!”

[We could.] Izuku smirked, and Shouta matched it.

“The both of you are completely hopeless! Shinsou isn’t some stray to adopt off the streets… even if that would be a lot easier. We need to speak with his parents as much as I hate the idea of it. We should also take all his things while we’re there so he never has to go back for any reason.”

There was the soft padding of some animal walking behind them, and suddenly Nedzu spoke up. “You have three weeks worth of a break before the training camp. That should be plenty of time to let Shinsou settle in, and give us time for the *other* thing.”

Shouta gave Nedzu a considerable glance that was laden with many emotions and information. Whatever the *other thing* was, it was urgent. Could it be Todoroki? They had all seen his memories during their terrible, horrifying, therapy session. The way Shouta and Nedzu shared a murderous look meant that they were planning something to get Endeavor far, far away from his children.

Izuku grinned slightly, and walked a little closer to Hizashi, who preened at the sudden attention. In a moment of fluffy passion that Izuku could practically see blossoming in Hizashi’s chest, his dad slung his arm around him and gave him a side-hug. “You’re so affectionate today, little listener!”

“You’re the one hugging him,” Shouta pointed out with a smirk that was soft and warm.

“Let me have this, Sho,”

Shouta just crossed his arms and huffed.

The next day, Izuku is woken from his slumber by Hizashi and Shouta. He was exhausted from his final exam with Tokoyami, and he honestly just wanted to sleep in.

But then he remembered the conversation they'd had while leaving Yuuei, about helping Shinsou get out of his foster parents house. Despite the heaviness in his limbs, and the ache in his eyes, Izuku scrambled out of bed instantly.

[Shinsou?] he simply signed, hoping he didn't look too eager.

Hizashi gave him a smile made of sunshine that seemed to light up his entire room. "Yeah! We just called his parents to tell them we'd be heading over there to discuss something with them. We weren't sure if we should bring you with us, but Nemuri just called and said that she'll bring Shinsou over with some stuff for his room. Are you okay with staying here and helping him set up?"

Izuku slowly nodded, before raising his hands to respond. [When will they be here?]

"Nemuri is already on her way, so… in about ten minutes? What do you want for breakfast before we leave?"

Izuku never really *wanted* any kind of food. He never really craved anything. As long as there was food to eat, Izuku would eat it.

But staying with Hizashi and Shouta gave him a sense of security, and taught him to crave things. Like affection, love, praise, hugs, smiles, happiness, *food.* At the moment, after careful, *careful* consideration he decided on pancakes.

He signed such to Hizashi, and his dad smiled. "Just what I was thinking! Do you wanna help me with the batter?"

Izuku was still bone-achingly tired but he agreed. There was nothing else to do, and Shouta was grinning from behind Hizashi's back, probably hoping for some payback for the last time they let Izuku in the kitchen. Cute pictures, which apparently Nedzu had made into his background on his main computer at Yuuei.

The three of them headed into the kitchen and Hizashi started by getting out the flour, baking powder, salt, sugar, milk, eggs and butter. He silently looked over his shoulder at Shouta, who was leaning against the counter.

"What?" Shouta responded to Hizashi's silent question. "Do you need something?"

Hizashi pouted. "Come help?" He begged, probably giving Shouta what he assumed was his puppy dog eyes.

Shouta sighed heavily, as if it was the most painful thing in the world, but pulled his hair into a bun at the nape of his neck. "Fine, fine. What do you need me to do?"

"Melt the butter for now. I'll heat the pan and Izuku can make the batter and you can help him."

"Alright." He grumbled, unfolding the butter from it's paper package. Izuku watched him patiently, waiting for instruction. He put the butter in a bowl and placed it in the microwave to melt.

Shouta came over silently, with a whisper of a smile on his lips. He grabbed something out of the drawer next to him, and Izuku belatedly realized it was a sifter. "Here," Shouta simply said, handing it to him before he grabbed a bowl and started to pour the appropriate amount of flour into the sifter Izuku was holding over the bowl.

Izuku just stared. What was he supposed to do with this, exactly? His brow furrowed in confusion, and Shouta just chuckled. He took the sifter from him and demonstrated how it was used, before handing it back.

Izuku copied the movements, tapping the sifter to the palm of his hand, watching in awe as the flour fell into the bowl free of bumps and clumps. After that was done they added the baking powder, salt and sugar.

Then Shouta measured out the milk and poured it into their dry ingredients before putting the melted butter in the bowl. Last to go in was the eggs, and then Shouta took over mixing everything together to form the batter.

Hizashi, in the meantime, had gotten the coffee ready for Shouta, and prepared tea for himself and Izuku.

The two of them sat down and sipped on their tea. It was iced just the way he liked it. Hizashi liked his own tea hot, but Izuku could never understand how he didn't burn the roof of his mouth. "So, are you excited for a little break from everything?" Hizashi asked.

Izuku shrugged. He never really had anything interesting to do to fill up his free time. The most he'd end up doing is sleeping in and awkwardly fumbling his way through conversation with Shinsou once he got moved in. Or the lack of it, if he was honest with himself. He was never a conversationalist, and he wasn't sure how Shinsou truly felt about being forced to live under the same roof as him.

Hizashi seemed to read his mind. "Don't worry about anything kiddo!" He said, placing a firm and comforting hand on his shoulder. "I'm sure you and Shinsou will get along well! I wouldn't worry about the Press or your mother either, for that matter! We've got everything handled,"

His expression darkened considerably at the reminder of his mother, who had successfully *escaped* prison. Her and his father, along with All for One were still out there, looking for the perfect moment to strike. Which only served to make Izuku even more nervous about Shinsou moving in with them.

What if he was acting when he'd been nice to him at school? What if he secretly hated Izuku, and loathed the idea of living with him? And worst of all, what if Hizashi and Shouta decided that Shinsou was worth more of their time than Izuku? What if they loved Shinsou more than they loved *him* ?

It was a stupid train of thought, not to mention self-sabotaging. Hizashi seemed to realize the small misstep he'd taken with their conversation and quickly smoothed it over. Or he tried to…

"I didn't mean to remind you of her," He said gently, his face pinched together with concern. "I'm sorry,"

Izuku briefly shook himself out of his darker thoughts, before he managed a tight smile. [It's okay.]

"Ahem," Shouta grumbled, shooting both of them a glare. "I'm glad you two have *plenty* of time to chat, but you both dragged me into this, so you better make these pancakes. I'm not a slave, and they're not going to make themselves,"

Hizashi pouted, but ultimately got up from the table and Izuku followed suit as the three of them set upon trying to make the pancakes without trashing the kitchen.

All in all, it wasn't going well. At all. The pancakes themselves were perfectly fine, according to Izuku's expert standards of pancakes but the kitchen itself was another story entirely.

Hizashi was terrible at keeping the batter from dripping on the counter when he transferred it from the bowl to the pan. Shouta was getting grumpy about it, and Izuku was just trying not to burn the pancakes.

But then Shouta grumbled louder in annoyance when more batter splattered on the counter. This time, some hit his cheek, and he glared at Hizashi.

Hizashi snickered. "What?" He asked innocently, with that smile that lit up an entire room. "Something the matter, Sho?"

Izuku put the last pancake onto the final plate, with two extra plates for Midnight and Shinsou. Shouta was muttering something under his breath, and Hizashi's smile just got wider. "You're grumpy today, Mr. Grumpy-Pants,"

"Don't call me that," Shouta snapped, but it lacked any heat. The whisper of a smile was pulling at his lips, and Izuku could see how he was trying to stay annoyed instead of joining in on Hizashi's antics. There was that sparkle in Hizashi's eyes that always promised mischief, and Izuku knew that Shouta noticed it.

Hizashi slung batter at his husband, and Izuku ducked on pure instinct, narrowly avoiding the batter that was suddenly flying everywhere around the kitchen. No one was safe, as Hizashi and Shouta started shouting at each other incoherently, throwing batter around the kitchen.

As quickly as he could, he turned off the stove top to avoid any terrible disasters.

"Why are we doing this?!?" Shouta exclaimed, dodging another swipe of batter. He hadn't come out of this unscathed. Shouta was already dripping with pancake batter. Hizashi was worse off than him and Izuku chuckled. "The kitchen's a mess!"

"What about me?! *I'm* a mess!"

"You started this!" Shouta shot back, "You can't complain that my aim is better than yours!"

"No! You're just really good at dodging!"

"Well Izuku is even better!" Shouta laughed, his face breaking into a wide grin that would unnerve most people. "He doesn't have a single drop of batter on him!"

Izuku didn't really like where this was going. Hizashi turned his sights on him with a grin. "Not for long," He promised.

A few seconds later, there was batter in his curls, and laughter on his lips. And then not even a second later, a flash of a camera went off, breaking all three of them from their own world of domestic behavior.

Shouta narrowed his eyes, and Hizashi blushed instantly, as Midnight cooed at the picture. Shinsou stood next to her, smirking as Midnight let him see it. Izuku blinked, and felt heat crawl up his face.

“You’re all too precious!” Midnight exclaimed, before nudging Shinsou. “I told you there was nothing to worry about. They’re all just a little quirky,”

Shinsou squinted at her. “D-did you just make a pun about Quirks?”

“Yep!” Midnight told him, with a bright smile. As Hizashi set the table. “Now let’s eat breakfast, shall we? And then Shouta, Hizashi and I have some things to handle. Izuku will help you move in! You can bond!”

“We’ll have to shower first, thanks to *him,”* Shouta grumbled with affection, shooting his husband a *look.*

“You like cats, right?” Shinsou asked critically, as Izuku handed him a plate of stacked pancakes. There was syrup and other things sitting on the table—miraculously free of any batter. And whipped cream, strawberries, and bananas.

Izuku pretended to think about the question for a moment, before nodding.

[We have a cat somewhere. I don’t know where she is at the moment.]

Shinsou’s eyes practically twinkled at that, and Izuku cursed himself for doubting Shinsou. For thinking such toxic things about one of his *friend’s,* who was actually his brother now.

“I smell pancakes, gimme.” Dabi demanded, with a crooked smile as he appeared out of thin air. Izuku blinked, unsurprised by his sudden appearance. He had gotten used to Dabi doing what he pleased.

[Can you even eat?]

“I can sure as hell try, green bean,”

[Green bean?]

“Is broccoli boy better?”

Izuku rolled his eyes and handed him an entire pancake. Dabi looked at it curiously, before shoving the entire thing in his mouth. Izuku raised an eyebrow and waited for a reaction.

“Well that was uneventful,” Dabi muttered, “Mark *‘Can I eat,’* off the list of random things we don’t actually need to know about your power. Food is tasteless, and I don’t even feel hungry.”

“Dabi, will you be helping Shinsou move in?” Hizashi asked, with a slight smile.

“Yeah, yeah. Gotta make sure the kids don’t hurt themselves by accident,” Dabi said with a grin that only growed. Izuku swatted him, and he disappeared.

They all finished up their food, and Midnight turned to them. “You three go get cleaned up,” She said in a rather motherly way. “I’ll clean the kitchen,”

Izuku shook his head with a slight laugh.

After all three of them had washed the batter out of their hair, they went and put their dirty clothes in with the dirty laundry. Then Shouta, Hizashi and Midnight left, promising to be back as soon as possible.

That left him alone with Shinsou. “So…” He began somewhat awkwardly, “Where do we start?”

Izuku shrugged, unsure himself.

“You two are a handful already…” Dabi sighed. “Let’s start by getting your clothes put up. Aizawa and Yamada already set up a bed for you,”

Shouta hated the idea of talking to Shinsou’s neglectful-ass parents. He just wanted to go home and help set up Shinsou’s things, but this was something that needed to be settled as soon as possible.

This couldn’t wait, and if he wanted Shinsou to be safe, he needed the assholes for parents out of the picture forever. So here they were, standing right outside of their door. Nemuri and Hizashi looked nervous, but Shouta wasn’t nervous. Yuuei always had systems in place just in case Shinsou’s parents didn’t want to hand over custody.

There was no fucking *way* Shouta was going to leave another child to suffer. He’d saved Izuku—even if it had only been after the terrible USJ incident—and he was sure as shit going to save Shinsou too.

Shouta raised his hand to knock and took a steadying breath. The worst thing that could happen in this situation is Shouta losing his temper. He tended to do that a lot when it came to the safety of children, but today he needed to be as calm as possible.

It was now or never, he supposed.

He knocked, and the three of them waited with bated breath for the door to open. There was shuffling on the other side of the door that he could barely hear, but then the audible click of a lock coming undone. The door swung open, and a man with a tired expression and white hair stared back.

“Who the fuck are you?” The man asked, with a souring expression.

Shouta gave him a cold smile. “Eraserhead. I’m here to take custody of *my child,"*

Chapter End Notes

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 77

Chapter Summary

Part two of dadzawa and dadmic getting their child! Endeavor is on thin ice and the Todoroki's finally are free of that burning piece of trash <3 Rei is a badass in this just so you know. Love her

Chapter Notes

I hope you guys enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The man barked out a laugh. But Shouta wasn't joking at all. His face remained cold and impassive.

"May we come in?" Nemuri asked, already smiling in that devilish way that promised danger. *Midnight's* smile, not the motherly smile she'd been wearing this morning at breakfast.

"Oh, so you're serious. Fine, come inside," The man grumbled, stepping out of the way of the doorway. He gestured for all of them to come inside. Shouta went first, his eyes never leaving the man. The house itself was dirty and utterly destroyed. The house in Shinsou's memories was cleaner, but maybe since Shinsou moved to the dorms his parents stopped cleaning. Or maybe Shinsou was the only one who cleaned in the first place, and without him his parents didn't even bother to pick up the slack.

Shouta just followed the man to the kitchen, and stared. "You can sit if you want,"

"No, thank you," he growled out, crossing his arms. "I would like to get this done as fast as possible."

The man ran a hand through his hair, glancing wearily at all three of them. “Is there something I need to sign? Does my wife need to as well?”

This was… easier than Shouta thought it was going to be. Nemuri was the one to grab the paperwork from out of Shouta’s grip, and placed them on the table.

“Yuuei requires both signatures from the parents if they’re willing to turn over custody to either one of the staff, or Yuuei itself. However, had you refused, we wouldn’t even need the paperwork to enact protective custody of Shinsou Hitoshi, considering all the evidence we’ve gathered.” Her face remained impassive as she said this, but Shouta could see the sick satisfaction. And maybe a little disappointment that this was going so smoothly. “Thank you for your cooperation,”

The man grumbled something under his breath that Shouta *wished* he hadn’t heard. “Damn brat… forcing Heroes to take him in,”

He frowned before speaking up. “Shinsou isn’t forcing us to *do* anything. We found out about his situation and decided to do something because it’s *never* okay for parents to neglect their *child* ,”

“But you have to understand, his villainous Quirk—”

Hizashi scowled, and it looked strange on a usually cheerful face. Shouta hid his grin behind his capture weapon because when you pissed his husband off there would be hell to pay.

“His Quirk is perfect for Hero work. If you’re too dense to realize the potential this kid has, then I’m happy to take him from you and make sure he *knows* how great he is. And if you’re that scared of his Quirk then you probably shouldn’t have kids in the first place.” Hizashi slammed his hands on the table, pushing the paperwork closer to the man. A pen sat right next to it. “And just for the record, the only villains I see here are you and your wife, so sign these papers *now.”*

The ‘or else’ went unsaid, but it was definitely implied. The man swallowed thickly and quickly signed the paper. He then called his wife to hurry home so they could get her

signature as well.

Shouta removed himself from the wall he was leaning against. “I’ll grab his stuff from his room,” He said as an explanation, and Hizashi suddenly stood to join him. The two of them ventured into what he assumed was Shinsou’s room.

At the sight of the nearly barren room, his stomach sank to his knees before he remembered all the stuff that Shinsou had brought to the dorms. What was left in this room were a few Eraserhead posters that Shouta didn’t remember printing, and a cat pillow that Shouta wanted to steal.

There were some remnants of school supplies scattered around, and the bedsheets on the bed were gone. “So he brought a lot of his stuff to the dorms, huh?”

“I *hope* so,” Shouta replied, as the two of them gathered everything up. “We’re going to have to get him new stuff for when he comes home from the dorms, like a new comforter and more clothes,”

“That’s fine! I can finally get that custom Eraserhead comforter commissioned!”

Shouta pinched the bridge of his nose. “No. We’re not doing that,”

“We’re totally doing it, Shou,” Hizashi said with a wide grin. “We’ll do it for the kid,”

He groaned. “Fine.”

“YEEAAAH—” Hizashi cut off abruptly with the loss of his Quirk as Shouta erased it with a fond sigh. “Oopsy…?”

Shouta facepalmed. “Let’s just get this over with, okay? We have to help Todoroki after this and I *don’t* want to come home to our apartment on fire because Dabi can’t figure out a stove,”

“Oh come on Shou have a little faith in him,” Hizashi commented as they left Shinsou’s room and went back to the kitchen. “I’m sure Shinsou will put out any fires that Dabi starts,”

Shouta rolled his eyes, and he stopped once he was standing next to Nemuri. At some point the wife had come home, and there were two very evident signatures on the paperwork. Nemuri gathered it up with a plastic smile that didn’t reach her eyes. “We’ll take our leave now. Have a good day,”

Her words were stiff and too polite, as the three of them left as fast as possible. They didn’t speak until they were sitting in Hizashi’s car, and driving toward the hospital that Rei Todoroki was staying at.

“So,” Shouta began, sending a backwards glance to Nemuri who sat in the back seat. “What happened while we were getting Shinsou’s things?”

Her face soured, and she took off her glasses. She rubbed at her eyes furiously, before placing them back on.

“I wanted to wring that bitch’s neck,” Nemuri growled aggressively, her eyes narrowing in anger. “The first thing she said when she walked in was that Shinsou didn’t deserve to be in the Hero course, and then she went on to say that he should’ve been muzzled! I was so close to smacking her where she stood,”

“They’re lucky I wasn't there to hear it,” Shouta snapped, “I would be arrested right now,”

Nemuri chuckled at that as they pulled into the parking lot of the hospital. They were going to discuss their plan of action before-hand, which Shouta thought was reasonable considering they were helping Rei take her children from *Endeavor* .

Shouta couldn’t wait to see the look on that child abuser's face. It was still iffy about whether or not they’d try to take Endeavor to trial yet. *Apparently* , All Might was on the verge of retirement, and the Hero Industry couldn’t handle losing its soon-to-be Number One Hero.

Personally he didn’t care about what the Hero Industry couldn’t handle. He wanted to see Endeavor behind bars, but it really wasn’t his choice right now. So the three of them went to Rei’s room.

When they arrived, Nedzu was sitting in one of the visitor chairs situated next to Rei, and the two of them were sipping tea together. All Might was standing nearby, looking awkward and unsure of his role here.

Upon noticing their presence, Nedzu smiled widely. “Why hello, Aizawa, Yamada, and Nemuri! I’m assuming everything went well with Shinsou’s particular situation?”

“Yeah,” Shouta replied, giving a polite nod toward Rei, who was dressed in jeans and a t-shirt. “What’s the plan, Nedzu?”

“It’s simple really. We’ll be heading to Endeavor’s current residence and retrieving the children. Ms. Rei is quite the formidable mother and she’s agreed to speak to Endeavor about this matter. Of course if anything goes wrong, you and All Might will subdue Endeavor. Nemuri, you’re our plan B should they fail. The entire goal is to safely transport the Todoroki family to their new residence. They’ve been made aware of the situation beforehand, as well.” Nedzu explained with a wave of his paw.

“That’s… kinda vague?” Hizashi mumbled, a look of concern flashing across his face for a moment.

“Don’t worry. I’m sure he’ll comply with our demands with a little blackmail,” Nedzu replied, taking a loud sip of his tea. “Not to mention he’s utterly terrified of Rei,”

Shouta grinned as Rei smiled sheepishly.

“Shall we head out?” Nedzu asked. “I can’t wait to surprise Todoroki-kun with the good news,”

They took two separate cars to Endeavor’s mansion. All Might drove one while Hizashi drove the other. Shouta tried to not be surprised that All Might knew how to drive because the man could *literally* launch himself across Japan with his Quirk.

Logically there would be no need for All Might to learn how to drive, so it must’ve been something he learned in America. But now wasn’t the time to wonder about how All Might learned to drive.

Their destination was coming up fast, and Shouta should be thinking about the safety of his *student,* rather than the mysterious background of All Might’s youth. The van turned into the massive driveway of the Todoroki residence with little trouble. Had All Might asked to speak with him or something?

Or did Endeavor already *know* ? Nedzu must’ve seen the look on his face because he spoke up. “I sent him an email before heading over. He knows that we’re coming for a visit, but that’s all.”

“I see,” Shouta grumbled, as Hizashi put the van in park. He turned around in his seat to face Ms. Todoroki. She didn’t seem nervous. “Are you ready?”

She took a deep breath in response before shooting Shouta her best smile.

“Of course. This is long overdue, Aizawa-san. My children have suffered enough at his hands. It’s finally time I take responsibility for my actions, and for my absence…” She wrings her hands together, the only outward sign of her nervousness. “I’m more afraid of what my children think of me because of, well, everything that I did. The only thing Enji can do to scare me now is hurt my children further. And I *won’t* allow that.”

Shouta places his hand on her shoulder, hoping that it comes across as comforting. “None of us will.”

“Yeah!” Hizashi exclaimed, “Now let’s go in there and save those kiddos!”

They all piled out of the car at once, and so did Midnight and All Might in the other car. The six of them stood in Endeavor’s driveway awkwardly for a few moments, as Nedzu went over the plan again. Apparently Shouta would accompany All Might and Rei to the front door, as Rei talked to her husband.

Naturally Midnight and Present Mic would escort the children safely out of the home and into the vans once Endeavor agreed to cooperate. And from there they’d take the kids to Rei’s new residence without drawing media attention.

Shouta hoped everything went smoothly. Especially because the Todoroki family had already been through so much. They deserved to escape an abusive household without the media jumping on them and twisting the story around.

And no, he wasn’t just projecting his feelings about his current situation. Which still wouldn’t be solved for a while, at least. He was just glad that he could keep the situation quiet out of respect for the Todoroki family, while also freeing them of their abuser.

He followed All Might and Rei up to the front door, finally feeling a bit of nervousness creep in on him.

It’s fine. He told himself firmly. *If anything goes wrong just erase his quirk.*

He sucked in a deep breath as All Might knocked on the door harshly. There were a few tense seconds where nothing happened, until they heard the tell-tale sounds of a latch unlocking.

The door swung inward to reveal Endeavor, still aflame and grimacing at his new company.

Specifically, his eyes went straight to All Might, instead of his wife. It's then that Shouta noticed the aura the man was giving off. An aura so heavy, and strong that Shouta was surprised he just now noticed it.

The air around them was thick and stagnant with pressure. A pressure Shouta has *never felt before.*

All Might stared down Endeavor, fire crackling in his eyes. Endeavor matched his expression almost exactly. The pressure increased, and Shouta felt as if he might collapse under it.

"All Might," He said into the silence. "What're you doing here?"

Fists clenched in anger, All Might replied stiffly. "Why do you *think* we're here, Enji? Surely you have an idea?"

"No I don't—"

"If you weren't so busy sizing up All Might," Shouta began, effectively cutting him off. "Maybe you would've noticed your wife who you put in a mental asylum for years, for no reason, I might add."

Endeavor's face went slack with those words, and locked eyes on Rei.

And if All Might's pressure wasn't suffocating, then Rei's *was.* She froze the very air in Shouta's lungs. He swore he could see snowflakes floating through the air like a mini-blizzard, a stinging cold that didn't belong in this warm weather they'd been having.

She was a walking blizzard, as she *glared* at her husband. Just watching her was enough to feel ice in his bones. Her icy gaze was enough to freeze Endeavor to his spot in the doorway.

Even All Might faltered, if only for a second.

“Rei,”

“Enji,”

“What… Why are you here?”

She smiled, and it was *cold. So cold.*

“I want my children, Enji.” She told him softly, in contrast to her outward appearance, almost resembling an ice-sculpture at this point. Ice invaded her gaze, and her words came out as white puffs in the air. Snowflakes rested in her hair, glittering in the sun. “You will bring me my children, *now* . You won’t ever hurt them again. You won’t speak about them. You won’t even *think* about them.”

Endeavor stood wide-eyed in the doorway, blocking their path. “Rei please,” He begged pathetically, but Rei’s expression hardened, as if carved from the very ice she could create.

“It’s over Enji. I’m done. You’ve hurt me and my children when you were supposed to *protect us.”* She walked up to him and jabbed her finger to his chest. “To everyone else—the media, the civilians, the commission—you might seem like a hero from the stories, but to *us* , to me, and to my children, you’re the *villain* . I’m sick of playing your games Enji. They end here and now and you better get *the fuck* out of my way! If you refuse to keep our children safe, especially Shouto, then you don’t deserve to see them! You don’t deserve to talk to them, or raise them! You’ve *failed!* It’s my turn now. I will protect them *from you!”*

Shouta almost started clapping as Endeavor went unbelievably pale, and stepped aside. The man looked nearly ready to piss himself in fear. Rei stomped past him, and All Might went in after her. Once it seemed all clear, Nedzu, Midnight, and Present Mic ventured inside as well.

“Aren’t you going inside too?” Endeavor asked after a moment, and Shouta grinned.

“No,” Shouta told him, coldy. “I’m going to stay right here, where I can see you.”

Endeavor looked like he wanted to ask why Shouta cared so much.

“I won’t let you hurt these kids,” Shouta told him, crossing his arms. “I failed to protect my own son from his abusers time and time again. I *won’t* fail this time,”

It didn’t take a lot of convincing from Rei to get the children out of the house. They followed her with stars in their eyes, talking wildly.

“When did you get out of the hospital mom?”

“Where’s Shouto? Does he know?”

“I think Shouto’s still in the dorms? Last I heard he was going to train with a few classmates.”

“I’ve already gone ahead and notified him!” Nedzu assured all of them, with a wide smile. “He’ll be heading to our next location with Hound Dog to meet with you for a while,”

Shouta only let go of the breath he was holding when everyone was far, far away from Endeavor’s house.

Izuku stared silently at the mess they'd made in Shinsou's room. He was almost awed at how easily they'd put everything away, only to destroy it when they took a break to make food and watch TV.

At which point, Shinsou despaired over the fact that Izuku hadn't seen any of the newer drama's on TV. So *then* they spent way too much time sitting on Shinsou's bed, wrapped in blankets with a bowl of popcorn as they watched a show about a kid who was born with a quirk that allowed him to see ghosts.

Izuku cried when the main character lost his dog, painfully reminded of Edgar and how he'd hardly thought of him since his disappearance.

Shinsou and Dabi tried to cheer him up with reassurances that Kacchan would find him eventually, and that Edgar was perfectly fine.

It didn't work, but Izuku still appreciated it. And now... There were blankets strewn everywhere. A few tissues were sitting on the floor, discarded haphazardly during Izuku's crying fit.

He started there, and Shinsou began to fold the blankets as Dabi materialized.

"The dads are home," He stated simply, snatching the tissues from Izuku's hands. "Help Shinsou clean up, and I'll throw away these tissues,"

Izuku nodded as Dabi turned away. He hurried over to Shinsou's bed as his brother finished folding the last of the blankets.

He straightened the sheets and fixed the comforter, as Shinsou stacked the blankets and put them away in the basket near his bed. He rubbed the back of his neck before turning to Izuku.

“Looks clean enough, right?”

Izuku nodded, just as Hizashi and Shouta poked their heads inside the room.

“H-hi,” Shinsou mumbled, suddenly nervous. “How’d it go… with everything?”

Hizashi broke out into a wide grin. “Just great, actually! I’m surprised it went so well. I expected more… drama?”

“Todoroki Rei is a *terrifying* woman, and that’s all I’m saying,” Shouta said gruffly, crossing his arms. “So what have you two been up to all day?”

“Crying over fictional dogs,” Dabi supplied, having returned from wherever he decided to throw away the tissues. “Right Izuku?”

Izuku flipped him off with a pout, and Dabi barked out a boisterous laugh.

Chapter End Notes

at all the people who might think this scene with Shinsou's parents makes no sense: listen I just wanted Midoriya to have a brother. And logically if you don't take care of a kid and UA shows up ur door what can you rlly do about it??? try and resist when you know they legally have custody over that kid coz you let him go to Hero School?? Any who that's my explanation on why everything went so smoothly with Shinsou

As always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 78

Chapter Summary

Class 1-A plays pool volleyball together and bonds. Then they go to the mall >:))

Chapter Notes

This chapter is a day late and I'm supppppper sorry about it!! New World launched yesterday and me and my beta reader (read: one of best friends!) were playing it after they finished editing this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shouta was happy to see his kids bonding so fast. It was cute if he was being honest. Hitoshi was a perfect match for Izuku during the mini-break they had before the training camp began. They had almost an identical sleep schedule, with Izuku's nightmares, and Hitoshi's insomnia.

Needless to say, Shouta and Hizashi slept more soundly knowing that if *anything* happened Hitoshi would be there in an instant, and Izuku would do the same.

He'd already found them passed out on top of each other in Hitoshi's room last night, with a movie still playing in the background. He *totally* didn't feel a swell of warmth in his chest at the sight.

He *totally* didn't take a picture and make it his lock screen. Hizashi *totally* didn't do the same, and they *totally* didn't spend their early morning cooing over the picture. But if Shouta was being honest with himself, the funniest part of adding Hitoshi to their family was the fact that he refused to be frightened by the demons that followed Izuku around.

Apparently, Hitoshi had found one hiding under his bed, and he glared at it until it slunk into the hallway and whined. But there were also times where he entertained them, and Shouta knew this because he was *also* an insomniac, and stayed up just as late as his children.

He had been grading tests in the dining room, sitting at the table when Hitoshi walked into the kitchen for *something.* Probably melatonin, Shouta had thought at the time.

And no, Shouta *wasn't* spying on his kid as he craned his neck to watch him. He *wasn't* worried about Hitoshi's terrible sleep schedule! No way! But Hitoshi had walked into the kitchen, and said: "Hey there demons it's me, ya boy,"

Shouta honestly didn't know if he should be scared of Hitoshi for saying that, or proud. But he had to admit it was kind of funny, especially after a demon that had been hiding in their cabinets for *weeks* waved at him in response.

Hitoshi had barely reacted and grabbed what he needed before going back to his room.

All in all, Shouta was happy that his kids were finally safe and bonding together.

Izuku didn't really play Minecraft all that often, but Shinsou did. So by extension, *he* played Minecraft, and he found that it was an enjoyable experience when Kacchan wasn't blowing up his house every ten minutes.

And Shinsou hardly took the game all that seriously. And he spent the majority of his time copying someone's build from youtube, and then spent—and Izuku *wasn't* kidding— *three* hours making a greenhouse for all his wheat.

Okay, so maybe Shinsou took the game seriously. Izuku hardly had a house built that was worth mentioning. He spent the majority of his Minecraft gaming experience taming dogs and feeding them happily.

“Where are you?” Shinsou asked suddenly, and Izuku shrugged. “You’re in your house still, aren’t you?”

Izuku smiled sheepishly.

“Holy shit how many dogs do you *have?!”*

[12] He signed out, feeling a bit smug at the amount he’d successfully tamed. [I have an army now.]

Shinsou just looked at him, his eyes wide and brow furrowed in confusion. “What the hell do you plan on fighting that would require twelve dogs?”

[Fighting? Who said I was fighting anything?]

“You’re hopeless,” Shinsou remarked playfully, knocking their shoulders together. “Wait, is one of them named after Edgar? Like Stain’s dog?”

[Possibly…?]

“That’s so sweet,” Shinsou whispered, and Izuku didn’t comment. He probably wasn’t supposed to hear it anyway. They kept playing Minecraft until lunchtime.

Blessedly it was Shouta who made lunch, instead of Hizashi who was almost as terrible in the kitchen as Dabi was. The four of them ate together in relative silence.

Or it would’ve been silent if Hizashi hadn’t looked up from the last final he was grading and suddenly said: “We should go do something!”

Izuku's reaction was instant and it was nothing but despair. "Oh come on you homebodies, don't be so bummed about going outside! The cat café isn't even that far away!"

Izuku took a quick glance at Shinsou and Shouta. They both had similar, if not identical looks of utter despair at the mere mention of going outside. But Hizashi's puppy dog eyes were too hard to resist apparently because Shouta was the first to cave.

"Fine," Shouta grumbled. "You kids are coming too. If I suffer we all suffer,"

Hizashi's smile widened, and he popped up from his chair excitedly. "Alright guys, let's goooo!"

Izuku for as much as he hated going out in public, felt a bit of Hizashi's excitement beginning to rub off on him as they all scrambled to put their shoes on. He had only gone to a cat café once, and that was right before the Hosu Incident.

"So do you think you passed your written exams?" Shinsou asked as they hopped in the car. Izuku contemplated the question for a moment.

He had studied a *lot* for these exams. Izuku knew for a fact that he probably did better than Denki, who looked ready to drop out at a moment's notice as soon as the tests had been handed out. He signed that out to Shinsou exactly, and he laughed.

"I think everyone did better than Denki, honestly," Shinsou told him with a shrug, as Hizashi drove them to the café. "He tried to study, but he just kept getting distracted. I felt kinda bad for him,"

[Me too.]

“Maybe next time we have important exams we should help him study,” Shinsou suggested, waving his pointer finger between the both of them. “I doubt he learns anything with Bakugou smacking him over the head with a packet,”

[Kirishima seems to get it though.]

“Yeah but that’s *Kirishima,* we’re talking about. He’s all about manliness. What’s more manly than having Bakugou smack you with a packet?”

Izuku slapped his hand against his forehead. [Only Kirishima would think that’s manly.]

“Only Kirishima,” Shinsou nodded in agreement.

“Okay little listeners, we’re here!” Hizashi said, turning around to face them. “Who's excited to pet some cats? I know I am!”

“The world could be ending and you’d still be excited,” Shouta told him, with a smirk.

“I would *not!”* Hizashi exclaimed as if wounded. “I would be really sad!”

“Liar,”

“Shoooooouta!” Hizashi mumbled once they got out of the car. “You’re so grumpy!”

“I’m just teasing you,” Shouta promised, with a wave of his hand. “Now let’s go see some cute cats,”

“He really likes cats, huh?” Shinsou whispered, and Izuku nodded fervently.

The entire experience was exactly what Izuku needed during his break right before the training camp. They had sat somewhere more hidden away, in a corner that was a bit quieter than the rest of the café. At some point, Shouta and Shinsou had collected so many cats that Izuku and Hizashi were forced to admit defeat in the fact that the cats didn't like them as much.

But that was fine. Hizashi, having no cats to focus on, was a chatterbox like usual and time flew by as they sipped on their drinks.

Izuku loved it.

A day or two later, Izuku found himself at Yuuei's pool with the rest of his classmates. Iida was the one to organize the entire thing for training, but Izuku could already tell that most of the class chose to ignore that part. Kirishima had a beach ball in his hands, and Denki had brought everyone drinks.

Iida, sadly enough, was already chopping his hands and trying to explain what kind of training they'd be doing. Kacchan had snatched the beach ball from Kirishima's grasp and jumped in the pool with no care in the world for whatever it was that Iida was saying.

Izuku kind of felt bad for him. "C'mon Iida it's our break!" Denki exclaimed as everyone followed Kacchan's example. "We should relax for a little before the training camp!"

Iida's shoulders slumped forward and he sighed. "Fine! Just this once!"

With that, they all divided themselves into groups of ten and started playing what Izuku assumed was the pool version of volleyball. Izuku found being in the pool awkward with his

wings. It took him a few minutes and a few failed attempts to close his wings fully before he could properly play the game.

It was utter chaos. Kacchan was *much* better at it than anyone expected, and the only one ballsy enough to hit the ball on Izuku's side was himself, which according to Uraraka, "Was a terrifying thing to witness."

Tsuyu, thank god, was exceptionally good at catching all the wayward beach balls that came flying at terrifying speeds towards them. She was the only reason that Kacchan's team didn't win the game yet. Shoji was also a great asset on his team, with all the extra arms he had.

But Kacchan's team had Tokoyami on their side, and Tokoyami used Dark Shadow to score a few points.

And then, there had been the terrifying moment where Todoroki asked if it was against the rules to coat the beach ball in ice, which led to Iida lecturing him on the rules for ten whole minutes.

But the game had ended without a winner, in the end. Why do you ask? Why Uraraka accidentally used her Quirk on the ball, and it floated up high enough to pop.

It was tragic, but not a surprise. It would make for a great story though, as Sero had mentioned directly after it happened.

And then Yaoyorozu brought up the fact that she could make a new one, along with an air pump, but by that time their pool time they had reserved came to an end.

They all got dressed and reconvened at the classroom to their surprise Shouta was waiting, seeing as they wouldn't have class for two more days. "M-Mr. Aizawa! I didn't expect you to be here!" Denki exclaimed worriedly.

Shouta seemed to sink deeper into his capture scarf. "I finished grading your tests early."

And that's all he said, as he reached into his tracksuit and placed them on the table. He began scanning the papers before calling out their names.

"Kirishima," He grumbled. Kirishima grabbed his test, and his expression darkened considerably. Izuku felt a pang of sympathy in his chest for his classmate, but ultimately he knew that Kirishima gave it his all.

He wanted to say something to cheer him up, but he was already pulling himself together, with an enthusiastic, "I'll do better next time!" He vowed, and Izuku hid his grin as best he could.

Shouta called everyone's name and handed back their tests, and Izuku was relieved to know that he passed with reasonable percentages. His studying had really paid off! He eagerly went over to Kacchan who was giving his test a smug look.

So he passed too? Kacchan looked up from his test and nodded at Izuku's silent question. "I passed," He said, before raising an eyebrow at Izuku. "Did you?"

"Of course he did!" Ashido exclaimed, sounding utterly despaired and depressed about her own results. "He's like, super smart! There's no way he failed!"

[You're putting a lot of faith into me…] Izuku signed, and Ashido shook her head.

"No, I'm not! I give credit where credit is due, Midori! You're too smart for us! You too Bakubro, Iida and Momo-chan! I'm going to flunk out of high school at this rate!"

"I'm sure it's not as bad as mine," Denki groaned, taking a seat at the nearest desk and rubbing his face. "I don't think I've ever flunked a test so *hard* before,"

Shouta, who had watched all of this in morbid amusement, decided to speak up. “All of you who failed will still be going to the training camp, but you’ll have remedial classes at the same time. Hopefully, during that time you’ll catch up to your classmates in terms of academic ability.”

“Thank god for Aizawa-sensei!” Sero exclaimed, at the same time as Kirishima let out a sigh of relief.

“Now, speaking of the Training Camp, I suggest all of you bring any outside clothing or flashlights.” Shouta pulled another piece of paper from his tracksuit, which only made Izuku wonder if dad kept everything in there. Should he ask Hizashi? “This is the list of supplies that are recommended for the trip,”

As he spoke, he handed each of them the list. Izuku scanned it briefly, before sighing.

Training Camp List:

- Flashlights
- Outdoor shoes
- Bug Spray
- Any daily medications prescribed by a doctor
- Whatever else you want that’s not ILLEGAL, problem children

Izuku failed to hide his smile at the last thing printed on the list.

Lucky for him it didn’t look like he needed to go buy anything off the list, which was a relief. But then Ashido decided to wreck all of that by suggesting they go on a class shopping trip.

Yeah, no. He wasn’t the type to go outside to a mall to shop. That was *not* happening. He was shaking his head before he even realized it, but *apparently,* they weren’t taking no for an answer this time.

“Come on guys!” She exclaimed, waving the paper around enthusiastically. “It’ll be a good time to do class bonding before the trip!”

That instantly had almost all of the girls in class on board with the idea. And then Kirishima had to butt in too.

“Oh, and I need some new weights for my training!” He added, looking thoughtful. “And didn’t you mention the other day that you needed a new pair of shoes, Shoji?”

Well damn, it really seemed like everyone was going.

“Oh, and you *have to* come, Deku!” Uraraka whined once she saw the hesitance written across his face. “Bakugou and Shinsou are going too!”

“I am?” Shinsou parroted, confused.

“Yes,” Uraraka replied, giving him the most deadly glare she could muster. Shinsou paled and nodded eagerly.

“Hell yeah I’m going,” He amended, his voice a bit more high-pitched than normal. “ *Totally* not because you threatened me.”

“You’ll need someone to chaperone all of you,” Shouta grumbled. As one, Class 1-A turned to look at his dad with pleading puppy-dog eyes. *“Not me,”*

“Oh c’mon dadzawa,” Shinsou replied, matching their dad’s tone perfectly. “What if we get *attacked,* and you’re not with us? Right Midoriya?”

[If I have to suffer, so do you.] Izuku signed at Shouta, feeling smug.

With a heavy sigh, Shouta crossed his arms. “Fine, but Present Mic is going with us too.”

“Yay!” Ashido exclaimed, jumping up in the air. “So when should we go?”

“Well,” Iida took the reins of the planning, chopping his arms up and down. “We have three days to prepare for the trip, so we should do it tomorrow. That way if one of us forgets to get something we have an extra day to get ready.”

“I agree,” Yaoyorozu said, with a perfect smile. “And of course if anyone forgets anything I’ll be able to make it for you, should the need arise.”

“A perfect plan!” Iida exclaimed, pushing his glasses up the bridge of his nose. “Is that okay, Aizawa-sensei?”

“As long as we go in the afternoon, I don’t care,” Shouta told all of them. “Any earlier and I might expel all of you,”

Shinsou laughed. No one else did.

The mall was packed with people when they got there, and Izuku really didn’t want to be somewhere so open. Some days it was easy to forget the All for One was still looking for the perfect moment to strike and take him away.

Other days such as this one it wasn’t so easy to forget. But on the bright side, he was with his family and Kacchan. He was protected as he could be while still going to the mall and having

fun with his classmates.

They had split into groups of two or more by Shouta's request, and they had to check in with the group chat at least every twenty minutes.

While to some of his classmates this seemed a little excessive, Izuku understood it perfectly well. After the USJ, the Sports Festival, and Hosu they weren't going to take *any* chances. And not to mention it helped with Izuku's anxiety immensely as he and Kacchan wandered around.

His brother—he was trying his best to get used to calling Shinsou that—had gone off with Tokoyami, Kouda, and Shoji to go sit in a bookstore until everyone was ready to leave.

Izuku had been tempted to do the same, but Kacchan was determined to get new weights and anything else that caught his eye. So he decided to tag along.

He had thought that he would get bored just following Kacchan around, but it really wasn't. He had some money that Shouta had shoved in his hand and *demanded* that he spent it. So he bought Kacchan and him matching necklaces.

They were simple in their design. Izuku had gotten himself a silver moon. And for Kacchan he got a golden sun on a thin chain. And when he asked Izuku *why* , Izuku just smiled.

[I don't know.]

He *did* know, but he wasn't going to sign it. It was simply too cheesy and embarrassing for him to know. Kacchan was his sun, but that was for Izuku to know and for Kacchan to figure out.

Still, he demanded that they wear them as soon as they left the store, and Kacchan complied.

After that, however, they wandered around. They had gotten everything on their lists, and now all they had to do was wait for everyone else to finish.

“Do you want coffee?” Kacchan suddenly asked as they neared a coffee shop. Izuku thought about it for a moment, before nodding. “Okay, I’ll be right back.”

Kacchan handed him the bags he’d been carrying, and Izuku took a seat at the nearest bench as Kacchan went into the store.

He pulled out his phone to check in with the group chat as Shouta had requested when something happened. The spot next to him had suddenly become occupied. Normally, he wouldn’t be phased by this much. He probably would’ve scooted away and given the other person space, but his instincts had him freezing in place.

“Good to see you again, Midoriya,” A raspy voice said from beside him.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you all enjoyed!! See you next Tuesday! <3

As always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 79

Chapter Summary

Shigaraki is a bitch SDFJSGKJFAK

Chapter Notes

I didn't post last week coz New World came out and I hyper fixated on it, and NOw I'm hyper fixating on MDZS fanfiction AGAIN?!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Good to see you again, Midoriya,” A raspy voice said from beside him.

It was like injecting ice right into his bloodstream. His phone was open, and his classmates were checking in with Shouta, but Izuku couldn’t move. He could already feel sweat beading at his brow, and his head throbbed in time with his erratic heartbeat. His wings were pressed against his back and twitching.

Shigaraki Tomura.

Izuku turned off his phone without typing anything. Shigaraki grabbed him by the throat at that exact moment, with one finger carefully lifted away from his skin.

“Fortunately for you, I’m not here to kidnap you.” Shigaraki began, his grip tightening so much that he could hardly breathe. “But before I ask you my question we need to move somewhere else.”

Izuku curled his hands into tight fists, hoping that someone had noticed that he never checked in with his classmates. Shigaraki stood, and Izuku hastily did the same. They walked away, leaving his phone and all of his bags sitting on the bench still.

He tried to suck in a deeper breath, but Shigaraki's grip was unbelievably strong. His nails were cutting into his skin, and he could feel the beginnings of crescent-shaped cuts dripping blood down his neck. He needed to *escape.* Izuku needed to warn someone—

"Don't even think of escaping," Shigaraki snapped. He dug his nails in harsher. "I would kill you, and a lot of people here before the heroes even realized anything was happening. So just be a little compliant for a few minutes,"

Izuku couldn't breathe. Shigaraki's grip had gotten too tight for him to be able to breathe at all, and his vision was beginning to darken. His chest burned from the lack of air, and he looked around desperately for someone he knew. Someone that would *help* him.

Demons stood at the edges of his darkening vision. Drawn to him because of the smell of his blood. But they knew it was too dangerous for them to assist him.

He couldn't see anyone he recognized. He saw strangers. Nothing was familiar here, as they walked to a nearby fountain and sat down. Fear settled in his gut, heavy and impossible to ignore. Like burning coals. If he aggravated Shigaraki and tried to pull him away, then people would die.

If he drew attention to himself, then people would die.

If he did *anything* other than listen to what he had to say, then people would die.

One more finger against his skin, and *he* would be dead. His skin would break and disintegrate until he was nothing but a pile of dust. His hands were shaking at his sides, and sweat trickled down his brow. Shigaraki had finally got himself settled and finally decided to ask Izuku a question.

Izuku was too preoccupied with trying to breathe, and not pass out while Shigaraki had a hold of him. Too busy battling fear. His dads had to have noticed something was wrong, right? Kacchan? There had to be *someone.*

“Why do you think the world hates you, Midoriya?” Shigaraki asked, loosening his grip just enough for Izuku to finally take a gasping breath. “Is it because of us, or because of *you* ?”

Izuku wanted to ask him why the fuck it even mattered. But a small part of him ached to know that it was because of *him.* Because he dared to be himself in a world where Quirks like his own weren’t accepted.

“They’re already turning their backs to you.” Shigaraki continued casually as if he wasn’t shoving shards of glass into Izuku’s already bleeding heart. “They hate you, and someday soon your little friends and whatever family you *think* you have will hate you too. Do you see anyone coming to save you right now? *Sensei* will save you. He’ll save you from this fucked up society!”

Izuku knew that Shigaraki was lying. He knew it right down to his bones, even if his chest ached at the mere thought of Shouta, Hizashi, Kacchan, and Shinsou turning their backs on him.

Logically he knew that they would never, but there was always that small insignificant part of him that didn’t want to trust anything or anyone. It told him lies, and sometimes—a lot of the time—he believed them. This time he couldn’t let that part of him control him.

So he did possibly the dumbest thing he could. He glared at Shigaraki and flipped him off. It wasn’t something he would normally do, but this situation called for it in his opinion.

Despite the growing fear in his stomach and the ache in his heart, he had to show Shigaraki his words didn’t matter. Sensei’s words and promises didn’t matter. They were just lies to get him to come back, and he *never* wanted to go back.

That, and help had finally arrived. He could recognize Shouta’s gleaming red eyes when he activated his Quirk. Izuku was quick to slam his elbow into Shigaraki’s gut as hard as he could.

The man-child screeched, his expression flickering between confusion as to why his Quirk wasn't working and pure rage at being elbowed. As soon as he was free from Shigaraki's grasp he scrambled away as fast as he could as his dad put the fear of god into Shigaraki.

"Who the *fuck,"* Shouta began, practically spitting with rage as he wrapped Shigaraki in his capture weapon. "Do you think you are Shigaraki, trying to hurt my student?"

Shigaraki glared at him, not saying a word.

"You good kid?" Shouta asked, not blinking or taking his eyes off of Shigaraki for even a second.

"He's fine..." Kacchan said from beside him suddenly, sounding out of breath. "Right?"

Izuku nodded, still trying to take deep breaths and calm his rapidly beating heart. The only injury he'd received was from Shigaraki's gnarly fingernails. It was almost a relief because Izuku knew it could be *much* worse. He could've been dead right now if it weren't for his dad's idea of having a check-in every twenty minutes.

"Here," Kacchan said, holding out a cup of iced coffee to him. "I got your coffee,"

[Definitely worth it.] Izuku signed sarcastically as he took it. Kacchan snorted but said nothing. Izuku took a sip of the drink as Hizashi and the police— *the police were here?!* — rounded the corner. Luckily, Shigaraki was quickly detained and cuffed so his Quirk wouldn't activate.

Hizashi had crushed him in a hug and cleaned the cuts on his neck with the mini first-aid kit he always packed in his Hero Costume. Izuku thought it was a clever thing to keep in a Hero Costume. Maybe he should ask Hatsume to add it in?

"Are you okay, little listener?" Hizashi asked, as soon as he was done. He cupped both sides of Izuku's face gently and locked eyes with him. "When Shou noticed that you didn't check

in he knew something was wrong! And then Bakugou confirmed it when he saw you and called us!”

[I’m okay.] He signed, and Hizashi let out a relieved huff of breath.

“I’m so glad!” Hizashi exclaimed as Shouta went over to make *damn sure* that Shigaraki didn’t escape. His dad’s words exactly.

After another bone-crushing hug, Hizashi let him go so he could take another drink of his coffee. At this point they had drawn a lot of attention from the civilians standing around. His classmates were also making their way over.

But there was a little boy making his way over, with a curious look in his eye. Before Izuku could even fathom why the kid was making his way over to him, the boy spoke.

“You’re that person from TV!” The boy said, eyes shining. He pointed excitedly at him with a smile. “My mom says that people don’t like you because your Quirk is scary, but that makes me like you even more! People are afraid of mine too!”

And suddenly it feels as if he’s been sucker-punched but in a nice way. “My Quirk is minor telepathy, and I can talk to people in their heads but… People don’t like that. They told me I couldn’t be a Hero but then I saw you on TV and thought—” the kid, who's probably hardly even started middle school, takes a deep breath. “—It doesn’t matter what people think, right? You were just trying to save people! If people don’t understand, who cares? You’re like an icon for people with ‘scary’ Quirks!”

He’s crying before he knows how to respond.

“Don’t fuckin’ cry Deku he’s complimenting you,” Kacchan grumbled, but it was half-hearted at best. He gave him a gentle pat on the back, but it did nothing to stop the tears. “You damn crybaby,”

He manages to wipe at his tears and have Kacchan thank the kid. The boy beams at him, before presumably joining his mother again who Izuku can definitely hear say: “He must’ve really appreciated that. You’re so brave,”

It made him want to cry again, but he resisted the urge to, as Shouta, Hizashi and Shinsou all took turns triple-checking that he was okay. Then Detective Tsukauchi needed a statement about what happened, but agreed to wait until Class 1-A was back at the dorms and safe.

“So you flipped off Shigaraki.” The Detective repeated, looking dumbstruck.

Izuku smiled sheepishly. [He was being mean.]

“Because… he was being mean?”

He really sounded close to passing out, and Izuku kind of felt bad. Izuku nodded, and he could definitely picture Shinsou laughing at him right about now.

There was a tense moment of silence where Detective Tsukauchi collected himself before saying, “Well I’m glad we caught him nonetheless. And I’m glad you came out of it with minimal injuries!”

Izuku could definitely agree about that. Usually when he encountered villains he ended up in a hospital for a while. This time he walked away with a few cuts from Shigaraki and nothing more. It was definitely an improvement.

“You’re good to go Midoriya,” The Detective said, ruffling his curls before he stood. “I’m really glad you’re okay,”

Izuku blushed at the contact, and walked out with the Detective beside him.

“Ready to go home?” Shinsou asked, looking exhausted, even though Izuku had shared some of his coffee earlier. “I could sleep for days right now,”

Shouta grunted in agreement, as the four of them left the precinct.

“Do you wanna watch movies with me when we get home, since those two—” Hizashi sent a meaningful glance towards Shouta and Shinsou. “—will be sleeping?”

Izuku nodded eagerly.

“Great! We can watch these movies I’ve been wanting to watch for *so* long!” His dad exclaimed. “I’ll even make stovetop popcorn!”

He and Hizashi watched *so many* movies that they fell asleep on each other that night.

Shouta took a picture and added it to his blackmail folder, for future use. Shinsou snickered, while petting Eclipse.

He sent it to Nedzu and All Might, feeling a bit smug.

Nedzu saw the picture that Aizawa sent the next day. It was right before he asked Mirio to join him in his office, and it brightened his day just a bit. He had been sulking after the Press had the audacity to break into his school and harm his precious student.

He pushed that problem away, for now, fully aware that it was something that would take time to fix.

Right now the most important matter at hand was telling Mirio that it was probably a good idea to have him work under a different Hero. Nighteye had proved to be a terrible Hero to intern under, so Nedzu was determined to get Mirio out of there as soon as possible.

Maybe Fatgum would take him on? Then he wouldn't have to be so lonely because Tamaki Amajiki would be working with him! That sounded like a pleasant idea, as he waited for Mirio to arrive. He had texted him, which Nedzu *knew* was a breach of privacy, but this was urgent! He would not be making any more mistakes.

Not since his utter clusterfuck with Midoriya. He was still trying to prove himself better than before. Helping Mirio steer clear of Nighteye who was an *asshole,* was a good thing to do!

It had nothing to do with Nedzu deciding that Nighteye should be *fired,* no way. That was a top-secret case he was working on. No one but him needed to know about what he was planning for Nighteye, except for maybe Aizawa and All Might. They were the only people who were going to be affected by Nighteye's expulsion from the Pro Hero scene, but he doubted Aizawa would even be surprised.

He would probably feel inclined to assist because of what Nighteye had the audacity to say in front of his son.

It was All Might that he was actually worried about. The man had always had a strange relationship with Nighteye, due to their past together. And now that Nedzu was coming to the realization that Nighteye was just as prejudiced as the rest of society, he couldn't let it continue.

And obviously, this wasn't his first time taking down a corrupt and narrow-minded hero. Their system of creating heroes wasn't the best, but there were people like him—other pros and even vigilantes—who made sure the corrupt ones were off the streets as fast as possible.

Like Flare Signal. A hero who, behind closed doors liked to rape and murder any woman he could get his hands on. The public had been outraged at that, and his trial had been ruthless and swift.

Alas, Nighteye's case wasn't as cut and dry. He'd made the comment about Izuku's Quirk and what he thought of the kid. He needed more evidence if he wanted to get Nighteye fired, but at the very least he would get his license to take on interns revoked.

But again, All Might. How would he react? Would he be angry on Izuku's behalf, or would he try to defend a long-time friend even if they were no longer close? Ultimately Nedzu knew that it didn't matter how All Might felt.

Nedzu was going to do what was necessary for the Hero Industry, and necessary for his students' safety. He couldn't let Mirio continue his internship with such an arrogant and rude hero.

He took a long drink of his tea, squinting at his screen as Mirio came up to the doors of his office. With a simple click of the button on the underside of his desk, the doors opened on their own. Mirio paused for a moment, seemingly surprised every time that Nedzu did that.

"Why hello there Mirio!" Nedzu exclaimed, setting his teacup down in its matching saucer. "I'm glad you could make it!"

“Yeah,” Mirio replied, smiling. “But I do wonder how you got my phone number to text me while I was training…”

“That’s top secret!” Nedzu informed him, with a smile that haunted Aizawa’s nightmares regularly. “But I called you here for an important discussion regarding your internship with Nighteye… especially after what occurred between him and Midoriya-kun.”

“You don’t want me to intern with him anymore,” Mirio hypothesized, taking a seat at the empty chair situated right in front of Nedzu’s desk. “Am I right?”

“That is correct, dear Mirio!” Nedzu told him, his smile sharpening further. “I’ve come to the realization that he’s not fit to take on any interns from now on! I’m very sorry to spring this on you very suddenly.”

Mirio furrowed his brow and took a moment to collect himself. Nedzu could tell because he was staring a hole into the wall behind Nedzu’s right shoulder, and his lips were pressed into a thin line. His student took a deep breath and finally spoke.

“I can understand *why* you would do that,” Mirio admitted, wringing his hands together. “What he said about Midoriya wasn’t very nice . I never thought Sir could be so *mean* because of someone’s Quirk. Before you called me here I kinda thought about ending my internship with Sir. Now that you’ve mentioned it too… I think I will,”

“I’m glad we’re on the same page. I’ve gathered all of your offers from this year’s sports festival and I've done you the favor of narrowing them down! Based on your past internships, I put aside any offers that were from Underground Agencies, and Rescue Agencies. You’re still shooting to be a limelight hero, correct?”

“Yes!” Mirio told him.

“Good! All the offers here should fit that criteria for you. Sort through them as long as you need, and come to me when you’ve made a decision!”

“Thank you principal Nedzu!” Mirio exclaimed, grabbing the stack that Nedzu had deposited on the table.

“It’s the least I could do you for, Mirio-kun! You’re welcome to go back to your training if you like!”

Mirio gave him another quick thanks before he grabbed the stack of papers and left his office. Nedzu grinned as he opened a tab that he minimized before Mirio had come in.

Nighteye, one way or another was going *down.*

Mirai had been nursing his pride for a while after *Eraserhead* almost broke his face. He was still reeling at the fact that Nedzu had let it happen, and even *threatened* him afterward.

It didn’t make sense that Nedzu would guard a child with a Quirk like *that.* It wasn’t the kind of Quirk that society accepted.

He glared down at his paperwork, just as his phone pinged with another email. With an annoyed sigh, he dug his phone out of his pocket and glared at the screen.

From:

Principal Nedzu

Subject:

Mirio Toogata’s Internship

Dear Nighteye,

Due to recent events I've decided that Mirio Toogata, one of your interns, is no longer allowed to intern under your agency. In addition, I've gone ahead and blacklisted your agency from all Hero Schools in the country. Any offers you send out will automatically be declined.

Good day, Principal Nedzu of U.A. Highschool.

Chapter End Notes

As always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

(Also if anyone has good slow-burn WangXian fic recs please give me some! I don't like modern AU's mainly because I love canon too much. I've been reading a lot of time travel and "watching the series" fics for MDZS)

Chapter 80

Chapter Summary

Beginning of the Training Camp Arc (Don't worry it's fun—at first)

Chapter Notes

The only thing im gonna say is im sorry I didn't update last week! I was a bit sick lol <3

There's a lot of texting in this chapter so here's a guide (they're hecka obvious but someone might get confused so—):

Dark_Knight: Tokoyami

Sleep? Idk her: Shinsou

IcyHot: Todoroki

Sunshine_Child: Kouda

ArmsDealer: Shoji

HeyDemonsItsMe: MIDORIYA LMAO IM SORRY I THOUGHT IT WAS FITTING

NeverSkippedTailDay: Ojiro

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He and Shinsou spent the last days of their break texting in the class group chat. It was pretty strange for Izuku, who had never had any friends to speak of other than Kacchan before Yuuei. Shinsou had admitted that it was the same for him, too.

But unlike Izuku, Shinsou had plenty of time to get used to texting in the group chat with their classmates.

So Izuku was hesitant to *actually* text, and ended up lurking. That was until Tokoyami decided to make a separate groupchat, and Izuku had an inkling of an idea that Kacchan probably told him to do it. Either way he was grateful.

The group was small and therefore much more manageable to deal with, which consisted of him, Tokoyami, Todoroki, Shinsou, Shoji, Kouda, and Ojiro.

He enjoyed talking with them rather than talking to all of his classmates at once. It was too overwhelming for him, and the smaller groupchat was a lot more laid-back and filled with memes.

The class groupchat however, was crowded with Denki constantly rambling about how Hagakure should stop dressing up as a ghost at one in the morning. Or Iida telling people to go to bed. Or Ashido talking about a bunch of TV shows he didn't watch. Sometimes everyone would be talking about card games he didn't know of, or things he'd never experienced.

"Did you see the meme that Tokoyami just sent in the chat?" Shinsou asked suddenly, from where he was sprawled out on Izuku's bed. Izuku looked over at him, and then shook his head. "It's hilarious,"

[I don't hear you laughing, though.]

"Oh come on," Shinsou replied with a smirk, "You know what I mean,"

[Okay okay. I'll look at it.]

Izuku opened the groupchat and smiled.

Dark_Knight: *meme.jpg*

Sleep? Idk her: OMFG MEE

IcyHot: I don't get it.

Sunshine_Child: It's a Pre-Quirk Era show. Really good <3

Dark_Knight: Blasphemy. This calls for us forcing you to watch it now >:0

Sleep? Idk her: I'm like 100% sure Midoriya hasn't seen it either.

Dark_Knight: >:OOOOOOOOO

ArmsDealer: *OH MY GOD YOU GUYS HAVE NEVER SEEN AVATAR?!*

HeyDemonsIt'sMe: How could you do this to me Toshi

Dark_Knight: Don't worry guys I'm downloading all of it on my iPad. I'll bring it to the training camp so we can watch it on the bus.

ArmsDealer: I'll do it too just in case we're not all sitting together.

Sleep? Idk her: Ok ok but like. Todoroki is definitely Prince Zuko.

IcyHot: Who?

NeverSkippedTailDay: THAT'S LITERALLY SO FUNNY AND SO ACCURATE

Sunshine_Child: hello Oijro! Did you sleep well?

NeverSkippedTailDay: yes ; - ; thanks for asking

Dark_Knight: it's too bright in this gc

HeyDemonsIt'sMe: ^^^

Dark_Knight: Only the Dark One understands my struggle.

Sleep? Idk her: oof

Sleep? Idk her: *sendhelp.jpg*

Sunshine_Child: are you okay?

Sleep? Idk her: suuuure

NeverSkippedTailDay: I could knock you out but Aizawa is scary

Sleep? Idk her: < - < Midoriya?

HeyDemonsIt'sMe: I like being alive at the moment.

ArmsDealer: LMAO

Sunshine_Child: I have question Midoriya, and Todoroki, but you guys don't have to answer

HeyDemonsItsMe: uhhh, I'll answer if I can

IcyHot: what is it?

Sunshine_Child: the other day Iida and Yaoyorozu asked all of us if we had any specific triggers...

NeverSkippedTailDay: We thought about asking you guys too, but we figured we should prabably ask you in a more private environment.

IcyHot: What are triggers?

Dark_Knight: hold on let me copy the definition from google

Dark_Knight: A trauma trigger is a psychological stimulus that prompts recall of a previous traumatic experience.

IcyHot: Oh. Fire, loud noises, isolation, being told to try harder. I can't think of anything else right now…

Sunshine_Child: that's ok! Thank you for telling us even though you didn't have to. We'll do our best to avoid triggering you Todoroki-kun! We love and support you! What about you Midoriya-kun?

Izuku didn’t respond. No one said anything, probably waiting for his reply, but he was still trying to process that his classmates even wanted to be aware of his triggers.

They *cared* enough to worry about potentially triggering him? He was blinking past tears before he knew it, swiping uselessly at them. Not for the first time, he was reminded that he had *friends.* People who cared about him, and worried for him.

People who aren't hurtful and violent. People he could count on and trust.

“A-are you *crying?!”* Shinsou exclaimed, scrambling to his side of the bed. “I’m sorry, I didn’t think that would make you cry,”

Izuku shook his head, bringing his hands up to sign. [It’s not that. They’re just being so nice.]

Shinsou let out a breath of relief, before he cracked a smile. “Of course they are. We care about you.”

[It’s still new to me.] Izuku told him, and Shinsou winced.

“I’m sorry,” He mumbled, glancing down at his phone. “Do you want me to tell them your triggers?”

Izuku nodded, wiping away the last of his tears. He took a moment to collect himself as Shinsou bumped shoulders with him. “You can write them down, if that’s easier. I can just send them a picture,”

[Okay]

“I’ll be right back,” Shinsou replied, shooting up from his position. Izuku watched with mild interest before returning his attention to the groupchat.

Sleep? Idk her: shit

NeverSkippedTailDay: Did we do something wrong?

Sleep Idk her: nah he's just happy we care. Like duh we care but anywho we're going to write them down and send it as a picture.

Dark_Knight: :((ofc we care

Sleep Idk her: Give us a minute and we'll have the picture :P he's okay btw

Sunshine_Child: that's good! Tell him we'd all die for him!

ArmsDealer: you're so wholesome we'd die for you too

NeverSkippedTailDay: ^^^^^^^^

Shinsou returned with a paper and pencil right as Izuku finished reading all the texts. He walked over to where Izuku was sitting and used Izuku's nightstand to write on.

"Okay," Shinsou began, giving him a meaningful look. "Hit me with 'em."

Izuku pressed his lips into a thin line, and it struck him that he was nervous. Shinsou was his *brother* , and it was probably a good idea for everyone that he let everyone be aware of things that could set him off. But he couldn't shake the idea that Shinsou would judge him.

Or that everyone might judge him, despite their intentions. And he didn't even want to think about how he probably should've talked to his therapist about his triggers before anyone else. Or at least his dads.

He could share the list with his dads after this though.

Shinsou seemed to notice his pause. "On second thought we don't have to do anything that makes you uncomfortable,"

Izuku shook his head. [It's okay.]

"I could go first," Shinsou said in a small voice, drawing in on himself. "So, when I was little my foster mom didn't really *feed* me sometimes?"

Izuku watched as Shinsou's expression got more and more withdrawn and far away. His hands were in his lap, and they had turned white with how hard he was clenching them. Timidly, he reached out and placed a hand over Shinsou's clenched ones.

"So sometimes I feel like I don't deserve the food that dadzawa and dadzashi make, you know?" Shinsou continued, his expression pinched and uncomfortable. "Sometimes I get supper, I don't know... upset about it? That and yelling… because my foster parents always argued about me. Or when someone tells me my quirk is villainous…"

Izuku could empathize with his pain. All of his life he'd been listening to his mother scream and yell at him. It had been a vicious cycle of berating and physical harassment. He was only now coming to terms with realizing that it wasn't *normal.*

So he understood more than he should. He squeezed Shinsou's hand harder, and Shinsou squeezed back. His brother's eyes were watery with unshed tears as he spoke. It struck him then that Shinsou was being unbelievably brave by admitting the things that hurt him or distressed him in any way.

He told himself that he could do it too, as he gathered his courage.

“What about you?” He asked, releasing Izuku’s hand so he could sign. “Other than being yelled at, being called names, being left alone or someone taking away my food I can’t think of any more that… trigger me,”

Izuku thought about it for a moment. What *would* be considered triggering to him? There were a number of things that had the capacity to trigger him.

[Darkness, being trapped in places, yelling, sudden movements, threats of violence.]

Shinsou nodded seriously, as he scribbled each one down. Izuku peered over his shoulder to watch as Shinsou added his own triggers on the other side of the paper. He took a quick picture and sent it to the group chat.

“Can I see that?”

Izuku jumped nearly a foot in the air as Shouta appeared out of *nowhere.* Shinsou looked just as surprised, and clutched his chest as if he was having a heart attack.

“W-When did you get in here?!” Shinsou asked, his voice thin.

“Just now,” Shouta told him, as Hizashi burst into the room as well.

“Is it okay if we see your lists?” He said with a pout, coming to stand beside his husband. “You don’t have to though—”

“Here,” Shinsou handed it over, refusing to look at either of them. Izuku, on the other hand, watched their expressions carefully.

What if they think we're a disappointment? What if they decide we're too much work—

Hizashi suddenly burst into tears. "Aw, my babies! Come here Can I hug you both?!"

Izuku and Shinsou both nodded and were suddenly pulled to their feet as Hizashi crushed them in a hug.

"You too babe!" Hizashi exclaimed, waving him over. "It's bonding time!"

Shouta let out a bone-weary sigh, but joined anyway. It was nice.

"Does everyone have everything from the list?" Iida asked from where he stood at the podium. Shouta was trying to get in as much sleep as possible before they got on the bus, so he made sure to tell Iida he was in charge.

"Yep!" Ashido exclaimed excitedly. "Let's just go! I'm so excited!"

Izuku was too busy texting Kacchan who was right beside him. The other boy had pulled a chair around to his desk so they could sit nearer, but he ended up texting anyway. Which was a typical Kacchan thing to do, now that Izuku was thinking about it.

Kacchan: So you're going to watch Avatar with the emo cult?

Deku: Don't call them that Kacchan! But yeah. We're watching Avatar… I'm not sure what its about

Kacchan: I’ve never seen it, but I heard it's good

Deku: Tokoyami was super upset when he heard I’ve never seen it, so don’t let him know you haven’t seen it either.

Kacchan: I won’t lol

Kacchan: Are you going to watch it on the bus?

Deku: Yeah. Is that okay?

Kacchan: Of course it is

Kacchan: Are you excited for the training camp?

Deku: Yeah! We’re going to be getting stronger!

Kacchan: You’ll never surpass me.

Deku: Oh really? How do you know that I haven’t already beat you?

Kacchan: That’s the confidence I like to hear nerd

Deku: :)

“Alright everyone, pay attention. Grab your things we’re leaving,” Shouta told them all, scanning all of his students. “Follow me out to the buses and we’ll be on our way. Class 1-B will be taking a different bus than us, but we’ll meet at the training camp. I expect all of you to be respectful to your sister class while we’re on this trip,”

“Sure thing Aizawa-sensei!” Denki exclaimed with a smile. “Except for Monoma,”

“Monoma gets no mercy,” Kacchan stated coldly, with a smirk that made Izuku’s blood run cold.

Apparently his classmates hadn’t forgotten the incident in the lunchroom, and what Monoma had said about his Quirk oh so long ago. He felt a swell of warmth in his chest at his classmates' protectiveness over him.

“Yeah!” Hagakure chimed in. “I’ll make sure to put hot sauce in his water bottle!”

“We’re *not* doing that,” Shouta told them, crossing his arms as he gave them all a stern look. “You’re hero course students, so you shouldn’t be doing petty things like that. Besides, Nedzu took care of Monoma and made sure he wouldn’t be making those comments again. Towards *anyone.”*

“Good,” Kacchan grumbled to himself, giving Izuku a side-ways glance as he said it.

“Now that all that’s out of the way, follow me to the bus,” Shouta said, waving the class over as he made his way to the door. He didn’t look back to make sure they were following as he left. Izuku was quick to make a grab for his bag, but Kacchan had beaten him to it. Izuku gave him a half-hearted glare as Kacchan smirked.

He didn’t try to talk Kacchan out of carrying his bag because he knew Kacchan would raise an eyebrow and completely ignore him. Sometimes Kacchan was too stubborn for his own good, but it was cute.

He smiled softly as he and Kacchan hurried to catch up with everyone else. When they finally reached the bus, Iida was trying desperately to get everyone lined up in an orderly fashion. Izuku hid a smile behind his hand because it was *obvious* that it wasn't working.

Even Yaoyorozu was on the verge of giving up, it seemed. Everyone was just too excited to even think about boarding the bus in a way that was orderly. Iida took a deep breath before sighing.

"Oh come on Iida, cheer up! We're going on a trip! This is gonna be fun, just relax." Uraraka told him, with a pat on his back. After a moment, Iida's shoulders slumped and he nodded.

"I suppose I could use some relaxation," He told her, before boarding the bus.

"Fucking finally," Kacchan remarked, adjusting his grip on both of their bags. Izuku resisted the urge to snatch one and relieve him of the extra weight. "If I was standing here any longer I'd chuck one of these at him."

[You can't do that Kacchan! It's mean!]

"I know," He replied with a sharp smirk. "That's the whole point,"

Izuku squinted at him, but Kacchan didn't say anything else in response. With a soft sigh he followed him onto the bus, and sat down near Tokoyami. As the last of them were getting on, Shouta said. "Here's the deal. We'll be on this bus for about an hour before our first stop so pay attention—"

But of course no one was listening. Denki was yelling about playing music, and Iida was reprimanding Aoyama for standing up in his seat even though Iida was doing the same thing.

His dad sighed, and turned to face the window in defeat. Izuku kinda felt bad for him.

“Oh good,” Tokoyami said as soon as he caught Izuku’s eye. “Todoroki is sitting next to Shoji to watch Avatar, so this works out perfectly.”

So of course Izuku spent the majority of the time on the bus watching Avatar the Last Airbender, trying his best to block out his noisy classmates. The ride itself was uneventful, besides the times Shouta raised his voice to quiet down his classmates.

Shinsou had fallen asleep next to Shouta at some point, and Izuku pretended not to notice his dad taking a picture of it.

And then the bus came to a stop abruptly. Heads snapped up in alarm, and Izuku glanced around wearily, expecting that the League had somehow found their location. There wasn’t a single good thing that the League hadn’t destroyed.

Their USJ trip? A disaster. The Sports Festival? He was still traumatized and still had nightmares. Hosu? He nearly *died, again.* Who was to say that the League wouldn’t try again, right now?

He looked toward his father, and he seemed relaxed. Izuku took one look at his calm demeanor, and forced himself to calm down. If his dad wasn’t concerned then he shouldn’t be concerned either.

“Everyone out of the bus,” Shouta said, in his usual monotone voice. “Don’t bring your things, we’ll be back,”

“Oh this must be a rest stop then,” Yaoyorozu hypothesized, as she stood from her seat.

Izuku didn’t think so, as he dug in his bag to grab his katana. His dad was wearing his logical ruse smile, but no one seemed to notice it except for Shinsou. They shared a look of mild terror as they got off the bus.

His terror grew as he noticed that they had stopped next to a cliff, and there was nothing for miles. Just a massive stretch of forest for as far as Izuku could see. This was definitely a logical ruse, but Izuku didn't know what his dad had in mind.

He didn't know which was more terrifying, the fact that there was a ruse at all or what the ruse was going to be. He quickly decided that not knowing was scarier, as Shouta grinned beside him.

"Oh no," Iida said suddenly, growing pale as he noticed Shouta's smile. "This is a ruse, isn't it?"

"Of course," Shouta told him, as the bus drove away, and a car pulled up. "You didn't think we got off the bus for no reason, right? Meet the Wild Wild Pussycats,"

As he spoke, the occupants in the car got out. Each member of the Wild Wild Pussycats smiled at all of them. There was a kid off to the side, glaring but Izuku ignored it for now.

"Hello little kittens!" A woman with brunette hair said with a wide smile. She was wearing a red outfit that matched the entire team. She waved around her cat-paw gloves as she spoke. "We're the Wild Wild Pussycats! My Hero name is Mandalay, nice to meet you!"

Only a few of Izuku's classmates said it back, as the next woman walked up. Her costume was a bright, energetic yellow that matched her excitement. She had long green hair that was left to cascade down her back all the way to her waist.

"Hiya!" She said, jumping in place. "My name is Ragdoll!"

So the last woman had to be Pixie-Bob, then. She wore the same outfit as her partners, but in a light blue color. "The name is Pixie-Bob, and it's so exciting to be helping Eraserhead out with teaching his little kittens!"

Tiger was the last to introduce himself, proudly wearing the puffy skirt that came with his Hero Costume. Izuku smiled at that, as all of them did a little team pose together.

"Now that introductions are over we can get started."

"Gotcha Eraser," Mandalay began, as she went over to the cliff to gesture to the expanse of forest below them. "We own this whole stretch of land out here. Everything you can see. The summer camp you're staying at is there—"

She pointed vaguely in a direction, and Izuku didn't like how he was beginning to realize what might be going on. "—at the base of the mountain."

"That's far!" Kirishima exclaimed.

"Uh," Uraraka started, seeming to realize something was amiss too. "Then why did we stop all the way up here instead? Why did the bus drive away?"

"I'm afraid we both know the answer to that," Tsuyu responded.

"That can't be…" Sato mumbled, as Sero laughed nervously.

"No *way* ," Shinsou groaned. "I'm already tired!"

"You were sleeping the entire trip though," Todoroki replied, in his usual deadpan voice.

"But still!"

Mandalay laughed. "It's currently nine-thrity in the morning. If you're fast enough you make it there by noon,"

“Holy crap! *Noon?!”* Ashido exclaimed, as if her whole life was falling apart right before her eyes.

“You should’ve guessed, like Midoriya, Shinsou, and Iida did. The training camp has *already* started,”

Chapter End Notes

Hope you all enjoyed! I wrote all the text conversations how I actually text soooo don't judge me lol

As always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 81

Chapter Summary

More of the Training Camp :DDD

Chapter Notes

Heyoooo!! Enjoy this weeks chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As soon as his dad stopped talking the ground went soft and exploded upward, toward the forest below. Izuku made sure to keep his sword in his hands as him and his classmates were jostled around by Pixie-Bob's Quirk.

Her Quirk itself was very easy to understand. It was named Earth Flow, and it gave her the ability to manipulate the ground in any way she desired. As he suddenly began to free fall someone grabbed him by the back of his shirt.

"Watch where you're falling, fucking nerd!" Kacchan exclaimed, as he redirected both of them mid-air with his explosions.

Izuku smiled at him as they both landed on their feet, unlike most of their classmates.

"That was cruel Bakubro!" Kirishima exclaimed, as he dusted himself off. "You only helped Midoriya! And has wings!"

"He can't fly yet," Kacchan replied, dusting himself off. "I had to. The nerd is always hurting himself,"

[Am not!]

“You totally are,” Shinsou grumbled, as he came up beside them. “Just the other day I saw you stub your toe on our coffee table and sign, ‘I didn’t survive the sports festival and Hosu to be killed by a coffee table’”

[Hey! It’s not my fault villains keep attacking us!]

Their conversation was cut off by Mandalay leaning over the railing and yelling down at them.

“Good news! Since this is private property you’re allowed to use your Quirks as much as you want to. You’ve got three hours, and you should be able to make it to the facility in that time.” Her smile twisted with sadistic glee. “That is, if you can get through The Beast’s Forest!”

Izuku let out a tired sigh after hearing that. Of course there was always a catch when it came to his dad's logical ruses. What else should he expect?

“Well, I guess we should get going,” Iida told them all, marching forward first. “If we’re fast we could probably make it in two hours,”

They all entered the forest together, only to spot a huge muddy monster in their path. It’s roar cut through the air. He froze.

He was frozen. He couldn’t move, even though he was fully aware that this must be Pixie-Bob’s Quirk. It sounded too much like the Nomu’s All for One had forced him to kill. It sounded too much like the Prototype-Nomu, like Stain.

He couldn’t see past the memories of his own hands ripping through Stain. Through all the Nomu’s he had killed as “training.” He could hardly breathe.

There was a series of explosions he could hardly hear. He *saw* them, but it felt fake, as if he wasn't really present in the moment. Everything was cold, and all the noise that reached his ears made it sound like he was underwater.

He wasn't even sure if he was still holding his sword. He wasn't even sure if he was still in his body. Izuku could feel a tightness in his throat that wasn't there before. His chest *burned* as if he was on fire.

"Midoriya?"

It was far away. Like he was holding his head under water, and someone was trying to get his attention.

"Hey Midoriya, are you okay buddy?" Kirishima asked, shaking his shoulder gently. Izuku nodded, but he was still so far away from reality.

"Are you sure?" Iida asked, placing a gentle hand on Izuku's back. "You don't look alright,"

Izuku managed to ease the pain in his chest by taking a big breath. Slowly he could hear sound rushing back to his ears, and feeling returned to his hands. He grounded himself by cataloging every sensation he could feel. It was then that he realized that they weren't moving forward. Everyone was staring at him with varying degrees of concern.

[I'm fine.] He lied, with a smile that didn't reach his eyes.

After a short pause, everyone continued to move until they came across the next monster. He told himself that it was just a product of Pixie-Bob's Quirk, and that seemed to help a little bit. He wasn't frozen like the first time, and he had half the mind to help by summoning a few demons.

Their dark shadowy claws ripped clean through the monster's body, and a cloud of dust rose into the sky as a result.

He ignored the tightness of his chest, and the phantom screams of Nomu that *weren't* there. Having a panic attack wasn't a good idea right now. He needed somewhere to hide. He needed to make sure his classmates were okay first.

Logically, he knew that it wasn't healthy, or possible to push away a panic attack. Was this even a panic attack? He didn't know.

He ignored all of it anyway. They advanced deeper into the forest, and his classmates worked together seamlessly as they took down each earth creature. Izuku tried to not be affected by the din of fighting. He helped where he was needed.

It was taking them hours to reach their destination, and Izuku could tell that his classmates were getting exhausted, just as he was. But the demons he'd summoned were helping immensely it seemed. No one was sweating due to Quirk exhaustion yet, and that was a plus in his book.

They were all just really tired by the time they reached the edge of the forest and entered into a clearing where the facility was.

Everything was washed in a golden glow of the afternoon sun, and Izuku noticed that Shouta and the Wild Wild Pussycats were waiting for them. All of them were grinning, except for Shouta who seemed to take one look at him and frown.

Sero immediately spoke up, "You said it would only be, like, three hours!"

In response, Mandalay laughed behind her glove. "I guess we timed it based on how long it would take us. Sorry!"

"Holy shit," Ashido whispered, going unheard by Shouta because he didn't reprimand her.

“I just wanna sleep forever,” Shinsou remarked from where he sat on the ground next to Tokoyami and Shoji.

“What a mood,” Denki responded, rubbing at his eyes.

“I thought it would take you longer, honestly!” Pixie-Bob admitted, with a cheshire grin. “But you did much better against my dirt monsters than I thought you would! You guys are seriously great. Especially the four of you!”

Pixie-Bob’s smile widened as she eyed Kacchan, Iida, Todoroki, and Izuku himself. Her tail was swishing behind her. “It seems like you’ve had quite a bit of experience. I call dibs on these kittens!”

At that she launched herself forward at Izuku, and he backpedalled in response. Dabi was there instantly, holding her back.

“Ooh? Whose this?” She asked, stopping her advancement. “I think I saw you during the broadcast of the Hosu Incident—”

Dabi leveled her with a dangerous glare that cut her off. And well, it could’ve been Kacchan’s glare too.

“Nevermind!” She said cheerfully, waving her hands around. She was glancing around frantically, and Izuku didn’t know why until he realized that he probably looked like he was on the verge of crying. “Anyways meet Kota!”

She gestured to the little boy that Izuku hadn’t noticed until that moment. He was scowling, just like he had been when Izuku first saw him.

At the mention of his name, Kota's glare intensified. Kacchan glared right back and for a moment the two of them seemed to be in a glaring match that made Izuku forget about nearly crying. Dabi disappeared.

"He's my nephew," Mandalay said after a tense moment. "He lives with me so I brought him along for the trip! Aren't you going to say hello?"

Kota turned up his nose and looked away. Mandalay sighed heavily, she had probably expected such behavior from her nephew. Izuku watched him closely, and from the edge of his vision he saw Todoroki and Kacchan doing the same thing.

Both of them looked about ready to walk over there and ask him what his problem was. Todoroki's reasoning seemed to originate more out of concern, rather than Kacchan who looked ready to throw down.

His reasoning was lost on Izuku, but he put an arm out to keep him from going after the poor kid. Kacchan glanced down at him and huffed, seeming to back down. Maybe the kid had annoyed him in some way?

"Enough talking. Get your stuff off the bus. Once your bags are in your rooms we'll have dinner in the cafeteria. After that you can bathe and sleep. Tomorrow your training starts for real, all of you better get a move on if you want to sleep." Shouta said, before turning toward the bus that was sitting idle nearby.

His classmates took his dad's words to heart as they all rushed to the bus to grab their things. Kacchan, much to his chagrin, grabbed Izuku's bag again.

[Let me carry it.] Izuku pouted.

"No. You need to go talk to dadzawa about what happened in The Beast's Forest. You look like shit," Kacchan told him, squinting.

Izuku glared at him for reminding him of the panic attack he narrowly avoided. Well maybe he *hadn't* avoided it, but at least he hadn't made a big deal about it. But Kacchan was too perceptive to not notice it. Of course.

"Yeah." Todoroki piped up, giving him a glance from the side. When had he gotten there? "I've had them before. Not fun,"

"What do you need to talk to me about?" Shouta grumbled, coming up beside him. Izuku's heart shot up his throat, constricting his breathing.

All he could think was that he was a disappointment. That even after all this time in a safe environment he was still broken and *wrong.* And— and Shouta would realize he was a *lost cause—*

"Let's go over here kiddo," Shouta whispered, guiding him away from his classmates. Everything felt far away, on the edges of his perception. It felt like he was back in the forest, floating underwater where everything was out of reach and quiet.

He was left alone to drown in the ocean of suffering around him. Choking on the water.

Izuku hardly registered the hand that ran through his curls. Barely registered the soft whispers of reassurance.

"Take deep breaths with me okay?" Shouta told him. Izuku could recognize his dad's voice even beneath the stormy sea of terror. "In for a few seconds and out alright? Just follow what I do,"

Izuku followed each intake of breath that his dad took, and exhaled when he did. It took a few minutes for him to finally breathe without choking on it halfway through, and open his eyes.

“Better?” Shouta asked gently, not pulling his hands away from Izuku’s. He was grateful for that. He nodded and Shouta gave him a rare smile and pulled him into a hug. “That’s good. Are you ready to go eat, or would you rather eat in my room?”

He didn’t really feel like dealing with that loud raucous laughter that he would probably have to deal with if he went to eat in the cafeteria. But he also didn’t want to be alone.

[Could I eat in your room?]

“Sure thing kiddo,” Shouta said, ruffling his hair. “I could ask Bakugou and Hitoshi if they want to eat with you,”

Izuku beamed at him, and Shouta huffed. He thought he heard Shouta mutter under his breath, “Too cute,” but that could’ve been a hallucination.

Five minutes later all four of them are eating on Shouta’s floor. Admittedly, his dad isn’t eating, but rather aggressively consuming jelly packs like they were coffee. Shinsou and Kacchan seemed to get along well, Izuku realized.

They were proficient in carrying a conversation while including Izuku in it. They discussed the Wild Wild Pussycats and even Kota. Kacchan seemed annoyed by the poor kid, and he admitted that it was because he glared at *Izuku.*

Which apparently was a cardinal sin in both Kacchan and Shinsou’s eyes. Izuku laughed at them, which only made Shouta ruffle his hair and make Shinsou coo. Which was not his desired effect.

After a while of talking and eating, Shouta decided to tell them that they should probably head to the baths and go to bed.

Izuku was a bit apprehensive about bathing *with* his classmates. It wasn’t like they hadn't seen his scars before, but it was always in the back of his mind that they were secretly

judging him.

But as he was undressing himself, and stretching out his wings Dabi appeared by his side. “I heard it was bathtime?”

Izuku huffed soundlessly, and nodded.

“Fucking bet,” Dabi said with a grin as they both stepped out to the baths, where everyone was already bathing. Izuku was glad that only a few of his classmates looked at him.

Kacchan must’ve said something to them. Izuku tucked his wings against his back.

He settled down in an empty spot next to Todoroki, who looked at him with an expressionless glance. There was a tense moment where nobody said *anything,* which was much worse than his classmates just staring at him.

Kirishima seemed to notice, clearing his throat and elbowing Sero, who was beside him.

“What kind of training do you think we’ll do tomorrow?” He asked, and it was like the spell was broken.

Sero perked up instantly, latching onto anything resembling normalcy. “I think we’re going to be training our Quirks, ya know? We’ve been working on Heroics for so long but we haven’t really worked on our Quirks yet. What about you, Midoriya?”

Dabi threw an arm around him as Izuku’s eyes widened. Sero was asking *him* what he thought? He wasn’t prepared to answer any questions, and for a moment he sat there, shell-shocked.

[I think you’re right.] He signed after a few seconds of awkward silence.

Sero relaxed and gave him a shockingly gentle smile. “Thanks Midori,”

Izuku gave him a nervous smile back. He didn’t notice how everyone collectively relaxed.

When they finished bathing all of Class 1-A and 1-B—who had arrived after Class 1-A—all crammed themselves into one room. Ashido got out a collection of board games and card games, and *dragged* Vlad King and Shouta into playing with them.

It was utter chaos as all of them played a variety of games. Some were playing Monopoly, while others were playing Cards Against Humanity or Uno.

Izuku chose Uno because he didn’t know how to play any of these games. Todoroki was in the same boat, and they ended up as a team because neither of them were competent enough to do it on their own.

Yaoyorozu took it upon herself to help teach them the ins-and-outs of Uno while they played.

His dad and Shinsou were threatening people while playing Monopoly. Shinsou even brainwashed Uraraka when he got mad. Izuku laughed behind his hand when he saw.

Kacchan and Dabi were playing Cards Against Humanity as quietly as possible to avoid the teachers noticing that they were playing something not school appropriate.

The entire “emo squad” as they called themselves, which consisted of Tokoyami, Koda, Shoji at the moment, were watching a Disney movie. Izuku had almost joined them but Uno had

won out in the end.

Their fun and games lasted for a long while until Shouta stood up along with Vlad King and announced that they should probably go to bed.

“All of you have training in the morning, so I would highly recommend going to bed as soon as possible,” Vlad King had said.

Ashido groaned in despair. “Okaaaay,”

“Aw man, already?” Denki grumbled, leaning heavily on his boyfriend. “It’s not even ten yet!”

“You’re getting up at five in the morning, so I would *suggest* —” Shouta emphasized the last part. “—that you go to sleep.”

After a moment, everyone sighed in defeat and they helped put away all the games. Todoroki quietly thanked Yaoyorozu for helping them navigate Uno and Izuku nodded along enthusiastically.

“Oh it was no problem,” Yaoyorozu began, until a shrill scream cut through the walls. Everyone froze instantly, their eyes going to Shouta and Vlad King.

Both of them opened the door and Pixie-Bob came running down the hallway. “There’s a *monster* in the kitchen!”

Izuku sucked on his bottom lip. He had a good idea of what the “monster” was.

“We’ll grab it,” Dabi said, as Izuku walked past his teachers and headed for the kitchen.

There, opening and closing the fridge in complete darkness—he wasn't scared. He *wasn't* — was a demon.

"Really man?" Dabi asked, sounding tired.

The demon kept opening and closing the fridge. *"Light…"*

Dabi raised an eyebrow.

"Darkness… poison… scared..."

Izuku reached out and his hand landed on the demon's shoulder.

"Light…" The fridge opens. *"Darkness…"*

The fridge closes.

"Poison…"

The demon turns to him with a smile that covers the entire lower half of it's face. It grabbed him and shoved him against the fridge.

Izuku froze, terrified as it's clawed hands cut into his wrists. It's shadowy hands were freezing against his skin. He could hardly hear what it was saying over the roaring in his ears, and the sound of the cabinets slamming open and closed again and again on their own.

"Scared..." It croaked, as if there was gravel in its throat. *"Scared…!"*

It shook him back and forth and Izuku was utterly frozen in place. He could hardly suck in a breath of air. ***"Scared scared scared — "***

The basement. Cold hands reaching from all sides screaming until his ears bled … The darkness. Trapped forever —

And the demon just disappeared. Like smoke.

"Izuku!" Shouta exclaimed, voice thin with worry. Izuku slowly slid down until he was sitting on the floor. He couldn't breathe. Something warm was sliding down his arms. He couldn't bring himself to look. There were dark figures peeking around the corners of his vision. He squeezed his eyes shut.

"Blood. Bleeding. Bleeding. Bleeding."

"You're okay baby. You're okay. Dabi turn on the light. *Turn the fucking light on or so help me Dabi—!"* Shouta spat venemously. "—Pixie-Bob, keep the other kids in their rooms. Vlad can you get me a first-aid kit?"

It felt like hours that he sat there, frozen. Still thinking about cold, cruel hands. His mother. His father. All for One. The Doctor. Mean demons.

"You're okay," Shouta kept saying, as he wrapped his wrists with gauze. It guided him back from the storm of emotions and thoughts that kept running in circles in his mind. "You're okay,"

There was a pause.

"Do you want to sleep in my room, kid?" Shouta asked, and Izuku finally opened his eyes. The sting from the sudden light lasted for a second before he blinked. He took a few moments to take a few deep breaths that Shouta guided him through with whispered encouragement and hair ruffles.

He nodded.

“Okay,” Shouta replied, helping him stand. “Let me go get Hitoshi, okay?”

He nodded again, and Shouta disappeared down the nearest hallway. Vlad King was watching him with a horrified expression.

“What was that?” He asked.

“A warning,” Dabi grumbled, crossing his arms as he came to stand beside Izuku protectively. “I don’t think it meant to scare him that bad though,”

“About what?”

“No fuckin’ clue,” Dabi admitted, throwing an arm around Izuku. “Guess we’ll see, huh?”

Izuku grimaced, recalling the message the demon had tried to relay. It definitely sounded like it was trying to warn him about something, but the way it had gone about it was… scary.

[It sounded ominous.]

Chapter End Notes

As always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 82

Chapter Summary

More Training Camp!

Chapter Notes

We get some bkdk moments as well as brother!Shinsou coz I said so. Also I was gonna upload this on thanksgiving but I was lowkey depressed so I said fuck that lol. I was also on vacation before that, hence why I didn't do it a few weeks ago either.... TT^TT love yall. enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He didn’t sleep well at all. And as a result, neither did his dad nor Shinsou. His mind kept pondering what the demon had been trying to warn him about, and he kept coming up with nothing good.

An irrational part of himself entertained the idea of villains attacking only for about five minutes before he pushed it aside. It was too scary to think about.

But he couldn’t sleep. He couldn’t keep himself from thinking that there were demons lurking, ready to deliver even more terrifying news. So he was a *little* paranoid, okay?

It got to the point that Shinsou laid right on top of him, and grumbled that he could practically *hear* Izuku’s thoughts from across the room.

“Go to sleep,” Shinsou begged, from on top of him. “For the love of god,”

And as slightly suffocating as Shinsou was, Izuku found himself falling asleep before he knew it.

Izuku wasn't the only one dead on his feet as they finished up breakfast and went out on the training ground. He could hardly stick his wings through the cut-outs on his P.E. Uniform.

The Wild Wild Pussycats were waiting for them to arrive, each of them too energetic for how early it was in the morning. The sun had barely begun to peak over the horizon, and they were already posing.

Izuku just wanted to hide in his dad's sleeping bag. He honestly felt like he didn't sleep at all, despite the six solid hours he managed to get in. Uraraka, Tokoyami, Kacchan and Shinsou specifically looked like they needed five more hours of sleep, judging by how they were struggling to keep upright.

He could relate.

Pixie-Bob sighed heavily as she realized that no one other than her team was matching her energy.

"I know it's a little early kittens, but it's time to get to work!" Mandalay told them, "Today we begin a training camp that will increase your strength. Take it away, Eraser!"

At that, Shouta yawned and walked over to where the Pussycats were standing. "The goal of our training camp is to increase your skills exponentially so that each of you earns a provisional license. This will allow you to face the dangers that continue to fester within the darkness. Long story short, getting your provisional license means that you can legally fight villains. So it's my top priority to make sure each and every one of you are ready to pass the test,"

He sighed heavily. "The amount of times this class has faced villains is unprecedented, so Nedzu thought it was a good idea to make sure each of you can defend yourselves. Bakugou." Shouta threw the baseball from the Quirk Assessment test at him.

Kacchan caught it and gave Shouta a look of confusion.

“Try throwing that for me.”

“Like in the assessment test?” Uraraka murmured, and Shouta nodded.

“Exactly like the assessment test,” Shouta told them. “When you first started school you could throw 705.2 meters. Let’s see if you can throw it any farther,”

Kacchan turned away from them and readied himself for the throw. Izuku didn’t need to see his face to know that he was grinning wolfishly, as he threw his hand forward and released an explosion.

He let out an incomprehensible screech as the ball sailed through the air. Shouta yawned again and displayed the amount on the screen of his phone. “709.6 meters,”

“Huh?! That’s it??” Ashido asked, her eyes blown wide with shock.

“Over the past three months all of you have definitely grown, but that’s only in terms of your mental prowess and technical skill. While we *have* trained with your Quirks on and off, it hasn’t been our main focus, until now that is,”

His dad’s smile was terrifying to look at. “This assessment will be a true test to see how far you’ve come. This training camp will be so hard you’ll feel like you're dying. Let’s hope all of you survive.”

Izuku *really* wanted to nap now.

“Now!” Mandalay continued, “We’re here to help you train your Quirks as Eraserhead just told you!”

“But there are twenty of us…” Tsuyu told her, putting a finger to her chin in thought. “How will you help all of us, and not to mention Class 1-B…”

“That’s easy!” Ragdoll piped up excitedly, like she had been waiting for this exact question. “First of all I must tell you that Quirks are just like muscles. And just like muscles, when they are overused they break and grow back tougher! They improve the harder you push them! Isn’t that right Eraser!”

“Yeah.” He grumbled. “There’s only one thing to do to train all of your Quirks all at once,”

“You break yourselves!” Tiger exclaimed, flexing. “Each time you do your Quirk will get stronger and stronger, just like Midoriya’s Quirk!”

“Like Midoriya’s?” Kirishima asked, as everyone turned to look at him.

Izuku wanted to hide somewhere far away.

“Exactly!” Pixie-Bob exclaimed, pointing at Izuku enthusiastically. “He’s a perfect example of how a Quirk can develop more and more with training. I just *know* he’s going to be a powerful Hero! I'll call dibs on him in a few years!”

Shouta glared at her, and she grinned sheepishly. “Or maybe not,” She amended. “Eraserhead might kill me,”

“I *will* kill you,” Shouta replied protectively. “There’s no *might* about it,”

Mandalay cleared her throat and came between them. “Let’s get started, yeah?”

Ragdoll nodded enthusiastically. “To answer your question we’ll be using our Quirks to make it easier to help all of you train! My Quirk is called Search. I can look at up to one-hundred people and know everything about them! Like their location, and weakness!”

“With my Quirk, Earthflow I can create the ideal training ground for each student!” Pixie-Bob exclaimed.

“And my Quirk is called Telepath. I can give advice to multiple people at once.” Mandalay explained before turning the spotlight to Tiger.

“I’m just here to beat you guys to a pulp!”

“I have questions about that,” Kirishima said in a high-pitched voice. After a short pause, where Denki laughed nervously, the Pussycat’s began giving everyone instructions.

Surprisingly, Izuku didn’t end up getting any instruction from any of the Pussycat’s. Shouta just pointed to the forest and gestured for him to follow.

“We’re just going to continue your training like usual,” Shouta explained once they were a safe distance away from everyone else. “We’ll add a few things into our usual routine, but it’s mostly going to be the same,”

Izuku nodded, and they got started.

He doesn’t know how long he and Shouta stood there in the forest. They went through the motions of his training routine. He reached past the limits his dad and Nedzu had set for him. He pushed past his threshold by miles, and has somehow managed to find a foothold within the power.

And then Shouta decided it was time.

“Do you want to try transforming?” He asked, his voice impossibly gentle. Izuku, who is sweating through his UA uniform and gasping for breath gives Shouta an incredulous look.

His dad just grins. There’s a moment of silence between them as Shouta lets him catch his breath.

“This *is* the best time to test it,” Shouta told him, his smile widening. “We’re far away from your classmates.The Pussycats and Vlad King have been notified of how dangerous and volatile your Quirk can be, so they’re willing to help if you lose control,”

And well, Izuku couldn’t argue with that logic. There was never a time better than now to master one of the only parts of his Quirk he’s been reluctant to use. With his dad by his side, ready to mitigate any serious dangers, he felt more at ease than he probably should.

Finally, he nodded and his dad held out his hand for the necklace around his neck. Izuku hands it over, and Shouta leans against the nearest tree to watch him. Izuku takes a deep breath and welcomes the rush of power.

It’s a rush he’d felt every time he took off the Quirk Suppressor. He clenched his hands to curb the anxiety twisting uncomfortably in his gut. He forced himself to remember what he did during Hosu, and how he changed his appearance with nothing more than imagining himself as such.

The horns, the sharper teeth, the inky black of his hands from producing too much power, and his eyes changing their shape and color. All of it.

There’s a stinging in his eyes, and the dull throb of a headache. But the pain meant that his transformation was successful.

His dad's expression didn't change, but he did pull himself off the tree he'd been leaning on. There wasn't any concern anywhere on his face that Izuku could identify, but there was curiosity there.

"Kiddo?" He asked, and Izuku noticed how Shouta didn't even hesitate to move toward him. There wasn't even a hint of apprehension in his shoulders, but that may have been on purpose.

Izuku nodded. Unlike the other times he'd transformed—the first *real* instance being surrounded by classmates and by All Might, and terrified out of his mind. The second being during the Hosu Incident with his life on the line—this time he wasn't scared. He wasn't fighting villains.

He'd been steadily mastering his power for so *long,* and here he was almost at peace with the rushing power that danced on his skin.

Shouta gave him a wide grin. "Good job kiddo," He said, taking his time getting closer and closer. "Do you think you can keep your control and move around a bit?"

Not to be one to disappoint, Izuku began to walk around and when dad suggested it, he tried a series of stretches. They even sparred, until Izuku was too exhausted to continue.

By then, the sun was beginning to set and everyone headed back to the building to make dinner and bathe again.

However, this time they were responsible for making dinner. Which ended up being curry, so Izuku was tasked with summoning Dabi to start some fires and help cut up vegetables. He pretended not to notice Iida slowly figuring out how to peel a potato for the first time, but he had to admit it was kind of funny, especially when Uraraka pointed it out.

And *then* everyone started cooing at him and Kacchan once they came to the realization that they both were really good at slicing vegetables. At some point Kacchan had come beside him, and according to Ashido, who wouldn't shut up about it, they were slicing their vegetables in sync with each other.

“You’re both so cuuuuute!” She exclaimed, from where she was watching one of the pots come to a boil. “Look at them Uraraka!”

“Aww!”

“That’s so manly!”

“Are you crying Kirishima?” Sero asked, with a laugh.

“He totally is,” Denki remarked, with a cheshire grin.

“All of us need to finish making dinner! This is no time to be socializing!” Iida exclaimed, and Izuku noted that he had finally finished peeling his potatoes. “We can talk all we want afterward!”

“Oh c’mon boss man,” Uraraka said, giving Iida her softest smile. “You don’t have to be so strung up all the time!”

“Maybe so, but someone needs to keep our classmates in line!” Iida exclaimed, chopping his hands in the air. Uraraka just laughed and her cheeks were dusted with a light pink that Izuku dutifully pretended wasn’t there.

He just passed on his vegetables to Kacchan who stirred it into their pot of food. And then they brought out the packets of curry that were divided into squares and put them in with the food. Soon the smell of curry permeated the air, and Kacchan silently brought a spoonful of it for Izuku to taste.

“Good?” He asked, and Izuku nodded enthusiastically. Kacchan gave him a triumphant grin in response. “Hell yeah it’s good. We made it!”

Izuku gave him a soft smile and Kacchan looked away. He grumbled something under his breath, but Izuku didn't catch it. He just kept an eye on the curry as it finished up cooking.

Soon enough everything was ready to be served. Iida and Jirou were in charge of plating everything and passing each plate to either a classmate, their teacher, or the Pussycats. They were halfway through eating together when Kacchan stood up and grabbed an extra serving.

"Oh, what're you doing Bakubro?" Kirishima asked innocently.

"Kota isn't here to eat," He answered bluntly. "C'mon nerd lets go find that kid,"

Izuku was shocked to be addressed, but didn't hesitate to pop up from his spot next to Shinsou.

[Okay!] He signed. Kacchan carefully wrapped the plate of food in plastic wrap to keep it from getting cold, and handed it to him. Izuku held it carefully with one hand and finger-spelled with his free hand.

[How are we going to find him?]

"He left a trail," Kacchan pointed out as soon as they ducked into the forest. He gestured to the tiny footprints that were visible. "We'll just follow it to wherever he is,"

And so they did. For the most part Kacchan was quiet, as they walked. It was a comfortable silence as they trudged through the forest, but eventually Kacchan broke it.

"Were you practicing with Aizawa-sensei?" He asked softly, as he grabbed Izuku's hand to help him step over a particularly large tree root.

Izuku nodded.

“And you transformed?”

Izuku furrowed his brow in confusion, and Kacchan must’ve seen it because he elaborated.

“Your hands. They had turned black for a while after you and Aizawa-sensei came out of the forest,” Kacchan told him. “Was it successful?”

Izuku nodded excitedly, and Kacchan turned his face away from him. Again. Just like the other day. He didn’t know why Kacchan kept doing that. Was he being annoying? Was he signing too much? Did Kacchan want silence?

He didn’t know. He just let them fall back into silence as they finally reached Kota’s hiding place. It was on a cliff, and they could see Kota from where they stood below it. He was glaring down at his hands, and sitting at the edge of the cliff.

He hadn’t noticed Kacchan and Izuku yet, so that was good. The two of them got all the way to where Kota was sitting before the kid even noticed they were there.

“Wh-what are you guys doing here?!” He exclaimed, crossing his arms. “This is my secret base, scram!”

Kacchan’s face visibly twitched with annoyance. “Why *you*— ”

Izuku elbowed him hard. Kacchan grumbled something under his breath before taking a deep breath.

“We came to give you food, you fucking brat.” He took the food from Izuku’s hands and shoved it towards Kota.

Kota glared at the plate and placed it on the ground next to him. “I don’t care. I’m not hungry,”

Kacchan matched his glare in its intensity and crossed his arms. “Well I guess you can die then, asshole.”

[Kacchan. You can’t talk to kids like that.]

“He’s dissing our hard work!” Kacchan seethed, turning to face him. “Our classmates worked hard on this food after training all day, and all he can say is he *doesn’t* want it!”

[It’s okay.]

“Nah, it’s not!” Kacchan shouted. Izuku tried to hide the way his whole body flinched at the volume, but Kacchan saw it anyway and lowered his voice. “What’s your damn problem kid?”

Kota let out a silent huff of air, and turned to face both of them. “You guys are just trying to act all heroic like heroes and it’s *disgusting!”*

Disgusting?

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?” Kacchan asked, coming to sit beside Kota. He was scowling at the kid still, but he didn’t seem as agitated as before.

“All of you trying to improve your Quirks is so dumb! You just want to show off!” He spat, “Everyone here’s so crazy. Calling people stupid names like “hero” and “villain,” and killing each other because of it. Always focusing on their Quirks. If *they* hadn’t been showing off they’d still be here!”

What does he mean by they?

“Who’re they?” Kacchan asked, squinting at Kota.

“My parents!” Kota snapped. “They were showing off and they got themselves killed by a villain! And everyone praised them for it! They died “honorable deaths for a hero,” but they *left* me all alone and all they gave me was a stupid water Quirk! That’s why I *hate* heroes!”

Oh. Izuku thought to himself, *now Kota’s anger makes sense.*

Of course a kid at Kota’s age would see it as his parents showing off. Kota wasn’t old enough to realize what his parents did was save people by sacrificing themselves. He would always see it as his parents abandoning him. Leaving him on his own, without even saying goodbye.

In Kota’s mind they were more occupied with being heroes and saving people to even think of how he’d feel once they were gone.

“What happened to Water Hose was pretty shitty.” Kacchan admitted, pushing the plate of food closer to Kota as he spoke. “But in the end they died. They couldn’t control that, ya dumb kid. I’m pretty damn sure that they didn’t want to die before saying goodbye, but blaming their *deaths* on why you hate heroes is just wrong. They wouldn’t want you to think that way about the world. They died protecting people and their dreams, so to be angry about it is just a waste of your time and will only hurt you in the end.”

Kota sniffled. And then promptly burst into tears.

Izuku hurried to sit down on Kota’s other side and offered him a hug. Kota dived into his arms and Kacchan turned away from him again, but *this time* Izuku saw the blush on his cheeks.

He tapped on Kacchan’s shoulder. [Do you want a hug too, Kacchan?]

Kacchan glared at him, before stammering. “No I don’t want a damn hug from you nerd!”

Izuku just smiled.

Chapter End Notes

As always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Test of Courage

Chapter Summary

Actually the test of courage that they never got to finish in canon lol

Chapter Notes

Enjoy the chapter guys!! I'm sorry I took so long. I just recently learned that my cat from my childhood has breast cancer and diabetes. :(its only a matter of time before she passes on so I decided to spend time with her instead of posting.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He decided that tomorrow he would start to work on Izuku's flying skills, but right now he was too busy thinking about how he was really proud of his kid.

Shouta has been watching his kid train with his transformation each day. And each day he learned a little more about his limits and capabilities. He got more comfortable using that aspect of his power, and so far they've had only minimal hiccups.

It took a lot of Izuku's concentration, it seemed to keep the transformation in check. But still, despite the slow development, at least their progress was steady and linear. There's no longer fear in his son's expression every time he loses control. It's determination to learn to control the beast, and each time he's been able to reel himself back in without hurting anyone.

He can spend about twenty minutes at the most in his transformation before it becomes too much for him.

Even if his kid looks frustrated with himself each time, Shouta called it progress. He made sure to tell Izuku that each time. He'd run his hand through his kid's hair and plant a kiss on his forehead where he was *sure* no one could see.

And then he'd tell his kid over and over that he was doing great, and that he was making progress. That was all that mattered in the end. It didn't matter how much progress. It didn't matter if Izuku could only manage to do a twenty-minute transformation because at least they'd taken that first step.

He told Hitoshi the same thing. Both of his kids were doing remarkably well and they *deserved* to know.

But not where anyone could see because that would ruin his reputation.

He just really loved his kids. So that of course led to him giving them a break. Which ended up being a test of courage in the forest.

Except Izuku was terrified of the dark. So Shouta had planned ahead to have Izuku stay inside the building with the kids who were taking remedial classes and have them play board games or something.

It turned out that Izuku was determined to do the test of courage with Bakugou anyway. Shouta was proud, so he allowed the remedial kids to join in.

Izuku wasn't going to let his fear get in the way of doing the test of courage. Especially if they got to scare Class 1-B. He knew that his class would be the one to come out on top. Not only had they faced villain attack after villain attack, they also had Izuku's Quirk to strike fear into their sister class.

He wanted to win.

He wanted Monoma to run away screaming as payback for the Sports Festival and what he said in the lunchroom forever ago.

It was kind of funny that his classmates shared the same sentiment, and it was fate that Class 1-A was scaring people first.

“So, so, so!” Hagakure exclaimed giddily, as they started planning. “Midoriya can summon a *lot* of demons, right?”

Izuku nodded in confirmation. Hagakure was jumping up and down excitedly but Izuku could only tell because her uniform moved with her. Ashido grinned widely.

“Okay so here’s the plan,” Ashido began, pointing at Izuku. “You’ll summon a bunch of demons to follow each group and terrorize them, and Momo will make us some costumes! Me, Aoyama, and Hagakure have been practicing our horror movie make-up so we’ll try to make everyone look as scary as possible!”

“Okay, but what’re we going to be? Ghosts?” Sero asked, putting a finger to his chin. “Ghosts are kinda overdone you know?”

“Zombies!” Ashido told them, motioning for everyone to sit down on the ground. “Hurry up guys, we've only got twenty minutes!”

“Oh, Momo you should start making clothes and tearing them up!” Hagakure told her, and Momo nodded.

Izuku watched all of this wearily, as Hagakure, Ashido, and Aoyama easily took the reins on this activity. He was kind of nervous to summon a lot of demons for this while he was left in the dark, but he wanted to scare Monoma.

Kacchan groaned from where he stood next to him.

[What’s wrong Kacchan?] He signed, and Kacchan sighed heavily.

“This won’t be enough to scare the living shit out of Monoma,” Kacchan admitted, but as he turned to face Izuku he was grinning. One of his more feral grins.

Izuku stepped back uneasily. He did *not* like that look. That look meant that Kacchan was scheming, and they never ended well.

“You remember how my mom was a fashion designer?” Kacchan asked, and Izuku slowly nodded. “Good. Invisi-bitch you got extra makeup?!”

It struck him right then that Kacchan’s scheme involved Izuku. He shook his head violently, backing away. He didn’t want to be involved in whatever Kacchan was doing. With his luck, they’d get expelled!

“Sit down, Deku,” Kacchan chuckled darkly as Hagakure handed him the makeup. Izuku sat down, coming to terms with his fate. “Now transform,”

What?

Izuku’s jaw dropped in disbelief. Kacchan wanted him to *transform* , right now?! Was he fucking *crazy?!* Ok. That was a stupid question to ask because of course Kacchan was crazy!

But he *did* want to scare Monoma. And he *had* been practicing his transformation with his dad, and he did perfectly *fine!* He took a deep breath and handed Kacchan his Quirk suppressor. The transformation had been getting easier and easier each time he did it.

He definitely had a long way to go before he could confidently say that he’d mastered all aspects of his Quirk.

In the end, he let Kacchan do what he *assumed* was going to be utterly terrifying makeup.

Once their twenty minutes was up everyone quickly got into their designated places, and Izuku summoned as many demons as he thought would be necessary to cover the path and follow each group around.

"Are you ready for this nerd?" Kacchan asked from beside him, with fake blood dripping down his jaw. Hopefully, his dad didn't see them and have a heart attack after this…

He and Kacchan were the only ones in the class who decided not to wear costumes. Izuku looked scary enough for both of them, and by the time Kacchan had finished the make-up their preparation time had run out.

[Yeah. I'm ready.]

Kacchan grinned, and it was terrifying with his makeup on. Izuku mirrored it exactly, as they heard the shrill screaming of someone from Class 1-B.

"Hm, seems like those extras actually know how to scare people," Kacchan commented as they waited. Izuku glared at him, crossing his arms.

[Don't call them extras Kacchan. They're our classmates.]

"Yeah yeah, whatever!"

Izuku smiled and Kacchan huffed in annoyance.

"You're always too nice," Kacchan grumbled, kicking up some dirt.

[You're just being prickly all the time Kacchan.]

“I am *not!”*

[Yes you are!]

“They were mean to you, Deku,” He pointed out, turning serious all of the sudden.

[Yeah but dad fixed it.]

“Damn broccoli boy,” Kacchan snapped, turning his face away so he couldn’t see what Izuku signed in response.

Izuku elbowed him in the side with a playful smile. Kacchan stubbornly kept looking away from him, but Izuku could see the growing smirk on his face.

“How come we haven’t seen any of Class 1-A yet?” Kendo asked rather loudly as she and Monoma suddenly appeared on the path. Both of them peered at the pair, ready to jump out when the time came.

“They must’ve given up on scaring us!” Monoma boasted with a laugh. Izuku frowned. “They know Class 1-B is better than them in every way!”

“That’s…” Kendo began, before heavily sighing. They got steadily closer. “Why are you even so obsessed with Class 1-B being better than 1-A anyway? We’re all going to be allies one day, we should get along.”

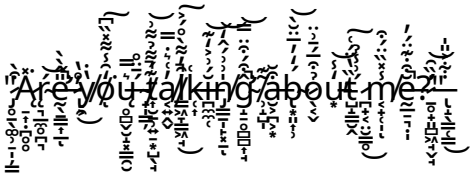
[We leave Kendo alone.] Izuku signed hastily, and Kacchan nodded as they stood.

“Get *along?!* With those freaks? Especially—”

Kacchan sprung into action with an enraged snarl and blocked Monoma's path. Izuku dutifully took his position behind them without being detected.

"Especially who?" Kacchan asked, in a dangerous and low tone that matched the murderous look on his face. If it had been anyone else Izuku would've been terrified. Behind his back, he summoned more demons to surround them while Kacchan was spitting with rage.

"Obviously that *devil—!"*



Monoma turned slowly, utter terror permanently etched on his face. He and Monoma locked eyes, and Izuku watched with a surprising amount of satisfaction as Monoma's eyes widened. He saw the horns, the wings fully extended, the golden eyes, and the bloody claws. For a moment there was nothing. And then Monoma went pale and *screamed.*

"KYAAAA!"

Monoma was so terrified that he ran right past Izuku and probably all the way back to the start. Mission accomplished. Kendo was smiling at both of them. "Can I go now?" she asked, pointing toward where the path led to the exit.

"Yeah," Kacchan told her, waving her away. "We only wanted to scare Monoma anyway,"

"It was pretty cool," She replied as she walked away, still smiling widely. "Monoma can get so carried away. Sorry about him."

Kacchan waved her away again, refusing her apology.

“It was, wasn’t it?” Kacchan boasted as soon as she was gone. “We did great! I’m pretty sure that asshole pissed his pants,”

Izuku shook his head and laughed.

Shouta had to admit that seeing Monoma scream bloody murder about a demon in the forest was pretty funny.

It was even funnier when more and more people came out looking as white as a sheet. His class had done a good job.

What *wasn’t* funny was when his little children from hell came out of the forest looking half-dead. Iida must’ve seen it in his expression because he was quick to reassure him that it was just makeup.

A part of him was pissed that his kids would unintentionally scare him like that. The other part of him was impressed that they did as much as they did for the test of courage in under twenty minutes.

With his kids being covered in fake blood that meant that they would have to get themselves cleaned off during the twenty minutes that Class 1-B would be preparing, so he directed them to the baths immediately.

Izuku looked rather pleased with himself as he and Bakugou passed him.

“You scared Monoma, didn’t you kid?”

Izuku flashed him a blinding smile and Shouta nodded in approval.

“It was *hilarious,”* Bakugou said.

“Good job,” Shouta said, patting Izuku on the head. “He was thoroughly terrified,”

“Hey, you’re giving out free head pats?” Hitoshi asked too innocently for all the blood that was on his face. “Do I get one?”

“Of course,” Shouta grumbled, and Hitoshi smirked.

“Thanks, Dad,”

“You’re welcome. Now go get cleaned up,”

Once they were gone, Vlad King whistled slowly. “You’re going soft Eraserhead,” He commented.

“Fuck off Vlad, you don’t even have kids,”

“I have twenty of them just like you do,”

“Fair point,”

“You’re still going soft,” Vlad pointed out with a smirk.

“My class is still better than yours,”

“Only because they have more experience.” Vlad crossed his arms and narrowed his eyes at him.

“I guess we’ll see which class is stronger once they do their first work-study,”

“Class 1-B will win.”

Shouta grinned. “That’ll be a first.”

Vlad feigned a hurt expression. “That was low, even for you Eraser,”

About forty minutes later both hero classes were winding down for the day. Izuku was utterly exhausted from the day’s activities, but at least his class had won the test of courage.

Being out in the forest in the dark without panicking was a new and exciting experience, and he was glad that Kacchan was there with him through it all. He confirmed for himself that he could get over any of his fears, and it felt more freeing than anything else he had felt in a long time.

There was hope for him to live a normal life, one that wasn’t bound by his fears. It was something he should probably talk about with his therapist, so for now he focused on playing the game of Uno that Todoroki-kun was surprisingly winning.

Ashido was kind of upset that someone as new to Uno as Todoroki was winning, but Izuku thought it was pretty funny.

Todoroki didn’t even know he was winning. Izuku was secretly rooting for him because his current hand of cards wasn’t doing too well right now.

From Sero's look of defeat, he wasn't doing so well either when Ashido changed the color to green. Finally, Izuku could put a card down, a wildcard. He looked up to Todoroki who mouthed 'Red.'

[Red.]

"Uno," Todoroki mumbled calmly as Sero screeched and Ashido groaned.

"You totally told Midoriya what color you had!" Ashido complained, but there was laughter in her voice.

"I might've," Todoroki told them coolly, with the smallest of smiles. Ashido cooed at the sight of it.

"Yo," Kirishima said suddenly, "First off, Todoroki my dude. You're not supposed to admit it! And Midoriya!"

Izuku looked up sharply, taking in Kirishima's sunny smile. "I've been meaning to ask for a while. Can I touch your wings?"

That… wasn't what he expected Kirishima to ask. He was honestly expecting anything other than that.

He wasn't even sure how to respond to that. Should he say *yes?* What was the harm of letting Kirishima touch them anyway?

[Sure.]

“Yay!” Kirishima exclaimed, as he got up and headed over. Izuku let one of his wings extend outward, and Sero ducked out of the way. Kirishima brushed his hand along the feathers, and Izuku involuntarily jerked back at the foreign contact.

His wings twitched at his back, and he could tell because he accidentally sent Sero sprawling.

“Whoa!” Sero exclaimed as he sat up. “Your wings are really strong!”

He quickly tucked his wings against the back of his shirt and covered his face in embarrassment. He just *smacked* Sero! With his *wings* !

“Fucking idiots,” Kacchan grumbled from right next to him, and Izuku felt a weight on his shoulder. “He doesn’t know how to use them yet,”

“But you used them during his final exams, didn’t you?” Kirishima asked, poking his hands that still rested over his face.

“It was in the heat of the moment,” Dabi said suddenly, which startled Izuku enough to uncover his face.

[When did you get here?] Izuku signed.

“Oh, just now. I was pretty bored,” Dabi explained, “We should totally go fly tomorrow, or maybe we could prank Eraserhead?”

“Dude we could prank him *right now,”* Denki proposed. “We have Momo who can make us anything we want!”

“But I don’t want to die,” Sero mumbled, “What would we even do?”

“Maybe we should fill his room with balloons?” Ashido replied, raising her eyebrows.

“Should we tape him to the ceiling?” Kirishima asked, as Shinsou suddenly paled and waved his hands around.

Izuku knew without turning around that their dad was probably leaning against the door, watching them all come up with prank ideas. He watched their demise like it was in slow motion. Todoroki proposed the idea of icing over his door so he couldn’t get out.

Jirou said they should switch his coffee for tea when he wasn’t looking. Kacchan said they should steal his capture weapon, as Shinsou got paler and paler. Izuku tried not to laugh. They were going to be *so* dead when Shouta scolded them.

“Oh really?” Shouta said as Sero suggested that they draw on his face. “And how would you go about that without me waking up?”

The resulting silence almost made Izuku burst out laughing as his classmates turned to face their teacher.

“H-how long have you been standing there?” Jirou asked nervously, twirling her earphone jack around her finger.

“Since Izuku smacked Sero with his wing,” Dabi answered when Shouta just grinned.

“You were standing there for that long?! *Why* ?”

“I wanted to know what you would come up with,” Shouta admitted. “None of you are very creative when it comes to pranks. Ingenium and Present Mic would do much better,”

“Did… did we just get roasted by our own teacher?” Denki asked himself in disbelief, covering his mouth.

“Yeah, you did,” Shinsou replied, with a heavy sigh. “I tried to warn everyone but no one was paying attention,”

“I’m sorry bro,” Kirishima said, “I was too caught up in it.”

“All of you are running laps tomorrow before training begins,” Shouta told them, smirking. “Don’t *ever* try to prank me,”

“Gah! I hate running!” Ashido wailed, covering her face.

“Okay but no one feels bad for Iida who *runs* as his training?” Jirou mumbled, patting Iida on the back, who looked ready to keel over.

“Rest in peace Iida,” Uraraka consoled him as Shouta hid his smile behind his capture weapon.

“All the girls need to return to their rooms for the night,” Shouta told them calmly once everyone had accepted their fate. “You have a big day tomorrow,”

Reluctantly all the girls packed up their board games and card games and then left. Momo paused in the doorway.

“Midoriya are you sleeping in here tonight? Would you like me to make you a nightlight?”

Kacchan shook his head, and replied, “I brought one,”

“I see,” She responded with a smile, as she walked out. “That was sweet of you Bakugou-kun,”

“Leave me the hell alone, Ponytail,” Kacchan grumbled, with a slight blush dusting across his cheeks.

“Aw, Bakubro, you really care about Midoriya don’t you?” Kirishima exclaimed.

“SHUT UP!” Kacchan roared, and Izuku hid his smile behind his hand.

“That’s yes in Bakugou,” Shinsou pointed out, with a shit-eating grin. It looked eerily similar to Shouta’s smile.

“It sure is,” Dabi added.

“All of you can fuck off,” Kacchan sighed.

“What a mad banquet of darkness,” Tokoyami said randomly as he stood next to Izuku.

Izuku nodded in agreement.

Chapter End Notes

Also, Im currently stuck on writing chapter 91... which is the aftermath of Kamino. This chapter is also before the provisional license exam arc, but my problem rn is whether or not to spread out the timeline and do a time skip? And also I need to decide who to have Izuku study under during the Overhaul arc. I'm thinking Hawks? How do you guys feel about it?

So:

Time skip or no time skip? (for context this time skip would just vaguely go over the therapy everyone receives, and Izuku's overall recovery from everything that's happened to him. And it would take place between the aftermath of Kamino and the provisional license exam.)

Internship with Hawks?

Lastly, as always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 84

Chapter Summary

Beginning of the kidnapping arc <3

Chapter Notes

I have no excuse as to why I didn't update, other than my cat died very recently (like a week ago? And I'm sad T^T

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The morning never came. Instead, they were all trapped in a terrible nightmare.

It started with a feeling of trepidation that Izuku couldn't explain, and it woke him up from a dead sleep. Kacchan was snoring beside him, seemingly unaffected by the smokescreen of uneasiness that filled the air.

He sat up and glanced around. Everyone except for Hitoshi was sleeping soundly. Nothing seemed amiss, but Izuku could shake the feeling of *wrong* that itched under his skin. Something was happening. Something was *wrong*. His throat ached, and his eyes itched.

"Izuku?" Hitoshi asked, his tone softened by his whispering. "Is there something wrong?"

He nodded and Hitoshi got up and walked over to him. "Do you want me to get Dadzawa?" Hitoshi asked in a hushed voice, even softer than before now that they were closer.

He didn't know how to answer. Did he want Shouta? Should he just sleep off the uneasy feeling in his stomach and forget about it by morning? He wasn't sure. He also didn't want to wake up Shouta for just a *feeling*. It would make him feel guilty for waking him up if nothing came of his sudden instinctual fear.

He shook his head. Hitoshi furrowed his brow in response and plopped down next to him. “Want to watch Youtube videos with me then?”

[Can’t sleep?] He asked, with his hands.

“Nope,” Hitoshi replied, with a grin that was eerily similar to Shouta’s. “Not a fucking wink,”

Izuku nodded in sympathy. He could only relate to insomnia a little bit, considering that he’s spent entire nights before, in terror under his blankets. Having Hitoshi beside him, suffering the same fate made him feel a little better. Of course, Izuku didn’t have chronic insomnia like Sho or Hitoshi, so he couldn’t say he understood their pain completely. That would be unfair of him.

Hitoshi plugged his earbuds into his phone and offered one of them to Izuku. He took it carefully, putting it in his ear as Hitoshi started up a video of someone working at a cafe. He could only see the worker’s hands as they poured ice into a cup and filled it with a specific type of drink, which according to the subtitles was some type of coffee.

The video also featured this worker assembling cakes and putting them in glass displays. Hitoshi must’ve seen his confused expression so he quietly explained.

“These are called cafe vlogs,” Hitoshi whispered just loud enough for him to hear. “Basically they record their shift at a cafe and make a video of it. They’re relaxing,”

Izuku could definitely see how they were relaxing. The din of customers talking in the background of the videos wasn’t distracting, but rather distant, almost like a hum of white noise to fill the silence.

They sat there for a while watching video after video until Izuku was on the cusp of feeling tired all over again.

That's when something physically shifted in the air. Hitoshi's head snapped up suddenly and Izuku followed his line of sight to see nothing. Everyone was still sleeping soundly. He turned to face Hitoshi who shook his head and went back to the video.

But Izuku was still trying to figure out the sinister shift in the air. It wasn't like the kind of shift that came with summoning his demons. Nor was it just a chill in the air. And then he noticed the fog floating in the air, originating from the closed door on the other side of the room.

It would've been too dark to see, but with the glow of Hitoshi's phone he could just vaguely make it out.

"Something feels weird," Hitoshi mumbled softly, alarm evident in his tone. "Doesn't it?"

Izuku nodded, feeling the sting of his eyes worsen as he took a deep breath. He paid it no mind. Hitoshi cast another look around the room, seeming to notice the fog as well. "We should get Dadzawa," He started to say, but Izuku suddenly *couldn't breathe.*

He tried to suck in oxygen, but his throat was *burning* along with an iron taste in his mouth. He got to his feet, ignoring the tears that sprung to his eyes.

He suddenly remembered the warning that the demon had given him. Something about light and dark. Poison. *Of course!*

He needed to get out. It had to be the fog. It had to be poisonous.

Izuku coughed, the sound slicing through the silence. And once he started to cough he couldn't stop.

Izuku couldn't even get a breath in between, and he vaguely registered that people were stirring around him. He hardly heard Hitoshi asking him what was wrong. He needed *air*. He scrambled to his feet and swung the door open, grabbing his sword on the way out.

He stumbled blindly down the hallway, through the thickening fog. A copper taste made itself known in the back of his throat. The air was burning him.

"Izuku? What's wrong?" Everything was so distant, but he could recognize dad's voice anywhere. He had somehow stumbled into Shouta's door, and his dad had opened it at some point.

The copper taste at the back of his throat increased until blood rushed up to his throat. He was coughing it up before he could think of covering his mouth.

Dabi was grabbing him by the shoulders, shouting something. His ears were filled with static, and everything was burning. His chest, his eyes, his throat. The air was poisonous. But it was only poisonous to him, seeing as Hitoshi had been completely fine.

Everything around him was a blur of dark colors and words that didn't quite reach him. The night air was crisp and cool around him which was his only indication that he'd even made it outside. At some point, he had squeezed his eyes shut, so he opened them hurriedly.

Dabi was holding his shoulders in an iron-tight hold, and Shouta was kneeling in front of him. Izuku hacked up the rest of the blood that was stuck in the back of his throat and took a few much-needed breaths of fresh air.

"What happened?" Shouta asked, just as Kirishima fearfully pointed toward the forest a few paces ahead.

"Uh, sensei is the forest on *fire?"* Kirishima asked, and Shouta whipped around to investigate.

Indeed there was a plume of smoke floating upwards from the forest. Izuku couldn't exactly see the fire itself, and the black cloud against the night sky was easy to miss so he had to squint to make it out but it was definitely there.

"Shit!" Shouta exclaimed, "Where are the Pussy Cat's and Vlad?"

No one had an answer. The only ones who even made it out of the building were Shouta and all of Class 1-A. Class 1-B and all the instructors were still inside, right?

Without warning, Izuku turned around back towards the building. Dabi yanked on his collar and snapped, "You're *not* going back in there!"

"I'll go—" Kacchan had started to say, but before he could even take a step forward the building exploded.

The ground shook with the force of it, and Izuku's ears were ringing like Kacchan had set an explosion off too close to his ears again. The building itself had splintered off into millions of pieces, raining debris everywhere. Kirishima and Todoroki were fast enough to block the biggest and therefore deadliest pieces of debris.

Izuku stared at the building in dawning horror. *Class 1-B* had been in there! Vlad King and all of the Pussycats. Even Kota…

His stomach sunk to the ground. His chest was heavy and aching as if he'd been stabbed.

"What…" Denki began slowly, and softly as if none of this could possibly be real. "What just happened…?"

"The building exploded," Jirou said, her voice firm. "But no one was inside. I didn't hear any heartbeats at all since I woke up,"

Izuku released the breath he hadn't realized he'd been holding this entire time.

"That's right little kiddos!" a deep, playful voice rumbled from the forest behind them. "Class 1-B and all the teachers aren't there anymore! We decided to play a game, isn't that *fun?"*

"A game?" Dabi echoed, pushing Izuku behind him and out of sight of the villain that was creeping closer. The villain didn't look all that intimidating if one were comparing this guy to All for One. He was blonde and extremely muscular with a mask covering his face.

However, the villain's Izuku felt like he needed to worry about *more* than the blonde guy, were the guys falling in behind him.

The Priest and a woman that Todoroki seemed to instantly recognize. "Black Widow," He growled.

"Son of Endeavor," Black Widow called, her voice both sultry and cold at the same time. "It's nice to finally get a rematch against you,"

Shouta leaped into action, his glare more murderous than Izuku had ever seen. His grip on his capture weapon was so tight that his knuckles were bloodless and white as he strode forward.

"There won't *be* a rematch," Shouta snapped, his voice cold and without room for argument. His eyes flashed red, eyes no doubt flickering between the three villains.

"Are you *sure?"* The Priest asked, "You aren't very good at protecting your kids, Eraserhead. Remember last time?"

Izuku flinched. The Sports Festival was unfortunately still a subject of a lot of his nightmares, even more than Hosu. It haunted him the way a ghost would haunt an empty house. Suddenly the poisonous air made a hell of a lot more sense. The Priest smiled in his direction and Dabi *growled.*

Kacchan lurched forward as if to attack but Kirishima held him back, his eyes wide with fear. Izuku was too scared to move and stop Kacchan himself so he was grateful.

"Listen here Class 1-A," Muscular said, drawing everyone's attention. "The game we're playing tonight is hide and seek! Isn't that fun?! Black Widow, scatter them!"

Shouta didn't have time to react as both the Preist and Black Widow moved in tandem. The woman hid behind Muscular, and the Preist rushed forward. Shouta's capture weapon wrapped around him slammed the Preist into the ground just as Black Widow's webs shot out and wrapped around all of Class 1-A.

Some of them were able to break the thread, such as Kacchan and Todoroki. Others, like Izuku himself, were caught off guard and stuck to the threads. Dabi shouted in alarm, and Kacchan reached desperately for him but to no avail. Izuku was flying high through the air before anyone could do anything.

"You'll join the Class 1-B and your teachers in the fun too!" Muscular yelled, cracking his knuckles. "Let's see who survives the game!"

Izuku was too busy crashing through trees, desperately holding his sword in a way that wouldn't end up stabbing him. He landed roughly on the ground, scraping his knees in the process. He scrambled to his feet and scanned his surroundings for villains.

He pushed away the feeling of dread and terrifying familiarity. This was just like the Sports Festival, through and through. Sure, the situations were slightly different and this time it wasn't a *show.* Nevertheless, he couldn't get the image of his wounded classmates out of his head. He couldn't get rid of the sound of his own grating screams echoing in his head.

Izuku's chest shuddered with each hurried breath he took. There was no one near him, but he still felt as if there were eyes on him. Weighing him down, waiting for the perfect moment to pounce.

This was another one of All for One's attempts to bring him back.

This was probably the best one yet, considering they were so far from any help whatsoever. He wasn't sure when help would arrive *if* it ever did. He tightened his grip on his katana and stalked forward.

"Izuku,"

Izuku jumped out of his skin, whipping around toward the voice only to find that Dabi had summoned himself to his side. He let out a short sigh and willed his heart to stop beating so wildly in his chest.

"It has to be the League coming after us again," Dabi mumbled more to himself than to Izuku. "But there's no help coming this time,"

Izuku glared and swatted at him. Dabi squinted at him and rubbed his arm. "What was that for?!"

[Help will come.]

He was lying. They both knew that, but it was better than facing the truth that they probably weren't going to make it out of this one. Unless the Pussycat's, Vlad King, Shouta, and all of his classmates defeated the villains. Which didn't really seem all that viable considering how organized they were, just like last time.

They continued on for a while until something dropped from the trees right in front of them.

At some point, half and half bastard and him ended up far away from Aizawa-sensei. The damn idiot named Muscular and the stupid slutty-looking Spiderwoman had taken their fight

away probably because they didn't want Aizawa-sensei interrupting, so of course, they ended up on the ledge of a cliff.

Katsuki was busy dodging fists and webs alike. Half-and-half was angry, throwing his fire around as if the forest around them wasn't already in flames.

"Come on kid, just let me get one hit in on you!"

Admittedly Katsuki had been lucky during this fight. He had been narrowly dodging everything this entire time, but the space he had was slowly getting smaller and smaller with all the ice that Todoroki was making to block the webs.

Not to mention how they kept bumping into each other. It was a mess with such limited space. The ledge of the cliff was cramped with all four of them fighting at the same time.

"Like hell I'll let you hit me, Buff Bitch!" Katsuki exclaimed and bared his teeth. He gave half-and-half a side glance to judge how he was faring in his own fight. He seemed to be at a stalemate with Spider Slut. Muscular screeched, and shot himself forward, his arms tucked in and prepared to finally land a solid punch on him.

Katsuki didn't notice his advance because he was too distracted with keeping tabs on Half-and-half bastard. It was his first mistake, and a costly one.

Pain exploded where Muscular made contact in his abdomen. The pure force of the punch itself had him flying backward at a terrifying speed until he slammed back-first into the face of the cliff. Its sharp edges dug painfully into his back, and all the air in his lungs left him.

For a moment he was disoriented, unsure if the sky was up or down. It took him a few precious, dangerous seconds to finally be able to breathe. In those seconds Muscular laughed as he cracked his knuckles, and Todoroki whipped around in alarm.

As soon as he could breathe he retched a stream of vomit. He groaned wiping at the corner of his mouth as he got to his feet again. He wiped away the sweat on his forehead only to realize that it wasn't sweat when his hand came back bloody and warm.

Fire-and-Ice was still staring at him with wide eyes. "Focus on your own damn fight, Hot Pocket!"

Todoroki heard him and turned his attention back to the spider lady. He glared at Muscular.

He wasn't going to lose. He wasn't going to let Muscular beat him to a pulp without fighting tooth and nail to deliver the same beating back onto him. All Muscular could do was enhance his own muscles until they burst from his skin.

But that was kind of the problem. In terms of strength, Muscular was objectively stronger than him. Katsuki had his explosions to aid him, but that meant almost nothing if he could never land a hit on the guy without being thrown around like a ragdoll.

Muscular was surprisingly fast.

So he needed to find a weakness. Something to exploit so he could win. He scanned Muscular up and down, before zeroing in on the mask on his face. There were many reasons why someone would wear a mask.

One was that the person didn't want people to recognize them, but that didn't add up considering Muscular's Quirk and villain name was out in the open. Two was that he had a strange mutation from his Quirk. Or three, he had something to hide under there other than a mutation, like a *weakness*.

There was also the possibility that the mask was just a natural part of him too, but Katsuki wouldn't know until he took it off.

He raced forward and Muscular rushed to meet him halfway. Katsuki had already expected it because Muscular seemed like the rash type that would rush into anything. So he was ready for the fist that came his way, but even though he was ready he still got punched. But unlike last time, he grabbed Muscular's fist, determined to make the most of his chance. He blasted Muscular's face with the strongest explosion he could muster.

This was about survival. Not detaining villains anymore.

Even if they didn't have permission to technically fight right now, it didn't matter anymore.

The mask on Muscular's face came flying off in millions of tiny pieces. And just like Katsuki had guessed, there was a glaring weakness. One of his eyes was a prosthetic. Or a robotic eye, who fucking knew these days with all the technology they were capable of making with Quirks now. Katsuki didn't give a fuck.

He lunged forward and viciously dug his fingers into that eye, taking advantage of Muscular's momentary surprise. He grimaced as his fingers grappled around the metal in his eye socket.

Muscular *howled* in pain and tried to throw Katsuki off of him, but he had long since wrapped one of his arms around the man's thick arm and stabilized himself on Muscular's shoulders.

That was until Muscular had a burst of strength, and Katsuki felt his wrist—that had just grabbed a hold of the metal mechanism in Muscular's eye—snap. They were both screeching in pain, and tearing viciously at each other, but despite the pain in his stomach, in his wrist, and the throbbing in his head he yanked the fucking eye out.

It was at that moment that Muscular threw him off the cliff. He was free-falling towards his death, and with only one hand to fire off explosions he wouldn't be able to fly himself upward and out of harm's way. Not this time.

But then there was high-pitched screaming, and a hand reaching out to yank him onto a bridge of ice.

“Bakugou!” Todoroki yelled, voice thin and shrill. “Are you okay? Do you *know* how angry Midoriya will be if you get hurt?!”

Katsuki scoffed. “You caught me so what’s the big deal, Icy Hot?! Anyway, how did you find the time to catch me?! What about Spider Slut and Mr. Muscle Man?! HAH?!”

Okay so maybe he was being aggressive. Half and half *did* just save him.

“See for yourself,” Todoroki grumbled, annoyed.

Katsuki looked over to the cliff. Muscular was screaming, with a chunk of ice in his face. Particularly, in his good eye rendering him completely blind.

Spider Slut wasn’t defeated yet. She broke through the cage of ice Todoroki had made.

“Damn,” Katsuki mumbled, “Maybe you’re cooler than I thought,”

Todoroki furrowed his brows in confusion. “Was that a pun?”

“Whatever,” Katsuki said, pointing at Spiderwoman. “Let’s just kick her fucking ass and figure out what the *fuck* is happening!”

Chapter End Notes

as always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 85

Chapter Summary

Todoroki and Bakugou fight some villains! Izuku acquires a child, and some of Class 1-B enter fights of their own <3

Chapter Notes

Me? Updating on time? More likely than you think lmao

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Todoroki let them down on the ledge of the cliff again, puffing out a breath of white. Katsuki swiped at the sweat—actually sweat this time—off his forehead. The both of them glared at Spider lady, or whatever her stupid villain name was, and she glared back. Just as fierce. With just as much fire.

Good. Katsuki had been itching to fight the villains who hurt his friends during the Sports Festival.

“How’s your wrist?” Todoroki asked, face grim and covered in patches of ice. He would probably start using his fire soon to warm himself up. Katsuki mentally recalled all the injuries he’d gotten so far.

His head was throbbing, from when he’d been thrown into the rock wall. His stomach ached but not as much as his hand and wrist, which he noticed was swollen.

“Fine for now. I won’t die,”

“But what about your explosions?” Todoroki asked, dodging a sting of web shot his way.

“I can fight with one arm if I have to,” Katsuki bit out, thinking only of Izuku who was out there. Alone. With villains after him. “We have to find Izuku. He’s all alone,”

“He has Touya,” Todoroki replied softly, and Katsuki whipped his head to the left to look at his face. He was smiling, but just a bit. He opened his mouth to say something, something along the lines of *‘How come you haven’t spoken to Dabi yet?’* but Todoroki was already speaking again. “Let’s focus on her first,”

Half and half was right of course. To get to Izuku they needed to defeat this bitch first.

“What’re we sitting around for then?” Katsuki asked, side-stepping the woman’s poor excuse of an attack. Another string of web. She was toying with them. Waiting for the fight to begin she wanted a rematch with Todoroki, and knocking them out while they talked didn’t seem to be her style.

Katsuki would’ve been ready for it anyway if she tried doing that. But that would be stupid of her, with two fire-related Quirks against her. Especially since her webs couldn’t hold up against fire.

This bitch was going to *burn* for thinking that she could hurt Class 1-A *again.*

“Are you two finally ready?” She asked, picking off dirt that was on her clothes. “I’m getting tired of waiting,”

Todoroki raced forward without a word, ice cracking and fire burning. He didn’t seem to notice that both sides had activated at the same time, but Katsuki did and he was staring at him wide-eyed.

Then he smiled and rushed to join half and half. Spider lady dodged with grace, almost liquid in her movements. Sadly for her, Katsuki was an expert in hand to hand.

He landed a solid punch on her jaw with his good hand, and her head whipped to the side. Todoroki took this time to kick her in the stomach, ice encasing his entire foot. She staggered, one hand clutching where Todoroki had kicked her. She smiled.

Webs burst from her free hand, spilling everywhere in their close proximity. Katsuki blasted away the nearest ones that tried to stick to him, and Todoroki did the same with his own fire.

More webs shot at them. More fire in response.

Soon enough Katsuki was sick of this game, blasting away webs and getting nowhere because new webs replaced them just a second later. He wasn't fast enough with just one hand, but he couldn't use both after his fight with Muscular.

He was blasting away another web when something cold was pressed against his neck. Something metal.

Spider lady laughed coldly in his ear, and Todoroki froze. Eyes wide, once he realized that She carried more weapons than just her webs. Shit. A dagger could just as easily kill as any Quirk could.

"Don't move, or your friend dies," She said, and Katsuki could hear the smile in her voice. The excitement that she had both of them right where she wanted. Under her control. Beneath her thumb. Killable.

Katsuki didn't dare breathe too loud, or swallow. Todoroki had long since put his hands up in surrender, watching Katsuki with cold fury on his face. This wasn't supposed to be how he died, Katsuki realized. Blood trickled down his neck, as Spider lady pressed her dagger harder.

He had been planning on being a hero first.

He had so many things he'd wanted to do. Protect Izuku, even though he seemed to be shit at it. He'd wanted to confess. To tell him that he loved him. That Izuku was the only thing that truly mattered to him. The world of Heroes could rot for all he cared, but god forbid if someone laid another fucking cruel *hand* on Izuku.

That dagger against his throat seemed rather intent on ending all of that though. He should move. He should explode this lady's hand off, but moving would probably set her off.

It's funny how time slows down when you know you're going to die.

He'd felt this way at the Sports Festival too. Izuku had been there, broken and bloody. He had a gun pressed against his temple, in a forest much like this one. A regular person would be stricken with panic, remembering the stark similarities in these two situations.

But in that moment Katsuki wasn't afraid for himself. He had been afraid of Izuku and that overrode any kind of fear that he'd probably felt towards himself.

This fear was different from the Sports Festival. This was death staring him in the face, and Izuku wasn't here to distract him. There was a flash of movement and Katsuki braced himself for death.

Something heavy and cold was on his shoulders suddenly, and around his neck. The pain never came.

"...Protect…"

A shadowy hand was wrapped around the blade, pushing it away from his throat. Spider slut grunted, trying her hardest to slit his throat. The demon wrapped around Katsuki's shoulders and neck growled.

Katsuki was quick to take advantage of whatever Izuku had done—it had to be him, there was no other explanation—and wrenched the weapon away from her. He threw it as hard as

he could, and it fell over the edge of the cliff. The demon launched itself from Katsuki's shoulders at Spider woman. Her eyes were wide with shock and terror.

Sweat covered her face, and her hands were trembling so much, Katsuki wondered if the demon did something to them.

She *screamed* when the demon landed on her shoulders. It wasn't as big as some of the ones Katsuki had seen before. For one, this one was missing both legs. It was just a torso, arms and a head. It screamed with her, as it tore at her.

"Should we…" Todoroki began, rushing to his side, worry written across his face. "Should we stop it?"

"I don't think we can," Katsuki replied, as the demon slammed the woman's head into the ground once. Twice. And then she stopped moving, hopefully unconscious. The demon looked around then, before its white eyes locked onto Katsuki.

It started dragging itself toward him. Long shadowy claws digging into the dirt, reaching for him.

"You… protect… you," It said, around a mouthful of teeth. ***"He wants me… to protect… you,"***

"Izuku?" Katsuki asked because it was the only answer. The demon nodded before vanishing in a puff of smoke. He stared at where it disappeared, and Todoroki went over and crouched next to the spot.

"That was weird," He said, before straightening. He went over to Spider lady and Muscle Head, restraining their hands with ice. "Okay, let's go."

Izuku nearly jumped into Dabi in pure fright as *Kota* fell from the tree he'd been hiding in. He thought it was a villain at first. Inko, Hisashi, All for One. Any of them but he never would've expected Kota.

Relief washed through him and he clutched his chest. "Oh! The kid!" Dabi exclaimed, pointing as if Izuku was completely blind in the dark. Which he *wasn't.* "Glad you're safe kiddo,"

Kota burst into tears immediately after Dabi spoke and ran up to him. Izuku could see the shift of emotions on his face and the change in his body language, the way he went from battle-ready to soft in one second. Izuku had seen it a million times, that soft expression, after a nightmare that left him screaming.

Dabi scooped Kota up in his arms and grinned. "We'll get you out of here, okay? We just need… to figure out where we are first…"

Yeah. That sounded like a great start, but all the trees here looked the same, one after another. The shadow of the Sports Festival was still hanging over him, heavier than ever. A forest. No help. Villains like cockroaches, infesting everything and hiding everywhere.

He was scared. He was *terrified* . He might just die. But he wasn't helpless. He wouldn't go down without fighting tooth and nail to live. This fear was temporary and didn't define him as weak.

To fight despite the fear was courage. That was what a hero did. It was a hero's job to smile even though fear was eating you up on the inside. Izuku reached for the moon necklace at his throat, just above his Quirk suppressor.

Kacchan was fighting too. He was probably scared too. Izuku drew on Kacchan's strength, hoping that one he'd be just as strong. He had to protect Kota and himself and he wasn't going to fail.

He told himself that he wasn't the same kid he was when All for One wanted him to spy on Yuuei.

Izuku was much stronger now. He wasn't just a tool and a punching bag anymore and he was determined to prove that to himself. By saving Kota. By saving his classmates, if they needed saving. By saving *himself* too. Which was something he kept pushing back every time it mattered the most.

At the USJ he had prioritized his classmates. The Sports Festival was a crueler iteration. The Hosu incident was probably the only incident where he actively saved himself.

He had been scared of dying, but saving himself had never been on the list of to-do's in situations like this. Not until recently.

He had always been strong enough to save himself *and* everyone else. He just went about it the wrong way. Izuku was sure he could get it right this time.

"What's with all this weird fog?" Dabi suddenly asked, cutting off Izuku's train of thought. He glanced around and also noticed the strange purple fog.

He almost leaned down to inspect it when someone shouted, "Don't breathe it in!"

Kendo. From Class 1-B. He straightened instantly looking around for her. For a second he could only see the trees and bushes from earlier but then she came out into the small clearing they were standing in.

She was carrying Juzo, another member of 1-B. Trailing behind her was Yui, and Tetsutetsu who was carrying Shiozaki. All of them were wearing masks, so he knew that this fog was probably dangerous to breathe in.

"What is it?" Kota asked fearfully, clinging onto Dabi for dear life.

"Where'd you get those masks?" Dabi asked.

“The fog knocks you unconscious, so wear one of these!” Kendo exclaimed, handing them each a mask of their own. Even Dabi got one. “Yaoyorozu gave them to us!”

Izuku hastily put his on. “I’m going to find the stupid villain that’s doing this!” Tetsutetsu said, pumping his fist in the air with a look of determination. To prove himself. To keep his classmates safe.

“What?!” Kendo replied, “It’s not safe! We should just look for our classmates and retreat!”

“Our classmates could be anywhere,” Tetsutetsu said, “We were all scattered around by that weird portal man,”

Kurogiri was here? He and Dabi shared a look, and Izuku couldn’t decide if this was a good thing or not.

Kurogiri was part of what was left of the Roses. Stain’s followers. So far he couldn't manage to do much for him, in terms of keeping him safe because of the villain he worked for. Izuku knew he was a potential ally even if he didn’t trust him that much, and his presence here meant that this attack was something beyond a run of the mill villain attack.

If he knew anything about the League, it was that All for One wanted him back. It had been his motivation since the USJ and it wouldn’t change unless he got what he wanted. And Izuku intended to make it *very* difficult.

“It’s not like we have permission to fight anyway,” Kendo continued, her expression giving away her anxiety. “We’ll get into trouble,”

“Does that really matter right now?” Dabi asked, “This is a life or death situation here.”

“Fair point,” She replied, turning to Yui. “I can’t let Tetsutetsu go alone… could you watch over Shiozaki and Juzo?”

Yui nodded. Izuku raised his hands to sign that he could help them, or at least watch over their friends but Kendo held up a hand. “Midoriya, you need to find the teachers and stay away from the villains. You’ve been targeted too often for it to be a coincidence that they’re here now,” He furrowed his brow and clenched his hands. “I know you want to help but it’s too dangerous,”

He could understand where Kendo was coming from. She was right but that didn’t mean he was going to listen. [I can help.] He signed anyway. [Kota can put out the fires that the villains made so we can all get out of here. Someone needs to protect him.]

Kendo looked conflicted. Honestly, they all did, concern written across each of their faces.

[I’m doing it.] He signed. [Good luck everyone.]

“Be careful,” Tetsutetsu said, “And if you see any villains you gotta retreat, okay?”

Izuku nodded, even though he never had any intention of retreating. At best he’d have Dabi run away with Kota. All of them broke out into different directions. Kendo and Tetsutetsu walked deeper into the fog, and Izuku headed towards where he’d seen the smoke.

They traveled silently, extra careful not to alert their presence to any villains that could be nearby. Kota was quiet too, seeming to catch on.

After a while they found the fire, and Dabi set Kota down. “You think you can do this Kota?” He asked, “It’s okay if you can’t,”

Kota looked between the two of them. His cheeks were covered in dirt and scratches from when he’d fallen out of that tree. Tear tracks were easy to see, as it cut through the grime on his face.

He looked down at his hands and nodded. Izuku realized he probably should've asked ahead of time if what kind of water Quirk he had, and if he was even willing to use it but they were pressed for time.

It turned out that Kota's Quirk was *perfect* for the job. He could shoot water out of hands, and it put the fire out quickly. It wasn't fair of Izuku to ask Kota to do this since he was a kid, and he felt bad about it.

But when Kota turned to him, beaming when he finished, Izuku smiled back. [Are you sure you dislike heroes?]

Dabi spoke for him. Kota's expression darkened.

"I do, but if I can help then I'm going to," Kota replied, crossing his arms. "I can hate you all I want later when we get outta here,"

"Sure kiddo," Dabi said with a smirk. "Let's go find Aizawa now, okay? You did amazing,"

Kota blushed at that, and turned his nose up at him when Dabi went to pick him up again. A slow clap behind them had all three of them whipping around to see who it was.

Hisashi. Of course. Why wouldn't it be him? His hold on his sword tightened.

"Izuku," He said, "You're coming with me. This time I won't fail,"

Izuku instantly went to shield Kota from Hisashi's view. His hands were shaking. He would never be able to forget the pain. The way his body seized up whenever Hiashi used his Quirk. He would never forget the fear, but he wouldn't let it control him tonight.

Izuku shifted into his fighting stance and he glanced at Dabi. He knew the drill already. *Take Kota and run. Find the teachers.*

"Oh?" Hiashi laughed. A hearty laugh. "Are you going to *fight* me?"

He gave Hisashi his most terrifying smile as Dabi turned tail and ran.

"Everyone in Class A and B!" Mandalay exclaimed, using her telepathy to communicate with all the students. ***"In the name of pro hero, Vlad King, you are granted permission to engage in combat! I repeat everyone in Class A and B! In the name of pro hero, Vlad King, you are granted permission to engage in combat!"***

"We have discovered one of the villains' targets. It is one of the students—Izuku Midoriya. Midoriya should try to avoid combat and acting independently!"

Tetsutetsu was charging right in just like Itsuka had expected. Which was *terrifying* because they had no idea what to expect if they actually came face to face with the villain creating all the gas.

"Did you hear that Kendo? We got permission to throw some punches!" Tetsutetsu exclaimed as they ran deeper into the fog.

There was one thing that rubbed Itsuka the wrong way about Mandalay's message. First, she mentioned Izuku as the main target of the villains, and Itsuka had *just* watched him walk out of her sight. Worry gripped her, and she almost wanted to turn around and look for him but she knew that Tetsutetsu would need assistance taking down the fog villain.

Secondly, Mandalay hadn't said a thing about the gas. She told Tetsutetsu as much. "That means it hasn't spread that far," She explained when Tetsutetsu gave her a look of confusion. "It's weird."

She gestured around them, "The gas is flowing slowly in one direction. Normally it would spread out more, right? But this gas is staying in a specific area and its denser here than it was farther back,"

"Which means?"

"I think the gas is swirling around the source, or the villain who is controlling it," She continued on and Tetsutetsu's eyes went wide.

"Damn you're so smart Kendo!" He exclaimed.

"But the denser the gas, the shorter the functioning time for these masks," She mumbled, touching her own mask. "So we have to do this quickly—"

"Let's do our best Kendo!" Tetsutetsu exclaimed. "Midoriya and the others are probably trying their best too!"

"Are you going to kill me?" The Priest asked, a faint smile pulling at the corners of his mouth. "That wouldn't be very heroic of you, Eraserhead,"

Shouta *never* wanted to kill a villain. He could hardly bear the thought that one day he might, and cut someone's life short. It was something that haunted him as an Underground Hero because most times, when a villain died it was because there was no other choice.

But tonight he would make an exception. The knife in his back pocket was heavy with that promise.

Chapter End Notes

as always:

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 86

Chapter Summary

> Ahem, the part everyone's been waiting for: Aizawa fighting the priest, and Izuku beating the shit out of his sperm donor of a bio-dad <3

Chapter Notes

> I'm gonna stop apologizing for not updating and finally just write the overhaul arc I promise!!!! T^T

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Ochako spotted Toga Himiko sitting in the tree above them twirling her knife, she froze. She grabbed Tsu by her shoulder and yanked her backward.

“What is it, Ochako-chan?” Tsu asked, unaware of the danger in front of her.

Ochako didn’t dare to take her eyes off of Toga for a second. Instead, she pointed at her and replied shakily. “Look! Up in the tree!”

Toga kept twirling her knife expertly between her fingers, with that slightly unhinged smile she always wore. Strangely enough, she didn’t move from her perch. She just watched both Tsu and Ochako for an uncomfortable while, seeing as neither party moved.

“Your blood is probably *very* pretty,” She said as she tilted her head to the left, twin buns bouncing ever-so-slightly.

No one spoke for a second.

“There’s twelve of us,” Toga continued, almost conversationally. “Our mission is to kidnap Izuku. Which… is against everything Stain wanted. Tell them that Izu-chan shouldn’t be out here alone. Tell them that the League is after him,”

Ochako took a cautionary step back. “Why’re you telling us this?” She asked, wincing when it came out shaky and uneven. “What’s in it for you? You just attacked us during the Sports Festival!”

Toga shifted on her branch, grip tightening on her knife. Her face twisted with guilt and frustration. “Kurogiri wouldn’t let us help,” She spat, knuckles going white. “He said we needed to play our part until it was the right time. *Now* is that time. It’s really unfortunate that I won’t get to taste your yummy blood, though,”

One second Toga was there, and then she was gone. Like she hadn’t been there in the first place. Ochako glanced around worriedly until Tsu tapped her shoulder. “She’s gone Ochako-chan, kero,”

“Do... Do you think everything she said was true?” Ochako asked, still scanning the trees for any sign of her.

Tsu nodded. “She didn’t attack us, and she has no reason to lie to us. Even if it *is* a lie we still need to warn the teachers,”

“You’re right,” She replied, biting harshly on her lower lip. “We need to find Mandalay,”

Shouta heard Mandalay’s Telepath as soon as he charged recklessly toward the Priest, but that didn’t make him stop. If anything it made him even more desperate than he already was to end the fight and find Izuku and Hitoshi.

He wasn’t going to fail again. He had failed as a hero and as a *father* at every corner.

It was honestly grating on him the number of times he'd failed his kids. He was determined to even the score this time around.

The Priest didn't even blink at his Quirk suddenly being erased. He hardly even flinched when Shouta's capture whipped toward him, reaching like living snakes toward him in a vain attempt to restrain him. Shouta knew it wouldn't be that easy.

The Priest ducked and weaved between the strands of his capture weapon, moonlight glinting off the blade the man had suddenly drawn.

He tried to cut through Shouta's capture weapon, but fortunately, his scarf was made to withstand someone trying to slice through it with a knife. That only gave the Priest one option, and that was to focus all his energy on dodging the capture weapon and trying to get a good hit in.

Shouta stepped back just in time to avoid a knife in his throat. A flash of metal was the only warning the Priest gave as Shouta's eyes began to sting from being open so long. He didn't blink. He couldn't let himself.

"C'mon Eraserhead!" The Priest yelled, knife cutting through the air wildly as he swung. His face was twisted with sick excitement and pure pleasure. "Where's all that rage from the Sports Festival!? Where's the promise of death that you had been spitting?!"

Shouta's jaw tightened as the Priest kept yelling. He didn't bother to listen anymore, most of it was the same statement over and over again anyway. The Priest's knife swung in a wide arc, and Shouta took the chance to disarm him by kicking his hand as hard as he possibly could.

It didn't matter what kind of grip the guy had on the knife, because Shouta's kicks were notoriously *strong*.

It went flying through the air and was lost in the underbrush. The Priest was smart and didn't run for his lost weapon. Instead, he drew his fist back and attempted to punch Shouta in the face. Probably so he would break the effect of Shouta's quirk. Which would've been smart if Shouta wasn't expecting it.

When the Priest's fist reached him, he grabbed and threw a punch of his own. It connected harshly with the villain's jaw. For some reason, it was gratifying to land a hit on the villain who *killed* his son.

He did it again before the Priest finally managed to tear away. The fight reset, and the Priest drew another weapon from *somewhere.* It was a gun this time.

It was as if time suddenly slowed down as he took aim. Shouta had a gun pointed at him many times within his Hero career and every time it happened he could recall how everything seemed to freeze.

Cold calm settled over him, as he lunged forward to close the distance between them. He needed to either disarm him immediately or grab him by the wrist and force him to shoot away from him. He couldn't afford a bullet wound right now. He couldn't afford *any* injuries. His kids could be hurt right now. They could be *dead.*

The gun went flying, and that was when Shouta realized how loose the Priest's grip had been.

The stabbing pain in his shoulder came a second late, as the Preist laughed too close for Shouta's comfort. The world tilted swiftly as his legs were knocked out from under him. There was a glint of light off metal, and Shouta completely relied on his instincts to dodge the blade before it could break his skin.

"I thought you were going to kill me Eraserhead!" The man shouted, eyes too wide, and smile too harsh. Shouta's eyes were burning. Aching. Stinging. He needed to end this.

Everything was happening fast. Too fast, as another blade sliced his torso. Shouta didn't think as he grabbed blindly for anything, as the Preist's weight pressed him bodily to the ground. There was only cold metal in his hand and then there was a gunshot ringing through the air.

Blood splattered, and it wasn't his own.

Hitoshi would usually say that his insomnia was the reason he hated the night, but that was *before* they had all been thrown about a forest in the dead of night with villains everywhere.

If he was being honest he hated the League. Not only were they fucking with his non-existent sleep schedule, but they were also fucking with his classmates. Which honestly, they did *way* too often. All for One really needed to pick up a hobby or something other than torturing kids because it was getting really old, really quickly.

It was a rehashing of the USJ, again and again. Which was how he found himself stuck with *Monoma* of all people and Yaoyorozu. Which wouldn't be such a bad match-up if Monoma was *anywhere else.*

But he was willing to admit that having Monoma copy his quirk and catch the villains unawares was a *great* plan. The three of them had captured a dude named Moonfish—that's what Yaoyorozu said his name was anyway—and just barely managed to run into one of the 1-B kids that could attach stuff to things.

Well, that was a vague explanation of the dude's quirk, but Yaoyorozu used it to her advantage to ask Awase to weld a tracking device to a Chainsaw Nomu.

After that entire fiasco, they just wandered. There really wasn't much else to do considering that where they'd been staying was blown to bits and they still didn't know where their classmates were.

"Vlad-sensei and the Pussycats were fighting a lizard man and someone name Mange," Awase supplied once they had all managed to escape the Chainsaw Nomu. "Should we go to them?"

Hitoshi was just about to say no, when Monoma spoke up.

"The villains are after Midoriya," he said, pointedly not looking at any of them. "The most logical thing to do is find him and *then* find our teachers,"

"Those are some words, coming out of *your* mouth," Hitoshi grumbled. He tried to tone down his irritation, he really did. Not even a day ago Monoma was bitching about how scary his brother was. It didn't work. His face was hot with anger, and his fists were clenched at his sides as his words came out harsher than he intended.

Sharp and seething.

"I'll admit…" Monoma replied as they transversed deeper into the forest. Towards where the fires had been. "I've said shitty things, *really* shitty things about Midoriya but now isn't the time to fuck around!"

Hitoshi scowled. Of course, Monoma was right. His stupid character development could wait until this was all over and they were back at Yuuei. Hitoshi could punch him later.

"He's right Shinsou-kun," Yaoyorozu added, urgency obvious in her tone. "What's more important right now is to find Midoriya and neutralize any villains we come across,"

"I know that!" Hitoshi replied, and he *knew* he was bordering on hysterical. But he couldn't help but feel as if the world was off-kilter and falling apart. His brother was the target of villains, which wasn't *new.*

But this was his family in danger. And he didn't even know where his dad was. Hitoshi hated the unknown almost as much as he hated sleepless nights. Everything was spinning out of control and he could hardly breathe past the all-consuming fear that he would be too late. That he would find his brother and father dead somewhere and *it would be his fault because he wasn't fast enough—*

“Shinsou,” His head snapped up in the direction of the voice that seemed to cut through the fog in his head. Yaoyorozu had put her hand on his shoulder. “Everything’s going to be alright. You know that right? For as much as we *all* worry about Midoriya, he’s strong. Probably the strongest out of all of us. And Aizawa-sensei has been a hero for years. If anyone is going to make it out of here safe it’s them.”

Hitoshi sucked in a trembling breath. “But—”

“You’re worried and I understand that Shinsou. But you need to breathe and we *need* to find Midoriya,” She added, putting her other hand on Hitoshi’s free shoulder. She made a show of taking a deep breath and letting it out. Hitoshi copied her for a few breaths until the trembling of his hands stopped.

He steeled himself. “I’m good. Thanks,”

Yaoyorozu shot him a warm smile. “It’s really no problem,”

He should be scared. Izuku should have run away for once while he had the option but he was frozen. Not with fear, but with *resolve* .

Hisashi and Inko had dominated his life thus far alongside All for One. They ruled with fear and pain, and Izuku had *finally* gotten a taste of kindness. He was determined to stay with his dads and Toshi.

He wouldn’t go back.

Hisashi stroked his chin with a growing smile. “This again?” He asked, smile widening. “There are no heroes waiting for you this time. I can take you and they can’t do shit about it.

Why even bother to fight?”

His knuckles were white with how tight his grip was. There were a number of reasons for him to fight Hisashi on this. It was the same song and dance as every time before. They were two different sides of the same coin. Hero. Villain.

They stared at eachother. For a second, neither of them moved. Hisashi seemed to be waiting for *him* to make the first move, and Izuku was all-too willing to comply. The air between them had gotten unbelievably tense in those seconds, and Izuku knew that if he was going to win this then he needed to be the one to initiate the fight.

He shot forward and Hisashi rushed to meet him just like he’d hoped.

But then Hisashi’s throat abruptly turned red and orange, and Izuku barely dodged in time and tucked his wings in to watch a stream of fire burst from Hisashi’s lips. A fire-breathing quirk. Of course All for One would give his right hand man a second quirk.

The stream of fire followed after his movements, setting the forest around them ablaze. Izuku dodged behind the nearest tree as another burst of fire spewed from Hisashi’s lips. He needed to come up with a plan. A strategy. Fast, before everything was burning.

He ducked behind a different tree, hyper-aware of roaring fire and Hisashi’s loud footsteps. Using his hell-fire here would probably only result in more fire. He could summon a few demons to surround and ambush him but Izuku wasn’t sure what other quirks Hisashi could have.

It really seemed to be his only option, though. His other options included being burned and he really didn’t want to deal with that on top of crazed villains searching for him.

He pressed his free hand against the nearest tree trunk, not trusting Hisashi not to attack him if he crouched. It was quicker to summon them this way, as the demons materialized beneath his hand.

Izuku didn't need to give them exact orders. They seemed to already know the drill, as they circled around their target. Hisashi was adnvacing on him. He could hear his footfalls that were too loud—stepping on leaves that crunched beneath his feet. The snapping of twigs underfoot—Izuku counted each step.

The man crept closer, and Izuku waited, holding his breath. As long as he dodged the fire and dodged Hisashi's hands the man couldn't get a single hit in. He told himself that this plan would work, that the demons would restrain him and Izuku could knock him out.

There didn't need to be any blood split in this fight. Hisashi was closer now, and Izuku shifted to hide behind another tree, farther away as the demons finally got into position.

For a moment all he could hear was Hisashi's footsteps and an angry exclamation of "I know you're around here somewhere! Where the hell did you go?!"

And then the demons pounced from their hiding places and Izuku revealed himself as well once he was sure that his sperm donor had been restrained. All his lud grumbling and curses really gave it away.

Had no one trained Hisashi in stealth?

Izuku's hand was wrapped tightly around the hilt of his sword as he approached the spot where Hisashi had been. His former father was thrashing against the hold of the four demons Izuku had summoned for the job. His head was pressed to the ground, so he couldn't breathe fire unless he wanted to melt his own face off.

"You!" He snarled, seemingly so angry that he couldn't think of anything else to add. He pushed against the hands keeping his head down and managed to glare at Izuku. He flinched at the dark expression that flitted across Hisashi's face. Hisashi thrashed again, and fire burst from his mouth again, and Izuku jumped back in surprise.

The demons that had been holding him in place were gone in an instant when they had been consumed by the flames, and Izuku cursed himself for thinking that he could capture Hisashi so easily. Obviously there was no peaceful way of resolving this fight.

Fear reared its ugly head in his gut, but he pushed it back down frantically. He forced himself to focus on the fire suddenly burning around him rather than the ice-cold grip of terror.

Hisashi was going on a rampage again.

Fire streamed from his mouth in all directions, and it was then that Izuku realized he probably didn't have good control over his new quirk. It would've been advantageous for Izuku if Hisashi wasn't spewing *fire,* but whatever. He dodged a stream of fire skillfully, as he watched for an opening.

He had to end the fight even if he got burnt. When Hisashi stopped to catch his breath, Izuku raced forward. Hisashi coughed violently but still managed to dodge the swing of Izuku's katana. Smoke billowed out of Hisashi's mouth, but there were no flames. He must've overused the new quirk. Izuku didn't waste his chance, and tried again to land a hit.

Hisashi dodged again, but Izuku pivoted at the last minute to follow his movement. He only ripped part of Hisashi's shirt, instead of doing any real damage. He had jumped back hastily, and glared.

They raced toward each other again, but this time Hisashi took him by surprise and kicked his katana right out of his hand. They grappled at each other immediately, Izuku not even pausing to think about the pain that would come from Hisashi's palms. His fist cracked against Hisashi's jaw, as his other hand searched empty air for where his sword must've fallen.

Hisashi's hands seemed to glue themselves to any exposed skin that he could see, but Izuku's mind was full of static and desperation.

The pain and panic felt like it was happening on a different plane all together as Hisashi tackled him bodily to the ground.

“You’re coming back with us!” Hisashi yelled, a smile stretching at his lips. “This time I won’t fail!”

Izuku kicked him as hard as he could in the abdomen and Hisashi choked on his words as all the air in his lungs left him. Izuku scrambled to grab his weapon just as Hisashi fell over. He had just about wrapped his hand around the hilt when another stream of fire came from Hisashi.

He couldn’t move his hand away in time, and the fire hit the back of his hand. A strangled cry of pain broke past his lips as his hand instantly started to turn red and burn. He could already see patches of his skin turning a little white, and his hand shook even more as the stinging pain got worse and worse with each second.

That couldn’t be good. He tried his best to ignore the sweat beading on his brow, and trailing down his back. He tried to ignore the tensing of his muscles and the throbbing, stinging, pain of the burn on his hand.

Hisashi wiped at his chin and laughed. Cold. Grating on his ears.

“This is more like it,” Hisashi commented, walking closer. Izuku pressed his lips together and grabbed his sword with his good hand. Hisashi’s throat started to glow again, and Izuku was preparing himself to dodge and get in close, when blue flames caught his eye.

Dabi shot out a stream of fire at Hisashi just as the man was shooting one of his own. They cancelled eachother out.

“Sorry I’m late!” Dabi called, smiling like an idiot. “What did I miss?”

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed the two month late chapter--

<3

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 87

Chapter Summary

Coming at yall with Monoma redemption 5 months later :p

Chapter Notes

there's no excuse as to why I took so long to update to be honest... i've been unemployed for a long, long time now (being disabled and unable to drive makes it hard to figure out what hours I can actually work sdkgjsgasd) so one would expect that I would finish this fic faster. Man I thought so too :T idk what happened tbh. Lots of family members died while I was writing this fic over the years, so maybe that contributed to my depression T^T. Now though, we have a chapter count!!! <3 the final chapter count might change depending on the short extra chapters I write, but this fic should end with the cultural festival arc. Even better news is that I've finished the Overhaul arc and I've already started setting up for the cultural fest. Please enjoy! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku sighed in relief at Dabi's appearance. Hisashi looked angrier than before, which was a plus in his book.

Dabi and Hisashi went at it instantly, plumes of fire cancelling each other out again and again. Izuku jumped in too, getting a little more burnt in the process, but he needed to find his way out of this forest.

Hisashi was really not a match for the both of them, even with two quirks. Dabi was relentless with each wave of fire, and Hisashi could only manage to cancel out his attacks with his own fire. But he really should've trained with his new quirk more because he would cough and there would be a moment where he couldn't use his fire-breathing.

Izuku launched himself at Hisashi pushing past the pain and the panic of Hisashi's original quirk, and did the only thing he could think of to disable at least one of his quirks.

He raised his sword, heaving with the effort of their fight, and grabbed Hisashi's wrist with his free hand. Izuku didn't know if he should feel bad. He didn't know how he was supposed to feel at all about what he was about to do.

Hisashi had been the subject of many a nightmare, and he along with Inko forced him into villainy for a short amount of time. This was his biological father. And he was about to cut off one of his fingers.

He thrust his sword down. Hisashi shoved him as hard as he could with his free hand, and Izuku's aim faltered, missing Hisashi's finger by inches.

Dabi was moving instantly, and pinned Hisashi snarling, "Stop it!"

He pressed Hisashi's face away from both of them and Izuku took a shaking breath. His sword shook in his hands. He had to do this. He had to save himself and finally free himself. From the nightmares. From the pain and fear that prevented him from moving forward in a permanent way.

Hisashi was just the first step. Then Inko. Then All for One and he would be *free.* And then he could *breathe.*

"Izuku!" Dabi exclaimed as Hisashi roared beneath them, thrashing. "You have to do it now! We can't restrain him and there aren't any heroes coming to save us this time!"

Dabi was right. He swallowed thickly ignoring the screaming in his heart that this was a little too cruel. He cut his pointer finger off and moved onto the next with a sinking stomach. He reminded himself that Hisashi was a villain. He deserved this. He hurt him when he didn't deserve it.

He blocked out Hisashi's incoherent screaming. It was out of anger, not pain. He probably thought All for One could fix anything Izuku cut off, but Izuku wasn't planning on letting Hisashi out of this forest unless it was in police custody.

He cut off the second, ignoring the sympathy pain in his hands. Or maybe that was the burns.

Hisashi screamed louder this time, “You little *asshole!”* He screeched, thrashing harder. “You’ll pay for this! All for One won’t let you live for long once he has you!”

“Oh fuck this!” Dabi yelled back, before swiftly knocking Hisashi out with a well placed punch. *“Stay* down!”

Izuku sighed heavily and ran a hand down his face with the hand that wasn’t burnt. He crawled away from Hisashi and sat down nearby, just breathing. He defeated his biological father.

He *defeated him.* Dabi grinned at him. Izuku smiled shakily back. A wave of relief washed over him.

“Midoriya-kun?” a voice asked, and Izuku whipped around, sword clutched tightly in his hands. “Is that you?”

Yaoyorozu ventured from between the trees, and Izuku felt his entire body relax. Trailing behind her was Toshi, Monoma who he wasn’t sure how to feel about, and Awase. And then a few seconds later someone else burst through the trees with popping explosions and an ice-bridge.

Todoroki and Kacchan regarded Toshi and his group with surprise. “You guys are here too?” Todoroki asked.

“Yes, we saw the fire--”

“So did we--” Kacchan replied, as Monoma moved to the edge of the clearing to keep watch instead of interacting with them.

“We should probably tie up Hisashi?” Dabi said, drawing their attention again. “And we should probably stop the bleeding in his hands too, as much as I hate to say it,”

Yaoyorozu nodded grimly, before seeming to realize what Dabi had said. “Hisashi?”

“Yep!” Dabi exclaimed, “We took him down!”

“How?!” Toshi asked, with the same look of concern that Kacchan was suddenly wearing. Everyone rushed over to look at Hisashi in shock. All of them saw that the man was missing a finger on each hand and they looked back at him with varying expressions of concern and relief.

“You…” Kacchan began, eyes wide. “You beat him.”

Izuku nodded, and Kacchan crushed him in a quick hug, a soft whisper of, “I’m glad you’re safe,” on his lips.

“All for One gave him a fire breathing quirk so we need to cover his mouth with something,” Dabi added as Yaoyorozu quickly restrained Hisashi’s hands with rope. She nodded before creating tape and put it over Hisashi’s mouth to ensure that he couldn’t use his other quirk. She even wrapped up his fingers.

“Are you hurt Midoriya?” Yaoyorozu asked gently, glancing down at his hands. He nodded and held out his burned hand. She sucked in a breath. “I’ll try to wrap it as best as I can, if that’s okay? We’ll have to get you to Recovery Girl as soon as possible with burns that bad,”

Izuku nodded again and Yaoyorozu wrapped his hand and his other minor burns that he’d gotten at some point.

Kacchan looked one second away from kicking Hisashi in the face. Toshi just shook his head at him, whispering, “Later,”

“Okay!” Yaoyorozu exclaimed, helping Izuku to his feet. “Let’s go find Aizawa-sensei,”

Izuku passed Hisashi, who was pinned to a tree with rope tied around his torso, despite his hands already being tied behind his back.

As a group they walked through the forest and tried to avoid any of the villains that could’ve been lurking in wait for them. Kacchan had a tight grip on Izuku’s free hand, unwilling to let go. Dabi stood behind him, and Shinsou was on his other side, with Todoroki in front.

Awase, and Monoma were a little further back, and Yaoyorozu was leading them. For a while nothing happened and they didn’t even know if they were headed in the right direction. For all they knew they could be walking closer and closer to the villains waiting for them.

There was a creak above them, in the trees and they all looked up at once.

“Gotcha,” a voice called out, unfamiliar.

Izuku saw nothing for a moment except for the leaves above them, and then very suddenly everything around him vanished. The leaves. The sky. Kacchan’s hand in his own.

Everything went black.

Katsuki had never felt so stupid in his life. One second Izuku’s hand was in his own, and in the next some circus *weirdo* with a bunch of marbles was laughing at them. And Izuku was gone. The villain explained that he had nabbed him, and that Izuku was in the marble he was carrying.

“Give him back!” Half and half exclaimed, as the villain twirled the marble in his fingers.

The masked man chuckled. “You don’t *own* him,” He said, “The big boss wants him back, can’t imagine why,”

“Then let him go,” PonyTail said, trying to sound calm. It didn’t exactly work.

Shinsou looked unbelievably pale, and he opened his mouth to say something, but closed it a second later. Katsuki could relate.

Half and half, unlike the rest of them, didn’t hesitate to let out a glacier of ice in an attempt to trap the damn villain. Of course, after the dust cleared they all realized the villain had managed to dodge the attack.

He sent another wave of ice. And another when that one didn’t work. Katsuki took the chance to scale the ice and reach the villain, using explosions the rest of the way. He went for the man’s hand where the marble was. He wanted to explode the damn idiot for being ballsy enough to hurt Izuku, but he didn’t want to accidentally injure him in the process.

Katsuki was surprised when his hand wrapped around the marble with no resistance.

“Oh, you thought that one was the right one?” The masked man asked, showing off the multitude of marbles suddenly in his hands. “That’s cute,”

“Hey!” Shinsou exclaimed, and the mask villain snapped his mouth shut.

“He knows what your quirk is…” Monoma mumbled, loud enough for Katsuki to hear as he grabbed wildly for one of Compress’s hands.

“Of course I do! We all watch the Sports--”

“Give Midoriya back to us and let him out of the marble,” Monoma snapped, and Katsuki gaped when the villain did exactly that with stiff, unnatural movements.

Compress placed one singular marble in Katsuki’s hand and stood stiffly on his tree-branch. The entire group let out a breath of relief as Katsuki landed back on the ground, and Compress snapped his fingers together.

Izuku landed right in front of them, looking confused, dazed, and a little scared. “Izuku!” Katsuki exclaimed, “Are you alright?”

Deku nodded, blinking a few times. [Fine.]

Katsuki let out a sigh.

There was another creak above them. Then another. Katsuki felt a wave of deja vu as they all looked up again, to see Toga and Twice in the trees above them. Inko glared from where she had emerged from the trees, with some reptile jerk with her.

“Compress! You did a great job!” one of them shouted. The guy in the black suit. “What the hell are you doing? You’re doing terrible!”

What the hell.

Toga giggled. “Let’s grab Izuku and go! Before the teachers catch up!”

For some reason she didn’t sound all that genuine. All of them stood there for a moment, neither hero nor villain willing to move.

Izuku reached up to his neck. And then everything was a blur from there.

Shouta pushed the corpse off of him. Blood was all over his costume but he didn't pay any mind to it. He would've dropped the gun too but he didn't want any overzealous villains or *students* to come across it.

It was bad enough he couldn't find anything to cover up that body with, but he was kind of on a time crunch.

He was running before he knew it. He knew he shouldn't shout. That he shouldn't call out for his kids when villains were lurking and waiting for another target, but he wasn't thinking rationally.

All Shouta could think about was his kids. His students. His comrades. He couldn't fail. He couldn't come out of this forest without all of his kids safe. He *couldn't bear another failure.*

"Izuku!" He shouted, voice carrying. "Hitoshi?!"

No response.

"Kids?!" He tried again. He needed to find *someone.*

"Aizawa?" A gruff voice called. Vlad. "Aizawa is that you?!"

Shouta walked toward the voice, only allowing himself a second to wonder if he was really speaking to Vlad, or an imposter. He burst through the trees into a clearing that was filled with most of Class 1-A and 1-B. It looked as though Vlad had been gathering another bunch of his kids while the Pussycats had subdued a couple of villains and stood guard.

Ragdoll was knocked out but other than that most of them seemed okay.

"The rest of my kids Vlad," Shouta began, sounding far away and worried even to himself. "Where are my *kids* ?!"

Vlad waved his hands placatingly. "I've been looking for them," He said reassuringly. "The ones missing are Monoma, Awase, Todoroki, Yaoyorozu, Bakugou--"

"Hitoshi and Izuku," Shouta finished. "We need to find them, now!"

"We're trying Aizawa-san," Tiger began gently, but Shouta wasn't having it. He appreciated Tiger's attempt at calming him down, but he knew what the League was capable of. He knew what lengths Izuku was willing to go to protect his classmates.

"Watch the kids. I'm going after them," Shouta grumbled, only to be stopped by Vlad.

"I'm coming too," he stated, "You can't do it alone,"

Shouta wanted to snap about how he didn't give a *fuck* if he couldn't do it on his own. He was going to do it either way, but he kept his mouth shut and nodded. Slower than he would like, they set off in a direction that Vlad had said he hadn't checked over yet.

They traveled in silence. Shouta's eyes missed nothing as he searched everywhere. He could feel himself growing impatient with each passing second. They could already be late. Izuku, Hitoshi and the rest of his kids could be dead right now.

The League had made it abundantly clear that they didn't care about killing kids.

“Aizawa...” Vlad began after a while, “I was meaning to ask earlier but why are you covered in blood? And why do you have a gun?”

“You’re a pro hero Vlad.” Shouta stated, eyes never breaking away from their search. “Take a wild guess,”

“You killed him. The Priest, I mean,” Vlad replied, tone completely neutral. “You got revenge,”

“I didn’t plan it like that,” He lied, “He was going to kill me. I had no choice,”

Vlad said nothing after that, and they continued deeper into the forest. The ground shuddered with the tell-tale sign that Izuku had transformed.

They were getting closer but they were still so *slow.*

It was the Sports Festival all over again. Shouta could feel the cold feeling of dread encompassing him. He was going to fail again, wasn’t he?

Shouta raced forward, pushing himself harder despite the cuts and bruises he’d earned from his battle with that Priest.

He had to change the outcome this time. He had to save his kids this time. *All* of them. By the time they reached where the kids were it was complete chaos. Bakugou was battling Spinner, the only villain that escaped the Pussycat’s clutches, and Yaoyorozu was supporting him.

Monoma was passed out but Hitoshi was fighting off Toga with Awase’s help, protecting him. Todoroki fought Twice with Dabi at his side.

Shouta scanned the chaos for Izuku, only to notice that the villains seemed to be retreating as they fought. Towards a portal. *Kurogiri’s* portal.

And struggling in the grasp of Inko Midoriya was his son, who looked glassy eyed and like he was losing strength to fight back.

Shouta wouldn't have known what to think if he didn't see the syringe on the ground next to the two. They *drugged* him. "Vlad, get the students!" He exclaimed, rushing forward. "I'll grab Izuku!"

Inko looked up then and they locked eyes. She started to walk faster toward the portal, but just as she stepped through it he wrapped Izuku in his capture weapon.

For a moment, the entire world seemed to freeze as he tugged as hard as he could. Izuku yanked and pulled at Inko's hand that was on his shoulder, pulling him backward into the portal. He raced to reach his kid, and Izuku thrashed like a wild animal to get his biological mother to let go of him.

Izuku locked eyes with him as he sank deeper into the portal. Shouta kept pulling the capture weapon taunt as he raced toward him.

There was no fear, as he expected there to be.

There was only terrifying determination. He was so engrossed in reaching his kid that he didn't notice Compress diving for him until he had been tackled to the ground.

"Go!" Compress shouted, and Shouta punched him as hard as he possibly could. He lost his grip on the capture weapon, and cursed. Compress started to *melt* into a pile of sludge and Shouta looked up at the portal just in time to see the League of Villains close that god-damned portal.

The remnants of what was wrapped around one of his sons were cut, and he was left staring at nothing. Just his shorter-than-normal capture weapon, Izuku's quirk supressor, and his katana that he had dropped at some point. Probably while he was being drugged by his own *mother.* And Shouta wasn't there to *help.*

Everything was too quiet. He sat frozen, staring blankly at where the portal had been not even twenty seconds ago.

He could *feel* tears streaming down his face, but he paid them no mind. Dabi carefully picked up Izuku's sword, and he could vaguely hear Vlad giving the rest of the kids orders to follow him back to where everyone else was, but he didn't hear it.

"He was…" Hitoshi began, and that's what broke Shouta out of his funk. "He was *right there!"*

With shaking hands, Shouta grabbed Hitoshi and checked him over for wounds. Once he was sure that at least *one* of his kids got out of this mess unharmed, he crushed Hitoshi in a hug and sighed.

Hitoshi was safe. He failed so much tonight, but he was glad that one of his kids was okay. They stayed in that position and Shouta could feel his tracksuit getting wet from Hitoshi's own tears.

Dabi threw the sword as hard as he could and *screamed,* tugging at his hair. And then he abruptly disappeared. His scream was cut off mid-way.

Hitoshi's sobs got louder once Dabi disappeared, and Shouta tried his best to hold himself together. He was failing. Or maybe he already failed, with how quickly Vlad had everyone leave them.

They stayed there for a long time. It felt like hours where Shouta did nothing but cry silently and stare at the spot where Izuku had been only seconds ago. He had been wrapped in Shouta's *capture weapon* for fuck's sake!

He was so *close.* He was so close but it wasn't enough. Shouta still failed. He was still a terrible parent and teacher who couldn't even keep his kids and class safe from *one* fucking villain attack.

Hizashi got the news of the attack on the training camp right when he had been ready to go to bed. But he had felt that something was wrong. That something had happened, so he stayed awake.

The call from Nedzu was a terrifying one. Which led him to now, where he was watching students get piled into ambulances with none of his family in sight.

Police were already in the area, but he didn't go to them. He went to Vlad first, and he hated how Vlad's face paled when they made eye-contact. Nedzu hadn't said much other than how his kids got attacked.

But Vlad's expression wasn't a good one.

"Vlad--" He said once he reached him. Vlad flinched, and bowed.

"I'm sorry," He replied hastily, not daring to bring his head up to look at him. "I failed as a teacher, I'm so *sorry,"*

And if that didn't have a pit growing in his stomach instantly, then nothing in this world would. "What happened, Vlad," He demanded, and he internally winced at the cold delivery. "Where's my *family?"*

"In the forest," Vlad stood, slowly as if he was afraid Hizashi might hit him for what he was about to say. "Shouta and Shinsou-kun are okay… but the villains. They took Midoriya."

"They *what?"* He heard himself say faintly, reaching for Vlad's shoulder to steady himself. Everything about that was wrong.

“The League of Villains kidnapped one of your children,” Vlad said, voice shaking. “Midoriya Izuku,”

Something broke when he heard that.

Chapter End Notes

I'll update tomorrow, and the next day (maybe everyday until we catch up to where I'm currently writing... who knows!!) <3

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 88

Chapter Notes

> Hello again! sorry about the delay I got really distracted reading fanfic instead of uploading my chapters lol.
>
> We're also getting into unedited territory with these chapters, so if there are any typos feel free to comment! Otherwise, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Himiko knew that to some people, she hadn't upheld Stain's last wish well. The Roses were supposed to protect Midoriya-chan from All for One.

To an outsider, or even Midoriya himself, it didn't seem like she or Kurogiri were trying their best to do that. Which was honestly a fair assessment, but Kurogiri had told her that to truly protect Midoriya long-term, they had to wait for the right time.

Some, mainly villains, would ask why they would bother to listen to a dead man's word in the first place. Why protect a hero course kid?

It was simple. Himiko respected Stain. Respected his wish, and his ideals that he left behind for them. And Midoriya was someone Stain had cared about, so she cared about him too.

After all her preparation, the sneaking, the lying, the method acting, she was ready. They all were.

It was finally time.

When Izuku came to, he noticed three things right away. One, he felt no pain which didn't make sense with all the injuries he'd sustained during his fight with Hisashi. Two, there was something tight around each of his wrists and he couldn't move. And third, he wasn't alone.

Kurogiri was polishing the glasses at the bar, and the rest of the League were standing in various spots. He hadn't expected to wake up in the bar, rather than that dark room where All for One rested with his Nomu.

He looked down at himself and found that yes, he was strapped to a chair and those were definitely quirk supressors on his wrists. His wings were pressed uncomfortably between his back and the chair.

It didn't make sense to him. Why wasn't All for One towering over him, enraged? Why was he sitting here like a hostage rather than a traitor? Where was his immeniet punishment and Nomufication?

He glanced around the League's hideout. The same bar he'd seen a few times. The same torn-up couch that sank in even when Shigaraki sat on it. The same busted flat-screen that Shigaraki used to play video games, not that Izuku had ever seen Shigaraki play any.

Everything was the same.

Kurogiri glanced up then, and set his glass down. For most of the League that seemed to be an indicator to leave the room.

The only ones who stayed were Toga, Spinner and Twice. After an awkward moment, Spinner turned to Twice and leveled him with a stern look and Twice left, looking quiet like a kicked puppy.

Once the door clicked shut behind them, Kurogiri turned to Toga and nodded. In fact, all three of the remaining occupants nodded at each other as if having a conversation telepathically. Then Kurogiri ducked behind the bar and the TV winked off with an audible pop.

Izuku flexed his hands, finding no other way to get his nervous energy out. What did those looks mean? What was going to happen to him? Why did they turn All for One's TV off?

Toga and Spinner turned to him as soon as the device had gone off. Both of their expressions were serious, and Izuku would chance it and say that Kurogiri's was too, under all that purple mist.

"We only have a little time," Spinner began, and that's when Izuku finally took in his appearance. He was wearing a *red scarf* like all the former Roses had. Even Toga was wearing a red band around her upper thigh, right where her skirt cut off.

Kurogiri was the only one without a direct homage to Stain visible on him, but he had already proved to Izuku once that he was on his side. Even if it didn't feel like it.

The only ones he had trusted were all killed during Hosu. Still, they had turned off All for One's TV for a reason, and for now Izuku wasn't in much danger. They were planning something.

Kurogiri was the one to speak up after polishing another, already shining, glass.

"The Heroes are already tracking your location," He said, and Izuku jolted in his chair. Kurogiri brought out a small circular device from under the bar. "Yaoyorozu managed to stick this on you before you were taken. And on one of the Nomu."

Izuku stared at the tracking device for a few seconds before looking up at Kurogiri. Why hadn't they destroyed it? What were their motives? Did they want to help him, after all this time?

The confusion must've shown on his face, because Spinner spoke up next. "It's time," He said vaguely, "We're getting you out and ending this,"

[Ending what?] He managed to finger-spell, even though he was sure none of them could've made it out, even if they knew how to read it. To his surprise Spinner smiled.

"I would've assumed that you knew what we meant by that." Spinner admitted, with a pleasant smile. "But now I kinda wanna keep it a secret,"

Toga smiled from her place on one of the bar-stools. "It'll be fun, don't worry!"

Izuku didn't match her smile. He had a feeling that this peace wouldn't last and it wouldn't be fun for any of them. This was the League of Villains. The same League that consisted of All for One and Inko. The very people who still haunted him and made it impossible to move forward in life.

Kurogiri plugged the TV back in, and instantly there was a familiar, crackling voice speaking. "What happened? Why couldn't I reach you?" All for One asked, but they all knew it was a demand for an answer.

His tone was cold and suspicious. He knew something was up with them. Izuku froze in his chair, a cold sweat breaking out in his palms. If he could move he would've scrambled for cover by the torn-up couch a little ways away from him.

But strapped to the metal chair like he was, he couldn't run and hide like his entire body screamed at him to.

He was forced to face that staticy TV and that cold voice that belonged to only one man. Izuku took a few shallow breaths, remembering all those times where both his dads, Kacchan and Toshi helped him through his panic.

Izuku needed to take deep breaths and finally face the darkness that All for One represented. Cowering was something only weak, terrified people did when they had no other options. Izuku steeled himself, jaw set and eyes narrowed as Kurogiri pulled out an excuse.

His confrontation with All for One and his mother was coming soon.

“My apologies sir. The connection failed,” Kurogiri said apologetically, “old extension cords, you understand. I will make sure to replace them soon.”

All for One, surprisingly, made a noise of vague understanding. “Bring me the boy,” He stated.

Izuku ignored the buzzing of fear in his chest, as Toga skipped over, face twitching as she attempted to keep the smile on her face. The restrains around his wrists and ankles suddenly sprung free when she inserted a small key into a keyhole he hadn’t spotted until just then.

Toga helped him up from the chair, but before he could even gain his own footing, a purple portal appeared at his feet. Toga gave his hand one last squeeze.

And then he was consumed by darkness.

There was the familiar ringing silence. The glow of the Nomu tanks that haunted his nightmares were situated in neat rows, creating a path straight to the chair that All for One sat in.

The TV monitor beside All for One’s chair was playing a live-feed of the bar, and in the bar their second TV was playing the footage of what Izuku assumed was a Yuuei conference. Nedzu, Vlad King and Shouta were all sitting in front of reporters.

Izuku felt himself sink into a cold calm. His heartbeat steadied, and Izuku found himself resisting the urge to shift into a fighting stance.

“Welcome home, Izuku,”

Two Hours Earlier

Shouta, Nedzu, All Might, and Yamada were all standing at Yaoyorozu Momo's bedside as she handed them the control device to the trackers.

"I placed one on the Chainsaw Nomu and one on Midoriya when I tried to treat some of his wounds. You should be able to see his coordinates as well as where the League keeps their Nomu," She said, looking utterly exhausted and worn out. Shouta was just glad she was okay.

Nedzu nodded from his perch in Shouta's scarf, hopping off of him to land near Yaoyorozu and grab her hand. "This is very valuable information, Yaoyorozu. You did a great job under those circumstances! Without you, I doubt--!"

Yamada cleared his throat loudly, and Nedzu's mouth snapped shut. "You'll…" Yaoyorozu began, twisting her white hospital sheets in her hands, once Nedzu let go. "You'll save him, right?"

"That's correct, Listener!" Yamada exclaimed, and Shouta couldn't bring himself to sigh at the volume. "Izuku will be just fine!"

His student finally seemed to relax after that, and Shouta turned and left the room. The logical thing to do was check on his other students, and call families to inform them of the incident. But the illogical part of him said that Nedzu probably already did that, and he needed to find his kid. Nothing else mattered.

Toshi was sitting with his classmates, and speaking to them in low tones in the waiting room when he arrived there. They all froze, and Shouta narrowed his eyes.

They looked guilty. They looked *suspicious* .

They were planning something. Why else would Toshi be speaking to Iida, Bakugou, and Todoroki? Why else would they be looking at him like they were just caught?

“What are you planning?” Shouta found himself asking.

“Nothing!” Iida exclaimed, with his familiar chopping motions accompanying his statement. “Absolutely nothing sensei!”

“Iida,” Shouta replied, with a smile pulling at his lips. He looked at each of the students individually, pausing longer on Bakugou and Toshi. “Maybe it would do you all a bit of good to take a few classes on how to lie. You never know when you might need it,”

Toshi tensed. “You can’t stop us,” he declared valiantly, tired eyes sparkling with determination. “We’re helping you and we’ll stay out of trouble!”

“I lost one kid tonight,” Shouta stated, sounding de-tached, even to himself. “I *won’t* be losing anymore. Do I make myself *clear?”*

There was a beat of silence. He took a moment to study each kid. Bakugou looked ready to explode, which he expected. Todoroki’s expression never changed. Iida and Toshi both looked properly cowed by his glare. He took a deep breath and grabbed Hitoshi and Bakugou by one of their shoulders.

“Look at me,” He said gently, once he noticed that both of them were glaring at the floor as if it would solve all their problems. The two of them resisted for a few seconds, before caving. “I will do *everything* in my power to make sure Izuku comes home. *Safe* . I won’t risk that being all for nothing if one of my kids gets hurt in the process. Do you understand me?”

The duo both went through similar expressions, anger, frustration, anxiety, fear, and finally, acceptance. Hitoshi nodded first. “Okay.” He replied, voice thick with unshed tears. “Okay. Just--you be safe too. Promise.”

“I promise, Hitoshi. I promise to bring *both of us* back home,”

He got crushed into a group hug very suddenly that almost knocked him over. Even Todoroki was hugging him. Which surprised him, considering the severe lack of physical affection Todoroki had received in his child-hood. Maybe he should hug Todoroki more often?Then a squeaky mouse-like voice cut through their little moment.

“Aizawa-kun!” Nedzu exclaimed, hanging from All Might’s shoulder now. “We must get going in time for the conference I’ve called together.”

Conference? What conference?

He kept his questions to himself as he looked over at Yamada. “Keep these kids out of trouble, please?”

Yamada nodded enthusiastically, as he came over to stand nearby the small group of would-be trouble makers. “I’ll keep all the Little Listeners safe while you’re gone Sho! No worries,”

As Nedzu and All Might passed them, Yamada pulled him into a hug. Everyone was hugging each other recently. As they pulled apart, Yamada gave him a peck on the lips. “I love you, Sho,”

“I love you too,”

It didn’t feel like a goodbye. It felt like a promise that when all of this was over that they were both going to nap for a week. And probably make sure Izuku was getting enough therapy. Actually, scratch that. They all needed more therapy. The *good* kind. Not the let’s-do-group-therapy-and-get-traumatized again, therapy. That still haunted his conscience to this day. If he could go back in time and punch himself and Nedzu, he would.

He separated himself from his thoughts and joined Nedzu outside, who was still perched peacefully on All Might’s broad shoulder. He could probably sleep there with no problem,

actually. “What’s this about a conference?” Shouta hissed. “What about my *kid?* What about saving him?!”

“Aizawa, please calm down,” All Might replied, “You, Nedzu and Vlad will be a distraction while--”

“Terrible plan!” Someone from the shadows exclaimed. “Hey, that's a great plan you’ve got!”

Shouta whipped around toward the voice to see Twice standing there, leaning against the hospital a little ways away from the main automatic doors. All Might instantly shifted into a fighting stance, and even Nedzu’s whiskers were twitching.

“What’re you doing here?” Nedzu snapped, looking absolutely feral.

“It’s time.” Twice said, tone serious as he approached them. As a friend or foe, Shouta had yet to deduce. “We’ve got a *better* plan in mind,”

He had been gathering the rest of them for weeks. Convincing a few of them to join their cause. At first he wasn’t sure that they’d join, but after a few conversations and promises of taking each of them out for dinner as payment, they decided to help.

He was grateful. Truthfully.

The Rose Massacre at Hosu hadn’t been the death of the entire organization, but none of the League needed to know about that. That was just how they liked it, actually.

They had mourned the loss of their main task force, of course, but they still used the distraction to their advantage. They gathered. They prepared. They were going to *win* .

“We’re going through with it,” He whispered, going through the methodical steps of cleaning each of their graves. The old, withering flowers were replaced with new roses. Midoriya should come visit them at some point. They would probably be happy to see him. “I hope you all enjoy the show,”

A hand, much bigger than his own, dropped onto his shoulder. “I know they will, Shi,” A deeper voice said.

They all stepped back from the graves. Shi pulled his mask onto his face, and shook out his nerves.

“Let’s get going before the party starts,” Shi replied, grinning maliciously behind his mask. He’d waited his turn for revenge, and tonight would finally be the right time. Everything the League of Villains had been building would fall by his hand.

It was Judgement Day.

The Heroes were gathering. The villains were unaware, seeing as All for One was occupied, and the rest of the League was celebrating a job well done.

The conference with Nedzu, Vlad King, and Eraserhead had begun. Reporters were shouting for answers. Asking if Midoriya Izuku was even worth saving. The villains laughed. Partied. They felt invincible. They felt that they had the upper hand. After all, what bigger boon than a hero student in their grasp?

It was cute, the demon supposed. They had no idea that all of this was short-lived and premature. They wouldn’t get the war they were hoping for. The war they were fighting was one born of shadows. Deception. Lies. One battle to strike down the devil. One battle to end an entire war before it got out of hand.

He shifted in the shadows. Waiting. Debating. There would be a moment, the *perfect* moment, to jump into the fray. It just wasn't right now. Not yet.

Midoriya stared down All for One, eyes still slightly glazed over from whatever drug that bitch Inko had injected him with. But Edgar wouldn't move from the shadows until things began.

Until the battle between David and Goliath shook Kamino to it's core.

Edgar was just trying to figure out which one of them was Goliath. He could feel Midoriya's power, and felt it since the day All for One altered him. He was still holding back, or at least he hadn't unlocked it's full potential just yet.

He wasn't too sure which one of them was stronger, and which one of them would come out on top of it all.

"You've done this to yourself," All for One said, a smile pulling at his scarred skin. "But you already know that, don't you Izuku? I can't say I'm surprised that you chose the hero's side, but can't you tell that my side is more favorable? You could grovel at my feet and I would let you come home. Isn't that easier?"

This was all a game to All for One. Midoriya had already proven time and time again that he wanted to be a hero. It was almost terrifying how attached he was to being a hero when that path had so much resistance to it.

All for One didn't care how Midoriya answered. He craved nothing but battle. He craved a clash of titans.

He had long since cast away the idea of bringing his prize home to switch sides and take his power. Specifically, after Shigaraki had been arrested.

It seemed to everyone that All for One's new goal was ending Midoriya Izuku where he stood. No more was the eternal struggle to get him to fit in the mold of the perfect villain. No more was there the cold patience and careful manipulation.

Midoriya Izuku was a valuable piece that stopped serving its purpose. He was a cog in the machine. A pawn to dispose of and forget about.

At least that's what Edgar had gathered from All for One's rants. The one's that happened when he thought he was alone, face cast in dancing shadows and the eerie glow from the Nomu tanks.

But then again no one really, truly, understood what was going on in All for One's head. And that was terrifying all on it's own.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys liked the new chapter <3

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 89

Chapter Summary

FIGHT! FIGHT! FIGHT!

Chapter Notes

>:) hi <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fear had run off somewhere. Izuku wasn't sure where it had gone, but he wasn't exactly in the position to dwell on it. He could feel his quirk spring to life beneath his skin, more comforting than ever before, since the suppressors were off.

At the very least he wasn't standing before All for One armed with nothing. That was a good sign.

He had already given his little speech about joining his side, but Izuku felt nothing. None of that fear suffocated him like before. None of that itching worry. None of that self-doubt.

He was done feeling those things.

All for One was smiling like he already knew the answer to what he asked.

"You and I would be stronger together," All for One continued on, finally standing from that throne-like chair. He carefully placed his life support mask on his face, and Izuku couldn't see All for One's expression anymore.

What caught his attention was that All for One's mask was a little different than before. Instead of being a navy blue skull-like design, it was black. That, and there was a cord that snaked across the floor ending somewhere in the shadows behind Izuku.

"I realized it a while ago after Shigaraki was arrested," All for One said, as the mask clicked into place. "This body of mine is dying, but *you*.. . Your body and Quirk are *strong* . You have a Quirk I cannot steal, just like my brother's. If I steal your body, think of all the things I could do! We would be the perfect combination, the perfect villain! I would become the strongest demon lord of all! Wouldn't that be amazing?!"

As he said all of this, Izuku's expression had gone from determined and severe, to confusion and apprehension. What exactly did All for One mean? Why did it sound like he was smiling under that mask? Like he'd won the game already?

He stalked forward, arms out wide. The mechanical inhale and exhale of that mask was too loud in his ears, and his heart was beating too hard in his chest.

What did he mean he wanted to *steal* his body? Was such a thing even *possible?* Izuku stepped back cautiously.

"Doctor!" All for One exclaimed, "Would you do the honors?"

Izuku whipped around, only for the fluorescent lights to turn on all at once. That's when he finally realized that in the middle of the room, surrounded by Nomu tanks, were two strange-looking vats that were wider and taller than the rest.

And then he eyed the snaking tube that connected to All for One's mask. It connected to one of the empty tanks that the Doctor had been standing next to. The aforementioned man crossed the room, closing the distance between them.

They were going to put both of them in those tanks. All for One really had a way to transfer his own soul into another body!

Shit.

A heavy hand dropped onto his shoulder, and he didn't hesitate. He rammed his elbow into All for One's stomach as hard as he could. Of course because the universe hated him, it did nothing. The Doctor had closed the distance by now, and was readying a mysterious syringe.

Izuku smacked it from his hand, and lunged forward. If he was even planning on fighting All for One he needed to get rid of those vats and The Doctor. As if able to read his mind, demons emerged from the ground and converged on the man as well.

But All for One's grip was too strong on his shoulder. Izuku didn't even get one step forward before he was yanked back.

"You *will* go in the machine," All for One said, tone dangerous.

Izuku flipped him off, just as one of the Nomu intercepted the demons that had been summoned. His eyes widened in shock as the Doctor chuckled. "Just in time," He said to the Nomu.

Izuku bared his teeth at the monster. The demons didn't seem that deterred, thankfully. They dashed forward, claws and teeth at the ready as well as one that wielded fire.

The Nomu was much bigger than all three of the demons that had come to his aid. Izuku pulled on All for One's grip as he was dragged toward the tanks. Nothing. He tried to punch him, throwing all his weight and strength into it as flames wrapped around his knuckles, but All for One merely dodged it with god-like reflexes.

The Nomu let out a long high-pitched scream from where it was still fighting Izuku's demons, but he didn't dare turn around to look. The Doctor had already left the Nomu to take care of the demons, and he was already standing at the control panel situated between both tanks.

Izuku struggled in the man's grip, but still nothing. He even tried to hit him with one of his wings.

It was now, or never. He had to transform or die. It was a pretty easy desicion.

All for One tried to shove him in the vat, but Izuku was already half-way done with his transformation. The floor rumbled, and the liquid in the tanks shook. Instead of aiming for All for One this time, he aimed for the tank itself, not caring if he cut open his fist.

The power beneath his skin rushed to the surface like a torrent. The vat exploded. Both of them, actually, as the impact of his punch affected even the air around them.

He could feel a heaviness and pressure at his forehead, where he was sure there were horns now. Izuku whipped around to face both the Doctor and All for One.

Now the real battle was beginning.

Toshinori stood outside the League's hideout in his muscle form. With him, was Endeavor,—as much as he loathed the man—Edgeshot, Kamui Woods, and Gran Torino. In front of them and behind them were rows and rows of Special Assault Team officers that were waiting for their signal to start the raid.

Detective Tsukauchi was actually the one in charge of giving it, but he was still watching the Yuuei conference on his phone. Waiting for the perfect moment.

His expression was dark and angry. Toshinori could just barely make out the questions the reporters were asking his co-workers, and he also felt a wave of anger wash over him, constricting his chest.

“Why bother saving Yuuei student Midoriya Izuku when everyone knows where his true loyalties lie?”

He clenched his fist so hard his knuckles popped.

“I’m afraid you’ve mistaken Mr. Midoriya for something he is not,” Nedzu replied cooly. *“Time and time again Midoriya has shown the true heart of a hero. Not only to me personally but to my entire staff. If all of you think he’s the perfect image of a villain you’re poorly mistaken. Out of all the students I’ve taught, he is the most heroic. Maybe even more than All Might himself.”*

“But Principal, the events of Hosu and his Quirk — ”

“Are not proof,” Aizawa-san answered curtly. *“That was self-defense, and there are countless people with Quirks just as jarring and “villainous” as his own. Those people aren’t villains just because of their Quirks and neither is he.”*

“Okay,” said a lady, *“Then how do you explain his parents and their obvious connection to the villain All for One?”*

“We have never once denied their connection to him.” Nedzu replied, *“However, that doesn’t make Midoriya a villain,”*

The debate went back and forth with no real end in sight, and Toshinori forced himself to block it out. There was no use in getting angrier and angrier before he got the chance to make sure Midoriya was safe and sound.

Detective Tsukauchi raised a hand, and one of the members of the Special Assault Team rushed towards the door to knock on it.

Toshinori got into position just as someone spoke cheerfully. “I am here to assist all of you today!”

Nedzu.

Nedzu, who was currently speaking during a conference. It seemed as if everyone turned around in alarm to look at the Principal of Yuuei. His smile was just as cheerful as the words he'd spoken. He was standing on Tsukauchi's shoulder.

"Sir—" Toshinori began, "How did you get here when…"

"Ah, Jin Bubaigawara helped us with that part!" Nedzu replied, holding what suspiciously looked like a gun. "Aizawa-san is currently on his way to assist Best Jeanist and his team with their investigation at the second League location,"

"May I…" Edgeshot began warily, "Ask why you're holding a gun?"

"To shoot villains of course!" Nedzu answered, "Just in case they try to escape!"

"Oh," Tsukauchi mumbled. "That makes sense. Please join All Might then,"

The poor officer who had stepped toward the door had been looking between the group confused for a while, but he finally raised his hand to knock.

"Pizza delivery!" He exclaimed.

A second later, Toshinori had blasted a hole through the wall. Only for the entire League of Villains to already be tied up, with the exception of Toga, Kurogiri, and Spinner.

Those three stepped through a portal before Toshinori could think about moving, each of them wearing a red scarf tied somewhere on their body.

And then Nomu dropped from grey portals. Midoriya was nowhere in sight.

Shouta had Izuku's katana in a tight grip as he jumped rooftops toward where Best Jeanists group was supposed to be. He was nearly there, too.

But that was before everything exploded violently. A massive pillar of blue fire exploded from where the warehouse should've been, and Shouta nearly lost his footing as the sword in his hands shook.

It escaped his grasp despite the tight grip he'd had on it and flew toward the fire. He ran faster, and as he got closer he saw Mount Lady shielding her comrades from the blast.

Shouta stopped one or two buildings away, glad that they had preemptively evacuated the nearby area before the fight. He wasn't sure if it would be enough to avoid any casualties seeing as this fight was bound to be a huge, catastrophic one but it was better than not evacuating at all.

The warehouse Best Jeanist and his team had been standing next to was nothing but rubble now, Shouta realized as the smoke began to clear. A deep familiar laugh carried on the wind, and every muscle in his body tensed.

"This is the game you want to play?" All for One asked, from wherever he was in the dissipating smoke. Shouta thought he'd felt fear when Izuku was kidnapped, but the fear currently shooting through him like lightning was much worse.

It was one thing to know your kid was kidnapped. It was another thing entirely to know that your kid was fighting a man with an unknown amount of Quirks in his arsenal. He had to move. He had to save his kid.

Bullseye never thought that Chizome would die. Especially not by Midoriya's hand, but he probably should've seen it coming.

He didn't think he'd be joining the last of Stain's little cult, either, but the scarf around his neck felt like a comforting weight. He had been friends with Stain at one point. He had loved him like a son. Or maybe as a brother he wasn't too sure.

When Shi had approached with the plan, he knew it was crazy. It was risky. After all, how was he supposed to shoot All for One in the head with confidence if he wasn't even aware of all the Quirks the man had?

At the time he hadn't been sure if he even wanted anything to do with the Roses that had turned into a vigilante group. Kill All for One? Save Midoriya? Retrieve the members of the League that had been undercover?

He didn't think he could do it. Not until Shi *and* Kurogiri approached him and offered to take him out for a meal afterward. It didn't help that he felt like he at least owed it to Chizome, to save his apprentice once and for all.

"Are you almost ready?" asked a feminine voice from behind. Mysterio, he recalled. Apparently she had been exploited by All for One, and Kurogiri was able to recruit her a little after the USJ at Yuuei.

"Yeah," Bullseye replied, checking that he was far enough from the edge of the roof. He was as far from the warehouse as they could afford to be without risking his shot. All for One was bound to leave the warehouse, or at least destroy it soon.

There was just no way in hell that heroes wouldn't show up and make a mess of things. He was counting on the chaos to get one shot in and retreat. His weapon was already in position and he'd checked it multiple times just out of habit.

He wouldn't miss the shot. It was virtually impossible with a Quirk that gave him perfect accuracy. The problem was All for One himself. Did he have a hardening quirk that would render Bullseye's bullets ineffective? What about a barrier Quirk?

And then again it would be hard to aim if the man was going faster than he could see.

"We've done the simulations," Mysterio said, as if she read his mind. And she was right. They had used her Quirk to account for most of the situations they could think of. "We just have to get lucky,"

There were millions where this flimsy plan would fall through. There were a few where it would work. In the end, Shi had said it was worth a shot. Pun *intended.*

All he had to do was wait for Kurogiri to arrive.

He and Mysterio watched the heroes arrive.

Ten minutes later, a purple portal opened up next to him. Just as the warehouse exploded.

Blue fire consumed him. It was warmer than his own fire, so he knew that his weapon had to be nearby. The building around him crumbled, but All for One didn't seem affected. The mask stayed on. None of the falling debris seemed to even touch him, as if they were afraid of him.

Izuku felt a sudden, familiar weight in his hands. His sword.

The Doctor had definitely been crushed, Izuku realized coldly as the walls fell away along with the ceiling. He was nowhere in sight. The Nomu vats had exploded, and dead experiments were strewn about like forgotten toys.

But some of the Nomu vats were empty when they hadn't been previously. "This is the game you want to play?" All for One asked, before Izuku could figure out where the Nomu's had gone.

"Yeah, I guess it is," Dabi answered casually, from right beside him. Fires were ignited in each of his palms, casting his face in fierce shadows. He looked more dangerous than he'd ever seen him.

Demons watched on quietly from the edges of his vision, as Izuku scanned his surroundings. The building they'd been in was torn to the ground, and the buildings nearest weren't in great shape either. The windows were shattered on some of them, while others were missing walls altogether.

"Stop right there!" someone shouted. Best Jeanist, Izuku realized belatedly as he risked a glance backward. "Step away from the child!"

Best Jeanist was with Gang Orca, Tiger, and Mt. Lady. All for One laughed heartily, before placing a hand on Izuku's shoulder, raising his other one to point at the group of Heroes. He hardly even blinked before a massive wave of wind and power blasted from All for One's hand.

It was like ice water had been dumped on him unexpectedly. He moved to rush forward to their aid as they disappeared behind a wall of kicked up smoke, but All for One shoved him backward.

Air whipped past him as he flew back, his momentum only stopped a few paces away when Dabi caught him.

He kept his eyes glued to where Best Jeanist and his group had been. The smoke began to clear again.

“As expected of the number four hero, Best Jeanist. I thought I’d blown all of you away,” All for One said to himself, rather than his opponents. Izuku could hear the smile in his tone. “To be able to manipulate everyone’s clothes and pull them to the side in an instant—”

Izuku let out a breath he hadn’t realized he was even holding. Rather than dead, the majority of Best Jeanist’s group was merely passed out from the blast. Worry still wound its way around his heart however, as he noticed Best Jeanist awake, lying on the ground. Prone to attack just like his comrades.

“That decision-making and skill… You must have nerves of steel to face me.”

And then he raised his hand again. Izuku rushed forward, but three things happened very quickly, almost at the same time. Best Jeanist wrapped All for One up in his own suit. A white strip of fabric wrapped around Izuku’s middle and pulled him away. And lastly, All for One’s life-support mask shattered while still on his face.

“Izuku!” Shouta exclaimed, as the capture weapon loosened around him. “Kid, are you alright?”

Dad was trying to get his attention, but Izuku was watching All for One with wide, horrified eyes as he broke free from Best Jeanist’s quirk. He tried to pull away to help. To save Best Jeanist from what was obviously *death.*

But Shouta’s grip was strong. And he didn’t really want to pull away from the safety and warmth. He felt terrible for it.

“Izuku you have to go!” Shouta exclaimed. Izuku glanced at him, noticing how his eyes were trained on All for One, Quirk activated. Dabi, in a storm of fire and fury, launched himself at All for One before he could even think of attacking Best Jeanist again.

Izuku knew he should leave. He knew now was probably his only chance, but he wanted to help the heroes take All for One down.

He didn’t want to leave and see on the news that someone died for him. He wouldn’t be able to live with himself.

So he shook his head and struggled against the capture weapon.

Chapter End Notes

Hope yall enjoyed! <3

This is an unedited chapter. So if u see any typos feel free to point em out :p

Chapter 90

Chapter Summary

The end of Kamino

Chapter Notes

Another day, another chapter lol <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bullseye never missed his mark. Not in all his days of being a villain—or vigilante depending on how you looked at his previous activities.

His shot didn't miss but that insufferable mask blocked his shot as he *predicted it would.*

But that was fine. They all knew this plan was fragile at best.

"Reload." Mysterio said. "Try again!"

Bullseye grit his teeth and reloaded. This time he would kill the bastard.

"No," Kurogiri answered, pointing down at the battle going on. "All Might is already on the scene. This is his fight. We should retreat,"

Izuku didn't know why, but it almost felt like time had stopped. Everything was at a standstill.

Dabi's hand was outstretched, flames still burning bright. Dad was holding onto him as if letting him go was unbearable. Best Jeanist's eyes were wide and fearful. Full of that kind of dread that only people who were staring death in the face had.

But no one was moving. Izuku didn't even know if anyone was *breathing.* Dabi looked frozen mid-air, utterly terrified. Dad's breathing was uneven and labored, eyes fiercely trained on All for One with his Quirk activated.

"Do you really think this is enough to stop me?" All for One asked, rubbing his jaw as he spoke. "One demon, two heroes, one of which is barely conscious? This won't take long at all,"

One strong hand reached for Dabi and swatted him away as if he was an annoying fly. Then All for One turned and kicked Best Jeanist, blood splattering messily on the uneven concrete they were all standing on.

Best Jeanist groaned, obviously still alive but it was still terrifying to watch. Everyone was frozen with fear.

Izuku felt himself take in a sharp breath of surprise. Dad let go of him in shock, and Izuku found himself racing forward without a plan. Without purpose. Izuku could've left this disaster zone, easily. He was confident enough in his flying abilities to at least get that far, but he *couldn't.*

"Izuku!" Shouta shrieked. Izuku hardly heard it over the blood roaring in his ears.

All he knew was that Best Jeanist didn't deserve to die for his sake. None of them deserved to die saving him. His blade flashed through the air, alight with fire and freezing to the touch.

All for One side-stepped the attack entirely. Izuku struck again, and All for One twisted out of the way with a laugh. Even without his Quirks, he was strong, fast, and probably difficult to defeat.

"Hit me with all of your power!" He exclaimed, a wide smile on his face. "Kill me, little hero, if you can!"

Izuku didn't hesitate. He couldn't afford to, not anymore. This was the only time where he could end all of this.

This was their only shot to kill All for One and wake up to a brighter tomorrow. He poured all the power he could into his next strike, the blade slicing through the air. With a surge of pure power, the force of his blade whistled through the air only to be stopped by All for One's overly muscled hand.

A Quirk.

But how was he using a Quirk if his dad was using Erasure? In a fit of crippling fear, Izuku glanced to his left, completely disregarding the Goliath before him. Dad was still using his Quirk but was kneeled next to Best Jeanist. Had he blinked? That could be the only explanation.

"What an interesting Quirk," All for One remarked, forcing Izuku to *focus* . In the back of his mind, he wondered why All for One didn't smite him right then and there, but he pushed those lingering thoughts away. All for One's hand had gone back to its original size, so Izuku knew that the momentary Quirk usage had to be because of his dad blinking.

"Aizawa I'll get everyone out of here!" came Dabi's sudden exclamation to his right. "Focus on that asshole!"

They exchanged blows, All for One still surprisingly fast and strong. Maybe dad couldn't erase all of his Quirks? That would explain it. His sword didn't even seem to be cutting into his skin whatsoever.

However, he could tell that his flames seemed to be doing some sort of damage because every time they parted he could see parts of All for One's skin turning black. And then something yanked him back, just as All for One reared his fist back to attack.

"Kid you need to get out of here!" He said, but Izuku was already shaking his head. The capture weapon around his waist didn't loosen at all, but that didn't stop Izuku from assuming a fighting stance. All for One was "watching" the exchange between them with no change in expression.

"I would've thought All Might would be here by now," The man said coolly as if Izuku hadn't leveled a building to get away from him. As if he wasn't a few seconds from razing Kamino to the ground with one of his many Quirks. "If I can't steal your body and remake you—" Dad froze at the wording as All for One tilted his head in Izuku's direction. "—then I'll just have to kill you, but I'd rather kill All Might as well while I'm at it,"

"What?" His father said, his voice trembling with anger and fear.

All for One just smiled. Eraserhead blinked.

A second was all the monster needed.

One second he was standing there and in the next, he was colliding with Dabi who had just dragged the last of Best Jeanists team out of harm's way. Dabi yelped in surprise, and dad groaned but didn't get up.

Izuku should've moved. He should've sensed danger, but his eyes wouldn't, *couldn't* leave the prone form of his dad. In the corner of his eye, he saw All for One lunge for him. He expected pain. He expected everything to end in an instant.

He didn't care. His dad was laying limp a few feet away. Dead or alive, Izuku wasn't sure. Everything was a little too far away for him to realize the dire situation he was still in.

And then there was snarling, and a short bark that cut through the fog in his head. A black blur had intercepted All for One's attack, his hand out-stretched and humongous. Multiple Quirks of the strongest combination created an attack, but that black blur— *a wolf* —had sunk its teeth into his arm, and All for One was yelling.

Everything was coming back. The sudden rush of burning fear, the cold embrace of uncertainty. The low moans of what were undoubtedly poor civilians that had gotten caught up in All for One's terrible, terrible scheme. Dabi cursed as he checked up on dad.

And then Dabi started to drag Shouta farther from the fight without even reassuring Izuku if he was alright. Almost like whiplash, his fear transformed into rage. How *dare* he attack his father? How dare he even think of injuring an integral part of Izuku's family? His *safe place?*

The feeling burned beneath his skin, cutting all of his racing thoughts short.

All for One would *pay.* Izuku would make sure of it. There was nothing to think about. No worries, no anxiety, nothing. It was just the comforting feeling of his sword in his hand. The overwhelming urge to cut All for One down for good.

The wolf that had intercepted the fight between them was still snarling, but he was standing in front of Izuku instead of biting All for One. It's outline was wispy like black smoke, but it was definitely a wolf. And it was definitely protecting Izuku right now, if the raised hairs along its spine said anything.

All for One stepped forward, mouth opening to speak, but the wolf-dog thing, whatever it was barked. *Loud* .

"Who knew that dog of his would be such trouble," All for One murmured, but Izuku still heard it.

Whose dog? Izuku almost asked, but he already had a theory. After all, why would Edgar go missing never to return? Why else except for All for One hyper fixating on hurting Izuku in

any way possible? That seemed to be his only motivation recently, and he wouldn't have put it past All for One to experiment on Edgar like he did Dabi.

All for One tried to swat it away like he did Dabi, but the dog only shifted backward, closer to Izuku. Once he realized it was a waste of time trying to get rid of the dog, he moved on to ignoring it, lunging toward Izuku. Which was exactly what Izuku wanted—no, *needed.*

He met All for One eagerly, still stewing in his anger. It would've been terrifying to face off like this before Yuuei.

Now though, Izuku had something he didn't have before. A support system. A brother. Loving parents. And there was nothing All for One could do to take him away from that. His blade sliced through the air, and he pushed more power into it than he'd ever dared before. His wrist ached. His entire *body* ached as the blade cut All for One's hand clean off.

The battle was a blur of blood, demons grabbing onto All for One only to be knocked aside, and All for One yelling about how powerful he was . None of that mattered.

He dodged a fist coming straight for his face at neck-breaking speed. The limb that Izuku had managed to slice off was growing back, albeit slowly. Nothing like the Nomu's he'd encountered.

All for One's blunt nails grew into blood-red daggers, slicing just inches away from his throat. He only managed to get out of the way because the dog— *Edgar.* It *had* to be. He was wearing the familiar collar and everything—sank his teeth into All for One's arm again.

Unfortunately in the process his grip on his weapon faltered. With a clatter it fell to the ground somewhere, but everything was hazy. Nothing but victory was on his mind, so he raced forward just as All for One was powering up another Quirk.

He barely realized what he was doing before he did it. The kick to All for One's gut didn't seem to do much, but the scalding hot blue flames that Dabi blasted at his back did a *number* on him.

Regeneration Quirk or not, fire was still fire and destroyed cells couldn't repair themselves. He got a good punch to All for One's unprotected face before his claw-like nails sliced into his side like knives.

Izuku blinked harshly at the pain, air leaving his lungs in a puff of air as he staggered. Hands on fire with his hell-flame, he crushed All for One's newly-formed hand in his grip. All for One roared in outrage, using his other hand to rake his claws along Izuku's face.

Blood trickled onto his shirt but Izuku ignored it. They continued their fight, ground shaking under the power of each attack they threw at each other. Flames licked up his arms, as the buildings around them started to creak and lean at dangerous angles. He drew his fist back for a super-powered punch but before his flames could make contact with the scarred patches of skin on All for One's face, the man jerked in surprise.

"All for One," All Might said from somewhere behind Izuku. He sounded deadly serious and so fiercely protective. "Your fight is with me *alone* . Let the boy go!"

That same cold chuckle from All for One. The same in-take of breath before he went on another tangent about how *important* Izuku was to his world-domination plan. Before he could open his mouth, however, Izuku socked him in the jaw. Edgar, for all his snarling and snapping, rushed over to him. The bell on his collar jingled as he sank his teeth into one of Izuku's wings and *pulled.* With way more strength than a pug should have. Ever.

He yelped in both surprise and pain.

"Izuku!" Dabi whisper-shouted as Edgar dropped him a few feet away, nudging his knee and whining. Probably trying to apologize. "Are you okay?"

Izuku nodded slowly, as Dabi entered his vision. [Dad?] he signed frantically, and his fear was most likely written all over his face because Dabi gave him a soft smile.

“Fine, just like Best Jeanist and his group. I promise.” Dabi said, as a helicopter swarmed overhead, probably trying to get live footage of All Might’s fight with the *literal* devil.

Izuku tried to scramble to his feet to see his dad, but as soon as he tried to put one foot in front of the other, pain laced through the wounds in his side. His back hurt like he’d been slammed repeatedly into a wall. His eyes stung.

He nearly collapsed right there, but Dabi grabbed him, looking rightfully alarmed. “You said you were okay!” He exclaimed, hands hovering, unsure. “You *lied* to me, green bean!”

Izuku glared at him, trying to convey that *maybe,* just maybe they could worry about his injuries when All for One was preferably six feet under. It wasn’t like he was bleeding out or on the verge of passing out. He just… needed help walking over to wherever Dabi had stashed away his dad for the time being.

Edgar seemed very eager to make up for the transgression he’d made by pulling on Izuku’s wing earlier, and doubled—maybe even tripled—his size so Izuku could grab onto him.

Dabi looked over him anxiously, but obviously didn’t find any injuries that were an immediate danger to Izuku’s overall survival. He went back to sending All Might and All for One weary glances. Izuku was hardly fazed by the resulting wind buffeting him with each blow that All for One and All Might exchanged.

Edgar was almost like a wall in the fact that he didn’t falter, and shouldered much of Izuku’s weight. Much quicker than Izuku anticipated, they were at his dad's side, who was still unconscious. Izuku delicately moved Shouta’s head into his lap so he didn’t have to look so uncomfortable, even like this. Gang Orca was hunched over his teammate, Best Jeanist, applying first-aid with shaking hands. “Is he gonna be okay?” Mt. Lady asked, and Izuku blinked in surprise.

He didn’t even notice that she was up and moving around. “Yeah. He’s stable for now.” Gang Orca said with unbelievable calm, “As long as one of us gets him to medical as soon as possible,”

“I’ll do it!” Tiger said, before anyone else could even offer. “You two are still needed here to support All Might until the back-up arrives,”

Best Jeanist was lifted delicately off the ground, and Tiger dashed off. Izuku focused his attention back on his dad, and apparently it got Gang Orca’s attention. “Hey there kiddo. Are you okay?”

Izuku didn’t respond. Not even with his hands. He was well aware that Gang Orca was one of the few heroes nowadays that learned sign. He just couldn’t bring himself to say anything as he brushed back a stray hair that was in Shouta’s face.

Gang Orca checked his pulse, already confirming what Izuku knew. “He’s just unconscious. He didn’t hit his head or anything, correct?” Dabi shook his head when Gang Orca turned to him. Then the hero turned to him, giving Izuku a concerned glance before asking again, “Are you okay?”

Dabi shook his head before Izuku could think to nod. “He’s got a few injuries from All for One,”

[I’m fine.]

“Regardless would you mind if I took a peek?” The man asked. Izuku looked at Dabi.

“Fine, fine. I’ll look after hobo man,” Dabi grumbled, gently coming to sit next to Shouta once Izuku let Gang Orca look him over. He was ordered to put pressure onto the wound in his side, seeing as Gang Orca couldn’t really give him stitches immediately. His first-aid kit was sparsely filled anyway, and he probably wasn’t trained aside from first-aid.

He started cleaning the shallow gashes on Izuku’s cheek when another earth-shaking exchange of fists came from in front of them. Izuku was almost too scared to look at the fight, but found himself looking over anyway. They were having his entire dialogue going on between each other, but he was too far away to hear.

“Look ahead for me please,” Gang Orca ordered, kindly. “All Might is doing his best to fight for us. The best thing you can do right now is get yourself patched up,”

And then he heard it. All for One cackling as more heroes arrived, helping with rescue efforts rather than helping All Might. Gang Orca called for someone to get him and Shouta out of here, but Izuku was seeing something no one else was seeing.

While Edgeshot, Mt Lady, and a murder of other heroes scrambled to save civilians, All Might had been grabbed by All for One. His meaty, Quirk-enhanced hand was wrapped around All Might’s thinning form. Wisps of smoke rolled off the Number One hero, and Izuku found himself staring at Toshinori from all those months ago.

He couldn’t exactly remember if he’d ever seen All Might as Toshinori at any point, but still. The connection made a lot of sense, but it was terrifying in this situation. He was no longer buff, and mighty. He choked, his power probably fading with exhaustion as he clawed at All for One’s fist.

The heroes had retreated with the civilians, and were now seemingly frozen in shock at the scene before them. Why wasn’t anyone *moving* ? Was the shock *that* great? Had they never even considered the possibility of All Might being weak? Of him retiring?

Gang Orca was shouting after him, but Izuku paid it no mind. He could see All for One’s hand tighten around Toshinori’s throat. All Might gasped, arm building as he tried to gain enough power to blast the monster away. His face was turning a different color from lack of air, but that didn’t stop him from finally wrenching All for One’s hand away just enough so he could suck in a much-needed breath. It wouldn’t be enough. All Might couldn’t do it on his own. That was just *suicide.*

And he refused to let All for One hurt anyone else he loved.

Izuku grabbed onto the back of All for One’s shirt, and with all the power he could muster from his transformation, he *threw him.*

Predictably he went flying and All Might gasped, quickly followed by him coughing so hard that blood dripped out of his mouth in a steady stream.

All for One had slammed into a building that Mt. Lady had already gotten some unlucky civilians out of. It collapsed on top of him with a loud crash.

Izuku used this moment to do a once-over of All Might. He was battered and bruised from the fight, but he was still standing. Breathing. Alive. He had almost relaxed, eyes scanning the rubble of the building that All for One was trapped under. For an entire minute, the rubble didn't move.

The breath that the world was holding seemed to finally release.

"My boy," All Might began, smiling even in his gaunt form. "Are you alright? We should get you to the—"

What he was about to say was cut off.

"That actually kind of hurt," All for One snapped, cracking his knuckles. "And it really seemed uncalled for, little hero,"

All Might didn't even react. He just moved to shield Izuku as if Izuku didn't just save his life a minute ago. He glared at All Might's back and stepped out of its protection. This wasn't just All Might's fight anymore.

It stopped being just the Symbol of Peace's job to take down All for One when Izuku came into the picture. It was time to give All for One a piece of his own medicine. Beside him, All Might faltered. "Young Midoriya! You can't be—"

All for One didn't give them the luxury of having a conversation mid-battle. He launched himself at both of them, hardly giving them time to even breathe. All Might's grip was impossibly strong as he shoved himself and Izuku out of the way of danger.

Pain shot through him at the rough way All Might was handling him, but he couldn't bring himself to be angry. They needed to find the perfect moment to attack.

"This is it, All Might!" All for One yelled. His entire arm was twice as big as before. It was all malformed and a sick combination of Quirks, and Izuku was acutely aware that getting hit by that probably wouldn't feel too good.

He could just barely make out the Quirks that All for One was whispering to himself. "Spring-like limbs, Kinetic Booster times four, Strength Enhancer times three…" Some of it was lost to Izuku as All Might coughed.

Then All for One laughed. "The shockwaves until now were just to wear you out. In order to kill you, I'll attack you with the ultimate combination of Quirks that I have right now!"

He reared back his terrifyingly large fist. "You'll die with regrets, All Might! And then I'll take back my vessel!"

All for One aimed a punch directly at them but All Might met his attack with his own fist. Sparking with the power of One for All that still dwelled in him. The buildings around them that had been on the verge of collapse finally did so, as the sheer force of their attack slammed into them.

Izuku scrambled to keep All Might from collapsing. Yet they were still being pushed back from the force. He couldn't brace himself against anything so they slid backwards. And then finally, Izuku gained proper footing and All Might's other hand inflated, getting a solid hit on All for One for good this time.

But the villain didn't even seem fazed by it. "You're getting weaker, All Might!"

"So are you!" All Might shot back, but he was swaying on his feet. He could hardly even keep his eyes open. Izuku was almost ninety percent sure that he was holding All Might up. If he wasn't here, All Might would have collapsed by now.

And he noticed something. They weren't paying attention to him. At all. The two of them had forgotten he was even *there* . All for One was powering up his other arm for another attack. An attack that All Might probably wouldn't *survive.*

Quicker than the thought formed in his mind, demons were scrambling to get ahold of All for One's arm and immobilize him. And then both of All for One's arms went back to normal very suddenly. Izuku didn't have to look back to see if it was his dad that was erasing All for One's Quirks. The demons held All for One tightly, claws slicing unforgivingly into his skin but Izuku wasn't sure how long they'd hold for.

And then All Might went limp in his hold.

For a moment everything went dark around him.

"It's time," a raspy voice said, and Izuku blinked.

The chain wrapped around his arm went taunt.

And then it ***snapped*** .

When he came back, it was as if no time had passed at all. But everything felt different. His injuries hurt like hell, but he wasn't exhausted like he had been moments before. Izuku adjusted his grip on All Might and curled his hand into a fist.

The ocean of power beneath his skin was cold and serene in a way that he'd never felt before. As if already at peace, knowing that All for One was about to be gone for good. His Quirk

wasn’t more powerful than before, but it was a lot easier to control and manipulate than ever before. He could just tell.

Flames engulfed him, cold against his skin.

“Foolish boy!” All for One howled, scarred face contorting into something even uglier. “We could’ve had it all! We could’ve ruled *everything!”*

“Farwell, All for One,” He said, a hint of a smile on his lips. He pulled his fist back, and hit that monster with all his remaining strength.

When his fist connected with All for One’s face, the man went flying, ultimately laying splayed out a ways away.

He didn’t get up. Not this time.

Peace settled over Izuku like a thick blanket. All for One was defeated, with just one punch.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed this chapter!

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 91

Chapter Summary

A little bit of the aftermath of Kamino and some Chisaki Kai things (he's kinda out of character with his motivations in this fic because I thought it'd be fun to switch it up a little) <3

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the delay lol I got distracted while reading other fics :)) enjoy this one! Today is the third anniversary of our discord server so I thought it was the perfect time to update again! Also keep in mind that my most recent chapters are relatively unedited! If u see some typo's just call me out lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku felt lighter than air. Tsukauchi had already arrived in his hospital room to inform him that Hisashi, Inko, and all of the League of Villains had been successfully captured. With the help of the brand new vigilante group in town of course.

Apparently, the Roses—including Bullseye, Mysterio, Toga Himiko, Kurogiri, Spinner, Twice, and Shi—had coordinated in tandem with the heroes to make sure that they were all captured successfully without incident.

And no, Tsukauchi wasn't going to hunt them down. After all, they had just miraculously *disappeared* after everything was said and done. He also said that All Might was expected to recover just fine after their fight.

"You saved his life, kid," Detective Tsukauchi said, with a grateful smile. *"Thank you,"*

He left after giving Izuku a quick hair ruffle on his way out. And then he was scolded by Shouta and Hizashi—they never yelled, but the worry was evident in their tones—until they felt like he understood how *dangerous* it had been to run back into the fight. *Of course* , he'd

understood what was at stake! The danger they'd all been facing! He understood more than anyone that it wasn't a wise decision to make, but it was the *right* one.

But then Hizashi started sobbing, and his heart squeezed in his chest. He felt terrible about worrying his family. Even Toshi, who sat in the chair at his left side, looked like he wanted to get in a few words as well.

His injuries hadn't even been life-threatening. Not like All Might's had been, but they were still pretty bad. The stab wounds from one of All for One's quirks had been pretty deep, and there were a number of bruises and lacerations he didn't remember getting.

The burns he'd gotten from Hisashi had been healed once he was kidnapped, which baffled the doctors since Yaoyorozu gave them an account of all his injuries before his capture.

One of his wings had been broken, but they were able to heal it pretty easily. It was thanks to Chizome-san's following that he had made it out of there with minor injuries.

"So," Toshi said as Hizashi gently wrapped Izuku in one of his warmest hugs. "What're we going to do with Edgar?"

At the mention of his name, Edgar—now much, much bigger than he'd originally been—wagged his tail where he was laying by Izuku's feet.

"I'm sure Eclipse won't mind another animal around the house," Shouta replied, a small smile on his face as he watched Hizashi take hold of one of Izuku's hands once they'd parted from their hug.

Izuku gave Edgar a pat on the head and the dog wiggled closer, still wary of his injuries. "He seems really attached to you," Hizashi added, "It would be cruel to make the two of you part,"

Edgar licked Hizashi's hand, and Izuku grinned.

In the days after the incident that led to one of the most notorious villains being incarcerated, Izuku had recovered from all his injuries and went to his sessions with his therapist. School wouldn't be in session for two weeks, to allow time for recovery, but Izuku still came to Yuuei.

It was weird, talking about—or in his case signing it out—what had happened during the training camp and the incident in Kamino. Sometimes it didn't feel real. Sometimes he wondered if All for One was truly defeated, or if he was just waiting for a day where he *and* Shigaraki could escape.

It was even weirder today, an entire week after the incident when Tsukauchi and All Might showed up at their door.

He hadn't seen Toshinori since the conclusion of the battle, and the poor man was still wrapped in bandages in some places. Shouta glared at them from his spot at the doorway.

"What're you doing here?" He didn't seem angry. Rather, he seemed utterly exhausted and not at all in the mood to hear whatever reason they dropped by for. "Did someone die?"

There were two reasons Izuku could think of for their being here. Either the world was ending and something terrible happened, or All Might was just here to talk. Which, if he was being honest, didn't seem likely. Tsukauchi's presence told him that much, at least.

"Actually, Aizawa-kun…"

Shouta took a step back, and Izuku made his way over to the door to listen. "Wait, did someone *actually* die?"

“Well…” All Might rubbed the back of his neck nervously. Tsukauchi shifted, giving All Might a faintly relieved look. “How should I put this?”

“Just spit it out,” Shouta replied coldly. “I just haven’t had my coffee today,”

It was true. These two had dropped by early in the morning, right after Shouta *and* Izuku woke up because Eclipse and Edgar were causing chaos. Shouta had woken up to a cat sleeping on his face, and Izuku woke up to Edgar nudging him and begging for attention. Which somehow led to the both of them meeting up in the kitchen much earlier than usual.

Toshi and Hizashi weren’t even awake yet.

Finally, All Might seemed to gather the courage to speak up. “All for One’s transfer to Tartarus was today.” The words hung heavy in the air. A spark of fear twisted in his stomach. “Unfortunately, on the way, the truck used for his transport was stopped by a band of vigilantes. The guards had been knocked out and All for One was killed.”

Izuku froze. All the fear that had settled in his stomach promptly vanished, replaced with relief. All for One was dead. He was *free!* He didn’t know whether to laugh or cry. Dad blinked in surprise.

“Come again?”

“All for One is dead.” All Might sighed heavily, a shaky smile pulling at his lips. He looked just as relieved as Izuku felt. “He’s *dead,”*

“And this band of vigilantes… who were they?”

“What’s left of the Roses,” Tsukauchi spoke up. “But we weren’t successful in tracking them down. It was especially difficult with Kurogiri present,”

Shouta nodded, and Izuku could tell by how his shoulders dropped that he was happy to receive such good news. “You confirmed that he was dead, right? This isn’t just some elaborate trick?”

“It was definitely him,” All Might said. “I just thought you’d like to be made aware of the situation,”

“Thanks,” Shouta replied, seeming a little hesitant as he added, “Would you like to come in?”

“No, thank you for the offer,” Detective Tsukauchi replied. “I’ve got to get back to work,”

“And you?” Shouta asked, turning to Toshinori who looked about ready to come up with an excuse on the spot rather than sit through an awkward morning with him. Which, Izuku thought to himself, was fair. Dad didn’t seem like he even wanted All Might to say yes.

“I also—”

Shouta nodded, and shut the door in their faces, with a mutter of, “I haven’t even had coffee yet. It should be crime,”

Izuku grinned as he watched dad peek through the peep-hole to watch them leave. Finally, when he drew away, Shouta yawned and they headed back to the kitchen, where Eclipse was waiting for her breakfast. He watched him feed the cat, and then pet Edgar, who didn’t seem to require food anymore after All for One’s experimentations.

Izuku found himself something small to eat until it was time for Hizashi to get up. Shouta, ever one to follow routine, got himself a jelly pouch and slurped it down like water as he stared at the coffeemaker.

Fortunately, Izuku wasn’t as tired as his dad was, and went into the livingroom to watch TV and wait for Hizashi and Toshi to wake up. Edgar, despite his bigger wolf-ish stature, climbed onto the couch and sprawled across his lap, eager to be pet.

The three of them did this every morning. Shouta would make his coffee, and mindlessly watch whatever Izuku put on the TV. Edgar would laze about and ask for pets, and Izuku would think about anything other than what happened in Kamino. Toshi would sleep in until Hizashi woke him up with a promise for coffee.

It was a domestic atmosphere that Izuku had finally settled himself into comfortably. Sure, some days were worse than others, where he expected anger and sharp looks. Where he walked on eggshells, accommodating his behavior for someone who wasn't there anymore.

Luckily on those days, Hizashi seemed a little too eager to be gentle with him and reassure him through his actions that he wasn't a threat.

Shouta plopped down next to him, weight causing a dip in the couch. He dutifully ignored the wagging tail that hit his thigh, nearly causing him to spill his coffee. He reached over and ruffled Izuku's hair, and Izuku couldn't help but lean into the contact.

The smile on dad's face was a soft one that would surely be the talk of Yuuei if Hizashi took a picture of it and sent it to their "totally secret teachers only chat." Izuku smiled back, and Hizashi's sudden coo caught even Edgar off-gaurd. He jolted in Izuku's lap and lifted his head, only to place it back down when he saw who it was.

"Aww, all my favorite people looking so cute!" Hizashi exclaimed, delighted. Shouta sank into the couch and mumbled something none of them could hear into his mug. Izuku couldn't help the embarrassed blush that climbed up his neck and cheeks. Hizashi grinned.

"So, we've got some time off from school!" Hizashi brought up as he headed inside the kitchen. "Do either of you want to go anywhere? Or is it another stay at home day?"

"I'd rather die," Shouta began seriously, "than leave my house today. All Might and Tsukauchi showed up at the door before I could even get my coffee,"

Izuku got up from the couch to offer assistance to Hizashi, and he became in charge of washing the rice. Edgar followed him dutifully, and huffed when he realized Izuku was too focused on getting the rice done and listening to the conversation at the same time to pay attention to him.

“Oh?” Hizashi replied, “What did they have to say? Was it something urgent?”

“All for One is dead.” Shouta said bluntly, forgoing dancing around the elephant in the room. Hearing it again make something loosen in his chest, and Izuku felt relief like he’d never felt in his life since he was adopted by his dads.

Hizashi’s reaction was honestly so much calmer than Izuku had been anticipating. Maybe a little too calm. “I don’t want to speak ill of the dead, but I’m glad that bastard is dead,” His father stated, “He definitely deserved it.”

“I agree,” Shouta said, eyes still latched onto the documentary Izuku had put on. “I feel like we can finally rest a little easier,”

The conversation tapered off after that, and it was a usual occurrence when all of them were still groggy and tired. Eventually, breakfast was ready, and Izuku set out for the impossible task of waking up Toshi, with a cup of coffee already in hand.

Venturing into Toshi’s room was like entering a lion’s den, in the sense that he wasn’t sure if Toshi would ignore him or smack him in the face with his pillow. He certainly hoped Toshi wouldn’t ruin this perfectly good cup of coffee that he currently held onto, but there were definitely times where Hizashi had returned to the kitchen, coffee spilled on his pajamas.

His brother’s room was dark, and his bed was a stormy sea of blankets with a large bump in the middle of the mattress. Seeing that Toshi wasn’t awake yet he set the mug on Toshi’s nightstand and prodded him tentatively.

A grumble. Another poke, more confident than the last one. Sharp eyes glared at him from the lump on the bed, until they latched onto the coffee that Izuku had just set down.

[Good morning, Toshi!] Izuku signed, and Toshi let out a massive, exhausted sigh.

“How come,” he lamented, as his hands searched for the handle of the coffee mug as he rose from his sheets. “I can wake up every day angry at the world, but as soon as you come in it’s all better?”

Izuku shrugged and settled himself on the bed, half-on, and half hanging off. [Are you ready to come out? Or do you want to sleep?]

“Only if there’s more coffee,” Toshi answered, knowing all too well that Shouta liked his coffee almost as much as he did. Izuku raised his eyebrow as if to say: “Don’t you already know the answer?”

The two of them left the room at that point, conversation essentially over until Toshi had at least two more cups of coffee. The morning flew past them, bleeding into the afternoon and night.

They took the rest days Nedzu had given the entire school for what they were, lazing about and absolutely not addressing anything Hero related. Well, aside from telling Toshi the news about All for One, which resulted in both of their dads once again voicing their distaste and hatred for a man already dead. Izuku viciously signed his own opinion as well.

The evil mastermind behind the League of Villains was no more. With the help of his family and frankly wonderful therapist who taught him how to acknowledge his reactions and emotions, he was able to believe in Toshinori’s words when he’d assured them that it wasn’t a trick this time. Izuku wasn’t paranoid looking over his shoulder for threats.

He was able to rest easy knowing Shigaraki and Hisashi were in prison. Never to see the light of day. Of course, his mother would haunt him. Dog every one of his steps until the day she too, was behind bars. For good.

But in the light of All for One's fall, the threat his mother posed seemed almost insignificant. After all, how could a villain like her reach him when he was surrounded by a *real* family? One that would protect and love him, just like his therapist said a genuine family was supposed to?

Hawks certainly disliked Sir Nighteye, and the extra work he ended up with because the man was currently under investigation only made him dislike him even more.

How come the Commission decided to force *him* to handle the Overhaul case? How come he couldn't just go to his favorite chicken wing place and take a break?

Hawks didn't know, but now he had to sort through all the evidence that Nighteye's team had accumulated during their own investigations. Overhaul was definitely a shady character and S-Class Villain.

With a five-finger contact Quirk that destroyed and reshaped things to the holder's desire, he was infinitely more dangerous than the run-of-the-mill villain. His Quirk alone sky-rocketed him into S-Class right next to Shigaraki Tomura.

Or it would've if Shigaraki wasn't locked away.

But the Hero Commission expected him to get rid of Overhaul as soon as possible, but Keigo already had something in the works. Everyone had seen what happened during Kamino and during the Hosu Incident.

For the first time in a while, Keigo wanted to take on yet another intern. It was only luck that he'd already taken on Tokoyami, who was classmates with the infamous Midoriya Izuku.

He was excited to meet the kid that the press had turned their back on, and piss off the Commission. He was excited to teach the kid to fly properly, and show him that the world of Pros had his back.

Overhaul could wait. After all, he was currently at a standstill with his investigations. There hadn't been any movement since before Hosu, and Overhaul's mafia was difficult to track if they left no hints behind.

He opened his emails on his phone and started to type one out to Principal Nedzu with a grin.

Chisaki hated dirty things, but more than that he hated heroes who couldn't see the whole picture of his master plan.

They always preached that the appearance of Quirks was *natural* . Just human evolution. Chisaki had doubts. He was almost certain they had been born in science labs all those years ago. A government project meant to create an army of superhumans that got out of hand. And it only grew from there, a massive government conspiracy that changed reality as they knew it. Quirks were *created* .

Quirks were a disgusting result of *human experimentation.*

It was disgusting. Chisaki hated it. How could an entire society idolize the very thing that made them fake? That made them monsters? How could they go about their lives, not realizing that they weren't even real? Chisaki had to fix this broken world.

He had to eradicate Quirks. He had to use Eri's quirk to his advantage to achieve his dream. He would become the savior of this world and everyone would be grateful to him! The world could go back to the way it used to be before the Quirk Wars.

A world where his Yakuza ruled, and no one could do anything to stop them. They could restore their former glory!

Overhaul stood from his desk and made his way through the twisting and turning hallways of the compound. Eri was already waiting for him.

He approached the massive, vault-like door at the end of the hall. Chronostasis was standing next to it, and opened it for him when he finally arrived, his expression impossible to see while the man's bird mask was on.

Overhaul entered the dark room, turned on the lights with a click and admired the small child strapped to the chair before him. Her eyes were wide and terrified, bright red and innocent. Overhaul didn't even feel a pang in his chest, nor any guilt for what was to come. He felt nothing, in fact. What was one child compared to his grand dream? What was one child, compared to millions?

"Eri," He said, as he pulled his gloves off. The girl flinched, but said nothing. "If you didn't have a cursed Quirk, I wouldn't have to do this,"

A lie, obviously. But it kept her in check, and he liked to see the fear on her face turn into terror. A sinister smile tugged at his lips.

"This is all your fault!" He exclaimed with a boisterous laugh, as he activated his Quirk. Blood splattered everywhere, and he only laughed harder.

This whole world was cursed. He was the only one who could save them. He *had* to do this. He had to.

Eri was the keystone to the new world.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed this chapter!

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Also! I forgot to add last chapter that this fic could've very well ended with Kamino Ward in a nice little bow, but I decided to end it at the Cultural Festival. Mainly because I wanted to write my version of Izuku saving Eri, and I wanted to see Eri enjoying the Cultural Festival with Izuku and her fam <3 Also I felt like it would be very healing for Izuku to save Eri from a situation he used to be in, to prove to himself that he's truly a hero <3

Chapter 92

Chapter Summary

Beginning of the Provision License arc!!

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the delay with this chapter! (I say delay because it was supposed to come out on the 8th or 9th but I got covid... I'm fine now though!!! So here you guys go!) <3 Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A month passed without Izuku really realizing it. He and his classmates had been busy with school work, perfecting their ultimate moves, going to the U.S.J. to finally get their rescue training, and going to sessions with Hound Dog unless you were Izuku, who went to a different therapist.

Sessions with Hound Dog became mandatory for the Hero Course, despite the protests of some—read: Kacchan—of his classmates.

They were all healing in their own ways, each at their own pace. Dad was extra vigilant in making sure Izuku's classmates didn't skip a session with the school counselor.

It wasn't perfect. Nothing ever was, but they all supported each other. Sometimes that meant going on a shopping spree using Endeavor's credit card that Todoroki had forgotten he even had. Sometimes it was helping his dads make dinner for everyone in the dorms when they all spent the night away from the apartment.

The time passed quickly, and before any of them knew it, the Provisional License Exam was upon them. They'd been preparing for weeks, and yet Izuku still felt anxious. What if one of them didn't pass? What if they *all* failed?

It was questions and worries like this that made it impossible to sleep the night before the exam. He couldn't even take a nap on the bus on the way there because everyone was just as nervous as he was and *loud* about it.

Not even Dabi's reassurances were enough to calm the pit in his stomach. It only got worse once they were off the bus and they stood before the building where they were to take their test.

It was strange to see so many classes from different regions all condensed together like this.

"Oh I'm so nervous," Uraraka murmured next to him, shifting from foot to foot. "What if I fail?"

"What if *I* fail? How do I face Tensei?" Iida replied back, arms swinging anxiously. "How do I face my family?"

"I know right?" Denki chimed in, "Imagine them being all excited to hear the results only to know that you failed spectacularly…"

"Way to kill my excitement," Sero commented, clutching his numbered suitcase in a death grip. Izuku looked around nervously once more, realizing that other Hero school students were staring. Very intently.

Someone from Ketsubutsu Academy approached with a kind smile that didn't reach his eyes. The stranger took his classmates' hands in his own, chattering away without a care. When he tried to take Izuku's hands into his own, Kacchan nearly bit their head off, shoving them away.

"Don't touch him," Kacchan snapped, teeth barred like he was prepared to bite if the need arose. The poor stranger who Izuku would later learn was named Shindo, raised his eyebrows and held his hands up in surrender.

“My bad, my bad. I won’t,” He responded, eyes narrowed as he retreated back to his own class.

Izuku, while not surprised by Kacchan’s protectiveness, wasn’t exactly prepared to see it in action. Usually it was after a villain attack, when he was being harassed by the press, or when he had nightmares. To see it put to use in front of a stranger who didn’t seem to have any ill-intent was surprisingly *adorable.*

To know that someone he loved as much as Kacchan was so ready to defend him from any threat unseen or otherwise, was reassuring.

Once the other schools were done staring at them, thanks to Kacchan’s heated glares, Shouta spoke up. “Alright everyone, let’s get inside so all of you can change into your Hero Costumes.”

Most of his classmates seemed to be relieved at the prospect of having a break from all the staring that the other schools were doing. Izuku wanted nothing more than for the test to start so he could stop worrying so much about how it was going to go.

He would feel better once he was busy doing something productive rather than stewing on the what-ifs of the test.

Getting to the massive locker rooms the facility was accommodated with was a hassle all on its own. From the jostling of other hero students to the confusing layout of the building itself. The building had massive navigation signs hanging from the ceiling, each with a hero school name on it, but still they all managed to walk past Yuuei’s designated locker room due to all the noise. Shouta’s exclamation—and his dad never *exclaimed* , so it really made them all realize just how loud it was in the main area—was the only thing that kept them all from getting hopelessly lost even before the test began.

Once dressed up, Shouta showed them all to the room that the other students were already gathering in, pressed against each other in one massive crowd like a can of sardines. Being adverse to being in such close proximity to loud, excited teenagers did nothing to soothe his anxiety until Todoroki, Toshi, Tokoyami and Kacchan took their places around him. His chest

swelled with gratitude at such a small but meaningful gesture. Had he looked that stressed? Or had they been worried about him this entire time?

"This place is packed," Todoroki commented serenely from in front of their little group.

"Is it too late to go home?" Toshi asked with an exaggerated groan as he tugged on Izuku's sleeve. "I don't need a license this badly. I can just leave,"

Kacchan glared fiercely at Toshi and crossed his arms. "You'll never be a Pro with that shitty attitude, Mindfuck,"

"Mindfuck—?" Toshi parroted, eyebrows raised so high that they seemed to melt into his hairline. "Can you be a little more creative, Explodo-Boy?"

"Can you be a little more dedicated?!"

"May darkness just swallow me whole," Tokoyami sighed. "Jesus Christ,"

"Same," Todoroki said, completely deadpan. Izuku shifted awkwardly as Toshi and Kacchan snapped at each other, going back and forth like an intense game of tennis.

Before they could start a friendly yelling match, a very tired and overworked man walked—no, *trudged* —up to the podium set up on the platform at the front of the room. The poor guy rubbed the back of his neck and leaned his forearms on the podium.

He blinked out at the crowd of students and for a moment there was nothing but awkward silence as everyone quieted in anticipation. "Um," The man spoke, seeming to sway with exhaustion. "Well then, let's do that provisional license thing…I'm Mera from Heroes Public Safety Commission. The kind of sleep I like is non-REM sleep. Nice to meet you,"

Izuku and Kacchan shared a look that said: *is this man okay?*

As he continued on, he sunk lower and lower onto the podium, looking for all he knew, like he was about to take a sorely needed nap.

"I've been so busy that I haven't slept for two days," Mera added, his voice muffled by his arms that were pillowed around his head. "We're short-staffed, and I just want to sleep. With that, I give you the orientation."

"He's not even bothering to act awake," Izuku heard Jirou mutter to herself.

"Is he gonna be okay?" Todoroki asked his question not exactly directed at anyone in particular.

"About the contents of the exam… honestly all 1,540 examinees here will have to win through a free-for-all exercise, based on speed. The first hundred to fulfill the requirements will pass."

His shoulders hunched up as nervous energy coursed through him. Only a *hundred* of them would pass?! That would mean only ten percent of the examinees would pass, which almost made it impossible for him and his entire class to pass the first time unless they had a plan!

He shared a look of dread with Toshi, finding the same nervousness reflected back at him.

"A lot has happened out in the world," The exam proctor continued, not sensing the nervous shift of the crowd. "Villains are getting stronger, as we all saw during the Hosu and Kamino incidents. The hero industry is over-saturated with professionals, and yet we're forced to be more selective with who we admit a license. Only the truly dedicated and experienced will be able to pass such a rigorous exam."

The man's statement was met with more silence. Around him, his classmates tensed, all remembering how terrible Kamino Ward had been for them. Izuku took a step closer to Kacchan, seeking comfort from the ugly reminder that All for One had wanted to steal his *body* .

“So anyway,” Mera mumbled as if he didn’t just bring up traumatic events to *teenagers.* A projected screen popped up behind him. “Here are the requirements.” He brought out a target and an orange ball. As he spoke, the projection behind him aided in his explanation. “The examinee will put three of these—” he lifted the target as an example, “—targets on their person. They can go anywhere as long as it’s an exposed area. You will also have six of these balls. The targets are made to only light up if they’re hit with these balls. If all three of your targets light up, then you’re out. The person who lights up your third target will have it count as their defeat. You win this round by defeating two people. That’s it for the rules.”

As he finished up speaking, a swarm of workers walked around the room, distributing the targets and balls.

“We’ll start three minutes after we’ve gotten to everyone,”

With that, the walls and floor began to shake violently, and Izuku’s head whipped up to watch in utter astonishment as the room around them unfolded like a cardboard box. All around them was the testing area, similar to the U.S.J. in the fashion that it had different types of landscapes and areas.

“Use your Quirks well and do your best. I hope the developments are speedy so that I can rest as soon as possible…”

Izuku was still gaping with his mouth open wide when an employee handed him three targets and six balls. Without really thinking he put the targets on, and a hand came up to his jaw to close his mouth.

“You’ll catch flies that way,” Came Dabi’s remark. Izuku cast a glare at him and elbowed him without any real force.

“C’mon Izuku,” Kacchan grumbled, in his endearingly grumpy way. “Everyone’s already moving we’ve only got a minute until the test starts,”

Looking around Izuku realized that Kacchan was indeed correct he hastened to follow after his classmates. They ended up in the rocky terrain, instead of heading for the more densely populated city area.

There was frantic chatter of Iida trying and failing to come up with some sort of plan. He was muttering so fast that his words mushed together until Todoroki spoke up.

“I’ll be going on my own,” though he didn’t look happy to be isolating himself from his peers. He almost looked anxious. “My quirk would only get in the way,”

Before he could even take a step away from Class 1-A, Kacchan and Toshi grabbed him on either side and huffed. “Listen Icy-Hot, your ice is admittedly something we’ll need on our side. The other schools will be gunning for us,”

“Why?” Yaomomo asked, brow furrowed with worry.

[The Sports Festival.] Izuku signed helpfully and understanding dawned on her face.

“I see,” She tapped her chin in thought, “Everyone knows our Quirks already. And what's more, they’ve seen our strengths and weaknesses,”

“Oh *shit,”* Denki muttered, “We’re so fucking screwed.”

“We are *not!”* Kirishima punched his shoulder playfully. “If we work as a team we should all be able to avoid getting crushed!”

[We’ve been through so many villain attacks.] Izuku signed. [A test is nothing in comparison.]

That seemed to cheer his classmates up in some way.

"The test has started!"

It was pandemonium instantly. Seemingly out of nowhere Hero class after Hero class closed in on them from all sides. Gone was the fragile confidence they just built, but Izuku refused to let the pressure get to him so early.

"It's about time we got to crush Yuuei!" Someone in the mob shouted, followed by an excited chuckle. They all thought it was going to be easy? Izuku shifted his stance, and Dabi came to stand at his side, ready for a fight.

Did they all think just because they watched the Sports Festival that they had the exam in the bag? Sure, they had the upper hand here, but having knowledge and putting it to good use were two different things.

Class 1-A waited in tense silence for the first ball to be thrown. Eyes flickering uneasily back and forth, it didn't escape his notice when the assault abruptly began. First there was a wall of ice to his right, covering the classmates that didn't have defensive or evasive quirks, courtesy of Todoroki. Then there was Yaoyorozu who created a shield to defend herself, and Aoyama who hid behind her.

Izuku covered Toshi with Kacchan's help, both of them using their quirks to block any incoming projectiles. Kacchan with his explosions, and Izuku with Dabi as a human shield.

Jirou used a shockwave with her new equipment to stop a student's quirk from hitting them from the ground.

But then just as the assault concluded the kind, smiling student from Ketsubutsu used his earthquake-like Quirk to crack the earth and forced them to separate. The fissures were huge, cutting them off from each other and making it hard to keep their own balance.

Izuku latched onto Dabi on pure instinct. And they fell in a heap with two classmates falling in after them. Once Izuku got his bearings he realized that he was with Tokoyami and Kouda

he smiled. Admittedly everything would be more fun if Kacchan had fallen with them, but he thoroughly enjoyed being around these two.

"Ah," Tokoyami said eloquently as they realized there was a wall of rock separating them from their class. "That's… unfortunate."

"No edgy statement today?" Dabi asked, not mocking but more curious than anything.

"I've run out of phrases," Tokoyami admitted, looking sheepish. Izuku turned to Kouda who was having a whispered conversation with a bird.

He raised his hands to sign just as Kouda signed to him. [I'm having the birds track our classmates.]

[That's genius!] Izuku signed back, a wide grin splitting his face. Tokoyami seemed surprised at Kouda's excellent idea as well. [Is there anyone on their own, or are they all in groups like we are?]

[Groups.]

Izuku let out a sigh of relief. That was really lucky, and honestly an ideal situation now that he was really thinking about it. Being in one huge group together wasn't the best of plans if you considered how stressful it would get once the group began to thin.

Staying in small, but efficient groups was both a disadvantage—if you were cornered—and an advantage. The advantage was needing to take down fewer opponents to be able to pass.

The two he'd ended up with were a perfect well-rounded group. Kouda could keep an eye out for enemies and their allies, while Tokoyami was capable of long-range attacks and short-range, just like Izuku.

Kouda was also useful for stealthy animal attacks.

[We should move.] Kouda signed. [The groups around here are too big to fight on our own.]

Izuku nodded, knowing for a fact that just because they were separated from their classmates didn't mean that other Hero students couldn't find them here. Glancing around he realized that they were actually pretty exposed. They had been blocked off with a massive wall of rock, where the terrain had been ripped up and moved about, but otherwise, all around them was even, open ground with no cover.

It was better if they moved to one of the city areas after all. They set off immediately, Tokoyami bringing up the rear of their group so Dark Shadow could easily cover for them. Izuku took the lead, with Dabi at his side, flames flickering and swirling around his fists and forearms.

They made quick progress crossing over the rocky terrain, and Izuku was actually surprised that they didn't run into an ambush immediately. Behind them where their classmates had been split up was loud with exclamations and Quirks going off sporadically. Izuku and his small group actually seemed to have gotten lucky.

"So far twenty people have passed." came a monotone announcement. Izuku

When they arrived at the city, Kouda tugged on both his and Dabi's collars, yanking them backward. A bird rested on his shoulder, Izuku noticed.

[What?] Izuku signed quickly, as they ducked into the nearest building.

[Bird says winds are changing. A Quirk.]

[Oh.]

Tokoyami, who had been quiet the entirety of their short trip watched the rapid-fire conversation. Luckily it seemed like he was keeping up.

All four of them peered through the window to look outside, where there were other students finally making their appearance. Groups attacked each other, desperate to pass the first part of the test.

He watched as one of them used a lighter to make fire and manipulate it with what seemed like a Pyrokinesis Quirk. Her partner unsheathed a pair of daggers and threw them at the group of approaching students. Izuku watched all of this happen with trepidation, worried that either group might injure each other badly, but the knife-thrower obviously knew what they were doing as his knives caught on their opponent's clothing and pinned them in place.

And then that's when it happened.

A huge gust of wind swept through the street Izuku had just been standing in, and the balls that the students had been holding onto were swept away. In the next second, a new gust of wind ripped through the air and dozens upon dozens of stolen balls came back down and eliminated everyone within their sights.

"120 examinees have been eliminated?! 21 people have now passed!"

"120?!" Tokoyami whispered in shock. "Did *one* person take down that many people?!"

"That seems to be the case," Dabi replied, "but I think it's safe to go outside now,"

Cautiously they approached the door of the office building they'd rushed into, but just as Izuku reached for the doorknob a protective wall of metal began to descend around the doors and windows.

“You really should’ve checked to see if the *inside* was safe,” A deep, alluring voice said from behind them.

Izuku whipped around in alarm, already assuming a fighting stance. On the other side of the room, leaning against the wall next to a door that led to a storage room—where the group had been hiding, no doubt—was another hero student.

Another announcement sounded through the room. ***“50 examinees have now passed. Halfway there, people. I can*** **taste** ***my soon-to-be nap,”***

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed this chapter!

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 93

Chapter Notes

I'll be updating three chapters today, and then updating every day until Christmas! Enjoy!! Hopefully this will motivate me to write chapter 101 for new years!

Update 1 of 3 <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Next to the student who called out to them were three others, all wearing the same high school uniform. Dark Shadow wrapped around Tokoyami, creating a protective barrier around himself and giving him shadowy claws.

Izuku looked around desperately to find even a hint of those dark figures that had been following them dutifully since he left the apartment this morning. He would do fine without their support, but having invisible allies right now would be incredibly helpful.

He didn't see them and had to deduce that they might've been stuck outside.

Both groups sized each other up for a moment, not moving. Then the boy who was probably the ringleader spoke up, pointing in Izuku's direction. "You're that kid from Kamino right?" he asked, not bothering to wait for Izuku's response. "I saw all of it go down on the news. You're powerful, yes?"

Izuku wanted to say that he was probably considered pretty powerful but Dabi answered for him with a nod. "What of it?" The fire-wielding man asked.

"I want to fight you," the boy answered, with a smirk that anyone would've found attractive. In fact, with his long, dark hair and wide round eyes, anyone would be hard-pressed to think of something that was unattractive about him. Except Izuku didn't really care to look.

Once was really more than enough. He wasn't as attractive as Kacchan, anyway.

During his inner musings about this person's attractiveness, he hadn't noticed that the other three had darted forward to go toe-to-toe with Tokoyami, Kouda, and Dabi. From the sounds of things, they managed to be holding their own pretty well as the ringleader approached Izuku, unarmed and humming an unfamiliar melody.

For a second Izuku didn't understand why the man would be humming. And then Izuku was hit with an abrupt wave of exhaustion that mad him want to curl up on the ground and sleep *right now.*

In the back of his mind, he knew it was a Quirk, but his first instinct was to get on the floor and curl around his sword. He closed his eyes, content to just take a quick nap when he heard a loud beeping noise.

And then another, before hands yanked him up by his collar and pulled him backward.

Izuku grunted in annoyance and opened his eyes, only to see that Kouda had distracted his opponent with rats and made his way over to save Izuku from having his last target activated.

He blinked tiredly at Kouda, who just stared at him with a stern stare born of concern. The poor kid who was being attacked by rats ran into the humming man, sending them both sprawling on the floor as he cried, "Get them away from me! Go away! Go away, no one wants you here!"

On the other side of the room, Tokoyami had already taken out one of their opponents and was helping Dabi with the other. Kouda and Izuku shared another look.

[It's his Quirk.] Izuku hastened to explain as the humming one shoved the rat away from his classmate. [His humming puts you to sleep.]

Kouda just simply nodded and went over to the humming man who had turned his back on them to stomp on some bugs that had crawled into the building. Apparently, his classmate was terrified of rats, and he of spiders.

Neither of them even cared anymore solely focused on the object of their fear.

Izuku watched as Kouda took both of them out without much fuss, seeing as both of them had begun to cling to Kouda in an attempt to escape the grasp of their respective fears.

“Midoriya, would you like to get a point?” Tokoyami asked as Kouda did a cute little dance to celebrate his quick and decisive victory. Izuku’s heart couldn’t handle the cuteness.

Izuku shook his head. [I didn’t do much this time around. You can take the point I need to go find Kacchan.]

Tokoyami looked torn for a moment. “But we could go as a team, it would be more efficient.”

[I’m not on my own.] Izuku signed in response. [Plus, Kouda probably knows his general location.]

In response, Kouda nodded. On a small notepad that he carried around in his many pockets, he wrote down Kacchan’s location and handed it over.

“Just take the point Midoriya. I’m not leaving you to go find Bakugou on your own. It’s very impolite of me,” Tokoyami grumbled, dragging the somehow unconscious last member of the group they’d been fighting.

Reluctantly he did as he was asked, and they bid Kouda farewell as he headed to the designated rest area for participants who already passed.

As the test progressed, Katsuki had seen a lot of his classmates around, who already passed. For example, he'd seen Denki, Sero, Kirishima, and Mina as one big group who managed to make it on their own.

About fifteen minutes ago he'd seen Uraraka, Aoyama, Iida, and Tsuyu pass by him, having also passed. Jirou, Yaoyorozu, Shouji, and Shinsou passed as well.

He hadn't seen any of his classmates who hadn't passed yet, and he was anxious to know if Izuku had passed already without him seeing, or if he was still out there trying to get points.

It left him anxious, but that didn't mean he wasn't trying to pass anymore, just biding his time until he saw Izuku. He had already secured a point and had *only* come across people who passed since.

He was now in the highway area with the bridge and cluster of buildings.

"He's gotta be around here somewhere," a voice said nearby. Katsuki whipped around in the direction it had come from. The city area. It *sounded* like Tokoyami.

And yet he made no move towards the sound, just in case it was a trap. Instead, he climbed up the ladder connected to the bridge and glanced around. There was no one on the bridge except for weirdly shaped meatballs that look suspiciously like flesh. He paid it no mind and peeked over to see the approaching group. For a few seconds, they didn't emerge from wherever they were and Katsuki was quickly losing patience.

Then from behind someone cleared their throat. Katsuki shot a glare over his shoulder and attempted to blast the offender away, exclaiming, "Fuck off!"

Which didn't work. He just dodged backward, and massive fleshy fingers floated in the air around him. They shot forward, and Katsuki blasted most of them away.

However, even though he'd been certain he got all of them, something warm and soft caught his arm and suddenly he was consumed by the nasty bit of flesh that got on him. Before he knew it, he was a small fleshy blob on the ground, glaring up at the asshole who fucking did this to him.

"97 examinees have passed! Three openings are left! Make it count people, I'm running out of coffee!"

He tried to move and to speak but he realized he didn't have a mouth, nor any muscles to roll himself anywhere. Fear seized him momentarily as he realized he might not actually pass this fucking test because he was *stuck as a meatball.* A second later a shadow passed over him, followed by two others. They landed on the bridge right in front of him, and he instantly recognized the head of green hair and Dabi's purple burn scars.

The man who turned him into a human meatball rolled his eyes. "Your friend has a foul mouth," He stated. "He annoyed me so I turned into a—"

"Meatball!" Dabi exclaimed, a laugh bursting from his lips as he clutched his stomach. "Look, Izuku, he's really a meatball!"

Izuku, his favorite person ever in the entire world, took one look at Katsuki and covered his mouth so Katsuki couldn't see his amused smile. Or so he *thought.* Katsuki glared at both of them.

"This isn't the time!" He wanted to say, but still, nothing came out. He resorted to glaring even harder. Dabi was laughing so hard that Katsuki was sure he should've passed out by now.

The kid with the weirdly shaped eyes glared at the group, obviously not pleased to be ignored so thoroughly as Tokoyami whipped out his phone *to take a picture.*

Like the fucking traitor he was.

None of them were even paying attention as MeatBall man attacked them with his massive floating fingers in the sky. Tokoyami wasn't going to dodge in time, and Katsuki internally chuckled at the thought of a meatball Tokoyami suffering the same fate as him, when Izuku dashed forward and shoved him out of the way.

Which spoiled any happiness Katsuki could've gotten out of this situation. Meatball Izuku was cute though, in his own little meatball way. A few green tufts of fluffy hair poked out at random angles and his freckles were splashed all around where his cheeks and nose should've been.

Soon though, they were forced to turn their attention to the battle going on in front of them as Dabi threw verbal jabs at the man,—not that Katsuki bothered to listen—attacking at the same time as Tokoyami so their opponent wouldn't have time to retaliate.

Tokoyami, in the end, was the one to finally land a hit with Dark Shadows help, and Katsuki could feel his body morphing back to its original shape. Before he could understand exactly *how* it was happening, he was standing on his feet again and rushing forward with an explosion at the ready.

He slammed his hand into the poor guy's abdomen and sent him flying. Izuku walked up from behind and tugged on Katsuki's gauntlet to get his attention.

[Hi, Kacchan!] Izuku signed, with a smile so bright that it almost hurt to look at.

"Hey nerd," He responded, "Did you come looking for me?"

All around them the meatballs turned into people. Katsuki was too distracted to care, attention solely on Izuku's rapidly signing hands as Dabi fought them off.

[Yes! Glad I found you.]

“I’m glad too, dork, now let’s pass this test so we can go figure out if everyone else passed too.” Izuku gave him a firm nod and they both faced what was left of the group of people that were no longer in meatball form.

In tandem their rag-tag group rushed forward, already reaching for vulnerable targets. In a matter of seconds, he, Izuku, and Tokoyami all passed and headed for the designated room where hopefully, the rest of their classmates were waiting for them.

“Congratulations! Our 100 examinees have passed! Please head to the rest area and wait until the last phase of the test begins!”

When they arrived, it turned out that everyone else had made it.

“What took you guys so long?” Todoroki asked when they finally approached.

“You won’t believe this baby brother,” Dabi said, slinging his arm around Todoroki’s shoulders, grinning at Izuku and Kacchan. “Izuku and Bakubro got turned into meatballs.”

“I—” Uraraka glanced between the two of them and Izuku ignored how red his cheeks got in embarrassment. “What do you mean, *meatball?!”*

“I managed to get pictures,” Tokoyami replied, pulling out his phone. Izuku almost wanted to grab it and forcefully delete the pictures, but he also kind of wanted to see what he looked like as a meatball.

“Hand it over! Hand it over!” Ashido exclaimed making grabby hands for Tokoyami’s phone. Uraraka nodded her head so hard it might as well have fallen off. Under so much pressure Tokoyami could only comply and hand over the goods.

Kacchan launched himself forward when Ashido let out a raucous laugh, handing it off to Uraraka. Everyone who ended up with the phone was met with a snarling Bakugou that they all dutifully ignored.

"I hate all of you." Kacchan declared when he realized he was getting nowhere. Their classmates laughed and cooed at the pictures before bribing Tokoyami into sending them to their class group chat so they could save those pictures.

Izuku probably should've been more embarrassed, but frankly, it had been too long since they had a chance to act this normal. More often than not they were being accosted by violent villains.

Toshi came up and offered both of them glasses of water silently with a look of pity. They all sat together, chatting away and relaxing, until the screens in the room turned on, showing them the testing area they had just been in.

All conversation stopped abruptly as the exam proctor, Mera, spoke. ***"Please watch this."***

Of course, everyone was already watching, so Todoroki commented, "I wonder what'll happen?"

Izuku was rather curious as well until everything on the screen started violently exploding. There were exclamations of surprise as well as utter confusion as the screen showed each testing area in ruins and on fire. It reminded Izuku of Kamino, in the worst way possible.

"This next test will be the last. We will have you perform rescue exercises as bystanders in this disaster site, and test how well you carry out suitable rescue procedures."

"There are people in there!" Shouji suddenly pointed out, suddenly pale.

"HUH?!" Hagakure exclaimed nonsensically, "But why?! That's so dangerous!"

"The civilians you will be rescuing are people who have undergone training to be professional people-in-need-of-rescue. The "Help Us Company," or "H.U.C." for short. The people from H.U.C. have dressed up as injured victims of a terrorist attack. They are scattered through the testing site. We will now have you all carry out their rescue!" There was a brief pause. ***"In addition, we will score your rescue based on points and if you have more points than the benchmark at the end of the exam then you pass. We will start in ten minutes so please use the restroom and take care of any other business right now."***

Ten minutes later, an alarm rang through the room, which made Izuku nearly choke on his water.

The screen came to life again, and they were all given a brief explanation of the situation going on outside. The walls around them began to unfold.

"Due to heavily damaged roads, the first group of rescue workers has been delayed! Until they arrive, the heroes in the area will lead the rescue efforts. Save as many lives as you can. Start!"

There was a whirlwind of activity almost instantly as hordes of students rushed to get to the scene first and be of assistance. Izuku's eyes were still on the screen before them, trying to remind himself that no, he wasn't at the epicenter of this attack, that no, he wasn't back in Kamino, fighting for his life.

This was an exercise. This was a *test.* Not real. Not reality.

Not Kamino. Not Kamino. *Not Kamino.*

The two scenes were too similar. No matter how many times he blinked away the figure of All for One standing in the rubble, he couldn't shake the fear nor the desperation that clogged his throat.

The terror at the thought that if All for One had succeeded, he'd be using Izuku's body right now to destroy the world.

If he had been any weaker…

He shuddered. "Midoriya?" Iida asked gently, hand coming to rest on Izuku's forearm. "Are you alright?"

The question garners the attention of the rest of the class, and that's when it seems to click for them. How similar it is to Kamino, and how Izuku might react to such a situation. Thankfully none of his classmates try to crowd and reassure him all at once. Instead, Yaoyorozu walks up and simply lays both her hands on his shoulders. It's strangely comforting, mostly because her eyes are soft and understanding and not at all judgmental.

"This is just a test, Midoriya-kun. No matter how much this might resemble Kamino Ward, it is *just* a test." Yaoyorozu said, kindly. "It's probably going to be difficult to remember that, but it would help to have familiar faces around you, right?"

Izuku thought it over for a moment. It would probably help him if he had someone who could ground him and assure him that he wasn't *back there.* He nodded, and Yaoyorozu tapped her chin in thought.

"How does grouping with Bakugou and Shinsou sound to you? Would they help?" She asked, and Izuku nodded again.

Then everyone started to separate into smaller groups at Yaoyorozu's suggestion and they also decided which area they'd assign themselves to. With everything situated, they headed out in their respective directions and assigned teams.

Kacchan, Toshi, and himself all arrived at the city area that had the most extensive damage. Everywhere he looked, there was fire, fake blood, and rubble everywhere.

He looked away, straining his ears in hopes of hearing anyone in need of assistance. For a moment there was nothing, and then: “Is anyone out there?!” A desperate, and strained female voice called. “Please help me!”

It was a welcome distraction from all the memories hiding right behind his eyelids, waiting for him to close his eyes just for a moment. The three of them moved toward the voice without actually talking to each other. It sounded like it came from a part of a collapsed building. Under all the rubble.

Toshi calls out, “We’re here, ma’am! Don’t move, can you tell us your condition?”

“Um—” Her voice was closer than before. Izuku spots a few loitering shadowy figures and waves them over. He has them hold the collapsing walls up as he enters the building. “My leg is trapped. I can’t—” her voice breaks with what sounds like genuine fear. “I can’t move it,”

Izuku found her first, with Toshi and Kacchan trailing behind, careful not to mess with anything that could compromise the integrity of the building. The walls around them were blasted with holes to hell and back. The floor they were standing on was littered with debris from the ceiling, and he could even see some electrical cords sparking nearby.

The victim was indeed stuck beneath an obviously fake slab of concrete. Yet, the way her face was scrunched up in pain looked very real and very frightening. He assessed her condition quickly, noting that she isn’t near anything that could hurt her or make the building collapse should they move the slab wrong.

Which is good. He channeled the calmest and collected part of himself, as he prepared himself to sign. Izuku needed to make sure she didn’t have any other injuries and that she was aware that she was in safe hands now.

[Hello ma’am.] He signed, even though he was almost positive that members of the H.U.C. wouldn’t bother learning sign language on his behalf. [We’re going to get you out of here just fine. My name is Morningstar. Can you tell me if you have any injuries we can’t see?]

Kacchan was surprisingly gentle as he spoke for him. The lady seems a little reassured as he speaks, and Toshi moves to one side of the slab and casts a glance at Izuku for assistance.

Wordlessly he goes to the other side and widens his stance in preparation to lift the concrete off of her.

“Alright,” Toshi’s voice shook, but not enough to be concerning. “We’re going to lift it on the count of three, and he’s—” He gestured to Kacchan, “—going to pick you up and assess your injuries before taking you to the first-aid station, okay?”

“One, two, three—”

Izuku realized almost instantly that the concrete was heavier than it looked, and would’ve taken a little effort to actually lift on his own. With Toshi’s help, it became easy, and they freed the trapped civilian with no complications.

After that, they escorted her to the first-aid area and relayed her condition to one of the hero students performing first-aid on the H.U.C. members.

For the better part of thirty minutes, they ushered injured elderly, children, and grown adults to the first-aid area with no problem. Izuku had almost forgotten the momentary panic that he’d felt when the test first began.

It almost seemed like they were almost done with rescuing when the overhead announcement blared through his ears.

“There has been a large-scale terrorist attack by villains!”

Explosion after explosion went off in the distance, making many of the hero students and mock civilians flinch.

Izuku, Toshi, and Kacchan had just dropped off a small sassy child. “Hey…” Toshi said to both of them, pointing in the direction of one of the explosions. “Look,”

Izuku, despite being terrified of what he’d see, looked over and felt his stomach plummet to the floor. Gang Orca and a mob of “villains,” were a ways off, but they were definitely too close to the first-aid center to be comfortable.

“Rescuing and fighting.” He heard Gang Orca mutter, “Can you do both at the same time?!”

“Villains have appeared and have started their pursuit! Hero candidates at the scene should continue their rescue efforts while also suppressing villains.”

“Rescuing and fighting?!” He heard a Shiketsu student snap, “Are they fucking serious?!”

“Aren’t they expecting too much?” Came another, unrecognizable voice from a different class.

“Now…” Gang Orca said, “What’ll you do?”

Izuku tried to remind himself that this was a test. After all, that was Gang Orca! Not some heinous villain out to snatch his body or beat him to a bloody pulp for betraying him! *Not All for One.*

The logical side of his brain said everything was fine, but the other side of his brain, the side that still shivered in fear when he thought of the League of Villains and his mother, was stronger.

He didn’t realize he wasn’t breathing until Toshi and Kacchan shook him out of his stupor.

“Hey, hey, hey!” Kacchan was saying, in tandem with Toshi’s panicked, “Shit, shit, shit,”

“You’re here. This is the provisional license exam,” The way Kacchan’s hands held both sides of his face was new and immensely comforting. “You’re here. With me, your *Kacchan* —” He spat the word Kacchan out and sounded rather embarrassed to have said it at all, but it made Izuku’s wobbly smile more genuine. “—I promise you’re safe with me and you’re *here,* Izu,”

Right. Right. When did he start thinking otherwise? Izuku nodded, more to himself than to Kacchan, and found himself putting his hands on Kacchan’s shoulders to prove it to himself.

Not Kamino. This was an exam. An exam that would end as soon as anything bad happened. An exam that his dads were watching and hoping he passed.

He took a moment to gather himself, forcing deep breathes into his lungs before he let go and nodded. [What needs to be done?]

“A group of heavy-hitters needs to hold the line,” Toshi said, expression grim and tight. “And everyone else needs to move the first-aid center until help arrives,”

All three of them shared a look. “Icy-Hot is already headed over with Wind Guy.” Kacchan said helpfully, “Izu can move a bunch of people easy, with his Quirk. Mindfuck, you help too,”

Toshi grumbled, “Really? Wind guy and Mindfuck? Where do you get this shit?”

“My genius brain, obviously.” Kacchan snapped, smirking in a way that was probably only endearing to Izuku.

[Kick ass.] Izuku signed with an identical smirk. Kacchan puffed up his cheeks and looked away, before storming off. Toshi and Izuku both got to work instantly, helping where needed.

There were a handful of students already headed toward a new area with the most severely injured victims, and Izuku decided to help by pushing power into the nearest demons that had followed him around in a little train during this entire exercise.

Despite the squeals and gasps of surprise, non of the victims complained when they were lifted up by one of Izuku's little shadows, and whisked away to the new first-aid area.

Toshi took his own civilian to carry, and Izuku picked up the small child that they had just rescued before Gang Orca showed up. He ignored the explosions popping in the distance and the flash of heat from the fire that was most likely Todoroki's.

The evacuation of the civilians took priority. Dabi manifested himself to offer assistance to Uraraka and Yaoyorozu both of whom were aiding three civilians. The chaos all around was surprisingly organized as well as disorganized. People went to and fro, shouting orders and offering each other assistance when needed.

Someone was helping set up the new first-aid center with a bunch of Shiketsu students. Another was checking over the last of the civilians that had been taken over to the new area.

Izuku and Toshi set their respective civilians down gently and looked back towards the on-going battle only to realize there was no one left at the old first-aid station, and that Shindo had been paralyzed during battle. They both darted forward, and grabbed one of his arms to get him out of harms way.

In front of them, Todoroki, Inasa, and Kacchan sort of had the battle under control for now. The fire tornado was very impressive. Just as Gang Orca was unscrewing a water bottle—most likely so he could combat the effects of the heat on his Quirk—a blaring alarm screeched through the air, followed by a new, welcomed announcement.

"That's finally it for the test, people. Congratulations. I'll be down there shortly to announce the results."

A few minutes later, Kacchan was huffing with exertion, next to him as the exam proctor showed them their results on a screen. Instead of looking for his own name first, he made

sure Toshi and Kacchan passed. With a breath of relief at finding them, he searched for his own.

He felt a clap on his back before his eyes locked onto his own name.

“Ya passed, you damn nerd! Don’t look so terrified!” Kacchan exclaimed, smiling. “We *all* passed!”

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys liked it! This chapter is unedited <3

Chapter 94

Chapter Notes

Update 2 of 3 <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku, Toshi, and Dabi all spent the last two days recounting the glorious battle that was the provisional license exam to Hizashi. Of course, each iteration done by Dabi was embellished and exaggerated in only the best ways, even though he hadn't appeared often during the exam itself.

The class 1-A group chat was a nightmare all on its own, with how relieved and overjoyed all his classmates were over passing. All Izuku wanted to do was sleep for a week from the sheer exhaustion of worrying over the results of the exam, but school kept him too busy to even think about doing such a thing.

Like right now, the classroom was noisy and way louder than normal. Even two days later, the adrenaline rush hadn't worn off for most of them. Todoroki, Kacchan, and Toshi seemed to be the only ones who looked halfway like they were getting over the initial excitement.

Well, with Toshi it was always hard to tell, with how he always looked a second away from passing out due to lack of sleep. And Todoroki's face always looked stern and cold even when he was trying to look relaxed, and Kacchan was always wearing a frown as if someone had kicked his dog right before his eyes.

All in all, they acted the most normal, so Izuku decided that he'd enjoy their presence compared to Iida and Uraraka who were both talking so animatedly he doubted he'd even be able to get a word signed out.

All four of them congregated to the black of the classroom, where Tokoyami and Kouda were having a completely silent conversation, signing back and forth to each other leisurely.

Four turned into six, and they all—mostly Toshi—lamented about how cruel it was that they didn't get a break after taking such an exhausting test.

"I mean come on," Toshi said, slumped over the desk he was sitting at. "They even pitted us against Gang Orca, I think I'm entitled to financial compensation for all the years *that* took from my life,"

"Mn," Todoroki said eloquently, taking a sip straight out of Toshi's thermos that definitely wasn't full of scalding hot coffee. "Mother was proud though,"

[You went home to see her?] Kouda asked.

"And my sister and brother," Todoroki added, with the smallest but gentlest smile.

From the corner of his eye, Izuku saw Toshi blink once. Then twice, and blush furiously at the rare sight of Todoroki's smile. Izuku raised his eyebrows at Kacchan and they both shared a conspiring glance.

This blossoming development was unexpected but entirely welcome. Ultimately Izuku decided that he wasn't going to get involved in whatever relationship was growing between his brother and his classmate. He was entirely too content watching from the sidelines unless a little push in the right direction was deemed necessary.

Kouda and Tokoyami picked up their conversation again, and Izuku was too drained to participate. Ever since they all passed their provisional license exam he's been tired and no amount of coffee or hugs from both of his dads helped. Despite that he took a moment to enjoy how normal this atmosphere was.

No villains were lurking. No pressure to succeed and fight for their lives. Just a normal highschool morning before classes began.

Kacchan suddenly dug through his pockets before presenting him with a red collar. Jingling on the collar, was a bell and a name-tag in the shape of a bone with the name Edgar engraved.

"Here," He said simply, cheeks pink and adorable. "I noticed your mutt doesn't have his collar anymore so I got him a new one."

Izuku's chest swelled with warmth, and his eyes were suspiciously stinging against his will. With gentle hands, he reached out to take such a thoughtful gift, even if most people would deem it utterly insignificant. To Izuku it was everything. It was a reminder that even if Stain was gone, there were pieces of him left. Living, breathing pieces of him.

Then Kacchan looked around and seemed to notice Edgar's absence like he had assumed that the half-demon, half-dog would never part from Izuku's side again. "Where is he anyway?"

[Nedzu thought it'd be a good idea to keep him in his office during school.] He signed, pocketing the collar with a radiant smile. [I think they'll get along.]

"That's—" Tokoyami began, brows knitted together, "That sounds terrifying."

"A demon dog and Principal Nedzu becoming friends?" Toshi interjected, with a dramatic shudder. "The world might as well end,"

"The world's *going* to end if everyone doesn't sit down in their seats and get ready for class," Shouta remarked, from where he stood, having gone unnoticed at the door of the classroom. In place of his usual frown, was a lazy smirk as he saw his gremlins still socializing and making noise. Definitely ten times more frightening than Nedzu becoming friends with Izuku's pet demon.

The resulting reaction was instantaneous. Everyone froze mid-conversation and rushed to their seats like they were on fire, Izuku and Toshi included albeit accompanied by Toshi's nervous laughter.

In an act of mercy, Shouta waited for them to settle down before continuing. “So usually first years won’t participate in work studies or internships outside of the ones you do for after the Sports Festival.” Which was a curious way of starting class.

And it only made Izuku wonder if they were once again doing something out of the norm just like they had done with the license exam. Otherwise, why would Shouta even bother mentioning it?

Ashido was the first to raise her hand, “What do you mean by usually?”

“I just came from a meeting where Nedzu informed all the teachers that first years have been allowed to take on these work studies.” He said, rubbing the back of his neck. “As such, everyone agreed that since these aren’t the same as your Sports Festival internships, we should have senior students better explain the differences.”

Shouta then motioned to the door and said, “Come in,”

Immediately someone opened the door and three students stepped inside, but Izuku only recognized one of them instantly. Mirio was impossible to forget, especially after the entire fiasco with Sir Nighteye.

“Midoriya-chan!” Mirio exclaimed instantly, forgoing the entire reason he was even here in the first place to make straight for Izuku’s desk. “How are you?”

[Good.] Izuku signed with a grin. [How are you?]

Mirio waved his hands enthusiastically, “I started interning under Fat Gum recently! He’s amazing!”

“Mirio…” one of the older students said, not even bothering to face Class 1-A. Instead, he was resting his forehead against the wall and hiding. “The work studies,”

“Ah! Those!” Mirio struck a pose and laughed awkwardly as Shouta sighed.

“These three have experienced work studies firsthand. They’ll be telling you how these work studies are different from your internships. They’re also known as Yuuei’s Big Three.”

“The top of all of Yuuei’s students… they’re really the Big Three?” Kirishima asked, awe coloring his tone as he leaned forward on his desk.

Mirio nodded with a little too much enthusiasm. Izuku was momentarily worried his head might pop right off his shoulders from how hard his head was nodding.

“Please introduce yourselves briefly,” Shouta mumbled, already zipping up his sleeping bag. “I’m going to take a nap.”

“Well!” Mirio started off, “Most of you already know me after… an incident at the front gates! Either way, my name is Mirio Togata!”

Mirio then gestured to his classmate who was staring resolutely at the wall in front of him, with his back still turned to the class. “This is my boyfriend Tamaki Amajiki! He’s really shy so don’t worry about him if—”

“I want to go home,” Amajiki sighed, shaking. Mirio let out a boisterous laugh, before patting him on the back with a little too much force. Izuku sent his heart out to Amajiki, who seemed even more rattled when Mirio pulled him away from the wall and slung his arms around him.

Shouta didn’t even get up from his position on the floor to scold them.

“My name is Nejire Hado!” the girl next to them spoke up, “We were asked to explain work studies to you guys but—” her eyes suddenly got a lively twinkle to them, as she skipped

forward towards Shoji's desk. "Hey, why are you wearing a mask? Are you sick? Or is it your quirk?"

Shoji looked about ready to respond when she suddenly straightened and said, looking over Shoji's shoulder, "Oh my, you must be Todoroki right? Right?"

"Ashido-san, if your horns break off will new ones grow? Can you move them? Asui, you're a tree-frog—not a toad, right? Midoriya-kun, is it true that Aizawa-sensei finally adopted you? Oijro can you support your body weight with your tail? Ugh, there's so much I want to know about all of you! It's so strange!"

"Get to the point," Shouta finally snapped, rolling over.

"Don't worry, Eraser!" Mirio flashed a thumbs up and a smile. "I'm going to wrap things up!"

Izuku waited curiously to see what Mirio would say on the subject of work studies. "Well you guys kind of look confused. We're just a bunch of third year students who suddenly showed up to explain work studies that aren't even supposed to be required yet…"

"You're confusing me more by putting off actually explaining," Denki lamented from his seat, scratching his head.

"Okay! Okay! I'll get to it!" Mirio placated, "You guys got your provisional licenses as first years, yeah? Well, why don't you all fight me at once?"

"Just explain what the fuckin' difference is between work studies and internships!" Kacchan exclaimed, "How would fighting you even teach us anythin' about that?!"

"Aw, c'mon! I wanted to spar!" Mirio groaned, and Kacchan squinted at him. A second passed between them before Mirio finally relented. "But I guess you do have a point,"

Hado was the one to pick it up from there, “Basically the biggest difference between the work studies and internships was that legally, you weren’t allowed to fight villains. The best you could do was follow the guidance of whoever you were interning under and provide outside assistance.” She dug her license out of her skirt pocket, and showed it to them. “However, now that all of you have received provisional licenses, this work study will be your first time working under a pro and actually participating in fights and investigations. During this time, whichever hero you intern under will teach you more of an in-depth process of working in or running a hero agency, and help you learn more about the industry through real experience,”

“We already fought villains before, though,” Asui pointed out. “How is that different?”

“Well for one, you’ll be working with a pro,” Mirio said, “And luckily, students in work studies don’t usually get involved in big cases until they’re third-years anyway. With you guys being first years I doubt you’d run into anything a pro-hero on the scene can’t handle,”

“Oh,” Asui let out a sigh of relief, “Thank you,”

“No problem!” Mirio chirped, “Does anyone have any questions? Does anyone want to spar with me?”

No one raised their hand and Mirio laughed it off. “Well, that’s all I can really think to tell you about work studies.”

“Can we go back to class now?” Amajiki asked timidly, “I left my bento in there,”

“Aw, but I wanna hang out with the kids more!” Hado exclaimed, looking utterly devastated that she couldn’t stay. “I want to ask them all kinds of questions!”

“As unfortunate as that sounds, they have English with Mic in ten minutes,” Shouta chimed in, still as a rock on the floor. The Big Three left after that, and both Izuku and his dad let out sighs of relief. Hado was simply too nosy, even if it wasn’t intentional.

“I advise all of you to spend these few days before the work studies start to get in contact with the heroes you interned with and see if they’ll take you on. Of course Yuuei also has a list of agencies for you to choose from if you want to work under someone else this time around.” He grumbled, before promptly falling asleep.

“It’s like magic,” Toshi spoke up, “I wish I could do that,”

Izuku snorted, drawing the attention of his nearest classmates. Uraraka cooed at him, and he pretended he didn’t notice.

“Who do you think you’ll do a work study under?” Denki asked Sero.

Sero shrugged, slumped over his desk and buried his head in his arms.

“God, what a mood,” Uraraka mumbled, “I was thinking about going back to Gunhead, but I learned everything I could there,”

“Same,” Toshi replied, “But I’m going with Dadzawa this time,”

“You didn’t even ask him,” Kirishima pointed out, “What if he said no?”

“He won’t,” Toshi said with a sly smirk. “I’ll bribe him with coffee and cats,”

“That might actually work…” Mina replied in awe.

[What about you, Kacchan?]

“I’m not sure yet either,” He admitted, “Maybe I’ll go with Present Mic this time,”

“What did I just hear?” Hizashi said as he poked his head inside the room, grinning practically ear to ear. “Does a little listener want to do a work-study with *me?!”*

“Isn’t that just what I said?” Kacchan snapped back in embarrassment. He crossed his arms and leaned back in his seat as he gave Hizashi a half-hearted glare.

“Spectacular!” Hizashi exclaimed, “Happy to have the resident hot-head of Class 1-A helping me out!”

“Tch. Whatever,” Kacchan grumbled, as Izuku smirked at him. “Don’t look at me like that, Izuku,”

[Like what?] Izuku asked innocently, not bothering to hide his grin.

“Nevermind, forget I said anything,”

“Oh!” Hizashi exclaimed as the bell rang to signal the end of homeroom, “I forgot to tell you. Nedzu would like to see you in his office, Izuku,”

[Right now?]

“Yep!” Hizashi shrugged, “I’m pretty sure it has to do with your work study, go on ahead!”

“I will take notes for you!” Iida exclaimed, “Do not worry about missing class!”

[Thank you.] Izuku grinned, and Iida mirrored his expression as he left the classroom.

He arrived at Nedzu's office quickly, and just as expected, the door opened before he could even think of trying to open the door himself. Nedzu sat on one of his couches instead of his desk, watching with rapt attention as Edgar snuggled up to him and wagged his tail.

"It appears that Edgar has taken a liking to me," Nedzu replied, looking up as Izuku took a seat opposite to him. "Would you like some tea?"

Izuku gave a small nod, and a warm cup of tea was pushed across the table toward him. He took a sip from it, and Nedzu continued on without prompting. "Earlier this morning I got an email from Pro-Hero Hawks, asking if you'd like to do a work-study with him alongside Tokoyami-kun,"

His teacup paused mid-way to his mouth, and Izuku locked eyes with Nedzu in equal parts excitement and surprise. "I think this would be a great opportunity for both you and Tokoyami. Of course, it will always be up to you who you decide to go with but—"

[I'd love to work with Hawks.] Izuku signed before Nedzu could ramble any farther.

"I'll see to it that I give Hawks the affirmative. I'm sure both you and Tokoyami will have a lot to learn from him," Nedzu replied, "Now, would you like to spend some time relaxing with Edgar? I'm afraid he missed you and decided to cling to me instead,"

That was when Izuku remembered the new collar and dog tag Kacchan had given him. He pulled it out of his pocket, went over and crouched by the couch, and fastened it around Edgar's neck.

Nedzu stood up and returned to his desk. For a while, Izuku just sat on the couch petting Edgar, until Nedzu spoke up again. "After Kamino Ward, I'm happy to tell you that most of the slander toward you has abated. Apparently seeing you standing triumphantly next to the Symbol of Peace made people come to their senses. Working with Hawks will only help you more. Still, I'm doing everything I can to make sure you're not villainized by the public."

[That's good news.] Izuku signed.

Nedzu mirrored him to the best of his abilities. “It is, isn’t it?”

Chisaki thought the League of Villains was over and done with. Especially after receiving news that most of the volatile members of the League had been locked up in Japan’s most secure prison, or killed.

The only ones not imprisoned or dead were the members of the League that had defected and created a group of vigilantes.

And well, apparently Midoriya Inko. How *that one* survived out of everyone was a mystery to Chisaki. Currently, she was seated on the couch opposite of him, a smile pulling on her lips.

“Let me get this straight,” Chisaki said, readjusting his gloves on his hands. Ms. Midoriya’s eyes followed the movement with no hint of fear. Foolish woman. “You say you want to work with the Yakuza? To distribute Trigger?”

“Yes,” Inko replied, daringly leaning forward with her hands clasped together on the table between them. “I’d be a great asset to the operation you’re running here,”

“How so?” Chisaki asked, leaning back into the couch, feigning disinterest. “Currently I have all the muscle I need to keep everything moving smoothly. What do you have to offer me? The League of Villains and their riff-raff have already been taken off the streets. The emperor of darkness who ruled all over the underbelly of society is dead.”

“Although All for One is dead, that doesn’t mean his *connections* are,” Inko answered smoothly. “Why limit yourself to supplying just Japan with Trigger when you could expand your empire and influence all the way to America? For an operation this big you need investment. And I can supply you with all the money you need.”

Chisaki raised an eyebrow. “And what's in it for you if you join us?”

“Protection, of course,” Inko replied before casting a glance at Eri who sat as far away as possible from Chisaki. “I’m also great with children,”

Eri ducked and hid behind the couch, and shuddered in terror. Even *she* had heard bits and pieces of what kind of woman Inko Midoriya was.

Chisaki laughed, tapping his fingers on the table. “I think we have ourselves a deal, Inko Midoriya,”

Chapter End Notes

Hope everyone enjoyed!! This chapter is unedited so it probably has typos T^T

Chapter 95

Chapter Notes

Update 3 of 3 <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For some reason, Izuku had thought the work studies wouldn't be happening so fast. Just a day after his conversation with Nedzu, Tokoyami was pulling him aside to speak with him about going to Hawks' agency.

With Nedzu's quick reply to Hawks' email, he and Tokoyami were among the first to get approved for an internship, other than Kacchan who had been approved to work with Present Mic almost instantly.

The conversation itself was relatively short. Their work study would begin today, with him and Tokoyami taking the train from Yuuei to his agency every day until the work studies were finished. They would be exempt from classwork, of course, but expected to keep up regardless.

Both of them were already standing at the train station, waiting for it to arrive.

[What is Hawks usually like outside of hero work?] Izuku asked, making sure to tap Tokoyami's shoulder before signing everything out.

His avian classmate tapped his beak in thought. "He's… energetic. Dark Shadow loves him, though." As he spoke Dark Shadow emerged from his torso, nodding very vigorously.

"Hawks likes fried chicken!" Dark Shadow added on, with what looked like a smile.

Tokoyami rolled his eyes in exasperation. Izuku must've had a look of confusion on his face because Tokoyami decided to elaborate. "Hawks can and *will* take us to his favorite fried chicken place. He's literally obsessed with I swear,"

[Isn't that kind of cannibalism? At least for him?]

"He doesn't see it that way," Tokoyami replied, with a half-hearted shrug as the train pulled into the station. Swathes of people shoved their way inside, so Tokoyami stuck close to Izuku as they boarded. Neither of them were really fans of drawn out conversations, so they stood in awkward silence as the train car doors closed.

Dark Shadow, however, didn't seem to like silence because they filled it with asking Tokoyami to click on certain memes on his phone. Or he asked Izuku an outlandish question and then started a debate on how Izuku was *wrong,* which was fun to experience.

Tokoyami seemed worried at first, before Izuku reassured him that it was fine. He liked talking to Dark Shadow, and thanks to his distracting nature, the trip from Yuuei to Hawks' agency went a lot quicker than Izuku expected.

Before he knew it, they were standing outside a huge building in Kyushu, not unlike most of the buildings surrounding it. It was an unassuming white color, with its uppermost floors slanting to one side, creating an odd angle. On the roof were several satellite dishes and a spacious area where Hawks could land, should he decide that doors were a waste of time.

Tokoyami paused at the doors and fished his phone out of his pocket. Izuku watched curiously as his classmate typed out a hasty text of: *We're here.*

Izuku nearly raised his hands to sign and ask why he texted Hawks instead of heading straight inside when he heard a call from above, accompanied by the sound of lazy wingbeats.

"What's up, kiddos?" Hawks greeted, with a lopsided grin. "How was the ride over here?"

“The same as usual,” Tokoyami replied. “I am honored to work with you again,”

“Oh c’mon little hatchling, we’re best friends! You don’t have to be so formal with me!” Hawks pouted, landing softly on his feet at last. “The same goes for you, too!”

Hawks jabbed a finger at Izuku’s chest as he said this, and Tokoyami coughed in a way that suspiciously sounded like a laugh at Izuku’s flustered expression. Hawks turned on his heel and faced the front doors of his agency, continuing on.

“Nedzu and I emailed each other,” He began, waving to the receptionist who blushed when he saw Hawks. “He said you need help “learning” how to fly. Which is not giving you enough credit in my opinion. You flew perfectly well during the Hosu attack, even if it was purely on instinct. What we need to work on is making it a muscle memory. Something you can do without needing to rely on deadly situations”

The entrance they walked into was modern in design with sparse furniture for guests to sit at. There were a couple of light blue couches to the right of the receptionist desk, and a table between them. To the left were multiple elevators.

“And of course, there are some techniques I’m going to teach you to fight better mid-air. Can’t believe it took this long for Yuuei to have someone teach you, little bird. But I can see that they’ve… been busy with all the villain attacks going on.” Hawks mumbled as he and Tokoyami followed the avian into the elevator, where he pressed the button for the highest floor. “What with the USJ, Sports Festival, Hosu, and then *Kamino* ? You kids have been put through the ringer.”

It was true. It seemed as if everywhere they turned, villains were hiding in the fog of war, waiting to strike. All for One was gone now, though, Izuku mentally reminded himself. The League of Villains had become ultimately divided between villains and Stain’s remaining followers.

The only true remaining member was his own “mother,” but he hadn’t seen hide nor hair of the woman. Hawks, unlike most people, didn’t shy away from mentioning all the traumatic shit they’d been through, sans Izuku’s abuse. It was almost cathartic and alarming at the same time.

The elevator doors closed, and the indicator at the top of the door read: **Floor 1.**

The number steadily rose and Hawks leaned against one of the walls of the small space, waving his hands.

“So teaching you is what I’m going to focus on for the first few days in tandem with my current investigation going on. I thought it’d be a better idea to keep you guys at the agency during this, since it would make things much easier, but I decided to wait until both of you were here to bring it up,” Hawks paused, to gauge their reactions. “I didn’t want to assume anything. I know Tokoyami likes the dorms better than my little agency!”

“I—I do not like the dorms better than your—” Tokoyami sighed heavily, “They’re just…”

[Quieter?] Izuku signed.

“Well… no. Denki-kun can get very loud. The dorms are just more familiar,” he huffed. “But I don’t mind staying here if it's more convenient for everyone,”

“What about you, Midoriya?” Hawks asked, as the doors to the elevator dinged open.

[I’m okay with it.]

Hawks grinned. “Cool! Don’t forget to pack tonight for when you guys come back tomorrow. Now c’mon! Let’s hop to it!”

Hawks led them through an office where many sidekicks were working in cubicles. Some of them seemed to be working on a specific case while others were simply filling out reports and other various paperwork.

“Afternoon, Hawks!” came an elated shout from one of the occupied desks.

Izuku spotted a woman with silky pink hair that reached her hips, and purple doe-like eyes. Her lips were curled up into a warm smile that made the scar on her lower lip stretch and distort. She had gotten it during the first-year Sports Festival of her Yuuei career. It was the sidekick Hermes! There was no mistaking it! He could recognize her white and gold jumpsuit anywhere, along with the golden winged ear cuffs she wore that were reminiscent of the actual messenger god in Greek Mythology.

She was a woman with a speed quirk not dissimilar to the Iida’s. While not exactly engines, the small wings on her ankles allowed her to run faster than Ingenium himself. The only reason she wasn’t doing as well as him in terms of popularity was because she was still a little too new to the business.

“What’s up Hermes?” Hawks shot back, “How’s the investigation going?”

“Overhaul still has yet to make any moves, but we’ll keep patrolling and gathering information,”

“Good. Take care though, he’s an S-Rank villain for a reason,” Hawks told her, and she nodded. “I’ll be taking these two up to the Perch for some flying lessons. You know how to reach me!”

Hermes and a handful of other sidekicks nodded, not bothering to look up from their screens, whether it be computers, or handheld tablets. They passed the office area, but not without Hawks pointing toward one of many coffee machines, “The coffee maker can literally make anything you want at a press of a button. If you want some at any point we can take a little break and come back down here, kiddos,”

The connected hallway led to rooms simply labeled with small signs. There were various restrooms, break rooms, change rooms, and bedrooms. According to Hawks’ on-going commentary, the rooms were used if patrols went on late into the day, or if someone didn’t feel like driving home.

For now though, that's where they'd be staying, and each room came with its own key.

At the end of the hall was a door labeled vaguely with the word *Perch* . Hawks dug into his pocket and presented a card.

"This," He explained, more for Izuku's sake rather than Tokoyami's. "Is my key-card. You're only allowed to use the perch to fly with my instruction and guidance. Until I deem you ready, you won't have a key-card of your own. Got it, little bird?"

[I understand.]

"Great!" he held the card up to the scanner next to the door, and it turned green and unlocked with an audible click. The Winged hero threw the door open and gestured for them to head out first.

"Welcome to the Perch!" He exclaimed as they stepped out onto the rooftop. Hawks' building was one of the tallest in the area, so they had a great view of the rest of Kyushu. The rooftop itself was nothing all that groundbreaking, in fact it was almost disappointingly normal. One side of the rooftop was covered in satellites, while the side they were currently standing on was empty and spacious. Plenty of room for someone to land and take off.

At the edge of the building on their side was an actual perch, which Hawks walked right up to.

"Don't think we'll try branching first," he said, "just a few exercises to get you used to using the muscles in your back sounds good for now,"

Dark Shadow emerged from Tokoyami's midsection. "Just flap your wings and you'll be flying in no time!"

"There's more to it than that," Tokoyami interjected, swatting Dark Shadow fondly.

“Yup!” Hawks agreed, “You haven’t really learned what it feels like to *fly*. It’s more than just flapping your wings and moving. You have to learn to control how you move, and if you're traveling long distances you need to learn how to glide using wind currents instead of wearing yourself out. That all comes with time and practice, though.”

Hawks walked in a circle around Izuku, and tapped the space between his shoulder blades. “Now, unfold your wings, little bird,”

Izuku didn’t really need to think or concentrate too hard for this part. His wings opened with a snap and Hawks nodded, satisfied. “Alright, now we’re going to try some basic movements to get you hovering in the air. Is that cool?”

[Sure.]

Hawks gave a quick demonstration, unfolding his own wings and moving through the motion of flapping. Up and down slow enough so Izuku could get an idea of what to do.

“Most of it will probably come naturally to you,” Hawks said, with his arms crossed, hovering just a few inches off the ground. “The hardest part will be getting used to dodging buildings and fighting mid-air,”

Right.

It was a bit awkward at first, trying to get his wings to move in sync. It was strange to feel muscles in his back working that he wasn’t even aware he had, but his wings were strong. Stronger than he anticipated because he was hovering above the ground in seconds, his own wingbeat jarring to his own ears. Almost as jarring as feeling nothing beneath his feet, and his feathers moving through the air.

“Okay, that’s good so far. Want to go a little higher?”

Tokoyami had joined them in the air at some point, and it was a comfort to see that his classmate was right there, just in case Izuku fucked this up. He didn't even try to fly any higher, paranoid now that he was in the air.

Izuku wasn't afraid of heights, but he *was* afraid of his own capabilities. What if he fell? What if he couldn't actually fly? What if he—

"Take a deep breath, Midoriya-kun," Tokoyami said, expression soft and understanding, "It was a bit scary for me too, at first. Hawks won't let you get hurt,"

"What he said!" Hawks replied, "It's okay to be a bit nervous. We've got plenty of time for everything, just take it slow. Besides, Nedzu would have my wings if you didn't make it back safely to school, ya know?"

Izuku nodded, more to himself than to the other two next to him. He'd been given wings along with his quirk for a reason. If Tokoyami—who didn't have the capability to fly unless he was aided by Dark Shadow—could do this, then so could he. He had been so excited to be here, to learn from Hawks and now he was wasting time worrying about falling down a few inches.

He wanted to know what it really felt like to fly.

He really, *really* wanted to experience it. Steeling himself mentally he ascended, a few more inches, and Hawks gave him a supportive thumbs up.

"Alright now we'll float back down to the ground. Nice and controlled, perfectly safe."

Once again, Hawks was the first to demonstrate. "This is a good technique to use when you're landing and you're already pretty close to the ground. Don't use it too high up though, the wind could sweep you away,"

He let his wings span out slightly curved, and he quite accurately floated down and landed. Izuku and Tokoyami followed, one looking more at ease than the other.

“You can also land just by slowing down how fast you’re flapping you wings though,” Hawks added, “Let’s try that,”

So the three of them worked through exercise after exercise, and by the end of it, Izuku knew how to land safely, ascend higher in the air, and how to clean his feathers, should they ever get dirty. Which is definitely something he never really thought about until Hawks brought it up.

His back was aching by the time they finished, but only from using new muscles rather than overuse.

When he told Hawks this, the Winged Hero nodded. “You're basically a baby bird right now, so you’ll have to keep at it and build those muscles until you can fly for longer distances. You’re just a student though, so you have plenty of time for all that and Tokoyami can help you out when you’re at Yuuei,”

From there, the rest of their day was spent being introduced to more of the sidekicks working in the agency, including a man with the hero name Gentle. Everything he touched turned elastic in texture, and both him and Izuku spent a good chunk of time analyzing the man’s quirk.

Gentle also spoke of a wife at home whom he clearly doted on. Her hero name was La Brava and she was another sidekick at the agency, but she wasn’t currently at work. Izuku thoroughly enjoyed listening to all the goofy things the two of them got up to, while Tokoyami got sucked into a conversation about sentient quirks with Hermes.

“Alright guys, I think it’s about time you headed back to Yuuei before I get an angry email from either Nedzu, or your homeroom teacher,” Hawks said, who had been in a meeting since they came down from the Perch. “Oh, and don’t forget to ask permission if you can stay off-campus here!”

As Hawks walked them out of the agency, Dark Shadow spoke up, “So how did you like your first day, Mi-chan?”

Izuku blinked once at the nickname. Immediately he decided he liked it, and nodded.

[It’s a lot slower than I expected.]

“Don’t worry,” Hawks laughed, placing an unbelievably gentle hand on his shoulder. “When we go on your first patrol you’ll know *exactly* why everyone calls me fast,”

Tokoyami whispered from beside him, “His feathers can travel long distances and grow in size. Any criminal that he comes across he detained in seconds,”

Izuku felt his mouth form into a shocked O shape. [Really?]

“Yeah, it’s quite fun to watch,” Tokoyami told him, as Hawks waved them goodbye from the front door.

The ride back to Yuuei was spent with him and Tokoyami theorizing what kind of investigation Hawks was involved in, which occupied them until they reached Yuuei’s gates.

As soon as they entered campus Edgar came tearing down the grass towards them, howling with joy and wagging his tail.

“You damn mutt! Keep running away like this and I’ll just let you get kidnapped again—!” Kacchan yelled after him. In his palms popped some non-threatening explosions. When he noticed both Izuku and Tokoyami he slowed down to a walk and crossed his arms.

Izuku crouched down to give Edgar scratches behind the ear.

He sent a scathing glare in Edgar's direction before switching his gaze to Izuku who smiled. Kacchan's expression softened and he huffed at the dog. "Next time just ask me to go on a walk,"

[Edgar can't talk, Kacchan.]

"Neither can you and I understand you perfectly fine," Kacchan shot back. "Edgar is just being a troublemaker,"

"I wonder who taught him that?" Shouta asked, walking up to them with his hands in his pockets. All three of them had appeared from the direction of the dorms, so Izuku safely assumed that Edgar had made a masterful escape to make it over to the gates in time to greet him.

"Whadda ya mean?!" Kacchan screeched, with the most offended look on his face. "I'm a perfectly good example! A model student!"

"Bakugou-kun *does* go to sleep at 9pm sharp, sensei," Tokoyami chimed in. "The earliest sleeper in our entire class,"

"Damn kid, you sleep at 9pm?" Shouta sounded almost offended with how early Kacchan went to sleep.

"Bold of you to say," Kacchan shot back, "You never sleep, unless it's during class,"

Shouta rolled his eyes and stopped in front of Izuku. "How was your day, kid?"

[Great! Hawks is an amazing hero!] Izuku replied in sign language. Shouta just patted his head and nodded in satisfaction.

All in all, it had been a good day.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you guys enjoyed this small update! <3 for the next 5 days I'll be updating on chapter a day! Hopefully, this fic will be over before the new year <3

Here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 96

Chapter Notes

> this update is kinda late today ^^; I had a lot of errands to run just in time for Christmas lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next time he and Tokoyami arrived at Hawks' agency, they were laden with packed clothes and their hero costumes. Looking rather proud of themself, Dark Shadow was carrying Izuku's sword and Tokoyami's heaviest bags.

Hermes, Gentle, and who Izuku deduced was La Brava—the latter was holding hands with Gentle, so it wasn't that hard to figure out—all met them at the doors.

"We'll help you get situated before Hawks gets ready for patrol," Hermes said, holding out a hand for the luggage Dark Shadow was holding onto.

"Dark Shadow likes to help," Tokoyami replied, and Dark Shadow nodded so fast Izuku thought they would get dizzy.

"Well alright then!" Hermes smiled to herself and turned on Izuku. "Do you need help carrying anything?"

But before Izuku could exactly answer she had already taken his bag out of his hand and dashed ahead of them to the elevator. The rest of them followed at a more sedate pace, up the elevator, and into their assigned rooms to unpack.

La Brava and Hermes helped Izuku settle in quickly. The rooms they were provided had a closet of generic spare clothes—most likely there for employees rather than interns—and a dresser full of pajamas of various sizes.

Occupying most of the one-room space, was a huge bed with simple white sheets, a TV, and a nightstand. Nothing extraordinary. The first thing he did was plug in a night light into the socket nearest to his bed.

Once he was done unpacking his extra clothing that Hizashi had lovingly packed for him, he was directed to a changing room to get ready for Hawks' patrol.

Five minutes later, he and Tokoyami were standing outside with Hawks who admired their costumes with an appreciative eye. "Looking good kids! Yuuei really doesn't fuck around with quality costumes, huh?"

Immediately after speaking, Hawks shoved his hands in his pockets and started walking. Hurrying to follow, Tokoyami and Izuku dogged his heels.

Down the street, Izuku spotted a man in a trenchcoat muttering to himself. The people around him were giving him looks of concern or confusion.

"I worked at this company for three years," the man said, bitterness coloring his tone, "I'm going to crush it right now! Damn company!"

Hawks continued his leisurely pace, happily chattering with Dark Shadow. "What's your favorite food?" the winged hero asked, "there's an amazing hot-pot place we can go to after this,"

Tokoyami looked ahead as well, and they traded concerned looks as the man in the trenchcoat continued on with his rant.

"Liberate me… Liberate me, Destro!" He threw his trenchcoat open just as they started to pass him. "Hooray for the metahuman liberation!"

Hawks, without stopping his conversation, used his feathers to immobilize the man. “You like pho, Dark Shadow?” He turned back to Tokoyami and Izuku. “Do you guys want pho?”

Izuku looked back and forth between the man with feathers sticking out of his back and Hawks, who didn’t even blink. He knew his mouth was open in shock, but no one besides himself and some bystanders even seemed put off by how Hawks ran a patrol.

“Oh, we could also get Yakitori!” Dark Shadow added as some ladies' dogs bounded into oncoming traffic. Izuku shifted his weight, on the very edge of going to catch the dog when Tokoyami stopped him with a hand on his shoulder.

“Mr. Schwartz!” A woman wailed, just as one of Hawks’ feathers increased in size and floated the dog back to the sidewalk. The woman burst into tears so huge that Izuku wondered if it was her Quirk.

“Thank you!” she said, clutching her dog tightly. Hawks nodded toward her and continued on.

“Hey, Hawks doesn’t usually walk around like this!” Someone else said. A simple man in a suit whose teeth glowed.

“Hello everyone!” Hawks suddenly exclaimed, with a kind wave. As soon as he acknowledged the civilians around him, they swarmed like a pack of bees.

“Oh! Good morning Hawks! Do you think you’ll make it as number two this year? I heard All Might has retired after the disaster at Kamino! Do you think he’ll announce it before they do the annual Hero Billboard Chart?” a small girl asked.

Hawks shrugged. “Who knows? I’d like to be number two, but you never know!”

“Who are these heroes with you?” an older man said, clutching his cane as he gave all three of them a warm smile. He looked at Tokoyami and then Izuku, before he did a double-take.

“Ah, the hero of Kamino!”

Hero of Kamino? Who? Izuku? That didn’t make any sense.

“You’re the kid who knocked out that potato-looking guy!” a boy said, “I saw it on TV! You saved *All Might!”*

“Yeah, he did!”

“And to think he’d been trending on HeroTube right beforehand, and not in a good way. Everyone called him a villain and he really went and told them! Hah! You’re really helping those of us out with “villainous” quirks!” Another girl exclaimed, showing him her claws. “My schoolmates used to bully me, but after seeing what you did for All Might they stopped! Thanks for that!”

Izuku opened and closed his mouth, unsure why he would even bother with the action.

With an audible snap, Dabi appeared at his side out of thin air.

“He says your welcome, you little gremlin,” he said, crouching down to her level so he could pat her on the head. The girl beamed at him, and the crowd around them kept going on and on.

Some of them wanted to hear about how Hawks’ day was going, and others recognized Tokoyami from the sports festival and expressed how impressed with him they’d all been, especially while they’d been under attack from villains.

Everyone demanded a picture with Hawks and “his little interns,” as Tokoyami and Izuku got affectionately called.

Once the crowd dissipated, Hawks turned to them both. “I’ve decided. We’re getting Pho,”

Tokoyami sighed, exasperated with the number two hero even as they walked inside the nearest Pho restaurant. Dark Shadow seemed extremely excited to eat and they were seated quickly by a very nervous-looking waitress, into the most private area of the restaurant.

Dark Shadow kindly ordered for Izuku, and soon all four of them were eating, alongside a bored Dabi.

Dabi didn't really need to eat, but Izuku tried to feed him some of his noodles regardless.

As Hawks slurped up his noodles—after he'd smothered his noodles and broth in sriracha and hoisin sauce—Tokoyami and Izuku tried to get information on the investigation he'd only mentioned in conversation.

"Well," Hawks began, tapping his chin, "We've taken over Nighteye's investigation while his hero license is temporarily suspended thanks to Nedzu."

"What kind of investigation are you doing?" Dabi asked, drawing a smiley face with the sriracha sauce in Izuku's pho.

"We're trying to get information on the Shie Hassaikai, an organization run by the Yakuza and spearheaded by a man named Overhaul." Hawks paused momentarily in his explanation to show them a picture of said man on his phone. The man had short, brown hair, and a strange beak-like mask. "There are a number of rumors in the underground that he's the one creating and distributing quirk-erasing drugs,"

Well, if that didn't sound utterly terrifying… Quirk erasing bullets would be a disaster left unchecked.

"Do they erase quirks permanently?" Tokoyami asked, voicing the same concern that had just popped into Izuku's head.

“Temporary, from what I’ve heard. Yesterday while one of your classmates was on patrol with Fatgum and another intern—Sun Eater—one of them got shot. It only lasted a couple of hours, but it's still alarming,”

“Huh,” Dabi mumbled, “So how do you plan on finding this… Overhaul?”

“We know where most of his hideouts are,” Hawks replied, expression stony and serious all of the sudden. “We’ve been monitoring each one for days, narrowing down which ones are currently in use, and which ones aren’t,”

The conversation tapered off after that, as each of them digested the information and finished up what was left of their meal. Hawks paid for the meal digitally, using one of the screens at the end of the table, and they returned to their patrol.

It was when Hawks got a call from the Hero Commission that they separated. Hermes had caught up to them at this point, and Hawks waved them off and told them to continue with the patrol.

Patrolling with Hermes was a lot easier, seeing as they could actually be of some help.

She gently instructed them on how to make one's presence reassuring no matter the situation. And she even gave Dark Shadow a high-five when he helped an old lady walk across the street while Tokoyami carried her groceries.

Then they stopped for a break and to discuss where to patrol next when a demon, out of the corner of Izuku’s eye, stood at the mouth of an alley and pointed at it. Which was strange because all the demons that had been roaming around, or following him today, had been pretty calm and docile. All of them tried their best not to distract him while he was working. This one, however, pointed again and Izuku wandered off toward it, head tilted in confusion.

Neither Hermes nor Tokoyami noticed, too busy ordering some ice cream for the group.

Once he reached the alleyway he noticed a small figure bolting toward him in a blur of white. The little girl rebounded off his legs, falling to the ground. She looked up at him, red eyes brimming with tears and burning with terror.

Izuku crouched down and helped her get back onto her feet. Her feet were bare, for some reason.

Bare and bandaged, like the rest of her legs, arms, and her neck. Something immediately itched at him that something wasn't right.

She was trembling from head to toe, tears spilling from her eyes as she looked at him.

[Are you okay?] he finally asked, hoping that she understood him.

The girl shook her head, curling into him. She knew sign language then. "I've seen someone who looks like you. A woman," she whispered shakily, nails digging into the fabric of his hero costume. "Help me, *please* ,"

Izuku knew it wasn't good practice to jump to conclusions, but his mind immediately went to his mother when he heard this little girl say something about a woman who looked like him.

Who else could it possibly be, anyway?

An old, ancient fear gnawed at him, but he ignored it in favor of gathering the small girl into his arms. *"Please, please help me,"* she whispered again, more urgently than before.

He thought back to the bandages, and instead of fear, all he could feel was rage.

“Now you know, Eri,” A deep, muffled voice said, from the shadows of the alley. A man emerged, wearing the same beak-like mask Izuku had seen from a picture earlier that day. “That you shouldn’t go around causing trouble for the heroes.”

Izuku froze. A strange feeling of foreboding and pressure pressed in on him. This was Overhaul. And he was standing right before Izuku, glaring at the girl burrowed in his arms.

“I’m sorry about my daughter, hero.” Overhaul continued as if Izuku’s face wasn’t white as a sheet and his hands weren’t shaking. Not from fear, but from molten rage.

This man was obviously abusing Eri. He had seen the same desperation in her eyes that had been in his for years. The same fear. The same fledgling hope that she could be saved.

Overhaul’s eyes creased into crescents and Izuku knew that he must be smiling under that mask. “She likes to play around a lot and gets hurt often. I don’t know what to do with her,”

He was lying. Izuku could sense it in the same way that Inko had always lied to Kacchan. Overhaul’s eyes narrowed with Izuku’s overall lack of response.

A moment passed between them, charged with an unnamed emotion and tension. Izuku tightened his hold on Eri and pressed his lips into a thin line. If he was anywhere else, and not in a populated area such as Kyushu he would’ve been long gone by now. Or at the very least, he would’ve gotten Eri to safety but as it was, they were out in the open. Standing in the middle of a sidewalk.

He couldn’t fight or run away without knowing what kind of quirk Overhaul had. It just wasn’t safe.

Footsteps sounded behind him. “What’s going on over here?” Dabi asked, expression cool even when he saw Overhaul. “Everything okay?”

Coming up behind him, looking just as tense as Izuku felt, were Tokoyami and Hermes.

“Everything is perfectly fine,” Overhaul replied, stepping forward. Izuku unconsciously took a step back, bumping into Dabi. “We were just going, weren’t we, Eri?”

Overhaul saw that none of them were moving, so he sighed and started to tug his gloves off. Eri sprang out of the safety of Izuku’s arms and wobbled toward Overhaul, a look of pure fear on her face.

The man put his gloves back on and sighed again. “It was lovely meeting you, heroes, but I’m a busy man.” Eri grabbed his hand and gave one last look over her shoulder as they turned back toward the alley.

Izuku couldn’t just leave her. He couldn’t just see another version of himself, walking back into the arms of his abuser and do nothing. Truthfully, he wanted to throw Overhaul into a building and run away with Eri safe in his arms.

He couldn’t stand the thought of giving Eri hope and then snatching it away just as quickly.

The smarter part of him knew he should do nothing. Let her go, and devote himself to the investigation to save her. The desperate, more devastated, part of him looked at the demon who had guided him here and mentally urged it to follow them.

Follow her. He pleaded, feeling like even this was hardly enough. ***Gather information. Return to me tomorrow.***

The demon dutifully followed his directions, taking hold of Eri’s free hand even though she couldn’t see or feel it.

As Eri and Overhaul disappeared from view something old, forgotten, and fragile broke in him. That child-like innocence that had been stomped out of him at the age of four was slicing into his heart again like shards of glass. His chest burned as if the wound was fresh. New.

His eyes stung and his vision blurred. He never hated himself more. Never before had he wanted to say fuck proper investigations and just run head first into a Yakuza stronghold.

His chest ached, and he really just wanted to cry alone in the solitary darkness of his own room. Each time he closed his eyes, even as Dabi tried to shake him out of his stupor, he just saw Eri's face. Scrunched up in terror, brows drawn together, and lips wobbling.

Izuku felt miles away as someone tapped a breathing pattern on his wrist. He couldn't tell when he closed his eyes, or when he started to hyperventilate, but he had.

He couldn't tell if it was Hermes tapping the inside of his wrist, Dabi, or Tokoyami. It didn't matter who was doing it. He followed the simple pattern because he knew he had to. In for four, hold for seven, and out for eight. Over and over again.

As his breathing finally evened out he opened his eyes to see that it wasn't Hermes, Tokoyami, or Dabi tapping his wrist. It was Hawks.

"Hey there," Hawks said, sounding way more subdued than usual. He removed his hand from Izuku's wrist. "Are you back with us kid?"

Izuku nodded, eyes burning and chest full of knives and regret. Dabi helped him stand—when did he end up sitting down?—and Hawks ruffled his hair.

"You feeling better, Mi-chan?" Dark Shadow asked, looking as concerned as Tokoyami did.

Izuku nodded even though he felt anything but better . The relieved look on Dark Shadow's and Hermes' faces was worth the lie though. Tokoyami, Hawks, and Dabi didn't look all that convinced, but they let it slide for now.

“Let’s head back to the agency for the day, how's that?” Hermes spoke up, glancing at each of them. “We have to file a report about today anyway,”

“Oh!” Hawks replied, with forced cheer as he glanced at his wrist. He had no watch. “Would you look at the time! Why don’t we go take a break and have an early dinner in a few hours?”

Izuku, who had no idea what time it was, just nodded numbly. He wanted today to be over and retreat to his room. He hardly paid any attention as they took a shorter route back to the agency.

His mind was firmly fixated on if Eri was okay. Was she in pain? Was she being beaten right this second? Had his interaction with her made it worse for her, wherever she was?

He didn’t know. And that was, perhaps, the worst part.

They arrived at the agency but Izuku hardly cared, hiding away in his room as soon as the opportunity presented itself.

He threw himself on his bed without bothering to change out of his hero costume. Seconds later, Dabi was splayed on top of him, sighing. His weight on top of him was comforting.

“Well damn,” Dabi said into the darkness, “What a day, huh?”

Izuku gave him a watery and tight chuckle, and Dabi rolled off of him and sat up.

“Are you okay?” Dabi continued, and even in the dark, Izuku could see how the skin between his brows was creased in concern. Izuku shrugged. He wasn’t okay. Not after seeing Eri like that and being unable to do a thing for her.

Was this how Kacchan felt all those years? Close enough to touch, but not strong enough to save?

Tears streamed down his face and he didn't bother to stop them. There was a soft knock at the door some length of time later, but he ignored it. And again when there was a second knock, so Dabi gave him a quick pat and went to open the door.

"Mi-chan we brought dinner—oh,"

Izuku sat up, swiping at his eyes in a half-hearted attempt to pretend he wasn't crying his eyes out. Tokyami and Dark Shadow were silhouetted against the light of the hall, both wearing looks of understanding rather than concern and pity.

Without a word, Tokoyami walked over and handed him the plate in his hands—pizza. At that exact moment he realized just how hungry he was, and he for lack of a better word, devoured it.

"Awesome," Dabi said, looking a bit relieved as he snatched the empty plate from him. Then he shoved a bundle of clothes into Izuku's waiting arms. "Now get changed,"

Izuku headed into the bathroom connected to his room, and did exactly that, pulling on a pair of neon pink sweatpants that were surely Shouta's, and an oversized shirt that read: Put Your Hands Up Radio!

He smiled at his own reflection, suddenly missing home but also fueled by anger to keep going and possibly save Eri.

When he emerged from the bathroom, the tableside lap was on, and Tokoyami was sitting on the bed between Dark Shadow and Dabi as all three of them browsed through the agency's streaming services.

When Dabi spotted him he said, "Pick one, Studio Ghibli, or Disney,"

“Disney is the superior choice,” Dark Shadow pouted, while both Dabi and Tokoyami looked at the sentient quirk like they were absolutely insane.

[We could always watch one of both.]

“I agree,” Tokoyami said, as Izuku settled himself on an empty space on the mattress. “Howl’s Moving Castle first?”

“I love that one!” Dark Shadow exclaimed, immediately snuggling up to Izuku’s side.

“And then we watch Frozen,” Dabi replied, “Shoto loves that one,”

Later that night, Izuku fell asleep with Dark Shadow on top of him like a massive blanket, with Tokoyami on one side and Dabi on the other.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed this one today!! See you all tomorrow for chapter 97!

As usual, here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 97

Chapter Notes

> Me: I'm going to update every day until Christmas!
> Also me: *has muscle pain on the 22nd and gets wasted on the 23rd*
>
> Anyway, here's upload 1 of 3! All of them are relatively edited, but ya know, I could've missed something lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku couldn't concentrate on any of the flying exercises Hawks and Tokoyami were trying to drill into him. He was constantly worrying about Eri and while he did the moves correctly, he could tell that both Hawks and Tokoyami were well aware of how far away he was, at least mentally.

After another round of flying exercises, Hawks told them to stop and said, "We're going to have a meeting,"

"A meeting?" Tokoyami parroted, watching Izuku carefully as he came to land. Like the amazing friend he was.

"Yeah." Hawks yawned. They had started training earlier than usual, so Hawks still hadn't gotten his morning coffee yet. "It's in about thirty minutes, honestly. We're planning a raid. To save Eri, and take the Quirk-suppressing drugs away from Overhaul. Well, there's more to it than just those two things, but you'll figure it out along with everyone else,"

"Oh that's great, isn't it Mi-chan?" Dark Shadow replied, "Now you don't have to worry anymore!"

Well, it did make him feel ten times better than before, that was for certain.

[Who's coming to the meeting?]

“A whole lot of people,” Hawks gestured vaguely before he started to count on his fingers, “Fat Gum and his interns, along with Lemillion this time. Rock Lock, your homeroom teacher and father, Eraserhead, Ryukyu and her interns I think—she hasn’t exactly responded—and a bunch of other small fish,”

Izuku’s chest swelled with warmth at how easily Hawks’ ignored all the recent exposure and pressure surrounding Izuku’s biological parentage. In fact, he hadn’t brought it up once, which was always a win in Izuku’s eyes.

“Let’s get you guys washed up and ready,” Hawks practically raced for the door. “We don’t have much time!”

Tokoyami grumbled under his breath, fond but tired, “It’s a wonder he even warned us beforehand,”

The first thing Izuku noticed when he walked into the meeting was that everyone was *loud.* While usually, he was good at dealing with it, he wasn’t used to so many people being loud.

In one corner of their spacious room was a group of obscure heroes Izuku had never heard of. While in the other, was a group of his classmates and the Big Three.

Tokoyami had been drawn over there when he spotted their classmates, but Izuku chose to stand by the door, anticipating the arrival of Eraserhead and his brother. Hawks, Gentle, and Hermes were all going over the files at the head of the table, a projection behind them displaying nothing as of yet.

When the door opened and his family walked through, he tried his best not to look too excited or pull them both into a hug.

His efforts were in vain when Shouta and Toshi both pulled him in for a firm hug. “How’s it been going, kid?” Shouta asked, hiding a smile behind his capture weapon.

Izuku decided the truth was needed, and he shrugged.

[Terrible.]

“Does it have anything to do with the case we were called on for?” Toshi asked, pulling him to take a seat at the table. Shouta followed after them, slumping forward and snoring immediately.

Izuku turned to Toshi without even a single blink at their father’s antics. He nodded, and Toshi looked about ready to ask another question when Hawks gathered the attention of the entire room. Shou—Eraserhead looked absolutely devastated that his nap was cut painfully short.

“Alright, everyone!” Hawks exclaimed, instantly silencing wayward conversation. “Let’s get this party started!”

Tokoyami groaned. Loudly.

Without missing a beat, the heroes gathered took their seats. Most of them stayed near or across from their interns. Which at the moment were: Fat Gum, Red Riot, Sun Eater, and Lemillion. With Ryukyu, Uravity, Froppy, and Nejire-Chan sitting together.

Hermes took the helm of the briefing after that, “Thanks to the information we received from you all, the investigation has moved forward substantially.” She gave a small smile. “We will now be holding a conference to share what information we have acquired regarding what the small organization, Shie Hassaikai, is planning.”

There were a couple of confused looks, mostly passed between Yuuei students who didn't have much of a clue about what was going on.

"Those of us from the Hawks Agency have been conducting an independent investigation ever since Nighteye's Agency handed it over to us," Gentle tapped on the clipboard he was holding.

"What prompted this investigation?" someone Izuku didn't recognize, asked.

"In Nighteye's files, he stated that there was an incident with this group and another, called Reservoir Dogs."

"Oh, I heard about that!"

"According to the case file, the police ruled it as an accident, but there were a number of points that didn't make sense," Gentle continued on. "So the Nighteye Agency began tailing them. Centipeder conducted a follow-up investigation as well and found that the members of the Shie Hassaikai have increased contact with those outside of their organization,"

Immediately, Izuku recalled what Eri had said to him.

"I've seen someone who looks like you. A woman,"

There was no mistaking it now. Inko was working with the Shie Hassaikai. Izuku fidgeted in his seat. Should he say something? Would it even change the outcome, or their plan if he did? Would that just make his dad pull him from the raid?

He made a split-second decision to say nothing for now. Izuku couldn't bear the thought of not being able to help in rescuing Eri.

“Due to more pressing information being uncovered,” Hawks said, glancing at Izuku. “We put out a request for help on the HN,”

“HN?” Uravity asked, confused.

Rock Lock, a man in a green and white suit, huffed and leaned back in his seat.

“It’s the Hero Network,” Neijire-Chan whispered, “It’s where Heroes can reach out for help with raids and stuff,”

That’s when Rock Lock finally spoke up. “Even if they’re from Yuuei, why are there kids here? We’ll never get anywhere with them here. The sun will set before we get to the actual plan.”

“Don’t say that!” Fat Gum suddenly exclaimed, pointing at his interns, Red Riot, Sun Eater. “These two have super important information!”

Sun Eater looked ready to bury himself into the floor, and Red Riot just looked confused.

“Continuing on,” Gentle steered them back to the matter at hand. “We suspect one of the Hassaikai’s main sources of income is the creation and distribution of unauthorized drugs. A drug that destroys Quirks, specifically,”

“Oh! At Red Riot’s debut the other day, a type of drug I’d never seen before was shot into Tamaki, and he couldn’t use his quirk for a few hours. That must be it,”

“I feel better knowing that you can recover from it.” Lock Rock voiced the relief that everyone was feeling.

“Did you know what was in it?” Eraserhead asked, gaze directed at Fat Gum.

“If it wasn’t for Kirishima’s brave actions that led to one of the bullets bouncing’ off his body, we wouldn’t have been able to get a sample. After analyzin’ the contents, we discovered something sickening. Human blood and cells were inside!”

Human blood?

Izuku’s thoughts stuttered to a halt, remembering Eri’s bandages.

“In other words, that effect came from a person? Someone’s Quirk?” Ryukyu asked.

“But wait, how is this connected?”

Hawks’ feathers twitched on his back and he pressed his palms firmly into the table. “The man Fat Gum and his team arrested got Trigger—another drug going around—to enhance his Quirk. He got it from a group of villains that Ryukyu stopped just the other day. That group she stopped is connected to the Shie Hassaikai because the Hassaikai sold them the drug.”

The projector suddenly lit up, showing a side profile of Chisaki Kai. Overhaul.

“The Young Head, Chisaki’s quirk is called Overhaul. His power lets him disassemble and restore things. Even organic matter. A quirk that can disassemble and reassemble things. And a drug that can break down quirks.”

Izuku gripped the table with all his strength to keep from running out of the room.

Hawks gave him a meaningful look. “Chisaki has a daughter named Eri. There are no records and even details of her birth, but when Midoriya encountered her, she had a large number of bandages wrapped around her arms, legs, and neck.”

“Don’t tell me…” Eraserhead began, only to be cut off by Rock Lock.

“Are you sure we need the kids around?” He asked, tone scathing and mean.

Hawks didn’t react to anything Rock Lock said. “We’re wondering if Overhaul is turning his daughter’s body into bullets,” the winged hero said, and the following silence was heavy with tension. “If Overhaul is left to his own devices, he’ll complete this drug and quite possibly make bullets that will permanently erase quirks.”

Izuku was losing all his patience for this conference by the second.

“Wouldn’t this have been resolved already if *that kid* had taken the child?” Lock Rock’s face was twisted with contempt and annoyance.

“Are you trying to insinuate that Midoriya was willing to risk the lives of the innocent civilians nearby by taking her away?” Hermes snapped, “I caught up to him. I was *there* . Overhaul was willing to do anything. *Anything* to get her back, and Midoriya had her right in his arms and she ran away. What did you expect him to do?”

Rock Lock was momentarily stunned. “I would’ve—”

“Don’t finish that sentence,” Eraserhead interrupted. “Because if I hear you would’ve risked those lives, I will find a way to get your license revoked,”

“Midoriya handled the situation better than I could’ve hoped for,” Hawks responded, “No one in this room is as frustrated as Midoriya is. Our goal for this raid is to rescue and protect Eri,”

“If it’s what we think, then this girl is the entire crux of the operation and the young head will want to hide her, right? Even if we push our way in, it won’t matter if she’s not there. Have you even identified where she is?”

“That is really our only issue,” Hawks admitted, “We got a search warrant from the police. And we have successfully narrowed down which base of operations they’re currently using, but what I worry about is that we don’t know her exact location inside. If they’re smart, they have an underground area that we don’t have blueprints for,”

“So we need to gather more information,” Ryukyu mumbled. “Perhaps we could call Nighteye in—?”

It was right then that numerous things happened. Eraserhead slammed his hand on the table, shouting, “Absolutely not!”

Lemillion growled, “No way in *hell,”*

And then phasing through the closed doors came the same demon he had sent after Eri. Izuku wasn’t sure if anyone else could see it, until Toshi yelped in surprise.

“Followed,” the creature said, capturing the attention of all the pros still assembled. No one moved, and Izuku saw that the majority looked alarmed. The demon crossed the room and kneeled at Izuku’s chair. **“Followed her. Found.”**

“Do you know anything else?” Eraserhead asked, not even batting an eye.

“She’s in the stronghold. Hidden. Can show you,” It held out a distorted hand toward Izuku. **“Can lead the way,”**

Hawks blinked in surprise. He kind of looked impressed. “Midoriya, did you have one of your followers tail them?”

Izuku nodded.

[I couldn't just leave her on her own.]

"Can we trust this information? What *is* that?"

"A part of his quirk," Toshi defended. "I trust those creatures say,"

"From experience, they've tried to warn us in the past about villain attacks on my class," Eraserhead said when people looked doubtful. With that, everyone settled down.

"You clever little bird," Hawks mumbled to himself, smiling.

Izuku wasn't a bird, but he grinned sheepishly anyway.

"Well, it's settled then." Hawks suddenly turned serious again, and Izuku wondered which was a mask. His seriousness, or his playfulness? "We make our move soon,"

The next hour and a half was spent briefing everyone on the most prominent members of the Shie Hassaikai, and their overall strategy for the raid.

That night, after spending hours flying the city with Hawks to clear his mind, Izuku dreamt *of Eri in Overhaul's cruel maw. Crying out in despair and desperation, but unheard while Izuku struggled in the searing hands of All for One.*

Then, those hands turned from calloused and ancient to long, thin, and feminine. Inko's hands. He could feel a tug on his navel, even as he pushed forward to hold Eri in his arms once more. To protect her.

And to protect the part of himself he saw in her. The innocent part. The child part.

He needed to reach her.

“D-don’t g-go!” Eri screamed, and Izuku grit his teeth even as Inko’s familiar and cruel hands gripped his shoulders tight.

He would save her. He had to save her. To prove to himself that he could . *To prove that he’d made progress, that he was worthy of calling himself a hero.*

He screamed in outrage when his mother tripped him, serpent-tongued as she spit verbal fire at him. Izuku refused to hear it. He crawled to his feet, burning with hatred and rage.

“P-please…” Eri whispered brokenly, “Help me,”

He scrambled forward, as desperate to reach her as she was to be saved. But before they could even touch hands—both of them reaching, crying, begging—he woke up.

The raid would take place early. As Izuku was getting dressed in his hero costume he wished time would go faster. He wished they were already standing at the entrance of the stronghold. He itched to get into action.

He glared at his reflection and clenched his fists.

Dabi appeared behind him and whacked him upside the head. “You need to keep your head clear for this one, Izuku,” Dabi said, tone gentle, but his eyes were burning with determination. “You can do it. You’re a hero. You’re going to save her,”

You can do it, he repeated. *You’re a hero. You’re going to save her.*

And he believed it.

He defeated All for One, with All Might's help. He defeated his father, and today he would face his mother in battle. While the trauma would always be there, and he would have bad days, there was a strange sense of closure and safety when he thought about both his parents in prison. Rotting there. Where they *belonged* .

And for some reason, he got a sick feeling of satisfaction at the thought of putting Overhaul in prison too.

"Let's knock some heads," Dabi grinned, as Izuku adjusted the blood-red scarf that he refused to part with.

Chizome-san would be proud.

Izuku finally left the changing room and met up with Tsukuyomi, Uravity, Froppy, Red Riot, Control Freak, and the Big Three. The big group of students moved down the hall where Eraserhead and Hawks were waiting.

"Are we all ready?" Hawks asked. He immediately received multiple nods, and he gave them an impish grin. "Perfect, let's head outside. Morningstar, Tsukuyomi, you'll both be with me during the raid."

Eraserhead took up the rear of the group—other heroes were already headed to the address—standing next to him and Control Freak. In front of them was the demon who agreed to lead the way. At least when they got inside.

"How're you holding up, kiddo?" his dad asked, tone hesitant. "You and Eri… you're very similar,"

Izuku nodded. [I'll feel better when I save her.]

"We all will. And then we'll help her the way we're already helping you," Control Freak added, taking a hold of Izuku's hand, to give it a small squeeze. "Bakugou's gonna be pissed he missed this,"

"Yeah, well." Eraserhead shrugged. "It was his choice to work with Mic. He'll live,"

There was a sense of heightened urgency once they made it outside. Most of them were divided up into groups that then ducked into cars and sped off. Hawks, Tsukuyomi, and Izuku were the only ones left standing. Counting the demon tugging on his scarf, there were four of them.

"It's time to take to the skies, boys," Hawks said with a wink, as his wings snapped out.

Dark Shadow curled around Tsukuyomi's frame, and Izuku's own wings fanned out behind him. The demon latched onto his back, but Izuku felt none of the weight as they soared through the air.

Last night was the first time he flew out in a cityscape. Hawks had been a maliciously mischievous instructor and laughed when Izuku nearly rammed head-first into a building.

Today, there was no trace of that man.

Regardless, he learned quickly that flying was his favorite thing in the world, aside from his family.

The three of them, plus a friendly demon, were streaking through the skies, and just below them was a labyrinth of skyscrapers, towers, and cars.

Hawks led the way, and Izuku strangely felt like one of those packs of birds he'd seen looking out the window sometimes. They always flew in a strange V shape, but in the air, it made sense to fly like that.

Tsukuyomi was on one side of Hawks, just behind him, while Izuku was on the other. The flight only took a few minutes and while Izuku was definitely enjoying the feeling of being weightless and free, it felt like it took years.

Eri could be suffering. She could be getting torn apart by Overhaul as they flew over.

That uneasy and itchy feeling came back.

He was practically vibrating with anticipation when the stronghold came into view and they started to descend.

When they finally, *finally* touched down on the ground, the police were in full riot gear and slamming on the door.

"Open up! This is—"

But before the poor policeman could even get his whole spiel out, the door next to them caved in with an ear-splitting crash and a man barrelled out, muscles thicker than All Might's hero form. He was wearing a strange beak-like mask, and as he stood Izuku realized the man was actually kind of huge.

"What do you want?!" the man screamed, obviously a member of the Hassaikai.

"Get back!" Ryukyu exclaimed as the man's muscles grew even more as he drew back for a punch. In a flash, the air around them stirred, as Ryukyu transformed to hold the man back. "The raid has already started, everyone! Go!"

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys liked this chapter <3 lova yall!

Chapter 98

Chapter Summary

WARNING: VILLAIN CHARACTER DEATH

(LETS GUESS WHO >:D)

Chapter Notes

Upload 2 of 3!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was a rush of activity, yelling, and overall chaos. Or it looked that way, as Hawks called him and Tsukuyomi to attention. All around him, policemen were scrambling as suddenly, like a tidal wave, more members of the Yakuza poured out of the building.

“We’ve got to split up!” Ryukyu yelled, “Just as we planned!”

And so, Uravity, Froppy, and Nejire-Chan stayed with Ryukyu just as they had planned. As everyone else—minus a chunk of minor heroes—ran toward the building, the Chief Officer in charge of the raid exclaimed, “We’re the heroes and police! We have a warrant to search your premises on suspicion of the manufacturing and sale of illegal substances! Step aside!”

Tattooed members of the Yakuza flipped the man off, and some even ran forward to intercept them, only to be stopped by the officers in riot gear and Eraserhead’s quirk.

“Stop resisting!” An officer yelled, “You’re under arrest!”

Ahead of him, the demon leading the way dashed into the building, with Izuku right on his heels. “Straight to the target, everyone!” Fat Gum yelled as they all stormed the building.

There was no way Overhaul hadn't seen or heard them coming. They had to be quick. It was now or never.

They tore through hallways, not even stopping for a moment as heroes tackled hostile members of the Hassaikai to the ground. Until finally the demon stopped at a vase of flowers and tried to pick it up. It slipped from its distorted grip and Izuku pushed the vase off the surface it was sitting on in his urgency.

With crooked fingers, the creature pressed a small square box in the center of the surface, and the wall gave way to a steep set of stairs going downward.

The demon melted into the darkness, and for a second Izuku panicked before he heard, **"This way,"**

He could hear several sets of footsteps following after him, as the creature led them down, down, down until the steps gave way to a maze of halls.

Izuku would've shouted in annoyance if not for the sure way Hope—that was the demon's name now, he deserved a name—navigated the hallways. And there.

At the end of the hall, they were sprinting down, was Overhaul. And in his arms was Eri, her eyes going impossibly wide and hopeful when she saw him.

Izuku felt himself shifting naturally. Between one gasping breath and the next, he could tell the transformation was done.

Once again, a cold wave of calm came over him even as the ground rose up in front of them. Fat Gum was shouting something. Izuku only had eyes for Eri.

Eri and… the woman standing in Overhaul's shadow, with that smile that was too wide. That smile haunted his dreams the same way All for One and Hisashi did.

Inko Midoriya's laugh rang through the air, high-pitched and cruel. The wall of concrete rising between blocked them all from view. The floor beneath his feet shifted and the hall itself twisted.

Likely the quirk of one of the Hassaikai members.

"Wait, Morningstar! We have to figure out how to get passed the w—"

The wall crumbled beneath Izuku's enraged fist, and he heard Fat Gum's mouth click closed. But it was too late. Chisaki and Inko were gone, and walls were blocking them every few feet.

The floor was still moving like water, but as soon as Rock Lock slammed his hands down on the floor, it stopped. Suneater pushed his way to the front with Lemillion.

"I can go through the walls and catch up to them!" Lemillion told them. "Suneater, help Morningstar break through the walls, and I'll give you my location once I find Chisaki!

The three of them nodded to each other. Hawks briefly offered him a feather, before Lemillion admitted that he couldn't keep it due to permeation.

"Well, regardless. Everyone here should take a feather so I can find you if we get separated," Hawks said, and suddenly all of them had a piece of Hawks with them while they worked.

Working with Suneater meant giving himself a moment to calm down while they broke down each wall.

Eventually, they came to a wide room, with three thugs standing at the ready. They all paused momentarily. There was an empty hallway to the left, unobstructed by newly built walls.

Suneater looked at the three men and pointed at the door. “Go!” He growled, but it didn’t sound like he was growling on purpose. Most likely he was just nervous. “I’ve got this handled, everyone go!”

When they all hesitated, Fat Gum gave Suneater a hearty smack on the back and said, “I’ve always believed in you Suneater! It’s about time you did too!”

As they all sprinted down the hall, Control Freak asked, “Was it wise to leave him on his own?”

“Yes!” Fat Gum exclaimed, momentarily groaning when the floor started to shift, *again.* “He’s as good as any limelight hero I know. He just lacked the confidence!”

“We’ve got to stop whoever keeps moving these walls,” Eraserhead grumbled, as Rock Lock slid and hit the wall face-first. Fat Gum really tried not to laugh, but Izuku still heard it. “He can’t have this much range. He must be moving… which means he has to be in the walls!”

Upon having this revelation, mid-sprint, a huge hole in the wall appeared, and a part of the wall morphed to try and push Eraserhead and Control Freak inside.

Fat Gum and Red Riot moved at the same time, pushing both of his family members out of the way, falling inside as the wall closed up again.

“They’re fine! Alive!” Hawks spoke up when several heroes cried out in alarm. “We have to find the man responsible for moving everything!”

They kept sprinting, and Izuku was surprised at the overall stamina that all the heroes trailing behind them had. Hope, who had kept pace with them, pointed upward ahead of them.

“There!” Hawks shouted, spotting a face in the ceiling. But before Eraserhead could erase the man’s quirk, they needed to get him out of the wall.

Tsukuyomi and Dark Shadow moved as one, with Dark Shadow covering Tsukuyomi’s entire body as they slammed into the ceiling, revealing Irinaka, the man who could control whatever he was inside of.

Usually, according to the files and strategy meeting they’d had the day prior, Irinaka could only go inside something the size of a fridge, and yet, here he was, moving around and controlling nearly the entire underground base to keep them at bay!

Eraserhead immediately erased his Quirk, and Hawks took out some Quirk-suppressing cuffs. Probably provided by the Hero Commission, as most heroes didn’t walk around with them in their utility belts.

“You should save those for Overhaul,” Eraserhead said.

“I have another pair,” Hawks replied, as a small group of police officers and minor heroes took charge of escorting Irinaka out of the building.

With the halls no longer shifting and creating an endless maze, they could finally reach Eri, Lemillion, and Overhaul.

When Togata reached Overhaul, he was surrounded by four people. One of them was a man with bluish-white hair, who was holding Eri. His hair was cut short, and the ends of his hair were shaped into arrows.

It could only be Chronostasis.

And there were two other Precepts, Shin Nemoto and Deidoro Sakaki. Quirks, Confession, and Sloshed, respectively. The fourth and final person standing near Overhaul was Inko Midoriya. It had to be. She had the same hair color as his underclassman, Midoriya-chan.

At Togata's arrival, Overhaul froze and turned to face him. His eyes were narrowed in suspicion.

"You shouldn't have been able to get here so fast." is the first thing the Young Head of the Hassaikai said.

"I took a shortcut!" Togata explained, keeping it vague on purpose. He pointed toward Eri in Chronostasis's arms. "I'm here to rescue that girl!"

"This girl doesn't want you to rescue her. To her you're not a hero, you're a victim." Overhaul replied, voice cold and monotone.

"Huh?" Togata asked, feeling a well of anxiety growing in his stomach. A victim? What did that even mean?

"I'm telling you that you're going to die, Mr. Hero," Overhaul laughed, and suddenly there was a mad glint in his eye. One of the three Hassaikai members clattered onto the ceiling, a bottle of alcohol in one hand as he laughed.

Immediately Togata felt the effects of the man's quirk, as he drew closer. He stumbled into the wall.

Deidoro slurred, "Why wouldya… come to a raid—" he cut himself off to giggle and hiccup, "—drunk?"

"You're the drunk one," Shin Nemoto replied.

“No, I ain’t!”

“You quite literally are,” Shin huffed, “Now, stand back and let me ask my questions!”

Every time Togata took a step he felt as if his equilibrium was off, which was a direct effect of the quirk Sloshed. This really wasn’t a good match-up for him.

“What is your Quirk? How did you get past Mimic?” Shin Nemoto asked, releasing purple waves in the air as he spoke. Against his will, Togata already felt the words forming.

“Permeation. It allows me to phase through any solid matter. I ran through the maze he created,” He blurted before he slapped a hand over his mouth.

Shit. I didn’t mean to say that.

Then Shin Nemoto raised the gun in his hand and shot at him. He managed to dodge, even though it was sloppy and unrefined. He really did feel like he was drunk when he couldn’t walk straight like this.

“Why bother rescuing Eri?”

“Because I’m a hero!” Togata yelled, “And everyone deserves to be saved!”

“We won’t let you,” Shin replied, shooting at him again, but Togata just let them phase through him, unperturbed. This was the little girl Midoriya-chan wanted to save. The little girl that was similar to his underclassmen in so many ways… He wouldn’t let a few bullets stop him!

“We live for the young boss’ ambition!” Deidoro exclaimed, throwing the bottle of saki he was drinking out of in Shin’s direction. Shin just side-swiped it, and it shattered on the floor. “He accepted us when society wanted us dead. He needs us! We must follow him, and we’ll walk with him forever!”

“We’ll share the joy when his dreams are realized!” Shin exclaimed, turning briefly just to watch Overhaul walk away with Chronostasis, Eri, and Inko.

“Now!” Deidoro and Shin shouted together, moving in tandem. If Togata wasn’t facing them down on his own, or if they weren’t villains he would’ve admired their teamwork.

As it was, he had no time for such thoughts.

“Die, you nuisance!”

Shin aimed his gun and Deidoro threw a barrage of knives in Togata’s direction. He dodged both the bullets and knives, ducking into the wall with a gasp for breath. Darting in a fast-paced zig-zag pattern in and out of the walls, gaining momentum, Togata kicked the first villain in the sternum, and slammed his fist into Shin’s face, shattering the mask.

“How can you still move?!” Deidoro gasped painfully.

“I deal with something much worse than intoxication all the time! My permeation used to make me nauseous as a kid!” He exclaimed, twisting around to kick Deidoro again, knocking him out cold just like his companion.

Then he whipped around to face the direction that Overhaul and the rest of his goons had gone in, and found that they hadn’t gone very far at all.

Izuku felt the ground tremor, and that's how he and the other heroes knew what general direction to go in to meet up with Lemillion. It continued to shake as they passed two men who were out cold on the floor, and then came up to a hastily constructed wall that had to be the work of Overhaul.

From afar he heard Rock Lock exclaim, "How are you all so fast?!"

No one answered him.

Izuku and Tsukuyomi broke the offending wall easily, dashing into the chamber beyond with Hawks, Eraserhead, and Control Freak on their heels.

Immediately, Izuku took stock of the situation in front of him. Lemillion was dodging attack after attack from Overhaul. The room was in ruins as spikes and pillars rose into the air in seconds, each attack dead set on maiming Lemillion in some way.

But Lemillion's Permeation kept him from getting hurt. Behind Overhaul were Chronostasis and Inko . Behind Lemillion was the small form of Eri, wrapped up in Lemillion's torn cape.

Hawks used one of his feathers to secure Eri and bring her into his arms. As soon as Eri realized she was somewhere else she cried out in alarm and burst into tears. Immediately, Hawks thrust Eri into Izuku's arms, along with his own feather.

"Get her out of here," Hawks ordered, "We've got this covered,"

Upon being thrust into Izuku's arms, Eri's eyes had gone impossibly wide with a tinge of hope.

Izuku turned on his heel and sprinted out of the hole he had created, accidentally knocking over Rock Lock in his haste.

Hope materialized, yanking on Izuku's sleeve to show him the nearest exit. Eri exclaimed in surprise. "It's my imaginary friend!"

With his hands occupied he was forced to speak. ***"His name is Hope. He's my friend too,"***

If Eri was surprised by his sudden speech, then she didn't let it show. "Y-you can see him?"

Izuku nodded as they dashed down the next hall, taking a sharp right as the underground bunker shook beneath his feet. ***"I sent him to keep you company before I could save you,"***

Eri's eyes got even more comically wide. "You d-d-did that f-for me?"

Izuku held her more securely to his chest and nodded. They were headed up a set of stairs now, and Izuku felt a little out of breath. He had been running since the very beginning of this raid, and finally, the adrenaline of finding Eri was wearing off now that she was safe in his arms.

That was until they reached the upper level, and the floor in front of them caved in. Izuku tightened his grip on Eri, almost too taunt with worry to recognize that he could be crushing her in his grip. Fortunately, she clung to him just as tightly, with her face buried in his neck.

As the dust and debris settled, Izuku finally got a look at the villain he'd be facing.

Inko.

How did she manage to escape all the heroes? How did she even blast a hole through the ground?!

Eri made a distressed noise, similar to the rumble of fear that bubbled up the back of his throat. This was the woman who abused him, and probably Eri too.

Could he fight? Could he *win?*

Those questions clouded his mind and invaded every corner. Could he? Perhaps in a different situation, in a different life, he would've said no. He would've turned and run with his tail between his legs. In a different world where he *didn't* hold Eri in his arms.

If he didn't have a *reason* to face her, then he would've run to the safety of his dads or his brother.

But he was holding Eri. A child who needed him to be stronger and bigger than himself. Who went through something so similar to his own hurts and trauma. This was his chance to not only save her but to soothe the child in him that always begged to be helped. Who *didn't* get that help until he stepped up to do it himself.

He would make sure Eri got the help she needed.

"Hand her over, Izuku," Inko demanded with her hands outstretched.

Like hell, he'd ever let Inko handle a child. Like fucking *hell.* Over his dead body. Izuku shifted backward, eyes narrowed and tense in preparation for combat. Inko raised a single eyebrow, not even looking vaguely impressed or intimidated.

Inko, Hisashi, and All for One never took him for anything more than a punching bag and a pawn in their machinations. He would've thought perhaps the events of Kamino would have her be more cautious towards him, but apparently not.

"Fine. We'll do this the hard way," Inko grumbled mostly to herself after she realized Izuku was determined to go down swinging.

The hard way, it turns out, was Inko using her quirk to obstruct his breathing with her attraction quirk. It was a trick she'd used too often, for it wasn't effective. It was just as good as trying to drown him, but he could still move and fight, even if he couldn't breathe.

His chest burned from the lack of air. Dabi appeared at his side at once, already reaching for Eri so Izuku's arms could be freed up for combat.

Eri looked distressed as she was passed around, but she didn't make a single complaint as he handed her Hawks' feather.

Izuku lunged forward and Inko stumbled back in alarm as his nails ghosted along her arm.

Bleeding gashes were ripped into her skin, but she didn't make so much as a sound of pain. Inko had always been like that, refusing to show weakness.

Izuku lunged for her again, this time with flames flickering and dancing in his hands. Inko successfully dodged but released her quirk. In retaliation, she reached for the knives strapped to her belt, and once they were free she threw them into the air.

The knives froze mid-air, glowing green with the manipulation of her quirk as they began to spin around her person.

This particular move with her quirk was something new to him. She had only ever used her quirk for defense, even if that meant cutting someone's airway off or stopping their heart in their chest. Izuku had thought plenty about the possibility of Inko using her quirk offensively like this and only came up with a few ways.

It seemed at least one of his theories was right.

The first knife to leave the orbit of her quirk hurtled toward his head and he dodged it and the one that followed soon after. He hoped Dabi saw fit to leave them behind. What was

important in this raid was getting Eri out above all else, and he couldn't very well dodge knives *and* protect both Dabi and Eri at the same time.

Another round of knives zoomed past him, nicking him in a few places and drawing blood when he wasn't fast enough.

He kept trying to blast her away with his fire but she was just as good at dodging as he was and kept dancing just out of reach. She drew the knives back to her with a flick of her wrist, and they whipped around her, gaining inertia as they slowly neared her.

Releasing her quirk at *just* the right moment was how she threw the knives. It was honestly ingenious if a little risky.

Izuku and Inko both glared at each other, and he was forced to acknowledge that they were truly related. They had the same burning flame in their eyes when they were pissed off.

If Izuku was any less resilient, he would've ended up like her.

Another knife found its home in his shoulder and he hissed when the pain hit him. It was nothing compared to everything else he endured, but it did surprise him when Inko drew the knife back to her, splattering his blood on the floor in front of them.

Moving his arm wasn't an option now. He threw out another stream of fire to disguise his advance toward her.

Inko was worn out from the fight, her chest heaving and sweat dampening her forehead. Izuku was used to prolonged fights.

He killed his flames when he was close enough to her. He didn't want to kill Inko by burning her alive. Izuku didn't want to kill her at all. She deserved to rot in Tartarus for all her crimes until she died a meaningless death.

Izuku delivered a swift punch, taking just a *little* pleasure in the crack that he heard when her nose broke. She made a guttural noise in the back of her throat, sounding both pained and surprised.

"Fuck!"

She only staggered for a moment, before her eyes got the same sharp glint her knives had. When she tried to stab him Izuku twisted her wrist hard enough to make her drop it.

They traded punches and kicks, dissolving quickly into a wrestling match on the floor when he tripped Inko and she dragged him down with her. Nails dug into Izuku's stab wound, and he screamed at the sharp white-hot pain.

Inko had a triumphant look about her but it quickly turned bitter and angry when Izuku kicked her in the stomach.

"Stupid child!" she snapped, with another knife suddenly in her hand as she hovered above him. And then he felt it. His heart froze in his chest, like it was being squeezed. There was a split second where Izuku was certain she was going to slit his throat because instead of reaching for her wrist, his hand went straight to his chest in alarm.

Inko drew herself up and raised her knife to cut downward but before she could kill him, the demon he'd named Hope came up from behind her and slit her throat.

Izuku felt all the color drain from his face, as well as any emotions. A distinct numbness settled over him as he watched blood pour from her wound. Inko's knife clattered to the floor and she grabbed her throat, trying to staunch the flow.

He sprang into action, feeling nothing as he ripped his sleeve up so he could press it to the wound. Fuck. *Fuck.*

Heroes weren't supposed to kill villains. This wasn't how his job was meant to be done. Hope remained where he stood, looking down at the scene as if it satisfied him. As if this was perfect revenge.

Blood poured between his fingers and Inko regarded him with nothing but contempt. Not even in her final moments did she soften.

He let out a shaky breath and tried to ignore how Inko's breath began to rattle with death.

Above and below him, he could feel tremors. Probably from the battle between Overhaul and all the other heroes present. Izuku was still trying to stop the bleeding when the walls around him collapsed and reformed.

The ceiling above them cracked and Izuku looked up to see spider webbing cracks. There was no time to think, no time to drag Inko out of the way. There was hardly a second for Izuku to throw himself forward and out of harm's way.

He turned around slowly, dreading what he would see.

Where Inko's body had been, was a splatter of blood and slabs of broken concrete.

She was dead.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed Inko's long-anticipated death! (hopefully this satisfied those of u in the comments wanting to kill Inko lmao) This chapter felt super important to me lol and I hope I did it justice <3

Chapter 99

Chapter Summary

The End of the Overhaul Arc!

Chapter Notes

Upload 3 of 3! <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku didn't know what he was supposed to do. He stared blankly at the spot where Inko had been, wondering if he was expected to cry over her. Wondering if he should be relieved.

He didn't feel any of those things. That numbness clung to him even as he got to his feet and dusted off his costume. The warm stickiness between his fingers was disconcerting, but it wasn't the first time he'd been covered in blood.

Izuku was still staring when he started toward the rubble. Below him was another massive tremor, and he could hear the shouts of battle somewhere nearby but he paid it no mind.

He didn't want to see Inko's body. He didn't want confirmation. He *needed* it. Going home without knowing… Izuku lifted the first slab and found it was surprisingly easy to do so in this form.

He continued to dig shoving debris out of the way when he heard frantic footsteps, but he needed to know. Izuku didn't stop, smearing Inko's blood on the concrete in places where it wasn't already stained.

There, peeking out from under the last piece, were a few locks of Inko's hair. Just as he was about to lift it to assess the damage, something gray wrapped around his midsection and

yanked him away.

He could tell the difference between Control Freak's arms wrapped around him and his dad's, seeing as Toshi's were considerably slimmer.

"Toshi?" He asked, turning to face his brother. He couldn't decide how he should look, so he kept his expression blank.

Control Freak tightened his grip on him and said, "Don't. You don't need to look,"

Did he know that it was Inko's body under that rubble? Did he know what Izuku did to her?

From father down the hall came another set of footsteps and Izuku turned to see Shouta come running down the hall.

"Dabi said you were—" he started, and then his eyes fell onto the bloody slab of concrete in front of them. "Oh."

That mostly summed up how Izuku felt if he was completely honest. Oh. No sadness, no relief. Just indifference.

"Is that—?" Shouta tried, again, glancing between her, Izuku, and Control Freak.

"Yea. That's Inko," Control Freak answered when Izuku hesitated. All three of them stared at the rubble, not saying a thing. Then the floor trembled again and Shouta shook his head.

"We need to go back," he told them, as he squeezed both of them in a brief hug. "Eri has been successfully saved thanks to you and Dabi, but we still need to apprehend Overhaul."

Izuku's chest lightened with the knowledge that Eri was safe. All three of them headed back to where the battle was taking place, which by now wasn't as far away as it had been.

When they arrived, Lemillion, Hawks, Lock Rock, and Tsukuyomi were working in tandem to try and apprehend Overhaul, but the man was too adept at using his quirk. Every time anyone tried to get even remotely close, Overhaul would create a wall that Tsukuyomi had to break before they could get anywhere.

And behind Overhaul was Chronostasis, shakily loading bullets into a gun. With Eraserhead and Control Freak on the scene, Izuku could confidently say that they should win.

But… Shouta wasn't using his quirk. Izuku glanced between Control Freak and Eraserhead, confusion prevalent in his expression.

"Pops got hit by one of the temporary bullets," Control Freak frowned, glancing at Eraserhead. Izuku looked at him in alarm and scanned him up and down to find the injury. It was like someone dunked him in ice water, with how fast his face paled and his breath caught.

Then he saw the bandages wrapped around Eraserhead's shoulder. "We don't know if it was a temporary bullet," Shouta said.

"You should get treated!" Izuku admonished as they ducked under a bullet aimed at them.

"I will when Overhaul is in cuffs," Eraserhead told him, firm like a parent who was refusing to give their child candy. What a fool.

"You're dumb, old man!" Control Freak shrieked, dodging a spiked pillar. "We've got this, now that Morningstar is here!"

Eraserhead glared at them, and then Hawks' voice carried over the din of battle. "Tsukuyomi and Morningstar need to team up! Everyone else needs to provide backup!"

Izuku and Tsukuyomi glanced at each other and nodded.

“Control Freak and I will take care of Chronostasis,” Eraserhead said, as Hawks and Tsukuyomi approached.

Overhaul was still trying to maim them with concrete spikes, but everyone had gotten better at dodging from repeated attacks. Tsukuyomi charged forward first, with Dark Shadow covering them in a shroud of darkness, slicing through the new wall of concrete that emerged. As Izuku joined him, sword brandished and at the ready, there was a round of gunshots from Chronostasis.

He forced himself to focus even though he wanted to look to the side and check on his family members.

Overhaul kept creating massive spires and a maze of spikes, but he and Tsukuyomi dodged and weaved between them, even using them to propel themselves forward.

Izuku let out a pre-emptive stream of fire, forcing Overhaul to dodge and not use his quirk for a moment as they advanced on him. Tsukuyomi reached Overhaul first and punched him so hard that the villain went flying.

Izuku felt vindictively happy when he saw Overhaul crumple into a heap on the floor. He deserved this for hurting Eri. Finally, the numbness from earlier washed away completely, leaving him *burning* with anger.

It crawled up his throat, hot and irrational. Inko deserved her fate and Overhaul deserved his too.

He wouldn’t feel guilty about it. He *wouldn’t* .

“Stupid little heroes! You don’t even think about how terrible society is!” Overhaul shouted, black lines crawling along his face, as he pressed his own hand to his skin. “So naive that you don’t understand the world we live in.”

Overhaul’s skin warped and deformed as he reconstructed himself. Hawks tried to stop him by sending a barrage of sharp feathers his way, but Overhaul dodged just in time. The villain’s body now sported six massive arms, and Izuku heard Tsukuyomi and Rock Lock curse in alarm.

Izuku didn’t even balk. He’d seen many Nomu in his time of being under All for One’s thumb. There were ones who looked worse than Overhaul at the moment.

Izuku used his wings to propel himself forward faster, followed swiftly by Dark Shadow, Tsukuyomi, and more of Hawk’s feathers that pushed both of them even *faster*.

Tsukuyomi and Dark Shadow punched Overhaul again and a second later Izuku kicked Overhaul up into the air and through the ceiling. Izuku could see the sky peeking through the hole and streaks of sunlight pouring into the room.

All three of them were airborne, as Overhaul suddenly gave himself wings mid-air, and were locked in a battle of reaching hands and retreating bodies. Hawks joined them not a second later, as Overhaul’s fist connected with Tsukuyomi’s face.

He grunted in surprise, but Dark Shadow kept him afloat.

When Overhaul tried to reach forward and touch Tsukuyomi, Hawks sped forward with a sword-like feather and severed his hand.

“No touching!” Hawks yelled, expression dark and his stance protective in front of them.

“Don’t you get it?!” Overhaul screamed, half enraged and half pained, pointedly ignoring Hawks’ statement. “How come none of you see the bigger picture!? This world is tainted

with quirks. It's a pandemic that society has learned to celebrate. Quirks aren't *naturally* occurring instances. Don't you see? The government invented quirks using human experimentation! And Eri was the key to curing society!"

Izuku, Hawks, and Tsukuyomi shared glances for a millisecond and they all looked baffled by Overhaul's… justification for abusing Eri.

"That's… *that's* why you tore apart your daughter?!" Tsukuyomi shouted in outrage, and Izuku only had a second to realize this was the first time he's ever seen Tokoyami so angry.

Overhaul flew forward, smiling in a crazed way that reminded Izuku of Inko on one of her worst days. "Daughter? Eri? She's hardly even *human* . A living curse! Of course, I would use her to reach my goals!"

Hardly even human? A curse? Izuku's anger reared its head again, making him irrational again. Instead of retreating from him when he tried to grab him, Izuku severed his hand much in the way that Hawks did.

Maybe it was cruel. Maybe it was too much, but he didn't care. Eri was a *child,* and Overhaul had viewed her as nothing more than a means to an end. Tortured her for his own gain. Abused her for his vision.

Overhaul screamed in agony, having lost two out of six hands. With all of his strength, Izuku grabbed Overhaul's shirt and threw him down back to the ground despite how advantageous it would be for Overhaul.

He wasn't thinking. There was only the rage so molten hot it felt like he was aflame. He dived down to follow Overhaul's descent. The man obviously wasn't used to using wings, for he didn't even think to use them to stop himself. Instead, he crashed down with a loud rumbling that almost resembled a small-scale earthquake.

When Izuku reached him, he stabbed straight through Overhaul's outstretched hand, pinning it in place. And then punched him in the face, uncaring for how his own claws cut into his palms.

“You know,” Overhaul laughed nasally. Izuku must’ve broken his nose. “You remind me of her. Cursed, just like her.”

Izuku punched him again with a growl. Overhaul’s head hit the road beneath him, and Izuku huffed out a satisfied noise.

“Morningstar!”

Overhaul’s face was cut up and bloody. “ *Izuku,* watch out!”

He pictured Eri’s terrified face when she saw Overhaul in that alleyway and punched him again.

“Chisaki!” Chronostasis called desperately, just as Izuku noticed the third hand coming for him a little too late. He shifted to jump away, but he knew he wouldn’t make it—

“Chronostasis—!”

“Freeze,” Control Freak said, completely monotone. Overhaul’s hands froze just before touching him, and Izuku took the opportunity to knock out Overhaul and look up apologetically at Eraserhead and Control Freak.

“I’m sorry,” he said instantly, as Hawks’ came over to drag Overhaul to the waiting police car with Tsukuyomi in tow. Eraserhead and Control Freak both looked too pale and too much like they nearly witnessed Izuku die.

Again.

“Don’t *ever* ignore my warnings again!” Toshi yelled, his voice thick with emotion as he crushed Izuku in a hug. Izuku wrapped his arms around his brother as an EMT came over to inspect Shouta’s bullet wound.

Finally, he let his shoulders drop away from his ears. He let his head fall onto Toshi’s shoulder as he let his transformation go. He suddenly realized how exhausted he was. Izuku had been holding his transformation for a long while, so it wasn’t surprising that when he closed his eyes just for a moment, he fell asleep.

Hitoshi wasn’t as surprised as he should’ve been when Zuku fell asleep on him. Almost instantly the EMT that had just finished patching up Dadzawa came over to check on him.

“Just quirk exhaustion,” the man said. He probably had some kind of healing quirk, considering Zawa hadn’t been rushed to the hospital with that bullet wound. “Not serious enough for hospitalization, but you can lay him down in one of the empty ambulances for a few minutes if you like,”

Hitoshi glanced around for Zawa, who was sitting inside one of the nearest ambulances, staring in awe at his freshly healed shoulder. He made his way over with Izuku securely wrapped up in his arms.

Zawa looked up and Hitoshi gave him a tired smile. “Don’t look so worried, old man,” he said, trying to lighten the atmosphere. “He’s just napping,”

The man let out a relieved sigh. “I’ve just been informed that Eri has been admitted to the hospital safely. Do you think you’d be up to come see her with me and Zashi? I have to go there for some blood tests anyway, to see what kind of bullet I was hit with,”

Hitoshi furrowed his brows and tried to keep his mouth from dropping open in surprise. “We just saved her! Of course, I want to go see her. Zuku probably will too when he wakes up!”

Zawa rolled his eyes good-naturedly and motioned for Hitoshi to set Izuku down in the ambulance next to him. Once Izuku was laying down with his head in Zawa’s lap, Hitoshi

squeezed in on his other side, and leaned his head on his dad's shoulder.

"So what happens if that quirk-erasing bullet was a permanent one?"

It was a question he dreaded to ask. Not because his dad was lesser without a quirk, but because he was scared of how much it would change everything. It was almost like losing one's hearing, or eyesight. Losing a part of oneself that had been there for as long as they could remember.

Suddenly losing it…

Hitoshi couldn't imagine.

"Nothing," his dad answered, ruffling Hitoshi's hair. "I'll adapt better than most heroes would. And depending on what happens to Eri, we might not have to worry about it at all. That is if she chooses to use her quirk,"

"Okay," he said because that was all he could think to say. "But how are we going to break it to Zashi?"

Dad froze at that but not like a deer caught in headlights. More like he hadn't thought of that particular situation. Caught off-guard.

"I'm sure it'll be fine," Hitoshi tried to sound reassuring but he wasn't sure how successful he was, "You were protecting me!"

That was the truth. Hitoshi had frozen just for a second in battle after Zuku had disappeared with Eri. And that was enough for Chronostasis to attempt to shoot him. But before it could hit him, dad intercepted the bullet.

So it was Hitoshi's fault.

“Yes. And I would do it again in a heartbeat kiddo,” He replied. “Zashi would too. Don’t feel bad about it,”

But oh, he would. He would feel fucking terrible until they knew for sure what kind of bullet he was hit with. He opened his mouth to say as such when Hawks walked up to them.

“They found Inko’s body,” He stated, without preamble. “They could hardly recognize her. Let alone determine which injury killed her,”

“Oh,” Again, that’s all Hitoshi could think to say. Inko Midoriya was a terrible woman. In his opinion, she deserved what she got and more, and the same was true for Hisashi and All for One.

But at the very least, none of them could hurt Zuku anymore which was a huge win in his book. He was more than a little petty and upset that he didn’t get the chance to throw a few punches at the people who made his brother’s life hell. A quick look at his father showed that Dadzawa had the same thoughts circling in his mind.

“They’re ruling it as accidental, due to all the damage caused by Chisaki during the raid,” Hawks said, and from the casual way he picked at his nails and smiled just slightly, he had something to do with how all of this was being swept under the rug.

Hitoshi really liked Hawks. All three of them shared tight smiles, before looking over at Izuku’s sleeping form.

“Is it bad I’m kind of happy about it?” Hitoshi whispered, just loud enough for the three of them to hear. Kind of happy was an understatement, though. He didn’t even feel guilty for being happy, to be honest. Sure, he would’ve been fine with Inko going to Tartarus as she deserved, but death was a much more surefire way to make sure she never came back into Izuku’s life.

They could tell Izuku he was safe and it would be truer than ever before.

“Nah,” Hawks waved away his concerns with his hand. “I think it's normal, at least in this case. Deserved, even, but don’t tell anyone I said that,”

“We won’t,” Zawa said, with a gruff huff of laughter.

Their conversation went silent, with Hawks rubbing the back of his neck restlessly. “To tell you the truth though, I don’t think Inko was alive when that slab of concrete hit her…I can’t tell you why I think that. It’s just my instincts telling me,”

“And you didn’t tell anyone?” Aizawa asked, his hand freezing in Izuku’s hair.

“No way! Someone like All Might probably would without knowing the consequences, but not me. Our justice system isn’t perfect, and we all know that the Commission would tear Izuku apart if they even *thought* they had an opening,”

“So you think *Izuku* killed her?” Hitoshi pressed on, a sheet of ice piercing his heart. If Izuku had to kill his own mother to defend Eri or himself… As much as Inko deserved it, *Izuku* didn’t. Killing someone was traumatic, and this wasn’t even the first time it had happened. It was a shit storm the first time with Chizome-san, and it took Nedzu a lot of work to keep the Press and the Commission from making it worse.

“I dunno,” Hawks then crouched down at their ambulance, to poke Izuku in the face. “Why don’t we ask? I mean I know it’s probably an insensitive question, but still… it’s better for us to know so we can help him work through it, yeah?”

“Don’t ask him that, Hawks!” Aizawa snapped, “He’ll come to us when he’s ready,”

“Oh calm down. You’ve gone soft Eraser, I wasn’t gonna be like “Hey kid did you kill your mom?” I was gonna ask him what happened between him and Inko, and if he didn’t say anything I would’ve left it there, jeez. Who do you think I am?”

Hitoshi stifled his laugh with his hand. Beside him, Aizawa glared at both of them but relented.

“Fine. If you can wake him up, go ahead. We need to go see Eri anyway, and Mic is on his way to pick us up,”

Hawks’ grin widened and he poked Izuku again. He made a noise of discontent and swatted at the bird hero's hand, eyes still shut with sleep.

“Zuku you have to wake up so we can go see Eri,” Hitoshi tried, as he took a turn poking Izuku’s cheek.

His reaction was nearly immediate. His eyes snapped open and he sat up.

[We can go see Eri?]

Hawks pouted, looking a little jealous. Hitoshi gave him a smug smile, and the hero stuck his tongue out in response. Very dignified and mature of him.

“Yeah, you definitely can, kid!” Hawks said once the two of them stopped making faces at each other. “But I am curious. What happened between you and Inko?”

His brother's face blanked completely, and both Hitoshi and Zawa shuffled closer to provide comfort. Zuku raised his hands to answer.

[Hope killed her.]

“Hope?” Hitoshi echoed.

[The demon that helped us find Eri. I named him.]

“Are you… okay, after that?” Hawks asked, placing a hand on Zuku’s knee, still crouched low.

His brother shrugged at all of them. Then his shoulders started to shake, and he hunched forward and he seemed to crumble right before their eyes. Tears streamed down his face as he tried valiantly to wipe them away.

Hawks sighed, and it was heavy and full of understanding. Hawks was, after all, the number two hero. So it would truly be safe to say that he’d seen a lot of things in his time as a pro. He gave Izuku a pat on the head.

Hitoshi pressed himself closer. As close as he could be, as he gave Zuku a crushing side hug.

“It’s gonna be alright, kid,” Zawa said softly, rubbing circles into his back. They let Izuku cry and cry, even when Zashi showed up with the car and joined their hugging session. He started crying too when Zawa gave him a quick breakdown of everything that happened.

Then, when the tears finally dried and Zashi stopped trying to strangle all of them—even Hawks—in a hug, they all started toward the car sans Hawks. But they were stopped by Tokoyami, Uraraka, and Tsuyu.

“A-are you all alright?” Uraraka asked, shifting nervously. “We heard about Inko…”

“We’ll be ok soon,” Zashi promised, “Are you kids alright? No one needs to go to the hospital?”

“Kirishima needed to go to the hospital, but it’s nothing too serious,” Tsuyu said, “We were going to visit him and Eri and everyone else,”

“We can fly you there, if you want,” Hawks said, gesturing between himself and Tokoyami. “I don’t think Present Mic’s care has enough room for all of us,”

“Is that legal?” Uraraka asked, but she said it so eagerly like she was hoping it wasn’t.

“I’m not sure!” Hawks said just as enthusiastically. “Are either of you afraid of heights?”

Tsuyu and Uraraka shook their heads.

“Then let’s go!”

Hitoshi looked at his dad as Hawks and Tokoyami prepared to take off.

“Are you okay with this?”

This question prompted Zashi and Dadzawa to share a look. Then Zawa narrowed his eyes at Hawks and crossed his arms.

“If you drop my students I will murder you,”

“Got it, Eraser! See you there!”

Hitoshi watched in mild amusement as his dad rolled his eyes so violently they just might pop out.

Izuku gave a weak chuckle and they smiled at each other. Today, despite some pretty major ups and downs they saved a little girl. Today, his brother had become the hero he’d needed when he was younger.

Today, Hitoshi felt like a hero too.

Chapter End Notes

As usual, here's The Discord link: click me and join the chaos!

Chapter 100

Chapter Summary

> Eri POV for a little bit, and then the set up for the Cultural festival, which is officially the last arc of the fanfic!! Chapter 101 will be the end of that mini-arc, and then inserted with a bunch of extra scenes! <3

Chapter Notes

> Hello and happy holidays everyone! I know this time of year can be difficult for some of us, for varying reasons. Hopefully, my updates helped you through some of that!
>
> I'm also currently working on chapter 101, and should have it done very soon!! (Might get a little delayed aka: after Jan 5th, coz league of legends has a prestige warwick skin that I wanna farm for, so if I post it a few days after the 5th, you know why! <3)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Eri hated the sharp smell that accompanied this place. It smelled too much like the room Chisaki kept her in when he was tearing her apart. A sterile clean smell that burned her nose. But more than the smell, she hated how many *people* came into her room to check the beeping machines beside her. To prick her skin with needles, to ask her questions, to ask in gentle voices if she needed more snacks and water.

Eri, simply put, didn't know how to react to this new situation. This new environment. She was terrified, and the people in white coats could tell. She wondered where her friend Hope had gone. She wondered where her Hero, the boy with green hair, horns, and wings had gone.

She wanted Hope to be here. She wanted her Hero, as the doctors kept calling him when she asked, to be here. Eri didn't want to be alone.

She clutched the white sheet beneath her, and her knuckles went white from how tight her grip on them was.

Everytime someone new entered her room she pressed herself against the bed, eyes wide as she kept them within her line of sight. Eri didn't know how long she'd been in this room because time always flowed differently within Chisaki's home. But it felt like a long time. A long time of her being surrounded by strangers, who didn't hurt her at all, or raise their voice.

She almost felt like she was dreaming. But it wasn't a pleasant one. She felt off-kilter and her stomach was in knots. Eri used to have a lot of scary dreams about falling from very high, and being in this sterile room felt just like that. She had nothing to grab onto. Another man wearing a white coat over his clothes came in and she locked eyes with him.

"Eri-chan, do you remember the hero who saved you?" He asked, and she nodded jerkily. "Would you like to see him and one of his dads?"

Eri nodded without thinking much of it. Of course, she wanted to see her hero!

Izuku was nervous about seeing Eri. Mainly because he knew what it was like to be in this kind of situation. Torn from everything you've known, and thrust into a brand-new environment. He wasn't sure how she'd react to his presence in her room, and nor did he know if she even really wanted to see him.

That's why he brought Hizashi along. He was amazing with kids, and he was one of the first people Izuku felt truly comfortable around.

He knew that if he couldn't make Eri comfortable, Hizashi would be able to. So when they entered the room, Izuku made sure to stick close to Hizashi, to make sure that Eri knew he was safe.

Eri watched their every move, stiff and uncomfortable on her own hospital bed. Izuku didn't move from the door and she seemed to relax just a bit.

He studied her as much as she studied him. Her hospital gown accentuated how thin and small she was. The fresh white bandages around her arms and ankles brought worry to Izuku's heart, a crushing weight on his chest. Had she been injured, and he didn't notice?

How could he not notice?

[Were you injured, Eri?]

Hizashi was quick to voice his question out loud, voice subdued and soft. When Eri answered that she wasn't injured, and just got her old bandages replaced by a nice lady they both let out relieved breaths.

After that, Izuku wasn't really sure what to do or say. He didn't dare move forward in case it made Eri scared, and he didn't really know what to say. He could say plenty of comforting things, but he wasn't sure how well they would stick considering he hadn't believed anyone's claims that he was safe at first.

And to be fair, no one had experienced the things he'd gone through. Not in the way that he and Eri had. They were so similar. One could easily say that they were the same, even though their experiences were different from each other. Maybe… maybe if he told Eri this, she would start to trust him?

He wanted Eri to have a chance at a good life like Izuku had been given. He wanted her to be safe.

If that meant sharing his experiences with her, then so be it.

[Do you know what sign language is, Eri?]

She shook her head when Hizashi spoke, and his dad went ahead and explained it to her. From there, in a quiet voice that didn't betray how he was truly feeling, Hizashi began to recount every bad experience Izuku had that led up to him not speaking anymore.

As Izuku continued to sign, to tell her of a big bad villain that used him, Eri started to relax further. There was understanding in her eyes where there had once been hesitance.

“You’re like me,” was the first thing she said, looking utterly awestruck. “Did the heroes save you?”

“No,” Hizashi said before Izuku could answer. “Izuku saved us and himself when we were too blind to see what was happening to him. But we promised that we’d keep him safe and help him be a hero to everyone else too,”

Izuku didn’t know if Eri understood what Hizashi was trying to say, but she nodded regardless.

“When he first met you he was so upset that he didn’t save you the first time,” Hizashi continued, with a small smile. “He wanted to be the hero he never had, for you,”

“And you did! You saved me!”

Izuku watched as Eri’s cheeks went pink at her own outburst, and how her lips tried to form something similar to a smile but failed. When she realized her face wasn’t working how she wanted it, she pouted.

“And since he saved you, that means you never have to go back there, Eri-chan. He can never hurt you again. *No one* will hurt you,”

Eri looked confused at that, and Izuku’s heart swelled as she looked at him in question. Asking without asking, if Hizashi was being truthful. He gave her a nod.

“Is this where I’m going to stay?” Eri asked, and she looked uncomfortable with the mere thought of it. “I don’t like it here,”

At some point in their conversation, Izuku and Hizashi migrated closer and closer. Izuku was now close enough to pat her gently on the head, and she leaned into it adorably.

Hizashi smiled. “Once you’re all better you’ll get to leave here,” he said, “How would you feel about staying with us and your hero?”

Izuku’s jaw almost hit the floor in surprise. Was he surprised by Hizashi’s question? Absolutely not. Did he think he’d ask her so soon? No. Especially since Nedzu and Shouta were outside, on the phone trying to figure out where Eri would go. Of course, the Commission wanted to take Eri—Izuku found out from Shouta’s heated curses—so Nedzu needed to move quickly with this.

There was no guarantee that Nedzu would let Eri stay with them specifically, even if they moved into the teacher and student dorms at UA. Izuku would share a room with Toshi if it came down to it and they didn’t move. He certainly didn’t mind it one bit. He loved Toshi.

“Can I?” She said in lieu of an answer.

Hizashi replied, “Of course!”

In response, Eri did an excited wiggle on her bed, and Hizashi chuckled. But sadly, that was right when Eri’s doctor came in to tell them that they had to leave for now.

Hizashi had to start dragging Izuku out of the room. He really didn’t want to go. Who would be by Eri’s side then? To keep her company? To keep her feeling safe? Hizashi had to go and take Hitoshi and Shouta home when he went to work. Shouta had to speak with Nedzu to figure out Eri’s situation. No one aside from him and Toshi could be with Eri right now.

As they reached the door, Eri burst into loud sobs. Hizashi froze immediately as the doctor frantically tried to calm her.

“Please don’t make him go!” She sobbed into her hands, and Izuku felt his heart breaking into a million little pieces. The doctor looked between the two of them and Eri, clearly lost.

“We really won’t get in the way, I promise,” Hizashi said, as Eri sniffled loudly, and tears still streamed down her face.

“The health of my patient is my utmost priority and I can’t help her if she’s distressed like this…” the doctor admitted. “If you’ve got the free time it *would* be preferable for you to stay,”

Hizashi and Izuku beamed at each other and went back to Eri’s bedside.

“Thank you,” she whispered, and the doctor just gave her a gentle smile.

For the next hour, Izuku spent time trying to figure out the things Eri liked, while Hizashi left periodically to ask for an update from Shouta and Nedzu. Toshi had been allowed to switch out for Hizashi at one point as their dads had to join a virtual Yuuei meeting. Which was just a fancy way of saying Nedzu Face-Timed them.

It turned out Eri liked apples, and her favorite color was the color of Izuku’s hair. He didn’t cry a bit when she said that. No, not a single tear. They also discovered that Eri loved how soft and fluffy Toshi’s hair was, and that her favorite animal was a bunny. That one took a while to figure out since Eri didn’t exactly know what bunnies were called.

Toshi was just beginning to explain to her what cats were when Shouta inched his way through the door. All three of them turned to look at him, and he ducked behind his capture weapon.

“Nedzu has come to a decision.” He rubbed the back of his neck awkwardly as both Toshi and Izuku’s eyes widened at the same time. “Legally, she’s Nedzu’s ward, but she’ll be living with us from now on,”

“Yes!” Toshi pumped at fist into the air, just like Uraraka usually would when she was excited. Eri looked a little confused at the gesture, but after a few seconds, imitated him. Adorable. “Did you hear that, Eri? You get to come live with us!”

Eri nodded enthusiastically, “Can we go now?”

Izuku deflated at that and Eri seemed to take note, for she stiffened and anxiety filled her. Shouta shook his head and made his way to Eri’s bedside.

“The doctors have to make sure you’re healthy before you can leave,” Shouta told her, “But my husband will be with you the entire time, and when you’re all better you can come home,”

“Did Principal Nedzu give him some days off then?” Toshi asked.

Shouta nodded, “We called his agency too, and they approved it as well,”

That put Izuku at ease. Seeing that he relaxed, Eri copied him and relaxed into her bed with a small sigh. She would come home with them soon where she would be safe. Where she could grow and heal.

Despite the events that led up to Eri’s safety—like his mother’s death—Izuku felt almost burden-free if only for a moment. Eri was safe.

It was the day after the Raid on the Hassaikai, and the high of saving Eri was finally beginning to wear off.

Izuku woke up that morning unmotivated to get up from his bed, despite Dabi’s gentle coaxing, and Toshi’s bribes that he’d share his morning coffee. He was content to stay in bed,

curled up under the sheets for the rest of his life. He didn't feel like crying, but he also didn't feel like forcing a smile on his face. He just wanted to sleep and ignore everything.

He killed his own mother, and he was expected to go to school afterward? He got a few texts from Hawks, who was also trying to gently remind him that it wasn't really his fault what happened to Inko.

Hizashi and Shouta came into his room too, pushing Edgar aside when he tried to smother Shouta with slobbery kisses and told him that he didn't actually need to attend any classes if he didn't want to. That's what finally got him to get up.

They dropped Shouta and Toshi off at Yuuei, and Hizashi and Izuku headed down towards the hospital to see Eri.

In the hustle and bustle of the hospital, they met Hawks who was also paying Eri a visit. At first, Izuku was a bit worried that Hawks would make Eri anxious, with how energetic Hawks could be, but that didn't happen.

Instead, Eri seemed utterly fascinated by his wings, and the bunny stuffed animal he gifted her only made Eri declare that they were now best friends. Seeing Eri so happy to hold her stuffed bunny reminded him that everything he did was worth it.

His mother had never been a good or kind woman. She was a villain through and through. While he still felt responsible for what happened, he knew logically that it wasn't *his* fault . She chose to be a villain. She chose to fight him despite knowing the risks. And when Hope deemed her too much of a threat, he killed her.

It wasn't his fault, but it was still his "knife" that killed her.

And yet, he felt more relief than guilt. Her death had changed something in him, that was for sure. Any killing, intentional or otherwise, changed a person just like how Chizome's death had changed him.

“You look sad today,” Eri said suddenly. “Are you okay?”

[I’m feeling better after visiting you.] Izuku signed, with a small smile. It was true, of course. He would never lie to Eri, but she still seemed rather concerned.

“You can hold my bunny if you want,” Eri said like she was giving him a choice, but she just placed the toy in his hands and pulled away before he could try to give it back. Hawks tried to stifle a laugh, but he failed because Izuku heard it and pouted at him. Hizashi was no help at all because all he did was get his phone out to take a few pictures of the scene.

Ugh. That was definitely going to make its way into the class group chat somehow. He was never going to live this down.

Hawks cooed at his phone when it suddenly pinged, and Izuku sighed heavily.

“Don’t be so grumpy kiddo, you’re so cute!” Hawks bumped their shoulders together playfully. Izuku almost glared, but then he saw Eri’s satisfied face. She had accomplished what she set out to do, and Izuku couldn’t help but give her a fond look and hold her precious bunny closer.

After that, more doctors periodically checked in on Eri, and Hizashi was informed that they didn’t think it was wise to let her leave the Hospital until they could prove that she’d do well in a social environment. It was a valid reason to keep her here, Izuku knew, due to the circumstances. But he was pretty confused about how they’d actually prove she was ready for the outside world.

He shared a look with Hizashi and Hawks and was certain they were all facing the same dilemma. Hizashi was tapping his chin in thought and Hawks’ brow was furrowed.

[Couldn’t we bring her to campus for a day?] Izuku signed, thinking that Yuuei would be the best place for her to step foot in for the first time. She would be surrounded by heroes and it would be much easier to control her environment and keep her from feeling overwhelmed.

Hizashi gaped as if the thought never occurred to him, and then suddenly shot to his feet as he snapped his fingers and pointed at him. “That might just work! Yuuei’s Cultural Festival is happening at the end of the month! Eri, would you like to go to a Cultural Festival with me?”

Eri glanced between them like she’d never heard of a Cultural Festival in her entire life. Which made a depressing amount of sense. Izuku had a feeling they’d be explaining a lot of things to Eri as she went through life.

“What’s a… Cultural Festival?” She asked, genuinely curious. “Is Izuku coming too?”

Hizashi grinned brightly and launched into a rather lengthy explanation of what Cultural Festivals entailed, and then broke it to her gently that Izuku might be preoccupied with his classes' own event for the Cultural Festival.

Her expression dropped, but Izuku was quick to promise her that he’d come to see her whenever he was free to do so. Eri then cautiously agreed to attend the Cultural festival, and Hizashi set off to find a doctor to run it by them for approval.

He returned five minutes later—during which, Hawks introduced Eri to more animals via pictures on his phone—with a satisfied glint in his eyes.

“The doctors have agreed to let you come see Yuuei!”

Aizawa-sensei hit them with an unprompted, “We’re going to have a school festival,” right at the beginning of class. Katsuki, honest to god, fucking hated this idea. His schedule was already pretty full, thank you very much! “Each class needs to participate with something. Figure it out gremlins,”

And then Aizawa-sensei crawled into his hideous sleeping bag and scooted himself across the floor into the corner to nap. Of course.

Almost instantly it was utter fucking chaos everywhere. Iida and Yaoyarozu tried their best to take control of the situation while Katsuki lamented the loss of his free time that he was going to spend with Izuku. Damn.

In the midst of all this, at some point, *he* was volunteered by his classmates as a messenger. Literally. They tasked him with sending Izuku each option they came up with for the Cultural Festival, so he'd be a part of the class-wide vote.

The extras were adamant that Izuku be involved regardless of his absence, which did *not* bring a small smile to his face. No way. Katsuki never smiled. Ever. And if anyone caught him doing it he'd deny it until the day he died. He glared at the board and found that the options weren't that bad if he ignored the first one.

So far, 1-A had three options written down: A reverse maid cafe,—ew—a petting zoo, which was okay, and a concert. That last one was surprisingly Denki's idea, and so far it had the majority vote.

He took a quick picture of the board and sent it to Izuku.

Kacchan: image.jpg

Kacchan: Vote for one

Deku: Petting zoo

Kacchan: of course you'd pick that one, nerd

Deku: What's that supposed to mean? >:0

Kacchan: Nothing. >:0

Deku: What did everyone else vote for?

Kacchan: Kouda, Tokoyami, Shouji, and you voted for the petting zoo. Uraraka, Tsuyu, and Hagakure voted for the reverse maid cafe. We're still counting the rest of the votes.

Deku: Update me when they reach a decision! Eri's going to be coming to the Cultural Festival.

Kacchan: Really?

Deku: Yup! She seems pretty cautious about it though.

Kacchan: Hm. Well, I guess we'll just have to make it fun for her. I'll tell the extras.

Deku: Kacchan don't call our classmates extras!

Katsuki turned off his phone and said loud enough for Glasses and Ponytail to hear, "Eri's coming to the Cultural Festival, and Izuku voted for the petting zoo,"

At the mention of Eri, everyone involved with the Raid perked up. The only reason Katsuki and the rest of 1-A even knew about her was because Kirishima and Uraraka accidentally let it spill that they rescued a little girl during the Hassaikai Raid. And after that, it became futile to keep it to themselves.

So yeah, everyone knew about Eri and what had been done to her. Almost all at once, his classmates softened at the mention of her. Iida quickly marked down Izuku's vote on his clipboard and pushed his glasses up his face with a serious expression.

“With that in mind, now we must do our best to make sure Eri’s experience is memorable! Everyone, please finish voting as soon as possible so we can get to work on our project as a class!” Iida exclaimed, despite Aizawa-sensei’s grumble for them to be *quieter.*

It was a rush of noise and excitement as Aoyama and Ashido exclaimed that they should do the concert. Soon after that, it was Katsuki’s turn and he decided that he’d just go with the majority vote, which happened to be the concert.

Yaoyarozu hummed to herself while double-checking the vote. Once positive everyone had been accounted for, she said, “We don’t really have much time to prepare, so we should decide on various things today,”

“Various things?” Denki parroted, “Like what?”

“Well, we’re doing a concert,” Tsuyu mumbled, “So we’d need to decide on a song first, kero,”

“Oh right, right,” Denki leaned on Katsuki’s desk and rubbed his chin. “Jirou, aren't you really good with music? You play a bunch of different instruments, don’t you?”

Jirou looked caught off-guard for a moment but nodded. “Yeah. Why?”

“That means you’re a music nerd, duh! Which song do you think we should do?”

“Since it’s for everyone shouldn’t we do something popular?” Ashido asked as everyone began to congregate at Katsuki’s desk, for some strange reason. He wasn’t good at music, god damn it! He only took drum lessons!

“Something upbeat! Something people can dance to!” Hagakure replied.

“We should play instruments!” Denki exclaimed, “Hey Bakugou didn’t you say the other day that you can play the drums?”

“Yeah, what about it?”

“Well, then you can be part of the band then!” Denki said, with a warm smile. “We’ve gotta make this great for Eri, so you *have* to do it!”

“No way,”

Denki squeaked in surprise, and then shook himself. “No? But think about how disappointed Midoriya will be if you don’t!”

Damn it. Damn him and his stupid classmates. They were all giving him heavily weighted looks as Denki smiled slyly. He didn’t really get a choice, with everyone looking at him like that.

“C’mon Bakugbro!” Sero exclaimed, “Do it for Midoriya and Eri!”

“Yeah, dude! It’d be super manly of you!”

Katsuki slammed his fist onto his desk and gave an annoyed sigh. “Fine! But you guys owe me some spicy noodles!”

“Deal!” Denki shouted, with the most triumphant look Katsuki has ever seen on his face. Manipulative bastards, all of them!

“Okay, so we’ve got the drums all figured out,” Jirou said, but it was mostly for herself, “We just need… someone on the keyboard, bass, guitar, and vocals,”

“Well, um, as part of my education I learned piano if that would be of any help,” Yaoyarozu told her.

“That’s perfect!” Ashido exclaimed, “I was hoping to have an all-girls group for some of our dances but you’ll be great on the keyboard!”

Iida chopped his hand through the air. “I’m not sure if a song and dance will be enough for our part in the cultural festival!”

“Oh! Oh! We’ve gotta do special effects!” Aoyama shouted. “We can divide it up easier this way too. We can have the band, our dancers, and then our backstage crew handling everything in the background! That way, our introverted classmates can still help without feeling pressured!”

“That’s a brilliant idea, Aoyama!” Jirou exclaimed, and Katsuki took this moment to relay all of this in a text to Izuku, so he wasn’t left fumbling when he finally got back to class.

“We can do streamers, sparklers, and a disco ball!” Sero tacked on, “Aoyama you’d make a great disco ball, actually,”

“That’s not a bad idea!” Aoyama laughed, “I’ll be positively sparkling!”

“Exactly!”

“Ooh, Kirishima and Todoroki can work together! What if— What if Todoroki makes some ice and Kirishima uses his quirk to break it up to make it look like it's snowing? And when you spin around, Aoyama, it’ll look like stardust!”

Aoyama positively beamed at that, and Katsuki shook his head good-naturedly.

“What about Midoriya and Dabi? They could totally make some cool effects with their fire! Bakugou, can you ask them for us?”

“Already on it, Cheeks,” Katsuki replied.

“Who will be singing the vocals?” Tsuyu asked, and all discussion came to a halt as the *entire* class looked over at Jirou.

“Why’re you all looking at me?” She asked.

“I think you should sing, Jirou-chan!”

“When you were tutoring us before the Training Camp, we heard you singing and you sounded super good!”

“I don’t think—”

“Sing something for us, then,” Katsuki grumbled. Usually, he’d leave it alone, especially because he wasn’t one to force people into doing things they didn’t want to do, but Jirou looked more nervous than reluctant.

“Fine!” Jirou huffed. Then everyone quieted down to hear her sing. Objectively she was really good. Katsuki entrusted her with the task of singing their vocals.

From there they had to choose two guitarists. Denki and Tokoyami took both spots.

The effects team was then decided as: Todoroki, Kirishima, Shinsou, Izuku, Dabi, and Sero.

The dance team was: Kouda, Mina, Uraraka, Tsuyu, Shouji, Ojiro, Hagakure, Satou, Aoyama, and Iida.

Personally, Katsuki thought this was going to be a disaster, but hey. Maybe it’d be fun.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you guys enjoyed this chapter <3 see you soon for the last one! (I'M NOT CRYING, YOU ARE TT^TT)

The Discord Link!

The End

Chapter Summary

The very last chapter of this fic T^T contains the conclusion of the cultural fest and a few articles written in lieu of a actual time-skips.

Chapter Notes

Firstly, I would just like to say that this fic has been something that has occupied my mind the most for nearly 5 years. I say 5, because I started this fic in late 2018 and finished it in the first days of 2023. Something Wicked has been an absolute fucking journey, and I'm so lucky that I had such adamant readers that came along for the ride. This fic would not be finished without you. This fic would not even exist without the other fic authors out there who inspired me so much. This was a labor of love for me, and as such, this fic will not receive any major edits after I upload this chapter (other than any typos ppl point out lmao). I will be the first person to say that this fic is flawed in so many places and there are so many things that I've done wrong (like making the bkdk in this completely background to the plot, instead of in the forefront of the fic), but this is a visual of how far I've come as a writer. So, I will not fix anything. It will stay as it is. But this isn't the end of my fic writing career! (You can't get rid of me bitches! The discord link at the end of the chapter will stay active!) All the fans of Wisteria and Shackles of Time will be happy to know that I'm picking both of those stories back up after nearly two years of solely working on SW. It might take me a while to get back to updating, since there are some scenes I'd like to revisit before I continue off where I last wrote. So I recommend rereading those fics when I start updating again, because some things will be different.

Thank you for reading the last chapter of this fanfic <3 (ignore me crying over finishing this okay? okay.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It wasn’t until the next day that Izuku attended his classes.

Class 1-A, as per usual, was loud and boisterous. Even more so since the school festival was coming up.

Izuku had never been to a concert, nor did he have any idea what to expect. So to be honest he was pretty grateful that he and Dabi were placed with the Special Effects team. He never had an opportunity to learn an instrument and he wasn't all that good at dancing, unless fighting counted.

As the day wore on Izuku noticed that his classmates were restless and eager for the school day to be over so that they could begin practicing. Todoroki kept tapping his pencil on his worksheet and Kirishima kept casting looks at Sero. Kacchan kept looking at the clock on the wall like it would make time go by faster. Everyone except for Izuku seemed super excited.

[What is a concert like?] He decided to finally ask, choosing Toshi as the safest option.

Toshi's expression didn't change from its usual exhaustion, but he did notice the barely there wrinkle between his brows.

"Well," he said, clearly trying to figure out how exactly to describe it in a way that made sense to someone who's never been to one. "It's loud. There's music, singing, dancing, and special effects."

[Special effects?]

"Like streamers or even fireworks sometimes. The special effects are usually really flashy," Toshi explained. "They're usually used to amp up the atmosphere,"

To be honest, Izuku didn't really think he'd truly understand until they actually started rehearsing. Either way, he nodded.

Toshi gave him a grin and turned back to the math equation on his worksheet. Izuku, however, kept trying to imagine what special effects his classmates had thought up. Would they do something with fireworks too, or did they have something else in mind that required less setup? Would they make special effects with their Quirks in mind?

The more he thought about it, the more he was eager to start talking with Todoroki, Kirishima, Sero and the others. He drifted through his school work.

All of their teachers noticed the unusual shift. It was a challenge to get any of them to pay attention to the classwork. Even Iida, who was usually the most attentive, had trouble when he was called upon by Ectoplasm.

None of their teachers really looked miffed about their collective lack of attention though. They were all too excited to make their concert as fun as possible for Eri-chan.

When classes finally did end for the day, Izuku was promptly swarmed by Todoroki, Kirishima, Toshi, and Sero.

“Hey Midori-bro!” Kirishima said, “Bakugou told you that you’re part of the effects team, right?”

Izuku nodded, matching the friendly grin on Kirishima’s face. “Great! It’s gonna be so cool to incorporate all of our quirks into this!” the red-head’s grin transformed into a fully formed smile as bright as the sun.

“We were thinking of using my tape as streamers,” Sero explained, as Izuku stood from his desk and they all slowly made their way to the dorms where they would presumably continue planning.

“And we’re going to use my ice to make snow,” Todoroki said, “Kirishima will shave it down using his quirk,”

“Aoyama will join us half-way through the performance to become a human disco ball,” Toshi replied, “I’m going to be helping with that, but we’ve all talked about some ideas for your quirk. How do you feel about using yours and Dabi’s fire?”

Izuku raised his hands to sign in response. [Sounds like it’ll be cool!]

Toshi had a contemplative look on his face as he pulled out his phone. “Earlier you said you’ve never been to a concert,” Izuku nodded. “So before we all start working on the effects I thought I should show you a few videos to work off of,”

“Midori-bro’s never been to a concert?” Kirishima gasped in shock. When Izuku looked over at him, he noticed that he and Sero looked a little heart broken, while Todoroki rubbed his chin in thought.

“I haven’t ever been to one either,” Todoroki admitted after a moment of solemn silence. “I would like to see the video as well, if you don’t mind?”

“Oh, of course. No problem,” Toshi said as he motioned for both of them to come closer as they stopped in the middle of the hallway. As soon as Toshi pressed play on the HeroTube video, loud music started to play and startled Todoroki. Toshi laughed sheepishly and turned down his volume, and they all continued to watch.

Izuku saw flashing lights, streamers falling from the ceiling, and laser effects. The video was from the perspective of a member of the crowd, so Izuku had a good view of the stage. There were spotlights on the main vocalist.

Once the short video was over, Izuku felt even more excited than before. It swelled in his chest, warm and eager. He could definitely pull something like this off! He could probably do even better, if he was being honest.

“Are you planning on spending the night in the dorms?” Shouta asked from behind them. Izuku turned around to face him. He and Toshi shared a look before they nodded. “Alright. Me and Mic will stay the night with Eri at the hospital. Midnight and All Might will be at the dorms tonight, but you can call if you need us, okay?”

Izuku took a few quick steps forward to pull Shouta into a hug, and his dad froze for a moment before he seemed to realize what happened. Izuku melted into the hug as Shouta beckoned Toshi forward and they all hugged.

Kirishima, Sero, and Todoroki discreetly headed back to the dorms without saying so much as goodbye. Izuku was grateful because a few seconds later, Hizashi appeared to join their little group hug. Then suddenly Dabi was there, getting lovingly pulled into the hug by Hizashi when they noticed he arrived. Afterwards, when they all pulled away, they shared goodbyes for the day.

Toshi, Dabi, and Izuku all headed back to the dorms.

Within the allotted time they had to prepare Eri visited the class twice, and marveled at the entire atmosphere surrounding Yuuei. It lifted the spirits of the entire class and made them very determined to succeed and make this concert a thing to remember.

Class 1-A prepared as efficiently as possible, running through countless rehearsals for the dance team and band team. The effects team didn't rehearse, so much as conduct a series of trials to see what combinations looked the best during their performance.

A few things were added here and there, like Uraraka lifting people into the sky with her quirk, and Sero securing them safely with his tape. Or in the case of Hagakure, she would sparkle and shine just as much as Aoyama, and in tandem with Uraraka's quirk she'd become their second disco ball.

Jirou and her group sounded amazing, and the dance team was scarily coordinated under Ashido's instruction. Everything came together with less havoc than Izuku was anticipating. Kacchan only exploded his drum set twice and Dabi only set fire to the building once. So Izuku was happy to say that no one died or got hurt before the day of their concert.

"Are you ready for this?" Sero asked, a little ways in front of him on the catwalk. "I'm kinda nervous,"

"We practiced this countless times," Kirishima whispered lowly, on the very cusp of giggling as the lights dimmed and the crowd below them became hushed. "There's no way we'll mess this up,"

Izuku nodded and took a deep breath. Mirio-kun was already down on the floor with Eri on his shoulders. Izuku spotted Hizashi next to them, saying something to Eri which made the girl tilt her head in a pleased motion.

Shouta was leaning against the wall as Dabi, Todoroki, and Toshi positioned the overhead lights and flicked them on. There was a moment of silence, before Kacchan yelled something incomprehensible, and a loud explosion shook the room as he slammed his drumsticks down onto his drums.

Jirou took that as her queue and started to sing, and the rest of the band started to play. Izuku let the music wash over him, as Yaoyorozu made a confetti cannon from her elbow and blasted confetti everywhere.

Kirishima started to shave down the ice that Todoroki conjured, and Sero started to tether the members of the crowd that started to float due to Uraraka's quirk. It was kind of chaotic, as Izuku let a few of his gathered feathers float down into the air, and Dabi unleashed his blue fire and made curious shapes with it.

Toshi hauled Aoyama to the center of the catwalk as the music reached its peak, and the shining hero-in-training spun around and sparkled. Hagakure floated up into the air and continued to dance as she shone brightly too.

Izuku watched with an awed expression as he watched the crowd that had originally been hating on their performance, smile and jump around. He even saw Eri crack the biggest smile he's ever seen. A wave of happiness washed over him from head to toe.

She looked positively happy in a way that he'd never seen.

He was still riding the wave of it when the song came to end, and had to drop down from the catwalk to grab Hagakure who hadn't been properly tethered. It was a stunt they had practiced many times, because it was easier for Hagakure to dance without Sero's tape.

Finally, when the last notes of the song faded and the cheers died out, Izuku turned to look at the rest of his classmates. Jirou, Yaoyorozu, Denki, Tokoyami, and Kacchan looked out of

breath, but were pleasantly shocked. The entire dance team was still smiling and waving at the crowd as they departed.

It was then that Hagakure jumped from his arms and pulled him into a warm hug. “That was so fun!” she exclaimed, “We all did so well!”

They did, didn’t they?” Izuku giggled along with Hagakure, once again feeling warm and fuzzy. Hizashi and Mirio came over with Shouta on their heels, and Eri ran over to him and bumped into Izuku’s knees as she attempted to hug him.

“That was *so* cool Izuku-nii!” Eri grinned from ear to ear, and Izuku couldn’t help but mirror her expression.

When he crouched down to pat her on the head, he said in a raspy, unused voice, “I know, right?”

Eri just hopped in place, still jittery from their performance. She didn’t find his speaking odd at all, but everyone around them *did.* In a good way.

Kacchan was the first to compose himself, “Izuku,”

Izuku tilted his head as his only response.

“You just spoke,”

Izuku nodded.

And then, it was kind of like a spell was broken and he was tackled by what felt like his entire class, Shouta, Hizashi, and Eri.

“This is amazing progress,” Hizashi sniffled.

“We’re all proud of you, kiddo,” Shouta said, and his classmates hastened to agree very adamantly and loudly.

Izuku couldn’t have asked for a better family.

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1 Year Later

The Endeavor Scandal

Former Pro-Hero Endeavor, less commonly known as Enji Todoroki, has been in court for the past six months facing accusations of domestic abuse. What many thought as an unfounded attempt at slander, has actually turned out to be a real, and terrifying case.

With the Principal of Yuuei at the helm of the plaintiff’s legal team, no detail was spared, and thus, it painted us a very real and very disturbing picture of what the inside of the Todoroki household looked like.

Enji Todoroki’s spousal abuse and extensive child abuse against his family was carefully documented by one of his own children, in hopes that one day something like this trial would come to pass. With all of this evidence in mind, the judges came to the swift and justified decision to declare Enji Todoroki guilty of all charges.

It goes without saying that his victims will finally be able to rest easy tonight, as justice was served.

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2 Years Later

Classes 3-A and 3-B Graduate!

Today, new heroes were officially released into the industry. Most notable are the members of Yuuei's Big Three: Bakugou Katsuki, Todoroki Shouto, and Izuku Midoriya. We all are wondering how the world might change with them out in the world to protect us. Many say that these two classes have surpassed all the classes before them, having dealt with villains left and right since their very first year.

There are even those of us who hope that the next Symbol of Peace might be among their ranks. Or perhaps a Symbol of Hope?

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6 Years Later

Pro Heroes Kacchan and Morningstar are Engaged?!

This evening at the Hero Gala, the Number One Hero, Morningstar was spotted sitting next to the Number Two Hero, Kacchan. What seemed to be a normal party for all the gathered Heroes, quickly turned into a celebration of the year, when the Number Two Hero dropped down onto one knee and pulled out a ring.

Our precious Number One was stunned, but quickly agreed! I am happy to be the first to report on this joyous news! After years of dating since graduating from Yuuei, they've finally taken the next step! Rumors straight from their former classmates have said that they've planned their wedding for some time next year.

After all the trails our pro heroes have experienced before and after Yuuei, I think they deserve this. Our Symbol of Hope, finally getting hitched? How exciting! The wedding will no doubt be spectacular.

---

9 Years Later

Izuku walked alongside Eri, with Dabi, Toshi, and both of his dads nearby.

“Do you think I’ll pass?” Eri asked, squeezing Izuku’s hand for comfort. Izuku let out a small laugh and then crouched down so he could look up at her. Back when he first saved her, Eri was so small, anxious and unsure. Now, she had grown into herself, happy, assured, and very kind. The makings of a great hero.

“Of course you will,” Izuku replied, “The Yuuei Entrance Exam isn’t as biased as it used to be when I did my exam,”

Toshi snorted from his right. “You bet your ass it isn’t,” his brother grumbled. “Me, dad, and Nedzu beat the Hero Commission into the ground to fix that,”

“Managed to help Hawks out too,” Dabi said.

“The Commission sucked, and they totally deserved it,” Shouta replied, and Dabi nodded sagely.

“But what if I fail anyway?” Eri asked, “What if I just bomb the test because I’m so nervous?”

Izuku smiled at her, and Kacchan huffed from behind him, “If you fail no one will think less of you, idiot. We can try other hero schools. Yuuei ain’t your only option,”

“Just remember that you’ve worked hard for this, Eri-chan,” Izuku said. “We’re all very proud of you, no matter what,”

“Deep breaths,” Hizashi advised. Eri nodded, and shook out her hands, before sucking in a deep breath.

“I can do this!” She exclaimed before she turned and walked through Yuuei’s gates.

“She’s the only child I’ve ever raised that won’t turn out to be a Problem Child,” Shouta said, with a fond smile and warm gaze.

“Oh I wouldn’t write her off just yet, love,” Hizashi replied, as he swiped at a stray tear.

Chapter End Notes

Once again, thank you for reading this goliath of a fanfic. Thank you for the motivation you've given me. I honestly don't know how to feel about finishing this. A part of me is so upset and sad, while the other part of me is relieved that I proved to myself that I can write something this big. I will cry about this in my bathroom once I post this lol. Also, thank you to all the members of the discord. You guys are literally my family at this point, and i'm kind of terrified of losing you all after this chapter is posted. But it was a wild ride with everyone. <3

If you'd like to see what else I'm writing, here's the discord link!

And lastly for the really sad peeps who are devastated this is ending (me):

“There is no real ending. It's just the place where you stop the story.”—Frank Herbert.

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